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*PICTURE OF
AMMA*

AWAKEN, CHILDREN!

*Dialogues With
Sri Sri Mata Amritanandamayi*

VOLUME I

Adaptation & Translation

SWAMI AMRITASWARUPANANDA



MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI MISSION TRUST
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AWAKEN, CHILDREN!

Volume I

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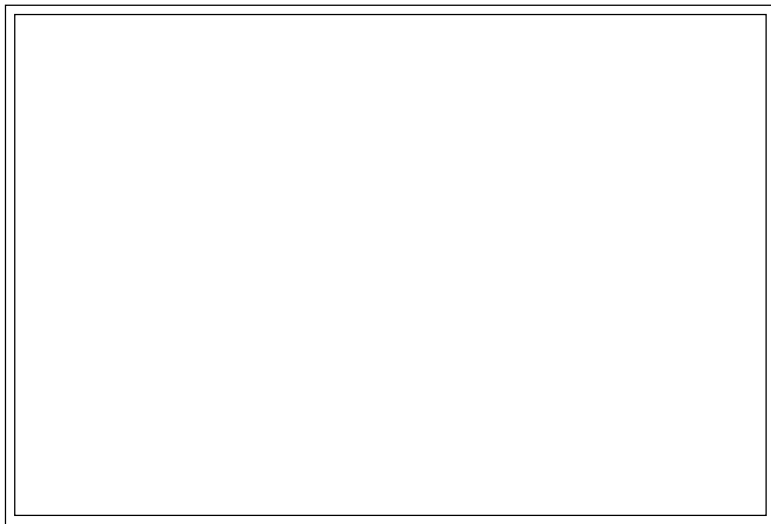
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SRI SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI

The Resplendent Luminary Immanent
In the Hearts Of All Beings



*Ṣoṣanam pāpapaṅkasya dīpanam jñānatejasām
Guru pādodakam samyak samsārāṇava tārakam*

The holy water that has washed the Guru's Feet, dries the mine of sins, lights the Lamp of Knowledge and helps one cross the Ocean of Transmigration.

*Ajñāna mūlaharanam janmakarma nivāranam
Jñāna vairāgya siddhyartham gurupādodakam pibet*

It uproots ignorance of the Self, puts an end to rebirth and its cause, actions. One should sip the holy water of the Guru's Feet for Enlightenment and Dispassion.

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Preface

Dear brothers and sisters, herein is contained a direct translation of Holy Mother's *divya upadesha* (Divine advice) into the English language. The tremendous blessing that is bestowed by presenting the Mother's teaching to the English speaking world is not yet fully realized. Now it is left to the reader to sanctify his or her life by a careful reading of the material and a whole-hearted practice of it in daily life.

Several points should be remembered in order that this translation is approached with right understanding. First of all, these conversations occurred between the Mother and Indian householders and renunciates in the cultural context of India. Also the Mother's advice is given according to the level of understanding of each person to whom she is speaking. Often a word-for-word English translation falls short of conveying the totality of what the Mother has expressed through her mother tongue, Malayalam. One must consider these factors when contemplating her words to achieve deeper insight.

Secondly, the Mother's use of language is direct and earthy. Her words convey an immediacy and intensity of purpose to transmit the Essential, particularly when speaking to *sadhakas* (spiritual aspirants). For instance, when it comes time to bring a point across to a renunciate, the Mother does not mince words. Thus we can understand her expression, "Worldly pleasure is equal to dog excreta," to be sound advice to one whose sole aim is God-Realization.

In a separate conversation with a householder, the Mother's advice takes on an entirely different tone. "Mother does not say that you must give up all desires. You can enjoy them, but do not think that this life is for that only."

Keep in mind that in the Mother's language, the word 'world' literally means 'That which is seen' as opposed to the invisible Reality or God. Knowing this will be of great help in interpreting her use of the word 'worldly.' When the Mother contrasts that which is spiritual to that which is worldly, she refers to the attitude with which actions are done. Spiritual actions are those actions which lead one to God through selflessness and purity. Worldly actions are those actions which lead one away from God, performed as they are in a spirit of selfishness.

Finally, the Mother speaks to us from the exalted state of *sahaja samadhi*, the natural state of abidance of a Self-Realized Master in the Absolute Reality. The challenge in translating is to render the Mother's transcendental vision into English for the layman. The vital ingredient in this process is the contemplative mind of the reader. Abandoning all superficiality, may our mind and intellect become subtle and assimilate the eternal Wisdom of the Mother's words. Firmly established in their practice, may we all revel in the direct experience of the Supreme Absolute without delay.

My heartfelt gratitude is due to Professor M. Ramakrishnan Nair, the compiler of *Mata Amritanandamayi Sambhashanangal*, the Holy Mother's conversations in Malayalam. The present book, *Awaken, Children! I*, is a faithful translation of the same, interspersed with some additional materials which were recorded by me. I would like to thank all of the Holy Mother's children who took part in producing the book.

Swami Amritaswarupananda

Introduction

Only in a Great Master who is established in the Supreme Reality can one see the perfect balance of Divine Fatherhood and Divine Motherhood, the beautiful blending of masculine and feminine qualities. Only such a person can transform another and mould the character of others. Integration of one's own inner personality, being higher than anything else, is possible only through discipline motivated by selflessness and unconditional love.

The Holy Mother Amritanandamayi's teachings, sayings and conversations are equally inspiring and throw light on the mystical expressions expounded in the scriptural texts. The Mother's teachings are surcharged with spiritual power and are a tremendous source of inspiration for people from all walks of life, especially for spiritual seekers. The Holy Mother has her own simple and lucid way of expressing spiritual truths with examples which make the points clear and intellectually satisfying.

From a worldly standpoint, she has not attended school beyond the fourth grade, yet her knowledge, wisdom and philosophical insight is immeasurable. In the early days, due to the visitors' lack of spiritual interest, only a few paid attention to the Mother's words. At that time, most peoples' interest was to fulfill their material desires. Thus, they gave less importance to the Mother's precious gospel regarding the Supreme Goal of human birth. Needless to say, her parents, relatives and villagers who were dead against her 'strange' behaviour considered her as one gone mad and took these words of the Mother to be crazy utterances.

However, at the age of twenty-one, the Holy Mother began initiating some educated young men and women who

had renounced hearth and home to dedicate their lives to God-Realization. They noticed the depth and simplicity of her explanations and began writing down her teachings. By the end of 1983, Prof. M. Ramakrishnan Nair, an ardent devotee of the Mother, started tape recording the Mother's talks whenever he stayed in the Ashram. Later, he compiled the "Conversations with Mata Amritanandamayi" in Malayalam from the said materials. This English translation of that book is interspersed with other interesting incidents which took place over the course of the last ten or twelve years in the presence of the Holy Mother. From 1979 onwards, at which time I came and settled near the Holy Mother, I recorded many of her conversations and it is from that material that the additional incidents have been woven into the narrative.

1 August 1976

It was a beautiful day soon after the rainy season. The sun's golden rays blessed the earth and the green leaves of the trees and plants danced a fanciful pattern in the warm breeze blowing gently over the blue waves of the Arabian Sea. The melodious sound of the sacred *chakora* bird could be heard at a distance. A soothing "OM" sound was being sung by the waves as they rolled onto the shore. The softness of the sound seemed to provide the drone note for the song sung by the fishermen, as they pulled in their nets. Large canoes made of wooden planks, held together by coconut fibers, moved slowly up and down the backwaters.

It was ten o'clock in the morning. The Ashram atmosphere was unusually calm and quiet. Peace seemed to permeate everywhere. The Holy Mother dressed in pure, white clothes was sitting on the verandah of the old temple. A group of college students who were interested in spiritual life arrived. They prostrated, then sat near the Holy Mother. Smiling, Mother asked them, "Children, have you eaten anything?" One student replied, "We had breakfast." After a few moments the conversation turned to spiritual topics.

God

Student: It is said that there is a God, but I am unable to believe that.

Mother: Children, to say that there is no God is like saying with your own tongue, "I have no tongue." Is it possible for a person who has no tongue to say, "I have no tongue?" Likewise, when we say, "There is no God," at that very

moment, we have agreed that there is a God. In order to say that a particular object is 'not', we must have previously had a general knowledge of the existence of that object. How can we prove the non-existence of something which is not known to us? Truth is only one. That is God. God-Realization is our life's aim.

Student: What is meant by God?

Mother: Son, if you can answer the questions which Mother is going to ask, Mother will tell you what God is.

Student: All right, I will answer.

Mother: Son, what did you eat this morning?

Student: I ate *dosa* (an Indian pancake).

Mother: What else did you eat?

Student: Chutney.

Mother: What was it made of?

Student: Coconut.

Mother: Where did you get the coconut from?

Student: From a coconut tree.

Mother: Where did the coconut tree come from?

Student: From a coconut.

Mother: Which came first, the coconut or the coconut tree? That is what Mother wants to know.

(The student did not reply.)

Mother: Son, why are you sitting silent? (Pause) Now, you should agree that there is a power beyond the coconut and the coconut tree. That power is the substratum of everything. That is God. It is a Unique Power which is beyond words and expressions. That is God. The First Cause for everything is what is known as God.

Student: It is easy to believe, when we are discussing the existence of a building or a coconut tree. But it is much more difficult to believe in something which we cannot see.

Mother: Son, would you feel angry if Mother asks you one thing?

Student: No.

Mother: Is your father still alive?

Student: Yes.

Mother: What about your father's father?

Student: He died long before I was born.

Mother: Do any of your grandchildren call your father a bastard because you have not seen your grandfather? Son, do you remember who gave birth to you? When you grew a little older everyone told you, "This is your mother." You believed it, even though you did not see the person when they gave birth to you. Will you believe it if someone says that there is cooking gas in cow dung? Cooking gas is not visible but gas can be extracted if one knows the technique. Oftentimes it is blind faith that leads us to the goal. Son, suppose you left your house to come here. You got into the bus which comes here. Isn't it because of your faith that you will reach the destination? You got into the bus even though there are many vehicle accidents. Wasn't your expectation that you would reach here simply blind faith? Children, isn't it because of your blind faith that Mother will talk to you, and that you in turn will talk to her? Children, all beliefs or faiths are blind.

Student: It is said that God is everywhere. If so, why is it necessary to go to particular places of worship?

Mother: There is wind everywhere but the person who comes to rest under a tree out of the scorching heat gets a special kind of rejuvenating coolness which filters through the leaves of the tree. Likewise, we can experience a unique peace when we go to *Mahatmas*¹. The significance of going to other places of worship is also the same. The atmosphere in a temple and a liquor shop are different, aren't they?

Student: Mother, how can we see God?

¹Great souls

Mother: Children, when there is good sunlight we can see numerous dust particles in the ray of sunlight which enters the room through a small hole. Due to the lack of concentrated light, it is not seen in other places. Our minds are very dim and have no subtlety. Just like charging a battery, when through subtlety we illumine our mind, we can see God. Having searched with our external eyes, do not say, “I am not seeing God, therefore I don’t believe in God.” We should not make a big fuss saying, “I will only believe in the things that I see.” Search, certainly you can see.

Without God’s grace, we cannot see Him. If we want to get His grace, the ego in us must be eliminated. The well might say, “Everyone is drinking water from me. If I were not here, how would they cook food?” But the well does not know that it was dug by someone and that the bricks which make it beautiful were made by somebody else. Our situation is also the same. We become egotistical thinking that “I am greater than everything else.” Even to move a finger we need God’s power. (Pointing her finger at a distance) However powerful a cyclone is, it cannot do anything to that blade of grass. Whereas the huge trees standing with their heads high will be uprooted. All grace will flow to us if we maintain a servant-like attitude (*dasa bhavana* or attitude of humility). After that, nothing can affect us. Where there is ego, God will not abide, and we will be uprooted by the cyclone of ego.

Another student: Mother, what about people who do not have time to go to ashrams?

Mother: Do not say that (there is no time). Children, for years together we will sit at the courthouse to get a foot of land. We won’t care about rain, heat, or any other impediments. Because of our desire to acquire some land we find time to try the case. Nobody would say that there is no time for it. Similarly, we will wait any number of hours to

see a doctor. Children, when you go to the theatre you will buy a ticket not caring how big the crowd may be or even how many kicks and shoves you may get. That much desire is there to see the movie. These are not difficulties at all if one is intent on the goal (*lakshya bodha*). Those who sincerely desire to see God will not feel that there is a lack of time.

By this time, a householder devotee and his family had come from Quilon, a town 35 kilometers south of the Mother's Ashram. They prostrated before the Holy Mother and took a seat there. After having some light conversation with them, the Mother again turned to the students.

God is compassionate

Student: Mother, there are many people who are suffering in this world. Some are rich and enjoy, but others die from starvation. Seeing this, it doesn't make sense to me to say that God is compassionate. Isn't God cruel?

Mother: Children, God is only compassionate. We must be deserving of His Grace which is constantly being showered. The river is constantly flowing. We construct a dam, then we complain that we don't get any water. We are the ones who made the dam. We will experience God's constantly flowing grace when the dam of ignorance and ego is removed. Our mother gave birth to us. She also taught us many ways to progress. No progress will be made if we do not obey her. Imposing cruelty on God is like blaming our mother for our disobedience. God, the Creator, has given human beings the power to discriminate between the eternal and non-eternal. We commit errors when we do not use this discrimination. As a result we suffer. One day a boy was going to the forest. His mother told him, "Son, do not go to the forest. There is a forest fire there, and ferocious animals are there." Why should the mother be blamed

for troubles which happen if he goes to the forest without listening to all this?

Student: Then what is it that causes the sorrow in life?

Mother: Desire is the cause of sorrow. The happiness that we get from worldly objects is only an infinitesimal fraction of the bliss that we get from within. The result will always be sorrow when we think that we are this body. This is only a rented body. At some point, we will be asked to leave it. Then we must go out. Before that, that which is eternal should be gained while residing in this body. If we have a house of our own, we can happily move out when we are asked to vacate this rented one. Then we can live in the eternal house of God.

Student: Mother, there are many people who still experience sorrow even after crying to God.

Mother: We call on God to fulfill our many desires. The mind is filled with desires, not with God's Form. That means that we see God as our laborer. It should not be like that. Even if God is the servant of His devotees, it is not correct for us to see Him as such. Dedicate everything at His Feet. We must have the attitude of surrender, then He will definitely protect us. Even after getting into the boat or bus, you won't carry the luggage, will you? You will put it down. Likewise, surrender everything to God. He will protect you. Have the thought that God is near you. If there is a place to rest nearby, the mere thought of unloading the luggage which we are carrying on our head lessens the weight of the burden. If we think that there is no place to rest, then the baggage seems heavier. In the same way, when we think that God is near, all our burdens diminish.

Many householder devotees tell Mother, "No matter how much we householders meditate or do *mantra japa* (*mantra* repetition), very little benefit is gained." Devotedly we go to the temple to pray to the Lord. Finishing the circumam-

bulation and standing in front of the sanctum sanctorum, if somebody comes and stands in front of us, our mood will change immediately. We will get angry. Even if God Himself comes in disguise, assuming a different form, we will get angry. This is our character. How then are you going to get the benefit of meditation, children?

Student: If God is omniscient and omnipotent, then why can't I realize the God-consciousness in me?

Mother: Son, God-consciousness is very close to you, that is why you cannot see it. Is it possible to see our own face without the aid of a mirror? Will it be possible to see our image in a mirror which is completely covered with dust? Look, after wiping away the dust particles and cleaning the mirror, certainly you can see.

Student: How is it possible to remove this ignorance?

Mother: Through devotion, through worship with pure, divine love, and with knowledge.

Student: Mother, while I was leaving the house I saw two crows pecking and injuring an owl's fledgling. It was fluttering and crying in pain. What injustice is this? If God is compassionate, why does He allow such cruelties in Nature? Innocent deer become prey to lions. Human beings slaughter cows and eat their flesh. Is there no end to this?

Mother: Children, nothing is in excess in this world. Everything is accurately weighed and measured and noted down. It is according to their *vasanas*² that beings take birth as a bird, cow or lion. Should God be responsible for that? Higher births are gained by finishing off each *vasana*. If this human birth, which we finally attained, is again spent living like an animal without using it for God-Realization, then we might take birth in this world as a bird or an animal.

²Latent tendencies.

Therefore, God is not being cruel. Each creature is experiencing the fruit of its actions.

Question: Mother, why is it necessary to worship God through a form when He is, in truth, formless?

Mother: Children, in order to get peace, we habitually share our sorrows with our friends. Instead, we should tell our sorrows only to the Universal Being. This is the aim of worshipping God with a form.

Once Shiva and Parvati were sitting together. Suddenly, Shiva got up and started running but immediately returned. Parvati asked Him, “Why did You return so quickly?” Shiva replied, “One of My devotees used to tell his sorrows, big and small, to Me only; he never used to tell others. Today while returning to his house, he was mistaken for a thief and beaten up. Seeing this, I went to rescue him but on My way I saw him telling his sorrow to some other man. ‘They beat me up for no reason! You should help me take revenge.’ Since My help was not needed, I came back.”

Do not increase your sorrows by sharing them with others. Tell them to God alone and try to solve them. If we share our sorrows with the Universal Being, we will get Eternal Peace.

An ordinary man may not develop love as easily for the formless aspect of God as he would if he worshipped God with form. Following the Path of Knowledge without devotion is like eating stones. The formless and omnipotent God can easily assume any form for the sake of His devotees. If one has full faith and confidence in the form of one’s Beloved Deity, he can reach the goal. We should think that God is our own Self. We should worship Him seeing all forms as different aspects of the same God.

Question: If God is one and non-dual, why should we worship Shiva, Vishnu and other such gods?

Mother: An actor takes many roles, but he remains the same. God is like that. Truth is one; the names and forms are different. Men have different natures and characters. The different forms of God were described by the ancient sages to enable us to realize Him by selecting names and forms according to our mental constitution. It is not that these are different gods. The sages have portrayed the non-dual God in different ways at different times according to the taste and temperament of the people.

Question: If God is one, then why are there separate places of worship for each religion?

Mother: Will an object change just because it is known by different names? For example, water may be called 'vellom' in Malayalam and 'pani' in Hindi, but does the color and taste change? No. Is there any difference between the electric current which passes through the fridge, the lamp and the fan? No, only the object differs. Christians call God as Christ and Muslims call Him Allah. Each person understands God according to his culture and worships Him accordingly.

Question: Mother, a lot of money is offered to God in temples for ritualistic worship and other purposes. Why does God require money?

Mother: God does not require anything from us. An electric lamp does not require the help of a kerosene lamp. God is like the sun. He sheds light equally on all things in the world. It is to this all-illuminating God that we offer a lamp and oil. This is due to our ignorance. It is like holding a burning candle in the daytime and saying, "O Sun God, here is light for You so that You can see the path clearly and walk." The offerings in temples are made for our benefit. God is the giver of everything. He does not need or want anything from us.

Temples

Question: What are the temples for? Isn't the sculptor who chiseled the beautiful image the one who deserves to be adored?

Mother: Just as we remember our father when we see his portrait, we are reminded of God when we see the image. When a devotee of Krishna sees the image of Sri Krishna, he remembers the real Lord Krishna and not the stone image. Temples and idols are needed by those of us who are drowning in ignorance.

Question: Are temples necessary for remembering God?

Mother: Small children study things by looking at pictures of animals in books. These pictures will help them in their studies. They get an idea of what a camel, lizard or tiger is. At a later stage they understand that it is only a picture, but at a young age these pictures facilitate development of the intellect.

Question: It is said that if the daily worship is stopped in a temple, adverse reactions will occur. Is this true?

Mother: As a result of man's resolve, the power of the temple gods will increase. If the worship is stopped, that power will diminish. The power of the god depends on the attitude of the person who installs it. Don't stop the daily worship performed in temples or to the family deity. If these rites are stopped, great misfortunes may result.

Suppose we feed a crow for ten days. On the eleventh day, if we don't feed it, it will follow us cawing. We will be unable to work attentively. Like this, if we stop the daily worship of the gods, they will always trouble us in their subtle forms. This will greatly affect weak-minded people, although spiritual aspirants will not be affected much.

It is not enough to build a boat; we should also learn how to row it. If we get into a boat without knowing how

to row, it will move hither and thither. Is it proper to blame the boat if we don't know how to row? Similarly, it is not enough to construct temples. They must be properly looked after as well. Daily worship should be performed. If not, misfortune may result. It is meaningless to blame the temples.

Question: Are gods and God different?

Mother: The gods are created and installed by man's resolve. Man's resolve has limitations and therefore his creations will reflect this fact. God, on the other hand, is all powerful. His power neither increases nor decreases, but is eternally the same. The difference between the gods and God is like the difference between animals and men. Even though everything is One, a dog does not have the discrimination that a man has. A dog loves only those who love it; it may bite others.

Question: If so, then won't temples become harmful to human beings?

Mother: Never. This applies only to the temples where gods are worshipped. As regards such temples, we should be a bit careful. The installation of gods is done by priests who are incapable of controlling their own life force (*prana shakti*). We should never stop the daily worship in such temples. Have you seen fish living in aquariums? The water must be changed frequently or else it will be harmful to the fish. If daily worship is performed properly, material prosperity will result.

The greatness of temples where *Mahatmas* have installed the images is unique. By their mere will, they give divine power to the images which they install. They make the resolve that the images should be identified with the Undivided Existence, Awareness, Bliss. Such temples and their images will be full of divinity, power and effulgence. They are not like fish living in aquariums, but like fish that live in the river. In such temples the daily *pūja* will never stop.

Even if the *puja* is stopped, there will be no loss of power. These temples will be centers of great attraction and will have eternally auspicious attributes. *Tirupathi*, *Guruvayur* and *Chottanikara* temples are examples of this.

Question: Why were human sacrifices conducted in temples?

Mother: The ignorance of people in the olden times prompted them to do this. They believed such sacrifices would please God. Misunderstanding the words of the scriptures, they performed these sacrifices. Look at our present day world. In the name of politics there is so much bloodshed. Atrocities like killing a man who changes political parties, killing the members of different political parties, shootings and stabbings are commonplace. Do any of these party's by-laws or ideologies sanction murder or such atrocities? The manifesto and ideologies are very good, but the actions of the followers may be entirely different. Similarly, there were some fools in the olden days. Blind devotion and belief prompted them to act like this.

Question: Do such people incur sin?

Mother: If an action is performed for a universal cause, there is no sin; but if it is for selfish reasons, sin is incurred. Once there were two *brahmins* in a village. Both became afflicted with the same disease. When they consulted a doctor he told them that if they ate fish they would be cured. As both were strict vegetarians, they were at their wits end. The first man, yielding to the demand of his wife and children, ate the fish and was cured. The second man, afraid he would incur a sin, refused to eat the fish and as a result, died. His family was orphaned and subjected to so many troubles.

Here the first man, by eating the comparatively insignificant fish, protected his whole family. This is not cruelty. The second man refused to eat fish and died, leaving his whole family to suffer. A family is of far greater impor-

tance than one or two fish. Don't we cut down trees to build a house? Such actions are not selfish. When we act with vengeance, likes and dislikes, etc., that is when we incur sin.

Question: Mother, why has the sanctity of the temples been lost?

Mother: In the name of festivals, people collect money and conduct worldly programs in temples. This makes the temple's atmosphere impure. Instead of cultivating devotion and good thoughts in people, such programs create vulgar thoughts and passions. What nonsense is done in the name of festivals; people getting drunk and engaging in fighting. In the temple surroundings they conduct drama, dance and such activities that arouse worldliness in the minds of the audience. Young children will also be affected by this. At the tender age when good thoughts should be developed, these programs will make them stray from the right path. These kinds of thought waves will make the temple atmosphere unholy.

Children, we alone destroy ourselves. First we should become good. We should see that the temples are kept pure. Only the arts of a divine nature, which increase devotion and faith should be held in temples. The daily puja should be performed properly. Now that the temple surroundings have been made impure, it makes no sense to accuse the deities. In olden days meditation, reading of the ancient scriptures, yogic postures and other spiritual activities were practiced in temples. Only stories connected with God would be presented as dramas during festivals.

The money collected from the public for festivals should be utilized for humanitarian purposes. There are so many people who are struggling without a house in our villages. We can build houses for them. Clothes and food can be given in charity to the poor. Help can be given to those

who are unable to conduct a marriage ceremony due to lack of money. Religious books can be printed and distributed free of charge and used for teaching children. Orphanages can be built enabling more children to be brought up with good culture and character. In this way, there would not be any orphans in the future. All this would help create unity among people.

Children, look at the Christians and Muslims and all the good things that they do. They build orphanages and schools where they teach the orphans religion and look after their needs. Have you seen any churches in a dilapidated condition? No. But see the plight of Hindu temples. So many temples remain uncared for and unattended. The Devaswom Board (government agency for the maintenance of temples) will take over the management of big temples because they can make money, while ignoring small temples.

We should take special care to renovate temples and conduct divine arts during festival seasons. United, we should take care of temples in the proper way. Their holiness should be preserved, otherwise our culture will degenerate.

Question: Is it possible to attain Liberation through temple worship?

Mother: It is possible, but one must worship with the understanding of the inner significance of the temples. God resides in the temples, but don't think that He is limited to the four walls of the temple. Have the firm belief that God is omnipresent. A bus will take us to the bus stop nearest to our house; from there we can easily walk the remaining distance. Similarly, the correct way of temple worship will take us to the threshold of *Satchidananda* (Pure Being-Knowledge-Bliss); from there only a short distance remains before attaining Perfection. You can take birth in a temple, but don't die there. That is to say that, in the

beginning, a seeker can do temple worship as a stepping stone, but the final and real goal is beyond all these things.

Mantra

Question: Do words have the power to change the character of a person?

Mother: Definitely. Once in a temple a *brahmin* was teaching spiritual matters to his students. At that time the king of the country arrived. The *brahmin*, engrossed in his teaching, was unaware of the king's arrival. The king became angry and berated the *brahmin* for not noticing him. The *brahmin* explained that as he was deeply involved with teaching, he was unaware of the king's arrival. The king then asked what the *brahmin* was teaching so earnestly that he was not aware of the king's presence. The *brahmin* replied, "I was teaching the children things which will purify their characters. There is no use if this is not taught with full attention and sincerity." The king mockingly asked, "Can mere words change character?" The *brahmin* replied, "Certainly! Change will happen." The king retorted, "It will not change just like that." At that moment one of the *brahmin's* students, a small boy, told the king to get out. As soon as the king heard this, he was enraged and roared, "How dare you say that! I will kill you, your guru and destroy this Ashram as well!" Thus said, the king caught hold of the *brahmin* by the neck. Then the *brahmin* told the king, "Please forgive me. Just now you said that mere words cannot change the character of a person. Yet, see how much your character changed when a small boy said just a few words to you. You were even ready to kill me and destroy everything."

Children, through words, character can be changed. If ordinary words can change the character, then think what power a *mantra* which emanated from the *rishis* (ancient

sages) and contains *bijaksharas* (seed letters: e.g. *om*, *hrim*, *klim*) can have.

Question: Mother, if a *mantra* is chanted will one get the benefit?

Mother: Definitely. But remember that *mantras* should be chanted with concentration. Depending on one's attitude one will get power. Mental attitude is the criteria. A doctor will prescribe medicine and tell the patient to take rest and avoid certain foods. If the patient follows the instructions, the disease will be cured. Like this, the *rishis* have told that if a *mantra* is chanted in a prescribed way, then certain results will accrue. If we follow their instructions meticulously, we will definitely get the fruit of it.

Rituals

Question: Mother do the rituals performed during *pitrukarma* (ancestral ceremonies) have any effect?

Mother: Children, a pure *sankalpa* (resolve) has great power, but only when the *sankalpa* is pure will rituals bear fruit. When *pitrukarma* is performed, the name, birthstar, form and attitude of the dead person is remembered and then the *mantras* are chanted. Each ritual has its respective *devata* (deity). Just as a properly addressed letter sent by a son to his parents in a distant place is received correctly, the effect of rituals will also reach the intended person. If the *sankalpa* is pure, the *devata* pertaining to that ritual will make its result reach that particular soul.

Rishis-Sages

Question: What is the guarantee that the *rishis* predictions will come true?

Mother: The ancient *rishis* were *mantradrishitas* (visionaries); whatever they said came true. Everything written in the

*Bhagavatam*³ about *Kaliyuga*⁴ has been accurate. “The father will eat the son; the son will eat the father. All the forests will become houses; all the houses will become shops.” Are these things not happening? We cut down the trees and build houses and shops in their place. Truth and *dharma* have no place at all. Is there any mutual trust, love, sincerity, patience, or sacrifice? Weather during the rainy season and the hot season is extreme. During the growing season, due to lack of rain, crops dry up. All these things were predicted by the sages.

The ancient *rishis*, eating only leaves and fruits, did *tapas*⁵ and realized the secret of the universe. The whole creation was like a mustard seed in the palm of their hand. Even inanimate objects would obey their command. The *rishis* made many discoveries in ancient times. Even present-day inventions, which we consider to be very great, were brought forth effortlessly by them. For example, scientists have produced test tube babies. Yet the sage Vyasa brought forth the hundred and one *Kauravas* from clay pots; he imparted life to mere hunks of flesh. When compared with this, the test tube baby is nothing. In the *Ramayana*⁶ reference is made to “*pushpaka vimana*”⁷, yet the modern airplane was invented only recently. There are many examples like this.

Mother does not say this out of disregard for present-day scientists and their inventions, but rather to show that there is nothing that cannot be gained by *tapas*. For the *rishis*, all

³An ancient scripture describing the deeds of Lord Vishnu’s incarnations.

⁴The present dark age of materialism.

⁵Severe austerities.

⁶A scripture describing the birth and life of Sri Rama, an incarnation of Lord Vishnu.

⁷An airplane made of flowers.

these things were quite simple. They were able to create anything through their *sankalpa*.

18 September 1976

The Mother was conversing with a few devotees sitting in front of the temple. Unnikrishnan, one of the first Ashram residents, was also present. He keenly listened to the conversation that Mother was having with the other devotees.

The path to Liberation

Devotee: Mother, what is the path to Liberation?

Mother: Children, what does Mother know? Mother is crazy. She will simply say some crazy things. Shiva! Shiva! Children, accept what you think is correct.

Permanent happiness will not be gained from the world which is changing every moment. Only if we depend on the Eternal Reality, will Eternal Bliss be gained. So much the better if the effort begins from a young age.

Devotee: Why do people make mistakes?

Mother: We are caught in the illusion that we will get happiness from the world. Then we madly run here and there craving to acquire it. Having unfulfilled desires, frustration and anger result. Without discriminating between the necessary and the unnecessary, we do anything we like. Can we say that this is life? Whose fault is it?

Devotee: It is said that without God's Presence and Will, even a blade of grass cannot bend in a breeze. Can human beings then be blamed for errors if God is making them do everything?

Mother: For a person who has the conviction, "The real doer is not me, but God," it is impossible to commit any mistakes. He sees everything permeated by God. It is impossible for that devotee to even think about making

mistakes. To say it in another way, only someone who has transcended all errors will have the faith, "God alone is the doer, even a blade of grass will not move without Him." There is no error or sin for one who has the conviction that God is the doer, whereas the fruits of the mistakes committed by a person who thinks, "I am the doer" must be accepted by him. He alone is responsible for his own good and bad actions if he thinks, "I am doing everything" without having the awareness that God is the sole doer. Having committed a murder, it is not right to then say that God is the doer. One whose thought is, "God is the doer" would not commit murder, would he?

Devotee: We would not commit murder or mistakes if God didn't give us ignorance.

Mother: In Creation there is ignorance and knowledge, discrimination and indiscrimination, everything exists there. God's Will is that we should use the discriminative power given by Him and do good action. A student may make mistakes while studying in school, but why should he be adamant that he should only make mistakes? He can progress towards goodness by using his circumstances, can't he? There is right and wrong in the Creation just as there is night and day. God has also given discrimination to human beings to refrain from committing any errors. We have to make use of it. The field is there and the seed is also there. Cultivate carefully and reap the fruit. Having acted as you like, do not say that God is the mischief maker. If you say, "It is God who made me do the murder," console yourself that "It is God who is hanging me." Do not make any complaints. How many times does God, dwelling within, warn us saying, "Don't, don't!" when we are about to commit some wrong deed? Why aren't we listening to that? Afterwards, are you putting the burden of the responsibility for your mistakes on God's head? If it is spiritual progress that

you children want, then what is needed is to take refuge in God with a pure heart and without blaming God or indulging in unnecessary disputes.

Cause and effect should merge some day. The effects are the sense organs, mind, intellect and vital forces. The world itself is an effect. Real life is a dispassionate, constant effort to merge these into the Supreme Self (*Paramatman*) which is the Cause. There is nothing that cannot be gained through a human birth. If the feeling that something should be gained is there, that life is not full. That State should come where there is nothing to gain. We must become eternally satisfied. That is Perfection. There will be no sorrow if and when the sense organs are withdrawn from sense objects.

Devotee: In which shape does God's radiant Power assume a form?

Mother: God is not limited like that. Everything is God's Will. He will assume forms according to the need. None of them are fruitless.

Devotee: Can there be more than one *Avatar* (Incarnation) living at a time?

Mother: It can happen. Why doubt? Didn't Parasurama, Sri Rama and Sita all exist at one time? What about Balarama, Krishna and Rukmini? There should be no doubt about more than one Incarnation of God being able to exist at the same time when it is the same God who has become all these worlds of diversity simultaneously.

Devotee: Mother, can *sankalpa* come true?

Mother: When the world is true, *sankalpa* is also true. If the world is illusory, *sankalpa* is also illusory. *Sankalpa*, if it is strong and sincere, will come true.

Elimination of the mind

Devotee: Mother, I have been worshipping God for a long time, but I have no peace of mind. What should I do?

Mother: Isn't it the mind which has no peace? Eliminate the mind, then the problem will be solved. Don't you agree?

Devotee: Is it really possible to eradicate the mind?

Mother: Why not? Isn't that the purpose of all paths? Don't let the mind go towards sense objects. That is possible through *sadhana* (spiritual practice). Now and then the mind will go outward. Immediately make it introverted saying, "No, I won't let you go."

Mind has three aspects, namely *vikāra* (emotions), *vichara* (thoughtfulness) and *vijñāna* (wisdom). It is *vikāra* which creates the problem. Jealousy, aversion, base love all come from *vikāra*. *Vikāra* will subside through control of the mind and senses. *Vichara* is the formation of ideas. The mind itself becomes the object. The mind has no existence bereft of the sense objects. *Vijñāna* is knowledge acquired through direct experience. Merging of the mind in Reality occurs when these three – *vikāra*, *vichara* and *vijñāna* – stop. To accomplish this, the mind should be introverted by withdrawing it from external objects.

Devotee: How do human beings become good or bad?

Mother: Due to *vasanas* actions arise and from actions, *vasanas* arise. From God alone we received the first *vasana*. From that *vasana*, action followed. According to the actions, good and bad come.

The law of karma

Devotee: If every person is experiencing the fruits of his actions, why should the suffering person be helped?

Mother: If what he is experiencing is the fruit of his actions, then isn't it possible that the fruit of your actions is

to save him? If his *vasana* is a cause for experiencing sorrow, maybe your *vasana* is a cause to help. Both are the continuation of past actions. Remember that if you do not help the ailing, you will have to enjoy the fruit of that evil action.

Devotee: I have no faith because I cannot see God. The *Mahatmas* can be seen. Therefore, isn't it better to worship them?

Mother: That is all right unless you hold on to form only and put aside the goal. Where is the place for *adheyam* (the substance) without *adharam* (the substratum)? You should also understand the relationship between the *Mahatmas* and God. It is the Essence of God which manifests through the *Mahatmas*, just as electricity manifests through a light bulb. *Mahatmas* should be approached with *Ishwara bhavana* (the attitude that they are equal to God). Only then is there benefit. The Guru should be considered as God.

Sarira tyaga Committing suicide

Another devotee: Mother, I have no interest in sustaining my body, but I have the desire for God-Realization. What shall I do?

Mother: The body will exist as long as there is desire. When one body is given up, another will be gained. Body is the representation of desire. Desire is of different kinds. There is no harm in the desire to know God. Not only that, you must have that desire. To attain God, spiritual practices should be performed. The body is needed for that, therefore the thought to give up the body is wrong.

Your mind is preoccupied with your body, that is why you feel that it is a burden and that it should be given up. There is no significance if someone who always thinks of

his body says that he is thinking of God. There will be no body-consciousness when the mind merges in God. Let the body exist or fall off; after realizing the Truth, it is not a problem. Therefore son, think of God at all times. That is what is needed now.

Mother knows that this suicidal tendency in you is not based purely on your longing to realize God. Isn't the main reason due to the calamities which recently occurred in your family? Son, don't you feel frightened thinking that those calamities, although they have subsided for the time being, are still waiting to burst out at any moment? Aren't you afraid of what may happen in the future? Son, don't worry. Nothing will happen. Cast off this fear, Mother is with you.

The devotee was wonderstruck when he heard Mother clearly and precisely reveal her knowledge of even his subtlest thoughts. It was perfectly true that a calamity had happened in his family and that he was feeling intense fear. After the death of his father a few weeks before, there was a huge dispute between the relatives each of whom wanted to seize the ancestral wealth. This culminated in a terrible fight. This unfortunate incident sowed the seeds of dread and terror in the young man's heart. He was the youngest of the family and a lover of peace.

Now he wondered how the Mother came to know of all this. He tried to fathom the mystery but failed. The young man looked with wide-open eyes at Mother's face and then with eyes cast down, he shed silent tears.

While Mother lovingly stroked his back and comforted him, another devotee asked:

How to know the Truth

Devotee: Mother, how is it possible to know the Truth while living in this world of plurality?

Mother: It is difficult to know God while being in this world. Both God and the world can be known if the world is seen as God. Suppose a white crane is sitting in the midst of many crows. When viewed from a distance, everything will seem black and dark. Upon coming closer, the crows can be distinguished. Coming a little closer, we will see the crane. Then our attention will be on that. Likewise, Pure Consciousness will not come into sight if we stand at a distance. Truth cannot be gained by searching outside. Truth is One. Search for It within. Truth is ever-existent, all else lasts for a short period of time. In reality, the essence of the world is only God but you must have the eye to see it so.

Devotee: It is said that God and the world are one. Then why are they seen as two?

Mother: Just as the sun during the sunrise and sunset is the same, God and the world are one. If all our energy is wasted on trivial things, that which is the Essence cannot be known. Discrimination must be used. *Satsang* (companionship with the Great Ones) is also necessary.

Devotee: I would like to ask some questions.

Mother: That which is made known will not become knowledge. Then what can Mother make you know?

Devotee: With what attitude should I visualize God?

Mother: It can be imagined that “I am God’s child.” God’s existence will also become more convincing when one’s resolve becomes stronger and stronger.

Devotee: The scriptures say that God alone is Truth, so whatever I see is not Truth. How then should one live in this world?

Mother: Live a detached life. Don’t attach yourself to work or to its fruit. Perform it as a sacrifice. Then your actions will become beautiful and beneficial to others.

Devotee: I am worshipping God in an image. While traveling, I am not able to continue doing it. Is there any harm because of this?

Mother: Harm may occur if you feel worried and think that the worship has been discontinued, whereas the worship will not be broken if the Beloved Deity is carried in your heart and worshipped mentally when you go out. Not only that, *manasa puja* (mental worship) is the greatest. Those who are unable to do that should worship with flowers.

Devotee: When will I be liberated from this cycle of birth and death?

Mother: To get liberated, the thought ‘I’ should be eliminated. This present body is the result of *sanchita karma* (accumulated actions) performed in previous births. The human body is something higher than other bodies. God-Realization can be attained by doing *sadhana* with this body. It is due to the acquired merit in previous births that one feels interested in searching for God in this birth. Your desire will be fulfilled in this birth itself if your resolve and effort is continued in the same way. The tendency to enjoy sensual pleasures should completely leave the mind.

Do not become a slave to circumstances

As the conversation continued, another devotee came to see the Holy Mother. He was a newcomer. Having prostrated before the Mother, he also sat with the other devotees. When he got a chance to clear some of his doubts he asked:

Devotee: Mother, for a long time I have been wanting to come see you. I could come only today. There is a time and circumstance for all these things, isn’t there?

Mother: Son, time is always favorable, but we are not favoring time, that is all. Both favor and adversity are within us only. Not knowing this, human beings become slaves to

their circumstances. Many good things will pass through your hands if you sit saying, "Let a good time come." Do not wait looking for a good time to do something. Do it immediately if it is good.

Devotee: It is said that God dwells within. Why is it then that nobody knows Him?

Mother: Ordinary people think they are the body and so as a result become attached to wife, child, etc. and do wrong actions. While drowning in ignorance like this, how can they know God who is dwelling in their hearts? God not only dwells in the heart, He is all-pervasive as well. The only thing is, we should try to know Him. Do not make the mind extroverted, make it turn Godward.

Devotee: Of all the various kinds of fears such as fear of enemies, of poverty, of starvation or other calamities, the most terrifying is the fear of death. How can it be conquered?

Mother: Fear of death will be removed when we become convinced that "I am deathless," won't it? We should understand the truth that "I am the Self. I am Brahman. I am deathless."

The glory of the Guru

Devotee: How can that be understood?

Mother: A Guru who is established in that knowledge should be approached. It is impossible without a Guru. Suppose we are going to travel to a strange place. We would want somebody who knows the path to protect us. *Satsang* is the easiest path. A scholar who has scriptural knowledge is not sufficient. Only a Guru who is a knower of the Self will be able to help. Only one who has known the path can show the way to others.

19 September 1976

The Holy Mother was lying in the front yard of the old temple gazing at the beautiful rising sun. Perhaps her mind soared to the heights of supreme bliss causing a semi-conscious mood. As she got up and walked into the shrine her steps were faltering like one intoxicated. Entering the temple, Mother started singing loudly calling out, “Amma... Amma!” now and then. After a couple of minutes, the Mother abruptly stopped singing and, placing her head on the *peetham* (the seat she sat on for the *Devi Bhava*), started chanting *OM*. She became totally lost to this world and eventually she began rolling from side to side on the ground.

One hour passed like this, then suddenly she got up and began dancing blissfully holding the image of Lord Krishna on her head. Replacing the image in its original spot, the Holy Mother, in the same blissful mood, emerged from the temple. It was then that she noticed the milk brought for her by a devotee had been spilled by the crows. The Mother sat on the floor and drank some of the milk by scooping it from the floor with her cupped hands. Thus the Mother fulfilled the wish of the devotee who had brought the milk for her. The next moment, the Mother joined the children who were playing games in the front yard of the temple. Now she looked exactly like a small mischievous child sporting with her playmates.

Although seemingly contradictory, these actions of the Mother were full of significance in the eyes of spiritually elevated people. Such childlike sports of the Holy Mother gave delight to the eyes of the devotees.

While the Holy Mother was playing with the children, some devotees came to see her. Having stopped her play, she approached the devotees benignly smiling at them. Now her mood again changed from that of a child to a compas-

sionate mother. Followed by the devotees, Mother went to the temple verandah and sat there with them. She lovingly asked, “Children, did you eat anything?” They replied, “Yes, we ate our lunch, Mother.” Mother inquired, “From where?” “From the shop,” they replied. Mother smiled as the devotees sat looking at her wondering at her compassion and love. They had many things to ask. It was often the experience of the devotees and aspirants who came to see the Mother that the Masterhood in her would be invoked by one’s thirst for knowledge. During such occasions one could see the unending flow of the Mother’s profound wisdom streaming forth in all its beauty.

True Knowledge

Devotee: Isn’t it disappointing to see *bheda buddhi* (differentiating mind) even in famous *sannyasins* (monks)?

Mother: Children, true knowledge cannot be gained by merely studying the scriptures. *Bheda buddhi* will be there as long as there is no Self-knowledge. Scriptural knowledge is external, whereas knowledge of the Self is internal experience. *Bheda buddhi* will not be seen in one whose mind has merged in God. Scholars will speak about renunciation, but they cannot withdraw their minds from sensual objects. A real Master is a knower of the Self. Such beings should work with people giving guidance to them.

Monks and renunciation

Devotee: Shouldn’t a monk keep away from the world? Once he has renounced the world, can he engage in material affairs again?

Mother: *Sannyasa* (formal renunciation, becoming a monk) is not renouncing the world and action. It is renunciation of the fruits of his actions (*tyaga*) that the *sannyasin* com-

mits to. It is the *dharma* of the *sannyasins* to lead the world. *Sannyasins* are the ones who give peace to the world. Whoever may protest, there will always be a group of Knowers of the Self in this world. Even today there are people who can sanctify the world by mere *sankalpa* (resolve). Not everyone will know about them. There are also many institutions which sincerely work for world peace.

Devotee: Can awareness of the Truth be gained through institutions?

Mother: What is meant by an institution is not an institution like a factory or a bank, but a charitable institution. Many people could be working for each charitable institution. Several such institutions should be formed, that is what Mother wants to say. If at least ten people take to the righteous path through each institution, in at least one of them, awareness of the Truth might awaken. They in turn will protect many others.

Devotee: In this way, how many years would it take for the entire human race to be turned into knowers of the Self? Would such a thing be possible?

Mother: It is not God's resolve for this to happen. Everything must exist in the Creation. Otherwise, how could the *leela*⁸ go on?

You see, it is not Mother's intention to keep these children inside the four walls of the Ashram forever. Tomorrow they have to go out and do good works in the world. Even though the world may not know the value of this now, in the future it will be known. Until then, the protests and abuses should be accepted happily.

Listening and getting absorbed in the ambrosial words and presence of the Holy Mother, the devotees were quite unaware of the passing of time. It was now one o'clock in

⁸The play of God.

the afternoon, yet no one wanted to get up and eat lunch. Hunger and thirst disappear in the presence of a great Master. Just then some more devotees arrived. The Holy Mother was cheerful and compassionate as ever.

Question: Mother, I always want to come and see you, but it is so difficult to find the time to do so.

Mother: (smiling) All those who come here say that there is no time. Then for whom is all this time? Each day some time should be set aside for spiritual development.

Devotee: We are doing spiritual practices as instructed by Mother. Our children are also doing *japa* and *dhyana*.⁹

Mother: Good. In the future they will not swerve from the path because they have begun doing this at such a young age.

Another devotee: (Pointing to his son) It is a school holiday. He came and told me that he wants to stay here for two or three days. I agreed.

Mother: Then let both the children stay. (Smiling) Here I will play with the children. In the middle of the game I will play tricks on them. Because they are afraid of me, the children will go along with all this.

Devotee: Mother, during meditation I get headaches. Why is this happening?

Mother: This can happen if meditation is not practiced at the correct time. A regular discipline is needed. Headaches may also occur if you focus your mind between the eyebrows during meditation. If headaches start, stop meditating for two days and switch to *japa* and *kirtana*.¹⁰ If the headaches return when you resume meditation, then, while meditating, focus your mind on the heart. Then there will be no problem.

⁹Repetition of a mantra and meditation.

¹⁰Repetition of a mantra and the singing of God's Names.

Question: Mother, how can we think of God with our limited intellect?

Mother: It is possible if the limited intellect of the individual is expanded. The intellect should be fixed on the attitude that “I am the Self” while giving up the attitude “I am the body.”

Devotee: Is that possible for ordinary people?

Mother: Anyone can do this if they really have the desire. The only thing is that they have to do *sadhana* (spiritual practice). They must understand the Cause which stands behind the perceptible non-eternal objects. The goal of human effort is to know that Divine Power which illumines even the sun, moon and stars.

Brahman and jagat **Absolute Consciousness and the world**

Question: Mother, it is said that *Brahman* and *jagat* are one. How can that be?

Mother: Just as every object that exists has a name, the world exists in *Brahman*. Name and form are inseparable. When there is the awareness of the world, there is no awareness of the Self. When there is awareness of the Self, there is no awareness of the world. There is butter in milk, but it is not seen. When butter is obtained through churning, it forms a ball. If heated, it melts and the shape changes. In the same manner, *Brahman* is not seen in diversity. It can be found when *sadhana* is performed. When butter is heated, there is no form, but when frozen it solidifies. God’s form and formlessness are like this. No dross nor waste in either.

Question: The scriptures say that we are not the body but the Self. If one believes this, is it necessary to trouble oneself with *sadhana*?

Mother: This is simply a belief that is obtained through telling, hearing and reading, isn't it? It will not last long. Whereas the faith gained from experience will last forever. Suppose a person was traveling with his son. They felt very hungry and thirsty. Then, pointing out the rice paddy plants on the roadside, the father started saying, "Look, this is a paddy plant. After some time there will be grain. If the paddy is husked, you will have rice. If we mix the rice flour, coconut and molasses, we can make a good dish and our hunger will go away if we eat it. But our hunger will not be removed with this knowledge. You must prepare and eat the food to remove hunger." Scriptures tell about *Atman* (Self), but what is the use if we do not experience *Atman*? What guarantee is there that we will get the time later when we think, "I will try for that"? Therefore, without wasting time, start the effort immediately.

Jivatman and Paramatman **Individual self and Supreme Self**

Question: Mother, are *jivatman* and *Paramatman* two?

Mother: In the phenomenal world (*vyavahara*) there are two. When *samsara* (the ocean of transmigration) is given up, there is only one. Suppose there is a dam in the middle of a lake. As long as the dam is there, the lake is in two parts; if the dam is removed, there is one lake. The dam is ignorance or *maya*. If that is removed, there is non-dual Knowledge. Duality only seems to be real. In truth, everything is strung together on one strand – the thread of *Atman*. The perception of duality happens when we are established in the pride of body-consciousness. Like air and movement, or fire and the power of burning, *Paramatman* and *jivatman* are one and the same. This perception of Unity is *Jñana* (spiritual knowledge or wisdom). Perception of plurality is

ajñāna (spiritual ignorance). Those possessed of a one-pointed mind understand that it is the same witness-consciousness within everything. Ordinary people do not know. A powerful one knows the unity of *jivatman* and *Paramatman*. He has no fear, no afflictions. *Jagat* (the world) is only appearance. God is beyond the world. The goal is to reach the non-dual State, abandoning all appearances born of plurality.

Evolution of the individual self

Devotee: Where is the evolution of the *jiva* (individual soul) leading?

Mother: Its journey is to attain something great. Searching and roaming about the whole world, one becomes dissatisfied. One begins to think of a way to gain satisfaction. All thoughts and doubts arise from the mind. Then one looks to see whether peace can be gained from within the mind. From then onwards the mind begins to become introverted. The inquiry continues. During this time obstacles will occur. Then we approach a *Satguru* (a Self-Realized Master). Again we move forward. At last the goal is reached. Such souls will later come forward to protect the world.

Devotee: Mother, will there be body-consciousness even after attaining Knowledge?

Mother: A *Jñani* (a Knower of the Self) is in constant awareness of the Self. He knows that the body is not real. Descending a little from the highest plane, the *Jñani* acts for the protection of the world. He can give up the body whenever it is necessary. After going to your village and telling news about the Ashram to many people, you can return at any time. Like this, a *Jñani* will do many things while he is in the world, and he will be standing in the awareness of Truth at all times. A *Jñani* has no body-consciousness. He has

only awareness of the Self. But others will feel that he has a body.

All of a sudden the Holy Mother closed her eyes and sat motionless, her face lit with a blissful smile. All the devotees who were gathered around her began meditating. A couple of minutes passed and when Mother slowly opened her eyes she began rapturously singing.

*By which Power this world has been created,
By which Power it is sustained,
By which Power it returns to the unmanifest,
Let us offer our salutations to that Great Power...*

Everyone joined her and went into an ecstatic mood. The Holy Mother shed tears of bliss, now and then calling out, “Amma, Amma” while continuing the singing. Her poignant song and elevated spiritual mood seemed to fill the devotees’ hearts with tremendous peace and tranquillity. Forgetting the world around them, they sang with great devotion.

The signs of Self-Realization

One of the resident *brahmacharins* (celibate student) had a doubt as to whether the Mother was a Realized Soul, but he was hesitant to open his heart to her. One day while talking to some of the residents, Mother turned to the *brahmacharin* who had this doubt and said, “A Self-Realized Soul is one who sees the Fundamental Principle in everything without even an iota of doubt. In him there is no place for the argument, ‘There is or there is not.’ He has the constant vision of the Truth alone, everywhere, in the front, back, above and below. In him there is no feeling of the existence of the apparent world. In the plane of Real Awareness there is no place for the world. The world merges

in the essence (*Satta*). Both within and without is the same Consciousness. It is beyond even the intellect. Only such a person can work for the protection of the world. Renunciation, feeling of equality, humility and simplicity are the trademarks of such a person.

The resident who was listening to the Mother's words with great wonder shed tears thinking of the compassion that she had shown him.

The way a Satguru disciplines

One of the residents was telling Mother things which made him sad.

Devotee: In the beginning, Mother showed great affection to me, telling stories and feeding me with her own hand. But now there is nothing. Now the only thing she says is to study the scriptures and do my *sadhana*.

Mother: (affectionately) In those days you needed so much attention. Now this is what is needed. Fathers build play-houses with leaves and boughs of a palm tree for their young children. In those days you could not understand spiritual principles. Therefore more external love was shown. Now Mother keeps that love within. What you need now is serious spiritual training. It isn't that Mother has any less love for her children.

Mother looked most lovingly at him and his face lost the sadness from which he had been suffering. A while later, a group of youths arrived. From their appearance it was clear that they were college students. They stood at a little distance. She smiled benignly at them and asked where they had come from. Perhaps it was the Mother's natural way of inquiring that made the students come closer to her. As they approached, she asked them to sit down. After they sat down, a few moments passed while the Holy Mother

sat silently in front of them radiating compassion and love. One of the students broke the silence asking:

Question: Is there a God?

Mother: Why doubt? What is, is only God.

Question: Then why isn't He seen?

Mother: What is all this that is seen? What we see in different forms is God alone.

Question: Then why don't I feel like that? What should be done to develop that feeling? Can it be said that everything of this diverse Nature is God?

Mother: Why not? Could there be diversity in God because you see Him as diverse? Diversity is felt because of the difference of each one's vision. Otherwise there is no difference in God. God's real nature will be understood when the attitude of difference in us is removed. What is the difficulty in perceiving unity in diversity? We have hands, legs, eyes, nose, etc., but aren't these different organs part of our own body? The limbs are not different from the body, are they? Like this, see everything that is seen as His limbs. The sun gets concealed by the clouds. In a like manner, God is concealed by the *vasanas*. He becomes visible when the dirt of latent tendencies is removed.

Question: How shall I do that, Mother?

Mother: The *vasanas* should be gotten rid of through *sadhana*. We are not the body; there is Truth within. That is what should be known. If we inquire outside, we won't get That. There is another thing; just as He is within, He is there without also. But searching for God outside is like trying to catch fish by emptying the ocean. Therefore, become introverted. When God is seen within, then He can be seen everywhere. The mind should be purified by getting rid of bad thoughts. God will shine in a pure mind.

Merits and demerits, prarabdha

Question: Mother, what is *punya* and *papa*?¹¹

Mother: The result of auspicious action is called *punya* and the fruit of inauspicious action is known as *papa*. Action which brings evil (*dosha*) to oneself and others is inauspicious, and that which brings prosperity and goodness is auspicious. *Punya* and *papa* can be transcended if *vasanas* are exhausted. For that the mind should be cleansed through *sadhana*.

The Atman is not affected by merits and demerits, happiness and sorrow. These affect only the mind. The *Atman* is merely a witness to everything.

Question: Mother, what is this *prarabdha karma*?¹²

Mother: Children, *prarabdha karmas* are those *vasanas* which exist in the mind (*chitta*) in a subtle form. The *prarabdha* will exist until knowledge of the Self is gained. We will have *prarabdha* as long as we have body-consciousness. The body does not have to perish. If awareness of the body is overcome, *prarabdha* will be finished. *Prarabdha* is related to the body. It will fall off when the knowledge that “I am not the body, I am the Self” is gained.

There is no birth or death for a *Jñani*. Everything is only seemingly apparent for him. For him there is nothing different from *Brahman*. The body will exist for some more time even after one becomes a Knower of the Self. The feeling that there is a body is for others. As far as a *Jñani* is concerned, what is called a body is also *Brahman*. There are people who live peacefully even in the midst of all this confusion. Nobody is bound by this *samsara* once an iota of the principle of Stillness is experienced.

Question: Mother, what is *tyaga*?

¹¹Merit and demerit.

¹²The results of the actions done in previous births.

Mother: *Tyaga* is abandoning all desire for the fruit of one's actions. He is liberated who is desireless. The desire arising from the feeling "I" and "mine" causes bondage.

Question: Since there is only one God, isn't one path enough? What are all these different methods of *sadhana* for?

Mother: Different means can be chosen for traveling. Travel can be done by water, air, or land, but the destination will be the same.

Question: Where is the best place to focus the mind when practicing *rupa dhyana*?¹³

Mother: Meditation in the heart is the best.

Question: Mother, when does the thought of God arise in a person?

Mother: The thought of God will arise all of a sudden due to the accumulated merits from one's past births. Then, if that thought is properly nourished, we can make progress. Otherwise, we will fall again into inauspiciousness. If *sadhana* can be started from a very young age, that is the best.

Question: Why are most people not interested in spiritual matters?

Mother: Due to the lack of accumulated merits from previous births (*purva janmas*), the desire for sense objects will be more predominant.

Time needed for God-Realization

Some householders who were serious spiritual practitioners came to see the Holy Mother. They sat among the other devotees and listened keenly to the topic which she was discussing. One of them asked:

Devotee: "Mother, I am a householder. All my time has been wasted. The *brahmacharins* who stay here with Mother

¹³Meditation on God as having a form

started doing *sadhana* at a very young age. Is it possible for me to reach the goal even if I start now?"

Mother: Why not? The mind should be firm. Not much time is needed for God-Realization. When a person feels the interest, then and there he can start the effort. If the effort is sincere, the beneficial effects will come faster.

Question: Is it possible for ordinary people to know God?

Mother: Children, God is also ordinary and therefore not difficult to know. But we should remember one thing. The ignorant ones who are drowning themselves in worldliness cannot know the Truth. Whoever it may be, he who has sincere interest can know and see God.

That which is needed first

Question: Once a person becomes interested in spirituality, what should he do first?

Mother: He should first approach a real Master. Then he should perform *sadhana* as instructed by that Master. He should take refuge only in a *Satguru*, with total faith and devotion to the Guru.

Question: How to search for and find such a person?

Mother: The Guru will come to one who has an intense desire to know the Truth. That omniscient Guru will gradually take the disciple to the goal. The *Satguru* is one who is capable of taking the disciple to the goal.

Question: Mother, I have saved a lot of money, but I have no happiness. What is the way to peace and happiness?

Mother: Not everyone has such good thoughts. These thoughts arise because of the merit of the good actions done in previous births. You cannot gain happiness if you go after sense objects. No one will wait for anyone in this world. Each one runs after his own happiness. God is of the nature of bliss and we can only live happily if we live in God. Faith is needed

for that. The thought that “I am the doer” must be eliminated. Remember that God is the doer. The mind should be always fixed in God. *Satsang*¹⁴ is necessary. *Sadhana* should be performed as instructed by the Guru. Meditation should be practiced. In the beginning stages, try to meditate for a short time. Later, it will be possible to meditate for more time. Always remember the Lord’s Name and avoid wasting time associating with friends.

Devotee: Mother, you should guide us.

Mother: Shiva! Shiva! This crazy one? God will do all that.

The Holy Mother was talking with some of the residents sitting in the front yard of the temple. It was eleven o’clock in the morning.

Brahmacharin: Mother, how does one gain bliss?

Mother: Children, everything depends on the mind. Through *chanting, japa, meditation*, etc. the mind will improve and become pure and one-pointed.

Another brahmacharin: Mother, what is fate?

Mother: There are some who take God’s Will to be fate. There are people who think that fate is unchangeable. This is not correct. We perform actions according to our *vasanas*, the result of which will eventually come to us. The fruits of the actions performed in our previous births are known as our fate. Fate can be changed and transformed through self-effort, especially through sincere prayer and meditation.

Question: Mother, there are so many religions. Which one is the best?

Mother: All religions which help people to realize God are good. If the path is not helpful for Self-Realization, then it cannot be accepted nor considered religion. Religion is that which helps Self-Realization occur. (Turning to the

¹⁴Association with the holy.

brahmacharins) You children are very lucky. You want to relinquish *samsara* at such a young age. This is not the result of one lifetime worth of merit. This is the merit from many lifetimes. Also, we might have met before. Otherwise we would not be together like this. Some of those who come here seem very familiar. It is impossible to get separated once we have met. Many of you do not think about the opposition and difficulties raised by your families. You do not even feel like going home.

It was six o'clock in the evening and the sun setting on the western horizon, as if dropping into the Arabian Sea, created a restful and gentle mood. The waves seemed to sing the vibrant sound *OM*. The Holy Mother, accompanied by the residents and devotees, began singing devotional songs while sitting on the front verandah of the temple. Mother slowly became more and more absorbed in the singing.

*O Thou Who art meditated upon
In thousands of hearts,
Thou blazest forth forever in the minds
of those Who have realized God...*

As the Mother sang these lines, she became overwhelmed with bliss and merged in a state of divine inebriation. Crying like a small child, she called out, "Amma, Amma!" and then laughed ecstatically. Her mood lasted for a long time. The residents and devotees were also filled with bliss as they continued singing, drinking in the nectar of the Divine Name. After some time, the Holy Mother got up from her seat and came to the front yard of the temple. She began a rapturous dance punctuated with blissful laughter. Some of the *brahmacharins* who were watching shed tears of joy. Others sat quietly and went into deep meditation.

After a while Mother's father arrived, caught her, and made her lie down on a mat thinking that something very

serious had happened to his daughter. But the Holy Mother was still in another world. Her hands formed a *mudra*¹⁵ and her face was radiant like the rising sun. When she finally came down to the normal plane of consciousness, one of the devotees said, “We were concerned that Mother would have danced on and on if Sugunanandan had not caught hold of her.”

Mother: He should not have done that. It was not good. It is unbearable if someone even touches this body on such occasions. Now this whole body feels like it is burning. In the future, be attentive and don’t let anyone touch this body.

Without saying anything more about it, Mother got up and walked away. It was almost eleven o’clock at night. Some of the *brahmacharins* went to meditate at the seashore and some inside the temple. The rest went to bed.

1 September 1977

Prapancha¹⁶ and Vedanta

A devotee from Quilon was asking the Holy Mother questions. When the Mother began to answer him, other devotees and a few residents came and listened carefully to the conversation. It was ten o’clock in the morning and the atmosphere was quiet and peaceful as the dialogue began.

Devotee: *Vedanta* (philosophy of non-dualism) says that the world is an illusion. If that is so, then what is the relevance of worldly life?

Mother: Son, *Vedanta* does not deny the material plane. It is just that *Vedanta* views the world in a slightly different way from the ordinary outlook. That is all. *Vedanta* says

¹⁵A symbolic gesture of the hands.

¹⁶The world.

that all that is seen is not as we think, but it is *Brahman* alone. The great *Vedantin*, Sankaracharya, worked so hard to uplift the world because he recognized the existence of the world. Look at the life of Vivekananda, who was a *Vedantin*. *Vedanta* is only saying that we should imbibe the correct awareness and remove the wrong understanding that we have about ourselves and the world. If we don't have the correct awareness, it is difficult to reach the goal.

In the beginning, the Guru will tell the disciple: "The world is an illusion. Reject it and become established in the Self." This is to speed up the *sadhana*. But at last, when the disciple reaches Realization, he will understand that this whole world is part of God. Then there will be nothing to reject. The world will be there for him to love and serve. This state is not hypothetical, but derived from experience.

Vedanta and image worship

Question: Mother, doesn't *Vedanta* speak against image worship?

Mother: No, *Vedanta* doesn't deny anything. Son, every person has an appropriate path for making the mind concentrated on the Self. Didn't Sankaracharya renovate temples, install images and compose poetry about gods and goddesses? Even so, don't get entangled in image worship forever. At a certain stage of *sadhana*, you will reach the Formless State where all images and forms merge and disappear. Even if one or two people might understand that the world is an illusion, to others the world will still seem to be real. Scriptures and paths are to uplift those who are wandering in ignorance. They are not meant for those who already know the Truth and have attained the Goal.

Question: Can a devotee become a *Vedantin*?

Mother: *Parabhakti* (supreme devotion) is pure *Vedanta*. A true devotee sees everything as pervaded by God. He does

not see anything except God. A devotee says, “Everything is pervaded by God.” A *Vedantin* says, “Everything is pervaded by *Brahman*.” Both are one and the same.

Question: Who is the real “I”? When will I become aware that everything I see is the real “I”?

Mother: That “I” which fills the whole universe is the real “I”. When the awareness that “I am not the body, I am the Self” awakens, we will understand that nothing is different from *Brahman*. At that time, we will know through experience that everything is “I” alone.

Question: Mother, if everything is happening according to God’s Will, there is not much place for our effort. Is it possible to prevent God’s Will?

Mother: If you have that much conviction, can’t you request Him to alter your fate? One who judges can also take back the judgment. Can’t you just try and see?

If you accept the unwanted and reject what you need, there is no point in blaming fate. Pride will not allow some people to search for God while desire for sensual pleasures will not let go of others. Some can’t find the time to make an effort. What is the result? Sorrow.

Everyone sat silently gazing at the Holy Mother’s radiant face with wonder and amazement.

Pranayama Breath control

After a few moments had passed, another devotee asked “Mother, will *pranayama* help me to attain *Atma Jñana* (Knowledge of the Self)?”

Mother: The mind will gain concentration through *pranayama*. Then it will be possible to fix the one-pointed mind on the *Atman*. The mind, when fixed on the Self, becomes liberated from *samsara*.

Question: Mother, why do so many come here for worldly purposes?

Mother: Not everybody comes to spirituality at the same time. If they did, then one Sankaracharya or one Sri Ramakrishna would have been enough. Different people approach the road to Liberation at different times according to their *samskaras*.¹⁷

What is bondage?

Devotee: Because Mother has entrapped me in my family, I cannot come here very often.

Mother: This is what all the children are saying. After gluing themselves to sense objects, they complain that God has bound them. God will hear everything, but will keep quiet.

Devotee: Then I am not going away from here anymore. Let Him look after all the necessities.

Mother: That is good! But once you have eaten all the *dal*¹⁸ and buttermilk we serve here, then we won't see you anymore! (All burst into laughter) It seems that until now you have been thinking that you are taking care of the household and that God has bound you to stay and do that. That is not the case. It is God alone who has been looking out for you and your household all this time. Son, bondage is nothing but the feeling "I am doing."

Another devotee mockingly said to him, "Only watery *dal* is available here. When you are at home you can have thick dal and *pachari*."¹⁹ (All laugh)

Mother: None of you should mock him. This son simply proceeds with caution.

That devotee, who was thoroughly convinced that Mother understood he was living as a *sadhaka* in his daily life, turned

¹⁷ Inherited tendencies.

¹⁸ Lentils.

¹⁹ A costly variety of rice.

to the others and said, “Mother sees each movement of mine. That is why she said that I am moving cautiously.”

Question: Mother, I don’t have any peace of mind these days.

Mother: Son, can’t you decrease a few of your outside activities? Practice meditation for a few days in solitude. Otherwise, the strain on your mind will worsen.

13 September 1977

What is freedom?

In the afternoon, a group, including a scholar, came to see the Holy Mother. She was sitting in the old temple. Two elderly women devotees from the neighborhood were trying to make Mother eat, but like an innocent and stubborn child she refused to eat regardless of their pleading. Every time they offered her something, Mother would begin playing and divert their attention from the food to herself. The devotees watched the heart-warming sight from a distance. After some time the Holy Mother saw them, and with childlike innocence she said, “Look, these mothers are trying to feed me, but I am not hungry!” One of the women said, “Amma has not eaten anything except some coconut water for the last three days. Please tell her to eat something.”

Finally, due to their persistence, Mother ate one ball of rice. Then she ran away like a child running from its mother while the elderly ladies stood helplessly holding the plate of rice. The devotees followed Mother to the front of the temple and sat near her after offering their prostrations. A few moments passed and her *bala bhava* (childlike mood) slowly disappeared. She closed her eyes and sat motionless as the devotees gazed at her face with wonder and rever-

ence. A couple of minutes passed in silence before the Mother opened her eyes. Withdrawing all other aspects within, she looked like a great Master. No one would have thought that this was the same person who, like a child, had been making merry only a few moments before. The visiting scholar at last began the conversation by pleading, "Mother, there are certain things we would like to know."

Mother: Shiva! Shiva! From this crazy girl?! She knows only one thing and that is that she does not know anything.

The devotees however asked their questions one by one.

Devotee: Mother, what is meant by freedom?

Mother: Real freedom means freedom from worldly existence, freedom from the cycle of birth and death. Total surrender to God is the easiest way. Either imagine "I am *Brahman*, I am everything," or think "I am nothing, I am God's child, His servant."

Devotee: What can I do to purify my mind?

Mother: Mental purity will come through constantly chanting the Divine Name. This is the simplest way. Not everyone has faith in chanting. Belief and disbelief are big problems. Even this world is the result of disbelief. Then how can disbelief be completely eliminated? Disbelief will leave only when our belief becomes firm. Once we have full faith, inquiry is not needed. Inquiry ends in faith. The faith that you children have now is not full. Try to gain perfect faith. Full faith means Realization.

The grace of love

Scholar: It seems as if Mother has practiced and mastered *yoga* and other disciplines.

Mother: Shiva, Shiva! I have not practiced anything. It seems that way, because love is so very natural to me. Love constantly flows from me to all of creation.

Scholar: How many people can love everyone equally like this?

Mother: Do not worry about the number of people who are able to love. Those who can receive love are also important. Their lives are indeed Blessed.

Mother's knowledge and the purpose of her birth

Scholar: What are Mother's future programs?

Mother: *Bhagavan* (the Lord) will look after all those things.

Scholar: Mother, were you born with supreme knowledge.

Mother: After coming here I returned that knowledge to Him. Who could keep all that knowledge? It will sit safely there in the hands of God, won't it? When we need it, he will hand it over to us, little by little.

Scholar: I have traveled a great deal, but I have not gained peace of mind anywhere. Mother, please help me.

Mother smiled and then all of a sudden entered into deep *samadhi*. Her body became stiff like a log of wood. Everyone silently watched her. Regaining partial consciousness, she requested the scholar to sing a song.

*O Lord, if the blue mountain is ink,
The ocean the inkstand,
The branch of the Heavenly Tree the pen,
The earth the writing leaf,
And using these, if the Goddess of Learning
Writes for eternity,
Even then, the limit of Thy virtues
Will not be reached...*

He sang with great devotion as the others sat in deep meditation. When the song was over Mother uttered "Shiva!

Shiva!” One of the devotees asked, “Mother, what should be done to quiet the mind?”

Mother: *Japa, dhyana* and similar *sadhanas* should be practiced.

Devotee: How long will it take to reach the goal?

Mother: That depends upon each person’s inner disposition.

Devotee: Mother, may I have your gracious look always with me?

Mother: Certainly. Those of you who truly desire freedom will be especially taken care of. This life (pointing to herself) is for that purpose.

Mother rarely spoke so directly. Rarely would she let people know that she had been born with full awareness and for such a purpose.

14 September 1977

A man from Trivandrum, a doctor and ardent devotee of Lord Krishna, came and prostrated before the Holy Mother. Mother smilingly asked him, “Son, where are you coming from?”

Doctor: Do you know me, Mother? You speak to me so sweetly; as if speaking to your own son after a long absence.

Mother: Do you think you would come here if we had not been acquainted in the past? Many people are very familiar to me. Between lifetimes the memory sits dormant, then finally, some people are able to remember.

Doctor: When I was in *Guruvayoor*²⁰ a man told me about Mother, and said that she is the embodiment of love.

Mother: Mother knows only love. (Looking at the book which the doctor was holding) What book is that, son?

²⁰A famous Krishna temple in Kerala, India.

Doctor: The *Bhagavad Gita*. In Mother I see all the characteristics of a *Jivanmukta* (Liberated Soul), just as Lord Sri Krishna described to Arjuna.

Mother: (Like a small child) What does it say in there?

Doctor: Did Mother ever read the *Gita*?

Mother: (Shaking her hands) Should I have read these things? No, it's not possible for me. Even if I manage to read it, after three or four lines, I lose control.

Doctor: What a fool I am! Why should Mother read books? Isn't Mother beyond all that? That is why people like me come here.

Mother: Never mind that. What is said in the *Gita*?

Doctor:

Ātmanyevātmanā tuṣṭaḥ sthita prajñasta dochyate

A man of wisdom is one who is content in
the Self by the self.

BHAGAVAD GITA, II, 55

Having heard these lines, the Mother became totally introverted. In a semi-conscious mood she chanted, "OM, OM" lifting her hands up in the air and shaking her head sideways. This continued for a couple of minutes. Then, slowly coming back to our plane of consciousness, she said,

"Always remember one thing. Studying the scriptures is good, but there should be no shortage of *bhakti* (devotion). You can read the books, but mere reading is not enough. Practice is also necessary. Mother cannot read or hear such books without her mind suddenly going to another world."

Doctor: But Mother comes back again.

Mother: It is enough if you learn to fix your mind on God just one time. After that, your mind will not leave God again.

Mantra diksha

The necessity of initiation

A few more devotees came and greeted the Mother.

A doctor: Is initiation necessary? Can't perfection be attained without that?

Mother: Partial perfection can be attained without initiation. In Kashmir, apples grow abundantly. Apple trees can grow in our village also, but they will not bear that much fruit. There will not be much flavor either. If grown here, they must be given much attention and care. Similarly, the Guru's presence provides the attention and care the devotees need for attaining the goal. If there is no Guru, one should be very careful. There is the possibility of falling. God's Presence cannot be felt without purity of heart.

The purpose of initiation is mental purity. Milk will spoil in a dirty vessel. First the vessel should be cleaned. Only then can milk be poured into it. Besides that, initiation will also help awaken the inner divine power. The *mantra*, having great power, enters the heart of the disciple from within the Guru, who is a knower of *Brahman*. Just as water is used for external cleanliness, internal purity is gained through initiation. When we blow on a spark of fire it ignites and becomes a great power.

There is a natural way of making yogurt by adding a little buttermilk to warm milk. If this is left sitting for a day, it will turn into yogurt. In a similar manner, initiation transmits a portion of the Guru's power to the disciple. It will enable the disciple to develop the power fully if he works on it sincerely and applies self-effort. Great power can also be created if *mantras* are chanted repeatedly.

Devotee: Is *mantra diksha* effective if it is given without the customary rites?

Mother: The Guru's initiation will always be fruitful. It is for the purpose of getting rid of the vacillation in the disciple's mind that initiation is given with all the customs and pomp. Without performance of customary rituals, the disciple might doubt the effectiveness of the *mantra*. If this happens, he will not do his spiritual practices properly. Not only that; if *acharas*²¹ are transgressed, their sanctity might be gradually lost.

Another devotee: Mother, I am a devotee of Devi. Having seen my enthusiasm, a *sannyasin* told me, "Child, there is no doubt that you will gain a perfect teacher without delay." Shortly after the *swami* said this, I met Mother.

Mother: Everything is God's Will. His grace is always with His devotees. That Embodiment of Compassion is constantly gazing at us. How can we possibly repay His mercy?

Devotee: Is God's grace and Guru's grace the same?

Mother: Yes. What is received through Guru's grace is God's grace.

Devotee: Mother, when will we be liberated?

Mother: Children, when you unload the burdens from your mind, that is when you will become liberated. It is not enough to simply say you have turned it over. It must be totally surrendered to God. Then you should continue happily doing what He makes you do.

Devotee: It is said that only pure foods should be eaten. How is that possible?

Mother: Before taking food, it should be offered to God. If poor people come, see them as God alone and give them part of the food. Then the food we eat will become pure.

As she was talking, the Mother's attention turned to the pictures of gods and goddesses hanging on the wall. Looking at the portrait of Lord Shiva, Mother said, "Oh... You?..."

²¹Customary observances.

Ancient One. Is it enough to sit like that? Who is going to be responsible for looking after all these people? I cannot be here very long.”

Devotee: Don’t talk like that, Mother! Who will take care of us if you go away?

Mother: Do not be sad, son. Mother was simply saying that. Is it possible to simply go away like that? Aren’t there certain things to be done?

Bhava darshan The Divine Mood

Devotee: Mother, are you always aware of your divine moods or are you only aware of them during *Devi* and *Krishna Bhava*?

Mother: It cannot be described that way. Different people’s faith is encouraged in different ways. Mother’s intention is that each person somehow grow closer to God. Some people only want to see *Devi* and *Krishna Bhavas*. Not only that; many know nothing about spirituality. Some people will start to understand spirituality because of these *Bhavas*. It is a little difficult for some people to believe what Mother tells them, but if the same thing is told during *Devi Bhava*, they will believe it.

A devotee who was sitting a little distance away asked, “Mother, why don’t you tell people the real reason for your coming?”

Mother: Shiva! Shiva! What shall Mother tell them? What does Mother know? Everything is *Devi*’s play. The trademarks of greatness are humility and simplicity. and the attitude that “I am nothing.” Everyone walks around trying to show off their abilities. The coconut feels, “Because of me, the dish was tasty.” The cook will say, “It was because of my skill that the dish was good.” The fire will say, “Because

of me the meal was nice.” The truth is that all ability is God’s alone.

Question: I would like to meditate sitting on the seashore. Is it all right to do this?

Mother: Certainly. That place is holy. You should sit there having prayed to the goddess of the ocean. After some time, you will not hear the roaring sound of the waves. You will only hear a slight *OM* sound. If you fix your mind on that, you will not feel like getting up. Very loud sounds and silence are equal. In both places, the mind will naturally become concentrated. *Om̐kara* (OM) can be heard on the seashore.

15 September 1977

The importance of traditional observances

The Holy Mother was sitting in front of the temple. One person was distributing Mother’s *prasada*²² to the other devotees. A little bit of *prasada* fell on the floor. Another devotee took it and threw it outside. Seeing this, Mother said, “What is that, son? Contempt for *prasada*? Lovers of God must not do that. *Prasada* never becomes impure, even if it falls on the ground. You can give it to birds or some animal if you cannot eat it.”

The devotee: Forgive me, Mother, I did not know I was making a mistake.

Mother: Don’t worry. It will be all right if you touch the place where it had fallen, while feeling an attitude of respect. All Godly actions should be done with devotion. Also, after we apply sacred sandalwood paste, the portion left on

²²A consecrated offering.

our hands should not be put on the ground. Instead, it should be wiped on a tree.

Devotee: Aren't these all external etiquettes? Who can observe all these rules? If they aren't observed, will *Brahman* be displeased?

Mother: *Acharas* should be observed as long as we live in the world. Even a person who has reached the Non-dual State and who need not be concerned with purity and impurity or do's and don'ts, should not ignore *acharas*, even though nothing affects those who have reached the goal. Whether or not we observe *achara*, *Brahman* has nothing to gain or lose. Anyway, ordinary people cannot advance without observing *achara*. For us to grow, *achara* is necessary. It will help us purify our minds. Remember too that *dharma* (righteousness) will decay if *achara* is not honored.

Another devotee: It is because of our merits accumulated in our previous birth that we could see Mother. Bless us, Mother.

Mother: All of you children came here because you have all been blessed by those who can bless. Hereafter, again it will happen.

Devotee: Mother, will I get God-Realization in this birth itself?

Mother: It is possible, if you try.

Another devotee: Here is God in front of us, isn't it so? What more then is needed? What else is Mother except an Incarnation of God?

Mother: Shiva! Shiva! What are you saying, son! Mother does not know about all this. Look, Mother is crying for God. Your birth will also be fulfilled if you call on God.

26 September 1977

Some other people who were very interested in spiritual matters had also come to see the Mother.

Question: Can the truth behind this world be known with our limited mind?

Mother: It is not possible to know the truth of the world if you sit thinking of limitations. The world can be perceived as the gross form of God. It is His Divine Play alone which is happening here. There is not a single place here which is not holy. Purity and impurity are our superimpositions.

Question: But what about all of the bad habits and customs (*anacharas*) we see around us today?

Mother: Do not judge a thing without knowing everything about it. The will of the Eternal God might be operating behind things which we consider to be *anachara*.

Devotee: I am convinced that Mother can save me. From now on I am not going anywhere else. Instead, I will come here frequently.

Mother: That is good. If all the items on the list are available from one shop, then you do not have to wander all around the marketplace. But you will still need money to buy the goods. In spiritual life, faith and dispassion are what is needed.. The means to Liberation can be bought with the money of dispassion in the vessel of *sraddha* (faith).

Tyaga and bhoga Renunciation and enjoyment

It was eight o'clock Sunday morning and already many devotees were sitting around the Mother. Some had a misconception that her highest spiritual moods were only during *Devi* and *Krishna Bhava* and that she was an ordi-

nary girl at other times. All of a sudden, Mother said (to no one in particular),

“Not everyone will understand if God’s actions are seen in individuals. Ordinary people will mistake it as something else. Otherwise, what a benefit they could receive by knowing God’s greatness! Such people, desiring that their household affairs should go smoothly, might go to temples and do worship or they may go and see some *Mahatmas*. Then they ask, ‘My son has to take the B.A. exam. Make him pass.’ Or they will say, ‘I have planned to purchase some land, but there are several obstacles. Make all those obstacles go away.’ How trivial they are!

“Those who have faith will not say such things to the *Mahatmas*. They will search for the path to Eternal Bliss. They will renounce anything for that. Some people relinquish everything for God. Some others accumulate everything for themselves. Those who accumulate will suffer. Those who give up will be joyful.”

Question: Is it possible to give up all wealth?

Mother: It is not necessary. But the mental attitude that wealth is ‘mine’ can be given up, can’t it? Do not be attached.

Question: Is it enough to think that my wealth is really God’s and that it is God-given?

Mother: More than enough. But not enough if it is only in so many words; it should be reflected in one’s actions also. What if we eat plenty and the neighboring families are starving? If the wealth which is in our hands is God’s, then why can’t we give some to the poor? If it is not given, that money will become the cause of troubles.

Ending the conversation at this point, the Holy Mother got up from the temple verandah and moving her right hand in the air and showing a divine gesture, she chanted “Shiva! Shiva!” Some of the devotees who had been listen-

ing to the Mother's conversation talked softly among themselves. One said, "See, Mother has understood all our doubts. The whole talk was intended for us only. Wasn't it you who said that Mother does not know anything when she is not in *Devi* or *Krishna Bhava*? Did you hear what Mother said just now? There is nothing that she does not know!"

Another devotee, who was an engineer, added, "Although I have been here several times, I never had a chance to talk to her, so I never understood her greatness." Another devotee had arrived just then and asked, "Did you talk with Mother?" "Yes, we did," replied the engineer. The latecomer, who had mistakenly believed references to Mother as a crazy girl except during the *Bhavas*, said, "Mother usually bursts out with some crazy talk." Understanding fully what the Mother had said, the other devotee replied, "What the Mother told us was not crazy. To tell you the truth, we are the ones who are crazy."

20 September 1977

A *sannyasin* had come to see the Holy Mother. Mother was in an abstracted mood and was walking around the temple. The *sannyasin* watched her closely without blinking his eyes or noticing anything else. She continued walking around the temple for a few more minutes. Then she stopped in front of the temple and her body slowly swayed from side to side. When she stopped in front of the temple, the *sannyasin* slowly approached her. The Holy Mother looked at him compassionately and inquired, "*Swami mon* (monk son)²³, where are you coming from? Have you had any food?"

²³Mother would often call some of her children by adding son or daughter to the name of their profession.

²⁴A famous temple dedicated to the formless aspect of the Supreme, unique in Kerala and perhaps in all of India.

Sannyasin: We heard about Mother when we came to the *Oachira* temple²⁴ and an urge arose in me to come and see you. Different people said different things about you. Finally, I decided to come and see you myself. Now it is clear that you are not as I heard.

Mother: There are two opinions for everything. One person is interested in one thing and another person in another thing. Not everyone will recognize everything. Out of jealousy some people will deny what seems obvious to others. All is His Will. Because of His Will, millions and millions of planets and stars exist in the sky.

Sannyasin: Isn't it because of gravity?

Mother: That gravity itself is God. What if gravity did not exist? There would be total disaster. Look at the order and harmony in Nature. Seeing and observing all this, wouldn't an intelligent person easily realize that there is someone or something which controls everything systematically? Look at the millions of living beings. God's greatness cannot be expressed. There are so many animals which live on the land, in the water and in the sky; some live both on land and in water. There are also people who live in God while being in *samsara* but they are very few.

Sannyasin: Nowadays even people with ochre clothes act like they don't need God.

Mother: That is not God's fault. Whoever calls, He will hear, especially if it is a selfless call. Compassionately, Bhagavan will give everything to His devotee.

Duality and non-duality

Sannyasin: All this will seem primitive to a non-dualist.

Mother: Does it seem like that? If so, primitiveness is in him. It is only by His grace that one gets the Non-dual Knowledge. Nobody can acquire Knowledge without Guru's grace and God's grace. Therefore, a real non-dualist will

not scorn this. For them, everything will be felt as different aspects of the same Truth. Those who walk the path of duality will ultimately reach Non-duality. The one seeker goes by himself and catches hold of God. Bhagavan catches hold of the other seeker and takes him closer to Himself. This is the only difference. Why scuffle with each other over this? Isn't it enough to reach the goal? One person travels by water, another by land. Both reach the same place.

Sannyasin: This is quite true. Various paths, one goal.

Two new visitors arrived and sat near Mother after offering their respects. Mother asked, "What are you doing, children?" One of them replied, "We have no jobs, Mother."

Mother: Devotion is needed. A job is also needed. The detached one does not need a job. Others do. Obstacles will crop up for *japa* and *dhyana* if one is starving. Food is important when there is hunger.

Devotee: I have no interest in anything. Just a kind of humdrum...

Mother: Disgusted with the world? Good, if it is a detachment from sensual pleasures. You do not have that much dispassion. For the time being, live doing some kind of worldly job with remembrance of God.

Devotee: But won't *vasanas* increase if we continue in the world?

Mother: This is not a problem if the work is performed while dedicating it to God. *Satsang* is also necessary now and then.

21 September 1977

To householders

Some householder devotees were sitting around the Holy Mother while she held a baby on her lap. She asked the

child's mother, "Will you give him to me?" The mother of the child replied, "Even now he is Mother's." Mother laughed and said, "It is enough if you give him to me when he grows up."

About that time more devotees arrived to see the Holy Mother. They offered fruits to Mother, then joined the other devotees. Looking at one of the women who had just arrived, Mother said, "Daughter, your husband has just been employed to drive a bus again, hasn't he?" Hearing these words of the Holy Mother, the woman fell at her feet crying, "O my Mother, O my Mother!" Her husband, who was a bus driver, had been without employment for many days. Just that morning he had been hired again as a driver. The devotee was astounded that Mother knew about it without being told. Overwhelmed with joy, she went on crying. Fondly patting the devotee's back, Mother said, "Do not be sad, children. God will look after everything." She turned to the householder devotees and said, "See, you householder children should always have Godly thoughts while living in this world."

An elderly man: Where is the time for householders to think about spiritual matters?

Mother: Sorrow alone is yours if you run here and there always thinking "my" house, "my" wealth and "my" children. Live your life surrendering everything to God. Protect your family and others thinking, "God has entrusted them to me." After all, how did this wealth and these children come to you? Where were your children when you came to this world? Now you say that they are all yours. When you die, who will they belong to? The property you own belonged to somebody else before. In the future it will be in somebody else's hands. There is nothing here that can be considered ours. Things change hands and come to us for a little time, that is all. Understanding all this, we should

live in the house taking refuge in God. Whatever work you may be doing, you can remember God, if you have the mind to do it.

It was now lunchtime. Calling all the devotees and residents, Mother went to the dining hall. When everyone was seated, the Holy Mother herself served food to them. While they were eating, she went to her hut saying, “Mother will be back soon; have your food children.” After lunch some devotees sat in solitude reading books while others discussed spiritual matters. Some simply sat alone in contemplation enjoying the solitude.

At three o’clock, Mother came to sit with the devotees again. She remarked, “Today is an auspicious day.” “Why is that?” a devotee asked. Mother replied, “All the children who came today are interested in spirituality. Mother is happy to see such people. Mother says some crazy things. They all say that they like it.”

Devotee: Again and again we come here because Mother says what is necessary for us to hear. Mother knows everything. Mother is just playing tricks when she says “Mother does not know anything. Mother is crazy.” It is not possible to tell us this anymore. We have begun to understand Mother’s tricks. (All laugh)

Devotee: People like Mother come to show us the path, don’t they? Mother, is it possible for us to get Liberation in this birth?

Mother: Do not say “for us.” There is no group Liberation. Liberation is attained in different births according to each one’s course of *karma*.

Devotee: All right, Mother. Do I have a chance to attain Liberation in this birth?

Mother: Very many chances. But you have to try.

Question: Everything is in God’s hands. Nothing can be done through mere strength of will.

Mother: Not so. Determination and effort endowed with enthusiasm are necessary. The result is according to *karma*. Nothing can be gained by the weak-minded. The ego should be destroyed. Otherwise Liberation is not possible. The ego can be removed through *bhakti* (devotion). With devotion, the attitude “I am God’s servant” will come. If not through devotion, the ego can also be removed through knowledge. Ho! How much devotion I used to have! Now, not that much is there. (All laugh) Once I asked the Divine Mother to show Her true devotees to me. Having said this, when I came from the temple, two real seekers were standing outside waiting for me. From then on, true devotees of the Mother started coming. The number of worldly people who came only to fulfill their worldly desires started declining.

One devotee said, “It was the same in Sri Ramakrishna’s life.” All of a sudden the Holy Mother, as if transported to another world, became oblivious of her external surroundings. Another devotee quietly said, “Whenever I come here I am reminded of Dakshineswara. There are not many who can fully appreciate being in the presence of a *Mahatma*.” A second man said, “Only those whom the *Mahatma* allows to know will know and come. How could anyone come here without having acquired merits in previous births!”

Mother got up from her seat and went to the backwaters and laid down under a coconut tree. It was now five o’clock in the evening. Two more devotees arrived to see the Holy Mother. After a few minutes, she got up from where she had been lying and came to greet them. When she began speaking, the others also joined them. A woman devotee brought a glass of tea and offered it to Mother. Mother said, “You should give it to Mother only after giving to all the children.” Saying this, Mother made the devotee put the glass down. Mother asked the newcomers, “Children, where are you coming from?” One man replied, “I am coming

from Chenganoor and he is from Tiruvalla.” Mother exclaimed like a small child, “I know where Chenganoor is, I have been there! Where is Tiruvalla? Is it in Quilon?” All laugh and one devotee replied, “No Mother, Quilon is south of Chenganoor. Tiruvalla is to the north.”

Mother: What does it matter wherever it is? Everybody comes here, then why should Mother ask “Where are you coming from? How many cows, jackfruit trees and so on and so forth?” (All laugh) Even then Mother will forget all this. One day I asked a *brahmacharin* son, “Are you returning from your house?” The *brahmacharin* asked, “Which house?” “Son’s house,” she replied. Then the *brahmacharin* said, “I don’t know where that is. If Mother can tell me where that is, I will go there. Once gone, I will not return.” When he said that, I understood what he meant; but even then I did not give up foolish talking. (Everyone burst into laughter)

Tea was brought for everyone. Someone cracked a joke. Mother said, “Children, do not laugh and crack jokes while eating.”

Life after death

Question: Mother, is there really life after death?

Mother: Yes. If this life is true, then life after death is also true. Because we are alive now, we were also alive before. Here after we will also live. When one dies, the *vasanas* will be stored with the subtle body. It is not possible to act according to the *vasanas* without a gross body though. Therefore the *jiva* enters a gross body suitable for it. The case of a liberated soul is different. They do not have to live in the same manner. There is no birth and death from the point of view of a *Jñani*. Therefore, they do not have life after death either.

Jñana and vijñana

Knowledge and experience

Devotee: Mother, if *jñana* is destruction of ignorance, then what is *vijñana* the destruction of?

Mother: (After laughing) It seems that you are going to go beyond death immediately. (All laugh)

Devotee: No Mother, I was just asking a question.

Mother: If *jñana* is the destruction of *ajñana*, it can be understood that *vijñana* is the destruction of *jñana*. If *jñana* is hearing and reading about Delhi, *vijñana* is like visiting Delhi. *Jñana* is intellectual knowledge, while *vijñana* is transcending the intellect, negating even the intellect as untrue, and affirming pure experience alone as the Supreme Truth. Don't you agree, children?

Devotee: Only Mother knows all this.

Mother: There was once a man who would go and sit in a big gathering of scholars. When the scholars discussed things, he would also stick his nose in without knowing the subject matter. He also had an opinion. The people teased him but he did not care. Eventually he also became a scholar due to his association with them. He would say, "No harm came to me from my *ajñana*. Because there was some discrimination, *jñana* dawned from *ajñana*. Even then, I did not let go of discrimination, and therefore *vijñana* ensued from *jñana*."

There was a young man who used to visit a potter. In due time he learned to make pots also. Even though he had no idea how to make pots, he learned it through close association and companionship with the potter. Children, suppose we visit an incense factory. After spending some time there, we return home and we can smell the fragrance of the incense on our body also. In a like manner, even weak-minded people or dullards would gradually evolve along

the spiritual path through the constant association and companionship with spiritual people.

Once I said, “God is all-pervading and He is within us.” Whereas now I see everything as God alone. God is both outside and inside the veil of “I”; the veil of “I” is also God. The veil is the body. The veil is not a problem anymore. That is *viññāna*. There is another thing. Once you reach the plane of consciousness of *jñāna* and *viññāna*, all concepts will vanish. There is not even *viññāna* in the plane of Pure Consciousness. Pure Consciousness alone is. That cannot be expressed.

Name and Liberation

Devotee: Is there any hope for me?

Mother: You should pray with great yearning. Then it is possible. It is enough to call and He will come before you without delay. Bhagavan is always standing ready to come running when the devotees call. (Mother laughs) Because of that, sometimes mistakes happen to Bhagavan. Sometimes He will come running even if He has not been called. Ajamila called his son “Narayana” and Bhagavan started running to him. He did not even care that it was not He who was being called. If you call His Name, He will come running. (All laugh blissfully)

Sage Bharata, a great Knower of the Self, thought about a deer at the time of death. Bhagavan did not come running. The reason is that ‘deer’ is not Bhagavan’s Name. Nobody had called Bhagavan “O Deer.” So Bhagavan did not go because His Name was not called. And Bharata took birth as a deer. Even then, because he had been a sage, he was saved. The other side can be seen if there is only a thin screen in one room. In Bharata’s mind there was only a thin screen of being a deer. Therefore, he could know who he really was even when he was born as a deer. Because

Bharata, a Knower of the Self, did not chant the Lord's Name, he took birth as a deer. Whereas Ajamila, an ignorant man, became liberated through the name "Narayana." That is the greatness of the Lord's Name.

In this birth, in this very moment, those who fix their minds on the Lord are liberated. Nothing else is a problem.

Endless beginning

Mother: What Mother has prayed to the Divine Mother for is to bring Her true devotees here. Others come for temporary peace. Still others, whether or not their desires get fulfilled, do not feel it necessary to come again and so they do not return.

Devotee: How can they know unless Mother makes them know?

Mother: How would it help to make it known to those who have no interest in knowing? There are still many yet to come and join. This is just the beginning, the endless beginning.

Another devotee: Are we also included in your list, Mother?

Mother: All are there in God's accounts. But your births will be fulfilled only if your calculations and estimations are cut off.

Vibration and stillness

Mother: (Pointing to one person) In the beginning when this son started coming here, some people asked him, "Why should you go there? She is possessed, isn't she?" But without caring, he came here. Then what? He understood that it was they who were possessed. (All laugh) Some people call the *Bhava Darshan* "possession." That is incorrect. It shows their lack of proper understanding. Both vibration and stillness are two different aspects of the same Truth. They are one.

To reach the state of stillness, it is necessary to hold onto something, which of course is changing. The means, whatever it is, must be a name or form, which is bound to change. Nobody can conceive of *Brahman* which has no form or attributes. Therefore, the majority of people need name and form. Mother has to consider them as well. Is it possible for Mother to discard the thousands who are in need of name, form and attributes in order to progress spiritually, for the sake of one or two *jñanis* who do not need it? Stillness and vibration are one and the same. If one is omitted, the other cannot be known. Inquiry is motion, the place where inquiry ends is stillness. Creating motion, God abides in stillness.

It was twilight and the residents were about to begin devotional singing. The Holy Mother got up from her seat and walked towards the temple verandah calling, "Come, children." Everyone got up and followed Mother. One devotee commented to his friend, "We have been coming here for so long, but we never heard Mother talking like this. The fact is that we have never stayed to hear it. We would come late in the evening to see the *Bhava Darshan* and after entering the temple we would leave the place immediately." The friend replied, "Did you hear what Mother said about the *Bhava*? It is to uplift ordinary people to God also. To make them closer to God and to develop faith in them, such things are needed. For those who come in search of pure spirituality, Mother will reveal her real greatness." The singing had begun and the heart-captivating songs of the Holy Mother filled the atmosphere with a divine fervor. She sang,

*There is nothing to tell to
The all-knowing Mother...
Walking beside us,
She is seeing and understanding everything...
The Primordial Being*

*Who is greater than the greatest,
Sees all the thoughts of the innermost self...*

The Mother's *bhajan* was always a source of tremendous inspiration to the devotees. While singing, she would always soar to the highest planes of supreme devotion equally elevating the listeners.

January 1978

Prabhakara Siddha Yogi

It was Sunday afternoon and devotees had already started coming for *Bhava Darshan*. Some of the devotees were talking about Prabhakara Siddha Yogi, an *Avadhuta*²⁵ whom they had met in Oachira on their way to the Mother's Ashram. Some of Mother's other devotees also had a desire to see him and expressed their wish to her. Mother replied, "If you are very desirous, Mother will make him come here." The conversation ended there. It was ten o'clock at night and *Devi Bhava* had begun. To the wonderment of the devotees, Prabhakara Siddha Yogi came to the Ashram that same night. It was very difficult to understand the yogi's strange behavior. His ways were incomprehensible to the devotees. Sometimes he spoke in a strange language and acted as if he were mad.

It was nearly dawn by the time the *Bhava* was over. The Holy Mother came out of the temple and sat near the yogi. When he saw Mother, he started saying, "Kali...Kali." He asked Mother, "Why did you call me here?" Mother re-

²⁵A Realized Soul who does not observe any norms in his external behaviour, sometimes acting like a sage but at other times acting like a child, madman or ghoul.

plied, “I did not call, did I?” “No, you called,” came his reply. “For the last few days I was being attracted here.”

Mother: These children felt like seeing you. That is the reason. That son (pointing to a resident) was very inspired to see you. Give him what is needed.

Yogi: What am I to give? (Turning to the resident) The person who can give what is to be given is already here. I am not needed for that.

The yogi pretended to be angry and pointed to Mother saying, “Do you know this person who is sitting here? No, you don’t know anything. This is a place where many things will arise. Many are yet to come. Many will come by air and water. Everything is here.” The yogi then turned to the Holy Mother’s father, Sugunanandan. “You must be very careful. This is not your house, it is the devotees’. You have to behave a little better. Do not make the devotees sad. All this is theirs.”

After roaming around the Ashram for some time, the Yogi left. Later, Mother told the devotees and *brahmacharins*,

“The yogi was brought here because these children said they wanted to see him. You will neither understand nor approve of his ways. Children, now go and do your *sadhana*. Everything that you want will come. Children, learn the Truth from yourself. There is not much use in trying to study people like the yogi. The path is different for different people. Everyone cannot assimilate everything. What you need is Self-Realization, not *siddhis*.²⁶ Nothing else is needed for those who get that (Realization).

²⁶Mystic powers.

15 January 1978

Taking disease

The Holy Mother was not well. She came from the hut later than usual. The devotees greeted her and stood around her.

Mother: Mother is not well today.

Devotee: Perhaps Mother has taken somebody's disease.

Mother: Oh, does Mother have the power to do it?

Devotee: Of course! One day Mother removed my illness and a few moments later we saw the same symptoms in Mother. But in Mother they lasted only a few minutes.

Mother: On certain occasions such things are necessary. Otherwise, to whom will the children call? When Mother's children have pain, she will say, "Mother (Devi, the Divine Mother), give it to me." Whether it is in your body or this body (pointing to her own), it is enough to suffer, isn't it? All is "Thy" grace. Only if we get that grace will real benefit come. No other benefit comes regardless of whoever else may help us. One look, one word or a touch from God is enough to get rid of all the impurities in a person. Because you are believers, Mother is talking to you like this. Mother does not know rationalism and such things. At the time of death, all reason will run away and hide. The inadequacy of those who pretend to be courageous will be proven then.

Devotee: Death comes not only to the rationalist, but also to the devotee, doesn't it?

Mother: All those who have taken birth will die. But death for the Knowers of God is something different. They are not afraid of death. Instead, they will welcome it. For they do not enter the world of death; they enter the world of God.

Another devotee: I heard that Mother has not eaten for several days. Why is that?

Mother: There is no particular reason, son. Look, Mother has no problem. Mother has done this many times in the past. So what? Did this body become weak? No, it remains vigorous.

Devotee: (Laughing) Mother should teach us that trick also.

Mother: It is not a thing which is possible through any trickery. It cannot be taught through words. Such a nature is there during certain times, that is all.

By this time a group of women devotees had arrived. They were members of a women's cultural center and began by asking the Holy Mother about the *dharma* of women.

Mother: There is only one *dharma*. That is to know God. There is no separate *dharma* specially made for women, but they have their own way to attain God. Women like yourselves should observe the scriptural statements and follow in the footsteps of Sita, Savitri, and Satyavati, who were embodiments of *stri dharma* (women's *dharma*). Living in it is greater than simply talking about it. Set an example for other women by living it. Take the case of Sita. The whole *Ramayana* entirely depends on the purity and virtuous character of Sita. What would the situation have been if Sita had obstinately said, "It is not possible to go to the forest, the country is rightfully ours?" But Sita did not do that. That shows her detachment towards worldly possessions. Her love for Rama shows attachment to God. Sita symbolizes a courageous woman who has acquired enough mental strength to confront the challenges of life through one-pointed devotion to her husband Rama. This also shows the infinite power of chastity. During her stay in Lanka, which symbolizes material wealth, surrounded by demonesses (negative tendencies), Sita would constantly remember Rama and shed tears due to the excruciating pain of separation.

It was because of that power that Rama could come to Lanka and kill Ravana. It is impossible for Bhagavan not to give an ear to the devotees' grief-stricken call. Where there is love, there Bhagavan is.

1 January 1980

A householder devotee and four young men came to see Mother. Several of the youths had heard about Mother but this was the first time they had come to see her in person. All four of them were humble and devoted. One of them was studying for his Master's degree and the other three for B.A. degrees. It was their inquisitiveness to know more about spirituality which brought them to Mother.

Mother came out of her hut and sat in front of the temple. All five guests prostrated before the Mother and stood by the side of the temple verandah. She affectionately asked them to sit down. Mother closed her eyes and became absorbed in meditation. After sometime, she opened her eyes and, turning to the students, inquired smilingly, "Children, do all of you like spirituality?" One of the students replied, "Yes, we go to temples and holy places." Mother remarked, "It is a wonder that children who study in college have interest in such things." The student replied, "We are very interested in knowing spiritual things and ask that Mother give us some advice."

Mother: Children, Mother is crazy. She will just burst out with some crazy things. All of you children call her "Mother" and because of that she calls you "children." Other than that, Mother does not know anything.

You children should live always remembering God. Do not waste any of your time. Repeat your *mantra* while doing each action. Practice meditation for some time every day.

Meditation

Student: Mother, how should we practice meditation?

Mother: Place a small picture of a God or Goddess that you like in front of you. Sit gazing at the picture for some time. Then, while closing your eyes, try to see the form within. When the form within fades away, again look at the external picture. Then again, close your eyes, and so on. Imagine that you are talking to your Beloved Deity, “Mother, do not go away and abandon me. Come into my heart. Let me always see Your beautiful form,” and so on. Cry, embracing your Beloved Deity. That which we meditate on will appear in front of us if we constantly call out with faith.

Meditation is good even for small children. Their intelligence will become clear, memory will increase and they will learn well. Mother does not say that all children must become *sannyasins*. Children, find a blissful life. You can understand the secret of bliss when you think of the nature of the Self. The waves of the mind will subside. Everything is there in you already. If there is faith, you can find it. The happiness that we get from the objects of the world is only an infinitesimal fraction of the bliss that we get from within.

Just as the filter fixed on the water tap absorbs the impurities in the water, so we should absorb the impurities in us with the filter of meditation. In the olden days, the jungles were outside. Now with much of the jungle cleared away, it has sprung up within everyone. In olden times there were wild beasts outside. Now those beasts are also within. It is the dirt within the mind, the jungle and wild beasts of the mind, that should be removed.

Student: What should be done to remove the dirt from the mind?

Mother: If the mind is to become pure, love for God must be developed. Virtues must be developed. The main obstacle to moving closer to God is our own selfishness. Selfishness automatically falls off when we feel compassion for others. Just as the saline taste disappears when fresh water is constantly added to salt water, the bad tendencies will leave us when we constantly think of good. See how many poor people are suffering without shelter, clothes, food or proper medical care. We will lose our selfishness when we become compassionate toward them.

Suppose we smoke ten rupees worth of cigarettes each day. In one month that is three hundred rupees. So much money would be available if we stopped smoking. A small hut could be built for a poor man with the amount of money spent for one year's supply of cigarettes. Presently, we do not understand that bliss is not in the cigarette, but within us.

You children might ask, "Then what about the cigarette manufacturers?" Even they are now saying that cigarette smoking is bad for one's health and that it will destroy the body and mind. People who have discrimination will not smoke.

Children, find satisfaction in others' happiness. For example, suppose we are comfortably seated in a bus. An elderly person gets in at the next stop and there is no vacant seat. Immediately get up and offer him your seat. Like this, we will become worthy of God's grace when each one of our small selfish tendencies is given up. In these ways negative qualities get destroyed.

We are all children of one Mother. The same eagerness with which we apply medicine to our burnt hand, we must show towards the suffering of others. If the left arm is burnt, does the right arm refuse to apply medicine saying, "It is not me who has the burn?" The real "I" permeates the

whole body. The pain in one part of the body is experienced by all other parts. Likewise, we unknowingly experience the pain of even the smallest creatures because the same Consciousness pervades everywhere. Children, understanding this, always act with compassion. We should not expect the fruit of our actions. It is enough to dedicate it to God. He will give what we need.

Question: Mother, how can we get rid of our sorrow?

Mother: We do not know what is eternal and what is non-eternal. Our desire is always for the non-eternal. Because of this, we become sorrowful. Then, due to this sorrow, the mind burns and burns and we become sick. In this way our lifespan decreases. Also, our minds become restless because wherever we go, we see the faults and defects in others. This is not the point of view that we should take. Look carefully at what is of value in the person and respect that. Forget what we have seen to be lacking. When we go to a place or meet someone new, instead of trying to find their faults and criticize them, try to see the good and appreciate that. You should only look at those qualities in which you are lacking. In this way, you will always see the good and this will end your sorrow.

Student: Mother, parents expect a lot from their children. Is it all right to stay in an Ashram without serving one's parents?

Mother: Children, parents often say "my" son, "my" daughter. But in reality, we are only their step-children. It is true that parents have many expectations, but think for a while. Do they discharge their duty towards their children properly? Mother would say "No," because their real duty is to give their children good culture, and this they are not doing. If any of the children take to spirituality, Mother will consider it a great blessing; not just for their family, but for the whole world. By taking to spiritual life, they would be

rendering a great service to their family as well as to the entire human race. Children, tell Mother which is better, to ruin one's life for just one or two people, or to sacrifice oneself for the good of the world?

Anyhow, it can be said without a doubt that only the *sannyasins* have served the world selflessly. Even today it is true. They never expect anything from the world. Whereas, the worldly people have only expectations and desires. And eventually these will steal away all of their human qualities and make them behave like animals.

If we are truly our parents' own children, they should be able to save us from death. We are God's children. What can we do? What use are we, if we do not have His power? Everyone seems to be our relative, while standing at the bus stop. Even so, they will go away when alighting at their own stop. This is life. We will remain alone. Father, mother and everyone else are like these relatives at the bus stop. Only the Lord is always with us.

At this time, *Brahmachari* Sreekumar came and sat near Mother and she continued,

"Children, it doesn't matter how much wealth we have. If we don't have the right attitude towards wealth, or use it properly, it will only bring sorrow. Even if there is immeasurable wealth, any happiness we might gain from it is only momentary. Wealth cannot give Eternal Bliss. Didn't Kamsa, Hiranyakasipu and others possess vast wealth? Did they ever have mental peace and tranquillity? What peace did Ravana²⁷ have although he possessed fabulous wealth? They all lived egotistically swerving from the path of Truth. They performed many actions which they should not have, and as a result they lost peace and tranquillity.

²⁷Kamsa, Hiranyakasipu and Ravana were all demonic kings in ancient India.

“Eternal bliss is not gained from wealth. Only non-eternal happiness can be gained from wealth. Then you might ask, ‘Do we have to abandon the wealth we already have?’ Mother does not say to abandon anything. Bliss and peace will become our wealth if we understand its proper place. For those who have turned Godward, material wealth is like rice with sand in it.”

Seeing that the students were listening with interest, the Holy Mother continued,

“In the olden days, young people lived at the residence of their Guru throughout the period of their education. During that time, they came to know what life is about, how to live and how to behave in the world. Because of that knowledge, they were blissful. They became strong-minded and could cross over every obstacle. They were fearless and ready to dedicate their lives to Truth. Like good lion cubs, they were perfectly healthy, had magnificent stature and were full of vigor. Unlike people today, who are short-lived and soft like lambs, they were endowed with a long life span and great strength. They were not afraid of anything. In those days, during the early evening hours, people would sing the Names of God. After that, they would review the mistakes they had made that day and repent, vowing not to repeat those same mistakes. That gave them consolation. But what about today? Times have changed. At dusk, people sit in front of the TV set, playing video games or watching movies. They scheme about ways to seize the other person’s money by fraudulent means or even by killing them. There have been some who did not even hesitate to kill their own mothers for the sake of gaining wealth. This is today’s world. How then can there be peace? There is no peace anywhere.

“*Ganja* (marijuana), sleeping pills, intoxicants, liquor — these means of delusion are the God people worship today.

If they do not have one of these crutches, they feel they cannot live. Having become slaves to all this, their lives are ruined and they destroy the lives of those around them as well. Nowadays, three year old children are shouting slogans, 'Hail the revolution!' Some older ones will shout, 'I will kill you,' to anyone who does not belong to their political party. Still others will go to school with the intent of inciting a strike. My children, don't get caught up in these things and become ruined."

Having said this, Mother closed her eyes and sat in an abstracted mood. After some time, she got up from her seat and showing a *mudra* with her fingers, she uttered "Shiva... Shiva!" As she walked out, Mother told Sreekumar, "Sit and speak to these children. Mother will come back after some time."

Student: While I was still forming a question in my mind, Mother would somehow understand my concern and would answer the question even before I asked it!

Sreekumar: Such experiences are not unusual.

Student: What inspired you and the other *brahmacharins* to come to the Ashram?

Sreekumar: It was Mother's pure and motherly love that brought us here. Her love and purity ignited in us a strong love for God and for ailing humanity. But, Mother's love must be known through direct experience. Without that direct experience, one will not know the depth and breadth of true unconditional love. One cannot even dream of receiving such love from one's own parents.

Mother's love comes from having known the Eternal. There is no selfishness in it. It is untainted love. Mother clears and cleans the path in front of us. It is enough for us to walk along this path. At present, we are like a pond filled with stagnant water. Mother connects the pond to the river by making furrows. Unknowingly, in the process, we be-

come closer to God, because Mother cuts off our selfishness with her pure and unconditional love. Mother acts selflessly; that is why she can do all this. What Mother does is not possible for one who is filled with desires. Our relationship with Mother is the true relationship. This kind of relationship is not available anywhere else.

All of a sudden Sreekumar's face became disconsolate. His eyes became wet with tears and were fixed on a distant point. He sat motionless.

Student: What's wrong, Sreekumar?

Sreekumar: I just remembered what happened on the first *Thiruvonam*²⁸ day after I met Mother.

Student: We would like to hear about it.

Sreekumar: It was the day before *Onam*. I was talking with Mother after *Darshan* and she said, "*Onam* is tomorrow. Children, please come back tomorrow." Some of her other children and I were sitting nearby when she said this. The next day, my family would not let me go without first taking food, as it was *Onam*. In those days, my family was not very close to Mother. Mother wanted us to eat lunch with her, but I did not know how to escape from the house. It was nearly eleven-thirty in the morning when the cooking was over. Soon after eating lunch, I started back to Vallickavu. All the buses were very crowded and none of them stopped. I waited for a long time at the bus stop. Although it was late, I was fortunate enough to get a direct bus to Vallickavu. I arrived at three-thirty in the afternoon. After taking the ferry across the river, I quickly walked towards the Ashram. I will never forget the sight which I saw then, such a heart-breaking sight it was. Mother was lying on the bare ground with sand all over her body. A pot sat on a temporary oven which had been made nearby. Several crows

²⁸The most important annual festival in Kerala.

were pecking and eating cooked roots from the pot and some pieces were lying scattered about in the sand. Later, when Mother awoke, she related what had happened:

“Mother asked the children to come here for lunch on *Onam*, didn’t she? But what was she to give the children to eat? Mother thought, ‘I don’t like to say anything to the family members.’ Mother herself made an oven in the yard and going to the garden, she plucked some roots and put them on the oven to cook. When it was fully cooked, the pot was kept closed without removing it from the oven. Having extinguished the fire, Mother waited for the children to come. Several times Mother went to the jetty and looked to see if the children were coming. While waiting, Mother did not eat anything. When it became late, Mother laid down in the sand. She began thinking, ‘It was wrong to call the children. On *Onam*, their families will not want them to leave their houses.’ At that moment, a crow pecked a piece of the cooked root from the pot. Mother got up hurriedly. Some pieces scattered on the ground. Some more crows came and tried to eat the root. Mother thought, ‘What will I feed my children?’ Mother felt sad and was about to drive the crows away, but then she thought, ‘They are also my children. Let them eat.’ Mother again laid down in the bare sand.”

After a few moments some other children arrived. Everyone brought something for Mother. She asked all of us to sit around her as she unwrapped the packages and distributed the banana chips and other food to each of us. She smiled with tears in her eyes. That innocent, childlike smile touched each of us deeply and we, too, began to cry. Since that incident, we will only eat with Mother during the *Onam* festival.

By this time Mother returned and called everyone for lunch. Everyone followed Mother to the dining hall.

Saturday, 5 December 1981

Mother was sitting on a cot in the hut. The roof and all four sides of the hut were thatched with coconut leaves. The entrance, being on the western side, faced both the backwaters and the Arabian Sea. Though a full view of the ocean could not be seen, the roaring sound of the breaking waves could be heard clearly on this side of the Ashram. Big fish, playfully diving through the backwaters, could be seen from the hut. Many varieties of flowering plants were growing on the raised ridges of the backwaters. Inside, on the walls of the hut, hung pictures of great saints and sages and different gods and goddesses. Grass mats had been spread on the floor in anticipation of arriving guests.

Some young men had come to see the Holy Mother. They entered the hut and sat on the floor after respectfully bowing to the Mother. She also sat on a mat and smilingly asked, “Children, when did you come?” One man replied, “Some time ago.” Mother asked if they had eaten anything and they replied that they had. One young man said, “Mother, we have so many questions; will you answer them?”

Mother: Mother is crazy. Mother does not know anything. She only babbles something or other.

Question: Mother, how can one improve the world?

Mother: Only one who has studied can teach. Only one who has acquired can give. Only one who is completely free from sorrow can free others from sorrow completely.

Question: Mother, what is meant by death?

Mother: Son, death is only a change like all other changes. Each being takes birth on earth according to the fruit of its actions. Coming here, they proudly live thinking “my” wealth, “my” wife, etc. Each one dies as they are trying to fulfill their desires. Eventually we are forced to go, leaving everything we considered as our own behind. While trav-

eling in a bus, we have to get down at the stop where we must alight. When we sat in the bus we proudly thought “my” seat and even claimed it so. But when leaving the bus, we do not take the seat with us. Only God knows how long we will be here. The existence of all of us is in God. The *jivatman* which makes the body act, departs, leaving behind the corpse. This is what we call death. But death is not the complete destruction of the body. It is the beginning of the decomposition of the five elements which will merge back into their original principles. This change of the body has nothing to do with the soul, which will remain unchanged forever.

Easy path

Devotee: What is the easy way to attain God’s Vision?

Mother: You seek an easy path due to a lack of surrender. God’s Vision cannot be gained simply by torturing the body. Whatever the path is, the mind should merge in God, that is what is important. Regularly performing *sadhana*, we should wait with patience. There is no shortcut, or easy way. Having put rock-sugar candy in your mouth, you would not quickly swallow it just because it is sweet. If so, your throat would get cut. Instead, you let it dissolve, then swallow it. *Sadhana* is also like that. The path of devotion is the simplest.

Devotee: Mother, what should I do to develop devotion?

Mother: *Satsang, kirtan, mantra japa, dhyana* — all these are helpful.

Devotee: But, Mother, how can those involved in worldly affairs sustain devotion?

Mother: Children, remember God while performing all actions. (Mother points to a man who is leading ducks through the backwaters) That is such a small boat that there is hardly enough room to stand. Yet, standing in that small boat, the boatman will balance the boat, row with

a long oar and lead the ducks through the backwaters all at the same time. Making noise by slapping the oar on the water, he will guide the ducks back on course if they start to stray away. At intervals, he will smoke a cigarette. When necessary, he will use his feet to scoop out any water that gets in the boat. Other times he will talk with the people standing on the bank. Even while doing all these things, his mind will always be on the boat. If his attention wavers even for a moment, he will lose his balance, the boat will capsize and he will fall in the water. Children, like this we should live in this world. Whatever work we are doing, our mind should be centered on God. This is easily possible through practice.

It was now time for lunch and one *brahmacharin* came to call the young men. Mother affectionately said, “Yes, my children, go and eat your lunch. It is Ashram food. There will not be many spices to add flavor. It is good to have some training!” Everyone went to the dining hall.

Purpose of birth

A few *brahmacharins* sat nearby while Mother was eating. She fed them small balls of rice. One *brahmacharin* asked, “Mother, what is the purpose of your birth?”

Mother: Mother’s birth is for the good of the world. Some people dig wells only for their own use. There are others who dig wells for the use of the whole village. Their intention is that everyone should quench their thirst by drinking water from the well. Mother dug at a place and there was water. Gradually that water flowed with the strength and fullness of a river. Some bathe in it and others quench their thirst from it. Each one does as he wishes.

Wasn’t Sri Krishna the Supreme Self? The Lord had no attachment to anything. Even then, the Lord incarnated on the earth and acted ideally for the good of the world.

This was not for Himself. He is not in need of anything. It is not for the Knowers of the Self that God takes birth. God assumes a body to bring the ignorant to the sacred path. What defamations Sri Krishna had to hear! Wasn't He killed by an arrow? Jesus Christ was crucified. If necessary, they could have reduced their enemies to ashes in an instant. Yet, they did not do this so that the world could learn what real renunciation is.

All of us should learn to live with an attitude of brotherly love and sense of equality, each with the other. Different kinds of people come to see Mother during *Bhava Darshan*. Some come out of devotion, some come for fulfilling worldly desires, some for curing diseases and others come for their own varied reasons. Even so, Mother accepts everyone. Could Mother not accept them? Are they different from me? Aren't we all beads strung on the one thread of life? Each one understands Mother according to their own way of thinking. Those who criticize me and those who love me are the same to me. A continuous stream of love flows from me towards all beings. That is Mother's inborn nature.

Lifting both hands in the air and looking upwards, the Holy Mother called loudly, "Shivane...Shivane..."

Kundalini

Question: Mother, yesterday I started to read a book about *kundalini shakti*, but it was so confusing that I finally put it down. What is *kundalini shakti*? How does it work? What is meant by "awakening of *kundalini*?" Mother, would you say something about this?

Mother: Son, first of all, a serious seeker should not think about and go on asking each and everyone about the working of *kundalini*, whether it is awakened or "Is it going to awaken soon?" Mother does not say that you should stop reading

and gathering knowledge about such things. Gathering knowledge is good, though too much reading can also be dangerous. Remember, mere reading without practice is harmful. Do your *sadhana* regularly with utmost sincerity, faith, and supported by self-surrender. All other subjective developments will happen automatically. You do not have to worry about it. It must take place provided that your effort is sincere.

Because you asked, Mother will say something about *kundalini shakti*. Mother does not want to disappoint you. *Kundalini*, or the serpent power, as it is called, is the vital force which flows in and through all living beings. This power is situated below the spine in the form of a coiled, sleeping female snake. It is awakened through incessant contemplation and Guru's grace. When it is awakened, it ascends through the *sushumna*,²⁹ which lies in the spine, and rises up to the top of the head which is where the male serpent-like form resides in the *sahasrara*.³⁰

Mother paused for a moment and the *brahmacharin* took this opportunity to clear his doubts about *kundalini* by asking, "Does all this exist on the gross level or on the subtle level?" **Mother:** This is subtler than the subtlest. As you know, there are six *chakras*.³¹ *Sahasrara* is the last and the subtlest. Each one of them is a storehouse of spiritual power which can be experienced only through yogic intuition. As the serpent power reaches each *chakra*, it makes that particular region fully blossom and mature before passing to the next. As the *kundalini* reaches each center, the seeker will get different kinds of visions, both divine and tempting. The *sadhaka* who is not under the strict control of a *Satguru*

²⁹A vital nerve.

³⁰The thousand-petalled lotus at the crown of the head.

³¹Mystic centers situated along the spine.

might misunderstand these lower states as something very great or even equal to Self-Realization. This may cause them to fall prey to many kinds of temptations. That is why it is said that a *Satguru* is absolutely necessary to guide the aspirant during the course of his *sadhana*.

Several changes also occur in the body when this power moves from one center to another. One feels a burning sensation all over the body, as if hot chilies have been rubbed on the body. The body also experiences tremendous heat and will have tremors now and then. Water may ooze from the pores like sweat. In certain stages, blood may come out of the pores and the body may become gaunt like a skeleton.

Brahmacharin: This sounds like a frightening situation, Mother.

Mother: Yes, it is. The *sadhaka* who undergoes these experiences for the first time may become very frightened. He might even become mentally abnormal or perverted due to fear and the lack of sufficient inner strength to withstand the situation. That is why it is strictly prescribed that *kundalini dhyana* should be performed only in the presence of a Realized Soul.

Brahmacharin: What things should an aspirant be careful about during this period?

Mother: During this stage the aspirant should be very careful and alert. He should be looked after with as much care as one would give a pregnant woman. He should not move his body unnecessarily. He will not be able to lie down on a mattress, because the smallest folds will be unbearable to him. He should use a straight, smooth wooden plank to lie on. The spine should not receive any knocks, as the after effects will be great. When the *kundalini* wakes up, the aspirant becomes a tremendous center of attraction and being deluded by this, women and others may flock around him.

In such a state, the absence of a *Satguru* to impart proper instructions may tempt him to indulge in sensual pleasures, thus draining away all his accumulated spiritual energy.

Brahmacharin: Mother, what happens when the *kundalini shakti* finally reaches the *sahasrara*?

Mother: Transcending all six *adharas*³² including the *muladhara*,³³ the *kundalini shakti* finally reaches the head which is its real abode. There is a showering of ambrosia that occurs throughout the body and it experiences a rejuvenating coolness. The old body gets transformed into a new vessel of tremendous spiritual power.

Roots absorb water and manure from the soil and carry them to the leaves. The leaves, in turn divide and distribute these substances among all the parts of the plant, including the roots. This refined energy sustains the tree. Similarly, the spiritual energy which reaches the thousand-petalled lotus from the *muladhara* transforms itself into ambrosia and, flowing through the nerves, pervades the whole body and nourishes it, imparting a rich glow and splendor, along with a marvelous supply of energy and vitality.

Another brahmacharin: Mother, I am not able to concentrate during meditation. Why is this?

Mother: Children, the mind is naturally one-pointed and pure, but up until now we have made room for many impure worldly emotions. For this reason, it has become difficult to make the mind concentrated during meditation. These worldly thoughts and emotions are like bad tenants. We have given them a small piece of our land on which to build a hut. Now, not only do they pay no attention when we ask them to leave, they rush forward to pick a fight with us. We have to work hard to kick them out. We might

³²The chakras.

³³The lowest chakra at the base of the spine.

have to take them to court. Likewise, to kick out the tenants of the mind, we have to file a case in God's court. It is a constant fight. We must continue fighting until we become victorious.

More *vasanas* will come up as you do more *sadhana*. While sweeping the floor with a broom, we may remove a lot of surface dirt. If the same room is wiped with a wet cloth, much more dirt will come off. In a similar way, more dirt will rise up when we do more *sadhana*. Try to remember that it is only for the sake of getting destroyed that all these *vasanas* rise up.

Brahmacharin: Mother, shouldn't we fight against the injustice in the world?

Mother: That is work for worldly people who are endowed with *rajasic*³⁴ qualities and not for a seeker of the Truth. Do not focus on the faults and defects of the world. God-Realization is our goal. After attaining that, we can make the world good in accordance with God's instructions. Is it practical to begin worshipping God only after wiping out all the injustice in the world?

Satguru Self-Realized Master

Question: How can we know whether one's spiritual experiences are valid or just imagination?

Mother: Son, for that a *Satguru* is needed. A *Satguru* is one who has already gained God-Realization. He will guide the disciple along the correct path and take him to the goal. Those who are sincere will get a Guru. It is not necessary to wander here and there in search of one.

Question: Mother, which is better, meditation on God with attributes or without attributes?

³⁴One of the three *gunas* or qualities of Primordial Nature.

Mother: That depends on the seeker. In the beginning, the *sadhaka* usually meditates on God with attributes. Later on he will be able to meditate on God without attributes.

Question: During meditation, it is difficult to clearly see the form of my Beloved Deity. Why is this, Mother?

Mother: It will be like that in the beginning. Though your mind might run here and there, later on after some practice, it will become fixed on your Beloved Deity. There is no other way than to continue your *sadhana* with all sincerity. Then the form will become unclouded.

Question: Why does the mind run about like that?

Mother: Because of *vasanas*.

Question: Can a householder attain God-Realization?

Mother: Why do you ask such a question, son? Just because your meditation is not yet firm? Is a householder's life not enough for you? (Everyone laughs) A *grihastashrami*³⁵ will easily attain God, but not a *grihasta*.³⁶ Attaining God-Realization is no problem for a *grihasta* who leads an Ashram life with a full understanding of the eternal and non-eternal. One can reach the goal if selfless actions are performed with an attitude of dedicating everything to God. A seeker should stay firmly fixed on the goal. He should not stop his *sadhana* out of disappointment and frustration, but should continue with firm intent on reaching the goal.

Question: Can't the Guru remove the shortcomings of the disciple?

Mother: A passenger can be dropped at the bus station, but he is the one who has to get into the bus. The Guru will show the path. All the rest depends on the mind and effort of the disciple.

³⁵One who makes his house into an ashram, i.e. who leads a spiritual life.

³⁶An ordinary worldly soul leading a married life.

Question: What is the difference between worshipping God with form and worshipping the formless aspect of God?

Mother: *Savikalpa samadhi*, which is the perception of the True Reality while retaining the state of duality, is gained through meditation upon God with form. Because of the vision of one's Beloved Deity as separate from oneself, one has the attitude of "I" and a feeling of duality. In meditation upon the Formless, the "I" sense is completely removed. There is only One. What is gained is *nirvikalpa samadhi*, the state of abidance in the Absolute.

Question: Mother, tell us about the disciples who come to earth wanting nothing for themselves, only caring for the benefit of the world.

Mother: They are *nitya siddhas*.³⁷ They are detached from the time of their birth itself.

Question: Why does the world slip into errors?

Mother: Due to *kāma* (lust) and *krodha* (anger) human beings commit errors and become unrighteous. Their desires need to be controlled.

Sunday, 6 December 1981

A fortunate cow

Since it was a *Darshan* day, there was a large crowd to see the Mother as Devi and Krishna and also to receive her blessings. At four in the morning, when the *Bhava* was over, an unforgettable incident took place.

A black cow which was living at the Ashram had given birth to a calf one year before. Over the year, it had been a beautiful sight to see the gleeful calf running here and there around the Ashram premises. But on this particular

³⁷Ever-perfect.

night, the calf suddenly became afflicted with an acute illness. Unable to bear the pain, it cried aloud, “Ma! Ma!” as if calling the Holy Mother. Although many people tried to relieve the calf’s suffering, their efforts were to no avail and the calf’s condition became worse and worse. The poor creature was struggling for its life.

Coming out of the temple after the *Bhava Darshan*, Mother went straight to the calf and with great love and affection placed its head in her lap. She caressed it and asked everyone to chant the Divine Name. After some time, Mother asked everyone to chant the sacred mantra “Om Namah Shivaya.” As the chanting was going on, Mother asked for some *tulasi*³⁸ leaves and sacred water to be brought in a *kindi*.³⁹ When the water had been brought, she poured some into the calf’s mouth. She then took some water in her palm and sprinkled it, along with the sacred *tulasi* leaves, onto the calf’s body. The calf was still gazing intently at the Holy Mother’s face. After a couple of minutes the Mother again caressed its face and body and said, “All right, you go.” After a few seconds the calf, with its head still on the Mother’s lap, breathed its last breath.

Mother later said, “That calf had been a *sannyasin* in its previous birth. Due to its *karma* it took birth as a cow. But, because of its accumulated merits from its previous births, it happened to be born in this Ashram. The *brahmacharins* raised it and it grew up hearing the Divine Names. Hearing the Divine Names it also left its body.”

Thursday, 10 December 1981

It was ten o’clock in the morning when Mother came into the kitchen. One of the *brahmacharins* was using the

³⁸The sacred basil plant.

³⁹A metal waterpot with a fluted rim.

gas stove to cook tamarind seeds for the cows. Mother commented, “Cooking gas is very expensive. This can be cooked using firewood. Also, the stove will break if you put such big vessels like this on it.” The *brahmacharin* did not heed the Mother’s words, but continued what he was doing. She continued her instructions by saying, “If you cannot cook this without waste of fuel and damage to the stove, then Mother will cook it.” He replied, “Where is the time to do *sadhana* if I must sit here doing this kind of work?” Hearing this, the Mother became serious and told him, “From now on you don’t have to do any work related to the cows.” Having said this, she entrusted the work to another resident. After this, the *brahmacharin* became sad. Even so, Mother would not agree to his requests to continue doing the work with the cows. What followed was a beautiful piece of spiritual instruction.

Mother: One should learn to do every action with utter dedication to God, shouldn’t he? Spirituality is not sitting in a corner with closed eyes. We should be ready to become everyone’s servant and also to see all equally. Going out into the world tomorrow, all of you should serve everyone without selfishness. Serving the cows is an especially meritorious action. Isn’t it said in the *Bhagavatam* that Sri Krishna used to graze the cows?

Once a sage got trapped in a fisherman’s net. As instructed by the sage, the fisherman took him to the king’s palace to be sold. No matter how much was offered, the sage did not agree to be sold to the king. At last, as suggested by a clever minister, the king offered a cow. Only then did the sage consent to be purchased by the king. The cow is that sacred of an animal. Serving a cow should be considered a good fortune – it is *sadhana* itself. Son, do not do this work half-heartedly.

One who simultaneously does *karma* (action) and remembers God is the noblest. Son, can't you repeat your *mantra*, while cooking the tamarind seeds? Otherwise, can't you read spiritual books? Sage Narada thought that he was a great devotee. Once Lord Krishna said, "Narada, there is one farmer on earth who is a greater devotee than you." Narada doubted this and came down to earth to see the peasant in person. He found that the farmer would chant the Lord's Name only three times a day. "How could he be a greater devotee than me?" thought Narada. Upon returning he mentioned his doubt to the Lord. The Lord gave Narada a small vessel filled to the brim with oil and asked him to keep it on his head and go round a particular hill without spilling even a drop. When Narada returned after finishing the round the Lord asked, "How many times did you chant My Name in between?" Narada thought and was surprised to discover that he had not remembered the Lord's Name even once because his attention had been fully concentrated on keeping the vessel of oil steady so as not to spill it. Bhagavan smilingly said, "Now do you understand what a great devotee that farmer is? Even in the midst of his toilsome work, thrice he is remembering Me."

The *brahmacharin* who had tried to say that cooking tamarind seeds was an obstacle for his *sadhana* understood his mistake and apologized. But Mother still did not allow him to resume that work. She said, "When you are able to do these works with faith and without selfishness, then Mother will ask you to do it. Until then, you should go and meditate." Out of remorse, the *brahmacharin* fasted that day. Learning that he had not eaten, the Holy Mother, out of her affection, also did not eat anything. The *brahmacharin* was greatly pained at heart to hear that she was not eating because of him, and he ate his supper. Thereupon the Mother also ate.

Saturday, 19 December 1981

The time was eight o'clock in the morning and the *brahmacharins* were getting ready to chant the *Lalita sahasranama*⁴⁰ as instructed by the Holy Mother. It was the first day of the *Laksharchana* when they would chant the thousand Names of the Divine Mother one hundred thousand times. Everyone came into the temple and sat around the sacred seat ready to begin the worship. All preparations were ready and *Brahmacharin* Unnikrishnan commenced the formal worship which would be followed by the chanting. Everyone had kept flower petals on a piece of banana leaf in front of themselves. They all sat with closed eyes as the verse for meditation was chanted. Unnikrishnan led the worship in the presence of the Holy Mother. He chanted the Names one by one as the *brahmacharins* repeated them and offered flower petals on the holy seat. Noticing one *brahmacharin* who offered the flowers carelessly, Mother said, "Do not perform the offering in an insincere or absent-minded way. If you do not feel like doing the *archana*⁴¹ now, take some rest, then continue later. Children, do not force the body to do the worship. It is not a problem even if the *puja*⁴² finishes a little late. While picking up each flower petal, visualize Devi's form sitting on the *peetham* (seat). Then offer the flowers at Devi's Feet. Doing this, you will gain good concentration. External attentiveness becomes the cause of internal attentiveness."

⁴⁰The Thousand Names of the Divine Mother.

⁴¹Worship of God by repetition of His Names.

⁴²Ritual worship.

Sahaja samadhi

The time was now three o'clock in the afternoon. *Brahmacharin* Nealu was conversing with the Holy Mother in the hut. Sitting nearby, *Brahmacharin* Balu was keenly listening to the Holy Mother's words.

Nealu: Mother, what is meant by *sahaja samadhi*?

Mother: Son, imagine that there is a rubber ball and a ring within us. The ball represents the mind and is always moving up and down, through the ring. At times it gets caught in the ring and remains motionless. This can be called *samadhi*. But the ball does not rest there permanently. It will again move up and down as before. Eventually, a state will come when the ball will rest permanently within the ring without any further motion. This is called *sahaja samadhi*.

In an advanced state of meditation, the *sadhaka* experiences merging of the mind, but when he gets up from meditation the mind starts functioning as before. *Sahaja samadhi* is the state when the mind completely merges. After that, the mind has no power to function independently. The person who has entered *sahaja samadhi* will be blissful seeing his Real Nature in whatever object is before him.

Tuesday, 22 December 1981

It was nine in the morning and Mother was sitting under a coconut tree in front of the temple. Some *brahmacharins* came and sat near Her. She said, "There is a real benefit in doing group meditation. At that time, everyone's thought vibrations are of a similar pattern, so good concentration can be attained. The atmosphere gets permeated with the concentrated energy of everyone's meditation and it becomes even more conducive to doing meditation."

One *brahmacharin* liked to spend his time only in the presence of Mother. He asked: “Is this feeling of mine appropriate?”

Mother: In the early stages, attachment to the Guru’s external form is good, but the disciple should not observe the Guru’s actions and try to judge him or her. In most cases the disciple becomes too attached to the Guru’s external form and forgets the Guru’s all-pervasive nature. Attachment to the Guru’s form with a firm awareness of his omniscience and all-pervasive nature is the perfect attitude. If there is attachment without proper awareness of the Guru’s infinite nature, the disciple can fall an easy victim to all kinds of negative tendencies. Devotion to the Guru backed with the understanding of his higher nature is real devotion.

Mother paused for a while and then, fixing her eyes on the blue sky said, “Balumon, sing a song.” He sang,

*O Thou who appears as this illusory
Universe filling it throughout,
O Radiant One, won't Thou dawn in my mind
And stay forever shedding Thy brilliance?
I will saturate myself drinking
Thy motherly affection...*

As the song went on, Mother sat motionless with her eyes still fixed on the expansive sky. Tears rolled down her cheeks. When the song was about to finish, she laughed blissfully while pointing her index finger towards the sky, all the while whispering gentle words, as if asking something of someone who was unseen to the rest of us. Again and again she burst into rapturous laughter. In a semi-conscious mood she turned to the *brahmacharins* and said, “Look here (pointing to her own body), this one’s will has no separate existence from that One’s Will. They are one and the same. If you take Mother as the body, then you

cannot grow spiritually. Mother is not this body. She is her childrens' Self. Mother is ready to give all that she has to her children, but you should become deserving of it. Mother is always giving what her children need, but you children are not yet ready to accept it.

“Children, always think of the goal. Only if you have strength of your own can you serve others selflessly. What will you say when others ask you something about spirituality? To be able to speak nicely on these matters, the scriptures should also be studied. Do not torture the body unnecessarily. Control of food should be gradual. You should meditate during the night time. Yogis do not sleep in the night, they will meditate. All of Nature becomes still at night. There are less vibrations from worldly dealings and good concentration can be gained.”

To the householders

It was a *Darshan* day and the householder devotees started coming one by one and in groups. Having greeted the Holy Mother, they sat down nearby. *Brahmacharin* Venu was fanning Mother while she distributed some sweets brought by a householder devotee. While distributing the *prasada*, she sang:

*Hey Shiva who takes everyone,
Take me also, hey Shiva...*

(All laugh hearing Mother's song)

One devotee asked Mother if he could ask her some questions. Mother replied, “Shiva...yes, yes,...ask, ask.”

Question: Mother, is it possible to lead both a spiritual and worldly life side by side?

Mother: Certainly it is possible, son. But one should be able to act selflessly. Sorrow comes when we think, “I am

doing. I must have the fruit of it. A certain amount of detachment is needed. Never think “my” wife, “my” child. When you consider everything as God’s, then it is not possible to be attached. When you die, your wife and children will not come with you, will they? God alone is Truth. A householder should also go to temples and ashrams.

Devotee: To say all these things is easy, but it is difficult to put in practice. How can we succeed at this? Please, Mother, tell us what we should do?

Mother: Children, it is not impossible. Nothing in this world is impossible, especially for human beings. Strong determination and unshakable faith are the two factors needed for success. Mother understands clearly that it is not so easy for a *grahasta*, because he is pulled from all directions. His mind is much too involved in worldly affairs. You must do your duty, but you must not get entangled in it. That is the problem. Suppose you are living in this world for eighty or ninety years. Why should you waste all of your energy just enjoying worldly pleasures and fulfilling your desires? After all, think about what you are doing with your life. Is it a matter of just repeating the same things you were doing the day before or jumping from one type of enjoyment to the next? If so, children, slowly try to change your life. Out of thirty days in a month, spend at least two days for your spiritual development. Try to change your bad habits by gradually replacing them with good thoughts and actions. Every day before going to bed, recollect the day’s activities and try to discriminate between the good and bad. Repent of any bad thoughts and actions. Make a strong determination to abstain from those kinds of thoughts and actions in the future. The next day also do the same. Before going to bed, compare your actions that day to the previous day and see the differences. Pray to the Lord to bestow enough mental strength to fight against negative tenden-

cies. Surrender everything at His Feet. Have compassion for ailing humanity. Do charity for righteous purposes. Real charity or renunciation is giving up your dearest things. Actually, it is said that the mind should be offered to the Supreme. But the mind is immersed in money and other such worldly possessions. So offering money for righteous things is equal to offering our minds. Such actions will make your mind more and more expansive. Expansiveness is God. Do not let your wealth be used just for fulfilling your desires and those of your family members. Let at least a small portion of it be used for the benefit of the world. This in turn will purify you.

Another devotee: Mother, you told us that householders should go to temples and ashrams, but there are many people who scoff at image worship. Why is this?

Mother: They criticize image worship because of their ignorance about temples and the science behind image worship. To put it in one sentence, the temple represents the body and the image symbolizes *Atman*, the soul, which is situated in the sanctum sanctorum (inner chamber) of the heart. The complete temple is the seeker's body in full prostration with all the *adharas*, including *sahasrara*. Ordinary people with gross intellects cannot conceive of a formless or nameless God even though that is His real nature. They need something to hold onto and someone to share their heart with. Being limited individuals, human beings are not satisfied with another limited being. Knowingly or unknowingly one is always in search of an infinite, universal Person to whom one can unburden one's sorrow and find peace. The ancient sages knew that the people belonging to the forthcoming ages would be unable to grasp these subtle truths unless it was put in a different way. Thus the idea of temples dawned in their hearts to make Truth available even to the grossest. But we misinterpret it and make a

mess. Whose fault is this? Who is there to blame? Neither God nor the great forefathers, we can blame only ourselves.

In any case son, why do you care if somebody out of utter ignorance says something about God or image worship? Let him babble. That shows his lack of understanding. Let us pray and work for his upliftment also. But let our faith be unshakable.

Devotee: What Mother says is perfectly true. If we can correct ourselves, then everything will become all right.

Another devotee: Mother, it is said that one will get mental peace if one goes to temples and prays sincerely. How does that happen?

Mother: It is true, we can get peace, but as you said, we must have sincerity. We want peace to come after we call “God” once having looked at the image and then closed our eyes. When we meditate on God with form, we are also meditating on our own Self. This means all other thoughts will be restrained and our mind will become concentrated on the image of God. This again means that there are no other thoughts, which cause all our external and internal problems and conflicts, except that one single thought of God. Fewer thoughts mean more peace of mind. More thoughts means less peace of mind. Moreover, when we go to a temple, the atmosphere is calm because everyone stands there with only one thought in mind. All minds will become one-pointed while waiting for the sanctum sanctorum to be opened and to behold God’s image. The atmosphere there becomes peaceful because of that concentrated thought. That is why we get peace when we go to temples.

Mother became absorbed in meditation. Opening her eyes, she called aloud, “Sreemone, bring the harmonium.” Looking smilingly at the devotees, Mother said, “Mere talking alone is not enough. Let us sing His glories and do a little bit of practice too.” By that time Sreekumar had brought the

harmonium and Pai had also arrived. Mother said, “Paimone, sing some *slokas* (verses).” Having prostrated before Mother, Pai sang,

O Mother, I know neither the divine mantras nor the yantras which embody Thy Power, nor do I know any verses which praise Thy glories.

O Mother, please tell me, there may be sons who are sinners on this earth, but is there a cruel mother?

Hearing the Sanskrit verses, Mother became totally introverted. Her body remained motionless. With half-closed eyes she sat like a statue. Tears born of supreme bliss rolled down her cheeks and her face became most brilliant. Pai went on singing until he also burst into tears. Sreekumar who was playing the harmonium slowly slid into a meditative mood. Everything became silent for a few minutes except for Pai’s sobbing.

At this time, one *brahmacharin* burst into tears while embracing the Mother’s feet. Later he revealed that he was thinking how fortunate he was to have Mother, the embodiment of innocent love and selflessness, as his Guru. How many devotees have wet those feet with their tears? How many are taking refuge at those holy feet? How many ailing people’s teardrops have been wiped by those hands? She gives everything for the benefit of others, keeping nothing for herself.

When the Holy Mother emerged from her ecstatic mood, Krishna Shenoy, an ardent devotee of the Mother, had just arrived. He greeted Mother and sat near her. Mother, with a mischievous smile exclaimed, “Hey, Krishna, you got your job back, didn’t you?”

Krishna Shenoy was speechless. With an air of amazement on his face, for a moment he sat gazing at Mother.

Tears fell freely from his eyes. Before long, he fell at Mother's feet and wept like a small child. The Holy Mother, with great affection and love, caressed and consoled him. When Shenoy regained his composure, one of the devotees asked him what had happened.

Full of emotion, Shenoy said, "How is it possible to explain? Everything is Mother's grace. After the last *darshan*, when I reached the factory where I work, I learned that a suspension order had been filed against me. The charge was for taking more holidays than was allotted without having officially informed the management. I had taken those holidays to come and see Mother. After meeting Her, I only wanted to be here with Her. But the astounding thing about the suspension was that everything was straightened up and the suspension was withdrawn within three hours. How did it happen? I don't know. It is still a mystery. As far as I know, nobody supported me or recommended the withdrawal of the suspension order."

One devotee: Who told you that nobody recommended that the suspension be withdrawn?

Shenoy: What do you mean?

Devotee: Don't you know that Mother was there to make the recommendation for you? (All laugh)

First devotee: But how did Mother know about all of this?

Shenoy: That is a good question. Is there anything which Mother doesn't know?

Mother: Yes, children, Mother knows one thing...that she doesn't know anything.

Question: Mother, can you please tell us what we householders need to know to grow spiritually?

Mother: In olden days *grihastashrama* (householder life) and spirituality were simultaneous. From the time the baby was born, the parents would chant *mantras* into the baby's ears. Thus, the child would grow up hearing divine *mantras*. Later,

the child would be sent to a *Gurukula*.⁴³ There he or she would learn all the Vedas and *sastras* (scriptures) observing perfect celibacy and practicing what they learned. Later, having married a girl who had been raised in the same way, a man would become a *grihastasrami* and would lead a righteous life. They would serve others selflessly and feed those in need. Their humility was so great that they had no hesitation to even worship the feet of the needy. Only for sustaining their family line did they have children. Then, the husband would see the wife as mother. When the child was in the womb, the mother would observe different kinds of religious vows. Because of that, the child would become noble hearted, wise and of real benefit to the world. Both the husband and wife had perfect control over their minds and would never allow themselves to be influenced by petty emotions. The quality of thoughts of a woman during her pregnancy will greatly influence the character of her child. The child born to a woman who maintains the remembrance of God during pregnancy will become a devotee. There is no doubt about this. Having raised the child and made him self-reliant, both the husband and the wife would go to the forest and do *tapas* (austerities).

But today everything is out of order because human beings have given up their intrinsic duty (*swadharma*). Great sages have written that in this *Kaliyuga* (dark age of materialism) people will be blind, deformed and with many other weaknesses. The forests will become houses. The houses will become shops. The father will be eaten by the son and the son by the father. There will be terrible floods. There will be no harvests. Then there will be terrible droughts. The cause for all this is the selfishness and lack of mental purity of human beings.

⁴³Residential school of a Guru.

Some more devotees came and prostrated before Mother. After some light conversation with them, Mother went near the huts where the *brahmacharins* were staying. It was time for their meditation and Mother went to watch them.

Wednesday, 23 December 1981

The mother hen and her chicks

Brahmacharin Venu was loudly singing Sri Sankara's *Nirvana Shatkam* while sitting in his room:

*I am neither the mind, intellect,
Ego nor memory;
Neither ears nor tongue
Nor the senses of smell and sight;
Nor am I ether, earth, fire, water, or air;
I am Pure Awareness-Bliss,
I am Shiva! I am Shiva!*

Venu's nature was that of a child in those days and this created a lot of problems for him. Constantly repeating the Divine Name, he would do all the work entrusted to him. One could always see his lips moving. Because of this, sometimes his mind would lose its contact with the external world and he would knock over or break objects that were near him. One day, Mother scolded him for not having any external focus. She said, "Son, constant remembrance of God is good but if you cannot concentrate your mind on the work that you are doing, then don't work. Go and meditate somewhere. If God is everything, then work also is Him. Do your work as worship. You cannot be careless while offering such worship."

Hearing these words of the Mother, Venu felt sad and went into his hut. It was then he sang the song mentioned

above. Having heard his singing, Mother came to his hut and said, “Son, in the beginning nothing can be gained if we walk around saying ‘Shivoham.’ If the egg is to be hatched, it must sit under the mother hen to be incubated. They hatch because of patiently sitting there for many days. Likewise, a *sadhaka* should perform *sadhana* according to the Guru’s instruction. It is not possible to hatch, if you sit chanting ‘Shivoham.’ Would you say ‘I am a hen’ before being hatched? Pure devotion is better. It is the easiest way. One should say, ‘Dasoham, Dasoham’ (I am your servant) in the beginning. ‘Shivoham’ is not something to be said. It is something to be verified through direct knowledge. If somebody beats you, is it possible for you to sit patiently thinking that he is Shiva? If so, chant ‘Shivoham’. Otherwise chant ‘Dasoham’ alone.” As Mother went out of Venu’s hut she sang the following refrain of one song:

If Thou givest me another birth, then bestow the boon of taking birth as the servant of Thy servants forever.

Thursday, 24th December 1981

It was a *Bhava Darshan* day and there were many people to receive blessings from the Holy Mother. As she called the devotees one by one, listening attentively to their woeful stories, Mother bestowed peace and tranquillity on each. Instructing them according to their mental caliber, she reassured them that she would always be with them. It was two o’clock when the daytime *darshan* was over. Getting up, Mother went into one of the *brahmacharin*’s huts. Having seen several things scattered here and there around the room, she said, “A *sadhaka* should have order and discipline. In the olden days when a bridegroom went to see the bride for their first meeting to make the marriage proposal,

he would judge the girl's character by observing the cleanliness of the house and surroundings. Likewise, others learn by seeing the character and orderliness of Mother's Ashram children."

Another *brahmacharin* came to seek Mother's attention, as he had become angry about something someone had said. **Mother:** Son, imagine that we are everyone's servants. Suppose you become angry with someone who comes here because, he has become angry with you. If that happens, you should understand it is your ego that is the cause of your anger. Understanding this, you should immediately control your mind.

Children, when you see a person for the first time, greet him. He may not greet you back if he is an uncultured person. The next time you see him, greet him again. He might not return your greeting on that day either. The next day you should greet him again, without any hesitation or hatred. Then he will think, "This man has been greeting me for the last two days and I haven't greeted him back. Again today he is greeting me. It is not correct that I am ignoring him." Eventually, he will automatically greet you. In a like manner, if there is virtue in us, we can make everyone good.

The *brahmacharin* listened silently and then feeling full of remorse he prostrated at the Mother's feet.

The Mother walked towards her hut followed by Gayatri. At five, the *bhajan* (singing) before *Bhava Darshan* began. The Holy Mother sang,

*The sound OM is ringing everywhere
As an echo in every atom.
With a peaceful mind,
Let us chant "OM Shakti."
O Noble One who is adored by the Universe,*

*We come to know Thee well
When this Universe is understood to be worthless
Which so far was felt as great...*

Sreekumar played the harmonium and Venu the drums. Balu and the other *brahmacharins* and devotees sang along with the Holy Mother. The Mother's songs were poignant with love for God. Filling the atmosphere with waves of supreme devotion, the song penetrated the hearts of the *brahmacharins* and devotees. All were led into a meditative mood. Some could be seen silently shedding tears of inner joy.

Friday, 25th December 1981

The path of Knowledge is difficult

It was ten in the morning. Mother was giving *darshan* to the many devotees who were present. Some westerners from Kanvashram in Varkala arrived just then. Most of them were newcomers. One named James was highly intellectual and did not believe in God with form. He strongly believed that there is no truth beyond intelligence. He said, "There is a Cosmic Intelligence. I believe in that, not in Rama or Krishna or Christ. What I want is peace of mind which I don't have at all."

Mother: Son, if this is your belief, let it be so, but it is not correct to say that other paths are wrong and your path alone is true. You believe in a Cosmic Intelligence, don't you? That same Cosmic Intelligence we call Rama or Krishna or Christ. Whatever the path is, *sadhana* should be performed and God should be known through direct experience.

When we worship Rama, Krishna or Christ, we adore the eternal ideals which manifested through Them. If They were mere individuals, nobody would have worshipped Them. When They are worshipped, the true seeker is not adoring a limited individual but the same all-pervading Cosmic Intelligence which you believe is the only Truth. To climb a tree, we need a ladder or something else as a means. Nobody can simply reach the top of the tree in one leap. If somebody tries, it is certain that he will fall down and break his arm or leg. (All laugh) These names and forms will serve as ladders to attain the Supreme without struggling too much. Anyway, self-effort is implied in all paths. Self-effort and grace are interdependent. Without one, the other is impossible.

The path of knowledge is possible only for a few who have accumulated the necessary mental disposition from a previous birth. Regardless of which path is taken, there can be no problem if one has a real Guru. In meditation with form also we meditate on our own Self. In the midday when the sun is directly overhead, no shadow can be seen. The same is the case with meditation on a form. We become That. When you reach Perfection there is no shadow. No two. No illusion. Son, once you understand it from your own experience, Mother will not object. Your path is a difficult one, but anything can be gained, attained and accomplished if there is faith. When you say, "Mine alone is true," just remember that it is the same Intelligence which you believe to be the Truth that makes others set to work on their paths.

Son, you said that you have no mental peace. What is the use in saying "Intelligence, Intelligence" if there is no mental calmness?

Balu translated the Mother's words to James who seemed very satisfied with her advice. All the while, Ganga was

sitting near Mother. It was obvious from the expression on his face that he had something on his mind. Before meeting Mother, he had been practicing *atma dhyana* or meditation on one's Real Self. After seeing Mother, he had changed his meditation to *rupa dhyana* or meditation on a form. Yet, he couldn't persist in it with the same enthusiasm and inspiration which he had in the beginning and felt a bit confused. He wanted to ask Mother some questions, so he waited for her to finish her conversation with James.

Before Ganga could say anything, Mother turned towards him and said, "Son, do *atma vichara* (self-inquiry) if you find it difficult to meditate on a form. You have more attraction to that, but more attention is required in that path. Don't waste even a moment but continue to ask yourself, "Who am I?" or think, "I am none of this" even during the work which you may be doing. Ramana Maharshi (Ganga's previous ideal) was a supreme devotee who had the attitude that 'I am nothing.' Now, no one is applying that teaching of his. He did not want fame yet that and everything else came to him."

Ganga was happy to hear Mother's advice and at the same time astonished to find that Mother had understood what was on his mind even though he had not said anything about it to her. He became convinced that she was closely observing both his internal and external activities.

In the evening, Mother went to a devotee's house in Quilon, some thirty-five kilometers away from the Ashram. Every month this family would invite Mother and the *brahmacharins* to their house. Many people would come there to see Mother and listen to her *bhajans* and her words. The day of Mother's visit was like a festival for them. Today, Mother also took the Westerners with her. There were two cars. Mother, Balu, Gayatri, the mother of the family and her daughter with her three year old son traveled in one

car. Five or six rode in the other car and the rest took a bus. The Holy Mother first inquired about their family affairs. Then slowly the subject turned to spiritual matters.

Mother: Children, don't think that you can start spiritual life after satisfying all your desires. The desires will go on and on. It is a never ending circle. When one desire is satisfied, another will immediately come up. If somebody thinks he will take up spiritual life after fulfilling all his desires, he is like a person on the seashore who waits for all the waves to subside before taking a bath.

The housewife's daughter: Mother, what is the way to overcome desires so that people like us can get closer to God?

Mother: Daughter, the only way is to understand that each and every object that you desire is riddled with pain. If the desires are not controlled now, later they will control you and eventually they will swallow you. Mother doesn't say that you must give up all desires. You can enjoy them, but don't think that life is only for that. That is dangerous. Let us control them gradually before their grip becomes too tight. Strong determination is needed. Try to lead a happy life with what you have. If you have more, give it to the poor and needy. For example, if you have twenty sarees, why can't you give at least two of them to those who don't even have one good saree? Sometimes rich people will purchase two or three sarees a day and then nicely arrange them in their closet. Every morning they will look at them and feel happy about their great achievement. Children, just think for a moment. Is this the right way to live? Thousands of people are thrown in the midst of poverty and starvation while we go on enjoying. If all are God's children, then the poor are also His children. If so, they are our brothers and sisters who came from the womb of the same Mother. Instead of creating more and more negativity by trying to fulfill desires, why can't you help the poor? You can't take any

of these so-called achievements with you when you leave this world. Only the virtuous deeds that you have done remain on God's list. The final judgment depends on that list. Helping others means helping ourselves to expand and become purified. Gradually, we should decrease the burden of attachment. This will help to increase the peace we experience in our daily lives.

As the talk went on, the baby boy started to whimper. He caught hold of his mother's saree and asked for something to eat. Since there weren't any edibles in the car, his mother said, "No, wait until we reach home." The child kept quiet for a few moments, then again caught hold of her saree and repeated the same request. Now the mother became a bit angry and said, "Keep quiet. Let me listen to Mother's words." But the child was hungry and couldn't keep quiet. After a few seconds he began crying out, "I want something to eat. I want something, I want something to eat." The mother this time became really angry and hit the child, pulling his hand from her saree. Now the child fell on his mother's lap bursting into tears, calling "Amma...Amma..." Now the mother's face bloomed with love and affection for her child. Embracing him tightly and kissing both his cheeks several times, she consoled him uttering soothing words like, "Mother's darling son... don't cry..." She asked the driver to stop the car and get some bananas for him. This was done immediately.

Now the Holy Mother turned towards Balu and said, "Did you see that? This is the correct attitude that a true seeker or devotee should have towards God or Guru. He may scold you or even kick you out but you should not loosen your hold. Like this innocent child, go on calling Him with more and more intensity. Go on asking while catching hold of His Feet. The relationship of the child to his mother is so strong that he didn't feel any hatred or

anger towards her. Instead, he tightened his hold and finally laid down on her lap when she hit him. This was enough for the hidden compassion of the mother to overflow all its bounds. Son, this is the kind of attachment that a *sadhaka* should have towards God. Whatever happens, hold on to His Feet without loosening your grip even slightly. Then He is bound to shower His grace. Love with attachment to God is good, but not love with attachment to the world.”

By this time, the group had reached Quilon and everyone got out of the car. The family members worshipped the Holy Mother’s feet and offered *purnaḱumbha*.⁴⁴ Then they led her into their house. The devotional singing started at seven in the evening and went on until ten. Sometimes, in the middle of the Mother’s ecstatic singing, she would burst into blissful laughter, while at other times she shed tears of joy. Occasionally she sat motionless and was lost to this world. The devotees gathered there were full of bliss and remained spellbound until the end. When *bhajans* ended, Mother gave *darshan* and it was midnight when everything was over.

It was past one in the morning when Mother returned to the Ashram. She sat on the front verandah for some time. All the Westerners sat around her. *Brahmacharin* Madhu, who was a native of Reunion Island, was there. He didn’t know Malayalam, Mother’s mother tongue, and felt sad because he could neither understand what Mother said nor could he talk with her. Looking at him, Mother said, “Children (referring to the Westerners), Mother is deaf and dumb in front of you and you too are in the same situation. Mother has seen your happiness when she utters any English words. Mother doesn’t know your language. Mother

⁴⁴A full pot of holy water offered to God or holy persons as a form of reception.

knows that you are very sad about it. But Mother can understand the language of the heart. (Like an innocent child) Have you ever heard Mother speaking English? Yes, Mother knows some. (Pointing to Balu) He taught me a few words like (Mother recites, pausing after each word) ‘Open the door, congratulations.’ (All laugh – Mother also laughs, pointing to Sreekumar) He also taught me one or two words.”

After a short pause Mother continued, “You should love others without any desire or expectation. You need not love me or respect me. I won’t be bothered about it. Nor do I ask any of you to serve me. If you were to get involved in that you would become angry. You know, Mother is crazy, isn’t she? Visualizing each and every atom of this world as the Truth, serve all with an attitude of equanimity. Equanimity is God.”

Madhu: There is hope for us. It will be easy if Mother can learn English. She can do it. (Mother smiles)

Mother went to her hut after spending a couple more minutes with them.

Sunday, 27 December 1981

The Holy Mother always observes both the external and internal actions of the *brahmacharins* and instructs each of them according to their mental constitution. Sometimes the instructions are general, at other times very personal. These instructions are spontaneous and soul-stirring and come irrespective of time and place. Sometimes it may happen in the middle of working or while traveling or in the middle of devotional singing.

Today, while sitting with the *brahmacharins*, Mother said, “Either you should dedicate everything to Mother whom you say is all in all, considering everything as Mother’s Will, or you should have faith in yourselves. Inquire into your-

self believing that ‘I am the Self pervading the whole universe.’ You should always be determined to reach the goal. Also, you should always be attentive while performing actions.”

Subtle beings

The Holy Mother went to the Ashram library. A devotee who was reading there told the Mother about an experience he had with subtle beings. He asked, “Mother, are such experiences valid? Do subtle beings really exist?”

Mother: Everything depends on the mind. If you believe in subtle beings, then they will be there. If not, then no. There are many beliefs which are not scientifically proven but they still remain as facts because they can be experienced or seen, not with these external eyes but with the inner eyes. We cannot simply deny them because we haven’t seen them. After all, have we seen or experienced even a corner of this vast universe? Certainly not. Then how can we say that they (subtle beings) do not exist? There are many things that we cannot perceive with the external eyes but they still exist. For example, look at that ray of sunlight which is entering the room through that hole in the roof. You can see numerous dust particles moving in it. Then why don’t we see them when that shaft of light is not there? Aren’t they there even when the light is not shining through? Yes. Likewise, subtle beings are also there but our mind is not subtle enough to see them. When the mind becomes clear and subtle enough through *sadhana* then one can see them. But a *sadhaka* should not give much importance to such experiences. He must simply ignore them and transcend them. This is nothing compared to the experience that you are going to have. Be careful that these silly experiences do not create obstacles on your path and distract your attention from the Real.

Real Guru and disciple

Another devotee: Mother, what is the nature of a real *Guru-sishya* (master-disciple) relationship?

Mother: In a real *Guru-sishya* relationship it will be difficult to recognize who is the Guru and who is the disciple. The Guru has a more servant-like attitude than the disciple. The only aim of the Guru will be the advancement of the disciple. The Guru's sole intention is to somehow mend (improve) the disciple. The Guru will observe each and every action of the disciple. But the disciple will not know it. Do you know what a real disciple will be like? He will be one who serves the Guru with the attitude that the Guru shouldn't even know about his *seva* (service). *Seva* means obedience. Spontaneously, the Guru will shower his grace on the disciple who acts with *sraddha* (faith). When the field is low, water will naturally flow into it. No matter how high a mountain is, no water will collect on the top — it will always flow down into the stream. Son, humility and simplicity are the trademarks of a great soul.

At this time *Brahmacharin* Venu approached Mother with a question.

Venu: Mother, I have a big problem. I feel aversion to some people. What should I do to remove it?

Mother: Son, aren't you meditating on Bhagavan's (Lord Krishna) form? Son, you ask Him, "Kanna! Aren't You the one who shines in me? Do You have hatred towards anyone? Isn't it Your mind, free of attachment and aversion, that I should have?" We will not reach that Supreme Self if there is even an iota of selfishness.

Venu: Mother, is it possible to completely remove likes and dislikes through meditation?

Mother: Certainly! When the mind becomes pure through meditation, each atom can be seen as the form of one's meditation. Then we feel love towards all creatures.

We do not know anything. Everything is controlled by that Supreme Self. We are a log of wood in the water. The wood goes wherever the current carries it. It doesn't have any power of its own. This "I" should become a corpse. Only then will knowledge dawn. If a corpse is put in water, it will move according to the course of the current. The corpse doesn't have the feeling of "I." God can be seen only if we develop this attitude. Either proceed according to His Will, convinced that "Everything is You," or inquire "Who am I," having the strong conviction "Everything is in me."

Chandru, who had been sent to the Chinmaya Mission Centre in Bombay, was at the Ashram to spend a few days with the Holy Mother. He came and sat near Mother.

Mother: (To Chandru) When you come back after three years of scriptural studies, don't waste time saying "Shivoham, Shivoham" (I am Shiva) without any experience. Without becoming a caretaker of someone else's wealth, become the owner of it. What is said in the scriptures should be brought into your experience through *sadhana*. If the word "molasses" is written on a piece of paper and you lick it, you will not get any sweetness. Scriptures are pointers.

It was four in the afternoon and many devotees had arrived for the *Bhava Darshan*. They were all sitting around the Holy Mother on the verandah of the old temple. One householder devotee's family who had come for the first time was also there. Their daughter could sing devotional songs beautifully. Mother asked her to sing a song. She sang "*Atmavin Dukham*" (Sorrow of the soul). That innocent girl's poignant song, full of love and devotion, stole the Mother's heart and she became lost to this world. Though there were about two hundred people sitting around Mother,

complete silence prevailed. All silently gazed at the Holy Mother's face as if seeing an extraordinary sight. The *Bhava Darshan* started at seven in the evening preceded by the usual devotional singing by the Holy Mother and the *brahmacharins*. It was three the next morning when the *Darshan* was over. Werner, who had been sent to Tiruvannamalai, returned that day to spend some time with Mother. Mother talked with him for some time. He always had one complaint; the delay in attaining SelfRealization. The clock rang five as Mother went to her hut that day. There wasn't much time to rest. Some devotees were already waiting with a car to take the Holy Mother to Quilon to attend a program.

In the early morning the Mother went to their house with some *brahmacharins* and Gayatri. During the daytime, the *brahmacharins* conducted a reading of the *Srimad Bhagavata*⁴⁵ and chanted the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother. In the evening, many people came to participate in the *bhajan* and to receive the blessings of the Mother. After *bhajan*, Mother distributed *prasada* to everyone. With great enthusiasm, Mother went on talking with the devotees, making jokes and inquiring about their family affairs. Because of the *Bhava Darshan* the previous night, Mother had not slept. Some of the devotees felt very sad about this. Due to their persistence, Mother finally went to bed at one o'clock. But in a few minutes she came out and approached a person who had just arrived. Learning that Mother had gone to bed a couple of minutes ago, he had felt very dejected. He was a poor man who had come from a distant place only to see Mother. As he was cursing his own misfortune thinking, "I am a sinner. That is why I wasn't able to see

⁴⁵A devotional scripture describing the life and deeds of Lord Vishnu's Incarnations.

Mother,” he saw Mother walking towards him. He could not control his emotions. Bursting into tears, he called aloud, “My compassionate Mother, it was so kind of you to come and see this worthless son.” Mother spent a few minutes with him, consoled him and went to her room. It was two-thirty.

The next afternoon, Mother and the *brahmacharins* returned to the Ashram. In the middle of the journey, Mother said, “God takes a body not for the knowers of the Self (*vigñanis*). The *vigñani* doesn’t need anything. God’s incarnation is to bring the *agñani* (ignorant) to the correct path. It is not necessary to improve noble ones.”

She continued, “If you *brahmacharins* go to any householder’s house, you should stand in front of the house. Only go inside if they invite you. If you enter the house, go into the *puja* room and sit there. During your period of *sadhana*, you should not go to other rooms. If you are asked a question, reply in just a few words. Even then, be very careful and do not forget the goal. We cannot understand the mental attitude of worldly people. Their thoughts will affect us also. The presence of a lustful woman will create lust even in a lustless person. Butter will melt if kept near the fire. Keep this in mind.”

The car stopped at the Vallickavu boat jetty and everyone got out. The sun slowly journeyed to the western horizon as everyone crossed the river and reached the Ashram premises. Hearing the pitiful cry of a goat in pain, Mother hurried to that spot. A goat was lying on the ground and crying in great pain. This goat had been raised by Mother’s family and had great love for her. The family members and a couple of devotees were standing around watching helplessly. For a week it had been afflicted by a disease in its udders. None of the treatments proved fruitful and the disease had continued to worsen. By the time Mother reached

the goat it was nearing its end. The Holy Mother sat at a distance and became intensely absorbed in prayer and meditation. As everyone looked on, the goat crawled on its knees toward the Holy Mother. Having reached her side, the animal placed its head on her lap and gazing at her face, breathed its last. Seeing this extraordinary sight, everyone started singing the Divine Names and chanting the sacred *mantra* “Om Namah Shivaya” with great devotion. It was a blessed death.

Friday, 1 January 1982

Disease and medicine

The Holy Mother was sitting in front of the dining hall. Ganga, Venu and some other devotees were sitting near her.

For the past few days, Mother had been very sick. She had been afflicted with a terrible cough and pain all over her body. The devotees, to express their love and concern, had brought different kinds of medicines. The Holy Mother drank from each bottle each day to fulfill their wishes. Out of his love and devotion to the Mother, Ganga became a little bit angry about her irregular and unsystematic way of taking medicines.

Ganga: Why does Mother take all the medicines they bring?

Mother: Son, they will bring it even if Mother says that she doesn't want it. Then, what will Mother do? It is for their happiness and satisfaction that Mother takes all these. If it is not taken, they will become sad. Mother's disease won't go away because of taking these medicines. The diseases of others are affecting Mother. That should be exhausted through suffering alone. You need not get angry with them. Why should you fear if you have faith in Mother? There

is only one doctor to cure my disease — that is the Supreme Self alone.

One devotee: Mother, can't you remove these diseases which you take from the devotees without undergoing suffering?

Mother: Yes, they can be removed by burning them up in the Fire of Knowledge (*jñanagni*). Even then, a little suffering must be experienced. In order to show that by its very nature the body must undergo suffering, whether it is the body of a saint or a sinner, Mother accepts suffering. *Mahatmas* suffer in order to teach us renunciation (*tyaga*).

Another devotee: Mother, can yogis live without air?

Mother: Those who have reached a particular state can. They can live merely by breathing air from within, without taking it from outside. They can live even if they go beyond this atmosphere.

Devotee: Mother, I have made no noticeable progress though I have performed *sadhana* for a long time.

Mother: Children, even if we sit for twenty-four hours with closed eyes, nothing will be gained if God's grace is not there. God's grace and Guru's grace are one and the same. Many people come to Mother and say that they haven't had any spiritual experience in spite of their best efforts for many years. Children, what we are doing now is like filling a tank by drawing water from a well all day long, from morning till evening, and then putting a hole in the tank. What happens? All the water flows out and the tank becomes empty. All our efforts have been in vain. Likewise, we may do some kind of spiritual practice, but the energy which we gain from it is drained out by indulging in worldly activities. This is like producing sugar with one hand and bringing ants with the other. The ants will eat all the sugar.

One who does meditation can be understood from his character. His attitude will be "I am nothing." He will have humility. We should have the mentality to prostrate to anyone

without shame. The ego can be removed only if we develop an attitude that “I am the servant of everyone.” Only then is God’s Vision possible. The goal can be attained within two or three years if you can perform *sadhana* intensely. You must have detachment. Do you know what kind of dispassion you need? Intense. If you were lying in the midst of a blazing fire, wouldn’t you scream out, “Save me, save me!”? We only make that intense call when we come close to death, when death stands before us, isn’t this true? God should be called with that kind of intensity. Not much time is needed to attain the goal if God is constantly called like this.

Sunday, 3 January 1982

Though various medicines were given by different devotees, Mother’s cough went on increasing. It was heart breaking to see the Holy Mother coughing. This morning she again said to Balu, Nealu and Gayatri who were sitting near her, “Don’t worry children. In reality this is not bothering me as much as you think. It will only last for a few days. Anyhow, the body has to suffer even if it is only for a short period of time.”

Nealu: Mother, why can’t you stop taking different kinds of medicines? That is also harmful.

Mother: Mother wants to show that these medicines can do nothing unless “She” (Divine Mother) wills. (Mother coughs for a long time holding onto Gayatri’s shoulder while Gayatri softly rubs her back.)

Balu: Mother, it has already been a week since this started. I can’t bear to see Mother suffering like this. (His eyes become filled with tears)

Mother: All right, no more medicines. This cough will be gone by tomorrow evening.

It was ten o'clock and, although she was very weak, the Holy Mother came out of her hut to see the devotees. She spent three hours with them. Nealu, Balu and Gayatri were wonderstruck at the tremendous enthusiasm which they saw in Mother as she talked with the devotees.

Sundays are the most crowded days and many devotees had come. The Holy Mother received each one. The cough troubled her several times and the devotees were greatly pained at heart. A young man who was very devoted said, "Mother, it is unbearable to see you suffering. Give some of it to me."

Mother: (laughingly) This love is good, but son, you know, it would be impossible for others to bear even an infinitesimal fraction of this weight. Son, Mother is not suffering at all. The body is suffering a little. That is quite natural. But Mother's mind is constantly reveling in the *Paramatman*. Pain and pleasure are like the waves of the ocean. They come and go, but they are only on the surface. Beneath, all is calm and peaceful.

The daytime *darshan* finished at two-thirty. At four-thirty, the Holy Mother returned to begin the devotional singing before the evening *Bhava Darshan*. She sang,

*O blue clouds, how did you get this blue color, this
beautiful blue color which is the color of Nandakumara
(Krishna) who sported in Brindavan?*

*O my beloved Lord, is Thy Will to make me drown in
this excruciating pain of separation?*

*O Lord of my life, O Beloved, my All in all, I am
unable to go away from Thee. Please do not abandon me.*

The Mother was transported to another world. Her songs created wave after wave of devotional bliss. The devotees

also sang aloud, clapping their hands and seeming to forget all about their surroundings. She again sang,

O Divine Mother, O Great Goddess, O Thou whose nature is Illusion, O Creatrix of the Universe, O Mother, I bow to Thee again and again...

O Empress of the Universe, Blue sacred One, O Great Illusion with beautiful limbs, O Supreme Goddess, Thou art the Friend of the devotees granting both Liberation and bondage...

Bhava Darshan started at seven, and continued until four o'clock the next morning. At the end of the *Darshan*, the Holy Mother sucked blood and pus from the wounds of the leper Dattan.

After *Devi Bhava*, while Mother was still behind the closed doors of the temple, people could hear her coughing. It was amazing that she had not coughed even once during the entire *Bhava Darshan*. Finally, when she came out of the temple, she seemed like a mischievous innocent child, so brilliant and full of cheer. She moved among the devotees, cracking jokes and sometimes sitting on the lap of an elderly woman and giving a hit on one devotee's back. Then she played with her pet black and white dog for some time, riding on him and pretending to fight with him. While doing all this, Mother coughed several times, but still went on with her innocent play until five a.m. when she finally went to bed due to the insistence of some of the devotees and *brahmacharins*.

Monday, 4 January 1982

The previous day Mother had stopped taking medicines, but still the cough did not subside. Today, during lunch

she said, “Don’t worry about this body. Mother is not at all attached to it. (Pointing to her body) This is here to do service to others. This can be thrown away at any moment. Its health or disease depends on the needs of others.”

Today Mother fed one ball of rice to all present with her own hands. At two-thirty, she went to her hut accompanied by Gayatri.

The evening *bhajan* started as usual at six-thirty. The singing reached its peak as the Holy Mother sang,

*O Beautiful One, please come,
O Consort of Purandara (Lord Shiva),
Please come,
O Auspicious One, please come...
O Giver of radiance,
Thou art the All in all of those
Who consider Thee as their dear relation...
O Mother, please remain as the spring
Of my inspiration...*

Intoxicated with God-love, the Mother began dancing ecstatically. The *brahmacharins* went on singing with great devotion. Moving from the temple verandah towards the coconut trees in the front yard, she danced round and round completely lost to this world. She was showing a divine gesture (*mudra*) with her right hand. A beaming smile lit her face even in the dim light. This ecstatic mood had gone on for more than half an hour and it seemed as though there would be no end to it. Some sat near by and others at a distance watching the Mother. Some of the *brahmacharins* made a chain by holding hands to protect Mother from hitting the coconut trees. Eventually Sugunanandan, because of his usual fear that his daughter would leave her body soon if this state persisted for a long time, appeared on the scene. Without asking anybody’s permission, he carried

her into the hut and laid her on a cot. Mother was totally lost to this world and her body now seemed like a corpse. Sugunanandan later related, “The little one’s body was so light in weight that it felt like I was lifting a basket full of flowers, but her face was glowing like the rising sun.”

After two hours the Mother came out of this deep *samadhi*. She asked for something to eat and Gayatri served her rice and curry. She ate barely two balls of rice, then like a small child, she asked for peanuts and soon for “mixture” (a combination of various tidbits). Finally, without eating anything, she got up and went away. The most amazing thing was that, as the Mother had said on the previous day, the cough had mysteriously disappeared. No symptoms of it were seen from that evening onwards.

Wednesday, 12 May 1982

After the evening *bhajan*, Mother was sitting in front of the temple with *Brahmacharin* Venu and *Brahmacharin* Werner.

Venu: Mother, should incense be lit during meditation?

Mother: Children, you shouldn’t use incense in that way. That will create a distraction in the mind. Your attention will be diverted to the smell. For a *sadhaka*, it is not necessary. That is simply a sensual pleasure. It is impossible to control the mind without conquering the senses. Whether it is food, fragrance, the opposite sex, whatever it may be, do not think that you can satiate your desires by enjoying them. Each time you give in to enjoying the senses, your *vasanas* will only increase. All the five sense organs are here (pointing to her own head). (Pointing to the area between the eyebrows) Ambrosia is also here. But human beings do not want the ambrosia, they only want sensual pleasure. By comparison, sense pleasure is equal to excreta.

Venu: Yes, Mother, but how can we control desire?

Mother: Desires will not arise once love for God arises. Attachment to other things will automatically decrease. If intense love for God arises, you become like one who is suffering from a fever. A feverish person will not feel any appetite at all. He will not feel anything if he sees food, however delicious it may be. At present, due to a lack of intense love of God, you need control over the senses. Because of our addiction to worldly pleasures, in the beginning, we should physically refrain from indulging the senses. In this way the tendency of the mind to seek sense enjoyment will gradually decrease. In due course, the mind can be controlled through physical abstinence. A drunkard cannot help drinking while seated in the midst of a hundred bottles of liquor. Therefore, he must first practice physical control.

Venu: Mother, how can the sense of “I” be destroyed?

Mother: Either surrender everything to God or Guru and become the flute in His hands, or have faith in “I” itself. It is good for a *sadhaka* to sit gazing skywards. There is no movement in the sky. It is attributeless and formless. There is only undivided bliss. When looking down at the earth, there are ups and downs. There is no diversity in the Real Thing. Always be convinced “I am of the nature of *Satchidananda*.”⁴⁶ We can learn lessons from everything if we have *sraddha* (faith). Everything is the Guru. Absorb that essence from any object, then throw away the rest.

Sunday, 4 July 1982

Werner had been performing severe penance. For the past four days he had been meditating day and night without drinking even a glass of water. One *brahmacharin* told Mother

⁴⁶Pure Being-Awareness-Bliss.

about this. Mother replied, “I will not ask him to eat. You should also have such *vairagya* (detachment). There has even been a great change in his complexion. It is a sign of getting closer to the Truth. Let him continue his practice.”

However, Mother did insist that Werner drink some tender coconut water. Then she said,

“Remember that to blossom, a tree must shed its leaves. The flower of love is blossoming within, that is why your desires are falling away. But it is not enough if we attain Liberation through intense renunciation and then keep to ourselves. Our liberation should benefit all people. For that, this body should be taken care of. Not only that; we may have to take birth again if the body perishes before we attain Liberation. Then the work will increase again.”

Realizing with all humility that what the Holy Mother said was true, Werner started taking food from that day onwards.

Mother said, “Ten *sadhakas* like him is enough. I will become your servant if you are ready to sit like that. I will bring food to the place where you are sitting. Mother does not ask the *sadhaka* who meditates all the twenty-four hours to study as well.”

A group of young men arrived. Some were college students and others had already graduated. One was studying for his Master’s degree in philosophy. Many times such students came only to ask some inane questions that they hoped would leave the Mother speechless. Only a few such students were really interested in knowing the Truth. The former always left feeling disappointed or humbled, as the Mother always replied quickly with remarkable answers. The philosophy student asked, “Mother, have you taken *sannyasa*?”

Mother: *Namah Shivaya!* Mother is one gone crazy. Some children came here. Mother told them that such and such

is Truth. Mother did not ask them to believe it. Mother has only said, "Look within yourselves." They called me "Mother" and because of that, I call them "children." Mother does not know any more than that.

Young man: Has Mother attained Perfection?

Mother: If Mother says, "I am perfect," there also the "I" comes in. Whereas, in the state of Perfection there is no sense of "I." Not only that; such statements always have a feeling of ego implied in them. *Mahatma's* always set an example for the world through their humility and servant-like attitude. They do this hoping that others will follow. Therefore, Mother does not want to say such things. Anyway, everything depends on the children's faith.

The young men, particularly the one who had asked the questions, appeared to be deeply contemplating Mother's statement about Perfection. Afterwards, the philosophy student stopped asking questions and remained silent. Later, when they were about to leave, the philosophy student remarked to Balu, "To be frank with you, we came to corner her, but we failed in the face of her wisdom, humility and simplicity."

Sunday, 8 August 1982

Vasanas Negative tendencies

It was eight o'clock in the morning and the atmosphere was calm and quiet except for the reverberating pulse of the ocean waves. The ringing of a bell indicated the beginning of the morning worship service. The chanting of the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother could be heard from the temple. The Holy Mother was meditating under a coconut tree near the backwaters. One *brahmacharin* brought her a

glass of tea. After some time, she opened her eyes. Gazing into the water for a long time, possibly enjoying the dance of light and shadow created by the ripples, she gently tossed stones into the backwaters. There was a beautiful smile on the Mother's face. Having offered the tea to Mother, the *brahmacharin* sat nearby and said, "Mother, I am unable to cry and call to God."

Mother: Son, if you want to long to become one with God, you must feel sorrow. While abandoning all other desires, you should have the attitude, "God alone is enough for me." You do not feel this kind of yearning, because your renunciation is not firm. The Vision of God will not be gained so long as even one iota of ego is left within us. The mind must become expansive. Everything should be seen as One. Compassion must be felt for others' sorrows and their difficulties must be felt as our very own.

Brahmacharin: Mother, are *vasanas* the result of this birth, or do they come from previous births?

Mother: Child, impressions created by actions performed in previous births manifest in this birth. These inherited tendencies determine the course of action during this lifetime. We should exhaust these tendencies by doing spiritual practices and at the same time avoid creating new ones. Take ten eggs and keep them under a hen to hatch. Suppose that one of the eggs is that of a duck, but the rest of them are chicken eggs. After hatching, the duckling takes to the water immediately. But what about the baby chicks? Not a single one will get into the water. Similarly, our *vasanas* come here with us. They are derived from previous births.

A mother's thoughts during her pregnancy play an important role in developing the child's character. That is why, in the olden days, a mother would always chant the Divine Name during her pregnancy. If this is done, the child will also be one who remembers God.

As soon as such a baby is born, he starts asking, “*Enge? Enge?*” He is asking “Who am I? Where am I?” But what do we do? Quickly, we pick the child up and start to feed it. The baby relishes the milk. Later, if we give it fresh water, it will not drink the water. It wants only sweetened milk. It also experiences the comfort of the mother’s contact. After some time it feels sad if it does not get milk. After milk is stopped, other kinds of food are given. Thus the mother binds the child.

The first *vasana* in a *jiva* (individual soul) is God-given. From that arises *ḥarma* (action). From those actions arise new *vasanas*. All these *vasanas* accumulate as latent tendencies inherited from the previous birth. Eventually they spring forth as a new birth. This cycle will go on spinning like this. Liberation from *samsara* is possible only through elimination of these *vasanas*. All spiritual practices, like *satsang*, chanting the Divine Name and meditation are performed for weakening the *vasanas*.

At this time another *brahmacharin* asked, “Mother, what should I say at this evening’s speech?” At the request of some of the devotees, Mother had agreed to send one of the *brahmacharins* to give a spiritual talk at a nearby temple. He wanted to know from Mother how he should present the subject.

Mother: Before talking about spiritual matters, you should first understand what sort of people you are talking to. Many people cannot understand complicated, subtle *Vedantic* terms. Only bread and milk can be given to a small child. His stomach will be in trouble if you give him rice and sweet pudding. When you talk to today’s youths, many of whom do not believe in God, you might say, “Let there be no God, but do you believe in ‘I’?” We can tell them, “Try to know that ‘I.’” As far as possible, try to instill *bhaya bhakti*

(devotion with reverence) in them. The world will be benefited by that.

Tuesday, 10 August 1982

Sadhana and scriptural study

A discussion was going on about the syllabus to be used for the *Vedanta* course that the Ashram would soon be starting. Some scholars and philosophy professors were present. Each one gave his opinion about which teaching method and text should be used.

Listening to all of the suggestions, the Holy Mother said, “Mother gives importance to *sadhana*. Scriptural knowledge is also necessary. But more time should be spent on *sadhana*. Meditation should be practiced at least six hours each day. There is no benefit at all in mere studying alone. If you draw a picture of a coconut tree, it is not possible to quench your thirst by plucking a tender coconut from it, even if you think that you can. *Sadhana* should be practiced simultaneously with scriptural study. That will become a constant meditation. In any case, we must have innocence and sincerity in any work that we are doing.

“In the beginning stages, due to the power of the *vasanas*, it is difficult to focus the mind firmly during meditation. *Satsang* (companionship with Great Souls) is more beneficial during the early days. Meditation is also a type of *satsang*. There, the companionship is with God. But it will take some time for that state to come. In the beginning, *satsang* is more beneficial than meditation. *Satsang* can be a close association or companionship with a Self-Realized soul. It can also be the discussion or hearing of spiritual truths expressed by them, i.e. studying the scriptures. But studies shouldn’t make one egotistic. Remember that everything is

done to uproot the ego. In the former case, it is a direct physical, mental and intellectual relationship with a Great Soul. In the latter, it is also the same type of relationship, but indirectly — by studying, reflecting, and practicing their teaching. In both cases, the aspirant or devotee must have utter dedication and devotion supported by knowledge. Spiritual practice becomes smooth and less complicated in the presence of a living *Satguru*. Those are the souls with whom we must establish an unshakable relationship.”

As Mother was talking, her mood suddenly and completely changed. In a semi-conscious state she said, “Everything is nothing but that Supreme Self alone. There is no form, nor name, neither Krishna nor Rama, nor Incarnations.” Mother entered into an abstracted mood. Her body became still and her face shone with the light of perfect peace. Everyone gazed at Mother. Their faces beamed with great devotion and wonder. One of the scholars sweetly sang:

Salutations to that all-pervading, all-knowing, omniscient, pure, attributeless, unchangeable, formless Omkara, the Absolute Sound, the Unmanifest, the non-dual Turiya (the Fourth State of Reality beyond the three states of waking, dream and dreamless sleep), the Supreme Self.

It took some time before Mother came down to the physical plane of consciousness. A few more minutes passed and then the lunch bell could be heard. Everyone bowed before the Holy Mother and moved off to the dining hall. As they were walking, the scholar who had chanted the Sanskrit verses said to his friend, “After hearing Mother’s talk and seeing her state of *samadhi*, I really feel sad to think how fruitless our long years of study have been. Yes, my friend, it was a waste.” As he finished his sentence, he noticed one of the *brahmacharins* passing by. He shook his head and added, “Lucky fellows.” That evening during the devotional sing-

ing, the Mother became intoxicated with divine love as she sang:

*Aren't Thou my Mother, O aren't Thou the dear Mother
who wipes away one's tears?*

*Aren't Thou the Mother of the fourteen worlds?
O Mother, aren't Thou the Creatress of this world?*

*For so many days I have been calling Thee, O Supreme
Energy? Won't Thou come? Won't Thou come?*

Tears rolled down her cheeks. She laughed blissfully calling, “Amma...Amma...!” Now her mood was that of a perfect devotee crying for God’s Vision with an overflowing heart. There were many devotees present and all were spellbound hearing the Mother’s *bhajan*. Like her presence, her singing also gave tremendous solace to the devotees. Some sat in contemplation and others clapped their hands, their bodies swaying to the ecstatic music. The *brahmacharins* were totally absorbed.

Monday, 16 August 1982

After the evening *bhajan*, Mother sat with the *brahmacharins*. She called Gayatri and asked her to cut the apple offered by a devotee into small pieces. As Mother was serving it she said, “Human beings can learn many things from Nature. For example, take an apple tree. It gives all its fruits to others, taking nothing for itself. Its very existence is for serving other living beings. A river is the same way. Everyone comes and bathes in it. It washes away everyone’s dirt and expects nothing. It willingly accepts all the impurities and returns purity, sacrificing everything for others. Children, each and every object in this world teaches us sacrifice. If

you observe closely, you can find that all of life is a sacrifice. Each one's life is a story of sacrifice. The husband sacrifices his life for the wife and the wife sacrifices hers for the husband. The mother for her children, the children for the family. Each one of us is sacrificing our lives in one way or another. But all of us are limited to our own little world. Without sacrifice, there is no world. Sacrificing everything for the good of the world is the greatest sacrifice. This little world of ours should evolve until it becomes the whole universe. As it grows, we can see our problems slowly dissolving away."

Brahmacharin: Mother, is it possible to reach the goal through meditation only?

Mother: Children, patience is *tapas*. The mental impurities will be removed if one patiently and constantly meditates, sitting in one spot. If there is a Guru, the disciple only has to do his *sadhana* and the Guru will take care of the rest.

Brahmacharin: Mother, it is said that Sri Krishna was a perfect Incarnation. Is this true?

Mother: Children, if Sri Krishna is the ocean itself, then Sri Buddha, Jesus Christ and Sri Ramakrishna are each waves in the ocean. Sri Krishna is the Supreme Self having assumed a form.

Brahmacharin: Doesn't a *Jñani* attain Perfection when he gives up his body? Do such people come back?

Mother: Children, that depends on their will. Just as a rubber ball bounces back, a *Jñani* can go and come according to the *sankalpa* which he made at the time of leaving his body. He would never think, "If I come back, I will have to suffer." *Jñanis* are ready to take any number of births for the upliftment of the world.

Tuesday, 17 August 1982

The time was ten in the morning and Mother was sitting with the devotees. Venu, Balu and Unni were sitting with her.

Mother: Always move with faith. One who has faith (*sraddha*) will never swerve from the path. Remember the form on which you meditate while doing your work. When you see somebody, chant “*Hari Om*” or “*Namah Shivaya*” first. This will help to create Godly thoughts both in the other person and in ourselves. When you talk with someone, imagine them to be the form on which you meditate. Imagine the form of your meditation to be present in the atmosphere while you are traveling by boat, car, bus or plane. Time will not be wasted if this is done.

Never become weak-minded. Do not see Mother only as this body. Sorrow will be the result if you children think that Mother is limited to this body. Always know that Mother is all-pervading. Have faith that Mother’s Self and your Self are one. Have the conviction, “I have power, everything is in me.”

All human beings say “I”, “I.” You should remember that the “I” is the same in all. That person is “I.” This person is “I.”

Some time each day should be spent in solitude. Soon after getting up in the morning meditate for some time sitting on the bed. Then you will get alertness. It is not necessary to be concerned with purity and impurity (at that time). At night before going to bed, contemplate on all the actions done during the day and all the thoughts that you had. If you have committed any mistakes against someone, repent for that mistake. This will help you not repeat the same mistake tomorrow. Many trees joined together are known

as a forest. Many thoughts joined together are said to be the mind. Thoughts should be diligently controlled. Instruction should be given to the mind: “O mind, think of only good things today. You should not run after the sense objects that you see here and there. Many temptations will come to attract you. You should not even look at them. Stand firm in God alone.”

You should have *satsang* for some time each day. All of you children should gather together and discuss some spiritual subject. In this way, through various *sadhanas*, the mind should be concentrated on God.

Mother turned to Balu and asked, “Son, sing some songs.”

*O man, wandering around in search of worldly pleasure,
have you peace of mind even for a moment?*

*Without knowing the principles of virtuous living, you are
groping in the darkness of Illusion out of confusion.*

*Like the moth that rushes into the flame, you are fruit-
lessly destroying yourself.*

Mother and the other devotees sang along.

Wednesday, 18 August 1982

The previous evening’s *Bhava Darshan* ended about two in the morning, and due to the infrequent bus services at that time of night, many devotees planned to leave the Ashram early the following morning. Knowing that Mother would be in her hut resting, when it would be time for them to leave, many of the devotees wanted to take leave of her at the end of the *Bhava Darshan*. They would stand outside the temple until after *Bhava Darshan* and wait for Mother to come out. Even after she had sat for nine or ten hours

continuously, the Mother would go to the waiting devotees and once more console them with a touch, a word or a look until each one had been seen. Sometimes she would call someone who had wanted to speak privately with her. Finally, she would walk around the grounds to make sure that all her children had a place to sleep. Usually it would be at least four or five o'clock in the morning before she went to her hut to rest. This night was no different.

At four o'clock, one devotee, Velayudhan Pillai, woke up and called some other devotees as well. The Holy Mother had agreed to visit his house that day and he was very happy. Whether Mother had taken any rest could not be known, since she came from her hut at five, ready to go. Some of the *brahmacharins* and householder devotees joined Mother and set out for Velayudhan's house in Haripad.

Velayudhan's house and front yard had been so beautifully decorated to receive the Holy Mother, it seemed as though a festival was going on. Velayudhan's elderly mother and other family members had come out to the front gate to receive the Mother and lead her into the house.

It was a blissful day filled with the reading of the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, *satsang* and devotional singing led by Mother. After the *bhajan*, the Mother became absorbed in a semi-conscious mood. She began walking straight into the adjacent compound, then she crossed that property and entered the next yard. Gayatri, Velayudhan's mother and several other devotees followed her. As she entered the second property, she turned and said, "Do not come."

There was an old, small but beautiful Devi temple in that compound. Mother entered the temple and sat in deep meditation for a long time. Later, when she came out of the temple, she walked around it in an intoxicated mood for more than an hour. As she circumambulated the temple, she raised her hands to the sky and sang:

*O Mother, Supreme Goddess Kali,
 Today I will catch hold of You and devour You!
 Hear what I am saying!
 I was born under the star of death!
 A child born under such a planetary conjunction Devours
 it's own mother.
 So, either You eat me Or I will eat You today!*

The family members were amazed since no one had mentioned a word about that temple to the Holy Mother. Later, while talking about that particular incident, Mother said, "That temple is where many *pujas* (worship) were performed with concentration and devotion." The family who owned the temple confirmed that that had indeed been the case.

Thursday, 19 August 1982

In the morning the Holy Mother was about to return to the Ashram. Since there was not enough space in the car for everyone, some were asked to go by bus.

One brahmacharin: I will also go by bus.

Mother: Mother will neither say that you should go by bus or should not go. If she asks you to go, then you will say that she has no love for you. Son, you are too sensitive and are seeing Mother with the same attitude that you see the mother that gave birth to you. You must see this Mother as the Mother of all; then only can you grow spiritually.

The *brahmacharin* was about to get up and go to the bus when the Mother said, "Son, you don't have to go by bus. Come in the car." The Mother knew that even though he was boasting that he would go by bus, in reality he didn't want to.

Everyone returned to Vallickavu by eleven-thirty, just in time for lunch. While all the *brahmacharins* were still in the dining hall, Mother came in and told them,

“Whatever Mother says should be considered for the good of you children. Sorrow arises because there is desire. There is no sorrow if you think, ‘Mother is my own.’ You cannot make progress as long as you have selfish interests. You children should have the dedicated attitude of ‘I have offered everything to my Mother, I want nothing for myself.’

Today was a *Darshan* day and the devotional singing began at five o’clock as usual. Mother sang,

*Hare Kesava Govinda Vasudeva Jaganmaya
Shiva Sankara Rudresa Nilakantha Trilochana
Gopala Mukunda Madhava
Gopa Rakshaka Damodara
Gauripati Shiva Shiva Hara
Deva Deva Gangadhara*

Then,

*Parama Siva Mam Pahi
Sada Siva Mam Pahi
Sambho Siva Mam Pahi
Parama Siva Mam Pahi
Akshara Linga Mam Pahi
Ayyaya Linga Mam Pahi
Akasa Linga Mam Pahi
Atma Linga Mam Pahi*

Everyone became absorbed in the ecstatic singing.

Friday, 20 August 1982

It was nine in the morning and the Holy Mother was sitting in her hut. Gayatri was serving her tea. The previous night *Darshan* had ended at two-thirty, but Mother had not taken rest until four-thirty. Even if she didn’t sleep for days at a time, she was ever fresh and full of enthu-

siasm. The Holy Mother took the glass of tea from Gayatri's hand and after one sip, put it down. With a frown on her face she turned to Gayatri and said,

"Daughter Gayatri, you have not chanted even a single *mantra* while making this tea. If it were a householder who did this, I would have forgiven you and never said a word. But as a spiritual aspirant, you should be chanting your *mantra* constantly, especially when preparing something for Mother. Even the householder devotees are careful to chant their *mantras* while making something for Mother."

Saying this, the Mother put the tea aside without drinking it. Gayatri became dejected and stood there silently with her eyes downcast. It was true that she had forgotten to chant her *mantra* while preparing the tea. She had been in a hurry to make the tea while in the midst of doing numerous other urgent tasks. Realizing the seriousness of her mistake, she felt repentant and took the incident as a good lesson to remind her that Mother was always watching her inner thoughts.

At that moment, Venu entered Mother's hut and bowed before her.

Venu: Mother, when somebody prostrates to you, why do you touch their body and salute them?

Mother: Son, isn't everything the one Truth? Mother bows down to the Truth. I bow down to my own Self.

Venu: Mother told me that the relationship between Mother and me existed over a succession of several births? If that is so, I should have known the Truth in my previous birth, shouldn't I? Why was I allowed to lead a worldly life for all these years?

Mother: Light will be sought only if there is darkness. One can renounce a thing only if one understands the thing to be renounced. Shouldn't it be known that such and such is not the truth, in order to understand that the Truth is

God? For that, you should be in the world. *Jñana* will not be attained within only one birth.

Brahmacharin: Sometimes God will give everything to someone who does no *sadhana* at all. Yet He doesn't turn around and look even once at one who is striving so hard.

Mother: God's nature is like that of a child. To some He will give. To some others He will not give. To become worthy of His gifts, one should have inherited goodness from the previous births. A Perfect Master is capable of seeing these subtle aspects which others cannot see. God will become the servant of one who has innocence. No matter how much they strive, no further progress will be made by those who do not have innocence. But you should not worry about grace. Since you have a Guru, it is enough if you do your *sadhana*. You children can know the Truth if you do *sadhana* for four years as instructed by Mother. Many are not attaining anything even after doing years of *sadhana*.

Brahmacharin: Is God the servant of the devotee?

Mother: Yes, He is the servant of His true devotees. A true devotee is one who takes everything as God's Will, both bad and good. In reality, there is nothing bad for him. Everything is seen as good and beautiful to a true devotee. For him, all is God, so there is nothing to hate. Something is good and something else is bad only for a person who has likes and dislikes. But in the case of a real devotee, there are no likes and dislikes. He sees God's Divine Hand behind every experience and every act. For such a person, is there anything that could be called 'bad'? If he hates or dislikes something, it is the same as hating God, which is unnatural to him. In his world there is only love. To such a devotee, God is his servant.

Mother suddenly entered an abstracted mood. As if from another world she said,

“Children, Mother is the servant of every one of you. I do not have a particular dwelling place of my own. I dwell in the hearts of all of you.”

Brahmacharin: Mother, you say, “Mother does not know anything. Mother is nobody,” now and then. Why do you say this? It destroys our belief (*sankalpa*) that Mother knows everything.

Mother: Children, whatever Mother says, will there be a decrease in your *sankalpa*? Do you know what the attitude is of those who have reached Perfection? Their attitude is, “I am everyone’s servant.” To say that “I am *Brahman*” is also a movement. But there is no movement in *Brahman*. There is nothing to say when you reach there.

At this point in the conversation the Holy Mother got up and walked towards the coconut grove.

It was after lunch and the Mother was lying on the bare ground in the dining hall. Her behavior was often incomprehensible. There was no such thing as ‘preference’ and ‘choice’ for her. Most of the time she would do whatever she felt like doing. No one could insist that she do something or refrain from doing something, unless she was in the mood of an innocent two-year old child. On such occasions, she might ask permission, beg, or do as someone told her to.

One who closely observes Mother could distinguish the different moods and aspects which would manifest. At different times she was the Master, the Mother, the Father, the innocent child, the proficient administrator and organizer. But this same, all-powerful Mother could at other times be found lying in the muddy backwaters, or in the scorching sun or pouring rain, in the sand or on the bare ground. Sometimes she would ask for a particular dish of food and after it was brought she would taste a little bit of it and then stop eating it forever. Sometimes she would eat a lot, at

other times very little. Sometimes it would happen that she would not eat any food at all for days.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why are you so loving to small children?

Mother: Mother used to imagine the children to be Sri Krishna and would talk to them keeping them close beside her. Mother used to call them to come nearby saying that she would give them toffees. Playing and playing like this, she would see them as Lord Krishna and would become absorbed in deep meditation. Then Mother would completely forget about the children and after two or three hours would regain consciousness. Even at that time, those children would still be sitting there. As soon as Mother opened her eyes they would ask, “Auntie, toffee...” They were waiting for that.

Spending some time with children is a *sadhana*. A child has all the signs of one who has reached Perfection. Children’s innocence will reflect in us also. Forgetting everything, we will sit looking at them. *Vasanas* have not yet manifested in them and are only in the seed form. Children have the eyes of one who has attained Perfection.

Brahmacharin: Is it possible to verbally express the experience of reaching *Brahmapada* (the Absolute State)?

Mother: Son, if Mother were to give you a pinch, would it be possible to say how much it hurt? Just as a dumb person cannot speak about the taste of molasses after eating it, similarly it cannot be said that such and such is the experience of the Absolute. Mother has the conviction that all her spiritual children will have that experience. Knowing that, there is no reason for us to speak of all these things now.

Brahmacharin: It is said that the mind of a Knower of the Self will always be fixed on the Truth. How is that possible?

Mother: Son, they have dissolved their minds completely through constant and intense spiritual practices. As a result, their minds are fully fixed on the Supreme. Because they are one with That, they can see everything as That. As is the mind, so is the man. When they see an object, what they perceive is not the external appearance, but that which illumines it. For a goldsmith, all ornaments, regardless of their shape, are nothing but gold. Likewise, for a Knower of *Brahman*, everything is nothing but *Brahman*. Even if they talk to someone, they are only talking to *Brahman*. They talk only for others, that is all.

The sun slowly sank in the western horizon. The auspicious twilight time arrived. The horizon remained red as if the fire of separation from her beloved sun was burning within. The vibrations created by the Holy Mother's poignant songs filled the atmosphere with divinity and bliss. Her elevating voice transcended everyone else's as she sang,

*O Blissful One, O Absolute One,
Whose form is of unsurpassed beauty,
Crossing the six mystic centers, the yogis
Come to know Thee, the Invaluable Treasure.
Thy Glory, O Infinite Power,
Is however, only slightly known to them.*

The singing ended by eight and was followed by *arati*, the worship performed by waving burning camphor before the deity. Afterwards, some devotees sat inside the temple and others sat under the coconut trees. Ganga and Madhu, two of the *brahmacharins*, went to the seaside. Mother was lying on the southern side of the temple in the sand. After supper, the *brahmacharins* came and sat around the Holy Mother. Gayatri was fanning her. The sound of the waves and the blowing of the breeze from the sea made the atmosphere calm and peaceful.

Venu: Mother, what is the state of sleep like for one who knows *Brahman*?

Mother: He will be in full awareness. He knows that he never sleeps. He will be a witness to the sleeping state of his body. If you children try sincerely, you will have all such experiences.

Brahmacharin: Mother, is it true that Brahma, Vishnu and Maheswara (Shiva) exist?

Mother: Due to the Primordial Resolve, vibration arose in *Brahman*. From that arose the *trigunas* or threefold qualities of Nature, *sattva* (goodness), *rajas* (activity) and *tamas* (inertia). These three qualities are represented as the Trinity. All these are within each of us. In this universe, all that we see is in fact existing within us. For example, sometimes a man will have the cruel character of a tiger, sometimes the gentle nature of a deer. At other times he will have the forgetfulness of a lizard. His character changes like the color of the chameleon. All of these exist within. During a particular state of meditation, we can grasp the essential principles from any object we see. It will be possible for us to know the mind of anyone we see. Those who are not under the supervision of a *Satguru* will waste their time and energy to measure others' minds during this state. This will obstruct their progress.

Brahmacharin: Mother, Vivekananda did not have the same amount of devotion to a personal God as Sri Ramakrishna had, did he?

Mother: Vivekananda had a *Satguru* in Sri Ramakrishna. He had firm devotion and faith in his Guru. One who has a *Satguru* does not have to have a particular God. The *Satguru* himself is God.

Brahmacharin: Mother, it is said that in order to test Sri Ramakrishna, some money was put underneath his pillow and he got up trembling. Why did he tremble like that?

Mother: If he trembled, it might be felt by others to be a weakness because then he would have seen money as different from God. But for one who has known *Brahman*, everything is *Brahman*. There is no difference like good and bad. If difference arises, it is duality. Truly there is no duality, don't you agree? But that doesn't matter. Sri Ramakrishna was setting an example to show how much distance a devotee and *sadhaka* should keep from gold.

Avatar and jiva Incarnation and individual soul

Brahmacharin: What is the difference between an Incarnation and an individual soul?

Mother: In an *Avatar*, spiritual tendencies exist in a fully developed form from birth, whereas others have to develop such tendencies through effort.

Do you understand? From birth, a great musician has the talent for singing. He can sing any song beautifully after only five minutes of practice. An ordinary person will not be able to sing like that, even if he works at it for five hours. The *Avatars* come with certain abilities, others have to develop them. Anyone can become like that through constant practice. *Sadhana* should be done properly. Never become lazy. Do not waste even a moment. In the olden days, Mother would not sit idle even for a moment. She would always meditate. If someone would come to talk, Mother would see them as the form of Devi. They could talk as much as they liked. Mother would be focused on God. If one moment of focus was lost, Mother would feel terribly distressed and think, "O God, look at how much time has been wasted." Then I would do twice as much *sadhana*. You will quickly gain the results of your *sadhana* if you practice with an urgency like that. Being part of God, we

are all incarnations. We call Perfect Knowers of the Self, *Purnajñānis*, meaning Incarnations. Others, whose knowledge of the Self is only partial are called *jivas*.

Brahmacharin: It is said that *Atman* is the root cause of everything. If that is so, then it is the *Atman* which causes the senses to function. Why, then, should *Atman* not also enjoy the fruit of its actions (*karma phala*)?

Mother: In the phenomenal world (*vyavahara*) there is the *Paramatman* and the *jivatman*. It is the *jivatman* which experiences the fruit of its actions. *Paramatman* is merely a witness to everything. You could think of *Paramatman* as the stage on which this world drama is being played out. Without the stage there can be no drama; but remember, the stage still exists even without the drama. The Self, the *Paramatman*, is the substratum on which all activities take place. Even so, it remains ever unaffected. It is inactive (*nishkriya*). It does nothing.

Brahmacharin: Does one take birth even after attaining *Atmajñāna* (knowledge of the Self)?

Mother: After *Atmajñāna*, one may, at one's own will, choose to take birth. Mother is ready to accept any number of births to serve the devotees and the suffering and for the protection of the world.

It was just past ten o'clock at night. Mother told the *brahmacharins* to meditate until eleven and then go to bed. She then went to her hut. One by one the *brahmacharins* got up and went to their different meditation places.

Saturday, 21 August 1982

It was six in the morning and Mother was visiting a devotee's house in Quilon along with some of the *brahmacharins*. About twenty-five people had come to see Mother and listen to the *bhajan*. Pai began the program by reading

the *Devi Bhagavatam*. Now and then Mother would read a few lines. It was melodious to hear her reading. Sometimes she would abruptly stop reading and exclaim, “Hey Mother! Everything is a play for You, but don’t play your tricks with this one. Hey Kali, You can’t fool me. I am Your daughter, little Kali!” Hearing the Holy Mother’s recitation and seemingly light, but significant utterances, the devotees laughed wholeheartedly and seemed overjoyed.

In the evening, Mother led devotional singing from seven until ten. Then Ganga led the chanting of *Sri Lalita Sahasranama*. The whole house was filled with the joy and bliss of devotion. After *bhajans* and chanting were over, Mother spent even more time talking and comforting the devotees. The family members and friends served Mother and the *brahmacharins* with great love and reverence.

Kirtana in the kaliyuga

Devotional singing in the dark age of materialism

A group of women devotees were sitting around the Holy Mother. A few of them had taken a course in *Vedanta*. Mother said to them, “The goal is *Jñana*, but the means is *bhakti*. Children, *bhakti* is the path that leads to *Jñana*. Devotion and love for God are essential. In this dark age, more concentration can be gained through *kirtan*(singing) than through *dhyana* (meditation). Today, the atmosphere is filled with so many different kinds of sounds. Because of that, concentration will not come easily and meditation will be made more difficult than ever before. These obstacles can be overcome, however, if one performs *kirtan*. Not only that; the atmosphere itself will be purified by your *kirtan*. Innocence will arise in you if you travel on the *bhakti marga* (path of devotion). Through *bhakti*, you can look upon everyone with the attitude of brotherhood.

A woman devotee: Mother, isn't *jñana marga* also good?

Mother: Daughter, *jñana marga* is very good, but very few can follow it correctly. If you have a real Guru, you can travel the path of knowledge. When the ego arises in the disciple, the Guru understands it and immediately corrects the disciple. Because of this, the disciple will not swerve from the path. But, if there is no Guru he will think, "I am *Brahman*. I can do anything. I have no attachment to anything." In this way he will easily make many mistakes.

A person who accepts the path of knowledge without having a Guru is like one who studies for an M.A. degree without attending the first grade. However, some will become followers of the *jñana marga* by the inherited *samskaras* of their previous births. From birth they will have the vision of inner light.

Devotees have *dasatvam* (humility, a servant-like attitude). They will gain the attitude "I am nothing. Everything is God." They will become a blessing to the world.

Sunday, 22 August 1982

Mother started back to the Ashram from Quilon in the afternoon. On the way, she visited and blessed the homes of two devotees. As her car proceeded, Mother suddenly said, "Son, stop the car. One of my children is lying in his house crying. Mother had told him she would visit him. Quickly drive the car there." Immediately the car was redirected towards the devotee's house. Only after arriving did everyone understand why Mother was so adamant about going to that particular devotee's house.

The head of the house was an ardent devotee of the Holy Mother. He was lying prostrate in the family shrine room and, like a small child, was weeping profusely. His wife, who was standing nearby, had no idea what to do to con-

sole him. Seeing the Mother approaching, he got up and burst into tears again as he tried to say, “Mother, I thought that I must be a great sinner. Why should I live after coming to know that Mother had gone back to Vallickavu, without having come to visit like she said she would?” Mother replied, “How could Mother go back when you were weeping so much and thinking of her? My son, your innocence and love stopped Mother from proceeding.”

With great affection, Mother consoled the devotee and sang a few songs in the shrine room and then *arati* was performed. The devotee was very happy after seeing all this. Taking leave of the devotee and his family, Mother again proceeded on her way.

It was four-thirty when Mother arrived and many devotees had gathered for the *Bhava Darshan*. Straight-away, Mother sat for *bhajans*. It was amazing to see her so full of energy after two days of outside programs and the journey back to Vallickavu. All the others were quite exhausted.

Krishna and Devi Bhava ended by three a.m. Afterwards, Mother came out of the temple and began spreading sheets and mats out for the devotees. Some of the devotees pleaded with her to go and rest. Mother replied, “How can Mother rest inside the hut when her children are lying outside exposed to the cold? You children say that Mother should sleep. Likewise, Mother thinks you children should sleep comfortably.”

Monday, 23 August 1982

Control of food

It was five-thirty in the evening and Mother was sitting in front of the temple with the *brahmacharins*. Venu asked, “Mother, what is the reason for dietary restrictions?”

Mother: In the beginning stages, *sadhakas* should observe such rules closely. They should not eat delicious foods and as far as possible, avoid chilies and oil. As fat accumulates in the body, the amount of semen also increases. If the desire for tasty food increases and is indulged, the passions in the body will increase. For a *sadhaka*, it is better not to eat in the morning. At night, only a little food should be taken. Diluted milk and fruit can be taken moderately. Half of the stomach should be for food, a quarter of the stomach for water, and the remaining portion for the movement of air. A small amount of sweet can be taken, but salt should be decreased.

At a particular stage of meditation, one might feel terrible hunger. If certain kinds of roots and leaves are eaten, the *sadhaka* will not feel hunger. In the highest state of meditation, food can be given up altogether. One can live for any length of time on the *prana* (vital force) drawn from within. Tasty or otherwise, everything is the same for one who has attained Perfection. He can travel in any world. He will not have attachment to anything. He is beyond likes and dislikes.

Ekagrata One-pointedness

Brahmacharin: Mother, what is the purpose of doing *sadhana*?

Mother: Son, one-pointedness of mind is the purpose of *sadhana*. Always practice while sitting in the same *asana* (posture). *Asana siddhi* (perfection in sitting unmoved) should be acquired. We should be able to sit three and a half hours at a stretch. The spine will naturally be held correctly if we sit in *padmasana* (the lotus posture). One must attain concentration somehow. Wherever a man of one-pointedness may go, he will have no problems. He can travel in any

world and never swerve. One who has concentration can bring others to spirituality with only one look. Even other living creatures who touch the spittle of a Realized Being will attain Liberation. Even the mere ants creeping along his path will attain Salvation. A *sadhaka* should meditate at least eight hours each day. External actions should be done during the remaining time. Sleep should be reduced at a particular stage of meditation and sleep will spontaneously diminish.

It was dusk and the soul-stirring songs of the Mother resonated in the atmosphere sanctifying the whole village. She sang in a God-intoxicated mood,

*O Mother Divine, the Eternal Virgin,
I bow to Thee for Thy gracious glance.
O Maya, Mother of the Universe,
O Pure Awareness-Bliss,
O Beloved Great Goddess,
I bow to Thee.
O Mind of the mind, O Dearest Mother,
I am just a mere worm in Thy play...*

As the song ended, she became totally absorbed in a transcendental state. Alone in her world, she got up from her seat showing a *mudra* with her right hand uplifted. With faltering steps as if drunk, she gently swayed from side to side in that mood of inexpressible divine bliss.

Those who stand on the shore can only see the flag of the ship which passes across the mid-ocean. The ship will be completely invisible. Likewise, we stood gazing at the moving image of the Holy Mother. Where is her real form hidden? Her divine nature is concealed from us beneath the layers of this ocean of ever-changing Illusion.

Saturday, 28 August 1982

The time was nine-thirty in the morning and the devotees were preparing flower petals for *Devi puja*. Mother joined in the preparations. She told the devotees,

“Concentrating on each action, we should proceed with attention (*sraddha*). *Sraddha* is the most important thing. Every action should be done as an offering to God. Without external alertness, internal alertness is not possible. If one has *samatva buddhi* (equal-mindedness), *shanti* (peace) will arise. Everything should be seen as One. There is no one to hate if we see ourselves and others as one.”

Dhyana and Brahmanubhut Meditation and experience of the Absolute

After the *Devi puja* worship was over, Venu came and sat near the Holy Mother. “Mother,” he asked, “no matter how much I try, I do not clearly see the form on which I am meditating (*dhyana rupam*). Why is this?”

Mother: Son, it will take a minimum of at least four years for the form to become clear and fixed within. In the beginning stages you should try to attain concentration by sitting and looking at the form. First, sit with your eyes closed for ten minutes, then spend the next ten minutes looking at a picture of the form (on which you are meditating). Initially, external alertness is necessary. If there is no alertness in one’s external nature, it will be impossible to conquer one’s internal nature (*antarika prakriti*). Anyway, you must be persistent in your practice if you are to attain realization of *Brahman*. Once you know that you are *Brahman*, there is nothing else to be known.

Brahmacharin: Mother, what is the state of *Brahmanubhuti* (experience of the Absolute)?

Mother: In *Brahmanubhuti* there is *anandam* (bliss). There is neither happiness nor sorrow. No “I” nor “you.” It can be compared to deep sleep, but in *Brahmanubhuti* there is complete and total awareness. In deep sleep there is no “I” or “you,” but there is no awareness either. It is when we wake up from sleep that I, you, yesterday, today, and all the rest of it comes, isn’t it? *Sahaja samadhi* (the natural state of abidance in the Absolute) is *purnam* (fullness, perfection). In that state, the mind has attained complete absorption.

Brahmacharin: Sri Ramakrishna used to pray, “O Mother, do not make me mad with *Brahmajñana* (the knowledge of Brahman). It is enough for me to become Your child.” Why did he pray like that?

Mother: Form is a ladder on the path of devotion. The devotee wants only to be God’s servant. Even after attaining *Brahmajñana*, a true devotee will want to continue to serve. In order to drink the sweetness of devotion, he will again come down. He will intentionally retain a devotional attitude. No one can be satisfied once they have enjoyed the *rasa* (essence or sweetness) of *bhakti*. Didn’t Sri Krishna Himself incarnate as *Gauranga* just to experience the *rasa* of *Radha bhava*?⁴⁷ Children, the sweetness of devotion is something special. *Brahman* has no name or form. It is infinite like the sky and is eternal. When we are believing in name and form, we are believing in the non-eternal. After attaining *Brahmajñana*, the true devotee can by his own *sankalpa* perform *rupa dhyana*.

The Holy Mother manifests all the signs of *parabhakti* (supreme devotion) that the great sage Narada has described. In the early days when she was performing *sadhana* to realize

⁴⁷Gauranga or Chaitanya Mahaprabhu of Bengal had the attitude of Radha, Sri Krishna’s Beloved, His greatest devotee.

the Divine Mother, she suffered the excruciating pain of separation from God. If she happened to forget the Divine Name for even a single moment, she would feel extremely dejected. To make up for the loss of time, she would chant or meditate with even more intensity. She saw everything as Devi; and in that mood she would even embrace the trees, actually feeling them to be the Divine Mother. Sometimes she would sit for hours on the banks of the backwaters, touching her nose on the surface of the water as if kissing the ripples. At other times, if she happened to see some women or girls dressed in sarees, she would run to them and embrace them calling, “Amma...Amma!” Now the Holy Mother is sharing her own experiences with her children and devotees. The Holy Mother has on occasions said, “Even now I am struggling hard to keep my mind down here. Especially while singing *bhajans*, it is always shooting up.”

Mother continued,

“While taking each flower into your hand to offer during the *archana* (the chanting of the Thousand Names of Devi), the Beloved Deity’s form should be remembered within. Then it should be imagined that the flower of the mind is being offered to God. Alertness (*sraddha*) is what is necessary. It is enough if you have *sraddha*, *sahodhara buddhi* (brotherly attitude) and complete faith. Progress will occur by and by. If there arises an iota of ego in the *brahmachari* children’s hearts, Mother will rub it and remove it that very moment. Mother is ready to take any number of births to serve the devotees, but Mother cannot become the servant of the ego.”

The bell was rung for lunch. There were no visitors today, only *brahmacharins*. Mother came to the dining hall and laid down on the floor. Calling aloud, “Shiva...Shiva...Shiva...,” she playfully pounded on anyone sitting nearby. Some of

the children would intentionally sit close to Mother so they could be a part of the play when she was in that mood. They considered it a great blessing.

As the *brahmacharins* watched Mother, her mood took a sudden change and she began rolling on the ground with her hands showing a *mudra*. Apparently, her mind had soared to some exalted plane. Her eyes were closed and a statue-like stillness came over her body. She was in a totally absorbed state. Gayatri fanned the Holy Mother, while some of the *brahmacharins* looked on, and the others meditated. It was almost an hour before Mother returned to her normal consciousness. When she opened her eyes, she asked for some water, which was promptly brought.

The Holy Mother has many times said, “If Mother expresses a desire, it is only to give you a chance to serve. It also helps me keep the mind at this level of existence.”

Wednesday, 1 September 1982

Today Mother was visiting *Brahmacharini* Vimala’s house in Vallickavu. From the very beginning of the Mother’s divine moods, that family had been extremely devoted to her.

Mother was sitting in the backyard of their house. It was five o’clock in the afternoon and the atmosphere was calm and quiet. The devotee’s family deity was the snake god and there were a number of small shrines situated randomly about the yard. On the western side of the old style Kerala house there were bushes, flowering plants and creepers. All of this gave the property the gentle appearance of a hermitage. Pai, Ganga, Balu, Venu, Ramakrishna, Gayatri and Vimala, along with the elderly mother of the house, were sitting near the Holy Mother. Venu asked about his Sanskrit studies.

Mother: Venu is a bit crazy about Sanskrit, but fascination for anything other than God is dangerous.

Pai: Mother, is there another birth for one who leaves his body after reaching the Supreme State?

Mother: Even after giving up the body, Realized Souls can, by their own *sankalpa*, maintain a subtle, separate existence. They do not have to completely dissolve in *Brahman*. By their own self-will they can again accept a body. They will come back only if they wish to do so for the benefit of the world.

Sarvatra samadarshinaha Seeing all as One

Venu: Mother, what do you expect from me?

Mother: Son, selfless service, even-mindedness, seeing good even in the mistakes of others; these are things which Mother wants from you children. If you children love Mother, you should love and serve all living beings. Only then can it be said that you love Mother. Do not think of your own comfort. Do not think even for a moment that “this is my body.” See everything as your own *Atman*. When others talk to you, listen carefully and observe even-mindedness (*sama chittata*). Talk to them only after they finish speaking to you. Aversion should not be felt towards anyone. Like a river flowing without hindrance, let your mind flow with the sound “*Hrim*.” You should have an unbroken remembrance of God. That cool air will give freshness to everyone. Whenever you see someone, remember God’s Form. Then knowledge will rise up from within you.

Son, there is only one Self. That Self is omnipresent and omnipotent. When our minds become expansive, we can merge with that infinite Self. Then there will be no selfishness or ego. There will only be vastness and everything

will be equal. To attain that, you children should serve others without wasting even a moment. Help the suffering. Do not expect anything from anyone, either mentally or physically. For a *sannyasin* there is no particular God dwelling in the sky. Both heaven and hell are on earth alone. The only thing he has left to do is to see God in everything. For a true seeker, Guru is everything. In fact, Guru and God are one. Guru's will is God's Will.

Usually the Guru will give the ochre cloth to a disciple only when he has reached an advanced spiritual state. In that advanced state, the disciple no longer prays for anything for himself. He understands that God has no form and is infinite. When our ignorance is removed, we can see everything equally in any circumstance.

Ganga was also sitting nearby listening to what Mother was saying. He was looking down, hanging his head. Turning to him, Mother said,

"Son, you had a desire to wear ochre cloth. You believed that it would help you overcome worldly desires. Mother did not give the cloth when you first came here, because at that time your expansiveness was still covered over. You only talked about *Brahman*, you did not go deeply into the matter. As far as you were concerned, there was no God. You thought only Ramana Maharshi was great, not any one else. Even with that attitude, you did not try to understand who Ramana really was. You only saw his "personality." You did not try to study Ramana, or think about his equal vision, selfless service and devotion. You were convinced of your importance, thinking 'I am the greatest.' Darling son, at least now, you should correct this attitude."

5 September 1982

Guru mahima Guru's glory

A doctoral research student named Mahatti, came to see the Holy Mother from Tamil Nadu. Mahatti had been interested in spiritual matters from a very young age. *Brahmacharin* Madhu from Reunion Island had told her about Mother. She needed an interpreter, so Mother sent for one of the *brahmacharins*.

The first *brahmacharin* to come for interpreting the conversation had been scolded by Mother earlier that morning for not milking the cow on time. In response, he had replied, "I can't" in a caustic and hostile tone. Mother calmly replied, "Son, you can say anything to Mother and Mother will forgive you. But Nature is not like that. Nature records your every word and does not forgive so easily. Words should never be uttered in that tone and attitude by someone who practices meditation." Mother called another *brahmacharin* and the conversation began.

Mahatti told Mother about certain spiritual experiences which she had had and sought Mother's instructions regarding her further spiritual advancement.

Mother: Daughter, do you have a personal deity?

Mahatti: No, I don't. I have no inclination at all towards any form of God or Goddess. But I have an intense thirst to realize the formless Self.

Mother: Daughter, name and form are ladders to help us reach the Formless. Those of us who perceive ourselves to be limited cannot conceive of the Unlimited. A form is needed to reach the Formless. Another thorn is needed to remove the thorn which has pierced our foot. Once the thorn is removed, both can be discarded. Likewise, after reaching

the ultimate goal you can abandon all names and forms if you want. Child, even when you meditate on the formless Self you need a pure *sankalpa* (conception). That is also a concept, isn't it? Even when you meditate on the form of a God or Goddess, you are not really meditating on an external object but only on your own Self.

Mahatti: That is a convincing point, but can Mother suggest another method which my mind will more readily accept?

Mother: Mother can understand your difficulty with meditating on a form. Therefore, whenever you feel like it and have the time, sit in solitude and try to visualize everything as pure light. Look at the vast sky and try to merge into that expansiveness. Look within and observe the thoughts and trace them back to their source. Give instructions to the mind such as, "O mind, why do you crave these unnecessary things? You think that this will give you happiness and satisfy you, but it is not true. Know that this will only drain your energy and give you nothing but restlessness and unending tension. O mind, stop this wandering. Return to your source and rest in peace." Try this, daughter. This will enable you to gain peace and tranquillity.

Hearing the Mother's words, Mahatti's face became bright and her smile revealed her inner joy. "Mother, I am so happy to hear these instructions, which fit exactly with my mental makeup. I am very grateful to you for this valuable piece of advice. This will remove a lot of struggle in my search to realize the Supreme." Mother affectionately patted her back as she prostrated.

Mother came out of the hut to attend to the other devotees who had been waiting. She sat on the verandah in front of the temple and one by one the devotees prostrated and sat nearby. A few of the *brahmacharins* were also present. One *bramacharin* seemed dejected and Mother asked him why. Even though she is aware of everything, she also knows

the soothing affect her motherly inquiries have on the hearts of her children.

Brahmacharin: Mother, before meeting you I was a devotee of Lord Krishna, but now I don't feel that way. Now I feel that everything is Mother alone.

Mother: Son, one who has a real Guru will feel no need for any other particular God. One can say that God and Guru are one, but a disciple will always have a higher place in his mind for the Guru than for God. Son, don't think that the Guru and one's Beloved Deity are two. In reality, they are one and the same.

Brahmacharin: Mother, what books should we be reading?

Mother: The *Srimad Bhagavatam* is good. All the inner principles are explained in it. A storyteller will not start telling the story from the very beginning. At first, he will amuse the people by telling certain other incidents. Once they start paying attention, then he will begin the real story. The *Bhagavatam* is like this. After many, many interesting stories are told, gradually they start telling the Real Principles. It is enough if you read only the eleventh chapter. All spiritual principles are contained in that one chapter.

In the beginning stages, aspirants should only read books like the *Bhagavad Gita*, the *Bhagavatam* and the lives and teachings of great saints and sages. Devotion must be developed first, then *jñāna* can be pursued. Otherwise the ego will become strong.

After reading *I am That*, Venu is imitating certain teachings contained in it without fully understanding the real principles. What Nisargadattā Maharaj (the author, a great *jñāni*) says is that he served his Guru with absolute faith for three years. He had perfect devotion to his Guru. It was only in the end that he said, "I am That, I am Brahman."

Brahmacharin: Is meditation on a form necessary, Mother?

Mother: Son, when we meditate on a form we attain peace and concentration. It is not the form that we attain. Through meditation on form dissolution of the mind (*laya*) will take place. In reality, even when meditating on a form, we are meditating on our own Self. Form is but the ladder to realizing the Self. After some time, the form will be felt to be a mere shadow. All experiences can be gained by ascending this ladder.

Wednesday, 8 September 1982

Today, Mother visited Srimati Mohanan's house in Quilon. She was an ardent devotee of the Holy Mother. It was ten in the morning. Mother sat on the front verandah conversing with Srimati Mohanan who asked, "Mother, while in the state of *Krishna Bhava*, do you return to your normal state now and then?"

Mother: No, only Krishna alone is there. There are many who still do not realize that Mother is assuming *Krishna* and *Devi Bhavas* by self-will and that Mother and Krishna are one. Even so, they have a special love and reverence for Mother and Mother will strengthen their faith. For now, seeing Mother and Krishna as two is helpful for the progress of their devotion. The feeling that both are one would shake their devotion. *Bhaya bhakti* will go. Mother will play with them and crack jokes, won't she? That is why they also think, "This innocent child (the Holy Mother) cannot be Krishna or Devi." People tell Mother so many things during *Bhava Darshan*, which they would never reveal to her during ordinary times. They believe that after Devi and Krishna have heard them, they will go away and nobody will know anything they have said.

The *brahmacharins* felt a little saddened to hear this reply of Mother's. When Mohanan went into the kitchen, Mother

turned to them and said, “You believe that everything is your Mother, but do not try to make others understand these things in that same way. It is all right if they see Mother and Devi or Krishna as two; they will still benefit greatly from their devotion.”

It was afternoon and Mother was lying on a cot with her head and feet resting on the laps of two of Mohanan’s children. Mohanan was fanning her. A few of the *brahmacharins* were also sitting on the floor nearby. Mother told them, “If one practices celibacy for twelve years, a new nerve will be created in the body. The power of the seed which ordinary men throw away for the sake of trivial enjoyment is changed into nectar. As concentration deepens, the length of the tongue will increase and then, bending back, it will rise towards the top of the head through a hole in the palate. During a particular state of meditation, some will drink this nectar by slightly severing the tendon that joins the tongue to the throat. Thus, if a single drop is imbibed, they become immortal. This is the inner meaning of the saying that the gods used to quaff nectar. Remember — it is this power that is lost each time a drop of semen is lost. Such discharges will take place both in men and women after the age of fifteen. Sometimes this loss will also occur while dreaming. This will not happen if we are alert during sleep. Do not eat foods cooked with a lot of oil. Try to overcome any attraction to women by seeing each as your Mother. If a lustful woman passes by, it is enough to make a lustless man become lustful. We can experience real and lasting elevated states if the power of celibacy is acquired. **Brahmacharin:** Even though I have done intense *sadhana* for so many years, my mind is still restless. I think this is due to the lack of Mother’s grace. Therefore, starting tomorrow, I am going to take a vow of silence and fasting.

Mother: Son, how will you get grace so long as you are thinking “I am doing?” Quite the contrary, you should have the attitude of surrender and the feeling that “I have offered everything to Mother, Mother will save me.” Your attitude is not one of renunciation (*sannyasa*). Mother will not let you walk along whatever path you like. Your thought should be, “I am doing *sadhana* not for my own selfish purposes, but for the benefit of the world.” Son, do your *sadhana* sincerely and with the utmost care. Don’t waste your energy thinking of the fruit. It must come if your effort is sincere and intense. One must forget the fruit of the action if one really wants to get the full benefit of it. Patience and self-surrender are very necessary for an aspirant.

Friday, 10 September 1982

It was Sri Krishna’s birthday and the Ashram and surroundings were being prepared for the auspicious celebration. The reading of the *Srimad Bhagavatam* had already begun. The Holy Mother also participated in the recitation by reading and listening.

As is typically celebrated on Lord Krishna’s birthday, *Uriyadi* began in the evening. *Uriyadi* is a folk custom that depicts the childhood sportings of Lord Krishna (in particular His escapades of stealing butter, milk and curd from the houses of the *gopis*). First, Mother dressed the young village children to look like Krishna and the *gopas* (cowherd boys) and each would carry a staff in his hand. A clay pot containing butter, milk and curd would dangle from a rope slung over a bamboo pole thirty feet high. As the boys came dancing up to the pot aiming to break it with their staffs, the pot would be pulled up and down and swing like a pendulum. At the same time, two *brahmacharins* stood on either side splashing water in their faces as they ran by.

This game went on until seven in the evening. The Holy Mother, like a small child, was laughing and clapping her hands in the merriment of the play. A sweet and blissful expression could be seen on the faces of the devotees.

That evening *bhajan* lasted a long time. While the praises of Sri Krishna were being sung, an old-style Kerala folk dance called ‘*Tiruvatira Kali*’ was performed by the women and young girls. After that, Mother sat in the front yard of the Ashram with some of the *brahmacharins* and householder devotees.

Venu: Mother, what is experienced in *samadhi*?

Mother: There is only bliss in that state. There is no happiness or sorrow, no “I” or “you.” *Samadhi* can be compared to deep sleep, but there is a difference. In *samadhi* there is full awareness(*jñāna*). However, after sleeping, no new awareness has been gained. Instead “I,” “you” and the world again emerge. Because of our ignorance, we feel that “All this is real.” To remove this ignorance, we should constantly practice fixing our minds on one object.

Ganga: The *Puranas*⁴⁸ say that Vishwamitra was a Realized Soul, yet he was sometimes seen as being extremely hot-tempered. Why is it so?

Mother: Son, whatever a Perfect Being does is for the benefit of others. In reality, Vishwamitra was only testing the devotion of Harischandra, his disciple. Similarly, all the quarrels made by the sage Narada were for the benefit of others.⁴⁹

Ganga: That reveals a lot. With Mother’s grace, I can do many good things in this world.

⁴⁸Ancient scriptures written in story form by the sage Vedavyasa.

⁴⁹Vishwamitra deprived King Harischandra and his wife of their kingdom and put them through other intense and prolonged trials. Likewise, the sage Narada also has been depicted as doing similar things.

Mother: Son, you should have your own power. Mother is telling you that there is no difference between she and you. Even so, due to ignorance, you cannot see the all-pervading Truth. Therefore, try to see everything as Mother's form.

Do not become angry with anyone. If somebody gets angry with you, immediately think, "The thing which is called 'I' is the same in me and in him. That 'I' is the *Atman*. *Atman* is only one. So who is there to get angry with?"

One-pointedness

Brahmacharin: Mother, how can concentration be gained?

Mother: Son, if you have an intense desire to reach the goal (*lakshya bodha*), one-pointedness (*ekagrata*) will be gained. There was a boy who had never done any work in his life. His father was a coconut tree climber by trade. One day the boy's father died. After his death, all the people would still come and call the son to pluck the coconuts from their tree. But what could he do? He didn't know how to climb coconut trees. The boy couldn't find any other way to earn a living, so he decided to learn coconut tree climbing. Of course this had to be learned with great care. If he happened to fall, his arms and legs could be broken and then he would never be able to climb the trees. His life would be wasted. Therefore, with great care, he tried to climb up the tree. Placing each foot with utmost care and embracing the tree tightly, he would climb a little ways and then come down. The next day he would climb a little higher. In this way, after several days he learned coconut tree climbing. Through practice, he was able to ascend and descend the tree very quickly.

A *sadhaka* should be like that. God alone is Truth. Only if this is realized will life be fulfilled. God-Realization alone is life's goal. That alone is the food for all eternity. But there are obstacles in the way of reaching there. If you

don't use immense care, you will slip and fall. One's life will be wasted if one falls down. We should have this kind of attitude in the beginning stages. Only then will concentration be gained. Children, try for That.

While singing *bhajans*, the Holy Mother rejoiced and danced blissfully like an innocent child. This made the devotees feel like Lord Krishna had once again taken birth. Everyone was happy and content.

At around ten o'clock, the *Srimad Bhagavatam* was read again, especially the chapter describing the birth of Sri Krishna. At midnight, *bhajan* and *arati* were performed in honor of the auspicious moment of Sri Krishna's birth.

Wednesday, 15 September 1982

Gudakesa Conqueror of sleep

It was quarter past five in the morning and *Bhava Darshan* was just ending. Even after sitting continuously for thirteen hours without moving from her seat, the Holy Mother was still energetic. She did not go to her hut but remained with the devotees and began talking to them.

Ramesh Rao was a young man from Haripad who wanted to stay in the Holy Mother's presence. He had been forcibly taken by his family and friends to a mental hospital in Trivandrum to undergo a series of treatments for mental abnormality. Pai, a close friend of Rao's and a spiritual son of the Mother, told her what had happened. Mother sat quietly in deep thought for a long time.

Brahmacharini Gayatri had been recently admitted to a hospital in Quilon after symptoms of cancer had been detected, and on this day she was to undergo surgery. It was Mother who had first pointed out to Gayatri that she

was suffering from cancer and had instructed her to immediately get medical care. The diagnosis merely proved the truth of Mother's words. This was not a wonder to anyone, as they all were well aware that Mother knows everything. Yet the news of Gayatri's operation had created a feeling of sadness in everyone's mind.

Now and then the devotees would invite Mother and the *brahmacharins* to their homes and the day would be spent blissfully singing, reading the *Bhagavatam* and conducting the *archana*. The previous night, a woman had come to the Ashram to invite Mother to her house the next day. It was not a good time to leave the Ashram, since Mother had many things to do in connection with Gayatri's operation, with Rao's matter, as well as with other Ashram matters. Mother explained all this to the devotee and said she was unable to visit her house on that day. The woman left with a dejected and disappointed mind.

For the past two days, Mother had neither slept nor rested. It was early morning and Mother was getting ready to visit Gayatri at the hospital. One *brahmacharin* requested, "Mother, please sleep a little." To this Mother replied, "It is not for sleeping that Mother has come here. All of you can sleep. Mother has to take care of so many children."

Saturday, 18 September 1982

Mother of the house

Today, because most of the *brahmacharins* were bed-ridden with a severe fever, all of the Ashram work such as sweeping the grounds, cooking meals and cleaning the vessels and utensils was done by Mother. Just as their natural mother would have done, the Holy Mother made hot gruel and took it to each one and made sure they drank it. Even in

the midst of all this activity, she noticed the dirty clothes of a *brahmacharin* who was about to go outside the Ashram. She lovingly scolded him for wearing it and asked him to go and change. It is worth noting that even during this busy time, Mother found the time to give spiritual instructions.

Talking to a *brahmacharin* about how an aspirant should control his diet, she said,

“At first, the quantity of food eaten should be controlled. A *sadhaka* should not eat much tasty food. If one gives in to the attraction for tasty food, it will become difficult to overcome many other things. No matter how tasty a thing is, it is not possible to know the taste once it goes down the throat. Tasty food will cause an increase in the quantity of semen. Because of that, lust will increase. Both tasty and tasteless food should become the same. Practice eating bitter things. Not only the tongue but all the sense organs should be overcome. Going to places that stink, try to overcome your aversion, by sitting there for some time.”

In the evening, Mother cooked tapioca root for everyone. On certain days the Mother would do all the Ashram work including cooking, while the *brahmacharins* sat for meditation and *japa*. She would bring rice gruel and bananas to the place where they were sitting.

At about four-thirty, a devotee named Srinivasan from Bangalore came to see the Holy Mother. Though he had been working as a doctor in the United States for the last ten years, he had retained the deep-rooted devotion to Lord Krishna which he had had since childhood. He had just arrived from the States the previous day. Inspired by a recent dream, he had come to see the Holy Mother. Balu was curious to know more about the dream, but thought it improper to inquire before the devotee had a chance to discuss it with Mother.

At five the doctor was called to the Mother's hut. Balu noticed his face beaming and shining when he beheld the Mother's form. His whole body was trembling and his eyes were filling with tears. Mother tenderly welcomed him and made him sit near her. After some formal inquiries, Mother asked him, "Son, tell Mother what you want to say."

Controlling his emotions, Srinivasan said, "It was a vision rather than a dream. I had not met or even heard about Mother when this vision took place. The striking thing was that the vision took place in the airplane, on the flight over to India. I had a window seat. For a long time I gazed at the sky and chanted my *mantra*. As I was chanting the *mantra*, I slowly glided into a semi-sleepy mood. Then, in the sky appeared a strong effulgence which slowly assumed a form. To my wonderment I found that it was the beautiful form of my Beloved Lord Sri Krishna. I was really thrilled and felt that each and every cell of my body was dancing in bliss. As I was drinking in the beauty of my Lord, there appeared just beside Him another equally radiant and splendid glow. That glow assumed the form of a lady wrapped in pure white clothes with a beaming smile on her face. Her nose ring sent forth rays which blinded my eyes. It seemed as if two suns had appeared in the sky at the same time. My mind soared up to the heights of supreme bliss. Actually I could not contain the tremendous amount of bliss which I felt. Both of them were dark blue in hue and both smiled at me. A few moments passed thus when Krishna turned to the woman, who was still smiling at me, and pointed His finger towards her. As He remained in that position, both of them vanished from my sight. I suddenly woke up. I was still enjoying the bliss and was quite sure that it wasn't a dream, but a vision. Even the semi-sleepy mood was felt by me as a created circumstance for this divine drama to take place. I knew that it was a

hint asking me to do something. But who is this woman, I thought? My eagerness to know the significance of this dream became so intense that I could not eat or sleep during the whole trip. All my thoughts were focused only on the vision. It was a sixteen hour flight, but nothing else entered my mind.

“The next morning at eleven o’clock I reached home. My parents and my elder brother warmly welcomed me with open arms. In spite of all their love and affection, my mind was agitated. The vision became more and more clear in my mind, especially the smiling face of the woman. I wondered, ‘What is this? I’m a devotee of Krishna, but instead of being attracted to His divine form, this lady’s face is overpowering me.’ My parents and elder brother noticed my strange mood and as I felt really confused, I could not give them a satisfactory explanation. I was doing everything more or less mechanically. When I entered the room, which they had arranged for me, I felt wonderstruck. Pasted on the wall was a picture of the same woman who appeared in the dream. Overwhelmed with joy, I turned to my parents and asked, ‘Who is this lady?’ ‘People say She is God,’ answered my elder brother. He continued, ‘I found this picture in one of the newspapers and felt a strange attraction to it. This room was occupied by me until yesterday evening. For your convenience I moved to another one.’ Rejoicing at heart, I requested him to tell me more about her.

“This is how I came to be here, Mother. Please tell me what it is that I am to do? I am yours, please guide me. Bless me by giving me implicit faith and devotion.”

Mother: Mother is really happy to see your innocence. This is something very difficult to achieve. Even though you have been living in the midst of worldly pleasures, you were able to maintain devotion and faith. It is that innocent devotion and faith which caused all this. Keep up this attitude and

that is enough for you to progress in spiritual life. Child, remember that Mother is always with you.

He cried like a small child keeping his head on Mother's lap. The Mother, with great affection and love, caressed him. Srinivasan left the Ashram at seven o'clock after he paid his homage to the Holy Mother and requested her to be in his heart always.

Wednesday, 22 September 1982

Today Mother and the *brahmacharins* went by boat to a nearby place to sing *bhajans*. At twilight, the blue expansive sky, the coconut trees growing on both sides of the backwaters and the gentle breeze caressing the water's surface all contributed to the gentleness of the moment and the serenity of the mood.

The Holy Mother rose from her seat and started dancing. Unable to control the bliss, she cried out, "Hoi, Ho, Hoi, Ho." Raising her hands up to the sky, she sang:

*The Sea of Compassion art Thou and if Thou art not
compassionate to me, who else is there to give me refuge?*

*My heart keeps on waiting for Thee. Will this day also be
lost in vain, O Mother? Will this day also be lost in vain?*

Everyone responded to the Mother's song. Taking water from the river with her cupped hands, she threw it in the air and called out, "Devi, Devi!" While standing in the boat with her arms lifted up to the sky, the Holy Mother suddenly went into *samadhi*. After a couple of minutes she slowly opened her eyes and asked Venu to sing a song. He sang:

*O ever youthful Mother, because Thou art not showering
mercy on Thy children, grief is intensifying in their hearts.*

O ever youthful Mother, allow me not to fall and sink down due to delusion like the sun that gets covered by clouds.

When the song was over he asked, “Mother, this is a good time for meditation, isn’t it?”

Mother: Yes, son. Nature is calm now. Dusk is a good time for *sadhakas* to do *sadhana*. More concentration will be achieved by those who meditate then. At this time the mind will get more one-pointed in the thought which predominates. But in worldly people more worldly thoughts will occur because their minds are immersed in that. Twilight is the joining of day and night, isn’t it? Two different natures are present at that time. The mind won’t stay focused on anything at that time. Living beings will be in a haste to go to sleep. They will be thinking about their day to day lives. This is a time when there are a lot of worldly vibrations. If all of that is breathed in, worldly waves will be created in us as well. It is because of this that we chant the Divine Names loudly at dusk. Leaving off bad thoughts, the mind can become concentrated on God. The atmosphere will become pure. Don’t eat or sleep during twilight. Because the atmosphere is impure, it will affect us through food. Just as changes are taking place externally in Nature, changes are also occurring within us at that time. There is a special relationship between the body and Nature. Just as there are planets in the external universe, there are subtle planets within us also. They are rotating as well. Solar eclipses, lunar eclipses and everything else exist within us.

In the olden days, Mother used to cut grass from the shore of these backwaters to give to the cows. With friends, Mother used to bathe here, and standing in the water, sometimes Mother would meditate.

Brahmacharin: Mother says that *sraddha* is needed. But what is *sraddha*?

Mother: Son, suppose somebody is talking to us in an angry tone. We should listen to everything with patience. We shouldn't feel angry at him. Anger comes when we think that we are the body. No anger or hatred will be felt when we are thinking, "I am not this body, I am the Supreme Self." Who is there to be angry at then? There is only one Self and it is all-pervading. It is in everyone. We must understand perfectly that we are not the body but the *Atman*. All this together forms *sraddha*. Using discrimination is *sraddha*. Faith and detachment are the signs of *sraddha*.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why am I not progressing even after doing so much meditation?

Mother: Son, due to a lack of *sraddha* there is no concentration. Experiences will come only if *sadhana* is done for at least four years with proper *sraddha*. Meditation should be practiced consistently. Don't waste even a moment. To one who has a Guru, complete faith in the Guru is enough.

Brahmacharin: Mother, even after experiencing *brahmananda* (absolute bliss) do you feel that the time you spend talking with us is wasted or that it is insignificant compared to that?

Mother: In the past, when Mother talked with someone, she used to feel that the time was being wasted; but today Mother sees all children as part of God (*Iswara amsa*). Just as a weaver goes on spinning thread even while talking to those sitting nearby, Mother's mind is fully immersed in That even while she talks to her children. Mother sees nothing but God. Therefore, where is the question of wasting time? Mother's dwelling place is in the hearts of her children.

Brahmacharin: On certain occasions it seems that Mother is worried about her children. In reality, does Mother have any attachment to anyone?

Mother: Children, in the innermost core, Mother is not attached to anything. She feels neither sadness nor sorrow, but the vibrations emanating from the children reflect in her. When they are sad, for their peace of mind, Mother will also grieve.

We must understand that, when there are no desires, there are no sorrows. We must be able to love without expecting anything in return, or without expecting anything from anyone else. We must always be thinking that we are the servants of all.

23 September 1982

The guru and discipline

One *brahmacharin* was not well. He expressed a wish to go home and rest for a couple of days.

Mother: Today is a *Darshan* day and Nealu will have to do all the work by himself if you go. Not only that, this is an Ashram and, having settled down here, Mother does not want you to wander about. If your body is trying to make you its slave, you should not give in to it so easily. Overcome it by applying strength of mind. There is nothing that faith and courage cannot accomplish.

The *brahmacharin* gave up the idea of going home. Because it was a *Bhava Darshan* day, devotees started coming at noon.

Mother (to one *brahmacharin*): The *prema bhakti* (loving devotion) of these householders is very deep. They are very innocent. Some days ago Mother became oblivious to the world while singing *bhajans*. In that state she was unable to walk; so crawling on all fours, she went to the other side of the yard and sat under a coconut tree. She had no external awareness at all. It was not until she regained consciousness that Mother knew where she was sitting. Do you know

why Mother did that? The girl who lived in a nearby house had an intense desire to see Mother, but she could not come here. That daughter was crying and crying looking over towards this side. It was then that Mother unknowingly went over to that side. So intense is the love and devotion of some householder devotees.

Brahmacharin: Why is Mother always creating sorrow in our minds?

Mother: Son, it has to be like this, until the disciple has complete surrender and takes refuge only in the Guru. Complete surrender and discipline under the Guru's guidance is needed. Isn't this a life of renunciation? It is not possible to get closer to God if there is no sorrow of any kind. Therefore, God will create some kind of difficulties through Mother. Having heated the iron in the fire, the ironsmith beats it. It is not possible to beat it into a shape without heating it up properly. Reformation won't happen if the iron thinks, "I will not allow myself to be heated in the fire." The Guru will create obstacles and sorrows for the disciple. The disciple should overcome all that with intense *sadhana*. Spirituality is not for idle people. The difficulties of the subtle level are hard compared to the sorrows of the external world. There is nothing to fear for one who dedicates everything to a *Satguru*.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why is it that sorrow comes to me now and then?

Mother clearly knew that his sorrow was caused by his belief that Mother had less love for him than for others.

Mother: This sorrow is due to your lack of complete faith. If there is faith, you wouldn't think that Mother has more love for them than she has for you. That is the cause of your sadness.

Brahmacharin: What do you mean by faith, Mother?

Mother: Complete obedience to the Guru's words. In front of a Guru, a disciple should be like a servant in front of his master. The servant has no opinions of his own, only complete obedience to whatever the master says — no opinions at all. When obedience awakens in the disciple, the Guru's grace will unknowingly flow to the disciple. Grace will flow to the disciple when he holds the servant-like attitude that "I am nothing." The Guru's heart will be filled when he sees the disciple's innocence. One's goal will be realized by worshipping God and serving the devotees of God with a servant-like attitude.

Thursday, 30 September 1982

It was *Navaratri*.⁵⁰ All over India, worship of the Divine Mother was taking place. From early morning onwards the neighborhood children came to the Ashram to place their books in front of the Goddess Saraswati, the Goddess of Knowledge, in order to get Her blessings for success in their studies. Also present were many devotees along with their sons and daughters. Mother was playing and cracking jokes with the children. She was cutting sugar cane and making them eat it. Mother herself seemed exactly like a small child. One would be amazed watching her. Some devotees mentioned the Holy Mother's words that "God has the nature of a small child. God won't even look at those who do *tapas* with their ego, but He will shower His grace on the innocent-hearted ones who do not do anything. This may be due to His childlike nature."

The Holy Mother continued playing with the children. The devotees' hearts and eyes took delight in watching the Mother's innocent sports. Knowingly or unknowingly they also partook of the bliss.

⁵⁰Nine day festival and worship of the Divine Mother.

Friday, 1 October 1982

Complete faith and Liberation

Today the *brahmacharins* along with Mother went to visit Sreekumar's house. After waiting a long time in Vallickavu, the bus did not come. The Holy Mother would not permit a taxi to be taken. She said, "Spiritual people should not spend money unnecessarily." Finally, a bus came and they reached their destination. As Mother was walking from the bus stop towards Sreekumar's house, she said to one *brahmacharin*, "I do not see the old enthusiasm in your meditation nowadays. After one hour of physical work, meditate for the rest of the time. Don't spend time looking after Mother's needs. You children will become weak-minded if you think Mother is sick or weak. If you think Mother has power, you children will also get power. Unshakable faith is needed. None of the children have full faith in Mother. Complete faith means Liberation. What is necessary for you children now is a regular routine."

About eating food prepared the previous day, Mother said, "The food we eat will influence our character. Don't eat the food cooked on the previous day. It is *tamasic* and conducive to dullness and inertia."

Next, the discussion turned to *kirtan*. Somebody mentioned Unni's songs. Mother said that some of Unni's *kirtans* had come from his meditations. It is possible to cry to God when the mind becomes pure enough through meditation. At that time, songs can be composed without effort.

Brahmacharin: Mother, will the mind subside by itself?

Mother: The mind can be controlled by constant practice.

All of a sudden, the Mother stopped walking. An elderly lady sitting by the side of the road was looking at Mother. The Holy Mother approached the old woman who, with

great difficulty, tried to prostrate to her. With great affection she lifted the old lady up and holding her by the hand, kissed her hand. The Mother then continued walking. On the previous day, the old woman had learned from Sreekumar's father that the Holy Mother was coming, so she had waited by the side of the road in order to have *darshan* of the Mother. **Mother:** Until now we were thinking, 'I am the body.' In the beginning there will be some waves in the mind. Through practice they will go. It is to control these waves that *sadhana* should be done sitting steadfastly in one place. The waves will not subside simply if you read some books. Instead, they will only increase. In the deep sea there are no waves. It is on the shore that the waves strongly break because there is little depth. Peace can be experienced when the mind becomes expansive and deep through *sadhana*.

Many people had come to Sreekumar's house to see Mother and listen to her *bhajans*. After supper all the children gathered around Mother. She said, "When I am with these children, I do not know that time is passing." Catching hold of her hands, the children were walking with Mother following her wherever she went. They fought with each other to determine who would sleep with Mother that night. Mother made each one of them lay down beside her for five minutes. When they see the Holy Mother, they do not want their own mother. They would come and gather around Mother on their own. Wherever she sat, they would also sit around her. If Mother happened to sit quietly, the children would also sit near her and gaze at her face. Many times when Mother sat in deep meditation they would sit with their eyes closed. This natural attraction of the children towards the Mother is proof of her unconditional love. This pure love, ever radiating from the Holy Mother, has remolded and transformed many lives, which were about to be ruined.

Monday, 4 October 1982

Gayatri was recuperating at *Brahmacharini* Vimala's house after her operation. She had been staying there for some days. Today Mother decided to visit her. Accompanied by some women householder devotees, the Holy Mother started from the Ashram. Even though it was only a short distance away, the *brahmacharins* felt very sad. With great emotion they stood watching Mother as she walked away. Some of them sought Mother's permission to follow, but Mother left saying she would return soon. The *brahmacharins* would feel pained at heart even if Mother left the Ashram for only half an hour or an hour. That experience was beyond any words the writer has to describe. In those days, it would cause unbearable agony for the residents to be away from Mother even for a moment. Those who were happy and smiling until then would become like living corpses.

Sometimes when Mother left the Ashram, she would only take a few *brahmacharins* with her. But sometimes even before reaching the bus stop, she would stop all of a sudden and say that such and such a son or daughter was crying. She would then send someone to fetch them. When the person who was sent reached the Ashram, he would find as the Mother had said, one of the children had been crying from a broken heart. The Mother would proceed only after that boy or girl reached her. Only those who are very close to the Holy Mother can understand the intensity of that pain. The heart will pain like the wringing of a wet cloth. At that time they would neither eat nor sleep. They would sit in a corner crying like a small child who has been separated from its mother. This mental pain of the residents must have been like the excruciating pain of the *gopis* of Brindavan when separated from their beloved Krishna.

Tuesday, 5 October 1982

At two o'clock the Holy Mother returned from Vimala's house. She summoned all the residents and distributed sweets to them. It seemed as if the Ashram regained its luster and glory after Mother's return. Bhargavan, an ardent devotee from Mother's village, came before the evening *bhajan* started. He believed that Mother was only divine during the *Bhava*. He had tremendous love for Sri Krishna and because of this, he would take a little freedom during *Krishna Bhava* by playing with Mother. Mother really glorified his innocence. When she saw him, Mother said, "Krishna has come." She then told the others, "Father Bhargavan's innocence is really deep. During *Krishna Bhava* he would say, 'Krishna, this man behaved in such and such a way, that man behaved in such and such a way, I went here, I went there,' and so on. His attitude is that Krishna is his own. Having said all this, he would simply look at Krishna and laugh. He could easily progress if he could accept the real path."

The Holy Mother's birthday was the following day. Many devotees started arriving. Some were decorating the Ashram and its surroundings. The *Bhava Darshan* went on until five-thirty the next morning. The Mother sat on the *peetham* receiving the devotees for twelve hours without moving from there. On some days she had sat for fifteen or sixteen hours and would be full of energy and ever cheerful. Tirelessly working for the well being of the world, she puts new light into their lives by instilling faith and restoring peace.

Wednesday, 6 October 1982

Birthday

Today is *Triṣṭartika*, the Holy Mother's birth star. Getting up early and taking a bath, all the devotees waited outside the hut to receive the Holy Mother and offer their salutations. The *brahmacharins* chanted the *suprabhatam*.⁵¹ After many requests and prayers, the Holy Mother sat on the seat which was specially prepared for her. One by one the devotees offered their *pranams* (prostrations), some garlanding her while others offered flower petals. The *brahmacharins* worshipped the Mother's feet and Pai did the *arati*. All the time the Mother was absorbed in deep *samadhi*. When she finally returned to this plane, she got up from the seat and distributed *prasada*. With her own hands she gave sweet pudding, rice gruel and clothes to the village children. The reading of the *Srimad Bhagavatam* and *bhajan* took place at the same time. As part of the celebration, in the evening a folk dance known as *Koladi* was performed by some of the girls. Gathered in a circle, they rhythmically beat two small wooden sticks as they dancing to the music which the others sang. The song glorified the Holy Mother, highlighting her great and good qualities and asking how to repay her for the transformation she had brought into the lives of so many.

*Today is the Kartika star
Which is my Mother's birthday,
A day shining forth with beauty
Causing us to overflow with joy.*

⁵¹A song requesting the Divine Mother to wake up during the early morning hours.

*You have made us blessed
And liberating us from worldliness,
You have made us devotees
And given us peace.*

*You have showered immense love on us
And we drank it forgetting everything.
O Mother, we have nothing,
Nothing to repay You with for this divine love
Which You have showered on us.*

*How many births have I done tapas
To gain this, Your Divine Presence?
I bow at Your Holy Feet millions of times
For making this life fulfilled.*

One child was watching the *Koladi* with great attention. Seeing that, the Mother said, “Look, have you seen the concentration of that child? We should have this kind of concentration and desire for God. Not even a moment will be wasted if we have love for God. All-encompassing bliss is available to one who dwells close to God.”

After the evening *bhajan*, the chanting of the *Lalita Sahasranama* took place. The residents and *brahmacharins* decided to offer the worship to the Holy Mother. When everyone requested, the Mother finally agreed to sit. The worship started. All the *brahmacharins* sat around Mother forming a circle. *Brahmachari* Unni led the chanting of the *mantras* while the others responded. One by one, lotus flower petals were offered at the Mother’s feet. The Mother entered into *samadhi*. At a particular stage of the worship the Mother started offering flowers to her own body and then to other’s bodies also. She sees the same Consciousness pervading everywhere. The Ashram was saturated with con-

centration and devotion. Everyone seemed to be at the peak of bliss. When the *archana* was over, there was a big heap of lotus flower petals around Mother. The Holy Mother looked like Mother Durga sitting on a large lotus. The sight was a feast for the eyes and devotional ecstasy for the heart.

What is there after death?

An ardent devotee of the Holy Mother died in the beginning of October, 1982. This incident inspired *Brahmachari* Venu to ask Mother about life after death.

Mother: There is a very subtle sheath covering our gross body. All our thoughts are imprinted in this layer. Like a tape recorder, this covering will record all acts which we do mentally, verbally and physically while we are alive. This forms a covering of thoughts. After death, when we leave the body, the thoughts and covering will rise up with the individual self. According to the actions done, each *jiva* will go to a particular plane. Even though the *jiva* has no gross body at that time, it will still feel hunger and thirst. Due to the actions done in the previous birth, it will feel as if in mid-ocean. It will have a lot of unfulfilled desires, but will not be able to fulfill them. Some *jivas* will even attack other living beings in order to fulfill their desires. Entering the living beings through their breath, these greedy *jivas* will destroy the consciousness of other living beings. After that, they will make them eat according to their own will. These *jivas* do not have the strength to give life to a dead body. Their attack can only succeed against one who has no mental power.

The next birth will be according to the thoughts one has at death. The *jiva* will go on accepting bodies until all desires are eliminated. Usually it is through the breath and food materials that a *jiva* enters into other bodies. Some *jivas*,

without much delay after death, accept other bodies according to their *karma*. Some others will wander around. It is for those that wander that the rituals are done by the relatives who are still living. By chanting certain *mantras* with concentration, it is possible for the wandering *jivas* to get a higher birth and stop their wandering.

But, the case is different as far as a Liberated Soul is concerned. He will merge with the Absolute just as the air in a soda pop bottle rises up and dissolves in the atmosphere upon bursting open.

Thursday, 7 October 1982

The Holy Mother was sitting by the side of the backwaters looking at the water. After a couple of minutes, she looked up and said to those sitting nearby, “Our mind is like the stagnant water in this canal. So many people are smelling the foul odor produced from it. This water needs to flow and unite with the ocean. Our minds are dirty due to accumulated tendencies. They can be cleaned by making all the thoughts flow towards God. Then the mind will become expansive.”

One of the *brahmacharins* asked, “Mother, why do you behave differently towards different people and sometimes in an incomprehensible way?”

Mother: For some time Mother will deliberately slacken the hook and let you nibble. Then when you are fully hooked, Mother will catch hold of you. You children have been living in the illusory world since birth. One day you come to Mother calling “Amma” but she cannot in the beginning suddenly start to discipline you. Disciplining has to come slowly and steadily, after properly understanding the mental constitution and assimilating powers of the student. The Guru must have patience and forbearance to train a disciple. Above all,

selfless love must be the basis of everything the Guru does. A *Satguru* will have all these qualities. You children would throw everything away and run from here if Mother manifests *Guru bhava* (attitude of a Guru) from the very beginning.

Mother got up and went to the hut. At that time Saraswati Amma, a householder arrived. Whenever she came, she brought food for Mother and the *brahmacharins*. She was waiting outside Mother's hut with a packet in her hands. Seeing her, the Holy Mother smilingly said, "Ha, you have come. Today Mother thought of you. Everything is straightened out, isn't it?"

Hearing this, Saraswati Amma fell onto Mother's lap and started weeping. Her eldest son was having tremendous problems as a result of not having a job. With Mother's permission and blessings he went to Bombay and was appointed to a good post. Saraswati Amma had just received a letter from him telling her about his appointment, but before she could utter a word about it, the Holy Mother smilingly revealed that she knew it already. It seemed she was telling Saraswati Amma that nothing happens without her knowledge, and this is what made Saraswati Amma cry.

The *brahmacharins* took every opportunity to sit in the presence of the Holy Mother and to listen to her nectar-like words. Venu and some of the other *brahmacharins* entered Amma's hut at this time. Venu playfully tried to sneak some of the edibles from the packet which Saraswati Amma had brought. Watching Mother's face, he slowly pulled the packet towards himself, while pretending nothing was happening. Just at that moment, the Mother glanced at him, and catching hold of his hand said, "You little thief! Are you trying to steal from the Greatest Thief? Aren't you Mother's son? She knows your nature fully well." Everyone laughed and Venu blushed with embarrassment from being caught.

Shortly after, another *brahmacharin* asked, “Mother, is scriptural knowledge necessary?”

Mother: Didn’t Sankaracharya and other great souls study the scriptures? Knowledge of the scriptures is a must. Scriptural study is *sadhana*. Keep in mind though, that it should rid you of the ego, not inflate it. Scriptural statements and principles will serve as weapons to help you fight against mental conflicts and weaknesses, which might arise during the course of your *sadhana*. While studying the scriptures, one should feel, “I am studying divine *mantras*.”

Venu: Mother, why does Sri Krishna not appear before me?

Mother: He will definitely come if you have such a desire. More external alertness is needed and patience should be instilled into the mind. You should also have *asana siddhi*. Today, if you sit for two hours in one posture, tomorrow you must try to sit for five minutes more. Afterwards, you should add ten more minutes. In this way you will eventually be able to sit three or four hours in one *asana*. Thus, when you have patience, everything else will come of its own accord. You should imagine that your Beloved Deity is walking beside you and is smiling at you while you walk, bathe or sit. Cry to your Deity, imagining that your Beloved is standing before you. Utilize more time during the night for meditation. In the olden days, Mother would not waste any time at all. She would do *sadhana* at night without even sleeping. When innocent devotion arises, whatever you see, you will feel as your *dhyana rupa* (form of meditation). When Mother was very small, She would imagine that Bhagavan was playing and dancing with Her, even while She was plucking grass or sweeping the ground.

One *brahmacharin* had an intense desire to meditate during the night time while sitting by the sea shore, but sometimes he felt fearful. Hearing this, one of the other *brahmacharins* asked, “Mother, do ghosts and evil spirits really exist?”

Mother: Son, Mother won't say that there are no subtle beings, but they cannot do anything to spiritual people. A meditator's proximity will give them much happiness. They will easily attack us if we don't have mental power. At a certain stage, subtle beings can be seen while meditating in the graveyard.

Brahmacharin: Is there any harm in showing *siddhis*?

Mother: It is harmful, only if the laws of Nature are transgressed. Not only that; others will also be fascinated by such displays. As far as possible, an enlightened person tries not to show *siddhis*. But if he does manifest some psychic powers, he has nothing to lose, because he is already enlightened. He is already full. Even so, if the energy he used in showing *siddhis* was used to help instill renunciation into his followers, that would be much more beneficial to the world. A person can easily lose sight of the goal and become deluded, if he involves himself in *siddhis*.

Brahmacharin: Mother, I have made so many mistakes. What can I do to make up for this?

Mother: Mother has already sought God's forgiveness for your faults. There is nothing in particular that you need to do. It is enough if you meditate well.

You children have so much devotion to Mother. It is just like the devotion that Sri Ramakrishna had for Devi. Many of you don't realize this until you are away from Mother for some time. On a number of occasions, different children have come and told me, "Mother, when we are away from you, and we see a woman, especially one dressed in white, we feel that she is Mother." When Mother is near, the children sometimes think, 'Mother is near, so why should we meditate?' That is why, in the beginning, Mother told you not to meditate on her form. Not only that; once you believe that Mother is one with God, then your mind should not falter even for a moment. Firm faith is needed. Don't

think, ‘Mother has more love for him then she does for me.’ All that kind of thinking shows a lack of faith.

Friday, 8 October 1982

It was soon after dawn and the Ashram grounds still had not been swept. The Holy Mother began the sweeping herself. Seeing her behaving in this way, the *brahmacharins* also started cleaning the compound. Within a few minutes the Ashram and surroundings were completely clean. Rather than telling others what to do, Mother set an example of the correct attitude and behavior by doing some of the work herself. In her eyes, all work is sacred and a means to reach God. No work is too low to be done by the Mother. Teaching the children by example has at times meant quite a bit of exertion on her part.

Control of food

Almost all the *brahmacharins* came from wealthy families and had led comfortable lives. As a result, they would sometimes fall back into old undisciplined eating habits and would eat at odd and irregular hours. If the Mother saw them doing this, she would scold them sternly and correct them without accepting any excuses. She would always remind them, “Children, without giving up taste, you cannot make spiritual progress.”

One day the Mother noticed one *brahmacharin* eating some tidbits that he had taken from the cabinet.

Mother: This son is always thinking about food. That is very bad. In the beginning, eating habits should be strictly controlled. Try to remember everything becomes excreta once it enters the body. If you sit thinking of food, where is the time to remember God? For just one day, do an experiment and see what happens after you have eaten a lot of

tasty food. You children will lose your semen. At least in the dream state this will happen. That won't happen if you eat only *sattvic* food. When your seed is lost, you will be angry with Mother and complain that this happened because of the lack of Mother's grace. What does it matter if you get angry with Mother, if you are not controlling your food intake? If you are serious in your intent on reaching the goal, you will control yourselves.

The *brahmacharin* felt ashamed and became a little defensive. He said, before thinking, "Am I the only one who eats everything?" He then left the room. After a couple of minutes, the *brahmacharin* with great remorse approached Mother and sought forgiveness for his indiscriminate act.

The usual evening *bhajan* was over at eight. One *brahmacharin* had been meditating and did not attend.

Mother: This is an Ashram and there must be a general routine. Everyone must come during the *bhajan*. Now, one person meditates while another does *pranayama* (breathing exercises) and some others do *bhajan*. This is not right.

Though she gives such general instructions, she also makes meaningful exceptions. The Mother will exempt anyone who can meditate well, from all other works and from the general routine. The Holy Mother will allow them to spend as much time as they can in meditation. They don't have to come to the *Vedanta* classes or to *bhajan*. The Holy Mother says, "I am ready to serve them and look after all their needs myself." But Mother is very insistent that everyone else actively participate in the daily Ashram routine which includes some hours of meditation.

9 October 1982

Make me intoxicated with your love

It was three o'clock in the afternoon and the Holy Mother was sitting on the front verandah of the temple. She called for Sreekumar and then started singing a song. Sreekumar came with the harmonium and sat near Mother. Mother gave him instructions about the song and its music. She then set the music to the song and began singing each line. In between, she told Sreekumar about the beat of the song and clapped her hands according to the rhythm. Balu, Pai and Ganga came and sat near Mother. Venu came and played the drums.

Times like these that the children spent with the Mother, listening to her compose and sing new songs, were considered blissful and unforgettable by all.

Eventually the Holy Mother sang the song creating an overflow of devotion, bliss and love which engulfed everyone present.

O Mother, make me mad with Thy Love! What need have I of knowledge or reason? Make me drunk with Thy Love's wine.

O Thou who stealest Thy devotees' hearts, drown me deep in the Sea of Thy Love!

Intoxicated by the song, Mother got up and started moving round and round. She was in an abstracted mood. The speed of her circling increased and in that state of total absorption, the Holy Mother now and then burst into blissful laughter. No sign of an end was to be seen. Sugunanandan, who was watching the whole scene, became very anxious and in great consternation caught hold of her. Calling out

‘My child!’ he made her lay down on his lap. Before anybody could stop him, he poured water on Mother’s head. Totally transported to a world unknown to those of gross intellect, the Mother burst into an uproarious laugh. It became louder and louder. Half an hour passed and still the uncontrollable laughing and overflowing supreme bliss continued.

The family members gathered around the Holy Mother. The Mother’s sisters started crying and Mother Damayanti also cried calling out to the Divine Mother for help. Owing to their spiritual ignorance, they thought that the Holy Mother was going to lose her mental balance. It took a long time for the Mother to come down to the normal state. When she did, it seemed that she had to struggle to keep her mind down at that level. Her eyes would roll up and fix themselves at the point between the eyebrows. A little over three hours later Mother regained her external awareness. She got up from her father’s lap and told him, “Father Sugunanandan, from now on don’t touch my body on such occasions.” Several times the *brahmacharins* as well as some learned people had told Sugunanandan and other family members not to disturb the Mother during such times. But they could neither control their emotions nor understand the situation. Later, the *brahmacharins*, as instructed by Mother, would sing *bhajans* when she was absorbed. In those days, Mother would lose her external awareness almost every day. It would take a long while, sometimes even hours, for her to come down. As the number of *brahmacharins* increased, the Holy Mother kept herself from getting totally absorbed. One day she said, “If Mother frequently lets herself get into that mood of supreme bliss, then the very purpose of taking this body will be defeated. Mother has a lot of very important work to do, including the raising of these *brahmacharins*.”

11 October 1982

Today Mother planned on going to a devotee's house in Quilon. It was seven in the morning and everyone was preparing to go. Noticing the dirty *dhoti*⁵² one of the *brahmacharins* was wearing, Mother said, "Son, go and change, then come back wearing a good *dhoti*. Cleanliness is necessary. Even if you have only one set of clothes, wash them daily. Bathe, at least scrubbing with sand if there is no soap available. External cleanliness is needed first. Wherever you go, take your own seat for meditation. You children should not use things which are used by others. Things which are urgently needed should be taken with you when you are away from the Ashram. For this reason, we will buy dishes for each of you to take with you.

Sadhana and vasana

When the Holy Mother reached the devotee's house, she became like a small child. Everyone took delight seeing the Mother's childlike innocence and sports. She danced as she was eating some peanuts given to her by a devotee. Like a child, she playfully said, "No, I won't give this to you." It was an unforgettable day for the family members. They watched the Holy Mother as if they were looking at the most attractive and precious of all things. The next moment, the Holy Mother, leaving the peanut packet which she said she wouldn't give to anyone, went into the family shrine room. This act of the Holy Mother's reminded the *brahmacharins* of Mother's own statement that God's nature is like that of a child. He is not attached to anything. After entering the shrine room and looking at the portrait

⁵²A piece of cloth wrapped around the lower half of the body, similar to a sarong.

of the Divine Mother, the Mother said in a childlike way: “Hey Grandma, look after the needs of these children.” Afterwards, she went to the terrace and lay down on a mat which had been spread there. All the family members were sitting around her. Mother was eating ice cream fed to her by the family’s youngest daughter. It was quite obvious that she was eating it only for their happiness. When she had three spoonfuls she said: “Enough. It was only for daughter’s satisfaction that Mother ate it.”

The head of the family, who was a spiritual aspirant, asked: “Ammachi, why do more *vasanas* rise up as we do more *sadhana*?

Mother: When we first start to clean a room, all the superficial dirt seems to be cleaned away. The room will seem as if it is clean, but when we wipe harder, we can see all the dust coming up. The *vasanas* lying subdued within us come up when we do *sadhana*. They come up only to get exhausted. Those are all illusions (*mithya*) and ever-changing.

The next day when the Holy Mother was about to return to the Ashram, the little daughter of the house expressed a wish to ride in the car with Mother. But saying that her classes would suffer, the parents did not take her. As the car started to move away, the little girl cried aloud looking at Mother, “Ammachi...Ammachi!” Since her parents were quite interested in her studies, the Mother thought that it would not be fair to say anything. The car moved forward but suddenly stopped after going only five kilometers. There was more than enough fuel. The driver checked the car but couldn’t find any trouble. It didn’t matter how much the driver tried — the car would not start. After some time, the Mother, who was keeping quiet until then said, “The car will start if it is driven back to the house.” They obeyed Mother’s words and the car immediately started. There was no trouble at all. They were amazed when they reached

the house and saw the little girl who had wanted to go with Mother lying in the shrine room crying aloud. When the girl saw Mother, she came running to her calling aloud “Ammachi!” and embraced her tightly while still crying and crying. Returning to the Ashram with the girl by her side, the Holy Mother said, “It is this daughter’s *sankalpa* that caused the car to stop. There is nothing that a pure and innocent *sankalpa* cannot make happen

13 October 1982

Mother was talking with four year old Shakti Prasad.⁵³

Mother: Son, you must become the *sannyasin* teacher of this entire world. You should teach everyone.

Sakti: I will become a teacher by studying in the school.

Mother: Son, sing a song. Let Ammachi hear it.

Shakti Prasad sang with great concentration folding his hands on his chest,

*Through my mind, speech and actions
I am remembering You incessantly.
Why then are You delaying to show
Your mercy to me, beloved Mother?*

*I am a miserable destitute.
I have none but You, Mother.
Please stop Your tests and
Extending Your hand, pull me up...*

Someone came near and Shakti Prasad looked in their direction. Mother said, “Don’t look about just because someone goes by. You must sing with concentration.” Shakti again sang. When the song was over, Mother made him repeat the English alphabet.

⁵³A child born through Mother’s blessings.

Mother: Mother's son should learn Sanskrit. Son, show us how you meditate.

Shakti sat in a perfect posture and meditated. Seeing this, Mother and the others were all delighted at his innocence.

The Mother within

It was three in the afternoon. Gayatri, Nealu, Venu and Ganga were sitting near Mother.

Question: Mother says that no spiritual progress will be gained if we sit looking at Mother's external form. What is meant by this?

Mother: Son, Mother said that so that you children would look inside. If you don't have strong faith in Mother, you will question Mother's actions. You may feel, "Why is Mother talking to that person for such a long time and not even looking at me." Such doubts are due to your seeing only Mother's external form. They will create many obstacles in your spiritual path. This kind of doubt-filled thinking will not happen if you enshrine Mother within. You must have the strong conviction that "Mother is not the body but the all-pervading Consciousness." Staying with Mother for some years, you will have to fight to overcome the tendencies of the mind. Only then can you win wherever you go. Children, the ignorance of the ego should be pulled up by the roots and thrown away. Sincerity towards the Guru will come only if the disciple stays with the Guru for some years.

Question: Mother, what should be done to control lustful thoughts (*kāma viṅkara*)?

Mother: Through constant association with the *Satguru* all those thoughts will be automatically removed. Desireless love also will help to diminish lust.

Just before the *bhajan* began, the Mother was talking about Ashram affairs.

A new brahmachari: Mother, how are the Ashram needs being met?

Mother: Children, whenever there is a lack of something, then and there God will have it sent. Mother has given everything to Him. He will look after it. Mother doesn't need anything. For Mother, her children are everything. Mother's heart will become full when she sees each child growing spiritually. What is necessary now is for you children to do spiritual practice. You don't have to pay attention to anything else. Somehow whatever is needed will come. You should meditate. That is what is necessary.

Thursday, 14 October 1982

Taking on disease

It was a *Bhava Darshan* day and *Devi Bhava* finished at about four in the morning. At the end of the Darshan, the Holy Mother sucked blood and pus from the wounds on a leper's head. On certain days, due to accepting the illnesses of so many people, the Holy Mother would become sick herself. She, however, would recover within a few minutes. The Mother says, "A perfect person is filled with compassion. When he sees a leper or some other seriously ill person, he will not feel disgust or aversion. Through concentration and divine power, he can absorb the disease into himself. Many of the sick people who are coming here have been carrying around their diseases for ten or fifteen years. Although they may have undergone different kinds of treatments, they have still not found a cure. If Mother accepts their illness, she will have to suffer only a few minutes and those poor people will have been saved from much more suffering."

It was three o'clock in the afternoon and the Holy Mother was lying on the cot in her hut with some of the residents sitting nearby on the floor.

Question: Mother, I see no improvement as a result of my *sadhana*. What should I do?

Mother: Child, don't worry. Improvement will come. It is enough if you try. While the airplane is flying across the sky, we will not feel that it is moving, but once we reach our destination, we understand that we have been traveling all along. Likewise, we are progressing, but it is too subtle for us to understand. After reaching the Goal, everything will become clear. Concentration is what is needed. One who has concentration can conquer this entire world. Everyone will feel attracted to him, just from hearing his voice. One look at him would be enough to bring even the most wicked person to the spiritual path. We should increase concentration through persistent practice.

Question: Mother, can meditation be done imagining oneself as the form?

Mother: No, you should not practice like that. Your ego will become strong if meditation is done on yourself. Not only that; it is always better to choose a Perfect Being for your form of meditation. Whichever form you meditate on, eventually you will come to the understanding that you and That are one. During the period in which Mother meditated, she saw herself as Devi.

Friday, 15 October 1982

Faith in Guru

Mother was in Quilon at a devotee's house. In the evening there was *bhajan*, *satsang* and chanting of the Thousand Names. Many people were there to see Mother and to par-

ticipate in the *bhajan*. One devotee brought it to Mother's attention that Nisargadatta Maharaj had left his body.

Devotee: Mother, it is said in the book "I Am That" that Nisargadatta Maharaj met his Guru at the age of thirty-four and had known the Self at the age of thirty-seven. He reached the goal within three years only. Is this true?

Mother: Son, there is an important point that you fail to mention. Hasn't it been said that he had complete faith in the Guru? If he had such faith, then there was no difficulty at all. It is not enough to consider only time for the attainment of the goal. Faith, disposition inherited from the past birth, and practice are all applicable.

Wednesday, 20 October 1982

It was evening and Mother was sitting in front of the Vedanta Vidyalaya (Vedanta School) surrounded by the residents and some visiting devotees.

One devotee: Mother, is there any harm if one stops performing *puja* to a particular form of God or Goddess?

Mother: Son, when we do worship to a form, we transmit life to it. In fact, when you children salute someone with concentration, power will flow from you to him and from him to you. However, if the worship is discontinued, the same power can do harm to you.

Question: Mother, it is said that there is godliness in human beings. If that is true, can a human become totally identified with God or can he become God?

Mother: He is God. There is nothing to become. But, at present, because of his accumulated tendencies, he is not aware of this great truth. Son, even if it is said that God is in man, there is a Power that transcends everything. That is the Supreme Reality. That is unique. That exists even beyond a Liberated Soul. The waves and the ocean are not

essentially different, but the wave does not contain the ocean; the ocean stands as the substratum of the wave. There are no trees that touch the heavens and no roots that reach the netherworld. This means that all names and forms are limited.

The cause of the mango tree and the seed

Brahmacharin: Will atheists agree that there is a God?

Mother: Ask the atheists this question: “Which came into being first, the mango tree or the seed?” If it is the mango tree, then a seed should have existed, and if it is the seed, then the tree should have existed first. The truth is that there is a power beyond both, which is the cause of everything. That is God. As we progress in *sadhana* we will understand everything. There is no point in unnecessary debate.

The topic suddenly changed and the Mother told the group about experiences during her *sadhana* period. “In the old days Mother was not even able to call ‘*Krishna*.’ Body-consciousness would be lost immediately. If concentration was not gained in meditation, I would angrily jump towards *Devi*’s portrait shouting at Her. I used to beat my head on the wall. But what is there to say about other times! I would embrace *Devi*’s picture with overflowing love and crush it into pieces. In those days, Mother would see only *Devi* in whoever came. If I happened to see any good looking girls nicely dressed up, I would leap and jump out of bliss. I felt all of them to be *Devi*.”

About her spiritual children, the Mother said, “All the children should have that kind of devotion. Children, if you see someone who looks like Mother, don’t you stand gazing at them? When you are away from Mother, won’t you cry

if you see someone who has a face which closely resembles Mother's? That devotion will help a lot. If you stay away from Mother, you will be able to cry and call to Mother. However elevated the state of a disciple may be, he will have a kind of selfishness when he comes in front of the Guru. Children, don't you have the feeling that Mother should have more love towards you than towards others?"

At that time, a *brahmacharin* who had gone out of the Ashram to run some errands returned. He had waited a long time at the bus stop but had been unable to catch a bus. After prostrating to the Mother, he sat near her.

Mother: Son, haven't you left yet?

Brahmacharin: I waited nearly one hour, but I couldn't catch a bus.

Mother: Is this a *brahmacharin* who is talking like this? Hasn't God given you good health? Don't you have hands and legs? Can't you walk? If you had walked, you could have finished all the errands and returned already! Would the time have been wasted if you chanted your *mantra* while walking? If the bus had come on the way, you could have gotten in, couldn't you? From now on, you children should not waste time waiting at the bus stop. While standing there, all kinds of people will want to strike up a conversation with you. All that will only lead to the creation of new *vasanas*.

Monday, 25 October 1982

Inaction in action

In the morning, Mother suddenly came into the kitchen and began doing all the daily chores. She sent all the *brahmacharins* away saying, "Go and meditate." Some *brahmacharins* stayed hoping to help.

One brahmacharin: Shall I simply stand looking on while Mother is working?

Mother: Child, Mother does not feel that she is doing anything. If it was simply for doing work that you came here, then you could just as well have stayed at home. Think about whether you can do work with an attitude of dedication to God. Mother doesn't think you can do that, so you children should meditate without breaking the daily routine. That is enough for Mother.

Venu: Mother, how many days before I will attain the Truth?

Mother: Do your work and don't sadden yourself thinking about time. God will give everything.

Brahmacharin: No matter how much work I do, if I don't have Mother's grace nothing will happen. With Mother's *sankalpa*, I could be liberated this very moment.

Mother: Son, don't talk like that. That shows weakness and a lack of understanding. If you do the work, you will get the wages. God will not simply give something to someone without their working for it. Self-effort and grace are interdependent. If *tapas* (spiritual discipline) is performed sincerely, you will see God's grace flowing to you. Sitting behind closed doors and saying, "The sun is not giving me any light" is silly. Open the door and the light will come in. Likewise, open the doors of your heart by removing egotistic thoughts and by developing qualities such as love and humility. That takes effort. God's grace flows in a never ending stream. You have to prepare your mind to become a suitable instrument and then receive it.

We should pray to God asking Him to always give us work. You shouldn't feel that "after doing all this work, I still don't have anything to show for it." God is to be loved without desiring anything. Even wishing for a vision is a desire. God said, when He was approached on these matters, "To overcome the mind is more difficult than finding

Me. See everything with an attitude of equanimity and that will overcome the mind.”

Don’t unnecessarily argue with others. Tell them, “I don’t have time to waste talking unnecessarily. My Mother has told me ‘Truth is God. That Truth is in you also. It is everywhere. When you find That, you will know your Self.’ Mother hasn’t even said to have faith in her.” Also tell them, “I am trying to know myself, to love and serve all with a brotherly attitude. My aim is not to attain Liberation.”

Brahmacharin: Mother, what is the nature of *Atman*?

Mother: *Atman* has no attributes. It is changeless like the sky. It cannot be said what It is. There is no motion at all. There is neither “you” nor “I” there. It can be known only through direct experience.

Mahabali

Venu: Mother, why did Vamana⁵⁴ push Mahabali⁵⁵ down into the nether world? Why wasn’t he sent to the heavens?

Mother: Son, even heaven is not permanent. When the merit which was responsible for sending a person there is exhausted, he will have to come down again. In fact, Vishnu was testing Mahabali’s devotion. He asked for three feet of land. After Vishnu measured two, when there was no other place, Mahabali offered his own head. Mahabali’s devotion was revealed then. It was Eternal Liberation that Vishnu gave to him. Whether in heaven or hell, there is no change for *Atman* at all. The *Atman* has no trouble even if pushed down to hell.

Marriage celebrations were going on in a house related to the Idammanel family.

⁵⁴One among the ten incarnations of Lord Vishnu.

⁵⁵An ancient king and great devotee of Lord Vishnu.

One brahmacharin: Mother, do we have to go to the marriage at the other house?

Mother: Don't ask such questions. What does it matter to us? *Sadhakas* should never participate in such functions. Help them, but only if they ask for help.

Thursday, 28 October 1982

Unsteadiness

One *brahmacharin* had a wish to go somewhere to practice meditation in solitude.

Mother: Mother won't allow you to go like that. You are trying to avoid confronting and defeating the obstacles that are arising within you. After two days you will come back. If you go somewhere, you should stay there at least a month doing *sadhana* without moving about. You won't even do that. Then you will say that staying with the Mother is the best. Go and meditate after changing your clothes.

The Holy Mother was sitting in the Ashram library after lunch.

Brahmacharin Balu: Can a *Jñani* bestow Liberation on one by mere *sankalpa*?

Mother: Certainly, but the disciple should have alertness and faith. One who has faith will not ask any questions of the Guru, but will obey the Guru's words implicitly. That is service to the Guru. There is no benefit if one does service and yet has no "*visala buddhi*" (broad-mindedness). Obedience and proper discipline are necessary. The Prime Minister entrusts each governmental department with the other ministers. What if they stand around to serve the Prime Minister without doing their job? Is this proper? Will he be happy? The same is the case with the spiritual Guru. God doesn't need anything, neither service nor flattery. For

the disciple to advance, devotion, faith and obedience are needed.

Sraddha

Alertness

The Holy Mother was working in the kitchen. It is fascinating to watch the Mother's kitchen work. She is fast and at the same time, very careful and alert. Within an hour and a half, she can cook rice and all the necessary side dishes for all the residents.

As the cooking was going on, the Mother told the *brahmacharini* who was assisting her, "By not putting enough water in the pot, you have burnt the mung beans. While performing a task, your full attention should be only on that task. Only then will you attain *sraddha* (alertness). Don't distract yourself by eating things or talking while doing your work. Instead, you should be chanting your *mantra*. Actually, you should always be chanting your *mantra* within. We should always be centered within. As an analogy, a man who has been rowing a boat for some time may sit and rest on his oars without rowing. But even then, he is alert as to whether the boat is going straight or not. In the same way, we must have inner alertness whether we are doing work or resting. Even if the Guru scolds us harshly, we should offer everything at the Guru's feet, while thinking that whatever happened was for our own good."

The Holy Mother noticed that a *brahmacharin* had not removed a banana peel which was laying on the floor.

Mother: So, you haven't removed that banana peel yet, even though you saw it laying there. If you leave it laying there, unknowingly somebody may slip on it and fall. Then the one at fault is ourselves for not removing it before.

Understanding his mistake, the *brahmacharin* removed the banana peel.

Mother: Likewise, you should also be alert while walking along the road. If there are stones or glass pieces, they should be removed. An egotistic person won't care about that, but we should, so that others don't slip and fall.

Brahmacharin: Why is it said that the disciple should stay with the Guru?

Mother: Son, the Guru alone can remove the disciple's *vasanas*. Otherwise, if one doesn't have a Guru, one should at least have a very strong spiritual disposition. Sitting in one corner of the jungle, the fox may decide, "From now on, I won't howl at the dog." But when he sees one, it will be the same old story and he will howl. Such is the nature of *vasanas*. When we are alone, we may feel that all the *vasanas* have subsided, but when a circumstance arises, we will see all of them rising up. If we have faith in the Guru, *sadhana* can be done sitting anywhere. Wherever a disciple sits, he will get the Guru's grace. Faith is what matters. Those children who live far away will have intense longing when they think of Mother with concentration. They will get what they need even without Mother's knowledge.

Brahmacharin: Mother, I feel sleepy during my meditation. What should I do to remove this?

Mother: Son, it is due to the lack of *sraddha*. You need more alertness. When sleep comes, you should know that sleep is coming. Then you won't sleep. At that time you can either repeat the *mantra* with eyes open or get up from your seat and repeat the *mantra* walking about. The mind is very tricky; don't let it enslave you. Not only that; in the beginning stages, all the dullness will come up. But if you have alertness and enthusiasm, you can overcome all this in due time.

Sunday, 7 November 1982

At seven in the morning the Holy Mother was sitting in the front yard of the temple where the coconut trees were growing. She was in an abstracted mood. After half an hour, she got up and started walking around like someone who was drunk. At times she turned around and around with her eyes closed and her right hand showing a *mudra*. At other times, she uttered certain words, as if talking to a person who could not be seen by the others. Suddenly she broke into a rapturous song,

*O Mother, for the satisfaction of my life, give a drop of
Thy love to my dry, burning heart.*

*Why, O why, dost Thou put burning fire as fertilizer to
this scorched creeper?*

*O Devi, chanting the Name 'Durga, Durga' my mind has
forgotten all other paths.*

*O my Durga, I want neither heaven nor Liberation. I
want only pure devotion to Thee...*

Hearing the song, the *brahmacharins*, who were watching from a distance, slowly gathered around the Mother. As she sang, tears of bliss and devotion rolled down her cheeks. When the song was over, in a semi-conscious mood, the Mother slowly sat down and remained still for a long while. Then, turning to the *brahmacharins*, Mother softly said, "Children, the sweetness of devotion is incomparable. Once you taste it, you will never enjoy tasting the objects of the world. Children, don't speak about *Brahman* to worldly people. Tell them only about pure love and devotion. To

those who are a little educated and rational say, ‘I am searching for my Self.’”

The meditation of a Jñani

Brahmacharin: Mother, does a *Jñani* who has attained perfection need to meditate?

Mother: No son, it is not necessary for them to meditate. Once perfection is attained, they will not perceive anything as separate from themselves. Even then, in order to set an example for others, they will meditate. Now, if Mother sits idle without meditating, you children will imitate her. That is why Mother meditates. Even after attaining Perfection, many *Mahatmas* did *sadhana*, didn’t they? That was not for their own sake. In the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, even Sri Krishna is said to have practiced meditation.

Brahmacharin: Can one attain Salvation living as a householder?

Mother: Certainly, but he must be a real householder. All his actions must be performed with full dedication. He must always discriminate thinking, “Everything is God’s, nothing is mine. He alone is my true Father, Mother, friend and relative.” A *grihastashrami* should always be careful not to get too attached to his wife, children, parents and other relatives. Attachment will cause sorrow. In the past, everyone had faith. At the time of birth, a *mantra* was chanted in the ear of the child. The child would grow up leading a chaste and austere life. After finishing his studies in the hermitage of his Guru, he would enter into the life of a householder by marrying. His wife also would have been brought up in the same spiritual way. While she was pregnant, she would take a vow of silence and do rituals in remembrance of God for the first six or seven months of pregnancy. The husband would also do the same. Therefore, the child born to them was pre-eminent. The child’s

nature would evolve according to the nature of the woman's thoughts during the time of pregnancy.

Brahmacharin: Mother, I am not getting concentration during meditation.

Mother: Son, for the first three years or so after starting to meditate, you should keep looking at the form of meditation. In this way, the form will get fixed in your mind. Gazing at the middle of the forehead or the tip of the nose, you must try to achieve concentration. Then you must control food; otherwise the food will control the mind. You should be careful about that. Good food and bad food, these are all just delusions of the mind. It is possible to live even eating grass. As we attain concentration in meditation, we get all the essence of food from within. There should be the desire to meditate. It is because of the lack of detachment that one doesn't feel like meditating.

Friday, 12 November 1982

The taste of work

The *brahmacharins* were building their own huts. The Holy Mother was helping them. No one wanted to let Mother do the work, but whatever they said was of no avail, since she was intent on helping with the building.

Mother: The difficulties of life will be understood when we do whatever work needs to be done. When even a little bit of work is done, we feel tired. Just think about what it must be like for those who work night and day, day in and day out? Only if we work like this will we develop compassion. Actually this is nothing. Still, Mother has to make you children carry more of the burden.

Food is to be taken after having worked. Then only the taste of work will be known. What happens in most of the

ashrams? Some books will be read from which the knowledge to speak will be gained. My children, Mother won't allow that. She will make you work hard.

One *brahmacharin* asked to go home.

Mother: Until now Mother gave you children the liberty to come and go freely. From now on, that will not be possible. This is an ashram and there is a certain discipline to be practiced. You should live here observing that discipline. You have to be careful while associating with worldly people. When you go home, your mother, grandmother and all the others will come and tell you about many worldly matters. You too will become immersed in that. As a result, new *vasanas* will be formed. If you have to go into a worldly person's house, sit there silently. If they ask you something, then answer with as few words as possible. What you children need to be focused on now is the removing of ignorance.

Thursday, 18 November 1982

The building of the *brahmacharin*'s huts was continuing. There was no water to mix the cement for the floors, so Mother was bringing water, carrying a big pot on her hip. Just then, one of the *brahmacharins* had finished washing one of his *dhotis* and was about to throw away the soapy water. The Holy Mother noticed this and said to the *brahmacharin*, "You children have no *sraddha* at all. You have not been through any difficulties. You are wasting things in this way because you have not known any suffering. You must have alertness in each and every thing you do. Don't mix and waste this much detergent for only one *dhoti*. This can be used to wash other clothes too. A *sannyasin* should never waste anything. In this way, the value of work will be understood."

One *brahmacharin* was about to go out wearing a big black *rudraksha* rosary around his neck.

Mother: Son, remove that rosary or people will stare at you. We don't need to make any external show. Devotion is not in outer show. In this *Kaliyuga* we must wear good clothes and comb our hair. It should be without any external show that we must teach spirituality to others.

Another *brahmacharin* came near Mother and said, "Mother, during meditation I am not seeing the full form of the Deity."

Mother: In the beginning it is difficult to hold the full form in ones' mind. Therefore, first try to visualize the feet of the Deity and focus your mind on them. Then gradually move up until you can focus clearly on the full form. Once that becomes absolutely clear, we become one with the Deity. For that, continuous practice is needed. All that is seen should be imagined as the form of your Beloved Deity. Everyone should be seen with equal vision. Imagine 'I am the servant of everyone.' If everything is the Self, then who is there to hate? A real devotee's heart must pant for God just like a fish taken out of water. He won't waste even a moment.

Some cannot meditate for even two hours. Therefore they should learn Sanskrit. Knowledge of the scriptures is also necessary. Then others can be taught.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why have you come down? Do you know what your real nature is?

Mother: Son, it is the body that is coming and going; the Self remains unchanged and all-pervading. From birth itself Mother knew that God alone was the Truth and that all that we see is not true. She could see her own reflection in each and every object as if in a mirror. Mother would constantly remember God and would cry, singing His Name. In the night I would sing loudly. I always had the strong feeling that without realizing and becoming one with Him, I could not live. Worldly pleasures were meaningless and

equal to poison for me. As a result, many people said that I was mad! Even the family members would say, “She is giving the family a bad reputation.” But Mother did not care. Mother has not come here just to do some silly thing and then go away. Mother has a clear goal and will not leave without fulfilling it.

Thursday, 9 September 1983

A newcomer

Just after Mother’s birthday, a college professor visited the Ashram for the first time. The big decorated shed still remained. He had seen the Mother’s picture and the article about her birthday in the newspaper. When he saw her photo, he felt strongly attracted to her and felt inspired to visit her immediately. He sat waiting for Mother on the front verandah of the temple. It was around noon and one *brahmacharin* told him that the Mother was in her hut reading the day’s mail and would come soon.

The professor, who later compiled the book, “Conversations of the Holy Mother” in Malayalam, experienced inexpressible peace and divinity in the atmosphere. He later related, “Then and there I was certain that there must be a highly evolved spiritual personality as the heart and soul of this divine center.”

In a few minutes the Holy Mother came. The professor gazed at her, without blinking an eye. Full of joy and energy, the Holy Mother came and sat on the verandah as the professor prostrated to her.

The Holy Mother smiled at him with a smile that registered deeply in his heart. Whoever has met the Mother will never forget her smile. A few moments passed silently, then the Mother asked,

Mother: Have you eaten anything, son?

Professor: Yes.

The Mother again smiled, and again remained silent. Now and then the Holy Mother seemed totally absorbed. She whirled around her right hand showing a *mudra* and uttered “Shiva, Shiva.” The professor watched in amazement. “Where am I sitting?” he thought. “She is not only an *Avadhuta* or *Paramahansa*⁵⁶ but something transcending both. What a tremendous peace in her presence.” As such thoughts passed through his mind, the Holy Mother said, “Say something, son.”

Professor: Mother, please speak. I will listen.

Mother: No, son, you say something. Let Mother do the listening.

Professor: I came to hear Mother’s words. That is the tradition, isn’t it?

Mother: You have read a lot. Enough. Now you should perform some *sadhana*.

The professor could not help but wonder how the Mother knew all this. From an ordinary standpoint he was a total stranger to Mother, but that was not at all reflected in their conversation. He was quite convinced by the aforesaid statement that she knew everything about him because it was a fact that he had studied much but had practiced little.

Mother: Son, everyday you must meditate for some time.

Professor: Since seeing you, on who else could I meditate with eyes closed?

Mother: That is all right, but even then, the Vision of God is also needed within, so that no trouble will occur. If you only see the external form, sorrow may come.

One *brahmacharin* came and sat down on the sand near Mother.

⁵⁶God-Realized souls who have gone beyond the necessity or observance of all the rules and regulations of spiritual life.

Brahmacharin: Mother, some devotees have an idea to bring out a souvenir pamphlet about you. Would you agree, Mother?

Mother: Darling son, this Mother of yours does not need any publicity. Son, don't be in a hurry. All the wealth of this world is "Mother's." Don't be in a hurry. Everything will take place at the proper time and when it is needed. Children, go and meditate without thinking about all this.

The professor then cherished a desire to know about the Ashram. The Holy Mother, as if understanding his thoughts said,

Mother: Son, it has only been two years since the Ashram was registered. There were so many obstacles, especially since Mother's form is that of a woman. There was no freedom. Many people had different doubts. Father Sugunanandan of this house had no faith at all in me.

Professor: (Hesitantly) About the needs and necessities of the Ashram...?

Mother: Look son, there is nothing here in this Ashram. Sometimes there has not been even a penny. Yet forty or fifty people need to be provided for. In the beginning, the children would come and ask, "Mother, what should we do for tomorrow?" Mother would sit quiet. Whatever was necessary would come here the day before it was needed. After things went on like that for a while, the children stopped complaining to Mother.

Some devotees just arrived and prostrated to the Holy Mother. They offered apples, mangos and other fruits at the Holy Mother's feet. The Mother distributed the fruit as *prasada* to the devotees.

One devotee: Because I had not seen Mother for many days, my mind became restless. This is why I had to come today.

Mother: Son, Mother is there within you. She is always with you. Sorrow will result if you think Mother is only

this body. Mother is everywhere and within everyone. So, don't worry.

Hearing these words, the devotee's eyes became filled with tears. The Holy Mother is always simple and humble in her statements, but there are occasions when she unequivocally and precisely declare her total identity with the Supreme Being. Such declarations spring forth spontaneously and unexpectedly when there arises a suitable situation.

Devotee: What should we do, Mother?

Mother: Chant God's name. Repeat the *mantra* while taking each step. That is enough.

Devotee: *Pranayama*...?

Mother: Breath control is not necessary. *Kumbhaka* (retention of breath) will come by chanting the Divine Name itself.

Devotee: Mother, even the so-called believers in God abuse us for coming here. How can they give an opinion without coming here and seeing for themselves?

Mother: Don't blame them, children. It is extremely difficult to remove egotism and jealousy. This kind of behavior is even seen in advanced *sadhakas*. We should not give importance to what those ignorant children say. Don't get angry with them. We would only lose our power by doing so, that's all.

Another householder devotee: Mother, my desire is to join the Ashram as soon as possible. What should I do?

Mother: Son, you stay in the house for now. The egg will hatch when the time is correct. Don't break it open before that. The bondages of the family will fall off in due course of time when your desire to realize God becomes stronger.

Professor: What are Mother's plans for future activities?

Mother: Mother's aim is to raise these *brahmachari* children who are here now, by making them do spiritual practices and by disciplining them to become good *sannyasins*. They

will propagate *dharma* in the future. Mother has given a regular routine to them. As there are no hired workers here, all the Ashram work is done by the *brahmacharins*. A *brahmacharin* should not cling to anything or anyone. He should be free from bondage and have self-reliance.

The Holy Mother was sitting in the front yard of the Ashram where there was a small coconut grove. A song exemplifying the oneness of Lord Shiva and Lord Vishnu filtered through the small speakers in front of the temple,

*Hare Keshava Govinda Vasudeva Jaganmaya
Shiva Shankara Rudresa Nilakantha Trilochana*

A householder devotee came and sat silently near Mother. She opened her eyes after some time saying “Shiva, Shiva.” Moving her head to the rhythm of the music, Mother was enjoying the singing. At the same time, she looked at the devotee and smiled at him most naturally. After some time, the devotee asked the following:

Devotee: Mother, please tell me what is needed for me to grow spiritually?

Mother: What does Mother know, son? She knows nothing. Mother is just saying some crazy things, that’s all.

Devotee: Mother is playing a trick on me.

Mother: (In a low tone as if to tell a secret) Now, now son, Mother will tell you something. One day when the three gods Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva went to see Goddess Saraswati, the Goddess of learning, they found Her sitting holding a book. When they asked, “What are You doing?” Devi replied, “I am studying.” Son, that is how infinite knowledge is. Won’t humility come when we remember that even the Goddess Saraswati is studying? Then, what about Mother? Never let go of humility.

Understanding that the Mother was asking him to always be humble, the devotee said, “Mother has understood

me correctly. Humility is what I lack. I have never been able to yield to anyone.”

Bhava Darshan

Outside the Ashram compound, on the other side of the canal, fisherwomen were beating coconut husks to make rope. Seeing that, one devotee said, “It is amazing that the Mother took birth in this place where coconut husks are beaten.”

Mother: Son, look at that rotten coconut husk. See how black and dirty it is. Have you seen them refining it by beating it again and again? Likewise, the mind should be made pure through intense *sadhana*.

Devotee: Mother, isn’t this ordinary mood enough for you? What is the purpose of the *Devi* and *Krishna Bhavas*?

Mother: Maybe it is God’s Will. If Mother sits in the ordinary manner, many people will not speak from their hearts, but they have no hesitation to tell everything to Mother during the *Bhava*. During *Bhava Darshan*, they are talking to the Bhagavan (Lord) and the Bhagavati (Goddess), aren’t they? The people think that afterwards Mother cannot remember anything. Thus, so many people are consoled by unloading their burdened heart before God. Therefore, isn’t the *Bhava* beneficial for others? Everything is His Will. Infinite and multifaceted is God’s play.

One *brahmacharin* who had gone home for a short time had just arrived and prostrated before the Mother.

Mother: Son, why are you late?

Brahmachari: It was late when I caught the bus, Mother.

Mother: It is not good for *brahmacharins* to go home during their *sadhana* period. They should not stand at the bus stops either. There are people of different characters at the bus stop. Instead of waiting there for the bus, you could start

walking in the direction of your destination. When the bus comes, then you can get in. This way, we will reach the place where we have to go, even if we cannot catch a bus. We could even purchase something to give to beggars with the money we saved from the fare. That is real and selfless service. We serve others by renouncing our own comfort. What if we had waited for the bus? Sometimes we might have to wait for four or five hours. We will have to go back if the bus does not come. We will be disappointed also. This is not proper for one who wants to lead a spiritual life. Therefore, you must walk without waiting for the bus.

Mother looked at the householder devotee. Even though Mother had told this to the *brahmacharin*, it also seemed applicable to householder devotees who do *sadhana*.

Mother: Similarly, a *brahmacharin* should not take food from a shop. The shop keepers are business minded. While using each ingredient, the shopkeeper's thoughts will only be on how to make more profit. While making tea, he will be thinking, "Is this much sugar really necessary? So much milk is not needed. Oh, the tea powder is a little too much." In this way, he is doing everything in a miserly and calculating way in order to gain more profit. His mind is not concentrated but filled with vacillating thoughts. The shopkeeper's attitude will affect those who eat the food from his shop. A *sannyasin* dreamt about newspapers even though he was not in the habit of reading them. During his sleep, the newspaper and news would appear clearly in front of him. He thought about the reason and began investigating the cause. It was then discovered that the cook was reading the newspaper while cooking. Due to carelessness, the fire in the oven would go out while he read the newspaper. Again he would light the fire and read the paper. This was the way the servant cooked the food. The vibration created by his habits reflected in the *sannyasin*. Different types of

characters are coming to the shop. We will hear different things there. The thought vibrations in the atmosphere will affect us as well. If control is not maintained, it will become a habit to eat from shops immediately whenever we feel hungry. It is not possible to see ourselves objectively or study ourselves without *tyaga* (renunciation). Bananas and lemonade can be taken while traveling. If necessary, milk and water can also be taken. In the beginning stages, an aspirant should be particularly careful. Just as plants should be very carefully raised until the roots are firmly fixed, the same is true for *sadhakas*. When his roots are firmly fixed, then he won't go astray.

Hearing the *Srimad Bhagavatam* being read at a distance, one devotee asked, "Mother, is it right to accept money for reading the scriptures?"

Mother: Son, it is not wrong for those householders who do not have any other means to earn their livelihood, to receive a *dakshina* (offering). But, reading the *Bhagavatam* desiring to get money is not correct.

Devotee: Mother, what is the meaning of the saying that God is of the nature of Love (*prema swarupa*)?

Mother: It simply means that He can give nothing but love. In fact, He is the only one who truly loves us without expecting anything. Children, even if all the creatures in the whole world love us, that cannot equal an infinitesimal fraction of the love we experience from God in one second. There is no other love which can compare to God's love.

A child stricken by illness was laying in a hospital. The doctors and nurses treated the child with great care. Seeing their expression of affection, the child was also very interested in them. When the illness was cured, they prepared to take the child home. The child said to the father, "How loving these people are." Before he could give an answer, the nurse handed over the hospital bill to the father. The

child wanted to know what that was. The father said, “This is the bill for which they have loved and served you. A separate amount is shown for each and every thing they have done. Their love was selfishly motivated.” Whoever loves you in this world will have a selfish interest in it. We will get real love only from God. Real love is selfless. Unconditional love will be seen only in God. What else can such a God be except the embodiment of Love? But, how many people know the glory of that selfless love? Those who have known even a little taste of that love won’t run after worldly happiness.

Friday, 7 October 1983

Navaratri celebrations were beginning in the Ashram. For the first day of worship, a large oil lamp had been lit in front of a portrait of Vidya Devi (the Goddess of learning). The reading of the *Srimad Devi Bhagavatam* had already begun. Chanting of the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother was also scheduled. The Holy Mother, Gayatri and the *brahmacharins* were preparing margosa (*bilva*) leaves for the worship.

One brahmacharin: Mother, all these leaves are damaged by worms. They are not good enough to be used for the worship.

Mother: Oh, that doesn’t matter, son. It is enough if we give importance to the devotion. We can do the worship with these leaves. It is not really the leaves, but the innocent mind (heart) that we are offering at the Feet of the Lord. It is enough if we take care of our minds so that we are not destroyed by worms.

A newcomer who had never had the opportunity to learn anything about the Mother asked, “Mother, do you have a Guru?”

Mother: (While still preparing the leaves) Mother has neither Guru, nor *sishtyas* (disciples). Mother bows down to everything in the world. All are Mother's Guru. Mother has learned everything from Nature. At a particular state of meditation we can get knowledge about the essential principles from any object in Nature.

The western horizon was dark and cloudy and showed signs of a pending heavy downpour. The ocean rumbled and roared as it slammed onto the shore.

Mother: There, did you hear the roaring sound of the ocean? That sound will be louder in shallow places where there is no depth, but the ocean will remain calm where it is deep. Likewise, the evil-minded ones will walk around making a commotion. While persons with profound understandings will be calm in any circumstance. They won't be moved by anything.

Devotee: Mother, which is better, to follow the philosophy of non-duality or the path of devotion?

Mother: Son, the path of devotion suits the majority of people. Can the majority be discarded for a few non-dualists? Sri Sankara, the exponent of *Advaita Vedanta*, propagated *bhakti*, didn't he? Didn't he compose many poems glorifying Gods and Goddesses and even installed images of the same? He knew that the path of devotion is what ordinary people need.

Ganga told me that Ramana Maharshi was a *jñāna margi* (follower of the path of knowledge) and did not accept *bhakti*. Mother did not agree with Ganga and he argued saying that *bhakti* is a weakness. Without reading any of Ramana Maharshi's books, Mother said that he approved of *bhakti*. So, how did Ganga change his mind and finally agree with Mother's point of view? Soon after, Ganga went to *Tiruvannamalai*. The first book that Ganga took from the Ramanashram library gave him a big surprise. It was a text written by Ramana Maharshi glorifying *bhakti*. That fin-

ished son Ganga's doubt. Ganga believed that Mother was speaking through Ramana Maharshi in that book.

Saturday, 8 October 1983

God's grace

It was eight in the morning and *archana* was about to finish. The Holy Mother entered the temple and sat near the holy seat. One *brahmacharin* began to get up immediately after the worship.

Mother: Don't get up immediately after the worship is over. While sitting there, the taste should be enjoyed for at least a little time. The effect of taking a medicine may not be felt immediately. It must be given some time to pervade the system. Likewise, the energy gained by doing *japa* and meditation must be given some time to take effect by sitting silently for a while.

The Holy Mother sang,

O Divine Mother, Mother of the world, O most courageous Mother, Giver of Truth and Divine Love, Thou art the Universe Itself...

All joined in. The singing reached the peak of devotional heights. It seemed that the Holy Mother was soaring high into the vast expanse of infinite bliss and carrying the others with her. Now and then she burst into ecstatic laughter, followed by calling out "Amma, Amma!" The singing penetrated the hearts of the *brahmacharins* and devotees and surcharged their minds with spiritual energy.

The singing went on for about forty-five minutes and ended with the *arati*. After some time the Mother came and sat in the front verandah of the meditation hall. A few householder devotees and some *brahmacharins* were also there.

Brahmacharin: What should I do to get God's grace?

Mother: Son, if we carry the burdensome weight of ego and desires, the gentle winds of God's grace won't lift us up. The load must be lessened.

In her youth, Mother never thought about anything other than God. When the wind touched her body, she would call out, "O Mother, are You running away having touched me? Mother, why aren't You taking me with You?" One will certainly get God's grace if they have that kind of devotion. But that is not possible without reducing the weight of worldliness in the mind.

Devotee: Is there a particular posture that is best for *sadhana*?

Mother: It does not matter if you cannot sit in one posture without moving for a long time. Assuming any sitting posture, you can repeat your *mantra* or meditate. *Japa* can also be done while walking. But you must sit and practice meditation. That will teach you patience. Sitting in one posture comfortably without moving is *asana siddhi*. This is good for meditation.

Astrology and its result

Devotee: It is said that one's horoscope cannot be changed. Is that true, Mother?

Mother: What is said in astrology is the result of the actions performed in the past. The fruit of actions can be obstructed through other actions, such as actions dedicated to God. A stone which is thrown upwards can be caught before it falls down. Likewise, the course of the fruit of actions (*karma phala*) can be changed before fructifying. A horoscope will give way before God's Will (*sankalpa*). It may show in one's horoscope that he will marry. But the horoscope will change if he does spiritual practices and happens to have *satsang* (the company of sages) at a young age. Thus he might be able to become a *sannyasin*. It will certainly

change, provided there is a good spiritual disposition and *satsang*. Self-effort, including doing spiritual practices such as worship, *japa* and meditation are indispensable.

Oblations to the departed

Devotee: Are oblations to the deceased ancestors necessary?

Mother: Mother will narrate an incident. The son of a person who lived nearby had caused his family great suffering, due to his being a vagabond and engaging in wicked deeds. Seeing his son's bad ways, the father would scold him. Even then, the son did not care and continued his ways. Feeling frustrated with his son's ways, one day the father said, "After I die, don't let him do even my death ceremonies. If he does, his sin will also come to me. Even if he does do the ceremonies after my death, I won't accept the offerings." When the father died, the son performed the ritual saying, "I must see for myself whether or not he will accept the offerings." Even though he performed the ritual several times, when the balls of rice, which he had offered for his deceased father, were offered to the crows to eat, the crows would not touch them, although they pecked at everyone else's.

Just as the correctly addressed letter will reach the addressee, the benefit of the rituals performed by chanting *mantras* with concentration will reach the soul of the intended person, wherever he might be. But as far as a real *sadhaka* is concerned, he does not have to do any of these rituals.

Sunday, 9 October 1983

Sraddha and nishtha
Alertness and discipline

More devotees were present than usual because it was *Navaratri*. Some were newcomers. It was eight in the morning when the Holy Mother came out of her hut smiling at the devotees. Everyone prostrated to the Mother and She touched each one and greeted them with all humility. Calling everyone, the Mother went to the front yard of the temple where the coconut trees were growing. Some devotees spread a mat under one tree and she sat there and started meditating, asking everyone to join her. About thirty people were present. All of them sat together and began to meditate. Seeing this unusual sight, the passersby could not help themselves from stopping and gazing for at least a moment. Shortly after the Mother closed her eyes, the devotees opened their eyes and remained gazing at her. After some time when the Mother opened her eyes, she found that everyone was sitting there looking at her. An elderly retired doctor said to his friend sitting nearby, “Who else are we to meditate on, when the personification of love is sitting right in front of us? But the Mother is simply playing games with us. What do we know about this divine play?”

The Holy Mother asked, raising her voice, “What are you saying, doctor son? (Turning to the other devotees) Doctor son is of the opinion that doing meditation when this crazy Kali is sitting here is not correct.”

The doctor was struck with wonder when he heard Mother repeating the sentence that he said a few moments before. He was sitting in the rear and was too far away for the Mother to have been able to hear their conversation. He exclaimed, “How did Mother hear it?” Saying this, he got

up from his seat, approached the Mother and prostrated at full length before her.

The Holy Mother caressed him with great affection, but did not say anything except, “Shiva, Shiva.” Tears of joy rolled down the doctor’s cheeks. The Mother gently wiped them away with her own hands. Greatly moved by this show of love, he loudly cried out “*Amma Saranam Saranam!*”⁵⁷ Many there shed tears of devotion. After a few moments he returned to his seat. An unusual peace pervaded the atmosphere. Everyone seemed in a contemplative mood. A few more moments passed in silence and in the extraordinary calmness and serenity. After some time, a young visitor raised a question.

Young man: Mother, why has God given happiness to some and sorrow to others?

Mother: God is not making anyone sorrowful. It is the demon which makes us sorrowful.

Young man: Isn’t God in the demons also?

Mother: Son, it is the character of the person that is said to be like a demon (*asura*). It is the *asura svabhava* (the demonic nature) which makes us sorrowful.

Young Man: How is that?

Mother: Suppose there is a blazing fire. Someone tells you not to jump into it. Without listening you jump and burn yourself. If fire is *Brahman*, the person who told you not to jump is also *Brahman*. In the beginning, using your discrimination, only do things which are needed. But usually when a circumstance arises, we will lose our discriminative power and do as our ego tells us. Ego and its products are *asuric* qualities. It will spoil our life and personality. In the olden days, both men and women would get this training at a young age to control the demonic forces

⁵⁷I seek refuge in Mother!

and become masters of their minds through scriptural studies and practical application in their lives.

In the beginning, a child will study out of fear of his father. But later, when he becomes aware of his place in the world and the society, he studies by himself. Likewise, at the beginning of the spiritual path, guidance and discipline are needed. But you can't blame God if you did not care for these things and then loaded yourself with sorrow by acting as you liked. Alertness (*sraddha*) is needed. Nothing is possible without that.

Sraddha and *nishta* (strict observance) are necessary. Once two fishermen went fishing in a river. Standing near a canal with thick vegetation, the first man said, "See, I am going to catch fish here by making a dam around this vegetation. Would you like to join me?" The second man said, "No, if I join you I may have to work until evening and if I don't catch any fish my children will go hungry today. I shall go somewhere else and try." Saying this, he left. Now the first fisherman started to build a dam with the mud and grass which was at hand. He had no tools with him and so he started to lift the water out with his hands. With patience and faith, without even a slight change in his attitude, he continued his work. Because it was not strong enough, the dam broke in many places and water started to gush out. But with a steady mind and firm faith, he went on repairing and continued his work. At last, in the evening he succeeded in his task and got plenty of fish. At that time, the other fisherman, after wandering here and there, returned to the place empty-handed. The first fisherman supplied him with fish and made him happy. Because of his unshakable faith and perseverance, he could save himself and the other man as well. The one who had no faith did not achieve anything at all. Not only that; his whole time was wasted and he unnecessarily dissipated his energy for

nothing. Dear children! Wherever one may be, if one has strong faith in God, he will succeed in everything. This is what we have to understand.

Guru

Young man: Mother, is a Guru necessary?

Mother: Son, a Guru's presence is unique. Even though the wind is everywhere, only under a tree will we find coolness. Doesn't the breeze that filters through the leaves of a tree give soothing coolness to those who are living in hot climates? Likewise, for us who live in the scorching heat of worldly existence, a Guru is necessary. A Guru's presence will give us peace and tranquillity. One whose goal is Self-Realization must have a Guru. Without a *Satguru*, Realization is hard to attain. The dormant subtle *vasanas* can only be removed by a Perfect Master. Even for gaining worldly knowledge a teacher is necessary. What is there to say then about spiritual knowledge, which is the subtlest of all branches of learning?

Devotee: It is said that *satsang* is good for spiritual upliftment. What is your opinion about it, Mother?

Mother: Yes, that is true. If there is *satsang* it is not necessary to do *sadhana* in the beginning stages. But it must be real *satsang*. Real *satsang* is the yoking of *jivatman* and *Paramatman*. God or Guru represents the *Paramatman*, the disciple or devotee is the *jivatman*. Yoking happens when the disciple or devotee applies the Guru's teachings. Scriptural discussion is also a kind of *satsang* because it reminds us of the Truth with which we are trying to have companionship.

Customs and discipline

Young man: Mother, is discipline necessary for *sadhana*?

Mother: A road is required for the buses, cars and bicycles. Traffic rules are also necessary, otherwise accidents will happen. Likewise, ordinary people should have discipline. There are no traffic rules for the wind and the bird. In a like manner, a Knower of *Brahman* does not need any discipline.

One devotee: It is said in the *Bhagavad Gita*, “Abandoning all *dharma*s, take refuge in Me alone; I will liberate thee from all sins; grieve not.”

Mother: Does it mean that everyone should abandon their *dharma*? The Lord would not say that. Other *dharma*s are not needed for those who have the attitude of complete surrender, not that *dharma* is unnecessary. Beginners must perform their duties but in a Godward direction.

The questioner was surprised on hearing Mother’s interpretation of the *Gita* verse. He might have wondered how Mother, who has no knowledge of Sanskrit and has not read any books at all, could give an explanation about a particular Sanskrit verse taken from the holy *Gita*.

Young man: Mother, I have no peace of mind. How can I gain that?

Mother: Son, this attitude of yours to know the way opens the door to the path. Now what is needed is *sadhana*.

Devotee: Mother, some people say that the knowledge of *Brahman* is enough and that image worship is not necessary.

Mother: Son, ordinary people need images and temples. When we are about to go to the temple we remember God, and after reaching the temple, we remember God. Thus, the temple awakens the remembrance of God in us. There is yet another thing. The *atmachaitanya* (consciousness) of the devotees will be reflected upon the image. There is a special power in the temple which retains the devotion and con-

centration of the devotees. By going there we also will get concentration and devotion.

Young man: Mother, there are those who say that temples are not needed because of the crimes committed by people who believe in religion.

Mother: If that is the case, then medical treatment and hospitals should also be done away with because of the mistakes committed by a few doctors. Instead of trying to correct the mistakes, should one be obstinate and say we should simply destroy the entire situation?

Young man: Applying ash is simply a custom, isn't it?

Mother: It is very good if you apply ash made from cow dung. First, grass will be transformed into cow dung. Then, after drying it out in the sun, it will be slowly burnt in a fire made from paddy husk. Having removed all the dirt (sand) through purification, one gets ash. After going through all these changes, this ash becomes a powerful medicine. It will destroy the bad germs in the pores. When we see ash, we should remember the end of our life, our death. Ash reminds us that at some time, this body will turn into ash.

It was lunch time. The Holy Mother took everyone to the dining hall and asked the *brahmacharins* to serve the food quickly. She said, "All the children may be feeling hungry." The devotees said, "Mother should also eat." "Mother doesn't need to now. Children, you eat. Mother will sit here." Saying this, the Holy Mother sat in the dining hall. Everyone ate except Mother, even though all had asked her to. The *brahmacharins* begged, "Mother, you haven't eaten anything at all till now. Please eat at least a little rice." Mother kept quiet. She laid down in the dining hall. It was three o'clock. At that time, a devotee of the Mother named Karunakaran came running to the Mother carrying a bag. He greeted her, but soon signs of sadness appeared on his

face. Seeing him, the Holy Mother, like a small child, snatched the bag from his hand saying, “What were you doing until now? My head is spinning due to hunger.” The bag contained rice and other dishes especially cooked by his wife to offer to Mother. The devotee’s joy knew no bounds when he came to know that Mother had not eaten anything until then. With tears in his eyes he said, “I knew that you would not eat, because my wife was constantly uttering your name while preparing it.”

The cooking had been finished early in the morning, and so, cherishing the desire to feed the Holy Mother, the devotee set out from his house intending to reach the Ashram before noon. But unfortunately he missed the bus and reached there only at three. It was quite obvious that the Holy Mother was waiting to fulfill the devotee’s pure and innocent wish.

After lunch, Mother laid down on the sand under some trees. Some *brahmacharins* and householders insisted that she lie on a mat, but she refused. A devotee who had not visited the Mother for many months came to see her at that time. Pointing to him, one *brahmacharin* said, “Mother, an old son has come.”

Mother: Are there old and new sons?

Those devotees who were sitting at a distance came closer and sat near Mother when she began talking. The Holy Mother got up and sat down next to one devotee.

Devotee: I have visited several times, but never brought my wife and children. Until now Mother has not asked anything about them. Sometimes I feel sad about it.

Mother: They are Mother’s children even from before, aren’t they?

Smiling like an innocent child, Mother said, “Doesn’t your wife cook lentils and keep them in the shrine room in front of Mother’s picture every day before the usual evening

bhajan? Whenever you beat or scold your children, don't they say, "We will tell Vallickavu Amma that you have beaten us and she will beat you!"

The devotee, hearing these words from the Mother's own lips, was overwhelmed with joy and wonder. He said, "Yes, I am a fool to think that the all-knowing Mother does not know or care about my family." He bowed down at the Mother's feet and chanted the following verse with tears in his eyes:

*O Annapurna Devi, the Ever-Perfect,
The Beloved and Life of Lord Shiva,
In order to get Wisdom and Dispassion
I am begging of Thee, O Mother Parvati.*

*My Mother is Goddess Parvati,
And the Great Lord is my Father.
The devotees of Lord Shiva are my relatives
And the three worlds are my home.*

Devotee: I heard Mother saying that in *Kaliyuga* concentration is gained more by singing devotional songs than through meditation. Should we give up meditation completely?

Mother: Children, what Mother said was that nowadays the atmosphere is filled with a lot of bustle and sound and therefore to attain concentration, *kirtana* is better than meditation. A silent and peaceful atmosphere is needed for meditation. Other sounds can be overcome by singing devotional songs loudly, don't you agree? Even beyond concentration is *dhyana* (meditation). *Kirtan* - concentration - *dhyana*, this is the progression.

Devotee: It seems that in Kerala there are more devotees of Krishna than of Devi. Why is that, Mother?

Mother: In each place the customs are different. It also depends on the mental disposition inherited from the previous birth. (Humorously, with a smile) Whoever they might be, they will be in trouble if they have not pleased Devi. In the olden days, the Guru, after initiating the disciple, would give him a *Lalitasahasranama* book (Thousand Names of the Divine Mother) and ask the disciple to chant it every day. Only then would he be sent out to do *tapas*.

Only one having the spirit of renunciation can realize Sri Krishna. This is because, in order to please Krishna, the Embodiment of pure *sattva*,⁵⁸ one must become like Him. Feelings of doership, self-importance and other such ego-centric qualities should be gotten rid of. Without renunciation, one cannot realize God. A devotee, during his course of spiritual practice, may have to undergo different kinds of trials and tribulations. Destroying your sense of ‘I’ and ‘mine’, He may deprive you of all your wealth and even then, only if you catch hold of His Feet, will He give His *Darshan*. Sri Ramakrishna said that he had undergone great difficulties to realize Krishna. But the bliss that you experience will be infinite and inexpressible compared to which the sufferings are nothing.

In olden days, a *Lalitasahasranam* book would also be given while getting initiated into Krishna’s mantra. Do you know why? So that the initiate should not be in want of food and clothing. Devi will look after that. Motherhood is predominant in God as the Divine Mother. Children will have a natural attraction to their mother, and a mother will be naturally loving and compassionate towards her children and will look after their needs. This is the case with the Divine Mother also. To get your bread, Devi should be satisfied. That is why She is known as “*Bhukti-Mukti*”

⁵⁸The principle of goodness, tranquillity and clarity.

Pradayani” or the One who bestows both material happiness and Liberation.

Devotee: Mother, what is the meaning of the verse “Without doing anything, She does everything?”

Mother: Mother doesn’t do anything. It only appears that She does everything. The sun does nothing, but without him nothing can continue. He stands as a witness, yet he does everything. Likewise, Mother is only a Witness. Though doing everything, She is not bound or attached to it. Therefore, She does nothing though doing everything.

One householder devotee: What is to be done for gaining mental peace?

Mother: Son, you should give some solitude to the mind daily. God’s Name should be chanted. Have faith in a Perfect Guru. A ladder is needed to climb a coconut tree. Guru is the ladder. When children are young, they study mainly out of fear of their father, mother and teacher. Therefore, it is clear that in the beginning stages, *bhaya bhakti* (devotion coupled with reverence and fear) is necessary. Thus, mental peace can be gained if one moves forward adhering to the Guru’s words.

Devotee: In order to gain mental peace, I have gone to several *sannyasins* but I got nothing from them. All of them were fakes.

Mother: Son, *shanti* (peace) will not be gained if you search outside. It should be sought for within. God dwells within. He should be known by becoming introverted.

Son, you have abused the *sannyasins*, haven’t you? That shouldn’t be done. Look at Sri Sankara, Swami Vivekananda and others. You can see that it was the *sannyasins* alone who did lasting good to the world. Siddhartha, who was an emperor, became the *sannyasin* Buddha and did so much good in the world. Yes, there are fake *sannyasins*, but are there fakes only among *sannyasins*? Do the virtuous ones

become worthless because there are also imposters? When going to the market, if you find that one of the shops is illegally selling goods, does it mean that all the shops are doing the same?

A young man: It seems to me that there is no meaning in going to temples.

Mother: Son, this is not true. When we see an artificial apple we are reminded of the real one. When we see temples and divine images, we will be reminded of God, won't we?

Young man: That is so.

Discrimination

Mother: It is not enough if you simply agree with everything. You should do *sadhana*. If you write 'sugar' on a piece of paper and lick it, you will not taste the sweetness. You must eat the sugar itself. Studying books alone is not enough. You should perform *sadhana*. If you want to get inspiration to do *sadhana*, life should be understood, after having observed it closely. After all, what is marriage nowadays but another bondage? It is a relationship of two bodies. It has nothing to do with the relationship of the souls without which marriage is severely lacking. In olden days, marriage and married life were considered sacred and divine and were a means to attain Self-Realization. The married couple's spirits were united and this led to peace and tranquillity, and eventually culminated in God-Realization. Nowadays it is nothing but another means to satisfy lust. There is no real love in it, only selfishness. Who will listen and contemplate deeply if it is said that the body is a bag of feces and urine! Children, don't think that Mother is saying to completely discard worldly life. That is not the case. What Mother is trying to say is that you should use this life in a more intelligent way, so that this world and your life will become more joyful and beautiful. Discriminate and see. Is the love

that we get from our relatives, wife, husband or children real? Isn't it simply for fulfilling their selfish ends that men love women and women love men? What will happen if she or he runs away with another man or woman? Then the attitude becomes just the opposite. You will be ready even to kill him or her. Is this love?

Mothers will say that they love their children. But do they? If they really love, why aren't they loving to the children of the neighboring houses? Therefore, what they really love is what is 'mine.' Mother would say that even the birth of a child is accidental and occurred during the course of the parents' effort to satisfy their lust and other selfish motives. If the parents really love their children, they would make them understand and assimilate spiritual truths, which would give them the mental strength and control needed to confront the challenges of life. Instead, parents throw their children into this world without giving them proper spiritual education and thus the children lead the same kind of lives as their parents.

We say that we love our children. But would any of those who love their children be willing to die for them? No one sees or hears of anyone who is ready to save their child's life by sacrificing their own. Do you know how many people say these things to Mother? A woman was watching when her child fell into a deep well. That mother was not ready to jump into the well and save her child. She cried and shouted aloud. The child was already dead by the time he was taken out, by a diver brought by a neighbor. Rare are such people who are ready to save another life by sacrificing their own. To be frank, worldly pleasure is equal to a dog's excreta. From one drop of semen we are losing energy equal to a hundred drops of blood. For a spiritual aspirant, *brahmacharya* (celibacy) is his wealth. As far as he is concerned, worldly life is indeed equal to a dog's excreta. For

a dog, human excreta is like nectar, but for human beings it is an object of loathing. For a spiritual person, worldly life is something to be loathed. Only if he has this attitude can he attain the goal. Otherwise, his energy will be dissipated by the objects of the world.

Real *vairagya* (detachment) will develop if one discriminates like this. Then it will become possible to perform intense *sadhana*. A *sannyasin* should acquire inner wealth by doing *sadhana*. *Sannyasa* is not child's play. It needs tremendous courage, courage born out of sense control. It is enough for a married person to look after his wife and two children, but a *sannyasin* has to carry the burden of the whole world.

In the middle of the conversation a lawyer, a devotee of the Holy Mother, also arrived and sat with the Mother. Hearing Mother's words, he raised a problem concerning his own mind and life.

Lawyer: What then is my fate, Mother? I am walking around getting involved in court cases, quarrels, lies and so forth.

Mother: That is all right son; it is the *dharma* (duty) of a lawyer to argue for his party in a suit. That is not wrong. A lawyer is only performing his duty when he argues for a murderer. Even so, you should accept only truthful cases, as far as possible. The sin does not go to the lawyer if the criminal is saved by the arguments put forth by him. The criminal is only saved from the court of law. He cannot escape from God's court. One must bear the fruit of one's actions.

Anyhow, like anyone else, a lawyer can also come to spirituality after abandoning worldly life. That is, he can come after the dawn of real *vairagya* has risen in him. Until then, *swadharma* (one's own *dharma*) should be performed dedicating everything to God.

Mother took the fruits offered to her by the devotees and cutting them into small slices, fed the devotees with her own hands. Everyone seemed happy with hearts overflowing.

Tuesday, 11 October 1983

It was eleven in the morning. The Holy Mother was sitting in the front yard of the Ashram in the coconut grove, when a group of householder devotees arrived from Trivandrum. They greeted the Mother and sat near her. Some of the *brahmacharins* had just finished their meditation and came and sat with the other devotees. The Mother expressed a wish to hear devotional songs. Sreekumar brought the harmonium and the Mother sang with devotional fervor,

O Devi, O Ambika, Beauty Personified, O Thou who art affectionate towards devotees, may Thou dwell here in order to end the sufferings of the devotees.

How many days have I been desiring to see Thee? I am praising Thee without losing even a moment. Did some mistake happen on my part or is it that Thou hast no mind to end my sorrow?

The *brahmacharins* sang along with the Holy Mother. Tears of bliss rolled down the Mother's cheeks and she called out "*Amma ente Ammal!*" (O Mother, O my Mother). All the devotees were immersed in the Mother's song. Some shed tears of devotion and others sat with closed eyes. When the song was over, the atmosphere was calm and quiet except for the singing of the fishermen which could be heard as they pulled the fishing nets from the ocean nearby. Half an hour passed in this way before the Holy Mother opened her eyes.

A young man asked: Mother, what are the signs of a person who has conquered his mind?

Another devotee interrupted: It is enough to look at Mother!

Mother: This crazy one? Very good! Children, those who have conquered the mind are like children. They have no attachment to anything. If a child sees gold he will take it. Then, throwing the gold away, he will grab a crayon if it is laying nearby. This is a child's nature. They do not have attachment to anything, no bondage. They have no egos at all.

One devotee: (humorously) Mother is a very egotistic person. Mother is the All-Witness and therefore everyone's ego is Mother's. The ego in me is also not mine, it is hers.

Mother: That is the attitude that is needed, son. This is the perfect way of thinking. But you should apply it in your life also.

Devotee: But in Mother not even a speck of ego is found. The Holy Mother laughed like a child.

Name and Love

A householder devotee arrived. She prostrated and kissed the Mother's feet.

Mother: It has been a long time since this daughter has been here!

Devotee: It has been one year, Mother. There has been no time available to come here.

Mother: There is time to go to the hospital if the child is sick. However long it might take, there is enough time to stand waiting for the bus. There is also time to stand in the long queue in front of the movie theatre, even in the scorching heat. But there is no time to go to temples and to come here. You will go running to the places which you like and to gain objects that you love.

Devotee: What can I do to develop love, Mother?

Mother: Daughter, when the Divine Name is chanted constantly, spiritual hunger will grow. Consequently, a taste for the Name will arise followed by love for God (*Isvara prema*). We are saved if love is attained.

Devotee: How can one repeat the Divine Name while working?

Mother: You can chant during leisure times, can't you? Then, through chanting during those times, the constant chanting will become a habit. At that time, even when we are doing worldly things, our breath will go on repeating the Divine Name. Thus, a state will come when we can do *japa* as well as worldly activities simultaneously.

A devotee sought Mother's permission to leave and prostrated before her while taking his leave. Touching his back, Mother saluted him in return. This is Mother's usual way, bowing down to the Indwelling Truth.

There is no matter: everything is Consciousness

A man who had heard about Mother came to see her in person. He went on babbling about his own glories and achievements. Later when he left, the Holy Mother jokingly said about him, "Son, once the tape starts playing, shouldn't the song finish? Is it possible to easily wash away the tough stains that have accumulated over many years?"

A science student (who was also interested in spiritual matters) asked, "The *rishis* (seers) declare that everything is *Brahman*. Modern science also says that everything is energy. Is there any connection between these two?"

Mother: Son, when we enter into the higher states (planes) of *sadhana* we can hear all these stones and wooden pieces talking to us. They are not inert but conscious. Then it will become clear that they are also talking. What is known

as matter is only at the empirical level. In reality, it is not matter. Everything is one and the same Consciousness.

An aspirant: Mother, why is it that one does not feel the circulation of the blood through the veins?

Mother: At a particular stage of meditation, when the mind becomes one-pointed, we can hear the sound of the harmonious flow of the blood through the veins. It can be experienced. It will be felt as if water is rushing through thousands of small pipes. Such experiences are not born out of any physical disorder. There is nothing to worry about. Several such experiences will occur when we progress in meditation.

Embracing a small girl the Holy Mother said, “See, look at this daughter. She is only seven, but she meditates like a great yogi. This daughter asked Mother, ‘Mother, where does the body go while meditating?’ When I lay down, she would fan me sitting in the lotus posture while repeating the *mantra* with her eyes closed. If Mother has her eyes closed, thinking Mother is asleep, she would embrace Mother’s feet and start crying and shedding tears. What kind of girl is this, O God?”

Mother laughed loudly like a small child. Everyone joyfully laughed with her. The little girl also expressed her joy smiling and embracing the Holy Mother.

Wednesday, 12 October 1983

It was eight in the morning. Mother and some other devotees were preparing *bilva* leaves for the *archana*.

One devotee: Mother, what happens if all these ants die getting entrapped in the *bilva* leaves?

Mother: Children, you don’t have to worry about it. All those will return to where they came from. You should prepare the leaves while chanting your *mantra* with faith.

Devotee: Do the *brahmacharins* practice *pranayama*?

Mother: A little bit. It shouldn't be practiced too much. *Kumbhakam* (retention of the breath) will automatically come when concentration is attained through chanting of the Divine Name. The *kundalini* will awaken. For that, no particular breath control is needed. How is it possible to practice *pranayama* during this age when even pure air is not available? *Pranayama* should be practiced with discipline under the guidance of an experienced Guru. It is a dangerous path if not done correctly. *Japa* is more than enough.

One *brahmacharin* came and made some complaint about another one.

Mother: Son, *brahmacharins* should not even think about anything which is against *sadhana*. All the power that is acquired through *sadhana* will be lost. They should have no anger at all. It is even more difficult to remove jealousy. The mind should always be vacant. Son, go and meditate.

The *brahmacharin* retired having offered his salutation.

One householder devotee: Mother, can a *grihasta* take *sannyasa*?

Mother: (laughingly) Oh, have you attained that state? (All laugh) A *grihasta* should look after his family. Don't go abandoning them. But you can give them up if there is complete detachment. Then you can leave your home. After that, not even a thought about your home should enter into your mind.

It was time for lunch. The Holy Mother went to her hut after instructing the *brahmacharins* to feed the devotees.

Story of Sandeepaka

After lunch, Mother narrated the following story to the *brahmacharins*:

Mother: Angiras was a great sage endowed with immense spiritual power. He had many disciples. One day, summoning all of them, he addressed them as follows,

“Due to the fruits of past karmas my body will soon be afflicted by the terrible diseases of leprosy and blindness. I would like to spend those days in Kasi (Benares). Now, I would like to know which one of you is willing to follow me to Kasi and serve me during those days of suffering?”

Looking at each other, the disciples all stood silent. At that time, Sandeepaka, the youngest of Angiras’ disciples stood up. With all humility he said, “Respected Guru, I am ready to come with you.”

The Guru replied, “You are too young. Also, you don’t know what service is.”

Sandeepaka said, “Revered Master, I am ready and will certainly come with you.”

Angiras explained, “It is easy to undergo suffering oneself but to serve the one who suffers is much more difficult.”

But Sandeepaka was determined. Such was the intensity of his desire to serve his Guru. Thus, the Guru and his young disciple went to Kasi. Soon after reaching Kasi, Angiras was afflicted by the disease and lost his eyesight. Sandeepaka sincerely and devotedly served his Guru day in and day out. He would never leave his Guru alone except to beg for their food or to wash his Guru’s clothes. He was constantly engaged in looking after his Guru and took the utmost care to meet even his slightest needs. He would say, “My Gurudev is himself Kasi Vishvanath (Lord Shiva presiding over the city of Kasi).”

In spite of little Sandeepaka’s unshakable devotion and utter dedication, the Guru would severely chastise him and accuse him of having made mistakes which he had not made. Sometimes he would scold Sandeepaka saying that the clothes were not properly washed, or that the begged food was sour and so on. At other times he would show great affection

and love to him and would even say that he was putting Sandeepaka to so much trouble.

One day, Lord Shiva appeared in front of Sandeepaka and said, "I am very pleased with your devotion and dedication to your Guru. Please ask for a boon." But Sandeepaka was not willing to ask for a boon without first asking the consent of his Guru. He therefore ran back to him, and after prostrating to Angiras, asked him, "O Revered Guru, may I ask a boon of Lord Shiva to remove your disease?"

Angiras angrily replied, "You are not my disciple, but my enemy. Is your wish to make me suffer more by having to take another birth? Don't you wish for me to become liberated in this birth?"

Sandeepaka sadly returned to Lord Shiva and said, "O Lord, forgive me! My Guru doesn't want me to ask for the thing which I would like to ask for. As for me, I do not want anything for myself."

Years rolled by and Sandeepaka, the embodiment of devotion to the Guru, still continued to serve his Guru with the same amount of love and surrender. One day, while he was going to the town to beg for food, Lord Vishnu appeared before him and said, "My child, I am very pleased with your devotion and dedication to your Guru. I am ready to give whatever boon you ask. You did not ask anything of Lord Shiva before, but this time you should not disappoint Me."

Struck with wonder, Sandeepaka inquired of the Lord, "Even though I haven't served You or even remembered You once a day, how could it be that You are pleased with my service?" Lord Vishnu smilingly replied, "Guru and God are not different, but are one. It is your service to your Guru which has pleased Me."

This time also Sandeepaka went to seek his Guru's permission to ask for a boon. The Guru said, "Sandeepaka, if

you want some boon for yourself, go ahead and ask. But don't ask for anything for me."

Sandeepaka returned to Lord Vishnu and said, "O Lord, give me more wisdom and knowledge so that I can understand how to serve my Guru according to his wishes. Most of the time, due to my ignorance, I am not able to understand what he likes. Therefore, O Lord, grant me the knowledge to serve my Guru properly." Lord Vishnu was very pleased and saying, "So be it," He disappeared.

When Sandeepaka returned from the presence of Lord Vishnu, Angiras asked him what the boon was that he sought from the Lord. Sandeepaka told him everything that had happened. Immediately, all the symptoms of leprosy disappeared from the Guru's body and his sight was restored. He stood smiling at his disciple and hugged him. The leprosy and blindness had been self-imposed by the Great Master Angiras in order to test the devotion and dedication of his youngest disciple. Being established in the Supreme Truth, he had no karma to work out. Graciously blessing Sandeepaka, the sage said, "I am very pleased with your devotion. No harm or danger will come to those disciples who serve their Guru with as much devotion and dedication as you have served me. May all of the disciples and their disciples through the ages be blessed because of you."

Children, this is real *bhakti*. If you have such devotion, then nothing else is needed.

Thursday, 13 October 1983

Mithya means changing

A person belonging to the neighboring house had epilepsy. The relatives of the patient came to see the Holy Mother who was sitting on the front verandah of the old

temple facing east. The *Mahamantra* (great mantra), *Hare Rama Hare Rama Rama Rama Hare Hare, Hare Krishna Hare Krishna Krishna Hare Hare* was echoing through the Ashram.

Mother told the relatives of the sick man, “For diseases like epilepsy and hysteria, practicing meditation is better than medicines. Those who have practiced meditation according to Mother’s instructions have been cured of such diseases.”

A young man sitting near Mother asked, “Mother, what is the best method of meditation?”

Mother: Children, there is no single path for everyone. Son, you should meditate on the form of your Beloved Deity and chant the *mantra* of that particular Deity. While meditating, the eyes can be fixed either between the eyebrows or on the tip of the nose. If you find it difficult to concentrate on one of these, then visualize your Beloved Deity’s form within the heart lotus. As far as householders are concerned, it is better for them to meditate in the heart. You can chant the *mantra* irrespective of time and place. Chanting the *mantra* using a rosary will help to attain more concentration and to maintain alertness.

Young man: Mother, how is it possible to remove sorrow?

Mother: We have been thinking that the body is eternal. That has created sorrow. Now we should learn to think in the opposite way. We should be thinking that the *Atman* (the Self) alone is eternal. We should realize this as well. In order to convince ourselves that the body is non-eternal, we must train the mind using the weapons of discrimination and detachment (*viveka and vairagya*). Look here son, if you put your finger in your nostril, mucous will come out. Similarly, from the eyes dirt will come out and from the ears the same. Now, if you do not brush your teeth for a day, your breath will smell terrible. If a wound gets in-

fectured with pus, a bad smell will come. In a similar manner, take every part and every organ of the body. What is it after all except a bag of feces, flesh and blood? This is the thing that you decorate with beautiful clothes and golden ornaments. Try to pierce through and see the Real Thing which makes it beautiful and shining. That is the Supreme Consciousness. This is how you have to discriminate and detach yourself from the body and the world of objects. Once you are convinced of the ephemeral nature of the so-called pleasure-giving objects, then you won't desire them. This will end sorrow.

Young man: This is really useful. Mother, some people say there is no God.

Mother: Children, that is like using the tongue to say, "I have no tongue." It is with the power given by God alone that one denies God. Not only that; when one denies the existence of something, he is actually affirming its existence. In order to reject something, one must first have a general idea of that particular object. For example, when somebody says 'There is no book,' it is quite certain that he knows what a book is. It is the same with God. Above all, the existence of God or the Self is a matter of pure experience. It is not a subject for arguing.

Young man: Is there any difference between the mind and the *Atman*?

Mother: Pure mind alone is *Atman*.

Young man: It is said that the world is *mithya* (an illusion).

Mother: Son, *mithya* only means changing. It doesn't mean that it is non-existent; it means that it is not permanent. If rice is ground it becomes powder, then transforms into edibles and then into excreta. There is only transformation. The object is still there. There is no change for *Brahman* (the Absolute). But there is change for the world.

Brahman alone is the Truth, the world is illusory. To understand *Maya* (illusion), *Brahman* (the Absolute) and such principles is very difficult.

Young man: Mother, isn't *Kurukshetra*⁵⁹ within ourselves, or is it outside also?

Mother: The battlefield of *Kurukshetra* is there both outside and inside. Symbolically, it is the constant war which is fought within each of us between righteousness and unrighteousness, vice and virtue, untruth and truth, evil and good, the demons and God. We cannot deny the fact that this *Kurukshetra* battle was also a historical truth. If you simply interpret everything symbolically, all these happenings which occurred long ago will lose their beauty and significance. People will become egotistic and arrogant thinking, 'Oh, everything is inside; then why and whom should I fear?' It must not be interpreted in that way. Rama, Krishna, Buddha and Christ were historical personalities who led a perfect life in each and every field, setting an example for the entire human race. You cannot simply say that *Dvaraka* (a city where Sri Krishna was living) is the *Sahasradala Padma* (the thousand-petalled lotus *chakra* in the head) and Krishna is the Supreme Power who dwells within, and so on. That is foolishness. A grandfather might tell his grandchild a hundred years after Mahatma Gandhi's death, "Child, you know what Mahatma Gandhi did? He fought against the British without any weapons. His weapons were truth and non-violence. He stood smilingly in front of the machine guns of the Britishers without thought of revenge or enmity. Indians lined up behind him and obeyed his words with utter submission. Even when he was shot dead he didn't cry, but uttered the name of Lord Rama. Above all, physically he wasn't a striking personality. He

⁵⁹The battlefield where the Pandavas and the Kauravas armies arrayed and fought one another.

always dressed like a peasant.” But the boy would tease his grandfather saying, “Grandpa, that was a beautiful story, but it can’t be true.” Later, somebody else may say that Gandhiji is an inner state. Children, it is foolishness to interpret things like that.

Young man: Mother, is there life after death?

Mother: Yes, there is. During our lifetime, all our thoughts and actions will be recorded by a subtle sheath which functions like a tape recorder. According to the impressions gathered during one’s lifetime, the *jiva* will take another body during which the recorded impressions will be replayed. Children, we can see some people who are very talented in music, mathematics, or in the sciences who have had no special training in that particular field. Neither their parents nor any of their family members, or ancestors were musicians, mathematicians or scientists, but this particular boy or girl manifests these qualities even from a very young age. This is where we have to agree with certain mysteries connected with our past birth. Anyhow, it is difficult to convince everyone about these things, though it still remains a fact.

Be intent on reaching the goal

Young man: Mother, what should be done to attain the goal?

Mother: Be intent on the goal. To be first in the class is the aim of a student who studies for a degree in engineering. He won’t go to movies. He won’t waste time making new friends, nor spend too much time with the ones he has. Even while traveling he will study. Circumstances won’t obstruct one who is intent on reaching his goal. When an intense desire to reach the goal arises, first, we should discriminate as to what is meaningful and what is not. We should have the awareness that things of this world are meaningless and we will not get bliss from these things. If

we want to get peace, we should inquire into the Truth. Mother doesn't tell her children to worship God or Mother, instead she says to know "who you are."

Worldly relationships are like the relationships at the bus stop. All will get off at some stop. You alone will remain. Therefore, what Mother says is to search for the Truth without getting engrossed in dreams.

Saturday, 15 October 1983

It was *Pujayeduppu* day.⁶⁰ By six-thirty in the morning many parents had already brought their children for the initiation into learning. As a part of the ceremony; everyone (regardless of age) is supposed to consider themselves as beginners sitting in front of Saraswati, the Goddess of Learning. At this point in the ceremony, the Holy Mother made everyone present write the first syllables of the alphabet in the sand and asked them to respond as she herself repeated each of the syllables in a loud voice. It was really a blissful moment. Everyone was overwhelmed with joy. There were men, women, elderly people, teenagers and children in the crowd. All were initiated into learning by the Holy Mother.

All of a sudden a young man, a medical student from the northern part of Kerala who seemed to be in his twenties, started crying, laughing, dancing and rolling on the ground. It was the first time he had visited Mother. He called out, "O Goddess, O Saraswati, O Amma Saraswati, here is your child, teach me, teach me, O Saraswati!" The Holy Mother smilingly went near him and caressed his forehead and chest with her hand and said, "Calm down,

⁶⁰Culmination of the *Navarathri* or *Vijayadasami* festival in honor of the Divine Mother, considered auspicious for initiating children into learning the alphabet.

child, calm down, Mother is here.” In a couple of seconds he became normal. He got up and seeing Mother standing in front of him, prostrated at her feet with tears of joy in his eyes.

The youth explained later, in a voice choked with emotion, “I was gazing at Mother’s face as I wrote the syllables as instructed by her. All of a sudden, even while my eyes were wide open, the Holy Mother’s form transformed into that of Goddess Saraswati seated on a beautiful white lotus holding the *veena*, *Vedas* and the rosary in Her four hands. She was dressed in pure white. But I could easily recognise Her face because it was the Holy Mother’s enchanting face. Tremendous light was emanating from all over Her body as if a thousand suns had risen up together. I could not control the bliss which I experienced. I became totally oblivious of the surroundings.” Before he could finish the sentence he again burst into tears.

By this time the *bhajan* started. The Holy Mother sang:

*O Kali, the Holy Consort of Lord Shiva, Parvati,
Shankari, my only refuge is Thy beautiful Lotus Feet.*

*Hail, hail to the Goddess of Knowledge, hail to the
Mother of the Universe, hail to the Mother who bestows
auspiciousness on Her devotees.*

*Victory, victory to the Goddess of Sound who holds the
veena in Her hands, victory, victory to the Goddess of
Speech who is the Ruler of the Universe.*

*O Lalita, the Power contained in the seed letters, the
Embodiment of Knowledge and the Liberator of the
Universe, I humbly bow down to Thee praying for Thy
Grace...*

The singing lasted for two hours but passed like five or ten minutes. Such was the bliss radiated by the Holy Mother.

Monday, 17 October 1983

The Holy Mother was sitting on the front verandah of the meditation hall. Many devotees were sitting on the steps as well as on the ground. Now and then a few of the residents came to seek Mother's opinion on certain matters concerning the administration of the Ashram. Some others came with a question or a doubt.

Devotee: Mother, how could you attract these children while they were still very young?

Mother: I haven't attracted anyone; on the contrary, they were attracted by something in this crazy girl. It is their *samskara* (latent tendencies) which brought them here. Anyhow, it is better to turn to spirituality when you are young. The more you live in this world, the more you will be lured to the worldly experience and *vasanas* (resultant habits). Each experience is an addition to the already existing habits. It will become more and more dense. A tender stick can be easily bent but a dry one will break if you try to bend it. Likewise, training young people is easy because they have relatively few conceptions and ideas about life in their mind. Whereas others have many preconceived ideas, and most of them are misconceptions. Still they cling to them strongly believing that they are right. The case is different however, if they have self-surrender and devotion.

Son, attraction is the nature of a magnet. In reality it doesn't attract anything. Iron filings get attracted to it by its mere presence. The magnet simply is.

Devotee: Mother, how is it possible for you to behave equally towards everyone?

Mother: Children, a spiritual person does not see the external appearance but only the Essence or God. When the sculptor sees a rock, he sees the beautiful image which he can make out of it, not the rock. Likewise, a *sadhaka* also should see only God which is the Essence in everything. Only then will he achieve equanimity (*samatva bhavana*). The electricity which comes through a fan, bulb or refrigerator is one and the same. The only difference is in the medium. Likewise, it is the same Consciousness which dwells in all living beings. We will not feel hatred or anger towards anyone when we think that the Consciousness which dwells in him is the same as in me.

Scriptures are billboards

Devotee: Mother, can one attain the goal through scriptural studies?

Mother: Son, suppose there is a billboard on the roadside saying that there is a jewelry shop in such and such a place. You won't get gold if you ask the billboard for it, will you? For that, you must go to the jewelry shop. Scriptures are like billboards. They are pointers – they point out the goal. That is the only use for them. We cannot get coconuts from a picture of a coconut tree. Scriptures are like the picture. Having drawn the blueprint of a house, it is not possible to live in it. We have to build a house according to the plan; only then can we live in it. Scriptures are like the blueprint. We have to work to attain the goal.

One *brahmacharin* was scrawling in the sand with his fingers. The Holy Mother noticed it.

Mother: Children, don't move your legs and hands unnecessarily. Movement shows the vacillation of your mind. Wherever you sit, sit with concentration without moving your hands and legs unnecessarily.

A devotee just arrived to offer a *dakshina*⁶¹ to the Holy Mother. The Mother declined to accept it. When the devotee insisted, Mother said, “Mother has not given *dakshina* to anyone. Then how could Mother accept it? Mother has neither Guru nor *sishtyas*.”

Guru Bhakti

A householder: Mother, some people say that a Guru is not necessary. Is that correct?

Mother: Consecration is not needed for a *svayambhu linga* (a self-manifested image). Disciplining under a Guru is not necessary for those who are perfect from birth. Even so, such people might accept a Guru in order to set an example. Sri Krishna studied in a *gurukula* (Guru’s residence), didn’t He? Whereas those who haven’t attained Perfection need a Guru. Is it proper to say that for *Atmavidya* (Self-Knowledge) one doesn’t need a Guru but, for all other arts, a Guru is needed? The person who says that a Guru is not necessary is an egotistic person who is not ready to bow down in front of another. He will not make any progress unless he serves a *Satguru* who removes that ego.

Suppose someone wants to learn carpentry. First he must find a master carpenter. Then his words should be listened to with patience and care. After that, he must reflect on all he has learned and try to assimilate it. Then follows the practical application by making a door, table or window. The same is the case with spirituality also. The Guru’s words must be listened to with great attention and devotion. Next comes discriminative reflection followed by application in one’s own life. Without a Perfect Master and grace, Realization is most difficult.

⁶¹A gift to a revered person like a preceptor or priest in connection with an auspicious occasion.

The Guru will test the disciple in different ways. Only one who has strong determination can withstand all those tests and proceed on the spiritual path. But once those tests are passed, then the infinite grace of the Guru will flow unimpeded towards the disciple.

Once there was a Self-Realized Guru who had a single disciple. One day, the Guru summoned the disciple and told him to sculpt an image of the disciple's Beloved Deity, Sri Krishna. Since it was his Guru's wish, he made the image applying all of his skill and talent. Upon seeing it, the Guru smashed it to pieces and said, "What is this? How ugly! Make another one." The disciple patiently and silently obeyed his Guru's words and made another image with even more care.

This time the Guru severely scolded him saying, "You are not sincere and don't obey my words. This image is even worse than the first one. Make another one." Saying this, he smashed the beautiful image of Krishna which the disciple had carefully made.

Thus the disciple made nine images all of which met with the same fate. Yet, he accepted the Guru's words and actions submissively without getting impatient or angry. He felt sad only because he could not please his Guru. Finally, when he brought the tenth image his Guru hugged him with overflowing love and said, "Now you are fit enough." Saying this, he touched the disciple on the forehead. Immediately, the disciple experienced the ecstasy of *samadhi*. By his Guru's grace he was able to sustain that high experience.

Children, there is nothing that the Guru cannot give. Guru is the Supreme Consciousness Itself. Selfless service and utter dedication are the two things which make one fit to receive the Guru's grace.

After staying in the Ashram during the *Navaratri puja* and performing his spiritual practices in the presence of the Holy Mother, a devotee from Kottayam came to take his leave. He saluted the Mother. While patting him on the back, the Mother said: “Son, now go happily and return. Mother is always near you. You have stayed here many days. When you get home, reflect on the memory of this experience. Remember the Divine Mother while walking, sitting or working.”

Devotee: Mother, please give me some further instructions.

Mother: You should get up early in the morning. Wash your face, hands and legs, then do *japa* for some time. After finishing your nature calls and bath, chant *Lalitasahasranam*. Don’t just chant the names. Chant sincerely and with devotion. Visualize the enchanting form of Mother standing in front of you and offer flowers at Her Feet. It is enough to offer mental flowers if flowers are not available. Son, if you find it difficult to visualize the full form of the Divine Mother, try at least to see Her Feet. Meditate for a few minutes when the chanting of the *Sahasranam* is over. Try to repeat your *mantra* even while at work. You should sing *bhajans* at dusk. Control food and sleep. Meditate for some time.

The Holy Mother took the rosary which the devotee had been wearing on his neck and, holding it in her hands, meditated for some time. Replacing it on the devotee’s neck, the Mother said, “Chant your Beloved Deity’s *mantra* on this rosary. Avoid mingling with people too much. Speak and behave softly and sweetly with your wife and children. If they are not interested in spiritual practice, slowly try to make them understand the importance of it and try to make them participate in the practices that you are following. When you return home after work, talk moderately only

for absolutely necessary things. Entering the *puja* room, do *japa* sitting there.

Saturday, 22 October 1983

A beautiful morning dawned, the rising sun's soft rays filtering through the leaves of the coconut trees and plants growing in front of the temple. This diffused light along with the gentle breeze produced a wonderful soothing effect. The chirping of the birds and the reverberating sound of the ocean waves made the whole Ashram atmosphere even more lovely and graceful.

The Holy Mother was sitting on the front verandah of the old temple with a group of educated young men. Cheerful as ever, the Mother's face was lit with a bright smile.

One young man: Mother, we simply wanted to see you and therefore we came. Yet I am inspired to ask something. May I ask?

Mother: A question? To this crazy one? (Mother laughs; then after a pause says) Yes, yes you can, son.

Young man: Mother, some say that this world is total chaos and confusion. Others say that there is a harmony beyond all these seeming diversities. What is your opinion?

Mother: Son, these are two different points of view derived from two different levels. Those who run after the external world will always experience nothing but chaos and confusion. Whereas those who go deeper, who inquire into its real nature, will certainly find that there is only harmony and oneness and no diversity at all. Children, everything depends on the mind. If the mind is well balanced, you can experience peace and tranquillity everywhere in the world; but if it is agitated the world will seem agitated. When we are on the earth we can see many things — houses, trees, huge buildings, forests, animals and people. But when we

are traveling in an airplane, flying very high, there is nothing; everything becomes one whole. Son, now the mind is full of many thoughts accumulated from the different experiences of life. When thoughts increase, we will not get any peace regardless of where we are or what we have. When thoughts decrease we can find peace even if we are not provided with any comforts or facilities. Those who decrease their thoughts through practice can find peace regardless of the time or place. For them, the so-called world of chaos and confusion becomes an abode of peace and harmony. For others it remains like a hell. All spiritual practices are methods to decrease thoughts and increase peace. Slowly but surely man can become more like God. Not only can one enjoy peace oneself but can give peace to others as well.

Suddenly Mother stopped and turning to one of the boys who was looking all around, said, "Son, stop fighting with your parents." One could easily see the shock that the boy experienced when the Holy Mother uttered these words. His face turned pale. Hanging his head, the boy sat silently for a few moments. The Holy Mother, who was smilingly watching the boy, now burst into laughter and asked, "Did Mother scare you, son?"

The young man, who still had an amazed look on his face, asked Mother in a soft voice, "No, but how did Mother come to know this? Even my close friends do not know. Did anyone tell this to you?" The Mother patted his back and said, "No, Mother was simply joking, don't worry." The young man in a firm voice said, "No, Mother, it wasn't a joke. What you said is true. I always fight with my parents. I am not at all hesitant to admit right in front of my friends and Mother that almost all the time it is my ego which makes me quarrel with them. The reason is that they won't give me money for my lavish way of living."

The Mother lovingly asked, “Is that correct, son?” Now he could not control his emotions. His eyes were filled with tears. In a broken voice he said: “No, Mother, I know it, but I was never aware of the fact that an unseen person always watched me. Now it is clear, Mother. I won’t repeat it. I promise in front of you.” The other young men were silently watching the whole scene with wonderment. Tears rolled down the boys’ cheeks. The Mother consoled him saying, “Son, don’t be sad. This remorse itself is the best redress for the mistakes that you have committed. The errors committed when we were ignorant will be forgiven by God. But once you become aware that they are mistakes, from then onwards try your best to refrain from doing them. Stop brooding. Forget about the bad actions that you have committed in the past. Once you take refuge in God, refraining from bad actions, they are like a canceled check.” The young man gazed at the Holy Mother’s face and again asked surprisingly, “Still, I am wondering how Mother came to know all these things.” The Mother just smiled, looked at him and turned up the palms of her hands in a gesture meaning ‘who knows?’

At this time, a householder devotee came with his family and prostrated to the Holy Mother. This was their first visit to the Ashram. Mother asked them to sit on the verandah.

Mother: Children, have you eaten anything?

Devotee: Yes, we had breakfast.

Mother: Children, you know *bhajans*, don’t you? Please sing some songs.

The devotee, his wife and children looked at each other in amazement. They were wondering how Mother came to know that they wanted to sing *bhajans* for her.

Mother: (Loudly) O my son Sree (Sreekumar), bring the harmonium.

Sreekumar came with the harmonium. The devotee and his family sang together:

*nandalala navanita chora natavaralala gopala
devaki vasudeva kumara deva deva gopala
mohana murali gana vilola mohana venu gopala*

Mother: (with great joy) Sing, sing!

They again sang:

*he nandala gopal
shyama gopal venu gopala
he nandalal...
giridhara gopala radhe gopala
shyama gopal venu gopala*

Mother: (in a begging tone) One more, please!

The devotee with his family sang:

*nanda ananda krishna sundara gopala
ananda govinda gopi gopala
he madhava he keshava
manamohana krishna jagadishwara*

The Holy Mother was very happy. She inquired about the devotee's children's education and other details. The Mother drew very close to them as if she had known them for a long time. The Mother said, "Children, come on, let's go to the seashore."

Mother took them to the seashore. Along the way, they came upon a stump. Only about one foot of it remained above ground. Pointing to the stump, the Holy Mother said, "Mother used to meditate sitting here."

The Holy Mother with the devotees went very close to the ocean waves. A giant wave suddenly rose up and broke on the shore. Like a small child, the Holy Mother laughed and called out "Shivo, Shivo!" Looking at the sea, the Mother

said, "Where the water is shallow there are waves and agitation, but the deep sea is calm."

The Mother wrote "Mother Sea" in the sand with her index finger. When the waves rolled up and erased it, the Mother laughed aloud like an innocent child.

It was lunch time when they returned to the Ashram. The Mother served food to the devotees herself and fed each one a ball of rice with her own hand, just like a real Mother with her children.

After lunch, Mother went to her hut. Some of the devotees conversed with the residents and others began reading spiritual books. Some of them sat in the coconut grove and sang *bhajans*.

It was dusk when the Holy Mother came out for the usual evening *bhajan*. The *bhajan* started at six-thirty with Mother singing:

*O Mother, even though Thou art near I am wandering
unable to know Thee. Even though I have eyes, I am
searching unable to see Thee.*

*Art Thou the beautiful moon that blooms forth in the
blue winter night? I am a wave that, unable to reach the
sky, beats its head against the shore...*

Such is the sobbing of the limited individual selves to attain the Unlimited. Knowingly or unknowingly they search for that Supreme Goal, but like the waves, they again fall down unable to reach the heights of Self-Realization. The endless search which began eons ago still continues until dissolution, only to begin once again.

Sunday, 23 October 1983

It was ten in the morning when Mother came out of her hut. Dressed in pure white, wearing ash on her forehead and with ornaments made of *rudraksha* on her ears, hands and neck, the Mother smilingly received her devotees.

Her nose ring shone in the sun's rays which made her smile all the more beautiful. The Mother walked towards the coconut grove and sat in a shady place. All the devotees, having offered their prostrations, sat in front of Mother.

The Holy Mother became absorbed in deep meditation. Some of the devotees also sat in contemplation while others gazed at the Holy Mother's form. Now and then the Mother showed different *mudras* with her hands and blissfully smiled as if she were beholding something. When the Mother came out of meditation, a woman from a nearby house approached her and began explaining her woeful story. She talked to the Mother as if to a friend or neighbor. It was quite obvious that her understanding about Mother was poor. Since there were many people sitting around, the woman left the place without spending much time near the Mother. When she had gone, the Holy Mother said, "People go to see doctors when they are afflicted by some disease. Likewise, they should go to spiritual centers when the mind gets sick. There they will get mental peace. But, usually they won't feel like going. They will simply suffer. God is waiting to help. But there is nobody to receive the help."

"Look, haven't you seen that woman? During *Krishna* and *Devi Bhavas* she comes and tells everything to Bhagavan and Devi. She thinks that Mother doesn't remember any of those things afterwards. Now she comes like this and tells many other things but only things concerning herself and her small family. What a pity! Everyone lives in their little world made of their own little dreams. (Mother laughs)

It doesn't matter how much sorrow comes; some people won't properly turn to God."

Devotee: Why is this, Mother?

Mother: It is the fruit of past actions that causes people to behave this way. That is how *vasanas* take over. Due to the lack of care or heedfulness they won't feel like doing the right thing even if somebody tells them about it. This is all the result of their previous birth.

The Mother noticed a *brahmacharin* leaving the meditation hall during the hour of meditation.

Mother: (to the *brahmacharin*) Children, when we set a disciplined routine, we must follow it regularly without fail. Punctuality in following one's discipline is most necessary. A person who has picked up the habit of drinking tea every day at a fixed time will get a headache if he doesn't drink it one day at that particular time. That is the way habits work. Likewise, you children should feel that kind of longing if you fail to perform your practice even one day. That shows your intensity and *sraddha* to reach the goal.

The *brahmacharin* returned to the meditation hall. The Mother says that one should not get up even for nature calls during meditation. "A *sadhaka* should have forbearance and endurance. Nothing should move him. Before meditation, you should tell your mind, 'Whatever may happen, I will get up from here only after the pre-determined hour of meditation is over.'"

The crows made a big noise by cawing while perching on the trees and flying haphazardly in the sky. It seemed that they had seen some food somewhere and were fighting for it. On the other side of the backwaters the fisherwomen were beating coconut husks. That sound mixed with the cawing of the crows echoed in the atmosphere.

One woman devotee: Mother, what is our path?

Mother: You children are householders. You should look after your children, husband and house. But all the time chant the Divine Name. Chant your *mantra* while doing any work. Both spirituality and worldly life should be carried out simultaneously. Let your world be firmly fixed on spiritual foundations.

Daughter, haven't you seen a person feeding ducks while guiding them through the backwaters? He will be standing in a small canoe. There will not be enough space in the boat even to keep his legs properly. If the ducks happen to stray away, he will guide them in the correct direction by splashing the oar in the water. All the time he is rowing the boat, he will be smoking a cigarette. If water happens to get into the boat he will bail it out. He will talk to someone who is standing on the shore. But, even while doing all of this, his mind will be fully concentrated on the balance of the boat. If his attention is distracted even for a moment, he will lose his balance and fall into the water. This is how you have to live in this world. Whatever you are doing, the mind should be fixed on God. This is easily possible through practice.

It is better to tell your sorrows, whatever they are, to God rather than to your husband. You should pray like this, "O God, please give peace of mind to my husband. Please bless my children." In this way, do everything thinking of God. Usually women are only thoughtful about their family. They should be a little more broad-minded. Remember that all are God's children. We will remove the thorns lying in front of our house. Why are we doing this? To avoid pricking the foot. To avoid falling down we remove a banana peel from the house or yard. Likewise, we should remove it even if it is lying on the path. We should think that all are our children or God's children. Don't think "Aren't they somebody else's children? Let them fall,

why should I care about it?” Our mental attitude should be, “O God, let even an egotistic person be able to pass by without falling down.”

First of all, our neighbors should be good. Is it possible for us to sit quietly in our house if a quarrel takes place in the next house? Can concentration be gained in meditation if some thorns are lying here? You will go on thinking restlessly, “Oh, it is piercing, it is hurting.” Likewise, if there are bad thoughts in the surroundings, that will adversely affect us. Concentration will be lost. Therefore we should pray like this: “O God, make everyone virtuous. It is because of their *samskāra* (mental tendencies) that they are saying and acting like this. O God, give Your light to all, pardoning everyone.” Always chant your *mantra*. Whoever you may meet, don’t forget to chant the *mantra*.

Daughter, don’t waste time talking about worldly things. Life will be wasted if you cling to worldly things forever. Suppose you live eighty years in this world. Why should you spend your entire lifetime only for desiring, enjoying and thinking about worldly pleasures? Can’t you think and turn to a higher way of living once you understand the momentary nature of these worldly objects? Otherwise, it is foolishness and nothing more than a pig’s life. The family man’s mind stays in the world, worldly thoughts gnawing away at his vitals. Even then, there are ways to save himself.

Woman devotee: Why do you say that, Mother?

Mother: Remembrance of God is a *vettuchembu*.⁶² Do you know what the specialty of *vettuchembu* is? In most plants, once the root starts to decay, the plant won’t sprout again. But this is not the case with *vettuchembu*. If there is even a bit of green portion anywhere, the shoot will come from

⁶²The root of a kind of tuber plant.

there. Remembrance of God is similar. Suppose it so happens that remembrance of God has entered into our mind at some time or other. It doesn't matter how much the mind is spoiled or how long it has remained under evil influences. When spiritual awareness dawns, that former thought of God will sprout. This is the special feature of Godly thoughts. So, we don't have to be afraid now, do we?

Mother smilingly continued, "Nothing will happen if you simply sit feeling happy about spiritual life. If you want spiritual progress, intense *vairagya* (detachment) and *sadhana* are needed. It is laziness to think that everything will turn out well without any effort. This *tamas* (inertia) is a great obstacle.

From the very beginning you should move with care. Suppose we are sowing some seeds. After they sprout, we spread thorns around that particular area. Why? To protect the seeds from getting destroyed by hens and human beings. In the beginning it is dangerous because they might pierce people's feet, but will the seeds sprout if you worry about that? Likewise, in the beginning stages, the *sadhaka* should protect himself from evil influences to help his spiritual progress. For that, *yama* and *niyama*⁶³ are necessary. Whoever comes your way, don't mingle too much with them. The seed of devotion will not sprout if you gossip and cling to your worldly manners to please everyone. All your devotion will be trampled and destroyed by relatives and friends. Don't heed their hatred. They cannot save us. They can only harm us. Bhagavan alone is the Savior. Therefore, whatever happens, hold tightly onto God.

We will lose the certificate of God if we act wanting or expecting a good certificate from our relatives. Those who remember God alone are our real relatives. Only those who

⁶³The do's and don'ts of yogic discipline.

help us towards the goal become our near and dear ones. Others are destroyers. When such people come, tell them, “You have your own path. My path is different. Please don’t feel angry, but this is the right path for me. I must follow this path now.”

When milk is being made into yogurt, it should be kept still. Only then will it transform properly. Similarly, in the beginning, *sadhana* in solitude is necessary. After the seed is sown, care should be taken to prevent the hens from pecking or scratching it. Once it germinates and grows up, there is no problem. In the beginning, don’t mingle too much with everyone. Women householder devotees should particularly be careful about this. Sitting alone, you should do *japa*, *dhyana* and sing *kirtans* without wasting time talking unnecessarily with your neighbors.

Woman devotee: Mother, what if they come to quarrel with us saying that we are having enmity with them?

Mother: Daughter, try to make them understand the matter. Let them listen if they care. Otherwise, don’t bother about them. We shouldn’t have hatred towards anyone. Tell those who are developing ill feelings towards us, “Look, it is not because of any bad feelings towards you that I am saying this, but how many births has it taken to get this human birth? The aim of human birth is God-Realization. Forgetting the goal, we have spent our time thinking that this body is eternal. Only now, that understanding has dawned. Why should we continue to make the same mistakes? Why should we speak ill of others and find fault with them? What is the use of it? We can chant many Godly *mantras* instead, can’t we?”

Children, we spoil our life thinking of our near and dear ones like husband, children and relatives. Are these so-called children our children? Where were they before birth? Whose children were they? Whose children are they when they

die? We say that the children are ours. If it is so, can we stop them from going when death comes? It is certain that they are not our children. All are His children, the Lord's children. It is He who gives life and takes it. He alone is the real owner of the *jiva*. Children, what foolishness it is to think of them as ours! You say that your husband is yours. Is he your husband? If so, you must be able to seize and detain him when death comes, mustn't you? If that is not possible, how can you say that he is 'your' husband? How can a thing which is not under our control be ours? Therefore, the husband is not ours. Everything is owned by Him. See and behold only the Essence in them. It is not the cashew fruit but the nut that we need. The fruit will get rotten after two days. But the nut won't decay. It is not the husband's body but the soul that we have to see. Not only the bodies but the spirits should be united. Thinking and contemplating this way, let us proceed forward surrendering everything to Him. Thus, you should give good advice to your friends and relatives. Even then, if they become envious, don't pay any attention.

We should direct all our attention to God discarding everything else. For example, when our child is sick, we will run to the hospital to see the doctor and get the medicine. As you are running, many people along the roadside will ask you, "Where are you going, where are you going?" You would say, "Not far—don't worry." There is no time to stop on the road and give the answer because you will miss the bus and won't be able to see the doctor. Likewise, ignoring everything else, we should go towards God. When you sit somewhere doing nothing, try to tell stories of the Lord instead of indulging in gossip and finding fault with others.

The woman devotee was very happy and seemed quite convinced. It was a moment filled with grace. All the devo-

tees were bathed in the nectarous words of the Holy Mother. Everyone sat motionless like statues listening to the great truths which the Holy Mother expounded in simple and lucid terms, making them alive and understandable through examples taken from daily life. The words went directly into the hearts of the devotees. Only if the Mother finds that the listeners are inquisitive does she give such long talks. Such occasions are rare. Sometimes in front of people who are not interested in spiritual matters and people who ask questions just for the sake of questioning, the Mother will not even open her mouth. To put it in Mother's own words, "No matter how much I tried, I couldn't utter even a word to them. I just got up and came back later. Without an inner feeling springing forth from within, Mother cannot show love or talk artificially. Everything depends on the children's character. Mother doesn't have any particular feeling towards anyone. But unknowingly Mother will feel a closeness to innocent-hearted people." But the case is different when atheists or rationalists ask questions only out of curiosity.

The woman devotee: We heard that for some reason Mother couldn't sleep last night.

Mother joyfully laughed and said, "Yes, yes, one of my sons was calling. Oh, what an innocent call it was! Finally, he fell asleep thinking and thinking of Mother. Wherever my children call from, Mother will hear them."

It was obvious from their faces that the devotees were very curious to hear more about the son whom Mother mentioned. At that time Balu, who was sitting near Mother, said, "It is true that Mother couldn't sleep last night. She was so restless and all of a sudden she said in a loud voice, 'Son, don't do it, Mother is here for you.' It was only at five in the morning that she slept peacefully, but only for an hour. We were also a bit worried about Mother's mood.

It remained a mystery to us as well until (pointing to a young man who was sitting in the back shedding copious tears) he came here today at seven in the morning. I told you that Mother slept for an hour. All of a sudden she got up at six, came out of her hut at six-thirty and sat outside in the sand as if waiting for someone to come. When it was five minutes to seven this young man arrived, out of breath, at the Ashram. It was obvious that he had neither slept nor changed his clothes. Seeing Mother sitting in front of the hut, he ran to her, fell at her feet, and burst into tears. The Holy Mother, with overflowing motherly affection, held him and slowly lifted him up. She wiped his tears with her own cloth and lovingly said, 'Son, Mother knew that you were coming. I was waiting for you. Mother came to you last night.' Hearing this, the young man again burst into tears. The Mother consoled him and talked to him for an hour and again went to her hut."

Even though the Holy Mother got up and went away, all the devotees were very curious to know more, so, to satisfy them, Babu himself said, "I was working as an engineer and had visited Mother a couple of times. I had strong faith in her. I received my engineering degree three months ago and fortunately was employed without much delay. I had a love affair with a young girl who was a medical student. We promised to marry each other as soon as the girl's college courses were completed and after I was employed. We promised we would marry each other, even if our parents protested. But, though my love towards her was pure and sincere, the girl's attitude was not the same. She became engaged to someone else and two days before her wedding to the other man took place, I had a total nervous breakdown. For the last two days I was wandering here and there like one gone mad. Last night I cried and cried calling out to Mother behind the closed doors of my room and finally

decided to commit suicide. I took out the thirty sleeping pills which I had purchased the previous day when the depression started and was about to swallow them. Then, all of a sudden I saw the Holy Mother entering into the room with outstretched arms. The door was still closed yet I was amazed to see her entering the room in flesh and blood. As she came in, the Mother called lovingly, 'My son, don't do it! Mother is here for you.' She approached me and took the pills from my hand, opened the window and threw them outside. Then she said, 'Don't act like a fool. You are Mother's son. Come to Vallickavu.' Saying this, she disappeared. I couldn't even utter a word. I stood tongue tied. Was it a dream or reality? I looked at the open window. It was closed before. Still not convinced, I went out and searched for the pills outside the window and was wonderstruck to find them lying there scattered around. I had no more doubt. This happened at four-thirty in the morning. Immediately I left for Vallickavu." Babu paused for awhile and looked at the devotees. All of them were sitting motionless like carved wooden images. Babu said, "Now, I hope the whole matter is clear."

All this time the Holy Mother had been sitting with her eyes closed. Within a few seconds she opened her eyes and smilingly saluted all the devotees and got up from the seat. All the devotees offered their prostrations to the Mother. The Mother, without uttering another word, walked towards her hut. Everyone looked at Babu, but now he wasn't crying. Instead, a joyful smile bloomed on his face.

Monday, 24 October 1983

The Mother was sitting under a coconut tree in the grove situated in the front yard of the Ashram. It was about ten-thirty in the morning. Though the sun's rays became more

and more intense, the shade of the trees gave protection from the heat, just as the loving guidance and help of a *Satguru* gives protection from the scorching heat of worldliness.

Three youths who were interested in spiritual and religious matters were sitting in front of Mother on the southern side of the Ashram. Across the backwaters, the people who were beating coconut husks were quarreling with each other. It created a lot of noise even on the Ashram premises. Slowly the noise died down and only the beating of the husks could be heard.

The Hindu Faith and ‘I’, the Supreme Principle

A young man: Mother, why is Hinduism so liberal and lacking in organization?

Mother: Son, the preceptors of old presented *Sanatana Dharma* (the eternal religion), not as a narrow religion constrained to a particular caste, creed or sect, but rather as a way of life that was open to anyone and everyone. All are welcome to this path. It belongs to everyone. Just like a compassionate and loving mother, it discards none. This faith declares that anyone, regardless of his or her mental constitution or path, can attain God through constant practice. Religion should be able to satisfy everyone equally without any distinction. Take for example a mother who has ten children with ten different personalities. One may be a high thinking spiritual person, another one a scientist. There might be an artist or sensationist among them, while another might be doing cultivation and physical labor. There could also be a rogue, or a robber among them. But the mother will consider them all equally. While serving food, she won’t serve more to the spiritual one or the scientist and less to

the artist or the rogue. She will be able to satisfy everyone equally while serving, talking or in showing love to them. Sometimes it might even seem that she loves the rogue more and gives him little concessions. Children, true religion is like this. Whatever the mental constitution or level of thinking of a person may be, true religion must be able to satisfy him fully. This is what Hinduism does. It provides a means to attain the Truth, regardless of any other consideration. There is the path of *bhakti* for those who are predominantly emotional and the path of *jñāna* for the intellectually predominant. If someone is hard working by nature and is interested in doing physical labor, the path of action (*karma yoga*) is there for him. But there are people who think that only their religion is valid and then they proclaim that Liberation is possible only by following their path.

Young man: Is that correct, Mother?

Mother: No, it is not. Kollam and Quilon are one and the same, aren't they? The ultimate goal of all spiritual practices and religions is the same, God. But He is known by different names, that is all. Is it correct if someone says that you can go to Delhi only by taking one particular road? There are many roads which will take us to Delhi, aren't there? We must be ready to accept this fact, instead of fighting each other in the name of religion.

Young man: What if they claim that only their path is the direct way to God and all the others are indirect?

Mother: No one has the right to make that claim. It would be out of utter foolishness and ignorance if someone said that. Mother would say that such people are totally ignorant about the purpose of religion. Such statements show the inability of the so-called followers to understand the teachings and lives of their masters.

Exponents of *Sanatana Dharma* have not declared that only one path is suitable for attaining the goal. All will reach

the same place, whether sitting on a bicycle, in a boat, or on an autorickshaw. Whatever vehicle we use, the destination is still Quilon.

Children, no great soul will say, "Only through me, you will be saved." Has Sri Ramakrishna said, "Follow me alone, otherwise there is no hope." Has Ramana Maharshi said that? Did any of the great saints and sages of the past make statements like that? No. A real knower of the Self will not say that. What they say is that you should move forward according to your chosen path, having firm faith in it. This is what is said by the founders of all the religions.

But after their demise, the followers interpret their teachings in different ways. Doctrines like, "Have faith only in our religion" or "Only through our path" are spread by followers who have no *visalata* (broad-mindedness). Do you know what a *Mahatma* means when he says, "Believe in me"? The "I" they talk about is not the small "I" which denotes the individual. It is that "I" which is the Supreme Principle. As far as a *Mahatma* is concerned, "In me" means "In God." Taking this and interpreting it as caste, religion or otherwise, the followers think in a narrow-minded way. When Sri Krishna told Arjuna, "Have faith in Me," he meant to have faith in that "I" which is the Supreme Principle. But now, some Hindus say that you will gain Liberation only if you believe in Lord Krishna; some others say that Shiva alone is the Liberator, and so on. This is not correct. The Truth is that however we call on the Lord, whether it is Krishna or Christ or Nabi, He will help us to attain the Supreme. Whether you come through the southern side or northern side or from the east, you can reach the Ashram. Those who say "Only our religion is true" are mistaken. Real *Mahatmas* will never be bound by an institution. They will go forward keeping the Supreme Truth alone as the ideal. Therefore, the great masters of Hinduism, who were

all Realized Souls, have not insisted on any narrow rules. They have not formed an organization. That is why, even after many eons, the Hindu faith still exists with its roots deeply entrenched. It is unshakable. No force can destroy it. The infinite power of Hinduism is derived from the *sankalpa shakti* (strong resolve) of the great saints and seers. Children, there is no harm in having many religions and faiths, but it is harmful to think that they are different and that one faith is higher than another. Do not see the differences, see the unity in them and the great ideals which they teach. What all religions show is how to develop compassion, love, faith, forbearance, endurance and renunciation. That is what is important. Religion means expansiveness, the ability to accommodate anything and everything. Religion is the merging of mind where all differences disappear.

The second youth: It is said that *Sanatana Dharma* is the source of all other religions and that other religions sprung from it. Is this true, Mother?

Mother: Yes, it is true. In the beginning there was only one religion. It was from that religion that all other religions sprang up, according to the needs of the different eras. In reality, there are no differences between the religions. There is only unity. Previously, in India, there was only one political party, the Indian National Congress. It is only recently that the other parties came into existence. Likewise, at one time there was only *Sanatana Dharma*.

A youth: The temple authorities in our place play movie songs instead of devotional songs through the temple's loud speakers.

Mother: Children, you should ask the members of the temple committee, "What is this temple for, what is its purpose?"

Young man: Mother, if we do that, there will be no one there to support us.

Mother: Son, don't think like that. You should tell them the matter without getting angry, "Dear elders, you are our fathers. We are young. We would like to ask so we can understand certain things from you. Is it right to do this in a temple? Is this place and its atmosphere meant to develop devotion and love in the hearts of people or is it meant to increase the worldly tendencies in them? As administrators of the temple, aren't you responsible for keeping the temple atmosphere pure and holy? Otherwise, what is the difference between a movie theatre and a temple?" Tell them to play devotional songs. If you say it lovingly, they will come to the right path. What a pity! Worldly songs being played in the temples. They won't even play '*Harinama kīrtan*' (devotional songs) early in the morning.

Young man: If they go to see a vulgar film, they will proudly say, "I am going to see such and such a film." But they are ashamed to say that they are going to an Ashram. If they go to an Ashram or other holy place, they would simply say, "I am going somewhere." They will name some place other than the Ashram.

Mother: (laughingly) They will go secretly. Otherwise, other's will tease them. Even if you have to hear their scoldings, tell them frankly that you are going to the Ashram. Let them scold. Our sin will be reduced. We are taking on sin when it is kept a secret. We must have the courage to tell the truth. Good character is the most important thing in life. That is the foundation on which you have to build your life. Character building is what we gain at ashrams and *gurukulas*. Ashamed to visit holy places, we consider cheap worldly things as something great and valuable. In truth, these only spoil our life and take away our peace of mind, leaving us in the midst of darkness. They will only increase our negativity. On the other hand, ashrams and spiritual people will lead you to light and bestow peace and

tranquillity in your life. This shows our lack of culture. You should frankly say, “I am going to the temple or Ashram. We have no peace of mind. We are going to the place where we can get that. You cannot give us peace of mind. We know that you yourselves have no peace. What difference does it make, if you tease us?”

The society which destroys itself

Young man: Mother, they will say that they see movies to get peace of mind.

Mother: After seeing the movies, they will start imitating what they have seen. Many people learn to steal and do other harmful things from watching movies. The children are even practicing fistfighting after returning from the movie theatre.

Several days ago two boys were fighting over there (pointing to the next house). One of the boys fell down unconscious. When asked, they said that they were trying the karate kick which they had seen in a movie. (All laugh)

Another harmful pastime is reading cheap novels. After reading such novels, people start doing all kinds of bad things. Many evil and malicious thoughts pass through their minds, which later end in harmful actions. Because of this, even the atmosphere becomes polluted.

In the olden days there were fewer people. Therefore the atmosphere was more pure. In those days, if there was one house here, the next house would be far away. In the area where there was only one house previously now there are a thousand houses. Not only that; in the olden days there were plenty of medicinal trees everywhere. One would not get sick if one breathed the air that was blowing over those trees and leaves. The trees grown in those days were the banyan, the country fig, the neem or margosa. They were all *ayurvedic* herbal trees. Now, most of them are cut down.

People started growing fruit-bearing trees, plants and vegetables which are good for eating, but even those were grown using artificial fertilizers which will do harm to the body. Using these artificial and so-called modern means, they multiplied the size and yield of the roots, vegetables and other plants by two or three times the normal. People are eating these foods, unaware that it will definitely do harm physically, emotionally and intellectually. Their children will also be affected. Nothing is natural nowadays. Even human beings are after unnatural things. They cannot act or speak naturally. Everything is unnatural. Therefore, they have lost their energy and glow. The air has become polluted due to the poisonous gas produced from factories. Even the health of human beings is quickly deteriorating. The only way to regain the lost natural state of both Nature and human beings is through spirituality.

Satya nasti paro dharma

There is no dharma superior to truth

Mother: In the olden days, people believed only in the truth. All families encouraged a truthful life-style. The people of those days lived truthfully even if their lives were in danger. Though one was a servant, he would not give up truth, even if somebody offered millions to him. If you catch hold of the truth, everything else will come to you. Without truth, *Lakshmi* (the Goddess of prosperity), *Bhairavi* (an aspect of Mother Durga), and even *jñāna* (knowledge) cannot exist. Truth is everything. Truth is God.

During that time, everyone practiced truth. The wife lived for the husband and the husband for the wife. They had the fruit of truth and self-sacrifice. They had an all-surrendering attitude, courage, love, righteousness and justice. Without truth, there is nothing, no *dharma* or *Lakshmi*. Even

if one's life was in danger he would tell only the truth. (Laughingly) Nowadays people tell such lies, even in the court, touching (taking an oath on) the *Ramayana*, *Bhagavad Gita* or *Bhagavata*! In those days, there was truth, there was *bhaya bhakti* (devotion endowed with reverence and fear) to *Ramayana* and other holy texts. But now, after taking an oath on the *Ramayana* saying "This is truth, what I am going to say is truth," the first word they utter will be a lie! (All laugh) Today the *Ramayana* is only a bunch of paper.

The youths and the devotees present greatly enjoyed the Holy Mother's talk. It was quite clear that they were really amazed to hear these highly enlightening words from a seemingly simple village girl who did not even have a formal education.

Young man: I have told some of my friends about Mother, but they were not convinced of Mother's greatness.

Mother: Son, when it is time, the fruit will ripen. Don't squeeze and make it ripen too early. There are people of different natures. You shouldn't try to argue with them. Each one's experience is their *pramana* (valid means of knowledge). We might not even believe it if somebody else tells us their experience. When we tell our experience to others, let them accept it or not. Otherwise, don't insist. Don't waste time on all this, children.

If someone comes to criticize you, say, "On the basis of our faith we go there. You have nothing to do with this matter. It cost us money to go to the Ashram. Do you think that we go to the Ashram for nothing? Consider that there may be something worth going for. We are going to the place where we get mental peace. What about you? You give the money that you have to liquor shops and tea shops. That is your habit. You don't have time and money for good things. Because of that, you suffer."

Young man: Do you send the resident *brahmacharins* to give speeches?

Mother: There is no big thing about giving speeches after studying books. Instead, you should speak only after you have gained experience. That which comes through experience is valid. Some times Mother will send one or two *brahmacharins* to give a speech. Mother has sent one son to study the scriptures. But others have not studied the scriptures at this time. Even then, they have conducted speeches in many places. They have shown others that one could give speeches even without learning the scriptures. This was possible as a result of their *sadhana* and experience.

Young man: We don't have irrevocable bonds to an institution or church like the people of other religions, do we?

Mother: They have many problems and entanglements concerning their existence. Therefore they are forced to stand together. The *rishis* thought it was better not to bind the Hindu religion. Where is the end to catch hold and tie? Whom do you think can seize hold of the vast sky and tie it? Therefore, they could not bind it. It lies open. Still, the fact remains that there is no unity. Because there are no bondages, it still exists without decaying. Organized religion also has its drawbacks. Look at the decline of the Buddhist faith.

Look at the people of some sects of Hinduism. They say that Liberation is possible only through their God. That is an extremely narrow attitude. They are giving speeches standing in market places as if God is for sale. They will beat you if you say that there is another God other than theirs. This is an uncivilized nature. But real Hindus will accept everything. What is there to reject? Everything is God only, isn't it? In the *Gita*, the Lord has said, "I am Gayatri among *mantras*, Himalayas among mountains, banyan tree among trees."

Two elderly people arrived just then and sat among the group of devotees after prostrating to the Holy Mother.

Mother: Children, where are you coming from?

First man: From Trivandrum.

Mother: Children, have you eaten anything?

First man: Yes, we ate, earlier.

Mother: Here lunch is at twelve-thirty. All children can take food from the Ashram. Are you leaving soon?

Second Man: We came to see and talk with Mother.

Mother: Yes, it should be for *satsang* that we should go to spiritual people and spiritual centers. It is good to spend some time there. *Satsang* is the best thing for spiritual advancement.

The newcomers were spiritually inclined. It seemed that they were *sadhakas*. Mother also felt some kind of closeness with them. When they were about to ask something, she said, “Children, have your lunch and then come. Mother will talk to you later.” The Holy Mother went to her hut after taking them to the dining hall.

In the afternoon the Mother called the newcomers to her hut. Getting up from the cot, Mother sat on a mat on the floor with them.

First man: Mother, are all *satsangs* equally good?

Mother: Son, whichever kind it is, all *satsangs* will have at least some benefit. Whenever or however people gather together to think of God or talk about Him is good, is it not? All will be thinking of the same thing. The homogeneous thought waves will lessen unnecessary thoughts and peace will be enjoyed. But the meeting should not be for arguing and disputing. That will only increase arrogance and ego. The *satsang* should be used for meditation, singing devotional songs, contemplating and discussing scriptural statements. It is most beneficial if you get a chance to see a *Jivanmukta*

(a Liberated Soul) or an *Avatar* (Incarnation of God). Their mere presence itself will benefit us.

Nirvikalpa samadhi and an Avatar

Second Man: Can one take birth again after experiencing *nirvikalpa samadhi*?⁶⁴

Mother: Children, if they are people who have descended from above, they will return after experiencing *nirvikalpa samadhi*. But they won't return if they are people who ascended through *sadhana*. They will just leave their body. Having thought about a particular thing before entering into *samadhi*, one can return to that same thought. This is possible. But this is possible only if one does it intentionally. Only those who know how can do this. Otherwise it will be like a kite with a broken string going up in the air. Incarnations can come back. In fact, an Incarnation doesn't have different states like *nirvikalpa samadhi*. They are always That only, *Purnam* (perfect). They have only certain limitations which they themselves have accepted for the *avatara karma*.⁶⁵

Both of the newcomers were very happy. The one who seemed to be the oldest said, "Mother, we are very blessed to be in your presence. We are ignorant children who are still very involved in worldly affairs. Mother, please bless us to come to you now and then so that we can unload our burdens and regain our peace and tranquillity.

Mother: (Smilingly) We ourselves have taken the burden and now we ourselves have to give it back. Mother doesn't want anything from her children except the burden of their sorrows and sufferings.

⁶⁴Absorption of the mind into the Formless Reality.

⁶⁵The activities that should happen during that particular Incarnation.

After saluting the Holy Mother, they took leave of her. It was evening and soon the *bhajans* began.

Friday, 28 October 1983

The day had passed. The sun slowly moved toward the western horizon ready to dive deep into the Arabian Sea. It was five in the evening. Some of the *brahmacharins* were meditating in the meditation hall while others were under the trees and a few had gone to the seashore. The Ashram atmosphere was calm and quiet. All of a sudden the Holy Mother, who had been very healthy and cheerful up to this point, was stricken with a breathing disorder (asthma). No particular symptoms had been seen earlier. This created a great amount of confusion in the Ashram. As each moment passed the disease became worse. Everyone was very distressed, seeing the Holy Mother struggling to breathe properly. The *brahmacharins* ran here and there in the hope of getting some medicine. Though they tried different medicines, none seemed to make a difference. Some of the householder devotees and *brahmacharins* shed tears looking at Mother. Some began chanting the Divine Names and *mantras* for healing the Mother's sickness. The Holy Mother rolled on the ground in great pain. Several hours went by like this. At ten that night, the Mother drifted into a seemingly sleepy mood.

Saturday, 29 October 1983

This sudden attack of asthma remained a mystery until the next morning. Early in the morning a lady from Quilon came to the Ashram saying she urgently wanted to see Mother. She sat outside Mother's hut waiting for her to come out. That day Mother came out before the usual time. All the residents were anxious to know whether the asthma attack

of the previous night had lessened. As the Mother was very enthusiastic and cheerful as usual, it was quite apparent that the disease had gone. Not only that; there was no trace of exhaustion either on her face or in her movements. Everyone was very happy and at the same time amazed. The woman devotee suddenly came forward and having bowed before the Mother, stood with her palms joined in front of her.

Mother: Why are you here so early, daughter? Isn't your sickness cured?

Hearing these words, the woman stared at the Mother's face in wonderment. As if in a dream she uttered, "Mother, you saved me yesterday. So, it was true. Now it is clear. The whole day I suffered a terrible asthma attack. In the afternoon it became worse. Unable to bear the pain and difficulty it created in the respiratory system, I cried aloud calling Mother. In a few minutes the disease was cured. The asthmatic trouble completely disappeared. Everyone was struck with wonder. The children in the house said that it was Vallickavu Amma who removed the disease. Then they started singing the Divine Name with great devotion. I also thought, 'Who else could remove this horrible disease except Mother?' Now I heard it from your own mouth. I came running to see you and to offer my salutations. Oh Mother, I have nothing else to offer." The woman burst into tears. The Holy Mother lovingly patted her on the back and comforted her.

Later the Mother related: "Mother could not help taking her disease when she heard that daughter's heartbreaking cry."

Yogaschitta vritti nirodah

The Ashram clock rang ten. The *brahmacharins* came out of the meditation hall having completed their morning medi-

tation. One young *brahmacharin* who had joined the Ashram only a week earlier approached the Holy Mother, who was lost in meditation, sitting under a coconut tree in front of the temple. The *brahmacharin* stood at a short distance away from Mother looking at her. A couple more minutes passed when Mother opened her eyes uttering, “Shiva, Shiva.” She smiled at the boy who then came closer to her and saluted her.

Before meeting Mother this *brahmacharin* was a *nirguno-pasaka* (worshipper of the Formless) although he worked as a priest in a temple of the Divine Mother Kali near his house. He later started meditating on the formless Self as instructed by a scholar. Before switching his meditation to the formless Self, he would meditate upon the fierce aspect of the Divine Mother, Kali. For a long time he used that form of Mother Kali as his Beloved Deity. He never used that form of meditation after he started the new technique. On his first visit to the Ashram, he had an informal talk with the Mother telling her his decision to join the Ashram. Before he could mention anything about his practices the Mother took a small picture of Mother Kali from the wall of coconut leaves and handing it to him said, “You are not mature enough to meditate upon the Formless. Therefore, meditate on this form of the Mother. Without love, nothing can be gained. Your mind has become very hard. Sprinkle it with the water of love and make it soft.” The astounded boy was tongue tied. He alternately looked at the small picture given by Mother and at the Holy Mother’s face. The picture was exactly the same pose of Mother Kali which he used to meditate on. Even the size of the photograph was the same. The boy, still unable to control his wonderment said, “Mother, I used to...” The Holy Mother then interrupted and said, “Yes son, Mother knows it, you used to meditate on this form of the Divine Mother and that is

why Mother gave it to you. Attain the *nirguna* (attributeless) through *saguna* (God with attributes)."

Now the boy sat near Mother and said, "Mother, I would like to know something about *yoga*."

Mother: Son, *yoga* is not something that can be told. It is an experience. It is the yoking of *jivatman* and *Paramatman*. The bliss of that union is inexpressible just as you cannot explain sweetness after eating honey. Many talk about it but have not experienced it. Though there are many paths, they are mainly sub-sets of only four: *bhakti yoga*, *karma yoga*, *jñana yoga* and *raja yoga*. The purpose of all *yogas* is control of the mind, which means thoughts. Whatever the path may be, attainment of the goal is possible only if the *vasanas* are attenuated.

Do you know what these different *yogas* are for? Different paths are needed according to each one's nature. The doctor treats the patient according to his bodily constitution. Some people are allergic to injections. Liquid medicine will be given to them. There are some others who would vomit if liquid medicine is taken. They will be given pills. But there are some for whom even allopathic treatment is not suitable. They will be told to take *ayurvedic* medicines. The doctor knows what the patient needs. The aim is to cure the disease, whereas the treatment can be done only according to the body's stamina. Likewise, when the disciple comes to the Guru, the Guru knows which path is suitable for him. For some it will be *raja yoga*. For some others it is *bhakti yoga*. Each one will be given what is best according to their mental state. He will be led on that path. For an emotionally predominant person, the Guru might advise *bhakti yoga*, instructing him to direct all his thoughts towards God. For an intellectual person the Guru may suggest the path of knowledge and ask him to discriminate and understand the ephemeral nature of the world. The path

of *raja yoga* will be given to some one who is interested in observing and analyzing the functioning of the mind. He will be asked to closely observe his mind and its tricky ways, to trace where the thoughts originate from and how to control them. A dynamic person who is hard working in nature would be asked to follow the path of *ṛkarma* dedicating all his work at the feet of the Supreme Lord, renouncing the fruit of all actions. Thus, the path of *yoga* differs according to the nature and taste of the disciple. But there is one thing: it cannot be said which path is better than another because each one is great and unique in its own way. Some may be weak by nature, others might be hard-hearted and so on. The Guru knows how to guide all these people.

Each one has qualities inherited from their past birth. Suitable treatment is needed. If thought over carefully, *bhakti*, *raja* and *jñana yoga* which say that “I am neither the mind nor the intellect” are all a kind of *bhakti*. *Bhakti* comes even when you say “I am *Brahman*.” It is not possible to perform *sadhana* without devotion to the eternal and pure *Brahman* saying “I am That.” *Karma marga* (path of action) is also good. What is needed is to act seeing everything as God and renouncing the fruit. Selflessness is the goal of spirituality. All *sadhanas* are only for that. No matter how much *sadhana* you do or which path you tread, no spiritual progress will be gained if there is selfishness in the mind. It cannot be said that one path is better than the other. The path will be prescribed according to *adhikāri bheda* (the qualification of the student). Each path is suitable for each person. There is no one path which is suitable for all. In fact, the differences in the paths do not really exist. Each path merges in the other.

The path expounded by Patanjali Maharshi is known as *raja yoga*. He also gave importance to *pranayama* and *kundalini yoga* in that book. The vital force which sleeps in the

muladhara (bottom of the spine) is awakened through *pranayama*. The principle of both *raja yoga* and *kundalini yoga* is subjugation of the mind. The purpose of all spiritual practices is nothing but that.

Samatvam yoga uchyate

Mother stopped talking and started singing:

*Come, O Mother, Who art the
Enchantress of the mind.
Give me, O Ambika, Thy Vision.
Let Thy Form shine
In the lotus of my heart.*

*When will dawn that blessed day
When my heart will become full of
Devotion to Thee?
Satiated with the repetition of Thy
Name, when will blissful tears flow
From my eyes?*

The Holy Mother went into *samadhi*. She shed tears of bliss. Regaining her consciousness, she said, “Son, the taste of devotion is something unique. The purpose of *bhakti yoga* which declares ‘I am nothing, everything is You,’ is meant for mental purification. The path of *jñana yoga* which considers, ‘I am the Self, everything is Me,’ is also intended to attain purity of mind. The aim of *karma yoga* in which one does selfless action, seeing God in everything, is also for mental purity. By attaining concentration of mind, *raja yoga* also aims at this. All *yogas* aim at *samatva bhava* (attitude of equality). What is known as *yoga* is *samatvam*. There is no God beyond that, whatever may be the path. That state should be attained.”

Mother: (To a householder devotee) The different paths are for people endowed with different natures. Look at this son. He used to do meditation on *suddha bodha* (Pure Awareness). But understanding his nature and mental constitution, Mother asked him to meditate upon the form of Kali. Also, this will soften his mind, which became very hard due to lack of love and devotion.

One who knows how to make paper flowers sees flowers in a sheet of paper when he looks at it. That memory comes because he learned how to make flowers. How could this memory spring up in a person who has not learned that art? Therefore, first we should learn. That means mental purity should be gained. For obtaining that, it is said that *bhakti* is necessary. Only those who have reached there could say, “Pure Awareness.”

We are not mature enough for that. The ego has not been removed. This being our condition, there is no use in walking around speaking about Pure Awareness. In the beginning, we must have *bhakti* alone. Otherwise our egos will become inflated. *Bhakti* alone will help to eliminate the ego. At present that is what is needed. Nothing else is needed now. Try to call God shedding tears. Don’t run after different *yogas*.

The Mother sang:

*Except through devotion,
There is no other way to get
The Lord’s Vision and to know Him.*

Mother: Werner said that he likes *atma dhyana* (self-inquiry). He does *sadhana* on that. Therefore, Mother tells Werner *atma dhyana* is the best. He is able to do *atma dhyana*, so Mother asked him to sit and meditate and he is doing that accordingly.

It is good to do *sadhana*, but self-observation also should be done so you can see whether you have attained concentration and the strength to love everyone equally, to act selflessly, and so forth.

The expansive “I”

Mother: Even here at the Ashram, there are so many distinctive natures. For each one Mother shows a different path. Mother loves all those who follow different paths, but Mother likes the path of devotion and gives importance to it. That is how Mother grew up. There is the expansive “I” and the narrow “I”. Expansive “I” is the Pure Principle (*suddha tattvam*). It doesn’t have any connection with *Maya* (illusion or Nature). The narrow “I” is the mind or *jiva*. The mind and creation are due to desire. In the expansive meaning, Mother is in everything that is seen. There is no Mother who is different from this universe.

We were talking about *yoga*. All that Mother says can be known through experience if one moves forward firmly holding to any one of these paths. Nothing will happen by simply hearing about it.

One Devotee: Mother, what can I do to melt my heart with God’s love?

Mother: You should call God in solitude and pray, shedding tears. The mind of one who has a wound on his body will be focused on the wound. He will always be thinking of ways to cure it. Likewise, we are afflicted with the disease of *samsara* (transmigration). We should have the desire to treat and cure it. Then our prayers will become sincere and love will fill our hearts with joy.

It was one o’clock. Telling everyone to go and have their lunch, the Holy Mother went into the temple.

Monday, 31 October 1983

Mother had not slept or rested well after the previous night's *Bhava Darshan*. Some of the devotees were still waiting to see Her and offer their respects before they left. Perhaps because of their intense desire the Mother came out of her hut at eight in the morning. When they left, the Mother sat on the corner of the temple verandah keeping her feet on the footstep. The chanting of *Lalitasahasranama* emerged from the temple. All the *brahmacharins* were in meditation.

A group of people from the extreme northern part of Kerala just arrived to see the Holy Mother. There were also some scholars in the group. The Holy Mother happily said, "Come children, come and sit here."

They all stepped onto the verandah and sat down having offered their salutations and the fruits which they had brought. The Holy Mother distributed oranges as *prasada* to everyone. After some time one of the *pandits*, who was a bit egotistic in appearance and movements, started asking certain questions to the Mother.

Scholar: What is *moksha* (Liberation)? Is it attenuation of *vasanas* or elimination of mind?

Mother: Son, both attenuation of *vasanas* and *mano nasa* (elimination of mind) are one and the same. That itself is *moksha*.

Scholar: What is the way to *moksha*?

Mother: Different people have different paths. For you it is enough if you practice *bhakti*. If a balloon is inflated too much it will burst. Beauty is in humility, not in being egotistic thinking that one knows everything. This can be attained only by sowing the seeds of *bhakti*. *Bhakti*, when fully ripened and developed becomes the huge shady tree of *jñana*. All are waiting to get that *bhakti*. We have succeeded if *bhakti* is achieved. Peoples' hollow utterances that they are *jñanis*

or scholars are of no use. The picture of a cow drawn on a sheet of paper won't eat grass. Those who have experience won't say that *bhakti* and *jñana* are two. When love for God comes, that is *bhakti*.

There was a sudden change in the scholar. He was really humbled. He clearly understood that the Mother's talk was aimed at him. His next question was with full humility and reverence.

Scholar: Mother, what is needed to develop real love?

Mother: Faith should come. *Vairagya* (detachment) also is needed.

Scholar: Mother, is it possible to attain *bhakti* through faith?

Mother: Yes, definitely it is. Faith and love are not two. They are interdependent. Without faith we cannot love someone and vice versa. If we have complete faith and love for someone, the mere thought about that person itself will give us a special joy. Do we get any joy if we have no faith in him and consider him a thief? The lover opens his heart to his beloved, because he has faith in her. That faith is the foundation of love. Love springs from faith.

One devotee: Mother, does love arise through *japa*?

Mother: Through *japa*, mental purity is gained. While chanting, we are replacing other thoughts with that particular *mantra*. Just as saline water loses its salty taste by constantly adding fresh water to it, so through constant repetition of a *mantra*, the number of thoughts can be reduced. In due course, all the thoughts can be eliminated except one, that is God. Love will spring through *japa* if one has complete faith and intent to reach the goal.

Devotee: What other changes will chanting the Divine Name bring in us?

Mother: Son, when the Divine Names are chanted sincerely and with devotion, peace of mind and tranquillity can be gained. As Mother said before, chanting will decrease the

number of thoughts. When there are fewer thoughts, you will get more peace of mind. Tension and mental agitation are caused by the numerous thought waves which in turn bring forth all other kinds of negative tendencies like lust, anger, jealousy, and greed. Divine Names when chanted with one-pointedness will enable us to accept both good and bad experiences as God's Will and blessings. This is not possible if your prayers are only to fulfill selfish desires. That will only help to increase the sorrow and disappointments in your life. Peace of mind is the most important thing. Without this, one cannot enjoy even worldly comforts. Son, when we have the desire to get a cure for a disease, we will move carefully. If medicines are taken, there occurs a change in the disease, isn't that so? Likewise, when we chant with concentration thinking, 'I am a patient, this disease should be removed' there occurs a change in our character. In the same manner, all our ways will change when our mind is focused on God. If you read the biographies of devotees and *Mahatmas* you will understand the difference between them and other people. Look at the lives of Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and Sri Ramakrishna and you will understand clearly the change that '*Nama*' (chanting the Divine Name) can bring about in us.

Scholar: Mother, is taking the physician's (Guru's) prescription regarding diet and habits necessary while taking the medicine of *Nama* to remove the disease caused by worldly existence (*bhava roga*)?

Mother: That is absolutely necessary. In the beginning it is indispensable. It is not so much needed after gaining concentration of mind. Your mode of life is very important. The character of a deer which eats grass and a tiger which eats meat are different, aren't they? Those who do meditation should not talk worldly things during the period of *sadhana*. In the beginning, complete silence is needed. Si-

lence, *sattvic* food, abstinence from worldly talk, *satsang*, regularity and discipline in doing *sadhana*, all these will come under the rules and regulations which a serious *sadhaka* should observe.

You should become introverted. Speak only when it is necessary. Only such a one can look within. Ability to endure will arise when desire to cure the disease is there. In the hospital at Vallickavu, Mother has seen people going and lining up in a queue. It didn't matter how much time they needed to wait, they would still wait. It is because of their desire to get rid of the disease that they come walking all the way from their houses in the sun undergoing all sorts of difficulties, and then stand in the queue for many long hours. What patience they have! Their only concentrated thought is to see the doctor and get the medicine. How will you ever see the doctor if you think that you do not have a disease? You will not be able to stand waiting. How will you cure the disease? One who thinks that he has no disease will not have the patience and won't wait for a long time either. When patience comes, the mentality to sacrifice also comes. Mere chanting of *Nama* is not enough. It should be done with concentration. Otherwise it is like pouring water on the surface of a rock. *Japa* is beneficial only if there is concentration. Both sitting for ten hours with your eyes closed and chanting the Divine Names with concentration for one hour are equal. There is a kind of rocket (fire-works) which goes up with great speed and a hissing noise and bursts when it reaches a certain height. *Bhakti* is like that. Liberation can be attained in a moment. It only takes one call, one call that is filled with love and forgetting of one's mind, intellect and body; that one call will take us all the way to the goal.

Just then a devotee named Ayyappan from Mavelikara came and prostrated before the Holy Mother. After con-

versing with him for some time, the Mother sat with her eyes closed for a couple of minutes. Everyone waited, gazing at the Holy Mother's form, until she came down from her ecstatic state. A few more moments passed and with a smile on her face, the Mother opened her eyes. After some more moments of silence, one devotee asked, "Mother, what is real devotion?"

Mother: The devotion of Hanuman is an example. *Bhakti* is surrendering or sacrificing oneself to Divine Love.

Devotee: What about the devotion of the *gopis*?

Mother: Son, the devotion of the *gopis* was also superior. But it was a little bit mixed with *vasanas* in the beginning. Knowledge had not yet arisen in them. In the beginning it won't. Otherwise, why did they get angry when Akrura⁶⁶ came? They had an attitude of duality. What was the reason for Bhagavan's (Sri Krishna's) departure from Ampadi (His birth place)? The *gopis* had not attained complete mental purity. Mother is talking about in the beginning. Later they attained a state where they could see Krishna inside, outside and everywhere. The seed has to be sown in the shade first. It can be transplanted when it has grown to a certain height; but until then, shade is necessary. Likewise, the seed of the *gopis'* love was sown and grown to a certain level under the shade of the huge tree called Krishna. Then, all of a sudden He left them to enable them to see Him within and become more expansive, to teach them self-dependence. In the beginning, the selfishness which the *gopis* had in their love towards Krishna helped them to increase their devotion tremendously.

⁶⁶A devotee of Sri Krishna who came to give a message to the *gopis* from the Lord telling them to see Him within and identical with themselves.

A young man who worked as a leader in the social and spiritual field was present. He was keenly listening to the Mother's words.

Young leader: Mother, it seems that many people are taking a negative attitude towards spiritual subjects. Why is this?

Mother: Son, this will happen if such matters are discussed with anyone and everyone. What Mother says is that *Hari Sri* (the first letters of the Malayalam alphabet) should be taught only to one who has a surrendering attitude. Only when the child approaches the teacher stretching out its fingers saying "I don't know anything, please teach me," will the teacher, catching hold of his fingers, make the child write the letters in the sand. How could a teacher teach a child who doesn't stretch out its fingers? If you approach those who don't have humility and try to make them understand spirituality, they will deny its validity. Anyway, you are doing good work in propagating *dharma*. It is God alone who entrusted this work to you. But the only thing is that you have to do it selflessly.

Young leader: But Mother, I need to understand more fully what is meant by selflessness. Suppose some aggressors forcefully pluck coconuts from the Ashram's coconut trees. Now, what would Mother do? Would you simply allow them to take the coconuts or would you call the police? Is it selfish to call the police?

Mother: There is one thing you should keep in mind. Everything is one Self. But a dog should be seen as a dog and treated accordingly. Holding up a stick as if to strike doesn't fall under selfishness. There is no harm in driving away an ignorant dog when it comes to harm us. Mother does not say that this is selfish. There is nothing selfish in obstructing a person who does harmful things out of ignorance. Not only that. If he is not prevented, he will become a

public nuisance and will create many problems in the society. What is important is that when you punish him, it should be done with a pure intention, that is, to correct him for his future good. It should not be done out of dislike or revenge. One shouldn't act desirous of selfish ends. It is beneficial for the world if you help to punish an aggressor who forcefully climbs on somebody's coconut tree. There the stress is not on selfishness but on *dharma*.

A *Mahatma*, if he really wishes, can create another world. But he won't do anything against the pre-established laws of Nature. It was they (*Mahatmas*) who formulated the rules and regulations of life and if they wish, they can break them, but they will not do so. Just as the supreme authority of a nation would not do anything which is against the constitution, in a like manner, great souls do everything only according to the rules and regulations set by the Ancients.

Above all, as far as great souls are concerned, they look upon everyone and everything equally. They won't waste their power to achieve trivial worldly things. For them, nothing is insignificant. That is, each and everything has its own place, neither more nor less. They know that even a needle has its own use.

To the *sadhaks*

Just then the Holy Mother noticed two *sadhakas* sitting on the bare ground.

Mother: In the beginning, *sadhakas* should be careful about many things. They should use sandals while walking. The earth has gravitational power. Try sleeping on the black sand on the seashore. You will become so fatigued that you can't even get up. The gravitational power of the earth is capable of absorbing our energy. Now we are standing enslaved by that attractive power. We are trying to overcome that. Therefore, wherever the *sadhaka* may sit, also

spread something on the ground. In the initial stages, a serious *sadhaka* should wear clothes that cover his whole body. Do not give negative vibrations any chance to affect your body. It is said that a *sadhaka* should cover his body so that if others happen to look at him, they will not see his full form. All these rules are necessary during the *sadhana* period. Besides that, a *sadhaka* also should not gaze at anyone. Don't speak too much. A lot of vital energy is lost through speech. In this way, with so much external alertness, the *sadhaka* can withstand and overcome the obstacles in the beginning. All these observances may seem to be a kind of weakness to a non-dualist, but such people can only speak about non-duality. All those who reached the goal were people who had observed the disciplines in this manner.

There are also people who have reached the goal without following all these observances, but they inherited tremendous spiritual disposition from their past birth. We who long to ascend from the level of the *jivatman* to the state of *Paramatman* need all these guidelines. It doesn't matter if a *Jivanmukta* lies in the sand or water. But we can do all those things only after attaining a particular stage. A *Jivanmukta's* power won't be lost without his will, because his mind is fully under his control. Even if he looks at a person or an object with his eyes, he won't fix his mind there. Only if their mind is fixed will their power flow out. It is beneficial for us, if they look with that resolve. Until that state is attained, a *sadhaka* should move about very carefully.

Young Man: Mother, then aren't the charges against Sankaracharya, saying that he has *tindal and todil*⁶⁷ correct?

⁶⁷An old custom in India existing among the higher castes forbidding the people who belong to the lower castes to touch or come close to them for fear of pollution by touch and nearness.

Mother: It is certain that it will do harm to the *sadhaka* if he mingles with those who don't have spiritual culture. If we live with a leper, won't that disease affect us also? Likewise, in the beginning stages it is very advisable for the *sadhaka* not to associate with others. Even if it is said that all are human beings, are all human beings the same? Some are thieves, some are innocent, while others are compassionate. Some have leprosy, others have T.B. and still others are perfectly healthy. It is harmful to mingle together without any control. Therefore, Mother cannot find any fault if Sankaracharya doesn't touch anyone. Maybe it is to set an example for *sadhakas*. All these rules are necessary for a *sadhaka* before the attainment of *Jivanmukti*. In a *math* (monastery), discipline and a regular routine are indispensable. A path is needed for human beings. The birds don't need it. An *Avatar* or a *Jivanmukta* doesn't need a path. But we can proceed only by following the *yamas* and *niyamas* (observance of rules and regulations prescribed by the scriptures and the great masters).

Beyond discipline

Mother: Some people would say that a hand fan is not necessary if there is an electric fan. A fan is not needed on the seashore. Likewise, if there is *satsang*, rules and regulations of worship are not necessary. But it should be real *satsang*. Who does *satsang* like that? Real *satsang* is the yoking of *jivatman* and *Paramatman*. At least there should be a sincere and dedicated effort to attain that unity. If that unity is there, then nothing else is needed. We are all seeds from fruits which are trying to ripen more quickly and we are finding it a bit difficult to sprout. Whereas, there are some others falling down from the beaks of birds on to the top of rocks. They would germinate lying there. The saliva which comes out from the bird's mouth is its fertilizer. It needs

neither sand nor water nor a fence to grow. It doesn't need someone to look after it either. It will grow lying there. It came enriched with fertilizers necessary for its growth. Such people are *Jivanmuktas*. They will be able to lead a life without any attachment to anything. They are people who came with fully developed spiritual qualities inherited from the previous birth (*purva samskara*). They won't become weak-minded under any circumstance. They will only act understanding the subtlety of a thing. They do not see the external appearance of things but only the Essence. All of this means that ordinary people do need *sadhana*. Otherwise it is not possible for them to reach the goal.

As she was talking, the Mother entered *samadhi*. After some time chanting, "Shiva...Shiva...Shiva," she became her normal self. The Mother continued,

Mother: Wherever *Jivanmuktas* go, people will go after them. They don't have to look for or search for disciples. People will automatically follow them. People will be attracted to them even without their knowledge just like dust caught in a whirlwind. That is the power of a person who does *sadhana*. Either their breath or the wind that blows over their body is enough to benefit the world.

Ordinary people should gain concentration through spiritual practices observing the prescribed rules and regulations. Otherwise, they will collapse. Whether it is a stone or paper, the artist beholds the object which he can make out of it. Likewise, a Self-Realized soul beholds the Essence in all objects. He neither sees the differences that we see, nor thinks that anything is without significance. Others, because they don't see the object that can be made from a stone or paper, may see only a useless thing. Unlike that, we should move forward observing things in a subtle way.

Young Man: Certain spiritual persons are being condemned for wearing silk clothes. Is there any significance to such things as silk clothes?

Mother: Son, there are good effects to be had by wearing silk clothes as well as by wearing certain animal skin. They will protect us from several evil external powers. *Rudraksha* has medicinal power. It is good to wear it on the body. It is especially beneficial to wear it on the neck, touching the cavity of the throat. Likewise, applying ash from a burnt corpse is also good. It has the power to prevent germs. Ash from the burial ground (*chutala bhasmam*) will also prevent polluted air from entering the body. Different things will be needed during each stage of spiritual practice. These are old *tantra yoga* practices.

The Holy Mother got up and went into the hut. Some devotees left, having taken leave of her. Others came to stay overnight in the Ashram. The western horizon gleamed pink in color as the sun dove deep into the ocean to take its evening repose. The Ashram atmosphere was saturated with peace and tranquillity. The *brahmacharins* began singing *bhajans*. The Holy Mother also came and sat for the *bhajan*. There was no light except the light from the oil lamps kept inside the temple.

The Mother sang in an intoxicated mood,

*O Goddess, Great Goddess, bless me.
O Leader of all, my salutation to Thee.
How many days have we been crying like this,
O Treasure of Compassion,
O Embodiment of Truth.
Please shower Thy Grace on us,
O Krishna, Lover of Thy devotees.*

*Why have we been pushed
Into this hell being tortured,*

*O Krishna, who nourished the Pandavas,
O Holy One?*

She sang like an innocent child calling out “Amma... Amma” now and then. The *bhajan* lasted for two hours. After the *arati*, the Holy Mother sat in the sand by the side of the temple. Everyone offered their prostrations. Then some went to meditate and others just sat near the Mother.

Nityanityam The Eternal and non-eternal

An Aspirant: Mother, what is meant by ‘*nityanitya vastu vivekam*’ (discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal)?

Mother: Shiva...Shiva...what do we know? Your Mother is crazy. She is uttering something or other. Accept what you feel is right. If a traveler happens to stand at a bus stop, one will look and smile at him. He will talk to him. At that time another person will come and so on, until a group has formed. Quickly all of them will become friends. As they talk, the bus comes and everyone gets inside. After traveling for sometime, the first traveler turns back and looks; none of these friends who had gotten into the bus with him are there anymore. “Alas, are they all gone? I thought that all of them would be with me until the end.” The poor fellow thought that all those people who traveled with him would be his friends forever. He was disappointed when each one had gotten off at his own destination and went his own way. He would not have been dejected if he had understood this earlier. In a similar manner, whether it is your father, mother or wife, they will leave you when it is their time. You will feel disappointment if you live fixing your mind on all these ephemeral beings and objects.

Therefore children, don't be deluded by these dreams which you see externally. They are all things and people who have to go when their time comes. If you are attached, what remains will only be sorrow, won't it? Therefore, despair will not be yours if you live understanding this beforehand. Without getting tempted by all this, remember God and live with an attitude of surrender to Him. God alone is the Eternal Truth. It should be understood that the world is not eternal. This is discriminating between the eternal and the non-eternal.

Everything will be all right if you move along this path. Suppose a person has a job in a bank. Many people will come to see him in the bank. They will speak sweetly to him. A clever person will understand that those people are coming not because of their love towards him, but to fulfill their desire. Understanding this, he will do his duty properly without being deluded by their sweet words and manners. He won't waste time talking. He will even be ready to lodge a case against them if they don't repay the amount that they had taken as a loan. Many people will come to see you when you have a position of power. But what will happen when the position is gone? Then all those admirers will not come. One should take refuge in the eternal Lord after thinking about all this with discrimination.

A person handles millions of rupees in the office or in the bank, but he knows that it is not his wealth. He has no attachment to it nor does he desire it. Likewise, the headache is over if we understand that none of the things in this world are related to us. One will have no more problems when it dawns in him that the wife and children are not his own. What we have as our own is God alone. Perform your actions in the world thinking, 'It is my duty.' Don't sit idle. You should work. In the beginning, a regular routine is needed. If you take tea today, tomorrow a headache will

come if you don't drink it. That is because of the habit. Therefore, good habits should be developed through a regular routine.

In the beginning, external rules and external attentiveness are necessary. One must move with discrimination. This is helpful. Otherwise, you might simply sit and say, "I am *Brahman*" (the Absolute). You can see *Brahman* jumping up and down with pain if a thorn happens to pierce the foot. (All laugh) There is no use in babbling without attaining that state of experience.

All these years we worked thinking that the world was eternal. Now, having understood the truth, some time should be set aside for the Self. Out of twenty-four hours, we should try to know the Self for at least one hour. Spiritual practices should be performed. That should be done regularly. Time lost cannot be regained. If millions of dollars are lost we can make it up by doing more business, but if even a second is lost it can never be regained. You should live understanding this.

Sadhaka: Mother, you have said that we are in the *vyavahara* (empirical plane) and we should move with subtlety. What does this mean?

Mother: Empirical means meaningless things and actions. *Mithya* does not mean perishing but rather ever-changing. The world is transforming from one state to another. Each and every object is changing. We might start out with whole lentils, then they are ground and finally we will have *parippu vada*.⁶⁸ But the basic thing, the lentil, has not been destroyed. It has only been transformed into something else.

When we say *Brahman*, everything is included. But, discrimination is needed because we are standing in *vyavahara*.

⁶⁸A kind of food made from ground lentils and spices, and fried in oil.

In the beginning we can progress only if we think, ‘This is day. This is night. This is good. That is bad.’

All that is related to *Maya* comes under *vyavahara*. That which is *mithya*, not Truth, is changing. To move with an awareness of this Truth is to move endowed with subtlety. *Nitya* is God. *Anitya* is worldly affairs.

Sadhaka: Mother, is it necessary for one to use a rosary when doing *mantra japa*?

Mother: Children, some kids learn to count using pearl beads. Using this method they can quickly learn. Likewise, in the beginning, using a *japa mala* (rosary) is very good for fixing the mind firmly on one point. Later on, *japa* will become a habit and you can continue even without a rosary. At a certain stage, the *japa* will go on automatically, even without our knowledge. One person used to write dipping the pen in the ink bottle. For ten days the ink bottle was kept on the right side. On the eleventh day he shifted it to the left side. Even though he knew the ink bottle was on the left side, his hand automatically moved to the right side. Similarly, *japa* should first become a habit. Then it will go on while walking, sitting or sleeping. *Japa* and prayer are good for concentration. Once compound letters are learned, there is no need to practice writing them down. But in the beginning, writing the letters is indispensable. Otherwise learning them is not possible. Showing a picture of an elephant or a horse to a child, the father or mother would first explain, “This is an elephant, this is a horse.” At that time, the child will think that the elephant and horse are the pictures. Later, the child will understand that the elephant or the horse is not the picture, but something very different. When the picture was first shown to the child with the explanation, “This is an elephant or this is a horse,” the child did not have an iota of doubt in his father’s words. He may even have become frightened if the father said,

“Look, the elephant is going to pierce you with his tusk.” Just like the child, first we must have innocent and blind faith in the Guru’s words. That faith will serve as a vehicle in which you can easily travel towards the goal.

Son, whatever the Guru does is only for the spiritual progress of the disciple. It is absolutely impossible for him to act otherwise. Mother is referring to a *Satguru*, not just someone who declares himself to be a Guru. A true spiritual Master may sometimes behave strangely. He may get angry with the disciple for no apparent reason and might scold him severely, blaming him for errors which he hasn’t committed. But those seemingly strange actions are not because the Guru is angry with the student. That is the Guru’s method of teaching self-surrender, patience and acceptance. For instance, the Guru might ask the disciple to make a beautiful image of Krishna or Devi. The disciple, forsaking food and sleep and applying all his artistic talents might take twenty days or so to make a beautiful image. Finally, he brings it to the Guru. The Guru won’t even look at it, or maybe he will snatch it from the disciple and smash it to pieces. During such occasions, a perfect student will remain totally calm. He will accept the Guru’s actions as being for his own good and won’t respond negatively at all. Each reaction which arises within us causes a delay in our attaining the goal. Whereas acceptance will cause grace to flow without any break. Son, the Guru has no selfish interests at all. He lives in *tyaga* (renunciation), his whole being is *tyaga*. The Guru burns his own body in the flame of *tyaga*, for the upliftment of his disciples and for the good of the world. From that blazing flame of *tyaga* each one of us can kindle a wick, so that we too can become a lamp on the dark path on which the entire human race is walking.

Sadhaka: (Bowing down to the Mother) Mother, that cleared many of my doubts.

He sat with joined palms and bowed head for awhile in front of the Mother and then asked, “Mother, Ramana Maharshi propagated the path of *jñāna*, didn’t he?”

Mother: He has said everything. When foreigners, who were predominantly intellectual came, according to their nature he instructed them to inquire, “Who am I and where did I come from,” using their intellect. But he also said that one should gain concentration performing proper *sadhana* to attain this goal. First, the Guru might act according to the likes of the *sadhaka*. Then gradually rules and regulations concerning *sadhana* and regularity in doing that will be insisted upon. *Sadhana* is necessary if you want to attain the goal. He says that one needs devotion also. Imagining each stone on the hill *Arunachala* as Shiva, he cried calling, “My Father, My Father!” He perceived *Arunachala* as Lord Shiva Himself.

He also sat in *tapas* in the ‘Patalalinga Cave.’ He practiced silence too. There is a picture of Ramana Maharshi cutting vegetables. In one or two books he talks about the nature of worldly affairs as well, but nobody notices that. The followers always want to limit the unlimited Guru. That is a pity. They (*Satgurus*) are expansive whereas the followers, wearing the spectacles of narrowness, try to impose their own narrow point of view on them. That is like trying to fill the vast ocean in a small bottle. Sincerely think for a while. Are we trying to accept their ways and words or to bring them into our little world of chaos and confusion in order to make others also confused? It isn’t enough to pay attention to any one part of the sayings of great souls.

Without some resolve (*sankalpa*), how is it possible to concentrate on the Self? For that, Ramana Maharshi has introduced the method of walking around the hill chanting the Divine Name. A raft is needed to cross the river. It is not necessary after crossing the river. *Sagunaradhana* (worship of an image of a God or Goddess) is performed at Ramana's ashram. But some are doing no *sadhana*, only saying, "I am *Brahman*." Having drawn the picture of a house, they want to live in it. Simply keeping Ramana's picture they do nothing, no meditation or other spiritual practices. Instead of this, let them chant the Divine Name, so eventually they can become a true follower of Ramana Maharshi, or some other *Mahatma*. How much he meditated! The *Mahatmas* will still retain *bhakti* even after attaining the state of *Jivanmukti*. Do you know why? To stay in this world. They won't give up *bhakti*. They accept it of their own will. The greatness of *bhakti* is something unique. They enjoy *bhakti*, having created it by self-will. You may ask, "What is there for them to enjoy?" but, they will do it to stay in the world.

One devotee: Mother, what is needed to attain concentration?

Mother: Son, there are no short cuts. Constant practice is needed. It is difficult to get one-pointedness. In the beginning, it is a great thing if by chance we get even one or two minutes of concentration when we do *sadhana* for one hour. *Sadhana* should be done continuously and sincerely without stopping until one-pointedness is gained. Once the seeds are sown, you should water them every day until the seedlings grow and reach a certain level. In between, if you stop watering, they will wither away, especially if it is dry land. One day they will become strong enough to withstand the heat. Then you can stop watering. Likewise, we have sown the seeds of spirituality in us. But the inside is very dry due

to being in the scorching heat of worldliness for a very long time. It might take some time for the sprouts of spirituality to come out. Sprinkle the water of *sadhana* regularly without any fail and wait patiently. But if you stop the *sadhana* because of lack of concentration and patience, then no result will be gained. *Japa* is necessary.

One young man: What benefit does the world get, if one sits and meditates with eyes closed?

Mother: Nature is benefited by the concentration of a *sadhaka*.

Young man: How?

Mother: Son, it will purify the atmosphere. At some point, modern material science will discover this. Not only that. We should not forget the services performed by the *Mahatmas* who were *dhyanis* (meditators). They derived power from meditation.

Son, in order to magnetize an iron rod, a powerful magnet should be rubbed against the rod in only one direction. When it is rubbed for some time, the iron will become another magnet. The molecules in the iron rod which were previously lying in disorder were systematized by the rubbing process. But this required another powerful magnet. Mother thinks that this is what happens in meditation also. By fixing the mind firmly on one thought, a *mantra*, Divine Name or Form, the thoughts are arrayed and directed towards one object. Power is generated when thoughts constantly flow in one direction, towards God.

This power is always radiating from a *Mahatma* which certainly creates spiritual energy in us when we sit in his presence. He can transmit that power to us through a mere touch, look or thought. But like the iron rod, we must allow ourselves to be magnetized, without raising any objection or words of protest.

Children, look at a river which flows with many branches. The force of the current will be very small. But if a dam

is constructed closing all the small channels, the water current will tremendously increase and we can generate electricity from it. Likewise, if the mind which is flowing outwards as thoughts and desires is directed to one point, infinite energy can be created. This energy will definitely radiate all around you revitalizing anything and everything. The quantity of energy will differ depending upon each one's subtlety of mind.

Son, T.V. stations are always telecasting programs. But, if you want to see a program, you must turn on your T.V. set. In the same way, tuning of the mind to the *Mahatma's* world is necessary. If that is done, then you can experience the flow of spiritual energy which is always flowing from them to you. For that, spiritual practice is a must.

The Mother paused for awhile and distributed the sugar candy *prasada* brought by a devotee. A few grains fell and scattered on the floor. One by one the ants came and gathered there. Pointing to the ants, Mother said, "Children, look here. First there was only one ant on the sugar candy grain, then many. One is enough for others to follow. If even one *vasana* remains, other *vasanas* also will follow. All *vasanas* must be destroyed without leaving even one."

Mother noticed one *brahmacharin* passing by at a distance. She called, "Come here, son." The perplexed *brahmacharin* came near Mother.

Mother: Son, tomorrow you should go and have your hair cut.

The *brahmacharin* nodded his head in approval and left the place silently.

A householder along with his family came in the evening. They had been devotees of the Holy Mother for quite a long time. They had a lot of problems. The wife had no obedience to her husband and their family life was not very peaceful.

Mother: That daughter has devotion to Mother but (smilingly) what kind of *bhakti* is it? What *bhakti*, what *japa* and what *dhyana* is it when one throws the husband into the midst of sorrow? Who needs the devotion of a wife who gives trouble to her husband? That is why the people of old gave more importance to mental unity than physical beauty in matters of marriage. If the wife is a pious woman endowed with patience, forbearance, devotion and endurance, she can transform the character of the husband even if he is a rogue.

Just then a father came with his little daughter. The Holy Mother called the little girl and made her sit near her. The father of the girl said, “Mother, please advise her not to cry insisting that she wants to see Mother after returning home from the Ashram.”

Hearing this, the Holy Mother embraced the little girl and laughed with great happiness.

One devotee: How fortunate it is to cry for God. That is how all of us have understood it.

(All laugh happily)

One young man: Does Mother ever suggest *pranayama*?

Mother: During the present age, *pranayama* is very difficult to practice. *Kumbhaka* (retention of the breath) will arise with love for God alone. Then why do *pranayama*? In *hatha yoga* and *pranayama* insanity will occur if a perfected Master is not there to guide the aspirant.

Monday, 14 November 1983

It was morning and the Holy Mother was sitting on the cot in her small hut facing the north. Four young men came to the Ashram to see her. Hearing from a resident that the Mother was sitting in her room, the young men

peeped in while still standing outside. The Mother saw them and said, "Come in, children."

All four of them entered the hut and sat on the carpet spread on the floor. The Mother got up from the cot and sat down with them. The young men, one by one looked at her quite surprised. They were all educated and had read a few spiritual books which kindled an interest to know more about spirituality. Recently they had heard about the Mother and were curious to see her in person and ask some questions. It was quite clear that the Mother's simplicity, humility and her loving call, "Children," influenced them to some extent.

Mother: (Smiling) Children, where are you from?

Young man: We are from Paravoor, near Quilon. This is my friend (pointing to one young man sitting near him) and the other two are his acquaintances. Together we came to see Mother.

Mother: (Laughingly) Shiva, Shiva, Shiva...to see Mother? Mother is crazy. Because the children call her "Mother" she acts some way or other doing some crazy things. Children, have you eaten anything?

Young man: Yes.

Another young man: We came after hearing about you. We have visited many ashrams.

Mother: How far have you studied?

Young man: I have completed a B.S. and he is a B.A.

By this time the Mother entered into deep meditation. A few moments went by in silence. The roaring Arabian Sea could be seen from the Mother's hut. The beating of the coconut husks by the fisherwomen could also be heard from across the backwaters. The Mother slowly opened her eyes chanting "Shiva, Shiva, Shiva," and whirled her uplifted hand showing a *mudra*.

One young man: We would like to know certain spiritual things.

Mother: (Laughingly) Shiva, Shiva, Shiva! What do we know about spirituality? He (God) knows everything. Children, you may ask. Mother may blurt out some crazy things. Accept it if you feel that it is correct. Mother tells her children, “There is a crazy Kali here. You will know her nature only when you get closer.” Shiva, Shiva! (Mother laughs)

The young men were really surprised. After a pause, he continued, “It is rich people more than the poor who are visiting the ashrams, isn’t it?”

Mother: Is there a reason that only the poor should go to visit Bhagavan and the rich shouldn’t? The rich have their own problems, don’t they? Children, more wealth means more problems. In spirituality there are no distinctions like small and big, rich and poor. For God, all are His children, none will be discarded. The rich who come into contact with ashrams and spiritual people do a lot of good things. Doesn’t it take money to do charitable things? Do the poor give it? No, they have no capacity to do so. Ashrams and spiritual people enable rich people to do *sat karmas* (virtuous actions). It is the poor who are getting the benefit of that, aren’t they? That is not a bad thing.

Spirituality is the right of both the poor and the rich. If remembrance of God is done with concentration and if you take one step towards God, God will take a hundred steps towards you. Are you ready for that? Son, are we getting concentration even for a minute? Without striving for that, we simply find fault with others. First we should try to correct our own drawbacks. You know, son, if one rich man becomes interested in spirituality, many poor ones will be saved because of the *dharma buddhi* (charitable mind) that he gets from the spiritual person or ashram.

Young man: What must be done in order to gain concentration?

Mother: Son, to gain concentration we must be intent on reaching the goal. Suppose one person is learning to ride a bicycle. Even if he falls down several times he climbs onto it again. Why? Because he intends to learn how to ride it. At that time, falling down or getting injured is not a problem. Concentration will be attained if there is a strong intent to reach the goal. It is not possible unless you strive hard. Attainment of the fruit is possible only through concentration.

Worldly love

At this time, a couple of householder devotees entered the hut and sat down after prostrating to Mother.

Mother: Take the case of worldly love. Does anybody love selflessly? Is it either for the woman or for the children that one gets married? Isn't it just for his own pleasure? Isn't it to satisfy his desire that one loves his wife and the father loves his children? Now, let us take the case of the child. We love the child because he or she was born from our ovum and semen. Other than that, do we love him or her selflessly? If so, why are other children not loved? Therefore, we love our child only because the child was born from our ovum and semen. Even then, we are loving ourselves only. Let that be for now. Suppose the house catches fire. The child is inside the house and we are outside. We would only cry calling out, "Please, somebody save my child!" We won't save the child by jumping into the fire, because we know that death would be certain. So, then who are we loving and who loves us? We love ourselves only. This is the nature of worldly love. Isn't this so? Allured by this love, we go away from God thinking "He loves me, she loves me." We become friendly with others only for our own

pleasure. Selflessness won't arise as long as the awareness 'I am this body' exists. That is the attitude they are holding. They become enticed thinking the people they saw at the bus stop were relatives. But all these so-called relatives will go to their own places. That Supreme Self, the Eternal Principle, that alone is the real friend. Understanding this truth, we must contemplate on its meaning, regardless of the path we might walk or the work we might be called on to do.

Don't give up the intent to reach the goal

Many obstacles will arise. No matter how many kicks we get, we won't get angry while waiting in line to buy tickets for the movies. Why? Because our goal is to see the movie, isn't it? When we really desire to see the movie, the kicks and sufferings are not a sacrifice. Likewise, suppose we were getting into a bus. Say there were many people trying to get in and they were pushing and shoving. Say one even came and hit us. We would probably not hit them back. It is not out of anger that they hit us, they just want to get into the bus in time to reach the office or home. If it was another occasion, they would have quarreled and even might have filed a suit. Therefore, because we are intent on the goal, we forget and discard everything. Then there are no differences like man or woman, friend or foe. While traveling, two strangers or even enemies might sit on the same seat.

In the same manner, we will sit patiently waiting till evening in the court verandah. Why? Only to win the case. No matter how rich someone is, he will sit waiting in the front of the court room. He is not hesitant to endure any amount of suffering. Don't we understand that nothing is

difficult if we have *lakṣhya bodha* (intentness on one's goal)? There will be no complaints like the wife is sick, the medicine isn't purchased yet, or the food is not cooked. He doesn't feel that it is a sacrifice when he lays down in the court yard from morning until evening because he wants to win the case. That is the goal.

Those are not sufferings. But when you come to the spiritual field, even a little suffering will be felt to be big. This is because of the lack of *lakṣhya bodha*. At that time we should think over all this. We undergo suffering for silly things. Not only that. Don't we proceed, enduring all the obstacles that arise during our effort to fulfill our desires? Likewise, obstacles will arise on the spiritual path as well. We should move forward enduring everything.

After living so many years thinking that we are the body, concentration will not be achieved simply by saying that we are the Self. We will be lucky if we can get even one minute of one-pointedness. Son, in the beginning you will feel it is very difficult. Even the ocean can be emptied but the mind cannot be brought under one's control. It is very difficult. One can move forward overcoming everything if *lakṣhya bodha* is there. No obstacle will be a problem if we remember the Beatific Vision that awaits us. Nothing is a problem when we think of that. We should try to control the mind through *tyaga* (renunciation).

Also, we must have faith. Faith is very important. But Mother doesn't say that you must believe in God. It is enough to believe in one's own Self. Our Real Nature should be known. *Atman* is eternal. The world is not eternal. You should become convinced of this. One should move forward believing in one's own Self.

Manifestation of siddhis

Young man: What is Mother's opinion about the display of *siddhis* (psychic powers)?

Mother: The *rishis* have written that it is not correct for *sadhakas* to display *siddhis*. But in the present world *siddhis* might become necessary. In olden days, the type of education which existed was *gurukula vidyabhyasa*.⁶⁹ Even at a young age, obedience to the parents and the Guru was taught. After that, the purpose of life and the reasons for which we took birth were learned. In those days, it was not taught to get married and have five or ten children. One virtuous child was enough. Even that one was born only after the couple performed *tapas* for a long time. They procreated a child with the semen of their *tapas shakti* (power of austerity). That child would be a brilliant and intelligent one. Having raised him and given him a proper education and made him fit to handle the challenges of life, the parents would then go for *vanaprastha*.⁷⁰ That was the system in olden times. Whether it was a king or a servant, *sannyasa* (total renunciation) was the goal of their life. But what about today? "I want to become a minister in the government, I want to become a doctor. I want to grab all the wealth! And then I want a scooter, a car, a house." This is today's way of thinking. Trapping the mind in restlessness and tension, we attempt to kill and rob. We are ready to get our share of wealth, even if it means killing our own parents. Today we don't give any value to our parents. We live in the midst of such desires.

⁶⁹Staying in the Guru's residence, serving the Guru and spending one's time in studies and contemplation for a number of years until all the scriptures were learned.

⁷⁰The third stage of life, renouncing the hearth and home and going to the forest to lead a life of austerity.

In those days, each step was made keeping spirituality as the goal. Today, we are not like that. Even children studying in nursery school are shouting political slogans. Many children during *Bhava Darshan* come to Mother and say, “Mother, I want to kill this person; Mother should help me.” This is what tiny little children say! There is enmity in the name of political parties. The children of today think that their party should thrive even by murder. In those days it was not this way. The attitude was ‘Love your neighbor as yourself’ as Jesus said. Today it is just the opposite. Display of *siddhis* should be evaluated in this background.

As the young men keenly listened, the Holy Mother continued, “Siddhis might not have been necessary in the old days when the people had spiritual culture. Then there was selflessness and *tyaga*. Today, everything is only based in selfishness. People are desirous of seeing *siddhis*. If they don’t, they won’t believe in God.

“Son, during this age, people want only to fulfill their desires. If their desires are fulfilled, then they will have faith. Thus, slowly they can be brought to the path of devotion. Nowadays, nobody goes anywhere if it is not to fulfill their desires. If there is sickness, they will go to see a doctor. Otherwise not. Whereas there are some, who having no disease, will go to see a doctor. Do you know what for? To get advice as to how to prevent disease. They see the doctor to learn where and when to do purification, how to live and what food stuffs are good. They are people who have good insight into affairs. Likewise, there are people who would approach great souls with the thought, ‘I must know what spiritual life is.’ Still, they may have desires to fulfill, but they will consider that as secondary. But such people can be counted on one hand. The majority crave to fulfill their desires. Manifestation of *siddhis* is necessary to lead them to goodness.

“In the world of today, all are afflicted with the disease of worldliness. They only go after desires. They fear whether the wife will err, the husband will err, the children will err, whether they will be able to become wealthy or become grandparents, and so on. They do not want spirituality other than for providing the solution for such problems. Most people are of this kind. Certain things will be needed to attract such people. This is like *katha prasangam*.⁷¹ The story will actually be only half an hour long but it will take hours to tell it. This is because in order to attract the audience it should be embellished with humorous or appealing touches. Only then can the people be attracted. No one will listen if the story is narrated in a nutshell. Some *Mahatmas*, according to the desire of the devotees or people who visit them, manifest *siddhis*. The intention of that is to attract the people towards God. They will be attracted to God and the Divine Power when they see the display of *siddhis*, isn’t this true?”

One young householder devotee: Mother, this conversation about *siddhis* reminds me of an incident that happened to me only two weeks ago.

Mother: What was that, son?

Devotee: Mother, like an innocent child you pretend you do not know anything, but I am fully convinced that you know everything that happens.

Mother: Mother knows only one thing, and that is that she doesn’t know anything.

Devotee: Mother, I know you are trying to fool me. Anyway, I like being fooled by you.

Another devotee: We are anxiously waiting to hear the incident which you were about to tell us.

⁷¹A public narration of a story with accompanying music.

Devotee: Two weeks ago my wife had a dream in which Mother appeared in front of her and said in a very clear voice, “Watch Resmi.” That is the name of our only child. She is only two years old. My wife immediately got up, but the child was comfortably sleeping near us. She woke me up and told me about the dream. I said, “Go back to sleep; it might have been a mere dream, don’t worry.” Neither of us gave much importance to the dream. For the next two nights, my wife Sarada had the same dream. The Mother appeared in front of her and said the same sentence, “Watch Resmi!” but more loudly. On the third night, my wife was awakened by the dream. She woke up screaming. Her scream woke me up too. When I turned on the light, I saw my wife sitting in bed trembling and sweating. Resmi also woke up and started crying. My wife took her and held her tightly to her bosom. Like one gone mad, she went on saying, “Mother, what is going to happen to my child Resmi, what is going to happen to my Resmi? Protect her.” Although the dream seemed insignificant to me at first, I had to take it more seriously when the same dream was repeated on the third night. I was very confused myself, but even then I tried to console my wife saying, “Don’t worry, Mother is there to protect us.” We could not sleep the rest of that night.

The next morning, Sarada and I, along with Resmi, went to the family shrine room and offered our morning prayers to the Mother seeking her protection, especially for Resmi. I had no more leave and also I had a heavy work load at the office. Therefore, I could neither come and ask Mother about this nor stay home with the family. Dedicating everything at the Mother’s feet and instructing Sarada to watch Resmi carefully, I went to the office. My mind was totally upset.

When I returned from the office, I was shocked and wonderstruck hearing Sarada's narration of the unbelievable incident which had happened that day.

At a quarter past ten my wife went to the kitchen to cook lunch. Resmi was fast asleep. Afraid of the warning given in the dream, Sarada didn't lay Resmi on the cot, as usual, for fear that she might fall down from it. Instead, she lay her down on a mattress spread on the floor. It was eleven-thirty. Sarada was immersed in cooking and other household chores. All of a sudden, as she was about to chop the vegetables, somebody pushed her strongly from the back. At that moment, she heard the Mother's voice as if scolding her, "I warned you to watch your child. Go, hurry up to the pond." Sarada rushed to the pond, which was situated on the south side of the house, only a few yards away from the room where Resmi had been sleeping. Sarada screamed aloud, upon seeing that Resmi was about to step into the waters of the deep pond. Sarada cried aloud and rushing towards the child, grabbed her. Hearing her loud cry, all the neighbors came running to the house. Everyone felt relieved seeing that the child had been saved.

It was only then that Sarada thought about how Resmi happened to get there. Noticing Resmi's plastic playball floating on the surface of the water, the whole incident flashed through her mind. Before falling asleep, Resmi was playing with the ball. When she awoke, she must have again played with the ball, which probably rolled out of the room through the open door and into the yard. Thus, each time the ball slipped away, it rolled a little further, until eventually it reached the pond. Resmi innocently followed after it."

The devotee stopped. He was silently shedding tears. After a few seconds he asked, "Mother, what you said is true. Who can help themselves from feeling attracted to you, my

God, when they come into direct contact with such experiences?”

Half of the time, while the story was being narrated, the Mother was immersed in deep *samadhi*. The Mother smilingly replied, “Son, this happened only because of your innocent devotion and faith, not because of this crazy Kali.”

The Mother continued talking about *siddhis*. She said, “It is a *sadhaka* who must not show *siddhis*. If he gets deluded by *siddhis* they will cause him to fall. As far as an *Avatar* is concerned, displaying *siddhis* will not cause a problem. The wonderful power which we call *siddhis* is God’s innate nature. Power will not be wasted if a Godly person shows *siddhis*. Didn’t Rama and Krishna manifest *siddhis*? How is God affected by the rule that *sadhakas* shouldn’t manifest *siddhis*? If you come looking for *siddhis*, then you come desiring an imitation. That is not the real thing. The real gem is there within you. Nobody is searching for that. Therefore, after showing them *siddhis* first, they later teach their students the essential principles of spirituality.

Young man: Sri Ramakrishna didn’t encourage *siddhis* at all, did he?

Mother: Children, don’t compare one *Mahatma* with another. Don’t ask, “If he has done this, why isn’t this one doing the same?” There are no two people alike. Is Sri Rama like Sri Krishna? No. Parasurama is not like Sri Rama.⁷² Hanuman is not like Parasurama. Sri Ramakrishna is not like Hanuman. The incarnation of Narasimha is not like Vamana.⁷³ There are differences between Incarnations. Even though the goal of all the Incarnations is one, the way in which they act is different. Don’t try to compare one with another. Is it possible to tell one person’s features looking at another’s?

⁷²Parasurama and Sri Rama were both Avatars of Lord Vishnu.

⁷³Narasimha and Vamana were two Avatars of Lord Vishnu.

Sri Ramakrishna said that *siddhis* should not be shown. There are two reasons for it. Firstly, it was to *sadhakas* that he said not to get deluded by *siddhis* because they would have a spiritual fall. That is true also. Secondly, he was setting an example to show how a true devotee should live. In order to set an ideal example of a true devotee, he did not show any miracles.

Usually *Mahatmas* won't show any *siddhis*. If they did show them, it would be a spontaneous manifestation in a befitting circumstance. They manifest *siddhis* not for the spectators, but naturally according to circumstance.

Children, don't be deluded by *siddhis*. They will quickly turn to misfortune and confusion. The Incarnations come in order to destroy desires, not to create them. Therefore, it is good if nobody shows or gets deluded by *siddhis*. Otherwise, one may fall. Usually spiritual people will desire to attain *siddhis*. Because of that, they will be ruined. Those who approach them also will be ruined without gaining any spiritual upliftment. When a person displays *siddhis* we will also develop a desire to learn them. Having learned *siddhis*, we pave the way for our own destruction. Children, try to shed at least two drops of tears for God. Ha! Devotion! It's taste is something unique.

Avatar Incarnation of God

Another young man: Mother, is an *Avatar* a person whose mind has become perfectly good?

Mother: Son, it is not that one becomes an *Avatar*, because his mind has become good. *Avatars* have full awareness from birth. Others will not have it. Not only that. Because the *Avatars* are in total identity with Nature, their mind is not what we usually consider as mind. All minds are theirs. In

other words, an *Avatar* is Himself the Universal Mind. *Avatars* will be far beyond all kinds of *dvandas* (pairs of opposites) including purity and impurity. Therefore, *Avatars* cannot be called a person whose mind has become good. When God descends in a human form, He or She is an *Avatar*. Therefore we cannot limit Incarnations saying that *Avatars* will appear in such and such a period of time at such and such a place. If God is omniscient, omnipotent and all-pervading, He can easily assume any form at any time, at any place irrespective of caste, creed and sect. The form he takes depends on the urgency and needs of the era.

Young man: Mother, will the infinite God come in a human form?

Mother: All forms have a limit. God, the Supreme Principle, is beyond that limit. An Incarnation (the infinite God in a limited form) in *Brahman* (the infinite Reality) is like an iceberg in the ocean. All the water in the reservoir will come through the tap but the tap is not the reservoir. There are limitations for whatever has a name or form. But, through this small body, God can act as He likes. That is the greatness of the form of an Incarnation. This is the reason that it is said that God and an Incarnation are one. There is no need to assume a body and descend for God to act. Even then, *Avatars* are beneficial for human beings to bring them closer to God.

Young man: Is there any meaning in calling a person who is alive, “Bhagavan”?

Mother: Child, that depends on our faith. Isn’t our father dear and great as far as his son is concerned?

The young man’s friend: Does that mean that it does not matter if we have no faith?

Mother: Not so, son. The mosquitoes will only get blood from an udder, even though the udder is full of milk. Someone else will squeeze milk from it. Faith alone is what is im-

portant. Here, two different things are gotten from the same udder, because of the different interests. Likewise, the thief, when he sees a post in the night, will think that it is a policeman; the girl will think that it is her beloved; one who is fearful in the night will think that it is a ghost. Is there any change in the post? The post is only the post. It reflects differently according to each one's nature. In which way did the *gopis* see Krishna? In which way did Kamsa⁷⁴ see Him, and what was Arjuna's attitude? Therefore, our faith is the cause for everything. The principle is that if we believe God is in a blade of grass, we will get power even from that. Didn't God appear from a pillar as the Man-Lion?⁷⁵ If so, can't God's Power manifest in human beings too?

Incarnation and an ordinary soul

(Extract from a talk which occurred on 27th December, 1981)

Devotee: Mother, what is the difference between an ordinary *jiva* and an Incarnation?

Mother: There are differences. A date palm tree that gives sweet fruits to everyone can be considered to be like an Incarnation. It can satisfy those who become hungry. Others can pluck its fruits and eat. Likewise, an Incarnation is able to give peace, tranquillity and spiritual power to both those who take refuge in him and others as well. There is no meaning if a seed of the date palm says, "Listen, I am the date palm." It should be grown with attention and care giving water and fertilizer in the proper way. If grown like that, a date palm will spring forth from the seed. There is no sense if the fruit of that tree, when it attains perfection, also pompously says, "I also came from this date palm, I

⁷⁴An enemy and maternal uncle of Krishna's.

⁷⁵An Incarnation of Lord Vishnu in the form of a half-man, half-lion, who saved His devotee Prahlada from a demon.

am also a part of it.” There exists a difference between the two until the fruit becomes the palm tree. It can also become the date palm. As said before, it should be grown with proper care, making a fence to protect it from stray animals and giving water and fertilizer. Even then, it might wither away due to the heat of the sun or might be eaten by some cows or other animals. The difference between a *jiva* and an Incarnation is the same as that. There are five hundred watt bulbs, hundred watt bulbs and night lights, but all shine with the same electricity which comes from the same power station. Even so, the light will be different. We are all just sparks, not even night lights. We have not become perfect. An *Avatar* is perfect.

1 December 1988

Mother’s talk to Western devotees

Mother: Children, you have come to the Ashram because you had a pure resolve to fulfill certain desires. Mother is not trying to put forth rules and regulations or to impede your freedom but there are some things that she must tell you so that your stay here will be fruitful.

In every corner of India you can see people in colleges. Those students who failed in their examinations when studying in colleges will go to tutorial colleges. Most of these tutorials are not giving proper discipline or coaching to the students. But there are some tutorial colleges where students will get good training and they will come out successful. Because those tutorial colleges trained their students properly, they had good discipline. So, in the beginning stages discipline is very important. Without this we cannot attain the goal. When the goal is attained, you can surrender this discipline also at the Feet of the Lord. Discipline is a must.

Some of you might feel that having to follow the rules and regulations here is like being in a prison, but this is not true. Mother does not want to restrict your freedom. But, if a child is given full freedom, he may jump into water or fire due to lack of proper discrimination. Likewise, if full freedom is given now, that will culminate in tomorrow's problem. Rules and regulations are made here now so you can be fully free tomorrow. It is to gain tomorrow's freedom that Mother is giving these rules today.

First of all, we must have love and respect for the *mantra* that was given to us by our Master. Always repeat this *mantra* wherever you are, whatever work you are doing regardless of time and place. Without talking unnecessarily, chant your *mantra*, have love for your *mantra*. These *mantras* will help purify the mind and take us to the Supreme. If you can repeat your *mantra* silently within, that is best. If you are unable to do that, then you can just repeat it softly moving your lips.

Some people may feel that the thoughts that continue to arise while they are repeating a *mantra* will dissipate their energy. This is not so. For example, take the water in a dam. When the wind blows, there will be ripples on the surface, but even then, water will not be lost. Likewise, even if there are thought waves within, the energy will not get dissipated if a *mantra* is chanted softly. It is the indulging in and talking about worldly things that dissipates our energy.

If you simply do your spiritual practices once a day, say after your bath or after your breakfast or lunch, it will not help you to reach the goal. Constant practice is needed. No matter how much we do, it will not help us to reach the goal without constant practice. Even if you take hundreds of births and do a lot of penance, this kind of intermittent spiritual practice will not help you to reach the goal. Whatever

work you do, regardless of time and place, you should be able to chant the *mantra* or reflect on the Vedic dictums or on the spiritual things that you have learned. Only then will you be able to attain the goal.

Do not think that all these prayers and chanting of a *mantra* and other external practices are only for weak minds. The more you chant and the more you pray, the more the mind will become clear and pure. For example, take a washing machine. When we put dirty clothes in, the more they get rinsed, the more they will become clean. Likewise, the more you chant your *mantra*, the more your mind will become clear and pure. Mother is just reminding you about certain things. You have your own freedom and you can choose whatever you like.

It is easy to realize God if you see God in each and every action you perform. Take for example the *gopis* of Brindavan. Their business was selling milk, ghee and butter, but on each and every bottle and container they would write the different names of Sri Krishna. On the bottles of spices they would write “Madhava” and on some other bottle they would put “Keshava.” When they went out selling, instead of calling out, “Butter! Ghee! Milk!” they used to call out, “Krishna! Hari! Mukunda! Madhava!” They could easily see unity in diversity. It is easy to attain God, if you see God in each and every action you perform.

It does not matter which path you follow. It may be *jñāna*, *ṛkarma* or *bhakti*. It does not matter if you are one who meditates on the formless Self or one who meditates on God with form. What is needed first is to cleanse the mind. Without that, no matter how much practice you do, it will not enable you to attain Perfection. Before we sow seeds, the weeds must be removed. Only then will we get a good harvest. Likewise, negative tendencies, likes and dislikes, must first be uprooted. Prayer and chanting of the

Divine Name will enable us to attain that goal easily. Whether it is worshipping the Formless, or God with form, what we need is a pure resolve; only then can we truly worship the Truth. Even to worship the formless God we need a pure resolve.

The Realization of God is not possible in a moment. It will not arrive one fine morning. It needs a lifelong practice. In the *Srimad Bhagavatam* there is a story about a character named Ajamila. He did all kinds of evil deeds while he was alive. Eventually, when he was breathing his last, he wanted to see his younger son named Narayana. He called out “Narayana!” but instead of his younger son, the messengers of Lord Narayana (Vishnu) Himself appeared before him and forbade the messengers of the Lord of Death from taking him. After reading this story, there was a businessman who thought that it must be easy to attain God. Simply you call God’s Name at the end of your life and God will appear and take you to heaven. Thinking in this way, he named his three sons Krishna, Rama and Govinda. He had done all kinds of evil acts. He had a shop and had committed many atrocities in his life like cheating, lying, and so on. Finally, when he was bedridden and was breathing his last, he called his three sons. When all his sons came near him, the thought that came to his mind was, “Didn’t you open the shop today? Isn’t there anyone in the shop?” This was the thought that sprang up in his mind, because all his life he was thinking about the shop and how to make a profit. Similarly, the thought that you follow all of your life is the one that will spring up at the end of your life. Definitely that will be the thought that comes to you first. So do not think that God-Realization is possible in a day or two. It requires a lifelong practice.

Why should Mother tell all these crazy things to you? All of you have read a lot and heard a lot. Mother is telling

you in order to remind you of those things, that is all. What you need is direct experience and Mother is asking you to do whatever is necessary to gain that experience. If we simply read and learn things, then there is no difference between us and a tape recorder. Whatever is recorded will be repeated. What we want is to apply all these scriptural statements to our lives and live them.

At the bus stop you can see a board indicating the timetable for the buses going to various destinations. If you simply stand there reading all the details, you can not catch a bus and reach your destination. If you want to reach your destination, you must catch a bus and get inside. Suppose there is a billboard saying that there is a jewelry shop in the next town. If you simply ask the billboard, you will not get the jewelry. You must go to that shop and purchase it.

Mother knows that you know all these things. Now what you need is to practice. The ego should be uprooted. All practice is for eliminating the ego. We also go about thinking that we are more important, greater or better than everyone else. This feeling stays with us wherever we go. Even if we apologize to someone, later we may think, “Oh, I shouldn’t have apologized. I am more important than him, why should I apologize?” These egotistic thoughts will always pull us down. Only in the presence of a Perfect Master can we remove such thoughts and actions. This is why we go to ashrams and live in the presence of great Masters. Only they can remove the ego in us. There is a huge tree dormant in the seed, but only if the seed is buried in the ground will the tree sprout. If the seed egotistically thinks, ‘Why should I bow down to this dirty earth?’ then its real nature cannot manifest. Likewise, only if we cultivate and develop humility is it possible to realize the Supreme Truth, which is our real nature.

In the beginning stages, a Perfect Master is a must. Otherwise, it is impossible to remove the subtle *vasanas* of the mind. For example, a child is more inclined to play than to study. Even if he studies, it will be out of fear of his parents or teachers. But after high school studies, he will have the desire to become an engineer or a doctor. Then he will concentrate on his studies and abandon all other play because now the awareness of a goal has arisen in him. He will automatically concentrate on his studies. Once discrimination arises, then the Guru within you will be invoked. Then you do not have to depend entirely on an external Guru, because you will get instructions from within. But until then, a Perfect Master is needed to guide you.

A parrot raised in a church or temple will have one type of culture. It will always be chanting God's Name. But the parrot raised in the liquor shop will always use vulgar words. Isn't this true? Great souls are always radiating spiritual power. We will be able to become one with that if our mind is properly tuned. Being in the world in the midst of all material pleasures is like sitting at the seashore. Due to the salty breeze, our body will also become coated with salt. But being in the presence of a Perfect Master is like going to an incense factory. After leaving there, your body will smell of a sweet fragrance. Similarly, slowly and gradually our mind will become purified due to the presence of a Great Soul.

When you are in the Ashram atmosphere, it is good if you move with utmost alertness. Selfless service and repeating your *mantra* is enough for attaining the goal. If these are not there, it doesn't matter how much penance you do; you will not be able to attain the goal. If you do spiritual practices without performing selfless actions, it will be like building a house without any doors, or a house which doesn't have a path to enter. Be courageous. Do not be idle.

Currently, we do not have the needed mental harmony. Because of that, Nature's harmony also is lost. Even now, one can clearly see the after effects of this disharmony. Either there is not enough rain, or there is too much. If we become harmonious within, then Nature also will be benefited.

Children, Mother is not saying that you should give up your present way of life or pleasures. But, in whichever way you choose to live, you should discriminate between that which is eternal and that which will pass away. If you do that, then you can enjoy peace of mind and spiritual bliss no matter what the outer circumstances of your life might be.



Glossary

- ACHARA: Traditional customs and observances.
- ADHARA: Substratum.
- ADVAITA VEDANTA: Philosophy of Non-duality.
- AJÑANA: Ignorance.
- AKARAM: Form.
- ANANDAM: Bliss.
- ANTARIKA PRAKRITI: Inner nature, as opposed to external Nature.
- ANACHARAS: Contrary to custom.
- ARATI: Waving burning camphor before the Deity as the conclusion of worship.
- ARCHANA: Worship through repetition of Names of God.
- ASANA: A seat; a posture in Hatha Yoga.
- ASANA SIDDHI: Perfection in sitting unmoving in one posture for more than 3 hours.
- ASURA: A demon.
- ASURA SVABHAVA: Demonic nature.
- ASURIC: Demonic.
- ATMA BHAVA: The spiritual attitude; to be established in the Self.
- ATMA DHYANA: Meditation on the Self.
- ATMA JÑANA: Self-knowledge.
- ATMA VICHARA: Self-enquiry.
- ATMACHAITANYA: Spiritual power; the illuminating soul.
- ATMAN: The Self.
- ATMAVIN DUKHAM: Sorrow of the soul.
- AVADHUTA: A Realized Soul who has transcended all the rules and regulations of the Scriptures, tradition and society.
- AVATAR: Incarnation of God.
- BALA BHAVA: Attitude of a child.

- BHAGAVATI: The Divine Mother.
- BHAGAVAN: The Lord.
- BHAJAN: Devotional singing.
- BHAKTI: Devotion.
- BHAKTI MARGA: The path of devotion.
- BHARAT: India.
- BHAYA BHAKTI: Devotion with fear and reverence.
- BHEDA BUDDHI: Differentiating intellect.
- BHOGA: Enjoyment.
- BHUKTI-MUKTI-PRADAYINI: Giver of worldly enjoyment and Liberation.
- BHAGAVATAM: Scripture about the life and deeds of Lord Vishnu's Incarnations.
- BHAVA DARSHAN: The Holy Mother giving an audience in the mood of the Divine Mother or Krishna.
- BHAVAS: Moods, feelings or attitudes.
- BIJAKSHARAS: Seed letters preceding mantras.
- BRAHMA PADA: The Absolute State; the highest position.
- BRAHMACHARIN: A celibate student studying the scriptures and undergoing spiritual guidance and discipline under a Guru.
- BRAHMAJÑANA: Knowledge of the Absolute.
- BRAHMAN: The Absolute.
- BRAHMANUBHUTI: Experience of the Absolute.
- BRAHMANANDA: Bliss of the Absolute.
- BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy and sense control.
- CHITTA: Intellect; mind.
- DAKSHINA: Reverential offering in cash or kind.
- DARSHAN: Audience or vision of the Deity or holy person.
- DASA BHAVANA: Attitude of being a servant.
- DASATVAM: Servitude.
- DASOHAM: "I am a servant."
- DEHA BHAVA: The feeling that oneself is a body.
- DEVATA: A god or deity.

DEVI BHAVA: Divine mood as Devi, the Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness.

DHYANA: Meditation.

DHYANA RUPAM: Form on which one is meditating.

DOSHA: Evil or defect.

DVARAKA: City where Sri Krishna lived.

EKAGRATA: One-pointedness.

GAURANGA: Sri Krishna Chaitanya, considered as an Incarnation of Sri Radha-Krishna, who lived in Bengal about four hundred years ago.

JÑANA: Spiritual wisdom or knowledge.

JÑANA MARGA: The path of knowledge.

JÑANI: A Knower of Truth.

JÑANAGNI: The Fire of Knowledge.

GOPAS: Cowherds of Brindavan.

GOPIS: Wives of the cowherds of Brindavan; divine lovers of Sri Krishna.

GRIHASTA: One living in a house, i.e., a married person.

GRIHASTASHRAMI: A spiritual-minded grahasta.

GUDAKESA: A synonym for Arjuna; one who has conquered sleep.

GURU: Spiritual master.

GURU BHAVA: Attitude of a Guru.

GURU MAHIMA: Greatness of the Guru.

GURUKULA: Residential school of a Guru.

HRIM: A seed letter associated with the Goddess.

ISHWARA AMSA: A partial manifestation of God.

ISHWARA BHAVANA: The attitude that oneself is identical with the Lord.

JAGAT: The world.

JAPA: Repetition of a mantra.

JIVA: The individual soul; life force.

JIVANMUKTA: One who has achieved Liberation even while tenanting the body.

- JIVATMA: Individual soul.
- KALIYUGA: The present Dark Age of materialism.
- KARMA: Action.
- KARMA PHALA: The fruit of action.
- KAURAVAS: The enemies of the Pandavas during the Mahabharata War, representing unrighteousness.
- KIRTANA: Devotional singing.
- KOLADI: A country folk dance.
- KRISHNA BHAVA: The divine mood as Krishna.
- KRODHA: Anger.
- KUMBHAKA: Retention of breath during pranayama.
- KUNDALINI DHYANA: Meditation on the kundalini.
- KURUKSHETRA: The battlefield on which the Mahabharata War was fought.
- KAMA VIKARA: Lustful feelings.
- KAMA: Lust or desire.
- LAKSHANA: Symptoms or signs.
- LAKSHARCHANA: Worship by repeating the Divine Names a hundred thousand times.
- LAKSHYA: Aim or goal.
- LAKSHYA BODHA: A mind intent on reaching the goal.
- LALITASAHASRANAMA: The Thousand Names of the Goddess Sri Lalita.
- LAYA: Merger or absorption.
- LEELA: Play.
- MAHAMANTRA: Great mantra.
- MANONASA: Destruction of the mind; permanent subsidence of the mind.
- MITHYA: Unreal.
- MOKSHA: Release from the cycle of rebirth.
- NAVARATRI: Festival of Nine Nights dedicated to the worship of the Divine Mother.
- NIRGUNA: Without qualities.

NIRGUNOPASAKA: One who meditates on the qualityless Absolute.

NIRVANA SHATKAM: A composition of Sri Sankara consisting of six stanzas on Nirvana or Final Emancipation.

NISHKRIYA: Actionless.

NISHTA: Established; regularity in practice.

NITYA: Eternal.

NITYANITYA VASTU VIVEKAM: Discrimination between the eternal and the transitory.

NAMA: The Divine Name.

OMKARA: The divine sound OM.

PADMASANA: Lotus posture.

PARAMAHAMSA: A God-realized Soul.

PARA BHAKTI: Supreme devotion.

PEETHAM: Seat or throne.

PRAMANA: Knowledge; means of knowledge; proof.

PRASADA: Consecrated offering to God or a saint.

PREMA BHAKTI: Loving devotion.

PREMA SWARUPA: Of the nature of love.

PRANA: Life force.

PUJA: Ritualistic worship.

PURANA: Ancient scriptures written by Vedavyasa.

PURNAJÑANI: Fully realized soul.

PURNAKUMBHA: Lit., full pot; a pot of consecrated water offered to a holy person on their arrival at a temple, house, etc.

PURVA SAMSKARA: Previously acquired tendencies.

PURNAM: Full or perfect.

RAJAS: The principle of activity; one of the three gunas or qualities of Nature.

RASA: Taste; juice; elixir.

RADHA BHAVA: Attitude of being Sri Radha, Beloved of Sri Krishna; supreme devotion.

RAJA YOGA: The Royal yoga; the eight-fold yoga of Liberation.

- SAGUNA: With attributes.
- SAGUNARADHANA: Worship of God as having attributes.
- SAHAJA SAMADHI: The Natural State of being established in the Supreme Reality.
- SAHASRADALA PADMA: The thousand-petalled lotus chakra on the top of the head wherein resides the Supreme Lord, the Goal of all Yogas.
- SAHODHARA BUDDHI: Treating all as one's brothers and sisters.
- SAMA CHITTATA: Equipoised mind.
- SAMATVA BHAVANA: Attitude of equality.
- SAMATVA BUDDHI: Mind endowed with the equal vision of beholding all as One.
- SAMATVAM YOGA UCHYATE: "Equipoise is yoga."
- SAMADHI: The equipoised state of Oneness with God.
- SANKALPA SHAKTI: Power of resolve or creative imagination.
- SANATANA DHARMA: The Eternal Religion of the Vedas.
- SARVATRA SAMADA: Equal vision everywhere.
- SASTRA: Scripture; science.
- SAT KARMA: Good or virtuous action.
- SATTVA: Principle of clarity; one of the three qualities of Nature.
- SATYA NASTI PARO DHARMA: "Truth is the supreme righteousness.
- SEVA: Service.
- SHANTI: Peace.
- SHIVOHAM: "I am Shiva."
- SIDDHI: Psychic power; perfection.
- SISHYA: Disciple.
- SUDDHA BODHA: Pure awareness.
- SUDDHA SATTVA: Pure sattva (see "Sattva" above).
- SUDDHA TATTVAM: The pure Principle.
- SUPRABHATAM: Good morning; verses requesting the Deity to wake up in the early morning hours.
- SVADHARMA: One's own duty.

SVAYAMBHU LINGA: A self-manifest linga or symbol of Lord Shiva.

TAMAS: The principle of inertia; one of the three qualities of Nature.

TAMASIC: Pertaining to tamas (see above).

TAPAS SAKTI: The power generated by austerities.

TINDAL AND TODIL: An old custom of avoiding impure substances and people for fear of ritual pollution.

TIRUVATIRA KALI: A village dance.

TRIGUNAS: The three gunas or qualities of Nature, sattva (tranquil), rajas (active), and tamas (inert).

TRIKARTIKA: A star or constellation.

TURIYA: The fourth state of Bliss beyond the waking, dream and deep sleep states.

VAIRAGYA: Detachment.

VANAPRASTHA: The third stage of life in which one leaves all worldly activity and devotes oneself to austerities.

VEDAS: The revealed scriptures of Hinduism.

VETTUCHEMBU: A kind of tuber root.

VIDYA DEVI: The Goddess of Knowledge.

VISALA BUDDHI: Broadmindedness.

VISALATA: Expansiveness.

VIVEKA: Discrimination.

VYAVAHARA: Empirical.

YAMA AND NIYAMA: The do's and don't of the path of Raja Yoga.

YOGASCHITTA VRITTI NIRODAH: "Yoga is the control of mental modifications."



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Picture of Amma

AWAKEN, CHILDREN!

*Dialogues With
Sri Sri Mata Amritanandamayi*

VOLUME 2

Adaptation & Translation

SWAMI AMRITASWARUPANANDA



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This book is humbly offered at the
Lotus Feet of Her Holiness
Sri Sri Mata Amritanandamayi
the Resplendent Luminary immanent
in the hearts of all beings



Shōshanam pāpapaṅkasya dīpanam jñānatejasām
Guru pādōdakam samyak, saṁsārārnava tārakam
The holy water that has washed the Guru's Feet, dries the
mind of sins, lights the Lamp of Knowledge and helps
one cross the Ocean of Transmigration.

Ajñāna mūlaharanam janmakarma nivāranam
Jñāna vairāgya siddhyartham gurupādōdakam pibet
It uproots ignorance of the Self, puts an end to rebirth and
its cause, actions. One should sip the holy water of the
Guru's Feet for Enlightenment and Dispassion.

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Preface

Dear brothers and sisters, herein is contained a direct translation of Holy Mother's *divya upadesha* (divine advice) into the English language. The tremendous blessing that is bestowed by presenting the Mother's teachings to the English-speaking world is not yet fully realized. Now it is left to the reader of the material and a whole-hearted practice of it in daily life.

Several points should be remembered in order that this translation is approached with the right understanding. First of all, these conversations have occurred between the Mother and Indian householders and renunciates in the cultural context of India. Also, the Mother's teachings are given according to the level of understanding of each person to whom She is speaking. Often a word-for-word English translation falls short of conveying the totality of what the Mother has expressed through Her mother tongue, Malayalam. One must consider these factors when contemplating Her words to achieve deeper insight.

Secondly, the Mother's use of language is direct and earthy. Her words convey an immediacy and intensity of purpose to transmit the Essential, particularly when speaking to *sadhaks* (spiritual aspirants). For instance, when it comes time to bring a point across to a renunciate, the Mother does not mince words. Thus we can understand Her expression, "Worldly pleasure is equal to dog excreta" to be sound advice to one whose sole aim is God-Realization.

In a separate conversation with a householder, the Mother's advice takes on an entirely different tone. "Mother does not say that you must give up all desires. You can enjoy them, but do not think that this life is for that only." Keep in mind that in the Mother's language, the word 'world' literally means

‘that which is seen’ as opposed to the invisible Reality or God. Knowing this will be of great help in interpreting Her use of the word ‘worldly.’ When the Mother contrasts that which is spiritual to that which is worldly, She refers to the attitude with which actions are done. Spiritual actions are those actions which lead one to God through selflessness and purity. Worldly actions are those actions which lead one away from God, performed as they are in a spirit of selfishness.

Finally, the Mother speaks to us from the exalted state of *sahaja samadhi*, the natural state of abidance of a Self-Realized Master in the Absolute Reality. The challenge in translating is to render the Mother’s transcendental vision into English for the layman. The vital ingredient in this process is the contemplative mind of the reader. Abandoning all superficiality, may our mind and intellect become subtle and assimilate the Eternal Wisdom of the Mother’s words. Firmly established in our practice, may we all revel in the direct experience of the Supreme Absolute without delay.

My heartfelt gratitude is due to Professor M. Ramakrishnan Nair, the compiler of *Mata Amritanandamayi Sambhashanangal*, the Holy Mother’s conversations in Malayalam. The present book, *Awaken, Children! 2* is a faithful translation of the same, interspersed with some additional materials which were recorded by me. I would like to thank my spiritual sisters, Sabari, Meera and Astrid who edited and typed the text, Brahmacharin Nealu who did the typesetting, and all of the Holy Mother’s children who took part in producing the book.

Introduction

With joy we present this second volume of “Awaken, Children!” to the readers and devotees of the Holy Mother Amrit-anandamayi. As in the first volume, I have interspersed the conversations with material which has been personally recorded by me over the years.

Words of *Mahatmas* are not merely meant for superficial reading. Mother does not want us to read and forget. She wishes that we should apply at least a little of Her teachings in our daily life, born out of our conviction of their practical utility. As She says,

“Faith gained through telling, hearing and reading will not last long, but faith gained through experience will last forever. You will not get sweetness if you write ‘honey’ on a piece of paper and lick it. Neither can you milk the picture of a cow nor live in the blueprint of a house. Practical experience is needed.”

The Mother is Herself an embodiment of all that She says, a living witness to all the eternal values mentioned in the texts of all religions of the world. Both Her teachings and Her life stand as a tremendous source of inspiration for people from all walks of life. How many scientists gained new insights into their particular field of research through Her words! How many scholars have felt thrilled to hear Her simple and lucid explanations of subtle and complex scriptural statements! How many doctors have been wonderstruck on seeing the miraculous cures effected by Her! How many engineers have been amazed at Her efficiency in planning! How many politi-

cal leaders have gained courage and self-confidence through Her words of advice! How many householders have found solace in Her loving protection! How many spiritual aspirants have been uplifted by Her presence and loving guidance! And how many countless lives have been set right and put on the path of integrity by Her gracious blessings!

Loving obedience to the words of the Guru is the meaning of “self-surrender” as told by Mother. Therefore, let us strive and try as best as we can to live by Her instructions so that we, Her children, may awaken to God-consciousness and thereby fulfill Her wish.

Swami Amritaswarupananda



In the beginning, many people who visited the Holy Mother were interested only in gaining material ends. They had very little knowledge about spirituality. Many of them thought that the Mother was like an astrologer or a fortune-teller who predicts the future. There were many who believed that the Holy Mother was visited by Devi and Krishna three times a week. Almost all the people who came in those days had no real spiritual background at all. Once their desires were fulfilled, they would never return until another problem or wish arose. They could not understand anything about the Mother's Supreme Realization. Soon things changed; the visits of people who were only interested in worldly things decreased, and people who were primarily interested in spiritual practices started coming to see the Mother. Eminent scholars and serious *sadhaks*, scientists and people from different walks of life greatly interested in doing spiritual practice started flowing to Mother. They realized that the Holy Mother was a unique soul and a storehouse of Supreme Knowledge. Then they, out of their longing to know, asked the Holy Mother various questions about their own spiritual practices. At this time She started manifesting more and more of Her *Guru Bhava* (Masterhood).

All those who asked the Mother questions found great joy, peace and inner contentment in Her answers. Even eminent scholars and learned people gained new ideas and insights into many subjects which they discussed with the Holy

Mother. Once they met Mother, they became very drawn towards Her and came to see Her time after time.

Tuesday, 1 November 1983

The *brahmacharins* were meditating at ten o'clock this morning since there was no scriptural class. The Holy Mother was sitting in the hut deeply absorbed in Herself.

The young men who had come on the previous day returned today. Seeing the Mother in an abstracted mood, they waited outside the hut. After some time, cheerful and smiling, the Holy Mother invited the young men inside.

Amma: Children, were you standing outside for a long time?

One among them: No, Mother, we were simply gazing at you.

The Holy Mother lovingly asked them to sit down. They sat down after prostrating to Her and one of them said,

Young man: We are here with more questions today. Who else can we turn to except you, Mother?

Amma: Questions and doubts should end; acceptance should come.

One young man: We agree, Mother.

Amma: (Smilingly) Good, at least you have accepted that (the young men laugh).

Question: Mother, is devotion a spiritual practice (*sadhana*)?

Amma: Son, devotion which is based on real spiritual principles (*tattwattile bhakti*) is a *sadhana*. But devotion prompted by desire (*kāmya bhakti*) cannot be considered a *sadhana*.

Young man: Mother, what is *tattwattile bhakti*?

Amma: *Tattwattile bhakti* is selflessly loving and taking refuge in God who has become everything, without thinking that there are many gods. One should understand that the Su-

preme Lord is omniscient, omnipresent and omnipotent. One should proceed with the sole aim of realizing God. It is useless to move towards the west when you want to go east. What meaning is there in simply wandering about with no direction in life? There should not be any delusion concerning the goal of life. For that, a *Satguru's* assistance is absolutely necessary. If *sadhana* is performed under a Guru conflict and confusion will not arise. Attempting *sadhana* without a Guru will lead to trouble.

Question: Who is a real *ḥarma yogin*?

Amma: A real *ḥarma yogin* is one who always remembers God throughout every action in which he is engaged. A real *sadhak* works seeing God in everything. This means he offers the action and its fruit at His Feet. Such a person's mind is not in the work but in God. It all depends on practice. In other words, one who thinks of the fruit of action while doing work will not be able to perform the action fully applying his ability or talent. He should forget the fruit in order to get the full benefit of the work that he is doing. Sincerity in the work one is performing is very important. If actions are performed sincerely and wholeheartedly, they must bear good fruit. Instead, if you worry about the fruit, not only will you fail to put forth the necessary effort, but you will not get the expected result either. A certain amount of dedication is needed for any and every action.

Haven't you seen the folk dancers who dance while keeping a pot decorated with flowers on their heads? They will do all kinds of acrobatics with the pots remaining on their heads. They will dance according to the beat (*tala*) and sometimes even roll on the ground. The dancer's mind will be on the pot even while displaying all these tricks. If for only one moment he withdraws his mind, the pot will fall down. This is how

you have to act. Whatever action you do, the mind should be on God.

Question: Can the Vision of God be had through this path?

Amma: Yes, children, but who can do so? Such people are rare, are they not? Who is able to see God in their actions? It is possible if you try. The path of action is good, but the actions should be performed selflessly. Most people are after name, fame and position. If they don't get it, they will fight for it.

Question: Mother, in order to walk in the path of *karma yoga*, is a Guru necessary?

Amma: Certainly, a Guru is necessary. Even though the wind blows everywhere, when we stand under a tree, a special coolness can be felt from the breeze which filters through the leaves. Likewise, even though God exists everywhere, being in the presence of a Guru is something very special. Though air is everywhere, one gets a special feeling when sitting near a fan. A fan is beneficial when it is hot. In the same manner, when we are living in the midst of worldly pleasures, a Guru is necessary to control the mind. After reaching a particular state, these problems will no longer arise.

Isn't there a difference between studying in school and staying at home to study? When we sit at home, desires like wishing to go near our mother and to be held by her, will arise. If any guests happen to come, then the mind will be with them. The child will not study attentively. That is why children should be taught at school. The child will sit there and learn attentively when he realizes that he cannot go home till the afternoon. Likewise, in the beginning it is difficult to do *sadhana* sitting at home. Different kinds of worldly thoughts will enter the mind. Therefore, the best way is to do one's *sadhana* in a pure atmosphere. For proper and specific instruc-

tions and guidance, a *Satguru* is necessary. Guru and God are one, but we have not grown sufficiently mature to realize that.

Some people say that an external Guru is not necessary and that the Guru within will guide us. Some others might say that they are themselves the Guru. It cannot be said that a child studying in the kindergarten and a student who is studying for a Master's degree are the same. We need to learn in order to reach the latter's stage. If we think both students are equal, it is utter ignorance. It is like saying that an apple tree full of ripe apples and an apple seed are one. The former can give fruit and shade to the people and quench their hunger, but the latter cannot. A seed can become a tree and give fruit; but to become a tree, it has to pass through several stages. In that process of becoming, if it is not properly taken care of, it may even get destroyed. It has to overcome and withstand adverse climatic conditions and also be protected from stray animals. Similarly, in a *sadhak's* life many impediments will arise both from within and without. For that, the presence of a living *Satguru* is needed. *Satsang*, also, is beneficial to remove ignorance.

Question: Mother, will one go mad through devotion to God?

Amma: Yes, son, but that is the madness for God. Worldly people are mad for the world. By realizing God, one becomes the King of the world; others are only beggars and slaves of the world. If one really goes mad as a result of one's devotion, it is due to pursuing the path without knowing the essential principles behind it. Anything can happen then. One will not go mad if one travels along the path of devotion, rooted in its principles.

Question: Mother, it is said that some devotees are deranged.

Amma: Son, are you asking about the craziness of the devotees? Do you know what kind of madness they suffer from? It is madness for God. From our point of view, they are crazy.

That is not ordinary craziness but God-intoxicated craziness. If one has that, one has succeeded.

In reality, who is mad, devotees or worldly people? A devotee, through his craziness for God, saves thousands and thousands of people from going madly after worldly pleasures, and getting drowned in them and dissipating their energy. Whereas worldly people get completely caught up in worldly affairs and become unbalanced, thereby destroying their own lives and the lives of others as well. Some commit suicide or fight with each other even over silly things. They dissipate their energy in smoking, drinking and other indulgences. Now tell Mother who is really crazy and which craziness is better?

Question: Mother, what if one doesn't approach a Master?

Amma: Child, never do spiritual practices on your own. This is a serious matter. There is a difference between doing without studying and having studied and then doing. One needs a teacher in order to practice. Practice is not like reading books; there must be supervision. Even to gain worldly knowledge, a teacher is needed. Since this is the case, think how much more imperative it is to follow the advice of a Master while practicing the spiritual science, the king of all knowledge!

Question: Mother, why is it said that a *sadhak* should not move closely with the opposite sex?

Amma: In the same way that our mouth waters when we see a delicious mango pickle, our mind will unknowingly vacillate when we see the opposite sex. It is just like the ground getting muddy when it rains. Even if the holy Ganges water falls on the earth, it will become turbid. In the beginning, a *sadhak* should always keep a distance when around them. Always consider a woman as mother or sister and a man as father or brother. Remember that, no matter how alert we

are, there are possibilities for falling into trouble. If that fear and strong discrimination are there, we will not look at the external appearances, but only at the subtle aspect of each person. Then every woman's breasts will appear to be the breasts of the Divine Mother. Otherwise, looking at a woman as a mere woman, you may end up walking in the wrong path.

A male *sadhak's* greatest enemy is a woman, and a woman *sadhak's* is a man. Not only that, women are weak-minded by nature, but they can become more steady than a man if they develop some manly qualities. However, most of them do not do so. There are some women who have transcended sexual feelings, but they are only one or two in a million. There may be only one woman in a million who could instruct a man in spiritual principles even when he approaches her with a lustful mind.

For a *sadhak*, a woman is like a whirlwind. In the beginning a *sadhak* should not go near women. No harm will happen once the mind has been controlled. He will not vacillate even if a woman happens to come near him stark naked.

My daughters might think, "Why is Mother putting the blame on us by calling us weak-minded? Are not men equally to blame for their faults?" Children, women have a natural softness and compassion with them. However much they may try to conceal that, it is very difficult for them to do so. Their mind will easily melt if a man shows a little love for them. It is enough if a man looks lovingly at a woman. Her inborn nature of surrendering her all to a man is awakened and she forgets everything else. Seeing that soft and surrendering nature of hers, a man feels an attraction for her and forgets himself as well. This compassionate and soft nature of women always leads them into danger. Both men and women have

their weaknesses and strengths. Why should anyone be blamed? Mother will try to awaken true knowledge in both through Her instructions.

Those who are overly attached to sports, games and movies should not keep the television in their room. The temptation will be too much for them to resist. During the period of *sadhana* it is best to keep away from circumstances which will arouse one's passions.

Do you know why the opposite sex becomes an enemy, spiritually speaking? When our parents had sexual intercourse, they never had a desire to have a virtuous and brilliant child. It is the same *samskara* that is lying in us. Weren't we born from the same blood? The thought that lies in one's mind is that the opposite sex is only for one's pleasure. In order to remove this *vasana*, one should keep one's distance, while perceiving them in a brotherly or sisterly way.

Question: Is that easy?

Amma: It is not easy, but it is also not impossible if you have the determination. Son, we do not feel anything when we see a child's nakedness, do we? We are supposed to be like that. The mind is the cause of everything, isn't it? Our mind does not become impure when we perceive someone as a small child, but it becomes lustful when we think that person is a grown-up. Everything depends on the mind.

Even the world appears because of the existence of the mind. In the waking state the mind functions; therefore, the world of plurality exists. Whereas, in the deep sleep state the mind stops functioning; therefore, the world and the objects do not exist. In the morning when we wake up, the mind comes back and the world arises as well. A Self-Realized soul, through constant spiritual practice, restrains all thoughts by focusing the mind on the Supreme. Thus when the thoughts

stop, the mind also subsides because it is nothing but thought waves. Then there is no world of plurality as we now see it.

Question: If one tries, can God-Realization be gained after crossing all these obstacles?

Amma: It is possible if you try, but who has the determination? Even to try requires a certain degree of spiritual disposition inherited from the previous birth and the desire to reach the goal.

Most people in the beginning show a lot of enthusiasm. They think that they can experience or gain that state in a few days, and when it doesn't happen, their enthusiasm slowly disappears. Constant and sincere practice is needed. But in some people you can see spiritual experience dawning at an early stage. This is due to their spiritual *samskara* inherited from the previous birth.

At this time a family from the eastern side of Kerala came to see Mother. The entire family prostrated to the Mother. The eldest lady of the family expressed a wish that the Mother be the first to give her grandson some solid food. This child had been born due to the blessings of the Mother.

One and a half years ago this woman's daughter and son-in-law had come to the Mother praying for a child. It was seven years into their marriage and still there was no child. The Mother had taken a banana and, after blessing it, had given it to the couple asking them to share it. She had told them that the woman would soon conceive and give birth to a son on a particular day in a particular month. She had also told them that since the child would be a Godly one, they should be very patient with him and cautious in their actions towards him.

As foretold by the Mother, the woman did indeed give birth to a male child on the exact day that the Mother had

indicated. It was to this child that the family wanted Mother to give the first solid food.

The Mother lovingly told them, “Children, Mother will give the food tonight during *Devi Bhava*. She usually gives it at that time.” However, the grandmother objected saying,

Grandmother: This child is very adamant and will not sleep without a cradle. Also, he may become sick from the sea breeze here. Therefore, we must reach home before dark. So, Mother, please do the ceremony now.

Amma: Is that so? Suppose the child were sick and you had to take him to the hospital. Would you tell the doctor that you must take the child home before dark because he won’t sleep without a cradle? Children, patience is very important, especially in regards to this child. He is not an ordinary child but a Godly one.

In spite of the Mother’s words, the elderly lady insisted that the child must be taken home before dark. Hearing that, the Mother kept silent and closed Her eyes. After a short while She opened Her eyes and was asked by one of the young men, “Mother, may we ask a few more questions?”

Amma: Yes, children, go ahead and ask.

Question: Mother, will God appear to us in the form in which we think of Him?

Amma: Son, definitely God will give us His *darshan* in the form in which we think of Him.

The Holy Mother stopped abruptly. She seemed to be immersed in deep contemplation. With tears flowing from Her eyes, She sat there motionless like a statue. After a few minutes, opening Her eyes, She sang,

*Creation and Creator art Thou,
 Thou art Energy and Truth,
 Creator of the Cosmos art Thou,
 And Thou art the beginning
 And the end, the Essence of
 The individual soul art Thou
 And Thou art the five elements as well,
 O Divine Mother!*

As She called “Devi...Devi,” the Mother shed tears of bliss and once again entered into spiritual ecstasy. After a long pause, upon regaining Her normal consciousness, the Holy Mother continued.

Amma: Son, certainly God will come in the form in which we think of Him but we must have the longing to see Him before He will manifest. The omniscient, omnipotent and all-pervading God, the *Nirguna Brahman* (Attributeless Reality), can definitely assume any form according to the wish of His devotees. *Nirguna Brahman* becoming *Saguna* (with attributes) is like ice becoming water or butter becoming ghee. The form which He assumes as God or Guru should not be considered as made up of the five elements, but rather as the embodiment of Pure Existence, Awareness and Bliss Absolute (*Akhandā Satchidananda Brahman*). He will also come in different forms in order to test the devotee’s renunciation and devotion.

There was one devotee who did severe penance to realize God. One day a stranger came to his house and said, “It seems that you are a great renunciate. If so, let me see the depth of your renunciation; give your wife to me.” Without any hesitation, the devotee gave his wife to the stranger. Having received the devotee’s wife, the stranger came out of the house. As he was leaving the compound, some friends of the

devotee happened to see the stranger accompanied by the devotee's sobbing wife. They mistook the stranger for a miscreant who was forcibly taking away their friend's wife. They caught him and beat him till he was black and blue. Hearing the uproar, the devotee came out of his house and was shocked to see the pitiful condition of the stranger who was breathing his last. With unbearable pain in his heart, he said, "What is this? What have you done to this poor man? I willingly gave my wife to him." He continued, "O Lord, please forgive my friends. Please save this man by giving my life to him. O Lord, take my life instead." As soon as he uttered these prayers, the stranger disappeared and the Lord Himself stood before him. Everything which happened was His trick to test His devotee's devotion and dedication. The Lord was testing whether the devotee had any selfishness. The Lord did not appear when he gave up his wife, but only when he had the willingness and mental attitude to sacrifice his own life in order to save someone else's life.

Children, it is our duty towards God to be compassionate and loving towards the poor and needy. When somebody is suffering, we should sympathize and take pity on him. But that alone is not enough; we should be ready to help him because God is everywhere, in everything. When we develop compassion and love for ailing people, His grace will spontaneously flow into us.

Sin means ignorance

Young man: Mother, the Christians call everyone sinners. Why is this?

Amma: Son, in fact, sin means ignorance or *vasanas*, i.e., the tendencies inherited from the previous birth. It is meaningless to hate someone, labelling him as a sinner. No one is without

faults. Otherwise, everyone should be hated because all have some blemish or other. What is called “ignorant” in India is called “sinner” in the West. That is all. *Papa* (sin) is a synonym for *ajnana* (ignorance). Those actions which take one closer to God are meritorious, while those which take one away from God are sinful.

Question: Mother, many saints say that he who goes on saying “I am a sinner, I am a sinner,” will become a sinner. What does that mean?

Amma: That is correct. When he goes on thinking and saying that he is a sinner or is weak, he will become unable to undertake any kind of useful work. Ups and downs are the nature of life and are unavoidable. An individual who thinks that he is weak or is a sinner will collapse before them. A sinner is one who does not have the mental strength to confront the problems of life. No doubt he will become weaker and weaker if he continues thinking “I am weak, I am a sinner. I cannot do anything, I cannot accomplish anything in life.” Whereas, he will gain more mental strength to face the challenges of life if he thinks, “I am not a sinner, nor am I ignorant or weak. I am strong, I am the Supreme Self or I am protected by God, I am His child.”

Fruits of action can be overcome

Question: Let it be so. Shouldn’t the fruit of actions be experienced?

Amma: Not quite, son. They can all be gotten rid of if we are really determined. The fruit of some actions can be cancelled through other godly actions. Mother can narrate a number of incidents to prove this point.

Suppose we are fated to be stabbed to death due to certain evil acts which we committed in our past birth. If somehow

in this birth, we are instructed by a great saint or spiritual person to start doing spiritual practices, such as observing vows, chanting mantras and the like, then when the predestined time would come, someone might stab us, but instead of it putting an end to our life, we might sustain only a minor injury. Pre-destined fate will follow its course, but its effect will be weakened. Son, fate, of course, is powerful, but the strength of good actions is even more so.

Question: Mother, is there an actual incident to demonstrate the point?

Amma: There are a number of such incidents. (Turning to Brahmacharin Balu) Balu, my son, tell these children one incident to demonstrate the point.

Balu: A couple used to visit Mother every now and then. One day the wife seemed to be very worried and mentally depressed. When Mother asked what was wrong, she told Her that she had visited a famous astrologer who predicted that her husband would die on a certain date which was only a few months away. When she returned home, the lady found the same signs in her husband's horoscope and became dejected. Having found no way to save her husband's life, as a last resort, she came along with her husband to Mother. Mother consoled her and suggested that both of them do certain spiritual practices including a vow of silence every Saturday. She asked them to chant a particular mantra every day in the morning and evening, and also at other times whenever they felt like it. She also recommended that they purchase a calf and raise it. They followed the instructions implicitly. On the fated day, to their amazement, the calf suddenly fell dead. Through their sincere and concentrated spiritual practices, they were able to neutralize the husband's past actions. As a result, the calf died instead of him. Fate had its way, but with an

unexpected turn. Mother said that their innocent prayers and pure resolve and faith helped them to transcend their fate.

Young man: If that is so, is it unnecessary to experience the fruit of one's actions?

Amma: Son, faith and alertness will help alot to cross over the many obstacles that might arise in our life. If we are alert, anything can be overcome, in the same way that an object can be prevented from falling by placing it on the ground. Moreover, the very impulse to act is the outcome of the fruit of actions performed in the previous birth.

But the fruit of actions will not affect a *sadhak*. Many men go to the Arabian countries for five or six years soon after their marriage, leaving their wife in their native place. They go abroad controlling their mind and relinquishing the pleasures of family life for the sake of earning money. Man has the adaptability to alter this life style to suit the necessity. Likewise, what if we give up worldly life in order to attain God-Realization? The old fruits of actions can be transcended by new actions. Actions can be changed by action. Markandeya's life span was extended through *tapas*, wasn't it? Do you know the story of Markandeya? Mother will tell you.

The sage Mrikandu had no children for a very long time. In order to beget a child, he did severe penance to please Lord Shiva. Finally the Lord appeared before him and asked, "Do you wish to have an intelligent and radiant son who will die at the age of sixteen, or a useless dullard who will have a long life span?" Mrikandu prayed for having the former kind of child.

As was foretold by the Lord, the newborn baby developed into a brilliant prodigy endowed with all qualities. The parents named him Markandeya (son of Mrikandu). All the four Vedas and other scriptures spontaneously dawned in his intellect. Everyone who came in contact with him felt attracted by

his good qualities and behavior. But his parents were very unhappy and would weep upon looking at his face, remembering that he would die at the age of sixteen. Somehow they managed to conceal this fact from him.

One day, however, Markandeya saw his parents shedding tears while looking at him and enquired the reason for their sorrow. With choked voices they related the history of his birth and Lord Shiva's prophecy. Thenceforth, Markandeya immersed himself in intense *tapas* with the strong determination to please Lord Shiva and overcome death.

At last the fated day arrived. When the messengers of Death came, they found Markandeya sitting in *samadhi*, absorbed in the thought of Lord Shiva. Since they could not approach him, the God of Death himself, Yama, came to take away Markandeya's soul. Waking from *samadhi* and seeing Yama, Markandeya threw himself on the *Shivalinga* and embraced it tightly. Throwing his noose around Markandeya and the *Linga*, Yama tried to pull Markandeya away. Infuriated, Lord Shiva manifested out of the *Linga* and killed Yama in order to protect His devotee. The Lord then bestowed eternal life on Markandeya and blessed him that he would remain sixteen years old forever! Then, in response to the prayers of the gods, the Lord brought Yama back to life.

What about Ratnakaran, the forest dweller, becoming the sage Valmiki? Ratnakaran had been a highway robber. Way-laying the celestial sage Narada, he was advised by the sage to give up his sinful way of making a living. Narada asked the robber to go and enquire from his family whether they were prepared to bear part of the fruits of the sinful actions by which he was supporting them. Shocked to hear that they would not do so, Ratnakaran returned to the sage and took refuge in him in order to escape the dire consequences of his evil actions. Narada advised him to chant the Divine Name

of “Rama.” Ratnakaran was so sinful that the holy name “Rama” would not come to his lips. Narada therefore asked him to repeat the word “Mara” which means “tree” but if reversed becomes “Rama.” Taking this advice to heart, Ratnakaran began chanting and became so completely absorbed that he was gradually covered over by an anthill (*valmika*). Thereafter, he became known as the great sage Valmiki, the author of the epic Ramayana.

Children, these stories are told to show us that fate can be transcended by strong determination and devotion to the Lord. If these are present, nothing is impossible.

Question: Mother, is it possible for a person who has committed many sins in his previous birth to do *sadhana* in this birth?

Amma: Son, even the thought to live for God arises due to the merits accumulated in the previous birth. Such thoughts arise because we have done good deeds. Circumstances also play their role. A person who lives near a workshop from childhood onwards might learn the work which is done there through friendship with workers. A change can occur in one’s life owing to association, but merits acquired from the previous birth are needed even for such circumstances to arise. That is why it is said that merits inherited from the previous birth are needed more than anything else.

Another point to be remembered is this: once one comes to a Perfect Master, all one’s sins will be washed away by His or Her grace. After that, one should not waste one’s time thinking, “Oh, I am a sinner,” but rather one should try to assimilate the Guru’s teachings. One should not brood over the past but should start on the spiritual path in earnest when real detachment comes.

Understanding the goal, we should strive hard to attain it. Mother doesn’t know anything; She has not studied any scrip-

tures; She is saying all this because you asked. Children, take whatever you want and reject the rest, in the same way that you drink the sugarcane juice and discard the fibre.

We must reflect, no matter how much we have understood these principles. Are we really loving our wife and children? Isn't it out of selfishness? We love others because they give us happiness, or fulfill our desires, or obey or respect us, or have a high opinion about us. Otherwise, we don't. If somebody hates us, feelings of revenge take the place of love. This is the case even with your own wife and children. If they disobey or disrespect you, you will not love them. Where there is real love there is no selfishness. Think of the ways that we devise to make money. We are even ready to kill others to acquire wealth if the circumstances are favorable. In most cases, all these atrocities are done just for the sake of a few people, for two or three members of the family.

Question: Mother, is the form of Kali a Goddess?

Amma: No, son, Kali is symbolic of the divine principle of fierceness which kills the ego. Similar is the case with the other forms of God. When we yell at a cow saying, "Go away!" when it eats the leaves of a young coconut palm, we have the same attitude of fierceness. The cow will not run away if we lovingly tell it to go. It needs a certain show of anger. Likewise, the Mother is roaring and killing the ego through the manifestation of Kali. Through this understanding we can transcend all forms.

Question: Isn't that form of Kali God?

Amma: It depends on our *sankalpa* (conception). We can become identified with that form if our resolve is strong enough. In that state (of being able to identify with an object), whatever we think of, we will become, just as *vettapacha* (a kind of plant) when dipped in ink turns the same color as the ink. If we think of a person, we will feel that we are that

person, or if we think of a cow, we will feel that we are a cow. During the course of *sadhana*, there are stages in which we would feel so. From there, we can go to the Attributeless State.

In the beginning of Her *sadhana*, Mother conceived of God as having a form and attributes. At a certain stage, whatever form Mother would think of, She would become identified with that person; if She thought of a child, She would become that child and even start crawling on the floor on all fours. After some time, Mother heard a voice within Her saying, “Both God with attributes (*Saguna*) and the attributeless God (*Nirguna*) are within you. Seek to realize your oneness with the Attributeless.” After that, Mother started chanting “AUM” and directly experienced that everything is *Brahman*, the Absolute. But Mother does not feel that the *Saguna sadhana* that She did was a mistake. It required much concentrated attention and led Her to the *Nirguna Brahman*.

Saguna and *Nirguna* are not two different Realities. Ordinary people like us can reach the Formless Being only through some kind of medium. For those who don’t know how to swim, a boat is necessary to cross the river, isn’t it? Mother is not saying that you should stay in the boat forever. After reaching the other side, you should get out.

Once there was a disciple sitting on the banks of a river in the Himalayas thinking, “I see God in the form of my Guru but he says that he is not the body. Yet how can I believe him? How can one be with and without form at the same time? Doesn’t he talk to me and do all other actions like ordinary people?” While the disciple was brooding over the matter, a block of ice suddenly crashed into the river. As the disciple looked at it, a squirrel jumped onto the ice which floated across the river. Upon reaching the other bank, the squirrel got off and gingerly jumped away.

Seeing this, the disciple thought, “No doubt the ice is only water, but without it, the squirrel could not have crossed the river. The formless water became ice and will eventually lose its form and revert to its original formless nature as water, but the form serves a purpose. Likewise, *Nirguna* becomes *Saguna* for taking us across the Ocean of Transmigration. Henceforth, I will look upon my Guru as the embodied form of the formless Absolute.”

All forms have limitations. There is no tree which touches the sky, and there is no root which touches the netherworld. This means that all names and forms are finite. We should go beyond all names and forms. Even though God is beyond all qualities and all-pervading, He will come in a form according to our *sankalpa*.

It was now noon and the Mother told everyone to go and eat lunch. One of the young men said, “Mother, with your permission we would like to stay here until tomorrow evening.” “Mother is only too happy to allow you to stay,” She replied. As she was about to go, the elderly lady who had brought her grandson for receiving food from Mother again approached Her and said, “Mother, you did not say anything about feeding the child. Please do it now so that we can go before dark.” Mother replied, “You will not understand now. You will come to understand only when ...” The Mother abruptly stopped and asked one of the *brahmacharins* to bring some flowers, sandalwood paste and sacred ash.

An oil lamp was lit and the Mother placed the child on Her lap. She then applied sandalwood paste to his forehead and offered some flowers on his head. She then fed him a little sweet pudding which the grandmother had brought with her for that function. When everything was over, the family prostrated to Mother and happily took their leave.

Turning to Brahmacharin Pai who was nearby, Mother said, “What a pity, poor people. They will have to bring the child back again.”

Wednesday, 2 November 1983

The Ganges river

Last night the *Devi Bhava Darshan* was over at three a.m. The Mother, as usual, spent some more time talking with the devotees after *Darshan*. At four o'clock She took one family to the back of the Ashram and talked with them until five. By the time She went to bed, it was almost six in the morning.

Today at lunch-time some householder devotees came to see Mother. She came to the *darshan* hut at three p.m. Everyone saluted the Mother and sat down. The young men who had come yesterday were also present.

Devotee: Will God be in the form in which I think of Him?

Amma: That form itself is God, your God. However, it is enough if you realize that both the water in the pond and in the river come from the sea. Through this attitude we can reach God. There is no problem if we consider the power that we see in our conceptualized form as God's power. Everything is one Power. We can reach the Ocean of Brahman through this river of form.

Let me tell you a story. Once there was a group of devotees planning to make a pilgrimage from Kerala in the southern part of India to the holy Ganges river in northern India. When they asked an old saintly devotee if he would like to come, he replied, “I am too old to make the journey. Please take my walking stick and after dipping it in the Ganges, return it to me.” When the devotees reached the Ganges, they bathed in it and then dipped the old man's stick in the river.

Unfortunately, the stick slipped and was washed away by the river's swift current. On returning to their village, they informed the old saint that they had lost his stick. "Did you lose it in the Ganges?" he asked. "Yes, in the Ganges," they replied. "Then, it's no problem." Going to his backyard, the saint waded into the pond and pulled out his stick! For a Knower of the Self, there is no good or bad, pure or impure. For him there is Purity alone. As far as he is concerned, there is no difference between Ganges water and the water in the pond. But for ordinary people, all these differences do exist.

Question: What is the significance of Ganges water?

Amma: Son, everything depends on one's purity and the strength of one's conception. If Ganges water is not available, a *puja* can be performed, imagining the water to be Ganges water. When we say Ganges, there is a Ganges within us as well. Modern science has proved that the river Ganges, the external one, has the power to destroy germs. Likewise, there is a Ganges within us which has the power to purify our mind. That is why it is said that Ganges flows from the head of Lord Shiva. When we reach Perfection through meditation, we become Him, the Possessor of Ambrosia. The pure Ganges rises up from within. That is what is depicted as the Goddess Ganga hiding in the matted hair of Lord Shiva. Goddess Ganga represents the Kundalini Shakti and its endless flow is the flow of the Ganges. From Lord Shiva, the Perfect One, it flows pervading everything and purifies the whole universe. That is what a *mahatma* (great soul) does. Through intense spiritual practices, he controls and sublimates all his passions, and with his purified vital energy, he sanctifies the whole world. Not that Lord Shiva is concealing His second wife in His matted hair. Some people say that Ganga is His secret wife (all laugh).

The power of faith

Young man: Does ordinary water become Ganges water through *mantra japa* (chanting of a mantra)?

Amma: Yes, it will, but faith is important, not the water. One small boy who saw the priests worshipping a *Shivalinga* in the temple cherished an intense desire to do the same, but he couldn't go into the temple as he was not a brahmin (member of the priestly class). The thought of performing a *puja* to the *Shivalinga* became stronger and stronger in his innocent heart. One day he had an idea. He took some stones and placed them one on top of another. Considering that as Lord Shiva, he started doing the worship. But the poor boy did not have the necessary ingredients to offer to the deity as did the priests in the temple. Therefore he offered plain water, imagining that it was rose water; sand became the food offering, and he used pebbles instead of camphor. After the worship, the boy sat in meditation just as he had seen the priests do, all the while thinking of Shiva. Seeing their friend doing the *puja* to the *Shivalinga*, the boy's friends also sat around him and imitated him, their eyes closed as if meditating. Their parents, not having seen them for a long time, came in search of them. They found the children and saw what they were doing. Taking it only as insignificant child's play, the parents knocked down all the *Shivalingas*. Seeing their parents, the children got frightened and ran back to their homes, all except the first boy. He sat there motionless. When he opened his eyes, he found that his *Shivalinga* had been knocked over. Bursting into tears, he called aloud, "O Lord, what happened to You? Where are You? What am I to do now?" In a few seconds, Lord Shiva Himself appeared before the boy and blessed him. That is the power of conception (*bhavana*) and faith. The Lord was pleased even when worshipped with sand and stones. All those ingre-

dients, though imagined, became real, owing to the *bhavana shakti* of that innocent child, and the Lord was pleased.

The temple in Ambalapuzha

The Holy Mother paused for a while and then continued. **Amma:** Children, do you know the story of the temple in Ambalapuzha (a town about fifty miles to the north of the Mother's village)? Priests were invited for the installation and consecration ceremonies of the statue. All of them were eminent scholars who could chant all the four Vedas by heart. In spite of their knowledge, they could not fix the statue firmly on the altar, however much they tried. When the problem remained unsolved, the temple authorities made some astrological calculations in consultation with the priests. According to the calculations, a competent person to do the installation was sitting a few yards away from the temple compound. When they went to the spot revealed in the astrological chart, they found a very primitive and crazy-looking man sitting there chewing betel leaves, having just finished eating fried fish. His name was Naranattu Bhrantan (Naranattu the Crazy). They brought him to the place where the installation was taking place, inspite of the priests' mocking at him and making rude remarks to the temple authorities. They held their noses and spat on the ground to express their disgust. They thought, "What made these people bring this ugly and low caste man here? What is he going to do?" Suddenly, all the priests vomited, but what came out was fish. Then the crazy man who had eaten fish spat on the ground and out came holy basil leaves. Everyone was wonderstruck. Taking some betel leaves, he chewed them and spat on the altar. Placing the statue on the spittle on the altar, he uttered a few words

in a scolding tone, “Hey Krishna, sit here!” The statue became firmly fixed thereon.

The name of that town, Ambalapuzha, originated from the word ‘tambulam’ (betel leaves, when chewed, are usually mixed with three other ingredients, tobacco, arecanut and lime, which together are known in Sanskrit as tambulam). The town was previously known as Tambulapuzha. It was that illiterate layman’s spittle and his chiding of God which bore fruit and not the Vedic chanting of the priests. This was because the “crazy man” was a Perfect Soul; whereas, the priests only wanted money. They did not have any spiritual power. Even the scolding of *tapasvis* (those devoted to the practise of austerities) is beneficial, because they are people who say, “O God, I want neither food nor sleep nor the body nor the intellect nor even You! O God, it is enough if You give me Your qualities, Your heart.” Their power is in their concentration and pure attitude.

The sages have declared that there is power in mantras. If they have ordained so, then definitely it is there. Even a wooden plank will move by itself if you ask it to do so after chanting a particular mantra. That is the greatness of the power which they (*mahatmas*) have acquired. If they ordain that by chanting such and such a mantra, you will get such and such a power, then that will certainly bear fruit.

We will get results only if medicine is taken according to the prescription of the doctor. In the same way, we will certainly benefit if the mantras are used in the way sages have instructed. Scientists and doctors discover medicines and other inventions through experimentation, but their experiments are concerned only with the external world. Even today they are experimenting and the universe still remains a mystery to them. The sages, on the other hand, analyzed their own mind and did intense penance. For them there was no mystery; every-

thing stood revealed to them. The mantras were discovered by the ancient sages through direct experience as a result of their penances. They spoke after having reached the state of Perfection. Therefore, their words will definitely fructify. They had the ability to create anything by mere will. They went beyond everything in this Creation. Therefore, concentration is the most important thing that we must acquire. Without concentration, no work whatsoever will be perfect.

Young man: Mother, isn't it enough to worship God while sitting in our house, or is it necessary to go to the temples in order to worship Him?

Amma: Son, it is all right if you are not going to temples. However, if you go to temples, you will benefit because the vibrations there are entirely different from those of a house or other places where worldly dealings are taking place. In a temple, everyone is thinking of God. The power radiating from the statue creates peace and serenity in the mind. The atmosphere is concentrated and impregnated with the one-pointed thought of the devotees who gather there. Because all are thinking of God in that atmosphere, it is easy for others also to attain concentration. But we should have the right attitude when we go to a temple.

If we have true devotion, we can see the form of our Beloved Deity in the statue installed in the inner sanctum of the temple. Suppose we sincerely love a lady. Whichever woman we see or meet, we will be reminded of our beloved. Sometimes there will be a slight resemblance. At other times there will not be any at all. Even then, we will think and imagine that this girl's nose is like hers, and that girl walks like her, and this girl's eyes are exactly like hers, and that girl's hair is like hers; we will imagine in this way. Likewise, when we see somebody else's child, we will attribute similarities such as, this child smiles like my child. Even if there are no

similarities, out of love we will feel as if there were. In a similar manner, one who has sincere love for God will see His form everywhere. If it is not there, he will imagine his Beloved everywhere. That is how real love should be.

Suppose a young man goes to the office. He has a deep love for a woman. He thinks, “She may be taking a bath now. Now she may be having her breakfast, and now she may be going to the college,” and so on. Thus his mind will be completely on her. Then he will think, “She will be holding her books like this.” Thinking and imagining in this fashion, he holds the briefcase in his hand in the same way as he imagines the girl would hold her textbooks; so much does she saturate his thoughts. Even while sitting in the bus, he may think about her. He will not be aware of the other things happening in the bus, whatever they may be. All of his mind is on the lady whom he loves. For us, this kind of love should go towards God. Because of his thoughts about her, even his ways will become like hers. Eventually he himself will become her, just as Radha became Krishna by always thinking of Him.

Customary observances (achara)

Devotee: Mother, is it necessary to go to Sabarimala carrying *irumudi kettu* (the baggage in which pilgrims to Sabari Hills carry their belongings and offerings to the deity on their heads)? Is it enough if the mind is made pure?

Amma: Son, first of all, we must sincerely enquire whether our mind is pure or not. What you say is correct. It is enough if the mind is pure, but is our mind pure? It is only in the process of purification.

Son, customs are very important. If there is no regular discipline and proper conduct, it is very difficult for those who

are still leading a worldly life to control themselves. There is no point in saying that everything is God or *Brahman*. We have not experienced it. We get angry when we see things which we dislike, don't we? Customs have meaning. People go to Sabarimala with the *irumudi kettu* on their head. They are carrying *punya* (merits) and *papa* (demerits), the burden of ignorance, symbolically in the form of the baggage, and offering it at the Feet of the Lord. Or else it can be thought of as the bag of renunciation. It can also be interpreted as all of our worldly desires and wealth, or the five elements of which the body is composed. This means that we are offering or surrendering everything at His Feet and praying for Ultimate Emancipation. There are many ways to conceive of this custom. Satisfaction arises when we observe customary rites. Then, isn't it good? This is another way to purify the mind. Son, without *achara* it is difficult to purify the mind. How can a student study in school without a schedule? How will a regular discipline come about?

Question: Isn't love for God enough instead of the baggage on the head?

Amma: Son, the baggage will not be felt as an unnecessary burden if there is devotion. What if everyone goes to Sabarimala waving their hands back and forth? They are remembering the Lord and Sabarimala when they see the baggage aren't they? Ignorant children will pass urine and excreta in the puja room. Likewise, certain disciplines and codes of conduct are necessary to restrain the ignorant from acting willfully. *Acharam* is necessary for alertness (*sraddha*). For Mahatmas, *acharam* is unnecessary, yet they observe them in order to teach us by example.

Son, you have asked if love is enough and whether it is necessary to go carrying the baggage on the head. Son, it is enough for those who have love to sit in the house. It is not

necessary for them to go anywhere. The Lord will come running to a place where there is love for Him.

The *achara* should not go beyond its limits. You should be careful about that. Some brahmins give too much importance to it, which is not good. This may create a lot of problems. They become bound by too much *achara*, which becomes harmful for their spiritual progress.

Question: Mother, will there occur a change in Nature through *mantra japa*?

Amma: Son, chanting a mantra with concentration will definitely create a change in Nature. At present, due to man's over-indulgence and evil acts, Nature's harmony has been lost. We have broken the laws set by Nature. Everything depends on the human mind. In the olden days when people were truthful and good-hearted and worked together with mutual love and sincerity, Nature also favored them with prosperity. It rained during the time when it was needed, and only the necessary amount. The sun also shone in the same way. There was perfect balance between Nature and human beings. Whereas now things have changed. Everything is in chaos and confusion. Human beings act as they like. Morality, righteousness, truthfulness, mutual love, faith and sincerity have all been lost. The balance has been upset. Nature has stopped favoring selfish human beings; now She is reacting. This is a great threat to the human race. The combined forces of human intellect and modern science with all its weapons cannot obstruct Nature's course. We will be saved only if we change. Meditation, prayer, chanting and other spiritual practices are the only salvation. This is not a punishment, but the way which God has provided to make us think, discriminate and act. If we don't change, it is like lying on our back and spitting up; the spittle will fall on our own body. We will be paving the way for our own destruction if we don't change.

Group chanting and prayer is very powerful. It can change anything. The lost harmony of the human mind can be restored only through a selfless attitude supported by prayer, meditation and chanting of mantras. First, the human mind should be harmonized, then the harmony of Nature will spontaneously take place. Where there is concentration, there is harmony.

Question: What should be done if we happen to get caught in the midst of people who discuss worldly affairs?

Amma: You children should try to avoid them. If that is not possible, chant your mantra while sitting with them. Or else tell them frankly but with humility, “My path is different, I cannot do this. I don’t have any time to gossip.” Another method to escape from such a place is to visualize your Beloved Deity in the person who is talking to you.

Don’t give attention to the worldly souls around you even if they protest. This is not a problem for us. Do we keep awake at night because the crickets are chirping? No. In the same manner, consider that their protests and abuses are born of their ignorance. Don’t feel hatred or dislike towards them. Pray for them. Suppose a student went to attend his examination. He could not answer the questions properly. Why? Because of his ignorance about the subject. It is not that he knew the answers but refused to write. Likewise, these people. Let them protest; they don’t know anything about spirituality.

Our *sadhana* will not proceed if we go on trying to please others. Nor is offending others our method, for they will do the same to us. Not only that. By offending, we are becoming as ignorant as they. That is not our path. Ours is the path of humility and patience. Therefore, don’t act otherwise. If we show humility and patience, this may also create a change in the person who criticizes us. If we get angry, then what is the difference between him and us? In the beginning we will have

to bear with the anger of some people. Some will say, “Krishna killed His uncle. Therefore, I also can do the same.” It was not because it was His uncle that He killed him. Krishna killed Kamsa because he was the embodiment of egotism. There is only one way to prove the existence of the Truth. Sit quietly and be calm.

Question: It is said that one should always remember God. How is it possible to think of God when one is doing some calculations or other work requiring mental concentration?

Amma: Son, it is possible even though the goal at that moment is something else. Work, whatever kind it may be, requires concentration. Even while working, we can surrender our action and its fruit at the Feet of the Lord. We can remember Him by praying “O Lord, make these calculations correct. You are the power behind my memory. Please help me memorize everything unerringly. My Lord, make me do this quickly. O Lord, why is this taking such a long time?” Thus, you can always remember God while at work. If this becomes a habit, then you can have thoughts of God while doing the calculations.

If you find it difficult, then you should pray before doing the work, “O my beloved Lord, I am going to do this work; please give me enough mental strength to do this as a worship of You. Help me to do this work with the right attitude. This is Yours, not mine. I am doing it with Your power, not mine.” Then do the work sincerely, with concentration, and as best as you can without thinking of its fruit. Try to derive happiness from the spirit in which you are doing the work. When it is over, again pray, “O Lord, thank you for Your blessings and guidance. I now surrender both the action and its fruit at Your Feet.” When this is practiced daily and constantly, it will become spontaneous.

Once the work is done, having put in as much effort as you can, with an attitude of surrender, then there is no need to worry thinking about the fruit. Fruit is something which will manifest in the future. Worrying about the past or future is meaningless. The former is no more; it has no validity. Even if you go on brooding about things that went wrong in the past, they will not be corrected. The future is also not in your hands. It is controlled by the Supreme. A true devotee who has surrendered everything to the Supreme will not worry about the past or future. For him whatever happens is God's Will. He accepts everything as His *prasada*.

Ramayana

Young man: Mother, we have troubled you asking many questions. If Mother lets us, we would like to ask a few more. Mother, in *Srimad Ramayana* it is said that Sri Rama had abandoned Sita. Even if Rama was an Incarnation, was it right for Him to do so?

Amma: Children, before we give an opinion about something, we should see the different aspects of it. Though Rama was an Incarnation, He was primarily a king, and secondarily a husband and father. In those days kings were not like the rulers of the present age. They ruled the kingdom with *dharma* as the basis. They never erred from the path of *dharma*. Rama was a true king. He always aimed at the happiness and peace of His subjects. When there was controversy about His wife, for the happiness and peace of His subjects He renounced His dearest one, Sita. This is real renunciation. Giving up a thing which is very dear to us is real sacrifice; relinquishing something which is insignificant cannot be called a sacrifice. As far as Rama was concerned, Sita was His heart and soul. In reality, they were not two but one. In order to please His sub-

jects, Rama, a true king, abandoned Sita whom He loved the most.

If you read and understand the Ramayana properly, you can see that both Sita and Rama were Perfect Souls. In that sense nobody could separate them because they were spiritually one. In fact, they had neither sorrow nor happiness because both of them were beyond all dualities. Even then, they suffered like ordinary human beings. That was to set an example of how we should live in this world without deviating from the path of dharma even when we are in the midst of life's problems.

You can see that the same Rama who abandoned Sita, shed buckets of tears the night before the abandonment and also when Ravana kidnapped Her. From that we can understand that He was a loving husband too. Moreover, even if She was renounced by Rama, Sita still adored Him. She never thought or spoke anything negative about Her husband even for a moment. She never thought of another man. That was only because She knew what Rama's duties were as a king and She knew what was in His heart as well. Their conduct makes it clear that Rama and Sita were Perfect Souls. What higher example is needed for us mortal human beings?

Today people never try to understand the scriptures properly. Not only that, they misinterpret them. That is the pity. There are many people who say, "If Rama could renounce Sita, I can also abandon my wife." On the other hand, some women will say, "If Sita could live with Ravana, what is wrong if I live with another man?" What moral degradation! Only renunciates who perform *tapas* can correctly interpret the scriptures, not others. Sri Rama ruled the kingdom, and at the same time was highly spiritual while living in this world. He was an ideal brother, son, husband, king and friend. He was even a good enemy.

Young man: Mother, that was a really good answer. We have never before heard an explanation like that.

Another young man: Mother, soldiers kill people. Isn't this a sin?

Amma: Son, it is not for their own selfish purpose that they do that. It is for the nation, to protect the country from its enemies, is it not? That is their duty. It is the *dharma* of a *kshatriya* (member of the military class) to fight. There is no sin in it. Sin is incurred when somebody acts solely on the basis of his likes and dislikes, as in taking revenge on someone, hating someone, killing in order to acquire wealth, and other similar evil actions.

Question: Mother, one of my friends has had many different calamities happen to him. He has told me to ask Mother, "Does God need me?"

Amma: Son, God needs everyone and no one. He is in us, but we are not in Him because our mind is attached to different worldly objects, particularly money and property. Therefore, our mind is in those objects, not in Him. That is the main cause of all our sufferings. God created us and the world. He teaches the Supreme Principle and *dharma* through the scriptures. What we experience is the result of living without caring about that. Even if you blame God for your evil acts and experiences, He will not be affected at all, but you will degenerate further and suffer more.

How many different kinds of deformed people stay in Oachira!¹ Some are without tongues. So many different kinds

¹ A village located about eight kilometers to the north of the Amma's Ashram. A festival is held there every year at which time hundreds of thousands of people visit the temple there. There will also be hundreds of beggars and deformed people present trying to get a little money from the visitors.

of people! Foregoing food and sleep, they call, “Shivane, Shivane (O Lord, O Lord!)” while asking for alms. Wealthy people and handsome people walk in front of them. Even after experiencing all their sufferings, they never think, “O God, we are also living in the same world as these wealthy and healthy people. Therefore, definitely we must have done something wicked in our previous birth or we would not be suffering like this.” They don’t learn any lessons even though they are laying there begging for their food. They fight and curse each other. Those handsome and wealthy people who walk by also don’t imagine that their fate might be the same if they commit evil acts.

Trials and tribulations, ups and downs, are the nature of life. They are unavoidable. When such experiences come, if you leave God denying Him, then you alone and not God are responsible for the consequences that follow. Whereas, if you hold onto His Feet at all times in all circumstances, then He will take care of you. Therefore, tell your friend to proceed with discrimination.

The time was five o’clock in the evening and everyone was sitting quietly with the Mother. The silence was suddenly broken by a scream from the door of the hut. Calling out, “Amma!” the elderly lady who had insisted on the previous day that Mother give her grandson sweet pudding came rushing in like a deranged person. Snatching the child from her daughter, she placed him at the Mother’s Feet and cried, “O Mother, please forgive us. Please forgive us for our egotism!” The entire family was weeping aloud. Mother lovingly lifted the grandmother and wiped her tears while consoling the rest of the family. “What’s the matter, children?” the Mother innocently enquired. A devotee of Mother’s who was also a

neighbor of this family and who had accompanied them to the Ashram said,

Devotee: Yesterday they came home by seven in the evening after leaving Mother. I was looking after their house in their absence and was there when they arrived. They narrated the day's events to me, after which I went home and went to sleep at about ten-thirty. Suddenly at midnight I was woken by an uproar in the neighboring house. Hearing their cries, I understood that something serious had happened and came rushing to their house. I was shocked to see the grandchild lying dead in his cradle, surrounded by his sorrowing family. At first, I could not think, but after regaining a little composure, I went about trying to find out if the child was actually dead. I shook him and sprinkled water on his face, but nothing was of any avail. There was no sign of life. An hour passed while the grandmother went on lamenting and crying out to Mother, asking for Her forgiveness. The mother of the child was unconscious on the floor due to the shock.

Suddenly, my wife ran to our house and came back with a bottle of holy water which had been sanctified by Mother and kept by us for use when we are sick. She sprinkled some of the water on the child's face and body. All of us anxiously watched to see any sign of life, while wholeheartedly praying for the child's resuscitation. To our wonder, after ten minutes the child opened his eyes and slowly moved his limbs. After one hour he had become perfectly normal. Realizing that they had committed a grave mistake in forcing Mother to do the feeding ceremony against Her will, they wanted to come here to seek Her forgiveness. Although they started from their house in the early hours of the morning, they could not make the proper bus connections and could only reach here now.

Amma: Do not worry, children. Consider this incident as given by God for your future good. Take it as a lesson to make you

more cautious and patient. Do not consider it as a punishment. God will not punish us. Out of His compassion, He will only give us opportunities to think, discriminate and act properly.

Although the Mother knew beforehand what was destined to happen, She did not assert any authority of Her own to prevent it. She never claimed that due to their disregard towards Her the family suffered. On the other hand, She attributed the entire incident to the Will of God. Such is Her egolessness.

14 November 1984

Renounce the ego

A young man: Amma, why does God make us commit mistakes?

Amma: Son, God is not making us do any mistakes. According to which one of God's instructions are we making all these mistakes? Aren't we committing mistakes knowing that they are errors, without listening to the warning given by our own conscience which is God? Son, which God has told you to act egotistically? You drive a car after drinking. An accident occurs due to your careless driving. What foolishness it is if you come out of the car and scold the fuel for creating the accident! Likewise, in our struggle to protect our false pride, we commit all kinds of negative acts. When there is no other way to escape from our misdeeds, we blame God, putting all the responsibility of our shortcomings on His shoulders.

Young man: Mother, if the ego is such a despicable thing, couldn't He have abstained from giving it to us?

Amma: Son, fire has both good and evil effects. It can be used for cooking rice, and also to set a house on fire. A knife can be used for chopping vegetables as well as to kill someone. Good and bad are determined by the use that we make of a thing. There is ego in the attitude, “I am God’s child, I am the servant of God.” There is also ego in thinking, “I am rich, I am great.” However, the former attitude will be for our good; whereas, the latter will lead us into evil. Everything exists in nature; just as there is darkness and light, there is good and bad too. It is our duty to move along the right path, using the discrimination given by God.

However much it rains, the water will not stay on the roof of a house or on the top of a mountain. From the mountain, all the water will flow down to the streams. Likewise, if there is a ditch, the rainwater will flow from all directions and fill it. Nothing will be obtained as long as the sense of “I” remains. grace will flow into us when we have the humble attitude, “I am nothing.” The egotist will not make use of the favorable circumstances given to him. He doesn’t have the mental strength to do so. We must always have the attitude, “I am nothing.”

If the seed has to sprout, it should go beneath the soil with the attitude, “I am nothing.” It cannot grow into its real nature as a plant if it haughtily thinks, “Why should I bow down to this dirty earth?” When the button on the handle is pressed down, the umbrella opens. Similarly, if we cultivate and develop humility, when our ego is made to bow low in front of the Supreme and His Creation, visualizing everything as Him, only then will our Real Nature unfold.

People who think, “I am great and something special,” are in reality smaller than anyone else. They will always try to project their ego while engaged in any action whatsoever. Just like an over-inflated balloon, they will have to burst one

day. The really great people are those who take themselves to be the servants of God and who serve all with humility and simplicity. The Supreme Reality is within us, but we are not aware of It. We remain in the worldly plane of existence due to our ego and this is why we do not know this truth.

Character building

Young man: What then is to be done, Mother?

Amma: Son, first of all, we should cultivate a good character. Suppose you meet a person and say, “Namaste,” (salutations) to him. Out of pride he may not salute you back. When you next see him, again say, “Namaste.” This time also, he may not respond. Repeat the same the third time. This time certainly he will think, “This man is saluting me whenever he sees me even though I have not responded at all, and he still continues to do it without any feeling of hatred. Now I must salute him back.” Thinking thus, he will return your salutation. In this way you can develop a good habit which will culminate in a refined character in the future, and will help others develop a good character too.

Character building is what is needed first. In the beginning we should deliberately do it. Don’t we have to grow? Suppose we have an intense desire to become a doctor. We will study, abstaining from all entertainment, even foregoing food and sleep in order to concentrate on our studies. Why? We want to become a doctor. Likewise, we should intentionally cultivate good character in order to reach the spiritual goal. If we do that, then we won’t feel anything as an obstacle. Character building is the first step to spiritual life. Children, try to become good by developing good character.

Skepticism

As the Holy Mother was talking, a serious-looking young man of about twenty-five came in. The Mother gestured for him to sit down. He sat and looked around with a proud expression in his eyes. It seemed that he wanted to make others feel that he was something special. The Holy Mother all of a sudden changed the topic of conversation and said, **Amma:** If ten people get peace of mind from a particular place and thereby grow, we should consider that perhaps there is something of real value there. A skeptic is always confused. He has no God, no father and no mother, and maybe he even beats his mother. On the other hand, one who has *bhaya bhakti* (devotion endowed with reverence and fear of God) will not commit any mistakes. In the olden days, the skeptics were those who would serve the world selflessly. Such people are not seen at all today. Mother would say that the genuine skeptics are really thirsting. They are the ones who love God because they are ready to love and serve the world even though they say there is no God. They are always seeing God, Unity or Oneness through others. Therefore, they do good actions. In the olden days, there were such people.

Today one says, “I am a skeptic,” and with an inflated ego, kills and beats others. This is what is done today in the name of rationalism. This is not what is needed. A real skeptic is one who lovingly makes others understand the essential principles of life and loves others even at the cost of his own life. That was why Mother said that today’s skepticism will cause only degradation. Genuine love arises in a believer when *bhaya bhakti* develops in him. Those who come near him will also gain peace. This is the benefit that the world gets from a devotee of the Lord. Today’s skeptics do not act after understanding the scriptures properly. Those who did in the

past, did good to the world. Today's skeptics walk around creating havoc without studying anything, holding on high two or three words taken from somewhere or other.

The rationalistic movement was formed in the olden days in order to get rid of certain evil practices which had crept into religion. However, the skeptics themselves did not really know what was proper conduct and what was evil conduct as based on the scriptures. The scriptures reveal the real purpose of life. That is why their movement has become a failure, synonymous with wickedness and revolution. They have nothing good to contribute to the world. Rather, they make people think perversely.

The child will not make any mistakes when he fears that the father will punish him. Therefore, *bhaya bhakti* is not something bad; on the contrary, it is beneficial. When children are young, they study well due to *bhaya bhakti*. Otherwise, we can see them becoming spoiled. We become good without committing any mistakes when we have *bhaya bhakti* towards God.

When the thirst for devotion and reverence towards God develops, good conduct and qualities like truthfulness, love, compassion and righteousness grow. One will have love and respect for one's parents and (other) elders. One will not tell lies and will try to control anger and other negative feelings. Due to this, the atmosphere becomes peaceful. From obedience arises discipline, and thence follows peace.

In the absence of policemen, thieves will rule because there is no one to fear. If there were policemen, three-quarters of the crimes would be prevented due to the fear of punishment, and the public would live in peace. Similarly, when people believe in the existence of a Transcendent Power which governs the universe and which metes out punishment to the offenders of Its Laws, they will do less evil which, in turn, will

result in more peace and happiness for society. Seeing their good example, others will also emulate them.

Some so-called skeptics ask why money should be spent in offering sweet pudding and flower garlands to God in the temple, when there are so many poverty-stricken people dying of starvation for whom the money could be spent. The skeptics do not care to think about how many people benefit directly or indirectly through the temple worship. How many people are employed by the temple in various capacities! The people who grow the flowers and those who transport them, as well as those who make the garlands, and the priests who perform the worship, all earn a living thereby. Finally, the worshipper derives satisfaction after the worship is over. See how many people benefit from mere flowers that blossom today and wilt tomorrow! How can we ignore this fact? Nature also is benefited. The impure air in the atmosphere is absorbed, and pure oxygen is expelled by the flower plants. This is beneficial to all living beings.

Life depends on air, the gross form of *prana shakti* or life energy. The sages observed that those who breathe quickly have a shorter life span than those whose breath is slow and calm. The pigeon is an example of a fast-breathing and short-lived creature. There is a close connection between the mind and the breath. With the increase or decrease in thoughts, there is a corresponding increase or decrease in the speed of the breath.

Through worship performed with flowers and chanting of mantras, man can attain a long and healthy life. During the worship, his mind will become concentrated and calm, which will result in his breath slowing down. This, in turn, will prolong his life and improve his health. Fast breathing is harmful to the body in the long run.

In the process of worship, thoughts will arise less and less, and the mind will gradually become pure and clear. Such a one-pointed mind will become an abode of virtues and spiritual power. The believer in God who performs the worship conserves energy through concentration, and thereby purifies himself and his surroundings. Is this not a real benefit?

The Ancients knew that in the present Dark Age of Materialism (*Kali Yuga*) humanity would not be inclined towards righteousness. Greed and the thirst for life alone would reign supreme. Offering sweet pudding and money to God were ways that the Ancients found for developing broad-mindedness, a charitable disposition, and love of God in humankind. It is said that love is sweet, that the thought of one whom we love gives a sweet memory. Offering sweet pudding to God is symbolic of offering our love to Him. But we have never heard that God eats that pudding. The worshippers and the temple employees are the ones who eat it, not God! So then, who benefits by such an offering? Not God, but humanity.

An offering becomes genuine when one gives one's mind and heart along with the offering. See the case of lover and beloved. They offer their hearts to one another and become identified with each other. Similar should be the case with a devotee and God. But how can a devotee truly offer himself as long as he is attached to things other than God? A person's main object of attachment is wealth. A large portion of his mind is occupied with thoughts of material gain. To make such a mind think of God is not easy. When a person offers money to God in the temple, he really offers a part of himself. In this way his attachments gradually decrease, and his love for God and charity increase. One will get the full benefit of any action only if there is complete dedication and self-surrender behind it.

The atmosphere in a temple is also conducive to our well-being. It is an atmosphere of serenity and inspiration. Just compare it to the feeling of a liquor shop. A parrot raised in a temple will repeat the Name of God. If raised in a liquor shop, it will repeat only vulgar expressions.

All this time the young man was keenly listening to the Mother's words. By then his pride had disappeared. He got up from his seat and approached the Holy Mother. Having prostrated before the Mother in a very gentle and humble way, he said,

Young man: Amma, I am a skeptic. I had many doubts about you and the work that you were doing. I came to argue with you and corner you. But, even without asking my questions, you have answered my doubts. What Mother said was correct. I was mistaken.

The Holy Mother smiled and caressed him.

Another young man: Nowadays, isn't it the theists who are making more mistakes?

Amma: Mother was not talking about bogus devotees. Suppose you visit a library where there are thousands of books. Upon opening one book, you find that has no value. Because of this, is there any meaning in declaring that the whole library is worthless? Similarly, if one or two devotees commit mistakes, does it mean that all are doing so? Those who have real devotion will not commit any mistakes. In fact, they are the real benefactors of the world. We often see things from a narrow point of view. That is not good. Be broad-minded. If you go through history with an impartial and discerning eye, you can see that it was devotees and spiritual people who really served the world. It was always they who restored peace

and tranquility when there arose a critical period in history. They never accepted a salary for the service they had done to society. They are the truly selfless ones. On the other hand, we become egoistic and arrogant when we say and believe that there is no God. Which is better, to become a devotee or an atheist?

Bhaya bhakti

Young man: *Bhaya bhakti* is blind, isn't it?

Amma: Son, until we become mature, it is the fear of our father and teacher that makes us learn our lessons. When we grow up, the *lakshya bodha* (goal-oriented mind) that we should become a doctor or engineer will develop. Thus, there are benefits derived from *bhaya bhakti* until we can discriminate on our own.

A child wants to go near the pond or well, but he is afraid of his mother because in the past he was spanked for going there. Is this fear blind or a weakness? No, such fear saves the child from falling into the pond and drowning. There will come a time when the child develops proper discrimination. Then no one has to tell him; he knows for himself. Improper discrimination leads to destruction, living as we do without *bhaya bhakti*. Don't you think so? Therefore, *bhaya bhakti* will do good up to a certain extent. Afterwards, *lakshya bodha* is needed.

Son, you have asked whether or not *bhaya bhakti* is blind. It is *bhaya bhakti* which protects us when we are living in ignorance. Many children are ruined nowadays because they do not have any fear or respect for their parents and end up in the company of bad friends.

What Mother has to say now is that we should encourage those who give consolation and peace to others, whoever they

may be. Children, you must proceed carefully. Mother does not say that you should blindly believe. Think and discriminate, then decide.

Saying this, the Holy Mother got up.

Amma: Children, you are not going now, are you? Mother will come back after some time. Please wait.

The young men came out of the hut and stood in the front yard of the temple. Having told one of the *brahmacharins* to play a *bhajan* tape, the Holy Mother then walked towards the southern side of the Ashram standing by the bank of the backwaters. The Mother stood there for a long time looking at the sky. The lines of a song sung by the Mother filled the atmosphere through the loudspeakers.

*O Thou Whose form is Power,
While listening to Thy Name,
The mind becomes divinely intoxicated,
The Heart trembles.
O how beautiful is Thy form!*

*Holy is the tongue that utters Thy Name,
Worthy of attainment
Are meditation and worship.
Invaluable is the intellect that merges in Thee.
Without these, this birth
And all external actions are in vain.*

Sitting in front of the temple, the young men silently listened to the song with eyes closed.

Incarnation

It was three in the afternoon when the Holy Mother entered the hut as cheerful as ever. The young men were already seated there expecting the Mother to come. As an expression of devotion and reverence, all of them stood up with palms joined as the Mother entered. With all humility, the Mother saluted them back and sat on the cot after asking the young men to sit down.

The Holy Mother closed Her eyes for a while and became absorbed within. When She opened Her eyes, one of the young men asked,

Question: Mother, will more than one Incarnation appear at a time?

Amma: Yes, son, it can happen. We can understand this by looking at Parasurama, Sri Rama and Sita or Balabhadra, Sri Krishna and Rukmini. They all lived at the same time, didn't they? There is no such law that only one Incarnation can take place at a particular time and place. Those are misconceptions.

Question: Isn't it also said that everyone is an Incarnation?

Amma: Yes, son, in a sense everyone is, but that should be realized. How many will understand even if told? Perhaps one in a billion, because it is not by intellectual understanding or mere book learning that this knowledge can be gained, but only through pure experience. It requires both human effort and Guru's grace.

Do you know how meaningless it is to say that everyone is an Incarnation? It is like saying that the coconut and the coconut tree are equal. The coconut tree is mature enough to give coconuts but the coconut by itself is not. The coconut may say, "I am also the coconut tree," but is there any meaning in that? A coconut tree is contained in the coconut, but it is not yet ready to bear fruits. The coconut can sprout and

grow and become a tree. But now it is only small and cannot produce any fruits; whereas, the coconut tree can give plenty of fruits to others. It is not enough if the coconut merely says, "I am the tree." It should be able to give an abundance of fruits. Similar is the difference between an ordinary soul or person who simply declares that he is an Incarnation, and a Mahatma who is established in the Real. It is not enough to say, "I am an Incarnation." One should be able to shower grace on others and bless them.

Young man: Even then, shouldn't an Incarnation be considered as only a part of God?

Amma: The feeling of being a part can exist only as long as there is body-consciousness. When that is transcended through *sadhana*, the *sadhak* becomes one with the Whole and the veil of ignorance is removed. In reality, part and whole are one. The sense of difference is due to ignorance. Incarnations do not distinguish between part and whole. We should understand the meaning of the "I" which they use. The "I" which they refer to is the Supreme Principle. It is not the "I" which is only five feet tall. "I" means the expansive, all-embracing "I," the "I" which sees everything as one. When an Incarnation says, "I alone am Krishna," which Krishna does He mean? The Krishna which is the Supreme Principle, which is everything. That Krishna is also Rama. When an Incarnation (*Avatar Purusha*) says "I," we will misunderstand and think that He is referring to that small little individual, but He is talking about the "I" which is the Supreme Principle.

Young man: Mother, we have learned that Prophet Moham-med had told those who did not accept his path that they would be subjected to severe punishment. Is this a sensible declaration?

Amma: Son, this can be interpreted in a different way. “My path” means the path which he followed, the path to the Supreme. “Severe punishment” is the suffering that we have to experience created by our *vasanas* when we don’t search for our True Nature. When Mohammed said “my path,” he was not referring to the “I” which is limited by the body but rather to the Universal or Eternal “I.” In that sense, the path he meant was also the path to Eternity. Son, try to have a positive attitude towards all the religions. Take the good aspects from them instead of finding fault with them.

Young man: What form can be attributed to God, male or female?

Amma: (Smiling) Son, God is neither a man nor a woman. He is beyond both. Male and female are within us. Someone or other said, “This is man” and “This is woman.” Isn’t it only after birth that we make the distinction? What was before that? Mother would say that all are women except the knowers of the Self. There are women among men and men among women. Almost all human beings are women by nature. One who has no control at all over the sense organs is a woman. One who has controlled the senses and mind is a real man. In that sense, how many men are there in this world?

Question: Mother, why then is God being worshipped as Kali? Is this not a female form?

Amma: Son, the sages have portrayed the gods and goddesses with different forms, having given each a particular meaning. Haven’t you seen pictures of Kali with the blood-soaked head of the demon Daruka in Her hand? That demon is the demon of *vasanas*, the demon of the ego which Kali has slain. That demon is within each of us and must be killed. Even so, not all deities are just products of the sages’ imagination. Some actually lived, like Krishna and Rama.

Question: Does a person who has been a woman in this birth become a woman in the next also?

Amma: Son, the next birth will be according to the thought that one has at the end of this birth. If the desire at the time of death is to become a woman, then you will become a woman in your next birth. At the moment of death, only the unfulfilled and strong desires will decide what you will become in your next life. If they are godly thoughts, then you will become a devotee, but if they are worldly thoughts, you will be again thrown into a world of *vasanas*. That is why it is said that you should cultivate divine thoughts through practice. You cannot think of God all of a sudden, especially at the moment of death. Only if this thought is firmly fixed and established through constant practice will it come at that moment. Son, do you know the story of Jada Bharata? Mother will tell you.

Jada Bharata was a king in ancient times. As the fruit of a life of righteousness, he developed a spirit of detachment and a strong desire for God-Realization. Entrusting the kingdom to his eldest son, he left for the forest in order to do intense *sadhana*. One day while engaged in *japa* by the side of the river, he saw a fawn being swept away by the current of the river. Getting up, he rescued it and took it to his hermitage. With great love and care he raised the fawn as if it was his own child. Soon he forgot all about *japa*, meditation and other spiritual practices due to his preoccupation with and affection for the fawn. Unexpectedly, the time for his death arrived. Even at that time he was lamenting the fate of the deer and died while looking at it. Naturally, he was reborn as a deer, but due to his previous *sadhana*, he remembered his mistake of the previous birth and remained aloof from his mother and all the other deer. Finally, he was reborn as a

man and achieved the Highest Goal through a life of detachment.

Young man: Mother, are you saying that a person who dies thinking of a house will become a house in his next lifetime?

Amma: (Bursting into laughter) Clever boy! He need not, but he might become a carpenter or a mason or a design engineer.

Young man: Can Lord Shiva be called “Mother”?

Amma: Yes, of course, He can be called so. It is said that the “I” has become the father, mother, child, brother, sister and all. Everything is Him alone. You call Him, giving any name. One will say “palu,” another will say “milk,” and yet another will say something else. Whatever the name, there is no difference either in the color or taste of the milk. God can be called both as Father and Mother. You were told that He is the Father, weren’t you? He is the real Father who disciplines you by removing the ego and correcting you, and He is also the real Mother who looks after and protects you lovingly, compassionately and affectionately. Both are two different facets of the same God. Both aspects are unique. You cannot compare That with anything in this universe. That is what manifests through a Perfect Master (*Satguru*), the perfect balance of both Divine Fatherhood and Motherhood. Everything is pervaded by the Supreme Self. He who has realized this can manifest any aspect at any time by self-will.

Steadiness in sadhana

Young man: Mother, some say that we cannot attain the Ultimate State unless we proceed on a particular path.

Amma: Son, a *sadhak* must be steady in his chosen path. He should have an idea about the goal to be attained. Especially in the beginning stages, he should stick to one path and have

a Guru who is a Self-Realized Soul. Towards this Guru he should have love, self-surrender and mental affinity. If you go on trying different paths and different Gurus, not only will it not help your spiritual progress but it will utterly confuse you.

Another young man: On their journey to Sabarimala², the pilgrims chant, “Swamiye Saranam Ayyappa” at all the temples they pass on the way. Why is this? Does Mother have anything to say about it?

Amma: That is not wrong. We should see the deity which we worship wherever we go. It is not good to change and worship different deities.

About Sabarimala and the attitude of the devotees during the period of their pilgrimage, Mother has only one thing to say. Cultivation of that attitude was a method found by the Mahatmas to unite people from different faiths in order to give their minds a sense of unity and oneness. Children, don’t you know that during the Sabarimala season the devotees call each other “Swami?” They consider everything, even excreta, as “Swami.” They call it “Poo Swami.” This is the same principle of nonduality, nothing but *Atman* or God or Swami. This particular period of religious vows and worship teaches the people self-control and a disciplined way of living. During the period of the forty-one days vow, the devotees abstain from all indulgence in drinking, smoking, sex, eating meat, fish and the like. Originally, this was introduced to give them a taste of a disciplined life, and that having tasted it, they might try to maintain the same way of living afterwards. But

² Sabarimala is a famous place of pilgrimage in Kerala which millions of devotees from all over India visit every year after observing various religious vows for 41 days. While traveling to the shrine, the devotees will be chanting “Swamiye Saranam Ayyappa” which means “I seek refuge in the Lord Ayyappa” (the presiding deity of Sabarimala).

most people do it mechanically and return to their same old life-style after the vow. Nowadays, even that is not seen. People go to that holy center as if going for a picnic. What a pity. A distinctive feature of the Kali Yuga!

Question: Mother, why is it not good to change deities and worship different ones?

Amma: Son, usually people see each deity as a separate entity. They don't see the principle behind it. Mother knows many people who become afraid if they forget to utter the name of one god among the many names of the gods they worship. They think that Vishnu will get angry if they chant Shiva's name while standing in front of a Vishnu temple, and vice versa. This is due to the lack of proper understanding about the principle behind the many gods. There are many rivers; each one has a different name and many branches but all have their source in the mountains. The gods and goddesses have diverse forms, but in reality, they are all One. The various names and forms are meant only to help us in our spiritual practice. Taste and mental constitution differ from person to person. Some like tea, some like coffee and others like drinking only lemonade. In the same way, each one can choose a deity according to his taste and mental make-up, which will serve as a ladder to attain the Supreme.

Once there was a famous devotee. A man from the next village heard about him, and therefore came to see him. The visitor waited outside in the front yard of the house. At that time the devotee was performing his worship sitting in the shrine. The man who came to see him looked in and found that he was worshipping Ganesha. At the same time the visitor dug a hole in the ground. Next, the devotee worshipped the Guru. The visitor dug another hole. Then the devotee offered a puja to Lord Subrahmanyam. Then again the man dug another hole. Then the devotee worshipped Lord Shiva,

Goddess Lakshmi and Goddess Kali, each separately. As each deity was worshipped, the man outside continued digging more holes. After finishing the *puja*, the devotee came out and saw so many holes all over the yard. He asked, “What is this; why are there so many holes dug here?” The visitor said, “I wanted water and so I dug everywhere, but I didn’t get any and therefore wasted my time. Had I dug one hole deep enough, I would have found water by this time.” The devotee understood. If he had completely surrendered to any one of those deities, he could have become a Liberated Soul long ago.

Young man: Amma, then what about these different mantras? There are many different ones, aren’t there?

Amma: Mantras should be given according to the deity one worships. Anyhow, it is better not to chant more than one mantra. We are trying to concentrate the mind and thereby reduce the thoughts so as to gain peace and purity of mind. Therefore, chanting one mantra is the best. That mantra should be a mantra related to your Beloved Deity. More than one mantra will confuse the aspirant.

Young man: What about a person who has no knowledge about all these things? Suppose one doesn’t know how to please the deity using a mantra. What does one do then?

Amma: Child, chanting a mantra is to purify our mind. You don’t need to please the deity at all with a mantra. Why does God need a mantra? What benefit is He going to get if we chant a mantra? Does an electric lamp need a kerosene lantern? No. God is Light. It is as if having lit a lamp or candle in front of Krishna’s or Christ’s picture, we would say, “O Lord, now You can see properly.” Is this needed by Them? It is only because They give the power of life that we are able to act. Then we say, “God, I will give You ten rupees for lighting a lamp.” What God says is, “There are poor people among My devotees. Serve them and then I will be satisfied

and feel compassion for you.” What does He need other than that?

The Supreme God is different from the gods (the minor gods or demigods). God is a name attributed to the Supreme Self when It assumes a form and attributes. There are worshippers of minor gods. Their worship is just like raising a dog in the house. If a thief or a stranger happens to come into the house, it barks and alerts us to the fact. It keeps enemies away from us. In the same way, a subtle aura will be around the person who worships with a pure resolve (*sankalpa*). That will destroy anyone who comes to hurt him. This is why nobody is able to do anything to a *sadhak*. Just as one who touches an electric wire is thrown off, those who come to injure a *sadhak* will experience their intention recoiling back on themselves, but they will not know why. Even without the knowledge of the attack, the *sadhak* will always be protected.

As this conversation was taking place, a snake was seen crawling along the inside of the roof of the hut. It slowly crawled away and disappeared. Looking up, the Mother and devotees watched it. When it was gone, the Holy Mother said,

Amma: Now and then he will crawl around here. He will come to the doorway of the children who light the lamp in the temple if they happen to be late lighting the lamps. Immediately, with joined palms they will call out, “Shiva, Shiva, Shiva, forgive me! I was mistaken and will light the lamp right now.” (Smilingly) Do you know how many times they have had to apologize to the snake? (All laugh)

Oblation to the ancestors

Question: Mother, why are oblations offered to the ancestors (departed souls)?

Amma: While alive, every being is surrounded by an aura. At the time of death that aura, along with the soul's inherent tendencies, leaves the body and floats about in the atmosphere, much in the same way that a balloon filled with helium floats. The scriptures say that the departed soul will remain in the atmosphere for two or three years after death. The feelings of attachment, of "I" and "mine" which ignorant souls have towards their relatives, feelings like "my sister," "my mother," and so on, persist even after death. The relatives also continue to consider the deceased soul as belonging to their family. Through this bond, when the relatives offer oblations to the departed soul with concentration, love, sincerity and a strong resolve, the departed soul will feel the effect and be uplifted and will gain peace or perhaps even a better birth. That soul ascends to the higher worlds when the relatives perform *pūja* for its sustenance, uttering the person's name and birth star and thinking of his or her form. The relatives' *sankalpa* acts upon the soul similar to the wind blowing a bubble up into the sky. Son, suppose we are living in a small village. However far it may be, a correctly addressed letter will reach us in our house. In a like manner, if oblations are offered in the right way, they will reach the soul for whom they were intended. If it is for our father and if he has taken birth in another place, the benefit of the oblations performed for him will reach him even there. Because we are offering the oblations, thinking of that soul's name and birth star and chanting traditionally prescribed mantras with concentration, the fruit of this action will reach the intended place. Some people continue to perform these oblations even three or four

years after the death of their relative, but this is more for the sake of remembrance than anything else. All of the aforesaid applies only to souls who are trapped in the bonds of attachment. Mahatmas who have gone beyond all such feelings can act according to their own wish after leaving the mortal frame.

Question: Mother, are rituals like formal worship (*puja*) necessary? Isn't mental worship enough?

Amma: Son, will hunger be appeased if you merely think of food? Don't you have to eat? In the beginning stages of spiritual life, *puja* and other ritualistic practices are necessary. They are one way to purify the wandering mind. The wandering nature of the mind can be controlled by keeping it engaged in the remembrance of God or Guru. While cleaning the *puja* room and *puja* articles, picking the flowers and making the garland and while doing the *puja*, the mind will always be thinking of the Lord's worship. This one thought will replace the many disconnected thoughts of the mind and give a sense of quietude. A fixed place, time and materials for worship are needed at the beginning. Through constant practice, one will reach a stage where one can perform mental worship at all times and places, but this is very subtle and is possible only after the mind has become subtle through concentration and devotion. After this, one will be able to perform every action as a worship of the Lord.

At this time some householder devotees came to see the Holy Mother. They offered the fruit they had brought to the feet of the Mother and prostrated. The Holy Mother asked them to sit down. It seemed that they wanted to talk to Her privately. Understanding this, the young men got ready to leave. As they offered their salutations to the Mother, She lovingly patted them and nodded approvingly saying, "Namah Shivaya."

27 November 1983

It was eleven o'clock in the morning. A householder devotee living in Bombay, but originally from Kerala, came with his wife and children to see the Mother. The Mother was sitting on the temple verandah with some other devotees. All of them saluted Her and offered the fruit and other things which they had brought.

Amma: Who is this? What brought you children here? Mother sometimes thinks, "Where are those children? Why aren't they coming?" Anyhow, whenever Mother thinks of you, She sees you.

One devotee: (With joined palms) Mother will call us, won't She? Though the body was there, our mind was here.

After a short pause, the devotee continued, "Mother, you asked what brought me here. I know nothing happens without your knowledge." As he uttered these words, both his and his wife's eyes filled with tears. Flooded with emotion, he continued, "Life was going along smoothly and there were not many problems for a long time, but two months ago, all of a sudden my eldest daughter died, and subsequently, in the following month, I lost my job."

For a few moments the devotee became speechless. Then he burst into tears. His wife was also silently shedding tears. The Holy Mother made both of them lie down on Her lap and gently stroked their hair. After some time, they both stopped crying and sat up.

Amma: (In a very loving voice) Son, Mother knows your sorrow. It is very difficult to overcome such circumstances. Even Mother feels sad about it. Nevertheless, there are certain unavoidable truths which we must face either today or tomorrow. Whatever begins must end; whatever is born must die.

This happens in everyone's life. It is quite natural that one might lose his mental balance when such things occur, but think for a moment. Does it make any sense if we go on grieving about it? Mother is not saying that you shouldn't cry at the death of your daughter. Yet if we don't regain our mental balance, then life will become more difficult. Ups and downs are the very nature of life. It is not the incident but how we confront it that is most important. Incidents by themselves cannot influence us. If we are mentally weak, their effect will be worse than if we are strong and well-controlled. The wise ones quickly overcome such situations. A wise man may also feel sad, but quickly realizes that it is all a play, that it is the nature of life. If you go on worrying, it will dissipate a lot of your energy and will make you inactive.

Suppose your finger is cut. If you simply cry while looking at the wound, it will not heal. Wash the wound and apply medicine; that is the only way to cure it. Likewise, brooding and crying over life's problems will not solve them. Try to confront problems and overcome them with proper discrimination and reflection. Crying will take away your mental peace and the problems will ultimately swallow you. But if you confront them with a steady mind, you can conquer them and become their master.

Devotee: Mother, these words of yours give us a lot of mental peace and strength. Mother, now we are in your presence and therefore there is peace. But what are we to do when we are away from you and feel as if thrown into the middle of the ocean?

Amma: Children, God is not confined to a particular body or place. There is not even an atom of space where He is not. Do not think that Mother is only in Vallickavu and is only this body. When you children pray sincerely, thinking of Mother, definitely that vibration will reach Mother and reflect on Her

mind. Your prayers and your pure and innocent *sankalpa* will bring Mother to you. Then you will feel Mother's presence and peace.

Devotee's wife: Having received the confirmation from Mother Herself, I feel very happy and peaceful.

The Holy Mother affectionately looked at her beaming face and lovingly patted her arm.

Another devotee: Mother, many obstacles arise in my *sadhana*. No progress is being made.

Amma: Son, suppose we work hard from morning till evening, and with that hard-earned money, we purchase peanuts every evening and eat them. Then at the end of the month, when we look in the cash box, there is no money at all. It was all spent for the peanuts; nothing was saved. Likewise, we do some kind of spiritual practice and then dissipate the acquired spiritual energy by indulging in worldly affairs. Who is to blame if the bucket used to draw water from a well has a hole? There will not be any water left in the bucket by the time it reaches the top of the well. All the water will have leaked out through the hole. Similarly, the power we acquire through meditation will be wasted if we involve ourselves in worldly activities without the proper attitude.

Question: What do you mean by the proper attitude, Mother?

Amma: Do your duties in this world as best as you can while surrendering everything to the Power which is beyond. Understand the nature of life. Act wisely without falling apart when obstacles arise and without getting too overjoyed in favorable circumstances. This world has been created for you. No saint or scripture says that you should not enjoy the pleasures of the world. But you are asked to exercise a certain amount of restraint while enjoying. Always maintain your self-control and be the master of the external objects and cir-

cumstances. Do not let anything enslave or control you. When your attitude changes, life's goal also changes, and then your mind becomes more calm and quiet. Take the example of Lord Sri Rama and Ravana. Sri Rama did everything for the welfare and happiness of all humanity; whereas Ravana's motivation was completely selfish. Sri Rama had an expansive viewpoint; Ravana viewed everything from the level of his own ego. Ravana wanted everything for himself; Rama gave up everything for the good of the world. Because of this, Rama is still adored and worshipped. Through Him thousands find solace and succor. Ravana paved the way for his own and the whole nation's destruction and became an evil character condemned by all. This clearly shows their difference in attitude and the effect thereof.

Question: Mother, is it possible for everyone to be like Sri Rama? He was an Incarnation, but we are mortal human beings.

Amma: Son, we always find an excuse when a situation arises where we don't want to blame ourselves. That is foolishness. We never try with determination. We have all the qualities in us, but we never try. We have all the instruments but we never use them.

Take the example of Valmiki who wrote the Ramayana. He was a highway robber, illiterate and primitive. Through constant practice endowed with determination, he became a great sage. He became a benefactor of the world through his compassion towards ailing humanity. How? Through constant chanting. Everything is within us, but our attachments in the name of love always pull us down.

Question: What does Mother mean by that? Do you mean that my love for my wife and children is not true love? Attachment is an aspect of love isn't it?

Amma: Son, only a person who is completely detached can love others without any expectations. Attachment is not an aspect of real love. In real love not only the bodies but also the souls will be united. There will always be the knowledge of the changing or perishable nature of the body and the eternal nature of the Self. Attachment binds and destroys the person who is attached and the person to whom he is attached. Due to this attachment, discrimination fails and discipline will be absent.

In the Mahabharata, Dhritarashtra, the blind king, was overly attached to his eldest son Duryodhana. Therefore, he could neither discipline his son nor make him think or act in the right way. This led to the total destruction of the king, his son and the kingdom. Whereas, Krishna was completely detached and could therefore love the Pandavas and, at the same time, discipline them. The story of Dhritarashtra and Duryodhana shows how the selfishness and attachment of one person can bring about the destruction of an entire society.

Question: Then what should we do?

Amma: Children, the eternal and non-eternal should be known through proper discrimination. Is the love that we get from the world real love? Is it possible for us to love anyone selflessly? In fact, it is not loving but cheating. If it is true love, it should be selfless. We are simply loving in the name of desires.

There was a girl who loved her friend so much that she wanted to buy a beautiful birthday gift for her. She searched and searched and finally found one but didn't buy it. On the day of her friend's birthday, the girl wrote a letter to her friend saying, "My dearest friend, my love for you is inexpressible. I wanted to send a beautiful birthday present to you and I found one but didn't buy it because the price was one hun-

dred and sixty rupees (nine dollars).” This is the kind of love that most of us have.

During weddings relatives and friends sometimes bring presents for the bride or the bridegroom. But each one of them buys a present hoping that twice as many presents will be returned at the marriage of their own son or daughter. Can this be called love? This is business-love.

We love our children. Don't we love them because they were born of our ovum and semen? Do we have the same amount of love for our brother's or sister's child or our neighbor's child? No. Why? Because they are not ours. Do we try to save our child at the risk of our own life if it happens to fall into a raging river? If the house in which the child is lying is on fire, will we jump into it? No. We know that if we do so, we will die. We don't love even our own child selflessly. Do we love our wife? Aren't we just loving her body, her flesh? Do we love the Self, the Real Being in her? We would even kill her if we found out that she loves another man, wouldn't we? What we want is happiness from her and if we don't get it our love is also gone. Do we really care about her happiness? No, because we always want her to act according to our whims and fancies. We want her to obey us. If not, our love disappears. This is not love. For us, real love is very difficult because we are always selfish and egoistic. Our parents had no thought of creating good children at the time of intercourse. Their minds were full of lustful thoughts only. They wanted pleasure. We are born of them. Then how will we get a good character? There is no need to blame them either. What they inherited was also the same. Degeneration is slowly handed down from parents to children and now that has been transferred from our parents to us.

Now everyone is madly running around looking for peace. Peace should come from within. What is to be done in order

to obtain this peace? We should live our life understanding and discriminating between the eternal and the non-eternal. That is the only way. We will get peace only through the knowledge that God alone is eternal. We love everything and everyone with expectation. It is only because of expectation that we hate. Hatred and anger come when our expectations are not fulfilled, when our desires are obstructed. We expect ten rupees from a person, and when we do not get it, hatred comes. Expectation is the cause of all this. Eternal peace and solace will be had only from the Self, our Real Nature.

Have faith in yourself

Question: Mother, what is real faith?

Amma: Real faith is faith in one's own Self. Even when we believe in an external deity or God or Goddess, we are believing in our own Self because that God or Guru is our own Self. If faith is only in an external object or deity, that faith cannot uplift us. With real faith, the worshipper or the devotee will have the understanding or awareness of the all-pervasive, omniscient and omnipotent nature of his Guru or Beloved Deity. Mother has neither told the *brahmacharin* children to have faith in a God sitting up above in the skies on a golden throne nor in Mother. Have faith in yourself. Try to know who you are. That is sufficient. If the grain lying in the granary egoistically thinks "Why should I bow down to this dirty earth? The paddy plant is within me," its real nature will not reveal itself. Only if it goes beneath the soil will its real nature manifest.

Children, in the same manner, only if you give up your *aham buddhi* (the egoistic mind) will it be possible to know your Real Nature. Otherwise, you will become prey to the rats of desires. If one rat happens to enter into a field, it will

destroy the entire crop. Likewise, one desire is enough. It will disfigure the beauty of the Self. This means that you will become a slave to *samsara*. To get rid of this ego it is said that we must have faith in God because when we believe in God, humility will arise. Real humility comes only when we are able to see everything as God. Humility means to become smaller and smaller. There are two ways to realize God. One is to grow bigger and bigger and become bigger than the world. This means to become aware that “Everything is in me, I am everything.” But this is not easy. This will easily inflate the ego because we don’t know how to grow big. It is not the ego that should be made big but the real “I.” The mind should be expanded to embrace and accommodate the whole universe within it. On the other hand, to become small is much easier. Consider ourselves to be the servants of God. God is not sitting in a particular place or on a throne. He is everywhere, in every object of the world. Therefore, when you think and discriminate properly, you can see that you are the servant of the world. Being a servant of God means being a servant of the world.

Question: Did Mother insist that these *brahmacharins* who are staying here must relinquish their hearth and home?

Amma: Shiva, Shiva, Shiva! Who is Mother to insist? Mother never insisted that anyone should stay here. Balu Mon got a job in a paper mill. There was a temple dedicated to Gana-pati near the mill on top of the hill. He would go there and meditate. He wouldn’t even eat his lunch. Seeing his indifferent nature, the officer said, “This is not possible. You must discharge your duties properly.” This is really what Balu was waiting for. Even before they asked him to leave the job he was finished with it and came here. Having come here, he started crying and said, “Mother, until yesterday I was destroying all my energy for nothing. Should I waste this body and

this human birth just for a woman and two children? Mother, don't push me into that world. My father and mother have enough wealth to live on. Then why should I make money and save it? I don't need it. Wouldn't it be better if I could give peace and solace to at least ten people with this body? Not only that, once we come to spiritual life, then we wouldn't think of harming anyone. That in itself is a good thing that we would be doing towards the world, is it not?"

They made the decision and came. Mother never decided for them. They had determination, so Mother accepted them. To give refuge to and guide those who want their life to be dedicated to God is Mother's duty and work in this world. If you go to a thief, he will teach you how to steal things stealthily. A cook will teach you the secrets of cooking. If it is a magician, he will teach you the techniques and secrets of his art. Each one will teach you the art which he knows. Likewise, this is my job. Whoever comes to Mother, She will ask them only to know God and will give the necessary instructions for that. What else can Mother teach them?

In those days the *brahmacharins* spent their days and nights outside under the trees, come rain or shine. There was no place or room for them to stay. That was good enough for them. There was nobody to give them food and there were no mats or pillows. Seeing their intensity and desire to know God, Mother did not insist that they should go. In the beginning Mother demanded that they all go to work, but they came back, having given up their jobs.

For a short while, the Holy Mother became abstracted. She stopped speaking and sat with Her eyes closed. The householder devotee also meditated until Mother opened Her eyes. She continued,

Amma: Children, none of you should believe just because Mother is saying all of these things. Look at Nature. Nature is a textbook from which we must learn. Each object in it is a page of that book. Each and every object in Nature teaches us something. Renunciation and selflessness are the greatest lessons that we can learn from Nature. Nature sacrifices Herself for humans; whereas, we not only exploit Her, but destroy Her. Yet Nature serves us. The earth is serving us; the sun, the moon and the stars serve us. What do we do in return for their selfless service? Nothing except harm. The unintelligent beings and things of the world have no thinking power, yet they selflessly serve each other and humans. Humans have discrimination and yet they are utterly selfish. They are not even clearing their debts to Nature.

Children, cautiously move forward understanding the subtle nature of whatever object you see. Then you will be able to understand that which is eternal. The well might say, “Could these people take a bath if my waters were not there? Could they get drinking water?” The well is not aware of where this water is coming from. Likewise, I might say, “Would these things happen if I were not here? I worked hard; no one but myself did it.” We are not aware of the source from which the power to act emanates. To know the eternal and the fleeting, it is enough if we know that Embodiment of Power. Mother doesn’t say that you children should become *brahmacharins* or *sannyasins*, but it is not easy to live a detached life while living in the world.

Devotee: Mother, even people who obtain *siddhis* through *sadhana* get into trouble. Don’t all of us know the story of Chennittala Siddhan?³

³ Chennittala Siddhan was a man from Kerala who had obtained psychic powers due to the favors bestowed on him by a saint to

Amma: That was not the power which he earned by himself through *sadhana*. They say that somebody bestowed that upon him. If it is obtained from somebody else without doing any *sadhana*, it will perish if misused. It will vanish if one does not maintain it through further spiritual practices. We won't feel like spending lavishly if it is the wealth accumulated by our own efforts. We will remember the suffering which we experienced. We will spend as we like if it is our parents' wealth because we did not undergo any suffering to get it. But we will use it cautiously if it is earned by hard work. *Siddhis* are not the criteria for measuring the greatness of a spiritual person. On the contrary, they are a *sadhak's* greatest impediment.

One-pointedness

Question: Mother, what should be done to get one-pointedness?

Amma: Children, you should make an attempt and see for yourself. Initially, it is difficult to get concentration. Don't stop your meditation and other spiritual practices because there is no concentration. Constant practice is the only way to achieve it. Until yesterday we were living in another world, the world of illusion (*Maya*). The experiences we had there will trouble us at first. Son, the *samskaras* of so many births are there in our mind. When we start doing *sadhana*, we can see all the negativity coming out and getting exhausted, just as more and more dirt comes off when we wipe the floor using a wet cloth. The mind can be made peaceful by sitting in solitude. Son, concentration will not be attained in the beginning. It is ab-

whom he gave water to drink during the saint's last moments. He became very famous but finally lost all his powers and died of a terrible disease.

olutely necessary to have a strong resolve to reach the goal. Suppose we are learning how to ride a bicycle. How many times will we fall down and get injured! Even then, we will not feel that it is a problem because our goal is to learn how to ride. How many shoves do we get at the ticket counter when we go to see a movie! We bear all that because our aim is to see the film. Likewise, whatever impediments come, you children should strive hard to get concentration, constantly keeping up the determination to reach the goal.

Students who have the desire to become engineers or doctors study hard with the intention of achieving their goal. Those who have understood what is eternal should proceed like those students. Time should not be wasted. Discipline arises automatically when the intent to reach the goal is there. Students who really want to learn study even while travelling in the bus. They do not complain that there is no light in their home. They will study even under the street light or go to a neighbor's house to study. Those who have determination are like that. Others will say, "I didn't study because there was no table, no light."

Think and discriminate between the eternal and non-eternal. Then if you children strive, you will get concentration. Whether it is for the body or the mind or intellect, won't you only benefit if there is concentration? We misuse time without knowing its value. Children, how much time is wasted by talking about and criticizing others. Why should we do it? Do we get any benefit out of it?

It is not necessary to meditate sitting with eyes closed in the beginning. Sitting in solitude, you should visualize your Beloved Deity while at the same time looking into the distance. Then cry for the Lord calling out, "O Lord, where are You, where are You? Let me see Your beautiful form and let me merge in You." If this is done, you will gain mental purity.

The twelve-thirty lunch bell sounded.

Amma: Come and eat, children. (Smilingly) Mother doesn't know whether it will be to your liking. Here the dishes are not too tasty. This is an Ashram. It is difficult to maintain *brahmacharya* (celibacy) if we are concerned about taste. This is a place for *tyagis* (renunciates), not for *bhogis* (those immersed in sensual enjoyment). The food given in the Ashram is *prasad* (blessed food).

After serving food to the devotees, the Holy Mother told the devotees that She would return later and went to Her hut.

At two-thirty, some more devotees came to see the Holy Mother. All of them were householders but very interested in *sadhana*. At three o'clock the Holy Mother again came and sat in the front verandah of the old temple. A few *brahmacharins* were also present. All the devotees prostrated to the Mother. Mother touched each one of them and saluted back.

That which is proper

One devotee: Mother, you are spending much time for us.

Amma: Mother is here for Her children, not for Her own comfort.

Devotee: You are too compassionate, Mother.

Amma: Mother does not know how to be otherwise.

Another devotee: Mother, what should I do?

Amma: Son, out of twenty-four hours, allow twenty-two hours for worldly affairs. Think of God for at least two hours. *Japa* should also be done for some time while sitting in solitude. It should be performed whenever you have the time, even at work. People spend their whole life thinking and brooding about their family and children. But what is this family and who are these children? Is it we who gave life to the children? They will become ours only if we give life to them. We are

only their foster parents. If they really belong to us, we should be able to save them from all circumstances, even death.

Once father Sugunanandan got very angry because Mother called him “foster father” during the *Bhava Darshan*. He told Devi, “You can go away from here. I want my daughter back.” She replied, “If I go, your daughter will become a corpse!” Still, he insisted. Then Mother suddenly fell down and became like a corpse and remained in that state for eight hours. A hue and cry arose around Mother. They even made arrangements for Her cremation. Having called Her “daughter,” they were now ready to cremate Her!

The person whom we love so much will be buried or burnt into ashes. That is the end of all relationships. We might remember him or her for a few more days or weeks. Then slowly we will forget all about them until they become a vague memory or dream.

The parents who are in the world are foster parents. Real parents are those who can restore one to life even after death. We should live with this thought in mind, surrendering everything to the Lord. Progress in this way.

When soldiers fight, they know that it is not for themselves that they are fighting. They are only performing their duty. You should live in this world in a similar way. Consider God alone as your true relative. Try to live in an Ashram atmosphere once a week. Slowly control your food and bad habits if there are any. Try to develop an inner detachment while discharging your worldly duties. Dedicate at least one day in a month to doing only spiritual practices like a vow of silence, *japa* and *dhyana* (meditation). Spend that day in a calm and quiet atmosphere where you can be away from all the family problems and other worries. You can control your sexual life as well through proper discrimination. Only if we try will we make progress.

Children, you should understand the limitations of the world. The world and worldly objects cannot enslave us if they are seen correctly. Don't give unnecessary and indiscriminate importance to things and incidents. Everything has a place in life but we either neglect it or over-emphasize it. Both are dangerous. There should always be a balance. You can enjoy the world, but over-indulgence is unwise. It will destroy all your virtues making you worse than an animal.

Devotee: Mother, what is the difference between today's society and the society which existed in previous times?

Amma: Son, in the olden days people also had the same requirements such as food, shelter and clothing, but *dharma* existed as the substratum of every activity. There was truth and love. There was cooperation and understanding among human beings. In those days, marriage was not only considered as a physical union of a man and a woman but as an oath taken by both, a joint endeavor to help each other lead a righteous life with God-Realization as the ultimate goal. They had patience, forbearance, endurance, forgiveness and love for God. In other words, they had real love. Real love comes only when there is a thirst for inner development. The husband was ready to sacrifice his life for higher values. The wife too had the same attitude. Their children also were brilliant and righteous. Whereas, today things have changed. The husband loves his wife but only if she dances according to his tune and vice versa. Today's love is not spiritual love but sexual love, love for each other's body. If physical attraction ceases, love is gone.

In the olden days husband and wife were devoted to each other. Through the power of their self-surrender and chastity, they attained Liberation. There is no such thing nowadays. You children should live in the world understanding this principle of dedication to righteousness. Then your children also

will become good. Parents should set an example by leading good and righteous lives in order to direct their children along the correct path.

Devotee: Won't we feel like clinging to the good once we come to know what is good and what is bad?

Amma: (Smilingly) It is not that easy, son. One who is totally immersed in worldliness would feel that there is nothing greater than that. When one gets married, then one would feel that there is no other heaven than that kind of life. One will not be able to think about any higher state than that. For him that is the highest thing in the world. Each living being, even a pig or an ant, thinks that its body is the best.

Once Indra took birth as a pig and forgetting everything lived happily in the mud with his wife and children. He thought, "How nice it is to be a pig." (All laugh) That is the power of *Maya*. Once you come to the world, you imagine that you need a wife, children, wealth, name and fame and position. Therefore, be careful. Perform *sadhana*.

At this point, the Holy Mother stopped talking and rose from Her seat. She went towards the southern side of the Ashram and walked to and fro along the bank of the backwaters. After some time She went to the hut and came back in one hour or so. It was nearly four-thirty in the afternoon.

Mother went with all the devotees to the seashore for a half hour of meditation. Meditation at the seashore in the presence of the Holy Mother was always very intense. The sound of the ocean waves coupled with the peace radiated by the Mother created a divine mood in the atmosphere. After meditation the Holy Mother sat gazing at the sun while devotees gazed at the Mother. There was an unusually pleasing and captivating smile on Her face.

Whenever Mother went to the seashore, many small children would gather around Her. That day they also came and

sat around Her simply looking at Her face. The Mother had some light talk with them and then distributed some toffees to them as usual.

Having returned to the Ashram, the Mother started the evening *bhajan* (devotional singing).

*Whose children are we, Mother?
Whose children are we?
What is the purpose of this birth
Which Thou hast given us?*

*I have no one to call my own.
Tell me who I am,
That I may dance in bliss.
O Blissful One, come, come.*

*O Blissful Mother, when is
The final journey?
That I may dance in bliss,
O Mother, come, come.*

This song was composed by the Mother long ago. The power of the song is really inexpressible when She sings it Herself. All the devotees experienced an overwhelming flood of supreme devotion. One cannot help crying to God with intense longing when the Mother sings.

Since it was a Sunday, the Mother's ecstatic singing went on till six-thirty p.m. The *Bhava Darshan* began by seven o'clock and went on until three the next morning. As usual, She enquired about the devotees once more before going to Her quarters at three-thirty.

28 November 1983

A van full of devotees from Trivandrum came to see the Holy Mother. The *brahmacharins* were meditating and the Mother was walking in the front yard of the Ashram at five o'clock in the evening. Gayatri was also walking just behind the Mother, holding a glass of tea in her right hand and the Mother's face towel in the left. As soon as She saw the group of devotees, the Mother approached them beaming with great love. As She walked towards them, Gayatri said, "Mother, please drink some tea." Without looking at her, Mother replied, "Not now, later is fine."

Amma: (To the devotees) Oh my children, you have come!

One devotee: Mother brought us here.

Amma: It depends how intense your desire is. If you are really desirous of accomplishing something, then you will certainly find a way to fulfill it.

The Mother sat on the sand with all the devotees around Her. They each prostrated to the Holy Mother and placed their offerings of fruit, flowers and other gifts in front of Her.

One devotee: There will not be any time for spiritual practice if one stays in the family. A hundred problems will come up.

Amma: If we have a real desire to know God, He Himself will solve the problems. There are so many such experiences! One should pray to God with a pure and innocent heart.

Once Mother, along with all the *brahmacharin* children, went to daughter Mohanam's house in Quilon. The next day, when everybody got into the car to return to Vallickavu, her youngest son, who loved Mother so much, also got in. Mohanam was also going to the Ashram, but she would not allow her son to go, telling him, "Tomorrow there is school so you must stay home." The boy started crying and through his tears

he said, “My Ammachi, if only God would make me an ant now, I could come with you sticking on to the side of the car.” Seeing the sorrow of that child, Mother did not even want to sit in the car. Mohanam would not listen even when Mother asked her to bring him to Vallickavu. Mother then kept quiet but was fully convinced that he would reach Vallickavu if his wish was indeed pure and innocent.

Mohanam was surprised to see her son at the Vallickavu Ashram that evening soon after the *darshan* had started. Do you know how he happened to get there? One of his mother’s distant relatives died all of a sudden. The relatives sent a message to Mohanam through one of their neighbors, but Mohanam was at the Ashram when he came to her house. He wanted to convey the message to her in person. Besides that, he harbored a desire to see the Holy Mother about whom he had heard from one of his friends. As he was not familiar with Vallickavu and how to get there, he took Mohanam’s youngest son with him as a guide. Whatever be the reason or chain of events, the important point is that Mohanam’s son did somehow happen to get to the Ashram to be with Mother on that very same day. That is the power of devotion and surrender.

If detachment arises

Devotee: Mother, my doubt still remains whether it is possible to do spiritual practice if one stays in the family.

Amma: Son, one will understand that all these worldly bondages are nothing if one uses his discriminative powers constantly. Children, do not relinquish your family and family duties all of a sudden. Perform your duties without thinking of past experiences, future expectations or the fruit of your actions. Always live in the present doing your duties as a

service to the Supreme. Avoid too much attachment. When you live in this manner, you will feel more peace of mind and one day you will be able to give up everything and dedicate yourself completely at the Feet of the Lord.

Buddha and Rama Tirtha each led a family life in the beginning. But they were always looking, observing and studying the nature of the world. They had so much *vairagya* (detachment). That is why they left their homes. Once detachment came, then there were no more relationships. No conflict arose for them even if it was their own mother who objected, for they could not attach themselves to anything anymore. That is the point. But children who don't have that much *vairagya* should not try to imitate this way of renouncing everything.

Question: Does that mean that one should wait until *vairagya* comes?

Amma: Son, what Mother means is that spirituality is not a way to escape from all the problems that confront you. If you run away from your home in the name of spirituality just to avoid the troubles of looking after your wife and children, this does not mean that you have renounced everything. The thoughts about your wife and children will be much stronger in your mind than when you were with them. Therefore, that is not the right way to do it. Perform your duties; at the same time, use your discrimination to avoid the danger of getting trapped in excessive attachment. Mother knows that this is difficult. It is a slow process. One needs a lot of patience.

At the same time, one cannot wait for *vairagya* to come. It is meaningless to think that one can satiate all desires and then take to spirituality, because desires are endless. They are like the waves of the ocean. They will appear one after another. A person was standing by the oceanside for a very long time. Another person who was watching him asked, "You

have been standing here for a long time. What are you doing?” He replied, “Friend, I want to take a bath in the ocean but I am waiting for the waves to subside so that I can bathe peacefully.” Desiring to lead a spiritual life after satisfying all one’s desires is like that person who wanted to bathe in the ocean only after all the waves had subsided.

Question: Mother, isn’t it a sin to abandon one’s mother and others?

Amma: It is not a sin if such a state of *vairagya* comes to you. Then their dejection will not affect you because you will be doing a greater good than merely being with them. When real *vairagya* comes, everything falls off automatically. It just happens spontaneously, without any effort. You cannot do otherwise.

A true seeker renounces everything for the good of the world. If one relinquishes his small family to become the servant of the big family, i.e., the world, there is no sin in it. When we make a pit around a huge teak tree to pour water and put fertilizer, many small plants and weeds will get destroyed. That destruction is not destruction. Nobody will care very much because compared to the teak tree, those small plants are insignificant and useless. Likewise, when real longing to realize God comes, one spontaneously cuts off all bondages. He may even give up his wife and children or parents. But he does not incur any sin by doing so because he has done this for the world family compared to which his small family is insignificant. A renunciate’s family will be protected and looked after by God. Whereas, aspirants who still have not developed that kind of *vairagya* must remain in the family and discharge their duties as best as they can, surrendering everything to God.

A bad thing can be abandoned for the sake of the good, can it not? Is it not for the good of our body that we kill a

harmful insect? We kill the worms and other parasites in our body. Do you think that it is a sin to kill an extremely poisonous snake? We destroy certain things for our own good and certain other things for the common good. When a true spiritual seeker gives up his family, he is doing that for the common good. One who is attached to the family and other external things cannot serve or love the world selflessly. Only if one is completely free from all kinds of attachments can he do so. Even though attachment and detachment are mental, in the beginning it is good to keep away from circumstances and objects which might do harm to the *sadhak*.

Family members will not die because renunciates have abandoned them for the sake of God. They will live on. Certainly there are many who have experienced this and survived.

When Rama Tirtha was about to leave his hearth and home, his wife said, "I am also coming." At that time, he said, "All right, I will take you with me, but you must fulfill three conditions. First of all, you should consider your husband as dead." "Agreed," replied the wife. "Secondly, take all your children to the market place and openly declare that these children are God's, not yours." With that she could not agree. "Then how can I take you?" he remarked as he left. He did not even have to state the third condition. However much they may try, mothers cannot develop such an attitude of detachment towards their children.

All of a sudden, Mother went into *samadhi*.

Question: So then, is it not necessary to perform one's dharma?

The Holy Mother, who was in an abstracted mood, did not reply. The questioner sat gazing at the Mother's face.

Some time passed and the Mother opened Her eyes. She understood that he had something to ask.

Amma: What, son?

Question: Don't those who become *sannyasins* without looking after their family need to perform any family duties?

Amma: Son, as Mother has stated before, everything depends on one's mental maturity. *Sannyasa* is not merely clothing oneself in ochre cloth. A real *sannyasin* is one who completely eradicates his *vasanas*. This means that he has no selfish motives at all. He no longer has duties towards his family or his relatives. Only one who has reached that state of selflessness is a real *sannyasin*. One who has attachment to the family is not a *sannyasin*. He must perform his worldly duties, surrendering his feeling of "I" and "mine" to the Supreme. This will enable him to exhaust the old tendencies and no new tendencies will be created. If one has burning *vairagya* to realize God, then he can free himself from the family bondages. In his case, this will happen spontaneously. It cannot be otherwise.

Question: Then one can run away when *vairagya* comes, can't he?

Amma: It is not something which comes one fine morning. In a few it may manifest spontaneously during the early period of their lives, in their youth, but this is very rare. In others, it will take some time. This can also happen when one meets a *Satguru*. By the mere touch, look or *sankalpa* this dormant *vairagya* will awaken. It is not a running away; it just happens. It will become difficult for them to be in the house henceforth. There is no sin in it.

Did Acharya Sankara remain with his mother out of concern for her welfare? They had no wealth or riches. Everything had been given away in charity. Yet Sankara left and took *sannyasa*. But didn't she get everything? She continued to live and got Liberation in the end too.

The mind should be made ochre. The color of ochre clothes is that of fire, which means the body should be burnt in the Fire of Knowledge. The body is the product of the ego. When the ego is gone, then you become a real *sannyasin*. But *sannyasins* of today are like *marambu* (a kind of wild yam) which closely resembles *chembu* (a kind of tuber). When *marambu* is pulled out, there will not be any roots. Likewise, today *sannyasins* have ochre clothes externally but no spiritual stuff within.

Question: But Mother, Acharya Sankara⁴ left with the permission and blessings of his mother, didn't he?

Amma: But how did he get the permission? He had to play a good trick. She might have been afraid that the same or a similar incident might happen again if she didn't allow him to take *sannyasa*. Anyhow, Sankara's mother was not like other mothers. She was a highly spiritual woman. After hearing all this, householders should not leave their homes in the name of *sannyasa*. You must truly have intense *vairagya*. Simply imitating will not work.

Question: What if permission is not given?

Amma: (Smilingly) That doesn't matter. If *vairagya* comes, you can go, that is it. Anyhow, which mother will agree to her son's taking *sannyasa*?

Devotee: So then, does Mother say that there is no sin at all if one abandons his family?

⁴ Acharya Sankara was a great philosopher-sage and exponent of the Advaita philosophy who lived in the eighth century in India. At the age of eight he tricked his mother into allowing him to become a *sannyasin*. He created an illusory crocodile through his mystical powers which seized him while he was bathing in the river. He then appealed to his mother to allow him to become a monk at least during his last moments. As soon as she agreed, the crocodile disappeared.

Amma: Yes, if there is real *vairagya*, one can leave the family. Many of the disciples of Sri Ramakrishna did so. There were other people also who came to him after abandoning their wife and children. He made them stay with him. Their family continued living; none of them died heartbroken. If such people have enough wealth for their family to live, then there is no problem. What Mother says is that even if there is not enough wealth, if one has real *vairagya*, no burden of sin will be incurred if he takes *sannyasa*, leaving everything.

Another devotee: Mother, is it beneficial to chant mantras even without knowing the meaning?

Amma: Son, just as one falls asleep if one takes sleeping pills even without knowing that they are sleeping pills, if you chant your mantra without knowing its meaning, it has its own power. Even then, it is better if it is chanted with *sraddha* (faith) and love. Concentration also is necessary. A mantra will have a special power if it is received from a *Satguru*, rather than choosing it oneself.

Once you get into a bus or train, it will take you to the destination even if you don't know who the driver is or which company manufactured the bus or train or from where the spare parts are available. It will drop you at the nearest bus or railway station and from there it will be only a short distance to your home. Similarly, a mantra will carry you to the threshold of God-Realization. From there, you can easily reach the Ultimate Goal.

Question: Mother, you said that a mantra received from a *Satguru* has a special power. How is that?

Amma: A Perfect Master can transmit a portion of his spiritual power to the disciple. That is what he does when he initiates a disciple. There is a natural way to make curd (yogurt). Take the culture and add it to milk and keep it still for a day. Within one day the milk will be transformed into pure curd.

Likewise, during initiation a real Master transfers a part of his spiritual power through his purified vital force into the disciple. In fact, the Master awakens the spiritual energy dormant in the disciple when he initiates him. Just as milk turns into curd when a little bit of buttermilk is added to it and allowed to set by keeping it still, the disciple through constant spiritual practice can fully develop this pure vital energy or spiritual power transmitted by the Guru into Pure Essence. He should still his mind through *sadhana*. The Guru always does this transmission of power only after understanding the competency of the student. This understanding includes knowing the spiritual disposition which the student has inherited from the previous birth.

When the Guru initiates the disciple, he sows the seed of spirituality. Just as we create favorable circumstances necessary for the germination and growth of the seed, we must take necessary steps for the strong growth of this spiritual seed sowed by the Guru in us.

Receiving a mantra from a *Satguru* can also be compared to the transplanting of a wild plant from the forest to the cultivated countryside. The Guru does that, the transplanting of our mind from the material world to the spiritual world.

It was time for the evening *bhajan* which began at six-thirty.

*Give me refuge, O Goddess, give me refuge,
O Mother, O Thou Whose divine form is being
Praised by the celestials. Salutations to Thee,
The Primal Supreme Energy!*

*Salutations to Mother Who is the Cause of
All auspiciousness, Fulfiller of all desires,
Perfection Itself, and the Source of Nature Herself.*

*Thou art the Cause of creation, sustenance
And destruction. Thou art the Destroyer
Of the wicked. I bow to Thy Feet Who art
Of the form of Pure Existence and Awareness.*

The Mother sang until eight-thirty after which the *arati* was performed just before nine. Afterwards, the Mother remained seated and the group of devotees one by one came and sat around Her.

Amma: The trinity -- Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshwara -- create, sustain and destroy desires; whereas, human beings create and nourish desires but do not destroy them. Destruction of desires is what is needed. Absence of that is the cause of all our troubles.

Mother doesn't say that you should not have any desires at all. Without desire, life is impossible. But never let desire control and enslave you. Desires should be under your control.

Question: Mother, is there a God separate from us?

Amma: Even though it is commonly said that God is within us, there is an Infinite Power which exists independent of and transcending every created thing. That Power is God and It is unique. That exists as the source and support of even a Liberated Soul. Which came first, the coconut or the coconut tree? The problem is unsolvable unless one accepts a creative Cause preceding Creation as its Source. That Transcendent Cause is God.

Question: Mother, just see how much this world has degenerated!

Amma: Son, do not look at the world. Look within your own self and remove the impurities from your mind. Practice seeing only the good in others. When all the impurities are removed from your mind, then you will be able to help make

others good. Whereas, if you go on blaming the world and finding fault with others, your own mind will become degenerated and you will also become like them. If we try to make the world good before becoming good ourselves, that will do harm both to us and the world. Only one who has studied can teach others; only one who is rich can help others financially; only one who has accumulated can give and only one who is completely freed from sorrow and impurities can free others from sorrow and make them pure.

If you know your own Self, the world will become your wealth, but to know the Self needs constant practice. Mother sees only the Pure Essence in you. One can become like that through practice. When a blacksmith sees a piece of iron, he will not care about the rust covering it. He will think of the object he can make out of the iron after removing the rust. A sculptor, when he sees a rock, thinks of the form he can carve out of it. He does not pay any attention to the moss on the rock. In a similar manner, we should see only the good in others.

Question: Mother, can householders attain Liberation?

Amma: Yes, but they must be real *grahasthashramis*. Living in the house, they must live like Ashramites. That is real *grahasthashrama*. While remaining in the house, they should live for God. It is possible to carry on a spiritual life while living in the world. The one condition is that one must perform actions selflessly without any attachment. One should not worry about the past or the future. Live in the present, surrendering your actions and their fruit at the Feet of the Lord. Perform your duties as sincerely as possible, keeping in mind that all is entrusted by God. Be satisfied with whatever is provided by the Supreme. Anyhow, when we act with an attitude of surrender and devotion, it will bear the best fruit. But do not confuse your mind thinking of the fruit. If you perform your

duties in the present, sincerely and wholeheartedly, considering it as your duty entrusted by God, then the future will become your friend. Live today with dedication, then tomorrow will be your friend. Get rid of “I” and “mine” and consider everything as God’s.

Question: Mother, who is a real Guru?

Amma: A real Guru is one who kindles and sustains the Light of Knowledge or spirituality in the disciple, destroying ignorance. A genuine Master always works with the *vasanas* of the disciples. He makes the disciple realize his negativities and helps him to eliminate them. A true Master never gives importance to *siddhis*. He has all the powers needed under his sway. Even then, he will always remain simple and humble. A true Master is a Self-Realized Soul. One can see and experience all the eternal virtues like universal love, renunciation, patience, forbearance, endurance, etc., in him. He will have equal vision and perfect balance of mind in all circumstances. There will not be even an iota of selfishness in him. He will have no desires except the good and well-being of the entire creation. He will neither find fault with others nor will he criticize anyone. Peace and tranquillity are his nature. Anger can never overpower him. If you see him get angry, that will only be for correcting and guiding others. His anger is another expression of his love. Such a Master’s anger is like a burnt shell. The burnt shell will have the shape of a shell but it will disappear if tapped with a little force. The real Master will appear to be angry but that is only an external show. His mind will not be affected by it.

Question: Mother, what are the signs of a true *Guru-sishya* (Master-disciple) relationship?

Amma: In a genuine *Guru-sishya* relationship, it will be difficult to recognize who is who because the Guru will have more of a servant-like attitude than the disciple. The Guru

will have the attitude to transform the disciple by every possible means. The Guru will watch each and every action of the disciple, but the disciple will not understand this. In a true *Guru-sishya* relationship, the Guru will have tremendous patience. Even if the disciple commits serious errors, the Guru will patiently forbear and will give opportunity after opportunity for the *sishya* to correct himself and become flawless. A real Guru will be like a true mother and a true father to the disciple. That means not only will he love the disciple selflessly and wholeheartedly, but at the same time, he will also be a good disciplinarian.

On the other hand, the disciple will serve the Guru with the attitude that the Guru should not even know that he is serving him. That is the duty of a true disciple. *Seva* or service means obedience. Obedience means self-surrender. Self-surrender means giving up one's own ego, the feeling that "I am doing and I must get the fruit of it." A true disciple will be ready to sacrifice all his comforts and even his body to serve the Guru. A true disciple's love towards his Master will be like the love of the Gopis towards Krishna. The disciple will have no secrets. He will be like an open book in front of the Master. He will always have the awareness that his Guru knows everything. Therefore, he will not commit any mistakes. In such a *Guru-sishya* relationship, the Guru will be in the disciple and the disciple will be in the Guru.

A real disciple will eat and sleep only after the Guru eats and sleeps. He will get up before the Guru gets up, and having finished his nature calls, bath and other morning necessities, he will do whatever is needed for the Guru. He will never show impatience or impertinence. Humility will be his trademark. Just as water flows automatically to where the field is low, the Guru's grace will automatically flow into the disciple when he sees the disciple's movements endowed with

sraddha (faith) and *bhakti* (devotion). But today it is very difficult to find such a *Guru-sishya* relationship.

Question: Nowadays we hear about many *Avatars* (Incarnations), but the *Srimad Bhagavatam* says that there are only ten *Avatars*.

Amma: Son, nowhere is it stated that God will incarnate only during a certain time, place and in a certain form. Nobody can predict where, how or when the glory of God will assume form. All that takes place according to His Will. He can incarnate in any place at any time. He is not bound by time or place. To protect *dharma*, the unlimited and formless Supreme Being accepts different limited forms according to His own *sankalpa* and again makes them merge in His Infinite Self. This is like the waters of the ocean rising up as vapor and returning again to the ocean as rain.

Bhava Darshan

Devotee: Some devotees believe that Mother is the same during the Divine *Bhava* as She is at other times. If this is so, then what is the significance of the *Bhava*?

Amma: During the time of the *Bhava Darshan*, Mother removes two or three veils, so to say, so that the devotees can obtain a glimpse of the Supreme. Even at that time, She is manifesting only an infinitesimal part of Her spiritual power. Different people have different kinds of beliefs. Mother's intention is to somehow help the people approach God. Some are interested only if they see Mother in the costume of Devi or Krishna. Not only that, very few people know anything about spirituality. Some people find it difficult to believe Mother's words during ordinary times, but if Mother says the same thing during the Devi *Bhava*, they will believe.

Question: Mother, is there any particular time for manifesting this *Bhava*?

Amma: No, there is not. It can be manifested at any time. Mere will is enough.

Question: Mother, why do you wear the costumes of Krishna and Devi?

Amma: They help people understand what *Bhava* is. People have a special pre-conceived idea about Krishna and Devi and Their dress. For example, when we think of the form of Devi, we have in our mind Her enchanting form adorned in a beautiful sari with a golden crown, a nose-ring and other adornments. Similarly with Krishna. When one says “Devi” nobody will think of an ordinary girl. There must be a distinctive quality in the manner of dress. This is what Mother is trying to do. By planting the impression of Devi in the minds of the devotees, Mother is trying to help them to make their faith stronger in order to grow spiritually. By wearing those beautiful saris, Mother makes the *Darshan* more picturesque and thereby instills greater life into the devotees’ *bhavana* (attitude). Son, each attire is important in its own way. We were naked when we were born. Later, according to the country and social custom, people adopted different kinds of dress. Whatever is the dress, the person is the same. In this age people give much importance to dress. Mother will make this point clear through an anecdote.

One man was cutting down a tree which was growing by the side of the road. Another man who happened to see him doing this said, “Don’t cut down the tree! It is wrong to do so, it is against the law.” The first man not only refused to stop but also scolded the other severely. The person who tried to prevent the ruffian from cutting the tree was a policeman. He departed but soon returned in his official dress. Even from a distance, the mere sight of the policeman’s cap was enough to

make the hooligan flee without looking back. See the difference in the impact created when the policeman came in ordinary dress and later in official dress! Therefore, special attire is needed to teach ignorant people. Likewise, the costumes of Krishna and Devi *Bhavas*. Some people who still feel dissatisfied even after talking to Mother for hours, will feel fully content after conversing with Her for only a couple of seconds during *Bhava Darshan*. They feel peaceful after having told all their worries directly to God. The special dress during the *Bhavas* also helps the devotees to keep the remembrance of the Presence of God. The costumes create a feeling of divine beauty in the minds of the devotees. Beauty is the nature of God, is it not?

Another devotee: Mother, what is the particular speciality of the Krishna *Bhava*?

Amma: Krishna *Bhava* is the manifestation of the *Purusha* or Pure Being aspect. There is no difference between Vishnu who incarnated as Krishna and the Krishna during Krishna *Bhava*. Devi *Bhava* is the Eternal Feminine, the Creatrix, the Active Principle of the Impersonal Absolute. All the deities of the Hindu Pantheon, which represent the numberless aspects of the One Supreme Being, exist within us. One possessing Divine Power can manifest any of them by his mere will for the good of the world. Here is a crazy girl who puts on the garb of Krishna and after some time that of Devi, but it is within this crazy girl that both exist.

Why decorate an elephant? Why should a lawyer wear a black coat or why does a policeman wear a uniform and a cap? All these external aids are meant to create a certain impression. In a like manner, Mother dons the garb of Krishna and Devi in order to give strength to the devotional attitude of the people coming for *Darshan*. The Atman or Self that is

in me is also within you. If you realize that Indivisible Principle that is ever shining in you, you will also become That.

Question: Should something be done to make Mother known to the world?

Amma: Children, know that Mother is the Truth. Mother needs no propaganda. Does the ever-radiant AUM need any propaganda? Those who have purity of heart and thirst for God will seek out Mother and reach Her.

At nearly eleven o'clock in the night, the Holy Mother got up from Her seat. One devotee said, "You were so gracious to us; you gave a lot more than we deserve."

Amma: (In an excited tone) Oh, what a pity! I am a cruel Mother, none of my children have eaten.

She called aloud "Balu!" He responded to Her call and immediately rushed to the Mother's side. The Holy Mother said, "You know that I am crazy. You should have reminded me about feeding these children!" Balu replied, "Mother, nobody has eaten. Amma said, "Alas, what a pity. I am so crazy that I forget everything. Hurry up, go and get some bananas." Balu brought some bananas and the Mother fed the devotees with the bananas with Her own hands. The devotees said, "Now Mother, we need your permission to leave."

Amma: Now, tonight? So late? You have not eaten anything except a few pieces of banana.

Devotee: We are full, and especially being fed by your hands, we are completely satisfied. We came by car and tomorrow all of us have to go to work.

Amma: No...no...no, don't go today, you can go early in the morning. Have a good rest and go.

Without saying another word, the Holy Mother left. The devotees were in a dilemma. They looked at each other, and one man said, "The van has to be returned; otherwise, we will have to pay more." Another one said, "Anyhow, it is only a two-hour journey, so let us go." The devotee who had asked most of the questions to the Holy Mother remarked, "If we go, we will be disobeying Mother's words." After a few minutes of discussion, the devotee who asked the questions turned towards Balu who was standing nearby and said, "Please tell the Mother that we had no other choice but to go, and therefore, we left." Balu did not reply as he felt that to do so would be indirectly supporting their wish to go and thereby disobey Mother's words. Even then, they all left within a few minutes.

29 November 1983

The next morning the Holy Mother was sitting in the coconut grove deeply absorbed in meditation. It was eight o'clock and the group of householder devotees who had left the night before against the Holy Mother's wishes entered the Ashram premises. They all seemed very tired and exhausted due to lack of sleep. Seeing the Mother sitting in the coconut grove, they felt more relaxed and related the previous night's adventure to Balu who was standing nearby.

Devotee: Without heeding Mother's words, we left the Ashram and reached the other side of the backwaters around midnight. We asked the driver of the van whether he felt too sleepy or tired to drive but he replied in the negative. Even then, we made him drink some strong tea from a tea stall in the village while going. While proceeding along, all of us without exception fell asleep, even the person who was entrusted with the duty of making sure that the driver did not fall asleep.

One hour or so must have passed when we were suddenly awakened by a deafening sound and a violent jolt. We found to our surprise that the driver had fallen asleep while driving and had crashed into a tree by the side of the road. The front of the van was completely destroyed but none of us got even so much as a scratch. Had the van missed the tree, it would have gone tumbling into a deep ditch by the side of the road. Even though we had disobeyed Mother, She compassionately protected us from a serious accident.

The place of the accident was far away from any houses or shops and it was past one a.m. Although we tried to flag down passing vehicles, none would stop. We simply waited there until five-thirty this morning when someone at last stopped and enquired whether we needed any help. Having reached the next town in his car, we hired another van and returned to the scene of the accident. After talking amongst ourselves, we decided to return to the Ashram to seek Mother's pardon for our disobedience. We have learned a bitter lesson.

After a few minutes, Mother opened Her eyes. As the devotees approached Her, She jocularly remarked,

Amma: My children have learned a good lesson just like the disobedient little goat in the story.⁵

All of them fell at Mother's feet offering their apologies for having gone against Her wishes.

Amma: Children, always remember that when Mother says something it should not be taken lightly. It is the Supreme

⁵ Once there was a little goat who was advised by his parents not to go to a certain pasture to graze as a wolf residing there would eat him. In spite of their advice, the little goat did go there and was eaten by the wolf.

that makes Her speak. Whatever She says must come to pass either in the near or distant future because Her words are not Her own but are that of the Lord.

After giving the devotees a few more words of consolation, the Mother remained silent. After prostrating to Her, all of them left the Ashram by nine o'clock.

After they left, the Mother went into the meditation hall where the *brahmacharins* were meditating. She sat there observing their meditation. Soon after that the Mother went to the kitchen and stayed there for a few minutes. She said to the *brahmacharinis* who were cooking lunch,

Amma: Do you repeat your mantra while cooking? It doesn't seem so. It will be good if you can write on a piece of paper, "Do not forget to repeat your mantra while at work!" and paste it in a place where you can easily see it. That will be a good reminder.

So saying, She left the kitchen and went to the cowshed where She found that the cows had not yet been brought out and were standing in the midst of cow dung. Without uttering a word, She untied all the cows and brought them to the open space and tied them to different trees. Having done that, She was about to clean the cowshed when the *brahmacharin* who was entrusted to do that work came to the spot. He rushed forward to prevent Mother from doing it, saying, "Mother, I am going to do it. Everyday I do it before meditation. Today I got up late and wanted to make up the lost time. Therefore, I went to meditate before doing this work. Mother, please give me the shovel; I will do it."

Amma: Son, Mother does not consider that a good excuse. A *sadhak* should consider each and every work that he undertakes to be *sadhana*, a means to purify his heart. If it were you,

would you lie down in the midst of your excreta? No! These beings, though unable to speak, still have their own pleasures and pains. We human beings, who have understanding and discrimination, should be able to know their feelings. Service is not only serving humans but also creatures, especially cows.

The *brahmacharin* apologized and promised that he would not fail to do the work again.

Then a householder devotee from Kottayam came with his wife and children to see the Mother. Another devotee, an LIC (Life Insurance Corporation of India) officer, also came with them. Seeing them, the Mother smilingly said, “These children here are very fond of hearing Mother’s scolding. They say that Mother’s scolding is sweeter than Her love.”

As he prostrated, the devotee said, “That is true, Mother. A Guru’s manner of disciplining is another facet of his love.”

The Holy Mother, along with the devotees, went and sat on the sand near the backwaters. The morning *puja* was going on in the temple. The chanting of the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother was just over and the *arati* was being performed. The sound of the bell echoed in the silent, quiet atmosphere.

The householder devotee: This sound of the bell has a special effect, especially in a silent atmosphere, hasn’t it, Mother?

Amma: That is true. When a bell made of bronze is rung, it creates a special vibration. That sound is closely associated with the human mind and impulses (nervous system). In classical Indian music there are many *ragas* (tunes), aren’t there? Each tune, when produced in the proper way, creates a certain mood or vibration in our mind. For example, there are *ragas* which can create a sorrowful feeling; there are *ragas* which can create a happy feeling. Those are based on the principles of sound. Sound is vibration, and different rates of

vibration affect the human mind and impulses, creating different moods within us.

Question: Mother, I am not getting good concentration in meditation.

Amma: (Smilingly) Son, constant practice is needed. Without this, concentration is difficult to attain. It is not something which you can gain in a day or two. We have been living on the material plane for a long time. *Sadhana* is not necessary if we are constantly aware of the Supreme Principle, but we are not so aware. It has been our habit to think and act any way we like. We never try to discriminate or control ourselves. Now when we try to control our mind and fix it on a certain point, all those past experiences and habits will rise and trouble us. Habits are very strong.

Suppose we have a wristwatch that we wear all the time. It is always on the wrist but one day we sell it. For a few days afterwards, we will continue to look at our wrist to see the time. This is the nature of habit. If this is the case with ordinary and seemingly insignificant habits, what to say of the stronger ones? When we try to change them, our mind will spontaneously turn again and again towards our habits. Only through constant practice can one get rid of them.

Question: Mother, what is real meditation?

Amma: Real meditation arises when the mind constantly flows towards the object of meditation. In that state the *sadhak*'s mind will become firmly fixed on the form of his Beloved Deity during meditation.

Meditation is not simply sitting with eyes closed. It is a state of unbroken concentration like an endless stream. At present, if somebody were to ask if we are meditating, we would say "Yes." Suppose we keep some water on the stove to make tea. If someone asks what we are doing, we would say that we are making tea. Actually, the water is only getting

heated up; it is only the beginning. We have not yet added the tea leaves, milk or sugar. Even then, we will say that we are making tea. Likewise, we say that we are meditating, but it is only the beginning. We have not yet reached the state of real meditation. We will get spiritual strength only if we still the mind, which is at present revelling on the material plane. The mind will run around when we sit idle. “Where is my child? How is my wife? Has she gone to the office?” It will wander like this. Meditation is to stop such wandering. In the beginning stages of our spiritual practice, the mind may continue to roam about. This can be stopped only through constant and determined practice.

Children, you have been discriminating between the eternal and the non-eternal for a long time. God alone is eternal. Our life’s goal is to attain Him. Son, you should not forget this.

Question: Mother, can one attain God by merely chanting the Divine Name?

Amma: Certainly, why doubt? But concentration is a must. *Kirtan* (singing the Divine Name) is the best way for householders. Having closed the door, one should imagine that one’s Beloved Deity is standing everywhere in the room. Then one should pray thus, “O Lord, are You not seeing me? O God, please take me on Your lap. I am Your child. I have no one but You as my refuge. Do not abandon me but always dwell in my heart.” Surrender all that we have to *Bhagavan* (the Lord). We will go to the railway station when we travel, carrying heavy loads. After getting into the train, we do not continue to carry the luggage on our head. Having unloaded it, we comfortably sit in our seat, don’t we? Once faith in God arises, then surrender everything at His Feet. We should live with the attitude that He will protect us. Everything is His, nothing is mine, He will take care of everything. We have to

think this way. A real parent is one who can create children and save them from death. Are we able to create children? If we can, then we should be able to bring back to life those children who die. But, of course, we cannot. Only God is the Giver of life and Creator of the world and all its beings. Therefore, the real father and mother is God. Others are only foster parents.

We have no control over the things or objects that we claim as ours. We have no control even over our own body or existence. Then what can we say about other things? How can we say that a thing which is not under our control is ours? Neither the creation of an object nor its sustenance or destruction is in our hands. Yet, foolishly we think that it is ours. Therefore, dedicate everything to God. We should always feel, “O Lord, I am just a puppet in Your hands. You are the one who gives me power. Even a blade of grass will not move without Your Power.” We should pray with longing, “O Lord, where are You, where are You? Wash away my ignorance. Wash away my ego.”

Question: Mother, epics like *Ramayana* and *Srimad Bhagavatam* say that the Divine Name has a power of its own, but Mother says that concentration is very important. I find these to be contradictory ideas.

Amma: Of course, the Lord’s Name has power. But for everything there must be *bhavana* (correct attitude) or *bhava* (feeling or mood). That is the same as concentration. For example, when a musician sings without feeling, the singing will have no appeal. Feeling comes only when there is *bhakti* or devotion. *Bhakti* towards an object or towards the work that we are doing is important. This feeling comes only when one does the work with concentration. It is a feeling of oneness, of merging in the work. In the same way, although God’s Name

has a power of Its own, when we chant It with *bhava* or concentration, It becomes more powerful.

Many parents name their children Krishna, Rama, Govinda and other names of God. Everyday they call their children by their names a hundred times, but are they getting Liberation or the Vision of God? The *tattwa* (the real principle) behind the Names should be properly understood.

This is the Dark Age of Materialism (*Kali Yuga*). In this age there is a lot of chaos and confusion. Meditation, being very subtle, is difficult to practice. The atmosphere is completely polluted with negative sounds and vibrations. Human minds have become very gross. No one has self-control. Most people think only of objects that will give pleasure. They only think of the body. Since people's minds are very gross, practicing self-control through singing and doing worship is much easier than through meditation, which is subtle. To remove a thorn we need another thorn. Likewise, to overcome the negative sound vibrations we need another sound. That sound is the Divine Name.

There are quite a lot of soot-like stains in our mind. All of that will get washed away when we chant the Divine Name. "You are the All, I am nothing." We should have that kind of love. Otherwise, concentration will not be attained. Son, householders should observe a vow of silence once a week. They should try to get up early in the morning. It is good if they have a regular routine. That will help them to discipline themselves. Until yesterday you were leading a life devoid of spiritual ideals. To get rid of the old habits and replace them with new ones, a regular timetable will be very helpful.

In the beginning you must have love for your daily routine. If you are unable to meditate, try to repeat your mantra. If you find that also to be difficult, then do *pūja* or sing the Divine Names. In whatever way, we must strive hard to attain

the constant remembrance of the Supreme. Do not let the mind think unnecessary things. One should meditate by concentrating one's mind on the form of one's Beloved Deity. It is enough to meditate on the feet if it is difficult to meditate on the full form. It is good if meditation is done in dim light. Outside light is a disturbance when we are trying to illuminate our interior.

One should sit gazing at the Beloved Deity's form for two minutes. Then having closed the eyes, visualize the Beloved Deity's form in the heart-lotus. When the form fades away from the heart, one should again gaze at the picture. Though the picture is made of paper and ink, one should imagine that it has consciousness (life). We can attain the Real only through the unreal. Because we are in the unreal, we forget about the Real. We should remember the Real through the man-made picture.

One should cry to God calling thus, "O Mother, where are You? Why did You leave me alone in this forest of materialism? Look, the ferocious animals of lust and anger are coming to eat me. O Mother, take me. Keep me on Your lap. Your lap alone is the safest place for me. Save me from these animals. O Mother, where are You, where are You?"

Our longing to see God should be like the intense desire that we would have to escape if someone were coming to kill us. Our painful longing to see God should be like the pain we would have while dying in the midst of a blazing fire. That much longing should there be to see God. If you are unable to call God the whole day, try at least until noon. You children should find the patience to do this as well.

Question: Is it enough to call God when one is afflicted by some disease or should we go to the hospital?

Amma: Son, human effort and God's grace are both necessary. The Ancients have said, "Half by man, half by God."

Self-effort is man's half and grace is God's half; yet, without His grace, nothing is possible in spite of efforts put forth. God and medicine, both are needed. Otherwise, why did the Lord Himself incarnate in ancient times as Dhanvantari, the Divine Physician? A doctor should be consulted if one becomes sick. We should pray to God for the medicine to be effective. Do not dissipate your power by grieving. It will be beneficial if you pray to God when you are afflicted. The Lord will do what is necessary; He will certainly do it.

The Holy Mother stopped for a while and sat with Her eyes closed. It seemed that She was immersed in Her own world. There was a feeling of utter peace and everyone spontaneously slipped into meditation. Nearly fifteen minutes passed by, after which the Mother slowly opened Her eyes. She was still in the same mood.

Nealu brought a cassette tape and played Swami Avadhutendra's "Hare Rama" *bhajan*. A few minutes went by as the devotees sat gazing at the Holy Mother's radiant face. The Mother was slowly swaying back and forth. Nealu turned down the volume of the *bhajan* cassette.

Question: Human beings cannot live without expectations but the scriptures say that one should not have any. How can one reconcile both these facts?

Amma: Children, as you know, the desire for happiness will always cause sorrow. It is better if one can transcend both happiness and sorrow. That means to accept them both equally, understanding this to be the nature of life. For ordinary human beings there is no harm in having desires or expectations. But that is not the problem. We are attached to our expectations. That is what brings sorrow. "I expect something" means it is not yet fulfilled, it is in the future. Something in the future can either be fulfilled or can remain

unfulfilled, isn't that true? Therefore, always expect that it can either be fulfilled or can remain unfulfilled. That is it. Be aware that something may or may not happen. Take it to be God's Will. There ends the problem.

There should be *sraddha* (care or attention) in every action of ours. We should imagine that we are removing the stains of our mind while washing clothes and bathing our Beloved Deity while giving a bath to our child. While walking, imagine that the Lord is walking beside you and sitting near you as you eat. Thus we should try to develop the habit of remembering God while doing our work.

Suppose we used to keep the key to the safe in a particular place in the house. We kept it there for a long time. One day we move it to another place. But due to our habit we will look for the key in the original place, even though it has been removed from there. Such is the nature of habits. Habits are very strong, whether good or bad. If we develop good habits, then it will become difficult for us to think or do wrong actions. Even if we want to do evil, good habits will prevent us from doing so. First of all, we must build up a good character. Good thoughts will help us to develop good qualities.

Question: But Mother, the mind is the thing that should be eliminated, shouldn't it?

Amma: Son, the mind is nothing but thoughts. Thoughts, when intense, become actions. Actions, when repeated, become habits. Habits form character. Therefore, to get rid of the mind, first we should change the quality of our thoughts. Good thoughts are useful to fix the mind always on God. Bad thoughts should be replaced with thoughts of the Divine.

Suppose there is some red-colored water in a vessel. If you go on adding fresh water to it, the red color will slowly become less until at last it completely disappears. Likewise, all bad thoughts can be gotten rid of by cultivating and devel-

oping good thoughts. In due course, all thoughts should be eliminated by fixing the mind on the Name or form of God. That Name or form will also have to be transcended in order to reach the Final State. The elimination of thoughts is equal to the elimination of the mind because the mind is nothing but a constant flow of thoughts. We will gain Perfection soon if our *sankalpa* (intention) is to attain the Ultimate Goal.

Suppose a thought arises in our mind to build a house. We will always be daydreaming about it. We will go on thinking about where it should be, how it should look and so on. At first we will build the house through our *bhavana* (imagination) and then later we will really build it. Similarly, constant *bhavana* about God will take us to God. We should pray to *Bhagavan*, “O Lord, please don’t let my mind go to the *vyavahara* (empirical plane). Please take my mind to the heights of God-consciousness.” As we rise higher, the things below will become smaller and smaller. When we rise still higher, everything will be seen as one Unity. Those who have reached the heights are able to see everything as One. The diversities of the world will not affect them. Our mind becomes more expansive as we rise higher.

Do not do *sadhana* with the intention of making it known to others or to please them. We don’t stop brushing our teeth, taking a shower or eating food because those are necessities. In the same way, we should remember that *sadhana* is also necessary for us every day. We will stink if we do not take a bath and brush our teeth. It will be troublesome for others also. We should understand that refraining from doing *sadhana* is as harmful as this. *Sadhana* should become a part of our life.

One-pointedness and concentration

As the Holy Mother was sitting conversing with the devotees, one *brahmacharin* came holding a hose to water the plants. However, the water pressure was very little. Mother looked at it and noticed that there were many holes in the hose through which the water was leaking out. Pointing to the hose She said,

Amma: Look at that, children. Because there are holes in the hose, the water is not coming out properly. Likewise, progress will not be gained in meditation if the mind is dissipated through worldly thoughts. At present, whatever spiritual power is gained through meditation and other spiritual practices gets dissipated through indulgence. It is like drawing water from a well in a bucket full of holes. All the water will leak out by the time the bucket reaches the top of the well. As we do spiritual practice, we should take care to control the urge for worldly pleasures. That Supreme Effulgence can be known through intuitive experience only if the mind is made one-pointed without sending it out to the world. Meditation can be done while fixing the mind either between the eyebrows or in the heart. If someone has no faith in God or in a form of God, they can make their mind one-pointed by fixing it on a point or on any part of their own body. One should continue doing meditation with the conviction that one's Beloved Deity is in one's own heart.

One may get a headache and pain in the eyes if one meditates on the spot between the eyebrows. Insomnia also may occur. If so, meditation should be stopped temporarily. If restlessness occurs, then it is best to meditate in the heart. In the beginning it is better to meditate in the heart. After having the feeling that the heart is full, it is not so dangerous if meditation is shifted to the spot between the eyebrows. In any case, it is best

for householders to meditate in the heart. One will feel a cooling effect by meditating in the heart, whereas heat is experienced if one meditates between the eyebrows.

Question: How should one meditate upon *Bhagavan's* form?

Amma: You should imagine that you are offering flowers at His Feet. When the form fades away, you should imagine that you are mentally embracing the Feet saying, “Father, why are You going away leaving me alone?” Mentally write “OM” at His Feet. Otherwise, repeat your mantra and imagine binding the Beloved Deity from toe to head with the rope of *japa*. Then, imagine that you are undoing this rope. This should be repeated whenever the form fades away. Imagining that the Beloved Deity is standing in front of you, try to see each and every part of the Lord’s body. Imagine that you are bathing Him with different things like rose water, coconut water, milk, yogurt, flowers and sacred ash. Adorn His head with a golden crown and put garlands on His neck. Mentally decorate Him with bangles and anklets. Just as the image is decorated in temples, we should adorn our own Beloved Deity. If your Beloved Deity is Devi (the Divine Mother), you should adorn Her with a crown, nose ring, necklaces and other ornaments. She should be dressed in silk clothes. If you do this, the Beloved Deity’s form will not escape from your mind. The mind will not get a chance to think about other things. All other thoughts will be restrained. Thus it will become possible to consistently meditate on the Lord’s form.

Children, do not forget to always repeat your mantra. In the beginning *japa* should be done in a low voice. Later it can be done moving the lips slightly. Finally it should be done mentally. Thus *japa* should be practiced constantly with each breath. Then *japa* will go on even if we don’t attend to it, even in sleep.

While walking, imagine that the Beloved Deity is walking by our side and that we are conversing with Him. While riding in a bus, gaze at the sky and imagine that our Beloved Deity is travelling along with us through the sky. If travelling by boat, visualize the Beloved Deity sitting in a fully blossomed lotus on the water. If sitting alone, imagine that the enchanting form of our Beloved Deity is standing at a distance. Through *bhavana* we should have the feeling that the Lord is always standing near us whatever work we may be doing. While blowing into the oven to kindle the fire, visualize the effulgent form of the Beloved Deity standing in the fire and blow at His Feet. In this way the mind will merge in the Supreme State through constant practice and our efforts will bear fruit.

Thus when we practice with constant remembrance of our Beloved Deity, we can keep the enchanting form of the Lord shining in our heart lotus. Retention of breath (*kumbhaka*) happens spontaneously when perfect concentration is achieved through ceaseless devotion just as it is achieved through the practice of *pranayama*. The path of devotion is enough. You children should not practice *pranayama*. If you do so without proper guidance, it will be like one who comes to get rid of madness and instead becomes even crazier! If you want to practice *pranayama*, a *Satguru*'s presence and instructions are absolutely necessary. It is dangerous if one practices *pranayama* merely from books. One may get constant headaches and pus may even come out of the nostrils; whatever is eaten will not be digested and will be expelled with the feces.

There are people who follow the path of knowledge. They say, "I am a *Jnani*," (a follower of the path of knowledge) and other similar expressions, but their way of living will be just the opposite of a real *Jnani*. *Bhakti* is not different from *jnana*. Real devotion is itself wisdom. One should put medicine on

a cut only after cleansing the wound with disinfectant. Otherwise, it will get infected and become a serious wound. Likewise, having destroyed the ego through devotion, wisdom should be established. Apply the medicine of *jnana* after cleaning the mind with the disinfectant of *bhakti*. Only then will there be true wisdom.

Question: Mother, how can one tame the mind?

Amma: Children, that is the most difficult thing in the world. It may be possible to catch the wind with one's hand or to swim across the ocean, but to control the mind is impossible unless one is strongly determined to do so.

In the beginning, the mind will not be inclined towards meditation. It should be subjugated very tactfully. You will not be able to catch a chicken if you run behind it but it will come if you call it after putting its food nearby. In the same manner, do not run after the mind to control it. By slowly questioning and tactfully instructing it, you can get it in your hands. Ask the mind, "O mind, why are you running after these objects? Are you getting any benefit from them? Don't you know that these things are ever-changing?" Thus, the mind should be tamed and eventually directed away from the world of matter to the world of Spirit. Having been distracted by sensual pleasures for a long time, it will not easily yield to Godly thoughts. Children, don't feel dejected, thinking that you have become a slave to the *vasanas*. Unknowingly we happened to become attached to this world. There will be no problem if we live knowing that God alone is our real relative. Whatever mistakes have been committed in the past owing to ignorance will be pardoned. But once you come to know the right from the wrong, you should try your best to refrain from making mistakes in the future.

Wife and children are only like those whom we meet at the bus stop. All fellow travellers who showed so much love

to us will alight and say good-bye at their respective destinations. Your wife, children and all your kith and kin will depart when the time comes. You will remain alone in the end. When we confront the problems of life, we are always alone.

In the olden days even if the husband happened to abandon the wife, she would continue to live, meditating on him always. Such was the case with Rama and Sita, Nala and Damayanti. What about today? If the wife is abandoned by her husband, her next thought is how to kill him. She may even re-marry and proudly walk in front of her former husband with her second husband. Therefore, this is not real love at all. Our own real nature, the Self alone, is our true friend. Somehow due to the fruit of past actions, we happened to come in contact with the world. There is no sense in being miserable about it.

We should live in this world knowing that we are only an instrument in the hands of God and with the faith that He is guiding us. We should try to confront life's problems courageously by thinking, "Nothing can defeat or enslave me. I am God's child." Do not try to run away from the problems. That will only give them more strength to overcome you.

Question: Mother, how should one keep good relations with one's wife and children and with other family members?

Amma: Do not make the wife and children suffer unnecessarily. If their characters are not good, do not dissipate your energy worrying about them. Worrying is not a solution to any problem; it will only make things worse. Discriminative thinking is the only way to overcome life's problems. When we worry, our power of discrimination becomes weak, and then even insignificant problems seem overwhelming. We should pray to God to give our family right-thinking, and we should consider their association with us to be the fruit of our past actions. We will not be miserable if we spend our time in Godly

pursuits instead of worrying about our wife and children. Is it possible for us to guide them along the right path? We do not have the power to hear sounds which are beyond a certain range. We also do not have the power to see beyond a certain distance. We are bound by limitations. What can we do? "Take care of everything, O Omnipotent One. I have no power to do anything. I have nothing to say. O Lord, kindly protect us." That is how we should pray. Otherwise, one will only be wasting one's time. Our family, as well as ourselves, will be ruined. In due course, owing to our prayers, God will guide them through the right path. If the husband is the one who is creating the problems, then the wife should have the aforesaid attitude.

In many families only one partner, the husband or the wife, will be good. In such cases, if one of them has patience, forgiveness and forbearance, things can be straightened out to some extent. Children, remember that if we forgive and forget others' faults, God will forgive and forget ours. If the wife is pious and has qualities like patience, love, forbearance and forgiveness, she can also change her husband even though he is uncouth. If she has the right attitude, family life will become peaceful. If both husband and wife are obstinate and unyielding in nature, both should try to correct each other by cultivating and developing patience and forgiveness in themselves.

The family should follow a regular discipline. Try to see God in every action. People blame either God or others for their sufferings but is there really any meaning in doing so? It is our *vasanas* and attitude that are the cause of our sufferings.

Truth is God. No one except God loves us selflessly. Having closed all the doors and windows, what is the meaning of blaming the sun for not giving light? Who is responsible? Open the doors and windows and the sun's rays will enter the room. We create the veil of ignorance and then

blame God for not showering His grace upon us. He is constantly showering grace. Why should we blame God? How can we receive His grace if the mind, which is filled with selfishness, is not made expansive? We should remove the veil of ignorance through *sadhana*. He does not expect anything from us. An electric light does not need a kerosene lamp.

There is no use blaming God for our sufferings or in saying, “He created me, but did He give me anything? Doesn’t He see my suffering?” We have the wealth and property given to us by God, but now there are tenants living on the property. Some people lovingly came and asked permission to temporarily live on our land, and out of compassion for them, we agreed. But they are not vacating, even when we need the space. They are even disturbing us and making it difficult for us to live there. The tenants represent lust, greed, anger, envy, jealousy, and other negative qualities, and the place we gave is our own heart (mind). Is there any meaning in blaming God for this? Was it not we ourselves who gave them permission to live in our place? We live fixing our attention on external things. When we try to go within after understanding what the goal of life is, they come like rebellious tenants waving flags, saying “Go away.” It is we alone who give the place for sense objects in the mind where God is meant to be enshrined. Children, do not blame God for the suffering that we have to endure because of our own negative qualities. What is needed is to evict them as quickly as possible through *japa* and *dhyana*.

Question: I wish to do *sadhana* but the thoughts of the past agitate the mind and make it impossible.

Amma: Children, there will be restlessness in the beginning. That is the nature of the mind. We should try to make it one-pointed through supreme love for God. Call God by any

name. A father will caress his small child even if the child calls him “da” instead of “daddy,” for he knows that it is due to ignorance. But if the grown-up son calls “da,” the father will punish him. God will certainly pardon the mistakes which we have committed due to ignorance. The errors which we have committed until yesterday are not errors, because until that time we had no wisdom. But once we know right from wrong, God will not forgive us if we make mistakes. Therefore, children, forget everything which has happened until yesterday. Once you surrender to your Guru or God, the past is like a cancelled check. From today onwards, live with alertness and walk carefully ahead on the path. You needn’t feel sad today, thinking about the dream you had seen yesterday. Try to forget everything, considering life to be a dream. Until now, we wasted time just for a few moments of happiness followed by sorrow. However, if we merge in the Supreme Truth, we can always experience Bliss. Even if all the people in the world were to love us, even then, we would not get an infinitesimal amount of the bliss that we get from God’s Love. Try for that Eternal Bliss in the time that is remaining.

Gayatri came with a glass of tea for Mother. Having taken two or three sips, She put it down. One devotee distributed the remaining tea among the others as *prasadam*.

Question: Mother, being a college professor, I have a good circle of friends most of whom are worldly people who talk only about worldly things. How should I deal with them?

Amma: Try to talk less with them, and even then, only if necessary. When they see that you are no longer interested in the things that they are, they will slowly avoid you. Don’t think that they will get angry with you; let all of them hate you if they wish. Don’t go towards things which will again create trouble for you. You should go towards stillness. Our

time is precious. It is not to be wasted by company with others. Whatever time you have, you should be more introspective. Many of the friends come only to gossip and chat, don't they? Lovingly tell them, "We have been talking for a long time. What are we going to gain by talking about and discussing all these things? My goal is to think about God, to give solitude to the mind. You might get angry with me if you don't like it. At present, that is not a problem for me. I can move forward only if I overcome obstacles. I am not angry with you, even if you get angry with me, for I have only love for you. But now I don't have any time to waste." Saying this in a very calm and loving tone, you should withdraw into solitude. Let them love or hate you. Such control is needed in the beginning. We will become good if we make friends with a river. It will make us reach the ocean. On the other hand, if we keep company with a dirty drain, we will also produce sewage, nothing more than that. Good company is with spiritual people or aspirants and will take us to God. Bad company will make our thoughts and deeds evil. A parrot raised in a temple or church will chant God's Name; whereas a parrot raised in a liquor shop will utter only vulgar words.

If friends come, ask them to stop gossiping and give them spiritual books to read. There is also another way to get out of such situations. Visualize your Beloved Deity in the person who is talking to you. While doing so, you will not even hear what they are saying, although they will feel as if you are listening. In this way you will not be wasting any time. All these restrictions are needed for a seeker of God. We are headed for danger when we see faults in others. Children, bear all this in mind and move carefully.

The Holy Mother stopped and asked Pai to sing. Sree-kumar played the harmonium while Pai sang a song glorifying the greatness of *satsang*.

*Through association with Realized Sages,
One becomes detached.
Through detachment,
One becomes free of delusion.
Through freedom from delusion,
One becomes free of mental movement.
And through that still mind,
One attains Liberation even while
Living in the body.*

The Holy Mother sat completely indrawn. Her hands formed a mystic pose (*mudra*), Her body perfectly still and Her face radiant with half-closed eyes. After five minutes, She slowly opened Her eyes uttering, “Shiva...Shiva.” It seemed that She was struggling to descend from the divine heights. A few more moments had passed when the Holy Mother said, **Amma:** Children, *satsang* is good. In the beginning it is difficult to do *sadhana* if we remain at home. Why do we send children to school? Isn’t it enough to study at home? No. If they sit in the house and try to study, their minds will go to the kitchen. They may wish to sit on their mother’s lap and their attention will be diverted to many different things. In school they will sit and study with concentration, knowing that they can go home only in the afternoon. Not only that, whatever subject is studied is best learned from an experienced teacher. Likewise, in the beginning stages, it may not be possible to meditate and do *japa* while sitting at home. Relatives and friends will come to see you, or your wife and children will disturb you for a hundred different reasons. *Sadhana* should

be done in the presence of a Perfect Master or in an Ashram. God cannot be attained by those who are immersed in worldliness, always remaining at home. Temples are built for this purpose. By going there, people who are involved in the world can attain peace and concentration. The concentration that one gets when one goes to a temple will not be gained if one sits in the house.

Even though the breeze blows everywhere, coolness will be felt more if we sit in the shade of a tree. In the same way, although God is all-pervading, His presence will clearly shine in certain places more than in others. That is the greatness of *satsang*. In the presence of a Perfect Master, one can experience God more than in any other place. Trees and fans are not needed for those who live in the Himalayas because it is always cool there. Similarly, a Guru may not be necessary for those who are highly evolved in *sadhana*. However, just as the cool breeze in the shade of a tree will give happiness to those who are scorched by the hot sun, the presence and guidance of a Guru is absolutely necessary for those of us who are still in the world. If you want to progress, *satsang* is necessary. If you feel mentally agitated, you should go to the nearest Ashram and sit in solitude, either reading spiritual books or doing *japa* or meditation. Constant meditation will not be possible in the beginning stages. You should try to acquire more spirituality without losing what you already have.

Even though we may be in the hot sun, we won't feel the heat if there is a good breeze. Similarly, wherever one may be, one will not feel troubled due to the benefit gained from living in the presence of the Guru.

Children, if you want to fight, you should fight against God. That will make you reach the goal. If you fight with humans, you will become evil like them. Your life will be wasted, everything will be lost, and both parties will be de-

stroyed. If you seek help, seek God's help. Arjuna fought with the help of Krishna and won. Duryodhana fought with the help of soldiers, and although he had much wealth, the result was complete destruction. Therefore, live with complete surrender to God. You can tell your sorrows to God. If you want to quarrel, you can quarrel with God. Children, you should develop this kind of mental attitude.

Without wasting even a single moment, continue your efforts and strive to attain the fruit. Always be aware that God alone is the Truth.

As She completed this last sentence, the Mother stood up. Her body became perfectly still. A benevolent smile formed on Her lips and Her face glowed with spiritual radiance. Both of Her hands manifested *mudras*; Her hair and sari danced in the sea breeze that blew from the west. She was obviously alone in a world of bliss. The devotees gazed at the Mother's face with unblinking eyes.

Balu and Pai sang a song which depicted the dancing form of Mother Kali, while Sreekumar and Venu accompanied them on harmonium and tabla.

*Victory, victory to the Mother
Who is the Holy Consort of Lord Shiva
And who is the Bestower of Supreme Devotion
And Liberation.*

*O Ocean of Compassion, who has caused
This world of plurality to manifest,
O Mother, please always dance
In the heart of this humble servant
Who remembers Thee constantly.*

Some *brahmacharins* meditated while others joined in the singing. After twenty minutes the Holy Mother opened Her eyes and walked with staggering steps. Like one intoxicated, She moved towards the backwaters and sat there for some time. Getting up, She walked to and fro in a bliss-intoxicated mood with both Her hands on the top of Her head.

9 December 1983

God, the servant of the devotees

Today Mother went to a householder devotee's house for evening *satsang* and *bhajan*. The house was decorated as if for a festival, and there were many people present. The head of the family along with his wife and children received the Mother in the traditional manner. They washed Her feet and waved a flame of burning camphor before Her, and then they invited Her into the house. Mother first went into the *puja* room. She sat there for some time and then went into the kitchen. With great love and affection She talked with the servant and tasted some of the food as well. The host, a very wealthy man, said, "It is a shame to talk with the servants like this."

Amma: Son, you see them through a worldly man's vision as having no status. In God's eyes there is neither small nor big, servant nor master. Greatness or meanness is in relation to the heart only. As far as Mother is concerned, everyone is Her child. Mother is also everybody's servant. Children, Mother came when you called, didn't She? Thus, She obeyed you, didn't She? Your servants also listen to what you say, don't they? Son, God is the greatest servant. He must wait for the call of the devotees, then He should immediately come running and grant them whatever they ask. Sri Rama and Sri Krishna were both servants of Their devotees. Mother re-

members God the servant when She sees the servants in the kitchen. Both He and they are serving. God serves the whole universe with all its creatures; these servants serve only a few. However, both belong to the same class.

Mother again went into the *puja* room where there was the well-known picture of Mother Kali standing on Lord Shiva's chest. Looking at the picture, the Holy Mother said, **Amma:** Shiva is *Brahman* (the Absolute Reality). The meaning of this image is that Shakti, endowed with the three qualities of *sattva* (tranquillity), *rajas* (activity) and *tamas* (dullness) becomes calm and peaceful by the touch of *Brahman*. The union of the individual and the Absolute is what is depicted in this picture.

10 December 1983

The Holy Mother was in the room above the meditation hall. Although it was already ten o'clock in the morning, She had not yet come to the *darshan* hut. She was giving some instructions to the resident *brahmacharins*. Some householder devotees were standing downstairs expecting Mother's arrival. They could hear Her voice from above and their eyes were fixed on the steps leading to Her room. Just then one *brahmacharin* came down from the Mother's room and said, "Mother is calling all of you." Having said this, he went to the meditation hall. With great joy and enthusiasm they ran up the steps.

Upon reaching the front door of the Mother's room, they looked in. There was a cot against one wall with a dresser by its side and a sewing machine on the opposite side of the room. The door leading to the balcony of the room was open. The stairs leading up to the terrace were visible in the

corner. From the terrace one could see the ocean to the west. When desirous of solitude, the Mother would go up there.

Mother was sitting on the floor cutting some cloth in order to stitch something. Next to the Holy Mother Gayatri sat, trying to help Her. Raising Her head, the Mother warmly welcomed everyone with a beautiful smile on Her face and exclaimed, "Oh, my children, come in!" All of them entered and after bowing before the Mother, they sat around Her.

Amma: (Smilingly) Children, do you know stitching? You must know all these things. Mother knows stitching and other crafts.

A woman devotee: Is this a big accomplishment for Mother who stitches the torn clothes of the mind together?

One devotee: Mother, who stitches the world with the cloth of *Maya* (illusion), can stitch anything.

Amma: (Laughing) Shiva, Shiva! What are you children saying about this crazy Kali?

Taking the fruit which the devotees had brought, the Mother cut it into small pieces and fed everyone with Her own hands. They were all very happy and blissful.

Amma: Sometimes, after feeding Her children, Mother feels that She is full. Nobody forgets to eat, but sometimes Mother forgets even to do that. Why does this happen?

Devotee: Mother, please do not play tricks on us. We are already in the quagmire of ignorance. Do not make us sink any deeper into it.

Another devotee: Mother, what should we householders do?

Amma: The mind, which is flying about in all directions, should be gathered together. Only then will it become spiritually strong. The mind cannot be fixed on a single point in the beginning. It should be tuned by doing mantra *japa* continuously. All your attention should be only on that. Do you

know what mantra *japa* can be compared to? In kindergarten we learn to write using a slate and to count using beads. In this way the lessons will easily sink into the intellect. Similarly, we can get concentration through mantra *japa*. There are people who attained the goal merely by chanting a mantra. It is not always possible to meditate, but mantra *japa* can be done irrespective of time or place.

A woman devotee: Mother, my mind has no steadiness. My love vacillates between different deities at different times.

Amma: A devotee, if really sincere in his desire to realize God, will have a chosen Deity. There will be a special love or attachment towards one of the gods or goddesses, unless one is a *nirgunopasaka* (a worshipper of the Formless). In general, people are afraid that gods or goddesses other than their own will get angry if they are not remembered or worshipped. There is no need for such fear. God is beyond human weaknesses, and therefore, the question of anger on His part does not arise. If God gets angry, He is not God. The apparent anger of God is only for the good of His devotees. When a mother scolds her children, it is not out of anger or hatred that she does so, but only to correct them.

All the different names and forms are, in essence, only one. With the same ingredients, you can make edibles of different names and shapes. Likewise, whatever be the name or form, God, the real Substance, is One. One can draw different pictures, but the paint is the same. Similarly, the power is one although the names and forms may change. Daughter, you received a mantra, didn't you? You should do *sadhana* keeping your mind steadily fixed on the Deity of that mantra. Understand that all names and forms are His. One must be intent on reaching the goal. A bit of restlessness will be felt in the beginning, but you should hold on tightly. Al-

ways think, “O Lord, You are the only one to help me, aren’t You? Please be gracious and dwell in my heart always.”

The children which you rear are not your real companions. Once the daughter is married, her mother’s place is second to her husband’s. For the husband as well, the wife comes first and then only his mother. All of them will get off at their respective bus stops along the road of life. Therefore, everything should be entrusted to one’s Beloved Deity. Your children also belong to God. What power does a servant have in the master’s house? He will be satisfied with whatever is given by the master. The master makes the decisions and asks the servant to execute them. He has no right to question. Similarly, we are the servants and God is the Master. He is the one who gives the remuneration, the fruit; so let us work sincerely and be content with what He, the Master, gives. The Real Self, the Essence, should be known. Children, all power belongs to God, not to us. We are puppets in His hands. If we work with the attitude of surrender, He will protect us.

The well says, “my water,” but the well doesn’t think about where the water comes from. The spring is the source of the water even without the well’s knowledge. In the same way, we also say, “I, I. Is there anything without me?” This is our mental attitude. But do we have any existence apart from the Supreme Consciousness?

A strong resolve to reach the goal is necessary. There is plenty of time to go to movie theatres and hospitals, but there is no time for temples and ashrams. Such is our way of living. Even while living in the world, householders should try to imbibe these principles. Otherwise, the mind will become restless. At least one hour every day should be spent thinking of God, one hour for the sake of the soul.

Real gain is from the Self alone. Only enquiry into the Self is of eternal value, and that is what gives peace. We

should know That as the true bliss. What happiness is there in worrying about the family? You should move forward, considering everything as ordained by Him. If one does so, peace will be gained.

Woman devotee: Mother, we are never without sorrow.

Amma: Sorrow is due to desire. We would have attained the bliss of Liberation long ago if desire was the means to attain real happiness. It is said that worldly life depends entirely on the sense organs. Because of this, all our energy is being dissipated through sensual indulgence. Living in the senses will not give us real bliss. Bliss is the same as the one-pointed thought of God.

*Remember, O mind, this supreme truth:
Nobody is your own!
Because of doing meaningless actions,
You are wandering in the ocean
Of this world.*

Remember this song, have *satsang* and always chant your mantra. Give up talking about others. We find time for every useless and unnecessary thing, yet we say that there is no time to think of God. Do not go to vulgar movies or read novels. Are we not sitting in front of the television or going shopping for hours on end? If you always fix your mind on the Lord, peace will be experienced.

Just then pandemonium broke loose among a group of crows. The Holy Mother suddenly rose and came downstairs. One *brahmacharin* came, holding a wet crow in his hands.

Brahmacharin: Mother, this crow fell into the water tank.

The Mother quickly took the crow in Her hands. The crow, which was fluttering until then, suddenly became calm. She asked the *brahmacharins* to chant some Vedic mantras while She blew on the crow's face. The crow died immediately. Having buried it with Her own hands, the Holy Mother again went to Her room with the devotees following behind.

One mantra and one form

Woman devotee: Mother, the mind runs after different forms.

Amma: The fruit (of worship) will be delayed if different gods and goddesses are worshipped from time to time. One will not find water if many small holes are dug in different places. It will be had only if you dig deep in one place. Worship should be done while being established in one's Beloved Deity alone. One should imagine that everything is that Deity itself. Someone says "palu" and another says "milk," but the meaning is the same for both. The difference is one of language only. It is difficult for us who are caught up in Maya to proceed without a medium. Because of this, we call God by different names. Shiva, Shiva, Shiva, Shiva!

The children who have come here from the West are intellectually inclined. Nevertheless, Mother gave them a brass pot of water and a thousand and eight pebbles and told them to imagine each pebble as a flower and offer it at the Feet of their Beloved Deity. *Sankalpa* is enough.

Children, life is momentary. You should live in this world with this realization.

*The early part of life is spent in helpless cries
And youth is spent in lustful attachment.
Now old age is coming
And all of your strength will be taken away.*

*You are going to become like a helpless worm
And without any work, will spend the time
Looking forward to the grave.*

Haven't you heard this song? For how long does this life last?

Question: Mother, is *punya* (spiritual merit) inherited from the previous birth a prerequisite for *sannyasa* (a life of renunciation)?

Amma: Merits inherited from the previous birth are an important factor. But if one has sufficient training and discipline from childhood onwards, one may turn to the spiritual life even if inherited merits are absent. Such people can be properly guided and made into *sannyasins*. But usually parents will not give their children for *sannyasa*; they would even prefer to give them to be killed. However, if the parents give them to God as *sannyasins*, at least they can always see them. Shiva, Shiva, Shiva.

The Mother went into a meditative mood. Uttering Her favorite mantra, "Namah Shivaya," the Mother opened Her eyes after some time and made a swirling motion with Her right hand.

Amma: We think that whatever is wanted will be had from the world. An American psychologist came here. He said, "Mother, thousands of patients come to me. They have no peace of mind and want to know how to get it. I give them some suggestions, but I myself am not getting peace even for a moment. I get solace only from spirituality. That is why I come to see Mother once or twice a year." This is today's world.

Question: Nowadays even *sannyasins* are opportunists.

Amma: True *sannyasins* are beyond fear and scandalizing. Such people never do meaningless things simply to please others. They will not swerve from the path of truth and righteousness. They are not afraid to declare the truth in any circumstances. If a *sannyasin* acts otherwise, one should understand that he is fearful and is only after name and fame. Don't try to reap benefits by pleasing others. Be established in Truth.

Devotee: Mother, we find it very difficult to come here because there is no one to look after our household affairs in our absence.

Amma: Children, God is the real watchman. Many people say, "There is nobody to take care of the house, so how can we come to the Ashram? There is nobody in the house; the children are sick." How many people steal without our knowledge! If we are the real watchmen, we should be able to catch them. What Mother means is, what can we take care of? We say that we want to take care of our children, but can we really do so? After seeing them off to school, are we able to see what is happening to them afterwards? At that time, who is looking after them? Entrust that work to the Lord. Is it possible for us to look after things as He does? Therefore, dedicate everything to Him saying, "O Lord, You look after everything and do what is needed." A thief will not enter, nor will a murder take place if you entrust everything to that Watchman. Other watchmen will do the work only if paid. Therefore, you should come here entrusting everything to God. Have complete faith in Him. Faith can do miracles.

Question: To have absolute faith is not easy, Mother.

Amma: That is true, but think for a moment. When we get into a bus, we blindly believe in the driver even though he is a complete stranger. He might even have caused several accidents. How many bus and car accidents occur everyday! Even then, what makes us travel in a bus or car again? Faith,

is it not? What about travelling in an airplane? Usually not even one person will escape alive in a plane crash. Yet, we believe that the pilot will take us safely to our destination. Take the case of a businessman. What makes him start a business? Isn't it faith that he will be able to make some profit out of it? What guarantee is there that all these things will happen as we expect? None at all. So why do we continue to do everything that we do? Faith.

All persons are limited individuals. How can one person save another? Only an Unlimited Power can save or protect us. Now tell Mother, is there any meaning in placing your faith in people? No, but still we do it. Why? Because we neither think about the meaninglessness of it nor of the true meaning in dedicating everything to God.

Effects of former births

Question: Mother, it is said that everything one experiences is the fruit of one's actions, but even people who have not committed any errors suffer. Why is that so?

Amma: Do we remember everything we have done? Do you remember the things that you did when you were young? Do you even remember the hymn which you learned last month? Then how could you possibly remember the actions of a previous birth? All our happiness and sorrow are only the results of our past actions, if not from this birth, then undoubtedly inherited from previous births. Even in the case of twins, a difference in their way of doing things can be seen. It is because of the effect of a former birth. There are people who say that it is due to the difference in the time of birth. Sometimes it happens that among two people who are born at the same time, one becomes a king and another a vagabond. In certain other cases, it happens that one is deformed

and the other is without any mishaps at all. Therefore, the fruit of past actions alone is the cause for the differences in experience.

There was a chicken in someone's house. Later another one was purchased and brought home. The hen which was already there started pecking at the newcomer because, for a long time, she alone had been the "all in all" there. The newcomer, however, did not leave. Saying, "I am not so worthless," she began pecking back. This went on for some time until both the chickens had bloody crests. This is the way of the ego, but we blame someone else when sorrow comes. The doctor tells us to observe a certain regimen, but we do not follow it and become ill as a result. Then, what is the meaning of blaming the doctor?

Question: Mother, how can ordinary people know about such things?

Amma: Religious education should be made part and parcel of our lives. Temples, schools and colleges should offer religious studies as well. Parents should take the initiative to impart knowledge to their children from childhood onwards. Like other subjects, religion, its theory and practice, should become an important part of our educational system.

Children, look at the churches of the Christians and the mosques of the Muslims. They give more importance to religious education. They won't allow worldly dramas and films to be shown there. What about Hindu temples? Are they not spending hundreds of thousands of rupees to conduct worldly dramas and other such things? Is there anything else needed to spoil our children's character? Parents have no control over their children. They do not discipline them. The Christians have a rule that they should go to church on Sundays, and they observe that rule. Even householders have a *japa mala* (rosary to do *japa*). They know the Bible and teachings of

Jesus Christ by heart. Whereas, the Hindus don't even know the meaning of the word "Hindu." How many professors and engineers and doctors are there in our country who do not know even a word of the *Srimad Bhagavatam*? In the Muslim community, the children are taught Arabic at a very young age. They are taught about their religion. They have very good discipline and etiquette. And what about the Hindus? How many temples are here in the village itself? With the funds raised by going from house to house they conduct vulgar dramas in the temples. In the olden days, children played by making temples in clay and worshipping therein. What do they do nowadays? Donning the costume of a government minister, they canvas for votes.

The Christians teach their children to become priests. Are we teaching our children to become *sannyasins*? Are the temple authorities doing that? People in the olden days had good devotion. Now devotion is motivated by desire. Our stand is that if God fulfills certain conditions for us, we will give this much money. Giving money to God is like giving a hand fan to the electric fan. Uplifting the community comes only through self-discipline and real surrender to God.

The time was almost one in the afternoon. The Holy Mother took everyone to the dining hall and She Herself served food to all the devotees. As they were eating, She went to Her room.

Ten minutes later, the devotees were surprised to see Mother coming out of Her room with Gayatri. They thought that She had gone to take some rest. Approaching Gayatri, they asked her what was the matter.

Gayatri: Mother is feeling very restless. Some devotees must be praying intensely for Her *darshan*.

Mother proceeded towards the boat jetty on the bank of the backwaters, followed by Gayatri and a group of devotees. After waiting there for a few minutes, one boat arrived and a couple from Bombay got out of the boat and rushed over to Mother. In their excitement, they even forgot to pay the boat fare and take their baggage, but seeing the situation, some other devotees did that for them. Their faces were beaming with joy and devotion as they prostrated to the Mother. Getting up, they said,

Devotees: Mother, we could take only two days leave from our jobs in order to come here. We have come by plane to save time, but we have to return immediately. We are having some urgent family problems about which we wanted to ask Mother. Unfortunately, we could not find any way to inform Mother of our coming and were worried that having come so far, we would not be able to see Her. We have been praying intensely that we would be able to have Mother's *darshan* and talk with Her before returning to Bombay. Mother has heard our prayers!

Having said this, the couple tried their best to control their tears of love and devotion. Taking them to the Ashram, Mother spent some time with them and on receiving Her blessings, they departed with a full heart. The Holy Mother then went back to Her room.

Such incidents are quite common around the Holy Mother. Her ways are always mysterious and beyond ordinary people's comprehension, but She is ever gracious. What can anyone say about those who have realized the Infinite?

19 December 1983

A physics professor from a college in Ernakulam came to see the Mother today. He was a devotee of Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa and was very much interested in doing *sadhana*. He had been doing spiritual practices for a long time but was dissatisfied with his progress. He complained about numerous obstacles and the lack of proper guidance. Having heard about the Mother from one of his friends, he developed a strong desire to see Her and that was why he came.

The Holy Mother sat leaning against the wall in the front verandah of the temple, near the door where She usually sits for *bhajan*. A few devotees sat in front of Her along with some *brahmacharins*. With great reverence and devotion, the professor prostrated to the Mother and sat in front of Her with palms joined together chanting a Sanskrit hymn composed by Adi Sankara.

*O Goddess Annapurna, the Ever Perfect,
The Beloved and very Life of Lord Sankara,
In order to achieve Wisdom and Detachment,
Give me alms, O Parvati!*

His eyes filled with tears that were about to roll down his cheeks. The Holy Mother wiped his tears and lovingly stroked his forehead and chest. An inexplicable feeling of peace pervaded the atmosphere and was clearly visible on the faces of all those present, especially on the blissful face of the professor. Some devotees spontaneously went into a meditative mood. All the while the Mother sat with a benign smile on Her face. After some time, the professor broke the silence.

Professor: Can I ask a few questions, Mother?

Amma: Namah Shivaya! What does Mother know? You children are very learned. Mother doesn't even know how to write "Ka Kha" (the first two consonant syllables in the Malayalam alphabet). The letters should remain in the memory, shouldn't they? Then you children call me "Mother" and Mother calls you "children." Shiva... Shiva... Shiva.

Having said this, the Mother smiled like an innocent child. That innocent smile was the smile of Universal Love. It was capable of stealing anyone's heart.

Scriptures and the goal

Question: Mother, my spiritual practices are not improving.

Amma: Children, be intent on the goal, that is what is important. Most of the people coming here for *darshan* have to catch the five o'clock bus the next morning in order to be able to reach their offices in time. By force of habit, they will wake up at four a.m. without anyone calling them. If they are not able to get up at that hour they may not get a boat to cross the river. There are also those who come for *darshan* for the first time. They will stay awake the whole night so as to be able to catch the bus. Their determination to reach the goal is what helps them to stay awake. Children, if this kind of *lakshya bodha* (goal-oriented mind) is there to see God, nothing can obstruct your path. Then you will progress by and by.

On some nights the *brahmacharins* would meditate late into the night. In the beginning, in order to find out who had real detachment, Mother would allow them to sleep only a little. In the day time sleep would come unknowingly when they meditated because of the lack of sleep at night. Then Mother would go and sit in the meditation hall, keeping a stock of small pebbles with Her. If someone happened to fall

asleep, Mother would throw a pebble at him. They would meditate with alertness owing to the awareness that Mother was near them. They would be attentive without being overpowered by sleep.

Mother sometimes tells the children, “Your happiness is Mother’s health.” Mother has no health other than that. Therefore, children, do *sadhana* without wasting time and attain real bliss. Mother’s wealth is Her children. Even if a hundred thousand rupees are lost, they can be recovered. But if one moment is lost, it can never be regained. Your time is precious. Move cautiously.

The *brahmacharins* do not have any interest in studying scriptures. They say that studying the scriptures will inflate their ego. Their only interest is to meditate. It is not difficult because they came to the Ashram at a young age.

Question: Is there no substantial benefit to be had through the study of the scriptures?

Amma: Yes, scriptures are beneficial. There is one son in Bombay who sent another son here to see Mother. Before coming here, he was given a map and told to take a train going to a particular place and to get off at a certain station. After reaching Vallickavu, there is a ferry for ten paise. All this was written and explained correctly to him. Because of that he came to the Ashram without any difficulty. Nobody could cheat him either because the directions and fares were written down and given to him beforehand. But would he have reached here had he simply sat in Bombay, having read all the instructions? Of course not. Therefore, what we call scriptures are meant to help us travel without getting lost. We can reach a place in one hour instead of wandering around for ten hours. Scriptures are pointers only; they are not an end in themselves. Do we taste sweetness if we write “honey” on a piece of paper and lick it? We should get that through experience.

Scriptures were written by the sages from their own experience. We should make the scriptural truths our own. Now they are only in the books and not in the heart. All the great saints and sages and our forefathers as well, did intense penance for years and years. Their renunciation and penance were only to set an example for the generations to come; it was for our sake. We should follow in their footsteps. It is because of their renunciation that both the world and human beings exist even today. If they had committed suicide when they became distressed, we would also do the same, following their example. Didn't Lord Krishna and Christ endure everything? Following their example, can't we also endure? We should also become renunciates like the sages.

There are many who want to make the world good, but to make the world good, shouldn't we become good first? Son, anger cannot be conquered by anger but only through love. Only one who is completely selfless can serve and love the world without any expectations. If there are expectations, service will be selfishly motivated.

Question: What meaning is there in merely sitting with one's eyes closed (in meditation)? Isn't some scriptural knowledge also necessary to serve the world?

Amma: Scriptures were written by those who came down from the plane of intuitive experience. Those truths can be known through experience alone. If one learns the scriptures without first having a certain amount of mental maturity, then one will always be thinking *advaitic* (non-dualistic) thoughts⁶ and become egotistical. The children who are here have come with some knowledge of the scriptures. Therefore, what Mother

⁶ Thoughts such as "I am not the body. I am the Supreme Being, greatest of the great. There is no need for me to observe any rules of morality or discipline."

has told them is, “Children, using whatever time that is available, make your mind one-pointed and try to know who you are. Know what your Real Nature is.” For the attainment of the goal, *tapas* (austerity or penance) alone is beneficial. The great *Rishis* (sages) said, “*Tapas, tapas* alone.” They proceeded forward based on *tapas* alone, not after reading some scriptures. As a result of their *tapas*, the scriptures spontaneously dawned on them. It was not due to studying the scriptures that they could immerse themselves in *tapas*. But scriptures should also be learned. Both are necessary for real progress, but one should not be bound only by scriptural knowledge. One should go beyond the scriptures.

Today people think that studying the scriptures is the same as spirituality. A real pundit is one who is established in the Supreme Self, not one who can give discourses on the scriptural texts like a preacher. Nothing but harm will be received from a person who goes out into the world to teach only after gathering mere book knowledge. That is what is seen in ninety-nine percent of the people.

The intention of the children here is to guide the world after experiencing the Truth through *tapas*. Let them study their own nature first. Then they will see the Essence behind everything in this world. On seeing a rock, a sculptor becomes blissful beholding the form which he can carve out of it; whereas, an ordinary person sees only the rock. In the same way, the children here will see only God’s Form in all the things of the world if they know their Real Nature. They won’t even see the externals, the flesh. Having only learned the scriptures, without meditating to gain real experience of Self-Knowledge, how many *sannyasins* become lecherous upon seeing a woman? When they see a woman, they see only the flesh; they don’t see the consciousness which is responsible for the beauty and vitality.

The bliss which the children here get is Mother's health and wealth. Mother's aim is to make them reach the plane of experience; *tapas* is meant for this. Let them know who they are. Mother doesn't say that you should believe in Mother or God, but know who you are.

Having made the children sit and meditate, Mother will go and do the kitchen work. Mother will bring and serve food at the place where they are sitting for *tapas*. What is needed is to develop concentration. The whole world will become ours if concentration is achieved. Just wearing ochre robes will not suffice. What our forefathers told us was to make the mind ochre.⁷ Only one who has subjugated his inner nature deserves to wear ochre. Nowadays, people who cannot concentrate their minds even for one minute wear it! Shiva, Shiva!

Question: Why does Mother make these children do hard work like carrying cement, bricks and other heavy things?

Amma: Children, an employer can be seen scolding an employee for walking too slowly while carrying a heavy load. He himself is not in the habit of carrying such heavy loads. It is a great sin if one says, "Hey, run!" without understanding that one is walking slowly due to the weight of the load. If the person who scolds is one who has known the weight of such loads, then it doesn't matter. He will know how fast one can walk with such a load. Only if these children carry such loads today will they have compassion towards the laborers tomorrow and understand their difficulties. Mother also carries the loads along with the children. She will not simply sit idle and make the children do the work. There is no greater or lesser here in terms of people's importance or work. Everything is part of *sadhana*.

⁷ Sannyasins wear only ochre-colored (rust-red) clothes in India.

Scriptural studies began in the Ashram only after making the children do *sadhana* for four years. Even now they are doing eight hours of meditation plus one hour for chanting the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother. In addition, one hour goes for practicing yogic postures (*asanas*), an hour for the study of Sanskrit and one and a half hours for the evening *bhajan*. On *darshan* days they sing *bhajans* till the end of *Devi Bhava*. Furthermore, there are two hours of scriptural studies. Only twenty days of classes are there in a month. Silence is observed once a week and they must also fast on that day. The children do all the work in the Ashram while chanting their mantra. The mind will become pure through such *sadhana*.

One *brahmacharin* went from here to the Himalayas. There is one *sannyasin* there called “Chiranjivi” (the long lived one) who is more than a hundred years old. He told the son who went from here, “Child, go back and save yourself. Even though it is nearly seventy years since I turned to this path, I have not gained anything because I was unable to develop faith in one Guru. Neither did I get a Guru who could instill faith and obedience in me. Therefore, even today I remain the same as I was when I came here so many years ago. You have Mother to guide you. That is due to the spiritual merits that you have inherited from the past birth. Go and do *sadhana* in Her presence. Through that alone will you benefit.”

Two devotees came to see the Mother. A Westerner of intellectual temperament also arrived. Immediately Mother asked, “Ha, where is Mother’s share?” Taking out a small packet which they had hidden in their hands, they gave it to the Mother. It contained some edibles which they had brought to offer to Her. The happiness of the devotees knew no bounds as the Mother opened the packet and tasted a bit. Having

tasted it, the Mother distributed the rest as *prasad* among the devotees.

Amma: Too many sweets are bad for your health. Food influences the character of a person to a certain extent. A controlled diet is very important as far as a seeker is concerned. Eat to appease your hunger and sustain the body. Give up the habit of eating simply when you see food that you like. Eat food but don't let the food eat you. What Mother means is that you can enjoy things, but self-control is always necessary. God created the world for you, not for Himself. Therefore, there is no harm in enjoying the objects, but remember that over-indulgence is always dangerous. Traffic rules are made for our benefit. Similarly, the rules and regulations in a factory or even in one's own house are made in order to instill discipline so that conflicts and accidents will not take place. In the same way, the Ancient Sages set forth certain rules of life which one should observe in order to live joyously in this world.

Westerner: Food doesn't have the power to change the character of human beings. Character is based on mind alone.

Amma: Yes, son, but the body is influenced by the mind and vice versa; they are interdependent. Just try to think deeply immediately after jogging for a long distance. It is not possible due to physical exhaustion. Similarly, one is not able to do physical work properly when the mind becomes weak due to sorrow caused by the death of a near relative or any other similar cause. Because there is a connection between the mind and body, the mind can be conquered if the body is controlled. Therefore, during the period of *sadhana*, food should be controlled in the beginning. Most *brahmins* are *sattvic* and relatively calm. Why? Because they are pure vegetarians. Those who eat meat and other non-vegetarian food are more *tamasic* and rough. Never eat flesh foods. That will make the mind

more restless and will create more semen in the body and therefore more passion. Meditation will become impossible. Vegetarian food will not create that much trouble. Look at the cruel nature of a tiger which eats meat and the calm nature of a deer which eats grass.

Westerner: I am not convinced. I must have more proof.

Amma: (Smilingly) Son, you will get it.

The Westerner left after two days. Though he disagreed with the Mother on the point of food, his faith in the Mother had increased immensely during his two day stay. Most interestingly, after two weeks he wrote a letter to the Holy Mother in which he said, “Beloved Mother, I am writing this letter full of remorse. On that day when I disagreed with you about the change that food can bring in one’s character, saying, ‘I am not convinced. I must have more proof,’ you smilingly replied that I will get it. Now Mother, I got it. During my one month stay in India, I didn’t take any non-vegetarian food. I reached Germany last week and I ate pork. After eating that, I felt a very strong desire to have sex and my mind became so agitated that I couldn’t sleep that night. Having not eaten meat for a long time, I could now clearly feel the difference. Now I know that it was you who taught me the lesson. Mother, you have given me enough proof, I am convinced. Mother, please forgive me for disagreeing with you and thank you very much for teaching me this lesson.”

Question: It seems meaningless to follow a regular routine? Can’t we live without that?

Amma: Children, if we drink tea for ten days, we will get a headache on the eleventh day if we don’t drink it. That is the power of habit. Our character is born of habits. Therefore, a discipline is needed in order to build up good habits. Our present way of living is the result of our past way of living. In

order to remove the bad habits and ways of the past we should develop good, new habits. A regular routine is needed for this to happen. In the beginning, we should have love for our routine and strictly follow it. Then only progress is possible.

Even if we are perfect, we should live as an example for others. If we tell a person who is afflicted with jaundice not to eat salt and tamarind, how will it be if we keep it around us? Seeing them available, he will want to eat it since he has not gone beyond taste. His mouth will water and he will break the regimen. Therefore, we should interact with the world cautiously.

Two children of two different houses had jaundice. The doctor told both of them to observe a particular diet. The mother in one house started cooking food without salt and tamarind for everyone. Because of that, the patient in that house followed the diet correctly. The mother in the other house gave the prescribed diet only to the patient but prepared food with salt and tamarind for the others. Do you know what the result was? The patient in the second house broke the regimen by stealthily eating the food which was made for the others. That child's disease increased and he died. Do's and don'ts are not necessary for a Self-Realized Soul. He is beyond all rules and regulations, yet he sets an example by abiding by the rules in order to uplift others. Worldly people can be uplifted only if we act in a disciplined way in front of them.

We are born naked, but because of that, do we walk around with our clothes off? We are wearing clothes for society's sake, aren't we? All these rules are needed for the betterment of society. A regular discipline is necessary.

Question: Mother, I am staying in a hostel. I cannot meditate there due to the blaring of film songs. What can I do?

Amma: Imagine that the hero and heroine of the song are Shiva and Parvati. Previously Mother used to dance intoxicated with devotion and bliss when She heard film songs. The problem arises when you think that the hero and heroine are worldly people. You should see them as Radha and Krishna, as one's Real Nature, the Self (*atmaswarupa*). Everything depends upon one's attitude, doesn't it?

One of the children who lives here now stayed in a hostel while he was studying. Whenever he heard a song, he would imagine that Mother was singing. Others used to tease him if they saw him meditating. Therefore, he would pretend as if he was sleeping while lying down under the mosquito net. When every one had fallen asleep, he would get up and meditate for a long time.

Solitude is necessary. You children should sit in solitude for at least some time. It would be good if you would move away from the hostel and stay in an ashram atmosphere or some similar place.

A devotee: Mother, today I heard one *brahmacharin* reading *Srimad Bhagavatam*. What a fine voice he has!

Amma: Isn't the sound that is produced in a cave special? Similar is the voice of the *sadhak* who is at a particular stage of meditation. The voice of people who have concentration will have a resounding nature. Others will feel attracted when they hear that.

Question: Mother, what is your opinion about seeing cinema films?

Amma: Movies which create a devotional mood are not very harmful, but other types of films should be avoided. Worldly films will create more negative vibrations in us. After seeing such films, people try to imitate what they have seen. One of the causes for the degeneration of our culture is the cheap films that are produced and shown in public. People spend a

lot of money, time and energy in seeing them without realizing the tremendously bad effect created by such films.

Long ago there was a film on the ancient king Satyavan and his virtuous wife Savitri. Haven't you heard that story? The husband Satyavan died. The pious and chaste wife Savitri, an embodiment of austerity, followed the God of Death, who was taking away the soul of the husband. Seeing the wisdom, chastity, piety and love of Savitri, the God of Death was pleased and asked her to seek a boon. She asked to have many children. When that was granted she asked, "How can I have children without my husband?" Thus even the God of Death was defeated by Savitri, a chaste wife. He gave back her husband's life.

A *tapasvi's* (one engaged in austerities) words will never fail. Even if he says something wrong, that will only be to make others good. Even seeming mistakes that he says or does will become correct.

Turning to a devotee who was sitting amongst the other devotees, the Holy Mother suddenly said, "Son, quickly go home." Usually the Mother would never say such a thing. The devotee was about to take leave of the Mother with great anxiety. As he got up after prostrating to the Mother, She said, "There is nothing to worry about. You are going to see something very interesting, that's all."

When the devotee had come to the Ashram that day, he had kept his motorbike on the other side of the river. For the past five days he had found that someone was stealthily siphoning out the petrol. Because of this, he had been having great difficulty getting home when he left the Ashram at night. Considering it a silly matter, he never mentioned anything about it to the Mother. While anxiously leaving the Ashram this day, he could not even guess what would be the interest-

ing thing that he was going to see. Upon reaching the other side of the river, he saw a person sitting near his motorbike siphoning out the petrol. The devotee caught the thief red-handed but freed him after giving a warning. Thus Mother Herself helped him to get rid of the trouble which he had been facing for the last few days.

Question: Mother, how can one gain subtlety of mind?

Amma: It can be gained through concentration which in turn can be attained only by fixing the mind on a point. This point may be the form of one's Beloved Deity. If one does not believe in God, then one can concentrate on an unmoving flame, on the tip of the nose, or on any other point on the body. Whatever the means, the aim is to gain one-pointedness. When concentration increases, thoughts decrease; and when thoughts decrease, the mind and intellect will become subtler. This subtlety will help in having subtle spiritual experience. Spiritual experience cannot be attained through the gross mind and intellect. Reality is subtler than the subtlest. To experience the subtle, subtle instruments are needed. To see the gross objects of the world, the external eye is enough, but to know the soul (Self), the internal eye is needed. When people speak loudly, we can easily hear them, but why? Because the sound is gross. But if they speak softly, we cannot hear them. Speaking softly is subtler than speaking loudly. Our ears are not capable of hearing soft sounds. Similar is the case with all the sense organs and the mind. Therefore, to experience the Self or *Atman*, which is the subtlest of all subtle things, we should develop subtlety of mind.

Question: Is Mother saying that there is justification in wanting to experience the subtle planes of existence?

Amma: One cannot understand everything about life if one stays on the gross, external plane. There are many mysteries in this universe about which one cannot even imagine. To

experience all those, one should go into the subtle planes of existence.

How many dust particles are floating inside a room can be known only when the sun's rays enter through a small hole in the roof or wall. Even though the dust particles are everywhere in the room, lack of concentrated light prevents us from seeing them. Now there is no light within you, only dense darkness. You are unable to see the subtle because your mind remains in darkness. When the mind attains subtlety through focusing one's efforts towards God, then all can be seen. What meaning is there in saying, "I don't believe because I cannot see," when one is lacking in subtlety? The effulgence of the Self will begin rising as our mind becomes more and more subtle. In that state we can see every atom of the universe. But this cannot be seen with the external eyes.

Just as the tape recorder records whatever we say without missing even a word, Nature records all of our actions. Each of our words and thoughts subtly exist in Nature. The power born of the penance done by the Ancient Sages is also there in Nature. Even today *Mahatmas* exist in their subtle plane.

There is a subtle aura around everyone's body. This can be seen very clearly around people who do *sadhana*. The aura of *sadhaks* is powerful. Others' auras do not have this characteristic. Ordinary people's auras are dark or cloudy. The aura around a *tapasvi* is bright like golden rays. If any harm is done to such people, their aura will become destructive to the offenders through the vibrations created by it. It is not necessary that the resolve of the *tapasvis* should be there for this to happen. They will not have any anger towards the people who trouble them. It is the subtle beings who do the harm. If we raise a dog, it will chase trespassers even if the people in the house are fast asleep. They will not know anything about the things which may happen outside. That is how

these subtle beings save the *tapasvis* from enemies. The enemy gets punished even without the knowledge of the *sadhak*. That is why appropriate results are reaped by those who vilify a *tapasvi*. In reality, one cannot even touch him without his permitting it.

The subtle aura around worldly people will retain all their actions. This aura along with the individual soul will travel through the air after death. Eventually that (the soul) will enter into the food of humans. Then it will become the fetus after entering the womb of a woman through the semen of a man. Some souls will remain without getting liberated from that condition for up to three years. The individual soul will advance according to the rituals performed by the relatives for the propitiation of the *pitrus* (ancestral deities). Some will get Liberation while others will again take birth. All depends upon the fruit of each one's actions (*karma phala*).

Some yogis enter directly into the womb. They become the soul of a fetus that has died while in the womb. There are other souls who are destined to attain Liberation within a certain number of births. They will depart after becoming the fetus in the womb. Such an abandoned body will be used by yogis for taking a human form. Thus yogis can take birth by their own will rather than as the result of the union of a man and a woman.

The soul will attain Liberation as a result of the proper performance of oblations offered to it and according to its worthiness. Suppose there is a small puddle near a pond. If more and more water is poured into it, it will fill up and flow into the pond. Likewise, the *karmas* done for the departed help to make them fit for Liberation.

If *pitru karma* (ceremony done to propitiate the ancestral deities) is done regularly, it should not be stopped. If stopped, harm will result. But there will be no problem if it is not

performed at all. Several families came to see Mother who were having problems caused by a break in the offering of oblations to the departed. They said, "There is some evil in the house. Cows don't live long; children are dullards and no children are born to newlyweds." They were always worried. They said that someone had invoked malevolent forces against them. But Mother did not see any such thing. Mother felt that the problems were due to the break in the *pitru karmas* and came to understand that subtle beings were disturbing the people. Upon enquiry, they said that they used to do *pitru karma* but had stopped after some time. Mother asked them to begin it again. When they did, everything became all right.

Therefore, the last word cannot be said about everything. There are certain things which are beyond the intellect and ordinary human perception.

23 December 1983

Today the Holy Mother inaugurated an Ashram branch in Pandalam, a village about fifty miles to the east of Vallicavu, the Mother's own village. The Mother and the *brahma-charins* came to the spot where the small temple was situated on about a quarter of an acre of land. It was an old temple which had belonged to a traditional Hindu family. They could no longer maintain it due to financial difficulties and so they transferred it to the Ashram.

The villagers gave a grand reception to the Holy Mother. They were all very happy and enthusiastic. The Mother purified the inner shrine and performed worship. This was followed by the chanting of the Thousand Names of the Goddess one hundred times, devotional singing and *satsang*. There was a large gathering and all participated with devotion and love.

Later, Mother came and sat on the front verandah of the temple to give *darshan*. A charming sight presented itself at

that time. A small child came and sat right in front of Mother, followed by a second, third, forth and fifth. Within a few seconds, fifty children were sitting around the Holy Mother. The most striking thing was that they were all below six or seven years old. They sat silently like carved statues in front of the Holy Mother for nearly an hour, gazing at Her face the entire time. They had come with their parents to participate in the festival. Wasn't it a wonder that those children sat silently in front of a person they were meeting for the first time in their lives? The Mother did not speak or make any signs to attract them, except for the never-fading smile on Her face. After one hour the Mother started giving *darshan*. Even at that time the children were not ready to move away. They sat there until their parents fetched them.

25 December 1983

After spending two days in Pandalam, the Holy Mother came back to the Ashram last night. There was a big crowd for *darshan*. Many householder devotees came with their children. Like another innocent child, the Mother played and laughed with the children. It was a wonderful feast for the eyes and a joy to the hearts of the devotees to see the Mother playing with their children. Mother even forgot about Her usual afternoon break and went on playing. Sometimes She would say that when She was in the company of children, She would become crazy and forget everything due to their innocence. Eventually the children became tired and sat down. The Mother also sat near them. She asked them about their studies.

Amma: Children, you should sing *bhajans* every day and meditate on God with eyes closed praying, “O God, make me a good and devoted child. Bless me to grow up as an obedient son or daughter. O Lord, bestow on me good qualities like

patience, love and forbearance.” (Turning to some parents who were standing nearby) Some people doubt whether children should meditate and do *japa* at such a young age. Remember that Dhruva and Prahlada⁸ made the Lord appear before them when they were young. The training and discipline which are given in youth will create a strong impression in the mind and play a great role in the building of character. Parents should take care not only to feed and fulfill the wishes of their children but also to discipline them, instilling faith and good culture.

Devotee: Mother, why are some people careless about Godly matters?

Amma: Look at those weeds. Everyone carelessly tramples them. When they become sick, the same people will ingest the weeds with reverence after understanding that they are medicinal. Those who are trampling now are not thinking that some day they may become sick. Now they feel strong and all-powerful. When a disease comes, they will seek the refuge of the weeds. Until then they will step on them. The same is true with the people who do not care now about God. When sorrow comes, they will turn to God and take refuge in Him. Until then they will turn their back on Him.

The Holy Mother asked the children to sing a song. Along with Mother they sang,

*O Lord, come, come to console me,
A mere atom in this infinite world.*

*O Lord of the Universe Who reigns over
The fourteen worlds, come before me today
And end my sorrows.*

⁸ Two princes in ancient India who did *sadhana* in order to get the vision of God.

26 December 1983

It was ten o'clock in the morning and the Holy Mother was sitting in Her room. Since there were no visitors, some *brahmacharins* had an opportunity to talk with Her.

Brahmacharin: Mother says that a *sadhak* should not mingle with worldly people. Isn't everything *Brahman*? Then why is it necessary to differentiate like that?

Amma: (Smilingly) Son, do you have the experience that everything is *Brahman*? Will the picture of a cow drawn on a sheet of paper give milk? Everything is equal only for those who have reached *Brahman*. For others good and bad exist, and they should behave accordingly. Even though the Inner Self of animals such as a cow, dog or cat is one, are they alike? Likewise, even if the Self (*Brahman*) in all human beings is one, their characters differ and therefore one should behave accordingly.

The water in the Ganges River and the water in the drain are both water. But son, will you drink the water from the drain? A *sadhak* should mingle with someone only after understanding that person properly. A plant should be protected by a fence until it has grown big. After that there is no problem. Now you are like a pond which will become polluted if mixed with drainage water. It would be best for a pond to join with a river. Son, won't you get burnt if you go near fire? If you are immune to fire, then differentiation is not needed. Only then can you say that everything is *Brahman*. Do not say so while you still perceive diversity. There are people who say, "There is no body, mind and intellect; the Self alone exists and I am the Self." The Self exists in the world of the Self alone. We are still in the plane of individuality. We have a body made up of the five elements which is affected by heat, cold and other dualities. It is in relation to these facts that we

live. We have not reached the state of *Brahman* yet. We will be afflicted with leprosy if we mingle with a leper, won't we? Likewise, if the *sadhak* mingles too much with worldly people, he will develop a character similar to theirs.

However, why should you children waste your time thinking about how to mingle with others? What is needed is the inner eye; you should become introspective. It is meaningless if one merely makes an external show of being a renunciate. There are some fruits which ripen on the outside first. These will quickly spoil. But those fruits which ripen from within will not easily spoil. What is important is inner detachment and introspection. A good *sadhak* will behave like ordinary people. In appearance both will look alike, but there will be a difference like that between a real rope and a burnt rope. The latter looks like a rope but will crumble to ashes if you touch it. Similar are the anger and other apparent feelings of a matured *sadhak*. All his worldly tendencies have been burnt up. They only seem to be there. That is only for the sustenance of the body. We should try to reach that state. On the other hand, don't spoil your *sadhana* by being too sociable and getting involved in other people's affairs in the name of everything being *Brahman*. A real Vedantin is the best socializer. But one should attain that state first. It is not enough to just walk around babbling Vedantic sayings.

One *brahmacharin* had gone to the market to make some purchases and now returned. Coming to the Mother, he informed Her regarding the details of his shopping. There came up the subject of a particular shopkeeper.

Brahmacharin: Mother, that shopkeeper charges more for the goods. That is why we are not going there now.

Amma: That is the way we must treat profiteers. You children are not careful enough when you are buying things. You will

pay whatever amount they ask. Therefore, Mother has to pay attention. When you come to know that Mother pays attention, you children will also be careful. Things should be purchased only after enquiring in detail. The shopkeepers also will be careful when they come to know that the customer is attentive. Otherwise, they will cheat us and will try to cheat others too. By our carelessness, we teach them to lie. Do not show sympathy to such profiteers. We dislike their actions not their soul.

Another brahmacharin: Mother, even a small sound distracts me while meditating.

Amma: We do not avoid sleeping because frogs and crickets make sounds in the night. It is their nature to do so. Children, do not pay attention to the sounds. *Sadhana* is not possible if you wait for the entire world to become favorable. Is it possible to take a bath in the ocean if you wait for all the waves to subside?

Brahmacharin: Mother, so many desires come up.

Amma: It is difficult to eliminate desires completely. Therefore, direct them towards God. Develop the desire to do *japa*, to meditate and to have *satsang*. These Godly desires are not wrong. The desire to realize the Self is good. Only worldly desires can be called desires. They will bind us; Godly desires will not. They will liberate us instead. Only if a small fish is used as bait will we catch a big one. It is not wrong to have a small desire in order to gain that which is great. Each step should be made carefully, like the walking of a pregnant woman.

Guru

Brahmacharin: Mother, some say that a Guru is not necessary.

Amma: A Guru is absolutely necessary for a *sadhak*. When a child goes near a pond, the mother points out the possible consequences and calls him back. The guidance of a Guru is similar. One can do *sadhana* without a Guru, but there will be a difference between those who have a Guru and those who do not. It is difficult to raise artificially incubated chickens in the coastal area. Much care is needed. Such care is not necessary for the chickens who have lived with the mother hen. When the chickens grow up unnaturally without a mother, it will be difficult for them to overcome unfavorable circumstances. Likewise, one who does *sadhana* in the presence of a Guru will gain enough mental strength to confront the obstacles that might arise both from within and from the world outside.

It is possible to transplant apple trees from places where they naturally grow. The only thing is that they need to be carefully looked after. Even then, there will be a difference in the quality and quantity of the fruit. The Guru's presence and perfect guidance give the favorable circumstances for *sadhana* and spiritual progress. Just as the mother hen protects the little ones under her wings, a Perfect Master always protects the aspirant. If there is no Guru, that lack will be seen in the *sadhak*.

In the coastal area the sand has particles of salt in it. It is therefore difficult to grow jackfruit trees there. But they will grow if you plant them in a hole filled with coconut fibre, soil and other nutrients. Once the roots take hold, we need not fear the salt. Until then, proper care should be taken. In the same way, due to the "salt" of latent tendencies, the plant of spirituality will not grow in the mind of the *sadhak* initially. It should be filled with love and devotion. Once these become deep-rooted, there will be nothing to worry about from the *vasanas*.

God-Realization is not possible without *sadhana*, but nobody has time for that. Keeping awake, factory workers do work during the night shift. They do not sit idle saying that they feel sleepy. If they are not alert, both their hands and the job will be lost. For attaining God-Realization, that kind of alertness and determination are also needed.

Brahmacharin: Isn't a *Jivanmukta* (a Liberated Soul) a person who has attained Liberation? Therefore, are not God and a *Jivanmukta* equal?

Amma: God is higher than a *Jivanmukta*. A *Jivanmukta* who stays in the body has limitations. God has no limitations. Bulbs come in various wattages such as twenty-five, sixty, a hundred and a thousand. Although the electricity which flows through them is one and the same, it shines in varying degrees according to the medium. Electricity can be compared to God or *Brahman*, the Absolute. The highest and the most powerful medium is an *Avatar*. If God is the ocean, the *Jivanmukta* is a huge wave and the individual soul is a drop of water. God is even beyond a *Jivanmukta*.

Brahmacharin: What harm is there if too much food is eaten?

Amma: Over-eating will increase dullness. A *sadhak* should take only light food.

Cry for the Truth

One *brahmacharin* came to the Mother with a complaint about a silly matter. He started to cry as he was telling the Mother about it.

Amma: A spiritual being should not cry for illusory things. He should cry only for the Truth. One who has to carry the burden of the whole world should not become weak in the face of insignificant matters. Don't cry. No matter how much

suffering Mother had in Her childhood, She didn't cry. She shed tears only for the Lord. A spiritual being should be strong.

The Mother noticed a *brahmacharin* leaning against the wall while meditating. Turning to him She said,

Amma: Do not lean while meditating. Leaning is a bad habit which must be overcome. The mind is a big thief. It is waiting for an opportunity to subjugate you. It is comfortable for the body if you lean but unknowingly you will fall asleep. You should do *japa* walking to and fro if you feel tired or sleepy. The whole world will become ours if we know the Real Essence. Then we cannot see anything as different from our Self. Only a lamp which has oil can light other lamps and shine by its own light. Only a person who has spiritual power can save himself and others. That oil of spirituality should be acquired through *sadhana*. Then you can go out and serve the world. However, if there is even a drop of water in the oil, the lamp will sputter when lit. Likewise, even a little vice is enough to make the mind agitated and disharmonious.

Brahmacharin: Is it compulsory that a *sadhak* should avoid mingling with the opposite sex?

Amma: Yes. If rain water falls on the ground, it will become muddy. The mind will be spoiled if a *sadhak* or *sadhaka* (woman aspirant) mingles with the opposite sex. The butter which sits near the fire will melt. Similar is the presence of a woman for a man and vice versa. Unknowingly it will create negative vibrations in the mind. This will become harmful to *sadhana*. *Sannyasins* should not mingle with the opposite sex before reaching the state of Liberation. (Smilingly) But there is nothing to fear for you children when Mother is here. It is enough if you meditate well.

Brahmacharin: Mother, unwanted thoughts come and disturb my meditation.

Amma: Until now we had no knowledge about our property. Only now has that knowledge arisen. The deed of ownership is in our hands but the land is in the hands of the tenants. It is not easy to evict those who have been living on our property for many years. We should argue in the court of God. The present disturbance is caused by deep-rooted past impressions in the mind. It is enough if you discriminate when thoughts come. Have self-surrender and faith. Try to reject unholy thoughts ruthlessly or just ignore them and replace them with good and divine thoughts.

Children, patience is needed to make spiritual progress. Never lose patience. Do your spiritual practices with utmost sincerity and wait patiently. If you are sincere, the results will come.

A person who goes to court will not say to the judge, “I don’t have any time. You must pass the judgment immediately.” However much time is needed, he will sit in front of the court house enduring heat and rain. Having gone to the hospital, we won’t tell the doctor, “I have no time. Diagnose me and treat me quickly.” But many people who come here to the Ashram have no time at all. They have a hundred problems at home. They don’t even have the time to bow down in the temple. Such is their lack of devotion and faith. Patience is needed for everything.

About mantras

Brahmacharin: Mother, shouldn’t we know the meaning of the mantra which we are chanting?

Amma: When we travel in a bus, train or car, it is not necessary to know who the manufacturer of the vehicle is, what type of engine it has and where the spare parts are available. The bus will take us to the destination; that is, to the bus stop

which is nearest to our house. Our whole aim is to reach the destination. Likewise, the mantra will take you to the destination, i.e., the threshold of God-Realization. From there, the Beloved Himself will lead you to the Supreme State, Realization. In the beginning it is not very important to know the meaning of the mantra. It is enough if one is aware of the goal for which the mantra is being repeated. There is no need in thinking, “Maybe the Goddess is sitting and looking to the left or maybe She is looking to the right. She has this quality and that quality.” Be intent on reaching the goal, that is what is necessary. Concentrate on the letters or on the sound of the mantra and do *japa*. Otherwise, it is enough to concentrate on the form of your Beloved Deity if you have one. Do not try to do all of these at the same time; it is not possible. The mind can do only one thing at a time. It is quite sufficient if you do any one of these practices.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why are some mantras to be chanted in conjunction with seed letters (*bijaksharas*)? Is not devotional singing sufficient?

Amma: Won’t we feel shocked if somebody shouts at us, “Hey you, go away?” Similarly, *bijaksharas* like “hrim” and “klim” have a special power. The Ancient Sages made the resolve that certain mantras coupled with certain *bijaksharas* must have a certain power. That will never prove false.

Brahmacharin: Mother, why is it said that mantras should not be chanted loudly?

Amma: Devotional songs and the Divine Names can be chanted loudly. But that is not the case with the mantras which the Guru utters into the disciple’s ear. The Guru will be giving different mantras according to each *sadhak’s* competency. It is not possible to give the same mantra to everyone. If chanted loudly, there is a chance that others will hear the mantra and repeat it resulting in negative consequences.

The Guru initiates according to each one's spiritual path, power of assimilation and physical and mental constitution. It is better not to chant the mantra loudly in order to avoid such problems. Mental chanting is the best.

27 December 1983

It was the Christmas holidays. As instructed by the Mother, the birth of that great soul, Jesus Christ, was celebrated in the Ashram also.

Today before coming to the meditation hall, the Holy Mother went to the temple where Brahmacharin Sreekumar was performing the daily worship in the absence of Brahmacharin Unnikrishnan who usually did it. Having finished the chanting of the thousand Names of the Divine Mother, Sreekumar was sitting in meditation. Mother gazed at him for a few seconds and said, "Be attentive. The mind is getting distracted." Saying this, the Mother touched the spot between his eyebrows with Her index finger and said, "Here, concentrate here."

The morning meditation was about to end. The Holy Mother came to the meditation hall from the temple and sat down. She reminded the *brahmacharins* about maintaining their daily routine and doing the physical work that was allotted to each of them. The Mother suggested that some work be given to those who did not have a particular job to do. It seemed that some of the *brahmacharins* felt displeased about having to do the work which they were asked to do. The Mother did not heed their objections but rather insisted that they continue with the same work.

Amma: Children, you must find satisfaction and happiness in any work given in any circumstance. You should not have a special interest in doing a particular work and dislike in performing some other work. This is how you can go beyond

likes and dislikes. Everything should be considered as God-given. Try to be a perfect instrument in the hands of God and accept whatever He gives happily. Otherwise, what is the difference between us and the worldly people?

Children, don't think that Mother is condemning the world and the people who are immersed in it. The world is created by God for us to enjoy and we must do so. But there are certain rules and regulations for everything. While you are in a court or police station or hospital, you have to abide by certain rules and regulations. Likewise, as you live in the world enjoying sense objects and utilizing natural resources, you must follow the rules put forth by the scriptures, teachers and Mother Nature. If not, you will have to suffer. But children, as far as a serious *sadhak* is concerned, he must always try to withdraw the senses from the outside world.

With regard to the *sadhana* of the *brahmacharins*, the Mother would never allow them to make decisions on their own and because of this, they would sometimes feel a little upset. Even then, She would be unyielding and if necessary, would even refute the points which they would bring forth to justify their stand.

When the conversation was over, the Holy Mother asked all the *brahmacharins* to sit for five minutes in a contemplative mood. She said, "Let your minds become peaceful and calm." Everyone obeyed the Mother. After that, She sang along with them,

*O Thou to Whom the celestials bow down,
Whose tale is wonderful, grant us the strength
To be devoted to Thy Feet.
We offer Thee all our actions done
In the darkness of ignorance,*

*O Protector of the distressed.
Forgive us for all our impatient utterances,
O Ruler of the Universe.*

The Mother became fully absorbed in the singing. At times like this, one could see the different facets of Her devotion pouring out one after another. Sometimes She would laugh boisterously and at other times She would shed tears of ecstasy. With both hands stretched forth towards the heavens as if appealing to the Divine Mother, She would sing with all Her heart. This, in turn, would open the floodgates of devotion in the hearts of the *brahmacharins* who would also sing with overflowing love towards God.

After the *satsang* and *bhajan*, the Holy Mother went to the hut to receive the devotees. The *darshan* went on until a little after one o'clock. Getting up, the Mother was about to step onto the staircase leading to Her room when She suddenly turned and said, "Alas, my son, I forgot!" Without uttering another word, the Mother ran to the temple followed by some of the *brahmacharins* and devotees.

Inside the temple they saw Sreekumar sitting in deep meditation. Already more than three or four hours had passed since the Mother had left him there meditating. The Mother sat near him, slowly and gently rubbing him on the chest. After a few minutes, Sreekumar opened his eyes but closed them again. This happened a few more times until he became his normal self. As instructed by the Mother, a thick blanket was spread on the floor. With the help of the devotees, the Mother made Sreekumar lay on it. Having said, "Now he is all right. Let him relax here for some time," She came out of the temple and closed the doors behind Her. As She slowly walked to Her room, the Mother commented, "He has gone up."

In the afternoon Brahmacharin Balu had an opportunity to be with Mother. She was lying down in Her room with Gayatri and Kunjumol sitting near Her. Balu prostrated to the Mother and sat near Her. The Mother stretched forth Her clenched fists towards the sky. Shaking them vigorously and making a grinding sound with Her teeth, She called out, “Kali...hey, Kali!” Pointing Her index finger upwards towards some unseen object, She produced some seemingly meaningless and bizarre sounds. She remained in that position for some time and then slowly became Her usual self. Balu asked, **Balu:** Amma, what is the meaning of all these mysterious gestures and moods?

Amma: (Abstractedly) Oh...I don’t know. They just come like that. (After a short pause) Do you know how much I am struggling to stay here in this world in the midst of all of you? It is really very difficult. But when Mother remembers the sorrows and sufferings of the people, Her mind melts and becomes compassionate. That is what keeps Her mind down here.

Balu: What was the experience that Sreekumar had this morning?

Amma: He was intensely desiring that Mother should come to the temple and give him some spiritual experience. Mother gave him a bit of just that.

All was silent. Balu gazed at the Mother and wondered at the mystery of this complex personality, who in appearance was just an ordinary village girl, but in actual fact was a storehouse of infinite spiritual power. He sighed and put forth another question.

Balu: Mother, how can one escape from evil thoughts?

Amma: Evil thoughts start coming up when we try to remove them. Previously we did not know that there were so many evil thoughts in us because we were completely immersed in

them alone. That is all. We feel that they are evil thoughts after we have developed a different attitude from before and now want them removed. Bad thoughts might arise during meditation. Then you should think, “O mind, is there any benefit in cherishing these thoughts? Do these have any value?” By thinking like this, you should reject unnecessary thoughts. Complete dispassion must come. Detachment should arise. The conviction that the sense objects are equal to poison should become firmly rooted in the mind. Always tearfully pray to God, “O Lord, please let me see You. You are my life; You are the Eternal One. Mind, why do you crave all these silly and meaningless things? They cannot give you the happiness which you thirst for. These are not the things which I asked you to seek.” Change will slowly come about through prayers to God and through questioning the mind.

Children, this is only the beginning. You should try hard. Cry to God while sitting alone under a tree or in any other solitary place, “O Father, O Mother, why am I thinking about such things? Isn’t sensual pleasure equal to a dog’s excreta and a mere illusion?” In due course, evil thoughts will go away.

Different paths

Question: Are many different paths needed to know God? Why are there the paths of knowledge, action, devotion and yoga?

Amma: Some people like to eat fried jackfruit. Others like to eat the ripened fruit. Yet others like to have it cooked as *aveel* or *toran* (two different vegetable preparations). For some it is not good for their stomach if they eat it ripened. Some others will become sick if they eat it fried. Even though the aim is to appease hunger, one type of food is not suitable for all. According to the taste and bodily constitution of the child, the

mother gives food. In the same way, the Guru instructs the disciple in which path he should choose and gives advice according to his character or nature. The sole intention is to reach the goal.

Different paths will suit different types of people. Concentration of mind is what is important. Some people will not get devotion. They will strive by controlling their breath while they meditate on the *kundalini*. Others who are very dynamic and creative will walk in the path of *ṛkarma* or action. *Bhakti yoga* or the path of devotion is the path wherein the devotee will have the attitude that everything belongs to God. Nothing and no one is one's own. In this path we are humble. The attitude of a servant, of being a nobody, will be there. Thus there are different paths.

There are many who talk about the path of knowledge. Mother has observed plenty of them. One sees no practice in action, only mere talk. They will say that everything is *Brahman*, the Absolute. If that is so, shouldn't they see others as one with themselves? But that is not usually the case. Those who are fit to walk in the path of knowledge will have a strong spiritual disposition inherited from the previous birth. The practice of knowledge is spontaneous for them. Others, in the name of knowledge, do nothing but babble and inflate their egos. They do harm to themselves and to others as well.

Whatever the path, a Perfect Master is a must, especially if practicing the path of knowledge or the path of yoga. Doing *sadhana* based on mere book knowledge is dangerous, especially if following either of the above two paths. Mother cannot approve of those people who walk around saying that they are practicing the path of knowledge. Their knowledge is only verbal. That is not what is needed. He is a real *Jnani* who is born with such a spiritual disposition inherited from

the previous birth. Other than such a one, nobody will become a *Jnani* just like that.

Question: It is said that one can see light in meditation.

Amma: *Sadhaks* who follow the path of devotion might not see it. That is mainly for *raja yogins*. For those who follow the path of yoga, that will happen when the mind becomes one-pointed. *Bhakṭi yogins* cannot see it so easily. They meditate on a form, don't they? Children, you need not pay attention to such things as seeing light. If you do happen to see it, do not give it too much importance. The Truth is far beyond all such things. Therefore, try to transcend light and reach the Truth.

Question: It is said that those who meditate on Mother Kali will get Her *darshan* quickly.

Amma: Do you know why that is so? Our mind will easily get fixed on Her *rudra bhava* (fierce aspect). (Smiling) That is predominating in our character, isn't it? Most of us are *rajasic*. Kali's form is suitable for a *rajasic* mind. Once the mind gets fixed on the form, if the *sadhak* continues with the same intensity and sincerity, the Deity will appear before him. Concentration of mind is all-important. Once the mind is conquered, everything else will become easy. All forms are only for gaining concentration. Among those, the form of Kali is special in that the mind will quickly get fixed on it. But Ultimate Realization is possible only through the eradication of *vasanas*.

Question: Is there any relationship between the form of worship that we are doing in this birth and that of our previous birth?

Amma: The Deity which we loved and worshipped in our previous births will become our Beloved Deity in the present birth. A real Guru will give only the form of the previous birth to worship in the present one. Even if the disciple is meditat-

ing on a different form, the Guru will give the correct one instead. The tendencies of the previous birth will subtly remain in a person. It is our experience that in accordance with our past tendencies, we will spontaneously exclaim, “Oh, my Krishna!” or “Oh, my Devi!” or other Divine Names when we accidentally fall down.

Question: Does the form have any significance other than as a support for concentration?

Amma: Some forms are products of devotees’ imaginations. Yet other forms are of Divine Personalities who actually lived in the past like Sri Rama or Sri Krishna. They are not simply imaginary forms meant only for concentration. As you know, Lord Buddha, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and Jesus Christ were great souls who lived at one time. Likewise, Sri Rama and Sri Krishna were Divine Incarnations who lived on this earth. They were not mere mythical heroes. Perhaps Devi might also have incarnated to slay unrighteous people. The story of the Ramayana takes place not only within us but it also happened externally. Krishna’s story also is actual history. Thus, all these have historical importance in addition to being forms of meditation. But these forms are not enough for a *tapasvi*. He should give up the form and go beyond. That is why Mother says,

*There is no tree which touches the sky;
There is no root which reaches the nether world.*

All forms have limitations and possess only certain defined qualities. We should go beyond them to God, who in truth, is *nirguna* (attributeless). However, we can reach there only by clinging to a form.

Question: What about meditation on a light?

Amma: Different people resort to different means in order to get concentration. All methods are there in Hinduism. God is there in whatever you see. If you think of Him as a blade of grass, He will give you *darshan* even in that form. For gaining concentration, you can use any prop, but you should have faith in it. We are the ones that give life to the form.

Suppose someone has a piece of his girlfriend's sari. When he looks at it, he will remember her. The value is not in the piece of sari but in her whom he sees through it. Therefore, it is priceless; it is not mere thread for him.

Depending upon one's individual capacities, the Guru will advise whichever path will enable one to reach the goal easily. However much *Advaita* (Non-duality) you talk, without concentration and a pure resolve (*suddha sankalpa*), no spiritual achievement is possible. For that, *sadhana* is needed.

There stood a hollow tree by the side of the road. A passerby said, "That is hollow, it is good for nothing." Another person said, "Not so, various things can be made from it." The first man ignored the second and walked away. The second man, however, cut the tree and removed all the decayed portions from the good wood. Though it needed a lot of effort, he could make what he intended. While the first man carelessly walked away saying that the tree was useless, the second man acquired the furniture which he made out of it. He gave life and form to it.

There is a son in Chettikulangara (a village about thirty kilometers from Vallickavu) who brought some very nicely made small desks to the Ashram one day. They were ideal to use as writing tables for *brahmacharins* and would have cost more than a hundred rupees if they had to be purchased. He made them by using pieces of waste iron which he found by the side of the road that had been thrown away after some construction work. He also found some pieces of pressed board

and rusty hinges which had been kept in a heap by the side of the road. For those who had thrown these things away, they were just trash. But this person saw the desk in those objects. When an artist sees a piece of waste paper, he sees the flower which he can make out of it. He doesn't see it as waste. In a similar manner, those who have reached the state of Pure Consciousness will see That alone in whatever they see. Because we haven't reached that state, we see only the chaff and not the Essence. We see only faults and drawbacks in others.

It was four o'clock in the afternoon. After saluting the Mother, Balu left Her room and went to the meditation hall. The *brahmacharins* were getting ready to chant the *Bhagavad Gita*. Having finished Her bath, the Mother came downstairs. Her resplendent form and benign smile filled the devotees with joy. They all stood with palms joined in reverence. A few of them had not had the chance to see the Mother during the morning *darshan*. The Mother took them to the hut. Amongst them was a very young bank officer who was a good *sadhak* as well and very interested in becoming a *brahmacharin*. As an inquisitive young man, he always would ask several questions to the Mother. As the Mother was giving *darshan*, he tried to clear his doubts.

Young man: What attitude is indispensable for a *sadhak* in the beginning?

Amma: Humility. The *sadhak* should always try to cultivate and develop humility. This is the first and foremost quality that is needed. Humility means obedience, surrendering one's ego and leading a life in submission to the Divine Will, that is, implicit obedience to the words of the Guru. The Guru is all-pervading, and therefore, a *sadhak* should try to consider

everything that happens to him as his Guru's wish. When that attitude comes, humility will manifest spontaneously.

Children, when the seed is sown beneath the soil it should feel, "I am nothing, I am nobody." With the dawning of that attitude, the seed germinates and the seedlings sprout. Humility is needed if you want to know the real "I." First you should cultivate that.

I do not care whether others love me or not. But what I want is to have a selfless attitude towards each and every person and thing in this world. *Sadhana* is done to attain that. We will not get this attitude in the beginning, but we should try constantly.

Children, always try to chase away the "I." It is a customary rule that a peon should show respect to his superior officer. That is his duty and there is no greatness in it. But an officer's greatness is seen when he respects the peon. Children, likewise, your progress lies in showing humility even towards a beggar. Mother does not see any greatness in your showing respect only towards Her. What Mother looks for is whether you children respect others or not, whether you children are selfless, or whether your attitude is egoistic towards others, whether you have humility or whether your attitude is, "I cannot bow down." These are the things which Mother cares about. *Sadhana* is for destroying the *vasanas*, but many people are nourishing them instead. This is not good. In the beginning, you should develop a good character. That character will guide you afterwards.

Question: Mother, which *asana* is the best?

Amma: Any *asana* in which one can sit comfortably is the real *asana*. You can sit in any way that suits you. In the circus there are those who work hard to learn tightrope walking. Later they can perform feats while doing so. They can even dance while standing on the tightrope. The same is the case when

learning to ride a bicycle. First we carefully learn to ride. Even though we might fall down several times, we still continue to ride. In due course we can show any feat. In the same way, in the beginning you should practice any one *asana* and attain perfection in that. Later there will be no problem in whichever *asana* you sit. Then you can meditate even lying down. But first you should reach that state.

With a hesitant look on his face, one *brahmacharin* approached the Mother. For some reason he wanted to go home. **Amma:** Children, it is not good to mingle with the family and other worldly people. In the beginning we should avoid worldly people. Otherwise it will not be possible to progress spiritually. Those who want to learn to ride a bicycle go to an open ground. Nobody would try to learn to ride a bicycle in a crowd. You don't want to hit somebody in the back. You should keep away from crowds in order to avoid accidents. Here Mother sings devotional songs, sits in *Bhava Darshan* and does different spiritual things without a moment's rest. All these make the people think of God. The *brahmacharins* chant the *Bhagavad Gita* and Vedic mantras. Even at that time we are thinking of God, aren't we? We may not have the patience to always sit and meditate with our eyes closed, which is difficult in the beginning. Slowly the mind will get established in God through these various means. When we practice in this way, we are not away from God for even a minute.

Chant your mantra always, even while taking bath or sitting on the toilet. Do not mingle too much with worldly people. The family people do not have the same amount of attachment towards you which you children have towards them. Their attachment ends when they understand that there is no benefit for them to be gained from you. Then why do you go there and intrude on them while expressing your love?

Children, try to do *sadhana* without wasting time. Once you have tied the cow, how can it get up and walk even if you shout, “Hey cow, walk!” Similarly, one cannot reach God while being in bondage. Do not try to row the boat after you have tied it to the shore.

Many people are destroying themselves by robbing and murdering for selfish gains or simply for harming others. Children, Mother is raising you to lead these people to the Supreme State. Show them the correct path, even if you have to sacrifice your own comforts.

Question: Some argue that *grahastashrama* (married life) is good while others say that *sannyasa* (renunciation) is good. Which is the best one to accept?

Amma: Children, each is great in its own way. A householder who leads a life of sacrifice, abandoning all selfish desires and performing all his actions dedicated to God, is undoubtedly great. A monk who gives up all sensual pleasures and leads a life of self-surrender and renunciation is also great. But today no one leads a married life correctly in accordance with the scriptures.

Here in this world there are many ditches and stagnant ponds wherein harmful germs flourish. A *sadhak*’s aim is to unite all these ponds of individual souls which are so harmful to the world and make them flow into the Ocean of *Brahman*. This world is filled with wicked actions and mutually opposing attitudes. A *sannyasin* should make human beings attain the realization of the Supreme Essence and thereby destroy all wickedness. That is what we come to spiritual life for.

Oh! How many people are in anguish! So many kinds of suffering exist -- no sleep, no food. During *Devi Bhava* and even at other times, Mother’s clothes will get soaked with the tears of the worldly people. Almost every person bursts into tears when they come near Mother. What for? They say,

“Mother, I don’t have any children,” “I am not getting that money,” “I cannot go there,” “They are scolding me.” Thus they have hundreds of sorrows. We have to look after their affairs. A spiritual being’s aim is not to get married and look after a family. The whole world is in us. We should have a feeling of responsibility like a king has towards his subjects. We should have the attitude, “These are all our subjects; they are suffering. We must save them.” Rama abandoned Sita for the good of the world. Why can’t we renounce our small selfishness? In due course we may be able to give up bigger things. Only then can we look after the world. How can selfish people make the world good? Ravana was destroyed because he lived for himself. Rama protected the world through His selflessness. We should imitate that. We should always imitate the *Mahatmas*. Even in His last moments, Jesus Christ prayed, “O Lord, forgive them for they know not what they do.” Krishna bestowed Liberation on the hunter who shot Him with an arrow. Such selflessness is needed. A *sannyasin* selflessly serves others. How will a householder who is himself suffering and immersed in selfishness be greater than a *sannyasin*? While a householder supports just one family, a *sannyasin* is obliged to support the whole world. *Brahmacharins* and *sannyasins* are the people who give peace and consolation to the world.

Moreover, a *sannyasin* is not a *bhogi* (one who indulges in sensual pleasure) like most householders, but is a *tyagi* (renunciate). Some people will say that such a life is too difficult. Let them say so. Our prayer is, “O Lord, give me the anguish caused by a life of renunciation so as to help me merge in You. Give me the longing to call You. Then only can I see you everywhere and serve You in everyone.

If one is a *grahasthashrami* (one leading a householder’s life strictly in accordance with the scriptural injunctions) he will

be a *tyagi*, but a mere *grahastha* (a married person who cares not for the life of a real householder) will never be so.

Whatever action one engages in, the mind should be in God. Haven't you seen "*Ammankudam Tullal*" (an ancient folk dance in India connected with Goddess Durga in which the dancers move rhythmically with decorated brass pots on their heads)? Whatever gestures they may make, their mind is fully on the pot which is on their heads. In the same way, our mind should always remain on God. God is the only object which always gives bliss. But in the beginning we should exert ourselves a little. Mother makes the children suffer a little here. Do you know why? These children have never known what life's sufferings are. They have all led comfortable lives before coming here. They must know what suffering is, what sorrow is. Only then will they be able to understand the sufferings of others. Only then can they serve them selflessly and wholeheartedly and know the gravity of the situation.

Do you know why the parents fondle their children? Because the children were born as a result of the parents' moments of pleasure. They have many expectations. Whereas, Mother got these children (the *brahmacharins*) as the fruit of Her suffering. Mother had done years of severe penance without even drinking water. That is why these children are coming to Mother now. Mother has no expectations except to take them to the Ultimate Goal. But that is not possible if they don't work hard. Children, you should love all. Only then will God love you. The state of equanimity is the real God.

It was *Devi Bhava* day. There were many people, so it was four in the morning when the *Bhava Darshan* was over. At the end, Brahmacharin Pai chanted a Sanskrit hymn composed by the great sage Sri Adi Sankara.

O Mother, I do not know the mantras or yantras (mystic diagrams) which reveal Your greatness. Nor do I know Your hymns and invocations, nor the stories of Your glory or the way of Your meditation. I do not know Your mudras (hand poses) or the way of worshipping You. O Mother, I know only one thing: if one chooses Your path, one will be saved from the miseries of life.

One could see that Pai was singing with his whole heart. As he sang he became overwhelmed with devotion and burst into tears. It became difficult for him to complete the chant. Brahmacharin Rao also shed tears of bliss. The young bank officer was also in rapture. On the previous day Pai had complained to the Mother, “Nowadays I don’t have the longing of devotion.” It was obvious that Mother had showered Her grace on him this day.

In the Mother’s Ashram quite often one could see the *brahmacharins* shedding tears of devotion while singing *bhajans*. The Holy Mother Herself has said several times that in this dark age of materialism there will be a band of youths who would relinquish all worldly pleasures and, fortified with the zeal of spirituality and love for God, would disseminate spiritual light throughout the world.

28 December 1983

It was afternoon when several young men came to see the Holy Mother. The *brahmacharins* welcomed them and after showing them around the Ashram, brought them to the front verandah of the temple. Soon the Mother came and sat in Her usual place where She sits during *bhajan* time. The young men, not knowing how to show respect to the Mother, remained standing. The Mother asked them to sit down and

added, "Children, it is enough if you respect yourself." Having said this, She smiled graciously.

Amma: Children, where are you from?

One young man: From Trivandrum.

Amma: Did all of you have your lunch?

Some time passed in silence while the Holy Mother sat in an absorbed mood with eyes closed. The young men closely observed Her. After a few minutes the Mother made a whirling motion with Her right hand which formed a mudra and chanted, "Shiva, Shiva..." Then She opened Her eyes.

One young man: We believe in scepticism and Marxism. We would like to know and understand the activities in this Ashram.

Amma: Son, each person's experience is his guru. Scepticism, Marxism and other similar philosophies are good, but are you actually able to live up to those principles? If you can, you do not have to accept anything else. People talk a lot but do very little. Talking and doing are two different things. Anybody can go on talking about the high ideals of life for days together, but if you observe their life, it will not have any connection with what they say. Such people cannot do any real service to society. The impact which they create among the people will be short-lived. Nobody will remember them after their death.

Take the case of Rama, Krishna, Buddha, Christ and other such great souls. They lived aeons ago, but even today people remember them and worship them. Why? Because they lived the ideals which they spoke of. They could bring about great transformations, both in the minds of the people and in society. Even today thousands are inspired by them. They were not mere talkers but doers as well. They were not receivers but givers of everything that they had. They were the real leaders, real thinkers and real reformers. Whereas, we are

neither leaders nor thinkers nor reformers but mere receivers. Mother does not claim any greatness. You are intelligent. Observe what is going on here and come to a logical conclusion. Mother wants you to think; She does not want to impose any ideas on you.

Therefore, children, what Mother says is that whatever may be your political party or principle, try to live by those ideals. Mother does not criticize the ideals; they are good. But live them; that will save both you and the country.

The young men were tongue-tied. Their intention was to corner Mother by presenting their ideals very logically, proving everything else as hollow and meaningless. Now what could they say when the Mother Herself supported their point of view? They seemed to be thinking something but did not utter a word.

Amma: If somebody happens to scold us or quarrel with us, we will hate him and might even beat him due to our enmity towards him. Sages have no enmity towards anyone. They have no political party. They love those who oppose them. That is what the sages and other noble characters of our epics did.

One devotee: Mother also does the same.

Amma: Namah Shivaya! Mother is your servant.

Young man: Mother, will you show *siddhis* (occult powers)? Are they not all fake?

Amma: (Smilingly) Mother does not have any *siddhis* and She never shows *siddhis* either. *Siddhis* have nothing to do with spirituality. Materializing things is against Nature's law. That law should be respected. If they want, great souls can break this law, but usually they will not unless an emergency arises. Nobody can create what does not exist. Only things which are already existing can be materialized. After all, why should

anyone do that? Such things as a watch or ring or necklace are available in the market.

Self-Realization is a state of perfect mental balance by which one can face all the situations of life without weeping over the painful and rejoicing over the pleasant. Welcoming both pleasure and pain while abiding in peace, and going beyond them considering them as the very nature of life, this is Self-Realization. This is not the same as showing *siddhis* in the way you are thinking.

Young man: But what about the general talk going around that many people had divine experiences when they came here?

Amma: That is their faith. One will be benefited through faith. Faith in the doctor is needed even for the success of the treatment. If we see certain powers in others that we do not have, is it sensible to say that they are false? Try to understand what that is. That is what is needed, is it not?

Children, accept what Mother says if you find it agreeable. Where there is concentration, there is power (*shakti*). Those who have it will show many things. If you want, you can call that power illusory. A river which flows through many branches will not have a powerful current. If the branches are redirected and the river is made to flow only through the main stream, the force of the current will increase greatly. It may even be possible to generate electricity from such a strong current. Similarly, at present our mind is flowing out towards hundreds of sense objects. If the mind is controlled and focused on one point, tremendous power will be generated which can be used to do wonderful things. What is the secret behind the powers of a magician or hypnotist? It is their power of concentration. They have developed it partially; spiritual beings develop it fully.

Siddhis are shown due to the desire of the people to see them. The Real Gem is within us. People are after *siddhis*, the imitation gold, instead of knowing and understanding that Real Thing. We are walking around begging without knowing this fact.

Once Mother had been invited to a certain place. The hosts and other devotees there started singing *bhajans*, but all of their attention was fixed on the sacred ash which was pouring out of the Deity's picture. What a pity! Mother told them, "You are wasting your time looking at ash which is available in the marketplace if you pay ten paise. You will be benefited more if you look at the Deity's Feet."

Try to live according to the principle of real spirituality. If you are after *siddhis*, your desires will go on increasing, resulting in bondage. We came to this world to free ourselves from these bondages, not to get more and more entangled. Mother is here to help remove desires, not to create them.

People who crave to see *siddhis* do not even need a Beloved Deity. They want only the things which the *siddha* creates. They will always be thinking, "Now he is going to create this, now he is going to create that!" They are even ready to give up the *siddha* for his *siddhis*. Do not go after those unworthy *siddhis*. Know the Self. Know who you are. That is what Mother has to say. There is nothing to gain by showing *siddhis*.

It was obvious that the young men were quite convinced. They also seemed to be very taken in by the Mother's simple and lucid explanations.

Amma: Children, everything will be known spontaneously if you do *sadhana*. Understand who you are. Know the Self. Then you can lead a life without attachment to anything. Such a state of mind will come if you do *sadhana* sincerely.

Even modern science accepts spirituality and the benefits

gained by the world from a real *tapasvi*. A hypnotist will hypnotize people. But later, he himself will collapse. He is like a battery; he will have power only if he charges, not otherwise. Both a *tapasvi*'s and hypnotist's power is gained through concentration. But the *tapasvi* always has that power. Other people use it for base things and will lose the power. They gain it only through unnatural means. The *sadhak*, on the other hand, acquires that power through severe and constant penance. Other people cannot sustain such austerity, but the *tapasvi* constantly lives in it. A hypnotist's power will go on diminishing and finally will get destroyed. But a *tapasvi*'s power never decreases; he is always full. A hypnotist hypnotizes another person by looking at him and instructing him. But he can do this only to a person whose mind is weaker than his own, not to those with stronger minds. A *tapasvi* becomes the very Self of everything. His will is universal. He can do anything and everything if he wills it so. Through rigorous spiritual practices, he becomes an unending storehouse of spiritual power. His battery will go on charging, not diminishing. The power of other people will easily be lost due to the inability to re-charge their power through concentration.

Even though the whole sugarcane is sweet, we will not eat the entire thing. Having swallowed the juice, we will throw away the stalk. Likewise, children, you do not have to accept everything that spiritual science says. Accept it only after observation.

Question: What about characters like Sri Krishna in the epics; aren't they just mere fictional characters?

Amma: We cannot say that Sri Krishna never existed and that He is a fabricated character. Everything about His birth and life are clearly delineated in the *Srimad Bhagavatam* and *Mahabharata*. The time and star of His birth and the incidents

which occurred during His life up to the time of His leaving the body are described in detail. Even today people celebrate His birthday. Hundreds of thousands of people have been and even now are inspired by Him. They praise Him and worship Him. How can a mere character born of the imagination of a poet create such an impression in the minds of people to even transform their lives? In addition to this, there are many things which give proof of Sri Krishna's birth and His activities in this world. Many places connected with His life still exist. We know those places where He lived and reigned. Sri Krishna was born, lived in the world and led a kingly life, yet showed us the path to Eternity, setting an example in every way. Is this possible in the case of a mere romantic character? Krishna is both within and without. At the same time, He is the Supreme Self. He did live in a human form but a *sadhak* should turn inwards and try to see Him there.

When worldly people look at subtle truths with their gross intellects, they cannot see anything. Do not say that a thing does not exist simply because you cannot see it. Most of us have never seen our forefathers; yet, isn't it meaningless to say that they never existed? Our own existence is the proof of theirs.

If you look at a map of Kerala, you can see a place called Oachira. In our part of the country Oachira is considered as a very important place. But in a map of India or a world map, it may not be visible. Because of that, is Oachira non-existent? It is foolish to think so.

Question: What is the benefit of *sannyasa*?

Amma: Children, do you have the patience to understand those things if Mother tells you? If so, Mother will tell you. Everything necessary will come to the place where a *tapasvi* sits. He doesn't have to go out searching. Worldly objects are not a problem for him. He always experiences bliss in the

vision of the Real Gem. He is blissful even in the dirtiest place. Circumstances cannot enslave him. He is the master of them. Because he has overcome all sorrow and is completely peaceful, he is capable of giving peace and happiness to others, eradicating their sorrow and disappointment.

A real *sannyasin* is a real servant of the world. In fact, he is the only one who serves and loves the world without receiving anything in return. For a genuine *sannyasin*, the whole world is a garden and each individual is a flower therein. He belongs to the whole world. He has no particular caste, creed, sect or religion. Everyone has equal rights to him.

How many people can get a job if there is a factory? Likewise, how many people can get peace of mind if there is a real *sannyasin*? How many people get transformed, inspired and become aware of the higher values of life because of him? The question, “Why *sannyasa*?” will not arise if you understand the great things done by *sannyasins*.

A lover will always think of his beloved. Spiritual beings also have this nature. They will imagine, “My Lord is like this, He is like that...” Thus through *bhavana* (imagination) the Lord’s nature will dawn in them. God will say, “I am attributeless, I am all-compassionate, I am Love, Truth, I reside not in a particular world, I am all-pervading, I am in all of you.” To imbibe and imitate these qualities, a medium is needed. Therefore, accepting the sages or *Mahatmas* as models, we should try to imbibe their qualities. Trying again and again, we will become That Itself, just like the plant “*vettapacca*” which becomes ink-colored when immersed in a bottle of ink. Do not think that we can understand the spiritual world without striving hard.

Householder and sannyasin

Question: Isn't a householder who looks after his family greater than a *sannyasin*?

Amma: No, that is not correct. A householder who looks only after his family is not greater than a *sannyasin*. But a householder who leads his life in a spirit of renunciation is. Both are great if they are observed in the correct spirit. Attitude is the important thing. How you do a thing is more important than what you do. A *sannyasin* is one who renounces everything and sees everything as equal to a blade of grass, be it a princess or the whole world and its pleasures. He tries to free himself from the sorrow caused by *samsara*. He even helps others in that. No dexterity is needed to enjoy pleasures, but mental strength is needed to cast away pleasures regarding them as equal to a blade of grass. Spirituality is for a courageous person. A householder is equally great if he leads a detached life surrendering everything to God, accepting all his experiences, both good and bad, as His blessed gift. But for most people it is difficult to lead a detached life while living with the family. Somehow or other one will get bound. Otherwise, one needs to have a tremendous amount of mental strength and detachment to lead such a life.

A real householder should be able to renounce everything whenever he wants to. He should be like a bird sitting on a dry twig. The bird knows that the twig will break at any moment. Therefore, it will be ready to take off at any time. Likewise, a householder should always have the awareness that worldly relationships are momentary and may break at any time. Therefore, like the bird, he should be ready to cast off all bonds and leap into spirituality. He should have the firm faith that all the actions in which he is engaged are just temporary work entrusted by God. Like a faithful servant he

must be able to do everything without the sense of ownership. Whenever the Master, God, asks him to stop, he must be able to do so. God is the employer and we are the employees. The employee does the work entrusted to him with sincerity, but at the same time, he knows that nothing is his. Whenever the owner or employer asks him to quit the job, he does so without any objection. In the same manner, a householder should be ready to give up all pleasures and worldly comforts whenever he wants to do so. He should do his duty but as a *sadhana*, as a worship to the Lord.

God is one

Young man: Many troubles are created in the name of the gods! Do you have anything to say about that?

Amma: Gods? There are not many gods. There is only one God. The different forms are only to enable people to adopt and use the form which they like, according to their mental tendencies. In this way the goal is attained easily. People in different countries call Him by different names. God is not many because of that. Sometimes in movies the same person will enact the role of Krishna, Bheema and Arjuna. The person is one, but the costumes are different. In the same way, God is one but is known under different names and forms. The same girl is looked upon as a sister by her brother and as a wife by her husband. The younger brother sees her as his eldest sister. There is no change in the person; she is the same girl. In a similar way, the Power is one but the names differ.

Now about the troubles. God is not needed for that. There are enough trouble-making evil *vasanas* in human beings. In fact, all troubles are created by our own ego and negative tendencies. These evil tendencies will create problems in the name of property, wealth, women, politics, false prestige, com-

petition for greatness and the like. It is the nature of human beings to quarrel in the name of something or other, most of the time in the name of silly and meaningless things. They quarrel even in the name of God. Those who do not have faith in God will create trouble in the name of something else. Thus the aim of having faith in God and real spirituality is to remove the evil tendencies which cause these troubles in the first place.

Therefore, it is not God or our faith in God which is the cause of the existing troubles in the world, but rather our non-belief in God. Our own ego is the troublemaker. Real believers in God and spiritual people are peace lovers. In fact, they are the messengers of peace and love. Do not see other people's faults.

The young man sat there silently immersed in thought. Then the Holy Mother continued,

Amma: Children, you will see only faults if you are keen on that. If you search for the good, you will find that. We can see people who lead an extremely evil life, walking around, saying evil things about good people. It is more difficult to see good in others.

It seemed that the young men were a bit humbled. They had nothing to say and simply listened attentively to the Mother's words of wisdom. Their prejudice might have made them think that they could have handled this "uneducated fisher-girl" easily. After a short pause, the Mother continued, **Amma:** There were two women who lived in neighboring houses. One was a munificent lady and the other a prostitute. The prostitute was a poor lady and had no other way of making a living. However, each time she committed a sin, she prayed to God with great remorse for forgiveness. The other lady, although she was munificent, always spoke critically of her prostitute neighbor to anyone who came to visit

her. Having given something in charity, she would tell them, “Look, that woman is a prostitute. Don’t go there.” She would say this even to beggars. Having heard of this criticism and the fact the neighboring lady had talked about her manner of making a living to all the visitors, the prostitute’s mind was always filled with repentance. She sincerely prayed to God for forgiveness. Years rolled by and both of the ladies died. As she was very charitable in nature and was respected by the people, the munificent lady’s dead body was cremated with reverence and honor, but there was not even one person to attend to the corpse of the prostitute. Somebody took it and threw it in a graveyard where it was pecked at and eaten by vultures and dogs. However, interestingly enough, the prostitute’s soul ascended to heaven and the munificent lady’s soul went to hell. Children, do you know why? Because although the first lady was munificent in nature, her mind was always keen on finding fault with the other lady. Therefore, her body which did all the charity was cremated with all honors, but her soul, which was only keen on finding fault with the other lady, went to hell. In the prostitute’s case, with her body she did wrong things, but her mind was always intensely repenting and praying. Therefore, her body was treated befittingly and her soul went to heaven as a reward for her pure mind. This will be the result if we sit looking at other people’s faults instead of correcting our own wrong attitudes.

The Mother sat silently with eyes closed uttering “Shiva, Shiva.” After a few seconds, She opened Her eyes and continued.

Amma: Children, what is the benefit in walking around looking at the faults of others and talking about scepticism and other “isms”? Day by day you will be spoiling yourself, that’s all. It is said that as you think, so you become. How can one

make others good when he himself has not become so. Even if we intend to, it is not so easy to become so. When such is the case, how will it be if we try to make the world good? Is the world so small that it can be made good just by thinking? God will look after all that. Without abandoning selfishness, no one can make the world good. Even great souls who were completely selfless could not make the whole world good with all their power of penance. Then what can be said about powerless, limited human beings who are completely under the sway of selfishness and ego? Children, instead of looking at others and criticizing them, try to correct yourselves first.

The young men gazed at Mother's face with wonderment. Again there was a pause followed by another question.

Question: There are more than thirty *brahmacharins* here. How are the expenses of this Ashram met?

Amma: That power which sent them here is looking after them. The help extended by the devotees is due only to the inspiration of that power. Not only that, those who stay here are people who are satisfied with what they have here. Even if they do not get certain things one day, they do not complain. But the Lord has never created such a situation. If something is needed today, it will somehow come. In this Ashram Mother has never asked anything from anyone, yet everything has come; everything was sent by Him. This is a place for *tyagis*, not for *bhogis*. Contentment in every circumstance, in all situations, is the trademark of a spiritual seeker. Only food sufficient to appease hunger is given here. Those who want something more need not come here.

Question: Is spiritual life necessary at such a young age? Wouldn't it be enough a little later in life?

Amma: That is left to them. Everyone has the freedom to choose their own path. Another person has no right to ques-

tion it. Why did you children choose the path of scepticism and Marxism? Because you have a natural inclination for that, haven't you? Each person has a different *vasana*, and it is that *vasana* which determines his field of action. There are others who like to drink only lemonade or fresh water. We should not be adamant, saying that everyone should like tea. These children accepted what they liked; that is their *vasana*. Even in worldly life among members of the same family, some become doctors while others become engineers, scientists or even peons. Everything depends upon one's predominant mental disposition.

Also one should remember that the strength to do *sadhana* and search for the Truth will decrease as we get older. Then where is the time to think of God? Only those who have strong spiritual tendencies inherited from previous births will take to the path of spirituality while they are still young.

Question: Is there any benefit in *sannyasa*?

Amma: Nobody becomes a *sannyasin* for some benefit. The meaning of the word "*sannyasa*" is to give up even the thought about benefit. If there is any benefit, it is not personal. It is benefit for the whole world. It is a natural evolution of compassion and an attitude of renunciation alone. The world is really benefited only by devotees.

Mother would say that those who have enmity towards Mother actually love Her more than the devotees. Do you know why? Because their only thought will be, "Somehow this girl should be destroyed. She must be killed, do you hear, killed!" They think more about Mother and have more concentration than the devotees do. Kamsa⁹ attained Liberation

⁹ Kamsa was the king of Mathura in Sri Krishna's time. After hearing a prophecy that Sri Krishna would kill him, he was always thinking of Him and the way to dispose of Him before himself getting killed by Him.

because of his one-pointed thought of killing Sri Krishna. Devotees will not have the same intensity of concentration in meditation which a thief gets while stealing. Therefore, even those who oppose Mother are benefited by Her.

At this point the young men who boasted of themselves as sceptics were really humbled. They were convinced. The young man who asked the question said, "Mother, although we were misinformed, we now thank the person who told us about you because if he had not said anything we would have not known about you. We have never heard such clear and simple explanations to clear our doubts. Now we take leave of you. We will come and see you with our other friends." The young men saluted the Mother who affectionately patted them on the back chanting "Namah Shivaya." With palms joined in reverence, they took their leave.

Mother was invited to a devotee's house in Quilon, so the father of that family came in advance to bring Her. Sitting in the hut, the Mother was talking to him. It was four o'clock in the evening. Some of the *brahmacharins* came with questions. **Amma:** Do not waste your time always asking questions. Concentration on your *sadhana* is what is needed. Mother gave a mantra to everyone. Do not be puffed up because of that and think, "I am Mother's disciple." Do not feel proud thinking, "I have the ticket" after getting into a bus or train. If you do not show the ticket when the ticket collector comes, he will immediately make you get off. He will let you alight at your destination only if you use your ticket for the proper place and in the proper way. Otherwise, you will have to get off before your destination.

Until now, everyone has been entrusted with selling only peanuts. Those who succeed in that will be put in charge of a general goods store and if successful, from there to a whole-

sale shop. If successful there, they will be employed in selling gold jewelry. Next, you may be made the owner of a department store if you succeed in all the previous endeavors. After that, you do not have to do any work at all. Mother has no responsibility in the matter of those who fail in the business which would give supreme happiness forever.

Leaders

Now the Holy Mother started talking about discipline.

Amma: Mother has entrusted each one in the Ashram with a responsibility. Others should respect what they say. That is a sign of spiritual humility and discipline. Even though there are teachers in the school, a leader is necessary to enquire whether the students are talking unnecessarily or doing other things against the rules and regulations of the school. That is needed in spirituality also. In the Ashram, Mother may not be able to sit near Her children always. You should not be defiant towards them.

Brahmacharin: Mother, can one discontinue *yogasanas*?

Amma: *Yogasanas* can be performed in two different ways, as a technique of meditation and as an exercise for the internal organs. In both cases it is not good to stop completely. Especially in the beginning stages, you should keep a regular time for doing them without fail. If they are done properly as a meditation, your power of concentration will increase. As an exercise they will give strength and balance to your internal organs. If you want, you can reduce the number of *asanas* in due course, but do not stop completely as it might create physical discomfort.

Devotee: Mother, why have you incarnated in this nasty place?

Amma: There is no such thing as clean and unclean for Mother. The lotus flower grows in the mud. If there is no mud, there

is no lotus. Therefore, can we say that mud is bad? Mere manure is used as fertilizer for beautiful flowers, is it not? Looking at the manure in this way, can we say that it is dirty? There is no good and bad for people who are spiritually thirsty. They will come here whatever the surroundings. Besides, in the last five hundred years there has been no Ashram in this coastal area. That lack also should be removed, should it not?

Devotee: Whatever be the matter, some people will always oppose. That is the nature of the world.

Amma: Son, opposition is absolutely necessary. Only if there are black goats in a herd can the white goats be recognized distinctly. The beauty of the white sand is seen because black sand is there as well. The darkness of black reveals the lightness of white.

After the usual evening *bhajans*, Mother went with some of the *brahmacharins* and *brahmacharinis* to Quilon in a hired vehicle. When the driver increased the speed, Mother said, “Son, drive slowly.” Mother instructed everyone to sing *bhajans* when the people started talking. She Herself sang,

*O Divine Mother, Mother of the World,
O most courageous Mother,
Giver of Truth and Divine Love...*

*O Thou Who art the Universe Itself,
Courage, Truth and Divine Love...*

As the singing went on, the driver increased the speed again. In the midst of the singing, the Holy Mother loudly said, “Son, stop the car.” After slowing down, the car came to a halt and veered a little to one side. After getting out of the

car to enquire why the car had veered, the excited driver found that one of the wheels was about to slip off. Everyone sighed and looked at Mother with joined palms. What if the car had still been going at a high speed?

Later when Mother reached the devotee's house, She said, "It was a very bad time for you children. Your devotion and faith in God saved you." With tears in his eyes, the father of the family said, "It was all your grace, Mother."

29 December 1983

After returning from Quilon, the Holy Mother lay down on a mat spread under a coconut tree to take some rest. The *brahmacharins* who could not accompany Her to Quilon seemed like people who had been separated from Her for a long time. They came and sat near the Mother after prostrating to Her. A trace of anger was also seen on one brahmacharin's face. Understanding what was in his mind, the Mother smiled and said,

Amma: The flowers of the coconut tree will remain near the top of the tree until they become larger and then bend low. In the same manner, we must also bend low (become humble) as we mature. Many flowers will bloom on a tree from which all the leaves have fallen, making the flowers notably visible. On those trees which retain their leaves, flowers will be seen only here and there. The flowers of Godliness will diminish if the leaves of ego, jealousy and other negative qualities increase. The full Vision of God is possible only if all the evil qualities of the mind are removed.

Usually there are no waves in mid-ocean. The waves are only by the shore because there is no depth there. A *Jnani* will be calm. It is people who have read only two or three books who make a big noise. They have no depth.

Question: How can one see God in everything?

Amma: Children, you have faith in Incarnations like Rama and Krishna, haven't you? Thus, if you can visualize God in human forms, why can't you see Him in other objects too? Is not God all-pervading? If not, He is not God. He is in each and every atom. In the beginning one should cultivate this attitude with deliberate effort. As you progress with your *sadhana*, this feeling will become natural. Practice is needed to attain perfection in anything. When such is the case with mere worldly arts, what to say of the Ultimate Knowledge? All this will be understood if the mind is made one-pointed. Electricity is produced from flowing water. A river which flows in different branches is first obstructed by a dam. From the resulting powerful combined flow, we produce electricity. Likewise, the Vision of God is possible with the power which is gained through concentration of mind. At that time we will come to know that God is everywhere; everything is God. Do not make a fuss now. Be calm; wait patiently and do your *sadhana*.

Question: Mother, what is the benefit of *satsang*?

Amma: Students who study engineering take the help of various instruments. Above all, they seek the guidance of an experienced teacher. For realizing God, we must utilize the *Mahatmas* as a means; they are the guides. Without their help it is very difficult to travel on this path. They will protect the *sadhak* like a mother hen protects the chicks. In their presence, we can feel God. They are the only ones who desire nothing except the well-being and spiritual progress of the students. Now we are in the scorching heat of worldliness. Their presence is like the cooling breeze in the shade of a huge tree. *Mahatmas* are like the Kalpataru (wish-fulfilling tree). Therefore, take refuge in them. That is the benefit of *satsang*.

Brahmacharin: Mother, my past frightens me. Is there no way to escape it?

Amma: While travelling on a river, nobody racks their brains thinking of where the source is. There is no need to do so. Several failures might have occurred in your past. There is no meaning in wasting your time thinking about that. What has happened is over. What is needed is to mould your future. For that, live in the present. Do your actions in a better way, surrendering everything to a higher goal and seeking refuge in God. Do not grieve thinking of the past; that is foolishness. You are wasting both your energy and capacities by doing so. By worrying about the past your mind becomes weaker and weaker and you lose the strength to deal with the present. Remember that you are God's child and that He will protect you. In that way you will gain the strength required to face the difficulties.

Brahmacharin: Those who abuse Mother have no sense of shame and Mother will simply sit there smiling. How is that possible, Mother?

Amma: Shame and disgrace are there only as long as you think that you are the body. Once the body-consciousness is transcended, then all differences disappear. Then there is only Oneness. The feeling of Oneness arises from the realization of Pure Consciousness. In that state who can tease or abuse whom, what disgrace and what shame is there? Not only that. Mother grew only because of such abuses. Therefore, how can She feel sad when somebody speaks against Her, whoever they may be? Mother can only love them.

Japa and dhyana

Question: Sometimes during meditation, *japa* and *dhyana* happen simultaneously. Sometimes the form alone remains; *japa* becomes impossible. At some other times, both cannot be done. What can I do, Mother?

Amma: In the beginning stages of meditation, *japa* and remembrance of the form are both necessary. *Japa* should be done even if the form is not retained. After some time, one will reach a stage where one can focus on the form alone, at which point *japa* is neither necessary nor even possible. Now and then, some may feel that the mind has become blank. That is only a feeling. The mind will not become blank so easily but that feeling will lead to sleep. At that time, either remembrance of the form or *japa* should be done with alertness.

The mind cannot do two things at the same time. Therefore, while chanting the mantra with your lips, you can either concentrate on the form of your meditation or on the sound or on the letters of the mantra. Otherwise, focus your attention only on the form without chanting the mantra. Do not try to focus both on the form and the mantra. That is impossible. There will come a stage when repetition of the mantra will happen spontaneously at all times.

30 December 1983

The *brahmacharinis* were sitting in the dining hall chopping vegetables. A few women householder devotees were also helping them. The Holy Mother also joined them and began cutting vegetables. As far as Mother is concerned, no work is low. Sometimes She can be seen cooking in the kitchen. At other times one can see Her carrying bricks and sand with the residents. She will be seen sweeping the Ashram premises or doing other work. It is wonderful to watch the Mother on such occasions. She could do any work most beautifully within the shortest possible time that others might make a mess of even if they tried for hours on end. Understanding that some

of the devotees present were not chanting their mantra, the Holy Mother, as if to a *brahmacharini*, said,

Amma: Any work, especially cooking, should be done while chanting the Divine Name. Cutting vegetables and thinking about worldly things, is this what should be done by people who wish to lead a spiritual life? Many people will eat the food cooked by you. If you let your mind wander while cooking, that will affect those who eat it in a negative way. On the other hand, if you chant your mantra while cooking, that food will spiritually benefit those who eat it.

One of the householder devotees seemed to be perplexed. She felt that Mother was talking about her because she was not chanting her mantra. She started chopping vegetables chanting her mantra and said to the Mother, “Mother, please bless me to chant my mantra always.”

Mother smiled. Another woman devotee asked, “Mother, it is said that women should not do *japa* and *dhyana* during menstruation.

Amma: There is no meaning in that. One can do *japa* and *dhyana* at any time. Not only that, it is especially at that time that it is needed in order to maintain mental purity. During menstruation there will be an increase in negative thoughts and feelings. Therefore, always do *japa* and *dhyana* at that time.

It was nine o’clock in the morning. The Mother came out of the dining hall where many householder devotees were waiting to see Her. Going to the coconut grove with all of them, She asked them to sit down. As it was time for meditation, the Mother said to the devotees, “Let us meditate for some time. Children, sit closer.” The Holy Mother closed Her eyes and entered into *samadhi*. Sitting near the Mother,

the devotees also tried to meditate. The Mother opened Her eyes after half an hour or so. The devotees were anxiously waiting to be called by Her so they could each unburden their sorrows and sufferings at Her feet. The Mother called the devotees one by one. Some of them asked Mother to clarify their doubts.

Attain the state of desirelessness

Question: Mother, it is said that another birth is needed in order to enjoy sensual pleasures if one becomes a *sannyasin* before fulfilling the desire for enjoyment. Is that correct?

Amma: This is applicable only to a person who has many unfulfilled desires. There are many such people who take *sannyasa* due to the excitement of the moment. Later all their spirit and enthusiasm diminishes and the predominant *vasanas* will start manifesting one by one. Such people will not have the determination to do any *sadhana*. In due course, they will come completely under the sway of their *vasanas*. At the moment of death, such people will be thinking of their unfulfilled desires and expectations. They will have to take another birth according to their *vasanas* in order to enjoy the pleasures for which they longed.

Question: Suppose one became a *sannyasin* after reaching *bhogantya* (the end of sensual pleasures). He has burnt his *vasanas* through *sadhana*. In his case, is another birth needed?

Amma: No, but such people will be only one in a million. A general statement cannot be made using them as the criteria. Generally speaking, one will have to be born again if he does not reach *bhogantya*. Anyhow, one cannot satisfy all one's desires and then become a *sannyasin*. It is like standing on the seashore waiting to take a bath after all the waves have sub-

sided. It is also not possible to become satiated by satisfying our desires one by one.

Question: Mother, you said that satisfaction will not come through the enjoyment of desires. It is also seen that once people immerse themselves in pleasures, they get more and more drowned in them. If so, how is it possible to take *sannyasa* only after all desires end?

Amma: Children, you should discriminate while enjoying worldly pleasures. Through constant discrimination, you will reach a mental state where you can give up everything. Relatives, riches, sensual pleasures and the like can only give temporary happiness. They are all non-eternal. It is not the external objects which give us happiness. There are many people who have all material pleasures but are still unhappy and discontent. Many commit suicide even while living in air-conditioned rooms. If the air-conditioned room was the source of their happiness, then why should these people commit suicide in it? Therefore, even if we have everything, if there is no mental peace, we cannot lead a happy life. If you go on craving for worldly pleasures, happiness cannot be gained. Understand that objects are ephemeral. Search for the eternal; that is the real source of happiness, the Self. Be satisfied with what you have. Renounce greed, selfishness and jealousy. If you can do this, in due course you will reach the state where all desires end.

We will not get much of the taste of the food if we eat while holding our nose. Also there is no taste once the food goes down the throat. Therefore, taste is only a sensation of the tongue. If we think and discriminate in this way, we will get the ability to eat without caring about the taste of food. In this way, by removing delusion through discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal even while enjoying worldly pleasures, it is possible to renounce everything, attain-

ing the state where all desires end. Only a *sadhak* will understand this. Others will think that these are things which are impossible. There are many worldly people who argue that pure celibacy is not possible. They are speaking for themselves, that is all. It is impossible for them to think that there are higher stages beyond their own. Those who do proper *sadhana* can observe perfect *brahmacharya* (celibacy).

In the evening, the Mother went to the seashore with all the devotees. The sun was about to set, its red color spread over the horizon and reflected in the vast ocean. Having prostrated on the seashore, everyone sat down for meditation. The ocean waves chanted the sacred syllable “AUM,” and a cool, gentle breeze blew from the West. The seashore was very silent. It was an ideal atmosphere for meditation. The Holy Mother told the householder devotees,

Amma: Children, meditate fixing your minds on the sound “AUM” produced by the ocean waves. Or meditate imagining that your Beloved Deity, sitting on a lotus on the surface of the ocean, is beckoning you with Her or His hands.

Having said this, the Mother closed Her eyes in meditation. After half an hour, the Holy Mother got up and walked along the seashore by Herself. It was dusk. Sitting on a rock which lay a few yards away from the spot where the devotees were seated, the Mother started singing loudly. Hearing the song, the devotees slowly got up from their seats, went near the Mother and sat behind Her. Absorbed in Divine Love, the Mother sang,

*Aren't Thou my Mother, O aren't
Thou my dear Mother Who wipes away my tears?
Aren't Thou the Mother of the fourteen worlds,*

*The Creatress of the world?
 For how many days am I calling Thee,
 O Thou Whose nature is Shakti!
 Won't Thou come?*

An unearthly Divine Presence pervaded the atmosphere. The devotees became inspired by the Mother's cries and they too sang loudly. It seemed that they even forgot where they were sitting.

It was seven o'clock by the time the Mother returned to the Ashram with the devotees. As usual She distributed toffees to the fisher-children who would wait for Her along the way whenever the Mother went to the seashore.

31 December 1983

It was four o'clock in the evening. A group of college students came to see the Mother, having heard about Her from one of their friends. They were very curious to know and understand more about Her. It was clear from their demeanor that they were not the arrogant type. The Holy Mother was sitting in front of the temple and happily welcomed the young men, inviting them to come and sit on the temple verandah. They all sat a little distance away from the Mother. The Mother's natural way of enquiring about their names, native places, studies and other details really impressed them. When the light talk was over, one among the students humbly asked, **Question:** Mother, young men who are almost our same age are living here as *brahmacharins*. Is this not escapism? Is *sannyasa* necessary at such a young age? Is it not enough to take *sannyasa* after leading a worldly life? Mother, please do not think that I am asking this simply to argue. I am having this doubt.

Amma: (Smilingly) Children, what makes you argue for worldly life?

The students looked perplexed.

Amma: Children, you have attachments to your family and to many other things. Is that not the reason you give importance to worldly life? We won't argue for things which we are not interested in, for objects which we hate, will we?

Student: That is right.

Amma: All right, children, what is the nature of this love which binds us to the life of the world. Children, have you ever thought about it?

The students remained silent, keenly listening to what the Mother was saying.

Where does happiness come from?

Amma: Children, all the love which the world offers will ultimately lead us to sorrow. There is no selfless love in this world. Is our life to be destroyed just for the sake of a woman or two children? We feel that we will get happiness from those, yet happiness is not in any object. It is from within us. Happiness is experienced when the sense organs are concentrated. Suppose there is a nice song on the radio. Only if we concentrate on it will we derive any happiness from it, not otherwise.

Student: Of course.

Amma: Such is the case with everything. Suppose we put a *laddu* (a kind of sweet) in our mouth. It tastes good only if the mind is on that sweetness, doesn't it? Therefore, happiness is derived from concentration of the mind. We feel that happiness comes from a woman or other objects. If happiness is derived from concentration, it follows that it is not dependent

on any particular object. Momentary happiness is experienced when we concentrate on momentary objects. What then will be the amount of bliss gained if concentration is attained on the Lord, the eternal repository of all glory? In truth, there is no greater or lesser bliss if it is observed with a subtle intellect. Bliss is only one.

Happiness comes from within. The dog will bite the bone and think that the energy it gets from the blood of its own wounded gums is from the bone. We are also similarly deluded when we think that the bliss we get, in truth, from within, is coming from an external object. What the *Rishis* (sages) want us to do is to think, "What is this birth for? Why all these sorrows in the world? What is real peace? What is eternal?" One should think about all these questions. The objection that you raise about *sannyasa* being escapism is due to your thinking that the world will give you happiness. In reality, is there happiness in worldly life? It is true that we wander about for happiness. But is there any time bereft of agitation? Is there peace? Where is happiness without peace? How can Mother recommend that one should embrace the worldly life which gives only agitation ?

Student: The human race should exist, shouldn't it?

Amma: (Smilingly) Ah, to think about the preservation of the world by us who came yesterday and will go tomorrow! Shiva, Shiva! We ourselves do not have any existence. We will die today or tomorrow. Then how do we sustain the world? Is the world such a small thing for us to protect? God will look after that. Children, concentrate on the elimination of your own sorrow. Even that can be gained only through hundreds and hundreds of births. When such is the case, how are you going to sustain the world? Will the world continue to exist only if we get married and have children? The world will

exist even if none of us are here. To find a way to protect oneself is more intelligent.

Student: Will one be saved if one believes in Mother or in God?

Amma: (Smilingly) Mother will never tell the children who come here to lead a spiritual life to believe in Mother, or in a God sitting up in the sky. Have faith in yourself. Know who you are. Who am I? What is the sense of individuality? What power do I have? What can I achieve? One should know one's Self first. For that, one should live understanding what is eternal and what is transitory. To understand, through an analytical study, the true nature of the world in which we live, is discrimination between the eternal and non-eternal. Do not say that it is unnecessary. One who is serious-minded should think about what is the substratum of oneself and the world. Erroneously considering the visible world to be its own substratum, don't make a meaningless uproar.

Experience transcends reason

Amma: We will come to know that there is God when we ourselves search and understand the difference between *nitya* (the eternal) and *anitya* (the transient). With the eyes of ignorance, we can see only up to a certain point. Having looked with such eyes, we say that there is nothing beyond the point where our eyesight reaches. The external eyes cannot see things which lie behind a wall or a tree. When it is very dark we cannot even see a person who stands right in front of us. The sense organs are undoubtedly limited. We can see more when we become subtle.

Student: Sceptics blabber alot.

Amma: It is good if it is real rationalism (scepticism). But what if the sceptics are people who believe blindly? When

they say that there is no God, are they saying so after having searched for Him properly? Experience is beyond reasoning. For each subject there are people who are well-versed in it. The words of such people are the valid means of knowledge. Likewise in the spiritual field also, there are people who have experience. It is their words which are the most authentic source of knowledge about that subject. They have seen God and also prescribe ways to see Him.

Mother has seen the sceptics giving a picture of their leader to the people when distributing his books. They will keep the leader's picture even after his death. Is this not blind faith? Why do they keep the picture? Because they love and admire him. In the same way, we love God and so we worship His picture.

A sceptic became Mother's devotee. That son brought some books. In one of the books it said that Christ and Krishna never existed. In another one it was written that Christ was a revolutionary. Just think, a person who wasn't born was a revolutionary! And to think that they worship the pictures of the people who write such unworthy words. Spiritual people worship the pictures of pure souls.

Today's sceptics cannot be properly called sceptics. Only a person who has eaten a thing can say whether it is tasty or not. What does it matter if one states an opinion about God, without having searched for and attained a proper knowledge about Him? Who would consider the denial of chemistry of one who has not even studied the subject? And what value is there in the denial of the science of physics by one who has not studied physics? What benefit is there in such so-called scepticism? Some people say that the attainment of God's Vision is the experience of a neurotic patient. This implies that, according to them, all the great saints and sages of the past and even their followers were all neurotic. What a non-

sensical statement that is! All these “patients” had some visionary experience, some extraordinary universal revelation beyond individual neuroses. Mother is sure that those who think a little will not blabber nonsense like this. Those who have common sense will not believe their words either.

In the same way, what sense is there in saying that they (sceptics) will believe only in things which they can see? The ancient *Rishis* said that there are many suns and moons in space, not only one sun and one moon and modern science has proved it. But we cannot see them. Would these people say that these suns and moons do not exist because they cannot be seen by the naked eye? The *Rishis* proved the validity of all their experiences in their own laboratory. Whatever is said in the Vedas and Puranas is being proven true. Modern science agrees with these ancient texts. Still these so-called sceptics go on talking like tape recorders.

There is a Power beyond words, an Inexpressible Power, and that is God. Everyone says that it is within, but it is not enough merely to say so. It should be known through intuitive experience.

Didn't A.T. Koor (a famous rationalist) say, “My eyes should be given to the medical college after my death?” When one says “My eyes,” or “This is mine,” it is implied that the object is different from “you.” When he said “My eyes,” it was quite clear that he must be different from his eyes. Therefore, when he said, “Donate my eyes after my death,” it should be understood that A.T. Koor was not the corpse. The real “he” was other than the corpse. There was a consciousness which existed in that body. That consciousness is God.

Student: Some lead a pleasant life, some others a sorrowful one. Why is God's Will such?

Amma: God does not differentiate. It is our *bhavana* (conception) that projects a sense of difference on Him. Using God's

own power, we abuse Him or we say that there is no God. It is like saying with our own tongue, “I have no tongue.” We are not looking into ourselves. We are looking at other things. We don’t think at all. We stand ready to kill those who tell the real principles of spiritual life. How did they kill Jesus? How did they act towards Nabi? Weren’t there people who threw stones at Sri Narayana Guru when he was alive? Now they worship him. But those great souls did not have even an iota of bad feelings seeing all this injustice. They are the ones who took birth to set an example for the world.

Without showing partiality to anyone, the river flows at all times. Having made a dam across it, we will say, “Look at the partiality of this river. It doesn’t flow this way.” Having blocked the flow of the river, why should we blame it, saying that the river is not giving water? Having consciously rejected God’s grace, we say that He is partial and shows differences. That is due to our ignorance. We do not observe things subtly.

Question: Why should we offer various things to God? Is it not to please Him?

Amma: God is Light itself. He does not need our wax candles and other material offerings. Lighting a lamp for God and offering food to Him is for our satisfaction and expansion of heart. All that we see is God’s. Then what can we give Him? On the other hand, it is we who steal that which belongs to Him. The *Rishis* showed us the way of devotion based on knowledge, but we do not care about that.

Devotion based on knowledge

Question: Mother, what do you mean by that?

Amma: Practice devotion while knowing and understanding the essential principles of spirituality. The devotee’s attitude should be that God is all-pervading, omniscient and omnipo-

tent. All that we see is God. We should love God for God's sake, for devotion alone. We should love God selflessly. We should have pure devotion, loving for love's own sake without having any worldly desires. He who really loves God will worship Him, seeing everything pervaded by Him and serving others as His forms. These are the ways of devotion based on a knowledge of the essential principles.

Seeing God only in a particular form without understanding the real nature of Godhood is not true devotion. If God abides only in a particular form or place, being limited, He is no longer God. Many people who are devoted to temple worship have this kind of faith. They think that God is only in the inner sanctum of the temple. This kind of faith is harmful and will not help us progress spiritually. If Hinduism is viewed from the point of devotion based on spiritual principles, it is neither a religion nor a cult.

If we want mental peace, we should understand the difference between the permanent and the transitory and act accordingly. All our relatives will depart some day and we will be alone. Therefore, we should think about the real goal of life. If we live with that understanding, we will not even fear death. Our forefathers showed us that path but we do not follow it.

We should somehow gain concentration. Meditation and other spiritual practices are meant only for that purpose. Scientists make discoveries through concentrated investigations while sitting behind closed doors, don't they? Concentration is needed even for that. Everything will be spoiled if there is no concentration.

Children, all of us are searching for Eternal Bliss, but we will not get it from perishable objects. We should search for the Imperishable Self. That alone is eternal. It is that effort

which goes on in the Ashram.¹⁰ The children who stay here have enough wealth in their homes for their parents to live. None of them have to earn money for their families. Mother has forcibly sent those children whose families were not well-off, back to their homes. Let them look after their family affairs first and simultaneously do *sadhana*. At present, they can only do that much. Otherwise, what will the family do?

Solitude and regularity in one's routine are necessary in the beginning. Otherwise, it will be very difficult to achieve anything spiritually.

Question: Are there any servants in the Ashram?

Amma: No, there are no paid servants in the Ashram. The *brahmacharins* themselves do all the work while repeating their mantra. Before one scolds a laborer, he himself should know the laborer's sufferings. Therefore, the work in the Ashram should be done by each person. Life in the Ashram is difficult. How much difficulty is there in learning to ride a bicycle! How many times will one fall down in the beginning! When such is the case while learning worldly skills, is it possible to gain the bliss of the Self without undergoing difficulty? Suffering is not a problem for those who are intent on reaching the goal.

Advaita Vedanta

Question: Mother, do you teach Vedanta here?

Amma: First let us learn the alphabet. Then we can move on to compound letters. Is it enough to say, "I am *Brahman*?" We should express the nature of *Brahman* in our actions.

¹⁰This is a play on words. "That effort" in Malayalam is "â shramam." Mother is saying the "â shramam" takes place in the "ashramam (Ashram)."

Even if someone scolds us, we should be able to remain calm without getting angry. We should discriminate thus, "I am not the body, I am the Self. If I am the Self, then there is no need of sorrow." A person deserves to be known as one who has reached *Brahman* when he has an attitude of non-hatred. In that state he does not have the feeling of inferior or superior. Everything is within us. We are the Absolute Self. But it is not enough to merely say so. The feeling of being the Absolute should arise within us. Both the jackfruit and the seed of the jackfruit are *Brahman*. The jackfruit is capable of giving sweetness, but the seed is not. It must sprout, grow, become a tree and then bear jackfruit. Until then, the seed is not the same as the tree or the fruit. The tree is within the seed but it is in the dormant state. If properly cultivated and looked after, the seed can also become a tree. Likewise, we can also reach the state of *Brahman* if we try.

What sense is there in calling ourselves *Brahman*, we who run after food and clothing while considering the body to be eternal? Look at great souls. They have no hatred toward anyone. Smilingly they mingle with everyone. They lead the world looking upon everything with an equal eye. That is what we must follow as an example. First we need a regular discipline. The fence of regular discipline is needed to protect the young plant of spirituality from the animals of worldliness. *Advaita* (Vedanta philosophy) is not something that should be told or taught by another person. It should be experienced through *sadhana*. What you see here in this Ashram are those disciplines which will lead one to that understanding through experience.

The *brahmacharins* must do six to eight hours of meditation a day. They must do all of the external work in the Ashram. They must cultivate humility and a service mentality and develop love for each other. Unlike worldly people, they

cannot go to the movies, nor can they go to the market and eat whatever they like. They have a strict diet. Sometimes the food which is served here will not be tasty. At other times there will be only rice without any side dishes. They sleep very little. Most important of all is *sadhana*. Intense *sadhana* is needed in order to get rid of the fascination with the world. It is not enough merely to speak of *Advaita*.

We are immersed in an illusion thinking that that which is, is not, and that which is not, is. We see the world through the eyes of ignorance. We must know the difference between what is eternal and what is changing. At present we are asleep but the goal is to reach a sleepless state. As we do *sadhana*, there will come a state where there is no sleep. At that time we will remain conscious even during normal sleep. The body will rest but the mind will remain awake. To reach that state we should advance a great deal in *sadhana*. When we awaken to God-consciousness, we will realize the world to be a dream. But now we tend to look outwards. The Ancient Sages, on the other hand, looked inwards and became omniscient. How many aeons ago did they write about today's happenings!

Uttering "Shiva, Shiva," the Holy Mother entered the indescribable state of *samadhi*. Her countenance became beautifully radiant and there was a gracious smile on Her lips. Everyone sat silently around Mother while looking at Her face, like honey bees surrounding a fully-blossomed flower. Having returned to Her normal consciousness, the Mother smilingly asked the students, "Children, didn't you get anything to drink?" The Mother then called Gayatri and asked her to make tea for them.

Image worship

Question: Since God is everywhere, is it necessary to worship a stone?

Amma: What is wrong with that? We remember the real apple when we see the artificial one, don't we? Likewise, the images of different gods and goddesses remind us of the Ultimate Reality. When a devotee beholds an image of Rama or Krishna, he is reminded of the real Rama who lived in Ayodhya and of Krishna who lived in Dwaraka. Since God is everywhere, He is in the stone as well. Our minds become concentrated when we worship a stone with the attitude that God is within it. It is not the stone, but we who receive the benefit thereof. It is we who get peace of mind.

Children, when you see a handkerchief given by your beloved, do you think only of the cloth and its price? You remember your beloved, don't you? Therefore, it is more a reminder of your beloved than it is a piece of cloth. *Bhavana* (attitude) is more important than anything else. When we worship a stone, it ceases to be a mere stone. The resolve (*sankalpa*) that the stone is God is behind the act of worship. It is that *sankalpa* which is important.

Question: It is said that the Ganges River has certain medicinal powers and that it won't get spoiled.

Amma: Son, modern science has proven it to be so through research and experimentation.

Question: Some disagree.

Amma: Without duality there is no world. Even a coin has two sides. A full day is comprised of day and night. The sun neither rises nor sets, but only seems to do so. It is said that only if there is opposition will there be growth. Different people will say different things. We should not pay attention to them.

*What is told will not be seen;
What is seen will not be told.*

This was said by the *Rishis*. We always talk about the world. When this world disappears, we will behold the eternal *Brahman*, but we will not be able to say what It is. We should see That and directly know what It is. At the same time, do not believe what is seen in the newspapers or what is heard on the radio or television. We ourselves should analyze and study the matter. Modern science has discovered through experimentation that the water of the Ganges River has the power to destroy germs.

Question: Why are there so many castes and religions?

Amma: Son, there is only one God. Mother does not care about caste and religion. People from all castes and religions come here. That Supreme Essence, the Self says, “In whatever way you conceive (of Me), I am there.” There are not many gods. Ultimately everything depends on one’s faith.

The world becomes the wealth of he who knows Reality

Question: Some people become *sannyasins* after renouncing everything. But even a *sannyasin* needs money, doesn’t he?

Amma: For one who has known the Reality, the world is his wealth. He has nothing else to gain. A real *sannyasin* is beyond all worldly needs. He is beyond happiness and sorrow. If you give him something he might accept it. However, even if he doesn’t get anything, he is still happy. No power can conquer him or his mind because he is beyond body-consciousness. In our country no *sannyasin* has ever starved to death. The Lord Himself will directly look after the needs of

a true devotee and renunciate. If anyone doubts this, let them come to Mother. She will prove it from Her own experience.

Question: Even devotees experience sorrow, don't they?

Amma: It is God Himself who makes them sorrowful. God will make the devotee suffer using egotistical people as instruments. Those who are sorrowful will call God with more concentration. In this way, God Himself will make a bridge and by means of that bridge He will come down.

Once the sage Narada went to see some *Rishis*. They said, "We have performed sacrifices for a long time but we have had no results." Then Narada replied, "You have performed fire sacrifices but was there any selflessness and love while doing so?" Narada continued, "I know a fisherman who had an intense desire to see the Divine Mother. He approached a *sannyasin* who told him, "The Goddess will appear before you if you call Her with as much longing as a person being held under water would long for air. If you call the Mother like that She will definitely appear." Having complete faith in his Guru's words and without caring about his body, his life or his house, he plunged into the water saying, "I will come up to the surface only after I have seen the Mother," and with that he whole-heartedly called out "Amma!" Immediately Devi appeared in front of him. The Mother asked, "Son, why did you call Me? What do you want?" The fisherman said, "Amma, I don't want anything. Make everyone in the world good, and bestow happiness upon them. My only request is that Mother should come and eat at my house whenever She feels hungry." Here again Narada continued, "The power of innocent love is obvious. If you call the Divine Mother with love and longing as that fisherman did, you also can receive *darshan*."

But however much they tried, no love grew within the *Rishis*. Thinking about this, Narada decided to correct them.

Approaching a demon of those days, Narada told him, “The Rishis are doing penance in order to kill you.” Hearing this, the demon angrily set out in search of the *Rishis* in order to kill them. Reaching their abode, he approached the *Rishis*, and catching them by their hair and beards, dragged them out and tortured them. In the struggle between life and death which ensued, the *Rishis* used all their powers and fully surrendered their minds to Devi, with the one thought, “There is no refuge other than Mother.” They called out loud, “Amma, Amma!” and at that moment Devi appeared in front of them and killed the demon, thereby saving the *Rishis*. It is the Lord alone who gives sorrow to the devotees, for only then will they call to Him whole-heartedly. However much worship and other spiritual practices you do, there will be no benefit if there is no love. If one is really a devotee, one will look upon sorrow as a blessing which will act as a bridge to the Lord.

It was nearly six o'clock in the evening. With much humility, all of the students except for one prostrated to the Mother and took leave of Her. This student remained seated in front of the Holy Mother. He said,

Young man: Mother, I am interested in taking *sannyasa*.

He seemed very inspired. The Mother smilingly consoled him saying,

Amma: Son, everything will happen according to God's Will. Enjoyment which is gained from worldly pleasures is like the enjoyment which one gains by scratching a scab. It is a pleasure when you scratch, but later it will become infected. It will itch again and become infected with pus. You may feel some temporary happiness while enjoying worldly pleasures, but later they will become the source of tremendous sorrow. The wound will not get cured if it is treated by merely applying

medicine externally. The external wound is only a symptom of the disease which you have within. The inner germs should be killed; inner cleansing is what is needed. If that is done, *sannyasa* is possible. But if that is not done, you simply walk around in ochre clothes making a show of renunciation. Taking up spiritual life is not an easy thing. It requires great mental strength and courage. Therefore, think well before deciding.

**Mother will yield to good character,
but not to wealth**

Very recently a branch of the Ashram started functioning in a nearby place. A devotee who joined in the activities there was disliked by a group of devotees who hailed from the same village. There were conflicts and protests concerning his coming to the Ashram branch. They counted on Mother to side with them in ousting the devotee and his family. Some of the devotees approached the Mother with this in mind and told Her, "Mother, you should keep him away from the activities of the Ashram for some time." When Mother asked why, they said, "If that one man is kept away, many others will favor Mother and the Ashram." Hearing this the Mother retorted,

Amma: Would you give one child among your children to your neighbors if they told you that they would give seven or eight of their children to you instead?

Devotee: No.

Amma: Then how could Mother discard one son?

Everyone was silent.

Amma: Mother will yield to good character but She will not yield to money and pride. Mother is free to do as She likes.

She will not allow anyone to obstruct that freedom. Mother is ready to yield to Her children's good character. All are children to Mother. She cannot show favoritism.

The next time the Mother visited the Ashram branch, the first house She visited was the house of that particular devotee who was opposed by the others. Most amazingly, Mother had never been in his house before. No one had ever told Her in which area the house was situated. After getting into the car, She instructed the driver to go in a certain direction, and when the car reached a particular house, asked him to stop. Indeed, it was the house of the dejected devotees. When Mother came to their house, all of them were crying before Mother's picture which was installed in their shrine room. They were very dejected thinking, "Today Mother will come to the Ashram but we cannot go and see Her." They were afraid that the opposition would create problems if they came. They told Mother that they had strong faith that She would come to their house in response to their heart-felt call. Later the Mother commented about this incident saying, "It was their innocent call which brought Mother to them." The family burst into tears when they saw that the Mother had come. She lovingly consoled them and sang a song,

*I will worship until the end of my life,
But rid me of my sorrow today.
O Goddess, Primal Supreme Power,
Bless me and remove my grief.
How many sufferings am I bearing.
Why art Thou delaying to cast
Thy gracious glance?
O Mother, drown me not in Thy Maya.
I bow to Thy Feet always.*

Listening and understanding the meaning of the song and realizing how the song was connected with their lives, all of them wept before the Holy Mother again and again. The Mother once more consoled them by putting each one on Her lap like a mother does to Her children and wiped their tears with Her own hand.

1 January 1984

A group of householder devotees came to see the Holy Mother. All of them were newcomers. They had read an article about the Mother in a newspaper and out of curiosity wanted to see Her. A few among them had a little spiritual background. It was nearly nine o'clock in the morning when the Mother, who had been observing the *brahmacharins'* meditation, came out of the hall and happened to see them. With a smile on Her face, She approached the visitors and welcomed them in Her own natural and spontaneous way. She asked, "Children, where do you come from?" It took a while for the visitors to realize that it was the Mother Herself who was standing in front of them. They never thought that they could see Her so easily and without any mediators. They could not even speak for a few seconds. Slowly one of them said, "We come from the North and this is our first visit."

The Mother again spoke, "Come on, children," and walked towards the *darshan* hut, the visitors following Her. First the Mother took a mat, spread it on the floor and asked the visitors to sit down. Then She said,

Amma: Shall Mother sit on this cot? It is just because Mother can see all of you easier and you children can see Mother without any difficulty. In reality, Mother does not like to sit higher than Her children.

The Mother's simplicity, humility and utter naturalness had a great impact on the visitors. A few moments passed in silence. For a while Mother was transported to Her own plane of awareness. She sat with eyes closed in meditation. After sometime She opened Her eyes uttering, "Shiva, Shiva," and made a circle in the air with Her finger. One man among the visitors asked a question.

Visitor: Many great souls and Incarnations have taken birth in India. All of them have tried for unity and integration. In spite of all their efforts, there are still many problems; chaos and confusion reign both in the lives of individuals and in life as a whole. Why is this so? Doesn't it mean that those great souls have failed in their mission?

Amma smilingly but penetratingly looked at the questioner's face and spoke as if from a different plane of consciousness.

Amma: No, it is not that they have failed but rather, that you have failed to apply their instructions in your life. You have read many books without understanding how to apply their teachings to your life. You have continued to beat your wife, you have punished your children without any reason, and have quarrelled with your parents without any cause. You have failed to discharge your duty as a husband, father, son and official. You have wastefully spent your money on intoxicants and other such things and are full of hatred and anger. Who is to blame, *Mahatmas* or people like you? When people like you live in society, how can life improve? First try to correct yourself. Let each individual try to do so. Then you can see the nation growing as a whole. The *Mahatmas* revealed the path. It is up to us to discriminate and walk on that path. Having arrogantly committed all kinds of prohibited

actions, what sense is there in blaming the *Mahatmas*, our great ancestors?

Beholding the Mother's extraordinary mood and sharp words, the visitors were taken aback. The man who had put forth the question sat with his head hung down. Even the *brahmacharins* who were present became a little confused on seeing the gravity of the situation. But in a few moments everything became clear, as the questioner threw himself at the Mother's feet crying loudly, "Forgive me, forgive me!" The Holy Mother gently lifted him, put him on Her lap and stroked his back with love and affection. Still he went on sobbing. The Mother said, "Son, don't worry, don't worry, everything will be all right. Now you have come to Mother, don't worry." Unlike Her previous expression, the Mother's face now radiantly shone with compassion and love. Later it came to be known that what the Mother had said about this man's personal life was true, that he had been leading an utterly unrighteous life. When Mother pointed out one by one his faults and weaknesses, he was astounded and, at the same time, filled with remorse as he recalled the evil actions which he had committed towards his wife, children and parents. Later he said, "I never dreamed that the question which I asked was being directed towards a person who was aware of all my thoughts and actions. When the Mother suddenly retorted, I was really shocked." Thereafter there occurred a great transformation in his life and his whole family became Mother's devotees. He even helped his friends and acquaintances to change their lives by bringing them to Mother.

After their friend's experience, the others were quite convinced of the Mother's omniscience. They did not ask Her any questions but reverently prostrated before Her and took

their leave, each having experienced Her motherly love and ubiquitous vision. Before leaving the Ashram they spoke to one of the *brahmacharins*.

Devotee: Actually we wanted to ask Mother many questions when we came here, but She has cleared all of our doubts by Her actions. One purpose for our coming was to seek the Mother's blessings for bringing about a change in our friend. Without expressing anything to Her about it, She has graciously fulfilled all of our wishes. Now we can go in peace.

When they had gone, the Mother rose from Her seat and went into the temple. When She came out, it was ten o'clock and She found some young men waiting to see Her. The Mother sat on the verandah and asked them to sit near Her. The young men, though seemingly educated, were not very polite. They exhibited a tendency to argue with the Mother.

Amma: Children, there is no meaning in mere dispute. Arguing must be for the sake of knowing the real nature of an object, incident or experience. *Tarka* (the science of logic) is not the mere juggling of words. The subject matter should become an experience. Would you get sweetness if you write the word "sugar" on a piece of paper and lick it? Will you get a bitter taste without chewing the leaves of the margosa (neem) tree? Children, what made you want to come to the Ashram?

One young man: We heard about the Ashram and felt like coming. We would like to talk to Amma.

Amma: What is there to talk about? All are in *samsara*¹¹ alone. What Mother says is how nice it would be if this *samsara* stopped. Children, however much rain water falls on the mountain-top, it will not remain there. It will flow down to

¹¹ A pun on the word "samsara" which means both "talk" and "the wheel of birth, death and rebirth."

the river below. The low-lying ditch receives the water from all sides. This is the greatness of humility. This is what is needed. Everything will come running to the place where there is humility. We should know that everything is within us. For that, humility is needed. Nothing can be gained if you egotistically walk around challenging others thinking, "I am great, omniscient, I have nothing to learn from anyone. I can win a dispute with anyone." Only after we ourselves have become good can we advise others.

The young men looked at each other. There was a sigh.

Question: Why is it that many people spend their time simply criticizing the Ashram?

Amma: That is their nature. Let us follow our nature. Why should we look at others and criticize them? A person from Tamil Nadu came and asked for a commodity in a shop in Kerala. The word which he used to name the goods was a vulgar one in Malayalam, the language of Kerala. The shopkeeper was about to beat him. Only when another person interfered and explained could he understand the meaning. It was the linguistic difference which created the problem. Likewise, we cannot find any fault in those who oppose us when we understand their nature. They have only that much knowledge and therefore they protest.

Some will write praising the Ashram, while others write with abuse. We are affected by neither. Look at our forefathers. How much Krishna and Christ had to endure! Mother has said that we do not need any advertisement in the newspapers. Truth will spread even without that. Didn't news spread even before there were newspapers and printing presses?

To know and experience something requires effort. To simply express an opinion about a particular thing does not require any effort at all. Move your tongue up and down and

different sounds will come out. To say that the Arabian Sea does not exist is easy. Any fool can say that. But to go there and experience the vast expansiveness and to feel the breeze from the sea, effort is needed. Children, an intelligent approach to a subject is important. Penetrate it. Then you can realize its real nature. Otherwise, you will see only its superficial nature which will always misguide you. Trying to find out the real nature of an object is real *tarka*.

The young men seemed stunned. They could not open their mouths for a few seconds. The Holy Mother lovingly smiled at them while they gazed at Her face. There was a short silence. Then Mother continued.

Amma: Children, Mother wants to ask you something. Young men like you always have a questioning nature. Mother likes that. But at the same time, Mother always wonders why young men like you will not try to do something which is useful for yourselves as well as for society. Can't you practice a little bit of meditation or other spiritual practice and see how they work? How can you label something as not good without experiencing the truth of it? Try, and if it doesn't work, then discard it or express your own opinion about it. Otherwise, it is unintelligent and illogical to criticize something without properly understanding it.

Young man: We accept what Mother says. Still, doubts always gnaw at us. After all, we are ordinary human beings, aren't we? Everyone speaks about God. Is there any clear proof that He exists? How is it possible to believe in something which cannot be proven?

Amma: All right, if there is no God, let it be so. Do we ever say that we do not exist? No. What evidence do you have to prove that your grandfather existed? Isn't it your own and your father's existence? Similarly, the existence of the Uni-

verse proves the existence of its Creator, God. Therefore, study yourselves first. Mother does not say that you should believe in Her or in a God who dwells up above in the sky. Have faith in yourself, in your own Self. You think that only that which can be seen and understood is you, that is, the body, mind and intellect; but you are something more than that. To know or to study yourself is not merely to have knowledge of your gross body and other things associated with it. That which gives you power, vigor, strength and the effulgence of life is something different. Modern science calls it energy and our Ancient Sages called it the Self, or God. You cannot deny “*Shakti*.” In reality, it is there that your real existence lies. That is the real “you.” To study yourself means to know that Self without which you have no existence, power or vigor. But that is very subtle. You cannot perceive it, but you can experience it. As you go more and more into it, you will get the power to understand that Self. But if you revel on the gross level, the subtle level cannot be understood. We reach God when we go in search of ourselves.

Question: The *brahmacharins* are very young. Is it necessary to take up *sannyasa* at such a young age?

Amma: One spontaneously renounces everything and takes to *sannyasa* when one has had enough of worldly life. It is a natural process. Nobody can become a *sannyasin*. It just happens. There is no special time for it.

Question: To become a *sannyasin*, why is an ashram and a Guru needed?

Amma: Why are doctors and hospitals needed but for the treatment of disease? If the disease is to be cured, the rules and regulations as instructed by the doctor should be observed. Likewise, a *sadhak* also has to observe certain disciplines. As he is imperfect and his understanding and discrimination are undeveloped, he needs a Perfect Soul to guide him and make

him walk in the correct path. The real *vidya* (knowledge) is to make the mind one-pointed. That is difficult if one stays in the world. The mind will get dissipated. But it can be easily controlled if one comes to an ashram and lives under the guidance of a *Satguru*. The atmosphere in an ashram is conducive to spiritual practice. The mind is like a monkey whose rope has been untied and let go. Agitation is the result if there is no mental control. Where is peace and tranquillity for worldly people? A spiritual person has peace. Those who imitate him will also get peace. It is to gain external happiness that we struggle to get into a cinema theater to see a movie. That happiness is only temporary. In spiritual life also, there is struggle, but that is for gaining spiritual bliss which is eternal.

Question: Are there different stages in meditation?

Amma: Yes, there are. But you will not understand such matters even if Mother were to talk to you about it. There are things which should be told to *sadhaks* alone. Proper understanding and assimilation are necessary in order to know such things. Anyhow, concentration is the basic factor. When concentration increases everything will be all right. Therefore, children, try to acquire concentration.

In the beginning one will not get real *dhyana* (meditation). What we do in the beginning cannot be called real meditation as it is just a practice or exercise to attain the state of *dhyana*. Even then, we will say that we are meditating. Results will be gained if you try constantly. Suppose we place a pot of water on the stove to cook rice. If someone were to ask, "What are you doing?" we would say, "I am cooking rice." In reality the rice is not being cooked, only the water is being boiled. Even then, that is what we would say. So even in the initial stages of *dhyana* we would say that we are meditating.

The different stages in meditation are subjectively experienced by the *sadhak*. Initially one will have to strive hard to focus one's mind on one's Beloved Deity. In the beginning it may not be possible to visualize the full form. Even then, one should not get depressed but should continue one's practice by trying to visualize only the feet of the Deity. In due course, one will be able to visualize the full form. Through the power of persistent practice, the form will become clearer and clearer. As meditation becomes deeper, the form will become full of life and may move and talk to the *sadhak*. The Beloved Deity may even appear before one whenever requested. This is real "Darshan" or God-vision. One's own spiritual power solidifies by the force of one's resolve and manifests as the Deity. Following this stage is the merging of the *sadhak* with the Beloved Deity through intense love brought about by constant remembrance of God and the renunciation of every other thought. From there, the Deity Himself will lead one to the final state of Non-dual Experience.

One of the young men: We have conversed with many scholars but none of them could give us very satisfactory or convincing answers. Mother has really opened our eyes. We are grateful to you, Mother, for clearing our doubts.

Amma: Suppose a person who is not a doctor teaches medicine and methods of treatment. The students would prefer to listen to a doctor. Similarly, classes for *sadhaks* and those who are spiritually thirsty should be given only by *sannyasins* and spiritual people; scholarly householders are not enough. Even after studying so many spiritual books and scriptures, they are still worldly people, aren't they? How can worldly people properly teach that which is beyond worldliness?

Mother is not here for dispute. Mother has spoken this much because She feels that you children have the inquisitiveness (*jijnasa*) to really want to know. The children here who

are *brahmacharins* would prefer to do what is seemingly bad, having given up bondage, rather than to do what is seemingly good while remaining in bondage. Giving up bondage means giving up attachment. Once attachment and aversion are gone, there is only love. Attachment binds you and makes you a lustful person; detachment uplifts you and makes you selfless. Doing apparently bad actions after giving up bondage does not mean doing things like plundering and murdering but rather making a show of anger and other passions for the good of the world. Even when a spiritual person who has attained the state of Perfection makes a show of anger, his mind will be filled with love. He is like a burnt shell, a shell in appearance only which will crumble into powder if you touch it. His anger is only an external show which he displays for the good of the world. He will be a good disciplinarian, a perfect lover of the human race. Even the seemingly cruel actions which Krishna did were for the good of the world. The general good of the entire human race is the Enlightened One's motto. He is not attached to a particular class, creed or religion. Whoever takes refuge in Him will be uplifted.

One cannot love and serve while remaining in bondage. There will always be some kind of selfishness. What a pity it is for people to remain as slaves to the world and worldly objects! Still, what false pride such people have! They think that there is no one greater than themselves. A cup of tea or a bottle of liquor is enough to enslave these "great men." The love which is experienced within the family is not selfless love. God alone loves us selflessly. We are saved if we become convinced of this.

The young men offered their salutations to the Mother and wished to take leave of Her. They were very contented. The Mother asked them to have their lunch in the Ashram

before going, to which they happily agreed. The Holy Mother and the young men entered the dining hall. The chanting of the *Bhagavad Gita* was in progress as the food was being served. A few of the residents had not yet come. Noticing this, the Mother said,

Amma: Everyone without exception must come and chant the *Gita* and the other mantras while the food is being served. This is the best time to test one's patience. Doing actions while remembering God will become a habit thereby.

Again, having noticed some of the *brahmacharins* sitting in a haphazard way without keeping their backs erect, the Mother said,

Amma: The spine is our center. We should always be aware of it. While sitting or standing, the spine should be kept straight.

Lunch was over. The Holy Mother lay down in the dining hall itself. Devotees had already started coming to the Ashram as it was *Bhava Darshan* day. Many of them sat around the Mother, including Lutz from Germany.

One devotee: Is not *Advaita* the Supreme Truth?

Amma: For whom? Those who have reached that state can say that everything is One. Even then one cannot say that there is no duality. There is duality even when we think, is it not so? One who has experienced that everything is One becomes silent. Then there is no one to speak. When you start speaking, there are two, or *dvaita*. *Dvaita* is needed to make people good. Mere speaking of *Advaita* will make people egotistical. *Advaita* is not something to be preached; it is an experience which one should live. Only through *dvaita* can one progress spiritually.

Question: On which point should one meditate?

Amma: Meditation can be done between the eyebrows and in the heart as well. Meditation in the heart is much easier.

Sometimes meditation between the eyebrows can cause headaches and pain in the eyes. Tears might come from the eyes and the body may also become heated. Meditation in the heart will have no such complications.

Lutz: The breath stops during meditation.

Amma: (Laughing) The breath will become still when we get concentration. We may even feel that the breathing has stopped. Oh, son Lutz, if your breathing stops, you will die. Let us try to die first. (Laughing) Nobody has died because of meditating. If you die while meditating, it would be such a death that you would not take birth again. Meditation will save us from all kinds of agitation. One need not be a believer in God to do meditation. One can imagine that one is merging in the Infinite just as a river merges with the ocean. This method will certainly help one escape from being agitated.

Question: Spiritual institutions give importance to visiting hospitals. Why is this so?

Amma: It is good if spiritual people visit hospitals at least once a month, particularly hospitals where lepers are being treated. This will help make the mind stronger and softer as well. Increasing ones *vairagya* (dispassion) will give more determination to the mind. The heart will become soft due to compassion. It will help us understand that those people are suffering as a result of wicked actions performed in their previous lives. We will think, "This experience should not happen to me. For that, I should tightly catch hold of God. I don't want to stay in this world, O Lord, I only want to merge in Your Feet." We will feel compassion towards those who are suffering and be ready to help them, while also thinking that this disease should not happen to us.

Question: Scriptural studies are also necessary, aren't they?

Amma: There is a kind of game played with stones. You, my son, may know it. Previously, Mother knew a girl who used

to play this game. It was really funny when she first played it because she did not know how to play it properly. Even without learning the game, she always wanted to play it. But she always played it incorrectly and foolishly. Therefore, the others would not even allow her to play with them. Only later did she learn it properly. If she had learned the game properly in the beginning, she would not have committed the mistakes, would she? That is why it is said that scriptures also must be studied. Only one who knows the path can travel correctly without getting lost. Scriptures will show you the way. They are pointers.

One brahmacharin: Mother, is *hatha yoga* good?

Amma: In the beginning *brahmacharins* should not learn *hatha yoga*. It is just like teaching them to lie. However, *hatha yoga* is good for householders for increasing their mental strength and to sustain their body. A *sadhak* comes to realize the Self by cultivating the attitude, "I am the Self, not the body." If he practices *hatha yoga* to make his body last longer, that will only help him to become more and more conscious of his body and this will pull him down from the path of Self-Realization. One can practice *hatha yoga* after the state of merging in the Reality. Thereafter, it is beneficial for the world if the body is sustained. *Hatha yoga* will be helpful at that time. In the beginning, pure love and devotion alone are needed. Bliss is gained when the sense organs merge in the mind through concentration. It is not obtained from exterior objects. Therefore, if you want bliss, try to acquire concentration. There is no point in running after *hatha yoga*.

2 January 1984

Vow of silence

Last night the *Darshan* was not over until four in the morning and the Mother went to bed at five. Neither lack of sleep nor irregularity in matters of food are problems for Her. All that She wants is the happiness of the devotees who throng to see Her. Every moment of Her life is dedicated to the suffering masses. The Mother eats Her lunch at five in the afternoon and even then, only one or two balls of rice or a few pieces of steamed vegetables. She has Her supper at five a.m. and has nothing later in the morning except perhaps one or two sips of tea or coffee. Even when She does take Her lunch or supper at those odd hours, She will be either reading a letter from a devotee or giving instructions to a *brahmacharini* or devotee concerning their *sadhana*. Or She may be consoling a devotee while making him or her feel that they are under Her protection, or possibly talking to a resident about the administration of the Ashram. The Mother says, "My wish is that even when I breathe my last, my hands will be resting on someone's shoulder, that I will be consoling and caressing someone."

Today after lunch Mother sat on the roof of the meditation hall along with some of the *brahmacharins*. Brahmacharini Gayatri was also present.

One brahmacharin: Mother, what is the significance of a vow of silence?

Amma: The shore is there to obstruct the waves of the ocean. What is there to obstruct the waves of the mind? That is the purpose for the observation of a vow of silence. The movements of the mind can be diminished through a vow of silence.

Question: Even though we don't speak while taking a vow of silence, the mind does not keep quiet, does it?

Amma: Haven't you seen the water in a dam? Though there are ripples on the surface, the bottom is calm. Nor does the water flow out. Likewise, while observing a vow of silence, there will be thought waves on the surface of the mind, but no energy will be expended or wasted. It is enough if you do not forget the goal. In the beginning, a vow of silence is indispensable for subjugating and sublimating the mind. Not much of the vital force will be lost. One's life span, health and vitality are decreased through talking. A person who breathes quickly will have only a short life span. This is why pigeons live only for a short time. More vital air is needed when we talk. At that time, the organs within us will undergo more wear and tear.

Another brahmacharin: It is difficult to understand everything that Mother says.

Amma: Faith is enough.

Question: Is everything that we experience the fruit of our past actions?

Amma: Yes. Every action that you do will have a reaction. Good actions will have positive reactions and bad actions will have negative reactions. The actions that we did in the past are known as fate in this lifetime. Fate is very powerful, but fate can be overcome to a certain extent by performing good actions in this life.

Question: Whether one is a householder or a *sannyasin*, food is needed to sustain the body; so what is a *sannyasin* to do?

Amma: A *tapasvi* need not wander in search of food. If his surrender is complete, whatever he needs will come in front of him. The spider, after weaving the web, sits in it. The prey which it needs will reach the web. Above all, a *tapasvi* lives to go beyond the body and to know the Self; a *grahastha* lives

to sustain his body. A real meditator can live even without food. Whatever nourishment he wants will be had from within. He is not a slave to food like a worldly person; he is master of it. During Mother's period of *sadhana* She lived for months without even drinking water.

Two kinds of desire

Question: Both the desire to lead a worldly life and the desire to lead a spiritual life are desires. What is the difference between the two?

Amma: In worldly life first there comes the desire to pass the college examination. After that is fulfilled, the next desire is to immediately get a job. After one gets a job, next comes the desire to get married. If that is also fulfilled, then other desires follow one after another. Thus, there is no end to the desires of a person who leads a worldly life. It is like a never-ending circle; it goes on and on. The person toils and struggles to get all his desires fulfilled. In the process he dissipates all his energies and finally collapses. Even then, there still remains a chain of unfulfilled desires. But due to the weakness of his sense organs, he becomes unable to fulfill or enjoy them, and the individual remains dissatisfied forever.

But with a spiritual seeker it is not so. His one and only desire is to realize God. He does everything with that as his goal. He has no worldly desires to fulfill. He withdraws his senses from worldly objects and fixes them on the form of his Beloved Deity. He sees that form in whatever he beholds. He tries to do everything selflessly. Therefore, there is no dissipation of energy. All desires end in his desire for God. His desire is for the highest and if that desire is fulfilled, he can save thousands from the cycle of rebirth. He becomes like a tree

giving shade and fruit to all humanity. He gives peace and tranquility to any person who approaches him.

The desire of the person who runs after worldly objects is of a lower nature. He is always selfishly motivated. He can neither save himself, his family nor society. He becomes an abode of chaos and confusion. But it is not only his own mind which becomes agitated; he creates the same agitation in the minds of others as well.

Both a thief and a doctor use knives. The thief, to fulfill his own selfish ends, kills people with his knife. The doctor, on the other hand, saves the lives of thousands of people with his. Likewise, the desires of a person immersed in the world destroy himself and others, but the desire of a spiritual person to realize God saves himself and also others from destruction. Such a person becomes eternally satisfied. That is the difference.

Now, what Mother wants to ask is why you children enter into disputes about a hundred things? Meditation is what is needed. Haven't you seen the gods and goddesses carrying weapons in their hands? These are hints about the *sadhak's* inner life. Maturity will come only through constant fighting with the lower mind. But in order to successfully carry out that inner fight, *japa* and meditation are necessary.

Brahmacharin: Mother, please forgive us if you find our doubts meaningless. To whom else can we turn to get our doubts cleared except you?

Amma: Do not worry, son, go ahead and ask.

Question: Was Vamana's pushing Mahabali down into the netherworld correct?¹²

¹² Mahabali or Bali as he was called, was a king in ancient times. In order to test his devotion to truth, Lord Vishnu incarnated Himself in a dwarfish form as Vamana, a young *brahmacharin*, and came to a fire sacrifice which Bali was performing. Seeing Him but not

Amma: What is the inner meaning behind it? Mahabali had performed intense *tapas* in order to merge into the Lord. In order to show the world what is true devotion, the Lord tested Bali to see whether he had any desire for external things. The Lord made Bali merge in Him. Bali first gave all of his wealth to the Lord. Then the attitude of complete surrender came. When even his head, that is, his ego, had been dedicated to the Lord, when he had no other desires to be fulfilled, it was then that *Bhagavan* pushed Bali's ego down into the netherworld. The inner meaning is that the physical body, the product of ignorance, disappeared and his soul was liberated for all eternity. Bali's ignorance was eradicated and his soul merged in the Lord. Whether in the netherworld or in heaven, the Self remains the same; it does not undergo any change or pain.

Question: Mother, what is the meaning of the saying; the world is a projection of the mind?

Amma: Whatever is seen is the projection of the mind. Suppose you have a dream in which you see that you are fighting with another person in the middle of the road. It is daytime, and therefore, many people assemble to see the fight on both sides of the street. Some reproach it while others encourage it,

understanding who He was, the king got up and offered Vamana a boon. Vamana requested only three strides of land using his stride as the measure. Bali asked Vamana to ask for something more but on refusal from Vamana, agreed upon the former's request. Lord Vamana then assumed His Universal Form and with the first stride, He covered the entire earth. With His second stride He covered the heavens. He then asked Bali where to place the third one as the entire Universe had been covered by the first two. Bali humbly offered his own head as the spot to place the Lord's foot. Doing so, the Lord sent Bali down to the netherworld and made him the king there.

and some try to stop the fighting. As your opponent is stronger than you, you receive a lot of beatings, kicks and blows. Finally, the police come and arrest both of you. You are placed behind bars for three days. When you come out, you are full of shame, hatred and revenge. You cannot contain it. Just at the same time you wake up from the dream. You become very restless. You think, "What a disgrace! Now how can I possibly face my friends and others? I should not have fought with that man. I could hardly return one single blow." Thinking in this way, your mental agitation increases. Somehow you want to get out of the situation. Therefore you sit down and slowly contemplate everything and slowly realize that the fight, the road, the opponent, the policeman, the jail, the people, the shame, the hatred, the revenge, all of it, was nothing but the creation of your own mind. Similarly, all that we see and experience in this world is a long dream. It is nothing but the jugglery of the mind. When we awaken into the state of God-Realization, we will come to know this fact through direct experience.

When there is no mind, there is no world. In deep sleep there is no mind and therefore no "you" or "I," day or night, wife or children, cars or television, yesterday or tomorrow. Immediately upon waking up, the sense of "I" comes and then everything else follows. The goal of spiritual *sadhana* is to eliminate the mind which consists of thoughts and desires. The Self is beyond all these. To know the Self, the mind should be eradicated.

Question: What should be done if friends come and talk about worldly matters?

Amma: Let them talk. Children, you should go on chanting your mantra within and remember your Beloved Deity. While looking at your friend's face, you can imagine your Beloved Deity's face there as well. If you are sitting, you can draw a

triangle or circle on the ground and mentally do archana to your Beloved Deity using stones instead of flowers. Remember the Self, your Real Nature, while doing each action. Before going to bed and immediately after waking up, meditate for some time sitting on your bed. Don't lie down to sleep. Lie down to wake up. Spiritual Realization is not possible without undergoing suffering. We are not perfect by birth. We should progress through action.

Don't row a moored boat

Amma: Children, you should give special attention to cutting the worldly bonds. (Pointing to a *brahmacharin*) That son says that he wants to go home every month. Once Mother sent him home in order to understand his mind. Afterwards, She did not let him go as She found that his attachment to his family remained. Had there been no attachment in his mind, Mother would have allowed him to go. How can a boat that is tied to a post possibly move even if you row it? It will move only if you row it after untying the knot. Otherwise, what use is there in rowing? Likewise, no progress will be gained if one does *sadhana* while being attached to the family and the world. (Smilingly) One fights with Mother for not getting the intended result, the complaint being that Mother is not showering Her grace. Mother doesn't show any such partiality to anyone. All are equal to Mother. She can give each one only what they deserve.

One brahmacharin: (Hesitantly) Mother, can we see the movie, "Kumara Sambhava?" It is a devotional movie.

Amma: Children, you are watching a film when you sit in the meditation hall, are you not? Could there be a more interesting movie than this world around you? If only Mother could see that the screen of Her children's minds was white! Movies,

even if they are devotional, will dissipate energy. Power will be lost even if you look carefully at something. It is better for a *sadhak* not to see devotional movies, especially in the beginning stages. Even devotional movies are not fully devotional. There are also many scenes which are capable of creating mental agitation.

A devotee who was a highschool teacher came and prostrated before the Holy Mother and silently sat near Her.

Amma: Not only that. There is no money here for such things. We can feed the poor if there is that much money. Worldly people simply waste money indulging in pleasures. How much are they wasting for trivial, selfish things like chewing betel leaves, smoking cigarettes and indulging in other bad habits! None of these people will spend any money on a good cause or even think that if the money which is spent on cigarettes and other indulgences is given in charity, a *brahmacharin* could be helped to live with minimum comforts. Many people are starving in our country. How many are without food, shelter, a proper education and without even a single penny to give their daughter in marriage? How much money are the politicians squandering away in the name of propagating their party and doing service to the nation! Everyone talks about service to the poor, but they do little to solve the situation. Spend the money which you unnecessarily waste on silly things to save the poor and needy.

The chain smokers, betel chewers, avid movie-goers and lovers of politics sincerely think that they can do a lot to help the suffering masses. Let them save a part of the amount which they spend on these meaningless things and use it to feed the poor, to build a small hut for the homeless, or to help a poor man perform his daughter's marriage.

At this point the Mother paused for a while and looking at the headmaster's face, smiled meaningfully at him. He had come to see the Mother only for a few minutes and therefore prostrated and took leave of Her. Having come out of the room, the headmaster told one of the *brahmacharins*, "Mother meant me, I am quite sure about it. I chew betel leaves and smoke a lot." He sighed and then he said to the *brahmacharin*, "I take this as Mother's command. Instead of telling me directly to stop it, She adopted a much more powerful and pointed method." From now onwards, this devotee began saving all the money which he used to spend on cigarettes and betel leaves and would either bring it to the Ashram in cash or in kind, or he would buy food for the poor and needy. Thus he completely got rid of his bad habits. Such incidents always happened around the Mother. Countless are the people who have completely refrained from all their bad habits by the mere sight of the Mother.

While talking to a group of people, the Mother knows how, when and towards whom to aim Her arrows. Aiming at someone who is sitting nearby, She might be talking to a person who is sitting next to him. Whatever is going on, Her arrow definitely hits the target and the right person will understand it in the right way. Sometimes the Mother will not tell someone to stop doing a particular thing directly, but in his presence, while talking to another person or to a group of people, She will mention whatever is necessary for him to hear. It will penetrate into his mind and transform him.

Question: Some Western psychologists say that spending time in solitude and meditation without being involved in worldly life is a mental disease.

Amma: Their perception is that the refuge for man is woman and vice versa. It would be difficult for them to live abandoning this idea as the guiding factor in their way of life. This is

why they say that. It is difficult to change their opinion as long as they remain in this state. They will learn when they develop more spirituality. Westerners are unable to think of a world forsaking material pleasures. Their slogan is to enjoy life to the maximum; body, body, body. Some of them go a little higher, up to the level of the intellect. There they stop and do not move one inch further.

As far as a spiritual person is concerned, neither man nor woman is his place of refuge. Human beings are not a refuge for human beings. All human beings are imperfect and an imperfect person cannot protect another imperfect person. Both will struggle like a small snake swallowing a big frog. The only perfect being is God or a God-Realized Soul. Therefore, the real place of refuge is God or one's own Self.

Actually, those who live an exclusively worldly life are victims of the mental disease of worldliness. They waste most of their energy on trivial matters and have very little mental balance. A small problem is enough to upset them. They may even commit suicide out of desperation and are enslaved by sense objects. They have no real wisdom or peace of mind. A spiritual being conserves his energy and uses it to save thousands of worldly people from going mad by giving them peace and mental comfort.

Question: It is said that celibacy will create diseases like dullness or mental aberrations.

Amma: Maybe it is true concerning worldly people because they do not do any *sadhana*. If the conserved semen is not channeled properly, it may create problems. The spiritual person withdraws it inwards and converts it into purified, vital energy. He will not have any mental disease but will have only bliss.

One brahmacharin: It was I who made today's vegetable dish. Did Mother eat it?

Amma: Mother cannot eat anything that is tasty. Mother does not know why. The mind does not go in for such things at all. Children, how is it that all of you care so much about taste and other external things? It is That Taste which we have to get. Without giving up the taste of the tongue you will not get That Taste, the taste of Self-Realization. The taste of the heart will not be had without giving up the taste of the tongue.

One *brahmacharin* spoke loudly. The Holy Mother commented,

Amma: What noise is this? A spiritual seeker's voice should be very soft. He should talk in such a way that the person who listens will be able to hear it only if he keeps his intellect, mind and sense organs concentrated.

At this, one *brahmacharin* approached the Holy Mother.

Amma: What is the matter, my son?

Brahmacharin: (Referring to another *brahmacharin*) Somebody is fast asleep in the room. (All laugh.)

Amma: That is all right. Last night he kept awake until very late. Even then, to sleep in the daytime is not good for anyone. A *sadhak* especially should not sleep during the day. At that time the air in the atmosphere is polluted. That is why the yogis utilize the night for doing *sadhana*. Exhaustion will be felt when we get up after sleeping in the daytime. When we wake up after having slept during the night, we feel more vigor.

Brahmacharin: Sometimes it seems to me that Mother looks less vigorous. Is it only a feeling of mine?

Amma: Within, Mother is totally unaffected, always blissful and vigorous. But if those children who have surrendered everything to Mother do something wrong, that would affect Mother's body. Since you children have dedicated everything

to Mother, your wrong-doings will affect Mother's body. Children, your happiness is Mother's health. Mother even removes your fate by taking such *prarabdhas*¹³ into Her own body. This also will affect the body. It is the law of Nature that the body must suffer and undergo change. Mother does not care about it. Let this body become like fertilizer for the spiritual growth of my children.

That statement really touched the brahmacharins' hearts. Some of them silently shed tears. Brahmacharini Gayatri could not control her emotions. There was a long pause after which Gayatri said, "You suffer a lot for us. Give part of your suffering to me."

Amma: (Looking at her lovingly and affectionately patting her on the back) Mother knows your pure love and innocent faith. But daughter, your body cannot bear even an infinitesimal part of the suffering that Mother's body takes on, not even for a moment. If I were to give it to you, you would collapse in a moment.

Question: Is it not the goal to go beyond all bondages?

Amma: Yes, to love everyone without getting attached. A spiritual person should become like the wind. The wind blows everywhere; it caresses and embraces everything without difference. It blows over fragrant flowers and foul-smelling excreta equally. It neither blows for a longer time over the flowers, nor for a shorter time over the excreta. It is not bound by anything. It is beyond all attachments.

One brahmacharin: Mother, there is no steadiness in the mind and concentration is not attained.

¹³ That part of one's accumulated past actions which are bearing fruit in the present life is called "*prarabdha*."

Amma: That is due to lack of *vairagya* (detachment). A strong and determined will is necessary to progress spiritually. Without this, you should at least have pure love and devotion towards your Guru. Attachment to the Guru will withdraw the mind from all worldly thoughts and objects. It will help to fix the thoughts on the Guru, and then steadfastness will slowly increase. Once the mind gets distracted from the goal or the Guru, it will immediately turn towards the objects of the world. Love is the force which binds the disciple to the Guru, and it is the same love which makes him realize God.

When the mind is constantly engaged in the thought of your Guru, what other thoughts can come? All other thoughts will be restrained; thus concentration will be gained.

Faith in the Guru and his words is another factor. Faith in the Guru will always protect you as a mother does. Faith that your Guru is omniscient, omnipotent and all-pervading is what is needed. This kind of faith will give you mental strength and power to cross over all obstacles that might arise on your spiritual path. Spiritual beings are the ones who have to guide the world. They should not be weak-minded. They should be like lion cubs, not like sheep.

Question: Why is it that good people always have to face opposition?

Amma: Good and virtuous people always fight against evil and vice. Society consists of more evil-minded and selfish people than good and wise people. Therefore, it is quite natural that they have to confront more challenges than others. To let yourself flow with the river's current is easy. But it is quite difficult to swim against the current, is it not? Likewise, the general tendency of human beings is to indulge in more and more evil. When one or two people come who want to propagate the message of *dharma*, it goes against the general ten-

dency, just like swimming against the river current. Naturally, it will be a difficult task.

Protests and opposition which come from the outside are easy to tackle when compared to the protests and opposition which come from within. Because the outer enemy exists in the present only, you know who, what and from where it is. But the inner foes are more powerful because they gather their strength from the past as well. All the habits and latent tendencies come together to fight with you. You do not know who or what they are, or from where they come. In most people, virtue is less powerful than vice. In other words, at present *Maya* is more powerful than God.

In the case of a devotee, it is God who creates the sorrows and obstacles in his life. As far as a true devotee is concerned, all the sorrows which he confronts will serve as a bridge to cross the Ocean of Transmigration. He takes them as a blessing sent by God to cut off his attachments to the world. They will serve as fertilizer for his mental flower which will blossom and spread its fragrance all around.

Another brahmacharin: Mother, when I asked in the office for a postcard, they didn't give me one. I want to write a letter.

Amma: Children, in the beginning stages a *sadhak* should not do things such as write letters or read newspapers. If it is absolutely necessary, you can write to your parents. They should get a little bit of consolation, shouldn't they? Don't write to other relatives or worldly friends. The friends will write back about worldly affairs and family members will write to you about family affairs. Then, even though you have left the house, what have you children renounced? Our *vasanas* will awaken when we read letters. If you write to them, then it is your turn to wait for a reply, and all that time will be wasted in waiting. In the olden days, *sadhaks* lived in the forests, in

huts made of grass. They had no contact with the outer world. Therefore, you have to live in the midst of all this constant fighting, without becoming prey to it.

Image worship

The Holy Mother uttered Her favorite mantra, “Shiva, Shiva.” The *brahmacharins* anxiously looked at each other, thinking that She was about to get up. Such occasions to ask questions and clear their doubts were not always possible. As they all looked at the Mother, She went into *samadhi*. A few moments later, having travelled all alone in the highest plane of consciousness, the Mother came down, again uttering, “Shiva, Shiva.” The *brahmacharins*, who had been meditating during the short period of time when Mother was in *samadhi*, opened their eyes when they heard the Mother chanting.

Brahmacharin: Mother, Swami Dayananda Saraswati saw a rat stealing the *naivedyam* (the food offering to God) when he visited a temple, and found that the statue remained unmoving. He consequently decided that there was no God in the image and thus he started opposing image worship.

Amma: *Brahman*, the Absolute, is motionless. The statue also is motionless. If the statue is to move, a *Jnani* (a Self-Realized Soul) should make the *sankalpa* (resolve) for it to do so. They are creators. They are the ones who instill power and vital force into the statue. Because they give their power to the statue, the statue will even speak. In reality it is the power of that particular *Mahatma* which is reflected in the image. If they want to, they can even make an inert plank move and do other such things.

How is it that the all-pervading God ceases to exist in the statue only because the rat happens to eat the *naivedyam*? To

say that God is all-pervading and to say, at the same time, that He is not in the image, is contradictory, is it not? If God is not in the image, then He is not all-pervading; and then, He is no God. God is there, even in the rat. Why can't you take it in this way -- that it was God in the form of the rat who ate the *naivedyam*? If you say that God is not there in the rat, then again it is imposing a limitation on God; whereas, God is limitless. What logic is there if you say that Ganesha does not exist because ants crawled into the molasses which had been kept as *naivedyam* for Him? (Smilingly) Ants and rats have no food ration card! Can't you imagine that God has allowed them to eat a little because of that? (All laugh)

Question: I have heard that different kinds of experiences will occur during the period of *sadhana* but I am not having any.

Amma: You will get the wages only if you work. You will get experience only if you do *sadhana*. After all, children, why do you bother about such things? Do *sadhana* as best as you can and do not think about the result. If you sit thinking about the result, then you will not be able to do your *sadhana* with all your attention. A *sadhak* is not supposed to care about such experiences. Run straight towards the goal.

Question: Is not *Advaita* superior even to God?

Amma: Children, you don't need *Advaita* now. Cultivate love and when the time is ripe, all other knowledge will come of its own accord. Devotion is the foundation on which you have to build your spiritual life. Non-duality is not something that should come from your lips. It is something which should be experienced.

There was a person who used to come every day to milk the cow in the Ashram. This particular day he did not come and so in the evening nobody had their usual evening drink of

milk. Without saying anything to anyone, the Mother Herself milked the cow. Later She said,

Amma: Dependence on others will cause problems and pain. We should try to become self-reliant as far as possible. If we milk the cow ourselves, the hundred rupees that we give the milkman will be saved. What Mother thinks is that the same amount could be used to accommodate one more *brahmacharin* at the Ashram. Children in search of God are coming with intense longing, looking for a place where they can perform *sadhana*. Due to lack of sufficient funds, it is impossible to allow everyone to stay here. The money saved can be utilized for that. We may have to do the work ourselves. Even if we have to put up with a little bit of pain, let us serve and help others with good intentions.

Mother doesn't see anything as *mithya* (unreal). To consider a thing to be unreal means to waste it, not understanding its real value. Mother milked the cow not to gain money, but because She sees the goal and purpose behind doing so. She does not consider any work as lowly.

Mother noticed one *brahmacharin* beating his fingers rhythmically. She said,

Amma: Wherever they sit or stand, spiritual people should remain still. Don't move the hands, legs or body unnecessarily. To help you to achieve that, imagine that the body is dead. Thus in the beginning if you imagine that you are dead, it will later become natural. It will become possible to remain still. A spiritual being should strive to make the body as if dead.

On hearing the Mother's words, everyone sat still, without moving any part of their body.

Question: Mother, which is best, devotion or knowledge?

Amma: Devotion fortified with knowledge is what is needed. Look at the tree and the creeper. If the tree is not there, the creeper will not grow upwards. You should approach *jnana* through *bhakti*. *Bhakti* which is not based on essential principles (*tattwas*) will only help to bind one. That is harmful. There are certain creepers that keep the trees completely bound. Likewise, *bhakti* without *jnana* will only help one to get bound more and more. *Jnana* means to grow straight upwards. *Tattwa bhakti* is that which embraces *jnana* tightly. Then it will not come down.

Bhakti and *jnana*, though seemingly different, are not two. *Bhakti* is the means and *jnana* the end. *Bhakti* without *jnana* and *jnana* without *bhakti* are both harmful. In fact, *bhakti* is the easiest and least complicated way. Anyone and everyone can follow it. *Bhakti* culminates in *jnana*. The Lord of a true devotee and *Brahman*, the Absolute Reality of the *Jnani*, are really one and the same. *Bhakti* is usually prescribed for people who are predominantly emotional, and *jnana* for intellectuals. *Jnana* without *bhakti* is dry, and *bhakti* without *jnana* is blind.

On the seashore

Twilight was approaching. The Holy Mother, along with the *brahmacharins* and Gayatri, went to the seashore. Everyone sat facing the sun as it set over the vast ocean. The reddish rays reflected on the Mother's face, lending a special glow to Her already radiant countenance. As the sun set on the western horizon it looked like a big, red-hot iron ball floating on the surface of the expansive sea. The day slowly took its leave and gave way to the night. The ocean waves sang their never-ending lullaby. The Holy Mother and the *brahmacharins* were deeply immersed in meditation. It was truly a wonderful

sight to see the Mother and Her children sitting together, meditating in this calm and serene atmosphere.

Here and there, a few fishermen stood watching the group. Who knows what they were thinking? The fishermen's children, who had been somersaulting in the white sand, stopped their play and stood still, gazing at the Mother and the *brahmacharins*. They were hoping to receive their usual share of toffees from the Mother.

After the Holy Mother and the *brahmacharins* had finished their meditation, the Mother sat, fixing Her eyes on the roaring sea. Without turning Her eyes away from the ocean, the Mother said,

Amma: The ocean is the *Akṣhanda Satchidananda* (Undivided Pure Being, Awareness and Bliss). The *Mahatmas* are the waves of That and its bubbles are the ordinary human beings.

A short distance away, groups of fishermen pushed their boats out into the water, and with great speed, proceeded to row away from the shore into the ocean. Like worldly people hurrying through the dense darkness of this world towards nowhere, the fishermen rowed their boats away into the ocean in the darkness of the evening. A flock of seagulls flew down and sat on the waves. The seagulls are like yogis full of detachment who are unaffected by the ocean of transmigration. The ocean cannot do anything to the seagulls. They sit only on the surface and can fly away whenever they want.

Pointing to a boat on the ocean, the Mother said,
Amma: Look, haven't you seen that in order to take the boat beyond the waves, the fishermen are rowing hard without paying attention to anything else. The people standing on the shore are encouraging them by waving their hands and making noise, but those in the boat aren't paying any attention to

that. They have only one thought in mind and that is to somehow go beyond the waves. Only when they reach that point will they take rest, for beyond the waves there is nothing to fear. Children, you too are among the waves right now. You will be able to reach your goal if you proceed without paying attention to anything else, keeping only the goal before you. If you are not alert, the waves will lift you and toss you over. In the beginning a *sadhak* should not pay attention to anything around him.

The external world is there in the mind itself. The traits of all animals exist within us. Just like chameleons, human beings change their character every moment. The tiger, snake and all other animals are there within man and all these should be sublimated through *sadhana*.

Having come to the seashore, you should imagine a lotus flower on the horizon at the point where the sea and the sky unite, and visualize your Beloved Deity sitting on that lotus.

A *sadhak* should not speak unnecessarily. Power will be lost if he talks too much. Nor should he get angry. He should always be rejoicing in God. A *sadhak* should wear clothes which cover his entire body and should not converse very closely with worldly people. A *brahmacharin* who has left everything of the world, keeping spiritual life as his goal, should not enter any house without being invited in by the family. He should remain outside until he is given permission. After entering the house, he should sit only in the shrine room if there is one. If people ask him something, he should answer but he should not speak unnecessarily.

Do not be too attached to anyone. *Brahmacharins* should never sleep in the bedrooms of worldly people. Inhaling the air which is permeated with worldly vibrations will awaken worldly thoughts in us. Do we have the same mental attitude

when we enter a temple as we do when we go to a night club? There is a difference, is there not?

Thoughts and subtle germs

The Mother continued,

Mother: Inside decaying objects, tiny worms and other creatures take their birth. When milk gets spoiled, small worms will be born in it. Likewise, subtle germs take birth according to the thoughts of human beings. In response to each and every thought of ours, subtle germs will take birth of their own accord. These germs will remain in the atmosphere and are capable of creating vibrations in the minds of others. Some day modern science will prove all this.

Children, in the beginning, a *sadhak* should not use a mirror or a comb. It is enough if you comb your hair with your fingers after wiping your head dry. Otherwise, time will be wasted. Not only that; instead of helping to remove body-consciousness, such actions will only increase it. We are trying to go more and more inward, not outward. By lessening external actions, we should make time to do *sadhana*. Our aim is to develop the inner spiritual beauty, not the outer physical one, is it not?

A *sadhak* should wear clothes of a single color. If you wear different colors, then the next thing will be to choose the nicest colors. Whatever object you perceive, it should be with the idea that it is your Beloved Deity. While handling books or clothes or while opening a door, mentally bow down, imagining that your Beloved Deity is standing in front of you. There will be no waste of time if you practice in this manner.

It was past six-thirty. The Mother got up saying, "Come on, children, let us go. The sea breeze at this time is not good for one's health." Everyone got up and returned to the Ashram.

After reaching the Ashram, the Holy Mother immediately began the usual evening *bhajan*. Having told everyone to sing the *bhajan* while visualizing their Beloved Deity in the heart, the Mother sang,

*Through my mind, speech and actions
I am remembering Thee incessantly.
Why then art Thou delaying to show
Thy mercy to me, beloved Mother?*

*Years have passed
But still my mind has no peace.
O darling Mother, please grant me
A little relief.*

Again She sang,

*O Mother, for the satisfaction of my life
Give a drop of Thy love
To my dry, burning heart.
Why, O why dost Thou put burning fire
As fertilizer to this scorched creeper?*

*Bursting out crying, how many hot tears
Have I offered before Thee?
Hear Thou not my heart throbbing
And agony coming out as suppressed sighs?*

The songs were filled with pathos, the inner call of an aspirant to become one with the Supreme. Ecstatically singing

the *bhajans*, the Holy Mother soared to the heights of supreme devotion. As Her feeling was reflected in Balu, he became intoxicated by the devotional fervor which pervaded everywhere and he burst into tears. Rao also entered into the same mood. The singing reached its peak of devotion and supreme love. The Mother seemed to be sending out a never-ending stream of bliss. The *brahmacharins* and other devotees swam in it. There are no words with which to express the devotional feeling which pervaded the atmosphere.

The *bhajan* ended at eight-thirty. After vespers, the Holy Mother went out into the coconut grove and roamed there for about fifteen or twenty minutes, Her hands clasped behind Her back. There was an extraordinary seriousness and glow on Her face. During such occasions, no one dared to go near Her.

Once again the Mother came and sat in the sand in front of the temple. Hoping to hear more of Her nectarous words, some of the *brahmacharins* gathered around Her.

Brahmacharin: Mother said not to mingle with *grahasthas*. But sometimes you also scold us for not taking proper care of them when they come here. Why is that so, Mother?

Amma: What Mother said was to keep away from *grahasthas*. But you should always serve *grahasthashramis*. However, they must be real *grahasthashramis*. A *grahasthashrami* is one who leads a spiritual life while staying at home with his family. A *grahasthashrami* is one who has made his home (*graha*) into an ashram. Children, although it is true that the purpose of your life is to serve everyone without differentiating, until you acquire a balanced state of mind and strong discrimination between the real and the unreal, it is better for your own spiritual progress that you maintain this sense of difference.

The subject of *grahasthas* is very interesting. When the sun sets, small children are unhappy, thinking that the sun is lost.

But when the dawn comes, again they rejoice, thinking that the sun has come back again. They don't know the eternal nature of the sun, that it neither rises nor sets. Worldly people are like that. With gain and loss, they rejoice and grieve, not knowing that nothing is really theirs. They do not understand the nature of their True Self.

5 January 1984

As it was a *Devi Bhava* day, the Holy Mother came to give *darshan* to the devotees in the hut. It was ten past nine in the morning, but before going into the hut, She visited the *brahmacharins'* quarters. As the Mother came out of each room, the *brahmacharins* who were inside would come out and follow Her. Suddenly She turned to a *brahmacharin* who was looking here and there and said,

Amma: A spiritual being should only look ahead. Looking this side and that shows a lack of concentration and alertness. When you walk along a road, look straight ahead, visualizing your Beloved Deity in front of you and proceed. Many things may be happening on either side of the road. Already there are many pictures in your mind. Do not take any more pictures with your mental camera. To remove the ones which have already been taken will take a long time. If you are adding more, be aware that the distance to reach God will increase.

Mother remained in Sreekumar's room for a while. Balu thought that it was the right time to clear his doubt. He asked, **Balu:** Mother has said that a *sadhak* will have to suffer a lot if he re-enters worldly life after doing *sadhana* for a long time. Why is that?

Amma: A spiritual person will certainly have to undergo suffering if he re-enters worldly life. The subtle aura which the

sadhak has developed around him through spiritual practices during his period of *sadhana* will bring calamity to the *sadhak* who re-enters worldly life. When he stops his *sadhana*, the *vasanas* which he was trying to subjugate will double in strength and cause a tremendous outburst of passion in him. When he fails to fulfill these cravings, negative feelings like anger and lust will overcome him and destroy his peace of mind, causing him to be like one gone mad. He will not have mental peace even for a moment. His or her family life will be an utter failure always troubled by obstacles.

Balu: Mother, some people have come from Germany today. I have just seen one of them standing in front of the Ashram smoking marijuana. Shall I ask him to leave?

Amma: Be patient. Politely tell him that Mother has said that he should not smoke marijuana here, that it is the duty of each one to maintain the sanctity of the place. Tell him that he is not free to do as he likes, that there are rules to be followed wherever he may be.

Balu left and returned within a few minutes. From the expression on his face, it seemed that his mission had met with failure.

Balu: Mother, I told him everything that you said but he became very angry and retorted, "I am my own boss. I won't obey anyone!" Then, he immediately left the Ashram.

Hearing this, the Mother smiled and said, "Everything is for the best." Balu could not understand what Mother meant by that statement regarding that egotistic and arrogant visitor. He therefore asked Mother,

Balu: Mother, what do you mean by saying this about such an arrogant person?

Amma: Wait and see.

Having said this much, the Mother went towards the hut to give *darshan* to the devotees.

6 January 1984

Cast off shyness

Last night the *darshan* finished at three-thirty in the morning. After that, the Mother met with a family of devotees who had been eagerly waiting to talk with Her privately. Following this, She went around to make sure that all of the devotees had something to lie down on. It was nearly five o'clock when She finally went to Her room.

Almost all the devotees who were staying at the Ashram this day had seen the Mother the previous day, and therefore, the Mother came only for the evening *bhajan*. After the *bhajan* the Holy Mother came to the dining hall. The supper was still being served. Today during the evening *bhajan*, Kunjumol, because of her shyness, did not sing when the Mother asked her to do so. Referring to this the Mother said,

Amma: Shyness is the first thing that a spiritual person has to give up. Shyness is a quality of women. Whether it is a man or a woman, once one comes to spiritual life, one should develop some assertiveness. (Turning to Kunjumol) What can be done if you, who will have to move in front of thousands of men some day, feel shy? Do one thing. Every day sing at least one *bhajan*. Mother will also make you deliver a speech in front of others. In this way you can remove this shyness of yours.

After saying that, the Mother walked out of the dining hall and went into the kitchen. Seeing all the cooking pots and other vessels lying in disorder, the Mother said,

Amma: Orderliness and cleanliness are very important. Every day when the cooking is over, you should wash the vessels and keep them in an orderly way. External orderliness leads to internal orderliness. You should always try to keep the surroundings clean and tidy. External disorder indicates your internal disorder. If things are in disorder, the mind will also be affected.

The Mother Herself started arranging the vessels in order. The *brahmacharinis* also joined Her saying, “Mother, we will do it,” but She would not stop. Only when everything was clean and in order did She leave.

8 January 1984

Today just before the Mother arrived at the hut for *darshan*, Balu spotted the same German man who had arrogantly left the Ashram a few days ago. He was standing by the temple. Remembering the man’s rude behavior, Balu felt a bit angry and avoided him. He thought to himself, “What business does he have here?”

At nine-thirty in the morning the Mother came to the hut to receive and give *darshan* to those who had come for the *Devi Bhava*. She was cheerful and fresh as ever. The Mother began calling the devotees one by one. On seeing the German man enter the hut, Balu stood near the Mother, expecting the man to create further trouble in Her presence. Much to Balu’s amazement, the Mother received the man with love and affection. Smilingly She asked him, “Son, what happened? Which boss caught you?”

On hearing those words of the Mother, a sudden shock passed through his body. With an astounded look on his face, he gazed at the Mother and burst into tears. Mother continued to pat him on the back to console him, all the while having

a mischievous smile on Her face. “Come on, son, do not worry, tell Mother what happened,” She said.

Balu stood with eyes wide open watching the drama unfold before him. He could not make out the meaning of the man’s mysterious behavior.

German man: (Weeping) Mother, it was you who made everything happen. After I left here the other day, I went to another town to the south with my friends. The very same day they left me there to myself. While I was sitting on the seashore smoking marijuana, two policemen suddenly approached me and put me under arrest. I was taken to the police station and put behind bars for twenty-four hours. I spent a sleepless night thinking of the arrogant way that I had behaved when I was here and wept to Mother for forgiveness. O Mother, please forgive me. You have taught me a good lesson.

He sobbed like a small child. Once again consoling him, the Mother said,

Amma: Son, it was out of ignorance that you acted like that. Do not brood over it anymore; you have regretted enough. Now forget it. Son, we should always try to cultivate humility. When the police caught you, you could not tell them that you are your own boss, could you? Similarly, if you do not stop when the traffic police ask you to, you may kill yourself and others. You cannot tell them that you are your own boss. Rules and regulations are needed for our spiritual development. We should lead our life in accordance with spiritual principles. It is the ego which says, “I am my own boss.” Unless the hard shell of the ego breaks, Self-Realization is impossible. For that to happen, a *sadhak* should cultivate obedience first and foremost. Child, this repentance of yours has made your mind pure.

Upon saying this, the Mother wiped his tears with Her hand. After a few seconds, Mother looked at Balu who was watching the whole scene.

Amma: Now do you understand why Mother said that everything was for the best? He has regretted his mistake and has been transformed into a devotee. Isn't that good?

Balu silently listened to the Mother's words. He thought, "Mother, what do I know? You know that I do not know anything." He could not reply to the Mother but humbly bowed down before Her.

One young man wanted to dedicate his life to spirituality, but since he came from a poor family, circumstances would not allow it. When the Holy Mother heard about his wish and the impediments in his path, She said,

Amma: Even though one comes to spiritual life, if there is no one to protect one's parents, it is the son's duty to do so. If there are other children to take over the responsibilities, then it is all right. It is not necessary to obey one's parents if they are an obstruction to one's spiritual practices. A spiritual aspirant can serve his parents, but he should do so seeing them as his own Self. If there is intense detachment, then there is no harm in relinquishing the family, whatever the circumstances may be. In such a case, no effort towards renunciation is needed; it happens spontaneously. God will not make a true aspirant's parents suffer. God Himself will take care of them. A real renunciate becomes the benefactor of the whole world. Compared to a small family consisting of a father, mother, wife and children, the world family is much greater. Dedicating one's life to God for the good of the world is far superior than sacrificing it for the few people in one's family. But if detachment is not that intense, one should look after one's family while performing spiritual practices as best as one can

until real detachment arises. Try to slowly detach yourself from worldly bonds.

Brahmacharin: Mother, what is true love?

Amma: Devotion imbued with wisdom is real love. That is what is needed. Love is of two kinds. Love towards the world and worldly objects is love of a lower nature. Love towards God is devotion, love of the highest kind; that is pure love. Everyone has love within him but it fully manifests only when it is directed towards God.

Question: Mother, why should one control one's diet?

Amma: It is very important to do so. Chilies, turmeric, salt, oily and fatty foods, mustard seeds, onions, fish, meat and other non-vegetarian foods will create more semen which, in turn, will cause more sexual desires to arise. These are all *rajasic* foods (those foods which increase passions) which will aggravate anger, lust and other negative tendencies. It is also not good to eat yogurt or drink buttermilk at night. Do not fill your stomach fully. Fill it half with food and one quarter with water; the other quarter should be left empty for the passage of air. It is better not to eat at night. If you feel hungry, eat some fruit. Sleeping immediately after eating will create problems.

The food that we consume has a strong influence on our character. Look at the traditional *brahmins* of India who do not eat any *tamasic* (that which increases lethargy) or *rajasic* food. Compare them with those who do eat such food. The former are relatively more *sattvic* (that which is conducive to clarity), calm, quiet and serene than the latter. Don't you know that food constitutes the body? The nature of the food that we eat will reflect in our physical and mental natures.

Question: Mother, why should one meditate on the aspects of God with form? Why not on the Attributeless *Brahman*?

Amma: Can you think of a quality, for example, love or truth, unrelated to a form? It is not possible to do so because qualities are formless in themselves. To think of a quality, we need an object which has that quality as its attribute. Then what can be said of the Attributeless *Brahman* which is beyond all conception? Our mind is so gross that we cannot possibly think of a God Who is formless, changeless and attributeless. Therefore, we need an object which is endowed with divine attributes. Krishna, Rama, Buddha or Christ are such Beings.

Our mind has the habit of always leaning on something as a support. As children, we are fondled by our parents and want to be loved and looked after by them. Afterwards when we grow a little, our interest is to play and be with friends of our own age. Then in school we have many other friends to talk to. Again in college we have our boyfriends or girlfriends to share our heart with. After getting married, our wife or husband is there to share our problems and worries. Thus till death, somehow or other we always have someone to whom we can open our heart. Such a mind which is dependent on others for its solace cannot conceive of a God who is formless and attributeless. We need a name and form to worship. So we say that *Brahman*, the Attributeless, is embodied in Krishna, Rama or Christ and that we should develop a relationship with Them. It is not Their bodies that we are adoring but rather the great ideals that manifest through Them.

Even to meditate on the Formless requires a sublime conception. Those who from birth itself are endowed with an extremely subtle mind can meditate on the Formless. But how many such people are there? Ninety-nine percent of the people are gross-minded. They have no subtlety at all. Can

we ignore the fate of the majority for the sake of the few subtle-minded devotees?

Question: Is there any special benefit in meditating on the forms of gods and goddesses?

Amma: By meditating on the forms of gods, concentration of mind and mental purity can be gained. We will get the qualities of the god upon whom we meditate. The basic thing that one should strive to acquire is concentration and attenuation of *vasanas*. To look at one point with open eyes is also a good practice for gaining concentration.

Study of scriptures

Question: Mother, is the study of scriptures indispensable?

Amma: Children, everything will be attained through meditation. Even then, meditation coupled with the study of scriptures is usually better than meditation without it. The awareness, “I am not the body, I am the Self. Can anyone hate me or get angry with me?” will assert itself in the mind. Mental equipoise will be gained. If a coconut tree is grown by a person who has studied agriculture, the tree will grow without any harm coming to it. He knows when and how to use fertilizer and pesticide and also knows the remedy even if it gets infested with worms. The coconut tree will be ravaged if it is looked after by a person who does not know these things. Likewise, a person who has studied the scriptures will have the ability to control himself when dangerous thoughts come into his mind, by reflecting on what he has learned from the scriptures. If used properly, scriptures can lead us to Perfection without much trouble. However, it is usually seen that the study of scriptures without a Guru and without doing *sadhana* will only help to inflate the ego.

Question: Will God assume a form?

Amma: God is omnipotent and omniscient. He can assume a form if He finds it necessary, but eventually, He will return to His real Formless Nature. Ice cannot remain as such for long but will ultimately revert back to its original state as water. We make salt from sea water. It will not remain as salt but will dissolve and become watery after a while. Similarly, God, the Omniscient, Omnipotent and All-pervading, assumes a form for some time and then returns to His Formless Being when His purpose is fulfilled.

Question: When is the best time to enter into spiritual life?

Amma: Right now is the best time. Son, there is no particular time to enter into spiritual life. Whenever you have the strong urge, that is the best time. One who is determined will start immediately without wasting a moment. But do not wait until all your desires are fulfilled. That will be like waiting for all the waves to subside before going to bathe in the ocean. It is better not to postpone. If you postpone, you may never start. Postponement shows lack of earnestness. Either you should come when you are young, or you should come after a real spirit of renunciation arises.

Love is what is needed

Brahmacharin: I am always feeling miserable.

Amma: Hmmm. That is good. Melancholy! And that too, even after coming here! Go ahead, be miserable. Maybe that is what you need. It is only possible to give what each one needs, is it not? Worldly people also say that they are always miserable. That is good if it is caused by the anguish to see God. That is bliss, not misery. But if your dejection is caused by something other than that, it must be due to unnecessary desires. (Smilingly) Mother knows the cause for each child's sadness after they come to stay here. If Mother talks to one

person, another one becomes sorrowful. If Mother praises one person, another one feels miserable. Another one is sad if Mother sits talking with *grahasthas*. Your misery is due to jealousy.

Desire is the cause of sorrow. Mother felt a desire for certain things when She was young. It so happened that such desires would be fulfilled immediately. Once when She saw a beautiful sari, Mother thought, "How heavenly it would be if Devi could wear it!" On that very same day a devotee offered a sari of the same kind to Mother. After that, Mother stopped desiring anything.

Having created desires, what a pity it is for a *brahmacharin* to be sorrowful. What is the difference between you and worldly people? One who is separated from one's beloved will always be thinking about them. The husband will always be thinking about his loving wife. Similarly, a *sadhak* should always think of his Beloved Deity. Do not let the mind wander towards other things. If you do not control the mind, misery will follow.

God undoubtedly exists. Even if one does penance for many births, it is impossible to attain Him without a hunger, a yearning to see Him. Love is what is most important.

The *brahmacharin* who had said that he was in misery sat with his head hung down. Later he told one of the other *brahmacharins*, "Mother knows everything that is going on within us as well as outside. We cannot hide anything from Her. She knew that my sorrow was due to jealousy, and by making me aware of it She has enabled me to overcome it."

The power of tapas

Question: Many people who come here say that their prayers to Mother always get fulfilled. Does Mother hear whatever things they say wherever She may be?

Hearing the question, the Holy Mother burst into laughter.

Amma: God is hearing all our prayers. In truth, the Lord knows each and every thought; He does not have to hear the prayers of His devotees. He is all-pervading. People's thoughts exist in God only, but they do not know it.

Children, Mother is crazy; She doesn't have any powers. All powers belong to Him. But whatever a *tapasvi* says or thinks will certainly happen. That is the power of *tapas*. Through *sadhana* one gains power; one becomes a storehouse of inexhaustible energy and vigor. Even in trying situations, one becomes capable of doing proper actions without breaking down. It is at such times that one will have to save the people who are wandering in *samsara*.

Worms and germs grow in places where water stagnates and this will create trouble. If one goes near this water, one may become sick. The trouble is eliminated if such stagnant waters are directed to the ocean through channels. That is what we have to do; the mind should be made to flow towards God through *sadhana*.

Question: Once God is realized, there is only happiness, is it not so, Mother?

Amma: God is neither happiness nor unhappiness. Happiness and unhappiness belong to the world. God is Pure Bliss (*ananda*). Happiness is limited but bliss is unconditional. It is the very nature of the Self. It is beyond everything. Supreme

Bliss is that in which you will become established forever upon realizing God.

One devotee: Is the costume really needed for *Bhava Dars-han*?

Amma: Is that all? What costume is there which Mother has not donned? Children, when we see the uniform of a post-man are we not reminded of the mail? Likewise, a lawyer's coat and a policeman's dress remind us of law and order. Therefore, dress also matters. There are many people who care about dress. Intellectuals may say that this is all nonsense, but how can Mother discard the majority, who are ordinary people, for the sake of a few intellectuals? The intellectuals should try to understand the real significance behind the dress.

Devotee: All costumes are Mother's.

The Holy Mother laughed in gay abandon as if intoxicated. It seemed as if She was unaware of Her surroundings.

Siddha and avatar

Question: Mother, is there any difference between an *Avatar* and a *Sadhana Siddha* (one who has attained the state of Perfection through spiritual practices)?

Amma: Yes, there is a difference between *Avatars* and those who have reached the state of *nirvikalpa samadhi* (absorption in the Self) through *sadhana*. It is like the difference between a person who goes to Bombay and returns immediately and a person who has been born and brought up there. If you ask whether they know Bombay, both of them will say yes. But the knowledge of the native is different from that of the casual visitor. *Avatars* come down with full awareness of Reality. They have no limitations except those which they themselves accept. It is not the same in the case of those who have at-

tained that state through spiritual practice. They have certain limitations. We do not look upon them as equal to Sri Krishna, do we? Many such people lived during Sri Krishna's lifetime, yet they were all worshipping Him. The waves are not different from the ocean, yet they cannot be said to be the ocean itself. We can see differences amongst those who have gained the state of *nirvikalpa samadhi*. The conduct of a *karma yogi*, a *jnana yogi* and *bhakta* will all be different from each other. Even though they all experience *samadhi*, one can see different moods in them corresponding to the spiritual practices which they have been following. The moods that were seen in Sri Ramakrishna were not the same as in Ramana Maharshi. The same is true of other Realized Souls as well. Therefore, even though they were all great souls, their Realization manifested differently. This depends on the path through which they attained the goal.

Question: Sometimes we don't understand all that Mother says.

Amma: Those who have learned the scriptures and have the power born of *sadhana* will properly understand what Mother says.

Question: Mother, is it very harmful for a *sadhak* if he loses his semen?

Amma: Cow dung is burnt and mixed in water in order to make sacred ash. The pure ash is obtained by draining away the water. In the same manner, if molasses is kept in a pot with a small hole in the bottom, a fluid will ooze out from there. That is not real molasses. It is the useless water content which is flowing out. What remains will be pure molasses. It will not be so harmful if you lose your seed unknowingly. It is not the real seed that you are losing at that time. Real seed gets lost only when it comes out due to lustful thoughts. Even if the seed does get lost, do not feel upset. You should do

meditation and *japa* during the whole day. If lustful thoughts still come, observe silence and do *mantra japa* the next day. Teach a lesson to the mind by observing a fast.

Another devotee: Mother, I have been doing *sadhana* for a long time now but there is no progress at all. Mother, you should bless me.

Amma: Son, when cooking oil is heated sufficiently for frying, you can hear a crackling sound. Until then we might feel that it is not yet ready, despite the fact that we have been heating it for such a long time. A little more time might be enough for the oil to become fully hot. In the same way, at a certain stage, a *sadhak* may feel that he has not gained anything even though *sadhana* has been performed for a long time. But a little more striving may be enough to see the result. Son, proceed courageously. God will take care of the rest.

One thing that you have to remember is not to dissipate the energy which you conserve through spiritual practices. Doing spiritual practices and at the same time indulging in worldly pleasures is like drawing water from a well using a leaky bucket. By the time the bucket reaches the top of the well, there will be no water in it.

Question: There is a saying that only a crying child will get milk.

Amma: So it is said, but it is the same mother who raises both types of children. She knows when they are hungry and will give them milk. The mother's mind will always be on the child who doesn't cry because she knows that he will not cry even if he is hungry. She will be thinking, "Oh, is that son hungry? Where is he? If it is the other one, he will cry when he is hungry. It will be sufficient to feed him then."

Question: Mother, what is the best time to do meditation?

Amma: Night time is the ideal time to do meditation. True seekers meditate at night. Ten hours of meditation in the

daytime is equal to five hours of meditation in the night. Even if you sleep the whole day, you will not get the same freshness and happiness which you will get from a few hours of sleep in the night. This is because in the night the atmosphere is calm and quiet. There are fewer worldly vibrations. Pure air is expelled from blossoming flowers and relatively few worldly thoughts make the atmosphere conducive to meditation. In the daytime there are poisonous germs in the air. The atmosphere is completely polluted with the worldly thoughts of people who are running after material pleasures.

Question: Mother, what a pity it is that human beings in this era are so bad.

Amma: The ocean has no color; the color that we see is the reflection of the sky. In a similar manner, the feeling that others are of bad character is only because of the reflection of our own character in them. Son, purify your mind and then you will see everyone as good. Virtuous people see only good everywhere, while evil-minded people see only bad. Therefore, try to see the good in everyone. Then many others will do the same when seeing your example.

Question: Is it possible to lead a spiritual life without a Guru?

Amma: To a certain extent it is possible. But if the attenuation of *vasanas* is to come about, one must live in the company of a *Satguru*. The Guru's grace should be received. The aspirant himself cannot remove his subtle *vasanas*. To overcome adverse circumstances one needs the guidance, instruction and grace of a *Satguru*.

Life after death

Question: What determines the conditions of the next birth?

Amma: The next birth is in accordance with the thought that one has at the time of death. Only intense and unfulfilled desires will come at that time.

Question: Then would one become a house in one's next life if one thinks of a house at the time of death?

Hearing the question, the Mother exploded into laughter. The other devotees also laughed loudly. Finally the laughing subsided.

Amma: If one dies thinking of a house one will not become a house, but one may become a person who builds houses. Otherwise, if the thought is about a half-built house, one will take another birth to fulfill the desire of completing it.

Question: The *Bhagavad Gita* says, "One who leaves his body thinking of Me (the Lord) will merge in Me."

Amma: That is true. But son, do you think that it is so easy to think of the Lord at that time? To think of Him at the time of one's death requires life-long practice. Only one who has directed all thoughts towards Him through constant practice can think of Him at the end. Otherwise, what will come in the mind at that time will be the prominent, unfulfilled desires.

There was a rich merchant who was very cunning and wicked. Having heard the story of Ajamila¹⁴, he thought that it would be easy to merge in God at the time of death if he

¹⁴ Ajamila had led a virtuous life in his childhood but later went along the wrong path and committed numberless sins. At the time of death, he called out to his son in fright on seeing the messengers of Death. His son's name was "Narayana" which is a name of Lord Vishnu. Hearing their Lord's name, the messengers of Lord Vishnu came and released Ajamila from the grip of the messengers of Death, declaring that one who repeats the Name of God at the time of death deserves Liberation.

gave Divine Names to his children and called them then. Therefore, he named his three sons Rama, Krishna and Govinda respectively. He never thought of God nor did he do any spiritual practice, thinking that it would be enough to call the names of his children at the time of death. His sole intention in life was to somehow make a profit. Through corrupt and evil ways, he made a lot of money. Finally, when he grew old and was completely bed-ridden and about to breathe his last, he called the names of his children loudly, “Rama, Krishna, Govinda!” Upon hearing their names, they all came. The old man looked at their faces and asked, “What? If all of you have stayed home, who is in the shop?” Immediately after saying this, he died! It is the previously acquired tendencies and nature that guide us on the death bed. To think of God at that time is impossible if one’s thoughts and actions were not pure while one was active in this world.

15 January 1984

Today was a *Bhava Darshan* day. People had already started coming before noon. Many inquisitive grahasthas and young men also came since it was a public holiday. The Holy Mother came to the *darshan* hut a few minutes past nine. The first person to go for Mother’s *darshan* was a gentleman from a village north of Cochin. He prostrated to the Mother but did not get up. He remained in that position like a log of wood for two or three minutes. The Mother did a most unusual thing. She placed Her feet on his head. The man suddenly sprang to his feet and danced in joy. He was laughing and weeping at the same time. He finally calmed down after some time and sat near the Mother. Afterwards, when leaving the hut, he explained to the devotees who questioned him that he had cherished an intense desire that Mother should place Her

feet on his head, and had decided that he would not get up after prostrating to Her until She did so. Intuiting his wish, the Mother graciously granted it. Even afterwards, the mere remembrance of this experience would send this devotee into ecstasy, much to the chagrin of his family.

Until noon the Mother received the devotees and sat talking with them. During lunch the Mother Herself fed all the devotees with Her own hand, giving each one a ball of rice. It was really a charming sight to see the Mother feeding the devotees with motherly love and affection. Having gone to Her room at one in the afternoon, the Holy Mother again returned at three. She sat on the temple verandah and as usual, the devotees sat around Her.

Faith

One young man: Isn't it blind faith to say that there is a God?

Amma: Children, everyone lives by faith. Having the faith that there is nothing harmful in front of us, we take each step. We do not place our foot down if we think a poisonous snake may be in front of us. Would you have started from your house to come here if you knew that there was going to be an accident on the way? Of course not. You set out because you had faith that there will not be an accident on the way. Isn't this blind faith? We eat food from restaurants because we believe that there is no danger in doing so. But there are people dying from food poisoning, aren't there? Life itself will become impossible if we do not believe blindly. We believe the bus driver and we believe the doctor. Thus, there are so many people in whom we believe blindly. Disbelieving everything is a kind of mental disease, isn't it? In certain kinds of mental illness, one can see the patient not believing anything. Life is possible only through faith.

Real faith, however, is different from the aforesaid ordinary faith. Faith should be born of meaningful principles. Only then can it be called faith. It was through such faith that our ancestors lived, abiding in God. None of them believed blindly. Those who have seen God directly become witnesses to His existence. Their testimony does not become invalid simply because we have not seen Him. Those who have seen Him prescribed the way for others to see Him. It is not right to reject their testimony without following their advice on a trial basis, is it? Isn't it a kind of blind faith to reject something without experimentation?

The young men remained silent. A few seconds passed.

Question: It is said that diseases can be cured using divine power. Is that possible?

Amma: The methods of treatment were introduced by the Lord Himself when He incarnated as Dhanvanthari (the first physician) in ancient times. Why did He do that? Because most people have the belief that disease will be cured only through doctors and medicines. However, the Lord will directly take care of one who has the attitude, "There is no one else who can save me; You alone are my refuge." The Lord's grace alone will cure the diseases of people who have that kind of faith and devotion. How many experiences are there as proof of this! If you don't believe all this, then gain conviction by sincerely taking refuge in the Lord and experience it for yourself.

Some say that divine power is not necessary, that the doctor can cure the disease. Couldn't it simply be the Lord who made available the help of a good doctor? However good the doctor may be, can he stop the soul from leaving the body? If so, let him hold his own soul back. Let him try not to die

himself. In this way, we can see that it is the Lord who saves even when we say that it is the doctor.

Question: Can one force the mind to meditate?

Amma: To make the mind meditate by force is like pushing a hollow log under water. It will shoot up to the surface as soon as you remove your hand. The same is the case with the mind. If you force it to do something, it will revert to its original nature as soon as possible. That is the nature of the mind. Mere suppression or force will not help. You should slowly try to conquer the mind by giving it new ideas, and cultivating good habits in the place of old and bad ones. Control the mind by using discriminative thinking.

Anyhow, in the beginning stages of meditation, you will have to sit and apply a little force. Otherwise it is difficult to teach patience to the body and mind. Once you start getting a taste for meditation, to sit will not be difficult and slowly it will become spontaneous. Until then you must strive hard.

In the olden days the atmosphere was conducive to meditation. There was no impure air. But in those days one had to do more penance to achieve anything. Today the atmosphere has become polluted, but one will progress as a result of doing even a little *sadhana* if it is done sincerely.

Question: Mother, is *japa* by itself enough?

Amma: Remembrance of the form of God is also necessary. Do not do mere *japa* for a long time without also remembering the form. Otherwise the deity presiding over the mantra will get angry.

At that time, a *brahmacharin* approached the Mother and prostrated to Her.

Brahmacharin: Mother, news has come from home that a relative has died. May I just go there and come back?

Mother: Children, *sadhaks* should not go to places where there is death or places where marriages are taking place. If they go to a place where there is death, they will see people sorrowing for a non-eternal object. A peculiar smell will arise from the dead body which spreads germs which will harm the *sadhak*. There, the relatives cry over an illusory thing, and lament about the unavoidable and unsolvable.

What if you go to a marriage celebration? Everyone thinks about marriage. The children think about their marriage which will happen in the future. The elderly think about their marriage which occurred in the past. Whom to marry is the thought of young men and women. Thus the whole atmosphere is filled with thought vibrations of marriage. The mind of the *brahmacharin* who is in that atmosphere will unknowingly go to that world, at least for a moment. That may become cause for his degeneration. Therefore, during the period of *sadhana*, do not go to such places.

21 January 1984

At eleven o'clock in the morning, the Holy Mother unexpectedly came to the kitchen. She took a bit of the vegetable curry which was made on that day and tasted it. She found that it was a little too tasty.

Amma: (In a very serious tone) You should not add more flavor like this for the *brahmacharins*. What they need is the taste of the Self, and this is an obstacle for attaining that.

The Mother then came out. Hearing the *brahmacharin* talking angrily to someone, Amma warned him.

Amma: A *sadhak*'s words will remain in Nature. Be careful. If you utter improper words, the reaction will come back to you. A *sadhak*'s wrong-doings will evoke the wrath of God.

The result of his errors will be multiplied by ten. How insignificant are humans before a cyclone. Likewise, nobody can say how great the power of God's wrath will be.

The Holy Mother went out and sat on the front verandah of the meditation hall. Meditation hour was over. Some of the *brahmacharins* came and sat near Her.

Brahmacharin: Mother, how many years of *sadhana* are needed to attain the Ultimate Goal?

Amma: Even four years are not needed to attain the goal if you do *sadhana* as Mother says. You can reach the destination sooner than others if you travel in a non-stop express bus. One who has the guidance of a Perfect Master and a strong determination to reach the goal will not commit mistakes. Such a person will be like the non-stop express bus. But it cannot be said how much time it will take to reach the destination by a person who travels in an ordinary bus which stops in several places while picking up and dropping off passengers. In other words, it is difficult to say how long a person who has no Guru and who is of weak determination will take to reach the goal.

Question: Mother, what is the best time for meditation?

Amma: The time from five p.m. to eleven a.m. is good for meditation. If you meditate for one hour, you should sit silently for at least two hours afterwards. It is good to observe silence every morning until eleven o'clock. Energy will be wasted if you speak. Don't waste your energy like a person squandering his hard-earned wealth on mere peanuts.

Some people say that they have been doing *sadhana* for four or five years but still there is no benefit. Even while they sit in meditation, they are thinking of what they are going to say afterwards. In this way they waste all their acquired energy by indulging in worldliness. Afterwards they complain that

they have not gained anything even after long years of spiritual practice. Energy will also be dissipated by spitting too much. Saliva is energy. But you should spit out the phlegm.

Once in a week you should live only on fruits. This will benefit both the body and *sadhana*. As far as possible, you should say “we” instead of “I.” This will be helpful to reduce the ego.

Question: Why should one try to enter the spiritual world which is gained through so much hardship?

Amma: Who told you that it is so difficult? Difficulties arise only after entering into this impure body. *Sadhana* is not a suffering or a hardship for one who has the determination to reach the goal. Even if you feel that it is a hardship, the purpose is to eliminate all of life’s other difficulties in order to gain bliss. For that, one has to undergo a little suffering. Why do students study? To get rid of all the hardships of study, and to obtain a permanent job so that they can live happily. Likewise, *sadhana* is done to remove all the difficulties of worldly life so that you can become a true servant of the Lord and the world, and thereafter lead a blissful life of mental equipoise.

Question: Even Nature has become polluted nowadays.

Amma: God’s creation has not become polluted. It is human beings who are so. Through their evil thoughts and actions, they trespass Nature’s laws and pave the way for their own destruction. Even animals, who live in harmony with Nature, are better than most human beings. At least a spiritual being should lead a pure and straightforward life. A spiritual being should be like a tree which gives shade even to the person who cuts it asunder. A spiritual being should be like the wind that blows equally over both excreta and the flower. Desires are the cause of *vasanas*. Therefore, you should control your desires. During *sadhana* a *sadhak* will become lean like a lizard. Later, if he wants, he can put on weight.

Wherever they go, *sadhaks* should either repeat their mantra silently or meditate. If it is a noisy place, they should sit in one place reading a spiritual book. Those who observe the disciplines correctly are the ones who really love Mother.

Mother got up and went to Her room at one-thirty. Again, at four-thirty, She came to the meditation hall. From four-thirty to six was meditation time. All the *brahmacharins* came, sat in their respective places, and started meditating. The Holy Mother closely observed them both internally and externally. By calling their names, Mother made those *brahmacharins* whose concentration had decreased become alert. To some She said, "See, you are losing your concentration on your form of meditation." To another one She said, "Be alert." It is Mother's habit to keep a few pebbles near Her while observing the meditation of the *brahmacharins*. She throws them at the *brahmacharins* to bring back their attention. Throwing one of those pebbles at a *brahmacharin*, the Mother warned, "You are thinking about something else. Open your eyes and repeat your mantra." Thus She sat there observing and instructing them until their meditation became deep. *Bhajans* began at six-thirty. The Mother sang,

*O Beloved of Radha, Lord of my heart,
 Destroyer of misery and Support of all,
 Is it not Thee only,
 The Embodiment of Consciousness,
 Who has occupied my mind?*

*Pleasure and peace, the intellect and mind,
 All household goods and
 A means of livelihood,*

*Is it not Thee Who has kindly blessed me
With all these?*

The *brahmacharins* and other devotees responded. The Mother abruptly stopped singing, feeling that some of the *brahmacharins* were singing without love and devotion.

Amma: (In a serious tone) Other than losing the power that you acquire through meditation, *bhajan* serves no purpose if it is not sung with concentration and love. Do not sing if you cannot sing with concentration. If the *bhajan* is sung with one-pointedness, it is beneficial for the singer, the listeners, and Nature as well. Later when the listeners reflect on the songs, they will try to live in accordance with the lessons enunciated therein. *Bhajans* should be sung with eyes closed. You should hear the song you yourself are singing and grasp its meaning. While singing, you should imagine that your Beloved Deity is listening to the song while sitting in your heart or standing before you. You should be able to shed at least one tear at the Lord's Feet while singing. During Mother's *sadhana*, She could not even utter the names of Krishna or Devi. If She did so, She would immediately become lost to this world. Mother desires to see Her children crying for God. That is how you can make Mother happy.

Having said these words, the Mother sang the rest of the song. The atmosphere became saturated with spiritual vibrations. It seemed that the Mother's instructions went straight into everyone's heart. They all lost themselves in the glory of chanting the Divine Name.

4 February 1984

It was nine-thirty in the morning. The Holy Mother came out of the meditation hall after sitting with the *brahmacharins*

during their meditation. Some householder devotees from the eastern part of Kerala had just arrived. Among them were some new people. It seemed that they were very interested in seeing the Holy Mother. As the Mother came towards them, the devotees became very happy. They all prostrated to the Mother and one elderly devotee who used to visit the Ashram frequently said, “Mother, we brought a few new people with us (pointing to three middle-aged people). Though they are from the same town as we are, these three work abroad. When we told them about Mother, they wanted to see you immediately.”

Her countenance lighting up with a benign, unfading smile, the Holy Mother affectionately stroked each of them on the arm. As She patted the third man, the Mother said, “Don’t worry, son, you will get another job by the time you get back.” In amazement he looked at the other devotees and again turned towards the Mother. He was about to say something to Her, but by that time the Mother had already proceeded towards the *darshan* hut calling, “Come on, children.”

The Mother Herself spread a mat on the floor for the devotees to sit on and then She Herself sat on the cot. But the next moment She got up and sat on the floor with the devotees. Her innate simplicity, humility and innocence were always an attraction and a source of inspiration for the devotees. When everyone was seated, the surprised devotee asked, **Devotee:** Mother, for the last twenty years I have been living in America with my wife and children. I hardly had any contact with my native town. For many years I have worked for a big firm, but last year, due to some misunderstandings, I lost my job. Since then, I have been searching for another one. Mother, my question is how did you come to know about the whole thing?

As he finished the last sentence his eyes filled with tears and his voice became choked. The Holy Mother, who was smiling all the while, looked at him calmly and said,

Amma: Son, forget about it. You will get another job which will be awaiting you by the time you get back. It is enough for you to know that.

As the devotee sat amazed and overwhelmed, the elderly man who had brought him said, “Sreedhar, what you have experienced is nothing. You are yet to experience many more wonders.” Uttering, “*Namah Shivaya*,” the Holy Mother said,

Amma: Children, Mother doesn’t know anything. The only thing She knows is that She doesn’t know anything. Everything happens because of the children’s innocent devotion and pure intentions.

Devotee: Mother, only you can say that. That is your nature.

Exactly as the Mother had said, the gentleman did, in fact, receive the appointment order for the new job the very next day after his return. He wrote a very touching letter from the States in which he said, “O Mother, O my God, what made you shower so much grace upon this insignificant child of yours? As Mother had said, the very next day after returning here I received an appointment order. Holding that in my hand, I saw Mother’s smiling and compassionate face. I could not control the stream of tears that flowed from my eyes. Even now, as I write this letter, I am offering flowers in the form of tears at Mother’s lotus feet.”

Another devotee: Mother, one of my friends tried to destroy my faith in you even though he has not even seen Mother.

Amma: Do not try to argue with such people. Immediately leave them. If you remain with them, they will create agita-

tion in your mind. Their arguments themselves are born out of faith, the faith that they can corner the believers with their arguments. They believe that there is no God. That belief itself is a faith, but a negative one. Protesting and revolting against anything and everything, such people will destroy their own lives. Anyhow, one day or another, in this birth or in any of the coming births, they must call God. When bitter experiences toss them up and down, when they become totally helpless in life, then they will call God.

Destroying someone's faith is a sin equal to the killing of a pious *brahmin*. Why should those who cannot save anyone shatter the faith of others? Anyhow, do not trouble yourself by worrying about such people. God will take care of them. Their mental makeup is their own. Let us proceed with our own. Such occasions can be used to test the strength of your own faith, to see whether it will shake or not upon hearing their words. Son, if they have the faith that they can shatter someone else's faith, let it be your faith that nobody can shake yours.

Another devotee: The spiritual path is very difficult. One does not even know how long one should strive.

Amma: Son, everything is in the hands of Time. One should perform one's *sadhana* sincerely and wait patiently. If you work hard, certainly you will get the result. Are you not familiar with the saying, "Bhishma's vow and Bhagirathi's efforts." Bhishma of Mahabharata fame stood by his vow of celibacy in spite of all temptations, and finally he attained Liberation. Likewise, Bhagirathi, a king of ancient India, persisted in his *tapas* in order to bring down the celestial river Mandakini to earth so that it would wash the ashes of his ancestors whose souls would then attain peace. He succeeded and legend has it that the present-day Ganges River is that river. Every aspir-

ant should have the firmness, courage, persistence and patience which Bhishma and Bhagirathi had.

It is good if one starts when one is young. If children between the ages of five and twelve come to spiritual life, they can gain spiritual experience before the age of twenty-five. If intense spiritual practices are done, one will start experiencing glimpses of one's real nature.

Question: Mother, why is it said that it is not good to sleep during dusk? And why do people chant the Divine Name at that time?

Amma: During the twilight hours, the atmosphere is filled with polluted air. It is the time when day and night meet. Thieves will think of the thefts that they want to do in the night. It is a time when different kinds of passions arise in pleasure seekers. In order to overcome these negative vibrations and keep one's mind unaffected and serene, it is better to focus one's attention on the Supreme Lord. One should not sleep at this time either. That will create a tendency always to sleep at that hour. One should chant the Divine Name and glorify the Lord. By doing so, the atmosphere will be purified and one will become peaceful and tranquil, keeping the mind concentrated on the single thought of God.

Question: Isn't it due to lack of self-confidence that one places so much faith in the Guru?

Amma: Self-confidence is good but what if it is only egotism? The difficulty in taking refuge in the Guru is due to the fact that the ego does not agree to surrender itself, is it not? Our discrimination has not developed properly. What is real confidence and what is not? We need someone who has real Self-confidence, the confidence born of awareness of the Real Self. Such a person can weigh the validity of our self-confidence and make corrections if necessary.

However long excreta lies in the sun, unless the wind blows on it, its bad smell will not go. However much *tapas* one does with the attitude of “I am a great *tapasvi*,” the attenuation of *vasanas* will not take place. For this, the Guru’s grace alone is needed. To go to an unknown place, one must put one’s faith in a guide. When such is the case for reaching a physical destination, what could be the objection to placing one’s faith in a Realized Soul in order to reach the supremely subtle and mysterious Inner Reality?

As instructed by the Mother, a *brahmacharini* brought a decoction made with pepper, ginger, molasses and basil leaves. The Mother drank a little and put it down.

A householder devotee: Mother, you should tell the neighbors not to soak coconut fibre in the backwaters surrounding the Ashram. It smells terrible.

Amma: Son, there is no bad smell when there is the attitude that it is “mine.” Nobody cares about the putrid smell of one’s own wound. With how much affection do we remove the excreta of our own child. Sometimes we might even vomit on our own body. Are we not accepting all those without complaint? Once the attitude of “mine” comes, then none of these are a problem at all. Think of the coconut fibre as ours, (Mother laughs) then there will not be any smell. (Laughter)

When we are working in someone’s factory, we will always try to skip work. We will have little enthusiasm and feel tired quickly. But if it is our own factory, the attitude changes. Then, even if we can’t eat or sleep, we will be enthusiastic. There will be no fatigue because it is our own. If you develop that attitude of “mine” towards everything, then all problems will disappear.

A new devotee: Mother, I have visited many spiritual places but have received nothing.

Amma: Children, reverential devotion should be coupled with the cultivation of a loving relationship towards your Guru. Reverence is helpful for our progress but real benefit will be gained only from that bond with the Guru. Without that, there is no meaning in complaining, “I received nothing.” It is difficult for a seedling to grow if you plant it in the midst of densely growing trees. It will have to bend to this side and that in order to get sufficient sunlight. If the trunk is crooked, a boat or any other such thing cannot be made using the wood from that trunk. The tree would have grown straight if there had been no obstacles to its getting light. We can easily and directly reach the goal if we remove the obstacles beforehand. To achieve that, attachment to the *Satguru* is necessary. That will rid us of all other attachments. Those who wander from one Guru to another are not fit for spirituality.

New devotee: Mother, what should I do?

Amma: Crying to God for five minutes is equal to one hour of meditation. If tears are not coming by themselves, try to cry by thinking, “Why am I not able to cry?” Son, try to develop devotion. That is the easiest way.

Question: What is the difference between spiritual bliss and material happiness?

Amma: It is like the difference between the water in the river and the water in the drain. You can no doubt quench your thirst by drinking drain water, but afterwards you will fall ill. If you drink river water, your thirst will be quenched and you will not become sick.

Question: What are the scriptures for?

Amma: Scriptures are like a map. Knowing the path, we can travel in unfamiliar strange places. Otherwise, there will be delay and we will wander about unnecessarily.

Sraddha (attention)

One of the devotees asked the Mother's permission to sing a song in front of Her. Mother said, "Sing, sing. Mother is happy to listen to God's Name." He sang,

O man, who craves for the pleasures of this world, do you have peace even for a moment? This precious human birth is not for that, but has a sublime purpose. Just as a moth sees a flame and jumps into it, you get deluded by the illusory objects of this world and begin to end your life without reaping any benefit.

That Ultimate Goal can be reached only by relinquishing pride and the desire for wealth and wife. O man, that is the only way to escape from this bondage.

Hearing the song, the Mother went into deep *samadhi*. Tears of bliss rolled down Her cheeks. The song and the Mother's high spiritual mood created a meditative atmosphere. Some devotees and *brahmacharins* meditated while others sat gazing at the Mother's blissful face. A few minutes passed and the Mother opened Her eyes uttering "Shiva, Shiva." It seemed that the Mother was struggling to come down to the mundane world again.

Amma: (After a long pause) Mother always maintains the attitude of a child while singing. If that attitude is not there, the mind will completely merge with God and then afterwards it will become very difficult to come out.

Some of the *brahmacharins* were observing silence and fasting on this day. When the Mother saw one of the *brahmacharins* passing by the side of Her hut, She asked him, "Son, are you

keeping silent today?” As an answer, he nodded his head in the affirmative and continued walking. As he was coming back, the Mother again enquired, “Son, did you eat anything today?” Without thinking, the *brahmacharin* answered, “No.” Immediately he realized his foolishness. Forgetting that he was observing a vow of silence, he had spoken. The Holy Mother and the other devotees burst into laughter.

Amma: Mother was testing to see how much *sraddha* (attention) you have. Children, you may feel that as it is Mother who is asking, why can’t I talk? (Looking at the devotees) He is not at fault. (To the *brahmacharin*) Even then, you should be careful; Mother will test you like this. Children, you should always proceed with discrimination.

Question: Mother, what is the benefit of following a controlled diet?

Amma: A controlled diet is good in every way. The body is made up of food. The good and bad qualities of the food will reflect in the body. As the body and mind are interdependent, whatever happens in the body will affect the mind, and vice versa. Do not use too much vegetable curry in your food. Use just enough to mix the rice together. If too many spices like chilies and tamarind are eaten, there will be an increase in semen which, in turn, will create more passion.

Seeing one *brahmacharin* sitting idle, Mother called him near.

Amma: Son, do not sit idle like this; God will get angry, and bad thoughts will arise in you. It is much better if you dig ditches and fill them again than to sit idle. How much work is there to do if you really look. You should spend your time doing some physical work if you do not have the mind to do meditation and *japa*. Sitting idle means letting the mind brood on unwanted things.

Brahmacharin: (In a sad tone) Mother, now and then there is a break in my *sadhana*.

Amma: Even if honeybees are sitting on the dates, he who desires them will somehow climb up and get the fruit. He who is intent on the goal will move forward and proceed, overcoming all the adversities.

Question: Is the graveyard a fit place to do *sadhana*?

Amma: Yes, it is. Normally a graveyard is very peaceful and calm. That is why it is recommended as a good place for meditation. Usually graveyards will be in a remote corner away from the noisy town or city. Therefore, the tense and chaotic vibrations of the city will not be there. Human beings with all their negative thoughts and vibrations are not there. Therefore, the atmosphere is conducive to meditation. But one needs mental strength and courage to sit there. The graveyard is also beneficial in reminding us about the transitory nature of life. Using ash from the cremation grounds is helpful in protecting one from poisonous germs.

Question: Doesn't a pilgrimage to holy places benefit a *sadhak*?

Amma: In the beginning it is good for *sadhaks* to go on a pilgrimage. Travelling in a spirit of renunciation will be an aid to understanding the nature of the world. But do not do too much travelling. It will become a habit, and then it will become difficult to do *sadhana* sitting in one place. Without wasting time, it is better to stay in one place and do *sadhana*.

In the olden days, however far it was, people used to walk all the way to the pilgrim center. Along the way they would stop here and there to take either food or a little rest. Whatever came to them of its own accord was accepted as God's *prasadam* and they were content. They bothered little about their bodily needs, comforts and climatic changes. Pilgrimages were undertaken with an attitude of renunciation. It would take months, sometimes even years, for them to reach the

pilgrim center. Due to their renunciation and detachment, by the time they reached their destination, they would have gained a lot of mental maturity and spiritual advancement. That is why it is said that one who goes to Kasi will get Liberation -- because of the way the pilgrimage was performed. Now everything is gone. Nowadays pilgrimages are more or less like picnics. If one travels about without having acquired the energy born of spiritual practice, one will just get tired.

Question: Why is it said that *sadhaks* should not eat certain foods?

Amma: It is because some foods are not helpful for developing positive qualities. However, it is difficult to say that a particular food should not be eaten at all. The nature and habits of human beings will differ from place to place as will the climate. *Sadhaks* who live in hot places will not eat certain vegetables that will heat up the body. Those who live in the Himalayas will eat them because it is cold there. Similar is the case with tea and coffee which may be considered as stimulating in a hot climate but as a necessity in a cold one.

Question: Nowadays sudden changes occur in the climate. Why is it so, Mother?

Amma: In the olden days the atmosphere was purified by performing Vedic rituals and sacrifices. But today no such practices exist and the atmosphere is polluted; it is filled with poisonous germs. Everything has become unnatural and artificial. People live out of harmony with the laws of Nature. Though devoid of a discriminative intellect, animals live in harmony with the laws of Nature. But the so-called intelligent human beings continuously break those rules and lead a less than animal life. The human mind has lost its harmony. In the olden days, this harmony was kept up through spiritual practices and righteous living. Now that is gone and Nature also has started reacting.

When trees diminish, rain also becomes less. Even the rain that does come, comes at the wrong time. Similar is the case with sunshine also; either it will be too much or too little. It is all because of the evil doings of human beings; no one else is to blame.

Vows

Question: Mother, what are vows for?

Amma: The atmosphere will be more polluted on certain days such as the eleventh day of the lunar month and the day of the full moon. It is to escape from this pollution that vows are observed on these days. Importance should be given to *sadhana* on these particular days, because on such days our mind can become more concentrated. Just as there are planets outside, there are subtle planets surrounding each organ of our body, whose movements are similar to those of the planets going around the sun. More concentration can be gained when these subtle planets reach a certain state of vibration. Only fruit should be eaten on these particular days since they are less affected by the atmospheric pollution due to their having skin. The polluting effect will be greater on grains and vegetables. In addition, you should remain silent on these days. The more you talk, the more you breathe in the polluted atmosphere's air. Mental control will increase when you lessen food, and concentration will increase.

One devotee: In many ashrams there is no importance given to *sadhana*. Book learning is most important.

Amma: *Sannyasins* and ashramites of the modern age think that Realization is the same as the study of the scriptures. They give more importance to preaching than to meditation and *japa*. The result is that they become egotistical. Mother is not saying that preaching is useless, but without acquiring

any spiritual power through *sadhana*, how can one's preaching be effective or useful? The subtle aspects of the scriptures can be grasped only if *sadhana* is done. If one studies the scriptures in the very beginning, then later one cannot sit and meditate. One's desire will be to teach others. The attitude will be, "Am I not *Brahman*? Then why should I meditate?" Even while meditating, the ego will rise up repeatedly.

5 February 1984

Today was a *Devi Bhava* day. Though it was a sunny day, the weather was nice and cool and the sea breeze which blew from the west had a soothing effect. The Holy Mother was in the coconut grove at eight-thirty in the morning. It seemed that She wanted to be alone. At first She walked to and fro by the side of the backwaters. Then, after some time, She sat on the bank and became absorbed in Her own world of Pure Consciousness.

At this time a group of devotees consisting of young men, elderly people, women and children entered the Ashram premises. They were very happy when they saw the Mother sitting in the coconut grove. They wanted to go and meet Mother there but Brahmacharin Pai prohibited them, saying, "No, please, don't go to Her now." They were a bit annoyed, but as there was no other choice, they waited.

It was nine o'clock and still the Mother did not move. Pai, with soft steps, walked towards Her and looked at the Mother's face. She was in the same mood as before. The sun's rays filtering through the palm leaves and the blissful smile which danced on the Mother's countenance lent a divine beauty to Her being. Pai remained gazing at Her face for a long time. He turned and sat at a distance watching both the Mother and the devotees in order to prevent them from going near Her.

Finally around nine-thirty the Mother moved slightly. Pai, who had been watching Her closely, went near. The Mother was sitting with eyes opened. He waited for a few more minutes until She turned around and looked at him. The Mother smiled and was about to ask him something when She saw the devotees who were anxiously waiting to come near Her. The Mother waved Her hand and called them. That was enough; in a moment all of them came running.

Everyone prostrated to the Mother after placing before Her the fruit which they had brought as an offering. The Holy Mother asked all of them to sit down. When they were all seated, the Mother lovingly inquired, "Children, have you had your breakfast?" One devotee replied, "No. Today, whatever Mother gives is our breakfast." Uttering "Shiva, Shiva," the Mother gave one banana to each devotee. Everyone was very happy. Another devotee said, "Mother, you should also eat something." Smiling at him, the Mother took a small piece of banana and ate it.

At this point, one devotee said, "Mother, may I ask a question?" Mother gave Her consent through a smile. When *satsang* began, some *brahmacharins* also came and sat with Her.

Self-effort and grace

Question: Can everything be gained through human effort alone?

Amma: Nothing will be gained without effort. But we can only put forth the effort. It is God who has to give the fruit. To open the lock we should go to the locksmith's workshop. If we have to open the lock of the ego, which is made of our likes and dislikes, we must get the key which is with God.

However much we work, nothing will be gained without God's grace.

During Her childhood, Mother and the children from the nearby houses used to play a game. Everyone would hit one person's palm and then run. The person who comes to catch us cannot do anything if we reach a certain coconut tree. They will stand waiting for us to let go of the coconut tree. Now and then, we will run, leaving the tree to be chased by the person who comes to catch us. But again, if we hold on to the coconut tree, he cannot catch us. In the same manner, nobody can do anything to us if we keep holding on to God. Then there is nothing to fear. But if we let go of God, then the objects of the world will haunt us.

Question: Can one reach the goal through faith in the Guru?

Amma: One can reach Perfection through faith in the Guru, but external love alone is not sufficient. Devotion strengthened by knowledge of spiritual principles is needed. Dedication of the body, mind and intellect is required. If one has faith in and obedience to the Guru coupled with knowledge of spiritual principles, *vasanas* will quickly get destroyed.

There is no point in strutting about making a display of one's devotion to the Guru and prayers to God. Sincerity is needed. One should cry and pray to God thus: "O Lord, don't You see me lying down below? O Lord, shower Your grace upon me through Your Hands of thousands and thousands of stars. O Lord, please give me the strength to remember You always. O Lord, give me sorrow so that I will constantly remember You. You alone are my refuge and consolation. How blissful is Your divine world! How beautiful it is! Lift me to Your world of thousands of twinkling stars. Do You not see the ferocious animals of lust and greed coming to swallow me? Are You not seeing me enveloped by poisonous germs and enduring tortures?" Such prayers will quickly bear fruit.

One brahmacharin: Mother, do you intend to establish new ashrams in different places?

Amma: Children, it is not necessary for you to think about ashrams and money. Don't worry, all will come at the right time. What you have to do is to reach the goal of life through *sadhana*.

One devotee: Mother does not reveal certain things so easily.

Amma: Spiritual matters should not be fully told to everyone. Some curiosity should remain in them. We should not make anyone feel satiated.

Achara - code of conduct

Question: Is it necessary to get entrapped in customs forever? Should one not go beyond them?

Amma: Good customs should be observed at least to set an example to the world. If spiritual people do not respect and practice *acharas*, who else will give importance to them? *Acharas* are necessary for a *sadhak*'s spiritual progress. Just as there is a way to act in front of a policeman, there is also a way to conduct oneself before a Guru, elders or in a temple or holy place. Customs will instill a sense of humility and obedience in a *sadhak* which will be an asset in his or her spiritual life.

Previously Mother made no differentiation between men and women. She was really crazy. Then the *brahmacharin* children came to stay and the Ashram came into existence. It was at that time that Mother started paying attention to *acharas*. Only if Mother acts as an example will the *brahmacharins* and others follow. God will make rules and require discipline but He is never bound by that.

One devotee: Mother, it seems that a devotee or *brahmacharin* who visited here from another ashram didn't like the huts and the minimal facilities.

Amma: Having been attached to another ashram first, wherever else one may go, that attachment will remain. This will incline one to find fault with other places. Only through discrimination can one escape from this.

A sadhak: Mother, what is the way to avoid doing that which is wrong?

Amma: Son, you know in your mind that what you are going to do is wrong. Then why should you still do it? Use your discrimination and try to withdraw your mind. If you are mentally weak and have a tendency to do something wrong, then physically remain away from places where you will be tempted.

God will not reside where there is ego and selfishness. If these are there, God will move a thousand feet away from us. He will come close if we call sincerely. Just one moment is enough to jump into the well. The difficulty lies in climbing out. To lose God is easy, but to regain Him is difficult.

Character is most important

Amma: If you want to gain God, the *vasanas* should be conquered and a good character should be developed. Action is what gives value to a person. Even if one is an I.A.S. officer (Indian Administration Service), others will give him the status of a peon if he commits a crime. Good character is most important. Gradually, you should win over the *vasanas* and the goal should be reached.

As it was *Bhava Darshan* day, people continued to come. The conversation ended and the Holy Mother then called the devotees one by one and gave a few minutes for each one to tell Her their personal problems.

At twelve-thirty the Mother asked everyone to go and have their lunch. When She was about to get up, a few more people came and saluted Her. The Mother gave them Her personal attention as well and finally went to Her room at one-thirty.

After lunch, the devotees came and sat in front of the Mother's hut and waited. After reaching the Ashram, the devotees would have thoughts of nothing but the Mother. Spending their time in Her presence was their greatest joy.

At three-thirty the Mother called them in. The devotees entered the hut. The room was not very big, and therefore, everyone had to squeeze and sit jammed in. Even then, all were so happy in Her presence that no one felt the discomfort. Those who could not get in the hut sat outside. The Holy Mother got up from the cot and sat down on the mat with the devotees. Someone among the devotees asked, "Didn't Mother have Her lunch?"

The Mother replied, "My children's happiness is Mother's food." The Mother had a pain in Her back. One of the women devotees massaged Her. The devotee was overflowing with joy. The Mother commented, "All the other daughters must be feeling jealous now. (All laugh) Each one of you should imagine that it is you who is sitting and rubbing in her place."

Control of mind

Question: Mother, what is the way to control the mind quickly?

Amma: You can control the mind quickly only through *japa*. Son, there is no short cut on the spiritual path. Whatever the way, a good amount of effort is needed. That is not like going to the market and buying something. Even then, by doing *japa* you can keep the mind from thinking unnecessary thoughts. However, concentration is absolutely necessary.

There is a benefit in following the path of devotion. One will get bliss from the very beginning itself. Thus one will be encouraged to perform *sadhana*. In other paths like *pranayama* (control of the breath), bliss will be gained only at the end. Just as one gets fruit even from the base of a jackfruit tree, *bhakti* is the path from which one gets fruit from the very beginning onwards.

Question: Why is so much importance given to concentration?

Amma: Nothing can be done properly without concentrating the scattered mind. Even ordinary actions can be performed perfectly only if there is concentration. Then what can be said of attaining the knowledge of God, the subtlest of the subtle? It is through the heat born of concentration that sexual energy gets converted into *ojas* (pure vital energy). Concentration is needed if unbroken celibacy is to become fully beneficial. It is said that it is harmful if worldly people practice celibacy. Do you know why? Because if they don't do *sadhana*, the seminal energy will not get converted into *ojas* and will remain stagnant in the body.

One devotee: So many different types of people come to see Mother. They all feel and experience that Mother is their closest relative. Mother dances to everyone's tune.

Amma: (Laughingly) Mother doesn't dance according to anyone's tune. The love that radiates from Mother to the whole universe influences them. Thus they feel that Mother is their own. Many of them do not know anything about spirituality. Some householders come and tell Mother all kinds of mundane things concerning their quarrels with neighbors and other such problems. Mother will sit as if She is listening with great interest. Do you know why? Because without going to their level, Mother cannot catch them and save them. A person who walks, catching hold of the hand of a child, must

walk slowly along with the child. Otherwise, the child cannot keep up with him. If he walks making long steps, the child may even fall down.

One devotee: The Mother will pretend that She is acting in accordance with everyone's wish. But finally She will make everyone dance to Her tune.

(All laugh, including the Mother.)

Amma: Those who do not call God even once can be heard calling Him a hundred times when a thorn pierces their foot. But God will protect those who constantly remember Him from all dangers.

Character affects the world

Question: How polluted the world has become! How is it possible to correct this situation?

Amma: The nature of the things in the world will be in accordance with our actions. A king was separated from the rest of his party when he went hunting in the forest. As he was walking, tired and weary due to hunger, he saw some forest dwellers. He asked them, "Which fruit is good to eat?" They replied, "Any fruit in this forest is good to eat. Even naturally bitter fruits are sweet here." The king was astounded and enquired as to how it could be so. They said, "The king who rules this country is a repository of good qualities. Therefore, the subjects are good-natured. Maybe it is because there is no one evil in the country that the trees give sweet fruits only. Nature is pleased with the good acts and qualities of the king and his subjects." The forest dwellers did not know that it was the king himself who was standing in front of them. Even so, they received him in a respectful way.

It was as an egoistic person that the king returned to his city. He was inflated with ego thinking that because of his greatness, even bitter fruits had become sweet. As a result, he started doing unrighteous actions. Later the king once again went to the forest. The forest dwellers saw him as he was about to eat some fruit and said, “Everything is spoiled due to the evil rule of the king of this country. Due to his wicked behavior, the subjects also are acting in an evil way and Nature has become displeased. None of the fruits here are good to eat.” The king was shocked and returned home thinking about all his evil actions with repentance.

Our character will be the cause of both good and evil in the world. Knowing that, you should live cautiously. The actions of human beings are the basis of Nature’s goodness.



Glossary

ACHARA: Traditional customs and observances.

ADHARA: Substratum.

ADVAITA VEDANTA: Philosophy of Non-duality.

AGNANA: Ignorance.

ANANDAM: Bliss.

ANACHARAS: Contrary to custom.

Arati: Waving burning camphor before the Deity as the conclusion of worship.

ARCHANA: Worship through repetition of Names of God.

ASANA: A seat; a posture in Hatha Yoga

ASANA SIDDHI: Perfection in sitting unmoving in one posture for more than 3 hours.

ASURA: A demon.

ATMA DHYANA: Meditation on the Self.

ATMA GNANA: Self-knowledge.

ATMA VICHARA: Self-inquiry.

ATMACHAITANYA: Spiritual power; the illuminating soul.

ATMAN: The Self.

AVATAR: Incarnation of God.

BHAGAVATI: The Divine Mother.

BHAGAVAN: The Lord.

BHAJAN: Devotional singing.

BHAKTI: Devotion.

BHAKTI MARGA: The path of devotion.

BHARAT: India.

BHAYA BHAKTI: Devotion with fear and reverence.

BHOGA: Enjoyment.

BHAGAVATAM: Scripture about the life and deeds of Lord Vishnu's Incarnations.

BHAVA DARSHAN: The Holy Mother giving an audience in the mood of the Divine Mother or Krishna.

BHAVAS: Moods, feelings or attitudes.

BIJAKSHARAS: Seed letters preceding mantras.

BRAHMACHARIN: A celibate student studying the scriptures and undergoing spiritual guidance and discipline under a Guru.

BRAHMAN: The Absolute.

BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy and sense control.

DARSHAN: Audience or vision of the Deity or holy person.

DASA BHAVANA: Attitude of being a servant.

DEVATA: A god or deity.

DEVI BHAVA: Divine mood as Devi, the Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness.

DHYANA: Meditation.

DHYANA RUPAM: Form on which one is meditating.

DOSHA: Evil or defect.

DVARAKA: City where Sri Krishna lived.

EKAGRATA: One-pointedness.

GAURANGA: Sri Krishna Chaitanya, considered as an Incarnation of Sri Radha-Krishna, who lived in Bengal about 400 years ago.

GRAHASTA: One living in a house, i.e., a married person.

GRAHASTASHRAMI: A spiritual-minded grahastha.

GURU: Spiritual master.

GURU BHAVA: Attitude of a Guru.

HRIM: A seed letter associated with the Goddess.

ISWARA AMSA: A partial manifestation of God.

ISWARA BHAVANA: The attitude that oneself is identical with the Lord.

JAPA: Repetition of a mantra.

JIVA: The individual soul; life force.

JIVANMUKTA: One who has achieved Liberation even while tenanted the body.

JIVATMA: Individual soul.

JNANA: Spiritual wisdom or knowledge.

JNANA MARGA: The path of knowledge.

JNANI: A Knower of Truth.

KALIYUGA: The present Dark Age of materialism.

KARMA: Action.

KARMA PHALA: The fruit of action.

KAURAVAS: The enemies of the Pandavas during the Mahabharata War, representing unrighteousness.

KIRTANA: Devotional singing.

KRISHNA BHAVA: The divine mood of Krishna.

KUMBHAKA: Retention of breath during pranayama.

KUNDALINI DHYANA: Meditation on the kundalini.

KURUKSHETRA: The battlefield on which the Mahabharata War was fought.

KAMA: Lust or desire.

LAKSHANA: Symptoms or signs.

LAKSHARCHANA: Worship by repeating the Divine Names 100,000 times.

LAKSHYA: Aim or goal.

LAKSHYA BODHA: A mind intent on reaching the goal.

LALITASAHASRANAMA: The 1000 Names of the Goddess Sri Lalita.

LAYA: Merger or absorption.

LEELA: Play.

MANONASA: Destruction of the mind; permanent subsidence of the mind.

MITHYA: Unreal.

MOKSHA: Release from the cycle of rebirth.

NIRGUNA: Without qualities.

NIRGUNOPASAKA: One who meditates on the qualityless Absolute.

NISHTA: Established; regularity in practice.

NITYA: Eternal.

NITYANITYA VASTU VIVEKAM: Discrimination between the eternal and the transitory.

NAMA: The Divine Name.

OMKARA: The divine sound OM.

PADMASANA: Lotus posture.

PARAMAHAMSA: A God-realised Soul.

PARA BHAKTI: Supreme devotion.

PUJA: Ritualistic worship.

PRANA: Life force.

PRASAD: Consecrated offering to God or a saint.

PREMA BHAKTI: Loving devotion.

PREMA SWARUPA: Of the nature of love.

PURVA SAMSKARA: Previously acquired tendencies.

PUARNAM: Full or perfect.

RAJAS: The principle of activity; one of the three gunas or qualities of Nature.

RASA: Taste; juice; elixir.

RADHA BHAVA: Attitude of being Sri Radha, Beloved of Sri KRISHNA: supreme devotion.

RAJA YOGA: The Royal yoga; the eight-fold yoga of Liberation.

SAGUNA: With attributes.

SAHAJA SAMADHI: The Natural State of being established in the Supreme Reality.

SAMA CHITTATA: Equipoised mind.

SAMATVA BHAVANA: Attitude of equality.

SAMATVA BUDDHI: Mind endowed with the equal vision of beholding all as One.

SAMATVAM YOGA UCHYATE: "Equipoise is yoga."

SAMADHI: The equipoised state of Oneness with God.

SANKALPA SAKTI: Power of resolve or creative imagination.

SANATANA DHARMA: The Eternal Religion of the Vedas.

SARVATRA SAMADA: Equal vision everywhere.

SASTRA: Scripture; science.

SAT KARMA: Good or virtuous action.

SATTVA: Principle of clarity; one of the three qualities of Nature.

SEVA: Service.

SHANTI: Peace.

SHIVOHAM: "I am Shiva."

SIDDHI: Psychic power; perfection.

SISHYA: Disciple.

SVADHARMA: One's own duty.

SAGUNARADHANA: Worship of God as having attributes.

TAMAS: the principle of inertia; one of the three qualities of Nature.

TAMASIC: Pertaining to tamas (see above).

TAPAS SAKTI: The power generated by austerities.

TIRUVATIRA KALI: A village dance.

TRIGUNAS: The three gunas or qualities of Nature, sattva (tranquil), rajas (active), and tamas (inert).

VAIRAGYA: Detachment.

VANAPRASTHA: The third stage of life in which one leaves all worldly activity and devotes oneself to austerities.

VEDAS: The revealed scriptures of Hinduism.

VETTUCHEMBU: A kind of tuber root.

VYAVAHARA: Empirical.

YAMA AND NIYAMA: The do's and don'ts of the path of Raja Yoga.

AWAKEN, CHILDREN!

Dialogues With
Sri Sri Mata Amritanandamayi

VOLUME III

Adaptation & Translation

SWAMI AMRITASVARUPANANDA



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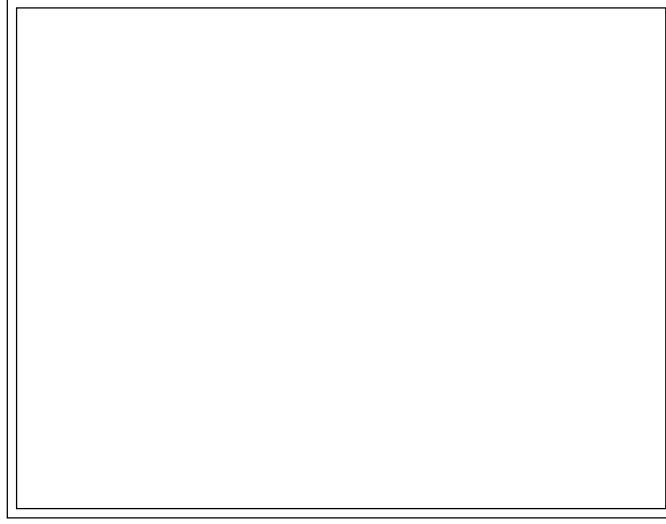
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LOTUS FEET OF HER HOLINESS
SRI SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI

The Resplendent Luminary Immanent
In the Hearts Of All Beings



Vandēham-saccidānandam-bhāvâtîtam-jagatgurum |
Nityam-pûrnam-nirākāram-nirgunam-svâtmasamsthitam | |

I prostrate to the Universal Teacher, Who is Satchidananda (Pure Being-Knowledge-Absolute Bliss), Who is beyond all differences, Who is eternal, all-full, attributeless, formless and ever-centered in the Self.

Saptasâgaraparyantam-tîrthasnânaphalam-tu-yat |
Gurupâdapayôvindôh-sahasrâmsēna-tatphalam | |

Whatever merit is acquired by one, through pilgrimages and from bathing in the Sacred Waters extending to the seven seas, cannot be equal to even one thousandth part of the merit derived from partaking the water with which the Guru's Feet are washed.

GURU GITA
Verses 157, 87

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

My heartfelt gratitude is due to Professor M. Ramakrishnan Nair, the compiler of *Mata Amritanandamayi Sambhashanangal*, the Holy Mother's conversations in Malayalam. The present book, *Awaken, Children!* is a faithful translation of the same, interspersed with some additional materials which were recorded by me. I would like to thank my spiritual sisters Sabari and Remadevi who edited and typed the text, Brahmacharin Nealu who did the typesetting, and all of the Holy Mother's children who took part in producing the book.

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PREFACE

Dear brothers and sisters, herein is contained a direct translation of Holy Mother's *divya upadesha* (Divine advice) into the English language. The tremendous blessing that is bestowed by presenting the Mother's teaching to the English speaking world is not yet fully realized. Now it is left to the reader to sanctify his or her life by a careful reading of the material and a whole-hearted practice of it in daily life.

Several points should be remembered in order that this translation is approached with right understanding. First of all, these conversations have occurred between the Mother and Indian householders and renunciates in the cultural context of India. Also the Mother's advice is given according to the level of understanding of each person to whom she is speaking. Often a word-for-word English translation falls short of conveying the totality of what the Mother has expressed through her mother tongue, Malayalam. One must consider these factors when contemplating her words to achieve deeper insight.

Secondly, the Mother's use of language is direct and earthy. Her words convey an immediacy and intensity of purpose to transmit the Essential, particularly when speaking to *sadhaks* (spiritual aspirants). For instance, when it comes time to bring a point across to a renunciate, the Mother does not mince

words. Thus we can understand her expression, “Worldly pleasure is equal to dog excreta,” to be sound advice to one whose sole aim is God-Realization.

In a separate conversation with a householder, the Mother’s advice takes on an entirely different tone. “Mother does not say that you must give up all desires. You can enjoy them, but do not think that this life is for that only.” Keep in mind that in the Mother’s language, the word ‘world’ literally means ‘That which is seen’ as opposed to the invisible Reality or God. Knowing this will be of great help in interpreting her use of the word ‘worldly.’ When the Mother contrasts that which is spiritual to that which is worldly, she refers to the attitude with which actions are done. Spiritual actions are those actions which lead one to God through selflessness and purity. Worldly actions are those actions which lead one away from God, performed as they are in a spirit of selfishness.

Finally, the Mother speaks to us from the exalted state of *sahaja samadhi*, the natural state of abidance of a Self-Realised Master in the Absolute Reality. The challenge in translating is to render the Mother’s transcendental vision into English for the layman. The vital ingredient in this process is the contemplative mind of the reader. Abandoning all superficiality, may our mind and intellect become subtle and assimilate the eternal Wisdom of the Mother’s words. Firmly established in their practice, may we all revel in the direct experience of the Supreme Absolute without delay.

INTRODUCTION

To express the inexpressible, the subtlest of all experiences from “where speech along with the mind returns, unable to reach There,” silence alone is the language, the language of the Self. A Perfect Master (*Satguru*) can teach his disciples through silence, provided that the disciples have the proper ears and heart to hear and assimilate the teachings of the Guru.

Our most beloved and revered Mother Amritanandamayi, who is ever established in that Supreme State of Silence, the Silence of Eternal Bliss and Peace, speaks only because we are not subtle enough to understand the meaning and depth of the spiritual message which She conveys through Her Silence. In other words, it is compassion, compassion alone, which prompts Her to speak to Her children about the indescribable state of Perfection.

The Mother’s compassion towards Her children, who play with the toys of sense objects in the muddy fields of the world, is vast, deep and infinite like the ocean. In order to make us taste, enjoy and experience the bliss of Immortality, the Mother continuously feeds us with Her nectarous words. But we children are stubborn and impatient. We do not turn to Her to have a sip of that Ambrosia. Whereas, She, the Mother is extremely patient, ready to wait and wait and wait, until we develop a real thirst for It. A loving and affectionate Mother, She still waits at the door-

way of our hearts, constantly knocking, hoping that we will open it some day to welcome Her and allow Her to dwell therein forever. The Mother's arms are outstretched. Simply fall into them. In Her all-embracing and all-consuming love, She will take us, carry us and bathe us in the never-ending stream of bliss and make us rest in Her arms, not for a while, but forever and ever.

We try to listen to the Mother's words but do not hear the Sound from the depths. We were trying to listen to Her through the previous two volumes; we listened but did not really hear it. Therefore, another opportunity to hear the constant ringing of Her call, both from within and without, is volume three of *Awaken, Children!*

Swami Amritasvarupananda

Winter in the tropics of South India was drawing to a close as the cool early morning gave way more quickly to the late-rising sun. In these early months of 1984 the Ashram consisted of a small temple, a classroom also used for meditation, huts of thatched coconut leaves, and the building which housed the family of the Holy Mother. The Arabian Sea was a short walk to the west, splashing its waves onto the shore, unceasingly beckoning the fishermen to challenge its waters. The long, wooden boats that braved this sea recalled ancient times. To the east, the *kayal*, a system of backwaters, was lined with the tall, wooden skeletal frames which held the large fishing nets for night-fishing. This fishing village had been the Mother's ancestral home, and now it had become a home for many spiritual seekers and devotees, whether they were residents or not, for "home" is where the Mother is.

Monday, 27 February 1984

A seven day discourse on the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita* was being conducted in the Ashram. Many householder devotees and inquisitive young men and women who were very eager to learn participated. This was a time when they could all stay with the Holy Mother while leading a life of seclusion and perform spiritual practices in Her Divine Presence. During special occasions like this they found peace and acquired enough mental balance in order to continue their daily activities in the outside world with mindfulness. Daily meditation on the seashore with the Mother,

chanting with Her the *Lalita Sahasranama* (the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother), attending classes on different scriptural texts taught by the residents in the light of the Mother's teachings were inspiring experiences for the devotees and something they will never forget in all their lives. On certain days, the Mother, with her own hands would serve lunch to all the devotees. The personal *darshan* (audience with a holy person) that each devotee received and the answers which the Mother gave to the different queries put forth by the devotees added even more splendor to those glorious days, thus creating an indelible impression on them.

Today was the final day of the discourse, which began on the twenty-first of the month. Just after the morning session of classes and meditation, the Mother was lying down on the sand behind the temple. Her head rested on the lap of a young girl and her feet was placed on the lap of another girl. A group of ladies sat attentively around the Holy Mother. They were longing to hear whatever she had to say, for they had always yearned for a rare moment like this, to be with the Mother in an informal situation. Not only they, but all of Mother's devotees wait for and cherish these precious moments. The Mother was in bliss, laughing and cracking jokes. The women also seemed very joyful, probably reflecting a fraction of the radiant bliss which overflowed from the Mother.

One lady: Amma, could you please give us some in-

structions about marriage and married life?

Amma: (smilingly) What has happened, daughter? Are you in a dilemma? Never leave *mon* alone. (*mon* means “son,” here referring to the husband. The Mother will often address her children as *mon*, “son,” or *mol*, “daughter.”)

(As all have burst into laughter) Daughter, marriage and married life, in fact, are another way to attain God-Realization, although many are not aware of it. For the attainment of this goal, both the husband and the wife need a certain amount of understanding about leading a married life coupled with spirituality. Patience, love and forgiveness are the three qualities that are needed to maintain a good relationship. In most cases, neither the husband nor the wife will have these qualities. Such relationships will always end up in a tragedy. Doubting each other’s love, they will always quarrel. A silly, insignificant incident or sometimes even a single word is enough to make them lose their mental balance. They will always blame each other but never try to find a solution for the misunderstandings and conflicts. As a result, they suffer and also cause their children to suffer.

Parents should always set an example for their children in words and deeds. They are their children’s first teachers. Remember that by fighting and arguing with each other in front of your children, you are setting a bad example and spoiling their future as well. If you cannot straighten out your own difficulties, that is your problem, but why should you create problems

in your children's lives too?

Children, life is not a joke; it is a serious affair which you should handle with the utmost care and alertness. After one has acted thoughtlessly, there is no sense in worrying and shedding tears about it; therefore, try not to act foolishly.

Question: Amma, please suggest a solution.

Amma: Suggesting a solution is easy, but living up to it is much more difficult and important. There should be a sincere effort from your end. It is not difficult if you really want to lead a happy life. Thoughtless words, indiscriminative actions, anger and impatience will always create problems. Why should we consciously jump into problems knowing that to do so will only create sorrow and suffering?

Anyhow, in order to solve a problem, either the husband or the wife should have a certain amount of patience. When Mother says "patience," love and forgiveness are also implied. Real patience comes only when there is love and forgiveness.

Suppose you have a weakness of getting angry easily. Now, what you should do is this. Once you become normal again, go and sit in the family shrine room if you have one, or sit in solitude; then regret and repent your own anger and sincerely pray to your Beloved Deity or to Mother Nature, seeking help to get rid of it. Try to make your own mind aware of the bad outcome of anger. When you are angry at someone, you lose all your mental balance. Your discriminative power completely stops functioning. You say

whatever comes into your mind and you act accordingly. You may even utter crude words at your own wife or children, or your own father or mother. Once you lose your discrimination you may even kill someone. By acting and thinking with anger you lose a lot of good energy. Become aware of this great truth, that these negative feelings will only pave the way for your own destruction, and sincerely try to put forth effort to overcome them.

WHICH IS THE PLACE WHERE MOTHER IS NOT?

At this time a devotee came to write down Mother's words. Seeing him coming, the Mother smiled brightly.

Amma: Here comes the novelist. (All laugh.) (Turning to the devotee) Son, you will give a speech today.

Devotee: Mother, please don't ask me to speak.

Amma: Son, if you are Kali's son, Mother will make you speak today.

Devotee: The *vasana* (tendency) to show off as if I am great will come if I speak.

Amma: That will not happen if you speak in Mother's presence.

Devotee: Mother is just saying that. This is how Mother plays tricks on everyone.

Amma: (in a very stern voice) No, it will not happen

in that way. You will not feel egoistic if you speak, having been told by Mother to speak.

Devotee: Anyhow, I do not feel like speaking.

Amma: But you speak daily in the college, don't you?

Devotee: (not speaking aloud, but thinking to himself) That is how I earn my livelihood. But I cannot speak in Mother's presence.

The Mother smiled mischievously and mysteriously. Fixing her eyes skyward, she replied,

Amma: If so, which is the place where Mother is not?

The devotee was tongue-tied. He was a scholar and a college professor and thus was stunned to hear the Mother speaking out what he was thinking; she had read his mind. The other devotees rejoiced, understanding the depth of the Mother's words. Even though the scholar wanted to say, "But Mother, I don't see you when I lecture in the college," he couldn't. Instead, he fell at the Mother's feet and agreed to speak that day. He said, "Obedience — unconditional obedience — is the only way in the Mother's presence, because she is omniscient and omnipresent."

For the rest of the day the devotees who had heard this exchange between the Mother and the scholar shared this incident with whomever they met, quoting the Mother's statement, "Which is the place where

Mother is not?" In fact, one could say that those words were literally echoing in the atmosphere.

KNOW KALI IN PRINCIPLE

Everyone was resting after lunch. Though the sun's rays were very strong, it seemed that the people hardly felt it. Maybe the Holy Mother's presence made them feel cool and relaxed. It was always true that whenever they visited the Ashram, the devotees would forget everything about the world outside, and would even become oblivious to the immediate surroundings and circumstances while they were in the Mother's presence. They were not bothered by the lack of bodily comforts. The Holy Mother was sitting on the cot in her hut. Taking this as a good opportunity, some devotees, both men and women, gathered around her.

Amma: The children need only their mother.

Devotees: Mother, we are all plunged in the quagmire of worldliness. These are the only occasions we get to cleanse the body and mind. Mother, it is your duty to clean us up.

Amma: Good, Mother likes this attitude. Children, it is good that you are so frank and direct in your questioning. However, to wash away the mind, the child should stand still without resisting. What if the child struggles and runs away while the Mother tries to scrub away the mud which has dried and become hard due to a prolonged period of accumulated dirt? Obey the Mother and allow her to remove it.

Another devotee: Amma, we have heard that when you visited the houses of some devotees you removed and brought here the pictures of *Bhadra Kali* (the fierce aspect of the Divine Mother). We also learned that you instructed that householders should not worship the fierce forms (of gods and goddesses). Therefore, we expected you to take the picture of Kali from our house as well. But you did not take it when you came to our house. Amma, why didn't you?

Amma: Children, you worship while knowing and understanding the *tattwa* (essential principle) behind it. There is no harm in that. Your attitude is that Kali is *Brahmamayi* (the nature of the Absolute Pure Being), *Parashakti* (the Supreme Power), and that She is Everything. Whereas, many worship Kali considering Her only as a fierce goddess who kills the enemies. Those who worship Her in that manner will have the same fiery nature. Quarrels and conflicts will occur in such houses, which will cause harm to them who worship in that way. In fact, that is the wrong conception and the wrong way to worship Her. There is no harm if one worships while understanding the essential principle or *tattwa*.

The devotee who asked the question was truly surprised because he had never disclosed to the Mother what the attitude was in which he worshipped Kali. He had instilled the same faith and idea in the minds of his wife and children; and therefore, when he heard the Mother address "children" instead of "son," he re-

alized that she knew all about their manner of worship. He was amazed.

THE MOTHER AND GOD IN ONE

As the puzzled devotee sat dumbfounded and inspired, a *brahmacharin*, out of his excitement, said,

“Mother is Kali, sometimes very fierce, but that is only when we are disobedient and arrogant. At other times, she is as loving as the Mother who gave birth to us. Mother has instructed the *brahmacharins* to fast on Saturdays. The *brahmacharins* do not have any work to do on that day, Only *japa* and *dhyana* (repetition of mantra and meditation). But Mother herself will prepare rice and curry for everyone and serve it by noon. Mother will not agree if someone says ‘no’ to the food. Mother has more love on that day.” (All burst into laughter, the Mother as well.)

Amma: Whatever it is, Mother is the one who gave birth, isn’t she? How can Mother bear it when the children sit without eating? Mother will become restless by eleven o’clock. Mother herself will go and cook all the food. There is another intention and meaning in cooking and bringing the food by Mother herself on that day of fasting. Mother wants to make the *brahmacharins* experience that if, having dedicated everything to God, one sits for God alone, then God will bring everything to him. Now Mother does it. Later

God Himself will bring and give everything to them.

Devotee: (Looking skyward, as if searching) Who is that God? Where is that God? I cannot see Him. (Again looking at the Mother, in a humble tone). Oh, oh, now I have found Him. Here He sits. (He prostrates at the Mother's feet. All burst into laughter.)

One householder devotee: Mother cannot bear it when the *brahmacharins* fast because she says, "Is not Mother the one who gave birth to them?" If this is the case, then she would be everyone's biological mother, wouldn't she? Yet, she doesn't show the same compassion to others as well, does she? How many people suffer!

Amma: (Smilingly) Oh, about that Mother will say that the *brahmacharins* who stay here are those who have come giving up all material pleasures with the attitude, "Mother alone is the refuge." Mother acts towards them accordingly. Whereas, the other children who lead a worldly life are not like this. They live egotistically, believing in their own power and ability, without taking refuge in God. Thus they experience sorrow caused by this. God gives the fruit (result) according to each one's attitude. Otherwise, God does not have any partiality at all. Let the others take refuge in God, relinquishing everything else; then God will also pay attention to their matters directly. The Lord lets those who have the egotistic attitude, "we are sufficient enough to look after our own matters," live in their own way. This does not mean that Mother has no love for them. Mother's love is equal towards ev-

everyone, but each one experiences it according to how they receive it in their heart.

One devotee: Here in this village many of the natives do not favor Mother or the Ashram.

Amma: They have faith in God. They will go to temples. Theirs is *kamya bhakti* (a lower type of devotion in which the devotee prays and worships the Lord in order to have his desires and wishes fulfilled). They do not know *tattwattile bhakti* (devotional practices performed while knowing and understanding the essential principles). They do not have the right understanding to know God through the essential principles. How can we blame them?

At this point Sugunanandan, the Holy Mother's father, came into the hut where she was sitting with the devotees. Seeing him, the Mother called out in a loud voice, "What, Sankara?" (Sometimes the Mother simply calls people by that name. Sankara is also a synonym for Lord Shiva.) And then she laughed like an innocent little girl. Sugunanandan grinned and patting his belly said, "Years ago Ammachi had told us, 'I have my devotees in distant places. They will come and join us here.' Now everything is slowly getting straightened out. (Rejoicing, enjoying himself) Oh my, all the things we have seen!"

Something very interesting had occurred in the meantime. As the conversation between the Mother and the householder devotees had been going on, one

little girl said, “After meeting Mother we have no fear at all. We have Mother with us.” Immediately after the girl had finished saying this, somebody pointed his finger up towards the roof of the hut. Everybody looked up and saw a snake hanging with its head downwards from the main wooden beam. It was swinging back and forth. The rest of its body was coiled around the beam. The children who were in the hut, particularly the little girl “who had no fear at all,” jumped out of the hut, crying loudly. The Holy Mother coolly remained seated on the cot, smiling and gazing at the snake. Seeing the Mother sitting there unmoved, the children felt a bit more courageous. They all came back to the hut, but feeling scared, they sat very close to the Holy Mother.

Amma: The main beam is the spine. The snake is the serpent power. (Referring to the snake) He resides here with me.

The snake slowly crawled into the thatched roof made of coconut palm leaves and disappeared.

One devotee: Among the Gods and Goddesses, Kali is the only one who didn’t marry. Eternal virgin, *yogini* (one who is established in eternal union with Shiva, the Pure Consciousness), eternally celibate! That is why Kali is very dear to me.

Amma: (Laughing) Whom should Kali marry? Who can marry Her? Shouldn’t there be two people in or-

der to marry? Where is that second person? How could Kali's marriage happen? Kali is neither man nor woman. She is both. She is Pure Consciousness as well as Primordial Nature. (In a voice filled with *Shakti*) She fills both outside and inside. Kali is the compassionate Mother of the devotee who longs to see Her as well as the fierce *Bhadra Kali*, who kills the ego of the egotistical one. Kali is everything. Kali is here and there, up and down, inside and outside, above and below... Kali!... Kali!... Kali!...

The Holy Mother stood up. The call became louder and louder. It even went beyond the highest pitch. At the top of her voice, she called out, "KALI!" The sound was seemingly endless. It reverberated and echoed all around. The atmosphere shook as if the hut was going to come down. It seemed that each and every atom repeated, responded and resounded to the call, "Kali!...Kali!...Kali!..." The atmosphere was charged with vibrant spiritual energy. The devotees stood still. They were struck with awe. There was pin-drop silence. The call slowly ceased. The Mother's body became still. All her hairs stood on end (like goose bumps). Her eyes rolled back and her breath stopped. She held a Divine *mudra* (gesture) in her right hand and her left hand was tightly gripped in a fist. There was a Divine glow on her face. A benign smile lit her countenance. All eyes were fixed on her radiant face. Five, ten, fifteen minutes. The *brahmacharins* started singing *bhajans* (devotional

songs) in praise of Kali, *Om Bhadra Kaliye...*

O Bhadra Kali, O Goddess who ever gives refuge
 Enchantress and Mother, bless me
 O Goddess who killed the demon Chamunda,
 Please lovingly protect Thy people,
 Giving them delight.

We bow to Thy Lotus Feet
 Which are adorned with gold anklets,
 O Chandika, O Beautiful One, O Great Dancer
 Bless us with Thy glance of grace.

O valiant Bhairavi,
 Who has severed the head of the demon
 Darika,
 We sing Thy praises, seeking Thy Feet,
 Hail, Ocean of Grace, we bow down to Thee.

Seconds and minutes went by. Half an hour passed.
 Brahmacharin Pai chanted some Sanskrit verses from
 the *Saundarya Lahari* glorifying and describing the di-
 vine form of the Mother:

United with Shakti, Shiva is endowed
 With the power to create the universe.
 Otherwise, He is incapable even of movement.
 Therefore, who except those endowed
 With great merits acquired in the past
 Can be fortunate enough

To salute or praise Thee, Mother Divine,
Who art the adored of even
Hari, Hara and Virinchi?

After thirty-five minutes had passed, the Holy Mother slowly brought down her uplifted right hand which held the Divine gesture. She slowly and gently moved her lips as if uttering something. The Mother tried to move from where she was standing, but her steps faltered. Fortunately, Gayatri, who was standing just by her side, gently supported her from behind and made her lie down on the cot. Thirty more minutes passed and the Mother regained her normal state of awareness. She sat down but still could not speak for some time. A few more minutes passed; it was now three o'clock. The Mother asked for something to drink. Gayatri brought *kanji* (hot rice gruel) of which the Mother took a few sips and then handed it back. The Holy Mother now seemed her usual self.

One devotee remarked, "Amma, you can switch on and off from this world whenever you want," to which she replied, "There is no switching on and off; it is always on."

Devotee: Amma, what is the meaning and significance of all the different *devatas* (demi-gods)?

Amma: Children, when viewed from *saguna* (the state of names and forms), the different realms of *devatas* (subtle beings), this, that and everything is there in existence. After having thought about how to control

nature in a way that is not harmful to human beings, the ancient *rishis* (sages) made the *sankalpa* (pure resolve) to create all these different *devatas*. There are essential principles in all of them. They have a purpose and a benefit. We should not abuse them without knowing the real matter. The *rishis* were not mere dullards.

Question: The *rishis* by their *sankalpa* created the *devatas* in order to prevent any harm from nature. Did that help to remove the harm thereafter?

Amma: It seems that son wants to put all the blame on the shoulders of the saints and sages. If you suffer, whose fault is it? Is it the *rishis* who committed the mistake? No, it is not. It is the evil actions of the people which created the disharmony in nature. The people became greedy and selfish; they wanted more and more. They were never satisfied. “More...more...more...” was their slogan. In their greediness and selfishness to achieve and possess more, they started doing all kinds of wicked and crooked actions. They totally polluted Nature. These *devatas* are nothing but Nature Herself. The people exploited Her. They did nothing to please Her. Steeped in selfishness, they became completely blind. In that darkness they forgot that it was from Her that they had received everything and that without Her blessing they would lose everything. Now it has happened that She has withdrawn Her blessings. It is now the urgent duty of all human beings to please Nature by performing selfless actions endowed with mutual love, faith

and sincerity. When this is done, then She will bless you back with endless resources. Simply blaming the *rishis* without knowing or understanding the logic behind their deeds is meaningless. Such an attitude is not good for an intelligent human being to have.

The Holy Mother continued,

Amma: Changes will go on occurring as the population increases. These changes can be both good and bad. Suppose there are ten children in a house. Nine out of these ten children will have devotion in the *Kali Yuga* (the dark age of materialism). Only one will be spoiled. But that one will be a person who “eats up” the other nine. A real demon! The children will have the same mother and father but will be of two different natures.

As the *Kali Yuga* ascends to its peak, devotion will also ascend to its peak. Ninety-nine out of a hundred people will have devotion.

Question: It is said that all the four *yugas* (ages or periods of time) will continue to come and go in a cycle.

Amma: Children, looked at from one standpoint, all four *yugas*, *Krita*, *Treta*, *Dwapara*, and *Kali*, exist in us at the same time. The *yugas* are dependent on one’s nature.

In the *Krita Yuga* (also known as *Satya Yuga*) there was only Truth, one hundred percent. This was the Golden Age. People in this age were completely selfless, living amongst each other with faith and mutual understanding, abiding by higher values. Perfect har-

mony existed between humans and nature in such a way that there was one hundred percent yield for crops sown. People would simply sow the seeds and then would have no need to return to the field until the time for the harvest. No fertilizers had to be used and no weeds interfered with the growth.

The *Treta Yuga* gave way to a twenty-five percent loss of truth; dharma declined. The once-perfect harmony between human beings and nature diminished so that some care was required for tending the crops. The yield decreased to seventy-five percent. In the *Dwapara Yuga* there was further decrease to a fifty percent loss of Truth. Tending of the crops required active cultivation with manure for fertilizer, irrigation, and removal of weeds. Even then, only a fifty percent yield was produced. Just as there was a diminishing yield in harvest, the human qualities of selflessness, faith, mutual understanding and abidance in higher values, also decreased proportionately in these two *yugas*.

Now in the *Kali Yuga* there is no Truth, no *dharma* (righteousness). Complete selfishness prevails among people. The harmonic relationship between human beings and nature has disappeared so that no matter how hard people have to work, production is always insufficient for our needs. It is said that in the *Kali Yuga*, the father will “eat” the son and the son will “eat” the father. This means that all the family bonds and ties will crumble into pieces. The relationships

like father and mother will all end up in utter meaninglessness. Oh, what an age! What things are being uttered by five year old children in this age! Such useless chatter! In the olden days even twenty-five year old people would not say such things. It is certainly the sporting play of the *Kali Yuga*. From now on the child will be speaking even as it comes forth from the mother's womb. The growth of the body will diminish as crooked-mindedness will increase in the *Kali Yuga*. How tall human beings used to be before! From now on as each year passes by, the height of human beings will become shorter and shorter.

BHAVA DARSHAN

Question: We have never heard of other *Mahatmas* having *Bhava Darshan* like you. Amma, can't you also do spiritual activities without *Bhava Darshan*?

Amma: Children, some will ask why things here are not like there, why things that are seen here are not seen there, and so on and so forth. Let us take our ancient history. Was Krishna like Rama? Was Buddha in any way like them? Was Jesus Christ like Nabi? It seems that each of their ways was different, even though they all taught the same principles. Should it be said that here Mother must act like them? *Bhava Darshan* can be considered as Mother's special way of acting. How many people have received peace and tranquility through this? That is the most important thing, isn't it? Ninety-nine percent of the people who come here are those who love *Bhava Darshan*.

BRAHMAN, THE ABSOLUTE PRIMORDIAL NATURE, AND CREATION

The Mother had been describing the Age of Kali when a devotee raised the question about *Bhava Darshan*. The discussion about the Age of Kali once again came up as the Mother finished speaking about *Bhava Darshan*.

One devotee: Mother has described the evil effects of the Age of Kali, hasn't she? I would say that all the problems and troubles arose because God has carelessly created the world; otherwise, how could things become so bad?

Mother laughed loudly and through the laughter she said,

Amma: Even before creation that Fellow (Lord Shiva) had related what was inevitable. And even after that, He gave the necessary instructions about how one should live here in this world.

Question: What do you mean, Mother?

Amma: Before creation, Shakti (the Primordial Nature, Cosmic Energy) heard an ethereal voice. It said, "There is only sorrow in creation. You should not try to do it." It was the voice of Shiva (Pure Consciousness). Shakti replied, "No, it needs to be done." Thus even before creation, Shiva gave hints to Shakti re-

garding the essential principle. It was only after that, that permission was granted to create.

After creation, He, the Pure Consciousness aspect, moved away. He went and hid in the depths. In reality, He has nothing to do with all these things happening around us. Later, Shakti went running to Him, complaining, "I have no peace. Look here, the children are scolding Me. They blame Me for everything. Nobody takes care of Me."

Shiva said, "Hadn't I told you at that very same time that it was going to be like this and that you should not pursue that (creation)? Now you create an uproar, having pursued that. Aren't you the one who is responsible for all this that has happened? There was no problem when it was I alone, was there?"

Humorously, the Holy Mother further related,

Amma: Sometimes when the longing of the children here in the Ashram declines, Mother cannot bear it. She will feel inexpressible pain. At these times Mother will tell her children, "Alas! At that very moment itself that Fellow (Shiva) had told me not to depart from Him and bother with all this. Look here, now I am suffering." (All burst into laughter.)

The Mother continued,

Amma: At that very moment He, that Man, had reminded me of all this. Now at this last moment, how can I go and complain to Him? He will ask, "Hadn't I

warned you about this earlier?” (laughing and rejoicing, enjoying herself).

Though jokingly put, these “crazy utterances” are profound and have great philosophical depth. Of course, everything is a joke for her, or a hide-and-seek game.

Like a little girl the Holy Mother sat, leaning on the back of a woman devotee. It was quite a sight to see the devotee’s joy, as if she had attained heaven. After a short pause, the Mother continued.

Amma: Children, what Mother has stated might sound like something worldly, but there are also spiritual principles in it. God instructs, prescribes, warns and reminds. He speaks through the scriptures and *Mahatmas* (*great souls*), sometimes from within, and other times through an experience. But we do not care about what God teaches. We go on creating and sustaining desires; we never destroy them. Creation and sustenance of desires will only push us again and again into sorrow. And then when sorrow comes, we rush towards God, panting and crying aloud. He is untouched by all this. He is not responsible for it.

That which is called *Brahman* is established in That Truth forever. Never will It change. That never has any involvement in all these external things. That is Truth. In fact, does anything exist when we are in deep sleep? No, there is nothing like wife or child, you or I, happi-

ness or sorrow. Only when we wake up from that state of deep sleep do feelings and ideas come, e.g., “that is my wife, this is my child, that is the backwaters, this is my house,” etc. Just as we are relieved from pain when we take a pain-killing drug, in deep sleep nothing of this world exists. This can be said to be somewhat similar to the state known as *Brahman*, i.e., nothing of this world exists for us. Deep sleep can be considered analogous to a slight glimpse of the experience of *Brahman*. In that state, there is neither bondage or pain, nor body or mind. That which exists is “That” alone. *Brahman* always remains as *Brahman*.

The difference between deep sleep and the state of *Brahman* is that in the former latent tendencies are there in the dormant state which will start functioning as soon as one wakes up; whereas, in the latter, all *vasanas* completely end. Their roots are destroyed.

What we call “real,” i.e., the world, is not something non-existent. *Mithya* only means ever-changing, not “it doesn’t exist at all.” The world is unsteady or unstable. Every moment it undergoes change. It is impermanent. An impermanent object cannot give us permanent happiness, can it? External appearance changes, but that which causes it to appear is changeless. That is *Atman*, the substratum upon which all changes occur.

Suppose we sow some grain. It grows up, yields and ripens. Human beings then eat it and, after digestion, throw out the waste as excreta, which again fertilizes the grass, which cows and other animals eat, and

the transformation process continues. Thus change goes on and on. The forms are different but there is no difference in the basic principle. It is only from the seed that the tree comes forth and it is only from the tree that the seed springs forth. This itself is That and That itself is This. There is no two, but only One.

LIFE AFTER DEATH

Question: Mother, if only the souls of the dead take birth again, then how has the population increased? And how then can the theory of life after death be true?

Amma: Son, couldn't there have been more individual souls in the previous age than in the present? Is there any scarcity of souls in God's creation?

That ten people take birth when ten people die is not what the theory of life after death says. There are billions and billions of *jivas* (souls), which include trees, creepers, insects, worms, birds, animals and so on. Any one of these can take birth as a human being. When a human being dies, he would not necessarily take birth as a human being again. He or she might take birth as a cat or a dog or as anything else. According to each one's *karma phala* (fruit of action), billions and billions of *jivas* in nature will accept any *janma* (birth) in the continuous cycle of birth, death and re-birth. All creatures of this world are evolving. Before the end of a particular lifetime each creature evolves and reaches a certain level. In some cases, downfall

will also occur. The next birth, whether it will be a higher birth or a lower birth, is determined by the evolution or degeneration of that particular soul. It all depends on the mental, physical and intellectual actions which one performs. Therefore, there is no difficulty in having an increase or decrease of population.

PURIFICATION OF DEPARTED SOULS

Question: Mother, for what purpose are the rites of purification of departed souls?

Amma: The souls can evolve and enter into higher planes, owing to the effect of the after-death rites or ceremonies. Some souls after death will come to a standstill. When a certain limit is reached where they can neither see nor hear anything, they neither enter the plane of *Paramatman* (Supreme Self) nor do they enter the world of *jivatman* (individual self). They stand in between that which vibrates and that which does not vibrate. When the purificatory rituals are performed by those thinking of the departed ones, the latter again take birth after having received purification. This is what happened in the case of Subhagan (the Mother's brother). Having remained in the Ashram atmosphere for three years after his death, Subhagan was born again as Shivan through Kasturi, (the Mother's sister). Even before it occurred, Mother had mentioned that it would happen in this way. The *jiva* which leaves the body remains in the atmosphere in the shape of a balloon. This will take another body

or be pushed into one according to the actions performed and the gravity of its unfulfilled desires.

Question: Will one take birth immediately after death?

Amma: No, it won't necessarily happen immediately. In the shape of a balloon the soul will remain as if neither on the earth nor in the skies. There is an aura around us. This works exactly like a tape recorder. All our words and deeds will be recorded by this. This air-like thing cannot remain in our body after death. Round in shape like a balloon, this travels through the atmosphere. It will select and take birth in a body befitting or suitable for its desires and attachments in its previous birth. Some *jivas* take birth on the earth only after two or three years.

It is enough if you tell such things only to those who have faith. Otherwise, there are people who would walk around saying that these are all mere stories. They do not know anything about it.

This aura which surrounds each human being will become darker and darker as we become more selfish, wicked and ego-centric. This will pull us back down onto this earth, making us suffer again and again. However, if we cultivate and develop good actions and good thoughts, the same aura will become golden in color, which will help us evolve to the higher planes of consciousness.

Question: What leaves one body and enters into another when one takes another life during rebirth?

Amma: Children, there is only one *Atman* (Divine

Self), not many. That *Atman* is all-pervading. It neither dies nor does it take birth. Therefore, the *Atman* can neither leave one body nor can it enter into another one. The *Atman* fills everywhere. Where can it come from and to where can it go?

It is the mind which goes from one body to another. What we call *jiva* is only the mind. This *jiva* will have a form like an illusory appearance. This will be just like waves. Attached to this will be the subtle body with all the inherited tendencies from the previous birth. Usually around a tree or such other thing, an aura can be seen surrounding it. While one is meditating, this aura can be seen around the face just like a layer of air, but not touching the skin. This aura will leave the body and go along with the *jiva* when we die.

Doesn't air exist in both the form of a breeze and a whirlwind? There is special power in a whirlwind, isn't there? Both are one, yet we can tell a difference between them. Even though the *jiva* is of the *Atman*, it does not merge with the *Atman*. The mind will remain separate due to its impurity. There is also a view that a pure mind without *vasanas* (vicious tendencies) is *Atman* itself. Then it is not the mind, but *Atman*, the Self.

Question: Mother, is this world real or apparent?

Amma: Children, it is apparent, and at the same time, not apparent. Shouldn't it be eternal if it is Truth or real? Do the dog and the cat exist for us in deep sleep? No, that is why it is said that the mind creates everything. The world of objects manifests only when the mind functions. At other times, no world, no objects.

That is why it is said that the world is apparent, not real. Through *sadhana* when the mind is eliminated, the world of plurality also disappears. In that state there is nothing but Brahman; even the world is Brahman. In the state of Realization everything is filled with Supreme Consciousness. Therefore, One who has attained this state beholds only Reality everywhere.

Until then, the apparent world is still present. When Eternity is experienced, the changing world stops deluding you. It is a state where you become constantly established in the changeless *Atman*. Children, do not think that the world will disappear completely when you become Realized. If that were the case, it would have disappeared when the first person attained Realization.

Question: Who takes it as is and not apparent?

Amma: Those who are deluded by it will take it as “real.” Those not deluded by it won’t have such feelings at all. They will always remain in themselves alone. They will perceive the Self through the Self.

Question: Amma, it is easy for you to say such things; you are beyond all these dualities. But what about the ordinary human beings who are attached and caught up in the worldly pleasures and objects?

Amma: Son, who told you that it is the worldly objects which have caught you up? It is the other way around. It is you who have caught them up. These objects themselves have no power to attract you or to catch you. You have tightly embraced them and you

do not want to let them go. Then you cry aloud beating your chest saying, “Oh, what can I do, these bondages, these relationships, my wife. My car has been stolen, my house is falling down,” and so on and so forth. None of the objects called you to them waving their hands. It is you who developed the attraction towards them.

There is a proverb in Malayalam, “You want to get something sitting on a higher elevation, but you do not want to let go of the thing kept in your armpit.” This thing kept in your armpit represents the objects of the world. You are tightly embracing them. If you want to obtain something on a higher level, i.e., eternal happiness, the only thing that you have to do is to loosen your arm a little, and it (the objects of the world) will fall away. But you want both; you want to keep the pleasures of the world and also have spiritual bliss. No, that is impossible. Therefore, slowly let the worldly pleasures fall off your bosom. Lift your hands and arms fully and the thing under your arm will fall down and you will have the object above.

Question: Amma, my question is, who is affected by *maya* when everything is *Brahman*?

Amma: Son, *maya* has not affected anyone; it is you who have embraced it. The illusory world has no power to delude you. It is you who have gone after it due to your accumulated tendencies. You look at things through the glasses of your *vasanas*. You weigh things and stamp them as good and bad according to your likes and dislikes.

Everything is *Brahman*, that is right. But have you realized That? It is like a blind person saying that there is light everywhere. Why do you talk unnecessarily about something which you have no idea about at all? You constantly experience the world and its objects, but you talk about something which you have never experienced.

For a person who has gone beyond *maya*, everything is *Brahman* since he constantly experiences It. But for a person who lives in *maya* it is not so. He has everything around him. Thus, he must put forth a deliberate attempt to come out of it. He should try to convince himself that the world and the pleasure-giving objects are flickering and dream-like.

Suppose you have a dream in which you see that you have accumulated a lot of wealth and have become a multi-millionaire. Then, in due course, name and fame follow and you are elected Prime Minister or President of the country. While you are dreaming, the dream is real, but when you wake up, it no longer has reality. Exactly in the same way, this (empirical world) is all a dream created by the thoughts and the mind, a long dream. *Atman* or the Self has nothing to do with it. It simply illumines everything, just as the sun illumines the whole world. The sun cannot but shine. In the same way, the nature of the Self is light; it cannot but illumine.

Just as you come to realize that the dream is unreal when you wake up, you will realize that the world is unreal when you wake up to God-consciousness.

Question: *Sadhana* need not be performed to wake up from a dream. We will wake up automatically. Similarly, *sadhana* is not needed to remove *maya*, is it?

Amma: Son, who told you that one wakes up from a dream without doing anything? In the dream state we dream that we are doing many things. We wake up as a continuation of the actions that we perform in the dream state. One cannot say that actions performed in the dream did not cause us to wake up. In the same way, dwelling in this diverse world in the midst of changing objects is a long dream. Although this world is a dream, we are so identified with it that we do not feel it as a dream. We believe that it is true. Therefore, *sadhana* is needed to wake up to God from this waking-state dream.

Although we are of the nature of the ever-free, eternal *Atman*, at present our understanding is that we are bound and limited. To remove this feeling of bondage and limitation, *sadhana* is necessary.

Little children will take excreta in their own hands. They will try to catch hold of fire or walk into a pond or river. Will grown-up people do this? No. Therefore, discrimination is needed for each one to grow according to their own inherited tendencies. One should move forward adhering to the instructions given by wise people. There is no use in disputing and arguing unnecessarily. Doubting is an aspect of the mind. You should use your discriminative powers to stop this doubting nature of the mind. Only when doubts come to an end will the light of God enter into one's heart.

Doubts will not end fully until the attainment of Self-Realization. One will not have the power to go beyond doubts until then. There will not be any doubts once you know what should be known.

THE NATURE OF THE MIND

Question: Mother, even if these are the facts, almost all people feel that life in the world is happy, don't they?

Amma: That is no wonder. That feeling is there in all creatures. Even a pig which lives in dirty mud thinks that life is very happy and that its abode, the muddy waters, is the best dwelling place on earth and that its ugly body is the most beautiful one of all.

There were once two astrologers who were very close friends. One day they wanted to know about their next births, what they would become. They made certain astrological calculations and found that one of them would take birth as an elephant and the other as an earthworm. The second man, who was going to become an earthworm, felt very sad and depressed. Seeing his friend's desperate mood, the first astrologer, who was to become an elephant, tried to console him. But it was of no avail. Finally, the would-be earthworm astrologer requested of the would-be elephant astrologer, "My dear friend, you alone can save me from this ill-fate. In your next birth search for me and once you find me be kind enough to trample me under your foot. For if you kill me, I might get a better body by

getting rid of the dirty body of an earthworm.” The would-be elephant astrologer said that he was only too happy to render this great service to his friend.

Years went by. Both the astrologers died, one after the other. As foretold, the first astrologer reincarnated into the body of an elephant and the other one, the body of an earthworm. But both of them forgot about their previous births. Luckily, one day the astrologer who took birth as an elephant remembered his previous birth and the promise that he had given to his friend. Immediately he went in search of his friend who had reincarnated into the body of an earthworm. In between lumps of clay, in ploughed fields, in loosened soil, under the trees, in muddy places and between dried cracks in the ground, he searched and searched. This went on for several days. At last when he lifted up a big rock, lo and behold, there lay his dear earthworm friend. The elephant astrologer was very happy to find his friend, who was now living with his wife and children under the rock. As the elephant raised his front foot to fulfill his promise to trample the earthworm, there arose a hue and cry. The earthworm shouted at the elephant, “Hey, demon, what are you trying to do? Are you going to kill me and my beautiful wife and children? Are you going to destroy my fancy house? Stop it! How cruel you are!”

Children, that is what every creature on this earth feels. Everything depends on one’s understanding.

What we do not like can be equal to ambrosia for someone else. What we like may be equal to poison for another person. There is no object in this world which can give happiness to everyone. In other words, there is no object in this world which has happiness as its nature. One person is very fond of watching T.V., but another person will get a terrible headache if he happens to look at the T.V. screen. There are people who enjoy smoking more than anything, but there are others who will cough if they merely see someone smoking. In this way, likes and dislikes differ from person to person.

People are drowning in pleasurable objects. Just as a pig which lives in the dirty mud thinks that it is the happiest place, human beings also think that living in the midst of worldly pleasures is heavenly. All pleasures of the world, whatever they are, end up in sorrow. Real bliss will be had only when we discriminate between the eternal and the non-eternal.

It was time for the discourse to begin. The Mother got up from her seat; otherwise, nobody would go to listen to the speech. The Holy Mother went to the hut and the devotees sat in the tent and listened to the discourse.

There were two pigeons which always sat on top of the meditation hall, on the roof of the Mother's hut or somewhere closeby whenever the Mother sang *bhajans* or conversed with the devotees sitting outside. This time too they were seen on top of the meditation hall. These pigeons would not move from the place until the singing or the conversation was over. They

would sit there unmoving as if listening to her. Sometimes these pigeons would come very close to the Mother if she was alone. Many times devotees and residents would see them sitting right in front of the Holy Mother when she sat in solitude. The Mother once hinted that they were two devoted souls.

The discourse went on until six o'clock. At six-thirty the evening *bhajan* started. The Mother, the *brahmacharins*, and a few householder devotees who could sing, sat inside the Vedanta Vidyalaya (a small hall like a classroom meant for teaching Vedanta to the *brahmacharins*), while the others sat in the tent specially made for these events. The Mother sang *Vedanta Venalilude...*

Now where is the truth of the Gita
That proclaims that Thou wilt help
A traveler to Brahman all alone?

Even though I am swimming
Through the forest-like way
For a peaceful soul, for the attainment of Thee,
My mind is filled with sorrow.
O Friend of the miserable,
My heart forever burns for something,
I know not what.
Hast Thou not the intent
To remove all my sorrows?

O Mother, O Bhagavati Devi,
Don't you know that without my merging

Into Thy mind-enchancing Being
There is no peace?

The devotees became totally absorbed in the singing and their hearts overflowed with joy. Some persons shed tears while others sat with eyes closed and palms joined trying to imbibe the bliss and become more absorbed in the *kirtan*. The Holy Mother always sang with eyes closed to set an example for the *brahmacharins* and other devotees. The Mother always reminds us,

“While singing the Divine Name, you should always keep the eyes closed; otherwise, the eyes, persuaded by the mind and tempted by the objects, will run after them. Children, behold the inner Light; it cannot be seen if you look at the external light.”

28 February 1984

The seven-day discourse ended yesterday. It had been a busy week. The Mother hardly had any rest. All of the three *Devi Bhavas* during the seven-day discourse were so very crowded that the Holy Mother had to sit for *darshan* from six-thirty in the evening until five or six the next morning. Besides that, she received the devotees in the daytime as well. Even though the Mother does not care about taking a rest, sometimes her body suffers due to the lack of it. Of course, her mind is always unaffected. This is quite

obvious from her ever-cheerful mood even when her body is tired.

Quite often she says, “Mother is happy when her children are happy. Mother’s health and wealth are her children.” If there are devotees to see her, she will not remain in her room in the name of rest or privacy unless there is a good reason. If somebody asks her to take some rest when her body is too tired, the Mother would reply,

“The purpose of this body and of Mother’s whole life is to serve her children. Mother’s only wish is that her hands should always be on someone’s shoulders, consoling and caressing them and wiping their tears, even while breathing her last.”

Every glance the Mother gives exudes compassion. Every movement she makes is an unforgettable visual delight. Every word she utters showers and embraces one with the bliss of immortality. Her deeds are a living witness to all the religious dictums of the world.

Not all who came to attend and participate in the discourse had gone. Some people planned to go after today’s *Devi Bhava darshan*.

The Mother came to the hut by nine o’clock, but it seemed that she was not well. Even though she took her usual seat on the cot, the Mother did not speak very much. Some people left, having offered their salutations to her. Others simply sat there silently as the Mother did not speak. Gayatri said, “Mother is not well. She didn’t sleep last night. The whole night

she was rolling on the floor. There is a terrible pain in her throat and she feels some giddiness too. If you devotees pray, she might take some rest.” There were pimples all over her body. A woman devotee suggested, “Why don’t we all go out. Let Mother take a rest today. Only if her body is well enough and healthy can she continue to bless us for a longer period of time.”

There is no need to say that the others all agreed to this suggestion. Everybody got up to leave the hut, but suddenly the Holy Mother exclaimed,

Amma: No, no, don’t go, children. Mother knows that you will feel very sad if you cannot see her after coming here. Do not think about Mother’s sickness. It has been taken from different people. Mother suffers for thirty or forty minutes, or maybe a day, what they have had to suffer for thirty or forty years. Mother is only happy to do this. Who will do it for her children except Mother? Nonetheless, whatever is accepted willingly can only be exhausted by experiencing it. Mother does not care about herself. Each and every drop of Mother’s blood, each and every particle of her energy is for her children. But she wants to see you growing, my children; she wants to see you growing spiritually. Children, you will only become weak-minded if you think, “Mother is tired”, or “Mother is sick...”, or things like that.

Her words were touching. Hearing them, some

devotees silently shed tears. One devotee couldn't contain his grief and said,

Devotee: Mother, why should you suffer like this for us? Why can't you give some of your physical suffering to us? Since we are your children, isn't it our duty to repay you, if we could, for the great sacrifice that you are making for us?

Full of love in her eyes, the Holy Mother heartfully laughed at the innocence of the devotee and replied,

Amma: No, son, neither can you repay nor can you endure even an infinitesimal fraction of the suffering that this body undergoes. Son, this innocence is good.

In a few minutes the atmosphere completely changed. The Holy Mother began receiving people one by one. Her mood was as cheerful as ever. There was singing which the devotees participated in, forgetting everything. After each song there was a meditative silence. Now and then the Mother also sang a song. At one point, the Mother sang a song which depicted Kali's fierce form, *Kurirul Pole...*

Who is this One with such awesome form,
Dark as the darkest night,
Swaying like a host of blue flowers

On the waters of a lake of blood?

Who is this One, dancing on the battleground,
Splattered with blood of all sides,
Masking Her Gorgeous Form
Even as She is clad only in all-pervasive ether?

Who is this One with three eyes,
Blazing as incandescent fire,
The One with disheveled hair
Appearing like a streak of dark rain clouds?

Why does the earth tremble
Bearing the brunt of Her mighty gait?
Oh! This frolic-some damsel is none
But the Beloved of Shiva who carries the tri-
dent.

If a devotee happened to have his or her head resting on the Mother's lap while having *darshan* as the Mother sang, that devotee received a longer *darshan*, truly enjoying the experience of bliss, since the Mother went into *samadhi* (equipoised state of Oneness with God) several times during the singing and was totally oblivious to the external surroundings.

Mother left the hut by twelve o'clock. At three o'clock she again came and sat in the coconut grove. Naturally, the devotees were also attracted to that spot. Now she was completely well. The pimples had disappeared, and she was quite normal. For a short while the Mother sat still and silent, fixing her eyes somewhere, indiscernible as to whether she gazed at

the sky or beyond to infinitude. She seemed to be all alone in her own world. Then turning her attention from wherever it was, she called the name of a young man sitting far behind the others and said, "Son, your mother wants to see you. Go home immediately." The Mother then turned to another devotee who was sitting near her and inquired, "Son, are you leaving now?" He replied, "Yes, Mother." "If so, then take this son with you to his house along the way," said the Mother.

By that time, the young man who was asked to return home came up to the Mother. Looking at him and pointing to the other person, the Holy Mother said, "This son here has a car. He will give you a ride. Don't worry. Everything will be all right." Both of them bowed down at the Mother's feet. She gave sacred ash to the young man that she was sending home but not to the other devotee. The young man seemed to be a little worried, seeing the mysterious way in which the Mother acted towards him. The Mother again smiled at him and said, "You look worried, son. Why be afraid? Mother is here for you, isn't she?" Both devotees then left.

Without speaking another word, the Mother sat in meditation for about ten or fifteen minutes. She opened her eyes and smiled at the devotees and said to them, "That son's mother is a heart patient. She suddenly had an attack. His father is out at work and he was here. There is nobody at home, but there is no problem now; she is all right." She stopped there as if

she did not want to disclose the rest.

A woman devotee who could not control her excitement asked in a loud voice, “But Mother, how is it possible that you know all that about them? The young man’s house is fifty kilometers away from here. Nobody came from there to inform you.” The Mother giggled and said, “Mother had to go there, because she prayed so innocently. It is her...” The Holy Mother stopped abruptly and said, “Now, let us stop discussing it. All those things just happen. Let us talk about something else.”

There was a short pause, after which, a *sadhak* (spiritual aspirant) asked,

Sadhak: Mother, is a vow of silence necessary for a *sadhu* (monk)?”

Amma: Silence is good. *Mauna* (vow of silence) will come spontaneously when we become introspective. Silence will help to prevent unnecessary dissipation of energy. We lose a lot of energy through talking. Most of the time our topic is something unimportant and silly. We discuss things about a film star or a movie, a football or baseball player, or maybe we recall an ornament or piece of jewelry that we lost two years ago, or perhaps we gossip about the neighbor or the woman we saw on the road last week. Does it make any sense to talk of such trivial things? By finding fault with others and criticizing them, we lose a lot of energy. Do we benefit at all from this?

If you want to feel the difference, keep silence for

a few days, say five days, and talk on the sixth day. When you begin speaking again, you will clearly feel that you have lost something which you had acquired.

Question: Mother, you say that observing silence will help to conserve energy. But what about the thoughts that arise in the mind?

Amma: There will arise bigger and smaller ripples in a dam in which water remains blocked and conserved. But the water will not flow out; it will remain in the dam. Similarly, thoughts will arise in one's mind even while one is observing silence, but since they do not get expressed through speech and action, a major portion of the energy will be conserved. This means that there will be relatively less dissipation of energy. Therefore, observing a vow of silence is good for those who really want to attain the goal.

Question: Mother, could you please give some instructions about how one should begin that observance?

Amma: Start with an hour, then two, three...and slowly try to do it for half a day, then for a whole day. Thus you can slowly and steadily increase the time for as many days as you wish. It all depends on your determination and *lakshya bodha* (intent on the goal). If you are really determined, you can even take a vow of forty-one days silence. However, do not start with

forty-one days in the very beginning. One whole day or even a few hours will do at first. Slowly you can increase it to forty-one or more days if you wish. Our habit is to talk; therefore, the mind will compel and tempt us to speak unnecessarily. In fact, real *mauna* means to speak moderately with very good control over your mind. But as our natural tendency is to speak unnecessarily without any control, we need to keep complete silence so as to train the mind properly.

One will feel discouraged if one tries to start with forty-one days in the beginning. One should proceed by getting the taste and by enjoying it little by little. The mind should become conducive or favorable by itself. Do not force it. Even then, it may become necessary to force two or three days in the beginning. Thereafter, one should take silence according to the taste that one gets from it. Having observed silence for a day, when we are about to speak on the next day, the mind will say, "Silence, silence." *Abhyasa* (constant practice) will guide you. Also, for the length of time that we maintain silence we will be able to chant our mantra.

Let everything happen as destined by God. But we must do *sadhana* (spiritual practice). It is useless and meaningless to blame destiny for anything and everything that happens in our life. In a certain way, that is nothing but foolishness. Act properly and sincerely, and then if something goes wrong, consider it as fate. It is the fruit of your own actions; so be at peace. But

still you must work in the present to make your future happy and blissful.

Children, speak less, and only when it is absolutely necessary. When you do say a word, say it very carefully because a seeker or a devotee should not utter meaningless things, even if only a single word.

Question: Mother, what is the right attitude to have?

Amma: If somebody gets angry, you should carefully try to prevent your mind from getting disturbed or unsteady. Some people will say, “I have not done anything wrong, and yet he scolded me. Therefore, I got angry.” You should consider it as, “Those scoldings might have been meant for me, even if I did not do anything wrong.” Then you should pray, “O Lord, whatever mistakes I may make, please remove them right at that very moment. O Lord, please point out my errors. O Lord, entrust me with Your work; please do not let me sit idle. O Lord, let it be Your work so that I can do it, whatever it may be, remembering You. O Lord, please let others point out my faults to bestow on me the right understanding, and let me not hate them or get angry with them, no matter whether they point out my faults in a harmful or a gentle way.” This should be the prayer of a devotee or a true seeker.

We are trying to learn how to see God, or the Pure Essence, in everything and everybody and not the demon in them, even in the wicked. If you see the demon in others, the very same negative forces will swallow you up and you yourself will become a demon in

the end. Children, that is not our way. Hate evil, not the evil-doer. If somebody is egotistic or selfish, hate egotism or selfishness, not the person. We can do this if we really try. If the son is a drunkard or a drug-addict, the parents will hate his drinking habit or his addiction to drugs but they will still love their son. In fact, such children are often especially loved by the parents. In the same way, try to love others, even if they are bad. The right attitude is, right understanding of a particular situation in life, using proper discrimination, and then wisely putting it into application.

AIR-CONDITION THE MIND

The Holy Mother continued,

Amma: Do not walk around complaining that certain people got angry with you and that they criticized and scolded you. Let them give a lecture criticizing and teasing you. You just keep quiet. All the things that they have said about you will revert back to them. When you react or retaliate, that means you have accepted it, and then they will fabricate even more things about you and you will also do the same about them. There is no way to settle that kind of argument, and the end-result is utter humiliation, anger, hatred, revenge, and the like. Son, why do you engage in such self-destructive processes? Observe silence, keep quiet. Do not accept what others say about you. Or, if you want to accept it, receive it as God's gift. If you are

very adamant and determined to accept it only as a demonic challenge, no one can save you from the final disaster, not even God.

Suppose somebody gives you a television as a present. What will happen if you do not accept it? No doubt he will take it back and keep it in his own home. In a similar manner, if you do not accept a word said or an act done against you by someone else, he will have to take it back. That is all there is to it.

Spiritual life is meant for renunciates. They will experience and enjoy bliss even if they lie in the trash. The mind should be air-conditioned, not the external world. If a person who has no peace of mind tries to sleep in a house with air-conditioning, will sleep come to him? No, it won't. How many incidents are there where people committed suicide even while living in air-conditioned houses. Having made enough money, people lie down on majestic beds in palatial buildings, but only if they have peace of mind will they get any sleep. Therefore, children, it is quite clear that it is not the external objects which give one comfort and happiness. If that were so, people with immense wealth should be able to lead peaceful lives. But this is not seen to be true, and they are often the most worried ones. If they want to sleep, they will need to take sleeping pills or an injection. Even to enjoy worldly pleasures properly, one must have a tranquil mind. Therefore, children, the mind should be air-conditioned. A person with an air-conditioned mind will

have only bliss at all times and places. That is what we have to strive for. Therefore, it is not wealth or any other thing that gives bliss. The real giver of bliss is the mind.

TO ELIMINATE MENTAL AGONY

Question: What should be done to eliminate mental agony?

Amma: Children, if one's mind is obsessed with difficulties, one should tell God. However, people do not do this. Instead, one person will complain to another; this person will discuss his problems with that one. A wife will tell her husband, and the husband will confide in his wife. Children will rely on their friends or parents, and elderly parents will talk with their children. Therefore, God will think, "All right, they remove their difficulties by telling each other, don't they? No one takes refuge in Me. Then why should I care about them? They themselves are enough for each other." But the fact is, our burden doubles when it happens in this way, when we simply tell others and do not rely on God.

We should pray to God in this manner, "O Lord, please bestow upon me the power to proceed intelligently and with proper discrimination in every circumstance. Let me not forget You in any situation. O Lord, both in happiness and in sorrow, grant me the boon to remember You without fail." We should always have a positive attitude towards life. Optimism is

a great factor for eliminating agony from life.

Take, for example, the life of Pumtanam (a great devotee of Lord Krishna who lived in Kerala about four hundred years ago). His devotion to Lord Sri Krishna was very deep. He was righteous, *sattvic* (full of goodness), simple and humble. Yet he had to face many difficulties. His only child died. His wife thought that he was crazy and became antagonistic toward him. Once he was attacked by a band of robbers as he was going to Guruvayur, (a famous temple dedicated to Lord Krishna). He had to undergo many difficulties, but still his devotion was unshakable. All the difficulties were the Lord's tests. Do you know the verse he sang when his only child died? "Do I need another child when *Unnikrishna* (Baby Krishna) sports in my heart?" His life was quite a tragedy from a worldly point of view, but he was always blissful. Do you know how and why? The answer is the previously mentioned verse which he himself sang. Once you enshrine the Lord within, there is only bliss, not just within but without as well. Real bliss will come to you, not the mere reflection (i.e., the so-called happiness we derive from external objects is merely a "reflection"). But to attain that bliss, you have to give up the so-called "happiness."

This is the case even in a worldly sense. In order to get more pleasure, you spend a lot of money on a T.V. Once you buy it, you automatically give up your radio. Why? Because now you get more comfort, more hap-

piness from the T.V. and less from the radio, so the radio is relinquished. In the same way, the happiness of spiritual bliss is the highest and most everlasting. Therefore, it is very expensive, and in order to attain that, you need to give up the lower and less pleasure-giving things.

Sorrow and happiness are relative. When there is more happiness and less unhappiness we call it a happy moment, and when there is more unhappiness and less happiness, a sad moment. Still, you are not completely happy because sorrow will come again. All your efforts to eliminate sorrow will end in futility. It is unavoidable and inevitable. Therefore, be aware that this is the nature of life, and accept it. Try to go beyond it. Welcome both happiness and sorrow equally.

Question: How can we go beyond it when we are bound by all these relationships and objects of the world?

Amma: What a pity! These inert, silly, trivial things have bound you. But in fact, son, it is not the things which have bound you. On the contrary, it is your mind which has entered into that bondage. The objects have no power to bind you. Human beings, who are supposed to control the objects, are now being controlled by them. This is the cause of all our problems.

Again, let us take the same Pumtanam's life as an example. Children, you know how his only child died, don't you? It happened when they were celebrating the child's third birthday. It was late at night and ev-

everybody was in a hurry to go to bed. The house was filled with guests and relatives. All of a sudden, a strong wind blew and put out all the kerosene lamps. When the wind subsided, they lighted the lamps again. It was at that time that they realized that the child was missing. They searched everywhere but could not find the child. At last, one person had an intuition and proceeded to remove the mats heaped in a corner. There lay the child, dead. Somebody had inadvertently thrown all the mats over to where the child had been sleeping unnoticed. Think of the tragedy!

This devotee, Puntanam, was very sad. He expressed it, but he could overcome it easily. Why? That is what spirituality teaches, to overcome any grievous situation. Of course, it was a great tragedy, maybe the greatest for this family. You may think, "But it was a child...the poor little thing." Yet this devotee clearly realized that it was nothing at all but a play, a play of his Beloved Krishna. Krishna here represents the Highest Truth. Anyhow, the body will die, today or tomorrow; it is unavoidable, inevitable. Will this change if we go on lamenting? No, it won't. Just as it is the nature of the river to flow, the sun to shine and the wind to blow, so birth and death, happiness and sorrow, success and failure are all part of the nature of life. But the True Self, Krishna or Rama or Jesus, never dies. That is what enlivens the body. "When that Universal Self is playing or sporting within me in the form of Krishna, why should I grieve?" The Self never dies nor takes birth. This is what the devotee

Pumtanam meant when he sang the verse.

The ocean is the Supreme Self, *Satchidananda*. The waves are the *jivas*, the individual souls. The ocean never changes; it remains as the substratum of all the waves that arise in it. What is a wave, after all? It is only water. One wave comes and disappears. Another one comes and that also disappears. Yet another one rises up in another place and in another shape. But what are all these? They are nothing but the waters of the ocean in different shapes and forms. The waves appear and disappear, re-appear and disappear again, but the water remains the same; it never changes. So waves are nothing but the same water in a different shape and in a different place. In the same way, the Supreme Self manifests as *jivas* in different forms and different shapes. The forms and shapes appear and disappear, but the essential principle, the substratum, that is, the Divine Self, remains forever unchanged, just like the ocean.

Question: Amma, that has made it very clear. So, what Amma says is that complete surrender to the Supreme Will is the only way to eradicate all the difficulties of life?

Amma: That is right, son. At least we should try to develop the awareness that everything that happens around us is His Will. As this awareness becomes stronger and stronger, our attitude also will change.

The Lord will take note if we have any selfishness, attachments or aversions. He will not come close if there is even a little bit of selfishness. The Lord will go

far away.

We should always pray to the Lord, “O Lord, I am an ignorant one. Though I am Your child, the *vasanas* (latent tendencies) keep me away from You. O Lord, be kind enough to remove these *vasanas*. Though on the level of the Supreme my real nature is of Thy Self, in this empirical world I remain as the child of my parents. O Lord, may my ignorance be removed. It is said that I am Thy child, but I do not know that. Free Your child from this prison.” Thus, one has to supplicate with longing and cry to the Lord.

To live in peace, one must get rid of all mental conflicts and see only the good in people. We become mentally weak when we look at the faults. We raise our level when we see the goodness. Whoever it may be, when we say that that person is bad, we have already become bad ourselves. Let ninety-nine percent of another person be wrong, yet we should see the one single percent of good in him. Then our own level will be raised. We will lower ourselves if we see the wrong in him. We should always pray, “O Lord, make my eyes see only the good in everyone. Give me the strength to serve the world selflessly.” We can have peace of mind only through such an attitude of self-surrender. Thus slowly you should try to become a good servant of God.

What this world needs are servants, not leaders. Everyone’s wish is to become a leader. We have enough leaders who are not real leaders. Let us become a real servant instead. That is the only way to become a real leader.

THE SIGNS OF A RENUNCIATE AND A DEVOTEE

Question: How should one maintain the constant remembrance of God?

Amma: Children, Mother knows that it is difficult for you who live in the midst of material pleasures and with family ties, to remember God constantly. But when you become aware that you are not remembering Him, immediately repent, “O Lord, I have forgotten you for this much time. I have forgotten to chant Your Divine Name for this length of time. O Lord, please forgive me. Please bestow upon me the mental strength to cherish Your Form within and Your Name on my lips constantly and incessantly. O Lord, please do not let me waste time like this. Let the desire to behold Thy Form burn within me.” Having repented and prayed thus, immediately start repeating the *mantra*. Again you might forget it. Don’t worry, go on applying the same technique of repentance and prayer whenever you realize that you have not been chanting the *mantra* for a long time. Slowly in due course, you will develop the power to remember Him incessantly.

A true seeker or a devotee who has dedicated his whole life to the realization of the Self, should constantly try to fix his mind on the Self or on some aspect of God. Just as a young man and a young woman who have fallen in love will think constantly of each other, just as a chaste wife will always think of her dear husband and just as a man who is of the same

character will think of his wife, we should think of God. The young man's mind will always be on his beloved. "Is she at the college now? Which sari is she wearing today? Now she might be sitting in the classroom. Though her body is there, her heart will be with me. Will we marry and lead a happy family life?" With such thoughts in his mind, he will constantly be thinking of her. Wherever he may be, he will have a special enthusiasm and joy of his own. He will always find a special beauty and happiness in letting his mind revel and wander in thinking about her. He will dive deeper and deeper into the world of thoughts about her.

In some other case, the husband may be away from the wife in a very distant place. As for the wife, her husband is as dear to her as her own life. Whatever activity she might be engaged in, she will be thinking of him. A *sadhak* should be like this. His mind should always abide in God's world. He merely performs actions, that's all, but his mind is fixed on God. If one proceeds in this way, he will reach There at the end. In the innermost recesses of one's heart there always exists a constant longing to realize God. He cries only to attain Him and merge with Him. Nothing lower than complete absorption in the Lord will satisfy him. Reveling in the world of inner beauty, that is, the Lord's immeasurable beauty, he will always remain inwardly drawn. None of the worldly objects will have any appeal to him. Such things will fail to entice or excite him. Such a devotee can be heard crying, "O

Lord, when are You going to come to me? Will you grant Thy vision to me and make me one with You or would You abandon me!" Or if it is a person who follows the path of knowledge, his prayers would be, "O Self that shines in and through every object in the world, O Omniscient, Omnipotent and all-pervading One, when are You going to reveal Your glory and splendor to me? When am I going to realize and become one with my own Self, casting away all the limitations of the body, mind and intellect?" This is how real *sadhaks* pray. Children, these are the signs of a renunciate and a devotee.

NOT MERE DEVOTION BUT REAL LOVE SHOULD BE THERE

It was a Tuesday, *Bhava Darshan* day. At five o'clock in the afternoon the Mother got up and went to her room. She came back and sat for the *bhajan* at 5:30 p.m. As usual, the Mother soared to the heights of supreme devotion and deep into her own Self as she sang *Bhramaramane Manasa...*

O hummingbird of my mind
Searching for pure nectar
You wander and become exhausted.

The grove of blossomed trees,
Bereft of sorrow, resides blissfully
On the banks of the river of devotion.
O Mind, do not be desperate,
For your Mother will come

To the pure heart one day.

O Shakti,
Thou art the spring of intelligence for the wise,
Removing all sorrows through knowledge;
I offer all my sorrows to Thee
In whom everything exists.

When is that day, O Mother,
When Thou wilt come?
Art Thou going to come
When all of my energy is dissipated?
O Mother, do not do that!
Won't Thou shower Thy grace upon me?
Who else is there except Thee
As my sole support?

29 February 1984

Last night the *Devi Bhava Darshan* went until three-thirty in the morning. As it was her daily practice, the Mother went around to make sure that all the devotees had a mat and a place to sleep. It was nearly five o'clock when she went to bed.

At ten o'clock in the morning, the young man who had been told by the Holy Mother to return to his home immediately the day before, showed up at the Ashram with his middle-aged mother. There were a few other devotees present. The young man's mother was almost in tears even as she entered the Ashram premises. Seeing them standing in front of the temple,

Brahmacharin Balu approached them and asked the young man, "What happened yesterday? Mother did not disclose it, but we all guessed that something mysterious had occurred. Could you tell me what it was, if you don't mind?"

The young man smiled, but at the same time he could not control his emotions. Pulling out a handkerchief from his pocket, he wiped the tears which filled his eyes, and then in a very soft and gentle voice, he remarked, "That was quite an experience. To put it in one sentence, Mother saved my mother's life and gave her a second birth, or maybe you can also say that the Mother extended my mother's life span."

The young man once again wiped away his tears. His mother was also crying. Through her tears, she said, "My child, the fact that I am still alive is quite unbelievable to me. Yesterday I was literally dead. (Referring to her son) He was here and my husband was at work. I am a heart patient. I was supposed to take a pill prescribed by the doctor every morning. I knew that there was only one more pill left. I thought that I could ask my husband to buy more when he came home from work. But unfortunately, I forgot to take my medicine yesterday. Every time I remembered it I had some work to do. And then after lunch, due to tiredness, I slept for about an hour and a half. It was three when I got up; therefore, I went to the kitchen to cook some light refreshment for my husband before he came home from work. It was quarter-past three. As I blew into the oven in order to light the

fire, I had an excruciating pain in my heart. It was so severe that it passed like lightning through my whole body and I felt that my heart was going to burst out. I knew that I was going to die. Suddenly, I thought about my son, who was here at the Ashram at the time. I prayed to the Holy Mother, ‘O Mother, if I survive for a few more hours, I might be able to see my son before breathing my last breath. Mother, will you please send him to me?’ In a few seconds I fell unconscious. I don’t know how much time had passed, but I slowly opened my eyes and looked around. ‘I am still alive,’ I thought. Suddenly, I smelled the fragrance which Mother always has around her. It was then that I beheld an unbelievable sight. The Holy Mother herself was sitting right beside me, gazing at me. She sweetly smiled at me, and rubbing my chest, she said, ‘Don’t worry, you are all right, daughter.’ Then I saw another amazing sight. I saw the Mother holding an empty glass in her right hand and in her left hand, the pill bottle, which was always kept in a closet in our bedroom. I couldn’t believe my eyes. Seeing my astounded state, the Mother soothed my forehead and said, ‘Yes, daughter, you took the medicine. Be at peace. Your son will be home in an hour.’ Saying thus, she placed the glass and the bottle down on the floor beside me and disappeared, after smiling at me once again. Yes, it was true, I could feel the taste of the medicine in my mouth. I was still lying down. I jumped up, ran out of the house and up to the front entrance gate. There was no trace of her. Like a mad-

woman I ran to the backyard, and not finding her there, I again went into the house and searched through all the rooms calling out, ‘Amma, Amma!’

“Slowly coming back to my normal consciousness, I went into the kitchen once again to make sure that the glass and the drug bottle were still there, for maybe it was all a hallucination. To my astonishment, I saw a lotus petal also lying there. I rubbed my eyes and pulled my eyelids wide apart in order to make sure that what I saw was true. While looking at the things again, I smelled the familiar aroma which the Mother always carried around her; it permeated everywhere as if to clear my doubts. The fragrance filled each and every room of the house. I took the glass, the pill bottle and the lotus petal and went into the *puja* room (shrine room). There I placed everything in front of Mother’s picture and cried, embracing her picture tightly to my chest. I was still in the *puja* room when my son came home.

“When my son found me, he seemed very much worried. In a broken voice, he inquired, ‘What happened to you, Mother? Is everything all right? Where is father? Is he all right?’ Now everything was clear to me. Mother, before she left, had told me that my son would come in an hour. He came before that. First I consoled him, reassuring him that everything was all right. Slowly, when he calmed down, I narrated to him everything that had happened. He listened to the whole story with wide-open eyes and a wide-open mouth. When the whole story was over, he spoke, but

very softly as of in a soliloquy, more to himself than to me, 'Mother, so that was it. Now I know, Mother, the reason you sent me home.' The next moment he burst into tears, calling aloud, 'Amma!'"

She paused for a while; and then she opened her purse, and very carefully, reverentially and devotedly took out a lotus petal. Showing it to Balu, she said, "This is the petal..." but before she could finish the sentence, she was overcome with emotion.

It was a few minutes after eleven o'clock. Looking up towards Mother's room, they saw the Mother herself coming down. Both the mother and the son ran towards the Holy Mother, and falling at her feet, they shed tears of gratitude. Slowly and gently lifting them up, the Mother affectionately put them both on her shoulders. Like little children they went on crying. Rubbing and patting their backs and whispering into their ears, "Makkale, makkale, (Children, children), don't cry." The Holy Mother consoled them with all the love and care of a real Mother.

No one understood exactly what was happening on the previous day when the Mother had all of a sudden told the young man to return to his home. The Holy Mother herself did not disclose it. This was nothing new as it was her nature to remain humble always. The revelation of the whole mystery made the devotees very happy for this miracle to have happened.

By eleven-thirty the sunny weather became hot. Accompanied by all the devotees, the Holy Mother

walked up to the edge of the backwaters and sat down. The coconut trees and other plants which grew there provided enough shade for everyone as a gentle breeze offered a cooling effect. The Holy Mother fixed her eyes on the water for a few seconds and enjoyed the fish swimming and playing therein. Then she turned around and looked at the devotees, who were thirsting to hear something from her. Recollecting the days she had spent in a God-intoxicated mood, the Holy Mother revealed, "This open ground served Mother a lot during those days. Ah, the time which I spent dancing and singing in bliss is incomparable..." Suddenly, she went into *samadhi*. Tears of bliss rolled down her cheeks. With her eyes fixed somewhere in a boundless dimension, she sat as still as a statue for quite some time.

Slowly coming down, the Mother again related,

Amma: It is always very difficult to remember those days. It will steal away all my external consciousness. The sweetness and bliss bestowed by desireless devotion is something unique. Though *advaita* (the state of non-duality) is the Ultimate Truth, Mother sometimes feels that it is all meaningless and would like to remain like a child in front of God. There are people who preach the *advaita* philosophy, but this will not help much to progress spiritually, even though it does give a certain amount of intellectual understanding. For people to have a glimpse and a taste of spiritual life,

devotion and love for the Supreme is absolutely necessary. Not mere devotion, but real love should be there.

One devotee: Mother, how can one make that differentiation? What do you mean by “mere devotion” and what is “real love?”

Amma: Son, devotion can sometimes be like a mere performance of one’s duty. For example, in this village, in almost all the houses you can see people chanting and singing every day at dusk, reading the *Bhagavata* and the *Ramayana* and other holy books when they get the time, and so forth. But are they doing it with intense love and longing to see the Lord? There are many people who simply do it as a duty. For them it is just a custom or a rule set forth by their father or grandfather. For the sake of family name they keep the custom of singing the Divine Name at twilight. But if we look into the kitchen or the other side of the house, we will find them saying loudly, “Hey lady, take this or take that from here to the other side,” even while they sing, “*Hare Rama Hara Rama, Rama Rama Hare Hare, Hare Krishna Hare Krishna, Krishna Krishna Hare Hare.*” This is the type of *bhakti* (devotion) that we ordinarily see. Most of the time, the goal will be fulfillment of desires. Such people have some devotion to God, but they consider Him to be a mere agent to fulfill their wishes. If their wishes are not fulfilled, then they think that there is no God or that the Deity in the temple is powerless. They have

no awareness about the essential principle behind it. They do not think that seeking God, serving God, loving God, and eventually merging in Him is very important. This lack of understanding makes them ignorant of real spirituality and thus they continue to do their own manner of devotional practices.

But devotion supported by real love for Him is different. It is another type of love which is selfless and constant. That love is an intense longing to merge into and totally identify with Love. Real love has an unquenchable thirst to become one with the beloved. In such love there is the factor of discrimination, e.g., “Why are we here in this world? Is there a God? If there is one, I want to see Him, experience Him and become one with Him. I find this world to be unsatisfactory; therefore, let me try to seek and find the Source of all, if there is one.” Then endowed with determination, the seeker starts his inquiry immediately, without delay. When such love comes, knowledge also arises. Love is there in any path, whatever it may be. Therefore, love is known both as *jnana* (knowledge) as well as *bhakti* (devotion). *Lakshya bodha* (intent on the goal) is needed. To whom am I calling? For what purpose? Constant remembrance of the goal that has to be realized is needed. That is known as *lakshya bodha*.

For what am I studying? Is it to become an engineer or a doctor or something else? Having decided or fixed a goal of what to become, one studies with determination. But while studying, one forgets about the end-result and concentrates fully on the subject to be learned. This is the sign of the sincere student. Would

any student learn anything without contemplating seriously about it? If somebody does that (neglects contemplation), then he is not a good student. First, think and decide what you want to become, then study to attain that. Knowledge (*jnana*) is needed behind action. The awareness of what I am working towards should also be there. So then, love, knowledge, devotion and intent on the goal (*lakshya bodha*) can arise. The student studies, and when the desire to score first rank comes, he will then dedicate all his time for that. There is love in dedication.

In the same way, a real devotee or seeker depends entirely on God and gets absorbed completely. By doing this, he becomes a deserving person to attain his goal. We work sincerely when we have the attitude, "I must attain God." To put up a show or pretense in front of others is not the type of devotion that we want. We should work with determination till we reach the goal. The goal is the fruit. That is Self-realization. If it is to be attained, we must forget about the fruit while working for it; otherwise, our concentration will be divided and real benefit will not be obtained. For that love is needed.

The Lord says that we should act without desiring anything. Children, only then will concentration come. There should be one-pointedness when we call God. We should converse with God, asking, "O Krishna, or O Devi, You stop there. You listen to this before You go. Where did You go, leaving me all alone? Are You trying to get away from me? No, I

won't let You go," and so on and so forth. This is how you should ask. Just as we ask our friends, we should ask Him, "Where did You go? Kanna (Krishna) why don't You come near me? Why are You not speaking? Are You a mere statue? No, that is not what I heard about You. It is You who gives us power, isn't that true? Why do You simply remain standing? Take me." Like this, you should imagine yourself talking to your Beloved Deity.

VAIRAGYA (DETACHMENT)

Question: How does one find peace and tranquility?

Amma: To attain peace and tranquility, our false way of thinking must first be changed. At present, we think that peace comes from the outside. This false conception makes us search for peace outside, in the objects of the world. But, in fact, real peace comes from within. The eternal fountain of peace is inside you. This truth should be understood first; then you can begin to work towards it.

To attain that peace, we should give solitude to the mind. Solitude does not simply mean to sit in an isolated, lovely place filled with natural scenery. Such a surrounding is only a small factor in helping us to gain real solitude. Real solitude is solitude of the mind; it means one-pointedness of the mind. Even a beautiful place will not give you peace of mind if the mind is agitated. Therefore, we should try to make the mind quiet by slowly controlling, gradually restraining

it from running after anything and everything. In the beginning you should make a deliberate attempt to subdue the mind. Then, in due course, it will become effortless.

Do not mingle too much with people. Human beings have a tendency to foolishly develop attachment to another person, especially if they are around him for some length of time and it is someone they like. You meet a stranger in a bus stop or railway station. He comes near you and tells you, "I don't know why, but I feel a spontaneous love for you. You are really something special!", or some such flattery like this. Not only does our ego get puffed up, but we also quickly develop an attachment to the person. You "love" him. Why? Because he praised you. Then one day he criticizes you for something. The moment he does that, you turn against him, you hate him, you get angry with him and sometimes you may even want to kill him. Your love is gone and hatred takes over in its place. Any peace you had is now gone, and tranquility has long since flown the coop. Why does all this happen? Because of the agitation of the mind.

The same is the case with a pleasure-giving object. You see an object. You develop an attachment to it. You want to somehow acquire it; therefore, you work hard and earn enough money to get it. But at the last moment, your hard-earned money is stolen by a thief. Disappointment and anger come because you could not fulfill your desire. Your desire is obstructed. You could not get the thing which you had become at-

tached to. You get angry with your wife, your children and whomever you happen meet. Again, your peace is gone. Thus this peace comes and goes. It never remains with you. Why? Because of your likes and dislikes. Therefore, try to be detached by keeping your mind away from the things that want to gush into it.

Whatever sorrow comes, take refuge in God. Tell Him, "O Lord, one person scolded me unnecessarily. I am very sad." Do not tell another person about it. Tell God instead, "O Lord, is it because I did something wrong? Or, Lord, is it You who made him do that? If so, then I have no problem because only if I have attachment would I become angry, wouldn't I? No, I don't have that. I don't have any attachment to the words or thoughts which other people utter. You are the one real nature of my Self. When I have to deal with others, I should depend solely on You and not on others, shouldn't I?"

Would we turn around and bark at a dog which barks at us as it stands by the side of the road? No, we wouldn't. If we did, then we would also be like a dog, wouldn't we? We have a world of our own with a culture and behavior befitting human beings. In the same way, each object or person has its or his own nature. We will state a very high opinion about a certain object or person without having observed properly. Afterwards we will remark, "Alas, I am ruined. I should not have bought that thing," or "Oh, what the heck! He acted in such an obnoxious way." It was we who had first given the object or the person a "big cer-

tificate” or a high opinion, and afterwards we regretfully realize the real nature of that person or object. As a result, we hate or condemn what we first admired. We should pursue our path, accepting and considering other persons and objects as having their own nature and not expect them to be otherwise. Do not pause to question or criticize their behavior. We are much more a dog than a dog itself if we turn around to question without understanding the proper nature of things.

Question: But this is difficult. How can we remain silent?

Amma: Those who have intent on the goal (*lakshya bodha*) will remain silent. They will always be alert and vigilant.

Some students, even when they are riding in a bus, will go on studying. They will neither play football nor go to the movies. They will not be seen wasting away their time gossiping or chit-chatting. Even if they sleep, they set the alarm before sleeping. They will get up early in the morning and study their lessons. A *sadhak* only needs one thousandth of the dedication and concentration of a student who studies to achieve the first rank in school. He will be saved.

We strive hard for ten or twenty years just to get a job. Two years in kindergarten, ten or twelve years in school, another five years in college and after that a few months or possibly years in search of a job befitting our educational qualifications. Even though we spend time and effort in studying and searching for a

job, the possibilities of obtaining a good job are slim. Use a hundredth fraction of that time for God and the whole world will come under your feet. Yes, this is possible through one-pointedness of mind.

Children, concentration of the mind, devoid of ego is the bridge towards God. *Samsara* (the ocean of transmigration) is a vast ocean. The waves of this ocean (the *vasanas*) are huge and gigantic. The bridge of concentration is the only means to cross the ocean of transmigration. Only if we set foot on the bridge and cross over can we reach God. There is no external bridge to reach God. It is an internal bridge of concentration which we ourselves have to build and cross over. It is God's or the Guru's grace which always supports and protects us from falling down during this "trans-oceanic" crossing.

How did Hanuman (the Monkey-God who was the devout servant of Lord Sri Rama) build the bridge? It was by making a bridge through His mental resolve that Hanuman reached the other side. The bridge will collapse if the ego comes while one is crossing over. The path towards God is concentration which arises in the ego-less state. It is not a bridge built with rocks, bricks and cement. Untainted, selfless and pure love is the bridge towards God. If the ego comes, beware, you will fall down.

CONCENTRATION AND LOVE

Question: Amma, you said that concentration is the

bridge. You also said that it is love which is the bridge. Which one is correct?

Amma: Both. Concentration and love are one, like two sides of a coin. Love should be there if you want concentration. It is impossible to make them stand separately. They are inseparable, just as the length and breadth of an object are inseparable.

When we have love for something, an incessant and unbroken stream of thought flows towards that object. The thoughts are only about that. Therefore, to really love we need concentration and to really concentrate we need to love the object, whatever it may be. One cannot exist without the other. A scientist who does experiments in the laboratory needs a lot of concentration. Where does this concentration come from? From his deep and intense interest in that subject. From where comes this deep interest? It is the result of intense love that one has towards his particular subject or field of study. Conversely, if one concentrates on a subject intensely, love for it will also develop.

It is experienced that there is tastelessness behind taste. What makes us feel this taste and tastelessness? These impressions are created by our own actions. We feel them because of the *vasanas* inherited from our father and forefathers. We forsake the quest for permanent spiritual bliss as we pursue worldly pleasures. Having abandoned sweet pudding, we go after crow droppings. Remembrance of God and repetition of the *mantra* is necessary in order to escape from this bondage to worldly pleasures. As we walk we should

try to chant our *mantra* once with each step, repeating it over and over again, step by step. Thus while walking, we can remember God as we chant His Holy Name.

You should repeat your *mantra* even while lying down. Embracing the pillow you should imagine that it is God. You should have the strong faith and conviction that God is always with you and will certainly appear before you if you call with longing. Try not to commit any mistakes and try not to get angry with anyone. Immediately when you get up in the morning, you should think of God and pray, “O Mind, you should only turn towards the right path. Travel towards God’s world. Do not go towards the empirical plane.”

BOW DOWN TO ANYTHING AND EVERYTHING

The Holy Mother continued,

Amma: Children, you should develop an attitude of bowing down to anything and everything. Keep the plate of food in front of you and bow down to the food before eating and bow down to the plate after eating. An attitude to prostrate to anything at any time should come. In this way, an awareness, “for what am I doing this,” will arise. Thus we should build up good character. Prostrate to the cloth you will wear. Bow down to the water with which you will take a

shower. During these occasions of bowing down, you will have a pure resolve to see the same consciousness in everything whether with form or without. While doing so, you are in fact remembering God. While taking a shower, imagine that you are doing so with the Lord. Even if you are on the toilet, imagine that you are talking to Him. Do not waste any time. Simply do it. Constant remembrance of God, irrespective of time and place, is real devotion. If you practice in this manner, He will come; He must come. God will come and play with you. Imagine that you are talking to Him while performing any action, whatever it is.

Thus, as your imagination and resolve become stronger and stronger, you can slowly feel His presence, both inside and outside. The vague presence in the beginning will culminate into a constant experience in due course, because of your incessant practice.

Question: Amma, what does the statement, “God is the servant of everyone,” mean?

Amma: He is not the Servant of an egotistic person but of a humble one. Humility is God’s nature. He is the Servant of everyone. In fact, He is the Universal Servant. But it is a bit difficult to catch this Servant. In order to catch Him, you must drive away the many masters of lust, greed, anger, and other negative qualities to which you are a slave at present. This Great Servant, the Lord, likes to serve only one master, and he should be a great master who is victorious over all these demi-masters. To him the Lord will become a Servant.

Nowadays everybody wants to become a leader. No one wants to become a servant. In reality, the world is badly in need of servants, not leaders. A real servant is a real leader. A real leader is one who really serves the people without ego and ego-centric desires. In fact, greatness is not in dress, and lordship is not in acquiring wealth. Real greatness lies in humility and simplicity.

The friendship of God, the Servant, can be gained only if the ego and false pride are removed. At present we sit with the pride of a chieftain. Our attitude should become like that of a servant. We should become more humble than anything else. We should remove the ego and then He will come running to us. There is no other way to attain God. The agony caused by the longing to see God is not sorrow; it is bliss. The state that we attain by calling and crying to God is equal to the bliss that the *yogi* experiences in *samadhi*. Some people would say that crying for God is a mental weakness. Let them say that. To cry for God is to gain the highest. Anyway, crying for God is far superior than crying for trivial and fleeting worldly pleasures. The happiness which we get from the objects of the world lasts only for a few seconds; whereas, the happiness experienced from God and the thought of Him is everlasting. That 'weakness' is sufficient for us.

The Holy Mother is a living example of the Servant to all who come to her. Forever established in that

Truth, she comes to dwell in our midst, on the physical plane, to guide us in our spiritual growth. Sometimes, however, it is difficult for her to stay down on this level of existence. Suddenly she went into a state of rapture. Her right hand formed itself into a divine *mudra*. Rotating the fingers of her right hand in the air, the Mother uttered her favorite *mantra*, “*Shiva, Shiva...*” Again, she sat motionless for some time. The devotees gazed at her countenance and silently waited for her to come down to the normal plane of awareness.

One of the women devotees sang from *Sri Lalitambike*:

O Mother, this jiva might have passed
Through several hundreds of other bodies
Before coming to this birth.
This time, by Thy Grace,
I have this human form.
O Mother, let me offer this human birth
Which is very rare to obtain
At Thy Holy Lotus Feet.

The Holy Mother once again uttered the Divine *mantra*, “*Shiva, Shiva...*” and slowly opened her eyes.

**DEVOTION, THE BEGINNING AND
END**

One devotee: Amma, some say that devotion is only the first step. What do you say about this?

Amma: Son, aren't all the big scholarly books written with the same alphabet that we used when we learned in the beginning to write? Without learning the vowels, how can one learn the consonants? (In the Malayalam language, children are taught the vowels first and then the consonants.) How can someone who has not learned "Ka, Kha," (first consonants in Malayalam) write big scholarly books? All great works are written with these consonants, "Ka, Kha." The alphabet is used in all words. These letters are important for us in order to write anything. The alphabet is the substratum of writing. If a building is built without making the foundation strong, it will collapse. This is necessary until the end, even after reaching There. Without the alphabet nothing is possible (to write). The same is the case in spirituality. Devotion is not a mental weakness; neither is it only the first step, but something like the substratum for attaining the goal. Victory is ours if *bhakti* is obtained. It is both the beginning and the end.

THE GLORY OF TEMPLES

Question: Mother, is it necessary to go to temples and give money there?

Amma: Children, human beings are living on the physical plane. They do not have any time to focus and unite their thoughts. They are always restless.

There will always be problems in a village where there is not at least one temple. It is said that one should not sleep overnight in a village where there is no temple. Due to lack of faith and lack of fear in a Supreme Power or Governor, the people in a village with no temple will do wicked things. Where there is a temple, people will take refuge in it. The concentrated prayers of the people and the worship performed in it create a special feeling of divinity and peace in the village atmosphere. The power of their concentration will always remain there. This, in turn, will give peace and tranquility to the villagers themselves. This was all introduced by the *rishis* with great foresight. Again children, due to the lack of self-surrender and obedience to a higher principle, there will always be chaos and confusion in a village without a temple.

We light lamps in temples and burn firecrackers during festivals. All these things have their benefits. Don't say that these rituals are superfluous. Let human beings offer at least ten paise (about half a cent) at the temple in the name of God, so as to not spend their entire wealth in eating and excreting like animals. How much money are we wasting on movies and other things?

People think that it is a shame to go to temples. "Do not offer any money there. If we say anything there, does God hear it?" These are the questions they ask. So what. Society has degenerated due to this faithlessness and arrogance. This reflects on all our lives.

Children, God does not need money. All the wealth in the world is His alone. What could we give Him?

We are always selfish. What will happen if we try to teach the world without learning ourselves? Children, if we are unable to withstand the problems of life, won't we become weak and unsteady? At least we can let a little of our selfishness lessen by going to temples to offer and dedicate our attachments in the name of a higher principle.

Atmospheric purification will occur by burning camphor, lighting oil lamps and performing similar actions. Worship performed externally is also helpful for this. At the same time, what God likes the most is *manasa puja* (mental worship). Many of those who come here to the Ashram are people who do mental worship while sitting in their homes. More concentration is achieved through mental worship than in external worship. In reality, one's own heart is the temple, but we have not yet realized that. Therefore, we need an external temple as a reminder of the internal one.

Question: Mother, is it necessary to worship trees, snakes and things like that?

Amma: Everything in God's creation has a purpose and a benefit, whatever it is. There is a use for everything, whether it is a dog, a cat or a hen. No matter whether it is an animal or a plant, there is a purpose behind its creation. Even if human beings do not have any use for something, other creatures do. The harmony of nature depends on all things which have

been created. Take, for example, the changes in weather patterns that have now occurred. Because trees have been needlessly cut down, we do not get the proper rainfall during the monsoon season. Furthermore, the temperature has increased, hasn't it? It is the trees which purify the atmosphere, absorbing all the impure air exhaled by human beings. Is it wrong to mentally worship those things which do good to us? For example, some things are considered sacred, so we honor them with due reverence, that's all. Lord Krishna has told Arjuna, "Among mountains I am the Himalayas, among trees I am the great peepal tree and amongst animals, the lion." When everything is pervaded by God, which thing is not to be worshipped?

Question: Is it right to sacrifice animals during rituals?

Amma: (Laughingly) Nowadays it is those who eat meat and drink daily who protest animal sacrifice in rituals. Do they really protest non-killing? Is it really non-killing that they object to? Do they have any sincerity? Do they have any love or compassion towards animals?

Real sacrifice is the sacrifice of our animal tendencies. That is what needs to be offered in the fire of knowledge. Interpreting this wrongly, people sacrifice animals.

Killing should not be done consciously. There is no problem or trouble if one can do it with the attitude, "I am not killing." There is no sin in that case.

Sin is incurred if one does it with full awareness of killing. In other words, it depends on the amount of attachment and detachment that one has while doing the act of killing. It is difficult for an ordinary human being to be detached while doing such an act.

Soldiers kill many people in a war, don't they? But they do not have any sin because by doing so they are discharging their duty. They perform it with the thought and awareness that it is for the benefit of the nation and the people. Therefore, they do not incur any sin.

Sin and sinlessness depend on the purity and intention of the goal which is to be attained. For achieving big things we will have to sacrifice small things. To plant teakwood trees we will have to destroy many small plants and weeds during the process of preparing and ploughing the field for them. But we do not care. We mercilessly pull those plants out and burn them. Why? Because teakwood trees are much more significant and useful as far as society is concerned. Therefore, we give more importance to the teakwood trees and much less importance to the other plants. We consider it as a good cause, a higher cause. Similarly, to attain a higher goal, renunciation of smaller things is a must.

Simply for taste, to appease their hunger, to fill their bellies, people kill thousands of animals daily. What compassion they have! Mother is neither justifying nor siding with animal sacrifice. Whichever way

you look at it, it is not good to kill animals in the name of religion. If there are people who protest animal sacrifice, they should refrain from killing animals and eating meat, at least, to set an example.

It is quite certain that the atmosphere will be purified if *homas* (rituals, sacrifices) are performed. There are certain times when both the atmosphere and nature become polluted and disharmonious. It is said that *yagnas* (sacrifices) and *homas* should be conducted during such times. These sacrifices will help set nature on the right track and purify the atmosphere. It is the duty of human beings to serve and take care of nature, which, in turn, will supply us with all the necessary things.

FAITH AND SADHANA

The Holy Mother got up and walked towards the side of the kitchen. The Mother's visits to the kitchen were always unexpected. At times the *brahmacharinis* (women aspirants) and the other women devotees who were in charge of cooking and other household chores were not very careful about keeping the cooking vessels in an orderly fashion. The same was the case with various cooking ingredients such as spices. Today the Mother's chance visit happened. She unexpectedly entered the kitchen and found some rice wrapped up in a newspaper, lying on a shelf. The *brahmacharini* who had cooked lunch had inadvertently placed the rice on the newspaper, forgetting to place it

back into the rice sack after she poured the measured amount into the cooking vessel. The Holy Mother immediately summoned the *brahmacharini* and said,

Amma: Is this the way to do things? It is external discipline and attention which leads to internal alertness. A spiritual seeker should learn to do things in an orderly way. At present the mind is in total disorder. We have to regain and restore the lost order and harmony of our mind first. Once that has been regained, the mind becomes conducive enough to contemplate upon the Supreme Self. To attain that inner harmony we should begin with external orderliness and cleanliness.

Children, do not consider anything as insignificant or unimportant. Even a needle has its own place. We should develop the proper eyes to see it and a mind to place each and every object where it should be placed. Neither a higher place nor a lower place should be given to it. This should be the attitude of a true seeker. Forgetfulness and inadvertence are not the proper attributes for a spiritual aspirant.

The Mother then took the rice from the shelf and put it back in the sack herself. She looked around once again and then walked out of the kitchen. It was time for the evening *bhajan*, so the Mother went to the temple verandah where the usual evening *bhajan* was being conducted. She took her seat and the singing began in a few seconds. The Holy Mother sang, *Shiva*

Shiva Hara Hara...

O Auspicious One,
The Destroyer, whose loincloth is the clouds,
The beautiful One playing the damaru (drum)
Who holds the trident in His hands
Bestowing fearlessness and boons,
Who wears ash on His limbs
and has matted locks,
Who bears the crescent moon on His forehead,
Who has eyes full of compassion,
Wearing snakes as a garland
And a necklace of skulls.
O Auspicious One, the Great God...

The devotees, singing the response to the Mother's lead singing, felt truly inspired by the powerful melody of this song to Lord Shiva, the personification of Supreme Consciousness. Following this came the haunting tune of *Kasturi Tilikam*, which especially delighted them as devotees often identified their devotion to the Mother with the devotion of the *gopis* (milkmaids) to Lord Krishna.

Krishna puts the vermilion mark on his forehead
And wears the Kaustubha gem on His chest,
From Krishna's nostril hangs a pearl ring,
With bracelets around His wrists
He holds a flute in His hands,
Sandalwood paste adorns all his limbs,

A pearl necklace hangs round his neck.
Victory to Krishna,
Who is surrounded by the milkmaids,
Who is the Crest Jewel of the cowherds!

About devotional singing, the Mother says, “When great souls sing, they radiate tremendous amounts of energy. They can make people forget about the world and worldly bondages. Their mere presence will fill people’s hearts with love and devotion for God. Peace and tranquility will take the place of restlessness and other negative tendencies. Concentration will come spontaneously. It becomes effortless. Even if people do not put forth any conscious attempt to acquire any spiritual energy, they will get it from that presence. For example, suppose we visit a place where perfume is manufactured. Even if we simply walk around without doing anything, we can still smell the fragrance on our body when we return home. In the same way, a *Mahatma*’s (great soul) presence transmits spiritual energy to those who come to visit him.”

This statement of the Holy Mother is what is truly experienced by the devotees when she sings. An onlooker will see people bursting into tears or spontaneously gliding into meditation, enjoying the unconditional bliss of supreme devotion while the Mother sings.

Bhajans continued until eight-thirty. After the *arati* (waving burning camphor in front of the Deity as the conclusion of worship) the *brahmacharins* went to

meditate in the meditation hall. The Holy Mother roamed around in the coconut grove for some time. She was in a state of rapture at the end of the *bhajan*. She might have been wanting to be alone. Having revelled in her own plane of consciousness for some time, the Mother came back and sat on the sand at the southern side of the temple. Somebody tried to spread a mat for the Mother to sit on. She smilingly commented, "A mat! For this crazy Kali who used to lie in mud and dirt. Spread it out for yourselves, children."

At this time a few other devotees who were sitting here and there came and sat near the Holy Mother. One of them asked,

Question: Mother, one devotee says that there is not much importance in *sadhana* and that it is enough to have faith in Mother.

Amma: Son, a person who has faith in Mother will perform *sadhana* as Mother instructs. Such a person will live without erring even a little bit. Will your disease be cured if you only believe the doctor but do not take the medicine? Not only that, faith will gain strength and steadiness only if *sadhana* brings experience. Otherwise, faith will slip into irresoluteness. You cannot progress without *sadhana*. Can't you see even *jivanmuktas* (those who have achieved Liberation while tenanting the body) doing meditation and *japa* (repetition of the mantra) to set an example? No

progress will accrue to him who simply sits, saying, “Faith will save me,” without doing anything. Unquestioning obedience is what is meant by faith and devotion. Whatever the Guru says, one should obey unconditionally. Do not ask any questions. Do not doubt the Guru. One should unconditionally obey the Guru, whatever he says, whether it is doing service to the Guru, service to society, *japa*, *dhyana* (meditation) or anything else. The *Satguru* instructs that which suits each person.

KANVASHRAMA

14 March 1984

Kanvashrama is a beautiful piece of land, an ashram, in a place called Varkala near Quilon. It is believed that a great sage named Kanva did penance there for a long time, hence the name, Kanvashrama. One can feel an extraordinary sanctity and peace here.

This place is owned by a Dutch devotee named De Reede, known by his spiritual name, Hamsa. Very much devoted to the Mother, Hamsa often invites the Mother to his ashram. As it is a place suitable to do *sadhana*, the Mother agreed to come with her spiritual children to his ashram and spend a few days there.

Accepting the invitation of Hamsa, the Mother decided to go to Kanvashram for a three-day trip from this day, the fourteenth of March, to the seventeenth. Everyone was getting ready to go. As usual, everything needed for the three-day stay at Kanvashram was

taken, including food supplies and cooking utensils. This was the usual practice whenever the Mother went there. The *brahmacharins* had to prepare their own food. Furthermore, the Mother would not allow them to take food or drink from tea shops or restaurants. The Holy Mother says,

“In the beginning a *sadhak* should not eat anything from tea shops or restaurants. While using each and every ingredient, the shopkeeper’s only thought will be how to make more profit. When making tea, he will think, ‘Is this much tea dust necessary? Is this much milk needed? Why can’t the sugar be reduced?’ In this way, he will only have thoughts to reduce the quantity used in order to gain more profit. The vibrations of those thoughts will affect the *sadhak* .

“There was a *sannyasin* (renunciate) who was not at all interested in reading newspapers. One day an intense desire to read the newspaper sprang up in him. Afterwards he started dreaming about newspapers and about the news. When enquiries were made, it was discovered that the servant was reading the newspaper while cooking. His attention was not on the cooking but on reading the newspaper. The thought waves of the cook affected the *sannyasin*.”

The van to drive the Mother and the *brahmacharins* to *Kanvashrama* arrived on the newly constructed sea-side road. One by one, the *brahmacharins* proceeded into the van, each one carrying a cloth bag on his shoulder and a vessel or some other parcel in his

hands. The Mother also took a big aluminum cooking pot. Even though devotees requested her not to carry it, she would not listen to them. The Holy Mother related, "Your Mother used to carry pots and more pots full of rice gruel on her head to and from distant places. Mother is used to it." Then, like a little child, she said, "I won't give this to anybody who asks. It is mine."

The van was filled. There were nearly twenty-five people. The Mother was always very careful to take each and every thing necessary whenever there was a trip. During such times she would become exactly like a mother who was taking care of a big family and looking after the needs of each member. Before the van moved, Mother inquired, "Children, did you take everything that is needed, as Mother instructed?" "Yes, Mother," replied Gayatri.

By one o'clock the van slowly moved south along the seaside road. Once again the Holy Mother's mood changed to that of an innocent child. Pointing to the different spots and things which she saw by the oceanside, the Mother started explaining what they were and how she knew those places.

Sometimes she simply gazed at the sea and sat silently like one lost to this world. After a few minutes the Mother started singing loudly, *Sundarini Vayo...*

Please come, O Beautiful One
Consort of Shiva, please come
O Auspicious One, please come

Please come, O Endless one.

O Vamakshi, Consort of Lord Shiva,
O Kamakshi, who radiates brilliance everywhere,
To those who look upon Thee
As their dear relative,
Thou art their very own.
O Mother, please remain
As the spring of my inspiration.

Being both of one and of many forms,
Thou art the Light of the Absolute.
Dost Thou not know my heart well?
Will Thou not come before me, even as I ask?

It seemed that the Mother wanted to sing all alone. Therefore, the children did not sing in response. They felt that it would not be appropriate to mix their voices with hers. Tears of supreme bliss rolled down the Mother's cheeks and she was slowly transported to another world. Watching her radiant form, a college professor whispered into Brahmacharin Balu's ears, "Look at her; what a wondrous and mysterious personality this is. A few minutes ago she was like a little child and look at her now! What a vast difference. Everything is her *leela* (play). We mortal human beings fail to understand such Divine personalities with our limited intellect, and thus we judge them incorrectly. By her Grace alone can we understand her. There is no other way. Human effort can only take us

up to a certain extent; beyond that, Grace alone is the light and the vehicle which comes to us.”

At this point an English sentence accidentally slipped out of one educated *brahmacharin's* mouth. The sentence was, “Eleven boys makes a football team.” Immediately when he finished the sentence, the Mother said, “It should be ‘boys make.’” The astounded *brahmacharins* and other devotees looked at each other. In the eyes of others the Mother has studied only up to the fourth grade. But such occasions are not rare when she reveals a little of her omniscience. The Holy Mother’s keen observation of even the silly and seemingly insignificant mistakes of her children is quite obvious from this incident.

Once in 1982 a devotee from the West came to see the Holy Mother. Ralph M. Dickson was his name. This American became a staunch devotee of the Holy Mother from the very first sight of her. He wanted to clear some of his doubts by asking some questions during *Devi Bhava*. But unfortunately, when he came up to the Mother, there was no interpreter near her. Even then, Ralph, due to his faith mixed with excitement, related to Mother the questions he wanted to ask. Later while conversing with Nealu, Ralph exclaimed, “I heard that the Mother studied only up to the fourth grade and that she did not speak English at all, but she spoke to me in English! I had no problem conversing with her. She understood whatever I said and I understood everything that she told me.” When we asked the Mother about this, she replied, “That

happened because of the faith and devotion of that son.”

The van proceeded along the lovely oceanside road. All of a sudden, the Holy Mother said aloud, “Oh, I am thirsty. Give me some tea.” She seemed like a small child crying for milk. The van stopped in front of a small tea shop. The Mother coolly stated, “Those who want tea can drink some now.” Almost all the householders had tea or coffee. Some of the *brahma-charins* also drank tea or coffee as well. But when someone brought a glass for Mother, she said, “Mother doesn’t feel thirsty now. Mother doesn’t want any.” But it seemed that the Mother took a little, and again the van drove on.

The Mother and her party reached Kanvashrama at three o’clock. The atmosphere and the surroundings gave the feeling of an ancient hermitage where saints and sages of the past with their disciples performed severe penance. This piece of land, which covered a vast area, was a forest full of cashew nut trees and various other kinds of trees, bushes, plants and creepers. There were several hills, big and small, on this isolated piece of land. Down below at the southern tip of the plot there was a beautiful pond. On the eastern side of this pond lay a dense forest which was full of poisonous snakes and jackals. To the south stretched paddy fields. Here and there in the midst of the trees and bushes one could see simple, small hermitages built with bamboo and coconut leaves. These were meant for spiritual aspirants who wanted to do seri-

ous *sadhana*. Sometimes Mother would instruct one of her children to go and do *sadhana* in one of these hermitages.

Since Hamsa was on tour, all the other residents of the ashram, headed by Markus, a German devotee who was in charge of the ashram, came and received the Mother at the entrance. After having first gone to the temple, Mother and all the devotees gathered together in the tent made of coconut leaves with all four sides open. First Markus offered a glass of tender coconut water to the Mother, then the residents of this ashram offered their salutations to the Mother. She took a few sips and put it down. “How are you, Amma?” inquired Markus. The Holy Mother with a smile replied in English, “Good, very good.” (Everyone laughed joyfully.)

Markus: It is good to hear Amma speaking English. If she learns it quickly, then we won’t have to depend on interpreters. The Mother can do it if she wants. The scriptures say that *Mahatmas* can learn anything and everything if they want, whatever it may be. Isn’t that so, Mother?

Amma: That is right. They only have to concentrate on that particular subject or object to understand and assimilate the essence of it. All knowledge becomes under the control of such a person. A king has all the wealth of his country and the subjects under his control. He just has to snap his fingers and the thing that he wants will be right there. But a good and wise king

will not misuse his power at all. He will use it only in circumstances when it is absolutely necessary. In the same way, *Mahatmas*, who are established in the Supreme State of Pure Consciousness, are the emperors of the universe. They have everything under their command and their glance is sufficient to make others act according to their wish and will. But like a just and wise king, they never do things against the already-set laws of nature unless there arises an absolute need for it.

One brahmacharin: Mother, why do some places have a special vibration and some others a strange and different one?

Amma: Each person's thoughts, words and deeds play an important role in the differences in vibrations. Places where there exists a good and spiritual vibration are where a serious *sadhak*, a saint or a person who has performed many good and selfless actions must have lived. For example, when you visit some houses you might have a very good feeling about the atmosphere in the house as well as with its members even though that is your first visit. This will be due to the mental calibre, devotional practices and such other good things that those family members do. Whereas, in some other houses we can feel an entirely different vibration. We may even feel that we want to leave the house as quickly as possible. This again depends on the thought vibrations of the people who live there. This difference can also be felt not only due to the people who live there at present but also due to those who lived there long ago. The intensity and the

time which the vibrations remain in a particular area or house will vary according to the intensity of the thoughts and actions performed by the people who lived there or who were associated with that place. This is the secret behind the feeling of a meditative mood and divine presence in places where *Mahatmas* have taken *mahasamadhi* (when a great soul leaves his body).

The vibrations in an office are entirely different from those in a house. The vibrations in a marketplace are different from those in an office. Again the vibrations in a temple or an ashram are totally different from vibrations in all the other places. While the atmosphere in a market place or a liquor shop makes one confused, chaotic and tense, the atmosphere in a temple brings peace, serenity and calm. The vibrations in a temple are much more elevating, soothing and peaceful than in an office or in a house or in a liquor shop. Why is this? It is simply because of the pure thought vibrations, mental resolve and attitude of the people who come and go in those places.

THE BLISS OF SINGING BHAJANS

The Holy Mother got up from her seat, and having come out of the hut, she called aloud, "Shiva...Shivane!" raising both her hands up and gazing skyward. She went to her room which was situated near the hut. The *brahmacharins* and other devotees had their evening hot milk diluted with water and

rested for some time. It was five o'clock.

A *bhajan* program had been arranged at the famous Janardanaswami Temple in Varkala at seven-thirty in the evening preceding a dance performance. Having had a refreshing bath in the cool and rejuvenating waters of the pond down below, everyone meditated for an hour or so in the calm and serene atmosphere of the ashram. Some meditated by the side of the Vishnu Tirtha, a very shallow pond which was considered sacred. Others sat under the trees. There were a few who meditated sitting on the other side of the pond near the forest.

At quarter-past seven they all set out to the temple and arrived a few minutes before seven-thirty. The Holy Mother had also come along, but she remained in the car which was parked half a kilometer away from the temple. Gayatri, one *brahmacharin* and a couple from the same town who were devotees of the Mother also stayed back with her. Since the stage arrangements were not completed in time, *bhajans* did not begin until eight o'clock. According to the published program, the ashramites were supposed to sing for two hours. It was ten o'clock and the dance troupe wanted to start their program without any delay. They asked the *brahmacharins* to stop singing. The *bhajans* were about to be concluded anyway, but the audience became excited. People got up and shouted, "We want to hear more *bhajans*. Continue the *bhajans*. No dance." Some of them even became agitated and shouted slogans, "Dance troupe, go back. We want to

hear only *bhajans*!” The frightened dancers slowly withdrew from the stage and hid in the a room until the *bhajan* ended.

It was a thrilling and wonderful sight that evening. The thousands of people who had gathered there in the temple primarily to enjoy the dance program at first felt very annoyed and irritated when they had heard the announcement about the commencement of the *bhajan* singing performed by the Mata Amritanandamayi Math. But now the same crowd did not want it to stop. The people truly experienced the bliss of the Divine Name on that day. What other factor except the Guru’s grace can bring such a transformation in the minds of the people?

When everyone got back to Kanvashrama, the Holy Mother related,

Amma: When Mother heard the uproar, she thought that the people were turning against her children for singing for such a long time. But the next moment Mother became reassured, thinking that that could not happen since devotion and devotional singing were the spontaneous music of the soul. Nobody can resist the inspirational qualities of such music penetrating one’s heart when it is sung with concentration and devotion. It is this natural attraction which has been proven today.

It was nearly midnight when the Holy Mother retired to her room. Before going to bed, the *brahmacharins* once again meditated in the deep silence of the night.

15 March 1984

The *brahmacharins* and the other devotees got up at an early hour of the day and did their usual chanting of the Thousand Names of Devi and then did meditation and other morning practices. The dawn at Kanyashrama was beautiful. Standing on the banks of the Vishnu Tirtha, one could see the sun rising up from the eastern horizon.

At seven o'clock the Holy Mother came and sat under the banyan tree situated on the southern side of the Vishnu Tirtha. Her hair was tied up in a knot. The golden rays of the rising sun reflected on her face and delineated more of its glory and splendor. The blissful smile which lit up her countenance seemed more luminous than the sun. Fixed on the infinite, her eyes were still and steady, without even blinking once.

The Mother sat there for a long time. It was nine o'clock and the Holy Mother was still seated under the banyan tree. Around ten o'clock, a few devotees came to have the Mother's *darshan*. They all prostrated before her and took their seats in front of the Mother in a semi-circle.

Among the devotees who came just at that time, there was a young girl named Miss D. (a fictitious name). She came with her father and her uncle. Miss D. was studying for her Bachelor's degree in philoso-

phy. Endowed with a strong longing to know God, Miss D. was very attracted to the Holy Mother. She kept gazing at the Mother's face without paying any attention to anything that happened around her. Realizing that she was burning with inspiration, Mother commented, "Miss D. mol (Daughter Miss D.) wants to swallow Mother up." Without even the least sign of timidity, she replied, "Yes, if possible." Mother laughed loudly. Everyone joined in laughter with the Mother, even her father and her uncle, although there was a slight sign of fear on their faces, seeing and hearing their daughter's strong inclination towards spiritual life. Their fear was that she would abandon worldly life and take up spiritual life.

One after another the Mother received all those who came to see her. It was nearly twelve o'clock noon, so the Mother invited all to have lunch. The devotees took leave of her, one by one, as the Mother got up from her seat and walked down towards her cottage. Hesitatingly, Miss D. also left with her father and her uncle, having prostrated to the Mother.

Responding to the invitation from a devotee's family, the Mother visited their home that evening. She sang a few *bhajans* there and did a *puja* in their family shrine room. After the singing and the *puja*, the Mother, overflowing with compassion and love, conversed with each and every member of the family, including the servants.

Everybody returned by ten o'clock. When she reached Kanvashrama, the Mother said, "It is too early for Mother to go to bed." This was a fortuitous

announcement for everyone. They were only too happy to hear that they could spend some more time with her. Everyone sat around the Holy Mother in the hut near the Mother's cottage. She looked at each one's face and smiled. Again there was a short pause. The Mother said, "Mother simply wanted to see all her children's faces."

One householder devotee: When the whole *Brahmanda* (the universe with each and every object in it) is within you, why do you want to see our external faces?

Amma: For your satisfaction. What will be your fate if Mother sits saying, "The whole universe with all of you is within me. Therefore, I don't want to see you externally." None of you will be here. A person endowed with a very strong sense of detachment and determination to reach the goal may not need such external attention. But Mother knows that you children need that care. You give very much importance to it, don't you? Know that Mother does things, whatever they may be, with a purpose. A touch, a word, a look, a smile or a patting (on the back) is sometimes sufficient to fill her children's heart and soul with strength, courage and peace. At present, the source of their inspiration solely depends on Mother's physical presence. As you progress spiritually, you may see her within.

Now the Holy Mother continued,

Amma: But sometimes it is painful to see her children act indiscriminately. (In a serious tone) For example, yesterday on the way here, Mother said that those who wanted to drink tea could do so. Except for a few everyone had something to drink. The fact is, Mother was testing your discrimination, but most of you failed. Mother felt a little pain seeing her children act in this manner.

Children, to test the mental strength and discrimination of the disciple, a Guru might ask the disciple to do many things, even things which are against spiritual life. Sometimes the Guru himself may bring it to him or create such a circumstance. A real disciple properly discriminates and accepts only the things that he needs and rejects all the rest ruthlessly. Things that he needs means those circumstances and objects which would help him to progress spiritually. His sharp discrimination will help him to overcome all kinds of obstacles which might arise in this path. Positive acceptance of the Guru's words and deeds and utter obedience to him with application of his teachings in one's life are what gives the greatest amount of joy to the Guru. This, verily, is the most precious *Guru dakshina* (offering) that you can offer to the Guru.

There are all different kinds of habits developed by us. All these habits must go, one by one. You may find it hard to remove them in a short period of time; yet you must strive to get rid of them with determination. At least a willingness to give them up should be there.

Habits are the biggest impediments on our path.

Our own actions are responsible for them. The diligent performance of virtuous or divine actions will help the old, bad habits to be replaced with new and good ones. This needs constant practice.

Tea and coffee contain intoxicants. They will destroy many things that help to purify the sense organs. They will awaken sensual desires. They are harmful to the body also.

The *brahmacharins* and the other devotees on this trip who had tea the other day while traveling to Kanvashrama now realized how diplomatically and unpredictably the Mother had caught them. Pricked by their guilty consciences, they remained silent.

Another devotee: Mother, why do you give so much importance to the control of food?

Amma: Children, the body is made up of food. A pure mind with pure thoughts will arise only in a pure body. To get a pure body the food that we eat should be pure and *sattvic*. The body and mind are interdependent. Whatever happens to the body will affect the mind and vice versa. Above all, to control the mind, a good control over the food that we eat is absolutely necessary. Skeptics and non-believers may label this as nonsense or illogical. “Nonsense or illogical” is the explanation or interpretation for things or phenomena which they do not understand. They view the entire spiritual science with a negative attitude. They believe only in things which they think they can prove

through scientific experimentation. Then why don't they try and test this science? Skeptics claim they believe in modern science, but scientists themselves ultimately believe in spirituality. What a contradiction! It seems that their only purpose is to make blank and illogical statements. How can such people elucidate something from this real science?

The time was eleven-thirty p.m. The Holy Mother with joined palms told everyone, "Mother begs pardon from all her children for scolding them. Mother feels that all her children are not different from her. That is why she talks in this way. Children, don't take it otherwise. It is only for your own good." Saying this, the Mother got up and went to her room. Everyone went to their respective cottages, having prostrated at the places where they were seated.

16 March 1984

As usual, the *brahmacharins* and the householder devotees arose at four-thirty a.m. and performed the chanting of the *Lalita Sahasranama*. When the first rays of the sun fell on the earth, they all sat around the Vishnu Tirtha and meditated. Some took their seats under the banyan tree. It was an inspiring sight. They all seemed like young *yogis* absorbed in deep meditation. The peaceful surroundings and serenity of the atmosphere added to the sacredness of this scene. The rising sun's sparkling, golden rays and the gentle,

cool morning breeze caressed them. The meditation continued until half past eight. The Holy Mother came out and sat under the banyan tree to give *darshan* to the devotees at nine-thirty. A group of spiritually inclined people were present. They conducted and participated in regular *satsangs* and other spiritual activities. They asked the Mother different questions. It is usually found to be true that people who have read and learned more are the ones who have more doubts.

Question: Mother, my mind runs away and wanders while I am trying to concentrate.

Amma: Son, it is the nature of the mind to wander. It cannot sit quiet. When we try to quiet the mind by concentrating on an object of meditation, we can see it wander even more. More thoughts will come. Beginners may get frightened and sometimes feel discouraged by these numerous thoughts which come up during meditation. These thoughts and other tendencies of the mind have always been there, but because we were engaged in different activities we had no awareness of them. These thoughts and other *vasanas* manifest only when we try to withdraw the mind from all external activities and concentrate on a single point. Constant practice coupled with determination is the only way to conquer the mind. Therefore, during such times, do not become frightened or discouraged. Continue your spiritual practices with determination.

Until now we have lived in the consciousness that we are the body. We have traveled a long way living in this world of plurality. All the impressions gathered

from the past experiences are there in the mind, some in the gross mind, but the major part are in the sub-conscious mind. They are dormant like a tree latent in the seed. To remove all these latent tendencies from the mind needs long term practice with patience.

Another man: Is *Raja Yoga* the best path?

Amma: Children, it is difficult to say “such and such” a path is good and “such and such” is not a good one. All paths are equally good if they are properly practiced with the right understanding. Anyhow, just one path cannot be advised for all people since people are different mentally, physically, and intellectually. The spiritual disposition inherited by the aspirant from the previous birth is the criteria to test which path is good for a person. Though all paths are equally good, each one works differently in different people. Each person will have a spontaneous feeling or inclination towards a particular path and that will be the correct path for him. In any case, to be on the safe side, it is better to approach a *Satguru* in order to find one’s path, to determine which direction one should go, to discover who is our Beloved Deity and to obtain other advice for one’s spiritual growth.

Children, as far as Mother is concerned, the path of devotion is the best and the easiest since most people are predominately emotional in nature. Not only that, *bhakti marga* (path of devotion) has no complications like the other paths. There are no harmful techniques or complications involved in love. Simply love the Lord. Love is not aggressive; it is a constant

flow.

It is always dangerous to do *sadhana* after reading books. Always be aware that those who write books and give speeches are not all Gurus. Try to follow the footsteps of those who have fully experienced what they say or write about.

Question: *Kundalini* will rise through the practice of *Hatha Yoga*, won't it?

Amma: Why do you think about all these complicated methods when there are easier ones? *Hatha Yoga* should be practiced under the strict guidance of a Perfect Master. You cannot simply adopt any method that you feel like. Each one will have a path which they would have followed in the previous birth. Only if that path is followed will one progress in one's practice.

If *Hatha Yoga* is practiced by oneself, it might lead to the danger of becoming more aware of the body and thus will inflate the ego. Whereas, the sole aim of spiritual practice is to get rid of this body-consciousness. Whichever is the path, it is enough to gain concentration. The concept about *kundalini* rising is a *bhavana* (creative imagination). We can have the concept about God as well. It is the same idea. Whether you follow the path of devotion or the path of *karma* or the path of *jnana*, this awakening of the *kundalini* must happen. The difference is that a devotee calls the same *kundalini shakti* as Krishna, Rama, Devi, Jesus or Buddha. Children, do your *sadhana* properly and sincerely. Do not waste your energy and time thinking, "When is the *kundalini* going to awaken? Will it rise up

if I follow this path or is the other path better?”

Question: Aren't Devi and other forms a mere *sankalpa*?

Amma: Do not say this. As far as a devotee is concerned, the form of his Beloved Deity, Devi, Krishna or Rama are real. If you do not like sweet pudding, why should you say that it is not at all good or that it is useless? There are many people who relish and enjoy it. Your favorite dish might be something else and something that someone else may not like.

All the names and forms, whatever they are, are only creations of the mind for one who has gone beyond the mind. But this is not the case for one who has not reached the state of Perfection. He or she may say that all names and forms are unreal and that *Brahman* alone is true and real. However, if he has not experienced Perfection, it is meaningless for him to go around declaring the unreality of forms.

Even people who have reached Perfection will set an example by worshipping, singing and chanting the different names, and glorifying the different forms, of Gods and Goddesses. They are the only ones who truly experience the world as illusory and not at all real. Yet they will perform worship and give adoration to what the forms represent because they know that we ignorant little children cannot rise up to their level of understanding and, therefore, need a name or form to aid our spiritual growth.

To pretend we know it all and to show off our pride (which is really false pride), we may say that

Devi is a *sankalpa*, that the names and forms of Gods and Goddesses are merely a state of mind and thus have no reality. What authority do we have to say such things? You may say that the saints and sages have stated this in the scriptures. But they realized the ultimate unreality of all forms through their own experience. Have you realized this? If not, keep quiet. Please do not taint and stain people's faith by your speech. The *rishis* were always afraid that they might stain this Truth through their speech. That is why they always prayed, "O Supreme Self, let my word be established in my mind; let my mind be established in my word."

Question: Mother, I do not understand. What fear? Where is the fear in this prayer? I don't see its relevance.

Amma: Son, here "Let my word be established in my mind" means "Let each and every word that I might utter while describing this Truth be established in my experience." The *rishi* prays to the Supreme Self for His Grace to reflect in his inner experience of the *Atman* in his speech. He is afraid that he would utter some untruth because whenever speech comes there is a chance for a new interpretation. Speech is also a product of the ego. The ego is the cause of speech which is the effect. The ego is false; therefore, the false nature of the ego will be reflected in the effect, speech. The *rishi* wants to sustain the purity of the *Atman* in his speech as well. That is why he prays that his speech should reflect his inner experience of the Truth.

The devotees and the *brahmacharins* sat amazed, looking at the Mother's face, wondering at her deep insight in whatever spiritual topic she talked about. One devotee remarked, "How simple are the Mother's explanations about the most complicated and subtle philosophical truths." The Mother laughed like an innocent child and retorted, "Hey, don't praise this crazy Kali. Crazy Kali's children are also crazy."

Question: Does Mother have the opinion that the different names and forms of Gods and Goddesses are real?

Amma: Children, someone who has never existed or who has never taken birth would not be worshipped and adored by millions of people. Nobody will celebrate the birthday of a person who has not been born, but we do celebrate the birthdays of Rama, Krishna, Jesus and other Great Souls.

What Mother would like to say is that names and forms are needed for people like us with the kind of mental calibre that exists today. It will help our spiritual growth. Do not say that ours is the best path and all other paths are wrong. If a person's choice is tea, have it, fine and good. Let those who do not like tea drink coffee, lemonade or plain water. Why should we bother our heads about people's personal preferences? Why should we say that tea alone is good and all other drinks, bad? The purpose is to quench the

thirst. Therefore, whether it is meditation on the Supreme with attributes or the Supreme without attributes, the goal is to attain perfect mental peace in any circumstance. Give up all such doubts about Gods and Goddesses and do your *sadhana*.

Anyhow, even when you meditate on the Formless, a pure creative mental resolve is needed.

Toys are needed for children to play with and for them the toys are real. Grown-ups do not need toys; they know that such things are unreal and lifeless. But the grown-ups cannot say that children should not have toys because they are not real.

Each person has a certain mental level and power of understanding. Let each person start from his own level. Do not try to thrust your ideas onto them.

Question: How can God be with form and without form at the same time?

Amma: Simply because He can become whatever He wants whenever He feels like it. God is beyond space and time. He is not bound by such limitations. Therefore, He can be both personal and impersonal. He can assume a form, but He is not the form, i.e., He is not attached to the form. When water is kept in different vessels of different shapes, it assumes the shape of each vessel. The water remains as water and does not become something else even if the shapes of the vessels differ. The water does not undergo any change even if the shapes of the vessels are different. In the same way, whatever shape, form or name He assumes, God remains as God. Let those who need *sakara* (God with a form) take that. How many can do meditation

on the formless? It is not a process which is possible for all.

Question: Mother, will *Raja Yoga* cause harm?

Amma: Nowadays many books are being published on *Raja Yoga*. Several young men became mentally troubled reading such books, breathing in and out irregularly. There is no harm if such practices are performed under the guidance of a very good Master.

On the other hand, it is good to read books depicting the life and teachings of real devotees. Read as many as you can. There is no harm in that. Aberrations of the mentally troubled will go if they read such books. Such books have real glue to make us glued to God. You will never err or fall.

Question: So then, is it sufficient to have devotion alone?

Amma: Mere *bhakti* is not sufficient. Love is needed. Only then will the mind get absorption.

Question: In the light of what you said just now, it sounds to me that devotion (*bhakti*) and love (*prema*) are two different things.

Amma: Son, look, this is how it can be differentiated. Devotion is praying and supplicating to God just to satisfy one's selfish motives and desires. Such people will generally cling to temples. Even if they do go to see *Mahatmas*, they will be very keen to present before the *Mahatma* all the problems that they have. Such people have devotion, but pure love is at a minimum in their devotion. They give suggestions or instructions to God or to the *Mahatma*, such as "My Lord, this is my desire. Please fulfill it," or "I don't want that to occur. Don't make it happen." They want Him to act

according to their own wishes and their own wills. They think they know more than He does. Their understanding about God or the *Mahatma* is far inferior to that of a devotee endowed with pure love, who loves God or the Guru for love's own sake. Such a person endowed with love wants nothing, not even Liberation. He simply wants to love God or the Guru, no matter what happens. To love Him is his happiness. He wants to cast off all his desires except the desire to love Him.

Therefore, *bhakti* (devotion) endowed with *prema* (love) is *prema bhakti*. *Bhakti* bereft of *prema* is mere devotion. Both a person with *prema bhakti* and a person with only *bhakti* will love the Guru or God, but the one with *prema bhakti* will give all importance to God or Guru; he has no choices, no wish or will of his own. His Guru is everything for him. He simply wants to love him, surrender to him, forgetting everything else. He wants to be consumed by the flame of the love which he has towards his Guru or Beloved Deity.

However, for the second type of *bhakti*, what is of primary importance is himself. He first wants to fulfill all his desires, then he thinks of God. As far as he is concerned, God or the Guru is like an agent to fulfill his desires.

Question: Mother, you said that an ordinary devotee's understanding about the Guru is far inferior to that of a devotee endowed with pure love. What do you mean by "understanding?"

Amma: It is not a mere intellectual understanding but

understanding coupled with an unending thirst to live up to it, that is, the understanding or the knowledge that the Lord is in everything and surrendering oneself to that Supreme Will. His own limited will dissolves and disappears in the Lord's unlimited will. Then there is no "he" but only "Him." There is only acceptance and no rejection, only pure love without hatred, only desirelessness and no desire. All his desires melt and disappear, except the desire to love his Beloved in any circumstance. He fully accepts the omniscience, omnipotence and omnipresence of God or the Guru and acts accordingly. Then it is not he who is acting, but the Lord who makes him act. This is real understanding. A true devotee must have this knowledge.

Ten-thirty a.m. Nobody even thought about having their breakfast even though refreshments were available. The Mother had even urged the devotees to go and partake of some food or something to drink, but everybody preferred to stay with her. At this time, a family, husband, wife and two children, came to see the Holy Mother. This was their first visit. They went to Vallickavu first. Learning that the Mother was at Kanvashrama, they came to see her here. They all approached and offered their salutations to the Mother and sat near her. The Holy Mother very lovingly asked from where they came and whether they had eaten anything. She called Gayatri and told her to bring something for them to drink. Then the Mother turned

towards their children, and calling them to her, she inquired about their names and the grades they were in, in school. The Mother then looked at the father and quite spontaneously said,

Amma: Son, the path of knowledge is not the right one for you. Yours is the path of devotion and your Beloved Deity is Mother Durga. If you abandon this path and follow the path of knowledge, listening to that man who is just a book scholar, that will obstruct your spiritual growth.

The man was dumbfounded with astonishment. It seemed that he wanted to say something, but for a short while he could not. He stared at the Mother with his mouth wide open. Then after some time when he had regained his equipoise, he silently shed tears, catching hold of the Mother's feet. The Mother slowly lifted him up and wiped his tears with her own hands. This show of love and affection made him cry again. Once again, he tried to control his tears. When he succeeded in doing so, he asked the Mother,

The man: Amma, I knew that it could not have happened without your knowledge; still I was not convinced. That is why I came to see you in person. I wanted to hear it directly from you, and you told me the same even without my telling you anything about it. You have blessed me and by your Grace I will try not to err from my path and will stick to your advice to the best of my ability. Also, Mother, forgive me for

testing you. It is because of my ignorance that I wanted such proof.

The Holy Mother simply smiled and kept quiet. By that time Gayatri brought tea for all of them. The Mother herself took the glasses from the tray and gave one to each person, after having sipped a little from three of the glasses. She did this for the husband and the two children but not for the wife. Everyone noticed this strange action of the Mother and they also might have felt that the Mother was being very partial on her part to do such a thing. But to everyone's surprise, the husband burst out laughing and through his laughter he said, "Amma, please pardon me for laughing like this in front of you." When he had finished laughing, he continued,

The man: I do not mind disclosing this about my wife in front of all those who are here. I assume that all of you are Amma's devotees and therefore there is nothing wrong in relating this to you. My wife was very skeptical about Amma. She did not even want to come with me. It was only because of my insistence she came. It is not her fault. She was brought up in such a skeptical family. On our way to Kanvashrama she even teased me, saying that I was too emotional, that I was silly to come to meet this lady whom she thought was an ordinary person who had no powers at all, that everything was only my own hallucinations. She even challenged, "If your Mother is all-knowing, let her give me a hint about her omniscience. If she

does that I will definitely believe her.” Now the Mother responded to her skeptical mind. She had taken a sip from all the glasses except hers, letting her understand that the Mother could clearly read her mind. This was exactly the answer for all her questions.

The man was thrilled, excited and inspired that the Mother had revealed her omniscience. The Holy Mother smilingly consoled the woman, saying,

Amma: Daughter, don’t worry. It is not because Mother knows everything but because she knows nothing that she acted in this way. Had she known everything she wouldn’t have hurt you like this.

The lady was humbled, and she said,

Lady: No, Mother, no. Don’t say that. You have given me a good lesson. Too much education spoiled my heart. Now I understand that prejudice is wrong. I know that it will go on troubling me, but if I surrender to you, you will destroy it. Please give me the strength and courage to surrender.

After saying this she silently shed tears. The Holy Mother embraced her and patted her just as a mother does to her child. They all spent some more time with the Mother and then took leave of her after having offered their prostrations. Before they left the premises,

the husband, whose name was Karunakaran, told one of the *brahmacharins* about the incident which inspired him to come and see the Mother.

Two nights ago he had a dream in which the Mother appeared to him and clearly said to him that he must quit the spiritual practice that he was told to do by the scholar who taught him the scriptures. He had heard about the Mother and was waiting for a chance to see her. Since he was studying the scriptures from the scholar who had instructed him to do the *sadhana* that he was doing, the dream did have some meaning for him. At the same time he loved and respected the scholar; therefore, he did not want to give too much importance to the dream. But the Mother appeared to him again on the following night. This time she added a few more things in her instructions to him. She said, "Son, I have told you to quit the spiritual practice that you are doing now. The path of knowledge is not the right one for you; yours is the path of devotion and your Beloved Deity is the Mother Durga. If you abandon this path and follow the path of knowledge, listening to that man who is just a book scholar, it will obstruct your spiritual growth."

Karunakaran continued, "This instruction given by the Mother in the dream was very clear and the dream was literally true. I was a devotee of Mother Durga for many years. I always worshipped her, but due to the influence of this scholar, I abandoned that path and pursued the path of knowledge as instructed by him.

But I have missed that love and remained discontented about my spiritual practices. At the same time, I did not want to displease him. In fact, I have a certain amount of attachment towards him, but I was longing to get guidance from a Real Master. After hearing about the Holy Mother, I had the dreams. The dreams, particularly the second one, had such an impact on my mind that I wanted to come and see the Mother the very next day. Besides this, even though I do have faith in Mother, to convince my ego, I wanted her to tell me directly about the dream when I met her. She did this as well. You know the rest of the story. Even without disclosing anything about the dreams or about my *sadhana* or about the devotion that I had to Mother Durga, she repeated the very same words that she had uttered to me in the dream. Now I am happy, very happy and blissful, not only because she answered my prayers but also because of the compassion she has shown to my wife in removing her skepticism, something that has always troubled her as well as me.”

The Holy Mother wanted to sing *bhajans*. She asked Sreekumar to bring the harmonium, and he went to fetch it. The Mother was still sitting under the banyan tree, now at eleven-thirty a.m. The atmosphere was very calm and peaceful. The Mother gazed at the Vishnu Tirtha. The water was still, and the Mother seemed as if she was enjoying it. Her blissful countenance shone with a beautiful radiance.

Sreekumar brought the harmonium. The Holy Mother sang a few *bhajans*, first *Kodanukoti*, then *Oru Nimishamenkilum*.

O Truth Eternal
Mankind has searched for Thee
For millions and millions of years...

The ancient sages, renouncing everything,
Performed endless years of austerities
In order to make their selves flow
Into Thy Divine Stream through meditation.

Inaccessible to all, Thy infinitesimal Flame,
Glowing like the effulgence of the sun
Stands still without dancing
Even in the fiercely blowing cyclone.

Flowery creepers, shrines and temples,
All have waited for Thee for aeons and aeons,
Yet Thou art inaccessibly distant.

Oru Nimishamukilum...

O man, who runs after
The pleasures of the world,
Do you have peace for even one moment?

O man, without understanding the essential
And real principles of life,
Deluded by the shadow of maya
You will perish like a moth in a flame.

In the evolutionary process
You have passed through different bodies,
Insects, worms and numerous reptiles,
Innumerable birds and animals.

Thus you have evolved
Through different bodies until at last
You came out as a human being.

O man, think and discriminate,
What is the real purpose of this human birth...
No, O man, this human birth is not to be
wasted
For silly and trivial worldly pleasures.
Remember, it has a right of its own.

O man, without giving up your false pride,
Your desire to acquire and possess,
Your desire to enjoy and indulge,
Without attaining That state
Of Supreme Brahman,
You cannot have peace or bliss.

These profound songs, pregnant with philosophical meaning, directly penetrated into the hearts of the devotees. They were all absorbed in deep meditation. The Holy Mother sat gazing at the vast blue sky and kept swaying from one side to the other. It was now noon. Suddenly the Mother said, "Shivane! None of my children have had their breakfast. What a cruel Mother I am. I forgot to give food to my children."

Come on, all of you, let us eat.” She called a few *brahmacharins* aside and instructed them to make arrangements to serve food to everyone. As they ran, the Mother shouted, “Hurry up, be quick. Don’t delay anymore.”

The Mother herself served food for everyone. The devotees’ hearts overflowed with joy and bliss. After lunch, one by one, the devotees left after offering their salutations to her. The Holy Mother also went to her room.

At three-thirty a group of college students came to see the Mother. They wanted to see the Mother and ask her certain questions. They were all between fifteen and twenty years old. The Mother came out of her room by four o’clock. She was very happy to see the young boys. They seemed to be a little perplexed when they saw the Mother. But she went near them, and like one who was well acquainted with them for a long time, she smilingly invited them to come and sit in the hut.

The Mother first of all asked their names, one by one, and the place where they each were from. They politely answered the Mother’s queries. The Mother’s innate naturalness impressed the students very much as they became more relaxed.

One boy who looked a little older than the others proudly said, “We heard about you and had a desire to see you; thus we came together. To be frank, all of us are not believers. Some are; others are inquisitive;

there are a few who are very skeptical.” He stopped. The Mother looked at them and smiled. Then she uttered her favorite mantra, “Shiva, Shiva,” a few times with her fingers held in a divine *mudra*. The Mother once again smiled at them, and then looking at the boy who introduced everyone, she asked, “Son, under which category do you fall?” The older boy blushed, hearing the straight-forward question of the Holy Mother. That was quite unexpected for him. He was tongue-tied for a moment, then slowly he said, “Mother, my parents are your devotees. I never came to see you before, but still I have faith in you. Yet I never had an opportunity to know you directly; that is why I came now with my friends.” The older boy had been a little proud when he talked at first, but now he seemed very humble.

Amma: Son, you stated that all of you were not believers and that some are inquisitive and others are very skeptical. By saying this you have not said anything new. That is the nature of the world. Not everyone can be a believer and not everyone can be skeptical. Even if everyone does turn into a believer, again each person’s points of view and concepts will change. Nor can we really make everyone a believer. It is just the nature of the world to have these differences. The shapes of two leaves from the same tree are not alike. Infinite is Reality and infinite are its manifestations. It does not really matter whether you are a believer or a non-believer or a skeptic. You can be a non-believer

but at the same time lead a happy and successful life if you have faith in *you*. You do not have to believe in Mother or in a God who resides up above in the sky on a golden throne. It is enough if you have faith in *you*. If you don't have faith in *you* then there is not much to gain even if you believe in God. Faith in God is to strengthen your faith in you, the faith in your own Self. This is, in other words, called Self-confidence, confidence in your own Self. If that is not there you cannot succeed in life, whatever your field may be. Self-confidence is nothing but mental balance, courage and control over your own mind to confront the problems of life. You cannot escape from the problems of life; they are inevitable, unavoidable. How are you going to face them if you do not have faith in yourself? You cannot.

A skeptic means one who doubts, one who questions anything and everything. That means he even doubts his own Self, his own existence. Such a person does not have faith in himself. He will walk around arguing, disputing and refuting, creating more doubts in his own mind and in the minds of others as well. He will be an utter failure in his life. Such a person cannot create anything; he destroys. How can such a person who has no control over his own mind be a benefactor of society? His own life will become a total mess. Spirituality and the spiritual masters teach one how to build up this faith and self-control, which are the most important factors to lead a happy life. Anyhow, Mother likes you because you personally came

to learn and find out. The majority of the people are not like this. They simply criticize and interpret from a distance without coming closer and studying things properly.

The Holy Mother paused. The students sat without uttering a word. They did not know what to say or how to begin. It seemed that they were searching for words. This whole time the Holy Mother sat looking at them with a beautiful smile which lit up her ever-radiant face. At last one boy broke the silence. He spoke out but in a low voice and with a very gentle and respectful tone, "Mother, you have, in fact, answered all our questions." As if to prove his innocence, he continued,

Question: I didn't come to question you. I am neither a skeptic nor a non-believer. In fact, I have a lot of interest to know more about spirituality and spiritual life. Mother, I have always wondered about the place of reason in spirituality. You said that faith is everything. But reason is also needed, isn't it?

Amma: That is a well-thought-out question. Mother likes it. Son, reason has very little place in spirituality. It should be dropped. After all, what is reason? It is the product of your intellect. What is intellect? It is the product of the ego. The ego should be eradicated. That is the aim of all spiritual practices. Therefore, reason, being a product of the ego, must go. In the path of Self-Realization, intellect or reason is a big ob-

stacle. Intellect always doubts. Doubt is not what is needed in spirituality. Here the entire thing depends on faith—faith in God or the Guru, faith in the Scriptures or in the Guru's word. Faith in the Guru uplifts you. Doubting the Guru will destroy you. Faith unites your diverse personality and helps you to see everything as One. Doubt cuts everything into pieces. Doubt makes you more diverse; faith makes you one and whole.

Too much reasoning is the problem today. People think that intellect is everything. But that is wrong. The world suffers because of this. People have no faith. They want to question, criticize and protest everything. They do not want to believe and surrender. They go on feeding their heads and making their hearts starve. Their heads grow and their hearts dry up.

Science needs reason. The very basis of science and scientific inventions are nothing but reason and doubt. But modern science cuts everything into pieces. It never tries to unite anything. This is how science becomes destructive. Science should be beneficial to the human race. This is possible only by using it to unite people with their minds.

Question: Mother, do you mean that reason is a useless thing?

Amma: No, son. It is not. The intellect is needed. Reason must be flexible. It should be used to support the heart, our faith, the love in us, the compassion and other higher ideals in us. This means that there

should be a good balance. Too much faith or too much reason, one at the exclusion of the other, are both dangerous. For example, a devotee has faith, utter faith, in his Beloved Lord. Still, behind that faith there is reason. There is the subtle understanding that all the worldly experiences, all that happens around him, both negative and positive, good and bad, are momentary and that these things just come and go. He does not cling to the world and the worldly relationships because he knows that they are all ever-changing. He does not give unnecessary importance to anything that happens. He never craves to acquire and possess. He is not after name and fame. He smilingly receives both the happy and unhappy moments of life because he knows that they are unavoidable and that it is the nature of life. All this needs intellectual understanding. But his intellect is very subtle and he uses it to reject whatever is not needed and to accept whatever is necessary. In short, his reason helps him to penetrate into the real nature of objects, the changing nature of them and the unchanging nature of his own Self. His reason helps him to strengthen his faith in the Supreme, never to weaken it.

CONCENTRATION

Question: Amma, what is the way to gain concentration?

Amma: *Sraddha* (alertness, faith) is needed. We do not go to a particular place when we learn that it is danger-

ous to go there. We will proceed with alertness. We do not eat something if we find out that it is poisonous. When we find out that there are thorns in a certain place, we do not walk through that place. Our alertness keeps us from danger. Similarly, through constant contemplation the mind will become one-pointed on God when we come to know what is non-eternal and what is eternal, what binds us and what frees us. Then the mind will gradually stop wandering. When we realize that we will not get the intended benefit out of an object, then we will not depend on it, will we? When the dependence on objects cease, the mind will become fixed and concentrated on the Self. Children, we must try very hard. None of these material things give us any benefit, although we may think they do. We should contemplate and understand that they are all like poison. It is difficult for us to get concentration when we, who until now have thought that the body was eternal, try to reverse ourselves and realize that the *Atman* is eternal. Constant practice is needed. You may not get it fully in a day or two, or a month or even a year. Still, you are getting it. Little by little you are improving. You may not be aware of it. Do not stop. Try and continue.

When we travel in an airplane we may feel that the aircraft is not moving, but it is, in fact, flying. Once we reach the destination, we will know that the aircraft had been flying all the time. Likewise, during the *sadhana* period you may feel that you are not making any progress, but you are. You will know it when you reach That state. You may not know the subtle

progress that you are making. Therefore, do not stop. Do not give up enthusiasm; try to sustain the spirit. Do it patiently and wait for the Guru's or God's Grace to come.

Question: What is Grace?

Amma: Children, Grace is a mysterious factor. Nobody knows when, how or where it will be bestowed. Human beings have no control over it. You can make the effort; you must. Then you wait. The deciding factor is Grace. That is in the Guru's hands, in God's hands. It is our experience that many things, for which we put forth much effort, do not materialize. That is due to lack of Grace. It is also known to us that certain things simply happen without any effort. That is the presence of Grace.

A pilot can put forth effort to fly his plane to the destination, but whether it will reach there or not depends on Grace. After all, it is a machine; anything can happen at any time. Any part can stop functioning at any moment. The pilot does not have any control over it. The airport authorities and the engineers will check everything before departure and will say "okay." But who can give the guarantee? Nobody can do that. The pilot might be an expert, but he has no control over the whole aircraft, not each and every part of it. So it is Grace which takes us to the destination, not the pilot. Of course, the pilot has a major part to play, but the deciding factor is Grace. We have heard many stories of how a plane has mysteriously escaped from a terrible crash even though the pilot had lost all control over the aircraft. There are also stories about how a plane has crashed even when the pilot did have good

control and where everything was seemingly in good order. Again it is Grace which serves as the deciding factor. Therefore, put forth the necessary effort and then wait patiently.

To surrender to a Guru is the best way to attain this Grace. Obedience and faith in the Guru and his words will make us competent enough to get this Grace.

Suppose we don't know Malayalam. That means we are a child as far as that language is concerned, aren't we? To learn that language we must surrender and obey the instructions of the teacher, accepting the fact that we are a child in that subject. Only then can we learn that particular language. In the same way, those who are ignorant about spirituality should approach a Guru just like a child, accepting the fact that they do not know anything about spirituality. The biased attitude of "I know" will obstruct the flow of spiritual knowledge and Grace from the Guru. If acceptance and surrender are not present, Perfection will not be reached. It is just like a child saying, "I know this; you don't have to teach me." When this happens he rejects the true knowledge that the teacher gives. He closes himself to that knowledge. His prejudice makes him non-receptive. When we are in the presence of a genuine Master, we must accept our ignorance and surrender to the Guru completely.

Question: Mother, why is there a lot of difference between the olden days and the modern age?

Amma: In the olden days people were selfless, and now people are totally selfish. That is the reason.

Children, in the olden days people had the same needs as today. They wanted food, clothing and shelter. They also had their education. They had games, arts and sports. They had civilization. They too led a married life and had children. The difference is that their way of life was not only concentrated on the world outside but on the world inside as well. They did not live only to acquire and possess wealth but also to know God. They had self-control, inner discipline. They always tried to develop good qualities like truth, compassion, love, renunciation, and patience. They were concerned not only about their own family but also about society. Each person truly felt that he or she had a duty towards society and discharged it sincerely and whole-heartedly. But today's world is just the opposite of this. People, due to their selfishness and ego-centered nature, have turned the world into a hell. Previously, the world was like heaven. We now point our fingers at each other. We criticize and question the other's arrogance or ego-centeredness. We cannot bear the other person's ego. Children, what about our own? We never think about that. We think that our ego is not a problem but that it is the other person's ego which creates problems. What a strange attitude this is. In reality, it is our own ego which creates the problems in our own life, not the other person's. Our ego should become a burden for us; only then will we try to get rid of it. At present we think that our ego is an adornment for us. This feeling inspires us to keep it as something precious. Just as

you feel that the other person's ego is unbearable to you, your ego is just as unbearable to someone else. Therefore, try to eliminate it.

In the olden days whatever work people did was considered by them as a means to attenuate their *vasanas*; even married life was for that purpose. Today people add more to the existing *vasanas* by acting arrogantly and selfishly.

It is said that the human mind will become dry and narrow as worldliness increases. A person will rise up and evolve when the mind becomes expansive. But when the mind becomes narrow, not only the mind but also the physical stature will be affected due to his selfish attitude, over-indulgence and lack of restraint. The height of human beings is quickly decreasing in comparison to the olden days. In the ancient days people were of magnificent stature and were very strong mentally and physically. In the olden days how tall were the students who would today be in the tenth grade! But now how short are even those students who are studying for the B.A. and M.A. degrees. In the future human stature will diminish. There is no broad-mindedness, only selfish, narrow-mindedness. This will cause both mental and physical disintegration.

The Holy Mother now stopped. It was five o'clock. The students seemed very happy. All of them had developed tremendous interest now. The older boy spoke again, "Mother, please forgive us if we have spo-

ken egotistically to you. Please pardon us for our ignorance.”

Another boy said, “Mother, I confess that I simply came to see you out of curiosity, but now you have opened my eyes. I will try to keep this spirit.” Still another student remarked, “Mother, I really had no faith in spiritual people or spiritual life. I was very critical about them. But now you have awakened the interest in me. I will never forget these instructions which you have given today.”

The Holy Mother went up to them and caressed each one of them on the forehead with much love and affection. She said, “Children, Mother is very happy to see all of you. Please come whenever you want to. You are the fragrant flowers of tomorrow. Build up good character and try to do something good for society.” They all prostrated to the Mother and left.

The Mother went down the hill near the pond and roamed around all alone. In a few minutes her melodious voice filled the air with a song about Krishna, *Nilakadumbukale...*

O blue kadamba tree,
Have you also seen my Kanna
Who is dark blue in complexion...

She was in an ecstatic mood. Gayatri and a few others walked down and watched the Mother from a distance. None of them went very close. The Mother walked with faltering steps, but her sonorous voice

did not falter as she continued with the second verse:

Oh, the waters on the shore
Of the River Yamuna, have you heard
The melodious, enchanting note
Of my darling Krishna's flute.

O animals and birds,
Why do you look all around
As if searching for someone?
Like me, are you searching
For the Beloved of the Gopis?
Are you also in the burning fire
Of the excruciating pain of separation
From Him, the Stealer of Hearts?

Finally the song came to an end and the Mother lay down on the grass. She became totally oblivious to the surroundings. Gayatri and Brahmacharin Sreekumar went closer. She was totally transported to another world. Her body was still, her eyes half-closed and her face glowed with immense bliss.

The song which she had sung still seemed to echo in the atmosphere. It created a deep longing in the hearts of all those who had heard it. The time approached five-thirty with the sun slowly sinking into the western horizon. A glorious blending of golden yellow and red clouds painted the sky with brilliant colors. Their reflection in the waters of the pond created a play of dancing light and shadow. The sweet singing of a nightingale from the forest near the pond accentuated

ated the calm and quiet mood. A gentle breeze blew from the west as if to wake her up from *samadhi*. It softly caressed the Holy Mother's form. A few strands of her curly dark hair fell on her forehead and danced in the breeze.

A few more minutes passed; it was nearly six o'clock. The Holy Mother slowly opened her eyes. She remained lying down, gazing towards the sky. Then she stretched her hands and gave a sign for Gayatri to lift her up from the ground. There she sat for a short while and then slowly stood up and proceeded to climb up the hill.

As usual there was the *bhajan* at six-thirty. The Mother was also present. At ten o'clock she again took everyone to the Vishnu Tirtha and meditated there for nearly one hour. Shortly after eleven o'clock the Mother and the entire group returned and retired to their rooms.

17 March 1984

Last night before going to bed the Mother instructed everyone that they should come and meditate by the side of the Vishnu Tirtha early the next day. Accordingly, the whole group gathered there before sunrise. The Holy Mother was already at the lake. She was sitting under the banyan tree. The *brahmacharins* and other devotees sat around the Vishnu Tirtha and meditated. The sun slowly rose from the eastern hori-

zon. The meditation went on for about one hour and a half. Afterwards everyone came and sat around the Holy Mother who was still sitting under the banyan tree. The Mother had some bananas at her side, and she distributed them to the devotees and *brahmacharins*.

One devotee commented, "What Mother gives is the fruit of knowledge." Another devotee remarked, "The fruit of our meditation is bestowed right after its performance."

Amma: Stop saying such things. You are wasting what you have gained through unnecessary comments. Keep silence for a few minutes.

Thereafter nobody spoke for some time.

By eight o'clock some devotees from outside of Kanvashrama came to visit the Mother. The sun's rays emitted greater and greater intensity. At this time a young boy who was about fifteen years of age came with a big notebook in his hands. He was sent from a nearby spiritual institution which ran an orphanage. They had forgotten to request the Mother to write a congratulatory note in the book on the day she had visited, so now they had sent it to the Mother for her to write a message in it.

Just as a mother does to her child, the Holy Mother expressed love and affection to the boy as she conversed with him. She asked his age and his grade in school. The Mother said, "It seems that you are very mischievous. What will be the end result of all

these mischievous deeds? You will end up in trouble for them, won't you? Therefore, my child, you should study diligently and grow up as a good boy. Okay?"

The boy enthusiastically nodded his head in agreement with what the Mother had said.

The boy: Amma, I would like your address.

Amma: Mother has no such thing as an address.

The Mother took the diary from the young boy and started writing on one of the pages:

Darling Children,

Your happiness is Mother's health. Let Children's attitude of selfless service last forever. The compassion that we show towards the poor and needy is the real duty towards God. That is real service. God does not need anything from us. What can we give to the Ever-Full One? The whole universe belongs to Him. The sun does not need a wax candle. An electric bulb does not need a kerosene lamp. These orphaned children are equal to God. God dwells in those who have the attitude "I have nobody else." Eternally blessed and blissful are those who look after them selflessly. Let Children's selfless service be everlasting,

darling Children.

A devotee wrote down the Ashram address and handed it to the boy, saying, “Here is Amma’s address.”

One devotee: Is Mother’s handwriting clear enough?

Another devotee: It is enough if one clearly understands the meaning of what Mother has written.

Amma: It is not enough if one reads Mother’s words only with one’s intellect. One should try to read them with one’s heart too.

A devotee wanted to take a picture of Mother. He asked the Mother’s permission. She said,

Amma: A *sadhak* should not permit others to take his picture. Some of our power will be lost while each photo is taken, just as the fetus is adversely affected if a pregnant woman is x-rayed. If Mother allows you to take her picture, the children (*brahmacharins*) will also imitate her in the same manner in the future. That is why Mother does not allow people to take her picture unnecessarily. Concerning herself, Mother has nothing to gain or lose.

Question: Amma, what do you expect from your children?

Amma: Nothing. Mother expects nothing. If you feel

that Mother expects something, it is to take you beyond all expectations. It is for you, not for me. A father or mother accepts whatever is given to them by their child, even if it is an insignificant object like a stone or a toy or a balloon. By doing so, the father and mother do not get anything; they do not expect it. Still, they accept whatever the child may give, however small or insignificant, just for the satisfaction of the child, not because they expect the child to give the toy or the balloon to them. When the child out of innocence gives the balloon to the father, he simply accepts it because he cannot reject it. When the child offers the piece of biscuit which he has played with for a long time and which is now full of sand or dirt, the mother simply takes a bite because she cannot reject the child's expression of love. The thing which the child offers is an expression of its love towards the mother. Not that she expects it from the child. In fact, she really doesn't want to eat it because it is full of dirt; still, she accepts it. True love cannot be rejected. A child's love is true because he has innocence. There are no expectations in true love. It simply flows like a river. In the same way, when you offer something to Mother, you are doing it as an expression of your love, aren't you? Mother accepts your love, your heart, not that she expects it but simply because she cannot reject it. When you offer something wholeheartedly, she cannot say "no." But she does not expect it. Whatever may be your offering, what Mother accepts is your heart.

Suppose one of her children makes a special dessert for Mother. While making it, he or she will be thinking of Mother all the time, dreaming about how Mother would like this special treat, about the way she would eat it and so on and so forth. And when that person brings this special delicacy to her, Mother cannot reject it because it is cooked in his or her love. It is his or her heart that is being offered. Who can reject pure, innocent love? Whether one accepts it or not, pure love simply flows.

Mother does what she does because she cannot do otherwise. To love is her nature, to serve is her nature. She doesn't expect anything in return. But your feeling that Mother expects you to do something will encourage you to do good things in life and to progress spiritually.

Krishna did not expect anything from the Pandavas. He did everything for them, for he could not do otherwise. That was His nature. He tried to correct the Kauravas as well. He tried to avoid the battle. He put forth all His efforts to stop it, but the Kauravas rejected Him. The Pandavas accepted Him; therefore, he was with the Pandavas. The Kauravas rejected Him, so He could not be with them.

The Mother got up from her seat to walk down the hill to the hermitage where she stayed. On the way she met a few more devotees who had just arrived. Among them again was Miss D., her father and her uncle. Mother stopped and affectionately called each one of

them to her and gave *darshan*. She commenced her journey down the hill, followed by all the devotees. She caught sight of a *chakora* bird (Greek partridge) sitting on one of the branches of a cashew nut tree. The Mother suddenly came to a halt, and stretching her arms towards the bird, she blissfully called out, “Oh, oh, oh, Amma, Amma, Amma...” She then made some unfamiliar sounds. After that the Mother closed her eyes and remained still for a few seconds, holding a divine *mudra* with the fingers of her right hand. Then upon opening her eyes, the Mother waved her index finger in a circular motion for a few times in the air and uttered the familiar *mantra*, “Shiva, Shiva...”

Arriving at her hut, the Mother stepped into her room. Still enchanted by their walk with the Mother, the devotees stood in front of her hermitage for some time before dispersing to their own rooms.

Hamsa, the head of Kanvashrama, was in Madras, so he left Markus in charge of the ashram. Markus was very devoted to the Mother. Extremely happy and blissful that she was here at Kanvashrama, he went around with great enthusiasm to find out if the devotees were in need of anything.

That morning at nine-thirty everyone had their breakfast. By eleven o'clock the Holy Mother came out again. The Mother, with the whole group following her, roamed around all over the hills, singing *bhajans* every now and then, entering into *bhava samadhi* at times, talking, laughing and asking questions like an innocent child, “How did this butterfly’s wings become so colorful?” or “Can you tell me how the bud

opens up into a flower?” She sometimes called aloud “Shiva” or “Amma” while gazing at the sky as she walked, or stopping and looking at a flower or a butterfly. Occasionally she would sit down to relax. Thus she made everyone roam, not only over the hills but within the reveries of their minds, allowing them to forget the world outside and all their problems.

By twelve-thirty the Holy Mother returned with all the devotees. She asked the *brahmacharins* to make arrangements for lunch. After the usual chanting of the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita*, everyone started eating. Just as a mother feeds her little children, the Holy Mother fed each one a ball of rice with her own hands. After that she went to her room.

After the three days at Kanvashrama, the party was returning to Vallickavu today. Everyone packed their things ready to leave. They all gathered in front of the Mother’s cottage by three o’clock.

It was the season of spring. The trees and plants bore beautiful and fragrant flowers of different colors. Though a clear and sunny day, it was not very hot. Miss D., the young college student, looked very thoughtful and sad. She was sitting in a corner on the verandah of the Mother’s cottage. The girl sat all alone, with her chin resting on her palms. She was awakened by her uncle’s voice, “Miss D., get up. Let us prostrate and take leave of the Mother immediately when she comes out.”

She got up and stood by her father’s side, fixing her eyes on the front door of the Mother’s room. At

about three-fifteen the door opened. The Mother announced that she would like to swim in the pond before leaving. She called all the *brahmacharinis* and asked them to come with her. Their happiness knew no bounds, for such an occasion to swim with the Mother was a rare treat indeed!

All of a sudden, Miss D., the young girl, jumped forward and tightly embraced the Holy Mother. The Mother also hugged her and lovingly inquired, "Daughter, what has happened?"

Through her tears, Miss D. replied, "Mother, I am not going back home. I cannot be away from you even for a second. Please don't abandon me, Mother." The father and uncle were shocked, as if a thunderbolt had fallen on them. They were stunned. They turned pale. It took a few moments for them to realize the gravity of the situation.

Smiling, the Mother soothed her forehead and in a very gentle tone said, "Daughter, go with your father and uncle now. Don't put them in a dilemma."

Miss D. declared in a very determined tone, "No, I won't go. I want to come with you." The girl would not let the Mother move. She did not loosen her hands, not even a little bit. The father and uncle were totally perplexed. They wanted their daughter back. At the same time their devotion to Mother stopped them from taking her by force. In a very calm and quite voice, her father said, "We will go and see the Mother at the Ashram in Vallickavu later. Let us go home now." Miss D. said, "No!" in a very stern voice.

Her uncle said, "Don't be stubborn. Think of your

mother at home. What will we tell her?"

Miss D. was unshakable. She said, "I am not going. My Mother is here."

There was no way to change her mind. She would not even move a little from the Mother's side. The father and uncle helplessly looked at the Mother. They could neither forcibly take her home nor could they leave her behind.

Finally the Mother took Miss D. down to the pond. The father and uncle waited, hoping that Mother would speak with her and change her mind. In a few minutes the whole atmosphere changed. The devotees could hear the splashing of water and through it the Mother's blissful laughter. Then everybody heard the Mother singing loudly while the girls responded to *Srishtiyum Niye...*

Creation and Creator art Thou
Thou art Energy and Truth
O Goddess, O Goddess, O Goddess!

Creator of the Cosmos art Thou
Thou art the beginning and end.

The essence of the individual soul art Thou
Thou art the five elements as well.

Some of the male devotees seemed a bit sad. One of them said, "What a pity. I wish that I were a woman. I really feel unfortunate and left out."

The whole atmosphere of Kanvashrama vibrated

with the Mother's divine voice. There was a large number of men and women devotees sitting farther up on the other side of the hill. All their attention was fully concentrated on the Mother's voice which emerged from the pond down below. There was not even a bit of noise which could disturb the prevailing mood. The chirping of birds and the Mother's poignant songs were the only exhilarating sounds which enlivened the whole ashram atmosphere. Everybody felt so happy and blissful, everybody except Miss D.'s father and uncle.

After bathing the Mother talked to Miss D., sitting on the concrete steps of the pond. She said, "Daughter, you should think it over again and again before you make a final decision. It is not an easy path. Don't be impatient. Go back to your home and think patiently. Look, your father and uncle are in a dilemma. You are giving them trouble. They cannot go back home without you. Your mother also will be very sad. What will be her condition when she hears that you have gone. Above all, if you leave home deserting your parents, it will bring a bad reputation for Mother and the Ashram. You can come to the Ashram and see Mother with your parents. So now you return home."

Miss D., "No, I am not going. I want to be with you." That was all she said and then she kept quiet. She was so determined and firm. She was not even slightly moved; she displayed no excitement at all. She was very relaxed and cool.

Just to play her part sincerely and properly, the Mother still tried other means. She summoned a few

of the elder *brahmacharins* to talk to her. Her father and uncle were also called. A long discussion took place. Each one tried to convince Miss D. about the different aspects of the matter. She quietly sat, unmoved, as if this discussion did not concern her. Every now and then she turned to the Mother and softly said, “No, I am not going.”

It was getting late. Mother had to reach the Ashram in Vallickavu that very same day. The scheduled time to leave had passed. Miss D.’s affair was still up in the air. She seemed to be a “hard nut.” Finally the Mother told her uncle and father, “Don’t worry, you go back home. Before proceeding to the Ashram, Mother will come to your house with daughter Miss D..”

Both the father and the uncle left.

Many things concerning Miss D. came into light later. She was very devoted even from a very young age. She had read only spiritual books. It was also her habit to do *japa* and *dhyana* regularly while at home. Several times she had told her parents, “I will take up *sannyasa*. I won’t allow you to give me in marriage.”

According to her own wish and will, Miss D. took philosophy as her main subject for her B.A. degree. Two days ago when she met Mother at Kanvashrama for the first time, she was completely drawn to her and decided to leave the world, accepting the Mother as her Guru. She had the strong feeling that Mother was the incarnation of Kali, the Divine Mother. Having understood her mind, the Holy Mother did not

even give Miss D. a chance to talk to her. The Mother also noticed that this girl was endowed with a very good spiritual disposition. She said, “Mother expected this when she saw her on the very first day. A girl with very good spiritual inclination. Mother knew that this would happen; that is the reason why she intentionally prevented the girl from having an opportunity to talk to Mother.”

Returning home after her first visit with the Holy Mother, Miss D. prepared to leave her hearth and home and take up *sannyasa*. On the morning of the seventeenth she left home, saying that she was going to the college. She took off all her gold jewelry and left them in the house. Just with the clothes that she had on Miss D. left the house and walked towards Kanvashrama without going to the college. It was at that time that she ran into her father and uncle who were coming from another direction on their way to Kanvashrama to have the Mother’s *darshan* again. They were surprised to see Miss D., and when they learned that she also wanted to see the Mother, all three proceeded to Kanvashrama together. Since Miss D.’s father and uncle were spiritually inclined, they were not against her wish to see the Mother. In fact, Miss D.’s father used to take her to classes to listen to spiritual discourses. Had they known that things would take such a sharp turn for what they considered the worse, they would not have brought her to see the Mother. Now the Holy Mother spoke to Miss D.

Amma: Daughter, external learning and education are also necessary. You can come and join the Ashram after finishing your studies. Furthermore, your father is a person who is learned in religious texts. It is not a blind devotion that he has. He knows the essential principles of religion. Therefore, it is not a problem for you to lead a spiritual life. But is your mother like that? No. She will scream and create an uproar in the house, which will make things worse. It is said that when the great Suka renounced everything and became a *sannyasin*, Vyasa, who himself was a great soul, went after him crying and calling aloud, “My son.” That is the power of *maya*. So what can be said about the reactions of ordinary people? No father, even if he himself is a *sannyasin*, will allow his son to become a monk. Your mother is the one who gave birth to you, isn’t she? Therefore, she will not be able to bear it if you were to leave her.

One devotee: (Intended for the Mother) The mother who gave birth is sitting here, right in the front. (All laugh, including the Mother.)

At last the van carrying the Mother and her children proceeded north. There was a lot of luggage on the carrier rack on top of the van. All the pedestrians and people who stood on the roadside looked at the extraordinarily big bundle of luggage on the top and were puzzled. As the van moved the Mother laughed and jokingly remarked aloud, “This is a trip with pots

and pans. We are beggars.” (Laughter)

All the while Miss D. was sitting close to the Mother. The latter was very cool and fully relaxed, acting as if nothing had happened. The others were thinking about what would happen when they reached Miss D.’s house. The girl seemed determined, but what would be the family’s response?

The van stopped in front of Miss D.’s house. Everybody there knew about the incident by now since the father and uncle had gone ahead of the Mother’s van. A small crowd was gathered in front of the house. Most of them were relatives, a few were neighbors and passers-by who were curious. Miss D.’s mother was crying, screaming and beating her breast. She ran out of the house and rushed towards the van, screaming and lamenting. She burst out at her daughter, who remained seated in the van, “Hey, girl, you’ll go only after killing me.” The father, uncle and other relatives even tried to bodily force the girl out of the van. No matter what was said or who tried to pull at her, Miss D. would not come out of the van.

Amma: The Ashram is a spiritual institution. Mother will not accept daughter without the permission of her parents.

Miss D.: Mother, are you abandoning me?

Amma: No, daughter, never. You are Mother’s alone. But the public will not believe that you have chosen to take up spiritual life out of your own volition. They

will say other things and even fabricate stories. Therefore, it is better if you come to the Ashram later, with the permission of your father and mother.

Miss D. remained seated in the van. She was unmoved. At last, the Mother stepped down off the van. She asked Miss D. to come out with her. The girl obeyed. The Mother caught hold of her hand and took her into the house. Having entered the house, the Mother loudly said, "All these people will say different things if I take Miss D. now. If she is determined enough and if she is destined to become a *sannyasini*, it will happen." Having said this the Mother explained to Miss D. particular statements and certain comments which people would make about Miss D. and her family if the Mother took her now. The family members were astounded and amazed to hear these things which the Mother was saying because she was repeating exactly what they had rebukingly said against her, even without missing a single word. (We were informed of this later by a devotee who had happened to be in the house at the time.)

As the Mother came out of the house, one elderly person related from behind, "What a wonder, this Mother. She is a person who knows everything. Didn't you hear her repeating all the things that we had said here, not even missing a single word!"

The van again moved north after leaving Miss D. in her house. One devotee asked, "Will they beat the girl

or do something else to her?” The Mother answered in a very determined voice, “No, they will not even touch her.”

As the journey north continued, the atmosphere changed and everyone became happy and enthusiastic. The Mother also soared to the peak of bliss as she ecstatically sang, *Maname nara jivitam makum...*

O mind, this human birth is like a field,
If not cultivated properly
It becomes dry and barren.

You know neither how to sow the seeds properly
Nor how to grow them well,
Neither have you the wish to know.

By removing the weeds and putting fertilizer,
By taking proper care,
You may have a good harvest.

The early part of life
Is spent in helpless cries
And youth is spent in lustful attachment.

As old age approaches
Your strength is taken away,
You become like a helpless worm
Without any work, time spent
Looking forward only to the grave.

The Mother led a few more *bhajans* as everybody responded. It seemed that they all forgot the fact that they were traveling in a van. Such was the joy and exhilaration as each person partook of the abundant flow of spiritual bliss.

When the *bhajans* were over the Holy Mother laughingly said, “When her mother created such an uproar, screaming and lamenting as she came towards the van, do you know what daughter Miss D. told Mother in a soft voice? ‘Mother, these are all just pranks to show Mother. It will last only for a short time.’ She is not a woman but a man. She was unmoved even when her mother was crying.”

Thus while the talk went on, the van stopped in front of another house, the home of a devotee. The Mother spent a few minutes there. First of all, she went to the family shrine room and did a small *puja*. The son, who was studying for his medical degree, did not want to continue. He wanted to take *sannyasa*. The parents were against this. His sister also had the same leanings. She read only spiritual books. The parents were very worried about what would happen to the children. The Mother consoled everyone and again got into the van. She remarked,

Amma: It is really strange to see people behave in this way. They would rather give their children to the God of Death than give them to *sannyasa*. What a pity! *Kali Yuga* at its peak. What else is there to say!”

En route was another program at another devotee's house. This was not on the main road, so the van had to deviate and drive a few kilometers through the back roads. At nine o'clock the Mother's party reached the house which was in a village. The *brahmacharins* were supposed to conduct *bhajans*; therefore, the Holy Mother remained in the van. Gayatri and a few householder devotees stayed with her. The devotee in whose house the *bhajan* was being conducted somehow learned that the Mother was in the van, so he rushed over and prayed to her to come and sanctify his house by her presence. Unable to disregard the devotee's prayer, the Mother entered the house, where he received her with proper respect and led her to the shrine room. A priest was performing the *puja*, and the Mother sat, simply gazing at the worship that he did.

The time was approaching eleven o'clock as we finished having supper after the *bhajan*. Upon leaving the house, we saw a monk giving a speech in the front yard. As his talk was nearing its conclusion, it revealed that he followed the path of knowledge.

One devotee said to the Mother, "It seems that the swami did not have much esteem for the path of devotion."

The Mother answered, "No, no, do not think this. These are the things that he said." And thus the Mother started repeating all the things the swami

spoke about, in the same order, from the very beginning. The devotee who had listened keenly to the swami's speech was struck with wonder. Neither he nor the others saw the Mother listening to the swami's speech at any time while they were there. To them it appeared that she was intent on watching the *puja*.

It was midnight when the Mother and the group reached Vallickavu. As soon as she alighted from the van, she loudly said, "Shiva...there is no water anywhere here." Nobody could figure out why she said this and everybody was curious. One *brahmacharin* could not contain his curiosity and asked her, "Mother, why do you say that? How do you know that? We have not reached the Ashram yet." The Mother simply smiled and said, "Nothing. Crazy, what else?"

But everyone realized the meaning of what she had said when they reached the Ashram. Each one went up to the water taps to wash their faces and feet, but there was not even a drop of water. Neither was there any water in the holding tank. For the last two days there had been no electricity either. Some wax candles were lit so that everyone could manage to get to their rooms and go to bed. By twelve-thirty the Mother also went to her room.

18 March 1984

The Holy Mother came to the steps near the front

verandah of her room in the morning at seven-thirty. Her curly black hair was loose, cascading down her back, reminding one of Kali, the Divine Mother. Some residents and householder devotees were standing on the steps. The discussion was about having women aspirants in the Ashram. Some did not favor the idea.

Amma: To avoid the possible obstacles in *sadhana* it is said that men and women aspirants should not be put in the same Ashram. There is no problem if there are girls endowed with *vairagya*. Even then, one should constantly be alert about this. Since the attraction between men and women is natural, pitfalls will occur if one is not very careful. Women aspirants need manliness. Previously, Mother did not like being a woman. She used to ask the neighbors, “When am I going to become a man?” Anyhow, as far as the Ashram is concerned, Mother is here to take care. Therefore, there is nothing to worry about.

While the conversation was going on, the Mother’s brother, Suresh, came and began cutting her fingernails. Her nails had grown very long. She did not care about such things. The Mother was not concerned in the least about her body. Sometimes Gayatri had to remind her about things like taking a shower, having her food and something to drink at the right time, going to bed, etc. The Mother was very careless about these personal matters, especially food and sleep. She had very little of either. As Suresh continued to care-

fully cut her nails, the Mother said,

Amma: *Mahatmas* will make rules for others. But they themselves do not abide by them. They are beyond all rules and regulations. Nothing binds them.

One devotee: While on the street, sometimes I feel like chanting the Divine Name aloud.

Amma: There should not be any shyness, shame or false modesty to chant the Divine Name. Call aloud the moment you feel like doing so. Do not suppress it. Let your heart break open and flow towards Him without any hindrance. Such spontaneous calls will certainly help to open the heart.

The Mother looked up and saw some children carrying bricks for the Ashram. Shivan, son of the Mother's elder sister Kasturi, was among them. The Mother raised her voice and said to them, "Shivan...carry the bricks chanting Aum...Aum...Aum." She then started talking about how to bring up young children.

Amma: If children are given proper training when they are very young, they will not err. Parents should take a personal interest for this to happen. Many children err just because of the careless upbringing by their parents. Love without discipline is not real love; it is mere attachment. Too much attachment, which is usually the case with parents for their children, espe-

cially in mothers, will spoil the child. Parents should try hard to build good character in their children. To make this possible, they themselves should have a certain amount of purity in their own character. They should set an example. A father who is a chain-smoker cannot advise his son not to smoke. By smoking himself, he actually encourages his son to do so. A father who always gets angry with the mother cannot ask his son not to get angry with his wife. A mother who always craves to see movies cannot advise her daughter not to go to movies. Parents have a great influence on their children. If the parents are morally good, their children will be also, and the reverse is true as well.

Suppose two boys walk down the street. One person may point out the boys to his friend and say, "Look at those children. I have never seen such arrogant and bad children before in my life." Then his friend might comment, "Oh, that is no wonder. Their parents are 'so and so,' aren't they? What else can we expect from the children of those people." We can also hear the opposite comments about some other boys or girls, "It is no wonder that they are so good. Their parents are so pure in character. Undoubtedly their children will be the same."

Therefore, parents should be very careful when they deal with their children. Don't give whatever they ask. They have no discrimination. If you do not use your discrimination when you fulfill their wishes, you are leading them to destruction. When you nourish their body, don't forget to nourish their minds by dis-

ciplining them properly. Give some physical work to your children as well. Let them sweat and toil a little every day. Otherwise, they will become lazy and good-for-nothing. Give them a chance to know the value of work.

Gayatri brought a glass of tea for the Mother. She waited with it in her hands as she stood behind the Mother. One householder devotee softly said, "Mother, tea. Please drink it before it turns cold." The Mother took the tea from Gayatri's hands and had just one sip and said, "That's enough." "Mother, you hardly drank it," said the devotee. "Yes, that is enough," answered the Mother. Then she continued,

Amma: People who are running an orphanage came to see Mother at Kanyashrama. They told Mother that they have more than four hundred children there. They educate and train them to do some work or other. The children can stay and continue on if they wish. Some lead a married life after leaving the orphanage. Mother asked those who run it to also teach *Vedanta* or give them some spiritual instruction every day to help them grow internally as well. This will help them to discriminate between the eternal and non-eternal. Through this, perhaps those who are orphans will not create orphan children again. They will not live like dogs. Dogs eat, drink, and procreate; they also bring up their young ones. What difference is

there if this is the same case with human beings? This is not life. This is death or equal to death. Human beings are meant to discriminate; therefore, try to live the way a human being should, not like an animal.

Human beings are supposed to be highly evolved. Even animals have discipline in their lives. A lion will never eat grass. A deer or an elephant will not eat meat. They do not change their instinctual routine, but human beings will do anything indiscriminately. We misuse our freedom of choice. If we do not live up to our intended purpose of spiritual evolution and act accordingly but instead act in an undisciplined and immature way, we are undoubtedly worse than animals. If we continue to act in an undisciplined way, it will only help pave the way for our destruction.

THE WORLD CAME OUT OF WORD

19 March 1984

Early in the morning Brahmacharin Unnikrishnan was performing the daily worship in the temple, chanting the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother. A few other *brahmacharins* were also chanting along with him, making the sound very pleasant to the ears and to the heart.

Two year old Shivan, Kasturi's son, was walking around carrying a photograph of Mother Kali, which belonged to a *brahmacharin*. He had a big smile on his face. At this time the Mother came out. She was

pleased to see the child carrying the picture. She told Shivan, "Son, set the photo down and prostrate in front of it." The boy immediately did so. "Son, now pray to Devi, 'Devi, please make me a *sannyasin*,'" instructed the Mother. Shivan repeated the sentence and everybody laughed. The Mother turned to the *brahmacharins* and said,

Amma: Look at this boy. See the obedience he has. He did just what Mother instructed. This is the kind of obedience and faith that an aspirant should have.

Shivan wanted a swing. He expressed his wish to the Mother in his own childlike way. He knew whom to approach. The Mother instructed one of the residents to make one for him. The Holy Mother again conversed with Shivan, "Son, you should chant 'Amme Narayana' while swinging, okay? You should also meditate sitting on the swing, agreed?" Shivan nods his head in agreement. At this time a *brahmacharin* came and whispered something.

Amma: Children, you should be very careful when you utter each word. It was from Word that the world came into being. The world exists on Word. You should talk very carefully. In the beginning there was total silence, the silence before creation, the silence of peace. In that state the cosmic mind was totally in an absorbed state. Then the Word, the first Word, broke the silence. Thus the world emerged. This creation

takes place in each one of us. Each mind is a small world. We have created a world of thoughts. Thoughts become desires, and desires, in turn, keep the cycle going. Therefore, be careful when you utter a word. We go on creating many more worlds through the utterance of words.

A householder's word is like sand; whereas, a *brahmacharin's* word has glue in it. *Brahmacharins* should speak very carefully.

Now the Mother sat down and started cleaning her teeth using burnt paddy husk mixed with salt and ground pepper.

Amma: Burnt paddy husk mixed with salt and ground pepper is very good for the teeth. Toothpaste and other things came later. In the olden days people used natural things. In those days people lived in harmony with nature and this gave them healthy minds and bodies. But now everything is artificial. People have stopped cooperating with nature and have stopped living in tune with nature. Therefore, nature has stopped cooperating with human beings. They have polluted nature, so nothing is natural anymore. Everything is poisonous and full of chemicals.

In the month of April the Mother had a plan to visit Kanya Kumari (Cape Comorin) with the devotees. One woman devotee agreed to meet all the expenses. The Mother rinsed her mouth and expressed

this about the possible forthcoming trip:

Amma: Ours is not a picnic. It is a spiritual trip. No one should speak unnecessarily. Do not try to find fault with each other during the trip. No gossip. No chit-chat. If householder children are coming, they should observe the routine of the *brahmacharins*. *Japa*, *dhyana*, *bhajans*, spiritual discussions, etc., should be done punctually. Everybody should participate in all this without fail. This trip, if it happens, is not to waste our energy by talking, sight-seeing and shopping. It is to acquire more energy. Remember, this travel with Mother is to stop the never-ending travel of our minds. Mother does not make these trips for idle reasons.

One *brahmacharin* had difficulty in accepting the theory of an *Avatar*, that God will descend to the earth assuming a human form to uplift righteousness, justice and truth. He asked the Mother about this.

Amma: Son, do you believe in the omnipotent, omniscient and omnipresent nature of God?

Brahmacharin: Yes, certainly I do.

Amma: If so, why have doubts in His creative nature? Such a God endowed with all those qualities is capable of doing anything if He wills and wishes. An ordinary human being endowed only with a limited body, mind and intellect cannot understand anything without the use of names and forms, let alone understand anything about God without form. In order to

make human beings experience Godly qualities, God the Formless assumes a form. Godly attributes by themselves have no form, color or taste. If He remains without a form, who is going to understand Him? Who is going to draw inspiration from Him? He will remain as something impossible and fabricated. The scriptures and the statements made therein will be a far cry from any human understanding. In order to make all this concrete, God comes in a human form to serve, to love and to set an example for the world. A human form is needed; therefore, He assumes a name and a form as per the need of the age.

God is omniscient. So, why do you doubt that He can take a form and descend to earth to serve the human race and restore peace and righteousness? God is formless, but he can assume any form at any time as He wishes. It is to enact His *leela* as a human being that God takes a form. He will behave exactly like human beings, but within, He will never forget His real nature.

Sri Rama was the Incarnation of Lord Narayana; nevertheless, didn't He shed tears when Sita was kidnapped by Ravana, the demon king? Sri Krishna was killed by an arrow shot by an ordinary hunter, wasn't He? What about Jesus Christ? Wasn't He tortured and didn't He suffer like an ordinary human being? They were all *Avatars*, yet when they were in human form, they wanted to experience everything that a mortal human being experienced. That is their greatness, to choose to suffer like a mortal even though they are fully aware of their

Godhood. That is the greatest, most wonderful renunciation that a *Mahatma* will do. He takes and accepts the suffering by his own will for the good of others.

In addition, you can see an obvious difference between a person who has attained Liberation through penance and a person who is born Divine, i.e., an Incarnation. An Incarnation takes thousands of people across the ocean of transmigration. He is like a huge ship which can carry thousands of passengers. A person who has attained Liberation through *sadhana* cannot do this.

An *Avatar* comes down with all the Godly powers, manifesting them on a very large scale. He will be aware of His Godly nature from the very moment of birth. Even if He does perform *sadhana*, it will only be to set an example for others. He will have infinite power and inexhaustible energy. Whereas, one who works to attain Self-Realization through *sadhana* will slowly evolve to that state. The difference is like one who is born and reared in Bombay, a native, and one who migrates there.

Brahmacharin: (With joy) Now it is clear. Now I understand that Mother is an *Avatar*.

Amma: (Laughing and rejoicing) No, no...your Mother is not an *Avatar* but a good-for-nothing crazy girl.

Brahmacharin: Yes, yes...your *leela* as a human being is really wonderful. Now, you cannot refute this. (Softly, as if in secret, he asks the Mother) Mother, please tell me, aren't you an *Avatar*? Don't play any

more tricks. (Now the Mother really bursts into laughter, seeing the innocence of the *brahmacharin*.)

At this time a pigeon came flying seemingly from out of nowhere and sat near the Mother. She took some puffed rice in her hand, and the bird pecked the rice right from her palm. Like an innocent child, she looked at the bird and suddenly started shouting, "Anandoham, anandoham, anandoham." (Blissful am I, Blissful am I...) She entered into the state of *samadhi* as she sat with the puffed rice in her out-stretched right hand. All of a sudden the pigeon, as if it did not want to disturb the Mother, stopped pecking and stood silently. The pigeon turned his head from side to side and kept looking at the Mother's face. But it neither moved from the place where it was standing nor did it take another peck of puffed rice with its beak.

Minutes passed. The Mother slowly came down from her interior heights. A few more minutes passed, and she seemed to be completely back in her normal mood. The Mother still kept her right hand with the puffed rice stretched out. To everybody's amazement the pigeon once again started pecking at the remainder of the rice. When it finished, the Mother closed her palm and withdrew it with the words, "That's all. Now you go." Immediately the bird flew away. The *brahmacharins* who were present were struck with awe and wonder. One *brahmacharin* commented, "This bird must have been a *sadhak* or a devotee of the Holy Mother in its previous birth." Turning to the Mother, he asked, "Amma, am I correct?"

The Mother smiled and said, “Who knows? Maybe.” After a short pause she continued, “There are *avadhuts* and *tapasvis* who can take any form they want. It could be one of them who came to see all of us together.”

Another *brahmacharin* retorted, “Amma, if it was to see all of us the bird would have come to each one of us. (All laugh.) But it did not move an inch from your side. Not only that, it did not show even a little bit of acquaintance to any one of us except you. (More laughter.) That means you knew each other. We poor creatures were left out. Therefore, it came to see you, Amma, not us.”

24 March 1984

Today some people from the east of Kerala came to see the Holy Mother and visit the Ashram for the first time. They were very inquisitive about the Ashram and the Mother. Because they were sincere and had no preconceived ideas, the Mother was also very enthusiastic in replying to their queries.

Question: Mother, we are very interested in learning about the Ashram. Different people say different things. While we were coming here, we heard some people at the junction in Vallickavu talking against the Ashram. It seems that they are not believers.

Amma: Children, most of them have belief in God. They go to temples and worship. Once a month they conduct the reading of the *Bhagavata* and the

Ramayana in their homes. But those children do not know what an Ashram is, nor do they understand *sannyasa*. They do not know anything about the inner principles of religion and spirituality. What they have are misunderstandings and misconceptions. (At this time some young men also came and took their seats.) Therefore, Mother does not blame them. The villagers say that there must be some fraud with so many foreigners coming to the Ashram. They wonder how all these people could come without any publicity given out by the Ashram. (Smilingly) Mother would say that it is God who is the thief. He is responsible for this fraudulence. It is that Fellow who does all this. Their question is how have we attracted people by ways other than the kind of publicity which uses paper and ink made by human beings. They only know about things which their intellect can perceive and understand. They do not know anything about the plane beyond the human intellect, nor do they want to put any effort into acquiring any knowledge about it. They use an easy method to avoid ideas about spirituality by criticizing and rejecting such ideas without finding out more about them. They cannot think of anything beyond this physical world. All their knowledge ends in their limited perception. They cannot be blamed because human nature is such.

ASHRAM, A PLACE FOR TYAGIS (RENUNCIATES)

The Holy Mother continued,

Amma: They say that it is a place of pleasure seekers. Let them come and see. Then they will understand that this is a place for *tyagis*, not *bhogis*.

These children from the West, you know how filled with pleasure were their lives there. But once they come here and surrender, they give up all their old habits and ways. They are happy and satisfied with rice gruel for food and the thatched coconut leaf huts for sleeping. Just like the other residents, they also sleep on the floor. They sincerely do their *sadhana* and are fully content. In fact theirs is real renunciation because they had everything, all material pleasures and comforts. They lived in the midst of it. If they want they can go back and enjoy it. Mother never insists that anyone follow this path. Even then, they have renounced all the pleasure-giving objects and choose to live such a hard life. You may not watch T.V. since you do not have one. Real renunciation is when you refrain from watching it when you have one.

There were times when there was nothing in the Ashram. Mother is very particular that nothing should be asked for or sought. Yet no difficulty has ever arisen so far. Mother has no doubt that everything is done by God. If you have to starve to death, that is also His Will. This is what Mother tries to teach these

children here. Mother wants to set an example for the children here. Mother will not go to catch the feet of rich people. Today if Mother does not set an example, tomorrow the children here will go after rich people. Mother will bow down in front of good character, but she will not bow down in front of riches.

There are five or six *saippu makkal* (foreign children) who have come here. All of them are very wealthy, but Mother does not want their money. Mother tells them, "Deposit all your money in your own name." Do you know why? Because if they bring it here it is possible for a little selfishness to arise in their minds, that it is their money being spent. That should not be allowed to happen. The children here have asked how we will live. Mother tells them that God will take care of everything. Yes, He takes care of everything now and He will certainly do so in the future. Even if there are a hundred children here, they should live together like one family. Love and respect for each other should be the guiding factor. That is what Mother wants. Nobody should be troubled here. People will come from the outside. A share of what we have will be given to them as well. We do not see them as different. If there is nothing, we will live eating leaves. That too is beneficial. Some leaves contain a lot of vitamins. Leaves which we do not use here are used in other places, aren't they?

If there comes a situation where we have to live by eating leaves, the children who live here will be ready to do so as well. This is a place for *tyagis*. Children, only *tyagis* will be blissful. Therefore, this place is not

fit for pleasure-seekers. Here there may not be enough salt, sour pickles or chillies for the food; but it cannot be otherwise. Until now they all lived eating tasty food. From now on let them live renouncing taste. This renunciation of taste will help them to acquire the Supreme Taste, the taste of the *Atman*.

Children, the people who criticize the Ashram cannot be any other way because that is their nature. The frogs croak and the crickets chirp at night. Nobody is kept awake at night saying, "I can't sleep due to this noise." That is the nature of those creatures. They are like that; they cannot be any different. In the same way, those people who criticize the Ashram cannot be contrary to their nature. Just ignore their words and pray for their souls.

Question: Amma, when we see the suffering of the world, sometimes we think that God is very cruel.

Amma: That is what everybody says. Our suffering is created by our own actions. The sole responsibility is ours. God is in no way responsible for it. It just takes a little bit of discrimination to understand this. Suppose you get angry with your wife and slap her. Afterwards you become mentally restless. You feel very sad for beating your wife; thus you suffer. From where did the anger come? It came from you, didn't it? Why did you get angry? Because she did not bring the coffee on time. Your desire to drink coffee at your accustomed time was obstructed; therefore, you got angry. The whole incident occurs only because of your attachment to coffee. The desire was not fulfilled at the right

time. You lost your discrimination, your mental balance, and thus you slapped your wife. If we observe matters in this way, we can find that all our problems and sufferings are created by our own lack of discrimination and loss of mental control.

Children, God is not cruel. He is compassionate. Is there anybody who really calls on God? There is no one who says, "O Lord, I want only You." But we say, "O God, give me this, give me that." This is how we pray. We only want our desires fulfilled. We do not pray for Him to come and dwell in our hearts. We meditate and remember the things that we need to get; we do not remember God. Then we will complain, "I have been calling on God for the last sixty years. He hasn't turned to look at me even once." If only this was said after having once remembered Him for at least one minute, then there would be meaning in the complaint. Mother will put in writing that God will not give sorrow. God gives prosperity, wealth, beauty, vitality and love; He will not give sorrow. Do not ever say that He gives sorrow.

If someone prays to God with devotion for devotion's sake, he will not suffer. Mother can guarantee this. If the contrary happens, Mother is ready to prove that such a person will not suffer at all but will always be blissful. Mother makes this statement not out of ego but from her experience.

We do not call on God. We make suggestions and tell Him what things we want. "Give it to me. If You don't, I will not make this offering to You." Ours are

not prayers but suggestions, demands or warnings. Try and truly call Him for at least five minutes a day. Then you will come to know that He does not give sorrow.

Children, sorrow occurs only when there is desire. Even before creation He had said, “You will always be blissful if you go through this way. Sorrow is the result if you go through the other path.” Children, having disobeyed those words you went and fell into the ditch, and now you say that you were pushed into it. God had told us about both ways. It is up to us to choose. If you want eternal and everlasting bliss, the path to God is available, but you have to work hard. If you are only interested in achieving momentary happiness, then the path to the world is open to you. This too needs effort but not as much as what is needed to attain God. To become king, one should be a repository of good qualities and talents. Similarly, to become His dear one and the king of the whole universe, one should have inner purity, and this takes constant striving. But to become a mere enjoyer of the items created and owned by Him, only little effort is needed.

Question: Why are there two paths? It was enough to have the path of happiness only, wasn't it? Why did God introduce the path of sorrow?

Amma: What? Do you mean that happiness alone is enough and there is no need for sorrow? There is everything in creation. Even a small needle and a blade of grass has its own purpose. Nothing is a waste in

creation. Keenly observe. It is sorrow which helps our growth. Human beings will not work and move forward if there is no sorrow. Fear of suffering and sorrow makes one work. If there were only happiness, people would not have feared anything, and this would have culminated in laziness and over-indulgence. Laziness and over-indulgence will only cause utter ruin.

It is your mind which creates sorrow, not God. There must be everything in creation, both good and bad. Having one without the other is not creation. To act understanding the place and importance of each and every object is our duty. Everything has its own place in life. Just give things their proper place, their proper due, neither more nor less, then everything will be all right.

Even if God had created a world of only goodness, human beings would have turned it into a hell through over-indulgence. Not only that, to understand and realize the greatness and beauty of goodness, the bad also is necessary, isn't it? Without anything to compare with, how can one know any particular thing? To understand and appreciate beauty, we must be able to recognize ugliness.

God has clearly given us instructions as to what is the path of bliss and what is the path of sorrow. Can't we abstain from vices, listening to His instructions?

Children, it is just like asking why God created fire which is dangerous. It was not to burn houses and kill people that God created fire. It was to cook food and

use it for other beneficial matters that He created it. If we use it to harm others, is it God who should be blamed? It is we who created the bad and turned it into a hell.

There is a child and there is fire. A child can be burned by the fire. But God has given the child a mother who warns the child about the dangers of playing with fire. We cannot say that since there are many children in this world, there should not be any fire in this world. How would we cook our food? Nor can we say that there should not be any electricity in the house because it might give someone a shock. Without electricity how would we run the machines and industries? No father or mother would say, "We have a little baby, so we should not have fire in our house." If there is a fire, the God-given mother or father will take care of the child. When the child grows up he will become discriminating enough to know that fire is dangerous and will handle it carefully. Even after he is grown up, if he knowingly jumps into the fire, is it God's fault? God did not create it for him to jump into and burn himself. Since He created fire for cooking and for doing other useful things, fire in itself is not meant to be used in a harmful way. Not the thing itself but the way it is used is important. A thing in itself is not dangerous, but the way it is used can make it dangerous. Your mother has told you several times that fire is dangerous and warned you not to go near it. But if you disobey, whose fault is it?

That is why it is said that religious texts should be

taught even at a very young age and that a Guru is necessary to guide us on the path. Today people do not want this at all. They think that they know everything. Nobody wants a Guru, nor does anybody want to be a disciple. As a result we are in sorrow.

What we breathe is “*soham*” (I am). Have we truly heard it and realized it, even once? How nice it would be if we really tried to hear it. The Lord is always telling us loudly, “You are That, you are That.” Try to hear this; be alert and attentive. That is what you are always singing, “I am That, I am That.” Try to listen to this. But nobody listens to the Lord! Strange!

Question: Why is it such that His voice cannot be heard?

Amma: It is not impossible to hear this. Children, if you sow, you reap; if you try, you get. The set rule is that one should try and hear it. If you simply sit on a chair and ask, “Why am I not hearing God’s voice,” without making even the least amount of effort to hear and know It, who can help you to hear that Sound?

A dog has no discrimination. We know that we should be careful when we walk in front of one. Having carelessly walked near a dog and having been bitten by it, we find fault with God.

Two of the visitors were good *bhajan* singers. The Holy Mother said to them, “Children, please sing some *bhajans*.” They sang *Matru vatsalya todenne...*

O Mother, even if you are here to protect me
With all the love and affection of a mother,

Even if I keep awake without blinking an eye,
Still there occur a number of thefts
In the home of the mind. Therefore,
O Mother, I get worried.

O Mother, the Destroyer of all afflictions,
Even though I daily make vow after vow
To continue my prayers constantly
Without any break,
O Mother, I know that it is only Your trick
If I happen to forget.

They sang the song with full devotion and love.
The Mother sat in a totally absorbed state. They continued to sing. The next bhajan was *Pirayentu chaitu...*

O Mother, what error have I committed?
What error has Thy poor child committed?

I do not long for many things
But only for the good fortune of Thy Vision.
Why didst Thou, O Goddess and
Mother of the World,
Create obstacles even for that?

O Mother,
This unfortunate one has come seeking refuge,
This helpless, unfortunate son.
O Mother, Loving Mother,
Show compassion and save me.

My refuge, my refuge is Thy Holy Feet,

Other than Thee, refuge there is none.
Enable me to bow at Thy Lotus Feet
Bless this suppliant, O Compassionate One.

Silence prevailed for some time when the singing was over. The Mother slowly opened her eyes. In front of the Mother sat a girl who was studying for her Master's degree in philosophy. Looking at her the Mother said,

Amma: Daughter, there is a billboard advertising a jewelry shop by the road side. You will not get gold if you ask the billboard. You have to go to the shop. You won't reach the goal if you learn philosophy. *Sadhana* also is needed simultaneously. Without *sadhana*, you will start walking around saying, "I am Brahman."

Balu-mon (son Balu) has a Master's degree in philosophy. After he had been doing *sadhana* for a few years, Mother asked him to get a degree in philosophy. First *sadhana*, then philosophy. The *rishis* wrote only after experiencing. It was not the other way around. It was not mere intellectual exercise. Therefore, children, don't act or pretend as if you are *Brahman* after simply reading some books. It is not enough if we walk around talking about what the *rishis* have experienced. You should experience it for yourselves through *sadhana*. You will just go on babbling after reading books if you don't do any *sadhana*.

Mere philosophy will make your heart dry. *Bhakti* is needed. Mother never allowed these boys in the

Ashram to study the *Upanishads* in the beginning. Mother wanted them to cultivate and develop *bhakti* first. After some years of devotional practices, Mother permitted them to study the *Upanishads*.

Faith is needed. One is liberated if faith comes. Complete faith is Liberation. Only through Realization will doubts go completely. A Guru is needed for that.

The girl: Mother, I would like to stay here in Mother's presence for two or three days, but my parents will not agree.

Amma: Daughter, God will definitely favor pure and innocent wishes. God will certainly help you if you have a sincere desire. Two children, one was Brahmacharin Sreekumar's sister and the other a child of his uncle, used to pray every day, "O Mother, we want to stay with you for three days. Mother, won't you fulfill this desire of ours?" Thus the two children used to pray and cry, looking at Mother's picture everyday. None of the family members brought the children here, but they continued their prayers. One day Sreekumar's father for some reason came to the Ashram with these children. His actual plan was to return home immediately with the children. Contrary to his plan, he had to go to Quilon urgently. Before he left he entrusted Sreekumar to take them back home the same day. There was a heavy downpour that day when Sree-mon went to the ferry with these children. There was no boat to cross the river; therefore, they came back to the Ashram. Although it was not the rainy season, it rained the whole day so they could not

leave. They were going to go the next day, but again it became impossible since there was a strike all over the state. Because the children were not seen for two days, relatives from their house came to fetch them on the third day. They all left on the following day, but only after staying for that evening's *Devi Bhava Darshan*. Thus those children stayed with Mother three days as they had prayed.

One day during their stay here, Mother was lying down with eyes closed as if she were sleeping. At that time she heard one of them telling the other, "Hey, Mother will hear what we pray to Her. She has heard what we have prayed sitting in our house. Yesterday Mother made it rain and today the strike." These are all proofs to show that God will hear the call of children endowed with dedication and innocence. Innocent prayers will be answered. If children say something, nature will catch it immediately and it will be fulfilled. That state should come for us also.

When a person is in the state of *jivanmukti*, he is unattached just as little children are. He might ask for something and then abandon it in no time. A *jivanmukta* will show love to all objects, but there will be no attachment to anything. He might be lying on a mattress at one moment and the next moment lying in dirty water. He may be living in a big house but will smile with full heart and accept it if he has to live in a thick forest the very next moment. In that state of *jivanmukti*, one's love for things is only apparent. When such a person expresses a desire, in reality it is giving an opportunity for others to serve him.

This state should come. Children have this state to a certain extent. That is why we feel an attraction to children and feel fascinated by their smiles and sportings. There is no *maya* in them; they are innocent and for that reason they have the power to attract. The difference between a Self-Realized Soul and a child is that a Self-Realized Soul has no trace of any *vasanas* in him. He has eliminated all *vasanas* through severe penance. In a child *vasanas* are there in the dormant state. They will slowly manifest as the child grows up. The attraction that we feel for him will also fade away as he gets older.

GURU

Question: Mother, who is a Guru? Who is a disciple?

The Mother remained silent as if she did not hear the question. Who knows why? A devotee interfered by saying,

Devotee: The answer to your question is very clear right here in Amma's presence. Amma talks and we all listen carefully. Even great scholars come to hear what she says. If one of us sits and talks, not even a child will come to listen. One who has known the Self and one who is capable of removing the ignorance of others is a Guru. One who listens with faith, sitting near the Guru, and one who surrenders completely to him in order to be disciplined is a disciple. This is the em-

pirical plane. This is not the plane where one experiences *sarvam brahmamaya*m (everything is the Absolute). There is no Guru and no disciple once you reach there. Guru and disciple exist before you reach the goal. Isn't the attitude to think in this way, "Who is the Guru and who is the disciple," derived from someone?

The Holy Mother now spoke.

Amma: A real Guru is one who is endowed with all the Divine qualities, such as equal vision, universal love, renunciation, compassion, patience, forbearance, and endurance. He will have complete control over his mind. He will be like a huge ship which can carry thousands of passengers. His mere presence will give a feeling of protection and safety, an assurance to the disciple that he will reach the goal. Like the moon his presence will be cooling, soothing and heart-capturing, but at the same time it will also be brilliant, radiant and shining like the sun. He will be soft like a flower and hard like a diamond in his manner towards the disciple. He will be simpler than the simplest and humbler than the humblest. Even his silence will be a teaching. A real disciple is one who can imbibe the life and teachings of such a Guru and follow his footsteps faithfully. Knowing and understanding the real nature of such a Great Master, a true disciple's heart will spontaneously surrender and willingly let him discipline him.

It is not possible to proceed very far on the spiritual path without a Guru. A guide is necessary to travel in an undiscovered country. A *sadhak*, through his penances, may succeed in getting rid of his gross *vasanas* without the help of a Perfect Master, but a *Satguru*'s help and Grace are a must in order to eliminate the subtle *vasanas* and to give up his individuality. There is a son who comes here. One day he openly told one of the *brahmacharins* that he had been doing spiritual practices for the last thirty-five years but never had a deep experience. He also said that he knows his problem which he stated was nothing but the hesitancy to come under the discipline of a *Satguru*. His subtle *vasanas* still remained even after thirty-five years of severe penance. He is a very sincere and hard-working son, yet no real experience occurred. This is what happens to people who cannot surrender. Once you come under a Perfect Master, then you simply obey his words and do *sadhana* without fail. If your surrender is complete and if you are determined to attain the goal, he will work with your ego, both the gross and subtle, and will take you across the ocean of transmigration. The subtle ego is very hard to break through with only your own efforts. The *Satguru*'s guidance will slowly bring it out and exhaust it. A Perfect Master always works with the ego of the disciple. But he will not start until the disciple is ready for it.

Mother does not want to insist that anyone do this. If it is the Lord's will that someone should be

here, let it be so. If it is to be that one should be somewhere else, let that be so. *Sadhana* will become smoother and easier if a *Satguru* is present.

THE MIND SHOULD BE MADE KASHAYA (SAFFRON)

Na-karmanâ-na-prajayâ-dhanêna |
Tyâgênaikê-amritatvam-ânasuh ||

“Neither through action nor progeny or wealth
But through renunciation alone one attains immortality.”

(KAIVALYA UPANISHAD)

Question: Do you initiate people into *sannyasa* and give them the saffron-colored cloth to wear?

Amma: *Sannyasa*! How easily one can utter that name! But have you ever thought of the deep significance of that word? It contains the whole of spirituality. Nobody can give renunciation. It is a state that should be attained or realized. It is also a state which spontaneously flows into you. It is a state where one becomes completely natural and spontaneous. One simply flows like the river, blows like the wind and shines like the sun. It is both that which should be attained and that which should be received. To attain

something, self-effort is necessary. To receive means that somebody gives it. Therefore, the state of *sannyasa* is both something that should be attained through self-effort and something that will be spontaneously and simultaneously given by the Guru (Grace).

The sole purpose of spiritual life is to renounce all that is not ours and to become what we really are. Real *sannyasa* is the renunciation of all desires and desire-prompted actions. In fact, it is the mind that should be made *kashaya* (saffron). *Sannyasa* is purely subjective, not objective. It is a state of the mind where one becomes completely peaceful and calm in all circumstances. In that state of renunciation, that which fills within will be expressed outwardly also.

Wearing ochre clothes externally has significance. It will help one to remember that Supreme State. It is a good reminder to make our body and mind always alert and vigilant. One who has donned *kashaya* will hesitate a little to commit any mistakes. It makes one remember about one's goal. The real *kashaya* has the color of fire. It indicates the destruction of body-consciousness and the awakening into God-consciousness. The body is burnt in the Fire of Knowledge; this is the meaning. Therefore, a *sannyasin* is supposed to be an embodiment of Pure Knowledge. He becomes the personification of all great qualities. He should maintain that in word and deed, in each and every action that he does. This will become spontaneous for one who has attained that state. For others it is a prac-

tice. They must make a deliberate and sincere attempt to move and act in this world in accordance with those principles until it becomes natural.

The great saints and sages of the past and others who followed in their footsteps did not give much importance to the dress and the name of *sannyasa*. They were the ones who made their minds *kashaya*. The most important thing is to know That (*Brahman*) through penance, not walking around in ochre clothes giving speeches after having studied the scriptures. If you do not adhere to the principles which you are teaching, it might result in other people wrongly evaluating spirituality and spiritual masters. Gurus and sages have said, “*Tapah, tapah*” (penance). It is only after experiencing it that they then said, “*Soham*,” (I am That). They did not say this before the experience. How many years they did *tapas*! (Jokingly) And we, after going through only the ABC’s declare, “No *sadhana*. Nothing is needed. I am That.” We have renounced all those great examples set by our forefathers and now act as we like. What a great renunciation! (Laughter)

The next step is questioning, who is the Guru, who is the disciple, and so on and so forth. (More laughter) The *rishis*, living in an elevated realm, were not conscious of their physical body even when someone had severely beaten them and hacked their hands off. When they did become aware of their external condition, they returned only love and compassion to those who tortured them. Such was their establishment in

that Reality. Whereas, if someone just looks at us in the wrong way we will ask with hostility, “Hey, fellow, why did you look at me like that?” The *Brahmanishtatvam* (the state of being established in *Brahman*) is gone. The *Brahman* disappears. Such people say that they are *Brahman*. And they question who is the Guru! Such a wonder! (The Mother laughs loudly.)

The young man who had asked the question “who is the Guru and who is the disciple” sat stunned. The Mother continued,

Amma: Mother doesn’t want to make such statements about initiating people into *sannyasa* and declare that she will be giving the name and ochre clothes to such and such people in the future. Let them struggle and let me see how many will come out victorious, and then if it happens, let it happen, well and fine. Mother does not want to make declarations.

The Ashram is a very good battlefield. Whoever comes to this field must fight. Some will be injured and hurt; some will withdraw and run away. Mother is waiting to see how many will emerge victorious.

Question: Mother, what is needed in this age?

Amma: Undoubtedly, self-discipline. Each one of us must become aware of the urgency for it. It is not simply a need but an urgent necessity which must be practiced by every individual of the country. We go on polishing and beautifying the body and the world outside while the mind remains a mess. Do all this polish-

ing and beautifying inside. Stop becoming tense about the external situations. Once the inside of a person is clean, then the outside automatically becomes all right. Stop giving too much importance to external objects.

All problems, both national and international, are due to lack of discipline.

Look at the *brahmins* (priestly caste) of the past. From childhood they contemplated on God. They had no bad company. It was a joint family system in those days. Everyone lived together. They worked in temples. They lived their life learning, understanding and realizing the essential principles. Their children were also full of vitality and radiance. No one could trick them or make them yield to trivial things. However, no such thing can be expected in the coming ages. Nowadays, many children who study in schools and colleges are addicted to marijuana and other drugs. It is lack of self-discipline that makes these children a slave to such dangerous things. In whatever field of life and whoever it may be, what is needed is self-discipline.

(Turning to the girl who was studying for her degree in philosophy) Daughter, whenever you get an opportunity, talk about spiritual matters with your friends. At least one person's mind might change if ten people happen to hear. That person may also become spiritual and contemplate on God.

The Holy Mother now stopped. Since it was a few minutes after one o'clock, she called one *brahmacharin* and asked him to take everybody to have lunch. The Mother got up from her seat and the visitors followed suit. She smilingly looked at them and in a begging tone said, "Children, all of you please have your lunch before going. Don't go without eating."

After saying this, she walked out, saluting everyone. Some *brahmacharins* followed her to whom she said, "Mother wants to be alone for sometime."

She walked alone on the shore of the backwaters for a while with her hands held behind her back and then later went to her room by one-thirty.

31 March 1984

Today the Holy Mother and the residents of the Ashram went to Brahmacharin Sreekumar's house. Upon invitation, the Mother occasionally visited the homes of *brahmacharins* and devotees. Such occasions were celebrated like a festival by the family members. Sreekumar's house was crowded with people, both devotees and neighbors. The Mother went around to each person, consoling and saying a few words to each one.

Children always have a very strong attraction towards the Mother. Here too, all the children from both Sreekumar's house and the neighboring houses stood around the Mother and blocked her way. As soon as she saw all the children so happily gathered together around her, the Mother also hesitated to go to the

room. Sreekumar requested of the Mother, “Amma, the people are expecting the evening *bhajan* at six-thirty and it is now nearly six o’clock. Amma, will you please go to the room now and get ready?”

The Mother, like a small child, retorted, “No, I am not going. I am going to stay here with them. (Turning to the children) Yes, children?” Together in one voice, they said, “Yes, yes.”

The Mother asked the children to sing a *bhajan*. Takkali, the daughter of Sreekumar’s elder sister, led the song, *Amma, Amma Taye...*

O Mother, Mother, dear Divine Mother,
Goddess of the Universe,
Giver of food to all creatures.
Thou art the Primal Supreme Power.

Everything in the world happens
Because of Your Divine Play.

All the children responded to the lead singer. Soon the Mother was singing with them. It seemed that she was just another child playing, singing and dancing with the little ones. At one point one of them asked the Mother in a loud voice, “Amma, Amma, are you God?”

The Mother laughed aloud and looked at the child. It was a boy who was hardly five years old. The Mother embraced him and asked, “Who told you that Mother is God?” The boy, pointing to Takkali, an-

swered, "Sheeja chechi" (Elder sister Sheeja.)

The Mother kissed him on both cheeks and replied, "You children are Mother's God."

All the devotees were enjoying the whole scene. They stood around forgetting themselves. At this time Sreekumar's grandmother, who was nearly seventy-five years old, came forward. With her hands around the Mother's waist, she spoke to her in a very sweet voice, as if to a child, "Now, dear Amma, please come to the room. Take a shower and eat something, and then come back." The elderly woman patted and caressed the Mother and repeated, "Please, come."

The Mother smiled at her. The old woman looked like another child. She was very innocent. The Mother could not reject her request. She kissed her face and walked into the room with her. As the Mother went in, she turned around and told the children, "Children, don't go. Mother will be back soon. We shall play together."

A few minutes later the Mother came out ready for the evening *bhajan*. It was not the same playful Mother; she was in a different mood. All the children surrounded her once again, but the Mother went into the family shrine room straightaway without even looking at them.

These changing moods of the Mother were always a mystery for everyone, even to those who were in close physical proximity to her. This mystery becomes more of a mystery as we spend more and more time with her. A few minutes ago she had been laughing,

playing and singing with the children. She had also become a child and one could see such innocence in her. The Mother even promised the children that she would play with them when she returned. Had the old woman not come she would have gone on playing with the children. At the time she seemed so attached to the children, but now when they surrounded her, she did not even look at them. How easily she withdraws herself from a person or a thing is beyond our comprehension. Infinite are her moods.

The singing started at around seven o'clock. Gradually it ascended to its peak as the Mother poured forth devotion and inspiration through her soul-stirring songs. The atmosphere was saturated with very high devotional fervor. It reached its climax when the Mother sang *Kamesha Vamashi...*

Salutations to Shakti (Divine Energy)
The Great Goddess
Who is accessible through devotion.
Salutations to the All-Pervading One,
The One True Essence,
The Infinite and Perfect Awareness.

Protect us,
O Thou, who sits on the left thigh of Lord
Shiva,
Who fulfills all desires,
Who shines through all animate
And inanimate objects.
O my Kamala (Lotus), Ruler of all...

The devotees blissfully sang with overflowing devotion. Everyone seemed to be transported to the *Devi Loka* (the world of the Devi). The Mother went on inspiring them more and more towards absorption into the Self.

The Holy Mother lost all her external consciousness and sat still. Her left hand was half-bent with its palm unfolded completely. The fingers of her right hand formed a divine *mudra*. Ecstatic tears filled her eyes and rolled down her cheeks.

Balu took over the lead singing. Rao, Venu, Pai and Sreekumar sang along with him. The devotees all responded with utter love and devotion. They went on singing the same song for a long time until the Mother came back to the normal plane of consciousness.

The *bhajan* and the *arati* ended shortly after ninety-three. The Mother went to the eastern side of Sreekumar's house where it looked like a small *tapovanam* (a place well-suited to perform penance). She disappeared in the dark. Gayatri silently followed her. Sreekumar's father got worried but was reassured by the *brahmacharins*.

Silence prevailed everywhere. The darkness resembled Mahakali's flowing, dark, curly hair, thus creating an awesome atmosphere of reverence. Sacred are these nights for pure souls as they utilize them to fix their minds fully on the Supreme. The stars twinkled in the dark velvet sky. The devotees waited for the

Mother to come back so that they could have her *darshan* before they left. By ten o'clock, the Mother emerged out of the darkness, followed by Gayatri. The latter reported that the Mother had been lying down in the sand, gazing at the sky and laughing every now and then in a strange but unique way. She also uttered certain sounds which did not resemble any familiar language. Gayatri added that it seemed to her that the Mother was talking to someone very softly.

Hidden behind the veil of *maya* is her real nature, unapproachable and impenetrable by finite human beings. When the Mother soars high to that plane of Infinite Consciousness, we mortals, for whom it is a totally strange and unfamiliar world, can only gaze at her human form with awe and wonder, unable to understand even an infinitesimal fraction of that Supreme State.

Once a *brahmacharin* said to the Mother, "Mother, my only sorrow is that I am utterly unable to understand you and your moods. How and when will I be able to understand them?" Straightaway came the reply, "Only when you become me."

AT ELEVEN SHARP

The Mother gave *darshan* to everyone. When it was ten minutes before eleven o'clock, she got up from her seat all of a sudden and announced that she wanted to go to a certain devotee's house. She seemed to be in a hurry. Without another word, the Mother

walked out of the house. Everyone immediately followed her. It was very dark and the path which led to the road was extremely narrow. This did not bother her as she walked briskly and quickly to the van. Sreekumar's father ran behind her and with some effort managed to catch up with a flashlight in his hand. She entered the vehicle and asked the driver to start the motor. The puzzled driver asked, "Where to?" By that time, Gayatri, a few *brahmacharins* together with Sreekumar's father and mother had somehow managed to get into the van. The Mother replied to the driver, "To Son Madhavan Nair's house." Again the driver was in a dilemma, "I don't know who that is." Understanding where the Mother wanted to go, Sreekumar's father gave the directions to the driver, and they proceeded. The Mother seemed very restless. Though the house was not very far away, she went on urging, "Drive faster, drive faster." Everyone was surprised at the Mother showing such excitement and hurry.

In five minutes or so the van reached the front yard of the house. A man was waiting outside. Like one who has gone mad, he rushed towards the Mother, fell at her feet and cried like a little child. It was none other than Madhavan Nair. He went on exclaiming, "Compassion, compassion, what compassion, what compassion." Most affectionately, the Mother lifted him up, caressed and consoled him. The devotee together with his wife ceremoniously washed the Mother's feet and led her inside the house. As the Mother made her first step into the house, the clock struck eleven times. Madhavan Nair once again burst

into tears as if he was reminded of something. The Mother went to their *puja* room and performed a small *puja*.

The *brahmacharins* sang, *Arariyunnu nin maha vaibhavam...*

Who knows Thy greatness,
O Thou who art the substratum
Of this illusory world.
Thousands and thousands of living beings
Seek Thy divine, radiant smile...
Who knows Thy greatness
O Mother, who knows...

As the nature of life
As the vitality of life itself
As the one who delights
In expressing compassion,
Existing as unlimited love,
O Devi, who art the blissful nectar of life,
Who knows...

O Thou who art worshipped by *tapasvis*,
O Thou who destroys affliction,
O Thou whose mind is inclined
To bless the ascetics,
O Thou who art ever-young,
O Thou art the beauty of the mind,
Please come, O Devi, Please come.
Who knows...

The family members could not contain their emo-

tions. They all burst into tears, which in turn brought tears to everybody's eyes.

The events had unfolded like a divine drama. We were spectators watching it without understanding the real meaning of it. Actually, this is what had transpired:

Mr. Madhavan Nair was a devotee of the Holy Mother who was fortunate enough to be initiated by her. Twice before when the Mother had visited Sreekumar's house, he had prayed that she would come into his house as well and purify it. For some unknown reason his wish did not get fulfilled on either of those occasions. This time too, when Madhavan Nair had heard that the Mother was going to visit Sreekumar's house, he had expressed his wish to the Mother. She had agreed to come when she had the time. With great expectation and a heart full of joy, he re-arranged his *puja* room and waited the whole day for the Mother to come. "Nobody should eat today unless Mother comes," he had told his wife and children. The day passed. Night fell. He came out of the house, stood unmoving, waiting for the Mother. With a very determined voice he stated, "I will wait until eleven o'clock today. If she doesn't come..." He stopped and remained where he stood. The time slowly passed. The clock rang nine-thirty, ten, ten-thirty, ten-forty-five...At ten minutes to eleven, the devotee's heart flipped around like a fish out of water. "Won't the Mother come?" he asked himself. His longing became stronger and stronger. From the deepest corner of his heart came a whisper, "Yes, she will

come. My Mother will come.” At that very moment he saw the headlights of the vehicle. It came and stopped in front of his house. Madhavan Nair’s emotions broke their bounds; he rushed towards the Mother and fell at her feet, crying like a child and repeating out loud, “O Amma, what compassion, what compassion...” Then when she stepped into his house, it was exactly eleven o’clock sharp! That was what happened.

1 April 1984

On a very calm and quiet morning, the sun slowly rose from the eastern horizon. Brahmacharin Unnikrishnan was performing the *puja* to the *peetham* on which the Mother sat during *Devi Bhava*. The eighty year old “Acchamma,” Amma’s paternal grandmother, sat in front of the temple making garlands and flower petals needed for the evening’s *Devi Bhava*. The ringing of the bell from the temple mingled with the sound of the ocean waves, adding a special charm and sacredness to the silent atmosphere.

Breakfast was served at nine-thirty. It consisted of *kanji* with salt, nothing else, not even pickles. This was the usual morning food. About the food the Mother says,

Amma: Have it if you like. This is an Ashram, a place for *tyagis*, not for *bhogis*. If you want to eat good, delicious food, stay at home. Taste is good for the tongue, not for the heart. It will nourish the tongue and ruin

the heart. Mother does not insist. Follow this only if you want to attain the goal. Otherwise, you can do as you like. Those who do not have *vairagya* cannot live here at the Ashram.

THE VISITORS

The Special Branch Deputy Superintendent of Police from Quilon came to the Ashram to collect information about the *Vedanta Vidyalaya* run by the Ashram and about the foreigners who stayed here. He noted down whatever was necessary. Since he was empathetic towards the Mother's activities, he liked the peaceful Ashram atmosphere very much. He wanted to see the Holy Mother and therefore waited.

A group of ten *Siddha Veda* followers (a spiritual path established by Swami Sivananda Paramahansa, Guru of Swami Nityananda) came at noon. The group consisted of both men and women. They had attended a conference in a nearby town and had heard about the Mother at the conference venue and thus came to see her. They started cooking their own special food, a mixture of rice and green gram. Among them was a young man who walked around with an air of pride mixed with contempt.

Followed by the *Siddha Veda* people a large group of devotees from Tamil Nadu arrived. It was as if the entire Ashram premises were filled with people. There were only a few *brahmacharins* in the Ashram who had to run around to make arrangements to provide food for the devotees and to find a place to keep their lug-

gage safely.

By three o'clock the Holy Mother finally returned from Sreekumar's house with the *brahmacharins*. Her presence showered spiritual bliss all around. Waves of enthusiasm rippled everywhere. At the same time, as if inspired by an invisible power, everyone's movements were automatically controlled. It became impossible for anyone to behave otherwise. Her mere presence enlivened the whole atmosphere with a special vibration of peace and tranquility. It was so obvious and clear that all could experience it.

The Mother straightaway went to the hut and started giving *darshan* to the large crowd of people. As it was Sunday, there were more people than usual. At Sreekumar's house she had been surrounded by adults and children until the last moment. There was not even a sign of impatience on her face as she finally ended *darshan* there at one o'clock and then went to her room.

One of the Mother's spiritual children, Gangadharan (now known as Sarvatma), once remarked, "Jesus was crucified only once, but here the Mother crucifies her body every moment for the world. This self-crucifixion of the Mother can be understood only by another one like her."

The *Siddha Veda* people stood silently observing everything. They were not standing in the *darshan* line. All of a sudden, the Mother called one of the women who came with them and asked her,

Amma: Aren't you the wife of S...? What happened to your husband when he went to the office without wearing a shirt? (The followers of Siddha Veda never wear a shirt.) Didn't he meet with some trouble there? You are not on very good terms with your husband, are you? Mother knows that there are a lot of conflicts in your family life. Maybe these family problems are God's will to make both of you get closer to your Guru.

The lady was stunned to hear the Mother speaking about so many things concerning her family affairs. This was her first meeting with the Mother; she had never met her before. She became very emotional and started to cry.

Next the Mother called the young man who seemed very proud and looked at everything with contempt. The young man was surprised when the Mother suddenly made a sign for him to come closer. He turned around and looked towards the back, thinking that the Mother was calling somebody else who was standing behind him in the queue. The Mother then called out, "No, no, it is definitely you, son...come." The man, still unable to come out of that surprised mood, slowly moved towards the Mother.

She received him as she had with the others. He sat next to the Mother, facing her. Placing her left hand on his shoulder, the Mother with a smile on her face, gently said,

Amma: Son, what do you want to realize? *Iswara* (God) or *eecha* (housefly)? If it is God, then the ego should die. Do you know the nature of an *eecha*? It flies around, sits in decayed and rotten things, spreads all kinds of contagious diseases, and finally it dies getting stuck to jaggery syrup or molasses. In the same way, an egotistic person will ruin himself and ruins others as well.

Therefore, you decide whether to realize God or the ego. The ego is not an adornment to anyone, whether he is spiritual or worldly. It always looks ugly in the eyes of others. We ourselves should become aware of that ugliness. Then it becomes easy to remove it. Son, here, Mother has no differences. She accepts everyone equally. Whether it is a person who follows the path of *Siddha Veda* or something else, it is the same to Mother. The ego, in any case, is the worst enemy no matter which path one follows. That is the first thing that should be uprooted. Mother knows that you are trying for that, but become more aware of it and at least try not to express it externally.

You think that yours is the only right path while you look down on the other paths and their followers. Son, this external show is not what is needed. Try to acquire inner beauty, then the outside will automatically be beautified.

The young man was dumbfounded. He was truly humbled. Later he remarked, "Never before have I met a person who could read my mind so clearly and specifically. She could easily deflate my ego with the

same ease as pricking a balloon.”

The experience of these two people appeared to be quite convincing for the whole group of *Siddha Veda* people. Now they too joined with the other devotees who were lined up to see the Mother. The Mother addressed the group,

Amma: The yoking of *jivatman* and the *Paramatman* is the goal. It is good to see that you children are doing *sadhana* according to the instructions given by your Guru. It is a rare blessing that you could dedicate everything for Self-Realization. Children, Mother is really happy to see you all together.

The lady whom Mother had called first stood shedding tears. The Mother called her once again, wiped her tears and lovingly consoled her saying,

Amma: Child, don't worry. It is all for the best. Acquire more strength to confront the impediments that might arise in your spiritual path. We cannot change situations in life, but we can change our attitude towards them. Try, Mother is with you.

The Mother then talked with the devotees who came from Tamil Nadu. They were very excited. Each one of them wanted to be in the front row.

Without even going to her room for a minute, the Mother came directly from the hut and sat in the front verandah of the temple to begin the *bhajan* at five o'clock. The singing started. The Mother soared

to the heights of supreme devotion and love. Along with her, she carried the hearts of the devotees as well. The Mother and the *brahmacharins* sang *Karunya Varidhe Krishna*, a favorite for many people.

O Krishna, Ocean of Compassion,
The thirst for life is ever-increasing,
There is no peace for the mind
And alas, confusion overwhelms me.

Forgiving all wrongs,
Wipe off the sweat from my brow,
O Kanna, I have no support
Other than Thy Worshipful Lotus Feet.

O Krishna, my throat is drying up,
My eyes are failing, my feet are tired,
And I am falling to the ground,
O Krishna...

After the *bhajan*, when the *Devi Bhava* started, the *Siddha Veda* people packed up and got ready to leave the Ashram. It seemed that it was against their policy to go in for the *Devi Bhava*. But suddenly the two persons who had personal experiences with the Mother, insisted that they should go in and receive the Mother's blessings. The others had to agree, so they waited for the two to go up to the Mother during *Devi Bhava*.

The *Devi Bhava* was over by three-thirty in the

morning. The Mother, as usual, went around to the devotees once again to make sure that everyone had a mat and a place to sleep. Many of them preferred to sleep on the sand. One devotee said, “Mother, this is a rare blessing and great opportunity that we get to sleep in this fine sand. We may not get this chance in the future. This place will be all filled with big buildings and houses of devotees.”

The next day during a discussion about the path of *Siddha Veda*, the Mother related, “The *Siddha Veda* children came, having made the decision that none of them would go in for the *Devi Bhava*. Therefore, Mother also decided that at least one should come in. And two of them did so.” (All laugh)

Devotee: Amma is the greatest trickster in the world.

Amma: Mother’s tricks are not to gain anything for herself but to make you gain something. Mother plays tricks only when there is ego and selfishness. She flows to where there is innocence and surrender. Give a little space for God; a little is enough. He will flow into you. We are now completely closed, not even a hair’s breadth of a crevice is there for God to peep in. To create that space as much as she can is Mother’s job!

It is wonderful to watch the way Mother deals with and treats the people who come to see her at the Ashram. She has her own unique way of being with each one. Each person’s mind is an open book to the

Mother.

The topic changed. Somebody asked Mother about Dattan, the leper. The Mother had licked and sucked the pus from his leprous wounds every day. It was an awful sight for everyone. One of the *brahmacharins* asked what she felt when she saw him. The Mother replied,

Amma: Mother sees him in the same way as she sees you or anybody else. He is also my child. How can a Mother feel loathing or hatred when she sees her son or daughter, however ugly or badly diseased he or she is? In fact, Mother has a lot of compassion and love for him. Mother's heart melts when she sees him.

Question: Isn't the disease the result of his actions in the previous birth?

Amma: Why do you think such things? If Mother says "Yes," then you will ask, "What kind of sin did he commit?" If Mother gives a description of that as well, then you might feel, "Then let him experience it since he had committed numerous sins in the previous birth." You yourself will develop aversion to him and consider him as a sinner. This is closing down your own heart, not allowing it to open and flow with love. If Mother gives the answer, "No," then it is against the scriptures because each one of us is experiencing the fruit of our past actions. Therefore, forget about it. The real way is to think and act with the attitude, "If it is his *karma* which makes him suffer like this, then it is my *karma* and *dharma* to love him and serve him." If

you think without compassion, that is narrowing yourself down. Your path is to become more and more expansive.

A *sadhak*'s heart should flow to everyone equally. He should not think about faults and failures. He should always think about victory and goodness. You might say, "This is the *sadhana* period. We are only *sadhaks*. That means a *sadhak* will err and fall, won't he?" Don't even think in that way. You should make your mind stronger and stronger to fight and win against the obstacles.

Children, let your minds open up fully and contain love with all its fragrance and beauty. Hatred and aversion will only make it look ugly. Love towards everyone gives real beauty, enhancing both the giver as well as the receiver.

Question: Mother, why do you receive Dattan at the very end?

Amma: The reason is that once Mother calls that son, the pus, blood and all the other filth from his body will be on Mother's *sari*. The germs from his wounds also will be on Mother's body as she licks all his wounds during *Devi Bhava*. It is to avoid the germs from spreading into other devotees' bodies that Mother calls him at the very end. Not only that, if Mother calls him in the beginning or in the middle, again the other devotees who have not yet come to the Mother will not be able to do so with an open heart, for they might be reacting to his leprosy. They will be benefited only if they come to Mother with fully opened hearts. Therefore, it is only for her children's

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Since morning today, the Mother had been pressing her forehead saying that she had a severe headache. Some of the newer *brahmacharins* offered her different medicines like Amritamjan and Vicks Vaporub. Somebody else asked, “Mother, shall I bring some pain killers?” The Mother smilingly rejected all these and said, “This pain doesn’t just go like that. Medicine cannot heal or cure this.”

The senior *brahmacharins* and other close devotees understood the meaning of what the Mother was saying. Whenever Mother took a disease from someone, whatever it was, her body had to undergo suffering. It was quite usual. This headache must have also been acquired for the same reason. However, the Mother, even though she was suffering, went on talking to the devotees about different spiritual matters.

One devotee put forth a question about the awakening of the *kundalini*.

Amma: Nowadays, talking about *kundalini* and its awakening has become a fashion. Another word which is usually used is *yoga*. They simply talk about it. Let them put forth at least a little effort to understand the real meaning of these words. The real meaning can only be known through *sadhana* and experience. Once you start getting real experience, i.e., as you go deeper into your own self, you will stop talking about it.

Waves occur only when the water is shallow, not where it is deep. As you dive deeper and deeper into the subtle realms of spirituality, thought waves slowly end. There will be only silence.

After all, why should you think and worry about *kundalini* awakening and all that? Some people go around to different *sannyasins* and *gurus* asking whether their *kundalini* is awake or not. Some others try to find a *guru* who can do it with one touch. Children, do not waste your time asking such questions. Do your *sadhana* sincerely with love and devotion. There will be progress. On the other hand, if you are always worried about the awakening of *kundalini*, then your mind is split, and that will affect your spiritual growth.

One *brahmacharin* brought some rice and vegetables for the Mother on a plate, but she did not eat it. A householder devotee who was nearly sixty years old remained seated without going for lunch. The Mother noticed him and said, "Come on, Mother will feed you." She took him to the kitchen and fed him with her own hands. As he swallowed each ball of rice which the Mother herself put into his mouth, tears of inexpressible joy ran down his cheeks.

Here human intellect fails to understand the meaning in a thirty-year-old ordinary looking village girl becoming the mother of a sixty-year-old man. Any meaning the intellect gives will be either a misinterpretation or an interpretation stuffed with reasoning or logic. To find meaning we must look not on the plane of the

intellect but on the plane of the experience which can only be known through the heart.

The Mother's headache continued. She wanted to be alone for a while, so she went and lay down at the southern side of the Ashram beside the backwaters. Nobody went there to disturb her.

At three-thirty arrangements were made in the library to show a film on the Mother to some devotees from the outside. With the enthusiasm and curiosity of a child, the Holy Mother also came and sat with the others. Seeing her own stout body in the movie, she called out, "Oh look, a demon," and started laughing. She remarked, "What will be my fate if I put on weight like this?" and again she laughed.

Scenes from the Mother's thirtieth birthday celebration, e.g., the chanting of the Divine Name and the performance of the *pada puja* (ceremonial washing of the holy Mother's Feet), were shown. Seeing her children sipping the sacred water with which the feet were washed, the Mother exclaimed, "What nonsense is that! Will Realization be obtained if the feet are washed and the water is drunk? Humility is what is needed."

The Mother still had the headache. Having locked the door, she lay down in the hut all alone. She again came out when it was five o'clock and she looked refreshed. The headache was gone and she was as cheerful as ever.

Just as children keep a stock of peanuts in their pockets taking them out every now and then to chew, the Mother little by little experiences the stock of dis-

eases which she takes from her devotees. One can see her suffering with severe pain at one time and not having any the next moment. She simply will get up and walk away as if nothing had happened.

There were some occasions when she was seen suffering a lot, even unable to sit without someone else's help. But the next moment when a devotee or an aspirant came to see her and talk to her, she would suddenly get up with as much energy as she always had and talk to that person for a long time.

At this time a devotee full of humor came. He talked very freely to the Mother. Every now and then, he cracked a joke and each time the Mother laughed with a full heart. At one point, he opened his mouth wide. He was about to imitate another person. In a split second, before he could close it, the Mother took a handful of sand and tossed it into his mouth. It was all over in a second. It was so quick. The devotee suddenly stood up and went on spitting out the sand. As he did so he expressed great joy, laughing and saying, "This is what she does to a blabber-mouth like me." Seeing him struggling with the sand in his mouth, the Mother rolled on the ground and laughed uproariously.

The devotee rinsed out his mouth and came back to where the Mother was sitting. He said to the other devotees, "What a fool I am. I should have swallowed the sand. Who knew what it was? It was *prasad*. Had I swallowed it, I might have attained Realization. We always think after the event." He sighed and stopped.

Many children were gathered around the Mother to witness this scene, as were almost all of the *brahmacharins*. Since this devotee, who was close to sixty-years old, was a classically trained singer, the Mother asked him to sing a song. By vocalizing the introductory cadence to open the song, coupled with making funny gestures, he once again created an amusing scene causing everyone to laugh, including the Mother.

The evening *bhajan* started at six-thirty. The Holy Mother was also present. It was raining heavily with thunder and lightning. The haunting roar of the ocean waves beating on the sand during the storm served as a constant drone from the west. The *bhajan* continued. The Mother in her spiritually intoxicated mood swung from side to side as she sang. The sound of the dripping rain drops provided background accompaniment for the song *Amme Bhagavati Nitya Kanye Devi...*

O Mother Divine, the Eternal Virgin,
I bow to Thee for Thy gracious glance.

O Maya, Mother of the Universe,
O Pure Awareness-Bliss,
O Great Goddess, I bow to Thee.

O Source of all the mantras in the four Vedas,
I bow to Thee again and again.

O Thou, the Parrot in the nest of Omkara,
I bow to Thy Holy Feet.

O Thou Who dwellest in the
Lotus face of Lord Brahma,
O Essence of the four Vedas, I bow to Thee.

All of a sudden the Mother's voice was heard above the music, "Who is that son?" The *bhajan* abruptly stopped. There was utter silence. Nobody understood why the Mother asked this question. Each one thought that he had done something wrong as the Mother again asked,

Amma: Who is that who played the wrong *talam* (beat)? Do not overburden yourself with great sin by doing so. Missing time while singing *bhajans* will bring harm. If you do not play with concentration, you will miss the *talam*. Many celestial beings and subtle beings are listening while we sing. Each instrument has a *devata* (demi-god). That *devata* will curse if we do not play the *talam* correctly.

This is another example of the discipline the Mother teaches as she uses every situation to impress upon the children how they must be ever-mindful of the actions they perform, even while playing an instrument.

They continued with the *bhajan*:

O Goddess of the world, it is just Thy play
To create the world and save it by undoing it.

O Mind of the mind, O Dearest Mother,
I am just a mere worm in Thy play.

O Thou who art merciful to the afflicted
Who doest everything without doing anything,
I bow to Thee.

O Kali of black hue,
Destroyer of the demon Mahisha,
Sankari, whose eyes are like petals of a lotus,
I bow to Thee.

O Thou who art ever young, Destroyer of sor-
row,
O Thou of Great Soul, Bhaskari, I bow to
Thee.

The singing continued until quarter-past-eight when the *bhajan* and the *arati* were concluded. The Mother remained on her seat leaning against the wall. Her eyes were closed as the devotees and the residents prostrated to her one by one. Still in an ecstatic mood, she continued every now and then to sing some *kirtans*. The inner bliss in which she reveled manifested itself outwardly as bursts of laughter.

After some time she lay down on the lap of a boy who was hardly seven years old. She returned to her normal mood and began patting and caressing the boy. The Mother asked him to sing. He sang *Kanna Ni Yenne...*

O Krishna, have You forgotten me?
O Thou with the color of a stormy cloud,
Have you forgotten me?
Not seeing You, my suffering increases
And my heart is unable to understand anything.

The Mother seemed very absorbed in the little boy's innocent devotion and singing. There was a beautiful smile on her face. When the boy finished the song, she asked, "Son, do you know *Manasa Vacha*?" He answered, "Yes." "Then sing," she requested. The boy could hardly sing the first four lines. He stopped and softly told the Mother, "That's all I know." The Mother went on singing the song celebrating the Divine, as both the devotees and the residents were gathered around her witnessing all the different moods she displayed.

Through my mind, speech and actions,
I remember Thee incessantly.
Why then art Thou delaying
To show Thy mercy to me, Beloved Mother?

Years have passed
But still my mind has no peace,
O darling Mother, please grant me some relief.

My mind sways like a boat caught in a storm,
O Mother, give me a little peace of mind

Lest I become a lunatic.

I am tired, Mother, it is unbearable;
I do not want such a life,
I cannot stand Your tests,
O Mother, I cannot endure it!

I am a miserable destitute
I have no one but You, Mother
Please stop Your tests,
Extend Your hand and pull me up.

All of a sudden the Holy Mother got up and went to the kitchen. It was time for supper. The Mother herself served rice gruel to all her children. When supper was over, the *brahmacharins* left the Mother in order to do their *sadhana*. Nobody wanted to leave her, but she would not let them stay around her during the times when they were supposed to perform their *sadhana*.

The silence of the night prevailed everywhere. Except for the resounding call of the ocean waves, there was no sound. The *brahmacharins* were seen meditating both in the meditation hall and on the verandah. Some of them sat outside under the coconut trees. When it was eleven o'clock the residents retired to bed, having finished that day's *sadhana*, to begin again at four-thirty the next morning.

The Ashram atmosphere was totally still. A nightin-

gale was heard singing a haunting melody. After a few moments, the bird also stopped. The stars twinkled in the deep, dark velvety sky. Suddenly breaking the quiet of the night, the Mother's voice was heard from her room. She was singing, *Anandamayi Brahmamayi...*

O Blissful One, O Absolute One,
 O Blissful One, O Absolute One,
 Whose form is of unsurpassed beauty
 O Blissful One, O Absolute One...

Her voice had an unusual touch of pathos. A few *brahmacharins* awoke upon hearing the song. They sat on the verandah of their huts and silently listened to the Mother. The song was powerful enough to make one glide into meditation effortlessly as the haunting, soulful melody unfolded... "*Aradharangal..*" (second verse of the same song):

Crossing the six mystic centers, the yogis
 Come to know Thee, the invaluable Treasure.
 Thy Glory, O Infinite Power,
 Is only slightly revealed to them.

The ocean waves served as the background melody. The heartrending song sung by the Mother filled the atmosphere with divine fervor. The cool, gentle breeze responded to the song and reverently carried the vibrations to the far corners of this enchanted night.

The Mother stopped singing. Silence prevailed but

only for a short time. It was again broken by the rhythmic jingling of the Mother's anklets. She must have been dancing, undoubtedly immersed in a blissful dance, forgetting herself and the external world, all alone in her own world beyond this one, where nobody else had access. Each of the *brahmacharins* who had woken up felt that she was dancing in his very own heart. Sad that they could not see their Beloved Mother dancing with the anklets on her feet, but visualizing and imagining in their minds how she must have been gliding the Holy Feet through rapturous steps of a mystical dance of Devi, they remained on the verandah of the hut with their eyes fixed, looking at the Mother's room.

At last the sound of the anklets stopped. The residents waited for a few more minutes, hoping that they would hear another song or more jingling of the anklets again. But thereafter no sound came from the Mother's room, so they all went back to bed as the clock struck twelve midnight.

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The clock in the dining hall rang ten times. A little girl in white clothes was making sandalwood paste for the morning's *puja*. As usual Acchamma was doing her daily duty of making garlands. The eighty-year-old lady still gets up at three-thirty every morning, takes a shower in cold water, does her daily chanting of the Divine Name, sings some *bhajans* and then goes out to

pluck flowers for the *puja* in the temple and for making garlands to adorn the statues and images of the Deity and for the Mother too. She is so old that she cannot even walk properly without bending over. Her determination, however, far outruns her old age.

On one side of the Ashram the *brahmacharins* were heard chanting the *Lalita Sahasranama*. The ringing of the bell while the *puja* was being performed echoed in the atmosphere. An enchanting musical note emerged from one of the huts. Markus, the hard-working devotee from Germany, was playing the flute.

This morning one of the *brahmacharins* went to the Mother's room and complained that his *vasanas* still remained even after doing *sadhana* for a long time. He blamed the Mother for not showering her Grace on him. He said that if the Mother did not remove his *vasanas* soon he would commit suicide.

Looking at him, the Mother sat without uttering a word for some time. When he cooled down a little, she called him to her and lovingly said,

Amma: Son, do you know how much energy you have wasted this morning? Mother appreciates your determination and thirst to realize God. It is fine and good that you feel the urgency, but patience is the most important thing that a *sadhak* must have to attain the goal. A true *sadhak* will not become impatient at all. Son, do you know that our forefathers, the great saints and sages of the past, did years and years of se-

vere penance in order to realize God? They never got impatient. Had they been impatient, nothing would have been achieved. It would have been a waste of time and energy if impatience ran their lives.

Even to achieve momentary worldly goals, one needs a lot of patience coupled with self-effort. So what can be said about spiritual realization, which is the only thing which bestows ever-lasting happiness and immortality?

Suppose someone wants to go to a foreign country, say America. First of all, he must apply for a passport and then must wait patiently for it to be issued. This will not happen in a day or two, for these legal matters take time. There are many legal procedures before a passport will be issued. Once it is issued to him, he must then obtain a visa. Above all, he will have to find a person to sponsor him. All these things are time-consuming. One should not get impatient and say, "No, no, I must go to America right at this moment. Why is it not possible? I must get the visa and the sponsorship this very day. Otherwise, I will commit suicide." Thus, if one gets impatient and commits suicide a few days after submitting the applications, what will be the result? He simply dies. Nothing else will happen. It does not matter how many births one takes; if he or she is not endowed with patience, God-realization is not possible. To fulfill your wish, you should move slowly, steadily, patiently, carefully and sincerely. If everything works out properly, you will achieve your goal. If you get impatient, everything will

be spoiled. You will not achieve your goal by getting impatient because you become mentally restless and scattered. By fragmenting yourself, you lose all your concentration and energy necessary to gain it. Constantly striving patiently, you can slowly make steady progress.

Son, Grace is not something which you can snatch from God or the Guru. Grace is something which spontaneously flows to the disciple. No one can say when, where or how it happens. You have no control over it. You can, and you must act. The rest depends on Grace. It just happens when the Guru feels that the disciple is fully ripe and ready. For this attainment, you need patience. You must put forth effort without thinking of the result. Then, when it is time, the Guru gives it. Do not spend time worrying about it.

Vasanas cannot be eliminated so easily. Son, how long have you been doing meditation?

The Mother paused and waited for an answer. The *brahmacharin* softly replied, "For the last two years." She inquired, "Are you doing meditation constantly? No. How many hours have you set aside to do meditation? Seven or eight hours at the most? The *brahmacharin* kept quiet. It seemed that the Mother was up to something. Again she asked, "How old are you now?" He started feeling ashamed to speak, as if he suspected something. Yet he answered, "Twenty-eight." She continued to inquire, "Have you meditated or chanted be-

fore coming to Mother?" "No," he admitted.

Amma: All right. Now look, son, you have done meditation only for two years, yet you have been in this world for twenty-six years before coming to spirituality. Now, that is only for this lifetime. Before that, nobody knows how many births you have taken and how much you have indulged. Now you are saying that all these accumulated tendencies should have gone within these two years' time. Not only that, here you are not even constantly engaged in getting rid of your *vasanas*. It may be true that you meditate for seven or eight hours a day, but what about the concentration you get? Let us say that you will get one minute of concentration when you sit for one hour. Thus, if you calculate, it will not even be ten minutes of concentration a day. So it is clear that you are not engaged in attempting to destroy the *vasanas* constantly. Furthermore, my son, previously you were constantly engaged in enjoying and indulging while you lived in this world. Now tell Mother whether there is any meaning in your argument?

The *brahmacharin* was tongue-tied. He turned pale as he sat with his head hung down. The Holy Mother put him on her lap and consoled him, saying,

Amma: Don't worry, son. Mother just wanted to make you aware that it requires long-term practice and patience. At least you are aware that those *vasanas* ex-

ist and that they need to be eliminated. That in itself shows that you have evolved. This awareness itself is a great accomplishment. People in the world do not even know that there are terrible *vasanas* in them. They are totally drowned in them. Compared to those people you children are much more evolved. Be happy. Why do you worry so much when Mother is here to take care of you? Mother is here for you, isn't she?

The Mother came to the hut by ten-thirty and the *darshan* began. One of the devotees asked a question about performing worship to different *devatas*. The Holy Mother replied,

Amma: Although *devatas* are superior to human beings, they depend on humans for their food. That is why in the *puranas* and epics we find stories of *devas* who obstruct those who are doing penance. Once a human being reaches the state of non-action, these *devas* will not get their share, which is mainly gained through various rituals and oblations. When a human being evolves to the state of *sannyasa*, he renounces all actions, even rituals and oblations. Thus the *devas* lose what they had been getting from that particular individual. Action is meant only for mortal humans, not for one who rises to the state of immortality. That means actions cannot bind such a person. He too works but he renounces the fruit of it, which also means renouncing the action itself. Detachment from

an action that you do means you are not doing it, that is, your mind is not identified with the action. Therefore, there is nobody to give and take, so this results in the *devas* losing their share. They do not want that to happen; that is why they create obstacles for a person who does penance to realize the Self.

There are different aspects of divinity which are potent within us. When we do good and wise actions, the goodness in us will be invoked and will lead us to progress and prosperity. But then, as we continue our striving, when we try to concentrate all our attention on the Supreme Self, this goodness itself will become an obstacle because, in order to attain the Ultimate Reality, i.e., Self-Realization, we have to transcend everything, even goodness. Goodness is also a bondage. These great ideals also exist as thoughts. To reach the state of non-action, the state of complete renunciation, all thoughts must go. The mind must disappear. If the mind has to disappear, all thoughts must disappear because the mind is nothing but thoughts. When we try to obtain that thoughtless state, the same good thoughts will also create impediments. Even good thoughts will try to pull you back to the same old state of action. They cannot exist without your cooperation, without your acting. Actions, doing good things, performing sacred ceremonies are food for these good thoughts; that is what makes them exist.

Rituals and other ceremonies will help to cleanse and purify the mind. Through rituals and other religious observances, the mind, filled with all kinds of

evil thoughts, will become good and virtuous. When that is gained, don't stop; proceed and transcend that as well. If you attach yourself to the good and virtuous, these again will become habits and consequently *vasanas*. Whether good or bad, a *vasana* is an obstacle in the path towards attainment of the state of Perfection. Therefore, do not halt for a long time with good thoughts; go beyond them. Only if you go beyond all goodness and badness will you reach the state where there is neither good nor bad, neither sorrow nor happiness, neither success nor failure, the state where you always remain as That, That alone. It does not matter whether you are bound with a golden chain or an iron one. Bondage is bondage, no matter with what one is bound. Therefore, to make the mind completely still, goodness also should be transcended. Good or bad thoughts will always create waves in the mind, which will disturb its stillness.

Devotee: It is all a question of renouncing all ego-centric thoughts and actions, isn't it, Mother?

Amma: You are right, Son. Thoughts and actions which would feed the ego in any way should not be done. Good actions and good thoughts also will bind you if they are performed or thought with an attitude of "I" and "mine." This is why it is said that one should approach a Perfect Master. He alone can help you get rid of the feelings of "I" and "mine." It is very subtle but strong. Subtle *vasanas* are more powerful than the gross ones. Things that are subtle have more pervasiveness also. When ice melts, it becomes water which is

more subtle and powerful and more pervasive. Water, when heated up or boiled, becomes vapor, which is still more subtle, powerful and pervasive. It has such power that this steam is used to run huge machines. Again, water power, when it is converted into electrical energy, becomes much more subtle, powerful and pervasive. In the same way, the mind and the thoughts with which it is constituted will become stronger and more pervasive when the subtlety increases. Human effort alone will not be sufficient enough to remove the deep-rooted subtle tendencies. God's or the Guru's Grace is a must. That alone can take the mind to the subtlest state where there are no thoughts and no mind. In that state of supreme subtlety, the mind transforms into the most powerful source of inexhaustible energy. In that state it becomes all-pervasive energy itself. That is the final death of the ego, which will no longer return.

Everyone sat amazed for a long time, looking at the Mother with all humility and reverence. It seemed that they all became aware of her greater dimension and omniscience. The most scientific explanations about the highest philosophical truths told in a very simple and lucid language by the Mother filled their hearts with immense bliss and inspiration. Her simplicity and innocence are fully reflected in her talk as well.

A simple looking village girl who had not even completed her formal education in school, who had

not studied even the preliminary texts of spirituality, who was not at all in the habit of reading anything, was talking like an eminent scholar and has become the master of scholars and of highly educated men and women! Is this not an extraordinary phenomena? Those who have eyes will see it. Those who have ears will hear it. Those who have a heart will know it.

The Mother paused for a while. She closed her eyes and was transported to another world of her own for a few moments. Uttering “Shiva, Shiva,” and whirling her right index finger in the air, the Mother opened her eyes.

Devotee: Brahmacharin Balu told me of an incident that showed how disobedience and egoism in front of the Guru can bring about one’s ruin.

Amma: (with the curiosity of a child) What is that? What did he say?

Devotee: He told me about a boy named Hari who often used to visit the Ashram and who did *sadhana* as you instructed. One day he didn’t eat because he was upset with you for not taking him with you on one of your trips. In order to console him and to make him eat, you offered a banana to him. He would not accept it. Again and again with the love and affection of a mother, you expressed the wish that he accept the banana and eat it. But each time when you offered it, he rejected it, saying, “No, I don’t want it.” All of a sudden your facial expression changed and you became very serious. You threw the banana away saying, “Here goes your last fruit. Son, this was your last

fruit.” Brahmacharin Balu told me that from then on that boy could never meditate even for a second. So he wanders here and there simply wasting his time and energy. He left spiritual life and now leads a worldly life with all kinds of problems.

Amma: Mother usually doesn’t say such things. Yet no matter how much Mother humbled herself before him, he would not obey on that day, and the words just came out. Even Mother herself could not stop them. Maybe that was his fate. God will not tolerate the ego. Children, the ego can cause great disasters.

It was four o’clock in the afternoon. The Holy Mother wanted to listen to a particular song titled *Saranagati* (Give Refuge, O’ Mother). A tape recorder was brought and the song was played. It had been sung by a resident with accompaniments. The Mother was completely absorbed in the song. The hut was filled with devotees.

O Mother Immortal, Who is Shakti,
The very Embodiment of Power,
Who dwells in the essence of all beings,
Who is the Personification of Auspiciousness,
And who is Purity in the exalted sense,
I bow to Thy Holy Feet.

After some time, the Mother got up and went out. She roamed around for a while in the coconut grove. Later she related, “Mother could not listen to that song and give her heart completely to it. Had she

done so she would have lost all control, which Mother did not want to do at that time since there were many people in the hut who know nothing about these matters. That is why Mother got up and left.” The song was over. It was time for the ensuing *bhajan*.

One by one the residents and the devotees from the outside came and sat in front of the temple. One devotee still sat in the hut and meditated. Suddenly the Mother stepped in asking, “Oh, son, haven’t you gone?” She sat on the cot. The devotee made a full prostration in front of the Mother. He took the Mother’s feet and placed them on his head. His eyes filled with tears, he prayed to the Mother thus: “Mother, these feet of yours are enough for me. I don’t want anything else. O Mother, please don’t make me play games in this world of plurality.”

The Mother carefully listened to him. Casting a compassionate glance at him, the Mother caressed her son with all love and affection. “Come, son, it is time for the *bhajan*,” she said as she went out and walked towards the temple.

The *bhajan* began as usual at six-thirty. The Mother was playing the *ganjira* (a small hand drum with only one head). In a few minutes she put it down and picked up the cymbals and began playing. It seemed that the Mother was struggling to keep her mind down. Now she also put the cymbals down and sang, creating waves of unconditional bliss which radiated all around with *Manase Nin Svantamayi...*

Remember, O mind, this supreme truth:
Nobody is your own!

Because of doing meaningless actions,
You are wandering in the ocean of this world.

Even though people honor you,
Calling you, "Lord, Lord,"
It will be for a short time only.

Your body, which has been honored for so
long,
Must be cast off when life departs.

For which sweetheart have you been struggling
All this time, not even caring for your life?

Even she will be frightened by your dead body
And will not accompany you.

Trapped in the subtle snare of Maya as you are,
Do not forget the Sacred Name
Of the Divine Mother.

The Lord will attract devotion-soaked souls
Like a magnet attracts iron.

Position, prestige and wealth are impermanent;
The only Reality is the Universal Mother.

Renouncing all desires,
Let us dance in that bliss

Singing the Name of Mother Kali!

Singing with the Mother, especially in the evenings, is a joyous experience which opens the heart to a much more elevated plane of devotion. Sitting on the powerful spiritual wings of the Mother, the devotees and residents fly high every evening at *bhajans*, drinking in the nectarous bliss of Supreme Devotion. Each moment is an experience, exposing the heart to another spiritual treasure chest. Today also it happened. Everyone sang forgetting themselves.

4 April 1984

Nobody knows when the Mother will come out or when she will go back to her room. No one can predict what the Mother will do or say. We may be quite convinced that she will do a certain thing at a certain time, but instead of doing that, she will do something quite unexpected and in an entirely different manner, one we would never have even dreamt of.

Day and night are the same to her. If she wants to do something, whatever it is, the Mother does it, irrespective of time and place. She is unpredictable and irresistible. Nobody can tell how the Mother will handle a particular situation. We may have ideas and calculations, but such ideas will all crumble into pieces as we watch the way she handles things. We see only the present, just the things that happen right now

in this moment; but the Mother sees through everything. Her eyes penetrate into everything, into all experiences, all happenings, going beyond into the far distant future. While we see only the gross aspects of a thing, her eyes pierce and penetrate into its recesses and draw out all the subtle, nay, even the subtlest, aspects of it.

Today a family of five from northern Kerala came to see the Mother. The Mother had not yet come to the hut. Understanding that they were newcomers and wanting to have some information, one of the residents went to them, greeted them with palms joined and politely inquired, "Where are you from? Is this the first time that you have visited the Ashram?"

The man who seemed to be the head of the family spoke. "We come from the northern part of Kerala. This is our first visit; therefore, we don't know much about the ways of the Ashram. Is it possible to meet the Mother?"

"Of course, you can. But the Mother has not yet come out. She will definitely come, but we can't say when." The resident spread a mat in front of the temple and requested them to be seated till the Mother came. It was only nine in the morning. The head of the family, not quite convinced, once again turned to the resident and asked, "Excuse me, are you sure that the Mother will come today?" "Don't worry, she will come," reassured the resident.

By nine-thirty the Mother came directly over to

where they were sitting instead of going to the hut. She walked towards the temple as if she knew that the new visitors were there. They all got up and stood reverently when the Mother stepped onto the temple verandah. The resident, who was still standing there, offered his prostrations to the Mother. Seeing him doing that, all four of them, who had wondered how to honor the Mother, also did the same. The Mother said, "Actually, Mother had intended to come down in the afternoon to see the devotees. But all of a sudden she changed her mind and decided to come now."

The head of the family expressed, "We are fortunate." They were all still standing. The Mother asked them to sit. Introducing the others to the Mother, the head of the family spoke. "The others with me are my wife, son, daughter and daughter-in-law. We have been thinking about coming to see Mother for the last two months, but it always got postponed due to different reasons. Even though we could not come until now, we have all been thinking about you almost every day."

The Mother closed her eyes for a few moments. Then she called the young girl, who was their youngest daughter, and had her lie down on her lap. The girl started crying. The other family members silently shed tears.

The Mother now lifted the young girl from her lap and wiped her tears, and once again made her lie down on her lap. She gently continued patting her back. The others also wiped their tears. The Mother,

in a soft voice told the father, "It was quite unfortunate for her to see the results of the test and find out that she had leukemia." There was an obvious shock which shook all three of them. They were already surprised when the Mother called the girl without their having given any hint about the terrible disease she had. Unable to restrain his feelings as was revealed by his quivering voice, the father exclaimed, "But we didn't disclose to you the fact that she had leukemia nor about how she found out about it. So you know everything." The whole family felt as he did, so once more there was an emotional upheaval.

The Mother very calmly said, "Forget about all this. Wipe your tears. It is not fair to become uncontrollably emotional in front of her. What she needs now is strength and courage to confront the situation. If you become too emotional in front of her, she will become mentally and physically weak."

They regained their mental control and discussed with the Mother what to do with their only daughter, whose name was Salini. She was still lying on the Mother's lap and the Mother continued to rub her back. Salini's mother said, "Although she is a medical student, Salini is very God-fearing. Every morning she does a *pūja* to Mother Durga. Even in this condition she does it without fail. But Mother, look at her fate. God has given her this terrible disease. Most unfortunately, as you have predicted, she happened to see the results of the test which we wanted to hide from her.

Mother, imagine the mental agony of a girl who knows that she is afflicted with leukemia.”

At this point, the girl lifted her head from the Mother’s lap, and looking at her face, Salini remarked, “Mother, I am not in mental agony as they say. I cry because I am in Mother’s presence, something which I have been thirsting for.”

The Holy Mother soothed her forehead and expressed her love and affection for Salini.

Amma: In fact, it is due to her *sankalpa* that she is here today. God will never forsake His sincere devotees.

The father: Amma, even without our saying anything about the disease, you disclosed it. Amma, you know everything. I believe that it is her devotion to Durga that brought us here today, and without even the least exaggeration, I believe that it is Mother Durga’s lap that she is lying on now. Amma, please save her; you alone can do it.

After his plea, he fell in full prostration in front of the Mother and wept. All the while the girl was comfortably lying on the Mother’s lap. When she heard her father crying, she lifted her head and said,

Salini: Father, we are at the Mother’s feet. Let her do what she likes. Please don’t say, “Do this, or, don’t do that.”

The Holy Mother looked at Salini's face in appreciation of her attitude. She asked one of the *brahmacharins* who was standing nearby to bring some sacred ash. When it was brought, the Mother held it right below her own nose, imbuing her pure, vital energy into it. Having applied some of the ash on the girl's forehead, the Mother gave the rest to her mother, instructing her to apply a little of it on her daughter's chest every day. She told Salini that she could also eat a little bit of it every morning and evening. The Mother once again consoled the family, telling them not to worry and that Mother would take care of their daughter. Salini then got up from her seat to go. Before they left, the Mother once again called all five of them to her and each one was duly attended to.

Leaving them, the Mother went and sat in the front of the meditation hall. The *brahmacharins* and a few householder devotees surrounded her.

One brahmacharin: Mother, is that girl going to be cured? Did you make a *sankalpa* to save her?"

Amma: It is not your job to think about that. Your job is to do *sadhana*. Why do you worry about such things? Everything will happen as it should happen. (Turning to the householder devotees) Anyhow, Mother liked that daughter's attitude. Death is right in front of her, yet she advises her father, "Let Mother do what She likes. Please don't say 'Do this, don't do that'." Her faith is very firm. She is one who has known the real principle of spirituality. Children, this

is a good lesson for you. This is how one should take refuge in God. One should pray, “O Lord, do as You will; don’t let me suggest. Let Your will be done.” Anyhow, Mother feels that her disease will be cured owing to her pure *sankalpa* and right attitude.

[Note: This statement came true, as the tests done after they visited the Mother proved that the leukemia cells in her blood had completely disappeared. Slowly she regained her health and became normal. The next time they visited the Ashram they told the Mother that after meeting her, this daughter gave up all medicines except the sacred ash given by the Mother, which she strongly believed was the best to cure her disease. Salini’s father said, “Even we became terribly scared thinking about what would happen to her if she stopped all her medicines, which had been sustaining her body and her life. But her determination was very strong. Finally Amma saved her.”]

Brahmacharin: Amma, what happens in *samadhi*?

Amma: Nothing happens. All happenings stop in *samadhi*. That is what happens in that state.

At twelve o’clock the Mother went up to her room. By the time she reached the room, an old relative of the Mother’s family arrived just for a visit. He was a middle-aged man. He knew nothing about spirituality. He considered Mother to be just an ordinary girl who belonged to his family. He had been very antagonistic about the Mother’s Divine Moods before. Now, he

doesn't protest, that is all. He followed the Mother and went into her room. Posing himself as one of the eldest members of the family, he walked into the room looking around with an air of pride. Then, pulling a stool toward him, he proudly sat on it, keeping one leg on the other, i.e., his right foot was placed on his left knee. This was a very disrespectful and egotistical way of sitting. Those who were present could not bear it. But as Mother was present, they could not say anything.

It is quite effortless for the Mother to adjust to any circumstance, any situation. Whatever be the circumstance, she could easily adjust it, placing herself at the level where she could be understood by the other person. Here the same thing happened. The Mother began conversing with the man, giving him a feeling that she was only an ordinary girl, a relative who was very much interested in the family affairs. It was very interesting to watch how diplomatically and, at the same time, naturally, the Mother had woven in the activities of the Ashram and the principles for which it stands. He was so caught up in *maya* that he simply shook his head for whatever Mother said and still remained seated in the same posture, putting on airs. However, this attitude did not last long. He slowly put his leg down and started massaging it with his own hands. There were also signs on his own face which made it clear that he was undergoing some severe pain in one leg. The massaging went on. The Holy Mother asked, "What happened, Uncle?"

Through the pain he replied, "I don't know why, but all of a sudden my leg started hurting without any particular reason." The Mother sincerely expressed sympathy, but the pain did not stop. It continued to increase. Unable to bear the pain, he who had walked in with an air of pride had to leave the room limping, supported by two people on either side. It seemed that it was the mental pain of the devotees who were present which got transmitted into his leg.

The Mother rose from the cot to take a shower as if she did not know anything about the things that had happened. It was two-thirty in the afternoon and until now, the Mother had not even had a glass of water to drink. Yet this was not a new experience. She always gives the least importance to her own needs. Sometimes she does not eat even if food is served at the correct time, which usually does not happen since her schedule for meals is always different. Breakfast is just one or two sips of tea. On most days it turns out that what normally is lunch and supper would become supper and breakfast and these terms are just for namesake. Then there are occasions when she is stubborn like an innocent little child and refuses to eat when the food is served a little late. But that is only to teach the *brahmacharins* a lesson about *sraddha* (faithful deliverance of one's duty, understanding the need of the situation).

In the evening the Mother went to the seashore. Two college professors, two children and a few *brah-*

macharins accompanied her. There on the seashore the Mother sat still, facing the ocean. The blue vast ocean, the symbol of infinity, with its unending waves of different sizes, was a magnificent sight which invoked peace and tranquility in a *sadhak's* mind. Although the nature of the ocean is never-ending waves, its mere sight can somehow help to sublimate the thought-waves of the mind.

The setting evening sun, radiating golden rays all around, shone on the western horizon. Its rays reflected on the waters of the ocean and colored that part of the sea a brilliant reddish gold. As if they were desirous of adorning the Mother's already radiant countenance, the rays showered themselves upon her face as well, accentuating her eternally blissful smile. There was the setting sun on the western horizon, and there was the Mother, the ever glowing Sun of Knowledge on the horizon of spirituality.

The Mother instructed the others who were with her,

Amma: You should meditate, imagining either a rock or a fully-blossomed lotus in the sea; then install your Beloved Deity sitting on it. Or you can consider the ocean as the world. In it vibrates the *jivatman* of the waves. Even beyond that, imagine the form of Devi sitting silently on a lotus, making everything still as the witness-consciousness and meditate on that.

After meditation, the Mother became childlike.

She started playing, digging holes on the seashore with her hands. Then she called one of the two children to her and covered the child's feet with sand. After that, she drew a triangle, symbolizing *Shakti* (power, serpent power), on the sand and placed a small piece of stone in the middle, representing the *bindu* (central point). Then the Mother began performing *archana* to it, using the sand to represent the flower petals that are normally offered from the heart. One of the girls also joined her.

After a while the Mother began playing with the waves in the sea. She took water in her cupped hands and splashed it on the children, who screamed in alarm and ran back to the shore. Seeing their plight, the Mother laughed. At one point, she took water in her cupped hands and poured it over her own head. As she repeated this a few times, she called out loud, "Hey...Shivane..."

One may wonder, is this person who sports like a small child the same one who protects thousands of people who throng to her for solace and succor? Is she the head of a spiritual institution? Is this the person who is the spiritual Guru and Mother of thousands of people who come from all around the world? These different faces of the Holy Mother are unbelievable and incomprehensible, even when one sees them with one's own eyes.

Returning from the seashore, the Mother went directly to the vegetable garden where she started plucking "country greens" (a term commonly used for many

varieties of amaranthus and chenopodium). Now she looked exactly like a housewife who is keen about the things that are needed in the kitchen.

CHAKKA KALI

The day was getting closer to dusk. From the vegetable garden, the Holy Mother slowly walked towards the front of the temple just as Harshan, son of Sugunanandan's sister, was approaching. He was lame. Since this cousin had been the Mother's fond childhood playmate, she was very excited when she saw him. Immediately her mood again changed to that of a little girl and right at that moment she wanted to play *Chakka Kali* (a children's game similar to Hop-Scotch).

The rectangular drawing was made on the sand and the game began. All the residents of the Ashram and a few outside devotees gathered around to see the Mother playing. They felt tremendous joy while watching her and the way she played. The Mother played just like a child who became identified with the game which she played, using all the different tricks that would be used by an expert. It also appeared that the Mother engaged in a bit of foul play.

She threw a stone, which is part of the game, into one of the divisions, praying, "Oh, Shiva, may I win the game." But the stone did not fall into the division which she wanted. The Mother humorously remarked, "Oh, Shiva did not cooperate!" (All burst into laughter). It bounced and fell at a distance. "Alas," the

Mother said, and with a desperate look on her face, she stood aside. Continuously jumping on one foot, the Mother started panting. But she did not want to give up easily. Like a determined, adamant little girl she went on playing.

Just then the sound of the harmonium and a *mridangam* (a double headed drum) were heard from the temple. The Mother ran towards the water tank to wash her hands, legs and face, saying, “It is time for the *bhajan*.”

What is this state of *jivanmukti*! How can we understand it? How can we comprehend the different moods? What interpretation can one give for these seemingly strange moods of such great souls? It is all a mystery until we reach that state of Realization. Utterly complex is the Mother outwardly but fully and perfectly integrated is her inner personality. She uses this external complexity as a veil to cover her inner Perfection. Not that she does not want to reveal her real nature to us, but it is to make our minds fully one-pointed on her so that she can work on us. The sportings of a *Mahatma* are only to draw and bind his devotees towards him. When they have fallen in love with him and are completely attached to him, the *Mahatma* starts disciplining them to make them know and realize the non-dual Self with which he is one. Otherwise, we would not be able to imbibe or appreciate him even if he did fully manifest his real nature. In one verse of the Mother’s own compositions, *Omkara Divya Porule*, she says, *Piccha nadakkunnu*

makkal...

Toddling you are, my darling children,
Mother walks beside you
In order to develop the consciousness
Of Eternity in you.

What was the meaning of Krishna's sporting in Vrindavan? What was all that stealing of butter from the houses of *Gopis*, playing with *Gopis* and *Gopas*, grazing the cows? What was that all about? Were all those childhood pranks and merriment insignificant and meaningless like the play of an ordinary child? No, they were not. They were all different methods to bind the devotees to Him and ultimately carry them to the highest realm of Absolute Awareness where He was established. But that would not have been possible if He remained in that state of bliss, without speaking, playing, mingling and moving along with the people of Vrindavan. Surely they would not have appreciated Him as they did. In the same way, the Mother comes down to our level of understanding and acts like one of us, manifesting little by little her glory to make us feel and appreciate her. She will slowly become dear to us, and then in due course, the dearest. Thus it will culminate in a very strong inseparable relationship from where she can easily lead us to the state of Realization. The Mother says, "In order to catch a thief sometimes the policemen will disguise themselves as thieves and will act in the same way.

Once the thieves are caught, the policemen will reveal their real identity. In the same way, Mother acts like one of you so that she can catch the thief of your mind and direct you to God."

The *bhajan* began. The Mother was transported to a rapturous mood. She raised both her hands and called aloud, "Amme, hey...Devi, my Mother." Soaring to the highest peak of spiritual bliss, the Mother sang, *Amme Bhagavati Kali Mate...*

O Mother, Supreme Goddess Kali,
Today I will catch hold of You and devour You.
Hear what I say!
I was born under the star of death.

A child born
Under such a planetary conjunction
Devours its own mother.
So either You eat me
Or I will eat You this very day itself!

I am not going to keep quiet
Unless I know of Your choice.
Since you are black
That blackness will rub off all over my body.

When Kala, Lord of Death, comes
With rope and rod
And tries to catch me with His noose,
I will smear the black ash

From my body onto His face!

How can I, who have contained Kali within me,
Be caught in the hand of Death?
Chanting the Name, "Kali,"
I will mock at Kala!

The Holy Mother continued singing the refrain (first verse above). The tempo reached its heights. All of a sudden the Mother got up from her seat and began dancing blissfully and rhythmically. This continued for some time. Then she moved toward the coconut groves and slowly disappeared in the darkness. Everyone got up to watch her but continued singing the same song in the same tempo a little while longer. Nobody went near the Mother as everyone felt that it was better to leave her alone when she was in this kind of ecstatic state. Through the darkness everyone could see the white clothes of the Mother. She now walked like one who was in oblivion. Her steps faltered. The fear that she might hit herself against a coconut tree made Gayatri and a few *brahmacharins* move toward her and keep a watchful eye on her. At one point she threw herself on the ground, which was wet from the rain, and started rolling around. Her infinite inner bliss manifested itself as continuous joyful laughter. Sometimes she clapped her hands and raised them skyward. The fingers of both her hands held two different divine *mudras*. The Mother made a noise with her tongue which sounded like the peculiar sound of

satisfaction and contentment which one makes after having tasted something very delicious. She was completely lost to this world. The Mother remained in this enchanted spiritual mood for a very long time.

One would wonder if it were the same person, who sported like a small little child on the seashore and later in the game *Chakka Kali*, who now became so immensely intoxicated with Divine Bliss.

Slowly the Mother's body became still. She remained lying for a while longer. Gayatri went near her and made sure that she had returned to her normal mood. She then sat down near the Holy Mother. The *brahmacharins* also got closer and sat on either side of her. In a few minutes the Mother sat up and remained seated.

The time was nine-forty-five. The residents and the other devotees had their supper of *kanji*. The Mother came to the kitchen and sat down on the bare floor. She had a few balls of rice from the food sent by a woman devotee. It looked as if it were only to fulfill the devotee's wish that she ate. The Mother fed all the children who were there at that time with the remaining rice. Immediately after that, the Mother lay down with her head on the lap of a girl who sat next to her.

Markus, the devotee from Germany, was also sitting close by. The Mother asked him, "Markus, chirp like a pigeon." Being a good mimic, Markus did so. Then the Mother said, "Next like a crow." He did that as well, followed by other different sounds like the barking of a dog, howling of a jackal, meowing of a

cat, etc. The Mother and the others enjoyed this and continuously burst into laughter. Hearing Markus imitating these different sounds, Harshan also was inspired. He too started making some sounds. There was a chain of laughter for a long time.

Leaving the kitchen, the Mother once again went to the coconut groves where she lay on the wet sand till ten thirty. It seemed that the Mother was struggling to keep her mind in this world. That unknown world, where nobody else had access, and where she was all alone at all times, lay far beyond this plural world of happenings.

Through the impregnable silence of the night flowed the sweet melody which emerged out of Markus' flute. When it was eleven o'clock the Mother went to her room followed by Gayatri and Kunjumol. Thus, one more day with the Mother had passed.

5 April 1984

Another day begins. Each day with the Holy Mother has its own charm and resplendence. A new, unique chapter begins; it is never boring. An ever-fresh feeling of enchantment and serenity surrounds the Mother irrespective of time and place. Whoever comes to that Presence can drink in as much as he or she wants. This ocean of beatified splendor, its holiness, its depth, its vastness and infinitude are for us to enjoy and experience. The Mother invites us most lovingly with overflowing compassion, stretching her

arms to each one of us. Let us go running and lock ourselves in that heart-soothing embrace of Divine Love and Beauty.

At nine o'clock in the morning the Mother summoned all of the *brahmacharins* upstairs into her room. Once in a while she calls all of them together and gives them some general instructions concerning their *sadhana*, their work (each one has a definite work prescribed), their behavior toward others, principles of spirituality in their lives at the Ashram, and other pertinent matters. Sometimes she would point out a resident's error during this time, if it was repeatedly committed.

To the assembled group of *brahmacharins*, the Mother spoke,

Amma: Children, you have all the proper circumstances to do your *sadhana* and pursue your spiritual practices without any hindrance. Everyone will not have such an opportunity. There are many who really want to dedicate their lives to spirituality yet cannot do it. Whereas, you have plenty of time to do it. Utilize this opportunity provided by the Lord to the utmost. If you do not, you will be cheating the great tradition of spirituality. This Ashram is the best place for you to fight and test your strength. If you win the struggle here, you can go anywhere in this world and you will not have to fear anything at all. However, you must strive hard to attain that state. You may feel that these rules and regulations are a bit difficult to follow,

but remember that this bondage which you experience now is to make you completely free in the future. If you had remained in the world, you would have been bound by the objects of the world. That bondage would lead you to more and more slavery and sorrow. But the bondage you feel here will help free you from all bondages in the future. Those who have real love for God and who are intent on the goal (*lakshya bodha*) will not feel this bondage. For them, this is the most suitable place to lead a happy and blissful life in doing their *sadhana* and performing selfless service to society and ailing humanity.

Look, children, Mother does not insist that any one of you stays here. The choice is yours. Therefore, the question is whether you want to minimize your enjoyments for some time in order to experience everlasting happiness. Or perhaps you not only want to minimize your external pleasures but you still want to indulge to the maximum and suffer. You are free to do both.

There are some people who say, "Let me enjoy the pleasures and then when it is time I will take up spirituality." Children, there is no such particular time to turn to spiritual life. A person's determination is the deciding factor. If you are waiting for old age to come after you have finished enjoying all the worldly pleasures, that is the worst period of time to do anything spiritual. In old age, you may want to think of God, but it will be too late as the mind will have lost all its

flexibility. The mind will become a storehouse of the past, filled with all kinds of thoughts. At that time, you can do nothing except simply lie down and recall past events, chewing the cud like a cow does, so to speak. You will simply lie down, watching the past on the screen of the mind. You will not be able to see the Lord's form as your eyes will lose their power of seeing. You will not be able to sing the Lord's glory properly. Old age will damage the throat. You will not have any teeth to correctly pronounce the words of the hymns or chants. You will not even be able to hear *bhajans* or other hymns or chants clearly, for your power of hearing will fail. Even to offer a few flower petals in front of the Lord's picture will become difficult because your hands will be trembling due to old age. Above all, the mind will become like a trash can. Even if you want to do any of these things, the mind will not let you do it. Even if you do manage to do something in this period of your life, it will only be mechanical. The mind will not cooperate at all. That means that there will not be any concentration. What is the use if you do spiritual practices without concentration?

Some say that *sannyasa* is to be taken after *grahasthashrama*. Who is a real *grahasthashrami*? A real *grahasthashrami* is one who leads an ashram life while living in his home, that is, one who leads a well-disciplined life even while leading a family life. Most people are mere *grahasthas*, not *grahasthashramis*. The latter is equal to a real *sannyasin* if he or she leads a life of self-

sacrifice and love. He is not selfish. He is not one who is totally enmeshed in the net of attachments and aversions. All of his or her attachment is to God, not to the world. For him the world is a means to attain God. The world is not a problem for him at all. If someone leads such a life, even if he or she is a *grahasthashrami*, one can attain God-Realization. But how many of those who live in the world lead such a life? It is difficult to find such *grahasthashramis* in this age.

Therefore, children, this is a God-given opportunity for you. You are fortunate to turn towards spiritual life at such a young age. Above all, you have Mother with you. Do your *sadhana* as best as you can and leave the rest in the hands of God. Try to observe and find out how competent you are. If you feel that it is difficult for you to continue here, children, you have all the freedom to quit the Ashram. But Mother will not allow anyone to act and behave against the principles of spirituality while staying here. A true spiritual life cannot be achieved by leading a life of pleasure. It solely depends on renunciation and penance.

There was utter silence for some time. Each person's eyes were fixed on the Mother. She looked at her children and gave a compassionate smile which soothed their hearts and souls. The Holy Mother got up from her seat and went up to each of the *brahmacharins*, who were all standing now. Fondly patting each of her children on the shoulder, she also lovingly caressed and gently rubbed the forehead of each

one. Her smile and this most affectionate touch made each of them feel very blissful. This inner feeling of joy was quite evident on their faces. Afterwards she called Gayatri and asked her to bring something to distribute as *prasadam* to her children. Gayatri brought some bananas. She gave a piece of *prasadam* to each person. She washed her hands with the water which Gayatri brought and proceeded to walk out of the room. As she went through the doorway, the Mother said in a very humble tone, "Forgive Mother if she has inadvertently said something which hurt her children."

This humility of the Mother always keeps her children aware of the need to be humble in spirituality. This is how she teaches her children. After saying something, she simply does not walk away. The Mother sets an example by doing what she says. She not only talks about self-sacrifice and love, but the Mother herself lives it. This is a great source of inspiration for those who come into contact with her.

Although the Mother expressed her humility through the humble statement above, the truth is that even the most severe scolding of the Mother has a sweetness of its own. Moreover, the so-called "scoldings" are not mere scoldings but real *satsang* (spiritual teaching). If somebody feels a little pain at all, by the mere touch and compassionate look from the Mother, the pain will melt away like an ice cube in the sun. She sometimes scolds someone for making a

mistake repeatedly. Through her words and manner she will make him feel that she is very angry with him so that that person will always remember and not make the mistake ever again. But the person who has received the scoldings will sometimes feel a little pain for being scolded by the Mother. In this case too, the Mother's medicine has an incredible power to heal his hurt mind. It is so simple. A few moments later, maybe a few hours later (but rarely days later), she will walk up to that person and smile at him, graciously touching him on the shoulder or patting his back. She will lovingly say, "My son," "My daughter," or "My child." Lo and behold! His mental pain and heavy-heartedness will disappear. Not only that, he or she will become immensely blissful.

A well-known *sannyasin* once came to the Ashram. His intention was just to see the Mother, spend a couple of hours in the Ashram and leave. But once he had the Mother's darshan, he could not go. He postponed going until the next day. The next day came and again he postponed it until the following day. He behaved like a two-year-old child when he was in front of the Mother. Strongly attracted to her, he became inordinately attached. If she did not look at him, he would not eat. He would sit alone and cry like a baby if the Mother did not say at least one word to him. He acted like one who had lost his senses, like one gone "mad." Such was his love for the Holy Mother.

One day the Mother was conversing with some of the *brahmacharins* about certain matters concerning

the Ashram. The *sannyasin* entered without asking permission. He had done the same on several previous occasions, but the Mother had kept quiet. This time, however, in a serious and very strict tone, she said, "Swami-mon, please go out. Don't you know that it is impolite to enter without permission?" The *swami* turned pale. Immediately he went out. Later the Mother found him sitting in front of the temple verandah; he was crying. The Mother approached him and again spoke to him without showing any love,

Amma: Swami-mon, look here, you are a *sannyasin*. You should not become weak-minded like this. It is people like you who should set an example to these *brahmacharins* through your words and deeds. The whole world might shout at you, speak ill of you, abuse you, fabricate tales about you and criticize you, but a real *sannyasin* will stand still. There will not even be a ripple in the mind of a real *sannyasin*. He would be unshakable. All criticism and insults should crumble into pieces as they hit against his strong mind. Look at the ochre clothes you are wearing. This means that you have gone beyond body-consciousness. Even if you have not attained that state, in order to set an example for others, a *sannyasin* should not express such weak-mindedness outwardly. He should be like a lion, not like a sheep.

The Mother's voice was very powerful. She was serious too. Having said this to him, she walked away

without uttering another word. The swami became totally upset. He could not contain himself sufficiently to withstand the Mother's words. He wept like a child. The *brahmacharin* who translated the Mother's words tried to console him but failed.

An hour passed. The swami still sat in the same place in front of the temple verandah. The Mother once again passed by. This time she approached the swami, smiled at him, rubbed his chest and said just one sentence, "Son, after all, it's your Amma, isn't it?" Without another word, she went to her room.

The *brahmacharin* who was present observed the swami's face, which revealed that he was in total bliss, in ecstasy. Due to overwhelming inner joy he could not even speak. A big smile beamed on his face and as he faithfully kept his hand on his heart, cherishing that spot where the Mother had bestowed her magic touch, he said, "What is this? What has happened? All the heaviness has gone. I feel very light and relaxed. I want that touch once more. I want that touch once more." He repeated this again and again. One could clearly see that his heart was filled to the brim. This one-touch-cure for mental agony is a familiar "miracle" among the Mother's devotees.

After the meeting with the *brahmacharins*, the Mother came down the steps. Now it was nearly ten-thirty in the morning and she went to the front verandah of the temple where a householder devotee was performing the reading of the *Srimad Bhagavatam*. She sat

there for some time. Acchamma, the grandmother, sat in a corner making garlands and listening to the reading simultaneously. The devotee was reading the part where the childhood sports of Sri Krishna were depicted. Acchamma seemed to be enjoying it very much. Hearing the stories of how Krishna stole milk and butter from the houses of the *Gopis*, Acchamma laughed loudly, showing her toothless gums, and commented, "Little thief." The Mother threw an appreciating glance at her innocent faith and devotion.

At this time a group of nearly twenty young men came to visit the Ashram and to meet the Holy Mother. They were all taken to the small hall which was situated on the south side of the temple. This was the classroom in which the *brahmacharins* were taught the scriptures. Mats were spread and they all waited for the Mother to come. The whole group of young men was undergoing a training about how to extract cooking gas from cowdung.

The Holy Mother came and sat in front of them on another mat. Then she found that some of them were sitting on the bare floor. She exclaimed, "Oh, my children, don't you have a mat to sit? Don't sit on the cold cement floor. It is not good." The Mother stood up and took the mat on which she was sitting. She herself went with the mat in her hands to that spot where they were sitting. The young men were perplexed and at the same time amazed to see her humility and her natural way of treating them. They got up from their seat and said, "No, Mother, no. We will sit on the floor. You please sit on that."

The Mother replied, “No, children, Mother is used to it. She can sit and be anywhere.” By that time, another mat was brought for the young men. The Mother asked the *brahmacharins* to spread that one for her. The *brahmacharin* showed a little hesitation to do that as the mat which he brought was not a very good one. He wanted to give it to the visitors and get the Mother’s mat back as it was a special one particularly meant for her. The Mother understood his mind and said strictly, “Don’t you hear me? Spread that mat for me.” The *brahmacharin* helplessly did so. The Mother made the young men sit on her mat and she sat on the other one.

When everyone was seated, the Mother asked, “Children, are all of you interested in spirituality?” Several of them gave positive answers. The Mother described the Ashram and the principles for which it stands. In conclusion, she explained,

Amma: It is not to make them stay here permanently that Mother brings up these children. One day or other they will have to go out and serve the world without expecting anything. Mother’s wish is to provide some real servants to the world. Now they cannot be sent out. They need to be molded. They need mental strength and balance to confront the different situations which they will have to face in the world. Mother thinks that these children will love and selflessly serve the people who are in the scorching heat of worldly problems; that is why she loves them.

One of the young men: Isn't there *grahasthashrama* (the second stage of life as a householder) and *vana-prastha* (the third stage of life, going to the forest for penance) before *sannyasa*? Isn't *sannyasa* the final stage of life? Why should these young men renounce everything now at this age?

Amma: Children, in the olden days whatever was the path chosen by an individual, it was only a means to attain God. Even married life was considered as another path to God. They maintained that purity throughout their life. Before getting married, most people spent ten to twelve years with a Guru learning and practicing spirituality. Then after coming out of the *gurukula* (the Guru's hermitage) they entered the next stage of life. Some continued as *brahmacharins* and became *sannyasins*, and others who desired to have a family got married and became *grahasthashramis*. It all depends on one's mental maturity and spiritual disposition inherited from the previous birth.

Suppose many people study music in a music college. They all learn the same lessons under the same teacher. The time they get is also the same. But you can see that some of them become real masters in that field. Some others don't. Why? It all depends on the predominant nature or innate tendency that one has. Just a push is sufficient for such people to become that. A mere touch is enough for them, and they will be on the right track.

Using force, external force, will stunt spontaneous

growth of a person. Of course, one should be corrected if he or she happens to swerve from the right path. Mother talks about those who have certain talents in and inclinations towards a particular field. Such people should be provided with the necessary circumstances for their inner growth. For example, if somebody shows great interest in painting, he should be encouraged to pursue painting. The parents or teachers should not force him to become a musician. If he is forcibly enrolled in a music college, he will be a failure. He cannot become a good musician because his innate tendency is to become a painter. Each person's *vasana* is different. That is how one person becomes an engineer, another a doctor, someone else an actor or a musician, etc. In the same way, those who have a spiritual inclination will become a seeker of truth. If you force such a person to become a lawyer or something for which he has no inclination, he will not be able to do it. It is unnatural for him.

Just as everything is not over when you are enrolled as a student in a music college, spiritual life is not completed just because you come and stay in the Ashram. Constant practice, always keeping the enthusiasm and interest at its peak, will only help to reach the goal. Therefore, son, it is not you or Mother who decides what people should become, the deciding factor is their accumulated tendencies.

Mother has tried several times to send them back to their houses and to find a job, but they wouldn't go. Therefore, Mother thinks that it is predestined for

them to be renunciates. Once they take refuge and surrender, it is Mother's duty to take care of them. In the olden days, *grahasthashramis* would have one or two children. Once the children were capable of standing on their own feet, the husband and wife would enter the third stage of life, *vanaprastha*, after having entrusted all the family responsibilities or official responsibilities in an appropriate manner to their children. During this period, they did severe penance and attained the fourth stage of life, *sannyasa*, the state of desirelessness. All that they had done previously while living in the world was only for the attainment of this goal. Their whole life was a preparation for this goal. Children, is this how people live today? Is it possible to attain this state while living at home? We all live our individual lives, but the attitude in which we approach our goal is the determining factor.

Is there selfless love in worldly life? What benefit does the world get from selfish people? How many times more is the benefit that the world gets from a real *brahmacharin* whose life is dedicated to selfless service than from a selfish person who is concerned only with himself. If you really look with an impartial and discerning eye, you can see that it is people who are established in *brahmacharya* who do real benefit to the world.

If there is a good ashram, the people who live in the world, that is, the *grahasthas*, will get solace and succor from it. *Tapasvis* and *brahmacharins* are always benefactors of the world.

Children, you ask why they should renounce everything now. Spirituality is not something that should be begun when you are old and weak. You will not be able to do any kind of spiritual practices at that time as you will become weak mentally, physically and intellectually. It should be commenced when you are young and your sense organs are strong. Old age is the most disorderly part of life when nobody can do anything creative.

Question: Don't the children have a duty towards their father and mother?

Amma: What duty, son? Doing good to the world is the biggest and greatest duty. This world is the biggest family. God is our real Father and Mother. Our real duty towards Him is serving and loving the poor and needy selflessly. The family consisting of a husband, wife and two children is the smallest fraction of this big family. Looking after the smallest fraction is nothing. That is narrowing down. On the other hand, by loving and serving the world family, the so-called "family" will also get a share of our selfless service. If we are only looking after the immediate family, neither they nor the world will be benefited. What Mother means is that regardless of how much we serve or love our family there will be only dissatisfaction and discontent. Whereas, it is through real service to the world that the family also gets real benefit. The *sannyasins* perform this duty much better than the *grahasthas*.

Not only that, the families of the *brahmacharins* who stay here have enough money to live. There are

also other brothers and sisters to look after the parents. So is it necessary for them to stay in the house only to make money? It has never been known that anybody has ever taken their worldly achievements with them when they died.

Children, look here, two days ago somebody who visited the Ashram was telling Mother about his life. He was a very wealthy man, a millionaire. He was afflicted by a severe ulcer on his foot. It was badly infected. Pus and blood were oozing out all the time. He was not even able to get up from his bed. There was nobody to look after him. Even his own children and wife had abandoned him. Therefore, he decided to give some of his property to a charitable institution as a gift. Hearing this news, his children gathered together and got a doctor's statement certifying that their father was insane. They forcefully seized him and committed him to a lunatic asylum after having beaten him up severely. This man, who was a millionaire, has nothing now. He is completely broken down. In tears he narrated this to Mother. This is the kind of love that worldly people have. The *brahmacharins* who stay here are trying to know the Self without taking up this worldly path.

It seemed that the young men were all happy. They all got up to leave. All of a sudden, the Holy Mother walked towards the row in the rear. She approached a young man. The Mother caught hold of his hand and asked, "Do you have something to tell Mother?"

The young man was very surprised. In front of all the others he replied in a surprised tone, "Mother, it

is really surprising to know that you understood my heart's wish. I am going through a very hard time. I wanted to confide all those problems to you and get some instructions about how to confront them. Mother, please allow me a few minutes to talk to you."

The Mother took him to the coconut grove and conversed with him, sitting in a shady place. While he was talking with the Mother, one of his friends had a talk with Brahmacharin Pai to whom he revealed, "Actually, on our way to the Ashram, he told me that he would like to have a talk with the Mother if it was possible. He has many problems. It is quite surprising that the Mother clearly understood him. I don't understand how it happened."

Pai replied, "It cannot be otherwise; that is the answer. The Mother is like a mirror. Our sincere prayers will simply reflect in her." The young man said, "Anyhow, we are all very impressed by her."

The Mother finished talking with him. He joined the group with a smiling face. Just then three Christian women came to see the Mother. One of them had visited the Ashram several times before and had several experiences. Today she brought two others with her. The other two newcomers were mother and daughter. The older of the newcomers (the mother) told her tale of woe to the Holy Mother. She had four children, including the one who came with her. Her husband had left her and was living with another woman. Sobbing and shedding copious tears, the lady

prayed that the Mother straighten out her family problems. "Otherwise, I will commit suicide," she said.

The young men who were about to leave saw this scene. The Mother had talked to them about the nature of family life only a few moments ago. Now they witnessed an example with their own eyes. It seemed as if it had been especially arranged for them.

Amma: Daughter, does he ever come home?

Woman devotee: Yes, he came yesterday, but I didn't speak to him.

Amma: No, no, daughter, that should not be your attitude. You should speak to him. You should be loving to him. Otherwise, his enmity will increase.

The Mother consoled her and wiped her tears with her own hands. Her daughter was also crying. The Mother lovingly caressed the daughter's head and said, "Child, don't cry. If you cry, your mother will become very sad and mentally weak. You should try to console her." The Mother entered the temple and returned with *prasadam* for them. Giving that to the lady she once again consoled her. The lady's daughter had a burn on her foot. It was infected. The Mother soothed the wound with her hands and put some medicine on it.

A few minutes before they left, some fishermen arrived. They waited for the Mother to finish with the lady and her daughter. The Mother turned to the fishermen. Since they had not been able to catch any fish for many, many days, they came to seek the Mother's

blessing. The Mother gave them some tulasi leaves after having imbued it with her pure vital energy. They left happily. From experience they knew what to do with it.

The Mother literally lives within her own saying, “Mother is the servant of all.” She always serves everyone who comes to her without any difference. She expects nothing. Neither can we repay her. The debt to the Guru always remains as a debt. No one can repay it. The most one can do is to sincerely follow in the footsteps of the Guru, to apply in one’s own life those principles by which she lives. The Mother says,

Amma: One can say that God and I are One, but one cannot say I and my Guru are One. The Guru is far beyond everything, even the Trinity. The Mother makes her children lead a life based on spiritual principles by inspiring them to remember God and thereby lead a life of selfless service and love.

How many people, who had previously lived an utterly selfish life, have beautified their own lives with the fragrance of selflessness and love for humanity through the Mother’s touch of Grace?

The Mother says,

Amma: Mother wants people to work hard to attain spiritual bliss. She does not want people to idle away their time in the name of spirituality. While people come to Mother for varied reasons, she will somehow

make them remember God. She doesn't want her children to chant the Lord's Name simply with their lips. Mother wants them to chant it with their hearts and live in the Lord's Name. Devotion is not simply doing *pradakshina* (circumambulation) around the temple, chanting "Krishna, Krishna" and then kicking the destitute beggar who asks for alms as you come out. The compassion and love that you show to the beggar is the real devotion to God. This is what the Mother wants her children to do.

The bell rang. It was time for lunch. The Holy Mother's elder sister Kasturi arrived with her two children, Shivan and Vishnu. Kasturi wanted the Mother to perform the first feeding to her second son, Vishnu. An oil lamp was lit. In a few minutes the Mother was sitting on the front verandah of the temple with Vishnu on her lap. She applied sacred ash on the forehead, chest and upper arms of the child. The Mother offered a few flower petals on the child's head. She waved camphor in front of the child. All the while she kept the child on her lap. The Mother then fed the child with her own hands. The child had a big smile on his face. He happily smacked and swallowed the few grains of rice which the Mother gave him. Raising one of his hands, the child caught hold of the Mother's *rudraksha* rosary and tightly held it up for a while, gazing at the Mother's face with the same big smile on his face.

Amma: Hey, little boy, what do you want, *rudraksha*

or rice, or do you want both?

Everyone present felt that the Mother asked the child if he wanted spiritual life or worldly life or did he want to become a *grahasthashrami*. It seemed that she was ready to give any of the aforesaid if the child asked. In a subtle sense, the child might have responded to her question and the Mother might have given it as well. Who knows?

6 April 1984

This morning one *brahmacharin* narrated an experience he had the morning of the previous day. The Holy Mother had asked him to make his *sadhana* more intense. She instructed him to get up at two a.m. and perform his meditation and other practices until six o'clock. He was happy to do it.

Amma: In the beginning you may find it a little difficult to get up at that odd hour of the night. It will become easy for you to do so once it becomes a habit.

The *brahmacharin* had doubts about whether he could do it or not. Therefore, he looked at the Mother's face and in a prayerful tone begged, "Mother, I have no power to do it. Please shower your Grace upon me so that I can sincerely follow your instructions without fail." The Mother encouraged him and furthermore said, "Son, don't worry about getting up at two. Tomorrow Mother will call you at two

o'clock." He thought that the Mother would come to his room at two in the morning and call him. But suddenly he realized that it was a Thursday when Mother spent the whole night in *Devi Bhava*. He ran different thoughts through his mind about how the Mother was going to call him. "Is she going to come to my room in *Devi Bhava*? Or is she going to send someone to call me? Or would the Mother finish *Devi Bhava* before two and come to call me?" Since it was a crowded day with so many people who came to behold the Mother as the Divine Mother, the *brahmacharin* did not get another chance to talk to the Mother to clarify this detail.

Though his faith in the Mother and her words were unshakable, yielding to human nature and its doubting tendencies, the *brahmacharin* borrowed an alarm clock from another resident and set it at two before he went to bed at eleven o'clock. The *Devi Bhava* was still going on. Judging from the big crowd awaiting to receive *darshan* from the Holy Mother, he estimated that it would easily go till three-thirty or four. Once again he sincerely prayed to the Mother and slept peacefully.

The *brahmacharin* was awakened by the sudden sensation of something falling on his face. Simultaneously, the alarm went off, which startled him. He turned on the light and searched for the thing which fell on his face. He was wonderstruck to see the object. It was a small, framed picture of the Holy Mother which was kept inserted between the thatched coconut leaves which formed the walls of the hut. The

brahmacharin slept with his head towards the wall, almost touching it. The time was exactly two. Thus the first day of his two o'clock *sadhana* started as instructed by the Holy Mother. He became more and more amazed when he remembered the way she woke him up at two. She had kept her promise. It was quite obvious that it was none other than the Mother who woke him up by making her own picture fall on his face. The *Devi Bhava* was still going on.

He was very anxious to share this experience with others. But he felt a bit sad later when Mother told him, "Son, if you had believed Mother's words and not set the alarm, Mother would have come to you in person, getting up in the middle of *Devi Bhava*. By setting the alarm, you proved that you were double-minded, that your faith was incomplete."

Today the Holy Mother once again summoned all the residents, this time to the meditation hall. The Mother talked about different things. The meeting was mainly meant to fix a timetable for performing the daily routine of the residents.

Amma: Children, to derive the full benefit of any action, whatever it may be, love for that particular action is absolutely necessary. Without this factor of love, your actions will be found lacking. Meditation should be performed with love. Chanting of the *Gita* also should be done with love. Performance of an action without love is a sin. In the same way, it is equally a sin to do a work hesitantly. Whether it is meditation or some other action, if work is performed with a

negative attitude, misfortunes will occur in the Ashram. It is the duty of each one of you to do it. The amount of interest and intensity that you put forth will show the sincerity and love that you have towards the Ashram and Mother.

Even to enjoy smoking one must have love. If one does not have love for it, he will not enjoy smoking at all. We can see some people holding their noses and running away from places where people smoke. There are others who will cough and vomit if they happen to smell the smoke of cigarettes. Whereas, those who like it enjoy smoking and they will take in the aroma as much as they can. Love for an object or action is the most important factor which inspires you to act. Dislike or lack of love makes you refrain from acting or show less interest in performing an action.

Children, you should try to develop this attitude of love for your *sadhana*. Your attitude should be, "Not enough, this is not enough. I should do more." The attitude, "if only circumstances could be better," should be given up. Don't waste your time walking around and talking unnecessarily. Do your *sadhana* punctually and sincerely. That is your duty now. Have the readiness to undertake any work which is for the common good with love. Don't say, "I will do only this work, not that one. I like to do this work and dislike to do the other one." This is not a good attitude, as far as a seeker is concerned. Undertaking or doing a work which you like is not at all a big thing. Anyone can work on something which he or she likes. There is

no greatness in it. For example, you like to do gardening but you don't like to remove the cowdung and clean the cowshed. You like to cook but you don't like to wash the dishes. You like to serve food but you dislike removing the leftovers. A worldly man can have this attitude, but a spiritual seeker should not. A spiritual seeker should perform any action with equanimity of mind, rising above personal preferences. You love and caress a charming, good-looking child but you feel aversion towards an ugly-looking child who is born in a low caste. These distinctions are common among worldly people, for they dwell in the world of likes and dislikes. Remember that the sole purpose of your life is to transcend these distinctions, all likes and dislikes.

Readiness and willingness to do any work at any time in any circumstance is the hallmark of spirituality. Spiritual people do it with love and sincerity, without expecting anything. That is why there is always a charm and beauty in whatever spiritual people do. They love to do the work because the work itself gives them infinite happiness. Whereas, we are concerned more about the result, and in that worry about the result, the work loses all its beauty. The factor of love is absent in our actions.

Now the Mother concentrated on figuring out a timetable for the daily routine of the residents. At this time she noticed one *brahmacharin* shaking his legs unnecessarily. She said,

Amma: This is a sign of mental restlessness and impatience. A *sadhak* should learn to sit without moving his hands and legs unnecessarily. It is a habit. He should also not look here and there unnecessarily. Such movements are done by people who have no concentration. You might have seen people who constantly bite their nails and those who simply sit, turning around and around the button on their shirt. These are cases of mental restlessness or impatience. It is also a kind of mental disease. Spiritual aspirants will try to overcome the mind and its habits. They should not be enslaved by such base habits.

Almost all worldly people have the habit of shaking their legs unnecessarily while seated on a chair. A *sadhak* should not do this. As much as possible, a seeker should sit in an *asana* (a sitting yogic posture) on the floor. Sit in an *asana* even if the opportunity arises for you to sit in a chair.

Before making the mind still, try hard to still the body. It does not mean that you should spend your time idling without doing anything. No, that is not what is meant. Unnecessary movement of your hands and legs and other parts of the body should be avoided.

THE BLISS-INTOXICATED DIVINE MOOD

At six-thirty in the evening the residents began the

singing of *bhajans*. After a few songs, Brahmacharin Balu started singing *Saranagati* (O Mother, Give Refuge). By the time the Holy Mother came to join in, the same song was still being sung since it was a long *bhajan*. She took over the lead singing.

O Light that illumines the whole Universe
And even the sun, moon and the stars;
O Primordial Nature,
Governess of the entire Universe,
O Universal Mother, who is the Incarnation
Of pure and selfless Love,
This destitute cries for Thy vision
With a heart endowed with intense yearning.

The Mother was unusually enraptured with the bliss of Divine Love. She swayed vigorously from side to side, back and forth. An inexpressible and indescribably beautiful blending of the diverse aspects of supreme devotion and love slowly manifested in the Mother. It enveloped each and every person present. Through the Divine voice of the Holy Mother the song attained wings. It soared up and flowed like a never-ending stream as the song continued,

O Mother, the ocean sings Thy Glory
Through the resounding of the Sacred Syllable,
Aum...one after the other,
Each and every wave dances gleefully
In time with the Pranava, the Primordial

Sound,
Aum...

With a voice full of feeling and a heart full of longing, the Mother called out, “Amme...Amme...” Her eyes were fixed on the sky above and her hands were out-stretched. The Mother’s call was so full of love and authenticity that it gave the feeling to everyone that the Divine Mother Herself was standing in front of the Holy Mother. The Mother sang out,

O Mother Divine, Thou art beyond
The scriptural verses of Purushasuktha
(Scriptural text which glorifies the
Universal Being).
O Mother, Thou art beyond the Brahmasutra
(Scriptural text which describes the
Absolute Brahman).
O Mother, even transcending all the four Vedas,
O Mother, Thou alone knowest Thee indeed.

At this point the Mother started laughing, an external expression of her inner bliss. This mysterious laughter persisted as the *brahmacharins* continued singing. The Mother clapped her hands like a little child and immediately raised both hands above her head. Now the laughter stopped, but her hands remained in the uplifted position for a while. The fingers of each hand displayed two different divine *mudras*. A beatific glow illumined her face. Bringing her hands down, the

Mother again sang,

O Mother, seeking Thee, this child will cry,
Wandering along the shores of many seas;
O Mother, to each and every particle of sand
This child inquires about Thee.
O stars, glittering in the vast blue sky,
Did any one of you see my Mother
Passing through this way?

The Mother sang these lines repeatedly, over and over again. The shawl which covered her head had fallen down as Gayatri tried to place it back into position. Strands of her hair fell loose around her neck and gently swirled around as her head swayed with the rhythm of the music. Tears trickled down her cheeks. Raising her hands up, the Mother went on calling, “Amma...Amma...Amma...” This went on until finally she burst into a flood of tears, but the next moment the Mother took a long, deep breath and became still. Her hands still manifested divine *mudras*. The *brahma-charins* went on singing,

O my Mother Bhairavi, there is no shore
Where I have not searched for Thee,
O Mother, my darling Mother,
Bliss-embodied One,
No time exists when I have not sought for
Thee,
O my Beloved Mother, for aeons and aeons
Hast Thou hid from me,

This poor child of Thine.
O Compassionate One, why dost Thou delay
To shower Thy Grace upon this child?

In the light of the burning oil lamp everyone could see the radiant face of the Holy Mother. No sign of external consciousness was evident. Saturated with divinity, the atmosphere evoked spontaneous meditation in the minds of all who were present, devotees and residents alike. One could easily discern that they were all singing with their minds fully fixed on the object of their meditation. Some sang with their minds totally focused on their Beloved Deity, shedding tears of bliss, while others sat unmoving, deeply absorbed in profound meditation. Struggling to bring her mind down to the physical plane of consciousness, the Holy Mother once again sang,

O Mother,
On Thy fingertips revolve hundreds,
Nay, millions of universes;
How is it justified if Thou makest me,
This poor child, also revolve
On the same fingertips of Thine?

Again the Mother was transported to her own world of infinite bliss. She lost her control to stay in this physical plane and stood up. As she walked towards the coconut grove in her ecstatic rapture, she allowed herself to drown completely in the ocean of love and supreme devotion. Such was her God-intoxi-

cated state. Spell-bound, the *brahmacharins* and devotees continued to glorify the Divine Mother as they sang,

O Mother, come to me,
Stand in front of me today;
I wish to inundate Thy Holy Feet with my tears.
O Mother, the sound that rings in my heart,
The emergent tune from my heart
Is the call of loving devotion unto Thee.
O Mother, other than that,
I need nothing...

The *bhajan* ended with these lines. Enjoying the experience of bliss and the fervor of pure devotion and love, everyone sat immersed in meditation. Total silence prevailed, the silence of inner peace. This hallowed atmosphere hung suspended in a sacred stillness as the cool, gentle breeze floated the beckoning call of the ocean from the west.

After the *arati*, everyone's eyes and hearts reached out in search of the Holy Mother. Standing at a respectful distance, they all watched the Mother dancing in pure bliss. It felt as if the Mother was dancing all around the entire Ashram even though she was only encircling that one particular spot in the coconut grove. Completely lost to this external world in which we were standing, she reveled in her own mystical inundation of splendor.

We can only observe from the outside. But what can we say, and how can we say anything about this utterly incomprehensible and mysterious plane of consciousness?

Yatô-vacô-nivarttantê-aprâpya-manasâ-saha

From where speech along with the mind
returns, unable to reach There.

[TAITTARIYA UPANISHAD]

How many commentaries, how many interpretations have already been written about that “undiscovered country” by different scholars and philosophers and how many are yet to come? Still it remains a mystery, unexplained and unrevealed.

Supper was being served. Some left for the dining hall, leaving behind the others who stood there drinking in the nectar of this most rare and wonderful scene, forgetting themselves. The time was ten o’clock as nearly two hours had passed. The Mother was still in the Divine Mood, but her physical movements gradually slowed down. By now the devotees and residents were all sitting down. Some meditated while others steadily gazed at the figure in the coconut grove. The Holy Mother lay down on the sand among the palm trees. Moments of abated breath passed in utter silence. As if to espy this unearthly, enchanted scene, the glittering stars peeped through the canopy of coconut leaves. Another half hour passed and the

Mother's voice again filled the air and the hearts of devotees with *Anandamayi Brahmamayi...*

O Blissful One, O Absolute One,
O Blissful One, O Absolute One,
Whose form is of unsurpassed beauty
O Blissful One, O Absolute One.

Devotees have always found this particular composition of the Mother's especially enchanting and were overjoyed to hear her continue, *A ra dharangal...*

Crossing the six mystical centers,
The yogis come to know Thee,
The Invaluable Treasure.
Thy Glory, O Infinite Power,
Is only slightly known to them.

The song echoed in the atmosphere. It seemed that the Mother, who had gone beyond, transcending all the six *adharas* (mystical centers), was struggling hard to bring her mind down to this world of plurality. From wherever she operated, every action and every word of the Mother's embodied a teaching. So too were her songs, as her children imbibed the lyrics of *Tripudiyum podiyayidum...*

O Mother, Who constantly dances blissfully,
I salute Thee.
The Chidakasa,
Where sits the thousand-petalled Lotus,
Wherein lies the Eternal Union of Shiva-Shakti,

Shines forth like a million suns shedding light,
At the same time in which the state of Tripudi
(The experiencer, experienced and experiencing)
Ceases to exist completely There,
At that Sahasrara, the thousand-petalled Lotus,
O Mother, Who constantly dances blissfully,
I salute Thee.

7 April 1984

It was three in the afternoon. The Mother was seated on the cot in the hut. The fragrance of incense permeated the entire atmosphere. Behind the Mother, on the wall of the hut, hung a large golden-yellow curtain on which the *Gitopadesha* (famous illustration of Krishna standing next to the chariot as He instructs a kneeling Arjuna) was beautifully portrayed in embroidery. There were a few devotees, both men and women, sitting on the floor close to the cot. They wanted to sit as close as they could to the Mother. The Holy Mother was conversing with them, with the never-fading smile on her face. One of them asked,

Question: Mother, can one do *sadhana* by repeating the *mantra* which was given in a dream?

Amma: Children, it is generally not good to do *sadhana* by repeating a *mantra* which one received in a dream. That *mantra* can possibly be just a feeling of the mind. It may not really help you progress spiritu-

ally. Since you have not attained the state of Perfection, whatever you feel or think may not come true. However, you may chant it after checking it with a Perfect Guru and having gotten permission from him. If *mantras* obtained through dreams are recommended, many people might proceed in that manner which will then increase the possibilities to err and fall. Therefore, it is better not to depend on *mantras* received in dreams.

Question: Mother, what is the significance of *bijaksharas* (seed letters)?

Amma: Children, *bijaksharas* symbolize the spiritual powers that are imminent in us. They have immense power. The great saints and sages, our forefathers, received them through spiritual revelations. They did not create them; they were already there in existence. Just as pearls and other precious things were there on the bottom of the ocean even before human beings found them, these *mantras* and the *bijaksharas* were already there in nature. The *rishis* through penance tuned their minds to that plane of consciousness. That is how these *mantras* and seed letters were revealed to them. Their minds became pure and clear like a crystal. In that pure mind dawned all knowledge. When we chant those *mantras* with concentration, that power will be awakened in us also. Each seed letter has a presiding deity. That deity or that aspect of spiritual power will be invoked in us when we repeat it with one-pointedness.

SELFLESS ACTION

Question: Mother, what is selfless action?

Amma: Action performed with concentration without the thought about its fruit is selfless action. Such actions are possible only when the fruits are surrendered to a higher ideal. We call that higher ideal God because only in Him can we see the perfection and balance of all the essential principles of life. We cannot see that in a limited human being. Therefore, when we sincerely do something for God, in reality, we are inspired by those higher values. Mother is not talking about people who worship God only to fulfill their desires. On the contrary, it is about people who sincerely seek God, just out of love for Him, not to gain anything from Him. Such people work inspired by the ideal. They work simply because working for that ideal gives them tremendous happiness. Similarly, when we are really devoted to a *Mahatma* or a spiritual master we work for him and his spiritual institution forgetting ourselves. We don't expect anything from that work. Why? Because we are inspired by the spiritual ideals in which the Guru constantly lives. That too is selfless action. One who selflessly acts does not grieve about the past. He does not become worried about the future. In a very relaxed mood, he works with concentration, love and dedication. His mind is not split, but is one-pointed. From such a mental attitude of one-pointedness, he derives a tremendous amount of energy. Only such people can uplift and

transform society as a whole.

Remember that when we worship a *Mahatma*, it is not his body that we worship or adore, but the higher principles which are manifested through him. He himself is an embodiment of those ideals; that is what we worship. The body is only secondary.

Again, remember that Mother is not talking about people who work for the success of a particular cult, creed, class, sect, community or nation. Their vision is still limited compared to the highest Ideal. Genuine workers are beyond and untouched by such limitations and are utterly selfless. They work solely out of love for everyone.

Question: Mother, why do you say that the body of a *Mahatma* is only secondary? Does that mean that it does not have much importance?

Amma: No, children, no. After all, the medium of the body is needed for the higher qualities to manifest. They do not have a form of their own. In reality love has no form. Only when love constantly flows through a person does it assume a form that we will be able to experience; otherwise, we cannot. Even when the *Mahatma* leaves the body people still worship the form for ages. It is just because it was through that body that all those great ideals manifested and helped us to experience it. That is the greatness of the body of a *Mahatma*. His body is also pure because it undergoes transformation and purification through his penance. His whole being is pure. It is not like the body of an ordinary human being.

Suppose there are twin brothers. They look alike. Each and every part of their body is so identical that it is very difficult to tell them apart. Their height, weight, everything is the same. Now, one of them becomes a great saint by doing severe penance and the other becomes wicked and crooked, influenced by malevolent company. People will worship and adore the saintly brother and hate the other one even though their bodies look the same. Even if the latter were a normal human being, people would not worship him like they would the brother who became a saint, although they might respect him since he was the twin brother of the saint. Their bodies look alike. Still, why do they adore the saintly brother and not the other one? It is because people feel God and experience Godly qualities such as love, equal vision, compassion, and renunciation in the saintly brother, but they do not feel those qualities in the other brother. Therefore, the qualities come first and only secondarily the body. Not that the body is insignificant. There is no doubt that a saint's body is divine too. His body is equally powerful since it is through that body that the Infinite Energy manifests with all Its glory and splendor. That body which *Mahatmas* themselves choose by their own will must have tremendous power to withstand the constant stream of *Shakti* which manifests through it.

A thousand watt bulb must have enough power to manifest that much of electricity through it. We cannot simply say, "After all, it is electricity which makes it shine." That is meaningless. Without the medium of

the bulb, electricity cannot be experienced. So the medium, the body, is equally important.

Question: Mother, what is the significance of meditation?

Amma: Children, meditation alone is beneficial. Do you know what is the position of those scholars who walk around without doing any *sadhana*? Haven't you seen people who stand as guards for somebody else's property like a paddy field or a wealthy man's estate? When these guards talk to someone, they will pose and speak as if the whole thing belongs to them. Scholars are just like that. They just walk around babbling, having heard or read the things that somebody else has said and experienced. They do not understand nor do they try to understand that those who said those things were not mere gate keepers or guards but real owners of it. The real owners are ones who have realized the inner wealth through meditation, not through mere intellectual knowledge. Whereas, those scholars, whose status is nothing more than a parrot or tape recorder, are like mere gate-keepers who pretend to be the real owner. A parrot will repeat whatever it is taught. In fact, it doesn't even know anything about the words that it repeats. Similarly, whatever is recorded in a tape-recorder will be played back when it is turned on. Such is the case with these book scholars.

In worldly life it is also the same; a peon or gate-keeper displays much more pride and arrogance than the managing director or the real owner of the com-

pany. In most cases the real owners are relatively humble and simple.

Therefore, children, those who want to make this knowledge their own must practice meditation. Meditation is not only good for spiritual aspirants but also for people in all walks of life. In a way, meditation is the only selfless action. Some kind of desire will cling to any other type of action. While doing meditation there is no such thought that somebody else should respect us and so on. As far as a true *sadhak* is concerned, meditation is only to purify his mind. That is his only thought.

People may interpret this thought of purifying the mind as a desire as well. But this desire for purification is to eliminate all other desires and thereby do selfless service to the world. The intention behind this desire is high and pure. Whereas, the intention behind almost all other desires is not so. While the desire to purify the mind destroys all other thoughts and desires, the desire to enjoy worldly pleasures redoubles the thoughts and desires, the end result of which will be sorrow and suffering.

Question: Mother, why does complete faith not come, even when human beings get various experiences?

Amma: Complete faith means Liberation. He who has complete faith is a Liberated Being. He has the full faith that God alone is, *Paramatman* alone is. Everything else is changing, momentary. He who has complete faith will experience that each and every object is

pervaded by Supreme Consciousness. Others, who have not experienced this, say that every object is pervaded by Supreme Consciousness simply because somebody else whom they respect has said so. Their words and deeds will not go together. They might say that God alone is and that one should have unconditional faith in Him. But if you watch them, you can see that they believe and take refuge in many other things and ideas. This is not complete faith. This is divided faith, having faith in the many and not in the One. Believing in many things is not faith. In fact, that is faithlessness. Faith is one-pointed, having faith in one and the same Reality. In that sense only a Self-Realized soul has real faith. All other faiths are incomplete and unreal. They have incomplete faith while attempting to attain complete faith.

Our faith is divided. It is in many, not in one. It is not one-pointed. We have faith in our body, our husband, wife, children, father, mother, car, house, etc. We believe that the body will live long, that all these people and objects are mine, mine forever. That is not faith. This kind of faith is unsteady as the objects we believe in are unsteady. This again shows the unsteady nature of our mind. A spiritual person's faith is steady and one-pointed; therefore, his mind is also steady. He does not believe in the body. His faith is in the one, changeless *Atman*, not in the changing, plural bodies. Only this kind of faith will help. But in the *Kali Yuga* it is difficult to have such faith. Even then, we should try hard to attain it.

Perfect faith comes only when there are no more

doubts, no more doubts in the existence of God, the *Paramatman*. At present we are full of doubts. Doubts are the cause of our lack of complete faith. All uncertainty should die. All beliefs in plurality should die and real faith should take its place. All arguments and conflicts should end to allow complete faith to take place. Until then, we will go on with our incomplete, little beliefs.

Mayyâvesya-mano-ye-mâm-nitya-yuktâ-upâsate |
Sraddhayâ-parayo-petâs-te-me-yuktatamâ-matâh ||

Those who have fixed their minds on
 Me,
 And who, ever-steadfast and endowed
 With Supreme faith, worship Me...
 Them do I consider Perfect in Yoga

[BHAGAVAD GITA, XII-2]

While listening to the conversations of the Holy Mother, both those who asked questions and those who sat and listened clearly experienced the most subtle aspects of the *Upanishads* and *Vedas* slowly blooming forth through her simple explanations. It was a unique experience for the visitors as well as the residents who were present.

Om jñâna-svarûpinyai-namah

Salutations to the Mother Who is the

Embodiment of True Knowledge.

FALLING DOWN FOR HER SON

9 April 1984

The Holy Mother was sitting on the northern end of the front verandah of the meditation hall at ten o'clock in the morning. Most of the *brahmacharins* sat in front of her. Gayatri and Kunjumol and a few women devotees sat behind the Mother. A few male householder devotees were also present.

Householder devotee: Amma, there is a letter from my younger son who is in Dubai. How should I reply?

Amma: When he left for Dubai this last time, Mother felt that there was going to be some problem with his job there.

Householder devotee: Your feeling was correct, Mother. He has had some serious problems with his job. He mentioned it in the letter he wrote to me. He says that it was Mother's Grace alone which helped him to straighten up the situation. It was very complicated. They even threatened him in many different ways. Mother has saved him.

Amma: This last time when he visited the Ashram, Mother wanted to give him a hint about it, but he left soon after the evening *bhajan*. Even then, Mother went with Gayatri searching for him in the dark, hoping to find him at the ferry on this side of the *kayal* (backwaters). By the time we reached the ferry he was

gone. However, while walking towards the ferry in the dark, Mother stumbled on something and fell into a ditch. This might have been another sign for the possible danger that he was going to confront. By falling into the ditch, Mother felt that the possible danger that he would have confronted was averted. God might have let him avoid it by making Mother fall down. When you write to him next time, ask him to think of God more constantly.

Question: Mother, several people have experienced the state of *nirvikalpa samadhi* (natural state of abidance). Are all of them in the same identical state or is there a difference from person to person?

Amma: Children, the state of *samadhi* is Perfection. One completely merges. There is no one to say even *Aham Brahmasmi* (I Am Brahman) in that state. Though it is said that people have the experience of Brahman, there is a difference in the power which they manifest. Krishna was not like Rama and Buddha was not like Krishna. Yet within them they will have the awareness of “I am That.” Externally, however, they will show a certain amount of limitations and differences. Two people are not needed to express one and the same *bhava*, for God manifests different *bhavas* through different forms.

Question: What about those who have attained *nirvikalpa samadhi* by doing *sadhana*?

Amma: There are people who suddenly attain that state, losing all control during the time of *nirvikalpa samadhi* without any *sankalpa* to come back. They merge in the Absolute Brahman forever, just like the

gas in a sodawater bottle goes up and merges in the atmosphere with the sound “pop” when it is opened. They wanted to attain that *samadhi*; that is why they sat in penance. Such people proceed wishing for that, and thereafter will not come back to earth since they have no individuality. Whereas, there are others, *nityamuktas* (eternally liberated ones), who will certainly keep some kind of *sankalpa* in their mind to return before leaving their body. They have an individuality of their own which they themselves have created with the help of the *sankalpa*. Even if they leave the body through *samadhi* and merge in the Absolute Consciousness, they can come back to earth again, if they want, for the benefit of the world. They can assume a form whenever they want.

One *brahmacharin* did not come for meditation at the correct time. The Mother said,

Amma: Children, you should not fail to do your daily routine. No matter how tired or sick you are, you should try to sit and meditate. That is what a really determined person does. Lying down and saying that I am sick even when only a headache comes shows your weak will. It is not fitting for an aspirant to be such. In the beginning you should develop a love for your daily routine. It should become a part of your life. If you are not able to do it at the set time, you should feel the pain of having missed it and the longing to do it. If she ever forgot to remember God even for a moment, Mother, during her *sadhana* days,

used to feel intense pain and cry to the Lord. To make up for that lost time, Mother used to do more severe and intense penance. That is the feeling you should develop.

Worldly tendencies will rise up if there happens to be a break in your *sadhana* in the beginning stages. If you want to stay in the Ashram, you should proceed towards the goal by doing *sadhana*. Children, time will not wait for you. You will not get the lost time back.

Question: Mother, many people commit suicide. Is it right to do so?

Amma: Children, people commit suicide for different reasons. Some do it because of family problems. There are many who commit suicide owing to disappointment caused by frustrated expectations. Failure in a love affair is a common reason which causes people to kill themselves. There are people who give up their lives for the sake of a common cause, for their community, class, creed or sect. This is no shortage of people who commit suicide due to love for their country. There were great warriors, valiant soldiers and rulers who committed suicide because they did not want to be captured or killed by their enemies. Thus there are different situations and circumstances in life when people make a decision to take their own life. Each one who commits suicide, no matter what category he falls in, will think that it is quite reasonable to commit such an act. He will think that it is the only way to escape from the problems which he confronts at that particular time; therefore, he will go

ahead and do it.

In most cases it is fear which makes one commit suicide, fear that their dignity or status in society will be lost, fear to confront the situation, fear that one might be killed by the enemy. In other words, it is mental weakness which develops the suicidal tendency in a person. Fear arises when the mind becomes weak and helpless to confront a threatening situation in life.

In any case, committing suicide is not correct. We must try our level best to confront every situation in life, using all our might and strength. Failure cannot be avoided; it is just another aspect of life. Life cannot be without success and failure. It is unavoidable, inevitable. Even if you commit suicide, the situation is not going to change. It is the nature of the sun to shine and illumine. It is the nature of the ocean to have waves. It is the nature of the river to flow. Each object has its own nature without which it would lose its very existence. This innate nature cannot be separated from the object. In the same way, it is the nature of life to have happiness and sorrow. The two are inseparable from life. Now think, why do you cry and worry about something which will not change at all? Is it not meaningless to do so?

Suppose there is a cut on your finger. Will the cut get healed if you keep looking at it and cry? No, it won't. The only way to heal it is to apply medicine and wait patiently. Again, if your hand is injured or if your leg is crippled, you do not cut off the whole

hand or leg. Nobody will do this. You will be ready to lie down on a bed for several weeks or months for the injury to be healed. You undergo the treatment, taking the prescribed medicines and wait patiently. This is what is needed in any circumstance. Putting an end to your life is not at all a solution to life's problems. You should sit somewhere, be relaxed and think properly. There is a solution to everything. You must try to find it. That needs patience. Do not lose patience; that will lead you to ruin. Patience is precious. If you think patiently, you can see many of your problems straightening up.

After all, committing suicide is not a solution for any of your problems. Remember that you are creating more problems for your family by committing suicide. Think of the trouble that they have to undergo. By killing yourself you push them into the midst of misery. Again, do you think that once you commit suicide everything ends there? No. By doing so you are creating a chain, a chain of misery. You go on extending and postponing your own evolution towards the Supreme.

Children, the life force is given by God. We have no right to put an end to it. It is against nature's law. Knowing this, if we do it, we will have to suffer for doing an unlawful act, a sin. From his treasury a good king will give gifts in cash or kind to his subjects. To misuse such a gift is improper. It is arrogance to misuse such a gift, isn't it? We have no right to use it in-

correctly. We must utilize it to accomplish good and righteous goals; otherwise, we will have to suffer. Punishment will follow any wrongdoing. In the same way, life is the gift of God. He wants us to use it to know Him, to do good and righteous actions. Instead, if we decide to put an end to it for silly and trivial reasons, this would be questioning His power. It would be misusing His gift to us. It would be arrogance on our part. He is the one who gave, He alone has the right to take it back. He alone is the one who has the right to decide when and how life should be taken. We have no power to create; therefore, we are not supposed to destroy life in any way we like.

Question: Some people commit suicide when their leader dies. Some others love their country so much that they do so when their country is in a crisis. Is this justified?

Amma: The best way to express one's love for one's leader after his death, provided that the leader had many good qualities, is by following in his footsteps and by serving society selflessly as he did, not by committing suicide. There is no meaning in committing suicide for a leader who was wicked and selfish. If somebody does that, it is just out of blind attachment to that person. That again means nothing.

Some people may commit suicide in the name of love for their country. But real patriots will not do that. They will try to contribute their part to overcome the crisis. They will try to renounce their happi-

ness for the sake of the country. Loving the country means loving the people who live there. Otherwise, there is no meaning in the saying, "I love my country." If you really love your country, love the people, serve them. Do something to eradicate their suffering. Instead, if you commit suicide, that means you do not want to do anything to solve the situation but only want to escape from it. Thus, if you analyze properly, you can find that you are more concerned about your own happiness than about your country's welfare. You don't want to be unhappy; that is why you commit suicide. By your doing so, the country loses your service.

Mahatmas leave their body in different ways. It is said that some of them left their body by consuming poison knowing that it was poison. This cannot be called suicide. They are the ones who have realized the Self. As far as they are concerned, the body is just a tool for them to use according to their wish and will. They can take it or give it up whenever they want. The body depends on them; they do not depend on the body at all. Whereas, our case is not so. We depend on the body. They control the body, and we are controlled by the body; that is the difference. They take a body for a certain purpose and leave it when the purpose is fulfilled. For them, living in the body is almost like living without a body because they are not at all attached to it. For them, the changes and sufferings of the body are the changes and sufferings of the body only. Their minds are not affected. *Mahatmas* are to-

tally detached from the body. Their body is for the world, for the people, for the devotees and disciples, but not for themselves. To cast the body off, they may choose any means. That is just like a bird flying away from its nest or cage. But for others this is not true. This human birth is very precious. Try to live this life, which is a gift from God, with intent on the goal (*lakshya bodha*). You should strive to know God.

One brahmacharin: Mother, I always have a fear of failure.

Amma: Son, Self-confidence is an important aspect that a *sadhak* should have. By “Self-confidence” we mean confidence in the Self, faith in the Self; hence, that I am the Self, everything is in this Self. In essence, having faith in the Self is having faith in God or the Guru, for the Guru is the *Atman*, the Self. With this kind of confidence or strong conviction that the Guru will guide you along the path most befitting your innate nature, the Guru will take you to the highest goal, and by the Guru’s Grace, you will come out victorious. Thus the victory will be the Self’s.

Faith and obedience in the *Satguru* will give us Self-confidence. Obedience to the Guru is very important. The Guru is the All-Pervading *Parabrahman* (Absolute Self) in human form; therefore, he is immanent. He is the Self of you and of the whole creation. Having faith in him is equal to having faith in your Self. Faith is utter obedience to the Guru. If you have that, son, then there is nothing to fear. On the other hand, disobedi-

ence to the Guru will cause the worst to happen.

There was a spiritual master who knew how to make pure gold out of certain leaves. His disciple had a desire to learn that art. He expressed his wish to the master. The master said, “No, I won’t teach that to you. A true seeker’s goal is to get rid of all desires.” The disciple’s mind became very restless. Due to this intense desire to learn the art, he could not even do his *sadhana* properly. Again and again he approached the master and requested him to teach him the art of making gold. At last, due to his insistence, the Guru taught him the art, having made him take an oath that he would never teach it to others or do it himself. After some years, the Guru left his body. The disciple stuck to his oath for some time and did not practice the art of making gold, but he could not stick to the oath for long. He finally decided to make gold. The disciple started collecting the necessary ingredients and got everything except one leaf. He searched for it everywhere but failed to find that particular leaf. Days and months went by; still he could not find it. His whole mind was fixed on finding the leaf. Finally his obsession drove him insane. From that day until his death, the poor fellow went on smelling all the leaves that he saw, wherever he was. He continued searching for the leaf. That was the result of the disobedience that he showed to his Guru.

A householder devotee came with his family to see the Mother. Their youngest son, a boy of eight or nine

years, was very close to the Mother. She caressed and played with him for a long time, making him sit on her lap. Beholding this sight, some of the residents smiled, looking at each other meaningfully. It always happened that if the Mother ever showed a special love or attention to a certain person, that person either became an ardent devotee, or in some cases, they left their hearth and home and came to stay at the Ashram permanently. Whenever such an occasion arose that the Mother showed a special affection to a particular person, the residents would say to each other, "One more hut," which meant that he or she would abandon worldly life and come to stay in the Ashram where the residents dwell in huts.

During one such occasion, the Mother said, "Mother doesn't look at children very intently. If she does, then one day or another, they will change their lives and come to spiritual life. Latent tendencies are yet to be manifested in young children. They have the ability to capture our minds. Then, if Mother's mind somehow gets fixed on them, they will change and come to spiritual life. Mother has a special feeling when she sees some people. It must be because of their inherited spiritual merits from the past birth."

Once the Mother went to the house of Mavelikara Valyammachi, a woman devotee who lives in a nearby town known as Mavelikara, about twenty-four kilometers from the Mother's Ashram. Her name is Saraswathi Amma, but everyone, including the Holy

Mother, calls her Valyammachi (elder mother). The *Gita* class was going on. Nearly a hundred children were present. The Mother felt so much love and affection for all the children. But every now and then the Mother glanced at two children. Both of them were sitting behind her, but even then the Mother would turn around and look at them. She felt a spontaneous attraction towards them. Later Valyammachi related that they were the children of a musician who was a good *sadhak* and a true devotee. As they were born to a devotee, his virtues and qualities were seen in them also.

Question: What is more important for one's spiritual growth, spiritual disposition inherited from the previous birth or the Guru's Grace?

Amma: Nothing is possible without Grace. Whether in this birth or in the previous birth or in the births yet to come, one cannot acquire a spiritual disposition without Guru's Grace. If you have any spiritual disposition inherited from the previous birth, that was also acquired through the Guru's Grace. This does not mean that self-effort is not needed. That, of course, is important. But effort is human; Grace is divine. Effort is limited; Grace is unlimited. The limited human effort can take you only to a certain extent. From that point it is the vehicle of the Guru's Grace which carries you to the goal. Do your *sadhana* sincerely with an attitude of self-surrender and love, and then patiently wait for the Grace to come. Nobody knows how or when that will happen. Through humility one can easily gain the Guru's Grace.

The time was half past twelve in the afternoon. The Mother stood up and walked towards the coconut grove. A few children from the neighboring houses were standing there, and the Holy Mother went near them. She was talking to them for quite a while, and both the Mother and the children conversed with each other laughingly. At one point the children burst into laughter, and the Mother did too. The others who remained in front of the meditation hall could not figure out the topic of their conversation as they were standing quite a distance away. The Mother was always very friendly and loving to the children and the adults who lived near and around the Ashram.

Leaving the children, the Mother went by the side of the backwaters. She stood in between two coconut trees looking at the vast sky and swinging her body slowly to either side. Her hands were clasped behind her. The children slowly walked towards her, not making any noise. They stopped when they reached a few steps behind the Mother. They simply remained there gazing at her. The Mother was oblivious to the circumstances. She did not move from that place for quite some time. Her eyes were still fixed at the sky. The children also stood there unmoving until at last the Mother looked back and smiled at them.

All these children, who were under ten, were used to seeing the Mother almost every day. Even then, this

spontaneous attraction and love which they felt towards her was something extraordinary. Even they called her “Ammachi.”

Turning around, the Mother looked at them and smilingly caressed their heads. The children looked very happy. The Mother then went to her room. The time was a few minutes past one.

At three o'clock a young man came to the Ashram. He seemed very distressed. Brahmacharin Balu was standing in front of the temple. The young man approached him and spoke, “I am Chandra Kumar from Bombay.” He spoke in Malayalam; therefore Balu asked, “But you speak Malayalam.” “Yes, I am originally from Kerala but I was brought up in Bombay,” he explained. Balu inquired, “Have you had your lunch?” and the young man affirmed, “Yes, in Kayamkulam” (a town about twelve kilometers from the Ashram).

He continued, “I would like to see the Mother. It is just to see her and talk to her that I especially came all the way from Bombay. Will I be able to meet her?” There was an anxiety in his voice.

Balu replied, “You know, it is difficult to say when she will come and when she will go. Not only that, today the Mother was here till about quarter past one.” Balu took him to the front verandah of the temple

* The *Bhagavatam* was written after the *Mahabharata*. Here the *Bhagavatam* is presented as devotion and the *Mahabharata* as the fight between the good qualities and the vicious tendencies or the fight between the higher nature and the lower nature in man. When all bad tendencies are annihilated, goodness preponderates. In such a mind, devotion arises.

and spread a mat on the floor for him to sit down.

“It will be my bad luck if I don’t see her and talk to her today,” Chandra Kumar expressed worriedly.

Balu reassured him, “Don’t worry. You will certainly get her *darshan* if you really long for it. By the way, how did you come to know about the Mother?”

Young man: I was going to tell you about that. It was quite accidental. Last week as I was returning home after work, I met a man traveling in the same train with me. He was between thirty-five and forty years of age. He was also from Kerala, so we easily began a conversation. When we stopped talking, he took a small book from his pocket and started reading it. There was a picture of the Mother inside the book. The picture attracted me very much, particularly the love and compassion which I felt in her smile and on her whole countenance. I asked him about her and he told me everything he knew about the Mother. I heard from him how his life was completely transformed after seeing the Mother. He had been addicted to drinking, smoking ganja and other bad habits. His wife and children suffered a lot because of his habits. They endured much distress. His elder brother forcibly took him to the Mother. He said that his meeting with the Mother marked the beginning of a new life. He told me that it was the Mother who saved him and his family from utter ruin. He completely gave up all his bad habits after meeting the Mother. Now he leads a happy and devoted life. He concluded the conversation saying,

“Though I was taken to the Mother by force at first, now thinking and cherishing her form are so spontaneous to me.” I got the inspiration to see the Mother from him. In fact I believe that it was God who made me meet him, because, dear brother, my family is also facing a big problem.

He paused for a while. Again looking at Balu’s face he asked, “Will I be able to see the Mother?” The young man seemed very sad and restless.

Balu was touched by the young man’s mental predicament. He said, “Let me try to find out whether the Mother will come down again or not.”

Just as he was about to get up and go, he suddenly saw the Mother coming down the stairs. He softly told the young man, “Look, the Mother is coming.” He added, “Sincere prayers always will be answered.”

The Mother, as if she knew that he was there, walked towards the young man, who was now standing in the front yard of the temple. Her white clothes danced in the cool, gentle ocean breeze. The Mother’s heart-softening and compassionate glance fell on the young man. She lovingly smiled at him, and he responded by bursting into tears. The young man fell at the Mother’s feet. As she bent down to lift him up, she wiped his tears with her own hands. The Mother took Chandra Kumar to the southern side of the temple.

He told the Mother everything he had explained to Balu. He continued as the Holy Mother listened

keenly, "Mother, my father and mother are in Bombay where I also live with them. My father is a business man and I help him in his business. I have an elder sister. She was in her final year of studies for a Home Science degree." He stopped and seemed as if gathering strength to complete the story.

The Holy Mother lovingly stretched her right hand and affectionately caressed his left upper arm. He continued, "Six months ago we began to notice a small change in her character. She had always been intelligent, cheerful and very polite in her behavior toward others. Slowly in a few weeks time, she became completely isolated, living in her own mind. Her cheerfulness and happy moods totally disappeared. She stopped talking to everyone, even to my parents and myself. At first we thought that it was only a temporary change. But we soon realized the gravity of the situation.

"She would neither eat nor drink nor could she get any sleep at night. Within two weeks she became a completely changed person. Mother, you can imagine how worried my parents were. We took her to different psychiatrists and psychologists, hoping that they could cure her. All their treatments were futile. Some people said that she was possessed by evil spirits; others gave the opinion that she was an hysteric. In any case, there was no improvement in my sister's condition. Her health has deteriorated fast. She has become gaunt like a skeleton. She always sits in her room, staring at something or other. The only thing that sustains

her body is the liquid food that we forcibly pour into her mouth. Sometimes she drinks it; at other times it just spills out of her mouth.

“Amma, my sister’s condition has been like this for the past six months. Nobody can figure out the cause or the cure for her disease. My parents are heartbroken. I am unable to console them as I myself am in distress thinking about her. I am very much concerned about my parents too. Looking after my sister and attending to her, they have neither slept or eaten very much since this illness began.

“Amma, please save my sister, please save my parents, please save our family from this crisis.” Supplicating in this manner, the young man covered his face with both palms and sobbed like one who had lost everything in life.

The Holy Mother sat closer to him, placed his head on her shoulder and gently rubbed his back. She consoled him saying, “Son, don’t worry, everything will be all right. Don’t lose your mind; give strength to it. Don’t worry, Mother is here.” Her soothing and loving words calmed him. He regained control of his emotions. The Mother lifted his head from her shoulder and wiped his tears, reassuring him, “Son, don’t worry. Mother feels that daughter (the sister) will be all right.”

The Mother then asked Balu to bring some sacred ash from the temple. When it was brought, the Mother imbued it with her pure and concentrated vi-

tal energy. She sat in meditation with the ash in her hands for some time and then gave it to the young man.

The Holy Mother then instructed the young man in how to use the ash and then got up to go. Chandra Kumar prostrated to the Mother and took leave of her. The Mother went to her room as the time was nearing four forty-five.

There were no more new visitors at the Ashram. The *brahmacharins* were meditating. The atmosphere was very calm and quiet. All of a sudden Gayatri came running down and asked if the young man from Bombay was gone. "Why?" inquired Balu. She handed over some sugar candies to him and said that it was *prasad* from the Mother for his sick sister. It was only five minutes after he had left. Hoping that he could meet him at the ferry, Balu ran to the boat jetty. By the time Balu reached there, Chandra Kumar had already gotten into a boat and was halfway across the backwaters. Balu waved his hand from the shore and shouted to him to wait on the other side of the backwaters. He took another boat across and handed the *prasadam* to Chandra Kumar.

[Note: Three weeks later, the whole family visited the Ashram. It was then that we came to know about the remaining portion of the divine drama which had occurred.

Three days after his visit to the Ashram, Chandra Kumar reached Bombay in the evening by train. It was a great surprise for him when his sister asked immedi-

ately when he stepped into her room, “Where is the sugar candy?” He could not believe his ears because after six months time when all hope had been given up, he heard his sister speaking for the first time. He was more amazed when he heard what she asked for; it was the sugar candy which the Mother was sending to her as *prasadam*. How did she come to know about it? He could not speak for some time. When he regained his composure, he could not wait to ask her all about it.

From his sister’s narration, Chandra Kumar learned that for three continuous nights, starting from the day he visited the Ashram, she had the same dream about the Mother. After each consecutive dream, she felt a special awakening, as if she were coming back to normal. Her parents also began to notice a change in her. On all three nights she dreamed that the Mother said to her, “Your brother came to see Mother. Mother will send some sugar candy to you as *prasadam*. Ask for it when he steps into the room. Take it from him and eat it. You will be all right.” After eating the sugar candy, she recovered both mentally and physically.]

10 April 1984

The blissful song of the fishermen pushing their boats into the ocean came flowing into the Ashram atmosphere. The mother sea happily received her children, the fishermen, into the cradle of waves and lov-

ingly carried them into her heart, the mid-ocean, singing her never-ending lullaby and affectionately caressing them with the arms of the splashing ocean waters.

The *Vedanta* class for the *brahmacharins* was being held in the meditation hall at eleven o'clock in the morning. The Holy Mother was sitting on the front verandah of the temple facing east. A few devotees from the outside sat near her. Some more arrived and took their seats, after having offered their respects to the Mother. Each one of them had his own problems. The Mother called the devotees one by one and listened to them. The conversation changed to other topics.

One devotee: Mother, a *soma yaga* (Vedic sacrifice for restoring the lost harmony of nature and atmospheric purification) is going on in Trivandrum. *Yaga* (ritual) is not the *dharma* of the age, is it?

Amma: Son, whether *yaga* is the *dharma* of the age or not, there is one thing which nobody can deny. That is, there exists a high degree of atmospheric pollution, and the performance of *yagas* is very good to purify the atmosphere. They offer many things which have very good medicinal power in the sacrificial fire coupled with the chanting of *mantras*. They are all very good for nature. Is it possible to do meditation or other spiritual practices in a polluted atmosphere? Even to do worldly things we need a certain amount of atmospheric purity.

Human beings, through their ego-centered thoughts and actions, have polluted the atmosphere.

The atmosphere is completely filled with poisonous smoke and gases from cars, buses, and factories. The worst poison which pollutes the atmosphere is the selfish and wicked thoughts of human beings. Nature's balance is gone. To restore and build up this lost harmony, *yagas* and *yajnas* will help. This is also another way to protect, preserve and spread the *Vedic* tradition.

Moral and spiritual values are the factors which give strength, integrity and unity to a nation. When that is gone, the nation also falls apart.

India's culture is spirituality. The origin of spirituality, though it is beginningless, to speak in empirical terms, is the *Vedas*. Therefore, to preserve, protect and spread the *Vedic dharma* is equal to preserving, protecting and spreading the moral and spiritual values of the country which will help to uplift and unify its people. This alone will protect the country from a great downfall.

Mother does not say that the performers of such *yagas* and *yajnas* should only do the external rituals. It is very important to understand the inner principles and live up to them. The goal is to transcend such rituals and oblations and to live constantly in its principles. How many can transcend them? There are still millions who do not know anything about them. How can those millions be ignored just because of a few who have transcended them? While doing them, try to explain what they really mean. Tell them the spiritual

significance of the rituals, the science behind these performances.

Son, the atmosphere becomes purified even when we light an oil lamp. Whatever the *rishis* said has meaning and significance. There is nothing to ignore. Look with a subtle eye and you can find the real benefit of such religious performances. There is no sense in criticizing something without studying it properly.

Devotee: Amma, isn't the performance of *yagas* and *yajnas* like taking the people five or six thousand years back? It is primitive.

Amma: How do you determine that? Are you trying to say that human beings have evolved? Mother doesn't think so. In fact, they have gone backwards. The criterion to determine whether one is evolved or not is one's mental maturity and broad-mindedness. If this is the norm, people who lived five or six thousand years ago were more evolved than we are. We are the ones who are primitive mentally, physically and intellectually. They were far superior than we in every field, in every word and deed. Try to see and evaluate things impartially without having any prejudice. Try to have a more intellectual approach and evaluation. The disintegration and destruction of those ancient societies were caused by people like Duryodhana, Dussasana, Sakuni or Dhritharashtra (wicked characters in the *Mahabharata* epic). They represent wickedness, selfishness and egoism. In those days there was only one

Duryodhana, one Dussasana and one Dhritharashthra; whereas today, each person is a Duryodhana, a Sakuni or Dussasana. We are mad after name, fame and position. We want to possess everything. Those individuals caused the destruction of an entire race. We are going to cause the destruction of the whole nation, nay, the whole world. Children, who is better, they or us?

The ancient wise men have told us and shown to us the terrible outcome of selfishness and egocentricity. They have also told us how to overcome these traits. Still, we do not want to listen to them. We do not want even to test or experiment with their advice. We just want to criticize what they have said. But who are we to say anything about it? There are those who have studied it properly and scientifically; let them be the ones to evaluate it. Anyhow, if these *yagas* and *yajnas* are performed as prescribed by the *Vedas*, definitely they must bear fruit.

Devotee: In the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita* Lord Krishna says, “*Yajnanam-japayajnosmi*” (Amongst *yajnas*, I am *japa yajna*). *Japa yajna* is the simplest and the most accessible to everyone. It is the *Kali Yuga dharma* (that which must be observed as right conduct in the dark age of materialism). Lord Krishna also tells Arjuna, “*Trigunya-vishaya-veda nistraigunyo-bhavarjuna.*” (The *Vedas* are constituted of the three qualities. Therefore, O Arjuna, go beyond them, i.e., the three qualities.) The limit of the *Vedas* is only up to the heaven.

Amma: It is possible for people to go beyond if they could go up to heaven, isn't it? It is also possible for

people to go beyond the three qualities if they can go up to heaven, isn't it? The discriminative person will definitely do that. That is why Mother said that they should not become attached to the act of just doing rituals. The performer himself should become the offering. The attitude should be, "O Lord, here, by offering this ingredient, I offer all my attachments to you. O Lord, now by offering this ingredient, I offer all my aversions to you. I burn all these in this fire of knowledge. Take this and purify me." This is the right attitude. But even to attain this state of mind one should either have a lot of inherited spiritual merit accumulated from the previous birth or a lot of *abhyasa* (practice) endowed with *vairagya*.

We cannot expect this attitude from everyone. This can be seen only in very few people. The others also will slowly reach this state through the performance of *yajnas* and *yagas*. But at present they want to fulfill their desires; therefore, they cling to the *yajnas* and *yagas* as prescribed in the *Vedas*. Through performance of these rituals, in due course their minds will become more and more subtle. They will realize that desires are a burden, that they cannot be exhausted completely and that they will only cause sorrow. As their minds become more and more subtle, they will find that renunciation of desires is the only way to get rid of all sorrow and suffering. Thus they will understand and imbibe the real meaning of *yajna*, that is, renunciation, and then they will also live in the *yagna* attitude.

Therefore, do not say that *yajas* are *mithya*. People have different tastes and are of different mental constitutions. Let each one of them choose what he wants. There is benefit in the leaves and branches of a tree even if you do not get the fruit. (The Mother indicates that the *Karma Kanda* of the *Vedas* are the leaves and branches; the fruit is *Atma Jnana*). People have turned their attention to spirituality due to the performance of *yaga*, haven't they? Therefore, there is benefit, isn't there?

Another devotee: Mother's answer is perfect. Even Veda Vyasa wrote the *Bhagavatam** after the *Mahabharata*. Devotion to the Lord which is followed by *jnana* can be gained only after performing actions, such as fighting negative tendencies and dealing with conflicts or other agitations within oneself.

Amma: Who can live without doing anything? Children, without performing any actions no one can live in this world. Isn't *karma* needed to reach *nishkama*? When all the *karmas* are directed to God that is *nishkama*. When it is directed to acquire objects, it is *karma*. When all actions are directed to God, that is *yoga*. When all actions are directed to the world, it is

*While Rama, Sita and Lakshmana were in the forest during the years of banishment from the Kingdom of Ayodhya, Ravana, King of Sri Lanka, desired to have Sita. He plotted to abduct her through trickery by enlisting the help of the demon Maricha, who adopted the guise of a beautiful golden deer which evoked Sita's desire. The deer lures Rama away from Sita, and the demon's deceitful cry, imitating Rama's voice, causes Sita to send Lakshmana away to save Rama. Through her own indiscriminative actions, Sita is left unprotected as Ravana forcibly takes her away.

kama. Acting in the world, seeing objects as they are and expecting the fruit of action, is *kamya karma*. Acting in the world, seeing the Lord in all objects without expecting the fruit of it, is *nishkama karma*. Karma should become *nishkama* first. Out of *nishkama karma* arises one-pointed devotion. From devotion arises *jnana*.

Once Narada saw a strong effulgence. He went near it and found that it was Jnana Devata performing penance. He asked upon whom She was meditating. She replied that She was meditating on the Lotus Feet of the Lord. Here also, the importance is stressed for *bhakti*. *Jnana* will not be received by a person who has no devotion. In that sense, one can say that both *bhakti* and *jnana* are one and the same.

Moreover, attenuation of *vasanas* will happen only if *karma* becomes selfless.

It is not enough if you simply sing *kirtans*, you should sing by involving all your body, mind and intellect in the *kirtans*.

Pointing to a laborer who was turning the soil with a spade (a primitive way of plowing), the Mother said,

Amma: Children, have you seen him turning the soil with his spade? He is a hired laborer. He does the work on a contract basis. He just has to put on a show that he is doing the work. He will just turn the soil on the surface, using the spade. He won't dig it properly, removing the weeds and the roots of coconut trees that have been cut down. How will the seeds

germinate and sprout if those are not removed? If it is his own land or field, he will dig it deeply and remove the weeds and the roots of coconut trees that have been cut down and other extraneous growths. He doesn't have any love towards the action that he does. He thinks only about the money, not about the work. Such a person, who loves only money and not the work, who works only because he is forced to, does not have any sincerity. There is no love in his work. He only wants to earn money. This is not the way to perform an action. Any action should be performed with love, and this should be your attitude when you call God. Calling and praying to God is also an action which should be done with love.

In some houses we can see the children singing *kirtans* at dusk. They are not doing it out of love and devotion for God. They do it just out of fear of their parents. They are forced to do it; they are helpless. There is no other way for them; therefore they sit and chant. But as they are chanting they will be fighting or snatching a toy or a doll from another child's hand, desperately scratching their heads, yawning and dozing off, breathing in and delighting in the aroma of the food that comes from the kitchen, and doing other distracting things while singing the Divine Name. This is not *bhakti*. They do it simply out of fear or helplessness. There is not even one iota of love in it. If this is the kind of *bhakti* that we have, the dirt within us will not go. Only if lust, anger and other negative tendencies are uprooted from within through sincere effort,

will God dwell within one. How can seeds sprout if they are sown without removing the weeds? In the same way, when there are the weeds of lust and anger in us, the seed of *bhakti* will not sprout in us and God will not dwell in us.

Question: Mother, it seems that here the *brahmacharins* undergo a lot of disciplining; is that much discipline necessary?

Amma: The ancient masters have thoroughly studied the human mind. They have pierced the mind, penetrated into it and understood all its subtleties. They knew very well the tricky nature of the mind. It is only after such exhaustive study that they have written down all the disciplines that a spiritual aspirant should observe. Today everyone writes a book. But Mother wonders about what study they have done about life and their mind. The *rishis* were not superficial; they spent days and nights, foregoing food and sleep to study their mind. The result was the attainment of Ultimate Knowledge. They knew well about the obstacles that a *sadhak* will have to confront during his spiritual journey because they themselves had faced them. They found methods to overcome the obstacles and this is what they instruct us to follow. It is from their own experience that they speak; it is not a borrowed idea.

Controlling the mind is the most difficult task; therefore, the disciplines are extremely arduous. They are not at all too much. Mother does not give the same kind of discipline to everyone. It depends on

each person's power to withstand the disciplining. All of the *brahmacharins* do not have the same mental strength to withstand it. Anyhow, discipline is not the first thing that should be done. Love and affection are the first thing to be given. Through the experience of pure love, when they come closer, we can then discipline them. That is what Mother does. Mother did not start disciplining any of them immediately after they came except for a few. Those few had the strength and maturity to undergo such discipline.

More detergent is needed if the cloth is very dirty with too many stains on it. In the same way, the mind is full of stains from different habits and worldly experiences. They can be removed only through proper disciplining.

Mahapurushas (great souls) and *avatars* (divine incarnations) will make rules. There is no way for ordinary people to escape without these rules. But the *Mahatmas* cannot wait for rules. They will make the rules, but they are beyond them. Great souls are beyond all rules. They will move away, having created the rules. God moved away, having created the world. He said that He was not at all related to this. We cannot question Him.

We will become good only if there is somebody to give us rules and discipline us. Aren't there superior officers in offices and in the army to discipline and make workers and soldiers obey? Without them and without the rules, proper disciplining cannot be carried out.

It is not possible to make a *brahmacharin* do *sadhana* later if he is not made to do it with discipline immediately after he comes. Therefore, very good discipline is needed from the beginning itself.

Question: Discipline under a *Satguru* is very hard, isn't it, Mother?

Amma: Oh that! Children, Mother will tell you. A real Guru will test the disciple in different ways. After some years of staying with the Guru, sometimes the disciple might feel that now he is perfect and that he has controlled his mind fully. He may think that nothing adverse can happen to him in any circumstance. In order to make him recognize his mistake and understand his own ignorance and to help him traverse that obstacle, the Guru will again test him.

Once there was a Guru who told his disciple, "Look here, my child, go to this particular place. There is a woman living there from whom you are to obtain certain things that I will indicate." After the disciple left to go on this errand, the Guru himself assumed the form of a woman and arrived at that particular place before the disciple. Upon meeting the woman, the disciple lost his self-control and became enslaved by her. The poor fellow did whatever she asked. When her demands were accomplished, the woman disappeared, but not after her having given a severe thrashing on the disciple's back. An ashamed disciple returned to the ashram, but he walked in as if nothing had happened. As soon as the Guru saw him, he asked the disciple, "Hey fellow, what is that on

your back? He stood perplexed, not knowing what to say. He didn't say anything due to fear and shame. The Guru then disclosed everything that had happened, revealing that he himself had played the role of the woman. Thus by exposing the disciple's mental state, the Guru made him understand his own weaknesses. He gave the necessary instructions for deepening his *sadhana* and let him go.

The Guru will test the disciple in every way. He will lock the disciple in a room where there are naked women standing. Sometimes the Guru will ask the disciple to apologize ten thousand times in a peculiar way for a silly mistake that he has committed, for example, to apologize on bended knees, with arms crossed over the chest, the right hand holding the left ear and the left hand holding the right ear.

"Please teach me the Ultimate Knowledge, O Master, if I am competent enough to be your disciple." Praying thus, the disciple should approach the Guru with an attitude of complete self-surrender. The Guru, if he accepts him, will put him through many trials and tribulations as he teaches the disciple whatever he himself knows. Finally, if the disciple comes out victorious in all his tests, the Guru will teach the *Brahma Sutra* to him, not only the intellectual material but the experience as well. Only if the disciple surrenders to the Guru will he be meritorious.

My children, what about today? If a person gets ten rupees, he will go to a bookstore, buy a *Brahma Sutra* text and finish reading it in one sitting. There ends the study of the *Brahma Sutra*. Thereafter, he thinks that he is *Brahman*. A person like this once came to the Ashram, claiming, "I am *Brahman*." Mother replied, "If you are *Brahman*, then that fish,

dog and cat are all *Brahman*.” What reply could he give? He simply said, “Yes, yes.”

One brahmacharin: (Indicating another person) That swami doesn’t do any *sadhana*, but he is very interested in getting disciples.

Amma: Why should you comment on others? Do not do that. Try to make your path clear. Please, my children, none of you should go in search of disciples. Whatever time you get, do *sadhana* and try to attain Self-Realization. Once you attain that goal, everything will come to you automatically. Do you know what you need now? You should try to meditate even while sitting in the toilet.

Son, it is foolishness to destroy this life without attaining that which should be attained. This body is like a business concern. *Atman* is what should be gained as profit from this business. The very purpose of human birth is Self-Realization, but that is the one thing that we forget. We forget the most important thing.

Another brahmacharin: Amma, I cannot control hatred and anger.

Amma: Son, no hatred or anger will come if you consider others as your own. A mother will not consider the odor from the excreta of her own children as foul-smelling, bad or harmful. An infected, putrid smelling wound full of pus on our own body is not a problem for us because it is our own body. We can bear the smell. But if it is on somebody else’s body, we cannot

stand it. We don't feel any anger or hatred towards our son or daughter even if they scold or hit us. Why? Because of the feeling that they are our own. Thus, if we hold the attitude that all beings are "my own," hatred and anger will go. We can overcome these negative traits if we become aware of their terrible consequences. Anger will make us do all kinds of evil deeds. It will dissipate all our good energies. It will take away our discriminative power and make us bitter, mad and even insane. Consider anger as your first and foremost enemy. If you become aware that you are going to get angry, leave that place immediately and try to contemplate in solitude.

All of a sudden the Mother turned to look at one young man who was a newcomer and said,

Amma: Children, before marriage a person will dream many things, such as, "My wife shall be of 'such and such' a nature; she shall be very beautiful and she shall love me like her own life," and so on. Such a dreamer will have a hundred different kinds of thoughts and imaginations. He may not find even one of these qualities in his wife after the marriage. Then disappointment arises and soon quarrels and fighting will begin. This will be followed by mental agitation and eventually the man and wife will end up in the divorce court. What a life this is! Sorrow alone is the result of one who lives in this non-eternal world.

Upon hearing these words of the Mother, the young man fell at her feet and cried. What Mother had just said was his own experience. He had had such imaginations and dreams about his wife and married life. But after the marriage, they always fought with each other and their whole life together was in sorrow. Now he was thinking about divorce.

There was a short pause after which the Mother asked Brahmacharin Pai to sing a bhajan. He sang *Bandhamilla*.

No one is ours
And there is nothing to call our own.
In our last days
Only the True Self will remain as ours.

We can take nothing with us
During the last journey.
Why then this madness
For earthly possessions?

That which truly exists is within us.
To see That, we must go within.
There is not even a trace of sorrow there.
There the True Self shines in Its own glory.

The awakening of the Inner Self
And True Knowledge
Comes only when egotism is completely gone.
We go from untruth to Truth

When we love and serve all living beings.

Entering into a rapturous mood, the Mother was sitting with eyes closed with tears rolling down her cheeks. She uttered a laugh in that state of sweet bliss. When she came back down to the plane of normal awareness, the Mother said,

Amma: The bliss of singing the Divine Name is something unique. It is inexpressible. Mother is not at all hesitant to take any number of births to sing the Name of the Lord. There is no question of gaining total and complete satisfaction in singing the Lord's Name. That is why even those who have reached that State will come down and sing the glories of the Lord with the attitude of a devotee. That is something which one will not feel fed up with at all.

At this point Brahmacharin Nealu came and prostrated to the Mother. He sat with the other devotees. One of the devotees asked the Mother about another devotee who was his friend.

Question: Amma, did he receive a *mantra* from you?

Amma: No. But it is not necessary to receive a *mantra* from Mother externally. It is enough if Mother's *sankalpa* is present. This power can also be transmitted through a glance or touch. Even then, *sadhana* is needed.

Question: Devotees who live in distant places say that they have seen Mother in surprisingly strange circumstances. What do you say about that, Amma?

Amma: That happens due to their strong faith and innocent love.

The Mother did not utter even one word more about it.

One devotee: The Mother has a body made of pure effulgence beyond this gross body that we see. Using that, she reaches as many places as she wants to at the same time. She is omnipresent.

Again the Mother kept quiet.

Question: Amma, it is said that the dangers of pitfalls are many while one pursues the spiritual path.

Amma: That is right. A *sadhak* should be very careful and constantly alert. One moment's carelessness can pull a person down.

Children, the dangers of pitfalls are there, even while standing one step below the state of *jivanmukti* (liberated state). A pitfall is possible even the night before *jivanmukti*. Recall the story about the churning of the *Milk Ocean*. Ambrosia emerged while the *Milk Ocean* was being churned. Snatching the ambrosia, the demons ran away before the celestial beings could retrieve it. It was taken due to a moment's carelessness.

ness. How hard they strived to get it back. A *sadhak* should always be alert. A moment's carelessness can cost you Ambrosial Bliss.

Sita desired to have the golden deer. She was the incarnation of the Goddess Lakshmi and was very wise. Still she was attracted by the golden deer.* Although Rama advised her not to crave for the it, she begged him to capture it. What followed was a whole chain of calamities. When the deer was shot by Rama's arrow, it (being the demon Maricha) gave out a cry, imitating Rama's voice. Sita then urged Lakshmana to go help Rama. Lakshmana tried to convince her that there was deceit behind this cry and that nothing bad could possibly happen to Sri Rama. But Sita was adamant. She lost her wisdom, her discrimination and all other virtues for a moment. She became angry with Lakshmana and even uttered insulting and crude words at him. This incident in the *Ramayana* symbolizes how a person, even one highly evolved, can err and fall at any moment, if one is not alert.

Question: Mother, how do we develop alertness when the mind is more attached to worldly pleasures?

Amma: Children, it is true that mental control is a difficult task while living in this world. It is like standing on the seashore. Even if we do not go into the water, the saline mist will stick to our body. It is just like taking a bath in a room where coal is kept. However much we try to clean our body, there will be coal par-

ticles all over us.

Children, even then, those who are really determined to attain the goal can score a victory over the mind. Even to achieve worldly ends, we will renounce many things. For example, a businessman who travels a lot will sometimes have to forsake many of the comforts he has at home. He may not be able to eat or sleep at the usual time. He will get only very little time to be with his wife, children and other family members. He will not be able to have his favorite dishes everyday. Still he works hard. In fact, in his desire to make money and to make his business flourish, he forgets all about such comforts. Think of the people who go to the Gulf countries to make money. They have to work hard. Most of them have very difficult jobs. They have only the minimum living facilities, a small room with five or six people squeezed in it. They have to cook for themselves and have to undergo very hard times. Once they go, these poor people cannot come back to see their wives, children, parents or friends for two years or more. Still they work, renouncing many pleasures and comforts, undergoing all kinds of hardships. Why? Because they need money. They want more comforts, so they endure these discomforts. They feel the need to endure, and thus they do not feel the burden of these sufferings or hardships. They are happy to do it.

In the same way, children, we should feel a similar need and urgency to attain this inner wealth. Once

that arises in us, then alertness will come, followed by renunciation and determination.

A businessman or a banker who deals with huge amounts of money will always be alert and vigilant. Why? Because a little bit of carelessness may culminate in a big loss. He does not want that to happen; therefore, he is alert. The Prime Minister's or the President's bodyguards need to be very alert and vigilant, because one moment's inadvertence can cause the death of the Prime Minister or the President. They do not want that to happen; therefore, they are very keen.

Similarly, one moment's lack of alertness can cause a pitfall in a *sadhak's* spiritual life. While being attached to an object or while in a particular circumstance, a *sadhak* might feel, "Oh, after all, it is only a small thing, not very significant. Nothing is going to happen if I do it." So he does it. Then a chain of reactions will follow. Be aware and alert that this can happen to you at any moment and then fix all your attention on the goal and work hard to reach it. Definitely you will get it.

Nealu, who was present, asked,

Nealu: Amma, as you said that in the beginning, controlling the mind is not an easy job, especially while living in the midst of worldly pleasures. This is still more difficult for the people who live in the West.

Their materialism is much stronger than here in India. What advice do you have to give them concerning this?

Amma: Mother is very happy to see the enthusiasm and spirit of the children in the West in wanting to lead a spiritual life.

Whoever it may be, *vasanas* will exist, except in one who has reached the state of perfection. To control the mind means to eliminate the *vasanas*. Actually what one should do is to try to remove the previously created tendencies and to block the entrance of new ones into the mind. This cannot be achieved in a short period of time. Mother will not ask you to stop indulging completely and devote all your time to doing spiritual practices. There are people who are interested in doing that, but the majority do not want to nor can they do it right away. They want both. They want to lead a worldly life and simultaneously lead a spiritual life. For them the best way is to slowly and steadily control the habits, one by one. During this process, one might fail many times. Let failures happen. After all, failure comes only to a person who tries for success. Therefore, do not get worried or agitated if failure happens. Again and again it might occur. But do not lose your enthusiasm and interest. Try again and again. Declare an open war with your mind. The mind might pull you and push you into the same old habits. Understand that it is only a trick of the greatest trickster, the mind, to divert you from the path.

Do not give up. There will come a point when the *vasanas* will lose all their strength and give way for the Lord to come in and rule. Till then try and keep trying. Let the failures “fail” to stop you from continuing your practice.

Children, this world is created by the Lord for you to enjoy. No spiritual master or scriptural text has ever said that everyone should give up all kinds of worldly enjoyments and engage in constant remembrance of God. No one has said that everyone change their residences and live in ashrams and become *sannyasins*. As Mother said before, there are people who can do it and who are determined to do it. Let them follow their path. But there is a way for others also to become closer to God. That is possible by slowly preparing the mind for that final leap while leading a normal life in this world.

While driving one must obey traffic rules and regulations. If not, accidents will occur. Not only you, but others will suffer if an accident happens. Likewise, while driving the vehicle of life along the road of this world, you have to adhere to certain laws, certain do's and don'ts. It is these rules and regulations that the Gurus and the scriptures talk about. If you follow them, you can avoid danger and will be safe both in your personal life and social life. However, conflicts and calamities will arise in both areas of your life if you break these rules and regulations through over-indulgence and other undisciplined ways.

Children, negative thoughts might arise in your mind while you proceed in your *sadhana*. Don't worry. Don't give them too much importance. Giving too much importance to negativity will make your mind weak. Once the mind becomes weak, you will not be able to do anything. It will become impossible even to put forth the mental strength or the capacity we already have in order to do our *sadhana*. Ignore them and continue your *sadhana*.

Therefore, children, do not worry. Mistakes might happen. Do not bother your head thinking about them. Remember, by worrying about them you are losing the mental energy and strength to confront and correct them. Do not waste your time worrying. Proceed and pursue your practice.

Children, remember food is for us to eat. Do not let the food eat us. This world is for us to enjoy. Do not let the world toss you up and down with attractions and aversions. This body, mind and intellect are tools for us to use according to our wish and will. Let us have perfect control over them. Do not let them control us.

The Mother then asked Sreekumar to bring the harmonium. She sang *Martyare Samsara*.

O Mother, Thou art the Redeemer of mankind
Taking us across the ocean of the world.
Thou art the Primal Cause of the world,

The Power behind the Universe.

Thou dost manifest as the three gunas
And as the Supreme Life Force.
I know, O Mother, that Thy love for us
Makes the fulfillment of human life possible.

The moonlight of Thy smile gives light
And peace to this world of misery and darkness.

Out of the five elements the Universe
Is made to manifest Thy Gracious Glory.
Thou art the Holy Waters,
The Elements and the Root Cause.

Thou fillest the whole Universe,
Manifesting them with and without form.
If, for even a moment, Thou abandonest me,
Tell me then, O Mother,
What is the use of this life on earth?

AUM

GLOSSARY

{Certain words are the same or similar in Malayalam and Sanskrit. Thus *Abhyasa* and *Brahmacharin* are Sanskrit whereas *Abhyasam* and *Brahmachari* are Malayalam}

ABHYASA(M): Constant effort

ADHARA(M): Substratum

ADVAITA(M): Non-dualism

AHAM BRAHMASMI: 'I am the Absolute' (Whole).

AMBROSIA: The elixir of eternal life (Amrit).

AMMACHI: The Mother. *Chi* is a word indicating respect.

AMRITATTVA(M): Immortality.

ARATI: Waving the burning camphor, which leaves no residue, with ringing of bells at the end of *puja* (worship) indicating total annihilation of ego.

ARCHANA: A mode of worship by repetition of one hundred, three hundred or a thousand names of the chosen deity.

ARJUNA: The third among the Pandavas and a great archer

ASANA: Steady position for meditation

ATMA(N): The Self

AVADHUT(A): An advanced wandering ascetic.

AVATAR: Incarnation. Great Souls who are fully aware of their identity with God right from birth.

BHADRA KALI: See Kali

BHAGAVAD GITA: The teachings of Lord Krishna to Arjuna at the beginning of the Mahabharata War. It is a practical guide for common man for every day life and is the essence of Vedic wisdom. *Bhagavad* means 'that of the Lord' and *Gita* means 'Song', particularly, an advice.

BHAGAVATA(M): The book on the incarnations of Lord

Vishnu, especially Krishna and his childhood sportings.
It upholds the supremacy of devotion.

BHAGAVATI: The Goddess of six virtues, viz, prosperity,
valor, auspiciousness, knowledge and dispassion

BHAJAN: Devotional singing

BHAIRAVI: Consort of Bhairava (Siva).

BHAKTI: Devotion.

BHAVA DARSHAN: The occasion when Amma receives devotees in the exalted state of Universal Mother.

BHAVANA: Creative imagination.

BHAVA SAMADHI: Absorption into the Self through devotion.

BHOGI: A pleasure seeker.

BIJAKSHARA(s): Seed letters in a *mantra*.

BINDU: Point.

BRAHMAN(M): The Absolute, Whole.

BRAHMANANDA: The incomparable bliss of Realization.

BRAHMACHARI(N): A celibate student under training of a Guru.

BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy

BRAHMAMAYI: Who is nothing but *Brahman* .

BRAHMANANDA(M): The bliss of Realization.

BRAHMANISHTATTVAM: Establishment in *Brahma*.

BRAHMASUTRA: Aphorisms on Vedanta composed by Vyasa.

CHAKKA KALI: A game played by children. The word "Kali" (with a short 'a') in Malayalam means play and (with a long 'a') Universal Mother.

CHAKORA(M): Cacabis Partridge. It is believed that seeing this bird at the commencement of a journey is an auspicious omen.

CHAMUNDA: An aspect of the Universal Mother.

CHANDA: A demon killed by Kali.

DAKSHINA: Offerings made to the Guru or the priest.

DARIKA: Another demon beheaded by Kali.

DARSHAN: Audience of a Holy Person or deity.

DEVA(TA): Demi-god, celestial being

DEVI: The Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness.

DHRITARASHTRA: Father of Kauravas and King of Hastinapuri. He was physically blind and blind with attachment towards his son, Duryodhana, which eventually led to the Mahabharata War.

DHYANA(M): Meditation

DURYODHANA: Eldest son of Dhritarastra and villain of Mahabharata epic.

DUSSASANA: Brother of Duryodhana.

EECHA: House fly

GANJIRA: A small hand-held drum

GITA: See *Bhagavad Gita*

GITOPADESA: Sri Krishna's instructions to Arjuna in the form of the *Bhagavad Gita*. (Famous illustration of Krishna in the chariot giving advice to a kneeling Arjuna in the Mahabharata epic.)

GOPA(S): Cowherd boy(s), companions of Sri Krishna

GOPI(S): Cowherd girl(s), known for their supreme devotion to Sri Krishna

GRAHASTA: Householder

GRAHASTAHSRAM(A): Householder who leads a righteous life.

GURU: Spiritual Master / Guide.

GURU DAKSHINA: Offering made to Guru as a token of respect.

GURUKULA(M): Residential school of a Guru

HANUMAN: A great servant devotee of Lord Rama who crossed the sea by jumping over it with the power of constant remembrance of the name of Rama.

HATHA YOGA: Gaining mastery over the body as a means of Self-Realization.

HOMA: Offering made to celestial beings by means of pouring clarified butter and other pure materials into

the sacred fire.

ISWARA: God

JANMA(M): Birth

JAPA YAGNA: The vow of constant repetition of a *mantra*

JAPA: Repetition of a mystical formula (*mantra*)

JIVANMUKTA: A Liberated Soul

JIVANMUKTI: Liberation.

JIVA(N): Life force

JIVATMA(N): Individual Soul

JNANA: Spiritual or divine wisdom

KALI: The Divine Mother. She is depicted in many forms.

Her auspicious form is called *Bhadra Kali*.

KALI YUGA: Present dark age of materialism.

KAMYA BHAKTI: Devotion motivated by desires.

KANYAKUMARI: The southern point of the Indian subcontinent where there is a temple of the Divine Mother as a virgin.

KARMA PHALA(M): Results of action.

KARMA: Action.

KARMA KANDA: Ritualistic portions in the *Vedas*

KASHAYA: The ochre color denoting the fire of Divine Knowledge.

KAURAVA(S): The hundred children of Dhritarashtra.

KAYAL: Backwaters

KIRTAN(AM): Hymns

KRISHNA: Principle incarnation of Lord Vishnu

KUNDALINI: Spiritual energy depicted as the serpent power coiled at the root of the spine which rises to the head by spiritual practices, leading one to Liberation.

LAKSHMANA: Brother of Lord Rama.

LAKSHMI: Consort of Lord Vishnu and Goddess of wealth.

LAKSHYA BODHA: Constant awareness of and intent on goal

LALITA SAHASRANAMA: Thousand names of the Universal Mother in the form of *Lalitambika*

LEELA: Divine play.

LOKA(M): World

- MAHABHARATA(M): Great epic written by Vyasa.
 MAHAPURUSHA(S): Great person
 MAHA KALI: A form of the Universal Mother
 MAHATMA: Great Soul
 MAKKAL(E): Children. *Makkale* is the vocative form.
 MANASA PUSHAM: Offering of the mind (heart) as the flower
 in worship.
 MANASA PUJA: Mental worship of God.
 MANTRA: Sacred formula, the repetition of which can
 awaken the spiritual energies and bring the desired
 results.
 MARGA: The path.
 MAUNA(M): Vow of silence.
 MAYA: Illusion.
 MILK OCEAN: The abode of Vishnu, represents the pure
 mind.
 MITHYA: Transient
 MOL(E): Daughter. *Mole* is the vocative form.
 MON(E): Son. *Mone* is the vocative form
 MRIDANGAM: A type of drum widely used in Indian classical
 music.
 MUDRA: A sign by hand indicating mystic spiritual truths.
 MUKTA: The Liberated One
 NARAYANA: Lord Vishnu
 NISHKAMA KARMA: Action without expectation of results
 NIRAKARA: Without form
 NIRGUNA(M): Without attributes
 NIRVIKALPA SAMADHI: The state of abidance in the Self.
 NISHKARMA: Non action, detached action
 NITYA MUKTA: The Ever-Liberated One
 PADA PUJA: Worshipping the feet of the Guru. As the feet
 support the body, it is the Supreme Truth that sup-
 ports the principle of Guru. Thus His feet are the
 symbolic representation of that Truth.
 PANDAVA(S): The five children of King Pandu and heros of

the epic *Mahabharata*

PARA SHAKTI: The Supreme Power, Universal Mother.

PARA BHAKTI: The supreme form of devotion devoid of desire, absolute love the Lord.

PARABRAHMAN(M): The Supreme Absolute.

PARAMATMA(N): Supreme Self.

PEETHAM: A high platform.

PUJA: Worship.

PRADAKSHINA(M): Circumnambulation.

PRASAD(AM): Consecrated offerings distributed after *puja*.

PREMA: Deep Love.

PURANA: Epic.

RAJA YOGA: The Royal Path of Union with the Supreme.

RAMA: Hero of the epic *Ramayana*. An incarnation of Vishnu and the ideal of Righteousness.

RAMAYANA(M): The epic about Lord Rama composed by the sage *Valmiki*

RAVANA: The villain of the *Ramayana*

RISHI: A great sage or seer.

RUDRAKSHA(M): A sacred seed (bead) having spiritual and medicinal value.

SADHAK(AN): One dedicated to attain the spiritual goal, one who practices *sadhana* (spiritual discipline).

SADHANA: Spiritual practices.

SADHU: Mendicant.

SAGUNA(M): With attributes.

SAIPPU: A Westerner.

SAKARA: With form.

SAKUNI: Maternal uncle of the Kauravas, a crooked intellect.

SAMADHI: State of absorption in the Self

SAMSARA: The world of plurality

SANKALPA: Creative, integral resolve

SANKARA: Siva. Amma sometimes uses it as a synonym for 'simpleton'.

SANNYASI(N): Ascetic who has renounced all worldly bond-ages.

SARI: A long piece of cloth worn by Indian ladies.

SATGURU: Realized Spiritual Master

SATCHIDANANDA: Existence, consciousness, bliss

SATSANG: Company of the wise and virtuous

SATTVIC: Of pure quality, goodness

SAUNDARYA LAHARI: Songs on the glories of the Universal Mother. The word means 'beauty' or 'intoxicating'.

SHAKTI: The dynamic aspect of *Brahman* as the Universal Mother.

SHIVA / SIVA: The static aspect of *Brahman* as the male principle.

SIDDHA VEDA: A school of *Yoga*

SITA: Wife of Rama

SOHAM: 'I am That'- the *mantra* that incessantly resonates within every person.

SOMA YAGA: A form of fire ceremony

SRADDHA: Faith. Amma uses it with a special emphasis on alertness coupled with loving care of the work in hand.

SREE RAMA: See *Rama*. *Sree*, or *Sri*, is a mark of respect

SRIMAD BHAGAVATAM: See *Bhagavatam*. *Srimad* means 'auspicious'

SUKA: Son of Vyasa who was perfect from birth.

TALAM: Beat, rhythm.

TAPAH: practicing spiritual austerities.

TAPASVI: One engaged in penance.

TAPOVAN(AM): Hermitage, a place conducive to meditation.

TATTVA: Principle.

TATTVATTILE BHAKTI: Devotion rooted in discriminative knowledge between the eternal and the ephemeral.

TYAGI: Renunciate.

UNNIKISHNAN: The Child Krishna

UPANISHADS: The concluding portion of the Vedas dealing with the philosophy of Non-dualism.

VAIRAGYA(M): Dispassion, detachment

VANAPRASTA: The third phase of life devoted to austerities and a secluded life.

VASANA: Latent tendency.

VEDA: Lit. 'Knowledge', the authoritative Scriptures of the Hindus.

VEDA VYASA: See *Vyasa*. As he divided the one *Vedas* into four, he is also known by the name of *Veda Vyasa*

VEDANTA(M): The philosophy of the Upanishads which declare the Ultimate Truth as 'One without a Second'.

VEDIC DHARMA: Injunctions on the righteous way of living as pre-scribed by the Vedas.

VISHNU: All-pervading. The Lord of sustenance

VYASA: A sage who divided the one *Vedas* into four and composed 18 *puranas* and also the *Mahabharata* and *Bhagavatam*.

YAGNA: Sacrificial rites and rituals.

YOGA: Union with the Supreme. Popular used in the sense of a set of exercises to make the body and mind fit for spiritual practices.

YOGINI: A woman accomplished in *yoga*

YUGA: Aeon. The four ages are *Krita (Satya)*, *Treta*, *Dvapara* and *Kali*. They represent the successive transition from a spiritual to material era. In Indian thought, the number '4' is associated with wholeness, hence, the 4 yugas. During each yuga, 25% of Dharma, or Truth, diminishes from the previous yuga.

CHAPTER 1

BEYOND DUALITY

In the tropics on the southwestern coast of India, the summer sun often blazes throughout the day. Yet even during the peak of this season in Kerala, the Ashram and its surroundings are not much affected by the intensity of the heat. A canopy of coconut palms provides abundant shade, and the breeze that blows constantly off the nearby Arabian Sea cools the air.

Although the Mother's first spiritual children had come to stay with Her many years before, the Ashram officially began in 1981. In those early years, before anyone dreamed of an Ashram or disciples and devotees from all over the world, days and nights spent with the Mother were a continuous series of wondrous adventures and intimate teachings, of discovering the many facets of this enigmatic Mother, and through these, discovering one's own Self.

Since 1982, the Ashram residents followed a regular schedule as more and more spiritual aspirants came to live there. Rising at 4:00 a.m. to chant the *Lalita Sahasranama*, the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother Sri Lalita, residents gathered for morning and late afternoon meditations and for classes on the

ancient scriptures. The daily schedule ended with evening *bhajans* as dusk released the sun to rest in the western ocean.

Each day visiting devotees came to see the Mother. While She kept no specific hours for these daily *darshans*, the Mother was sure to see every person who came. Although there were still times when She met with devotees out in the open under the palm trees, *darshan* was usually held in a special hut built for the purpose.

16 April 1984

At nine o'clock in the morning the Ashram was calm and peaceful. The residents were still meditating in the hall, and the melodious singing of a nightingale added a delicate charm to the tranquility of the morning. The Holy Mother came out of the meditation hall where She had been sitting with the brahmacharins, observing their meditation. With Her hands held behind Her back, the Mother began walking back and forth in front of the temple. There was a majestic appearance about Her. One of the residents approached the Mother and stood beside Her, as if he had something to say. Realizing his wish, the Mother stopped walking and stood in front of him.

He said, "Amma, people are scandalizing Amma and the Ashram, gossiping and speaking a lot of nonsense. They are saying that it is not proper for Amma to embrace people. How can we make them understand that Amma is One with the Supreme Being?"

The Mother replied, “Those people who are supposed to know will know and understand. The others are not familiar with a Mother who considers all as Her children. Therefore, though they criticize, Mother does not blame them. Son, they are like that. They cannot be otherwise. It is their nature.

“Petrol (gasoline) can be used for running a car as well as for burning a house. People who use petrol for burning want only to destroy. They do not consider the creative aspect of petrol. Most people love only for selfish motives and do not know Mother’s unconditional love. They do not know that love can be expanded to embrace the whole universe. They are familiar only with a limited capacity for love. Mother’s life is for giving happiness and peace to people, but people do not understand this. A needle can be used to stitch and sew things together as well as to injure someone. People live in too much strife and division. Mother’s aim is to unite people’s hearts with God and to make them one with Him. But these people who criticize the Ashram want to hurt and injure people.

“People judge things according to their mental dispositions and tendencies which are limited. Due to this limitation their judgements are wrong most of the time and they miss the essence of things.

“A plant in which an ayurvedic physician sees great medicinal value is nothing but grass for a person who harvests food for cows. Likewise, people differ according to their individual *samskaras* (illusions). It is through the glasses of their *vasanas* (accumulated ten-

dencies) that each one views and judges the world. The color of the glasses differs according to a person's tendencies, but in all people identification with these *vasanas* is so strong that they feel that their judgments, and their judgements alone, are correct.

"People in ignorance, people who have no spiritual grounding or even any spiritual tendencies, will not see or understand what Mother is doing. They live in total ignorance, unaware of such things. Let us pray to the Lord and seek forgiveness for them. But those who are supposed to know will know. They will come here, overcoming all obstacles."

"Amma, what makes these people live in ignorance? Why are they blind? What covers their vision?" asked the resident.

"It is nothing outside which envelopes their vision, but it is their own mind," answered the Mother. "The mind full of thoughts is ignorance; the same mind devoid of thoughts is *Atman*, the Self. People are so identified with the body that they miss the Reality, the Essential Principle. They see the waves and forget about the ocean. They see only the clouds and miss the vast expansive sky. They see the flower and fall in love with it, but they overlook the plant. The waves come and go, appear and disappear, but the ocean remains the same. The same can be said about the clouds in the sky and the flower on the plant. People miss the Reality, the Substratum, which is the Enlivening Principle, and this is a big loss. To forget It is the biggest loss.

"Duality exists only when you are identified with

the body. Once this identification is transcended, all dualities disappear. In the state of Supreme Oneness, the pot (the body), breaks, and the space inside the pot becomes one with the total space. There is no more conditioning; only the One exists. All differences such as man and woman, healthy and unhealthy, rich and poor, beautiful and ugly, pure and impure, vanish. You will then see and experience the electricity, rather than the bulb or the fan or the refrigerator, which are objects powered by electricity. Once this happens, how can one say, 'I will only do this, not that' or, 'I will receive only women, not men.' In this state of total non-identification with the body, all differences disappear."

At this point the Mother sat down on the front verandah of the temple. She continued, "Even the feeling that there are men and there are women is one of degree because in every man there is woman and in every woman there is man. People are half man and half woman. Some men are more womanly than manly, and of course, the opposite is also true. One's actions and thoughts will reveal masculine or feminine traits. What is a real human being? A real human being is one who is endowed with self-control and mental strength. But who is without any weakness? Even a dictator, who may seem like a strong-minded person, is a weakling because he rules, tortures and kills people out of fear for his own security. Fear is the greatest weakness.

“The elements which constitute the bodies of both men and women are the same. God used a little more flesh to make women, that’s all. What is there to be ashamed of in considering both men and women equally if one is fully established in that Non-Dual state of Reality?

“Son, Mother never has the feeling, ‘woman’ or ‘man.’ Mother’s only feeling is that all are Her children. There should be at least one person who hugs one and all, seeing them as Her children, shouldn’t there? Who else is there to do that? Mother cannot change Her innate nature, out of fear of what people might say.”

One of the brahmacharins asked, “Amma, may I go to Mookambika Temple and come back in a few days?”

Amma cautioned him, “Son, why do you wander here and there? This is another tendency of the mind. You think that by going to Mookambika or some other holy place you are fulfilling a divine desire and that it is therefore not harmful. Of course it is not harmful if you have the right attitude and faith. But when such a desire arises, you should observe the mind closely in order to make sure the desire is genuine. The desire is usually just a product of your craving to travel and go sightseeing. But you cannot confess that to me; therefore, you express it in the guise of a pilgrimage with a divine purpose.

“This is a strong *vasana* in many people, to think

that they are doing the ‘right thing’ when really all they want to do is satisfy their usual desires. Merry-making, sight-seeing, traveling around and seeking entertainment are common *vasanas* in people. These *vasanas* will still follow a person even if he abandons one way of living and chooses another. The only difference is that the mind will express it in another way. But the basic *vasana* will remain the same. It is just like renouncing chocolate and switching to ice cream. The object changes, but the desire remains the same. You do not know how skillfully the mind tricks and fools you. Beware, and use your discriminative power on such occasions.

“Once you accept a Perfect Soul as your Guru, stop wandering, both mentally and physically. Stay with the Guru; surrender to Him or Her. That is it. Cast off all worries and unnecessary brooding over incidents and experiences of the past, and mentally and physically travel towards Him, toward His real Being. This is the real journey.

“When you are in the presence of a Self-Realized Master, try to be firm and unshakable, whatever may happen. Everything should be left to the Guru’s will. You will be in trouble if you move around, straying away from the Master in order to fulfill your desires and wishes. Self-surrender is very much needed.”

Next a devotee asked a question, “Amma, what is the explanation for Realized Souls expressing desires in childhood, like wanting to play on a swing or want-

ing toys, when they take on a new birth after having given up the body of the previous life?”

To this the Mother explained, “A Self-Realized Soul might express desires, but there is a big difference between the attitude of a Self-Realized Soul and that of an ordinary human being. When an ordinary human being develops a desire for an object, he creates a chain by becoming attached to the object. This chain of attachments gets longer and longer and goes on binding him. He has no control. He will be haunted all the time by all kinds of desires, whether they are necessary or unnecessary, helpful or unhelpful, permitted or prohibited. His mind becomes a real marketplace.

“A Realized Soul, too, will sometimes express desires, but He is of an entirely different calibre. He has complete control over the desires. You might see Him eating, sleeping or dressing like an ordinary person, but He is not attached to whatever He does. He can give it up easily. He is just like a child. A child is not attached to anything. He will move easily from one activity to another, let go of one object when another interests him more. If a Realized Soul takes another birth after casting off the previous life’s body, He might express desires in His childhood, asking for this or that. But even though a child, He will remain a witness, and He will be fully aware of His Real Self. He might act like other children, but what harm is there in this? A child should be like a child, shouldn’t he? A child should be mischievous, sport about, play with

toys, and cry for his mother's milk; otherwise, he is not a child. That innocence is the attractive thing about children.

"It is said that Sri Krishna, the All-Knowing One, wanted His father to capture the moon for Him when He was a child. He was full of playfulness. He expressed desires like all children do, but He was fully aware of His nature. So this is the difference. An ordinary human being has no control over the mind, but a Realized Soul, whatever his age, has one hundred percent control. His mind and desires function without compromise as he instructs them. In a mortal man's case, the mind and the desires function as they like, uncontrolled. The Realized Soul, whether he is a child or a grown-up person, creates a desire by his will, and he has the power to destroy it whenever he wants. Other people create desires but are incapable of destroying them."

A householder devotee arrived who had only recently started coming to the Ashram. He bowed down in front of the Mother and offered Her the fruit which he had brought. This devotee was very keen to know more about the Ashram. Seeing how young the brahmacharins were, he asked the Mother, "Should they be required to lead a spiritual life at such a young age?"

"Son," the Mother said laughingly, "it is not due to Mother's insistence that these children have chosen a spiritual life. When they first came, Mother told them,

‘I don’t have any faith in you who come here, deluded by an ordinary girl.’ And do you know how they replied? ‘Until we met Mother, we never even considered living a spiritual life or becoming monks. But we believe in that power that is in You which has created an effortless transformation in us.’ Therefore, son, it was purely their choice, not Mother’s.

“Do you think that somebody can be dragged into spiritual life unless they chose it wholeheartedly? No one can ever make you eat something that you do not like. Just to please someone, you might taste a little, but you will not eat the whole plate. If you eat only due to someone else’s insistence, the food will not stay in your stomach. You will vomit. If this is the case with ordinary things, then what can be said about choosing a spiritual life and renouncing all other choices? This is something which must happen spontaneously. Nobody can force spirituality onto someone else. It happens out of urgency. In this state of urgency, a person cannot do anything but choose spirituality. There is no explanation for this; it just happens.”

Another householder devotee requested clarification concerning Self-Realization: “Amma, it is said that the ‘I’ will disappear when one attains Self-Realization. How does that happen?”

“The ‘I’ ceases to exist when the mind attains perfect concentration,” the Mother answered. “The feelings of ‘I’ and ‘mine’ are due to the ego. The ego is

nothing but identification with the body and mind. The mind is thoughts. When thoughts are present, we remain a little ego. There is no spontaneous expression. Everything is filtered through the ego. Through the narrow vision of the little ego, we see only the waves of the sea. When thoughts are eradicated through constant practice and concentration, the ego, 'I', disappears. When through our concentration, the little ego is reduced to ashes, we become the Limitless and Impersonal and can thus comprehend the Ocean of Bliss. The remains of what looks like the ego will be there, but it is not real. It is not productive.

"Ask a scholar, 'Sir, what is your opinion about this planet and the people on it?' He will probably answer, 'This is a world full of useless fools!' Furthermore, he will most probably feel that he is the only wise person on the planet. Such a scholar has the most inflated 'little ego' you can find. He is a man who sees only the waves. He cannot even take a peep at the Ocean of Bliss. He can see only separate entities, only individuals, only differences and divisions. He cannot see the whole; he sees only the parts and pieces.

"Ask the same question of a *Mahatma* (great soul) and He will reply, 'There is only the Self, nothing else. God alone exists. Everything is beautiful; all are good and wise.' He beholds the Whole, the Oneness. The *Mahatma* experiences unity in diversity, in everything, in all circumstances, irrespective of time and place. For him everything is an extension of his own Self. He

cannot blame, criticize or hate anyone. His small 'I' has disappeared and he has become the 'big, impersonal I'. This state comes only when the ego disappears. In order to attain this, one needs a one-pointed mind.

"God Himself will be the servant of the person who has gained one-pointedness of mind. Mother guarantees this, children. You try and see what happens."

The Mother's bold assurance struck the household devotee with wonder. His eyes were fixed on the Mother's face. After a short while, he said, "Amma, how do we even begin..."

"Even while in the midst of numerous worldly problems, you children still think of God and show great interest in doing spiritual practice. This in itself makes Mother feel very happy." The Mother's reassurance was encouraging.

Another question was raised: "Amma, it seems that God didn't think before creating the world. Had He thought about it, there would not be so many complications and troubles."

"From His point of view," said the Mother, "the 'Old Man' has not created the world at all. He is flawless. We are the ones who create shadows and reflections. Again and again we create them, giving them reality. Running after these shadows and reflections, we fantasize and thus create our own world of chaos and confusion."

“Son, who is responsible for all this complication and trouble? Is it God? No. It is you. You alone are the cause. God created day and night to make us happy. Both are beautiful unless we act improperly. Day is the time to act and discharge one’s duties, and night is the time to rest and relax. Who is responsible if somebody covets another’s possessions and steals things at night, or if someone is a terrorist and uses the time to make bombs in secret? Is it God or is it the person doing those things? Animals, which are considered to be less evolved than humans, do not have problems like us, the so-called intelligent beings. Animals live much more in tune with nature. But it is arrogant and selfish human beings who are always disturbing nature’s harmony.”

SPIRITUAL QUALITIES OF WOMEN

At around ten o’clock, some householder devotees arrived with their families. Some of the children were students in grade school and some were in college. The Holy Mother led all of them to the room above the meditation hall where She spoke to them for some time, showing great interest in their household affairs and inquiring about how their children were doing in their studies. Just like a loving mother, very much concerned about her family, the Mother conversed with them about various topics, filling them with warm feelings of motherly love and concern. It was obvious that the Mother’s soothing and affectionate words made them very happy and relaxed. She took a piece of

rock-candy, broke it up into several pieces and distributed it to the devotees as *prasad* (a blessing in the form of a gift).

The conversation slowly evolved to spiritual matters. There were more women present than men, and perhaps taking this into account, the Mother began talking about women. “Woman is *Shakti* (power). She is much more powerful than man. Though it may be difficult for a woman to have a determined mind, once she does, no power can stop her. She cannot be defeated then. Spiritual realization is easier for a woman to attain than for a man, provided she has the proper discrimination and determination. But by nature, women are yielding and giving and this often results in being unsteady. This unsteadiness should be overcome through constant repetition of one’s mantra and remembrance of God. A woman’s self-confidence is often weak, but she can make it unshakably firm. A woman can do it, for she has the patience to achieve. A man cannot raise children because he lacks patience. Men are impatient for results. Women have both patience and love, but in general, they lack determination and self-confidence. While men generally have the latter two qualities, they should develop patience and love. Because determination and self-confidence do exist within them, women should try to awaken these qualities and make them strong.

“Many people live with the misconception that women are only supposed to give birth and raise children. These same people might also think that men

are the only ones who can rule and command. Both ideas are wrong. A woman can rule as well as a man if she brings out the dormant masculine qualities within her. And a man can be as loving and affectionate as a mother if he works on that unmanifested feminine aspect within him. But there is an important point to remember: while developing and even practicing patience and love, a man should retain his determination and self-confidence and a woman should maintain her patience and love even after she has cultivated determination and self-confidence.

“Women are the repositories of infinite power. In spiritual matters they can surpass what many men attempt to do; therefore, do not think that women are lower than men.

“Women should wake up from their sleep, wake up to spiritual awareness. There is infinite spiritual power within them. They are not weaklings and they must realize this. They have at their disposal two very powerful tools, love and patience, which are the sharpest and the strongest weapons of all. These two qualities are capable of conquering anything with ease.”

“Amma, what do you say about people in India imitating the West?” asked one of the devotees.

“Children,” the Mother replied, “it is a pity that India is trying to imitate the West. That is not our culture. It does not belong to us. It is a very dangerous tendency to imitate Western culture. But look at the

Westerners; they are trying to follow us. They want spirituality, whereas we crave material wealth. If you must imitate the Westerners, imitate their good qualities like the sincerity that they show to the work they undertake and the external discipline that they have. Instead, we imitate them blindly. Each nation has a culture of its own. The very existence of a country is dependent on that. If that root culture is not preserved, the country will face its downfall. India's cultural heritage is spirituality. Spirituality is the vital energy of India. If that is gone, the nation will perish. Therefore, that should be protected. In order to save the coming generation, parents should wake up. Their children's future is in their hands, and they can help them to a certain extent. Parents should try to inculcate in their children's minds the value of leading a spiritual life. This is the most valuable wealth that parents can give to their children. Material wealth will perish, but spiritual wealth is imperishable.

"Problems will arise in married life. When a time of crisis comes, spiritual truths will save a man or a woman from mental turmoil and emotional distress, which are quite common in modern society today. While feeding children food and providing them with other necessities, remember to feed them with some spiritual values as well. If you don't do this, you will spoil your children in the name of motherly love or fatherly love.

"In the olden days when people felt sorrow, they did *tapas* (intense spiritual practice, literally 'heat').

They engaged in austerities in order to remember God. In this way they gained strength to face their problems. Nowadays, unable to confront unhappy moments in life, people resort to liquor and drugs. Unable to face problems, they seek to escape them. Such a pity! They do not know what they are doing. In relying on intoxicants to avoid their problems, they are paving the way for their own destruction.

“Once a person becomes addicted to intoxicants like liquor, marijuana, cocaine, heroine, or other drugs, the addiction swallows him completely. He becomes so dependent on intoxicants that he is not able to function normally without them. In the beginning he may feel that the drugs or alcohol are enjoyable. But as he becomes dependent on them, needing more and more to get the desired effect in order to forget his problems, he realizes that the drugs are no longer pleasurable. Addiction to habit-forming drugs forces an addict to rely on them totally; they become a biological need and he becomes obsessed with always needing the drug. So obsessed is an addict that he neglects his loved ones, his family and friends, and he neglects his duties and responsibilities in order to obtain his drugs. Ultimately, he neglects himself; his health becomes ruined. His physical body weakens, and he becomes susceptible to disease. What is worse, he does not care about himself. Habit-forming drugs cause the brain to deteriorate and cause damage to the nervous system as well as to other organs of the body. If an addict produces children, they may be born men-

tally retarded or physically deformed. Therefore, parents, take good care of your children. Do not let them fall victim to alcohol or drugs. Give them the necessary spiritual education while they are still young.”

Speaking humbly, a woman devotee said to the Mother, “Amma, I have brought you some *parippuvada* (a delicacy made of dal, deep-fried in oil). It is not very good. Will you have some?”

With a radiant smile on Her face, the Mother said, “Certainly. Mother likes whatever is brought by people with devotion. Even if it is poison, it will be made good and pure by the innocence of their hearts.”

Taking a small steel container out of her handbag, the woman joyfully handed it over to the Mother, who, removing the lid, took one piece out and had a bite. Beaming a smile at the devotee, She exclaimed, “Good! Very delicious!”

The Mother then fed the other half to the woman, who was overflowing with joy. Then She fed each person present a small piece from the container. When there was still one *parippuvada* left in Her hand, the Mother broke it into two pieces. Again She fed the woman devotee with one piece, and upon handing her the remaining half, the Mother, with a mischievous smile on Her face, said, “Daughter, you feed Mother now.” Sitting in front of the devotee, She opened Her mouth. The woman looked as if she were in a dream or in another world. Such astonishment and such tre-

mendous joy lit up her face. As she put the treat into the Mother's mouth, the devotee struggled to control her tears. Immediately after feeding the Mother, she broke down and sobbed like a child.

Through her tears, she said, "I cherished the desire to feed you while I was making this food. And when you fed me and the others, that wish again became strong. O Amma, you have fulfilled my heart's desire."

The woman could not control her tears. Still sobbing, she sang *Ellam Ariyunna Ammayodu...*

*No need to tell anything to the all-knowing Mother,
Walking beside us,
She sees and understands everything,
The Primordial Being
Sees all thoughts of the inner self.
It is never possible for anyone to do anything,
Without Her knowledge.
The Primordial Lord abides in all.
Let us all worship with joy the
Embodiment of Truth and Awareness.*

The other devotees sang the response* to the song as they silently wept, visibly moved by what had taken place. Absorbed in Her own world, the Mother sat with eyes closed.

CHAPTER 2

TRIP TO KANYAKUMARI (CAPE COMORIN)

*Bhajans or devotional songs are usually sung with one singer leading and a chorus responding.

19 April 1984

After the evening *bhajan*, everyone made preparations to go to Kanyakumari, a holy place and pilgrimage center which is situated on the southernmost tip of India where three seas meet – the Arabian Sea, the Indian Ocean and the Bay of Bengal. The famous Devi temple there is dedicated to the Goddess as the Eternal Virgin, and it is the center of attraction for thousands of devotees from all over India. Mother's devotees had expressed a strong desire for Her to visit this place. They were not so much interested in seeing the Cape, and if it were not for Mother's presence, most of them would not go on their own. The real secret behind their desire was that such trips provided an opportunity for the devotees to spend more time with the Mother. Furthermore, traveling with Mother is always a unique experience, something the devotees can cherish in their hearts forever.

The preparations were completed and more than fifty people gathered together, among them both Ashram residents and householder devotees. The devotees had hired a tourist bus for this trip and had procured cooking vessels, sacks of rice, and other ingredients and items necessary for making food. This was to avoid, as far as possible, having to eat at restaurants and other public places.

After crossing the backwaters, the brahmacharins, with the help of the householder devotees, tied all the luggage on top of the bus and finally everyone was

seated inside. At this point, Mother suddenly said, “Look, children, this is not a picnic or a sight-seeing trip. Consider this as part of your *sadhana* (spiritual practice). Tempting circumstances may arise, but always be aware of your goal. As far as Mother is concerned, She has no special interest in making this trip. She has no reason in agreeing to go other than the happiness of Her children. Try to consider this journey as an effort to journey into your own Self. Talk less. Try to chant your mantra as much as you can. Remember God or your beloved deity whenever you have time. Do not pay any attention to the objects or events which you might see on either side of the road. The mind is already full of images, do not burden it with more. We are trying to remove the existing ones. Let us finish with those and not add any more. If you must speak, do so, but softly and moderately. Do not talk about unnecessary matters. Time is very precious for us. Mother is not at all worried if you lose one *lakh* (100,000) rupees, but if She sees Her children wasting even a second, Mother feels very worried and sad. Lost time will not be retrieved.

“While traveling, many of our *vasanas* will manifest. Be aware of that and try to control your thoughts and sense organs. Children, when you are all alone, staying away from crowds and not mingling with people, you may not be aware of the latent tendencies dormant in you. Rather, you may feel peaceful, happy and content when you are alone or in favorable company. But if you cannot maintain that peace and con-

tentment while you are in the midst of people whom you do not like or while you are in a tempting situation, that peace or contentment is not genuine. To maintain that peace and contentment in all circumstances is our goal. Therefore, children, try to have maximum mental control. Practice love, patience and forbearance during this trip. This is a good opportunity for you to put those qualities into practice. Someone may disagree with you and another may argue with you. Don't react; try to be calm. Your calmness will disarm the other person. If you have any complaints, come tell Mother about it, but do not get angry; do not speak roughly or use harsh words.

"If anger arises in you, do not express it immediately. Leave the place. Go and sit somewhere by yourself. Contemplate and meditate. You will find that the cause of your anger is not in the other person but within you. It is not the other person that causes it, but your past. The past is your reference book. Anger is within you. Someone accidentally touches the anger in you, and you erupt.

"Anger is like an infected wound. When somebody touches it, you feel the pain. And if the touch is hard, pus and blood will come out, creating more pain. Yes, anger is a deep, infected wound. It is a disease and needs to be treated. It needs your compassion and loving attention. Therefore, when someone gets angry, remember that he is a sick person. Do not make him more sick; do not let more pus and blood flow out of his wound. Do not make him experience more pain by

pressing and squeezing harder and harder. This means that we should not return anger. By getting angry with a person who is angry with us, we are not treating the wound but making it only bigger and deeper. What an angry person needs is condolence. Take pity on him and soothe his wound of anger. Children, once again, Mother wants to remind you that this is an opportunity. Mother knows very well that it is quite natural to have conflicts and arguments when we are in a group. None of you are Self-Realized; therefore, disagreements among you can happen. But try to practice love and patience.”

Mother paused for a while and then She said, “Let us now begin our journey.” As the driver started the engine, the devotees called out together, “*Jai Bolo Satguru Mata Amritanandamayi Devi!*” (Victory to the Perfect Master Mata Amritanandamayi Devi). Again Mother’s voice was heard, “Sing a *bhajan* in praise of Ganesha,” and they sang *Gajanana*...

*O Elephant-faced One...
 O Son of Parvati,
 Abode of Compassion, Supreme Cause...
 Destroyer of Obstacles who is served by the virtuous,
 Pure Consciousness, of dark blue hue,
 Eternal One, bereft of sorrow,
 One who gives good results...
 O Protector of the afflicted,*

*Illuminator of the Self, full of Bliss
And worshipped even by Indra...*

The time was 11:00 p.m. as the bus began to slowly move. The devotees continued singing. Everybody was very enthusiastic and happy. It seemed that all were full of blissful anticipation. Mother's instructions had instilled the spirit and strength of a genuine pilgrimage in the minds of the devotees. Everybody looked forward to a wondrous spiritual journey.

For most people, a picnic provides the opportunity to temporarily forget their daily routine and to enjoy pleasure objects as much as they want. On such occasions people in the world go on eating, drinking and indulging as they try to be happy. They want to forget everything, all their worries, tensions and strains. And to achieve this they depend on objects which they think will give them pleasure. Of course they do get a certain degree of happiness and will succeed in forgetting their worries for a short time. But afterwards, when they return to their daily lives, they will be thrown back into the midst of worries and problems. Not only that, through over-indulgence they will have dissipated all their energies and will not be able to function effectively. Caught-up in a vicious cycle, they end up worse than ever, heading towards disaster.

This journey also looked like a picnic. But it was a spiritual picnic under the guidance and leadership of a Perfect Master, a Knower of the Self. With such a

leader it was not really necessary to select an idyllic place for the picnic, for a *Mahatma* could create waves of spiritual vibration all around, immersing the participants in the bliss that issues from within. At this picnic the food was the Divine Name. On an ordinary picnic people seek pleasure in external objects, letting all their energies drain away as they depend on things outside themselves for satisfaction and happiness. But the spiritual seeker conserves energy by relying on his own Self, the source of happiness. While people in the world descend until they break down and succumb to the morass of a meaningless life, spiritual people have the opportunity to rise up and ultimately ascend to the state of Bliss and Immortality.

Life is a picnic. We have a choice of two places to have this picnic. One site is beautiful and alluring to the senses which perceive the external world, but this place offers only a mass of confusion within one's mind. The other is not so attractive or appealing on the outside but filled with immense bliss and peace for one's inner being. We are free to choose. Ordinary people in the world and spiritual people are both looking for happiness. Whether it will be a temporary happiness which will culminate in never-ending sorrow or in a temporary endurance of trials which will lead to everlasting bliss, is for us to decide. One site is found within and the other is the external world. One is the path of eternal bliss and the other is the path of temporary happiness.

The devotees clapped their hands and kept on

singing. The night was under the cover of rain clouds. The darkness reminded one of the dark blue hue of Mother Kali. The moon peeped through the rain clouds as they were scattered by the wind. The devotees stopped singing as Mother said in a loud voice, "Count the heads." One resident approached Her and said, "Amma, we have a list of the names of everybody traveling in the bus." "Okay, then call each name and let the person respond by chanting 'Om Namah Shivaya'," Mother said. This brahmacharin began calling out the names one by one, and the devotees responded as instructed by the Mother. She laughed and apparently enjoyed this very much and remarked, "Just like being in school."

When the roll call was completed, Mother started singing *Maname Nara Jivita Makum...*

*O mind, this human birth is like a field,
If not cultivated properly
It becomes dry and barren.*

*You know neither how to sow the seeds properly
Nor how to grow them well,
Neither have you the wish to know.*

*By removing the weeds and applying fertilizer,
By taking proper care,
You may have a good harvest.*

As the singing continued, the rain clouds slowly disappeared. Both heaven and earth were lit up by the

shimmering moonlight. Immersed in a completely in-drawn state, Mother kept on singing while Her eyes were fixed on the silvery sky above. *Radha Ramana...*

*O Beloved of Radha, Lord of my heart,
Destroyer of misery and Support of all,
Is it not Thee, O Embodiment of Consciousness,
Who occupies my mind solely?*

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The next morning at around five o'clock, the bus carrying Mother and Her children reached Kanyakumari. They at once proceeded to a small ashram which belonged to a swami who had great respect for the Mother, and he was very delighted to see Her. Everyone had a chance to rest from their all-night journey.

At 6:00 a.m. they went to another spiritual center and rented rooms. Half an hour later everyone went with Mother to see the sunrise. She stood on a rock facing east as the sun slowly emerged from the sea. Yellow rays of sunlight blended with the reddish glow of the sky, and this light slowly pervaded the eastern horizon and was reflected in the sea. The Mother stood like a statue on the rock, gazing at the sun, beholding its glory and splendor. Her countenance shone with a radiant smile. Raising both Her arms, She sang *Vandikyunnen...*

*In order that You dance within me,
O Mother, O Adorable One*

*I bow and surrender to Thee.
Existing as the Power of Life
Within the individual soul,
If You should leave, all would become still.*

*O Universal Energy, the Self of Perfect Bliss,
Come, come, O Supreme Light
Remain, never abandon me.*

*O Thou Atom of atoms,
Who pervades the Universe,
Dweller in the Thousand-petalled Lotus,
Come, come.*

*Thou Whose brilliance equals millions of suns,
Dweller within myself,
That Mother alone is the only hope
For getting merged in Her.*

The devotees sang the response. Afterwards, with everyone feeling as if they had been bathed in the eternal glory of the Supreme Light, they slowly walked back to their rooms. Each cherished the vision of the rising sun glowing on the horizon, the soothing sounds of the ocean waves lapping on the shore, and the divine feeling which the Mother had created through Her physical presence and Her singing. The charm and beauty of this occasion was utterly inexplicable.

RECEIVING THE GURU'S PRASAD

Later Mother and the group went into the city of Kanyakumari to visit the Devi Temple. By the seashore on the southern side of this temple lived Mayi Amma, an *avadhuta* (one in a state of bliss, beyond the observance of social mores).

A few years earlier, during the first visit that Mother had made to the Cape, a devotee who accompanied Her had a wonderful experience with this *avadhuta* who lived with her pack of dogs. No one knew much about her. She was said to be more than 150 years old. She very seldom spoke, and if she did utter something, it was hardly understandable. She was indeed a totally incomprehensible character.

Just the day before that first visit to Kanyakumari, that particular devotee had come to the Ashram and was with the Mother when She was eating Her lunch. A few of the brahmacharins were also present, and as it was Her custom in those days, Mother would feed all those who sat near Her before She Herself would eat. Mother offered a ball of rice to everyone, including that devotee, who was a strict vegetarian. Because the Ashram was right in the middle of a fishing village and fish was generally eaten by the villagers, the man was worried that there was fish in the rice and therefore was hesitant to accept the Mother's *prasad*. Since only vegetarian food was made at the ashram, there was no fish in the rice at all. Mother did not insist, so he did not take the *prasad*.

The next day the same devotee was among the

people in Mother's party who happened to be with Mayi Amma while she was having her lunch. Mayi Amma, too, gave *prasad* to everyone. When it was the devotee's turn to receive *prasad*, Mayi Amma put aside the rice and vegetables she had been distributing and uncovered a separate dish, took out a big piece of fried fish and pushed it into his mouth. This was quite unexpected! Nobody even suspected that there was fish in the *biksha* (alms) she had received. No fish had been given to anyone else, except that devotee who had refused the *prasad* from the Holy Mother the day before. Everyone else had received plain rice mixed with vegetables. The devotee turned pale and sat with the fish between his teeth while everyone burst into laughter. He could neither swallow it nor could he spit it out. He was in a dilemma. For although he was a strict vegetarian, this fish was *prasad*, therefore sacred. Finally he had to swallow it, closing both his eyes tightly.

Later he confessed, "That was God's punishment for my having doubts about Amma in not accepting the *prasad* which She had offered me. That was a good lesson for me."

Another incident of someone refusing the Holy Mother's *prasad* is worth relating at this time. It happened in 1979, back in the days when devotees from the neighboring houses used to bring food to the

*The creative power of thought and will manifesting as feelings, prayers, attitudes and resolves.

Mother. The Mother never cared what they brought as an offering, and sometimes they brought fish as a side dish for the rice. She knew that for the local villagers fish was a staple food and one of their favorite dishes. About this the Mother has said, "While cooking the food, the devotees constantly chant their mantras. These children bring it with great *sankalpa* * and devotion. How can Mother refuse it when their devotion and *sankalpa* are so pure and innocent?" And so even though all the Ashramites were pure vegetarians, the Mother would lovingly accept this favorite food of the villagers.

A second particular incident involved a woman devotee who had come for the Mother's *darshan*. As she was sitting next to Mother, another devotee from a neighboring house arrived with *biksha* for Mother. A side dish of fish came with the rice she brought, and, as was Her custom, Mother offered one ball of rice with curry to this woman devotee beside Her. The woman took it in her hands, but she did not eat it. After the woman had left, Mother commented to some of the remaining devotees, "What a pity! That daughter did not eat the rice," When the woman had returned to her home, she became sick, vomiting constantly whenever she ate or drank anything. Day by day her condition grew worse. She could eat nothing at all, and, as a result, she became very weak. Although she tried different medications, nothing relieved her condition. A whole week passed in this manner when suddenly she was struck with the revela-

tion that her vomiting condition was caused by the fact that she had refused to eat the Holy Mother's *prasad*.

Immediately she returned to the Ashram, and as she stepped into the *darshan* hut, the woman heard the Mother saying to another devotee the very words she needed to hear, "The Guru is God. Whatever the Guru gives should be accepted with utmost reverence and devotion. Even if it is a seemingly insignificant object like a stone or a blade of grass, one should accept it as one would the most precious thing. One should not refuse the Guru's *prasad*, whatever it might be. Ordinary human beings cannot understand with what *sankalpa* the Guru gives the *prasad*. *Satgurus* know what to give and when to give it. Therefore, accept whatever they give. Never deny the Guru's *prasad*."

Hearing these words, the woman was overcome with emotion. Now she was fully convinced about the cause of her sickness. She fell at the Mother's feet and sought forgiveness for her ignorant behavior. Mother consoled her and fed her with a small piece of banana which she ate. Thereafter, the vomiting completely stopped. It had taken her a whole week to realize the cause of her troubles, but it was a lesson duly learned. Such incidents with the Mother are worth remembering because they illustrate how to respond in the presence of a Perfect Master.

After spending the day visiting the temple and dif-

ferent parts of the shore around Kanyakumari, Mother returned in the evening to the ashram, accepting the invitation the swami had extended to Her that morning. At five o'clock the swami spoke a few words about the Mother before the evening *bhajan* began. He said, "Even today there are *jivanmuktas* (Self-Realized souls) and *avatars* (Divine Incarnations) in this country. Amma is this kind of Divine Incarnation. But people do not have the eyes to see it. Those who have not inherited from their previous birth the ability to recognize them will scandalize *jivanmuktas* and *avatars*, thus making it impossible for others to come to know and worship these great souls. This is a very sad situation."

The *bhajan* lasted for an hour or so. One of the songs led by Mother was *Amme Yennu Loru...*

*Why is it that my hairs stand on end
When I remember the word 'Amma'?
Why do I forget everything else
When I think of Mother, my Mother?*

*Thirst and hunger have left me,
I have also forgotten my daily bath,
I know not what day or date this is,
I forget everything in the thought of Mother.*

*Brahmacharini Gayatri ("mol" means "daughter" in Mother's language, Malayalam) is Mother's personal attendant. In 1984 there were only two brahmacharinis who lived with Mother, Gayatri and Kunjumol, both of whom looked after Her personal needs. There were other women who came for extended visits and some householder residents.

*What is my mind pining for?
Why does my body tremble when I look
At the blue sea, the blue sky
And the white clouds?
Mother's sweet form
Is a solace to suffering minds,
Now my only thought is
When will I see Her again?
When will Mother come to me?*

After the *bhajan*, the group returned to the center where they had booked rooms. Mother also returned but remained outside, still in a blissful state after Her ecstatic singing. She did not want others around Her at this particular time. All alone She walked a short distance away from the building and sat under a neem tree. At ten o'clock, the center and its environs were quiet even though there were many people staying there. Half an hour passed. Everyone was still waiting outside the building, with the hope that they could once again see Mother before they went to bed. As if in response to their wishes and prayers, Mother's voice emerged from the dark, "Gayatri-mol."* Everyone's attention turned in the direction of Her voice as the glow of expectation shone on their faces. "Call all the children." That was enough. Gayatri did not have to inform them, for the whole group immediately ran toward Mother. Each one wanted to sit as close to Her as possible. Jostling, they tried to get

closer and closer. When at last everyone had settled down, a silence prevailed which was broken only by Mother's voice, "Children, if any of you are too tired or feel sleepy, don't strain yourself. Don't feel that because Mother has called, you must sit here. Mother just wanted to see all Her children together; that's why She called you." But none of them wanted to go to bed, for their hearts craved to spend as much time as they could with Mother.

SUBTLE FOOD OF THE GURU

One of the devotees remarked, "We are hungry children, Amma. Give us something to eat. How can you ask us to go to bed when we are badly in need of food? We cannot sleep when you are going to serve food here."

Amma said, "This is subtle food. To taste this subtle food one needs a subtle tongue. Children, the Guru is, in fact, your food. A true disciple should try to eat him up. The Guru is waiting to be swallowed by the disciple. But most disciples are unable to do that, for they lack the subtlety to do so. They know only about the gross body of the Guru."

"Amma," asked one of the devotees, "what do you mean by subtle food? And what do you mean by 'eating up the Guru'?"

Her reply came, "It doesn't mean that you should bite him and eat him up." All laughed, the Mother included.

When the laughter subsided, Amma continued,

“The Guru’s real form is something far beyond the physical plane of existence. It transcends even the Trimurti (the Trinity – Brahma, the Creator; Vishnu, the Preserver; and Maheshwara, the Destroyer). It is the Supreme Principle itself. One should try to see through the physical form of the Guru to his inner form, the subtle form. One needs subtlety of mind to know and realize this subtle nature of the Guru. Through *sadhana* one should try to attain that state of mind. This food is not something which can be taken through the mouth. It is to be imbibed through the heart. Imbibing the higher principles in which the Guru lives is eating up the Guru. If you see only the Guru’s physical form, without trying to understand his inner nature, you will always end up in danger. Let Mother tell you a story to illustrate this point.

“There was once a Master who had two disciples who always competed with each other. One day while he was resting the Guru called both of them to massage his legs. The Guru was lying down and the two disciples sat on either side of him. The first disciple said, ‘Look here, the right leg is mine, and the left is yours, okay?’ The second disciple replied, ‘Agreed. And don’t encroach on my territory. If I am going to take care of the left leg, don’t butt in.’ The first one answered back, ‘I and my right leg will not interfere with you and your left leg.’ So they started massaging. The poor Guru was not aware of this division. He fell asleep, and as he shifted positions, he unknowingly lifted his right leg onto his left. This was enough to en-

rage the second disciple. The furious disciple stood up and accosted the first disciple, 'You broke the agreement. Remove your right leg from my left leg this very moment. If you don't, you will see who I am and what I can do!' Upon hearing this, the first disciple also got up, yelling, 'Shut up, you braggart! Go ahead, let me see what you can do to my right leg! Do it, if you dare!'

"Both of the disciples grabbed two long sticks. The second disciple got ready to break the right leg while the first was bent on taking revenge by breaking the left leg. Hearing the argument between the two disciples, the Guru woke up and was surprised to see them standing one on either side of him, furiously glaring at each other while brandishing sticks. He exclaimed, 'What is this? What are you two doing?' The disciples coolly retorted, 'Go back to sleep. This is none of your business. We can settle this matter.'

"This is what happens if one does not try to see beyond the physical Guru. One should strive hard to see the real nature of the Guru. That real nature is something beyond His physical form. To perceive that essential nature of the Guru one needs subtlety, subtlety to penetrate the Guru. Otherwise, it could culminate in something like this incident of the two disciples trying to break the Guru's leg.

"Subtlety of mind can only be attained through concentration. It comes when the mind is completely

*Anoraniyan Mahatomahiyam in Sanskrit, meaning "subtler than the subtlest, bigger than the biggest."

focused on the Supreme Principle, when all thought waves have ceased. In that state your mind becomes as expansive and vast as the unclouded sky.

“The Guru is the Creator, the Sustainer and the Destroyer, and at the same time He is beyond these. The Guru is the Supreme Principle made manifest in the form of one who sheds light upon the disciple. By sowing the seed of spirituality in the disciple, the Guru wakes him up from the sleep of ignorance. Externally we are wide awake, that is, we are in an ordinary state of being awake to the world of objects. We are wide awake to the plural world of objects and fast asleep to the real world of Consciousness. From this standpoint, one may wonder, “How can I wake up again?” It is the inner awakening that is the real waking up. Even though every morning we wake up to the external world of objects, we are fast asleep internally. We are asleep, not awake to the Reality of the Self within. The Guru makes the disciple understand and realize that he is sleeping, that he is in ignorance. In order to remove something, one should, first of all, know that it is there. The Guru makes the disciple aware of his own ignorance. Having done this, a Satguru makes the disciple work in his spiritual practice in order to remove this ignorance.

“More precisely, the Guru wakes the disciple up from sleep, makes him aware that he is sleeping deep within, and by putting him through rigorous spiritual training, he awakens the spiritual energy within him. Working side by side with the disciple, the Guru

breaks the shell of his ego. Thus the Guru becomes the destroyer, the destroyer of the ego.

“A Great Master is the embodiment of the ‘subtler than the subtlest’ principle.* Only when the disciple becomes as subtle as the Guru can he realize his unity with such a Perfect Master.”

The Mother paused. All could clearly see Her face as they sat around Her under the neem tree. The moon was shining in the sky and its glow caressed the earth. The moon which enhanced that night was like the Mother who beautified human hearts. In that peaceful atmosphere everyone seemed very much absorbed both in the Mother’s form and in Her words. Someone in the group commented, “Amma, you are that Guru. You are that subtle principle.”

Amma did not pay any attention to him. She just sat gazing at the moon. Another devotee reminded Her that She had not said anything about ‘eating up the Guru.’ But She did not reply. She remained looking at the moon. She was in a rapture, for Her eyes were still and fixed. Realizing that the Mother was in an absorbed mood, the devotees kept quiet. It took a few minutes for Her to come down.

She then continued, “ ‘Eating the Guru up’ means to merge in him completely. You should dissolve. The ‘I’ or the ego should dissolve and disappear. Disappearance of your little self and total identification with the Guru’s inner Self is what is meant by ‘eating up.’

This is total Oneness. Forgetting all about yourself, your entire being should enter into and disappear in his Pure Being. This is 'eating up the Guru.' It is possible only through love, only through the heart, not with the head. Love can easily consume the Guru. Love can easily consume your ego. Once the ego is fully consumed by Love, the Guru will simply enter into you or you can simply enter into Him. Both are one and the same because then there is nothing to obstruct, nothing to stop the flow. This flow of love goes both ways and becomes one. The Guru is already flowing constantly, flowing and overflowing the brim with love. And through love you flow into Him.

"In the state of pure innocent love, the lover is always hungry. He wants to eat up his beloved. There is an insatiable hunger in pure love. One can see and experience this intense hunger even in worldly love. But in spiritual love the intensity reaches its peak. That apex is the extreme point, the ultimate limit which is limitless, for this love is all-expansive. In a true seeker this love becomes like a forest fire, yet it is even more intense, more consuming. His whole being will burn with the intensity of that fire of love. In that blazing fire he himself gets consumed and then comes the complete merging.

"What happens when you eat food? The digestive process makes it one with your body. The food will become one with you. It will become your body, mind and intellect. Similarly, the Guru is your spiritual

food. Eat him up if you can. Imbibe him. Let his light and love fill your body, mind and intellect. If you do this then there will be no more body, mind or intellect. You will become love. The Guru is waiting to be consumed. If you are hungry, swallow him up. If you are not hungry, starve in order to feel hunger.”

Astonished by the imagery, a devotee exclaimed, “Starve! It’s not about giving up food that you are talking, is it? Could you please make this clearer?”

“Son, you are right,” Amma said. “Mother does not mean physical starvation. Make the mind starve. Stop feeding the mind with thoughts. We continue feeding the mind with the food of desires and thoughts. This has become a habit, and the mind now thinks that this is the best food. This is a habit which should be removed. The mind should know that this food will give us a ‘stomach ache,’ if not now, then later. The mind should know that this food of thoughts and desires is harmful and that there is food far tastier and healthier than this. The various spiritual practices make up the most delicious and healthful food. Once you experience this, start to feed the mind regularly with the Divine Name, *japa* (chanting one’s mantra), *dhyana* (meditation) and other spiritual practices. Slowly the hunger to have more and more of this spiritual food will grow until at last it becomes a terrible hunger. You will want to swallow God. But to attain this, starve the mind. Stop feeding the mind with worldly thoughts and desires.”

Mother stopped. After a few moments of silence, She asked Balu to sing a *kirtan* (devotional song)...*Katutta Sokamam*...

*O Mother, let me not fall into this
Deep dark pit of sorrow.
I am neither a scholar
Nor one born under a lucky star.
Nevertheless, intense are my thoughts
Fixed on Thee,
O Mother, walk not away,
Simply casting a smile at me.
Renouncing all other forms of happiness
And constantly remembering Thy purity,
I chant Thy transcendent Names.
O Eternal Auspiciousness,
To remember Thy words
That this birth is to exhaust
All errors from my past births, I console myself.*

*O Embodiment of Compassion,
Remove my ignorance.
Bestow pure intelligence on me.
In the midst of worldly pleasures,
I always gaze upon Thee
Yet unhappy am I. O Ruler of all worlds,
Giver of greatness, light the lamp
Of equal vision in my innermost self.*

It was nearly eleven o'clock. Mother said, "Children, all of you go to bed now." After having pros-

trated to the Mother, all got up and went to their rooms. Mother, accompanied by Gayatri, sat under the neem tree for a while longer. She put Her head on Gayatri's lap and lay there in silence. It was not quite midnight when She finally went to Her room.

A few brahmacharins and householder devotees did not go to bed on returning to their shared rooms. Instead, they sat on their beds and began discussing the day's conversations with the Mother. The late-night discussion quickly evolved into a dispute, for each one of them had his own interpretation of Her wisdom-filled words. As the lively discussion continued, someone knocked on the door. All wondered who it could be at such a late hour, for it was already 1:30 a.m. They thought that it was perhaps the caretaker or a guard. Assuming it must be the night watchman, they opened the door. How surprised they were to see the Mother standing there, with Gayatri just behind! The Mother had a serious look on Her face.

A few moments passed before She spoke, "Have you forgotten so quickly about all the things which Mother told you before we started this trip? It is one-thirty in the morning; you know that it is wrong to be talking so loudly at this hour. You are not the only ones staying here, you know. There are many, many others. Why do you disturb their sleep by making so much noise? To share your ideas about the *satsang* (spiritual talk) is all right. But to enter into a dispute about it, and adamantly say that what you felt is the only correct interpretation is wrong, totally wrong. By

doing this you are narrowing your mind. Sharing ideas is different from disputing. In sharing both parties listen and tell, give and accept. This gives you a broader attitude. It helps you grow. There is no harm in that. But when disputing, you talk – you don't listen. You give your ideas but don't accept the ideas of others even if they express a genuine idea. Thus you are closing yourself, narrowing and limiting yourself. This is dangerous. Moreover, whatever Mother said was meant for contemplation, not for dispute. It was meant to be exercised, not analyzed. It was not to be cut and chopped into pieces with your head."

Having said this much, the Mother left. The devotees and brahmacharins were full of remorse for what they had done. They did not speak another word. They switched off the light and went to bed, feeling a bit sad about the whole incident.

In a few minutes there was another knock at the door. Almost in unison they jumped out of bed and in a split second, the light was turned on. Opening the door, they found Mother standing there, smiling this time. She said, "Mother could not remain in the room after having scolded Her children. She felt restless. Children, did you feel sad?" She was full of compassion.

Together they replied, "No, Amma, not at all." One devotee added, "We realized our mistake. We should not have done that. Amma, we are all ignorant children, so ignorant!" and he began to cry.

With great affection, Amma consoled him and the others. Dividing the plantain She held into small pieces, She fed a bit to each person and once again spoke a few consoling words, “Children, don’t be sad. Mother can only do things which are good for you, things which will make you grow spiritually. She cannot act otherwise. Mother feels that freedom with Her children; therefore, She cannot help correcting you when you make mistakes, for She thinks that you will take it in the right way. Mother feels that you are Her own. Children, you should also try to feel the same way, that Mother is your own. Then there will not be any sadness or mental agitation.”

Her words were so full of concern and love that the devotees and brahmacharins could not control their tears. Each one of them cried privately while lying in bed that night, cherishing in his heart the Mother’s innocent love for Her children. They all felt themselves cradled to sleep in the Mother’s arms.

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The next morning at seven o’clock, the entire group left for Marutvamala, a sacred hill. Also called Medicine Hill, this little mountain is famous for the ayurvedic herbs which grow on it. The ancient *Puranas* (epics) say that Hanuman, the great servant devotee of Lord Sri Rama, was sent to obtain some divine herbs to heal Lakshmana, Rama’s devoted brother who was wounded in the battle against Ravana in Sri Lanka (Ceylon). Ravana had abducted Sita,

the wife of Rama, and the battle was fought to rescue Sita. Lakshmana was wounded by a spear thrown by Ravana and was lying in a coma. Only herbs obtained from Mt. Kailash could restore him to consciousness. Rather than waste time looking for the individual herbs, Hanuman uprooted an entire portion of the mountain and flew back to Sri Lanka. As he rounded the tip of India, a piece of the mountain fell off near Kanyakumari, forming this sacred medicine hill, Marutvamala. Today many seekers come here on their pilgrimage, climbing this hill to make offerings at its Hanuman shrine, and *sadhaks* (spiritual aspirants) can be found performing *tapas* in small caves dispersed on this hill.

NAYANAR SWAMI

A short distance away from the main road, where the path leading to Marutvamala Hill began, there was a small house where another *avadhuta* (this one an old man) used to live. His name was Nayanar Swami. Mother had met him on Her first visit to Kanyakumari three years before.

During his lifetime, Nayanar Swami had stayed in one very small room in the house which belonged to a lower class Tamil family. The dark room from which he is said never to have emerged was filled with sacks and pieces of wood, and all sorts of other seemingly useless things which he had used to make images of goddesses and gods. He was a very strange character whose actions were incomprehensible to most people.

Yet many divine powers were attributed to him. Nayanar Swami had left his body one year before this present visit. In fact, just after returning from Her visit with Nayanar Swami three years earlier, Mother had predicted that he would leave his body after two years' time.

Some very interesting things took place at that first meeting of Mother and this *avadhuta*. The Holy Mother and a group of about twenty devotees were on their return trip to Vallickavu after having spent three days in Kanyakumari. During those three days, most of their time was spent in *satsang*, *bhajan* and meditation on the rocks by the seashore and in the Devi temple by the side of the ocean. Traveling in a hired van, the group began to proceed north. Hardly had they gone ten kilometers when all of a sudden a strange looking old man jumped in front of the van, waving his hands as if to signal the vehicle to stop. "Stop the van! There is Nayanar Swami!" Mother shouted.

The van was stopped and everyone got up from his seat. Seeing the swami enter a small house, Mother and all Her devotees followed him inside. Mother sat down in front of Nayanar Swami and everyone gathered around. The *avadhuta* swami was very excited. He muttered a few words in Hindi and then, pointing his finger towards the Holy Mother, he called out, "Kali! Kali! Deathless One!" As he shouted these words over and over again, the Mother's *bhava* (mood) suddenly changed.

Her tongue stuck out, Her eyes bulged, and She produced a peculiar sound which was similar to that of the seed letter 'Hrim' being chanted constantly in an unbroken stream. As She manifested all these gestures, the Mother levitated. She was not touching the floor at all! The fingers of both Her hands held divine *mudras* (yogic gestures). The Mother was portraying the fierce aspect of Mother Kali, and the swami appeared to be very excited and delighted indeed.

The brahmacharins and devotees began singing a *kirtan* (devotional song). They were all a bit frightened and worried to see the unexpected changes in the Mother's mood. Some of the women even began to cry. Eventually the Holy Mother returned to the physical plane of consciousness, and Her normal self. The swami also grew calm. At this point, one of the Mother's devotees reached out with his palm towards him and asked, "Swami, will you give me *brahmatvam* (the state of Brahman)?" Nayanar Swami forcibly turned the devotee's hand towards the Mother and said in Hindi, "Here, you ask Her. She is the right person to ask."

Later when the brahmacharins asked Mother why She manifested the divine mood in the swami's presence, She answered, "He desired to see it." They did not know what She meant.

Now, three year later, as Mother and the group left the bus to climb the sacred hill, they were greeted by

the local people. Upon seeing the Mother and Her devotees, the family with whom Nayanar Swami had lived came running towards them and offered their prostrations to Her. They expressed their wish to have a picture of Amma and the address of the Ashram saying, "Three years ago, when all of you left after visiting the swami, he exclaimed to us, "Do you know who that was? She is Kali, Bhadrakali!" They also told us that as the van had moved away, the swami had come out of the house again and stood there staring at it until it disappeared from his sight. They added that the swami had never come out of his room, not before nor since, except for those two times, that is, when he had jumped in front of the van to make it stop, and when he had come out to watch the Mother drive away.

One of the devotees gave the lady of the house a picture of the Mother and the Ashram address, which the family was very happy to receive. Mother and the group of devotees took leave of them and started to climb the hill.

Marutvamala was very beautiful. There were shady trees, rocks and caves on the hill, making it an ideal setting for a life of asceticism and contemplation. Everyone climbed the hill with great enthusiasm, even the elderly people who had come with the group in a separate car which followed the bus. All were so happy to make this pilgrimage with Mother that they did not feel any weariness or fatigue. Occasionally Mother turned around and asked the elderly devotees, "Do you feel tired? If you do, sit down and rest for a

while.” They always replied, “No, we are not tired. When Amma is with us, how can we feel tired?” It was actually amazing to see how these elderly people climbed the hill which was quite steep in some parts along the way.

As She walked, the Holy Mother started singing devotional songs. Everyone responded blissfully. With arms outstretched in ecstasy, the Mother sang as She ascended the hill. One devotee was carrying a tin container full of banana chips on his head and set it down in front of Mother who distributed the food to everyone. Again, She sang... *Hariyude Kalil...*

*Without falling at the Feet of God,
None can extinguish the fire
Of the sorrow of transmigration.
Without bowing forever to the Guru,
None will gain the bliss of Liberation.
None can reach the Lord
Without getting absorbed in chanting the Name.
None can attain the state of Liberation
Without merging in the sweetness of devotion.*

*He who does not meditate, do japa
Or other spiritual practices,
Will not partake of the nectar of Bliss.
Without righteousness and compassion,
Good actions cannot be performed.*

*In this world, only God is the Friend
Of the devotee and the Supporter of the helpless.*

*When He is with us,
How can we be without support?*

HUMILITY

The group reached a place on the hill where there was a beautiful temple, and everyone stopped there for a short while to rest. Two monks of the place came up to the Mother and bowed down before Her. They had heard about the Mother and wanted to meet Her, they explained. She talked to them for a few minutes, and when they left, She said, "One of them is a good *sadhak*. Mother knew this immediately upon looking in his eyes. He is very humble too."

Reminding the devotees about the importance of humility in spiritual life, Amma again spoke: "Humility will come as one progresses in *sadhana*. Humility means seeing God in everything or perceiving one's own Self everywhere. Humility means accepting the Will of the Supreme. Humility means self-surrender, surrendering our will to the Will of God. Once that is done, one can only be humble because one sees that whatever happens in his life, whether positive or negative, is His will. In this state, all reactions disappear. There are no more reactions, only acceptance. Therefore, humility can also be interpreted as total acceptance."

Mother got up from where She sat, saying, "Let us continue climbing." As the group moved up the hill,

Mother led the chant, “Shyam Radhe,” to which the devotees joyfully responded with “Radhe, Radhe.” Sometimes Mother switched and chanted “Radhe, Radhe,” and the group replied, “Shyam, Radhe.”

Although it was a hot day, the breeze lessened the intensity of the heat. Mother kept on chanting, “Shyam, Radhe.” All of a sudden, She stopped chanting and stood still. She was in *samadhi* (absorption in the Self or God). With both hands raised forming a divine *mudra*, the Mother remained perfectly still. Her eyes were half-closed, and a beautiful smile glowed on Her face. Minutes passed. Slowly She regained consciousness but remained unmoving for a little while longer before proceeding. Silence prevailed for some time. No one spoke.

It was Mother who broke the silence, “Children, don’t forget to chant your mantra. The period of *sadhana* is like climbing a high mountain. You need a lot of strength and energy. Mountain climbers use rope for pulling themselves up. For you, the only rope is *japa*. Therefore, children, try to repeat your mantra constantly. Once you reach the peak, you can relax and rest forever.”

The sun became more and more intense. Someone tried to hold an umbrella for Mother, but She refused it, “No, no. Mother doesn’t need an umbrella. How can She stay under an umbrella when all Her children are walking in the sun? Besides, She is used to it. Come rain or shine Mother used to spend all Her

days and nights outside in the open air. Sugunanan-dan-acchan (father) and Damayanti Amma used to get so worried about Mother's staying outside that they built a raised shelter in order to protect Her from the rain and the sun. But She never remained there. Mother was very determined to transcend both heat and cold by enduring them. The heat of obstacles will not affect a person who constantly remembers God."

As the group continued climbing, Mother noticed some people relaxing under some shady trees. Another wise saying followed, "When the time comes, the leaves will fall off of even shade-giving trees, and you who sit under them will again have to sweat and toil in the sun's heat."

This was a hint which meant that God alone gives eternal shade, and that none of the worldly places of refuge is permanent. These temporal shelters will perish one day or another, pushing one again into deep sorrow.

Mother continued, "Only a few, very few among the millions who have tried for it, have ever reached the goal. It will certainly not be possible to reach the goal if you forget the goal while sitting in the shade along the way.

"Some *sadhaks* come and ask Mother the day, date and even the time of their realization. Poor people, they don't understand that thinking and brooding about such things are distractions from the goal. Chil-

dren, there are express buses and local ones. Once the express bus starts from its point of origin, it never stops until it reaches its destination. One can easily predict that the express bus will reach its destination on time. However, the local bus will stop and take people from every junction, and one cannot state the exact time that it will arrive at the destination. Similarly, the determination and *lakshya bodha* (intent to reach the goal) of some *sadhaks* are so strong that they won't stop until they reach the goal. Such *sadhaks* are like the express bus, and a Satguru can tell when they will reach the goal. On the other hand, most *sadhaks* are like the local bus. They lack determination and *lakshya bodha*; therefore, it is difficult to say when they will reach the goal. They are like people who sit in the 'shade' forgetting the goal."

A devotee remarked, "Amma, you are always sitting, aren't you? It is we who walk, isn't that so?"

"If Mother sits, everyone will sit, and then no climbing will take place," came the Mother's immediate answer.

Everyone felt that She was indicating that the wheel of creation will come to a standstill if God becomes inactive.

Some *sannyasins* (renunciates) were sitting on either side of the path. Mother asked the householder devotees to give them alms, explaining, "In order to sustain the body, these *sannyasins* need food. By giving alms to them, householders gain merit. In order to

lead a happy life in the world, a householder needs such merit. Giving alms to the deserving is a way of acquiring merit. But a true spiritual seeker tries to go beyond both merit and demerit; therefore, he does not care about its gain or loss.”

Eventually Mother and the whole party reached the peak which was named Pillattadam. It was an especially lovely place from which one could see all the surrounding areas. There was a shelter here with a natural rock covering for a roof, and several large, flat rocks where one could sit comfortably. Just below there was a natural cave which was occupied by a *sannyasin*.

As Mother and all Her children sat on the rocks, She gazed at the eastern horizon for a long time. The atmosphere was peaceful and serene, as this place was totally isolated from the outside world. A strong wind blew from the west, but that slowly subsided after a short while. Mother seemed to be revelling in Her own world, and the whole group remained silent. Some time passed and then She sang... *Kodanukodi*...

*O Truth Eternal,
Mankind has searched for Thee
For millions and millions of years.*

*Renouncing everything, the ancient sages
Performed endless years of austerities
In order to make the Self flow
Into Thy Divine Stream through meditation.*

*Thy infinitesimal Flame, inaccessible to all,
Glowing like the effulgence of the sun,
Stands still without dancing
Even in the fiercely blowing cyclone.*

Then Mother asked Balu to sing a song. He sang one which he had composed once when he had to be away from Mother for a few weeks...*Sokamitentinu Sandhye...*

*O Twilight, why are you sad?
Are you also wandering on the shores
Of past memories?
O Dusk, bathed in reddish hue,
Is the fire of sorrow burning within you too?*

*O Twilight, have you a Mother like mine?
Or have you seen my Mother
Who radiates the beauty
And coolness of purity like the full moon?
O Dusk, should you see Her, please convey
The message of this helpless son who cannot speak
Due to deep sorrow caused by the pain of separation.
O Twilight, please offer
These flower petals at Her Feet
And kindly convey my humble prostrations to Her.
When you return I will confide in you
The heart-rending stories of my former days.*

After singing more songs, Mother asked everyone

to close his eyes and meditate. She also closed Her eyes and became deeply absorbed. Many of the devotees preferred to sit gazing at the Mother, as most of them had chosen Her as their beloved deity. Yet, bound by Mother's words, everyone turned his gaze inward.

Having spent an hour or so at the top of the hill, at 1:30 p.m. the party began climbing down. There was not much talking during the descent, but *bhajans* filled the air. Mother sang mostly *namavalis* (simple songs chanting the Divine Names). Clapping their hands joyfully and enjoying the nectar of devotional singing, everyone followed Mother down the hill.

SUFFERING OF THE POOR

Upon reaching the foot of the hill, Mother approached some huts where extremely poor Tamil families lived. She spent some time with each of them. Conversing lovingly, She inquired how they earned their livelihood, whether or not they received any support from the government, and asked specifically about other problems they had. Mother seemed very concerned, and expressed much compassion and love for these people, hugging and kissing every one of them, and, with Her own hands, She distributed some sweets and other food.

Upon leaving, Mother said, "Poor children. Mother is deeply wounded in Her mind, seeing these people's suffering. Who will take care of them? People

talk about helping the poor, but no one seems to be doing anything for them. Children, compared to the suffering of these people, our suffering is nothing. God has provided us with food, clothing and shelter. But these children have nothing. Let us use our God-given faculties with utmost discrimination. We must not cheat Him by misusing them. These children might have misused such gifts in their previous births, and that is why they are suffering now. Still it is our duty to have compassion for them. In fact God created the rich to help the poor, the healthy to assist the unhealthy, and normal human beings to help and serve the mentally retarded and physically deformed.”

A devotee asked, “Amma, why does God keep quiet when people are suffering like this? Can’t He do something to remove it?”

“Yes, He did something, son,” came the Mother’s answer. “He created us, hoping that we would do something to help them. We should think of them. We should try to feel their suffering. In order to do this, we should try to put ourselves in their place. We have never suffered in our lives, so we don’t even know what suffering is. We consider our personal problems as big and important. But children, there are more important things in this world. There are far bigger problems to solve. Yet we think of our own problems only. We do not consider others’ problems nor feel any compassion for them. That is our biggest problem. Only a person who has really suffered can understand the suffering of others. We have never

dived deep to the bottom of the sea to collect pearls. We do not know how difficult a task it is, for we are used to buying pearls from a shop. Therefore, we do not know the immense task behind the matter.”

By now the group had reached the bus. Mother was the first to get in and the others followed. When all were settled in their seats, She continued, “There are two occasions when most human beings are happy or unhappy. They are happy when their enemy or one whom they dislike is unhappy or suffering. But they are unhappy when they hear that he is having a good time or a contented life. Mother will tell you an anecdote.

“There were two neighbors who were enemies. One day one of them went to buy some wood to do some maintenance work on his house. Unfortunately, upon returning home, he realized that both pieces of wood that he had purchased were decayed inside, and thus he felt very unhappy about the waste of his money. He then left the house in that state, but when he returned, he was laughing and rejoicing. His wife was curious and asked, ‘Why are you laughing like this? What is the matter?’ He replied, ‘How can I not laugh? You know, in buying the two pieces of rotten wood we did not lose so much money, but our neighbor suffered a huge loss. He bought twenty pieces of the wood from the same shop, and all of it turned out to be just as useless!’” Everybody in the bus burst into laughter.

“Children, this is our attitude,” Amma said after the laughter ended. “We do not have a heart that feels the sorrow of others. We feel happy when our neighbors are unhappy, and we feel unhappy when they are glad. But *Mahatmas* reflect both the happiness and unhappiness of others and express them sincerely. That is the difference between a mortal being and a *Mahatma*. He has the heart to feel others’ sorrow and suffering. The sorrow of others is his sorrow, and the happiness of others is his own happiness. But ordinary human beings are totally self-centered. Children, try to hear the cries and know the pains of suffering people.”

The bus stopped in front of the center where the group was staying. It was now almost three o’clock. Mother went immediately to Her room, while the others had lunch before going to their rooms to rest. Two hours later the group gathered again and went walking to the seashore with Mother in the lead.

Among the devotees there was an eighty-five year old scholar who was an authority on Sanskrit grammar and logic. He was constantly talking, introducing a topic and asking the others to pose questions about the subject. He was very restless and clearly wanted to show off his vast knowledge. He debated, argued and disputed. As the group neared the seashore, Mother called to him, “*Pundit mon* (scholar-son).” Although he boasted in front of others, this learned old man was like a three year-old boy in front of the Mother. His

devotion to Her was very steady and firm. His age did not affect his health at all. He had been practising *hatha yoga* for many, many years, and therefore, he was very strong, cheerful and vigorous.

Upon hearing Mother calling him, the pundit ran towards Her. She looked at him and smiled mischievously, for She had been listening to everything he had said. He bowed low in front of Her. With one hand She caught hold of his hands, and with the fingers of Her other hand, She playfully tapped the top of his bald head as if it were a drum. "Son," Mother remarked, "you have wasted eighty long years with your Sanskrit and logic. After so many years of study, you should try to move from the head to the heart. It is too late for you to do it alone, so Mother is trying to tune you, intellectually at least, by strumming on your head."

Everyone laughed, except for the pundit, who turned pale and said, "Amma, forgive me for my ignorance." He looked a bit distressed. The Mother's words had obviously made him reflect on his life.

After a fifteen-minute walk they reached the seashore. Mother stood still for quite some time, looking out at the vast expanse of the sea. Then She asked everyone to sit down and meditate. Before they began, Mother gave instructions: "Visualize a fully-bloomed lotus flower in the ocean and imagine that your be-

**Bhava roga* or the disease of worldly existence.

loved deity is sitting on it. Try to imagine that the deity is looking at you, smiling at you, calling you near and blessing you. Try to see clearly each and every part of your beloved's form—the eyes, eyebrows, nose, lips, cheeks, forehead, hair, crown, everything. If you don't like to do this, you can simply concentrate on the sound of the ocean waves."

Having given these suggestions, the Mother Herself became immersed in meditation. Everyone meditated with Her as they sat before the ocean, its waves unceasingly washing up on the shore, creating a rhythmic drone. The evening light became diffuse as the glow of twilight softened into dusk, and the seagulls emitted a final cry to mark the close of day.

SADHANA, SELF-SURRENDER AND LOVE

After returning from the seashore, Mother and Her children sang *bhajans* in a hall at the place where they were staying. A good-sized crowd came to listen to the Mother and to receive Her blessing. By nine o'clock the *bhajan* and *darshan* were over and Mother returned to Her room. Some very sincere *sadhaks* and a few other devotees who wanted a private audience with the Mother came to see Her. She sat on the front verandah of Her room and invited them to sit in front of Her. They prostrated and sat down.

After a few minutes of light conversation, one of the *sadhaks* asked a question: "Amma, how should one do *sadhana*?"

Mother answered, "Children, you can adopt any

path you like. Son, one path cannot be advised for all. *Sadhana* should be prescribed according to each one's personal inclinations and mental constitution. It is like prescribing different kinds of medicine for people with different diseases. The same medicine cannot be prescribed for all. The medicine and its dosage must differ according to each patient's disease. The same applies to our *sadhana*. Each person is different in nature and, therefore, should be instructed in such a way as to help him personally to progress spiritually. Spiritual practice is a medicine which can eliminate all diseases caused by the nature of existence.* But if the prescription is not correct, like the wrong medicine for a patient, it can cause harm.

"*Lakshya bodha* and effort coupled with patience are needed. In the beginning, one can meditate on the personal aspect of God. But later one should go beyond the form. To attain this, mere reading and studying the scriptures will not suffice. One should also contemplate, 'For what purpose do I read, what is my real goal in life, and what should I do to attain that goal?' Try to keep the mind on God no matter what you are doing. Only if we attain mental maturity can we remain calm, even if somebody scolds us.

"Which path to follow depends on the spiritual disposition one has inherited from the previous birth. This birth is a continuation of the previous one. Whatever path you follow, the mind should flow spontaneously towards it. Love is necessary. To approach a Perfect Master is another way to find your

path.

“Regarding *sadhana*, the most important thing one should remember is to maintain the spirit and practice it until you reach the goal. It is always a deliberate attempt in the beginning. You have to remember it constantly and try to do it without fail. Now, *maya* (illusion, illusory power) is much more powerful than God in us. This means that negative qualities are more powerful than positive qualities. As a result, the chances of losing enthusiasm and giving up the practice completely or decreasing its intensity are stronger than the chances of continuing it. Therefore, you must deliberately continue doing your practices, putting forth as much effort as possible until they become spontaneous.”

Another asked, “How can one attain complete surrender?”

“*Saranagati* (complete self-surrender) is not something which can be taught verbally,” explained the Mother. “It will come if you develop love and faith. Pure and innocent love for God is what is really needed. The mind should long to become one with God.

“Like love, surrender cannot be studied or learned from any books or from any particular person or from a university. Self-surrender comes as love grows. In fact, the two grow simultaneously. The more you love a person, the more you surrender to him. This is what happens even in a normal love affair between a

man and a woman. The lover and the beloved surrender to each other's wishes and wills, as the love between them grows into fullness. His likes become hers and vice versa. Surrender is nothing but giving up one's individuality, giving up one's likes and dislikes for a higher goal. Even in ordinary love both the lover and the beloved give up their likes and dislikes, which constitute their individuality, for the sake of their love. In spirituality, the seeker renounces all that he has to the Supreme Principle, God. All that one can claim as one's own, all the attachments and aversions one has are the product of one's ego. They can also be referred to as *vasanas* or accumulated tendencies. All these things which we claim as our own do not, in fact, belong to us since we have no control over them. Reputation, fame, position, our homes, wives, husbands, children – none of these can stay with us permanently. We may have such things now, but who knows what is going to happen the next moment? But this is not the case with the accumulated tendencies, with the ego. The ego is our own. It belongs to us. Nobody else can claim it. Therefore, real self-surrender is surrendering or renouncing one's ego at the feet of the Supreme Self."

From that answer arose another question: "Amma, you said that love could not be learned from a university or by reading books. But we feel inspired when we read or hear about Divine Love, don't we?"

"That's true," came the Mother's reply. "But if you observe closely, you will see that people who feel so

inspired after reading or hearing about Divine Love, will quickly forget it and can easily feel the opposite if they become provoked. Are you able to dive deep into this feeling of Divine Love? Are you able to sustain that spirit of inspiration within your heart? If so, what you said is correct. But in most cases, this does not happen. People read and feel inspired, and then they forget. Mother is not trying to say that reading and hearing about Divine Love is insignificant. No. But this is what is meant: reading gives us an intellectual understanding of Love, but love is not of the intellect. Love is in the heart. Love is not associated with logic, but with faith. Love is religion; logic is science. Love joins and unites; logic cuts and divides. Love is oneness; logic is multiplicity. Love is deep; logic is superficial. Logic can be taught because it is concerned with the head, but love cannot be taught because it is the language of the heart. This language cannot be expressed through words. It is a spontaneous feeling. Something in the intellect can be expressed verbally, but feelings in the heart cannot be put into words. Ask a lover, 'How much do you love your beloved?' He will say, 'Oh, I love her so much!' or maybe he will say, 'I love her with all my heart and soul.' What feeling do you get from this statement? None."

Another question was asked: "Amma, then what is the way to develop love?"

Mother answered, "Son, in order to develop love one should be in a place where the circumstances are suitable for this goal. To live in the presence of a Per-

fect Master is the best way to develop love. The Guru helps you by creating the circumstances necessary to fill your heart with love. These circumstances are not only external, but internal as well. The Guru creates both. He works directly with the disciple's *vasanas*, which stand as the main obstacle in the path of love. Through created circumstances, he first attracts and binds the disciple with his person. Once the Guru is fully aware that the disciple is totally attached to him, the next step is elimination of the ego. For that to happen, the Guru again creates situations, working with both the gross and the subtle ego. Once the ego is removed, your inside becomes empty. All the old stuff has been removed, and you can now fill yourself with love. The removal of the old and the filling with the new happens simultaneously.

"The circumstances created by the Guru are so powerful, so precious and alluring, that the disciple will start cherishing and memorizing each moment that he spends with the Guru, and he will start loving the Guru with his body, mind and intellect. The disciple's love will flow both to the physical and the spiritual forms of the Guru. When he comes to know that his Guru is the very Consciousness that shines within and through all objects, the disciple starts to love everything.

"The Guru's words and deeds are beautiful. Through His beautiful words and deeds, He creates unforgettable moments and events in the disciple's life. The Guru's love intoxicates the disciple. His de-

sire to love and to be loved by the Guru becomes like a blazing flame. Slowly, in due course, the Guru removes the disciple's craving to be loved by Him, and he develops in its place the craving to be in loving service to Him. Again, in order to make the disciple understand and realize that the Guru is not the body but the all-pervading Self, He creates circumstances for the disciple to see Him in everything and to serve Him through every action. For this love to take place, the disciple must empty the mind of all its desires. That is why Perfect Masters always insist on the importance of *sadhana*."

In his excitement, one of the brahmacharins present called out, "This is exactly what Amma does to us!" Everyone enjoyed the spontaneity and innocence of the young man's remark. They all turned to him smiling. Amma's response to this was, "You know, these children here were really afflicted with *Amma bhrant* (craving for Mother) when they met Her. But Mother always wonders why these children are so mad about this 'crazy Kali.'" A devotee responded, "Amma, it is that 'craziness' which attracts and binds us."

As it was nearly 10:30 p.m., Mother got up from Her seat. All who were present offered their prostrations to the Mother. After having expressed Her love

*Pronounced 'Kunyumol'—meaning "little daughter."

and affection to the sadhaks and the other visitors,
She proceeded alone towards the neem tree.

From the direction of the tree, one could hear
Mother singing a song...*Ennude Jivita...*

*O Mother, my boat is sinking
Here in the ocean of this world.
The hurricane of delusion
Fiercely rages on every side.*

*Clumsy is my helmsman, the mind...
Stubborn my six oarsmen, the passions.
Into a merciless wind
I sailed my boat,
And now it is sinking;
Split is the rudder of devotion.*

*Tattered is the sail of faith,
Into my boat the waters are pouring.*

*Tell me, what shall I do?
Alas! With failing eyes,
Nothing but darkness do I see.
Here in the waves I will swim,
O Mother, clinging to the raft of Thy Name.*

It sounded as if Mother were walking around as
She sang. The night was cool and Her melodious
haunting voice filled the air. Various people staying at
the center came out of their rooms to see who was
singing. They remained on the verandahs of their
rooms listening to the Mother's inspiring song. When

the song was over, there came a pause, but the spiritual vibration created by the song was so powerful that no one really noticed that the singing had stopped, so enraptured they were with a feeling of enchantment.

Then the Mother really soared to the heights of spiritual bliss. From where they stood on the verandah, the devotees and the brahmacharins could hear Mother laughing. It was as if She were so far beyond human feelings that the only sounds which She could make were these gentle laughs. Due to Her overflowing and uncontrollable bliss, the song automatically stopped when it was only half over.

Mother was alone under the neem tree, except for Gayatri and Kunjumol,* two of Her oldest and closest girl disciples who looked after all of Mother's personal needs, especially at times like this when She forgot Her body completely. Like one intoxicated, Mother roamed about with faltering steps. Gayatri and Kunjumol followed Her closely to protect Her from falling down or stumbling over something.

Half an hour had passed this way. Now, with Gayatri and Kunjumol holding Her hands and guiding Her, Mother was taken to Her room. Soon the brahmacharins and all the devotees retired to their rooms as well. Thus the last day of the visit to Kanyakumari came to an end. The next day the group journeyed back to the Ashram, singing *bhajans* as they rode in the van and reached there by two in the afternoon.

CHAPTER 3

WORK IN PRAISE OF GOD

25 April 1984

On this day, beginning at nine o'clock in the morning, all the Ashram residents and some visiting devotees were engrossed in cleaning the Ashram premises. It goes without saying that Mother was also present. Like everyone else, She carried sand and bricks, swept, collected trash and cleaned clogged drains. Whatever work Her children did, Mother did as well. Her presence gave vigor and enthusiasm to all those who participated.

When some people started gossiping at one point, Mother cautioned them in this manner, "No talking. This is not mere physical labor; this is spiritual work, work entrusted to you by God. Although you do not earn any monetary wages for it, payment is made by Him in the form of His Grace. In order to avail oneself of this, one should remember Him while doing the work. That 'Old Man' is a miser. He won't give anything to those who are lazy. He is very selfish, and will not think of those who do not think of Him. You must please Him, praise Him and adore Him. He likes being praised very much; He will not wake up unless you praise Him. But the praise that He likes is not ordinary praise. It is not the same as when you compliment someone or someone compliments you. When you praise someone, you do so because you want to be liked by him, thus your ego is involved. And when

someone praises you, your ego gets puffed up.

“When your ego is there, you go away from God; the distance between you and Him becomes greater and greater. But through singing His glories, you become closer to Him, closer to your own Self. By praising God, you become innocent and pure, because when you glorify Him, you are not glorifying another person; you are actually glorifying your own Real Self. There is no ‘person’ to be glorified. He neither accepts nor rejects your praises because there is nobody there to accept or reject them. The Absolute Self alone is in that Nameless and Formless state. The form and the praises are meant for your own benefit, thus when you chant or sing the glories of God, you are glorifying the Self or the Atman which is not different from your own Real Nature.

“To forget ‘doer-ship’ and to go beyond the attitude of ‘I do the work and I want the fruit of it’ one should lift one’s mind to that Supreme Principle. Do not talk while working. Talking will neither help us think of God, nor will we be able to do our work properly. Talking is an unnecessary waste of time and energy. Replace talking with the singing of the Divine Name. In this way you will be able to stop the inner babbling. Glorifying or praising the Lord is, in fact, the process of awakening your own inner Self.

“Once again, when you praise someone or when another person praises you, your ego or his ego gets inflated. But when you praise Him, your ego gets deflated until finally there is no ego at all. As God is be-

yond everything, nothing happens to Him. He remains as He is.”

As if lost in a dream, everyone stopped working and moved towards Amma as She spoke these words. She, however, continued to sweep the ground. While the devotees had all forgotten their work, Mother remained so intent on Her sweeping that She did not even notice the assembled crowd. Suddenly She looked up and, seeing everyone standing around, Mother exclaimed, “Hey, what are you doing here? Go and do your work, you lazy bums!” One devotee said, “Amma, your nectarous words made us inactive.”

Without paying much attention to this comment, Mother said, “Come on, children, let us sing together while we work,” and She began to lead a chant...*Thirukathukal Padam Nan...*

*Let me sing the glories of Thy holy acts.
Please grant me a boon:
When I sing of Thy glories,
Please come into my heart.*

*Remove ill fate, Goddess Durga. O Kali,
Every day I beg to have a vision of Thy form.*

*I know not the method of meditation,
Neither is there melody in my music.
Have mercy on me
Let me immerse myself in bliss,
O Essence of the Vedas.*

And then another... *Chitta Vrindavanam*...

*The melodious sound of the flute
Is rising from the Brindavan of my mind,
O Lord in the temple of my mind
Who abides in the form of awareness,
O Sweet Lover of flute music,
Lord of the world, Son of Yadu...
Peacocks of the pure mind
Are eternally dancing in the service
Of that Being.*

*Upon hearing that beautiful music of the flute,
I enter into an ecstatic mood in deep meditation
On that One who is fond of the flute.*

Each one's cup was filled to the brim with joy. Forgetting all about the world outside, and even forgetting themselves, the devotees worked and sang the glories of God. It was obvious that their minds were fully concentrated on the Mother, as She led them in song. This was an example of real *Karma Yoga*. Everyone worked without expecting anything, all the while fixing their minds on the Divine.

When the singing had finished, Mother called out "*Hari Bol!!*" (roughly equivalent to 'Praise the Lord!'). The next moment, dropping Her broom, She began to run off calling out, "Children, you continue to work! Mother will be back soon." But as soon as She had left, the devotees felt depleted of all their vitality and

stood perfectly still. As if She knew that they had abandoned their work, the Mother turned around after She had gone just a few yards, saying, "Don't worry. Mother will come back in a few minutes. But we should try to finish this work before lunch. Yes, yes, now go ahead."

With this assurance from Mother that She would soon return, all felt happy and resumed their work with the same enthusiasm as before. Sure enough, in half an hour Mother came back carrying in one hand a bucket full of sweetened coffee and in the other, a packet of banana chips.

She set these down near the people working, and having asked someone to bring glasses, She called all Her children to come and began serving all the residents and devotees. In order to make sure that everybody had his share, Mother called out each person's name, asking, "Son," or "Daughter, did you get any?" One devotee asked, "Amma, are you not having any?" She answered, "Mother is full when She sees Her children eating and drinking."

There was a little more work left to do. One small heap of sand still had to be carried to fill in a spot where the land was low. Mother got up. Without calling anyone, She walked towards the sand pile, taking with Her a shovel and a basin. Upon seeing this, the devotees and the brahmacharins immediately jumped up and hurried to the sand pile, saying, "Amma, no, no. We will do it." But Mother paid no attention. Ignoring them, She began shoveling the sand into the

basin. Then, carrying this on Her head, She walked towards the landfill. The devotees followed suit, and within a few minutes the work was completed. Mother then went to Her room, and the devotees were free to bathe and get cleaned up.

The Mother came down from Her room again at three o'clock in the afternoon, and sat in front of the meditation hall. Devotees and resident brahmacharins gathered around, but since there was not enough room for everyone to sit, She moved over to the *darshan* hut. Seeing that some of the brahmacharins had taken the seats closest to Her, She advised, "Let the householder children sit here. You move to the rear. You live here and always have the opportunity to see Mother. But these children get a chance only once in a while." The brahmacharins immediately obeyed, making room for the householder devotees to sit closer to the Mother.

The Holy Mother began by receiving the devotees who had come to see Her that day. She asked the brahmacharins to sing while one by one She gave *darshan* to the devotees. They sang with the accompaniment of harmonium and tabla.

Upon hearing the song, the Mother went into *samadhi*, and the devotee who was about to approach Her for *darshan* was asked by a brahmacharin to move aside. The Mother was clearly transported to another realm. Her right hand, forming a divine mudra, was in a half-raised position, while the other hand was placed

on Her chest. Her face glowed as She sat completely still, statue-like, remote yet mysteriously near.

Brahmacharin Pai chanted some *slokas* (verses) from the *Devi Mahatmyam*, a Sanskrit work in praise of the Divine Mother.

*To that Ambika
Who is worthy of worship by all devas and sages,
Who pervades this world by Her power,
Who is the embodiment of all the powers
Of all the hosts of devas, we bow in devotion.
May She grant us auspicious things.*

*O Devi, we bow before You,
You Who are good fortune
In the dwellings of the virtuous,
And ill-fortune in those of the vicious.
You are intelligence in the hearts of the learned,
Faith in the hearts of the good
And modesty in the hearts of the high-born.
May You protect the universe.*

Immersed in devotion and flooded with the Mother's spiritual power, the devotees tingled with anticipation, and all eyes were fixed on the Mother's radiant face. After about fifteen minutes the Mother regained consciousness and opened Her eyes, as She chanted "Shiva...Shiva...", and waved Her right hand in circles, a gesture familiar to the devotees yet inexplicable.

A FAMILY IN DISTRESS

Darshan resumed, and the Mother continued to receive and bless each person individually. Soon a group of people entered the hut. As they came in, it was quite obvious that they were a family. Without acknowledging the next person in the *darshan* line, the Mother called for this family to come forward right away. They all looked very sad. One of the two girls in this family wept uncontrollably as she moved towards Mother. "My child...daughter, do not cry," Mother said to the girl. "Do not grieve about what happened. Be consoled. After all, the flames did not consume the whole house. A great danger that could have occurred has been overcome by a smaller one. Moreover, you did not do it intentionally."

Hearing the Mother's words, the family members looked at each other in wonderment. It was quite clear that the Mother was referring to the tragic event which had happened to them even before they disclosed it to Her. With the crying girl on Her lap, Mother tried to console the family, saying, "Children, what has happened, has happened. It is past. The past is past and gone. Never is it going to come back. Even if you worry, all that has been lost is not going to return. Have confidence, courage and mental balance. If those are lost, then everything is lost. But if you maintain control of yourselves, Mother would say that nothing has been lost at all." As She spoke, the Mother rubbed the back of the man who appeared to

be the father as he knelt before Her with his head on Her lap.

Watching the Mother with these devotees, one felt that She was even more despondent over their troubles than the family members themselves. By expressing Her sympathy and motherly concern for their sorrow, She clearly helped them overcome their mental distress, and slowly they all calmed down. The father pleaded, "You are all-powerful and all-knowing. Amma, please save us from this deep sorrow." The whole family then sat around the Mother and had a long discussion with Her. Then, the Mother once again comforted and caressed each of them. While giving *prasad* to them, She assured them that everything would be all right. "Don't worry. The marriage will definitely take place." By the time they left, they were not only relieved and relaxed, but they actually seemed happy.

After they had gone, Amma turned to the next person who was waiting for Her *darshan*. She smiled at him and said this to him: "Son, don't think ill of God or of anyone. You musn't get angry without discerning and understanding the reason and real purpose behind an action. Anger will close your heart and this is where God is supposed to dwell. By getting angry, you are slamming the door of your heart right in His face. Son, don't do that. Those children are confronting a very difficult time. That is why Mother called them before calling you."

The Mother then related the cause of the family's deep sorrow. A few days before, the parents of the two girls were out during the day dealing with matters concerning their elder daughter's marriage. Both of the daughters were home, and the younger one wanted to take something out of the wooden chest that was kept in the parents' room. The room was rather dark and since there was no electricity, she carried a kerosene lamp. The girl opened the chest with the lamp still in her hands. While she was searching for what she wanted, the lamp tipped over and fell into the chest, the kerosene spilling all over the contents. Unfortunately, the chest was also where the parents kept their clothing and all their valuables. The kerosene-soaked clothing easily caught fire. The girl was shocked. She screamed and ran out of the room. She and her elder sister, the bride-to-be, screamed loudly. Hearing their shouting and screaming, the neighbors came running. They extinguished the fire, but not before the chest was completely burnt. The fire consumed part of the room, but luckily it had not spread to any other part of the house.

The parents were heart-broken because all of the money which they had saved for their daughter's marriage was put in that wooden chest. Since the marriage was scheduled for that month, they had withdrawn from the bank, just the day before, the amount required for her dowry and other expenses. Now they lost all of that money. To make matters worse, the bridegroom's parents, upon hearing about the fire,

now opposed the marriage because they considered the fire to be an inauspicious omen. Thus, the whole family was in deep mourning.

The whole time the Mother narrated the story about the family, the young man whom the Mother had reprimanded sat with his head hanging down. He did not utter a single word. At last, he raised his head and spoke in an apologetic tone, "I am sorry, Amma. Please forgive me. I am not only ignorant, but a fool as well, to think that Mother would give special attention to someone without a particular reason. I also thought that I could hide my thoughts from you. But you caught me. Forgive me, Mother, forgive me." Praying thus, he lamented, for when the Mother had called the family instead of calling him, even though he was the next person in the *darshan* line, he had felt very angry towards the Mother. He had felt that the Mother was being unfair, being partial towards the family. He thought, "It is my turn to have *darshan*. How can Amma call on them, ignoring me. I have been waiting in the line for a long time and they just came. She is not impartial."

It was later revealed that the Mother's words had come true regarding this family. Even though the bridegroom's parents were against the marriage due to the fire, which they considered a bad omen, the young man loved his betrothed so much that he insisted on

marrying her, in spite of the fire. He did not believe it to be an inauspicious sign. So much did he believe in this marriage that he even threatened to remain a bachelor forever if the parents did not give their consent. So adamant was he about this that the parents finally relented.

Nevertheless, though this one problem was solved, the bride's family still had the problem of the money. The whole family kept praying to the Mother. Almost seventy-five percent of the amount lost was meant for the dowry, which the bridegroom's parents had demanded, for such was the custom. Days passed. Nothing turned up. The girl's parents were very worried. They only had enough money to make the preliminary arrangements.

Three days before the marriage, a friend of the bridegroom's family brought a letter signed by the bridegroom and his parents. The letter stated that their son was absolutely against the custom of dowry. In fact, he had known nothing about it because it had been a secret arrangement made by his parents. Upon discovering it, he felt outraged that he had not been consulted in the matter. His parents, realizing how strong-willed their son was concerning this marriage, not only gave up the idea of the dowry but even offered to give whatever was necessary, in cash or kind, to make the marriage take place happily and smoothly on the scheduled date. All these miraculous changes occurred after the girl's family had gone to see the Mother. Meanwhile, after Mother had warned how an-

ger can close one's heart to God, the *darshan* continued as the brahmacharins sang.

The Mother's *darshan* concluded around five o'clock. She emerged from the hut and sat on the front verandah of the meditation hall. Since the meditation time for the brahmacharins was from 4:30 - 6:00 in the evening, Mother looked inside the hall and upon finding only a few brahmacharins there, She asked, "Where are the others?"

One latecomer was standing just outside the door, hoping to get in without Mother noticing him. As he tried to sneak inside, Mother suddenly got up from where She was sitting and walked towards the door. Giving him a serious look, She said, "Don't you know that 4:30 is the time for meditation?" He tried to answer, "Yes, Mother, but..." The Mother interrupted, "No buts...If 4:30 is the time for meditation, you must be here for it, unless you are engaged in some other important work. Where were you? What were you doing?" Hesitatingly, the brahmacharin answered, "I was reading but fell asleep." The Mother's response to this came quickly, "Hey, what are you saying? Being a brahmacharin, aren't you ashamed to say that you fell asleep while reading a book? That shows lack of awareness. You are not alert. If you can't read without sleeping, how can you hope to meditate? Meditation requires a lot of alertness! If you are alert, you can be wide awake, even if you have not slept for days on end."

Overwhelmed by the seriousness of Mother's expression and tone, the brahmacharin was a bit frightened. But seeing this, Amma burst into laughter and called him to Her. She gently patted his back, but remained firm in what She said to him, "Are you afraid of your Mother? It was only a joke. Don't think that Mother is angry with you, son. Nonetheless, you should try to follow the schedule of meditation, *japa*, and yoga practices. This is very important. Discipline is needed for a *sadhak*. If we do not consider discipline as being important, then we won't take spiritual life seriously."

Mother sat with the brahmacharins and meditated for some time. She often does that to inspire them and to observe them as well. On such occasions Mother always keeps a few pebbles on hand. Whenever She sees a brahmacharin dozing or losing his concentration, She throws one of these pebbles at him and says something to help him regain his one-pointedness.

The Holy Mother returned to Her room at around 5:30 p.m. and came down again for the regular evening *bhajan* at 6:30. Her ecstatic singing filled the atmosphere... *Ambike Devi Jagan Nayike Namaskaram...*

O Mother, Goddess of the Universe,
I bow before Thee.
O Giver of happiness, I bow before Thee.

*O Thou whose form is Peace, Who is omnipresent
Thou art the Great Deluder,
Without beginning or end.
O Thou whose form is of the Self, I bow before
Thee.*

*Intelligence, knowledge and speech,
All are Thee only.
O Devi, it is Thou who ledest the mind.*

She sang song after song, gradually building up to a crescendo of intense devotion. All hearts opened effortlessly and experienced a great wave of Divine Grace. Nobody could resist being affected, such was the power created by the Mother's singing. She Herself allowed it to carry Her to its peak. Like a boat that has lost all control and is being tossed wildly by the waves, the Mother allowed the ecstasy of singing the Divine Name to carry Her wherever it would. The outpouring of devotion surpassed all limits when She sang... *Devi Saranam Saranam Amme...*

*Give me refuge, O Goddess,
Give me refuge, O Mother.
O Thou Whose Divine Form
Is praised by the celestials,
Salutations to Thee, the Primal Supreme Energy!*

*Salutations to Mother Who is the Cause
Of all auspiciousness, Fulfiller of all desires,
Perfection Itself and the Source of Nature Herself.*

*Thou art the Cause of Creation, Sustenance
And Destruction.
Thou art the Destroyer of the wicked.
I bow to Thy Feet Which art of the form
Of Pure Existence and Awareness.*

At a certain point, the Mother stopped singing and got up from Her seat and started dancing blissfully, with both Her hands raised half-way, and Her fingers held in a divine *mudra*. A beautiful smile lit up Her face, and every now and then She uttered a mysterious laugh.

Everybody continued to sing, drinking in the nectar of pure devotion. They were fascinated by the Mother's graceful movements as She glided around the floor in Her dance of divine rapture. Slowly the dancing ceased, but She remained swaying back and forth to the music until She finally sat and then lay on the cement floor. The singing also stopped and absolute silence prevailed. It was a beautiful, profound silence, and those present slipped easily into meditation and experienced very powerful concentration.

Over an hour passed before Mother regained ordinary consciousness. Keeping Her hands on Gayatri's shoulders, She walked to Her room leaving everyone in an elevated mood. No one wanted to disturb the feeling of Divine Love and concentration they were experiencing, not even after Mother had left. Most of the residents and visiting devotees remained meditat-

ing in the temple and on the temple verandah. Some of the brahmacharins went to the meditation hall. Not until 11:45 p.m. did anyone bother to eat dinner.

Each moment with the Holy Mother is a moment to learn love, to imbibe it, and to live in it. Singing with the Mother provides a rare opportunity to feel and experience the Divine within ourselves, the pure and innocent love in us.

CHAPTER 4

26 April 1984

The Mother began receiving devotees in the *darshan* hut this morning around eleven o'clock. Since it was a *Devi Bhava* day, there was a large number of people in the hut. One woman devotee was singing a lovely *bhajan* about Krishna's beauty. The first half of the traditional song described His childhood antics, the way He stole butter and milk from the homes of the *Gopis* or milk-maids and shared it with His friends. The song continued, telling about how Yashoda, His Mother, once tied Him to a huge mortar stone, hoping to keep Him out of mischief, and how He dragged it around, continuing to make trouble. The Mother, while She continued to give *darshan* to each person, was laughing and enjoying the song, making comments here and there. At one point She said, "Little Thief! How skillfully He won every person's heart. Mischievous fellow! He was a good thief, a thief who stole everything from everyone but for a higher purpose."

The woman sang with utmost devotion. Having described Krishna's childhood games, she went on about His physical beauty. The last half of the song was about Radha's love, about Her aching heart and finally, the excruciating pain She experienced when Krishna left Brindavan.

Even though a devotee was lying on Her lap, the Mother became perfectly still as She appeared to become engrossed in the song. All of a sudden She started crying out, "Krishna! Krishna!" This went on and on. Her head was tilted back and Her half-closed eyes turned upwards. As instructed by a brahmacharin, the devotee slowly moved from Her lap to one side. At last the call ceased, but the Mother entered into a deep state of *samadhi*. Her right hand showed the divine *mudra* which She used to show during Krishna Bhava, and the crying had culminated in a blissful smile that made Her look very much as She had during the Krishna Bhava. Her eyes were half-closed, and there was an indescribable glow on Her face. The devotees present felt thrilled and almost all of them either glided into deep meditation or shed tears of love and bliss. They all could feel that She was totally identified with Krishna. Everyone present felt that this was truly a feast for the eyes to behold. The woman whose singing was instrumental in prompting this to happen sang another song in praise of Krishna. After that, the brahmacharins took over, chanting some slokas from the *Narayaneeyam*, a work in praise of Krishna...

*I adore the Form of the Lord
Whose head is crowned with a diadem
That rivals the sun in its brilliance;
The beauty of the forehead enhanced
By the vertical mark of sandalwood paste,
With eyes brimming with mercy
And face lit up by a benevolent smile,
With nose attractive, well-proportioned,
With ears adorned with fish-marked pendants
Adding lustre to the cheeks by their reflection;*

*Wearing on the neck the luminous jewel, Kastubha,
The chest resplendent with a variety of decorations—
Floral wreaths, strands of pearls
And the auspicious mark called ‘Srivatsa.’*

*This Form of Thine
Consisting of Pure Bliss Consciousness,
The sweet nectar of fascinating beauty
Is showered everywhere, captivating the minds of all
Who devotedly hear the recitation of Thy deeds
And excellences, inebriating them with bliss,
Exciting a thrill all through their limbs,
And bathing their bodies with cool streams of tears
Welling up from the ecstasy of joy.*

*Ascending and descending notes in Indian classical music.

**In India it is a common practice for the spiritually inclined to salute the threshold when entering a temple or room where a *Mahatma* is present. This salutation is a gesture of touching first the floor with one's right hand and then bringing it to one's forehead or heart.

The Holy Mother's divine mood lasted for about twenty minutes. It seemed that She had not yet come down fully to this plane, so it was with great difficulty that She continued to receive people. She asked for a glass of water. Perhaps this was a means of coming down to the world of forms, thoughts and actions. By concerning Herself with objects, She can keep Her mind down on the empirical plane. Water was offered to Her by Gayatri. She took a few sips and again closed Her eyes for a few more moments. Then She whirled Her right index finger in the air a few times, a gesture She often makes but has never explained since it does not belong to the realm of explanations. Again *darshan* resumed. After a short while, She again began to look like Her normal self.

DO NOT LAUGH AT OTHERS

27 April 1984

The brahmacharins were having lunch. Two of them talked and laughed together as they ate. Suddenly the Mother's voice was heard: "Hey, fellows! Are you talking and laughing while you eat? What a shame! How can you do such a thing? You are living in an Ashram, striving to realize God. Aren't you seekers? Yet you are talking about someone, laughing at his weaknesses and making fun of his drawbacks, aren't you?"

The laughing brahmacharins were taken aback. As the Mother approached them, they stood up from their seats, with their heads hanging down. She con-

tinued to reprimand them, “Don’t hang your heads down. That shows that you have committed a mistake. Innocent people never look down. They always look straight ahead. They are not afraid. Those who have not committed any errors are not afraid of anyone. But you hang your heads down. That shows you have done something wrong, and that now you are afraid of punishment. Mother does not want to punish you; She simply wants to correct you. So, look over here and tell the truth. Whom were you mocking?”

The two brahmacharins looked at the Mother’s face and mentioned the name of another brahmacharin. One of them said in a soft voice, “We were making fun of the way he chanted the *Lalita Sahasranama* off-key.”

Now Mother burst into laughter. She turned to the other brahmacharins, saying, “Did you hear that? They were making fun of (She says that brahmacharin’s name) and the way he chants the *Sahasranama*.” Then She said in admonishment, “What children you are! Don’t you feel ashamed? This is the biggest sin—to mock others. Are you yourselves perfect? When you tease someone, remember this truth that somebody else is teasing you, laughing at your faults and flaws also. If you remember this, you will not mock anyone again.

“Children, you all know that the first mantra of the *Lalita Sahasranama* is “Sri Matre Namah,” Salutations to the Great Mother. She is Mother, Mother of all. What are the greatest qualities of a Mother? Love,

forgiveness and patience. Our Mother (the Divine Mother) is endowed with all the three qualities in their purest form. Therefore, even if you commit any errors, She will forgive you. No mother will instruct her children to call her 'mother' only after they have studied the *Saptaswaras*.^{*} A musical voice is not needed to call one's mother." Mother stopped for a minute and then said, "Children, now sit down and eat." Before She left the dining area, She instructed all the brahmacharins to come to Her room after lunch.

Upon finishing their meal, the brahmacharins climbed the steps to the Mother's room. The door was open as Mother was waiting for Her children. As a sign of devotion and reverence, each of the brahmacharins touched and saluted the floor of Mother's room as he stepped across the threshold.^{**} Each one also prostrated to the Mother before he sat down. Mother waited until everyone had arrived. When all were present, including the brahmacharinis, Gayatri and Kunjumol, She had everybody chant 'OM' three times. Then, Mother asked them to meditate on the form of their beloved deity for a while. Mother also sat in meditation. Then She joined Her hands in prayer and remained in that posture for a few moments. There was pin-drop silence. Mother looked at Her children and smiled, Her face full of compassion and love for them. The serious face and stern tone of voice She adopts sometimes is only external. It is one of the masks She uses to discipline

Her children. Within, the Mother is always loving and compassionate.

Amma proceeded to speak, “My children, you are Mother’s wealth and health. Mother does not want anything from you except your spiritual growth. When She finds that you are not growing internally as She expects you to, Mother feels very sad. Life is a play for those who have attained the state of perfection, for them it is not so serious any more. But for you that is not true. You should take things seriously; this is a discipline for you now. Seeing and taking things too lightly is not good for a *sadhak*.

“Children, a *sadhak* is one who is striving hard to reach the goal. How can one take things lightly while striving hard to attain eternal freedom? Only after liberation will there be spontaneity in one’s responses. At present, nothing comes spontaneously to you except your old *vasanas*. You are trying to eliminate them and replace them with the higher values of life. Therefore, everything is a test, a hard test for you. Take these tests seriously. When Mother says ‘seriously,’ don’t misunderstand and think that She is asking you to put a serious look on your face. No. The attitude you have should be serious; this seriousness should be something internal. Sharp discrimination is what is needed.

“Take the example of someone getting angry at you for no reason. For a normal person it is difficult to remain calm and undisturbed in such a situation. But you should use your discrimination in order to keep

your mind well under control. For this to happen, introspection is needed. To accept the anger as a blessing sent by the Lord in order to test your patience, or to ignore it and remain unaffected, one needs sharp discrimination. In both cases a *sadhak* must make a conscious and continuous effort in order to proceed towards the ultimate goal. This is not a light matter. Do not consider it as child's play. This is the way of life that you have chosen. Your life is dedicated entirely to this purpose. When you have attained the goal, you will be able to perceive the whole world and all the happenings around you as child's play. Then you can be spontaneous. At that time all fears automatically drop away. Then you can play and laugh and be happy like a child. But until then you must take life as a serious affair.

“Obstacles and difficulties are challenges to confront and to conquer. A challenge cannot be taken as a light matter unless you are an adept. You are not an adept; therefore, take it seriously.

“To fight in the battlefield is a game for a master in the art. But for the ordinary soldier who is not experienced in the art of war, it is a struggle between life and death. The Mahabharata battle was child's play for Krishna and Arjuna because both of them were masters in using all kinds of weapons. They had all the divine weapons under their control. But for the ordinary soldiers it was a real challenge. For them the battle was something which had to be taken seriously. If they took it lightly, their lives would have ended

with their heads rolling on the ground.

“In the same way, children, for a person who is established in God, all that happens around him is a play. The whole world is a play. All abuses, criticisms, insults, hatred and anger showered on him return unaccepted to those from whom they came. Whatever is not accepted is returned to the giver. Or another way of putting it is that a Realized Soul accepts everything. He accepts things, but they cannot remain with him. He is like a doorway; things just pass through him. Nothing can remain with him. Or you can say that he is like fire. What is thrown in the fire gets consumed by the flames and disappears. One who is established in the Supreme is always spontaneous. For him acceptance comes readily, but for you, it is not spontaneous. It is a real struggle, and a struggle cannot be taken lightly. What you are really dealing with is fighting your own negative nature. Fighting is a challenge which should be considered seriously.

“Children, eventually this struggle will become totally ‘struggle-less.’ This fighting will be completely ‘non-fighting.’ When this happens, then your actions and your acceptance of things will be spontaneous.”

Mother stopped for a while and looked at Her children. They were all listening to Her words very attentively, marveling at Her wisdom and knowledge. Before coming to the Mother and adopting the life of renunciates, most of these young men had excelled in their various fields of study and work. And now, they

were sitting in front of this ordinary-looking village girl who was almost the same age as they, listening to Her words like obedient little children. To an outside onlooker, the Mother looked like any other girl in this provincial fishing village, but in the hearts of these spiritual aspirants, they knew they were sitting before Wisdom Incarnate.

Amma resumed talking: “This afternoon Mother saw two of Her children making fun of and laughing at someone else’s weakness. Children, before judging another person, try to observe your own mind, your own thoughts and your own actions. Try to see your own faults and weaknesses. Become aware of them. If you can do this sincerely, you will not find fault with others because you will realize that your own mind is more of a mess than theirs. Then you will not laugh at others.

“To laugh at somebody else’s shortcomings is one of the lowest things you can do. If you must laugh, laugh at your own weaknesses; laugh at your own stupidities. This is far better than laughing at someone else. By being able to laugh at your own faults, at least you become aware of your own lower or false nature. If you can laugh at your own lower nature, this means you are evolving, and this is consoling. You will be fit for immortality, or at least, you are getting closer to it. When you laugh at yourself, this means that you are slowly becoming aware of your own ignorance. This is a good sign. Once you realize that you are ignorant,

then it is easy for the Guru to work on you. Many disciples or devotees simply say they are ignorant, but they really do not mean it. Deep down in their minds they think that they know many things. Actually they do not recognize their own ignorance. A person who laughs at his own weaknesses and faults realizes and recognizes his own ignorance. He can easily evolve and rise to the Supreme State of Blissful Laughter. He can soon laugh, watching the whole universe as a play of God. Therefore, children, do not tease or make fun of others. It is very painful for Mother to see Her children behaving so cheaply."

Again there was a long pause. Amma asked the brahmacharins, "Children, is Mother's long speech boring you? If so, Mother will stop." No one replied. There was absolute silence. She resumed, "Silence means 'yes,' doesn't it?"

Immediately one of the brahmacharins who had created the problem at lunch said, "No, Mother, no. Your beautiful *satsang* has made us dumb of speech. Now we realize our stupidity and feel like laughing at our foolishness. Amma, please enlighten us by giving us more and more satsangs like this. Let our talking, both inner and outer, be stopped by contemplation of your words." As he sought forgiveness for his mistake, tears welled up in this brahmacharin's eyes.

Amma consoled him, saying, "Son, don't worry. God forgave you as soon as you realized your mistake and repented."

Then She continued, “Children, you might have read this story from the life of Krishna. It happened in Brindavan. The mischievous Son of Nanda, together with His playmates, the Gopas, one day sneaked into the house of the two teachers who had taught them the alphabet. Both teachers were rather odd characters. They were fast asleep when Krishna and His friends started their mischief. As they had planned and using the paints they brought with them, Krishna and His friends painted the faces of the teachers to look like clowns. Finishing their work, Krishna and His friends left and went outside where they waited, hoping to have some fun when the teachers woke up. Soon the fun began. As one awoke, he looked at the face of the other, who was still asleep, and started laughing at him, wanting his companion to see how funny he looked with his face covered in dots and lines of various colors, so he vigorously shook his sleeping friend. The friend woke up, rubbed his eyes and started laughing, pointing at the first one’s face. Both of them continued to laugh at each other until, at last, they looked in a mirror. Then they stopped laughing. At that point, they were in a hurry to wash their faces.

“Children, this is how we are. Though this story seems to be just a funny and insignificant incident among Krishna’s many pranks, there is deep meaning in it. It depicts the human tendency to laugh at other people’s weaknesses. When you laugh at someone, remember that someone else is laughing at your weak-

nesses. No one is perfect. Look in your inner mirror, and you will see the black marks in you. Once you see them and become aware of them, you will stop laughing. Then you will be in a hurry to remove them. Until then, making fun of others will continue to close your heart. Children, do not laugh at others and remain closed in your own heart. It is self-destructive. You are here to throw away the old habits which are so deep and dense within you. Don't fall victim to them. To make fun of others, to laugh at others' weaknesses is the nature of students in regular schools and colleges, but not that of a spiritual seeker. But because it is so strong a tendency, it is easy for you to fall prey to such behavior. It will defeat the very purpose for which you are here. You are here to remove the old *vasanas* and to keep from creating any more."

Suddenly the Mother's facial expression changed. With a pitying look on Her face, She said in an urgent, pleading tone, "Stop adding to them, children; stop adding to them."

Mother again stopped for a while. She closed Her eyes and a few tears rolled down Her face. Seeing the Mother crying, everyone's heart was filled with sadness, and their eyes also swelled with tears.

Then She revealed more: "Children, Mother was not sad when all the villagers were against Her. Nor did She feel dejected when Her parents and other family members turned totally antagonistic towards Her. Mother did not feel sad at all when the skeptics and

nonbelievers scandalized Her. But now Her own children make Mother sad. Deep down in Mother's heart She is completely detached; there is no attachment to anything. But on the surface She has created an attachment for your own good."

For a few more minutes, the Mother sat in a meditative mood. Everyone followed Her example. When She opened Her eyes, Mother spoke again, "Let us sing a *bhajan* together before we conclude. Children, pray to the Supreme to bless you with love in your hearts. Love alone will purify. Pray for that. Pray to remove all those things which stand as obstacles to the flow of Love."

The Mother sang...*Ente Kannunir...* and the brahmacharins sang the response.

*Although You see my tears, O Mother,
How is it that You feel no compassion,
...You feel no compassion?*

*Although many days have passed since I came
To seek refuge at Thy Feet, why aren't You pleased,
...why aren't You pleased?*

*O Mother, why are You remiss in granting
Peace of mind to Your devoted servant,
...why are You remiss?*

*Your Feet are the sole Refuge of this poor soul,
Thus grant me refuge, bless me, O Mother*

...grant me refuge and bless me.

Mother's heart overflowed with Divine Love, and this was reflected in Her children. Everyone sat absorbed in meditation when the singing was over. After spending a little more time with the brahmacharins, Mother got up and went out on the terrace. As usual, Gayatri was about to follow Her, but She said, "No, Mother wants to be alone for a while." She remained there on the terrace as the brahmacharins, one by one, prostrated in front of Her bed and left the room. The time was three o'clock, and all proceeded to their afternoon chores, still contemplating the Mother's words.

CHAPTER 5

28 April 1984

Eight o'clock in the morning was meditation time for the brahmacharins all seated in the meditation hall. Some of them had already begun and some were just getting settled to begin, when suddenly, from Mother's room upstairs came the melodious sound of the tamboura, a stringed instrument. Knowing it was Mother who played the instrument, no one could think of meditating anymore. Opening their eyes, they all sat very much alert, as they keenly listened to the sound of the tamboura.

Some of the brahmacharins who were not satisfied just to listen went outside, hoping to catch a glimpse

of Mother through the openings in Her balcony wall. Unable to see Her, they were disappointed and sat facing Her room. In a few minutes, to the accompanying sound of the tamboura, Mother's voice was heard as She sang to Krishna...*Ini Oru Janmam...*

*O Krishna, give me not another birth
Lest I fall into the deep quagmire of delusion.
If You give, then bestow on me the boon
Of taking birth as the servant
Of Your servants forever.
O Krishna, You fill my mind
With Your Holy Name,
Reveal Your Lotus Feet, bright and clear therein.
Keep my mind ever balanced
And all will be felt to be Your manifestation.*

*O Krishna, Treasure of Compassion,
I salute Thee with joined palms,
I humbly salute Thee...*

Hearing the Mother singing, some of the householder devotees also gathered on the side of the building under the balcony. They stood or sat there, motionless, like statues carved out of stone. The blissful singing of the Mother created an atmosphere in which one could glide easily into an introspective state. The Mother continued with another song full of pathos ...*Karunya Varidhe Krishna...*

*O Krishna, Ocean of Compassion,
The thirst for life is ever increasing,*

*There is no peace for the mind.
Alas! Confusion is too much.*

*Forgiving all wrongs,
Wipe the sweat from my brow.
O Kanna, now I have no support
Other than Thy worshipful Lotus Feet.*

*O Krishna, my throat is drying up,
My eyes are failing, my feet are tired,
I am falling to the ground,
O Krishna.*

The song stopped abruptly as did the sound of the tamboura. It seemed that the Mother had entered a rapturous mood. At this point more than ever, everybody wanted to run upstairs and be with the Mother, but they could see that the door to Her room was closed. Even so, some of the brahmacharins made an attempt to get in, but failed and returned downstairs, where all continued to look up toward the Mother's room, mentally visualizing Her God-intoxicated mood. Thus the morning's meditation period was spent in actually hearing the singing of the Beloved Deity and in making attempts to actually see Her physical form with eyes open rather than closed.

Each time one watches the Mother, there is something new. Each moment one spends with Her opens

the door to a new experience, to a never-known aspect of the Divine. Living and moving with a *Mahatma* always gives one a feeling of ever-freshness.

The unquenchable thirst of Her devotees and disciples to always be in the Mother's presence, to gaze at Her face for hours on end, is certainly the product of this ever-fresh quality of the Supreme Consciousness. As much time as they spent with Her, the Mother's children were never satisfied; it was never enough. Thus they could not remain in meditation with their eyes closed, when there was the hope of peeking at Her form. While what is new becomes old, and what is old is quickly worn-out, the Ultimate Reality, without beginning or end, remains forever new, forever fresh. And one cannot help but experience this ever-freshness in the presence of those who are established in the Supreme Self. They are not only ever-fresh but ancient too.

BELIEVERS AND NONBELIEVERS

Many devotees were waiting to have Her *darshan* when the Mother came downstairs at 10 o'clock. They followed Her to the hut where She sat on the cot for a few moments with eyes closed. Upon opening Her eyes, She looked toward the back of the hut and called to a person who was sitting in the very rear. "Son..." No one responded, so She again called, "Son..." This time a man raised his head and looked behind him, thinking or perhaps pretending that She

was referring to someone behind him. “No, no. Pundit-mon. You. Son, Mother is calling you,” and She gestured with Her right hand for him to come. With a surprised look on his face, the pundit got up and went near the Mother. Again She gestured for him to sit down. He seemed astonished. As soon as he sat in front of Her, She playfully tapped his head a few times, smiling as She rhythmically chanted “Hanuman” with each tap. At this point, the scholar fell at the Mother’s feet and burst into tears. He cried aloud saying, “O Mother, forgive me for testing you. Forgive me, forgive me for testing you.” The Mother lifted him up, wiped his tears and comforted him. She asked him to sit by Her side and continued to give *darshan* to the other devotees.

This man was apparently a scholar of Sanskrit literature and scriptural texts, and this was his first meeting with the Mother. He related his experience to the residents later: “I had heard many stories about the Mother from many different sources. I wanted to see Her, but I had doubts about Her omniscience. Therefore, when I finally decided to come, I set up these conditions: ‘If She is a genuine saint, She must call me first, irrespective of where I sit in Her presence or of how many people there are at the time. I also wanted Her to state the Name of my *upasana murti* (the deity that he worshipped) when I met Her. Amma did both and has filled my heart with faith and love for Her. Even before I disclosed who I was, She knew that I was a scholar. That is why She called me ‘Pundit-

mon.”

As the *darshan* continued with the scholar sitting next to the Mother, the brahmacharins began to sing at Her request. When they finished, the scholar expressed a wish to chant a Sanskrit *sloka* to the Mother. It was from the *Ramayana*, of Hanuman’s praise of Lord Sri Rama.

*Please give me this blessing,
That my love for You should never diminish.
Do not allow me to think of anything else
Or divide my love between
You and any other person.
I want to live as long as Your great Name
Is preserved among the sons of men.
Let me be Your devotee forever and ever.*

Having chanted the verse, he humbly confided to the Mother, “Amma, this prayer by Hanuman to Rama is also my prayer to you.”

She laughed and replied, “To this crazy one? Shiva! Mother is mad, a nut!”

The scholar responded, “Yes, you are right, Mother. For ignorant people like us, *Mahatmas* are crazy. We lack your craziness, craziness for God. We lack the craziness to love everyone equally. That is our problem. Mother, we need a little bit of your craziness to straighten out our problems.”

*An ancient sacred horse ritual

No further remarks came from the Mother; instead, She sang a song, a *namavali*, *Krishna Vasudeva Hari*. The brahmacharins continued to sing, and when that song was over, a young man put forth a question: "Amma, there are believers and nonbelievers in this world, aren't there? What does the believer get from his faith in the existence of God? Does he get something that the nonbeliever does not?"

"Son," the Mother replied, "faith in God gives one the mental strength needed to confront the problems of life. Faith in the existence of God is a protective force. It makes one feel safe and protected from all the evil influences of the world. To have faith in the existence of a Supreme Power and to live accordingly is religion. When we become religious, morality arises, which, in turn, will help to keep us away from malevolent influences. We won't drink, we won't smoke, and we will stop wasting our energy through unnecessary gossip and talk. Morality or purity of character is a stepping stone to spirituality. We will also develop qualities like love, compassion, patience, mental equipoise, and other positive traits. These will help us to love and serve everyone equally. Religion is faith. Where there is faith, there is harmony, unity and love. A nonbeliever always doubts. He does not believe in unity or in love. He likes to cut and divide. Everything is food for his intellect. He cannot be at peace; he's restless. He always questions; therefore, the foundation of his entire life is unstable and scattered due to his lack of faith in a higher principle.

“But a person who is endowed with real faith will be steadfast. A person who has religion can find peace. The source of this peace is the heart, not the head. A person with faith believes in unity, love and peace, not in division and disharmony. Mother is not talking about religion in the narrow sense, but in the broader sense.”

“But, Amma,” the young man further inquired, “these qualities can be seen in some nonbelievers as well, can’t they?”

The Mother responded, “Maybe. But due to the lack of faith in a Supreme Power, they will not have anything to hold on to and surrender to fully to when adverse circumstances arise. As far as a believer is concerned, God is the Supreme. God is an experience. God lives in us through desireless love, compassion, forbearance, renunciation, and qualities like these. If a nonbeliever has any of these qualities in him, in their purest form, he will get all the benefits of a believer. What Mother means by ‘believer’ is not someone who has faith in a god or goddess but someone who gives value to higher principles for which he is willing to sacrifice everything. If these qualities serve as the principles by which the non-believer lives his life, he will be equal to a believer. On the other hand, if those qualities are only on the outside, if they are shallow and not deep, a person will not have the benefits of a true believer. Often nonbelievers like to talk, but they do not put their words into practice. They are shallow and talk only to put on an impressive show. They do

not have anything to hold on to. They lack the faith in a Supreme Governor of the Universe to save them from the problems of life.

“If one keeps only an ideal or a principle as the goal of life, he can lose his mental stability during certain weak moments, which will result in the giving up of all the values which he has cherished in his entire life. This will not happen in the case of a true devotee. A true devotee is always optimistic. His first and foremost quality is acceptance, whatever may happen in his life. He holds on to his Lord and considers everything as His *prasad*.

“A person endowed with faith in the Supreme holds on to that Principle when a crisis occurs. It is this faith which gives him a strong and balanced mind to enable him to confront any trying situation. Qualities like desireless love, compassion, forbearance and renunciation should become integrated in our lives. A truly religious person lives with faith in the existence of a Supreme Principle. For him these qualities are greater than his life. He will give up his life but not the principles by which he lives. He is willing to die for his spiritual principles.”

The Mother then proceeded to tell a story to illustrate this point. It was about the Pandavas and the horse that was chosen to roam the length and breadth of India. After they had completed the *ashwamedha yagña*,* the Pandavas released the chosen horse. The custom was that whoever dared to stop and seize the

horse was considered to be challenging the supremacy of King Yudhisthira, who had performed the special ceremony which had culminated in the release of the sacred horse.

King Mayuradhwaja was a great devotee of Lord Krishna. He was a repository of all virtues, whose wisdom and knowledge of the *Vedas* (scriptures) were known throughout the land. Above all, he was a man of deep compassion and self-sacrifice. This king Mayuradhwaja seized the ceremonial horse of the Pandavas, and thus Arjuna, the great Pandava hero, considered it his duty to fight him. But Krishna dissuaded Arjuna from doing so, for He wanted to demonstrate to the Pandava hero the power of King Mayuradhwaja, his self-sacrifice, truthfulness and devotion. The Lord also wanted to humble Arjuna's pride.

According to Krishna's plan, both He and Arjuna proceeded to King Mayuradhwaja's palace in the guise of two brahmins. They received a warm welcome, and the king offered them generous hospitality. On the eve of their arrival, at the feast that was arranged for these two guests, the Lord, still in brahmin disguise, stood up before all those who were present and began to narrate this tale of woe:

"O wise and virtuous King, as we were coming through a forest on the border of your empire, a tiger snatched away the young son of my companion. Half the body of the poor child had already been swallowed by the beast before we were able to reach him. But taking pity on us in our grief, the tiger promised

to return the child alive if we fulfilled a certain condition.” Feigning reluctance to disclose this condition, Krishna paused. The king, however, was eager to hear the rest of the story and urged Him to continue.

“O great King, the tiger asked for the gift of the right half of the sanctifying body of Mayuradhwaja, the pure and holy emperor of the land. Now tell us, how can we eat peacefully with this great agony gripping our hearts? Only if you promise to give the tiger half your body will my companion’s boy be saved. But how, great King, can we ask such a thing of you?”

Without showing the least bit of hesitancy, the king readily and gladly agreed to give half of his body to the tiger. Thus, upon finishing his meal, the king sat on the floor and instructed his queen and his son to saw his body into two halves. Each holding one end of the saw, the queen and her son began to cut the king’s body in two. As the two brahmins (Krishna and Arjuna) were witnessing this event, they noticed tears filling the left eye of the king. Immediately, Krishna interrupted and said, “Oh, you are giving the promised gift with tears. That means that you are sad to leave the body, and you are giving it up unwillingly. I cannot accept anything given with tears. A real gift is something given whole-heartedly.” To this King Mayuradhwaja replied, “Sir, if I were unwilling or hesitant, both eyes would shed tears, wouldn’t they? But only the left eye is crying because it will not serve a good purpose. The right half of the body is going to be used for a most sacred purpose in saving the life of

a helpless boy. But since the left half will be thrown away to be eaten by dogs and vultures, it is lamenting that it, too, cannot serve a higher purpose. The right half, on the other hand, is jubilant about being sacrificed for such a meritorious purpose.”

As the king finished speaking, Krishna revealed His real form to King Mayuradhwaja and blessed him with everlasting bliss and contentment. Arjuna’s pride was humbled, and the king’s humility and self-sacrifice were duly rewarded by the Lord Himself.

In response to the story, a devotee commented, “Amma, this is far beyond an ordinary person’s conception, isn’t it?”

“This is what Mother was going to say,” Amma said. She further explained, “This story is, of course, not to be taken literally but figuratively. Certainly there were great souls who could act in this way, but now everything is only in words, not in actions. Here the king was willing to sacrifice his own life in order to uphold the principles by which he lived. This is something far beyond an ordinary person’s thinking and understanding. But you should try to see the spirit and the principle behind the story. That is why Mother says that faith and spirituality are not to be taken lightly. Spiritual principles should become an integral part of your lives. Only when they are practiced in your daily life will you be able to experience the benefits of faith and of spiritual principles in their fullness.

“Life is full of misery and the fear of death. Nobody can escape these inevitabilities. But a courageous man can live a happy life. A man who is afraid of death, afraid of losses and afraid of sorrow can never be happy. To be fearless comes only through religious practice. A truly religious person is neither afraid of death nor is he afraid of losses. He is really courageous. He lives for the Truth, and he breathes for Love. His whole being is dedicated to that. Unlike the religious man, a nonbeliever is afraid. First of all, he is afraid of believers and the principle of God. He lives in fear that God will win. He is afraid that believers will predominate and he will lose. This fear in itself makes him a weakling. But a person who is endowed with faith in God is not afraid of nonbelievers nor of people who might scandalize him for his beliefs. His faith is so firm and intense that he strongly believes that God will take care of everything and that Truth will ultimately win. And this is what is happening everywhere. One should be daring enough to open one’s eyes and see this. A real believer is full of strength, immense strength. Nothing can harm him. All of life’s obstacles, whether created by human beings or by nature, will crumble when they hit against the firm and stable faith of the believer.

“While a nonbeliever will waste his life and energy in speaking against or spreading falsehoods about something which he insists does not exist, a believer really lives by his belief and acquires more strength and more energy through his faith in God. He is not

wasting his time and energy in trying to prove or disprove anything. Besides, if God is something which does not exist, why do these nonbelievers walk around trying to prove it, the non-existence of a 'Not'? That's foolishness, isn't it? How many lifetimes are they going to waste like this? One day they are bound to raise both their hands and accept God as the Supreme Power. Nature will make them acknowledge God, if not in this birth, definitely in the next life. This is because the more strongly they deny Him, the closer they become to Him. Negative thoughts about God are still thoughts about Him."

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A DEVOTEE AND A DISCIPLE

A scholar asked the Mother, "Amma, what is the difference between a devotee and a disciple?"

"Son, strictly speaking, a true devotee and a true disciple are one and the same," answered the Mother. "A true devotee is a true disciple and vice versa. Both a disciple and a devotee have devotion; they both begin with devotion, so to speak.

"A disciple is one who is endowed with devotion to the Guru and is willing to undergo being disciplined by him. But in the beginning stages, even the disciple's devotion will be incomplete. Complete faith will still be lacking. Questions may arise; doubts may occur. In the beginning, a disciple will have a thirst to be loved by the Guru, and he will be jealous about the attention given to other disciples. At this stage, the

disciple will have an attachment to the Guru or love for the Guru, but this love will be tainted with selfishness. It is always a struggle in the beginning stages. Yet because of this attachment and love, incomplete though it may be, the disciple will not be able to quit the Guru. The Guru will bind the disciple with his love and then will gradually help him evolve. In due course, as a result of the constant practice and effort under the guidance of the Guru, the disciple will rise up in love. His devotion will become genuine. His sole aim will be to serve selflessly and love the Guru without any expectation of reward. Thus he rises up from the state of an unsteady and indiscriminative disciple to that of a steadfast and immensely discriminative disciple. He rises from the state of a selfish devotee to that of a selfless and pure devotee. When there is nothing left for him but the Guru, then he is a true disciple.

“A true disciple is one who is willing to surrender everything to God or the Guru and desires nothing but the attainment of Supreme Knowledge. He wants to be disciplined by the Master. Whatever may come, a real disciple will not leave the Master until he attains the Supreme State. He may have to go through a lot of difficulties, a lot of mental and physical taming and training, but a real disciple will happily surrender to these trials in order to win the Guru’s grace. His only wish will be to serve the Guru selflessly and to do things which will please him. The Guru may try to confuse the disciple by acting and speaking in strange

and contradictory ways. The Guru may accuse the disciple of mistakes that he has not committed. But a true disciple will be endowed with the mental strength, determination and discrimination to overcome all these impediments.

“A true disciple gives up his ego, his individuality. The river of the Guru carries him wherever the Guru wills. He has totally surrendered to the current of the Guru. He loses all rights on his body; he becomes like a corpse. He simply lets the Guru or God take him wherever God or the Guru wants. He doesn’t judge the Guru. Such a disciple sees the inner Guru, not just the outer form. For him everything is the Guru. He himself has become a bankrupt; he has nothing of his own. He has nobody else to depend on and nothing more to claim as his own. Strongly bound to the Guru in his total surrender, he has no other choice but to seek the Guru’s grace. Fully aware that Perfection cannot be attained without the Guru’s grace, he knows that he needs to empty his mind completely in order to receive it. At every moment he strives to attain this. He tries to imbibe silence, which is the Guru’s real nature. He knows that he should keep quiet first to experience that inner silence. The Guru or God is his Beloved. Once he comes near the Guru, he tries to be quiet to imbibe or hear that silence.

“A real devotee also considers everything as the will of his Lord. His whole being is constantly in a prayerful mood. For him, every word and deed is a prayer, a worship of his Beloved. Having surrendered

everything to his Beloved Lord, a true devotee is always in a blissful mood. There is no place for hatred or anger in him. When everything is his Lord, how can he hate or be angry? He will always be in a pleasant and peaceful mood. All conflicts and divisions cease to exist in him. Those who hate him and those who love him are equal to him. Not only love, but anger and hatred are also *prasad* for him. Not only good, but bad also is *prasad* for a true devotee. Not only believers, but nonbelievers also are nothing but his Lord for him.

“As far as a true disciple is concerned, even though he may choose a god as his beloved deity, no god or goddess is higher for him than his Guru. For him the Guru is both the means and the end; the Guru alone is the goal to be realized. But in the case of a devotee, he considers his beloved deity as everything. Still, the fact remains that in order to get the full benefit of his *sadhana*, he needs the help and guidance of a *Satguru* (Perfect Master).”

The scholar further questioned, “Many people come to see you. There are also a lot of people who are devoted to temple worship. They are also known as ‘devotees,’ aren’t they? But the qualities that you mentioned are not seen in the majority of them. What is the difference?”

Mother answered, “Although all worshippers are generally known as ‘devotees,’ unlike a true devotee, they have not surrendered everything to God. They

may still be involved with affairs in the world, and they may continue performing desire-prompted actions. They will still have desires, ambitions and anxieties, and are prone to crave excitement. Yet they do love God. They pray to Him, sing His glories and speak very highly of Him, but still they retain the ego – the individuality, the *vasanas*. In response to circumstances that arise in their lives their actions will be the result of the ego rather than relying on the God.”

“Is this applicable to disciples too?” asked the scholar.

“Yes,” said Mother, “but not to those disciples who are completely surrendered to the Guru. There are some who are still desiring to lead a material life even after meeting the Guru. Not seeing clearly who the Guru really is, that is, seeing only the outer form and not the inner nature of the Guru, they might have doubts about him. Perceiving only the outer, they judge the Guru. Unable to understand the seemingly confusing or contradictory nature of the Guru, they will not be able to withstand the disciplining of the Master. Their attachment to the Guru has no ‘glue.’ Their determination to reach the goal is not as strong as that of the true disciple or the true devotee. Self-realization is not their primary goal and maybe not even their secondary goal. Their first choice is to fulfill their own desires through ways they think best to achieve them. They even consider the Guru or God as a person through whom they can fulfill their desires.

“Such a devotee or such a disciple is only partly

devoted; whereas, a true disciple or a true devotee is fully devoted to the Guru or God. Truly devoted means to surrender everything to the Guru or God. The Guru's will becomes his wish. The Guru's words become his way of living. The Guru's deeds become his path to follow. 'I' and 'mine' disappear completely. 'He' and 'His' alone exist for one in that state, a state of total egolessness, like the cloudless sky. Thus in being totally devoted, the true devotee or the true disciple has no other choice but to be disciplined or taught by the Guru, for discipline makes one a fit instrument of the Guru or God.

"A true devotee or a true disciple is a perfect instrument in the hands of the Guru or God. The progression can be put in the following manner: First, we have devotion to the Guru. This devotion can be interpreted as love which makes us attached to the form of the Guru. When that attachment is full and complete, then the discipline starts. Discipline is nothing but demolishing and rebuilding, making a new person out of the old one. It requires operating, cutting, removing unnecessary things and obstacles, then stitching and joining to make us function again without any 'sour notes.' This part of the process is a bit painful, but once that is completed, we can feel comfort and relaxation when the smooth, unhindered playing of the Guru's music moves through us. We are then his instrument, and He can play on us in whatever way he wants, because we are totally devoted to him. Because the heaviness of the ego is gone, we become lighter in

weight. Lighter in weight, we can be easily carried by the Guru to the final state of Oneness.

“Sometimes people call themselves a devotee or a disciple, but the factor which determines whether one is a devotee or disciple depends on the amount of surrender that they have towards the Guru or God. In fact, devotion to the Guru or devotion to God are one and the same because God and Guru are one and the same. The formless Supreme Principle, out of sheer compassion and love, assumes a form, and that is the Guru. Devotion to the form of the Guru takes us to the formless aspect of Him, which we call God or *Paramatman*.”

Some Western devotees were present and the Mother’s words were being translated for them. One of them asked a question: “Amma, how can one develop that kind of devotion to the Guru in order to be disciplined by him or her?”

“In some people it is spontaneous and in others it is a slow process,” Mother said. “In order to accelerate this process, we should come under the direct guidance of a Perfect Master. Love is not something which can be taught by someone or learned from somewhere. But in the presence of a Perfect Master we can feel it and, in due course, develop it because a *Satguru* creates the necessary circumstances for love to grow within us. These circumstances created by the Guru will be so beautiful and unforgettable that we will truly cherish these moments as something pre-

cious and invaluable. They will remain as a sweet memory forever and ever. One incident of this kind will create a big wave of love in us. More incidents like this created by the Guru will make a chain of exhilarating memories which will produce waves and waves of love within us, until at last there will be only love. Through these circumstances the Guru will steal our heart and soul, filling us with pure and innocent love.

“However, all this depends on the urgency that one feels. One has to feel the need for it. An urgent need cannot be ignored. We will do anything to try to fulfill it. We will not rest if an urgent need is not fulfilled. But most of us do not feel this urgency to be devoted to God. We think that life is possible without devotion to God and live our lives depending on the world, not on Him.

“At present, God is the last item on our list. But He should be the first. If we put God first, all other things will fall into proper place in our lives. Once we have God in our lives, the world will follow. But if we place the world first, God will not follow. If we embrace the world, God will not embrace us. To have God in us is a struggle in the beginning, but if we persist, it will lead us to everlasting bliss and happiness. All struggles will end. To embrace the world is easy and things go smoothly in the beginning, but this will culminate in never-ending sorrow and suffering. We are free to choose one or the other.

“Mother knows that it is really a difficult task for you children who are from the West. But if you can

become aware of the non-eternal nature of objects while living in Western society in the midst of so many temptations, you will be able to understand the hollowness of such pleasures. You will not succumb to the temptation of material pleasures. No matter what the circumstance, you will realize that such things cannot give inner happiness. Once you are able to exercise that principle, you will become stronger than the people here. But, children, you do not have to worry about it; you will get it by being with Mother and through your willingness to surrender.”

This conversation occurred during a pause in the *darshan*. There were still a few more people to be blessed, so the Mother resumed giving *darshan*, as the brahmacharins chanted some slokas from the *Devi Mahatmyam*...

*O Devi, Who remove the sufferings
Of Your supplicants, be gracious,
Be propitious, O Mother of the world.
Be gracious, O Mother of the universe.
You, O Devi, are Ruler of all
That is moving and unmoving.*

*Salutations be unto You, O Devi Narayani.
O You Who abide as intelligence
In the hearts of all creatures,
Bestow enjoyment and liberation.*

Salutations be unto You, O Narayani.

*O You Who, in the form of minutes, moments
And other divisions of time,
Bring about change in things
And thus have the power to destroy the universe.*

*Salutations be unto You, O Narayani.
O You Who are the good of all good,
O Auspicious Devi,
Who accomplishes every objective,
O Giver of Refuge, O Three-eyed Gauri!*

*Salutations be unto You, O Narayani.
You Who have the power of creation, sustenance
And destruction. You are eternal,
You are the substratum and the embodiment
Of the three gunas.*

One woman devotee came for the Mother's *darshan* and burst into tears as she reached the Mother's lap. Her husband, who had also been a devotee of the Mother's, had recently died. As Mother wiped her tears, the woman spoke, "Amma, my husband was lucky; he died a peaceful death. He had Amma's grace. Even when he breathed his last breath, my husband had Amma's picture clasped in his hand. He was courageous and confident until the end. Amma, by your grace, your daughter (referring to herself) was also very composed. I chanted the *Lalita Sahasranama* as I sat beside him and applied Amma's sacred ash on his forehead. All the while he was repeating his mantra. After he expired, I thought, as I was

sitting next to his body, 'Why should I be sad? He has gone back to Amma. After all, he was Amma's son.' I felt very peaceful and tranquil. He is with you, isn't he, Amma?"

As the woman told her story, the devotees noticed the Mother also wiping Her tears. The Mother looked at the woman and said softly, "Yes, daughter, yes. He is with Mother." The lady now calmed down as if she had heard what she wanted to hear. She wiped her tears and was at ease.

Later the Mother explained, "She wanted a confirmation from Mother that her husband was with Mother. She felt worried before that. That is why she was crying."

INNOCENT FAITH AND HOW TO STUDY THE SCRIPTURES

When the *darshan* was over, the scholar again asked a question: "Amma, the scriptures say that a person who has attained the state of Brahman is beyond all dualities, like happiness and unhappiness, success and failure. But I saw Amma crying when that lady lamented her husband's death. I know that there must be a reason and a purpose for everything you do. Amma, be kind enough to give me an explanation for this."

Smiling at him, Mother gave this response, "Son, what you saw was only a reflection of her sadness. Mother could feel her pain. Mother's tears reflected her tears. If you stand in front of a mirror, whether

you smile, laugh, or cry, everything will be reflected. But the mirror will remain unaffected. The mirror simply is; it simply reflects. The mirror does not do anything. It is actionless, feelingless. So, it is for the sake of their devotees that *Mahatmas* act and express feelings. Although that woman was sad and crying, her innocent attitude made Mother very happy. Therefore, Mother's tears were of happiness, too. Yet really they were neither; both the tears of sadness and those of joy were only reflections. Son, Mother has nothing of Her own. Everything depends on Her children. If they are happy, Mother is happy. If they are unhappy, Mother is unhappy. But She is neither of these."

Hearing the Mother's explanation, the scholar was very pleased. He prostrated in front of Her and said, "Now I see that I have been wasting my life immersed in the study of books. I am doing some kind of spiritual practice, but whatever I acquire through that is certainly spoiled by this study and constant inner talking. My head is full, but my heart is almost empty. Had I performed spiritual practices with the time and energy which I have spent in studying and learning the scriptures, I would at least have gained something. Amma, you have taught me a very important lesson. Your living example of love and compassion for others teaches me more than all those books. Now I see how stupid I have been to bury myself in books, foolishly telling myself, 'I am Brahman,' without giving any thought to real *sadhana*. "

"Son, don't talk like that," said Amma. "Study of

the scriptures is also necessary. It will give you more clarity and understanding. It will also help you to discriminate properly when an obstacle arises. You have gained knowledge from the scriptures that has helped you understand Mother and Her words, haven't you?"

With palms joined, he immediately said, "No, Amma, no. Please don't say that I have understood you. No, I haven't understood Amma at all. My knowledge about you is nothing at all."

"Son," Amma explained, "what Mother means is that you now have a relatively clear vision. Children, those who have studied the scriptures properly and have understood their real meaning will not become egotistical. Such study will not be a waste of time or energy. On the contrary, it can very much help a person during times of difficulty, provided one uses discrimination.

"Theory can help, but there is a limit to its value. After a certain point, words or speech become a hindrance, a great hindrance. Eventually, you will have to drop the words. But this is not possible if you study them without the correct attitude. Don't be bound by the words of the scriptures. Study them with the attitude, "This is not the reality, and therefore, I should not feel attached to it. This is only the plan of the house; I cannot live in it. In order to build it and make it suitable to live in, I must work hard. Therefore, I must not get entangled in mere words." With this kind of attitude towards the scriptures, one can easily drop them when he wants to; otherwise, as pun-

dit-mon puts it, the inner talking will not stop.

“It is a pity that most people who are in the field of scriptural study pursue intellectual learning without applying what they’ve learned in their own lives. They think that they have reached the goal, but as far as their actions are concerned, they are no better than a nonbeliever caught up in the world of likes and dislikes. They are full of ego. They don’t know that the words which they have been studying and repeating in their heads have actually created a big wall between themselves and God.

“One should try to develop innocent faith. Innocence is of the heart. The head cannot be innocent. The head is full of questions and doubts. Shallow understanding of the scriptures is dangerous. A tendency to dispute is another problem seen in many who study the scriptures without understanding them properly.”

This led to another question: “Amma, what do you mean by innocent faith?”

“Son, let Mother tell a story.” Amma proceeded to illustrate the meaning of innocent faith with a story about Lord Shiva and His Consort, Parvati. “The Goddess Parvati had a serious concern. Although it was said that all those who take a dip in the Holy Ganges will be purified of their sins, She saw that this was not happening. ‘Why not?’ Parvati asked Lord Shiva.”

* A spiritual discourse or advice given by a sage or religious scholar. Also, the company of the wise and virtuous.

“Her husband replied, ‘Because they do it mechanically. None of them have innocent faith. They bathe in the Holy Ganges without believing in its purifying effects.’

“Parvati could not believe this, so the Lord made a suggestion, ‘Let us go down to Earth and see for ourselves.’ And so, together they left their heavenly abode and descended to Earth. Picking a spot near the Ganges River, they assumed the forms of an old woman and man. Having instructed Parvati on what to do, Shiva, in the form of an old man, then threw Himself into a deep, dark ditch.

“As instructed, the Goddess, in the form of an old woman, started beating Her chest and crying loudly for help. Many pilgrims passed their way after having bathed in the holy river, and Parvati pleaded with them, ‘Look, good people, my husband has fallen into this hellish ditch because of a curse that befell him long ago. He will die there if he is not rescued before sunset. It is already late afternoon. For God’s sake, save my husband!’ She lamented like a madwoman.

“Taking pity on Her, some people came forward to save Her husband, who was crying loudly for help from the bottom of the ditch. But as if suddenly recalling something, the old woman went on, ‘Only a pure and sinless person can save him. That is what was declared by the person who cursed him when I

*Faith. Amma uses this word with special emphasis on its aspect of alertness coupled with loving care of the work in hand as an offering to God or Guru.

prayed for a remedy for the curse. If a sinner tries to save my husband, his head will break into a hundred pieces, and he too will die.' Hearing this, all those who had come forward to help retraced their steps and disappeared from the spot.

"But soon another person came forward volunteering to help Shiva out of the ditch. Parvati again stated the conditions of the curse. Without hesitation, this person answered, 'I am no more a sinner. I am pure and sinless as I have taken a dip in the holy waters of the Ganges. Mother Ganges has washed away all my sins.' There was not an iota of doubt in his mind as he spoke these words, yet he was not presumptuous in his confidence. From his innocent faith ensued fearlessness. There was no fear of death in him. His faith in the Ganges was so firm and unshakable that he really felt that all of his sins had been washed away and that he was now absolutely pure. He was totally unassuming. And so, due to his innocent faith, he really was absolutely pure.

"The others did not have faith; they doubted, and thus their sins were not washed away. The others bathed in the river simply out of respect for the words of the saints and sages that the waters of the Ganges are purifying and holy. But their belief was only in their heads. They had no faith in their hearts. They did it mechanically, out of respect for the *rishis* (sages). But this man alone was endowed with real and undivided faith in the purifying power of the Ganges.

"Children, innocent faith means doubtless faith. It

means you have no doubts about what you feel and that you have no questions. You simply accept the Guru's words as truth. Just like a child. You tell a child as you point to a closed door, "There is a goddess in that room." The child will have no questions; he will accept it as one-hundred percent true. This kind of faith towards God or the Guru is innocent faith. Faith endowed with the innocence of a child is what we need.

"Innocence comes when there is love. Divine Love makes you like a child. Love makes you accept anything and everything. The lover does whatever the beloved says. We can see this even in ordinary love. When love is sincere, the lover will even jump from the top of a three-story building if the beloved asks him to. His love for her is so intense that he will act like a madman. When one really loves, one's intellect becomes empty; one stops thinking. No thoughts, no mind, nothing. Only love remains. This 'forgetting-all-else' kind of love culminates in innocence."

Mother sat with Her eyes closed for some time after talking about innocent faith. Then She opened Her eyes and chanted Her favorite mantra, "Shiva...Shiva..." Then She instructed everyone to meditate for a few minutes.

Since it was around 12:30 p.m. when She got up from the cot, She told everyone, "Children, do not go without eating lunch," and instructed one of the brahmacharins to take all the visitors to the dining hall and

serve them food. But before leaving, the Mother noticed a bunch of bananas that a devotee had brought. Taking them and breaking them into little pieces, She fed each and every one of the devotees a piece with Her own hand. Everybody was happy, and one person remarked, "One little piece of banana from Amma's hands is enough to appease our hunger. Now we don't have to eat." Many agreed with him. The Mother left the hut and went to Her room.

At 4:30 p.m. the Mother came down to the meditation hall and sat for an hour with the brahmacharins. She then proceeded to the kitchen and upon entering, inquired, "What's new here?" Kunjumol, Gayatri and the other women and girls who worked in the kitchen all stood behind the Mother as another of Her surprise inspections began. They knew through past experience that She would catch them for even the slightest bit of disorder or lack of cleanliness that She found – and always She found something amiss. Although they fearfully awaited the Mother's discovery of their mistakes, they knew that along with any scolding, a beautiful *satsang** would come.

The Mother went straight to the storeroom, where She looked into each container and inspected the shelves. When She came back into the kitchen, the women all heaved sighs of relief, thinking that everything was all right. But the Mother proceeded to look into every pot, scrutinized the plates, each cup and all

the other utensils. She looked at a large pot that was sitting in one corner of the kitchen and gently rubbed it as She looked inside. Without mentioning a single word or revealing any hint of discontent, She tried to lift up the pot. Seeing the Mother's attempt, all the women came closer in order to give Her a hand. She stopped them with the words, "No, none of you should touch this. This pot has sat here unattended for more than two weeks. It was here in the same place when Mother visited the kitchen the last time. I wanted to see if anyone would clean it without being asked." She displayed Her palm which was black from the dirt on the pot.

"Look at this," She continued, "it's covered with dirt, both inside and out. This shows your lack of alertness. If any one of you had *sraddha*,* you would not have left this pot sitting here like this. Remember, doing service in the Ashram and taking care of the things which belong to the Ashram is equal to serving Mother. Such service shows your love for Mother. You should try to take care of these things with as much love as you have towards yourself, as if these things were your own. A careless person is not fit to be a spiritual seeker.

"External carelessness will lead to internal carelessness as well. God is beauty. He is purity. He is the harmony behind everything. There is a harmony behind every object, every place, no matter how insignificant it may look. The scriptures say that food is God. The kitchen is the place where food is cooked; therefore, it should be kept clean and tidy. There is a tendency to

make the kitchen a mess. That is wrong. Do not allow yourselves to follow old habits. We are here to change, not to continue in the same old ways.”

The Mother Herself then carried the big pot outside to the water tap. Again the women rushed forward, this time to do the cleaning, but the Mother would not allow it. She cleaned the pot all by Herself. After scrubbing and rinsing it, She brought it back into the kitchen and put it back in the same place, turning it upside down after having swept the floor. And thus, this incident served as a precious lesson for all the ladies and brahmacharinis who worked in the kitchen.

Even though the evening *bhajan* at 6:30 p.m. was a daily routine, one never tired of singing devotional songs with Mother. She had first begun singing and composing devotional songs to God when She was very young. Her singing was an out-pouring of supreme devotion and all-encompassing love, and every evening those who gathered together for *bhajans* would always find Her presence an elevating experience. It was easy for one's mind to readily flow towards one's *Ishta Deva* (beloved deity) as one's heart overflowed with Divine Love. On this particular night Her whole being radiated with spiritual glory and splendor as She sang...*Pakalantiyil*...

*Time has reached the end of the day,
But my Mother has not yet arrived.*

To sit alone, this one is afraid, O my Mother.

*How long must this aching heart weep helplessly?
Who is there to give company to this one
Enveloped in darkness, O my Mother?*

As Mother repeated some of the lines over and over again, She soared to a high, exalted mood. Tremendous vibrations of Her singing filled the evening twilight. At last, She continued the song with tears streaming down Her cheeks...

*Do You take it as a play?
If so, I do not understand Your viewpoint.
Why such a fate? Is it because
I have not uttered Your Holy Name?*

*This one always searches with an aching heart
For Thy Lotus Feet.
Give me the taste of that sweet nectar
Of devotion in my heart.*

Everyone present was deeply moved upon seeing Mother cry. Hardly anyone could control his tears and some even cried aloud like Her. Spiritual bliss prevailed everywhere as everyone was totally transported to an inner realm of joy. Suddenly Mother took a long, deep breath, and the crying stopped. Her body was absolutely still. Everyone became frightened to see Her holding Her breath for such a long time. She sat in a perfect meditation posture with Her eyes half-

closed. The inner bliss manifested outwardly as Her face glowed like the full moon. There was still no sign of breathing as this state continued. Some brahmacharins felt that singing might help to bring Mother down to a normal state, so they sang, beginning with a slow tempo...

Sita Ram Sita Ram Sita Ram Bol...

Radhe Shyam Radhe Shyam Radhe Shyam Bol...

Gradually, step by step, the cadence increased until it reached a very fast tempo. All those present sang and sang with all their hearts. As the song continued in full swing, Mother let out a blissful laugh. She raised both Her hands, which held divine *mudras*, and at one point She placed both hands on top of Her head. Her eyes remained closed while the laughter of ecstasy continued. This divine mood of the Holy Mother lasted for a few minutes before it slowly subsided. The residents sang the *arati* as one brahmacharin waved the camphor flame inside the shrine, and then the closing prayers were chanted.

The Mother continued to sit in the same place with Her eyes fixed skywards. After a while, She got up, but because She had not yet fully come out of the exalted state, Her steps faltered as She tried to walk. Assisted by two women devotees, Mother went to Her room.

Three hours had passed since the beginning of *bhajans*; it was 9:30 p.m. Everyone prostrated and stood up, looking at the Mother until She disap-

peared from sight. Then the residents dispersed. Some went to their huts and meditated. Some moved towards the backwaters at the edge of the coconut grove and did mantra *japa* as they walked to and fro along the banks. Some householder devotees remained seated on the verandah of the temple and meditated, while a few brahmacharins chose to sit inside the temple. Thus another unforgettable day with the Mother passed, granting us a vast treasure of experience to cherish as part of the eternal memory.

CHAPTER 6

CONCENTRATION AND MEDITATION

29 April 1984

Since this was Sunday, another *Devi Bhava* day, many people had arrived the previous evening in order to spend a full day at the Ashram and to receive the blessing of the Holy Mother in *Devi Bhava*. At seven o'clock in the morning, the Ashram was already crowded with devotees. The morning *puja* was being performed in the temple. One brahmacharin chanted the *Lalita Sahasranama* and others chanted the responses. Some devotees had assembled on the temple verandah and were also chanting the responses.

When the chanting was finished an hour later, the Mother came to the meditation hall to observe the brahmacharins in meditation. As an expression of respect and reverence, they all stood up when the Mother arrived. When She took Her usual seat, they

prostrated fully in front of Her and then returned to their seats. Upon sitting down, the Mother immediately closed Her eyes and began meditating. The residents followed Her example.

After some time, the Mother called out to one brahmacharin by name. Startled, he opened his eyes. He was obviously a bit scared. A mischievous smile danced on the Mother's face. The brahmacharins, who had all opened their eyes upon hearing Mother's call, looked back and forth between Mother's smiling face and that of their frightened brother who now hung his head in guilt.

"Have you finished enacting the role?" She asked. "Yes, you have done it well. Now it is time to come out of your sweet reverie. Wake up."

The same mischievous smile still played on Her face, and everybody continued to listen and watch without understanding at all what was going on. Still, everyone sat with eyes wide open. Promptly came the following statements from the Mother, "Why did you others open your eyes? Did I call you? This shows your lack of concentration. If your minds were concentrated on the forms of your beloved deities, you would not have opened your eyes. You would not even have heard anyone call. This is a clear example of your lack of *sraddha*. How are you going to attain God-Realization if you are so outwardly oriented? Only a person endowed with strong determination can attain God. A single sound was enough to wake you up from meditation, and it was not even related

to you in any way. A true spiritual seeker's concentration and determination should be such that he will be unshaken even if a mad elephant charges at him.

"Mother called one of you, but you all opened your eyes, so curious were you to see what was happening. Shame on you. Mother would have been happy if just one of you had remained unmoved, if one of you had continued to meditate. But no, that was too much to expect."

One brahmacharin dared to say, "We opened our eyes because it was your voice. Had it been someone else's, we would not have paid any attention. After all, we all meditate on your form."

To this Amma responded, "Whether it is Mother's voice or somebody else's, if you were really absorbed in meditation, you would not have heard it. Once concentration is attained, you are in contact with the inner Mother, that means your own Self. Even when you meditate on the name or the form of a God or Goddess or Mother, you are, in fact, meditating on your own Self, not on some external object. In deep meditation there is no outside world. You will not hear, smell, taste, feel or see in that state of one-pointedness. Mother knows that none of you have reached that total state of Oneness. Yet, Mother would have been extremely happy if one of you had at least pretended to remain in meditation. Now, close your eyes and continue to meditate. Try not to let the mind wander. Imagine that the heart is full with your beloved deity's form."

When meditation was over and the Mother had returned to Her room, all gathered around the ‘victim’ brahmacharin, eager for him to reveal what the morning’s incident had been about. “While sitting in meditation,” he explained, “I was carried away by thoughts of a drama in which I acted a role during my college days. My thoughts were on how beautifully I had presented the character.” Everyone roared with laughter when they heard this confession.

Among the thousand names of the Divine Mother in the *Lalita Sahasranama*, which is chanted daily at the Ashram, one mantra is *Sadachara Pravratikayai Namah*, meaning ‘one who enforces good conduct.’ After hearing this interesting experience of the ‘actor brahmacharin,’ another fellow resident interpreted this mantra in a different way. In this mantra *Sadachara* is considered one word, but when divided in two, it takes on a different meaning, for *sada* means ‘constant’ and *chara* means ‘spy.’ *Pravratika* means ‘one who does them.’ Thus, according to this brahmacharin, the Mother is one who is constantly engaged in spy work. He said, “Dwelling within us, Amma always does spy work. She squeezes all information out of us, no matter what it is.”

Around ten o’clock the Mother came to the hut and began giving *darshan*. The brahmacharins were asked to sing. Brahmacharin Pai started with a few slokas from the *Sri Guru Paduka Panchakam*, verses 4 and 5...

*Salutations again and again to Sri Guru's sandals,
Which serve as the Garuda,
The mantra against poison,
To the multitude of serpents of desire and such...
Which bestow the treasure of discrimination
And dispassion, which grant true knowledge,
And which give immediate liberation.*

*Salutations again and again to Sri Guru's sandals,
Which are the boat on which to cross
The endless ocean of the world,
Which bestow steadfast devotion,
And which are a raging fire
To dry the ocean of spiritual intensity.
Then he sang...Amme Ulakam...*

*O Mother, this universe of Thine
Is verily a madhouse.
O Divine Mother, impossible it is for me
To describe Thy Divine Love.*

*Please feed me daily with Thine own beautiful hand
The nectar of Love, and thus remove my pride
Arising from the identification of the Self
With the body. Make me infatuated with that
Love.*

*O Mother, Inner Core of the Scriptures,
If my eyes shed tears of devotion
When I utter the Name of Kali,
Then all the Scriptures would become secondary*

Things fit only for the intellect.

INFINITE MASKS OF THE MOTHER

To watch the Mother give *darshan* is always a fascinating experience. An infinite number of masks are at Her disposal, and She goes on changing them from one moment to the next, as She glides effortlessly between roles. This changing of masks goes on and on, for none of these faces are really Hers. None of them is Her real face, which is something far beyond the realm of forms. The Mother is not at all attached to or identified with any of these different faces or roles. She wears each one for a particular purpose, and once that purpose is fulfilled, the mask is quickly removed. To each of Her children She shows a different mask, depending on the time and need. Even though She shows a mask, the fact remains that each one of these masks are not at all mere masks but a reality, a strong link to establish their personal relationship with Her, and thus feel that Mother is their own. Meaning, although for Mother these different faces are just like masks which can be removed and replaced at any time, in the hearts of Her children, She creates the feeling that She is their own and She is with them all the time. But while we become identified with and attached to this face and role, the Mother remains detached and unchanged. She can wear it or throw it away at any time.

On this day, like so many others, one lady was telling the Mother about the difficult situations she had

to confront in her life. Her husband was very sick; he could not work due to his ill health. They had three daughters, all of whom were over twenty and not yet married. Such was her tale of woe. As the Mother listened intently to all that the lady had to say, one could clearly see how sad the Mother was. The anxiety She displayed on Her face when the woman was lamenting about her three unmarried daughters was evident. The Mother consoled the woman, wiped her tears and assured her that everything would be all right. Hearing this, the woman's face lit up, and by the time she left the Mother's presence, she appeared happy and relaxed.

Next came someone who looked very happy. "Amma, by Your grace I have gotten the promotion that I have been waiting for," he said. "I had been expecting and hoping it would come, but somehow it was delayed. I grew very disappointed, thinking that I would never get it. But all of a sudden yesterday the promotion notice came. It is Your grace, Amma." The man was exuberant with joy as he had the Mother's *darshan*, and the Mother, too, seemed very delighted and was wholly participating in his happiness. Joyfully, She told someone sitting near the cot, "Look, this son got a promotion. How long he's waited for it! He got it by God's grace." After this happy man moved aside, there came a young man who looked as if the burden

*Mastery of the mind through the control and transformation of the psychic equipment.

of the entire world was on his shoulders. Two such different faces, one right after the other. Now the Mother's face changed to empathize with that of the sad young man.

Thus Her face goes on changing, but She is never identified with or bound by any of Her faces or moods. She is such a Master at this art of changing masks that She can even wear more than one at a time. With so many children all with different needs and demands, the Mother is an Adept at giving each one just what he needs.

It once happened that for three days the Mother did not so much as look at Brahmacharin Balu, while She continued to converse with the other brahmacharins. For this reason, Balu had stopped eating. Upon learning about his fast, the Mother insisted that he eat, but Balu was stubborn and would not obey. In his early days with the Mother he used to be stubborn, demanding and disobedient at times. Again and again the Mother asked him to eat, but he would not. Thus when, on the third day of his hunger strike, Balu and Brahmacharin Sreekumar were sitting beside the Mother, She was extremely loving towards Sreekumar, but displayed anger towards Balu. Out of one eye poured love, while anger darted from the other. While She may show infinite masks, infinite faces, infinite moods, deep down the Mother remains the same – unattached, undivided, totally One.

From *Ananda Srishti Vahini*, which is often chanted at the end of *Devi Bhava*, we have these lines which de-

scribe the Mother's infinite number of masks. Who is She, really? Numerous words can be written to try to describe Her, but the answer can only be found in one's heart.

*Salutations to Thee, O Great Divine Goddess
Who art the support of all creation,
Of infinite states and infinite aspects
And ever in the state of supreme dance.*

*Salutations to Thee, O Ever-Effulgent One
The Mother of Immortal Bliss,
Ever-breaking the silence of the dead of night,
Thou art Protector of righteousness
And all that is wholesome in the world.*

*Salutations to Thee, in the form of Guru,
Thou art Goddess Shiva
Showing the path of dispassion
With a smile like the lotus flower.*

*Prostrations to Thee, O Bhadrakali,
Fierce form of Devi and cause of auspiciousness.
Permeating the whole of consciousness,
Thou art full of compassion and the cause
For the submergence of individuality in everything.*

*Prostrations to Thee, O Mother,
Ever-effulgent and wearing a crown,
Thou bestowest heaven and Liberation.
As the cause for everything in and beyond nature,
Thou art beyond time.*

CHAPTER 7

QUESTIONS ASKED BY WESTERNERS: WHICH PATH TO FOLLOW

30 April 1984

The previous night's *Devi Bhava* ended at three o'clock in the morning. Since it was part of Mother's routine to go around among the devotees making sure that everyone had a place to sleep and a mat or a blanket to sleep on, it was a little after four o'clock when She finally went to Her room.

In the early afternoon came a group of Westerners who were spiritual aspirants traveling around India, visiting pilgrim centers and spiritual institutions. They had already been informed about the Mother's greatness by a friend and therefore requested to stay for a week. As they walked around the Ashram grounds they were impressed with the peaceful atmosphere. Brahmacharin Balu led them to the northern side of the Ashram where they were given rooms in the guest house.

Mother came down around three o'clock in the afternoon. Immediately She went to the coconut grove. Presuming that She was going to sit there, Gayatri spread out a mat on a spot where there was good shade, and Mother came and sat there. She sent Gayatri to fetch the Westerners, and they all came running, exuberant with delight. After offering their prostrations to the Mother, they gathered around Her and

sat. First of all, in Her usual manner Mother gave *darshan* to each one of them individually. The personal *darshan* they received was a totally overwhelming experience for them. Thus they sat entranced, gazing at the Holy Mother.

As Mother sat and looked at them, smiling, an inexplicable expression of compassion and love beamed from Her face. No one could speak as the moments passed in silence. Finally Mother inquired, as Balu translated, “Children, have you eaten?” Spellbound, they continued to gaze at the Mother. It was impossible for them to verbally reply, so they nodded their heads in the affirmative. Mother further asked, “Children, did you all get a room?” and again their response was non-verbal. Mother, being struck by a funny mood upon seeing them continue to sit like dumb mutes, grabbed the two closest ones and shook them vigorously. This finally awakened them, and they all roared with laughter. When that subsided, Mother said, “Mother is very happy to see Her children.”

Light conversation followed for a brief while. Again came a pause, after which one of them asked a question, “Amma, which path is the best for Westerners? Most people in the West show a lot of interest in following the Path of *Jñana* (Path of Knowledge). Should this be encouraged? What is your opinion?”

“Children,” Mother answered, “whether it is in the East or in the West, one’s spiritual path can only be indicated according to one’s inherited spiritual disposition and mental constitution. One path cannot be

announced in a public address as the one and only path for all. To embark on a spiritual path involves personal guidance and disciplining. In the olden days, the spiritual masters always tested the competency of the disciple before giving advice. It was never general advice for all. That is why all the spiritual texts like the *Upanishads* and the *Bhagavad Gita* are in dialogue form. The advice given is particular to the individual. Each person is a patient with a different disease. Some people are in the beginning stages of a disease while others are in the middle stages. In addition, we find people with chronic diseases and still others who are half-cured. Therefore, the treatment for each person cannot be the same. The medicine will be different and the dosage will vary.

“Many problems will arise if only one path is prescribed for all. Real spiritual growth will not take place if a person who is supposed to follow the path of devotion is told to take the path of *Raja Yoga*.^{*} It is like telling an asthma patient to take medicine for diabetes. Being advised to take a path not appropriate for them is a stumbling block for many people in their spiritual quest. Mother cannot say that one path alone is good enough for everyone in order to attain the goal.

“But generally speaking, the Path of Devotion is the easiest and the least complicated. While anybody can love, not all can do *pranayama* (breath control) or *Hatha Yoga* (yogic postures). Only certain people endowed with a certain mental and physical constitution

can do these. But love has no prerequisites. Whoever has a heart can love, and everyone has a heart. To love is an innate tendency in human beings. However, we cannot say that *pranayama* or *Hatha Yoga* come naturally to human beings. *Bhakti* is love – loving God, loving your own Self, and loving all beings. The small heart should become bigger and bigger and, eventually, totally expansive. A spark can become a forest fire. So to have only a spark is enough, for the spark is also fire. Keep blowing on it, fanning it. Sooner or later it will burn like a forest fire, sending out long tongues of flame. At present, love is like a spark within us. Constantly blow on it, using the fan of the Divine Name, *japa* and meditation. You may perspire, sneeze and cough, but do not stop. Your body may become hot; tears may fill your eyes; you may want to faint. But do not stop. If you perspire, you sneeze and cough, persist in your efforts, and be assured then that you are heading towards the goal. Soon you will become Love itself. This is the reward for your love.

“The Path of Love, otherwise known as the Path of Devotion, is the best one for Western children. Of course, this is a general statement. In the West, society is such that people, even from early childhood, are intellectual and take an intellectual approach to everything. It is the product of their ‘modern’ education. They are fed with all kinds of factual information about the empirical world, and the emphasis is on science and technology. So their analytical minds are well-developed, but their hearts are dry. In most cases,

the hearts of people in the West remain under-developed and imperfect. The head is big, but the heart is shriveled up and dry.

“What is the cause for this dryness?” the Western man further asked.

Mother elaborated, “The social norm that prevails paves the way for this dryness of the heart. One gets one’s first lessons in love from one’s mother. But in the West, the roles of mother and father become confused. Mothers become fathers and thus lose the quality of motherly love. They have no real love for their children. The instability of married life is another factor. The husband-wife and the mother-father relationship is so weak and fragile. A child who lives in this kind of situation cannot be loving. He or she cannot be affectionate. Such children do not even learn the most basic lessons of love. Of course, love cannot be taught like one can be taught to read and write. What Mother means is that there are no proper circumstances created for them to develop love in their lives. They grow up seeing the conflicts, arguments, disputes, hatred, fighting and finally the separation of their parents. They never experience what love is, which is what they are supposed to learn from the mutual love between their father and mother. The parents are the two Gurus which the children see from birth until they come into contact with the world. If the seed of love is not sown at home, it cannot sprout or blossom.

“The Path of *Bhakti* teaches love. First, you de-

velop one-pointed love towards God. When that love becomes the center of your life and as the devotional practices become more and more intense, your vision changes. You come to understand that God dwells as Pure Consciousness in all beings, including you. As this experience becomes stronger and stronger, the love in you also grows until at last you become That. The love within you expands and embraces the entire universe with all its beings. You become the personification of Love. This Love removes all dryness from you. This Love is the best cure for all emotional blocks and for all negative feelings. Therefore, Mother thinks that the Path of Love is the best for Western seekers.”

FORMATION OF QUALITIES IN CHILDREN

One of the Western women responded in agreement, “What Mother recommends is really the perfect path for Westerners. I know from experience how much pain and tightness there is within me—and how little love. In our efforts to imitate men, we Western women have lost our essential femininity. This is really sad. A life based on love and patience is what we need.”

Amma continued further, “Mother was just about to say that patience is another quality which is lacking in Western society. Children, a mother must have great patience in bringing up her children. A mother has to put into effect the molding of the child’s character. The child learns his first lessons of love and pa-

tience through his mother. But she cannot simply talk about love and patience and expect her son or daughter to adopt those qualities. No, that is impossible. She has to set an example of love and patience by putting those qualities into practice in her dealings with her child.

“A child can be very adamant and uncompromising, of course. But that is the nature of most children since their minds are not fully developed. Caring only about their own needs, they can be very selfish and stubborn. But, that is permissible, for it is not contrary to nature or to the laws of nature. But if a mother becomes stubborn and impatient, that is something very bad. That will create hell. A mother must be patient—patient like the earth.

“A father is just as deeply involved in rearing the children as the mother. A father, too, must have patience. When a father grows impatient, that is the end of the child’s innocent and trusting life. He or she will grow up to be impatient and adamant, never having experienced what it meant to be patient since nobody had shown them what it was. Socially, they will have a difficult time. Friends will not be patient with them. They cannot expect their girlfriends or boyfriends to have patience. Society is not going to be patient with an impatient boy or girl. Children will not have an opportunity to learn patience and love from anybody else if they do not learn these qualities from their parents. If the mother is patient and loving with her children, they, too, will grow up to be patient and loving.

But if the Mother is not, the children are not going to be loving and patient because they will not know what it is to be so. We cannot blame them for that.

“Children express what is taught to them and what they have experienced while growing up. Therefore, you should be very careful and cautious for your children’s sake. Be careful about what you say. Be careful about what you do, because each word that you utter and each deed you perform creates a deep impression in your child’s mind. It goes deep into his heart because those are the first things that he sees and hears. They are the first impressions indelibly imprinted upon his or her mind. The mother is the first person with whom the child is in contact. Next comes the father. After that, the elder brothers and sisters. All other relationships come later in life. Therefore, in front of your children exercise good control over your mind. Create a good home environment for them in which they can grow up. Otherwise, you will have many worries in the future.”

FAMILY LIFE AS AN ASHRAM

“Amma, so you are saying that family life is not something to be taken lightly, that it is not just something that happens in the course of our lives. Should it be considered as another form of *tapas*?” asked another Western man.

“Children,” Amma replied, “Mother does not like to use the word ‘*tapas*’ because it scares many Western children. They think that *tapas* involves physical and

mental torture. They are afraid that through *tapas* they will lose all their desires, and they do not want that to happen. They want to enjoy life. But the only problem is, they have the wrong idea of 'enjoying life.' Real enjoyment of life depends on relaxation, not on tension. Yet, most people, not only in the West but also in the East, are very tense almost all of the time. Men are not able to spend any peaceful moments with their wives and children. They are more worried about their work, their business, their status in society and about what others will think or say about them. They are always worried about one thing or another. They want a new house, a new car, a T.V., or a new relationship. A person engrossed with life in the world always wants some new thing. He is fed up and bored with old things. He can never be satisfied with what he has. He thinks that new things will make him happy. His mind is always set on what he does not have. He is always living either in the past or in the future, never in the present, and he runs after everything he craves. He goes on acquiring and possessing. He has no time to enjoy, to relax and be in the present. So finally, he collapses. This is what happens to most people in this so-called 'modern society'—be it in the West or East.

"A family is not merely a group of individuals who live together. As they live together, this 'group' can learn to understand many things. It is another type of *gurukul* (the family of the Guru). Just like the spiritual Guru, who treats his disciples as his own children, the father and mother are the gurus in this case, and the

children are the disciples. In the *gurukul* a very strong bond exists between the Guru and the disciple. The master is always like a father or a mother to his disciples. So there is nothing wrong in comparing family life to a *gurukul*. In the olden days in the Guru's hermitage, sometimes, if he was not married, the Guru was both the father and mother to his disciples. But if Guru had a wife, she was the mother of the Guru's disciples, exhibiting love and patience while the Guru took care of the teaching and the disciplining. That was how it used to be in the ancient Indian *gurukuls* where the master led a householder's life.

"In most families today, there is both a father and a mother. With the correct understanding about family life and about life as a whole, they can play their parts properly. The mother can try to impart in the child virtues like love, patience and forbearance, and the father can lovingly prevent the child from doing things which would do harm to society, his family and to his own life. The father can teach him obedience and respect for others. In some cases, a single parent becomes both the father and mother. It is possible if one tries. In all cases, the parents are the first ones to set an example, to show their children how they want them to be. If a good example isn't set, it is an impossible task to raise children properly. A father can also be a good mother and a mother can also be a good father. But this balance cannot be attained unless one

does proper *sadhana*.

“So the family house should not be a place where a group of individuals live together in conflict, always fighting and arguing. It is not a place for just eating and sleeping, thinking that this is what life is and that this is what enjoyment is. That makes family life hell. It will cut your personality to pieces. Family life such as this is equal to death. A person who leads this kind of life in his family is nothing more than a corpse. This kind of family is like a prison where the inmates have no personal contact; they are just there, adjacent to one another. But you can turn your family into a haven, your house into a home, an abode of happiness and bliss, a place of peace and love. There definitely is effort involved; it can be a kind of *sadhana*. It is all right if you want to call it *tapas* if that helps you think of it as a serious matter.

“Nobody wants to be unhappy, nobody wants to suffer. Everybody wants to be happy at all times, if possible. But the way or the path they choose to accomplish this end is often wrong. The present way of living will only end up in greater distress and sorrow. The problem is you. It’s within you, not outside. If you really want to enjoy life, try this path of mental disciplining and see what happens. There is no harm in putting forth some effort, doing some *tapas*, if it helps to bring more happiness. You want to enjoy life; of course, nobody wants to suffer. But remember that enjoyment depends on how you live life.

“A *griham* (house) is an ashram or hermitage. That is how the word *grihasthasrami* (householder) came into being. A *griham* can be converted into an *ashramam*. An ashram is a place where people devote all their time and energy to the remembrance of God, doing selfless service and developing qualities like love, patience and respect for others. They do spiritual practices to help them see unity in diversity. First, they fill their own hearts with love, and then whatever they do and wherever they go, this love is expressed in all that they do. They see beauty and harmony everywhere. This is what life in an ashram is intended to be. Family life can also be like this. It was like this before, in the olden days. If they did it, so can we. That is why a householder devotee is known as a *grihasthasrami*, a person who leads an ashram life while remaining in his house. He is a person who tries hard to attain the supreme goal, bliss, even while living with his wife and children. This is possible if you sincerely try.”

FEAR OF SURRENDERING

Another question came from a Western man: “Amma, it seems that even though many Westerners are seeking spirituality, when it comes to renunciation, they have weak wills. I would even say that they are really frightened to give up possessions and surrender. Why is this?”

Mother said, “Son, this attitude is found in the people of India as well, but it is more apparent among Westerners. As Mother said before, people are afraid

to give up their desires. They think that they cannot live without them. There is nothing to be afraid of because nobody is going to force you to give up your possessions and surrender your will to the Guru's will. No real Guru will press you or threaten you to do anything.

"Mother does not force anything. Her children have all the freedom they want. Mother has said, even to the children who live here, 'Children, you have the freedom to choose. If you have any strong worldly desires and if you find it difficult to continue as a brahmacharin, you can frankly tell Mother about it. Mother Herself will find a girl for you and will arrange for your marriage. But if you are interested in continuing the path and if you truly feel that this alone is what you want, then you should try to live according to the rules and regulations of the Ashram. But you are to free to choose.'

"Furthermore, no real Guru will start disciplining you as soon as you move to his ashram. If you are interested in following the path, he will wait patiently until you become mature enough to be disciplined. There is no sense in instructing you to do things or not to do things if you are not truly willing to accept the Guru's words. This would be like talking to a rock. So the Guru is not going to force you or even instruct you to do something which you don't want to do. But he will make you become willing to surrender, not forcefully but slowly, patiently taking you to a point where you will have no other choice but to sur-

render. Therefore, the fear that the Guru will force you to surrender is meaningless.

“After all, why should the Guru press you to surrender? He is beyond all interest in anything. He is beyond desire and desirelessness. He has no selfish motives, for he is beyond everything. To force something onto somebody else is the nature of greedy people. The Guru is not at all greedy; so why would he do that? Surrender is not something which you do to somebody else. It is to your own Self that you surrender. The Guru does not want anything from you. He does not have any personal interest, nor does he have anything to gain from your surrender. He is ever full and complete. The Guru knows only how to give, and he goes on giving. The Guru does not need any of the external things that you might give him. The giving up is for your inner growth, for your own peace of mind and for your own bliss. It is for the unfolding of your little self into the big Self.

“Seeing only his body, people judge the Guru externally. They project their own ignorance onto him. This is what makes them afraid to surrender. They think that the Guru will control them or snatch everything from them. They are afraid that he will take away their individuality and make them suffer. Because they see only the human form of the Guru, they fear that they will be tricked by him. The Guru is beyond the body; he is beyond being human. He is the embodiment of pure consciousness. In reality, he is formless and nameless. There is no person there. Only nothing-

ness. How can the formless, nameless Guru snatch anything from you? How can he control you? He simply is, and you benefit from his presence. If you really want to use the Guru, then surrender to your own Self. Your Self is the same as the Guru's Self. Therefore, there is nobody who will claim, demand, argue or snatch. Surrendering to your own Self is for your own spiritual upliftment. It is not for the Guru, not for the Guru at all."

The group of Westerners listened intently to the Mother's words. They were clearly very happy to hear Her answers. The one who appeared to be the leader of the group expressed her gratitude to Mother, "Amma, You have really clarified some questions that have bothered us for a long time. This has been truly enlightening. We had many more questions, but you have answered them without our having to ask them. It is said that one cannot repay the Guru. Nevertheless, Amma, please accept our humble prostrations at Your Feet." They all prostrated in front of the Mother.

Mother called Brahmacharin Sreekumar to bring the harmonium. When he brought it, She sang a few *namavalis* and the Westerners joined in the response. Their attention was completely focused on the Mother. Seeing Her God-intoxicated mood, they all sat gazing at Her with awe and reverence. Seeing these different moods of supreme devotion manifested in the Mother was a new experience for them. When She

finished singing, Mother remained in a totally indrawn state for a short while. Then returning to the physical plane of awareness, She got up from Her seat and walked towards the southern edge, near the backwaters. The ripples of the water reflected the glow of the late afternoon light.

THE INCOMPREHENSIBLE MOTHER

Late in the evening, after the *bhajan*, Mother was lying down in the sand on the south side of the temple. Her head was on Gayatri's lap and Her feet rested on the lap of another woman devotee. Almost all of the brahmacharins and other Ashram residents were present. Mother was in a very playful mood. Like a child, She caught hold of Gayatri's hair and pulled. Gayatri bent her head down, but Mother kept pulling until Gayatri's head touched Mother's chest. Then She let go of the hair.

The next moment Mother closed Her eyes and with Her right hand outstretched, She went into *samadhi*. Everybody remained still. After a while, She came out of this mood, whirling Her right hand in circles and uttering a distinctive sound which She makes such times when She moves in and out of *samadhi*. Mother did not speak; neither did the brahmacharins ask any questions.

After a short while She placed Her right hand on the ground and began to dig a small hole. Suddenly She took a handful of sand, and threw it at one

brahmacharin's face. As he coughed and spat, struggling to remove the sand from his mouth, Mother roared with laughter. She rolled off Gayatri's lap onto the sand, laughing uncontrollably. After a few moments, She sat up and again grabbed another handful of sand. The brahmacharins watched this, and expecting a face-full of sand, some began to move quickly away. But She did not throw any. Seeing that Mother had stopped playing, the brahmacharins who had run away now returned. But as they sat down, the sand came flying. Mother's aim was perfect. The very same brahmacharins who had run away were now showered with sand. They rushed to the water tap to wash their faces and rinse their mouths, and when they returned, Mother was in Her normal mood.

Now one of the brahmacharins asked a question, "Shouldn't whatever a *Mahatma* gives be accepted with love and reverence?"

"Yes, that's what the scriptures say," answered Amma. "There shouldn't be any question or doubt about it. Simply accept what is given and keep it as an object of worship. However insignificant the object may appear, we should not refuse it because we do not know what we are being given. In our eyes it may appear as a silly object. But it can be a rare blessing bestowed on you with a special *sankalpa*. *Mahatmas* can do this. A gift like this can be the fruit of your *sadhana*."

"You may think, 'Oh, I haven't done any spiritual

practices in this lifetime; so how can this be the fruit of any *sadhana*?" If you have not performed any *sadhana* in this lifetime, you must have done something in your previous birth. That is why the Guru blesses you. You don't know anything about your previous life, but the Guru knows. Not only about your previous life, but He knows about all the births that you have gone through; He knows everything that you have done. He knows the past, present and the future. He knows what you have been, what you are and what you will become. Even a handful of sand is valuable and precious if a *Mahatma* gives it to you.

"Even if a person has not acquired any spiritual merits in previous lifetimes, a *Mahatma*, out of sheer compassion and love, can shower His grace on him or on whomever He wants. We do not know in what form this grace will come."

The Mother was clearly pointing out the mistake they had made to the brahmacharins who had run away. Full of remorse, one of them said, "Amma, we did not have enough discrimination to sit unmoved when You threw the sand on us. We simply thought that Amma was playfully throwing sand at us. We did not see the inner depth of Her game. Amma, please forgive us for our error." They each prostrated and sought forgiveness of the Mother.

Amma consoled them, "No, children, no. It is not your fault. It is Mother's mistake. Sometimes Mother becomes a little playful and does something like that.

But, children, Mother simply does it. In fact, there is really no ego involved.”

She paused. Then all of a sudden, She burst into a song... *Uyirai Oliyai...*

*O Goddess Uma, where are You,
You Who are said to be the life, light
And firmness of the earth?
O artful One Who exists as the wind, sea
And fire, have You no mercy on me?
All wisdom has fled to a distant place,
Repeated births continue,
Unreality has become reality
And all defects are increasing
In the absence of You,
Who are Real Knowledge concealed.*

The sound of the ocean waves served as background accompaniment to Mother’s song, and soon She was again lost in a mood of divine rapture. She laughed and smiled as tears rolled down Her cheeks. Raising both Her hands, the Mother sang. As Mother Herself has said, Her mind is always spontaneously shooting up to the highest plane of consciousness. Within a split second She can switch off this world of plurality, this world of names and forms, and travel towards the unknown. Just like a child who can go to the kitchen and obtain the message needed for the stranger waiting in the sitting room, Mother can ascend and descend any time She wishes. Mother has

free access to both worlds. We onlookers see only the closing and opening of Her eyes, the circling of Her hand, the uttering of *Namah Sivaya* or a blissful laughing, but we know nothing about the incomprehensible Supreme Reality where She is constantly established.

Mother's exalted mood cast a spell of charm and delight over all Her children, who sat unmoving, their eyes fixed on Her. The night was indeed enchanted, and all of nature seemed to respond to the Mother's divine bliss. After about ten minutes of this magical stillness, Mother's mood abruptly changed. She lay down in the sand and began rolling restlessly from side to side. All of a sudden, She said, "I want some roasted *katala*" (chick peas).

"O Narayana!" Gayatri exclaimed. "We have no *katala*. How can we get any at this hour?" It was as if she knew that this request would not be quickly forgotten. Sure enough, just like a small child, Mother went on saying, "I want roasted *katala*, I want roasted *katala*." Immediately Gayatri jumped up and ran, first to the Mother's room, and then she ran to the kitchen and again back to the Mother's room. The Mother continued to ask for *katala*. Luckily, Gayatri could find some in her cabinet, so she brought it to the Mother. Sitting up, Mother popped a few pieces into Her mouth, and then proceeded to distribute a bit to everyone present. Noticing that two brahmacharins were missing, She sent someone to get them, but the messenger returned alone, reporting that both were

meditating.

At this point, Mother Herself got up and strode towards the hut in which one of the missing brahmacharins lived. Everyone followed behind Her. Entering his room, She tip-toed up behind him as he sat in meditation, quickly grabbed his head, and stuffed the *katala* into his mouth. Jumping up from his seat, he was, needless to say, very startled. With an astonished look still on his face, he stood before the Mother, chewing a mouthful of food. As if this was just what She had wanted to see, Mother watched him and laughed.

Aroused from his meditation by Her loud laughter, the other brahmacharin who had been sitting in an adjacent hut came to see what was going on. Having intended to play this same trick on him, when Mother saw Her second victim in the doorway, She said in a disappointed tone, "Oh, here he is! It would have been fun, but the chance is lost. Maybe another time." These words invoked yet another round of laughter. She gave this brahmacharin a handful of *katala* and, making sure that everyone had received his share, She handed the bowl to a brahmacharin, and followed by Gayatri and Kunjumol, She proceeded towards Her room.

Although each one is precious and unique, incidents of the Mother's playful and strange behaviour are not rare. In recounting these actions of the Mother, we find that first She wanted some fried *katala*. Yet when it was brought, She hardly ate any. Instead, She distributed it to everybody; thus it was a

play for Her. As Mother has explained, Her playful and strange behavior often serves the very practical purpose of keeping Her mind fixed on the physical plane of consciousness. Her mind can easily rise up and dwell forever in divine union; therefore, out of benevolence for Her children She strives to remain on this physical plane. And for Her children who were lucky enough to be present on such occasions, these incidents are especially precious gifts. They provide unforgettable remembrances, memories to be cherished and contemplated for years to come. It is through these incidents and their memories that the Mother creates the most ideal conditions for cultivating in Her children the seed of Divine Love.

Aparigrahyam (incomprehensible) is the word used in the scriptures to indicate Brahman, the Supreme Truth. Brahman is incomprehensible. It cannot be comprehended through the limited faculties of the mind, intellect or the sense organs. This word is applicable to a person who has attained the Supreme State. The ordinary human intellect will search for the meaning of the actions of persons in the Supreme State, but that search is futile because the realm of the Supreme transcends everything. Stop searching for a meaning to their actions. Simply accept their actions as they are. Any attempt at explanation or interpretation will not reveal anything, for the meaning does not

*Ground rice flour and ground coconut mixed together and steamed in an iron or wooden cylinder, served with cooked garbanzo beans and usually eaten for breakfast.

come via words. The search of the intellect or reason has to stop. Only in silence can one know and experience it. Once it is known, the knower 'keeps mum.'

A *Mahatma* is like a child. *Balavat* is the term used in the scriptures to describe this childlike nature. He neither has any regrets about the past nor does he have any anxieties about the future. He always lives in the present, totally unattached. To an ordinary human being, who is burdened with all kinds of preconceived ideas and prejudices, a *Mahatma* might appear unreasonable or crazy. The scriptures call this aspect *bhrantavat*. The fact is, he cannot be comprehended by human intellect. To get a glimpse of his real nature, one should drop his reasoning. Until one's reasoning is dropped, the *Mahatma* remains inexplicable, incomprehensible and indescribable.

CHAPTER 8

A PROFOUND TEACHING ILLUSTRATED IN EVERYDAY COOKING

1 May 1984

On this morning Mother came downstairs even before eight o'clock and headed towards the east, away from the Ashram, followed by Gayatri and Kunjumol. As She passed a few brahmacharins sitting in front of the meditation hall, the Mother glanced at them and asked, "What are you talking about? Is it worthwhile?" Not waiting for an answer, She continued on and passed 'Unni's hut,' which was only a few yards away

from the Ashram. (This hut belonged to a fisherman's family who were devotees of the Mother. It was situated just east of the Ashram temple. On this spot now stands the new seven-story temple building; its construction was begun in 1986).

Wondering where She was going at this early hour, two of the brahmacharins decided to follow Her. But they did not follow too closely, knowing from experience that the Mother did not always like them to go with Her when She went out. Mother had Her own reasons for this. Sometimes when She was about to leave She would specifically tell them not to come and would often give reasons why. And other times She would simply go without saying anything. On those occasions, like this morning, when nothing was definitely said, the brahmacharins took it as an indication that they could come if they wanted, and always some of them would follow behind. Because they could never be sure about what the Mother would say or do from one moment to the next, whether it was all right for them to come along, or whether She might suddenly turn around and tell them to go back, the young men followed at a distance, hoping She would not send them away.

When Mother reached the edge of the backwaters, She turned towards the south, still accompanied by the two girls. Pausing at the water's edge, She turned and looked at the brahmacharins, shouting to them, "Hey, you little thieves, no problem! Come along!"

Thus getting a green signal, the two boys ran and

joined Her. They walked together, and along the way She pointed out a public water tap and recalled, "This is the spot where the windmill pipe was. Mother used to wait here for long hours to fetch water for the household needs. But She never wasted time. If there was a long queue Mother would go and cut grass for the cows. Whether Mother was standing in the queue waiting for Her turn or cutting grass for the cows, She would never cease to remember God and to repeat His Name."

After a brief pause, She continued, "The villagers were very kind to Mother. They tried to help Her whenever they could. They knew that Mother worked day and night, attending to all the household chores. The difficulties that She had to undergo and Her devotion to God were also well-known throughout the village. Therefore, even if Mother left Her empty water pot near the tap and went off to cut grass for the cows, one of the villagers would always fill it and keep it aside for Mother."

At this point they reached the house of Pushpavati Amma, an ardent devotee of the Mother. She was, in fact, standing in front of Her picture when Mother entered the house. The very small hut with one bedroom and a kitchen was filled with household utensils. Half the space in the small bedroom was occu-

*In India there continues the tradition of the 'poet-singer' who reads or chants the tales of the ancient gods and heroes, just as in the Greek tradition, Homer sang about the adventures of Ulysses.)

pied by a large wooden box, the kind used to store rice in traditional Kerala homes. Seeing this small hut, one wondered where all the family members slept.

Hearing people entering her house, the middle-aged lady, who was standing in front of the altar, woke up from her prayerful mood. When She saw the Mother with a big smile on Her face standing in front of her, the lady's pent-up emotions gave way. Tears streamed down her face as she fell at the Mother's Feet. All her children came out of the kitchen and prostrated. Mother lifted Pushpavati Amma from the floor where she was still lying in prostration, shedding copious tears at the Mother's feet. She rose to her knees, but continued to cry, as she embraced the Mother's waist. Most compassionately, Mother stroked her and kissed her on the cheek. Then Mother hugged and kissed each of the daughters, who were also crying. Sobbing like a child, Pushpavati Amma said through her tears, "It has been such a long time since You've visited our house. When I woke up this morning, I felt so sad. I even said to my children that You must have forgotten us. When You walked through the door, I was praying, 'O Amma, if only You would come, then I would be happy.' I prayed and prayed and now You have come." Again she was caught up with emotion.

Amma turned to the brahmacharins and explained, "Previously, Mother used to visit here frequently, but that was before there were so many people at the Ashram. Now Mother's *prarabdha* (usually meaning

‘past actions which are bearing fruit in the present’, but here the term is used to mean ‘responsibilities or burdens’) has also increased.

Turning back to the woman, Mother told her, “Just as you have responsibilities to take care of, Mother also has the burden of so many children who have renounced everything and surrendered their lives to Her. What can one do? Years ago, before these children came, Mother had more time to spend with you. But now Her time is slowly being divided among so many other matters. Anyhow, Mother has come when you really had the longing, hasn’t She? The fact is, Mother was going to remain in Her room today, but suddenly She felt like coming here. Without even mentioning one word to Gayatri, Mother just walked down the stairs. Maybe it was your innocent desire that brought Mother here.”

Mother went on, “You say that you wanted Mother to visit your house, but you never told Her. Even though you always come to the *Bhava Darshan*, you never said anything to Mother.” Since Mother had sat down on the floor, one of the daughters brought a mat and requested Her to sit on it. Mother lovingly refused it, “No, daughter. This is fine.” Then She continued as before, “How am I supposed to know your desire if you do not tell me?”

The woman smiled and said in an innocent way, “O *Kalli Amme* (O Mother, You little Thief)! Why do You play tricks on us? You know everything. That is why You come here even without my verbal request. I

always wanted to tell You but I simply couldn't say anything whenever I came near You. Anyhow, You heard my prayers. You saw my anguish and pain, didn't You? I know that You know everything, and I had faith that You would hear my prayers."

Mother laughed and rejoiced at Pushpavati Amma's innocent remark. She turned around and told the brahmacharins, "Look at her innocence. Learn to be innocent like this." With these words the brahmacharins now thought they understood why Mother had allowed them to come along. It seemed to them that She wanted them to witness this incident, and they learned an important lesson. She further advised the brahmacharins, "Do not drown your innocence in the letters of the scriptures."

One of the daughters brought some *puttu* and *katala** to Mother and Her party. She served tea for the Mother and *palum vellam* (hot milk diluted with water) for the others. Mother drank the tea and ate a little of the food as She told the brahmacharins to drink their milk. The Mother fed each of the family members with Her own hands and then a little was given to each of the those who came with Her. She said, "It is too early for them have this heavy breakfast. Mol (daughter), pack it up. They will eat it later, after their meditation."

Mother now went into the kitchen and looked around a little. She sat down near the fire on which an iron cylinder of *puttu* was being cooked in a pitcher of water. Mother removed the tube from the pitcher and

tested it to see whether it was done. Seeing that it was still raw, She put the tube back on top of the pitcher, and not wasting an opportunity to dispense a bit of spiritual wisdom, the Mother gave this analogy, “The pitcher is the body, and the water in the pitcher is the mind. The fire is *tapas*. The fire boils the water and steam is produced. The steam cooks the raw mixture of rice flour and coconut into a delicious food, *puttu*. People can appease their hunger by eating this good food. Similarly, we are raw and uncooked now. We are a bunch of useless things called the body, mind and intellect. Yet we carry them around with great pride. We are full of selfishness and egotism. These raw, useless faculties should be cooked in the heat of *tapas* to transform them into something useful. For this to happen the water of the mind, the ego and thoughts, should disappear in the intense heat of *tapas*. *Tapas* makes the mind subtler and subtler, pure and more expansive. And thus you become a good and useful person for the world. When you can love and serve humanity, you become food for the world.”

After it was cooked, She removed the *puttu* from the tube. While refilling the cylinder with the mixture of rice flour and coconut, She further elaborated on this same theme: “Look, now we are like this, raw like this rice flour. Uncooked, nobody can eat it, for it will cause stomach problems. Not only is it useless, it is harmful. This is how we are now.” She held up and displayed the tube as She continued: “We should en-

ter into this dark prison-like tube of *tapas* to get cooked and thereby become freed so that we can be of some use to others. One may feel that the period of spiritual practice is a period full of strict rules and regulations, a period of control. We may feel that *tapas* and renunciation imprison us, that they make us lose all freedom. But know that this prison-like feeling is temporary and that it will soon take you to eternal freedom. Just like the *puttu*, we become food for the world once we are cooked in the fire of *tapas*.

“A real *tapasvi* (one engaged in austere spiritual practices) lives for the world. He remains in his body only for the world. He sacrifices himself for the good of the world. He becomes the inner food for those who approach him, seeking to quench their inner thirst and to appease their inner hunger. He is the food for those who thirst for the Truth. Sri Krishna became food for the world. Jesus and Buddha also willingly served as food for the world. But to become this food, one should cook oneself in the fire of *tapas*. The Gopis of Brindavan cooked themselves in the fire of their love for Sri Krishna. One may think that they did not perform any severe penance, like sitting long hours absorbed in meditation, fasting or torturing the body. But through their intense love for the “Butter Thief” who also stole their hearts, they too, were doing *tapas*. This is what is meant by His stealing butter from their homes; He was stealing their hearts. The excruciating pain of separation from the beloved makes one extremely heated up. In that heat, the ego melts

away and finally there is union. In this state of union, a cooling down takes place, and one becomes totally peaceful and full of bliss.”

The Holy Mother returned the tube of *puttu* to the pitcher on the open fire pit and got up. Everyone relaxed. While listening to Her words, they had been transfixed. A simple, everyday household job of making a breakfast food had just been the subject for a most profound spiritual talk. Who could have drawn out such great spiritual principles hidden in simple cooking? Pushpavati Amma remarked, “There is nothing that Ammachi does not know.”

Although she was an ordinary-looking village woman, Pushpavati Amma was quite familiar with spiritual principles. Her husband, also a devotee of the Holy Mother, was highly respected and loved by everyone in the village as an outstanding *Bhagavata* reader.*

The *Lalita Sahasranama* glorifies the Divine Mother as *tattvartha svarupini*, meaning ‘the embodiment of all spiritual principles and their meaning.’ Such incidents and occasions make one feel that the Mother is the personification of all Vedic dictums and wisdom.

Before leaving their house, the Mother performed a short *puja* at the family altar. On the way back to the Ashram, the Mother spoke more about this family. “Pushpavati Amma is a pious lady. During the days when Mother was ill-treated by Her elder brother, she

used to take Mother to her house. Mother would sit in her front yard and cry, praying to the Divine Mother. Sometimes Mother would get so absorbed in meditation that She would not come out of it for many, many hours. Pushpavati Amma revealed that she used to get very worried and frightened on such occasions, thinking that Devi would take Ammachi's body away. She used to cry and pray to the Divine Mother, requesting Her not to take Ammachi away. She is very innocent. Most of these villagers have innocent faith; but they have no spiritual understanding. They believe God is different from man and that man cannot become God. If they had spiritual understanding in addition to their innocent faith, it would be very easy for them to progress."

Upon reaching the Ashram, the Mother at once told the two brahmacharins to go and meditate, since it was past their regular meditation time. On the way to Her room, She peeked into the hall through a window and, seeing that all Her children were there, She climbed the stairs to Her room.

HOUSEHOLDERS AND SPIRITUAL LIFE

By ten o'clock quite a few people had already come to see the Holy Mother. They were waiting, some in the *darshan* hut and some on the temple verandah. The Mother came to the *darshan* hut in an

*Vedic ritual followed by the distribution of wealth, both to the brahmins and to the poor and needy.

hour's time as the devotees were singing...
Amritanandamayi...

*To Mata Amritanandamayi, Immortal Goddess
Salutations again and again.
May You rise like the dawn in my inner mind,
O Mata Amritanandamayi!*

*O Mother, I know not how to sing
Your sinless praises.
O Pure One, Your holy words
Are nectar to Your children
As the cooling clouds are to life.*

*O Detached One, Bestower of destiny,
Universal Enchantress, continue Your dance,
O Ambrosial One, by the radiance
Of Your gentle smile
My heart is overflowing with sweet nectar.*

As an expression of their love and reverence for Her, the devotees all stood when She entered the hut. Utterly humble, the Mother prostrated as She always did, and everybody prostrated in deference to Her example. The singing continued as She sat on the cot, where She remained throughout the *darshan*. Before receiving the waiting devotees, She called the little children who came to Her one by one. In their innocent attraction to Her, some of the young children did not want to leave the Mother's lap, so the Mother had them sit beside Her on the cot. But often they did not

want to move away from there either, and finally their mother or father had to carry them away.

When each of the children had been seen, the devotees went for *darshan*. As this proceeded, a male devotee asked a question about how a householder should live in the world and still maintain a spiritual life.

The Mother gave him this reply: “A householder who wishes to lead a spiritual life after completing his responsibilities in the world should exercise renunciation from the very beginning, because it won’t come easily. Renunciation demands constant and long-term practice. He may not be able to relinquish everything externally; therefore, he should try to be detached from within. His mind should not get too involved in things. In order to keep this spirit of inner detachment, *lakshya bodha* is very important. Whatever happens in the home or outside, one should always contemplate and pray in this manner: ‘My goal is far beyond all these silly and trivial worldly problems. O Lord, please do not push me into these conflicts and arguments. Give me the strength and courage to be in the midst of these problems and still remember You and remain detached. Let me try to work through them as part of my duty, but let me be untouched by their vibrations.’

“A good householder should be a *sannyasin* internally. Mother does not say that a man should run away from his duties. No, he shouldn’t. He should perform his duties as best he can. It is not good to

run away from life. That is cowardice. A person who runs away from life is not fit to be a spiritual seeker. That is why Krishna did not let Arjuna run away from the battlefield. Life is a battle. It is not something to be avoided. Furthermore, you cannot avoid it. What will you do to avoid it? You may run to the Himalayas, or to a forest, or to an Ashram in order to escape from life. But life will follow you there as well. Just as you cannot run away from death, you cannot run away from life. Wherever you go, death follows. Wherever you go, life also follows. You cannot avoid either; you can only transcend them. Therefore, an intelligent person does not try to escape from life, but lives it sensibly, giving proper attention to his affairs.

“The intelligent way of living life is to have a good foundation in spirituality. Children, do not try to run away from your duties. If you are a householder, perform your duties properly, but try to be detached as much as possible, so that you can prepare yourself for total renunciation. If you are a spiritual seeker or a *sannyasin*, you are still living in the world, aren’t you? Therefore, you have certain duties towards society. Of course, nothing binds a true *sannyasin*. But since most people are not *sannyasins*, they should play their part well in the world. Do some good and beneficial things for society, but try to be detached. As a person who leads a spiritual life while leading a family life, prepare yourself for the final letting go.”

“Amma, how is this possible?” asked the same devotee.

The Mother continued to explain, “Whether one is a *grihasthasrami* or a *sannyasin*, renunciation is the means to the end. Internally, a householder should be a *sannyasin*. Externally he should be active, performing his duties neatly and well. Externally he has desires and needs to fulfill. He may need acquisitions and possessions, but at the same time he should prepare himself to drop everything at any time. A *sannyasin* who lives in the world should also be like this. He should be dynamic in his actions, but untouched and totally detached within. That is the secret.

“A *sannyasin* is one who has dedicated his entire life, both external and internal, for others, for the good of the world. Whereas, a real *grihasthasrami* is one who still leads a family life externally, but a *sannyasin*’s life internally.

“In order to set an example, a *sannyasin* also should perform actions while living in the world. He should not sit idle saying, ‘I have attained the state of actionlessness, therefore I don’t have to do any work.’ This will set the wrong example that others will follow. Even after attaining the state of perfection, a true *sannyasin* who lives in this world of pluralities will be very dynamic, active and creative on the outside. But he will be totally silent within.

“Once a *sannyasin* was traveling in a train. Many other passengers were in the compartment with him, and everybody had several pieces of luggage with them. Noticing that the *sannyasin* had by his side a cloth bag stuffed with things, one of the passengers

observed, 'We are worldly people. We have many possessions. But you, too, have a bag full of things. Is there any difference between you and me, other than the color of our clothes?' The *sannyasin* smiled and kept quiet. A few minutes later, the train was crossing a bridge over a river. All of a sudden, with a beaming smile on his face, the *sannyasin* took the cloth bag and a few other things he had with him and threw all of them out the window into the river below. With the same expression on his face, the *sannyasin* turned towards the passenger and asked, 'Dear brother, can you do that?' The passenger exclaimed, 'What! What are you saying? All our valuables are in our bags. How can we throw them away?' The *sannyasin* smiled and replied, 'I, too, had my so-called valuables in that bundle, but I could easily renounce them without any feeling of pain or attachment. Whereas, you cannot do this since you are attached to your things. That is the difference between us.' Realizing his impertinence, the passenger hung his head and kept silent.

"Children, a real *sannyasin* is like this. He is totally dispassionate. Even the things that he may seem to possess cannot bind him. He is free, eternally free and untainted. Such a being can easily renounce all things.

"A householder, on the other hand, may not be able to renounce things so easily, but he should try to quiet his mind. A householder's mind tends to be noisy with all the problems which disturb him from every direction. He is always worried about his personal problems, his wife's complaints, his children's

needs, social demands, and so on. He cannot keep quiet. Both internally and externally he will be running around, wandering to and fro, talking and discussing, calculating and solving, disputing and fighting, and finally collapsing again and again. Mother knows that it is very difficult to overcome these problems which make thunderous noises both in your head and in your minds. But it is not impossible to learn to obtain silence within. Most of our ancient masters were householders. They could do it. They were also human beings. So if they did it, we can do it. If they had the power to do it, we also have the power. To give an example of how a real householder should be, Mother will tell you a story.”

The Mother proceeded to tell the story about the golden mongoose, one of the tales from the *Mahabharata*: The eldest Pandava, Yudhishthira, who was the king of the city of Hastinapura, once performed a great *yagña*.^{*} This *yagña* was praised by all as he distributed rich presents to the lame, the blind and the poor as well as to the priests and learned men. Food was served and distributed in abundance to all.

While the ceremonial rituals and distribution of gifts were in progress, amidst the cheering praises in glorification of the great King Yudhishthira, a mongoose appeared on the scene and began rolling on the very spot where the ceremony was being conducted. This was a strange mongoose, for half of his body was golden in color. The mongoose rolled and rolled

around for a while. Finally it stopped. Looking at the assembly of learned men, the mongoose said, "This sacrifice, O learned ones, is not as great as that of the brahmin family." The learned men reacted, "How dare you try to belittle this great sacrifice which is being performed exactly as prescribed by the scriptures! We are all well-versed in the ancient scriptures, and we are sure that these ceremonies are being performed exactly as prescribed. Yet as you have apparently found something amiss, we would like to know what wisdom you have to share. Please tell us about the greater sacrifice that you seem to have witnessed."

The mongoose then narrated his story. "In Kurukshetra there once lived a brahmin family. The family consisted of four members—the brahmin, his wife, their son and daughter-in-law. They led a simple and austere life. Even in the best of times, the brahmin ate only one meal a day, and that consisted of only a few grains of corn. But a time came when a great famine descended upon the land. No crops could grow and even the weeds dried up. At last the family could not find anything to eat, and the entire household went hungry for several days. Then one morning the brahmin found some barley. His wife and daughter-in-law pounded the barley and divided it into four equal portions. They were about to eat when suddenly a guest arrived.

"Even in this time of hardship, the brahmin welcomed the guest with all humility and love. He offered water for the guest to wash his feet and brought a seat

for him to sit on. After inviting the guest to partake of some food, the brahmin went into the kitchen and returned with his portion of the barley. Offering the simple food to the guest, the brahmin said, 'Sir, forgive me, this is all I can offer to you.' The guest gulped it down and wanted more. The brahmin felt very troubled, thinking that he would have to do the unthinkable thing of sending his guest away hungry. But the wife happily offered her portion of food. The guest ate that and still he wanted more.

"The brahmin did not feel any impatience or anger towards the guest, but again he was worried that he would have to send the guest away hungry. Then the brahmin's son came forth offering his portion of the food. Again, after that was eaten, the guest looked at the brahmin with a dissatisfied look of hunger on his face. The brahmin once again wondered how he could please his guest. This time, the daughter-in-law persuaded him to give away her share too. The brahmin graciously offered that to the guest, saying, 'Here, sir, please have some more.'

"But this time the guest's response was different. 'No, that is enough,' he said. 'You have passed the test. I am very pleased with all of you. You were prepared to sacrifice everything, even your lives, in order to fulfill your *dharma* (right action, righteousness). Hunger deprives a person of all righteous thoughts and actions. But your renunciation and steadfastness have impressed even the *devas* (demi-gods). One who conquers hunger has won an abode in heaven. Now

all of you come with me to the abode of the immortals.’

“Thereupon, the guest revealed his true form to the brahmin family. A *deva* stood shining before them, and with a golden chariot, he took the brahmin and his family to heaven. I was witness to all these events. Soon after the *deva* took the brahmin family up to heaven, I went over to the spot where the brahmin had been standing while serving the guest. A few grains of barley flour were scattered on the floor. I rolled over it. To my amazement one half of my body turned golden! Since then I have been visiting every place where a sacrifice has been performed in order to see if, by rolling over the sacrificial ground, the other half of my body will also turn gold. But all my attempts have ended up in failure. No sacrifice has equaled that of the brahmin. Great indeed was the brahmin’s sacrifice.”

After Mother had finished telling the story, She spoke about how its meaning could be applied to spiritual life: “Children, a *grihasthasrami* should be like this brahmin family. In both the story about the *sannyasin* who threw away his bag and the story about the brahmin family, there is one thing in common. It is renunciation.

“This potential is in everyone. It may be in seed form, but it is in everyone. If you keep the seed in your pocket, it will not sprout. The seedling will not germinate by itself. You need to sow it, fence it in to

guard it from stray animals, protect it from too much sun and too much rain, apply fertilizer at the proper time, remove the weeds, water it appropriately, and thus care for it well. It will then grow into a tree, a huge, shade-giving fruit tree. It will yield an abundance of blossoms and fruit. This kind of effort is needed to attain the goal. The saints and sages did *tapas*, and thus they attained the goal. We should also try to attain the goal with steadfastness.

“Sri Krishna was a householder. He had many responsibilities, but He was the embodiment of detachment. Sri Rama was also a householder and in addition to that, a king. He was the embodiment of *dharma*. King Janaka (father of Sita, the holy consort of Lord Sri Rama) was a king and a householder. He, too, was a *jivanmukta* or liberated soul. They all found enough time to do *tapas* and to lead a spiritual life even in the midst of all their court duties and other problems.

“If we say that we have no time due to our problems and family responsibilities, that is simply an escape. That means that we have no desire to follow the path of spirituality. We are lazy and want to avoid work. So immersed in *maya*, so trapped in its net, we do not even realize that there is a reality higher than the body and the external world around us. We have no eyes to see it, no ears to hear it and no heart to feel it.

“If we want to be more honest and sincere with ourselves, it would be better if we were bold enough

to admit, "I'm not interested in spiritual matters," rather than twisting the truth by saying, "I have no time." When we really have the desire to do something, time and the proper conditions will be at our disposal. Time and circumstance follow desire."

Another question about how to conduct one's spiritual life while living in the world was asked: "Amma, suppose somebody is a businessman, and he is spiritual as well. His Guru is in town, but he has some business crisis and cannot leave his work. What should he do when such a challenge arises, when he has to choose between his Guru and his business?"

"Son," the Mother replied, "you said the businessman is spiritual. Has he surrendered everything to his Guru? This is the question to be asked. There are businessmen who want to give up their business and take up spiritual life; however, the Guru may ask them to continue the work as a *sadhana*. If this is the case, the man should remain at his office and attend to his work and not leave if there is a crisis. If the Guru has asked him to continue to work in his business, it is no longer his own work but the Guru's work. So if he chooses to leave at a time of crisis in order to go see the Guru, that is not right. His business is in service to the Guru; therefore, he must remain and settle the problems as part of his *sadhana*. That is what the Guru wants him to do. Such a person should constantly remember his Guru while he is doing his work. His mind should revolve around the Guru at all times.

“However, when the intensity of one’s concentration on and love for the Guru is so strong that he is totally absorbed in that alone, then he cannot continue to do any external job. External work spontaneously falls away just as a ripe fruit falls off a tree. All this depends on the amount of surrender one has. There are people who leave their work to go see the Guru even if there are problems that need to be settled. In such cases, faith will protect them. But remember that this faith should be a pure and taintless faith without even one iota of doubt. Doubt will spoil its intensity and interfere with faith. It will create an obstruction to the flow of the Guru’s grace. If you have faith, you can leave everything in the hands of the Guru, whatever the situation may be. You can go see him or anyone at any place, for the Guru’s hands will be there to protect you. That faith arises when you no longer have any doubt about the omniscience, omnipotence and all-pervasive nature of the Guru.

“How many people have this kind of unshakable faith? Sometimes a certain amount of faith comes even to ordinary people, to people who have not given up all their attachments. But this will not last long, for it arises in a particular situation and disappears after some time. They will not be able to sustain this faith. Yet while it lasts, this faith will prompt them to act without fear, so they will be benefitted by it.

“Then there are the kinds of people who will give their own reasons on whether to go see the Guru or not. They are in between the two categories already

mentioned. They do not have complete faith and have not surrendered fully to the Guru. These people stick to their work due to over-attachment, but the reason they give will be something else, they will try to give a more 'noble' reason. They may have reverence for the Master, but their faith in him is not very strong; it is divided. They stick to their work because of excessive attachment and lack of spiritual aspiration.

"There are also those who leave their work because they are incapable of dealing with problems that arise. They do not have the strength or courage to confront problems. In the name of wanting to be with the Guru they escape from their work, but they do not really go to be with the Guru. They may go to see the Guru, but it is only to run away from the problems at work. They will not gain anything. Even while sitting in the physical presence of the master, they will be brooding over something else. Such people have weak wills and are unstable. They neither lead a healthy life in the world nor a good spiritual life.

"Some people are attached to the Guru's form, which is very good, especially in the beginning. Attachment to the Guru will help make the roots of spirituality go deeper. Such people may lose their power of discrimination when they hear that the Guru is in town. They will become over-excited. In this excitement, there is the possibility of doing things with lack of discretion or of neglecting responsibilities. If they can't help but go to the Guru, then they should entrust their work and responsibilities to a capable

and trustworthy person who can handle them. Such people should at least have enough discrimination to choose a substitute for themselves.”

Darshan continued. The brahmacharins sang...
Arikil Undenkilum...

*O Mother, even though You are near,
I wander about, unable to know You.
Even though I have eyes,
I search, unable to see You.*

*Are You the beautiful moon
That blooms forth in the blue winter night?
Unable to reach the sky, I am a wave
That beats its head against the shore.*

*As I come to understand the truth
That all worldly comforts are worthless,
I long to know You,
As I shed tears day and night.*

ONENESS WITH GOD THROUGH LOVE

“How does love for God culminate in Oneness?” a devotee asked the Mother.

She answered, “Son, as the mind becomes more and more one-pointed through spiritual practices, thought waves gradually decrease. And the mind, along with the thoughts, disappear and dissolve into the total mind. Our mind is nothing but a part of the

universal mind, the cosmic mind. Thoughts are like a wall which stands between our own minds and the one cosmic mind. It is like two rooms separated by a wall. Demolish and remove the wall, and the rooms become one.

“In pure innocent love there is no wall. The wall of thoughts disappears. The lover’s mind becomes one with the beloved’s. In selfless love the lover forgets everything. Past and future drop away and love alone remains. There are no motives behind this love, except the desire to become one with the beloved. Remembrance of God becomes constant. The constant and one-pointed remembrance of one’s beloved makes one forget all about the world.

“When Krishna left Brindavan, the Gopis became mad with love for Him. They thought that He would return, but He did not. Remembering Krishna and His Divine Music, the Gopis became oblivious to the external world. Slowly it disappeared from their sight. In their perception everything turned into Krishna. Whatever they saw was Krishna’s enchanting form. Whatever they heard was the melodious music of His flute. They did not see cows as cows, but as their Beloved. They did not see their husband or friends, but instead, they beheld Krishna’s form. The blowing of the wind and the trickling of the water in the river sounded to them like the Divine Music of His flute. Love rose to its supreme heights, and they became truly mad with Love.

“Once a Gopi saw two deep footprints under a

flowering tree. She immediately thought, 'These must be His, my beloved Krishna's Feet.' She continued to imagine, 'Why are the footprints so deep? I know! Some lucky Gopi was with Him. She must have asked for some flowers from this tree. Since the branches were too high for her to reach, Krishna carried her on His shoulders in order for her to reach the flowers. And that is why the footprints are so deep. Oh, how fortunate that Gopi is! She is the luckiest among women to have been carried by Krishna.'

"Such was the condition of the Gopis. Whatever they saw, they somehow related it to Krishna. Their burning love for Him was so great that their individuality disappeared. Their minds were consumed by this burning love. The inhalation and exhalation of their breaths, the throbbing of their hearts and the pulsation of their blood—everything moved with the thought of Krishna. The all-consuming flames of love destroyed the world of thoughts, the world of diversity. There were no more thoughts; only Krishna. They forgot to eat or sleep. They forgot everything, as they became totally identified with their beloved Lord. Mad with love, the Gopis used to say to one another, 'Dear friend, look at me. I am Krishna. Look at the peacock feather which adorns my head. Look at the way I walk. Look at my hands and the flute I am holding. Look at my dark blue complexion.' Thus the Gopis, intoxicated with love, forgot themselves and merged into Krishna.

"In this merging with the beloved deity the small

'I' disappears, for the mind stops functioning. Through constant remembrance of the Beloved you become Him. He becomes your food and you eat Him. Now the food that we all take in is a variety of objects. Through the sense organs we partake of pleasurable objects—seeing desirable things with the eyes, hearing nice sounds or flattering words with the ears, smelling exotic fragrances with the nose, tasting delicious food with the tongue in the mouth, and touching and being touched or caressed, which is felt by the skin. All of these are a form of eating, eating which makes one's ego puffed up. But this kind of eating, this partaking of sense pleasures, stops when you eat your Beloved. Then, the feeding of the mind with sense pleasures gushing in through the sense organs automatically stops. A constant process of spiritual purification takes place within you via another simultaneous process of giving up what you claim as 'I' and 'mine.' Those pleasurable objects cease being separate objects when you eat your Krishna, Rama, Devi, Jesus or Buddha. When you stop partaking of sense pleasures but start eating Him through those objects, diversity ends. Your Beloved becomes your food; no matter what you partake, it is your Beloved, and thus you become One with Him. Only Oneness exists.

"Only when you are not so attached to the world will it be possible to remember God. Holding onto the world will obstruct the remembrance of God. But once you become established in this remembrance, you will see and think of everything as God. Life in

the world cannot be an obstacle once God is enshrined in your heart. So bind Him with the rope of love. If you forget all about yourself, then all that you see, smell, taste, and touch will be Him. Thus you become one with Him. Your little world of ego disappears and you become the Pure Self.

“Children, do you know the story of Vidura’s wife? Vidura was the brother of the blind King Dhritharasthra and served as the prime minister in his court. Lord Krishna was going to visit Vidura’s house, so they made all the preparations to receive Him. Vidura’s wife was, of course, very excited. She made all the arrangements necessary for an elaborate welcoming ceremony, and when everything was ready, she went to take a bath. Being unpredictable, Krishna arrived earlier than expected, and Vidura’s wife was informed.

“Hearing that Her Lord had arrived, she forgot everything; she could only think of Krishna. Her mind became completely absorbed in Her Lord. In that divinely intoxicated mood, she took a banana, peeled it and threw away the fruit, feeding Krishna with the peel. Forgetting herself and becoming totally oblivious to the circumstances, she did this again and again. The Lord, however, relished the peels with great joy and happiness.

“Love makes one forget all things. Our selfless, innocent love is the greatest offering that we can give to the Lord. It is the most delicious food for God. This story reveals the essence of pure love. Pure love makes

one forget everything, even one's physical existence. That forgetting about oneself culminates in Oneness. The little 'I' disappears as you become identified with the Beloved. Pure love is Oneness."

The Mother stopped talking and continued giving *darshan* to people. The residents sang a *bhajan*...*Adi Parashakti*...

*O Primal Supreme Power,
Please bless us, rid us of distress.*

*O Goddess with eighteen arms,
Mounted on a lion,
Thine eyes are worshipped by lotus petals,
O Thou Who hast a gentle smile.*

*O Goddess of the Universe,
Dance in my heart always;
Granting me all boons,
Please consider this supplicant with kindness.*

As they sang the concluding verses of the song, Mother was transported to another world. She closed Her eyes and sat still. Her hands showed two different divine *mudras*. The chanting reached its heights with everybody singing, and the *darshan* hut reverberated with..."Om Shakti, Om Shakti, Om Shakti, Om..."

The Mother slowly came down to the normal plane of consciousness. The song gradually subsided, then there was silence. She resumed receiving people

as there were only a few more who had not been blessed by Her. Mother blessed the last person, and getting up from the cot, She prostrated on the floor as is Her usual manner to set an example for us, and proceeded to walk out of the hut. She continued walking to the edge of the backwaters where She spent a little time before returning to Her room. Having relished the Mother's spiritual food, the devotees now went to the dining hall to have their lunch.

CHAPTER 9

YOUNG MAN FROM RISHIKESH

2 May 1984

Soon after the morning meditation one of the brahmacharins noticed a young man sitting in front of the temple. He had a long beard and long hair, and there was a calm, quiet manner about him. The brahmacharin was very impressed by the young man's meditative posture and serene look. After the usual breakfast of rice gruel, served to residents and visitors alike, the brahmacharin once again came to the temple verandah to see if the young man had stirred from his meditation, but he found him still deeply absorbed. Half an hour passed, and the young man was still sitting on the verandah, but his eyes were open now. The brahmacharin asked him, "Have you had your breakfast? If not, please come and have some." Very politely he answered, "No, I have not, but I do not want to eat before I see Amma."

Sitting down next to him, the brahmacharin in-

quired, "Where do you come from and how did you come to know about Amma?"

The young man revealed that he was from Rishikesh and proceeded to share his experience of how he came to know about the Mother. "I am also a *sadhak*. By God's grace I have been on the spiritual path for the last fifteen years. I live in an ashram in Rishikesh with the Ganges River only a few yards away. Every day I spend some time on the banks of the river, chanting my mantra and meditating.

"Of course, this holy river is most conducive for meditation, but recently I began to have problems in concentration due to some mental agitation. Two weeks ago while trying to meditate, I heard someone calling my name, not only once, but several times. I did not open my eyes, thinking it was only my imagination. So I continued to sit with my eyes closed and tried to concentrate on the flowing sound of the Ganges. Again came the voice calling me. It was a female voice, calling me again and again. The sound was so clear that I had no doubt that someone was calling me, so I opened my eyes. I looked all around, and as I was doing this, the voice came again, "Here, look here." The voice seemed as if it was coming from the Ganges Herself. I sat gazing at the water and as I held my gaze, a form slowly began to take shape on the waters.

"This form became clearer and clearer, revealing itself as a woman in pure white clothes. Around Her stood many saintly-looking people who clearly showed

great reverence and devotion to Her. Rubbing my eyes, I looked again and again. It was not a dream. It was a reality. My eyes were wide open. I could see this woman and all those who were standing around Her, but I could recognize none of them. A divine aura surrounded Her, and I could not take my eyes off Her.

“Radiating peace and bliss, She smiled graciously at me. Slowly I became totally unaware of the external world. The saintly-looking people who were around Her also disappeared. All that existed was the lady in white and myself. Time and space did not exist. I was all alone in Her presence. Gradually She grew bigger and bigger. She became as big as the universe, and there was nothing but Her. A strong effulgence emanated from Her whole being, and I was totally enveloped in that light. Then all of a sudden, the form disappeared and there was only pure light filling the entire universe. And then, in a split-second of a moment the light suddenly became a pin-point. That is all I could remember. I was aroused to normal awareness hearing a constant ringing in my ears. It was the same voice, “Come to Me. Come to Me. Come to Me.”

“Gradually regaining my ordinary consciousness, I looked around. I was stunned to see that it was already dark. I looked at my watch which registered 8:30 p.m. Since I had begun sitting for meditation that afternoon at around five o’clock, this meant that nearly three and a half hours had passed. The flowing sound of the Ganges filled the air. Everything else was silent.

“I returned to the ashram. The residents wanted to know where I had been all that time since it was not my normal routine to spend such long hours outside of the ashram. My daily visit to the Ganges was usually around an hour, never more than an hour and a quarter. From the look on my face and my sudden indrawn manner, the residents suspected that something had happened to me. But I kept quiet. I did not feel like talking. The experience was so overwhelming and full. I could not sleep that night. I was haunted by the vision of that form which had appeared in front of me, and my heart and soul were totally immersed in it.

“That day marked a great transformation in my life. The next morning found me a completely changed person. The fellow ashram residents noticed this change in me and were very inquisitive, asking questions of me constantly. But my thoughts always revelled in that enchanting form of the lady whom I saw in the vision, and my heart continued to overflow with the bliss of that experience. It is not that I wanted to avoid the others, but I remained unable to speak.

“Finally the news of my behavior reached the ears of one swami who also lived in the ashram. He was a *sadhak* himself and a good soul. Summoning me, he lovingly inquired about the reason for the change in me, and for some reason, I felt that I wanted to disclose everything about the experience to him. I related it all to him, and I also told him that my mind was now completely absorbed in the vision of that form. I

asked whether he knew anything about this lady in white. I could easily give him a description of Her since the vision was so clear. He listened to me carefully and told me that he would try to discover who She was.

“Days went by and my longing became more and more intense. I was like one gone mad. I was unable to sleep and I gave up eating. After a few days, the swami called me to see him again. He had a big smile on his face, and without any introductory remarks, he pulled out a picture from his pocket and asked if this was the lady whom I had seen. I jumped up and danced with joy because that was a picture of Her! He gave it to me and told me who She was and where Her ashram was located. He also revealed that while he had listened to me relate my experience to him, he had felt tremendous inner peace and a strong feeling that this must be a Great Soul. This caused him to immediately begin inquiring about Her, and finally he met another swami living in Rishikesh who was from Kerala. From this swami he learned about Amma.”

The young man showed the picture to the brahmacharin. Full of emotion and his eyes swelling with tears, he asked, “Will I be able to see Amma today?”

The brahmacharin assured him that he would certainly be able to see the Mother, telling him that She is always available for Her children. Again he invited the young man to have some food.

He replied, “My brother, I have not been eating

for many days now. I do not feel like eating. I am not hungry. Anyhow, let me see Amma first. If She asks me to eat I will do so. Until then, please do not insist that I take any food."

The brahmacharin was about to leave when he saw the Mother coming down the stairs. "Here comes Amma," he said in a soft voice.

The young man jumped up and looked around. Just as a hornbill bird waiting for water runs to catch falling raindrops, he ran towards the Mother and fell into full prostration at Her Feet. The Mother lovingly lifted him up, and holding his hands, She brought him back to the verandah of the temple. He sobbed like a little child, while She expressed tremendous love and compassion to him by patting his back and rubbing his chest. Wiping his tears, She laid his head on Her shoulder and consoled him, "My son, why do you cry now? You have come to your Mother, haven't you? Son, don't cry. Mother is here for you." These sweet and loving words soothed him and gradually he could somewhat control his emotions.

In a short while he calmed down and the Mother proceeded to reveal to him something only he could understand, "Son, Mother did not want you to jump into that 'other thing' which disturbed your mind. Do you understand 'the other thing'?"

The young man looked at the Mother's face in astonishment and nodded his head, saying softly, "Yes, Amma, I understand."

The Mother continued, "Mother wanted to

sharpen your *vairagya* (detachment) and determination. She also thought that such an experience would help you to deepen your faith and devotion, and thus to give up that idea totally. Son, your fate would be totally different if you had not received that vision. Sincere *sadhaks* should not stray from their path, no matter where they might be in this world. Mother knows that you are very sincere in your spiritual practice and She did not want you to go astray. That experience you had was to awaken devotion in you. It was to intensify your longing. Mother repeats, a sincere *sadhak* should not go astray. Son, do you understand what Mother is saying?”

The young man gazed at the Mother’s face in amazement. He couldn’t speak and therefore nodded his head in affirmation. While the others who were present wondered what this ‘other thing’ was, the young man once again wept like an innocent child.

Through tears he said, “Now it is very clear to me that it was you who appeared before me. You came to save me from a pitfall. Amma, now I know why you bestowed such a wonderful vision on me. You wanted to change my mind. You wanted to create a transformation in my life. Yes, Amma, you are right. If I had not had this vision, I would not have changed my decision. Amma, you have protected me; you have kept me from wasting my life, from getting entangled in *maya*. Amma, Amma, you have revealed everything to me.”

None of the residents witnessing this scene understood the meaning of the Mother's words and were curious to know about what Amma had said. But before leaving the Ashram, the young man spoke to the brahmacharin whom he had first met. "I did not want to tell this part of my story before having Amma's *darshan*. Now, however, I feel that this would be a good lesson for all sincere seekers to let them know that the Guru's protection is always with them if their desire to attain the goal is sincere."

The young man related the rest of the story. It involved the conflict that he was having with his family concerning marriage. Although he had two other brothers, as well as two sisters, he was the eldest son, and everybody in the family, parents and siblings alike, were insisting that he marry. Even though he was living in an ashram, having dedicated his life to *brahmacharya* (celibacy) and spirituality, he visited his family regularly. His family was not very keen on his desire to be a monk and continually urged him to marry. They told him about different girls whom he could meet to select a wife.

While he had been quite confident in his determination to lead a spiritual life away from the affairs of the world, his self-confidence began to weaken as his family became more and more insistent. So powerful were their appeals and entreaties that he began to consider that it might not be such a bad idea to lead a spiritual life while simultaneously leading a householder's life. One day upon returning to the

ashram after being amidst the worldly vibrations of his family home, he began to rationalize that even the ancient saints and sages were married and had children. He even began to daydream about different girls whom he might choose as a bride.

At the same time, he was also crying and praying within, begging God to help him and protect him. He realized that he was not able to remain steadfast in his resolve to be a monk since his fantasies and desires kept gnawing at him. They became so overwhelming that he could not even find solace on the banks of the Ganges. So agitated was he and unable to find peace of mind, he was on the verge of committing suicide, thinking of jumping into the river, when the vision of Amma came to him.

He finished his story: "That experience helped reinstall my courage and self-confidence. It gave me such spiritual bliss that I could easily overcome my mental agitation and instability. That is what Amma meant when She said those words to me. She did not want me to get enmeshed in worldly bondage. That is why She gave me such a rare gift that has transformed me completely."

Thus the young man from Rishikesh concluded his story. Taking leave of the brahmacharin, he was full of joy and enthusiasm as he left the Ashram.

THE NATURE OF THE GURU

The Holy Mother was still sitting in front of the temple at 11:30 a.m. Almost all of the residents were

there. One of the brahmacharins asked a question about sincere seekers: "Amma, there are many sincere *sadhaks* in this world, aren't there? But it seems that God or the Guru helps only a few from such dangers."

Amma replied, "Son, first of all, a sincere *sadhak* has no dangers, for he takes everything as God's will. For him everything is *prasad*, both negative and positive. The word 'danger' has no meaning in his life. He is always optimistic, not at all pessimistic. Secondly, how do you know that God helps only a few? This young man is the only one that you have seen. Sincere *sadhaks* will always find a way to overcome difficult situations in life, for they depend on divine grace. God will go in search of them to help them and uplift them.

"Sincere *sadhaks* will undoubtedly receive grace. Mother says this unconditionally out of Her own experience. Sincerity springs forth from the deepest recesses of your heart. It cannot be superficial. Some people are sincere only in words but not in deeds. They will not receive the benevolence of Providence or have divine hands to help them because they are shallow. No sincere *sadhak* will stray from the path; Mother can guarantee this. Somehow or other, he or she will be saved. God or the Guru cannot abandon such *sadhaks*. Just as a brood of little chicks is protected under the wings of the mother hen, sincere *sadhaks* will always be under the care and grace of the Guru or God. No matter where they are, they will al-

ways be under the protective wings of the Supreme Being.

“Mother does not say that the less sincere *sadhaks* will be completely abandoned by the Guru. That will not happen. They will also be taken care of. But just to teach them a lesson, the Guru or God might let them fall, only to save them later.

“Look at that son from Rishikesh. Of course he had desires. But Mother knows how much pain he endured to overcome them. He tried hard; his heart was aching. He really wanted to rid himself of the desires which were interfering with his desire to realize God. He did not sit idle. He prayed and cried to God to show him a way out of his confusion and doubt. Therefore, God had to help him. God must help a true devotee. It is His responsibility to do so. When all are plunged into the quagmire of illusion and desire, a true *sadhak* is the one who tries to emerge from it and know God. He is the one who offers his own life at His feet. He wants to sacrifice his body and mind for his own spiritual evolution and for the upliftment of the world. God is with him or her who is willing to do this. That is why that son had that vision. Children, this is a very good lesson for you.”

Another brahmacharin made this remark: “Who gave him the vision? I don’t think that it was God who gave that vision to him. It was you, Amma. You bestowed that rare blessing on him. He saw your form in the vision, not some god’s.”

“It was the fruit of his prayers,” Amma explained. “That vision was the result of the tears he shed. And it was the outcome of his innocent faith, determination and intense longing.”

She further elaborated on the nature of the Guru, “The Guru is like the sun. He just shines. He cannot be otherwise. He just shines and whoever keeps the doors of his heart open receives the light. God simply is. He has no conditions and no limits. He gives unconditionally. If the door of your heart is closed, He will not come in. He will wait outside, but He will not break in. He is not aggressive because He is love. Love is not aggressive. Love is a constant, uninterrupted and unbreakable flow. Compassion is like a stream, a never-ending stream. It never hurts anyone. Hurting is the nature of human beings. Love never hurts. Compassion never hurts. But we hurt people because we have egos. The ego is happy to see others’ unhappiness. The ego is happy to see others struggling and suffering.

“The Guru is neither an ego nor is He egoless; He is beyond these. Neither the clouds nor the sky, the Guru is beyond them. He simply is. You can see your suffering reflected in the Guru, and you can see your happiness reflected in Him. He, however, is neither happy nor unhappy. He is like a mirror. The ego, on the other hand, cannot reflect anybody’s feelings. An ego is clouded, unclear and dusty. It cannot see anything; it is blind. The ego cannot see others. The ego sees only you, the little you alone.

“The Guru is not an ego. He is the universe. He is everything. He can accommodate anything and everything. You can see His external form but not what’s inside. Internally, He is inaccessible. The Guru is unpredictable. You cannot say that He is like ‘this’ or like ‘that.’ You really can’t even say what an ordinary human being is like, let alone a Guru, who is extraordinary. Yet while He is extraordinary, He is ordinary too. He is both. Don’t try to label or judge Him. And don’t expect Him to be a certain way or to fit into a particular kind of mold. He cannot be stereotyped. He cannot be judged with your limited intellect. Whatever you say about Him will be wrong because the Guru cannot be explained. His being cannot be reduced to words. Again, whatever you may say about Him will also be correct because He is everything. He is night as well as day. He is darkness as well as light.

“Sri Krishna was a great Master. He was a person who enacted all roles. He had hundreds and thousands of masks. People mistook the masks for Him. Whatever they said about Him was wrong, for He was beyond all judgements. The Kauravas made many statements about Him and the Pandavas, too, said many things about Him. But they were all wrong. Those who understood at least a little about Krishna kept quiet, because they knew that whenever they spoke about Him, they missed the mark. Even His own wives could not understand Krishna. His friend and disciple, Arjuna, saw a tiny part of Him, as did Bhishma, Uddhava, and Vidura (devotees of Krishna

in the ancient classics). Others, too, saw Him in a similarly limited way. But still He was far beyond what they could understand. What Arjuna saw was His cosmic form, but he could not experience His formless aspect. Many scholars have tried to explain Krishna. Many are still trying to interpret Krishna and to depict what He is, but these interpretations and depictions do not really reveal anything about Him. Even Vyasa, who wrote about His life in the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, could not explain Krishna fully because all his explanations and descriptions were dependent upon words. Words come from the intellect and from the mind, both of which are limited. But the Guru is far beyond mind and words. Such is the nature of a truly great Master.”

Everyone sat fully absorbed in the Mother’s talk as if he had just received a taste of that nature of the Guru. The Mother’s words were full of authenticity. There was so much power in them. Everyone felt that the Mother was talking about Herself even though She had not referred to Herself specifically. Some of the brahmacharins had the feeling that the Mother was saying to them, “You speak a lot about ‘Me,’ but that is not ‘Me.’ You continue speaking and you always miss the mark, my children. You always miss ‘Me.’”

No one spoke. There was a majestic expression on the Mother’s face clearly displaying spiritual splendor and glory. As She sat in the midst of the residents and

devotees, She appeared to be detached from Her surroundings. She might have been reminded of Her own real nature. Her eyes were fixed on a particular point, but it was difficult to say where. Even though wide open, the Mother's eyes were completely unmoving, not even blinking for five or six minutes... Her spine was erect. It seemed as if She were not even breathing. Her hands were on Her lap with palms up. It took a few more minutes for the Mother to come back from that mood. Uttering Her favorite mantra, "Shiva...Shiva," and whirling Her right hand in the air, She returned to Her usual state.

A brahmacharin requested further clarification: "Amma, You said that the Guru neither has an ego nor is He egoless, that He is neither the clouds nor the sky. We are trying to become egoless, aren't we? So why did you say that the Guru is not without an ego either? In the analogy 'neither the clouds nor the sky,' if the sky is expansiveness, then are You saying that the Guru is not expansive? But our understanding is that expansiveness is the final state. These seem to be contradictions. Amma, will you please explain?"

Amma proceeded with an explanation, "Children, one quality cannot exist without its opposite. When you say, "He is good," the concept of 'bad' is also there. Without bad, good cannot exist. When we say 'dark,' the idea of 'not dark' or light is implied. If there were only darkness or only light, we could not describe either because there would be no contrast.

When we say 'the flower is beautiful,' we definitely have an idea of something being 'not beautiful' or ugly. All the statements that we make are like this. To say 'beautiful,' the opposite must also exist. To say 'good', 'bad,' its opposite, must exist as a concept. Otherwise, there is no comparison. In this world of names and forms, in this world of duality, we can only think and speak in terms of the concept of opposites and contrasts.

"Similarly, when we say the Guru has no ego nor is He egoless, we are indicating that He is beyond the world of duality. There are no words to describe the state in which the Guru is established. When we say 'neither the clouds nor the sky,' these are still words which indicate forms. No matter what words we use, words will always be limiting. This means there is a boundary. We might use the image of the sky as 'expansive,' but this is only relative, that is a cloudless sky as compared to a cloudy sky. But still, the concept of 'sky' indicates a limit. Even to say the Guru is 'egoless' indicates a limit. Any description implies a limit, and where there is a limit, contrast is possible. The opposite must exist.

"To say the word 'expansiveness' also brings an idea of 'non-expansiveness'; whereas, the Supreme State where the Guru dwells is far beyond all comparison and contrast. In reality, it cannot be expressed in words. But for us who are only familiar with names and forms, there is no other way to get an idea about this inexpressible state except through comparisons,

contrasts and analogies. Yet this state of Supreme Oneness is far beyond them all.

“In the Supreme State where the Guru is permanently established, duality does not exist. There are no contrasts and there are no opposites. That Supreme State is beyond limits. You cannot say, ‘This is where it ends.’ It is endless. Now, you might say *maya* or ignorance is the opposite. But *maya* or the world or ignorance is only a projection of the Supreme Reality. It cannot exist without Brahman. Nothing can exist without Brahman, the Absolute. Brahman is totally independent; whereas, the world depends on Brahman for its existence. Brahman alone is. Therefore, in the One, the Whole, all comparisons and contrasts of opposites cease to exist. What we are speaking of is far beyond human comprehension. We cannot say anything about it, for it transcends everything. There is an apparent contradiction, but that contradiction is in your head. Drop the reasoning, and you will see that there is no contradiction at all.”

Another brahmacharin raised this query: “Amma, You said that the Guru never hurts anyone, but You scold us sometimes and we feel hurt.”

Amma explored this question, “Son, you say Mother scolds you, but you do not say why. Does Mother scold you for a little mistake that you have committed just once? No. She points out and corrects for repeated errors, mistakes that are serious impediments to your growth. You may call this scolding. So

if Mother scolds you, it is in order to make you strong. Mother's children should have the strength to confront all difficulties of life no matter where they are. This Ashram is a real *kalari*, a place where warriors train for martial arts with sword and shield. You should become real warriors, really courageous ones.

"Mother only loves you. She has only compassion for you, and She is very patient with you. But that external expression of love, compassion, affection and patience does not always help you grow. You remain selfish. You forget the goal and start acting indiscriminately. You children become jealous and start fighting one another for Mother's love. She has never scolded you. On the contrary, She only tries to remind you about what to do, how to do it and when to do it. Mother only tries to make you be more careful and alert. This comes as an expression of Her love for you.

"Now, about scolding. She will say something when you repeat the same mistakes again and again. She might say something to correct you if She sees you repeatedly doing something which hinders your growth. But She does not scold just for the sake of scolding. If Mother thinks that to say something firmly to you is the only way to make you aware of your goal, then She will say it firmly to create an impression in you. Otherwise, what is the use of living here if you are not going to change your habits and attitudes in order to expand your vision about life? The very purpose of being here will be defeated if you want to remain always the same without growing spiri-

tually.

“Children, do you know how much scolding, how many trials and tribulations Mother had to undergo in the past? Damayanti Amma observed all of Mother’s actions minutely. If there was any little bit of trash left over in the courtyard after it had been swept, she beat Mother. When all the vessels were washed, she scrutinized them, and if there was even a slight trace of dirt, she scolded Mother. While Mother was sweeping the ground, if even a single stick of the broom happened to fall out inadvertently, she would not spare Mother. If one speck of dust or ash happened to fall into the pot while cooking, punishment followed. When Mother plucked grass for the cows, Damayanti Amma watched from a distance to see if Mother indulged in gossip with others. She beat Mother if Mother stood around to talk with someone. Mother did not feel hurt because of the scoldings, not even from the physical beatings, because Mother took all these experiences as the benevolence of Providence. Mother’s mind did not become bitter or resentful; instead Her mind turned inwards.

“Children, the pain that you feel upon being reprimanded for an error is not the fault of the person who scolds you. Pleasure and pain belong to the ego. Your ego is hurt, that is why you feel pain. You want to do something the way you like, but somebody is against it and they tell you. That is why you feel sad or experience pain. You do not think that what you want to do may be wrong. Failing to consider the problems

it might create if you act the way you want to, you do not think of the consequences of your improper conduct. You are not considerate of others and how they might feel as a result of your selfish actions, that you might cause them pain. You think only about your pain. You feel hurt; your ego is hurt.

“Somebody pointed a finger at your ego, and you cannot bear it. You feel hurt because your ego is questioned. Feeling that your self-importance is being diminished, you react negatively because you cannot tolerate it. You cannot see anything but your own little selfish self and the small world created by your ego. If somebody puts a little dent in your tiny little world by trying to correct you, you get angry at him. You abuse him, criticize him and place all the blame on him. You think you are innocent. You think you are trying to be a good boy, clean, pure and flawless. Then you say that the other person hurt you, that he scolded you and that it was all his fault.

“Just what do you think of yourself? Do you think that you are a perfect soul? No, you are not. You are just a limited ego. You can attain perfection, but for that to happen, you need guidance. You need to be corrected. You need to be disciplined. That is what a disciple must undergo. If you do not allow somebody, and this ‘somebody’ means a Guru, to work on you, then it is difficult for you to be transformed.

“The Guru’s scoldings are not to be taken as mere verbal jugglery. They are blessings. When the Guru starts scolding you, that means His grace and compas-

sion have started flowing towards you. He has set His eyes on you. He wants to save you. He wishes to free you eternally. The Guru cannot hurt anyone. The river cannot hurt you; the wind cannot hurt you, and the sun cannot hurt you. They simply are. They are just present. The river cannot change its nature. The wind and the sun cannot change their natures. In a similar manner, the Guru cannot change His nature.

“The Guru sheds light. Just as wind cannot stop blowing, the river cannot stop flowing, or the sun cannot stop shining, the Guru cannot stop being what He is. A person can hurt you because he has an ego. A person, who has an ego, sees you as different from him. He has the feeling of ‘the other.’ His ego and your ego will conflict. But the Guru sees no differences. He is beyond all differences. He does not have the feeling of ‘the other.’ He has no ego, for He is not a person. In fact, there is no person there at all. There is only Consciousness. Consciousness cannot hurt anyone. Whatever comes out of the Guru is for your good. You are the one who perceives it as something that causes pain, and then you complain that it is the Guru’s doing.

“Human beings cultivate fragrant flowers and trample common weeds. They grow beneficial and useful trees and cut down useless ones. Human beings kill wild, ferocious animals and breed gentle, useful ones. They have a whole history of exploitation. Such killing is exploitation. It comes from selfishness; it does not come from love. They cultivate flowers and

fruit trees, but the reason is to exploit them for their own selfish purposes. Fruit is used to appease their hunger and quench their thirst. Flowers are used to decorate their hair, their homes and gardens. If the flowering plants stop blossoming or if the fruit trees stop producing, they cut them down or pull them out and throw them away.

“The same thing happens in their domestication of animals. They need milk to nourish their bodies, so they raise cows. No sooner does the cow stop giving milk, than it becomes beef. If it no longer serves one selfish purpose, they kill it to serve another selfish purpose. They exploit the cow and then destroy it. Cats and dogs are raised for their own enjoyment, not because they have tremendous love for them. On the contrary, it is because the animals love them, and they need that love from the animal. If their dog bites them or the cat steals their food, their love for the animals disappears, and they start hating them. It is the same among family members. Yes, the same thing happens. People exploit each other. The father and the mother become a burden when they are old and weak, and they are sent to an old age home. Children love their parents when they are dependent on them for their food, clothing and shelter. Once they become independent the love disappears. In its place come conflicts and arguments. Children, this is the situation in the world. This is how human beings live, depending on others, exploiting them for their own gratification,

and finally destroying them once their needs are met. That is the nature of the world.

“But *Mahatmas* are not like that. *Mahatmas* are like the wind. While human beings enjoy the aroma of fragrant flowers but trample down the weeds, the wind gently blows and caresses both the flowers and the weeds. The wind never pauses to smell the sweet fragrance of the rose or the jasmine flower, nor does it stop blowing on putrid-smelling excreta. It has no preference and knows no difference. It is beyond all differences. The same is true of a *Mahatma*. He loves all and accepts everything, both what we call ‘good’ and ‘bad.’ He is beyond all likes and dislikes. He simply is. Whoever wants to benefit by a *Mahatma*’s presence can do so. Those who do not want to come to him do not have to. They can criticize him, abuse him, insult him or scandalize him if they like. But do not think that his attitude towards them will be any different. He will remain the same. He will always be the same, for he sees no differences. He sees everybody and everything as Pure Consciousness. However, you are different. You see differences. But remember, your being different and your seeing differences belong only to you. They have nothing to do with the Guru, for He remains the same. You cannot divide Him by projecting your own state of seeing differences onto Him.”

All those present listening to this, the brahmacharins, householder devotees and visitors, were tremen-

dously inspired by the Mother's enlightening talk. They were all spellbound. It was an incessant flow of pure knowledge, like the flow of the Holy Ganges. It was so clear and spontaneous and it dispelled all their doubts. Everyone felt that the Mother was talking about Herself when She was talking about the Guru. It was Her own experience that She was sharing with the listeners. Devotees have hundreds of experiences they can share about the Mother's limitless compassion and love. They can relate numerous incidents to show how She is beyond all differences.

When the Mother stopped, that particular brahmacharin who had made the retort about feeling hurt when he was scolded felt very ashamed of himself. He said in a voice full of remorse, "Amma, I seek your forgiveness for making that comment. I was not protesting. I did not mean that your reprimands are unnecessary." He paused for his throat was choked up. With tears in his eyes, he continued, "Amma, please do not stop correcting me. Please continue doing that. I just wanted to tell you that even though I knew that your reproofs were for my spiritual upliftment, they caused a little pain due to my ego. Forgive me for my faults, forgive me, my Amma." Filled with remorse, the brahmacharin could not control his emotions as he tried to wipe his tears.

What followed was another display of the Mother's overflowing compassion for Her child. His innocence also filled the Mother's eyes with tears. Her

all-enveloping love was showered upon him as She put him on Her lap and patted his back with great affection. The Mother wiped his tears, and slowly lifted him up from Her lap and put his head on Her shoulders. Keeping his head there, She spoke to him soothingly, "Son, there was nothing wrong in your question. In fact, Mother liked your frankness. It is said that one should present questions to the Guru like confronting a cobra. A cobra keeps its hood folded most of the time. But if you hit it, immediately it will unfold its hood. The more you provoke it, the more it will unfold its hood. In a similar manner, when you ask the Guru questions, be demanding of him. By asking provocative questions, you will get more profound answers.

"A sincere, inquisitive seeker will spontaneously ask questions. One should not fabricate arduous questions just for the sake of asking. If questions are asked just for the sake of asking, you may not get the proper answers for them. The determining factor is the inner thirst of the questioner in his desire to know. That will invoke the Guru as well, because the Guru, by nature, prefers to abide in the Self, in the inner silence. To come to the level of the physical body and have to communicate is a struggle for Him. To speak about the Supreme Truth is something which He does not want to do. Speech distorts Truth. He does not want to distort Truth because His speech and mind are established in the inner experience of the Truth. To speak requires an ego. In the case of a Perfect Master,

He has to create an ego to speak and to teach. But when the Guru speaks, He speaks out of His own experience; that is what He puts into words. His words do not distort the Truth. To make the Guru speak, the disciple, the devotee or whatever questioner, should put forth sincere questions. They should be guided by the quest to know. Before a serious seeker, the Guru cannot remain silent. He must speak.”

The brahmacharin’s head still rested on the Mother’s shoulder. As She gently lifted his head, She eased his mind further by clarifying what She was saying, “Therefore, son, you don’t have to worry about the question you put forth. That was a sincere and spontaneous question. A well thought-out question can be lacking in sincerity, for it loses its spontaneity. Sincere and spontaneous questions are often true questions that just come out with no effort. Don’t be sad.”

The Mother’s soothing words consoled the brahmacharin. Then another brahmacharin made a remark, “If one can lie on Mother’s shoulder for such a long time, I would also like to ask a sincere question.” Everybody laughed and the Mother also burst into delightful laughter. She kept on laughing for a while as the atmosphere began to lighten up.

CHAPTER 10

*From the *Kenopanishad*, ‘*manaso manah*,’ or ‘Mind of minds,’ meaning the Supreme Purusha, the Absolute Consciousness, the Witness Consciousness.

WORK AS WORSHIP

3 May 1984

At 6:30 a.m. Mother was sweeping the Ashram premises. When they saw this, Gayatri, Kunjumol and some of the brahmacharins rushed towards Her and tried to take the broom away. "Amma," they insisted, "please stop, we will do it." Bent over the short reed broom, She went on intently sweeping the ground. She did not look up at all, despite the persistent pleas for Her to stop. Some went to fetch more brooms, hoping that they could help Her by sweeping another side of the compound. When Mother saw them coming with brooms, She said, "No, no. No help needed. Take the brooms back." They continued to pester Her until finally She stopped and stood up straight to admonish them, "Stop talking. Do not make any noise. When Mother works, She wants to do it with concentration. Mother considers this worship. Mother sees God in the work, not just the act of sweeping."

With those words, Mother continued to sweep. Still everyone followed Her, but they did not say anything further. Her sweeping was done quickly and efficiently. Not only was the ground clean but the marks left by the reed bristles of the broom left a pleasing pattern in the sand. Mother surpassed all others in doing this work. Since it was a daily custom, the residents usually took turns to sweep the compound, and usually it took at least forty-five minutes to do it. Mother swept the entire Ashram premises within

twenty minutes, less than half the time.

After completing the work, Mother sat down on the south side of the temple. Although perspiring after such vigorous sweeping, She was not at all tired. The group that had been following Her now gathered around, but not too closely, for they were a bit afraid. Mother did not say anything. She wiped Her face and hands with a towel offered by Gayatri. Kunjumol brought a glass of tea for Her, but she simply stood holding it, afraid to ask the Mother to drink. Finally, overcoming her fear, Kunjumol said, "Amma, tea." She replied, "No, I do not want any. I am not going to eat or drink today."

Now came the real *satsang* as She proceeded to talk about the matter on hand: "You children have no real *sraddha*. It was 6:30 a.m. and nobody had swept the Ashram grounds. Don't you know that it should be completed before dawn? Don't you know that this is an Ashram, a place of worship? How many brahmacharins are here? How many? And these girls have also become careless. It is your duty to keep the place clean and tidy. None of you had the common sense or discrimination to do it. Can you sit and meditate in an untidy, dirty and ugly place? No, you cannot. You need a clean and orderly place for that. If the place is untidy and dirty, it will affect your mind. You will not be able to concentrate. If you do not keep the Ashram environment clean, visitors will think that those who dwell here are of the same dirty, disor-

derly nature.

“People use every opportunity to judge Mother. They will think that the Mother is not bringing up Her children properly. It is for your own benefit that Mother is concerned about how people judge the Ashram. What they say will not affect Mother. She can live anywhere, regardless of what people say. Mother is used to that. She has trained Her mind very well. During Her *sadhana* period, Mother spent Her days and nights outside in the open air, rain or shine. She has lain down in the sand, in the muddy backwaters and amidst the rubbish. Mother has eaten pieces of glass, used coffee grounds, and even human waste. She did these things in order to transcend everything. She had that much *vairagya*. Children, do not think that the things that Mother says or does are for Her own benefit. They are all for your benefit. Mother has nothing to gain or lose. For Her everything is the same. For you, however, everything is not the same; you still see things as different from one another. You have a long way to go.

“Furthermore, none of you has ever experienced sorrow in your lives. Never having toiled or sweated in your life, you do not know the difficulties that other people have. Most of you come from well-to-do families. With nothing to worry about, you simply sat down at the dining table and food was there waiting for you. No chores were required of you; you did not even have to wash clothes. You grew up accustomed to having your parents fulfill all your wishes.

“But spiritual life is not for such people. To lead a genuine spiritual life one must know through experience what suffering is and what sorrow is. A person who grows up in the midst of plenty cannot easily lead a true spiritual life. He needs to come down to the ground. He must be willing to go through real life, a life of strenuous work. He has to be given an opportunity to taste and smell the odor of his own sweat. You children do not know the value of work. Do you know, work is God. Mother used to always pray to the Lord, ‘O Lord, give me work. Give me Your work.’”

A brahmacharin spoke up, trying to explain that the person who was supposed to sweep had left the Ashram early in the morning to go on an errand. But Mother interrupted, saying, “Children, do you know that beginning at age nine Mother had to be up at three o’clock in the morning to start Her day’s work? The whole day She was constantly engaged in different tasks. She began by cleaning the house and sweeping the premises. Then She had to attend to a hundred other chores: fetching water, cooking three times a day, cleaning and feeding the cows, milking them, scrubbing the cooking vessels, washing clothes for the entire family and beating coconut husk with a wooden pestle to make coir (rope made from coconut husk fiber). Sometimes Mother had to beat raw husk which is even more difficult. Due to constantly carrying jugs of water and pots of hot *kanji* (rice gruel) on Her head, a bald spot appeared. The hair fell out, but

Mother was not bothered by this.

“Throughout the entire day Mother’s own simple garment was never dry. She had to wade through the backwaters in order to collect grass for the cows. Fetching water and washing the family’s clothes, She was always drenched. Mother would have liked to have seen Her own clothes dry, but She never murmured a single word of complaint. Even though She had so much work, Mother would pray to God for more so that She would always be busy in dedicating Her every action to Him. Mother was scolded harshly and even beaten physically, but She used this adverse treatment to turn Her mind inward instead of becoming bitter or resentful.

“In addition to Her duties at home, Mother was sent to Her relatives’ homes in order to render service to them. At Her grandmother’s place, Mother was engaged in every kind of work, sometimes even having to act as a boatman to ferry Her cousins across the backwaters to school.”

Amma paused for a while as everyone sat still. Then She continued, “Children, Mother was constantly busy from the time She was five years old until She was twenty. Even today Mother does not like to sit idle. She simply cannot.

“If a *sadhak* does not work, he is cheating the world and cheating God in the name of spirituality. None of you has had to suffer like Mother. Even today you have no difficulties or vexations. You do not have to think or worry about anything. Look at

Mother. She does not have to do any work, but still She does. She works, but the work is not for Herself, not to earn wages, not for name or fame, not to please anyone. Still, doing the work gives Her happiness and bliss. Mother does not expect anything from anyone. She simply works because She feels like doing it.

“Children, there were other family members whom Mother could have asked to help Her during those years in the early period of Her life when She was working so much. She could even have said, “I cannot do all this work. There are other children. Ask them to do some of it.” But no, She never uttered a word of complaint nor did She seek anybody else’s help. The Mother accepted everything as the benevolence of Providence. She never thought of Her work as a burden. On the contrary, She was only happy to do it because She considered it as God’s work, as work coming from God’s Will. The work was Her *sadhana*.

“When someone says, ‘It was the responsibility of so-and-so to sweep today, but because he was not here, the work was not done,’ that is the attitude of a person who is insincere and not conscientious. Especially since you are spiritual aspirants, you should not have this kind of attitude. You would not have said that if it were your own house. ‘If it is mine, I will do it. But if it is someone else’s, I don’t care. I’m not going to do it for someone else.’ That is the attitude of a selfish person who thinks only of ‘I’ and ‘mine.’ ‘It is none of my business to poke my nose into somebody else’s affair,’ is always the attitude of selfish people.

Children, we are trying to get out of this narrow vision. The attitude we want to cultivate is ‘Everything is mine; everything is God’s. I am just an instrument in His hands here to do His work.’

“You are the ones who have to soar high into the vast sky of spirituality. And to do that, you need the wings of selflessness and love. We should be able to do everything with love and sincerity. The opportunity to love and serve others should be considered a rare gift, a blessing from God. We should be happy and thank Him for providing such opportunities. A spiritual seeker should always be positive in his attitude. He should never harbor any negative feelings or negative attitudes. To be positive requires strength and courage. It requires a daring mind to give up old habits and to develop and cultivate new ones based on spiritual principles. It is possible. This is the purpose of *sadhana*.

“Ordinary people choose and do only work which they like. Spiritual seekers should not have that attitude. Discarding likes and dislikes, they should be able to do any work at any time. Therein lies greatness.”

Without another word, Mother got up and left. Since it was now nearly time for morning meditation, everyone rose to go, their minds full of regret yet in-



spired by the Mother's words.

TWO MOTHERS

During *darshan*, one of the householder devotees asked the Mother a question: "Amma, I once heard You say that there are two Mothers, the outer Mother and the inner Mother. I do not understand what you mean by that. Will you please tell why there is this division?"

This reply came from the Mother: "Son, there are two different aspects of Mother, the *maya rupam* (the illusory form) and the Mother of the 'Mind of minds'.* The *maya rupam* is the external form, the body. You consider this body as Mother and you call this form Mother. But in the depths of the 'Mind of minds,' there is another Mother. You do not visually see the Mother which is in the 'Mind of minds.' You only see the external Mother.

"The outer Mother, the *maya rupam*, will laugh, play, speak, eat, sleep and do everything that ordinary human beings do. This form mingles with you and communicates with you. This form changes. This form gets older. It was born and therefore, it must perish. It has a beginning and an end. Through close association with this body, you can understand this Mother, the outer Mother, to a certain extent. You can speak to this Mother. You can ask Her questions. The children love this form, and the Mother also loves Her children. You can sometimes please the external Mother. You make Her happy and you can make Her cry. You

can feed Her, serve Her and make Her rest. She will enjoy playing jokes. She will worry about Her children. She will sometimes show attachment. She will sometimes express likes and dislikes. The external Mother will sometimes 'dance' according to your whims and fancies. This external Mother is important. The outer Mother is just as important as the Inner Mother, for without it you will not be able to have any idea about the Inner Mother.

"The Inner Mother, whose true nature is infinitude and silence, manifests visibly through this body so that Her children can have a glimpse of the Mother who is deep within. This body is powerful; it has the power to express the infinite inner power. The reason this external Mother exists is to help you reach the Inner Mother, the Mother of the 'Mind of minds.' The Inner Mother has none of the external qualities. It is totally silent and attributeless in the 'Mind of minds.' Silence is the language of this Inner Mother. All spiritual practices are done to please that Mother. Whatever service you do for the external Mother, the *maya rupam*, is done to please the Inner Mother. You actually cannot use the word 'please' in the case of the Inner Mother. When you open up through spiritual practices, the experience of grace just flows into you. Then it is there within you. It was always there.

"You cannot even call the silent Inner Mother 'Mother,' because 'Mother' is a name, and there are no names or forms in the 'Mind of minds' where the Inner Mother is. That Inner Mother is completely de-

tached; She has no likes or dislikes. Neither excitement nor worry exists for that Mother. She doesn't sleep or eat; She doesn't love nor hate anyone. She simply is. Whatever is expressed through this body is for you, for your spiritual growth. Without the body you cannot even get a glimpse of the Inner Mother. The fact is this external Mother does not exist as you think you are seeing Her. That Inner Mother alone exists. That Inner Mother is still, silent, changeless, immovable..."

She did not complete that sentence. Before She could say anything else, the Mother suddenly burst into blissful laughter. The laughter was loud, but it did not last long, for Mother immediately took a long, deep breath and became absolutely still. She sat in perfect meditation posture with Her eyes closed and head slightly raised. After an initial deep breath, there appeared to be no exhalation. Time passed. Everyone grew tense and worried. It was as if their breath had stopped as well. Some people suggested shaking the Mother vigorously, but when Brahmacharin Pai chanted a Sanskrit *sloka* from the *Soundarya Lahari*, this idea was forgotten.

*United with Shakti, Shiva is endowed
With the power to create the universe.
Otherwise, He is incapable even of movement.
Therefore, who except those endowed
With great merits acquired in the past
Can be fortunate enough
To salute or praise Thee, O Mother Divine,*

*Thou Who art adored even by
Vishnu, Shiva and Brahma.*

This was followed by the *Karunalaye Devi* chant in which everybody participated wholeheartedly.

*O Goddess, Abode of Compassion,
Giver of all things desired,
O Katyayani, Gauri, Sambhavi, Shankari...*

*O Essence of OM, O Mother...Mother...Mother,
Thou art the Essence of OM,
Lover of the sound 'OM,'
When Thou hearest the mantra 'OM Shakti,'
O Mother, Thou wilt come running, O Great
Maya.*

*Creation, preservation and destruction
Of the universe are all Thy doings,
O Mother, all is Thyself, Thou Thyself art all.
There is none other than Thee, O Mother,
This suppliant has no other support except Thee,
The Self of Bliss. O Blissful Self,
Grant me a good boon.*

Hearts were filled with exhilaration, and most people were sobbing, unable to hold back their tears. As they sang they held their palms together in reverence as they fixed their eyes on the Mother. The momentum of the chanting ascended to its climax when the lead singer chanted, "Amme... Amme... Amme..." As the chorus resounded, it was almost as if a dam

had burst, and inspired by the Mother, the waters of love and devotion poured forth. Everyone was transported to heights of emotion no words can describe.

Hearing this loud singing mixed with crying at such an odd hour of the day, some of the villagers came over to the Ashram to investigate what was happening. They stood a short distance away and watched the Mother and the devotees, who were sitting on the front verandah of the temple. The chanting continued... with more slokas from the *Soundarya Lahari*...

*The dust of Thy Feet is the island city
Whence comes the luminous sunrise
Of spiritual illumination,
Driving away the darkness of ignorance
From the hearts of devotees.
It forms the cluster of flower buds
From which pours forth the nectar of intelligence,
Enlivening the dull-witted;
It is a veritable necklace of wish-yielding gems
For the poverty-stricken. For those immersed
In the ocean of samsara, it becomes their uplifter
Like the tusk of Vishnu (which raised the earth
From submergence in the pralaya waters
When He incarnated as the cosmic boar).
O Consort of Parabrahman! Scholars who know
The real meaning of the agamas (scriptures)
Describe Thee as Saraswati, Goddess of Learning,
And the Consort of Brahma. Furthermore,
They speak of Thee as the lotus-born Lakshmi,
Consort of Vishnu; also as Parvati,*

*The Daughter of the the mountain
 And Consort of Shiva.
 Yet Thou art, however, the Fourth—
 That unique Power which is the Source
 Of the three deities mentioned—
 Of inconceivable and limitless majesty,
 The indeterminable Mahamaya
 Who revolves the Wheel of this world.*

*O Mother! The crest of the Vedas
 Bear Thy Feet as its crown.
 May Thou condescend to place those Feet
 On my head as well – the Feet, the water—
 Offerings of which form the Ganga
 In the matted locks of Shiva,
 And the bright red dye which gives
 Brilliance to the jewels on the diadem of Vishnu.*

At last, people noticed a slight movement in the Mother's body. Their eyes were riveted on Her with great anxiety and fear, and they took note of every single movement She made. First Her hands slowly moved, then Her feet started gently swaying back and forth. Next came a visible movement of Her lips as if She were murmuring something. Gradually the rise and fall of Her chest indicated that Her breathing had returned. Everyone heaved a sigh of relief and their anxious looks disappeared. It was perhaps over ten minutes since the Mother had entered into *samadhi*, and now as She was coming out of it, the singing continued in full swing. When the song was over, She

opened Her eyes. Then came the familiar but inexplicable circular gesture of Her right palm while She softly chanted the mantra, “Shiva... Shiva.” Within seconds everybody found the Mother back in Her normal mood. No one had been aware of the passage of time as it was already one o’clock, even though three hours had passed since the beginning of *darshan*.

Time always passes quickly whenever one is in the presence of the Mother. One becomes so enraptured that one loses sense of both time and place. The scriptures say that one who attains the State of Perfection is not bound by time and space. It is a truism that a person has the same experience of not being aware of time or space when one is in the presence of a Self-Realized Soul. Perfect Masters can easily steal the minds of people who come to see them. Once the mind disappears, the world also disappears. The concept of time and space exists only when there is mind and when one is conscious of the outer world. Thus, when one transcends this outer world consciousness, time and space also disappear.

It is an innate quality of a *Mahatma* to attract people’s attention to Himself and to make people forget the world outside. All genuine *Mahatmas* do this, and so does the Holy Mother. Her spontaneous expressions, Her words and deeds, and Her all-consuming love make one feel fully relaxed and peaceful. In Her presence the concept of time disappears. People have the feeling that they have spent only a few min-

utes with the Mother, only to realize afterwards that they have spent many hours with Her. That is what happened that day.

Only a few people were left in the queue as *darshan* was drawing to a close. Nobody had thought about lunch, so when *darshan* was over, the Mother exclaimed, “Oh, none of my children has had their lunch. Such a pity! What a cruel Mother I am.” She ran to the kitchen and after putting the rice and curry dishes in the appropriate containers, She brought the food to the dining hall and proceeded to serve each person with Her own hands.

First spiritual food had come from the Mother’s words; now there was food for the body from Her own hands! Joy brightened the faces of all as they partook of this special repast.

When asked if She would eat, the Mother replied, “Mother’s stomach gets filled by serving food to all Her children and seeing them eat together.” Flashing a bright smile to everyone in the dining hall, She then went to Her room.

CHAPTER 11

SPIRITUAL LOVE AND WORLDLY LOVE

7 May 1984

Today in response to a question put forth by a devotee about the difference between spiritual love and worldly love, Mother gave the following answer:

“Son, love is love, but the intensity is different and

the depth is different. Spiritual love is as deep as a bottomless pit. How deep and how expansive it is cannot be measured. Spiritual love is without limits or boundaries while worldly love is superficial and not very deep. The spirit of worldly love is not constant. Its rhythm fluctuates; it comes and goes. The beginning is always beautiful and enthusiastic, but slowly it gets less beautiful and less exciting until it ends up being shallow. In most cases, it ends up finally in upset, hatred and deep sorrow.

“Spiritual love is different. The beginning is beautiful and peaceful. Shortly after this peaceful beginning comes the agony of longing. Through the middle period, the agony will continue to grow stronger and stronger, more and more unbearable. Excruciating pain will ensue, and this pain of love will prevail until just before it leads up to unity with the beloved. This unity is beautiful, even more inexpressibly beautiful than the beginning of love. The beauty and peace of this unity in love remains forever and ever. Love of this kind never dries up or diminishes. Always alive, both within and without, it is constant, and each moment you live in love. Love will swallow you, eat you up completely until there is no ‘you,’ only Love. Your whole being will be transformed into Love. Spiritual love culminates in unity, in oneness. Sometimes a relationship between two people, if it is pure, can reach that union. Mother will tell a story.”

Mother proceeded to relate a story about pure

love between two people named Manohari and Arun. The daughter of a king named Shaktivarman, Manohari was a beautiful princess and a paragon of virtue. Her mother, the queen, had many servants. One of them was a pious lady named Arundhati, who had a son named Arun. Since Arundhati's husband had died, Arun was her constant companion. When she came to the palace to serve the queen, Arun naturally came with her. Princess Manohari and Arun became childhood playmates.

Since they were children, no one attached much importance to the amount of time they spent playing together. The years rolled by, and their close friendship continued as they grew up. They confided in each other what they did and how they felt. Whenever Arun came to the palace, Manohari was eager to share with him everything about herself and about life in the palace. "Ah, my dearest friend, the queen has given orders to have made for me a beautiful bed inlaid with precious gemstones... This golden gown I am wearing was presented to me by the king... Do you know, soon the queen is going to have a beautiful garden made for me? We will play together in that garden." Such were the things she told him. Arun always listened keenly to the princess' stories, and he, in turn, talked about how his mother strained and toiled day in and day out, in order to bring him up. Manohari, being the model of all good qualities, had great sympathy and compassion for Arun's situation and for his hard life.

Time passed and as they became young adults, their relationship was stronger than ever. They were bound to one another by an unbreakable chain of love. Their love was not a shallow, superficial love, but one of great depth. It became very difficult for them to be away from one another as they each began to feel the agony of separation. At the same time, it was very difficult for them to see each other as freely and constantly as before since they were no longer children but young man and young woman. Yet they managed to meet secretly and pour out their hearts to one another. Silently gazing deep into each other's eyes, they would forget about the world outside.

Even while physically apart from each other, Manohari and Arun would be lost in thoughts about each other. Their minds always revolved around thoughts of where the other was and what the other was doing. The excruciating pain of separation burned in their hearts. When they could meet and be together, their encounter became like meditation. They sat facing each other, looking in each other's eyes. Verbal communication almost ceased as their hearts communicated through their eyes. There was no physical contact, yet they experienced the warmth and depth of pure love."

Mother paused and then made some comments about pure love: "Children, where there is pure love, there is no lust. Where Rama is, Ravana cannot thrive. That is, where there is pure, taintless love (Rama), lust (Ravana) will not exist. Mother remembers another

story.

“Having kidnapped Sita, the holy consort of Rama, and taken Her to Lanka, Ravana, the demon king, tried different ways to win Sita’s heart. But all his efforts failed. Sita constantly chanted Rama’s name. She was always thinking of Rama and Her heart was one with Her Lord’s.

“Although Ravana was demonic, his wife was a virtuous and honorable woman. Wanting to please her husband, she suggested a way to win Sita’s heart. ‘Look, my lord,’ she said, ‘you have many magical powers. You can assume any form you want. Take the form of Rama and approach Sita that way. Surely, She will be yours.’

“Ravana immediately replied, ‘Once I become Rama, then there is no *kama* (lust) in me. What sense is there in approaching Sita that way?’

“Pure love transcends the body. It is between hearts. It has nothing to do with bodies.”

Mother continued with the story of Manohari and Arun. “The two lovers lost all their interest in other things. Manohari spent all her time in her private chambers experiencing the agonizing pain of separation. Arun wandered around, feeling torment at being away from his beloved. The flame of love burned and consumed them. Their hearts were like burning tapers. The king and queen noticed the change in their daughter. They wondered what was happening to her, so they appointed some spies to discover what

she did and whom she saw. Before long, the whole story of the relationship between Manohari and Arun was exposed. It became the scandal of the palace.

Immediately the king sent Arun in exile to a remote island. He further ordered his soldiers to kill Arun by poisoning his food and then to bury him. The soldiers did as they were ordered. Hoping to avoid suspicion, they did not use a coffin to bury Arun. Instead they put Arun in a simple wooden box and buried him in the dead of night.”

Pausing from the story for a few moments, the Mother closed Her eyes and sat absorbed in Her own Self. She laughed blissfully every now and then. After a few more moments, the Mother opened Her eyes, and twirling Her right hand in the air, She chanted, “Shiva, Shiva. Shiva, Shiva.”

Silence prevailed until someone reminded Her about the story. Mother continued, “Okay. Where were we? Oh yes...The soldiers buried Arun on a certain spot on the island.”

The story continued: Unknown to the soldiers, two robbers were hiding in the bushes closely watching everything. Since it was dark, the robbers could not see what the soldiers were burying. All they had seen was a large box which the soldiers carried on their shoulders. Thinking that it was some treasure, they immediately dug it up when the soldiers had gone some distance away. The robbers were excited and

happy, thinking that God had bestowed some great fortune upon them. In their excitement and wishful anticipation of digging up buried treasure, they were shocked when they opened the box. It was no buried treasure but a man.

At first they thought it was a corpse, but noticing movement in Arun's chest, the robbers realized that he was still alive. Though he was unconscious, Arun was still breathing. Taking pity on this man who was buried alive, they sprinkled some water on his face and took him out of the box. When Arun regained consciousness, they give him some water to drink. Immediately upon drinking, Arun started to vomit. He continued to vomit for some time until cleansed of all the poison.

Arun looked around and was puzzled to see that he was still alive. Although the robbers asked him many, many questions, he gave no answers. He did not speak; he simply looked at them. Both robbers became overpowered by an unknown and mysterious sympathy and compassion for this man. Being so moved by this strange compassion, they stopped asking questions and let him go. Regaining his physical composure, Arun walked away into the dark like one transported to another world.

The king had kept his orders of the exile and execution of Arun a secret. The soldiers and the queen were sworn to secrecy. Even though Manohari knew nothing about Arun's fate, she immediately became restless and experienced severe and excruciating inner

pain the moment Arun was banished. This pain reached its climax when Arun was buried alive, and her suffering plunged to agonizing depths. She received no news from Arun. It had been a long time since they had seen each other, a long, long time since lover and beloved had been together.

Day after day, languishing in tumultuous waves of pain, she became thinner and thinner. Forgoing food and sleep, she thought only of the one she loved. The entire royal family became very worried. Her health quickly deteriorated until finally the princess was completely bed-ridden. Many eminent physicians were called. They tried all different types of medicine and treatments to no avail. Nothing could restore Manohari's health. Her face was gaunt and pale, but her eyes remained wide open all the time, glowing with love even though she was in deep pain, wanting to be with her love, Arun.

Mysteriously, every now and then strange wounds, bruises and cuts appeared on her body. There was no explanation for this since there were no dangerous instruments lying about her room. It was truly puzzling to the doctors. Sometimes she fell out of her bed as if she had been thrown off. At other times she was found crawling on all fours on the bed. Occasionally she would murmur strange sounds that appeared to have no meaning. But as much as these disturbing, unexplained things happened, there were also times when she was completely peaceful and calm. Maintaining the poise of the princess that she was, she ap-

peared to be totally normal, except that she would not say anything or even acknowledge the presence of other people who came to her room. Nobody could figure out what all these things meant and it remained a great mystery for everybody at the palace.

Meanwhile, Arun was all alone without anybody to whom he could pour out his heart. He wandered over hills and plains, across rivers and through forests in search of his beloved Manohari. Sometimes he would dash about in a frenzy like a mad man. His external appearance was that of a crazy, deranged man with long matted hair and a long beard. He became thin and gaunt like a skeleton. His eyes sank deep into their sockets, but even though hollow, they still glowed with burning love. He neither ate nor slept. Constantly on his lips was the name of his beloved, Manohari. Even though he looked like someone who had escaped from an insane asylum, there was something special about him. The islanders became used to Arun and his strange ways, and they grew very fond of him.

As the days went by, Arun's love became much increasingly intense. He sometimes called out loudly, "Manohari!" He even started asking the people he met, "Where is she, my heart's beloved? Have you seen her?" Since he spent most of his time in the forest, he would also ask the animals, birds, trees, creepers, bushes and even particles of sand, had they seen his beloved?

Suddenly the Mother once again went into an intoxicated mood. Her eyes were shut and tears ran down Her cheeks. The way the Mother was narrating the story was so touching that all the listeners were also moved to tears. Whenever the Mother mentions something about pure love, She drifts away from this world. Love is Her real nature; thus, occasions on which She must talk about love must be a real 'test' for the Mother to keep Her mind in a lower level of consciousness.

After some time Mother came back to the normal plane of consciousness and She continued the narration: Arun's burning love for Manohari prevailed, so much so, that even the ferocious wild animals became calm and quiet in front of him. The lions and tigers became his friends. They were so tamed by love that they lay down peacefully next to the deer and the rabbits. They sensed his sadness and also shed tears when he cried. They joined in his ecstatic dancing when he twirled about in the bliss of love. Then when the excruciating pain of separation struck him, he fell unconscious.

Sometimes when he fell or stumbled about, he injured himself on a sharp stone or a branch, or ran into a tree. Rain or shine, he was always out in the open air, totally oblivious to the condition of his body. So identified were the two lovers that whatever happened to Arun manifested on his beloved's body. That was the mystery behind the injuries, cuts and

bruises which manifested on Manohari's body.

Since the princess Manohari was completely bed-ridden and had fallen into a coma, her body was wasting away. She lay like a corpse. Sometimes her lips moved slightly, and if someone paid close attention and listened carefully, he could hear her say, "Arun... Arun... Arun..." Other than that, she hardly breathed. Her parents were drowned in deep sorrow for their daughter. They gave up all hope for her recovery. The princess's attendants, who loved her dearly, gathered around her bed lamenting. The entire kingdom was plunged in gloom. Even crops failed to yield a good harvest.

At this point a saintly man appeared one day at the palace. He carried about himself an aura of serenity and profound peace. When he saw the sorrowful state of the king and the queen suffering in their concern for their daughter's strange malady, he requested to see Manohari. He entered the princess's chambers and saw the girl lying in a coma. Looking silently at her pitiful form for a few minutes, he sat down and went into meditation. Opening his eyes, the saint called for the king and queen. He told them, "Your daughter can be saved, but..." He stopped.

The king quickly entreated, "O Reverend One, tell us. Whatever it is, I will do it. Please tell us what it is."

The saint revealed, "Your daughter is deeply in love with a man. He alone can save her. There is absolutely no other way. Otherwise, she will soon be dead. Call the man here and let him touch the princess. He

will bring her back to life.”

The king was stunned and fell down at the saint's feet. He confessed the whole story about how he had exiled Arun to a remote island and ordered his soldiers to poison and bury him. Remorse struck the king's conscience and tears came from his eyes as he sat in repentance at the feet of the saint.

Upon assessing what he had just heard, the saint again sat in meditation. Coming out of his meditative trance, he smiled as he assured the king, “Don't worry, the boy is still alive on the same island where he was exiled.” Before the saint left the room, he gently and affectionately caressed the princess as if blessing her that soon all would be well.

There was another pause. During this short interval, one of the new brahmacharins was about to ask a question, but he did not, remembering that it was improper to interrupt when the Guru was speaking. Realizing his wish, the Mother inquired, “Son, come on, don't hesitate. What is it that you were going to ask?”

“Amma,” the brahmacharin said, “you said that Arun even asked the animals and birds about his beloved Manohari. That doesn't make any sense to me. One would be mad to do something like that.”

To this, Amma replied, “You are right, son. He was mad, mad with love. When a person is mad with love, he doesn't see objects in their many forms, but he beholds his beloved in whatever he sees. He sees all-pervasive life pulsating in all objects. He becomes one-pointed. He becomes alert and aware. His mind flows

only to one object, his beloved. Everything else ceases to exist in this kind of madness.

“In ordinary mental craziness the person loses all concentration, and he turns both the mind and the world into a hellish mess of confusion. But in this madness which ensues from pure love, one becomes totally one-pointed. His whole being, every pore of his body, becomes totally concentrated. Here the madness becomes divine and divinely purifying.

“Children, what did the Gopis of Brindavan do? They, too, found messengers in all objects, both animate and inanimate things. The pain of their separation from Lord Krishna was so unbearable that they even thought that a bee would be a good messenger to intercede to the Lord on their behalf. One Gopi’s message was this, ‘O bee, pray to my Lord to please wear the garland of my adoration.’ Another Gopi said, ‘Tell my Beloved to come and illumine the darkness of my heart.’ Radha’s message was, ‘Supplicate my Beloved Lord to make the desert sands of Radha’s heart sprout into green grass, so that His Feet may tread thereon, light and soft.’

“What did Rama do when Sita was kidnapped by Ravana? He too inquired about His beloved of the trees, creepers, birds and animals. Let us finish the story now.”

Mother continued: The king immediately sent a troop of soldiers off to the island to find Arun. The soldiers who had performed the burial led them to the

spot where they had buried the box. Digging at this same spot, they found nothing. No trace of anything that had been buried there could be detected and certainly no sign of any body. The soldiers were then divided into small groups and sent to scour the countryside in search of Arun. Wherever they went they asked the local people if they had seen the young man. Eventually they heard about a crazy wanderer who had a special air about him.

Continuing in their search, they finally came to the forest where Arun was living. They were astounded to see a man dancing, singing, laughing and crying amidst lions, tigers, deer, squirrels, birds and other forest animals. The animals neither did any harm to the soldiers nor did they run away in fear, but they remained very calm, quiet and friendly. The soldiers wanted to find out if this strange man was indeed Arun. They really did not think that this could be the same person they used to see at the palace. How could they find out? Finally, one person had a good idea. The best way to discover if this was Arun was to repeat the name of the princess loudly for him to hear. So one man was appointed to approach the crazy man and call out, "Manohari... Manohari... Manohari..."

Upon hearing this most pleasurable sound and feeling ambrosial nectar flooding his heart, Arun turned and followed the sound. His eyes were filled with ecstatic love as he ran towards the sound of his beloved's name and fell at the spot where the soldiers were standing. Now they were sure that this was Arun.

So they lifted him up onto their shoulders to carry him away. The animals and the birds silently stood by, watching the whole scene, shedding tears as they witnessed their dear friend and kindred spirit being taken from their midst.

Arun was brought back to the kingdom. As he stood by Manohari's bedside, a radiance emitted from his entire being. His mere presence brought life and vitality back into her body. He touched her, and like one awaking from a deep sleep, she was gently aroused. She felt as if she were in a trance as she beheld her lover. She smiled at him and he at her, their eyes drinking in deep draughts of love. It was as if they had never been separated, and in a sense, they never were.

The king and queen were filled with joy and gratitude that their daughter had returned to life, and all the court attendants rushed about with beaming smiles on their faces to tell everybody that the princess was awake and well. But the world of the court was not what these lovers wanted. They wanted nothing of the world. Their hearts had already been united long before the exile, and their world was the world of love. Both of them chose to follow a spiritual life, so they renounced the world to become *sannyasins* as their hearts remained in union forever.

Thus Mother ended the story of the two lovers, Manohari and Arun. It was a tale of enchantment that stirred the hearts of all. Everyone remained silent.

Moved with emotion, each person sat still and watched the Mother. Within the hearts of the devotees, there was the feeling that they were seeing before their eyes the embodiment of Love itself. Sometimes they felt that if they stared intently at Her they would detect the secret of what they were searching for, but that, of course, was always elusive. The silence was finally broken by the Mother singing... *Nin Premam...*

*O Mother, make me mad with Thy Love!
What need have I of knowledge or reason?
Make me drunk with Thy Love's Wine!*

*O Thou who steals Thy devotees' hearts
Drown me deep in the Sea of Thy Love.
Here in this world, in this madhouse of Thine,
Some laugh, some weep, some dance for joy.
Gauranga, Buddha, Jesus and Moses
All are drunk with the wine of Thy Love.
O Mother, when will I be so blessed
To join their blissful company?*

Everyone felt that the Mother was expressing the beauty and fragrance of pure love through Her words and through the song. She stopped for a while. Again there was a deep silence. All eyes were fixed on the Mother because Her eyes remained closed for some time. The impact of the story was so touching that it seemed that everybody present was experiencing the silent depths of pure love. The cool sea breeze which blew from the west gently removed the cloth covering

the Mother's head. A few strands of Her hair danced in the cool air. The Mother opened Her eyes as She put the head cloth back in position.

One of the brahmacharins took this opportunity to ask a question, "Amma, what is the conclusion?"

"Children," Amma replied, "whether it is spiritual love or worldly love, love remains love. The difference is only in depth and degree. Even if love has a worldly touch in the beginning, it can reach the highest peak of purity if it becomes one-pointed and selfless. Pure love has nothing to do with the body. It binds and unites the soul of the lover with the soul of the beloved. But as Mother said before, pure love does involve a tremendous amount of self-sacrifice. At certain points it may cause great pain, but pure love always culminates in everlasting bliss.

"In that ultimate state of oneness, even if the lover and beloved retain their bodies, that is, even if they exist as two bodies, deep in the depths of their love they are one whole. It is like two banks of the river. The banks are different; they are two as we see from the outside, but deep down they are one, one united in the depths. The same is the case with genuine lovers. Though they appear as two persons externally, deep within they are one, united in love."

A devotee then asked, "Amma, why is there so much pain and suffering in pure love?"

Mother explained, "Because what is impure should become pure. All impurity should melt and disappear

in the heat of the pain of separation and longing. This suffering is known as *tapas*. The Gopis became totally identified with Krishna through this pain. Their pain was so excruciating and intense that their individuality disappeared completely and they merged with their beloved Krishna. The impurity is the feeling of 'I' and 'mine,' the ego. The ego cannot be eradicated unless one puts it in this furnace of love. Love is heat and cold at the same time. It consumes you first. That consuming is a bit painful. But if you have the power to withstand the pain, you can relax and experience the heart's soothing coolness and the oneness of love.

"Let Mother give you the example of the Gopi Neeraja. Originally, she was from another province, but she was married to a Gopa from Brindavan. Before coming to Brindavan, she had been warned about Krishna. But when this Gopi first saw Krishna during the Govardhana festival, she was completely drawn to Him and she fully surrendered her heart to the Lord. This spiritual attachment made Neeraja pass through severe ordeals, but she endured them with great courage. When she first met Krishna, the Lord was playing sweetly on His Divine Flute as He stood at the foot of Govardhana Hill. Thereafter, Neeraja would often visit that bower where she first saw Him just to inhale the holy air.

"When Krishna left Brindavan for Mathura, the separation from her Beloved Lord Krishna was unbearable for Neeraja. Yet she suffered silently for years and years. Like all the other Gopis she thought that

Krishna would come back some day. Neeraja waited and waited, spending her days and nights in the bower.

“Years rolled by and Krishna never returned. For Neeraja the pain of separation was excruciating. Her agony grew unbearable, and finally one day she collapsed, unable to withstand any more. As she lay in the bower about to die, Krishna appeared before her. “I have always longed to again hear Your Divine Flute,” she told Krishna. The Lord replied, “I did not bring it.” But just to fulfill her wish, Krishna broke a length of reed from the bower and made it into a flute on which He played a melody that melted Neeraja’s heart. As she listened to that tune while lying on the lap of her Beloved Lord, Neeraja, the true lover and true devotee, finally merged into Krishna forever and ever.

“Pure love removes all negative feelings. Destroying all selfishness, it expects nothing but gives everything. Pure love is a constant giving up – giving up of everything that belongs to you. What really belongs to you? Only the ego. Love consumes in its flames all pre-conceived ideas, prejudices and judgements, all those things which stem from the ego. Pure love is nothing but the emptying of the mind of all its fears and the tearing off of all masks. It exposes the Self as it is.

“For the lover to wholeheartedly receive and welcome the beloved, pure love prepares the mind by chasing away all the enemies of love. This results in a constant flow of the lover’s heart towards the be-

loved. There is an unquenchable thirst to drink in the beloved, an unappeasable hunger to eat him up and an immeasurable intensity to become love. It is the death of the ego to live in love. But once you attain unity with the beloved, then there is only peace, love, light and silence. All conflicts end and you shine forth in the radiance of Supreme Love. In order to attain this highest kind of love one has to undergo some pain. But that pain is not pain when you consider the unending flow of bliss which you are going to gain when you reach the goal.

“To reach the destination you must travel, and you may have to endure some hardships along the way. You may have to travel for many, many hours in an airplane or for several days on a train without proper sleep or food. Once you reach your destination, however, you can lie down, rest and relax. A river has to flow many miles in order to reach the sea. Profit comes after losses. Likewise, the eternal peace of love comes after some trials and tribulations. In order to gain the highest form of bliss one has to undergo purification. Purification is heating up the mind in order to remove all impurities, and this process inevitably involves pain. Even to attain something material, a certain amount of sacrifice is involved.

“While momentary happiness obtained from the world ultimately pushes you into the throes of never-ending sorrow, spiritual pain uplifts you to the abode of everlasting bliss and peace. It is up to us to choose between temporary happiness, which will culminate in

never-ending unhappiness, or temporary pain which will culminate in everlasting peace.”

A devotee added, “Pure and innocent love is capable of eradicating everyone’s problems, both mental and physical. That is what Mother’s life is all about. Her universal love bestows peace and tranquility to all those who come to Her.”

Amma continued, “Children, love can accomplish anything and everything. Love can cure diseases. Love can heal wounded hearts and transform human minds. Through love one can overcome all obstacles. Love can help us renounce all physical, mental and intellectual tension and thereby bring peace and happiness. Love is the ambrosia which adds beauty and charm to life. Love can create another world in which you are immortal and deathless.

“Pure love is the best medicine for the modern world. This is what is lacking in all societies. The root cause of all problems, from personal problems to global problems, is the absence of love. Love is the binding factor, the unifying factor. Love creates the feeling of oneness among people. It unifies a nation and its people. Love creates a sense of unity while hatred causes division. Egotism and hatred cut people’s minds into pieces. Love should rule. There is no problem which love cannot solve.

“In the modern age, human minds are dry. Too much reasoning has spoiled the contemporary mind. People use their intellects for everything. They have

lost their hearts and their faith. Beauty lies in the heart. Beauty lies in faith and faith dwells in the heart. Intellect or reasoning is necessary, but we should not let it swallow the faith in us. We should not allow the intellect to eat up our heart. Intellect is knowledge, and knowledge is ego. Too much knowledge means nothing but a big ego. The ego is a burden, and a big ego is a big burden.

“If a person’s intellect predominates, he will not be able to enjoy sweetness and beauty. Unable to penetrate the surface of things or dive deep within, he will perceive only exteriors. While sitting on the seashore, instead of enjoying the beauty of the waves and the vastness of the ocean, he will think about how the ocean came into existence. Filled with such thoughts, he will even fail to notice the gentle caress of the breeze from the sea, its expansiveness and vastness. A predominantly intellectual person will not be able to imbibe and experience the magic and enchantment of a moonlit night. He cannot simply appreciate something for what it is but must engage in analysis. He will try to analyze the moon as a luminous body, attempt to give a scientific explanation of the moon and how it shines. He cannot think in other terms.

“While drinking a cup of coffee or tea, his thoughts will be on how to breed a new species of coffee beans or tea leaves. He will not be able to enjoy the flavor of the tea or coffee. Thus the intellectual person who has no love in him will always miss the

beauty and charm of everything that comes to him. Think of the life of such a person. Can we call it life? It is death, nothing but death. We want to live life as well as we can. We do not want to make life a mess. Therefore, we want everything in perfect proportions, without too much or too little of anything. Presently, the intellect predominates and there is not enough love. Therefore, we must strive to empty the intellect of useless thoughts and fill the heart with love. That is the solution for all the distress and confusion of modern society."

Another question arose about love and war, "Amma, you state that love should rule and that there is no problem which love cannot solve. But is this applicable to the modern world where each country is intent on increasing its military force to attack and conquer other countries? How can a nation hold on to the theory of love and practice it when enemies are lining up artillery at its borders?

"Children, in pure love there is no attachment," explained the Mother. "One has to transcend all petty human feelings to attain Supreme Love. In other words, love dawns only when detachment arises. All attachments to all other things, whatever they may be, should fall off, and the mind should become fully one-pointed. Here, love alone is the subject and the object. Such love will not arise from attachment; it is a product of total detachment. Therefore, when a challenge confronts the nation you must fight for the good of the country, if it is a good cause, but with de-

tachment.

“In order to fight without attachment, the battle must be waged not against the evil-doer but against the evil. The fighting is not against an egotistic person in the opposite army but against the ego, the destructive force. It is not out of hate that you fight but out of detachment and love – that is, detached love or love without attachment.

“All wars and all conquests arise from the ego, in most cases the national egos, the collective egos of a nation. Rarely is it personal egos. Whenever there is a conflict, it is between two big collective egos. Each side may shout at the top of their lungs that they are fighting for the common good, for the protection of the nation’s freedom, for the peace of all of humanity, and so on. But if you penetrate to the real cause, you will find that it is their egos fighting. If some country or leader poses a threat to a country or to the world, threatening all nations and all of humanity, you may fight, but fight with love. If you go to war, fight with love for humanity; fight against evil and against unrighteousness. Fight with detachment, for real love arises from detachment.

“Real love arises only when all attachments to individuals, objects and personal interests drop away. Then the battle becomes a beautiful play. It becomes selfless service extended toward the entire human race out of love and compassion. In that fighting your ego will not fight, but love will fight to consume the ego and transform it into love.

“Lord Krishna was ‘love incarnate,’ even while He fought in the epic battle described in the *Mahabharata*. Although He sided with the righteous Pandavas, He did not hate the evil Kauravas. He still loved them, but he did hate the evil that motivated them. For righteousness’ sake He wanted to save the country from total destruction. The cause He stood for was universal. Had it been the Pandavas who had acted in an unrighteous manner, Krishna would definitely have taken the side of the Kauravas. He was not attached to individuals. On the contrary, He was supporting *dharma*. He was fully detached from everything, even from His own abode. That is why He could smile even when His city, Dwaraka, was swallowed up by the ocean.

“Krishna fought in the battle with complete detachment because His love was not divided. His love was whole. Pure love is undivided. Pure love sees oneness; it sees no caste, creed, sect or religion. Pure love can fight, kill or destroy; yet there is no hatred in it, only love. When pure love fights, it is not one person fighting with another. It is the higher nature fighting against the lower nature. Pure love has no form. Even if there is a form, that form is only for the sake of having a name to identify it, such as Krishna. Behind that form is the formless love because love has consumed the form in its flames.

“What opposes pure love is the ego. It is ignorant, limited individuals fighting for an evil cause. But love does not see the form or persons. Love sees through

the form and wants to burn the ego in its all-consuming flame. There is no hatred involved on the part of love, for pure love has no ego. When only love is involved, it can fight and kill, but at the same time, it can love and even walk away untouched because that person who is the embodiment of love is the embodiment of detachment as well. That is why Krishna could fight and still love. Rama could fight with Ravana and still love him. Jesus could whip the corrupt merchants and still love them. That is why Krishna could bestow the highest form of blessing, salvation, upon the hunter who shot Him with an arrow, causing Him to cast off His human form. That is why Jesus could forgive and pray for those who tortured His body. Krishna, Rama and Jesus were detached and undivided. Being whole and pure, Their love transcended all forms of attachments and aversions. In Them there was nothing but love and compassion. For Them there were no individuals, no separate entities. Everything was a whole.

“Children, we should take Them as examples. Follow Their footsteps and fight if society calls for it, provided it is for a good cause. Discharge your duty properly, but be detached. Have love and compassion for the entire human race.

“In this modern age, to be detached while at war is quite difficult because almost all nations have their own vested interests. Therefore, Mother knows that it would be an almost impossible task to observe the principles just mentioned. Most soldiers are bound to

obey the commands issued to them. Even then, a person who is truly devoted to *dharma* will not fight for an evil cause. He will have a universal outlook. But if one is helplessly pushed into such a situation, he should fight, taking it as his duty towards his country, and sincerely pray to the Lord for cleansing him of all sins which he might incur. He should not have any personal envy or selfishness towards the other nation.”

The western sky over the Arabian Sea glowed with a brilliant red and golden hue as the sun sank on the horizon marking the end of another day. From the southwestern corner of the Ashram premises, one could take in a panoramic vista of the dark blue waters and the setting sun. High waves rose and fell upon the shores of the black sand with a thunderous crash. Big fishing trawlers lined the seashore, waiting to set out to sea at the turning of the tide. The constant roar of the ocean echoed through the Ashram. The Holy Mother was sitting on the south side of the temple, facing west. The Mother sat in a perfect lotus posture with eyes opened; She was unmoving and transfixed, revealing a visible depth. She radiated an extraordinary aura of divinity.

The Holy Mother slowly glided into a state of rapture. With Her eyes half-closed She sat motionless. Her sister Kasturi’s son, Shivan, came running and stood in front of the Mother, gazing at Her face. After a few moments, he squatted down beside Her. His eyes were still fixed on the Mother’s face. Perhaps in-

spired by the Mother's ecstatic mood, he also sat like a little yogi and started meditating. With eyes closed he began chanting 'OM.'

The Mother continued in Her exalted mood for a while longer. As the tide turned, the waves lapped on the shore while the fishermen pushed their long boats into the sea. Excited that the weather was most favorable for a good evening catch, they were in a merry mood as they chanted their rhythmic, traditional songs, creating an ancient setting for the timeless quality of the Mother's mood.

As the Mother slowly opened Her eyes, She remained facing the western horizon. Then She turned and looked at Shivan, who was still repeating 'OM.' Very pleased with him, the Mother called, "Shivan-mon... Shivan-mon (son)." He opened his eyes and immediately asked in his own innocent way, "Ammachi, why did you call me? I was meditating." His innocence deeply touched the Mother, and She smiled with delight as She moved closer to him. Gently caressing his head with Her right hand, the Mother said, "Good boy, you meditated for a long time. That is enough for the time being, okay?" Shivan nodded his head in agreement. Taking him by the hand, the Mother said, "Now, get up, son. Come along with Mother." Pointing to the banks of the backwaters, She continued, "We will go and sit there for a while." Holding hands, they walked together to the southern edge of the Ashram. The Mother sat there for some time with Shivan at Her side.

The evening *bhajan* began at the regular time with the brahmacharins and resident devotees singing. In the middle of the *bhajan*, the Holy Mother joined in as they sang... *Idamilla...*

*Here I am a wanderer with no hearth or home.
O Mother, give me refuge, lead me towards Thee,
Let me not get tossed about in deep waters
But extend Thy helping hand, take me to the shore.*

*Like butter poured in fire
My mind is being burned in this world,
A bird can at least fall to the earth
But for a human being,
Who but Thee art the Support?*

After this song there was a short pause. Everyone waited for the Mother to start the next *kirtan*. She sang... *Kali Maheshwari...*

*I salute Kali, the Holy Consort of Lord Shiva,
Who is verily the Mother of the Universe.
O Mother, what a great magical power
This world has,
Which completely blocks the mind to think
And contemplate Thy Divine Form and Name.*

*O Great Goddess Kali,
It has been declared that You are
The Root Cause of this world,
Having neither head nor tail,*

*Neither alpha nor omega,
Thus mixing up truth and untruth.
O Mother, crazy indeed is what You have done.*

*O Kali, O Great Illusive Power,
Can one find any reason
In this universal play performed by Thee?
Crazy indeed is this play,
O Thou Who art intoxicated
By drinking the bliss of eternity.*

*O Kali, One Who causes the final dissolution,
Being the One who weaves heaps and heaps
Of the beginningless cloth of maya,
It is such a strange sight
To see Thee wearing the severed hands
Of Thy enemies around Thy waist.*

The Mother sometimes would cry, and at other times, She would burst into ecstatic laughter. At a certain point She drew within and became totally absorbed while the brahmacharins took over the lead singing. Next Her gestures were like those of an innocent child in supplication to its mother. With both hands raised, She called out, "Amma...Amma... Where are You?" or "Hey, Kali... Kali! Come here."

With this kind of supreme devotion, different aspects and different layers of the Supreme Consciousness appeared, disappeared and reappeared in the manifestations of the Mother's body. Perched on those wings of divinity, everyone present passed beyond the ordinary to the blissful world of supreme

love and devotion. As She sang, one could see the Mother wiping tears every now and then.

Whenever She talks about the path of devotion, Amma says, “Look, children, Mother knows very well that all names and forms are limited and that God is nameless, formless and attributeless. Still, the sweet and blissful feeling that one has from singing the glories of the Lord is an incomparable and inexpressible experience. While singing to the Lord, it is very difficult for Mother to control the mind and bring it down. On such occasions She may become mad with Divine Love. It is a real struggle to keep the mind down. Therefore, Mother puts on a temporary veil which can be removed at any time. It is this veil which helps the mind to remain in this physical plane. This veil can be removed by mere will whenever Mother wants. Children, innocent love can easily take us to that inexpressible experience. Therefore, try to develop that love in your heart.”

The *bhajan* ended at 8:30 p.m. Even after the *arati* the Mother still sat in the same place, Her gaze fixed beyond. Her right hand rested on the right cheek with the elbows resting on the knee of the right leg which was kept in a bent upright position. Her eyes were still and did not blink. The Mother remained in that absorbed mood for about a half hour and did not leave to go to Her room until nine o'clock.

CHAPTER 12

A DEVOTEE'S EXPERIENCE OF KALI

11 May 1984

A devotee who had a wonderful vision the night before during *Devi Bhava* was sharing it with one of the residents. He was very excited and wanted some clarification about the vision. He related what had taken place. While the residents were immersed in singing *bhajans*, his mind was overflowing with love and devotion for the Mother. They sang a song about the Mother... *Entinamme Hara...*

O Mother, Why do You stand
Keeping Your Foot on Lord Shiva?
Also what have You relished
For Your tongue to stick out?

O All-Knowing One, You always walk around
Like an ordinary girl who knows nothing;
But I know within me that this is how You are,
O Omniscient One.

Though fierce, how pleasant and compassionate
Is Your countenance, O Mother.
My longing to sleep on Your lap
Is becoming more and more intense.



*O Kali, the Enchantress,
People say that You walk around intoxicated,
Having fully drunk.
O Eternal Truth, Who knows
What You drink is the Nectar of Immortality?*

*By placing Your Foot on Your Father's chest,
O Mother, You show us that Your Holy Feet
Can only be attained through the quality of Sattva,
By filling the mind with sattvic qualities.
O Mother, kindly bestow that quality
Upon this humble devotee as well.*

His eyes were fixed on the Mother's face. All of a sudden everything disappeared from his sight. In a whirlpool everything seemed to dematerialize while his eyes were wide open. The temple, the people and the surroundings vanished from his sight. No singing reached his ears. The entire universe with its duality and diverse nature disappeared. He lost his own individuality, and even the Mother's form vanished from his sight. Though he wanted to call or shout aloud, he could not move or speak. He felt as if he were moving out of his body. He experienced that he was different from his body. Then he beheld the entire universe flooded with effulgence. His eyes could not stand the light.

Slowly the light solidified into a form. While he was experiencing great difficulty in seeing, the effulgence evolved into the fierce yet enchanting form

of Mother Kali dancing on the chest of Lord Shiva. There was the Great Mother's infinite spiritual glory and splendor, Her protruding tongue, big red bulging eyes, and the divine weapons which She held in Her numerous hands. Awesome as She was, the devotee was so relaxed and blissful that all the fears he had before dissolved. He expressed it this way: "Her form was such that even Lord Shiva would be afraid to go near Her, but the compassion, love and spiritual bliss which I experienced were like ambrosia, so soothing to the heart that they removed my fear and delusion."

Gradually everything returned to normal, and the devotee was thrown back into the realm of time and space. Coming back to his normal consciousness, the devotee fainted and fell backwards from his sitting position. Some other devotees who attended to him found him perspiring profusely and breathing irregularly. After taking a few gasps of air, he remained breathless for a while. As time passed people became worried, not knowing what was happening to him.

Mother, who had been watching the whole scene with a mischievous smile on Her face, sent a rose that She took from the garland She was wearing with instructions that it be held close to his nose. As soon as the rose was placed near him, he began to breathe normally. Then he opened his eyes and sat upright. The expression on his face revealed much serenity and bliss. As if returned from another world, the devotee looked around to re-orient himself. Finally, he kept his gaze on the Mother's countenance. A special,

sweet smile of inexpressible joy lit his face as he sat in deep meditation throughout the night until the *Devi Bhava Darshan* was over.

The next morning he was still full of bliss and peace. He confessed, "I am unable to control the spiritual bliss I am experiencing which comes from deep within. It is a rare experience that Amma has bestowed upon me." The brahmacharin to whom this experience was being told felt envious of this middle-aged man who had been given the rare blessing to behold the vision of Mother Kali.

Later in the *darshan* hut the devotee once again saw the Holy Mother while She was giving *darshan* to people. He begged the Mother, "Amma, I have no doubt that you are none other than Mother Kali. It is also very clear to me that it was you who appeared as Kali in front of me. Who else could give me the *darshan* of Kali other than you? But, Amma, maybe it is my ignorance, but still I have the desire to hear from your own lips, 'I am Kali. It is I who gave you the *darshan*.' As my Guru and *Ishta Devata*, you must tell me that. Please, Amma, please..."

The Mother kept looking at him. There was an expression of tremendous motherly love and compassion on Her face. A few moments passed as the Mother kept quiet, yet not turning Her face away from this devotee. He began sobbing like a little child. He covered his face with both hands and fell on the Mother's lap. With great love the Mother rubbed his back and tried to console him, saying, "Son... son..."

don't cry, don't cry." But he couldn't help crying. Then She lovingly put him on Her shoulder and whispered something into his ear. As soon as She did this, he burst into a sudden stream of blissful laughter. He jumped up and started dancing. Laughing and crying at the same time with tears of joy rolling down his cheeks, he shouted, "Kali! Kali! Mahakali... Kali has come as my Guru and *Ishta Devata*. Kali! Kali! Kali..." He kept on repeating this until the Mother finally laid Her right palm on his chest to calm him down, and he returned to a normal state.

Later he related that this blissful mood lasted for about two weeks. He revealed that indeed the Holy Mother had whispered in his ears that She was the one who had given him the *darshan* and that She was Kali. That was the reason for his rapturous joy.

DO NOT JUDGE OTHERS

While the Mother gave *darshan* to people, one of the devotees mentioned the name of another person and asked the Mother about him, "Amma, why do you let him come here? He is a very unpleasant person; he has bad character."

Mother said in reply to this devotee's remark, "Son, God descends to the earth for the sake of people in ignorance. They need to be transformed. How can you judge someone when you yourself are plunged in ignorance? Do you know how much that son has changed? Do you know how much he regrets

and repents his past? It is people like him that need the most attention. When someone like that changes for the better, it is of great benefit to society.

“One needs only a little stain remover to remove a small spot, but more has to be applied if it is a bigger and denser spot. Likewise, a person who is already spiritually inclined may not need much attention and care, but a person who has spoiled his life without having any real principles to live by needs greater attention and personal care in order to be re-educated and to lead a worthwhile life. Light coffee needs only a little milk. Strong coffee needs more milk. Mother is ready to take any number of births to help such people. How can Mother abandon them? Who else would take care of them?

“If that son is to be prevented from visiting Mother on account of your judgement, then you need to be driven away. You should get the same treatment. You are more ignorant than he. He, at least, openly admits his mistakes and expresses remorse, whereas you do not even know how much negativity you carry within you. Are you a perfect soul? No, you are not.

“Are you asking Mother to abandon people who are in ignorance? Is the body not a product of ignorance? We do not give it up, do we? This whole world is nothing but ignorance, *maya*. Why do we try to acquire and possess more and more, even after knowing

*Chapter 2, Verse 27: “Death is certain of that which is born; birth is certain of that which is dead. You should not, therefore, lament over the inevitable.”

that all this is illusion? Each one thinks that he himself is good and that others are bad. This is wrong. If you are good, if there is goodness in you, you should be able to see goodness in everything. You see the bad in others because there is bad in you. Children, try to realize this truth. Do not point at the faults and errors of others. Realize your own mistakes and try to correct them. Let your own errors, your own ego, become a burden to yourself, not to other people.

“Only when we become aware of the burden of our own ego will we be able to remove our faults. At present, we cannot bear someone else’s ego or mistakes, but ours is all right. “My ego is beautiful, but his is ugly.” This is our present attitude, and this attitude should go.

“Children, try to be humble. We are here to see God in others, not the evil or ignorance in them. That is what our practice should be. We don’t need a Guru or an ashram to see evil in others. Children, why do you come here? What is the purpose? What is the goal? Undoubtedly, it is to remove your old habits and tendencies. It is to lead a higher life based on spiritual principles. Do not forget that. Do not forget your goal. By seeing ignorance and evil in others, the very purpose of coming here is defeated.

“The feeling of ‘other’ should go. That feeling is due to the ego. Try to see oneness, the whole. Seeing the parts is ego, but seeing the whole is egoless. Seeing the branches, leaves, fruits and flowers as separate, we forget the tree. To perceive the branches, leaves, fruits

and flowers as separate is ego. To see the tree as tree, as a whole, is perfection. Seeing only the hands, legs, eyes, nose and ears as different parts is ego. When we see the body as a whole, that is perfection. But the problem is, we cannot see the whole. We pay attention only to the parts. We concern ourselves with division, 'the other,' separate from us. Mother does not see parts. Mother sees only the whole. Mother sees only God, the Supreme Atman. Mother cannot do otherwise. Children, seeing 'the other' will divide us, but seeing the whole will lift us to the undivided state. Therefore, try to be egoless; try to be humble."

The devotee felt guilty for his thoughtless comment. He said regretfully, "Amma, I am sorry for making that comment. Amma, please forgive me for my ignorance. You know what is best for everyone. My ignorance is so dense that I forgot all about your omniscience and made that thoughtless comment."

Ever-compassionate, the Mother affectionately patted him on the back and said, "No problem, son. It happens. That is the nature of the mind. Think how many times a child falls down and injures his body before he learns to walk properly! Committing mistakes is quite human, but try to refrain from doing it again and again. Try to learn a lesson from every mistake you make and try not to repeat it. If it happens accidentally, no problem. Don't worry. But consciously making the same mistake again and again is a tendency of the lower instincts. Don't do that. Try to overcome

that weakness. If you persist in that weakness, it will ultimately push you into darkness from which there is no escape.”

Mother got up and walked towards the coconut grove. She started walking around under the trees with Her hands held behind Her back. After a while She sat down in the shade with Her eyes fixed on the vast expansive sky. Seeing Mother sitting alone and thinking that She might like to be away from people for a while, Brahmacharin Nealu put a sign up on a coconut tree not far from where Mother was sitting. It read, “Please do not disturb. Amma wants to be alone for a while.”

Out of his love for Her, Nealu always felt that Mother was working too hard and that She needed a lot of solitude and rest. He was very concerned about Mother’s health. Thus, whenever he had the opportunity, he attempted to serve Her in this manner. Sometimes when Mother was resting, Nealu guarded the door to Her room and let absolutely no one go inside. However, if Mother found out about his efforts to give Her ‘peace and quiet,’ She would invariably see to it that his plans were spoiled. Still, all the past attempts and failures on his part did not change Nealu’s attitude. He was ingenious at implementing new ideas in order to give Mother some rest. Now he was trying again.

Having posted the sign on a tree, Nealu sat a few yards away, ready to prevent anyone who might dare

trespass. After a short time and for no apparent reason, Mother called a brahmacharin to Her and started conversing with him. In no time Mother was again surrounded by devotees, brahmacharins and householder residents. Poor Nealu did not know what to do. With a discouraged and frustrated look on his face, he removed the sign, muttering to himself, “What to do! Amma doesn’t want solitude or rest.”

Sitting in the coconut grove surrounded by devotees and residents, Mother sang a song... *Hamsa Vahini...*

*O Goddess Who rides the Swan
Mother Saraswati (Goddess of Wisdom)...
Who is the Moon to the entire Universe
Who resides on Sringeri Mountain
Who plays in the bliss of music...*

Mother has Her own way of doing things. Trying to do something against Her wish and will is foolish. One cannot set any limits on *Mahatmas* like the Mother. They are beyond all limitations. One cannot fit them into a frame of rules and regulations or set conditions for them. Such boundaries are for ordinary mortals. But once we transcend the world of duality, our words and deeds become the law. Then we will not be bound by anything.

CHAPTER 13



INEVITABILITY OF DEATH

22 June 1984

A reception for the Mother, followed by a *bhajan* program was being held in Alleppy, a town forty miles north of the Ashram. As the van carrying Mother and Her children drove on the highway, they passed the corpse of a boy who had been hit by a car. Mother advised, “Do not look on that side of the road. The sight might haunt you during meditation.” Silence prevailed as the van drove by the accident.

Then Mother continued, “We will understand how silly this life is if we realize that we are next. To really have the awareness that we will die will help increase detachment. Death always follows us like a shadow. Knowing and understanding the inevitability of death, one should strive hard to realize the eternal truth before the body falls off. Nobody knows who is next. Nobody can predict it.”

One of the brahmacharins quoted a great scholar and a Realized Soul, who wrote the *Srimad Bhagavatam* in Malayalam based on the Sanskrit original: “Even when people see their own loved ones dying right in front of their eyes, they are full of hopes and expectations about life. Alas! Never do they think

*In India it is a customary ashram practice to chant from Chapter 15 of *Bhagavad Gita* before partaking of food. This chapter embodies the quintessence of *Vedanta*, and it also discusses the digestive processes and the vital energies involved.

that death will come to them one day. Even if they do think about it, their conviction is that it will not happen for the next hundred years.”

Amma’s responded in this manner, “That Great Being was right. Mother has heard a story. There once was a king who wanted to know when he would die. He summoned an eminent astrologer who could predict the future. In studying the king’s horoscope, he made some astrological calculations and found that the king was going to die that very evening at dusk. One can easily imagine the great dismay of the king when he heard this, for naturally he did not want to die. He wondered how he could escape death. Now, this is not surprising. Who wouldn’t try to save his own life if it were threatened or if he learned that he were to die at a particular time? The king acted quickly. He immediately summoned all the great scholars in his land and ordered them to find a way to overcome death.

“The scholars convened and began discussing and disputing. They searched many different scriptural texts to find a way to save the king’s life. When one learned being suggested something – a way, a ritual or a mantra – another scholar would refute it and recommend another method. Thus it went on and on without reaching any conclusion. Afternoon fell and still no conclusion had been reached. The king became very restless. He yelled at the scholars, ‘Hurry up, hurry up! Quick! It is getting late.’ But the scholars, as usual, were caught up in the words of the scriptures.

They could not move beyond the rhetoric and their dispute. Finally a wise elderly man of the court whispered to the king, 'Sire, do not rely on these people. They will not find a solution. If you want to save your own life, take the fastest horse you have and go as far as you can away from the palace before dusk falls. Don't waste any time. Start right now. Go!'

"To the desperate king this sounded like a good idea. Soon he was flying on the best horse from the royal stables. Before dusk fell he had traveled hundreds of miles away from the palace. Exhausted, the king wanted to rest, so he dismounted and lay down under a tree. Lying there on his back, he began thinking about the events of the day and was feeling happy that he had tricked death by leaving the court before nightfall. Since he felt safe, he glided into sleep. Soon dusk fell and all of a sudden, death jumped out from nowhere. His thirsty eyes fell on the king as he declared victoriously, 'I knew you would come here. I have been waiting for you here by this tree. I was beginning to get worried, thinking that you would not make it in time. Anyhow, you got here just in time. Thank you.' In no time the helpless king was in the grip of death."

Thus Mother finished the story. The van continued along the road for a while, and again She spoke: "Children, who can run away from death? When you are born, death also comes with you. Each moment of your life you are getting closer to death. People are

not aware of this. They are so enmeshed in pleasures of the world that they totally forget this. There is no time when death does not exist. In fact, we lie always between the jaws of death. The wise ones are aware of the inevitability of death and try to transcend it.

“While living ‘in life,’ a wise person acquires the mental and spiritual strength to live also ‘in death’ or to live in eternity beyond death. He dies to his ego. Once one dies to the ego, there is no person, and thus there is no one to die. Such people are so full with life that they do not know death. Having transcended death, they know only life, ever-pulsating life everywhere. They become the very essence of life. Death is an unknown phenomenon; it does not exist for them. The death that we know about – the perishing of the body – might happen to them, but that death is only a change for them. They do not fear death of the body. But in life and through death they will remain as the essence of life which will assume another form if they so wish.

“The waves are nothing but the water. After one wave rises and falls, the same ocean waters take the form of another wave in another place. Whatever form or shape they may take, they are nothing but the ocean waters. In a similar manner, the body of a perfected soul may also die like the body of an ordinary human being. The difference is that while a mortal human being considers himself a separate entity—a part, different from the Supreme Consciousness like a single wave isolated from the ocean—a perfected soul

is fully aware of his oneness with the Absolute. He knows he is not an isolated wave but the ocean itself, even if he has taken human form. Therefore, he does not have any fear of death. He knows that it is a natural phenomenon, only a change. He knows very clearly that just as a wave rises up, dies away and rises up again in another shape at another place, the body too must pass through birth, death and birth again. *Mahatmas* know that they are the ocean, not the wave. They are the *Atman*, not the body. But an ordinary person thinks that he is the body, an isolated wave, and that he is finished forever when the body dies. This fills him with fear because he does not want to die. Thus he grieves when he thinks of death. He wants to run away from death.”

A devotee who was traveling in the van with Mother quoted from the *Bhagavad Gita** in which Krishna tells Arjuna not to grieve about death. He paraphrased in his own words: “Arjuna, death must happen after birth and birth must follow death. Therefore, do not grieve, thinking of this inevitable phenomenon. There is no meaning in it.”* What Amma had just said was a beautiful interpretation of Krishna’s words.

One swami, author of a very popular spiritual book, was also traveling in the van. He sat in the seat just in front of Mother. The whole time they were traveling, the swami was looking at Mother’s image re-

flected in the rear-view mirror of the van. He remarked like a child, "I can see Amma's image in the mirror." Mother laughed and gave a retort, "You will be able to see God everywhere when the mind is cleansed of all its impurities and made into a clear mirror."

A brahmacharin, still remembering what they had passed on the road previously, asked Mother a question, "Amma, you said that those who did not have enough mental strength should not look at the corpse of the boy hit by the car because that would haunt them during meditation. Why did you say that?"

"Son," Amma said smiling to him, "that is the nature of the mind. Whatever we do not want to think about will come first. Let Mother explain this with another story. A king who was completely bald-headed had an intense desire to have his head full of thick, black hair. So sensitive was he about his baldness that he always wore a turban. He tried many different kinds of medicine and underwent various types of treatments, but nothing worked. Feeling very sad and desperate, he finally summoned the most renowned and eminent physician of the land and ordered him to invent a medicine to produce the growth of hair. 'If you fail,' the king threatened, 'you will be beheaded.'"

"Such an order from the king threw the physician into a great dilemma. Although he knew clearly that there was no such medicine for baldness, he could not tell the king that. For if he did, that would be the end

of his life. Therefore, the physician decided to tackle the problem in a diplomatic way, hoping that he would somehow be able to save his own life. Bowing low with all humility in front of the king, he replied, 'Your Highness, I consider it a great privilege to make the medicine for you. I am honored. But, Sire, please be kind enough to grant me two weeks time to make this very rare medicine.' Since two weeks did not seem too long a time to wait, the king agreed.

"Two weeks later the physician appeared with the specially prepared medicine. In the private royal apartments, he presented the medicine to the king. The king was exuberant. He felt that his dream of having a head of thick, dark hair was coming true at last. The physician cleared his throat and said, 'Sir, this is an oil which is very rare and precious. I have especially prepared it for Your Highness. I have no doubt that it will take effect in a very short period of time, but...' The doctor stopped in hesitation. His curiosity aroused, the king jumped up from his seat and asked, 'But...what? Speak out!' The physician continued, 'Nothing, nothing serious. It is only a very minor point. While applying the medicine on your head, don't think of rats, that's all. That's all, nothing else, and everything will be fine.'

"The king sat back and relaxed. He thought, 'That is nothing. Not to think of rats while applying the

*When a Great Being comes to the threshold, it is the custom in India to show due respect to this person by washing the feet, placing a garland on him, and waving a camphor flame before him.

oil...’ He sent the physician away after having given him the promised reward.

“The next day a happy king got up early in the morning and took out the medicine from the closet with reverence. After chanting a prayer, he poured a little on his right palm and was about to apply it on his head, and what came rushing into his mind? Rats, big rats, marching in a long procession!” A roar of laughter filled the bus. When that calmed down, Amma completed the story, “The king was shocked and poured the oil back into the bottle. Yet he was not ready to give up so easily. He tried again and again, at different times of the day, outside the palace and in his garden, but each time the number of rats increased. He became so exasperated that ultimately he threw the bottle of oil out the window.”

The story ended with more laughter, and when that finally subsided, Mother continued with these comments: “Children, this is the nature of the mind. Whatever incident, object or idea we want to forget will follow us and haunt us wherever we go, no matter what time of day or what we try to do to forget it. *Sraddha* and devotion are the only ropes with which we can bind this mind.

“We have been living a totally uncontrolled life for so many years. Now whatever we hear or see will easily get imprinted in us. It just rushes into the mind without being invited. It will take time to bring the mind under control. Practice coupled with patience is needed to attain that.”

Mother glanced at everyone in the van with a bright smile on Her face and then started to sing... Sri Chakram... as everybody joined in on the response.

*In the mystical wheel Sri Chakram
Dwells the Goddess Sri Vidya,
That Devi, who is the nature of motion,
The one Power that moves the wheel of the Universe.*

*Sometimes riding on a lion,
Manifesting as the Power of the Creator,
Sometimes mounted on a swan,
O Mother who leads and controls
The Divine Trinity,
Is not the Goddess Katyayani
Yet another of Thy forms?*

*These devotees pay obeisance to Thy Forms
For the alleviation of their miseries.
O Mother, who among human beings
Captivated by Maya understands the truth
That this human body is most despicable?*

*O Mother, Thou who sports riding on a tiger,
How can one in ignorance hope to extol
Thy most exalted majesty?*

Now the van was getting closer to the program site. Mother stopped singing and sat with eyes closed for the rest of the time, deeply absorbed in Her own Self.

Most of the brahmacharins also meditated or repeated their mantra until they reached the temple where a reception was arranged. After the reception, there were *satsang* and *bhajan* which lasted until 10:00 p.m. Then the Mother began to give *darshan* to the thousands of people who had gathered in the temple in order to receive Her blessings. The Mother sat until 2:00 a.m. giving *darshan* until the very last person was individually received.

CHAPTER 14

REMEMBERING GOD WHILE EATING FOOD

23 June 1984

During lunch two brahmacharins were serving the food while another one led the chanting of the fifteenth chapter of the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita*.^{*} Only a few were responding as others kept quiet. Quite unexpectedly the Holy Mother stepped into the dining hall. She was a bit angry at seeing the lack of *sraddha* of the brahmacharins.

“Why is nobody chanting the *Gita*?” asked the Mother. Then came more words of practical wisdom: “One can learn patience if he remembers God even while sitting in front of food. Food is always a weakness for human beings. Nothing enters the mind when we are hungry. We forget what is around us and start eating without caring about others. Once hunger overpowers us, we lose all patience.

“Hunger deprives one of all patience. Even if God suddenly appears in front of a hungry person, he wouldn’t care. If one observes a family in the home, one can see the father, son or daughter getting angry if the mother is a little late in serving food when they come home hungry from work or from school. This lack of patience due to hunger is a weakness. At times like this one may lose all discrimination and pick a fight with another person, no matter who it might be. A spiritual seeker should not fall prey to this weakness. He should be able to remember God and to maintain his mental balance and calmness in front of food, even if he is extremely hungry.

“The human mind is very attached to food. Food nourishes the body, and since we are attached to the body, we are attached to food. The craving for taste is tremendous. Altogether, food is a weak point as far as human beings are concerned. So to maintain patience and remember God while seated in front of your favorite dish is nothing short of working on your attachment to the body.

“In addition, children, remembering God before you take food is a very good reminder to make us aware that we eat to know God, that this food with which the body is nourished is an instrument to serve Him, to pray to Him and to bow down in front of Him. Once again, our remembrance of the Supreme Principle will be refreshed. We always forget God; therefore, we should try our best to refresh this memory at all times. We should try to remember God

from moment to moment until it becomes effortless. Consider the time you sit in front of food as a very good opportunity for that.

“Children, always remember and be aware that you are here for God-Realization and not for ‘Ashram realization.’ The purpose of chanting the Gita before our meals is for each person to remember God, not because it is simply a custom at the Ashram.

“The mind, body and intellect will be purified if you eat food, after having offered it to Brahman, the Absolute Principle. The negative vibrations in the food, if there are any, will also be removed if you chant the *Bhagavad Gita* and the purification mantras with one-pointedness. By doing so, atmospheric impurities will also subside.”

The Mother is beyond everything, yet at this moment She was putting on a mask of anger in order to teach the residents. For a teacher such masks are needed. One brahmacharin laughed while listening to the Mother, thinking that behind this mask is the ‘real person’ who is not at all identified with this mask of anger. (In reality, there is no ‘person.’) “For Mother this is also a play,” he was thinking.

The Mother turned and admonished him, “Don’t laugh. What makes you laugh? Do you think Mother is joking? What good will it do you if you think that this is only another mask of Mother’s and that She is not identified with it? It does not help you to simply ‘write this off’ as just another one of Mother’s *leelas*.

By thinking this is just another mask, you are taking things too lightly. This is not a silly matter. You should consider this seriously.”

The brahmacharin was stunned to see the Mother reading his mind clearly. Before he could express his astonishment, the Mother continued, “Children, do you know the value of food? Do you know how many thousands there are in this world who crave for just one grain of rice to appease their hunger while you laugh and enjoy yourselves sitting in front of this food? Even today before taking food Mother sheds tears, thinking of those who are thrown in the midst of poverty and starvation without having even watered-down rice gruel to appease their hunger. And here you sit and laugh. How can you do that? This is equivalent to laughing at those who are starving. Children, think of them. Let your minds be filled with compassion and love for them. Then you won’t laugh. You must learn to shed tears for them. You need to have real concern for them and to be able to share their sorrow. When will you attain that renunciation? Children, food is God. Have due respect for it.”

The Mother paused for a while. After a few moments, She turned around and spoke to the devotees who were standing near Her, “These children have never experienced the hardships of life. They have not experienced what real life is. They were well taken care of at home. They were masters in their homes; they only commanded and never learned to obey anyone.

Now they should get good training to become ideal servants of the world. To make them understand the seriousness of life, Mother puts on a display of anger.”

Mother got up and went into the kitchen. She returned with a few pieces of cooked tapioca root in Her hands. Mother fed each person with a small piece. Now Her mood was different. Again another mask, the beautiful mask of an all-caring, all-loving Mother.

The Mother’s statement that She sheds tears thinking of those who are stricken with poverty and starvation recalls an incident which happened in the beginning in 1980. One day Mother was not eating. All the pleading to make Her eat failed. There was no apparent reason for Her fast, and no one knew why She was not eating. Mother did not even drink a glass of water. Although everybody tried to find out why, Mother remained quiet. She seemed deeply absorbed in thought, sometimes crying, as She sat alone on the banks of the backwaters. Finally at ten o’clock that night Mother took a little food.

Disclosing the reason for Her fast, Mother said that a few neighboring families were starving. There was nothing to eat, and they could not catch any fish that day. Learning of their distress, Mother did not feel like eating. She wanted very badly to send some food to them, but these families had no empathy towards the Ashram. They were, in fact, dead-set against the Ashram. Years earlier, in the days when the few

residents of the Ashram themselves hardly had anything to eat, Mother had sent vegetables and rice to these families, but they refused the food. Therefore, this time Mother said, "Regardless of their attitude towards the Ashram, Mother would have sent them some food. However, Mother knows that they would not accept it, and by rejecting the food offered, they would be incurring bad karma. Mother does not want that to happen. Whatever attitude they may have about the Ashram, they are also Mother's children, aren't they? Mother must have the patience to bear with them. Who else will have the patience if Mother doesn't? Let us not harbor any bit of hatred or anger towards them. Let us pray to God that they will grow spiritually. Anyhow, now they have gotten something to eat. That is why Mother also ate a little food, to participate in their happiness."

At three o'clock in the afternoon Mother was getting ready to go to Quilon to visit a devotee's home. Some devotees were going with Her, and this time Mother did not ask Gayatri go with Her, even though Gayatri always traveled with Mother wherever She went. No one knew why Mother did not ask her to go, and Mother offered no explanation. Gayatri felt

*Tantric sadhana is the path to attain the state of union of Shiva and Shakti through the acceptance of everything as divine. The vedantins or followers of the path of Non-Dual philosophy, the philosophy of Oneness or Vedanta, are characterized by their stress on renunciation as a means of negating duality.

**An aspect of the Divine Mother.

deeply hurt. Heartbroken, she stood at the edge of the water as the boat carried Mother and the devotees across the backwaters. Reaching the other side, the Mother was about to step into the car when She suddenly told one of the devotees, "Go and fetch Gayatri. She is very dejected. What a pity! This cruel Mother has not called her. How can a loving Mother forget a crying child. Her sorrow is Mother's sorrow as well. We are not going without her." Thus Mother's heart poured out love and compassion for Her daughter. In a few minutes Gayatri came. She was very happy. She still shed tears, not out of sorrow but out of joy, thinking how quickly Mother had responded to the prayer in her aching heart.

Mother reached Quilon by four o'clock. The family members were exceedingly joyful to have the Mother in their home. Immersed in their love towards Her and forgetting what was the proper way of welcoming a *Mahatma*,* they simply stood gazing at Her. The children embraced the Mother, and She caressed them and affectionately asked them about their studies and other things. The Mother went to each member of the family and to all the neighbors and friends present. Lovingly patting a person's back, rubbing another's chest or sympathetically talking to still another, the Mother made every single person very happy.

At the *bhajan* in the evening, the family members, friends, neighbors and others who had come from the nearby area all participated. As requested by one of

the women devotees, the Mother sang *Amme Bhagavati Nitya Kanye Devi...*

*O Mother Divine, the Eternal Virgin,
I bow to Thee for Thy gracious glance.*

*O Goddess of the world
It is just Thy play to create the world
And save it by undoing it.*

*O Thou Whose nature is as the shadow of the
Real,
The Cause of Life, O Thou Who art full of Maya,
I bow to Thee.*

While the Mother sang with rapture, the young lady who had requested the song, burst into tears as she could not contain her tremendous love.

After supper at around 10:30 p.m., the family members wanted the Mother to watch a video movie which depicted the stories and experiences of great devotees of the Divine Mother. To fulfill their wish the Mother agreed to watch this film with them, and as She watched it, She became uncontrollably intoxicated with Divine Love. One of the stories was about a fisherman who had an innocent, pure love for the Divine Mother. He was illiterate, but he had an intense longing to see Devi in flesh and blood. The Mother's mood completely changed as She watched this story. She jumped up from the seat and started dancing and singing. The sounds which She made

while in that rapturous mood were varied, but they cannot be transcribed into words. In ecstatic laughter, the Mother embraced and kissed some of the girls and the elderly lady next to Her as She sat down again.

After watching the video for a little while longer, the Mother got up and went to Her room. She was still in an exalted mood as She left. It seemed that the Mother wanted to avoid seeing the movie anymore, for it might carry Her away into a totally uncontrollable state.

CHAPTER 15

A MIRACLE IN COURT EVIDENCE

27 June 1984

The hour was almost noon as a middle-aged gentleman approached the temple. Brahmacharin Balu greeted him and the man, Mr. V., revealed, "I have been here twice before. After the first two visits, there was a long gap. But still, my devotion to Amma has remained strong. In fact, without Her grace and help, I would have been behind bars by now." He paused. Brahmacharin Balu asked him whether he could bring him something to drink. "Just plain water," he answered. When Balu brought the glass of water, he found him sitting on the south verandah of the temple.

After drinking the water, Mr. V. continued, "I was in great trouble when I came to have Amma's *darshan* that first time. Actually, I came to visit Her to pray for

Her guidance and blessings in order to get out of the serious trouble in which I was entrapped.”

The man told his story. Apparently a case of fraud had been falsely lodged against him by one of his relatives. Since this relative’s family were very influential people, they were able to fabricate the necessary evidence to expose him for fraud. Mr. V. knew that if he were found guilty, his life would be ruined. He had a wife and three daughters and their lives too would be in disgrace. With his family’s reputation ruined, he felt that no men in this world would have the open-heartedness to marry any of his daughters. For himself, it was a matter of life and death because he felt that if he lost the case he would have no recourse but to commit suicide, and if he did, his wife and children would follow suit, feeling that their future was doomed. Mr.V. did not disclose any details about the case, but Balu could tell from his manner of expression that it was something that would have been a total disaster for him and his family.

Mr. V. said that the public knew he was innocent and knew that his opponents, selfishly motivated by vested interests, were deliberately trying to destroy him and his family. Yet such strong and convincing evidence had been fabricated against him that he had no way to refute it or defend himself. There was no legal action he could take to expose their fabrications. He expressed to Balu, “So I had no recourse in which to save myself and my family from the impending catastrophe, but my faith in God, in Mother Kali, was

strong.”

“One day,” he continued, “one of my friends told me about Amma. He even related to me some of his personal experiences with Her, and this instilled faith and confidence in my heart, torn and pain-ridden though it was.” My conviction and faith that Amma was the Divine Mother Kali Herself gave me strength and courage. That was what brought me here to meet Amma for the first time. She really conquered my heart and assured me that I would win the case. I am convinced that Amma is Kali, and subsequently She has clearly verified that to me through experiences I have had since meeting Her.” The man paused.

Balu asked, “Did you get your problems straightened out?”

Mr. V. proceeded to disclose how he prayed to Amma and continued to pray, even though, with each court hearing, it was more and more difficult for his lawyer to refute the points of accusation lodged against him. Everyone thought he would lose, and soon his own confidence and courage became weaker and weaker. He began to wonder, “Are Amma’s words not going to come true? Has She abandoned me?” Yet his faith in Amma remained unperturbed. He continued to pray and supplicate Her every day, undergoing trials of burning in the furnace, never certain about what his opponents would do to him. Finally, when the verdict was reached, he won the case.

“I knew I was going to win because who can refute Amma’s point, that key sentence, that key which

locked the doors from the impending doom,” he said. Words choked in his throat as Mr. V. wept. With great difficulty he controlled his tears and wiped his face. Balu sat and waited, wondering about the last part of his statement about the key sentence.

Upon regaining his composure, Mr. V. cleared his throat and said, “I know you are wondering how it happened. Amma made it happen.” He proceeded to relate what had taken place late one night in his living room when he and his family were at the point of despair.

“Sitting in the armchair, I fell asleep. After awhile I was awakened by a strong light and a divine fragrance which pervaded the entire room. My children and my wife were sleeping on the bare cement floor. They did not seem to be aware of what I was experiencing. I wanted to awaken them but could neither speak nor move. As I was gazing awe-stricken in wonder, the light solidified into the form of Amma...in flesh and blood! She came up to me and affectionately caressed me, smiled at me and in a gentle voice said two sentences. The first sentence was a hidden and unrevealed point concerning the case which I call the ‘key sentence.’ Secondly, Amma told me, ‘Go and tell this to your lawyer right now, immediately after I leave.’ Then She gave me some sacred ash as *prasad* and disappeared without another word.”

As he returned to regular consciousness, he saw that he was still sitting in the armchair and that his family was still sleeping on the floor. After a few mo-

ments of re-adjusting his awareness, he saw that he was holding the sacred ash in his hands. Here was proof of his vision. He called his wife and children, and told about the vision and showed them the ash. The divine fragrance, which was similar to that of jasmine, still lingered in the room, and they could smell it. He glanced at his watch and noticed that the time was 2:30 a.m.

“Taking my motorbike,” Mr. V. recalled to Balu, “I rode to my lawyer’s house five kilometers away. When I told him about the hidden, unrevealed point which Amma had told me in the vision, his face brightened. I told him the whole story about Amma’s appearance. He believed it totally because he, too, was a believer in God. The following day in court, my lawyer argued the case on the basis of this new point which finally saved me.”

Since it was almost one o’clock, Balu requested that Mr. V. come to the dining hall to have lunch. Gently refusing, he said, “No, not now. How can I eat before having Amma’s *darshan*?” He went to the *darshan* hut to sit and wait.

The Mother came to the *darshan* hut around two-thirty. Mr. V. was the first to have Her *darshan*. She received him, exclaiming, “Ah, son, Mother knew that you would come today. You won the case, didn’t you? Mother is happy.” Mr. V. fell at the Mother’s feet and cried aloud. He embraced and kissed Her feet and then put them on his head. He literally washed the Mother’s feet with his tears. Like a child wailing for

his mother, Mr. V. continuously called out, "Amma... Amma... my darling Amma! O Amma! You have saved this poor destitute from hell."

Such a touching scene deeply affected all those who were present, and they found it difficult to hold back their tears, even though they were not aware of what this man had gone through in the last few years. Bending down, the Mother gently lifted him from his prostrate position and made him put his head on Her lap. She held him there for a long time. Mr. V. slowly regained control of himself, and the Mother had him sit by Her side where he remained in a meditative mood for the rest of the *darshan*.

As the Mother received Her children for *darshan*, the brahmacharins sang...*Samsara Dukha Samanam...*

*O Mother of the World,
Dispeller of the sorrows of transmigration,
The shelter of Thy blessed Hand
Is the only refuge for us.*

*Thou art the refuge of the blind, lost souls,
Remembrance of Thy Lotus Feet
Protects all from danger.
For those deluded ones
Who wallow in the dense darkness,
Meditation on Thy Name and Form
Is the only solution for their wretched state.*

*Cast a glance
With Thy beautiful glowing eyes on my mind,
O Mother, Thy Grace is the only means
For reaching Thy Lotus Feet.*

Then the Holy Mother Herself led a song...
Govardhanana Giri Kutayakki...

*O Cowherd Boy
You have turned Govardhana Hill into an umbrella
You have made Radha Your dear friend.
O Krishna, You have transformed my heart
Into Gokulam (Krishna's sporting place).*

*O Enchanting Player of the flute,
Your divine music turns shadows
Into silver-blue moonlight,
Your endearing Name, O Giridhara,
Fills the mind with auspiciousness.*

*O Madhava, Your different moods transform
The sorrows of the heart into nectar,
Your beautiful and pleasing Form
Fills one's life with love overflowing.*

Half way through the song, the Mother slipped into a rapturous mood. Her eyes were fully closed and Her head was tilted a little to the right. The Mother remained still. Lying on Her lap was a woman devotee, who lifted her head up to look at the Mother's face. Seeing the exalted spiritual mood of the Mother, the

devotee gently moved back and sat in a reverential mood with palms joined.

Although the brahmacharins and devotees have seen the Mother ascend to ecstatic planes while singing *bhajans*, giving *darshan*, or chanting the Divine Name, each time it is a new experience. They sit in meditation or look at Her as their *Ishta Devata* or wait in anticipation.

Some time passed as the Mother remained in that divine mood, and when She came back to normal consciousness, the Mother resumed giving *darshan* to the rest of the devotees.

A QUESTION ABOUT TANTRA

While the *darshan* continued, one of the householder devotees put forth a question, “Amma, people who follow *tantric sadhana* think that it can bring quick results. They also think that since everything is divine, there is nothing to renounce. They do not condemn the body as the *vedantins* do.* For them, the body is dwelling place of *Tripura Sundari***; therefore, they consider it pure. Amma, please say something about this.

The Mother said, “Any spiritual path, whichever it may be, involves renunciation. Without practicing renunciation the desired benefit will not be obtained. Mother does not believe that a Perfect Master guiding *tantric sadhaks* allows them to do with their bodies whatever they like. Even if they consider the body

pure, that is no excuse to indulge without discrimination and self-control.

“All paths can bring quick results if they are practiced properly and sincerely with *lakshya bodha*, not only the path of *tantra*. Quick results do not come as a matter of mastering complicated techniques. The path of devotion is the least complicated method. However, all paths lead to the same goal, and all paths incorporate devotion or love as essential to the practice. Even in the *tantric* path love plays a major role. How can one progress without love?

“Now about condemning the body. No path condemns the body or the world. They do not condemn the body in *vedantic sadhana*. After all, how can one perform spiritual practices without a body? It is ridiculous to think that the body is unimportant. Not torturing but training and taming the body is what is needed. A beginner cannot simply declare, ‘Everything is divine, including the body, and therefore, I am going to enjoy and indulge.’ He is not going to reach the goal that way. A certain amount of self-control is absolutely necessary. Otherwise, what is the difference between a *sadhak* and a person who keeps on indulging in sensual pleasures? Realization will not come just like that.

“Realization will come if one can concentrate totally on one’s own Self, forgetting everything else and not letting in a single thought. Even to build up a very muscular body one needs years of constant practice. How much effort is involved to become a good karate

master or a wrestling master? How much effort is involved before one becomes a good musician? Nobody has ever attained anything in this world without making some sacrifices through renunciation and constant effort. Everything we do involves some rules and regulations. So why do people claim that renunciation is not needed in the case of the highest attainment of Self-Realization? Mother cannot agree with them on that point. They may say that they are the Self and that God is within them. They may say, 'You are That. You are the Divine,' and things like this. But they can keep saying things like that for aeons and aeons, and nothing will happen.

"You can get as many people as you want to support you and hail you, telling you that you are Brahman, but that will not bring about Self-Realization. You will still be the same old person. Consider those who have attained Self-Realization, and think about the lives of the great saints and sages. They were the exponents of renunciation, and they did *tapas* and strived hard to reach that state of Self-Realization. Those who have attained it will not speak. They do not go around saying, 'I have attained it. I am Brahman.' Neither will they say, 'No renunciation is needed. You are That already. It is within you.' People who say such things are shallow. Shallow people like to talk. Shallow people do not speak from experience. They have not experienced the depth, because where there is depth, there is no speech. There is only silence. If those who are Self-Realized speak at all, their

speech touches the heart. It purifies and transforms the listener. Their words go directly to the listener's heart. However, when those who say that God is within them speak, their words remain on the surface, in the intellect for some time, and disappear until they hear it again the next time.

"Mother would say that *tantric sadhana* is one of the most misunderstood and misinterpreted paths. In the name of *tantric sadhana* people start drinking, engaging in sex and other licentious and irresponsible behavior. They say that they are offering it to the Divine Mother, but ultimately such people get totally carried away by such indulgence. Their ignorance about real *sadhana* becomes denser and denser, and so they argue that whatever they do is correct.

"What is involved in *tantric* worship is an offering. The fact is, the principle behind the worship is what is to be offered. This offering is not external; it is internal. You offer your individuality, or your ego, to the Divine. Furthermore, the references to sexual union in the worship are not to be taken as something to be done by a male person and a female person. It is the final union, the union of the *jivatman* (individual self) and the *Para-matman* (the Supreme Self). It is symbolic. It symbolizes the union or the integration of the feminine and masculine qualities – the union of *Purusha* and *Prakriti*, the merging of the mind into the Supreme Reality. It is the attainment of a perfect balance between the inner and outer natures of the *sadhak*. It is the experiencing of and becoming established in All-Pervasiveness, which ensues from the union of Shiva and Shakti.

"In that state the *sadhak* transcends everything and merges with the Supreme Principle. That Supreme Oneness is the meaning of sexual union in *tantric puja*. This union of the masculine and the feminine happens within you. It is not external. This union of Shiva (Supreme Consciousness) and Shakti (Primor-

GLOSSARY

{Certain words are the same or similar in Malayalam and Sanskrit. Thus *Abhyasa* and *Brahmacharin* are Sanskrit whereas *Abhyasam* and *Brahmachari* are Malayalam}

ACCHAN: Father

AGAMAS: Scriptures

AMMA BHRANT: Madness for Mother

AMMACHI: The Mother. *Chi* is a word indicating respect.

ANANTASAYANA: The image of Lord Vishnu laying on the serpent Ananta which represents infinite Time.

ANORANIYAN MAHATOMAHIAN: Sanskrit for “Subtler than the subtlest, bigger than the biggest,” a description of Brahman, the Supreme Reality.

APARIGRAHYAM: “Incomprehensible, ”an epithet for Brahman.

ARATI: Waving the burning camphor, which leaves no residue, with ringing of bells at the end of *pūja* (worship) indicating total annihilation of ego.

ARCHANA: A mode of worship by repetition of one hundred, three hundred or a thousand names of the deity.

ARJUNA: The third among the Pandavas and a great archer.

ASHRAMAM: Hermitage or residence of a sage.

ASHWAMEDHA YAGÑA: An elaborate Vedic sacrifice using a horse as the offering.

ATMA(N): The Self

AVADHUT(A): A Realized Soul who has transcended all social conventions.

AVATAR: Incarnation. Great Souls who are fully aware of the purpose of their birth and their identity with God.

BALAVAT: Having the nature of a child, alluding to the nature of a Realized Soul.

BHADRAKALI: See Kali

BHAGAVAD GITA: The teachings of Lord Krishna to Arjuna at the beginning of the Mahabharata War. It is a practical guide for common man for every day life and is the essence of Vedic wisdom. *Bhagavad* means 'that of the Lord' and *Gita* means 'Song', particularly, an advice.

BHAGAVATA(M): The book about the Incarnations of Lord Vishnu, especially Krishna and His childhood antics. It upholds the supremacy of devotion.

BHAGAVATI: The Goddess of six virtues, viz, prosperity, valor, auspiciousness, knowledge and dispassion and lordship.

BHAJAN: Devotional singing

BHAKTI: Devotion.

BHAVA: Mood.

BHAVA DARSHAN: The occasion when Amma receives devotees in the exalted state of the Universal Mother.

BHAVA ROGA: The disease of birth and death.

BHRANTAVAT: Having the nature of a madman, alluding to the nature or appearance of some Realized Souls.

BIKSHA: Alms.

BRAHMAN(M): The Absolute, Whole.

BRAHMACHARI(N): A celibate student under training of a Guru.

BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy

BRAHMATVAM: The state of being Brahman, the Absolute.

CHARA: Spy.

DARSHAN: Audience of a Holy Person or deity.

DEVA(TA): Demi-god, celestial being

DEVI: The Goddess.

DEVI MAHATMYAM: A sacred hymn in praise of the Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness.

DHYANA(M): Meditation.

GITA: See *Bhagavad Gita*

- GOPA(s): Cowherd boy(s), companions of Sri Krishna.
- GOPI(s): Cowherd girl(s), known for their supreme devotion to Sri Krishna.
- GRIHASTA: Householder
- GRIHASTASHRAMI: Householder who leads a righteous life.
- GUNAS: Good qualities. Also, the three qualities of Nature: Sattva (Clarity), Rajas (Activity) and Tamas (Dullness).
- GURU: Spiritual Master / Guide.
- GURUKULA(M): Residential school of a Guru
- HANUMAN: A great servant devotee of Lord Rama who crossed the sea by jumping over it with the power of constant remembrance of the name of Rama.
- HARI BOL: "Praise the Lord."
- HATHA YOGA: Gaining mastery over the body as a means of Self-Realization.
- ISHTA DEVATA: Chosen or Beloved Deity.
- JAPA: Repetition of a mystical formula (*mantra*)
- JIVANMUKTA: A Liberated Soul
- JIVANMUKTI: Liberation.
- JIVA(N): Life force
- JIVATMA(N): Individual Soul
- JÑANA: Spiritual or divine wisdom
- KALARI: Temple. Also, a training ground for the martial arts.
- KALI: The Divine Mother. She is depicted in many forms. Her auspicious form is called *Bhadra Kali*.
- KALI YUGA: Present dark age of materialism.
- KALLI: Thief (feminine).
- KAMA: Desire or lust.
- KANJI: Rice porridge.
- KANYAKUMARI: The southern point of the Indian subcontinent where there is a temple of the Divine Mother as a virgin.
- KARMA: Action.
- KARMA PHALA(M): Results of action.
- KARMA YOGA: The spiritual path of detached action, of

dedicating all the fruits of one's actions to God.

KATALA: Chick peas.

KAURAVA(S): The hundred children of Dhritarashtra, enemies of the Pandavas, who fought in the Mahabharata War.

KENOPANISHAD: One of the main Upanishads or texts on the philosophy of Non-dualism, part of the Vedas.

KIRTAN(AM): Hymns

KRISHNA: Principle Incarnation of Lord Vishnu

KUNDALINI: Spiritual energy depicted as the serpent power coiled at the root of the spine which rises to the head by spiritual practices, leading one to Liberation.

LAKH: One hundred thousand.

LAKSHMANA: Brother of Lord Rama.

LAKSHMI: Consort of Lord Vishnu and Goddess of wealth.

LAKSHYA BODHA: Constant awareness of and intent on the goal.

LALITA SAHASRANAMA: Thousand names of the Universal Mother in the form of *Lalitambika*

LEELA: Divine play.

LOKA(M): World

MAHABHARATA(M): Great epic written by Vyasa.

MAHA KALI: A form of the Universal Mother

MAHATMA: Great Soul

MANASO MANAH: Sanskrit for "Mind of the mind," referring to the Witness Consciousness or Brahman.

MANTRA: Sacred formula, the repetition of which can awaken one's spiritual energies and bring the desired results.

MARGA: The path.

MAUNA(M): Vow of silence.

MAYA: Illusion.

MAYA RUPAM: Illusory form.

MOL(E): Daughter. *Mole* is the vocative form.

MON(E): Son. *Mone* is the vocative form

- MUDRA: A sign by hand indicating mystic spiritual truths.
- MUKTA: The Liberated One
- NAMAH SHIVAYA: The Panchakshara Mantra meaning “Salutations to the Auspicious One (Shiva).”
- NAMAVALIS: Songs consisting of the Names of God.
- NARAYANA: Lord Vishnu
- NARAYANEYAM: A devotional hymn about Lord Vishnu’s Incarnations, a poetical condensation of the *Srimad Bhagavata*.
- NISHKAMA KARMA: Action without expectation of results
- OJAS: Sexual energy transmuted into spiritual energy through spiritual practice.
- PADA PUJA: Worshipping the feet of the Guru. As the feet support the body, it is the Supreme Truth that supports the principle of Guru. Thus His feet are the symbolic representation of that Truth.
- PALUM VELLAM: Milk diluted with water.
- PANDAVA(S): The five children of King Pandu and heros of the epic *Mahabharata*
- PARABRAHMAN(M): The Supreme Absolute.
- PARAMATMA(N): Supreme Self.
- PRAKRITI: Mother Nature or Primordial Nature.
- PRANAYAMA: The practice of controlling the mind through breath regulation.
- PRARABDHA: Responsibilities or burdens. Also, the fruits of past actions manifesting as the present life.
- PRASAD(AM): Consecrated offerings distributed after *puja*.
- PRAVRITTIKA: One who acts.
- PREMA: Deep Love.
- PUJA: Worship.
- PUNDIT: Scholar. *Pundit-mon* is the Mother’s affectionate way of addressing a scholarly devotee, literally “Scholar son.”
- PURANA: Epic.
- PURUSHA: The Supreme Self. Also means “male.”

PUTTU: Ground rice and coconut steamed in a cylindrical vessel.

RAJA YOGA: The Royal Path of Union with the Supreme.

RAMA: Hero of the epic *Ramayana*. An incarnation of Vishnu and the ideal of Righteousness.

RAMAYANA(M): The epic about Lord Rama composed by the sage *Valmiki*

RAVANA: The villain of the *Ramayana*

RISHI: A great sage or seer.

SADA: Always.

SADACHARA PRAVRITTIKAYAI NAMAH: A name of the Divine Mother meaning "One who enforces good conduct.."

SADHAK(AN): One dedicated to attaining the spiritual goal, one who practices *sadhana* (spiritual discipline).

SADHANA: Spiritual practices.

SADHU: Mendicant.

SAHASRANAMA: Hymns consisting of the Thousand Names of God.

SAMADHI: State of absorption in the Self.

SAMSARA: The world of plurality, the cycle of birth and death.

SAMSKARAS: Mental tendencies accumulated from past actions.

SANKALPA: Creative, integral resolve manifesting as thought, feeling and action. The sankalpa of an ordinary person does not always bear corresponding fruit. The sankalpa of a sage, however, always bears the intended result.

SANNYASI(N): Ascetic who has renounced all worldly bondages.

SAPTASWARAS: The seven notes of the Indian music scale.

SARANAGATI: Surrender to God.

SARI: A long piece of cloth worn by Indian ladies.

SATGURU: Realized Spiritual Master.

SATCHIDANANDA: Existence, Consciousness, Bliss – the attributes of Brahman, the Absolute.

- SATSANG: Company of the wise and virtuous. Also, a spiritual discourse by a sage or scholar.
- SATTVIC: Of pure quality, goodness.
- SHAKTI: The dynamic aspect of *Brahman* as the Universal Mother.
- SHIVA: The static aspect of *Brahman* as the male principle.
- SITA: Wife of Rama.
- SLOKA: Sanskrit verse.
- SOUNDARYA LAHARI: Devotional hymn by Sri Sankaracharya addressed to the Divine Mother.
- SRADDHA: Faith. Amma uses it with a special emphasis on alertness coupled with loving care of the work in hand.
- SRI GURU PADUKA PANCHAKA: Hymn of Five Verses to the Guru's Sandals.
- SRI RAMA: See *Rama*. *Sree*, or *Sri*, is a mark of respect
- SRIMAD BHAGAVATAM: See *Bhagavatam*. *Srimad* means 'auspicious'
- TANTRA: A system of Indian philosophy that teaches one to look upon all Creation as a manifestation of the Divine.
- TANTRA SADHANA: The practice of Tantric disciplines.
- TANTRIC PUJA: Worship conducted according to Tantric principles.
- TAPAS: Literally "heat." The practice of spiritual austerities.
- TAPASVI: One engaged in penance or spiritual austerities.
- TAPOVAN(AM): Hermitage, a place conducive to meditation and tapas.
- TATTVA: Principle.
- TATTVARTHA SVARUPINI: A name of the Goddess meaning "The Embodiment of all spiritual principles and their meaning."
- TATTVATTILE BHAKTI: Devotion rooted in discriminative knowledge between the eternal and the ephemeral.
- TRIMURTI: The Divine Trinity of Brahma the Creator, Vishnu the Preserver and Shiva the Destroyer.

TRIPURA SUNDARI: A name of the Goddess meaning “the Beautiful One of the Three Cities (the three qualities of Nature).”

TYAGI: Renunciate.

UPANISHADS: The concluding portion of the Vedas dealing with the philosophy of Non-dualism.

UPASANA MURTI: The form of God which one is meditating on or worshipping.

VAIRAGYA(M): Dispassion, detachment.

VANAPRASTA: The third phase of life devoted to austerities and a secluded life.

VASANA: Latent tendency.

VEDA: Lit. ‘Knowledge’, the authoritative Scriptures of the Hindus.

VEDA VYASA: See *Vyasa*. As he divided the one *Veda* into four, he is also known by the name of *Veda Vyasa*.

VEDANTA(M): The philosophy of the Upanishads which declare the Ultimate Truth as ‘One without a Second.’

VEDANTIN: A follower of the Vedanta philosophy.

VEDIC DHARMA: Injunctions on the righteous way of living as pre- scribed by the Vedas.

VISHNU: All-pervading. The Lord of sustenance.

VYASA: A sage who divided the one *Veda* into four and composed 18 *puranas* and also the *Mahabharata* and *Bhagavatam*.

YAGÑA: Sacrificial rites and rituals.

YOGA: Union with the Supreme Being. Popularly used in the sense of a set of exercises to make the body and mind fit for spiritual practices.



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CHAPTER I

Monday, 2 July, 1984

By eight o'clock in the morning, the night's rain had abated somewhat, but dark clouds still hovered overhead. The Ashram grounds were flooded from the early morning downpour. Except for the thunderous roar from the ocean, the Ashram was quiet and serene.

Because of the rain, the previous night's Devi Bhava had not been as crowded as usual and had ended by one o'clock instead of four or five in the morning. A man who had come to Bhava darshan was sitting on the temple veranda. By his side was a small, old wooden box which looked like a cage. One of the residents approached him and asked if he needed any help. The devotee, a Muslim, replied that he would like to see Amma, even though he had just had Her darshan the night before. As they walked together across the grounds, the man told the resident that he was from Chertalla, a town about 60 kilometers away. He was in the perfume business and earned his living by selling the perfume that he himself made. A week earlier he had come

to Karunagappally, a town very near the Ashram, in order to sell his perfumes. There he had heard about Amma, and that very same day he had come to the Ashram for the first time. Since it was a Sunday, he received Amma's darshan during Devi Bhava and returned to Karunagappally, where he spent the night in a mosque. In the middle of the night he had an unusual experience, which he proceeded to tell the resident.

"I was awakened by the sound of somebody opening my perfume box, this box that I have right here by my side. Startled, I jumped and sat up in bed. I was struck with wonder as I beheld Amma looking through my perfume box. She was just as I had seen Her in Devi Bhava. Seeing the startled look on my face, Amma smiled and said to me, 'Son, Amma was searching for pure sandalwood extract. But there is none here.' She then threw me a quick glance and an endearing smile and disappeared. I was left feeling very sad that I could not give Amma what She wanted. So yesterday, I came with the sandalwood extract and sprinkled it over Her during Devi Bhava. Amma seemed very happy and I too felt blissful doing that. She even exclaimed, 'Oh, you brought it.' From that remark it was clear to me that She knew what had happened that night in the mosque. A surge of devotion arose in my heart and my eyes were filled with tears."

The innocent perfume seller had a big smile on his face. He continued, "I feel that my life's goal has been fulfilled. Now before I go, I would like to see Amma once more and bow down at Her Feet. That is why I am still here."

Just at that moment the Holy Mother appeared on the balcony of Her room. The Muslim devotee stood up and

bowed down in front of Her with all humility. Mother said to him, "Oh son, are you still here? Have you had something to eat?"

He answered, "I stayed behind to see You once again before continuing on my sales journey. By seeing Amma I have had my food."

Amma laughed and remarked, "Son, you are speaking profound words."

The man answered joyfully, "I am speaking the truth."

There is nothing special about pure sandalwood extract for a Mahatma, who is beyond all desires and who is established in the state of supreme detachment. It is not that the Mahatma wants to have an object like that. He does things like this to create a circumstance so that we will be inspired. Such experiences also instill faith and devotion in our minds. They serve as a ladder for the devotee to ascend slowly toward his goal.

A brahmacharin approached to tell Mother that he would not be able to go for the morning meditation because he had some important work to do.

"All right, son," Amma said to him. "Go to the meditation hall and explain to all the others the reason for your absence. Only after doing that can you go and attend to the work. If you are absent without an explanation, others will be tempted to break away from the discipline. Whatever you do, you should try to set an example for others; you should serve as an inspiration to your brothers. Every action of a spiritual seeker should carry a message and a lesson for others. There should be an ideal behind each and every act of a true seeker."

The brahmacharin prostrated to Mother and went to the meditation hall. Mother once again expressed Her love and affection to the Muslim devotee and retraced Her steps to Her room.

WORK WITH LOVE

Later in the day at about 2 o'clock, Amma came to know that the cows had not been fed. She felt very sad about the animals being tied to their stalls, and summoned the brahmacharin who was in charge of feeding them. As he approached Mother, he hung his head and confessed that he had simply forgotten to feed the cows. With great astonishment Amma exclaimed, "What! You forgot to feed those poor creatures that cannot speak to express their hunger and their thirst? Do you, yourself, ever forget to eat or drink? We humans can ask for food when we are hungry, but they can't, can they? This is a great sin. A spiritual seeker should be able to know the feelings of others—not only the feelings of other people but of all creatures. Don't think that because they are unable to express themselves verbally as humans do, other creatures do not have feelings like humans.

"To be able to put oneself in another's position, to be able to see and to feel as another person does, this is the rare gift of an earnest spiritual seeker. Know that these creatures also have feelings. To provide food and drink for them at the correct time, knowing that they, like us, feel hunger and thirst, is a sadhana. Do not feed the animals mechanically. Don't do it just because it is one of the jobs assigned to you. It must not become mere routine. Try to see that the life that pulsates within you and I is the same

life that pulsates within the cows. Try to feel their hunger and thirst, then the work will become a sadhana.”

After saying this, Amma Herself took the fodder from a sack in the storeroom and started preparing the food and water for the animals. With great hesitation and fear, the brahmacharin approached Mother and requested Her to let him feed the cows. Amma turned to him and said, “Don’t say anything now. Mother wants to do this with love. Let these animals feel love in their food.”

The brahmacharin stood next to Amma apologizing profusely and pleaded with Her to be allowed to feed the cows, but Amma did the work without paying any attention to him. As She fed the cows, Amma caressed and rubbed each animal on the face and forehead with great love and compassion. The animals showed their gratitude by rubbing their heads against Mother’s shoulder. There was a smile of contentment on Mother’s face. When the cows finished the mixture of water and feed, the Holy Mother walked over to a nearby haystack, and pulling out some hay from the heap, She offered it to the cows. After once more rubbing and caressing the animals, Amma returned to the Ashram. Only after feeding the cows did She eat that day. It was nearly 4:30 p.m. when She had Her lunch.

There is always a special charm and beauty in whatever Amma does because of the tremendous amount of love She pours into every act. We do not know how to love. There is no love in our actions, and therefore, no beauty in what we do. We are always anticipating the fruit of our actions; the result is restlessness and lack of concentration. A one-

pointed mind and a selfless attitude are very important in order to imbue one's work with love. If these are absent, love is not possible.

HEART AND INTELLECT

At about five o'clock in the afternoon a small crowd of people had gathered on the front veranda of the meditation hall. In the heart of this gathering was Mother, surrounded by the brahmacharins and householder residents of the Ashram, all experiencing the blissful state of singing the Divine Name. Amma sang the lead and the group responded to *Kamesha vamakshi*. . .

*Salutations to Shakti, the Great Goddess
Who is accessible through devotion;
Salutations to the Seed,
The One Truth,
Infinite and Perfect Awareness.*

*O You, who are the left eye of Shiva
Fulfilling all desires
And shining through all that is animate
and inanimate,
O my Kamala, Ruler of all,
Protect us*

*Goddess of the celestials,
Protect them from all sorrows.
O Pure One,
Protect even the Lord of the Ocean of Milk (Vishnu).*

*The Creator does His work due to Your glance.
Salutations to You who came forth from Brahma,
As Saraswati, the Seed of the entire Universe.*

After the song there was a meditative atmosphere for a while. When Mother looked at Her children with an inviting smile, one of the brahmacharins asked, “Amma, this afternoon while you were feeding the cows, I heard you tell the brahmacharin not to speak, that you wanted to do the work with love so that the animals could feel it. I didn’t understand the real import of what you said, but it sounded to me that there must be some connection between love and speech. Could you please explain?”

Amma replied, “Son, you are not wrong, but the real connection is not between love and speech. The real connection is between love and silence. When there is real love, there is silence. There cannot be any words—there is only stillness. Just like a perfectly calm lake, there cannot be any ripples or waves when real love is experienced. Ripples and waves are a distortion, a distraction, a disturbance in the mental lake. Love ensues from stillness of mind. In that stillness one can experience silence. The talking of the mind stops completely. Real love is felt in that silence. Silence is the only language of pure love.

“Real love exists in the heart. The love that exists in the heart cannot be spoken; it cannot be put into words. The heart is not the place for words. Words are part of the intellect. The intellect can speak, but it is nothing more than a tape recorder; it records and spits out words and words and words—words that don’t contain any feelings. The intellect cannot feel compassion; it cannot feel love or kindness. It

can only reason. It will even try to reason out love and compassion. Son, where there is too much talking, there is no love. One who really loves is constantly in a meditative mood. Thoughts cease to exist in the presence of such love. The true lover only meditates; he never thinks. All his thoughts are about his beloved, so there are not numerous thought waves in his mind. Only one thought prevails and that singular thought is about his beloved. When there is only one thought, there is no mind. The lover's constant single-minded focus on the beloved touches the innermost recesses of his heart, where words and speech cannot reach. All explanations stop. No more elaboration is possible then. The lover gets drawn into a constant state of meditation. At that point the two become one.

"Meditation prevails in real love. You become silent and remain at rest in your own Real Self. One cannot speak when one is at rest in one's own Self. That is why Lord Dakshinamurti, the first Guru, always remained in silence. It is said that Lord Dakshinamurti taught his disciples through silence. He did not speak, and his disciples did not speak either. But the Lord taught and the disciples understood him.

"But now nobody will understand the silence of a real lover or a meditator. They may consider him strange or call him crazy because the silence of meditation is unknown to them. They are familiar only with words, and the so-called love that they have experienced cannot exist without words. They feel it is impossible to express love without words. However, in that experience of oneness with the beloved, there is no speech. You become silent and still. This state is known as samadhi, a state where you are in constant meditation."

Amma paused for a while and then continued: "There is a story about Lord Shiva and His Holy Consort, Parvati, which will clearly illustrate what is meant by the silence of oneness with the beloved." Thus She proceeded to relate the following story as the devotees listened attentively.

One day Lord Shiva and Parvati were conversing. Shiva, who was always established in the state of samadhi, often wandered about, leaving Parvati alone on Mount Kailash. At a point when Parvati could not bear the pain of separation anymore, She asked Shiva to teach Her how to enter into the state of samadhi so that She could always remain in Oneness with Her Lord. The Lord agreed and instructed His Holy Consort to sit in the lotus posture. He told Her to close Her eyes and meditate, fixing Her gaze within. As Parvati meditated, Shiva asked, "What do you see now?"

"I visualize Your Form in my mental eye," answered Parvati.

Shiva instructed Her further: "Transcend that Form. What do you see now?"

"I behold a brilliant light."

"Now go beyond the light. What next?"

"The sound 'Aum.' That is what I hear now."

"Go beyond the sound. What do you experience now?"

"No answer came to this last question. Her individuality disappeared and dissolved. She became one with Her Lord. In that state there was nobody to speak or listen. She attained the final state of love, the eternal and inseparable union with Her Lord, where the mind with its words and intellectual thinking cannot reach. "

Amma paused at the end of the story. Then She continued, "Whether this story actually happened or not is not important.

Try to imbibe the essential message that the story conveys. A person who always thinks intellectually cannot understand the feelings of the heart. He cannot understand the meaning of meditation and love. He knows nothing but talking. What's the use of such an intellect?"

Mother paused and the brahmacharin immediately spoke up, "The entire existence of life itself is indebted to the human intellect. What about all the scientific inventions and all the developments of the modern age! They have all been made possible by human intellect. Amma, are you saying that the intellect is useless?"

"Son, try to understand clearly." Mother explained. "Try to be very attentive when you listen to Mother. Remember to use the heart instead of the intellect.

"Children, Mother is not trying to say that the intellect is entirely useless. It is needed; it is absolutely necessary. But it has an appropriate place of its own. Put it where it belongs. Do not use it inappropriately. To place inordinate emphasis on the intellect is dangerous. That will spoil the beauty of life. Too much intellect and not enough heart will cause conflict, disappointment and frustration. There should be a balance between the heart and the intellect. If we penetrate deeply into all aspects of life, we will find that love is hidden behind everything. We will discover that love is the force, the power and inspiration behind every word and every action. This applies to all people, irrespective of race, caste, religion, or profession.

"To an outsider, a scientist making experiments in the laboratory appears to be doing solely intellectual work. Most people will say that his work takes brains, and therefore it is intellectual work and not something that involves the heart. But look carefully into the process. What will be revealed

is that there is love in his work, that his heart is engaged in the work. In fact, if you can really see, you will understand that without love one cannot do that kind of work. In reality, the more you observe, the more you will realize that love is the force behind all scientific experimentation and inventions; it is behind all work.

“Love sharpens the intellect. The more love you have, the more sharpness and clarity you will have. You may call it a sharp or subtle intellect, but it is love that is working behind that sharpness or subtlety. It is just a question of realizing this. Some realize it, and some don’t.”

The brahmacharin was listening thoughtfully, but he wanted further clarification: “Amma, I understand, but not completely. Please be kind enough to elaborate a little more.”

Amma continued, “Son, no work can be performed without concentration. Whatever the work is, mental or physical, and whether it is easy or difficult, exciting or mundane, concentration is required. **Now, what is concentration?** Concentration is nothing but stillness of mind. Concentration stops the flow of thoughts. When thoughts stop, the restless mind ceases in its activity and stillness is possible. That stillness of the mind comes only as a result of love. For a scientist it is the love to be inventive and to experiment which helps him dive deeply into his work. He loves to work hard. The common terms used in relation to this are ‘interest’ or ‘sincerity’ or ‘intense desire.’ These terms are synonymous with love. Without love there is no interest, no sincerity or intense desire. Isn’t that correct?”

“Amma, in that case, why this differentiation between heart and intellect? They’re almost the same thing, aren’t they?”

“In the ultimate sense there is no difference at all. But in your present mental state, there is a difference which you yourself impose due to your ignorance. You have not yet reached the Supreme State of Oneness. You are still in the world of duality. You are still in the world of words and phrases—the world of differentiation—hence, this explanation. Once the limitations are surpassed, then there is only love, nothing but Divine Love. In fact, all these explanations and different terms are only to make you understand that experience alone can reveal Truth, and that words and explanations will not do much good.

“When thinking and reasoning predominate in a person, we call him an intellectual. And when there is more love and compassion, we call it heart. Both heart and intellect are needed. In fact, as far as the intellect is concerned, what we really need is not just thinking, but discriminative thinking, a discriminative intellect. We need to be able to think properly and discriminate between good and bad, and we also need a good heart in order to feel and express love. Heart and intellect are necessary for both a sadhak and a person who leads a regular life. Usually, this balance between the heart and the intellect is hard to find.

“Children, love is our real nature. We are of the nature of Divine Love. That love is shining in each and every one of us. As love is our innate nature, there cannot be any manifestation of any kind without this power of love behind it.

“Certainly the scientist who is inventive and who experiments has love in him. But that love is limited to a narrow channel. It is directed only to the scientific field in which he works. It doesn’t embrace all creation. He is more or less bound to the laboratory where he sits, or to the scientific

equipment which he uses. He does not think of real life. He is more interested in finding out whether there is life on the moon or on Mars. He is more interested in inventing nuclear armaments.

“A scientist may claim that he is trying to find the truth of the empirical world through an analytic approach. He dissects things to analyze how they function. If he is given a kitten, he is more interested in using the animal for research than in loving it as a pet. He will measure its rate of breathing, its pulse and blood pressure. In the name of science and the search for truth, he will dissect the animal and examine its organs. Once the kitten has been cut open, it is dead. Life disappears and any possibility for love is gone. Only if there is life is there love. In his search for the truth of life, the scientist unwittingly destroys life itself. Strange!

“Life is love. To see and feel life in everything is love. Life is not on the moon or in the sun. On the contrary, the moon is life, and the sun is life. Life is here. Life is there. Life is everywhere. There is nothing but life. It is the same with love. Wherever there is life, there is love and vice versa. Life and love are not two, they are one. But ignorance about their oneness will prevail until Realization comes. Until Realization comes, the difference between intellect and heart will continue.”

There was a deep silence. Everyone’s gaze was fixed on Mother’s face. She was expounding a profound truth with the greatest simplicity. Everyone sat spellbound until the silence was broken by the flow of Amma’s nectarous words as She continued.

“A scientist is more concerned about the outside than the inside. He is more interested in the parts than in the

whole. He is so engrossed in the world he perceives, that he is totally unaware of the inner universe. He has many great ideas. He is endowed with a sharp intellect, but his love is limited to the scientific field only. It does not embrace everything. Mother would say that a real scientist should be a real lover—a lover of mankind, a lover of all creation and a lover of life.

“A rishi is a real lover because he has dived into his own Self, the very core of life and love. He experiences life and love everywhere—above, below, front, back—in all directions. Even in hell, even in the nether world, he sees nothing but life and love. For him there is nothing but life and love shining forth with splendor and glory from all directions. Therefore, Mother would say that he is a ‘real scientist.’ He experiments in the inner laboratory of his own being. He never creates division in life. For him life is one whole. He always dwells in that undivided state of love and life.

“The real scientist, the sage, lovingly embraces life and becomes one with it. He never tries to fight with life. While the scientist tries to fight and conquer life, the sage simply surrenders to life and lets it carry him wherever it may.”

As She finished the last sentence, Amma entered into a state of samadhi. Her eyes were wide open, but they were still. Her body didn’t move at all; it was so motionless that one could not even detect the rise and fall of Her breath. Amma’s exalted mood lasted some time. While Amma was absorbed in samadhi, one of the brahmacharins sang a song, *Anupama gunanilaye*. . .

O Mother, O Goddess,
Abode of unique qualities;
You are the Support of those seeking refuge.
O You who are modest due to Your wisdom,
And gentle, due to love,
Give me a bit of Your compassion.

Even without my saying it,
You know that I don't know enough
To know anything.
Reveal Your Feet and bless me,
for I am falling into the ocean of misery.

STILLNESS OF MIND

When She came down to the normal state of consciousness, the same brahmacharin asked another question. "Amma, you said that concentration makes the mind still. I have heard that scientific research and experimentation require a tremendous amount of concentration. If so, scientists who spend hours and hours in the laboratory, sometimes even days on end, must experience that stillness of mind. Isn't that true? Is that kind of stillness and the stillness that you are speaking about, one and the same? If not, what is the difference?"

Amma replied, "That is a very intelligent question. Son, though both of them may have a mental stillness, there is vast difference in their experiences. A scientist might experience a certain kind of stillness when he concentrates on a particular experiment or when he is in the process of inventing something. But when he leaves the laboratory, he becomes the same man again. Even though a scientist,

he too has vasanas. Controlled by his old habits and vasanas, he will be forced to act according to his mind and desires. He can't remain there in that state of 'no-thought' for long. The scientist can't hold on to the experience of stillness for any great length of time. It simply begins when he enters the laboratory and ends when he comes out. It is true that when a person has one-pointedness, a certain stillness of mind is gained. It can happen even to a layman at certain times. Mother will agree that the concentration is more intense in the case of a scientist than in the case of a layman. The scientist's mind is subtler than that of the layman. The stillness of mind gained by the one-pointedness of the scientist is a special gift, but this kind of stillness does not last long. It comes and goes. It happens when he is in the midst of test tubes and machines, not in his real life. In real life he might be a total failure.

"Children, a rishi's stillness of mind results from the total dropping of the mind. In whatever circumstance he is, the rishi's mind is always still, irrespective of time and place. He goes behind the mind stuff and attains the state of 'no-mind.' The ego dies in him, and thus he is egoless, completely free from the grip of desires. On the other hand, the scientist still carries the burden of ego and still has many desires. Completely emptying the mind, the rishi has fully unburdened the weight of the ego. He is completely free because nothing weighs him down. He is like a mirror, pure and clear as crystal, with no images of its own. If you see any images, they are all reflections, and reflections do not belong to the mirror. The mirror simply reflects. It neither owns nor disowns anything.

"The kind of stillness that you were talking about sometimes happens to a poet when he writes poetry or when

he is lost in thought about a theme while looking at nature and weaving his own imaginations. Stillness can come to a farmer as he fantasizes about his crop and the immense harvest that he is going to reap. An ordinary lover who contemplates his beloved can also have the same experience. But these people are all still egocentric. They are still on the mental plane. They are all overburdened. Their heads are full of thoughts, ideas and plans for the future. Once they come out of their so-called stillness, which does not last long, they are once again the same old small ego.

“A scientist keeps adding to his existing ego. He gathers more and more knowledge, more and more information, which only inflates the ego. However, a rishi is completely empty. He becomes like a corpse in a river. He lets the river of life carry him anywhere it likes. The scientist is externally full, full of knowledge about the world. The rishi is internally full—full of the experience of Oneness with the Supreme Absolute. The scientist sees many; the rishi sees One. The scientist is only a part of existence, while the rishi is the whole of existence. While the scientist burdens himself with facts and figures, the rishi becomes empty so that all knowledge can pass through him without affecting his experience of that Oneness. While the scientist limits and narrows his vision, the rishi expands and embraces the entire universe.”

Mother stopped talking and asked the brahmacharins to sing *Kodanukoti*. . .

*O Eternal Truth
For millions and millions of years
Mankind has been searching for You
The ancient sages renounced everything,*

*Performed endless years of tapas,
To make their Self flow
In meditation
Into Your Divine Stream*

*Inaccessible to all, Your Infinitesimal Flame
Glowing like the effulgence of the sun
Stands still without even dancing
In the fiercely blowing cyclone.*

*Flowers, creepers and shrine rooms,
Temples with newly installed sacred pillars,
All are waiting for You
For aeons and aeons,
Yet still You are inaccessibly distant.*

PRAYING AND CRYING TO GOD AS MEDITATION

Friday, 6 July, 1984

Amma was giving darshan in the hut. One of the devotees asked, “Amma, I know only a little about spirituality. I have faith in Mother and I want to lead a devoted and dedicated life. Could you please tell me something about becoming more spiritual?”

Mother gave him this answer: “Son, first of all, you should give up the idea of becoming more spiritual. Just try to pray sincerely to God and meditate on Him. Don’t think about becoming more spiritual; for that very thought can sometimes be a hindrance.

“Cry and pray to God, and sing His glories. Don’t overstrain yourself by trying to sit in lotus posture or holding your breath while meditating on His form. Meditation is remembrance of God, a constant and loving remembrance. Consider Him as your beloved or just consider yourself as His child. Or consider Him as your father or mother. Simply try to think of Him as we think of our father or mother or beloved. How does a lover remember his beloved? Certainly not by sitting in a lotus posture. The remembrance happens spontaneously while he is lying down, walking or sitting on the banks of a river, or it may happen while he is at work. It does not matter where he is or what he is doing. Likewise, remember your beloved deity whenever you can, no matter where you are or what you are doing.

“Contemplate Him as your creator, protector and the final abode to where you will return. Try to feel Him with your heart; try to feel His presence, grace, love and compassion. Open your heart and pray to Him, ‘O Lord, my creator, protector, and final resting place, guide me towards Your light and love. Fill my heart with Your presence. I have been told that I am Your child, but I am ignorant of my existence in You. My beloved Lord, I do not know how to worship You, or how to please You, or meditate on Your form. I have not studied the scriptures; I don’t know how to glorify You. O Compassionate One, show me the right path, so that I can return to my real home which is nothing but You.’

“Children, pray and shed tears as you think of Him. That is the greatest sadhana. No other sadhana will give you the bliss of divine love as effectively as sincere prayer. You don’t have to undergo any academic training to love God. You don’t have to be a scholar or a philosopher to worship Him

or to call out to Him. Just call out, but let the call come from your heart. Just as a child cries out for food or to be fondled or cuddled by his mother, call out to Him with the same intensity and innocence. Cry and pray to Him. He must reveal Himself. He cannot sit silent and unmoved when somebody calls Him like that.

“Children, innocent prayers, calling out to the Lord, is a powerful way to please the Lord. You don’t need to be a scholar to do that. Even for an uneducated layman or an illiterate forest dweller, the Lord’s grace can be attained if one is really determined to achieve the goal.

“There is a story which illustrates this point. One of the disciples of the first Sankaracharya was very proud of his devotion to the Lord. His beloved deity was Narasimha, the man-lion, the fourth incarnation of Vishnu. In order to please his beloved deity and to have His vision, the devotee went to the forest to perform intense tapas. For many days he meditated sitting on a rock near the hermitage, and became seriously engaged doing austere sadhana. The sadhak did not notice that one day a forest dweller came to watch him. The forest dweller observed him with great curiosity but couldn’t understand why this man was sitting in such an odd position, upright with crossed legs. Since the devotee had his eyes closed, the simple man mistook the meditative posture for sleep. The forest dweller was so curious and eager to speak to the sleeping man, that he came every day and waited for hours, hoping that the devotee would open his eyes.

“At last, a day came when the sadhak emerged from his meditation. The simple forest dweller approached him with great respect and asked, ‘Tambra,* why do you always sit

and sleep? Why don't you lie down?' Seeing the innocence of the forest dweller, the devotee laughed and said, 'Oh, silly man, I am not sleeping. I am meditating on the form of my beloved deity.'

"Of course the forest dweller didn't understand anything. Having lived in the forest all his life, he was uneducated and illiterate. 'Meditating? Beloved deity? What is that?' he exclaimed. The devotee said, 'You do not understand this sort of thing. I am calling and praying to my Lord.' The forest dweller again wondered, 'What! Calling someone without moving from this place? Why don't you go and look for him?' The devotee did not reply. He simply smiled and went back into meditation.

"Days passed. The forest dweller's curiosity wouldn't let him rest. Unable to control his urge to know more about the person whom the devotee was searching for, he once again approached the sadhak. With great hope he asked, 'Tambra, who is this man you are calling? Can I help you find him?' The devotee was extremely pleased with the man's sincerity. Since he knew that the forest dweller would not understand anything about meditation or other techniques of sadhana, the devotee said, 'Look here, the person I am calling is not a human being but a peculiar kind of lion, a supremely powerful man-lion.' With this answer the forest dweller was satisfied.

"The days rolled into months and during this time the two became close friends. The forest dweller felt sad about his tambra, who was always sitting in meditation, forgoing food and sleep. He thought, 'What a disobedient creature this man-lion is! Look at tambra; he has become so lean and weak for want of food and sleep. I must do something

to help him. That arrogant creature, who refuses to respond to my tambra's call, must be taught a lesson!' He decided to set out on a journey to look for the man-lion, but first he wanted to obtain permission from his tambra. The innocent forest dweller waited for the devotee to open his eyes, then told him of his intention, asking for permission to go. The devotee laughed heartily, 'What a crazy, ignorant man! He thinks the Lord lives somewhere in the forest.' With full conviction that the forest dweller would meet with failure, but thinking that there was no sense in trying to make him understand, the devotee gave his permission. Enjoying the forest dweller's foolishness with great mirth, the devotee again closed his eyes and went into meditation.

"The forest dweller began his search. He went from cave to cave, from bush to bush, over hills and into valleys. He looked everywhere. Not a single place in the huge dense forest was overlooked in his search for the Tambran's lion. Even after he had searched through all the caves, all the bushes, all the hills and all the valleys, he wouldn't give up. He then began calling out, 'Tambrante simham, va, va.' (My master's Lion, come, come.) He became totally unaware of space and time. Feeling neither hunger nor thirst, he became gaunt like a skeleton. His constant call, 'Tambrante simham, va, va,' echoed everywhere in the forest. It filled the atmosphere, creating a constant and very powerful vibration all around.

"The trees, mountains, valleys, bushes, birds and animals stood still when he called out 'Tambrante simham, va, va!' Even without his knowledge the search had transformed itself into an intense inquiry which slowly had burnt away his primitive nature and along with it all his vasanas. The 'mind

stuff slowly dissolved and all thoughts disappeared; eventually even the verbal calls ceased. He became totally silent. Only the all-consuming fire of love burned within him, and this soared directly up, transcending the celestial abode and finally entering the abode of Lord Vishnu Himself. The flames of this supposedly ignorant forest dweller's meditation were so powerful that Vishnu had to respond. Assuming the form of Narasimha, the man-lion, he appeared before the simple forest dweller.

"The forest dweller pulled out a creeper, tied it around the Lord's neck and led Him back to the tambra who was still sitting on a rock with his eyes closed, trying to see the form of his beloved deity. The forest dweller called out, 'O Tambra, open your eyes. Here is your man-lion. I brought him here for you.' The devotee woke up after repeated calls, and he could not believe his eyes. He rubbed his eyes again and again, looked and looked again. Still he could not believe his eyes. His Lord, the magnificent incarnation of Lord Vishnu, was standing right there before him. With one hand the forest dweller was holding a creeper tied around the Lord's neck, and with the other hand he was feeding Him green grass.

"Seeing how amazed the tambra was, the forest dweller said, 'Tambra, come down. Take your lion. He is all right. He is not dangerous. Come on down.' The devotee scrambled off the rock like an insane man and fell down in front of both the Lord and the forest dweller, crying loudly like a child seeking forgiveness. The forest dweller was puzzled by this. Now the Lord spoke, 'Get up, my dear one. Do not feel disappointed. Remember that dear to Me are those who lovingly remember Me, constantly feeling My presence both within and without. The ego cannot exist where there is

real love. Where there is real love, there I can easily enter and dwell.' Having said this, the Lord placed His hand on the forest dweller's head, giving him moksha, final emancipation. The Lord consoled the devotee, saying that he too would reach the ultimate state during this lifetime. The devotee became genuinely humbled.

"The forest dweller had not studied any scriptures, but he had a loving heart. His search was not even for himself but for someone else. This kind of person, endowed with such a loving and compassionate heart, is more dear to the Lord than one who meditates sitting in the lotus posture, proudly contemplating his scriptural knowledge and techniques of meditation and japa.

"Children, taking this story as an inspiration, try to pray until your heart melts and flows out as tears. It is said that the water of the Ganges purifies whoever takes a dip in it. The tears that fill the eyes when one is remembering God have tremendous power to purify one's mind. Such tears are more powerful than meditation. Such tears are verily the Ganges."

Mother always instructs people differently. She sees each being clearly and instructs according to each one's mental caliber and inherited spiritual disposition. Mother advises some to continue on the path that they are following, while She instructs others to do an entirely different form of sadhana. There are cases in which Mother tells a sadhak to continue the same sadhana that he is doing, but with slight changes. Most people who come to see Her are instructed to follow the path of love, devotion, and prayer. Few are those who are told to follow Vedanta, the path of non-duality. According

to Mother, most people are not competent enough to perform Vedanta sadhana. Her strong conviction is that Vedanta sadhana will obstruct people's spiritual growth if it is practiced by immature and incompetent people. Mother believes that the number of people who really understand Vedanta and its implications in life is very small.

Amma says, "Vedanta is not something to be talked about. It is a way of life. It is to be lived. Nowadays in the name of Vedanta people get caught up too much in the head, and they destroy all the beauty and charm of spirituality and Divine Love by indulging in egotistic talking and egoistic ways."

The reader may find it strange that Mother should instruct a devotee not to struggle to sit in lotus posture or to hold his breath while meditating. Instead, She will instruct him to cry to the Lord and pray with innocence. Mother says that many people come to Her with the complaint that they have never had a real 'experience', even though they have been performing intense sadhana for several years. Mother believes that this is mainly due to the lack of love and innocence in their sadhana. To really live and to attain real spiritual experience, one must develop the qualities of love and innocence. Amma says that whatever spiritual path one pursues, it should be built on the strong base of *prema* (supreme love) In the case of the devotee who had asked the question, the path of devotion must have been the sadhana which would help him to grow spiritually, since that is what Amma advised him. A real Master knows what is best for his devotees and disciples.

It was nearly six-thirty in the evening. Amma got up

and walked toward the temple verandah. It was time to begin the evening bhajan. All the residents and the visiting devotees came and took their seats. Soon the chanting began with the accompaniment of the harmonium and the tabla. Amma sang *Adi Parashakti*. . .

*O Primal Supreme Power,
Please bless us, rid us of our distress.*

*O Goddess with eighteen arms,
Whose mount is a lion,
Your eyes are worshipped even by lotus petals,
O You who have a gentle smile.*

*You have a radiant face
And possess all seven virtues in equal measure.
Your anger is like that of a mad elephant;
You are worshipped by the gods like Ajan.*

*O Goddess of the Universe,
Dance forever in my heart,
Consider kindly this suppliant,
Granting me all boons.*

The blissful moments of singing along with Amma and of experiencing a taste of supreme love and devotion lasted until eight-fifteen. After the arati Amma was found lying in the sand not far from the temple. A few brahmacharins and Gayatri were with Her. Since the sand was wet, somebody brought a mat for Amma to lie on. Gayatri pleaded with Her to lie on the mat, but Amma did not move. It seemed

She was enjoying the wet sand. She started rolling on the ground. Taking this as an opportunity, Gayatri spread the mat on one side hoping that Amma would roll onto it as She was turning back and forth; but Gayatri was disappointed because Amma stopped rolling, and lay still in one spot . Pointing Her right index finger skywards, Amma uttered a number of peculiar sounds, which sounded as if they might be a strange and unknown language. Her extended finger remained in the same position for some time while She lay motionless with Her eyes closed. Several minutes passed before she returned to Her normal mood.

One of the brahmacharins who was present during the afternoon conversation asked, “Amma, this afternoon you instructed a young man just to pray and cry for God. If you want to know God, is that enough?”

“Yes,” Mother said, “if it is done with all one’s heart. Son, don’t think that spiritual practice only entails sitting in lotus posture and meditating or repeating a mantra. Of course, those are also ways and techniques to remember God and to know the Self. They certainly will help to train and tame the naturally restless body and mind. But it is wrong to think that those practices are the only way.

“Take, for example, the gopis of Vrindavan and Mirabai.* What was their sadhana? How did they become Krishnamayis (full of Krishna)? Was it through long hours of sitting in a lotus posture doing rigorous meditation? No. But of course they did meditate. They did constant and intense meditation, but not sitting with crossed legs. Devotees like the gopis and Mirabai constantly remembered the glories of the Lord, cherishing His divine form within themselves, irrespective

of time or place. They just cried and cried until their tears washed away their entire mind-stuff, until all their thoughts were gone.

“Children, when we cry we can forget everything effortlessly. Crying helps us to stop brooding on the past and dreaming about the future. It helps us to be in the present—with the Lord and His divine leela. Suppose someone very dear to us dies—say our mother or father, wife or husband, or a son or daughter. We will lament, thinking of him or her, won’t we? We forget everything else. At that moment nothing else comes to our minds except the sweet memories of the departed one. We will have no other interest than thinking about and contemplating that person. Our minds become fully focused on that person.

Children, crying has the power to make the mind completely one-pointed. Why do we meditate? To get concentration. So, the best way to get concentration is by crying to the Lord. That is a very powerful way of remembering God, and that in fact is meditation. That is what great devotees like the gopis and Mirabai did. See how selflessly Mirabai prayed, ‘O Mira’s Giridhari,* it does not matter if You don’t love me. But, O Lord, please do not take away my right to love You.’ They prayed and cried until their whole being was transformed into a state of constant prayer. They kept on worshipping the Lord until they were totally consumed by the flames of Divine Love. They themselves became the offering.

“Once you become the offering, once your whole being is in a state of constant prayer, then what is left is not you but Him. What is left is Love. Prayer can perform this miracle. Crying can accomplish this feat. What is the purpose of

meditation? It is to become love. It is to attain Oneness. Thus there is no better meditation technique than praying and crying to the Lord.

“Supplicate Him. Pour out your heart to Him. Prayer is nothing but emptying the mind, ridding oneself of the *vasanas*. Prayer is nothing but accepting His supremacy and remembering your own nothingness. ‘I am nothing. I am nobody. You are everything.’ Prayer teaches us humility. You are seeking His refuge, His love, His grace, compassion and help, in order to reach Him. You are calling out, trying to reach out. Prayer is surrendering the ego. From deep within you are trying to reach out. You are trying to become expansive. You tell the Lord, ‘O Lord, I have no power. I thought I had, but now I understand that I am helpless. I am in the dark. I cannot see. I am nothing. Guide me, lead me, help me. It was my ego that made me think I was something great. Now I realize that I am helpless. Without Your grace I cannot be anything. . .’ What is this? This is exposing yourself as a totally helpless creature without Him and His Grace. This is humbling yourself. This is the genuine way to exhaust the *vasanas*. There should be the awareness of helplessness; one should feel one’s helplessness. Helplessness will make one humble. Humility in turn will help one get God’s grace as well as human love.”

Amma was still lying in the sand. She stopped for a while. Nobody spoke for some time. Mother asked for something to drink, but when Gayatri brought it, She didn’t drink. Incomprehensible are Her ways. After a long pause, one of the *brahmacharins* said, “Amma, how does the prayer of a mere believer differ from that of a true devotee?”

Amma answered. “Mere believers, as distinguished from

a true devotee, usually pray too. They may use the same terms, and they may engage in the same manner of supplication. In fact the words they use can be identical. But they are just uttering words, meaningless words. They do not truly pray from the heart; they babble. Out of fear or in order to fulfill their desires, they say something, which according to them is prayer. But in reality they are suggesting to God, and even instructing Him, that these are the things they want and those are the things they don't want. They say, 'Give me what I desire and what I like. Do not give those things that I dislike.' How can this be prayer? This is just trying to establish supremacy over God. This is questioning God's omniscient nature. The so-called believer is saying indirectly that he knows better than God what is best for him and what is not. Can we call this prayer? No, we cannot. It is just an exposition of his ego. He still has his own likes and dislikes. His goal is to fulfill his desires. Desire is the central point around which his prayers revolve.

"A true devotee, however, offers himself to the Lord when he prays. Prayer is an offering, an offering of one's own life. Real prayer is real surrender. In real prayer there is nothing to ask, nothing to demand, no suggestions. A true devotee realizes that his Lord is both within and without, that He is all-knowing and all-powerful—omnipresent, omniscient and omnipotent. Understanding this, the devotee simply tries to express his total helplessness to the Lord and accepts Him as the sole protector and guide. In such sincere and open-hearted prayer, the devotee confesses the uselessness and the burden of his ego. Why should one keep a useless thing? Therefore, he prays to the Lord to remove and destroy it. This kind of prayer is real meditation, and it will definitely

take one to the goal. In real prayer the devotee has no likes or dislikes. He wants to give up his ego. He tries to see everything as a manifestation of the Lord. He has no other desires to fulfill except to merge in eternal union with his Lord.”

Another question was brought up: “Can a person be benefited by someone else’s prayer?”

Mother replied, “Yes, that can happen. The concentration, devotion, and pure resolve of the person who prays can affect another person and his desire can be fulfilled. That kind of prayer will work for the fulfillment of a desire, to save someone from danger or to cure a disease.

“But if the goal is to realize the Supreme Being, you should become completely egoless. That requires self-effort. The sadhak himself must pray sincerely for the removal of his negative tendencies. He should work hard. This prayer is not to achieve anything or to fulfill any desire. It is to go beyond all achievements; it is to transcend all desires. It is an intense longing of the sadhak to return to his real, original abode. He feels and becomes aware of the burden of his own ego, and this feeling creates a strong urge to unburden its heaviness. It is this urge which expresses itself as prayer.

“Removal of the ego cannot be attained through the prayers of another limited soul. It takes self-effort and the guidance of a Perfect Master. Working on the ego, or emptying the mind, becomes easier in the presence of a Divine Master. Although Mother has said that somebody else’s prayers cannot help remove another person’s ego, a Satguru’s mere thought, look, or touch can bring about a tremendous transformation in the disciple. If He so wishes, a Satguru can even bestow

Self-Realization on His disciple or devotee. He can do anything He likes. His will is one with God's will.

"If you pray for the fulfillment of petty desires, you are stuck to your mind and all its attachments and aversions. Not only that, you are adding more to the existing vasanas. New desires, new worlds, are created. Along with that, you lengthen the chain of your anger, lust, greed, jealousy, delusion, and all other negative traits. Each desire brings with it those negative emotions. Unfulfilled desires result in anger. In contrast to that, when one prays for purification for the purpose of creating *Atma bodha* (awareness of the Self), the vasanas are destroyed. Such prayers will completely change your outlook toward life. The old person dies and a new one is born. However, praying for the fulfillment of petty desires does not involve any change in one's personality. The person who prays in this way remains the same; his attitude remains unchanged.

"This is not to say that you should not be concerned about those who are ill, or those who are less fortunate than you. Pray for them, that the Lord may help them. This is far superior than praying for little petty desires to satisfy the senses. But remember, if your goal is Self-realization, it is your ego, your vasanas, that have to be removed. This needs self-effort and a Satguru's guidance and grace."

After this discussion on prayer, the melancholy tune of the song, *Karunatan katamiri*, filled the atmosphere. . .

*O Mother, kindly cast a compassionate glance at me
That I may attain peace of mind.
I adore Your Holy Feet in the flower of my mind.*

*Day and night, waves of sorrow
Rise in my mind, overwhelming it.
You are the Ruler of the Earth,
Destroyer of sorrow and Giver of good.*

*Thus, show Your mercy to me.
O Mother, give me a chance
To adore Your Flower-like Feet.
May Your look of compassion fall on me
That I may become filled with Bliss.*

*Kindly shower the nectarous drops
Of Your Pure Love on my mind,
Which is miserable and helpless,
Thus letting me bathe and swim
In the cool waters of the Ocean of Bliss.*

SPIRITUALITY IS GIVING UP THEN TAKING UP

Another question was raised: “Amma, what is the best way in which we can explain spirituality, or interpret it is?”

Mother answered, “Spirituality is not something to be explained or interpreted. It is an experience. In fact, to really know what spirituality is, all interpretations and explanations should end. One should be very receptive. There should not be any inner talking or any judgment. All interpretations belong to the head. All interpretations are borrowed ideas or ideas woven out of some other ideas. They are all repetitions. Spirituality can be experienced only in stillness and silence. It is the dropping of all information gathered from the outer

world.

“Mother has heard a story. There was a Mahatma who never let others know about his greatness. He always carried around a big sack full of toys and toffees. Whenever he saw any children, he gave them toys and sweets. One day, a team of learned scholars stopped him and said, ‘O Revered Holy One, we know that you are a great being. We know you are acting. By carrying around toys and toffees you are trying to put a thick curtain between yourself and us. Please do not delude us. Tell us something about spirituality.’

“Immediately when he heard this, the Mahatma dropped the sack and walked a few yards. The people asked, ‘What is this? We don’t understand the meaning.’ The Mahatma replied, ‘This is spirituality, unburdening the burden of your ego.’ The scholars said, ‘All right, what next?’ Retracing his steps, the Mahatma picked up the sack and put it back on his shoulder. He said to them, ‘This is spirituality: to drop or renounce everything. The heavy sack is your ego with all its negative tendencies, like anger, greed, jealousy, and selfishness. It is a burden. This is the weight that keeps you down. Unburden the weight of your ego. And then, after dropping it completely, you come back and carry it again. But now it is weightless. In other words, don’t carry it again until you feel that it is no longer a burden. The ego is then no longer an ego then, but an apparent ego. It is interesting to watch how the apparent ego works. It is just a play. This Self-made ego is here to amuse this one and also those who approach it. This Self-made ego now contains toys and sweets to amuse children.’

“Children, spirituality is nothing but giving up and then taking back. Spirituality is to unburden everything and then

take the burden back. But this time the burden is no more a burden. To put it in another way: don't take up the burden until you feel that it is weightless. Yes, when you have completely emptied yourself of the inner burden, you take it back—you carry the burden of the world. But now you won't feel any heaviness. On the contrary, you will feel a tremendous amount of joy springing forth from deep within, even while carrying the burden of the world. Previously, it was real suffering, but now there is no suffering at all, because your mind is fully at rest, and therefore, you do not feel it to be a burden anymore. Even though you still perform actions, you are involved and at the same time not involved. You start seeing things from an entirely different angle. You play a role, but you never identify with it. You remain outside. No matter what you are doing, you always feel blissful."

A comment was made, which revealed some confusion: "To drop the ego and then take it back, and yet remain egoless without feeling the burden of it. How difficult to understand!"

Mother continued: "Amma has said that it is an experience, that it can neither be grasped nor can it be explained or interpreted by the intellect. The intellect has an explanation for every single thing. People are not ready to accept anything without an explanation. They think that there must be a logical explanation for everything. Poor things! They think they can explain the nature of this universe with all its mysteries. Modern scientific thinking is responsible for imparting this kind of attitude to human minds. The modern scientific approach deals only with phenomena and objects that can be perceived. It deals only with the empirical world that can be measured with external instruments,

and the conclusions drawn have to be intellectually understandable.

“This concept of modern science has damaged people’s faith. Love cannot be perceived, neither can faith. They are not tangible. These qualities cannot be put into words; yet they are the very foundation of life. Without them, life is not life but death. The beauty and splendor of life depend entirely on love and faith. They cannot be explained except in real life. It is our experience that without love and faith, life becomes like a machine or like a corpse. Just as a corpse decomposes, life also starts decomposing in the absence of love and faith. This is our daily experience. Every moment is an experience of this great truth. It is amazing that people still ask for proof and explanations of this. It is a pity that they have such doubts about the truth.”

In a split second, Mother once again soared to the heights of spiritual bliss. She was now in a strange mood. She took a handful of wet sand in Her right hand, made it into a ball and placed it on Her forehead. After this, She became very still. Mother closed Her eyes and for some time remained in Her own world, a world totally incomprehensible to the human mind.

Suddenly Mother began singing *Nilameghangale*. . .

*O dark-colored clouds
How did you get your bluish hue
The same dark complexion
As Vrindavan’s Son of Nanda, Sri Krishna?*

*Did you go and meet Baby Krishna?
Did He smile at you and talk to you?
Did He cast a glance at you
with His blue lotus-like eyes,
Sweet as honey?*

The deep silence of the night and the profound elevating feeling created by the song made the minds of everyone glide into a tranquil state. It is indeed wonderful to listen to Mother's nectarous words and ecstatic singing; for She fills both heart and soul with love and contentment. But these intervals of deep silence, when She radiates the bliss of Her own inner silence, are of a beauty beyond words. During these meditative moments, those in Her presence can dive deep, with no effort at all, into the innermost recesses of their own hearts, where they experience silence and peace.

Coming down from Her exalted mood, Mother turned to the side, and the ball of sand fell from Her forehead. One of the brahmacharins carefully picked it up and held it in his hands.

Once again the person who had asked the question about explaining spirituality pursued the same line of thought: "Amma, you did not explain why the saint doesn't feel the burden, even though he is carrying it."

Mother smiled mischievously. She might have been thinking how silly they were to continue to ask the same question even after being told repeatedly that spiritual experiences are indescribable and cannot be explained. However, the Most Compassionate One again blessed Her children by giving a few more hints: "Son, before answering your question, let Mother tell how the intellect keeps on

raising objections and doubts. It never lets us believe; it never lets us have undivided faith. Look at you now. Even after you have been told that spirituality is cannot be explained, your intellect doesn't allow you to accept it. It won't allow you to believe. It keeps demanding proof in the form of more and more explanations. This will never stop unless you become aware of how meaningless this repeated questioning is. The more proof and explanations you are given, the more the intellect demands. This is because proof and explanations are food for the intellect. Without doubts, words, and explanations, the mind and intellect cannot survive. They cannot exist. The mind's very source of existence is knowledge from the outside world; therefore it is constantly after facts and figures. Knowing this, try not to feed the mind.

"The saint stops feeding the mind with knowledge of the world. Once food for the ego is stopped, the mind stops its habitual and mechanical functioning. The saint becomes the sole controller. The saint lives in the heart. While the head is the seat of the ego, the heart is the egoless abode. The saint stops living in the head; he leaves the ego and moves to the heart. He does not doubt. He does not divide, but is undivided. He is the universe.

"Once the ego is removed, you are no longer a person. You are consciousness. You are formless. The ego is the material that gives name and form. Once the ego is destroyed, name and form disappear. You may give the saint a name, and you may perceive him as a form, but he is neither. He is like the wind. He is empty space. Everything passes through him. The entire universe—all the suns, moons and stars, the mountains, valleys, and forests, the oceans and rivers, the people and all living creatures—pass right through him;

and he simply remains untouched, unmoved, and unperturbed. He lives silently, peacefully, and blissfully. Because he is egoless, he is 'no-mind.'

"Here is another way of looking at it. While remaining under water, we do not feel the weight of the things we carry, no matter how large the quantity may be. But come out of the water and try to carry the same things. You may not be able to move them an inch. Likewise, the Mahatma dives deep into the whole of existence. He becomes existence itself; and buoyant in the space of existence, the 'burden' he carries is weightless. Thus, it is not really a burden that he carries. He feels no burden—for, since he is egoless, he is unburdened.

"A saint lives in love. He lives in compassion. A saint is the embodiment of love and compassion. In pure love there are no burdens. Nothing can be a burden to pure, desireless love. Real love can carry the entire universe without feeling any weight. Compassion can shoulder the suffering of the entire world without feeling the slightest pain. What we call the heavy burden of the entire world is weightless to a Mahatma. He carries this 'burden' out of sheer joy and bliss; but in fact, he does not carry it at all. He cannot carry anything, because he is not a person or a form. He is space itself. He can contain anything. Everything exist within space, and still there is plenty of space left in space. Space is limitless and inexhaustible.

"There is no division in that state; one becomes totally undivided. There is only space. Division is created by us. As a result of our karma, the ego creates division. It is like a house divided by walls into many rooms. Before the house was constructed, there was only space. After the walls were put up, the space was divided into separate rooms. But in

reality, even when the house is built and division is created by the walls, there is still only space. The house exists in space. If you demolish the walls, the house disappears, and again you have only space. Likewise, the ego can be compared to the walls that delineate all divisions. Remove the ego and you will again become space.

“But son, what good does it do you, if you simply hear all these words and ideas? You should try to attain that state of being unburdened. Only that is worthwhile.”

Another brahmacharin felt moved to speak, “It is beautiful when you speak about such things, Amma. Though we are at the lowest ebb of life, we feel so inspired when you speak. Sometimes there is a tide of inner urgency; we feel strongly motivated to know and experience that supreme state. But this feeling does not last long; it soon dies away.”

Taking up this point, Mother elaborated, “The tide comes and goes. The tide comes in when you are in situations similar to this, inspired by satsang. The sum total of such inspiring circumstances will culminate in an urgency that will be felt constantly. That will be the take-off point. At that point you will have no choice but to take the final leap, the final soaring upwards. A real Master will take you to that point by creating intense and inspiring situations. As you become more and more receptive, the intensity of the circumstances will increase. That is how a true Guru takes even the most unworthy student slowly and gradually to the goal.”

The brahmacharins rejoiced to hear this statement. One of them, considering himself an unworthy disciple, said, “I am happy now, thinking that I too have hope. I am waiting

for the day to come when my mind will be filled with the intense desire to merge with Mother.”

Mother retorted, “Don’t simply wait without doing anything. Do not waste your time just waiting. Utilize the time to prepare the mind, by creating more and more of a gap within so that the Guru can enter. He is always ready to step in, but at least a small crack must be there. Once the Guru has entered, then everything is all right; he will do the rest. He will see to it that you are eaten up. But at present, there is not even a small crack. Try to create an opening, or at least a crack, and allow the Guru to occupy a small space within you. In due course, he will see that the ego is pushed out, so that your entire heart is occupied by him alone.”

After these statements, Amma began to sing *Agamanta porule*. . .

*O Essence of the Agamas, who fills the universe,
Does anyone know You
Who are full of wisdom?
O Blissful Self,
Eternal Being, devoid of sorrow,
O Supreme Primal Power, protect me.*

*You dwell in all hearts, knowing everyone,
Eager to offer the bliss of Liberation,
Unseen by the wicked,
Yet always shining
In the meditation of the virtuous.*

O You, who shines forth

*As Eternal Truth,
O Devi, Eternal One,
Illumine the Path of Salvation,
And shine in me, a fool among mankind.*

*Clearly I tell You, O Mother
Deign to enter and shine in my heart.
Choose me to praise Your story
And liberate me from this maya.*

At ten-thirty in the evening it started to rain. It seemed that Mother wished to be in the rain, for She did not get up. As if in tune with Her, everyone remained seated, except Gayatri, who was concerned about Mother's health and physical needs. Gayatri got up, for she could see that the drizzle would soon turn into heavy rain. But Mother did not move. Gayatri pleaded with Mother to get up and move to the temple verandah, or go to Her room. Suddenly the drizzle became a downpour, and everybody got drenched. The moment the drizzle had begun, Gayatri had unfolded the umbrella which she had carried with her, and she tried to hold it over Amma. But Amma was enjoying the rain, and only with much reluctance did She give in to Gayatri's continuous pleading. Finally Amma got up and went along with her to Her room. The brahmacharins stood there a few more moments, as if lost to this world. It took a few minutes for them to realize that Mother was gone. Then suddenly, they all jumped up and rushed to the temple verandah.

One of the brahmacharins, who was shivering, commented, "It seemed to me that Amma wanted to see whether we'd

get up and run away when the rain came. Perhaps it was a test. But then again, maybe not. Mother has Her own reasons. Perhaps She simply preferred to stay in the rain.”

Another brahmacharin said, “I don’t know how to act on such occasions. For example, Gayatri insisted that Mother should go to Her room, whereas none of us uttered a single word. We just sat there and kept quiet. Of course we remained in the rain, too. But my question is, which is the right attitude, Gayatri’s or ours?”

Sharing these feelings of uneasiness, another brahmacharin commented, “Now that you have raised this question, I also have a guilty conscience about it. I think we should have asked Amma to go to Her room before it rained so heavily.”

A discussion followed and the brahmacharins concluded that they should ask Mother about it when they had the chance. They then went to their rooms. The only sounds were those of the wind blowing, the rain falling and the ocean waves roaring.



CHAPTER II

WHICH IS THE RIGHT ATTITUDE?

Saturday, 7 July, 1984

In the course of the morning the brahmacharins had the opportunity to ask Amma the question that was bothering them the day before. One of them asked, “Amma, yesterday while you were in the rain and it started to pour, Gayatri pleaded that you go to your room, whereas we did not say anything. We just kept quiet. Now, Amma, kindly tell us if it was wrong of us to be silent.”

Laughing loudly, Amma replied, “No, no, children! Don’t worry, your attitude wasn’t wrong. Both Gayatri’s attitude and your attitude were correct.

“Gayatri’s sadhana is to take care of Amma’s physical needs. She is very conscientious about that. The lover, in the beginning stages of love, is always very attached to, and concerned about, his or her beloved’s physical body. This attachment, or strong bond, continues until the final state when the lover becomes totally one with the beloved. The attitude of ‘I and You’ continues to exist in the lover until

the final merging takes place. Gayatri is always concerned about Amma's body; Amma's physical needs are what she thinks and dreams about ceaselessly. Her concern for Amma's body arises from her pure love for Amma. That is how it should be—having attachment and deep concern for the Guru's body, even though the Guru is not at all bothered about his own bodily needs. Attachment to the Guru makes one detached from all worldly concerns and worries. It helps the spiritual seeker forget about the world and concentrate on God. The spiritual progress of a disciple or a devotee depends on the intensity of his or her remembrance of his Guru or God, which is also meditation; and this will culminate in total Oneness. Gayatri's thoughts are always focused on Mother and Her needs; there is therefore nothing wrong in Gayatri's attitude. It's fine.

"Children, have you heard the story of Krishna's headache? Lord Krishna one day pretended to have a severe headache. When the sage Narada came into the Lord's private chambers, he saw Krishna rolling on the bed, unable to bear the terrible pain. Expressing great sympathy, Narada inquired if there was anything he could do for the Lord, if there were any remedy to ease his pain. Krishna, as if undergoing severe pain, murmured in a barely audible voice, 'The only medicine is the dust from My devotees' feet. This unbearable pain will disappear only if such dust is applied to My forehead.'

"When he heard this, Narada thought, 'Oh dear! I am the greatest devotee of the Lord; how, then, can I commit the terrible sin of giving the dust from my feet for the Lord to apply on His forehead? That is impossible. I cannot do that.'

"But still he wanted to obtain a cure for the Lord, so

he went out and searched for someone who would give the dust from his feet for the Lord to apply to His forehead. First the sage went to Rukmini and Satyabhama, the Holy Consorts of Krishna. They immediately refused, not wanting to commit such a big sin. Next Narada went to see many saints and sages who were renowned for their devotion and tapas, but none of them was ready to commit a great sin like that.

“A disappointed Narada returned to Dwaraka, the abode of Sri Krishna. He told the Lord that those whom he had approached were afraid to incur such a grave sin, and asked where he should go to find the remedy. Seeing Narada’s helplessness, the Lord, still feigning severe pain, smilingly replied, ‘Go to Vrindavan.’

“So Narada went to Vrindavan, where the gopis were thrilled and excited to see the great devotee of Lord Sri Krishna. They surrounded him, eagerly asking questions about Krishna. After answering their questions, Narada finally told them about the severe headache and its sole remedy, that this was what he had come to ask for. Without a moment’s hesitation, and as if they had gone insane, the gopis began filling bags and bags of sand from under their feet.

“Narada was shocked and exclaimed, ‘What are you doing? Don’t you know that this is the worst sin, to make the Lord wear the dust from your feet? Are you crazy!’

“The gopis in their intense love for the Lord cried out, “Then let us incur this sin, no matter how severe it may be. We don’t care. We don’t care about sin or merit. Our beloved Krishna’s headache must be cured—that is our only concern. If this dust from under our feet will cure His headache, we don’t care what punishment lies in store for us.

We will gladly accept it.'

"Narada was amazed at the unconditional love and devotion that the gopis had for Krishna. Returning to Dwaraka with the bags of sand from the gopis' feet, Narada found a healthy and fully healed Sri Krishna sitting with a welcoming smile lighting His divine countenance. Narada now realized that the whole headache event was a divine drama played by Sri Krishna to humble him. He was certainly humbled as the Lord said to him, 'My dear Narada, while you and all the others were worried about incurring sin, the gopis were only concerned about Me. They were not at all bothered about what great sin they would incur; in fact, they were willing to accept whatever consequences might befall them for the so-called sinful act of giving the dust of their feet to the Lord. They thought only about Me—that Krishna should be well, and that His pain should end. This was their sole concern. Their bhakti is beyond compare.'

"Children, this attitude of the devotee caring for the Lord's physical well-being is very good. For him, the Lord is both his beloved and his all-in-all; so it is perfectly in keeping with his love and devotion for the devotee to care about the Lord's bodily comforts, His health and physical needs. The devotee's attachment and constant remembrance (one-pointedness) arises out of this attitude, which is very good."

The brahmacharin then asked, "Amma, in the beginning you said that our attitude was not wrong, but your explanation makes it sound as if Gayatri was right and we were wrong."

"No, no. Not so," Amma assured him. "Mother was just about to say that your attitude came from a place of being

fully identified with that particular set of circumstances. You were in a state of forgetfulness. You didn't see the rain coming; you had not seen the rain clouds gather. Your mind was so concentrated on watching Amma at that particular moment, that even when it started to rain, you did not notice the rain drops. You were living in the moment with Amma, and nothing else mattered. However, since it is Gayatri's sadhana to take care of Amma's physical needs, she was more concerned about Amma's health. She saw the rain coming and was very worried that Amma would get drenched. So, of course, she wanted Amma to get out of the rain and go inside. Both her attitude and yours are correct.

"If Gayatri's attitude can be compared to that of the gopis, who without the slightest hesitation sent the dust of their feet to cure Krishna's headache, your attitude in that moment can be compared to that of the gopi who burned her fingers when she saw Krishna.

"Children, do you know that story? There was once a gopi who was told by her mother-in-law to light the lamp in the house, as dusk was falling. So she went to the neighbor's house to get fire. Back in those days there were no electric lights, not even matches. To light a fire you had to strike a flint, or rub two sticks together; and if somebody did that, he would keep the fire going so that others could start their fires from it. It was a common thing to go to a neighbor's house to fetch fire. The gopi took with her a cotton wick soaked in oil, in order to light it from the lamp at the neighbor's. Just as she placed the oil-soaked wick in the fire, she heard someone say, 'Look, there's Krishna at the door!' She immediately turned and saw her Beloved Krishna standing right there. So struck was she by the sight of her Lord that

she simply stood there gazing at Him, unaware of the burning wick in her hand. Totally oblivious to the outer circumstances, she did not notice that her fingers were burning. She felt no pain, for she was not at all conscious of her body. Meanwhile, her mother-in-law was waiting for her to bring the fire; when the daughter-in-law failed to return, the mother-in-law decided to search for her. When she arrived at the neighbor's house, she found the gopi standing entranced, gazing at Krishna. So enchanted was she by His presence, she did not even know that her fingers were burning.

"But remember, this is just an example. You and Gayatri still have a long way to go to reach that state of supreme devotion.

"Children, if you consciously act in a selfish way, that is wrong. For example, if out of anger or spite, you deliberately let Amma stay in the rain, that would be a very harmful attitude, which could adversely affect your spiritual progress. Also, had you run out of the rain without caring about Amma, without seeking Her permission to leave, or without being told by Amma to go, that would have been wrong. However, none of you did any of those things, so don't worry.

"Some people have the attitude that Amma is God, that She is beyond everything and that nothing can affect Her. They think of Her as being all-powerful and know that She can even live without food and sleep, because Her energy is inexhaustible. They consider Her to be the Supreme Brahman, the Absolute. This attitude is also correct.

"The difference is that while a devotee sees both the external and the internal aspects of the Lord, people who believe that God is the Absolute Brahman see only the internal. To you and Gayatri, Mother is your beloved Lord and all-

powerful God; She is everything to you.

“Children, Mother knows that you and Gayatri are deeply concerned about Mother’s physical well-being; but in that particular set of circumstances, you became identified with the moment and you forgot everything. However, Gayatri was more concerned about Mother’s physical body, because that is her sadhana. In both cases, this forgetfulness and identification happens only once in a while. It should become constant—and that is the point when you experience a taste of supreme love.”

The brahmacharins were very happy to hear that they had not made a mistake in unwittingly allowing Amma to stay in the rain. This explanation relieved them of any feelings of guilt. As instructed by Amma, one of the brahmacharins sang *Mara yadukula hridayeswara*. . .

*O most charming One, Lord of the Yadava’s hearts
With the complexion of rain clouds,
Bearing the Goddess Lakshmi on His chest,
O Lotus-eyed One, where are Your fingers
That caress soft lullabies?*

*O You who lived in Vrindavan as the son of Nanda,
Who danced and played in the hearts
Of Lord Chaitanya and of others,
You are alpha and omega.
To You who are bonded to Your devotees,
We join our palms in adoration.*

At about three o’clock in the afternoon Amma was

roaming through the coconut grove. This seemed normal enough, yet there was something unusual in Her manner. One could discern that She was reveling in the higher planes, for the residents had seen Her do this before. It was a particular mood of Hers, abiding in the absolute stillness of Her real nature, while She moved about. This continued for some time.

A few minutes later Mother stopped and looked up at a young coconut tree. Up in the tree an owl was being attacked by a flock of crows. The angry crows screeched wildly as they mercilessly pecked at the defenseless owl. It seemed certain that the crows would kill the owl.

Mother picked up a stone and threw it at the crows, but the crows were not bothered and continued their attack. Mother then picked up several stones and shot them rapidly at the crows. This time the crows accepted defeat and flew away, leaving the owl alone. But soon the poor bird fell down from the tree, fluttered weakly on the ground in front of Mother, and then lay still. There were wounds all over its body. Mother sat down and took the bleeding bird in Her hands, caressing it compassionately. With a sad look on Her face, She gently placed the owl on Her lap. "Gayatri," Mother called out, "bring some hot water and towels."

One of the brahmacharins ran to Gayatri and reported the matter to her. A few minutes later, Gayatri came down from Mother's room with hot water and some towels. Seeing Mother's white skirt covered with blood, Gayatri let these words slip out of her mouth: "Oh dear! Amma, Your skirt is covered with blood. The skirt is ruined."

Mother threw a serious look at Gayatri. The love and compassion She had in Her eyes for the owl was not visible

in the look She gave Gayatri. It was more like a warning, as if to say, "Wait till I finish tending to this poor and helpless bird." Gayatri guessed the implications of that look and turned pale.

Using the hot water and the towel, Mother washed the blood from the owl's wounds with great love and concern. She did this with great care, each time washing out the blood-stained towel in a different container. The attention Amma paid to a seemingly insignificant owl was such that everyone present felt as if She were nursing Her own child. Mother did not speak a single word as She treated the bird. When all the blood was removed and the wounds were clean, Mother patted the owl's body dry, using a fresh towel. Then Amma asked Nealu to get some turmeric powder. Nealu quickly returned with turmeric from the kitchen. It was the ready-made type of packaged turmeric powder which had been purchased from the market. But that was not what Mother had in mind: "That's no good," She said. "Get a dried turmeric root, grind it and bring it here."

In a few minutes the freshly-ground turmeric powder was ready, and Mother, with Her own hands, applied the powder on the bird's wounds—under the wings, on the head, around the eyes, and on the neck. She searched carefully to find each wound in order to apply the turmeric powder. As She was doing this, the owl sat silently on Mother's lap without fluttering or moving at all. The owl seemed to be in bliss rather than pain, and it even looked as if it had recovered. Having carefully put the turmeric powder on all its wounds, Amma closed Her eyes and sat in a meditative mood for a few moments, keeping the bird on Her lap. Opening Her eyes, Amma once again rubbed the bird's back. Then

She handed the bird over to Balu and instructed him to take care of it until nightfall. Without moving from where She sat, Amma washed Her hands and remained sitting where She was.

Gayatri reminded Mother of Her blood-stained skirt: “Amma, don’t you want to change your skirt?”

As if waiting to hear these words, Amma retorted, “No, Mother does not want to change. She wants to keep the blood on Her clothes. It reminds Amma of the helpless creature and of the pain it underwent. It symbolizes the pain and agony of the entire creation. It makes Her remember the helplessness of those who are in sorrow and are suffering. Thus Mother can remember the need to feel compassion and to express it to all creatures, no matter how insignificant or useless they appear to be. It is very painful for Mother to see how self-centered Her children are. Instead of feeling compassion towards this helpless bird, Gayatri is more concerned about Amma’s clothes. It is painful to think that as spiritual seekers, Amma’s children do not feel the pain of other beings.”

Gayatri hung her head and sat very still. A heavy silence filled the atmosphere and everyone began to feel something of Mother’s concern for the entire creation. It was awesome. Tears streamed down Mother’s face, but no one knew why. Who can comprehend the meaning of the tears of one so compassionate?

Whenever Mother’s mood changes, there is a change in the atmosphere around Her. Her mood is inevitably reflected in the people near Her.

Amma began talking again: “The thought that Her children are not able to feel compassion, that they cannot

imagine themselves in someone else's place, is extremely painful to Mother.

"Without love and compassion the world cannot exist. The whole of existence is indebted to the Mahatmas for the love and compassion they have showered on all creation. This creation and all the creatures in it are an expression of compassion. Those who have attained the state of Self-realization do not want to come down. They go beyond. They exist in the beyond. They *are* the beyond.

"That which is beyond is the state of stillness, the state of Oneness. In that state, there is no motion and there are no thoughts, because there is no mind. For love and compassion to be felt, a mind or a thought is needed, a sankalpa (resolve) is required. So, from the state of 'no-mind,' the state of absolute stillness, a mahatma steps down—perhaps not one, but many steps down—because of his concern for those who are helpless and are groping in the dark. The mahatmas have never wanted to come down. Why should they, when they are one with eternity? Why should they bother about others? Why should consciousness be concerned with the created world? The fact is there are no concerns in that state of Oneness. There are no feelings in that state. There is neither compassion nor lack of compassion. So a mind is created for the purpose of feeling love and compassion, and to be concerned about suffering humanity. By Self-will the Mahatma creates a body through which love and compassion can be expressed. Once compassion arises within, the Mahatma descends to the human plane of consciousness. Why does he do this? What for? Have you ever thought about it? He does it only to create the spirit of love and compassion within you."

Mother stopped for awhile. One of the brahmacharins asked Her, "Amma, it sounds as if you too did not want to come down, as if you would have preferred to remain in that state of Oneness. Then how does this coming down happen? How does that compassion arise?"

Amma, the compassionate one, spoke, "Mother has heard a story about Buddha, about what happened when he became enlightened. Listen carefully.

"Through years of tapas, Buddha became enlightened. When he attained enlightenment, Buddha remained silent for many days. He did not want to speak. He just wanted to lose himself in that oneness with the Supreme Consciousness. So he kept silent. Now, the celestial beings became very distressed. They grew anxious, wondering whether Buddha would ever speak at all. They knew that his enlightenment was a very rare gift; and thus they wanted him to speak so that the entire world and all its creatures could benefit from what he had attained. If he did not speak, it would be a tremendous loss to the world.

"So the gods came down from heaven and appeared before Buddha. Bowing down before the Great Soul, they repeatedly prayed that he would speak. They said, 'Holy One, please speak! Your experience is unique and incomparable; therefore, be compassionate. There are many people who are immersed in pain and sorrow. One single word from you will give them hope. Your mere presence will give them peace and tranquillity. There are also seekers of the Truth who need your help. Guide them to the state of Self-Realization. A word, a glance, a touch from you will be a showering of ambrosia upon them. O Great One, please speak!'

"At first, Buddha, the Enlightened One, paid no heed

to their prayers. Then after their continued insistence, he tried to explain to them that nothing he could say would fully express his experience of the Truth. The gods continued to plead with him, 'Think of ailing humanity. Have compassion for those who are in sorrow and despair, longing for someone to give them solace and peace of mind. Think of those seekers of the Truth who are badly in need of someone to guide them to the goal. They need guidance. If nobody helps them, they may look back and think, "I have been waiting for so long to reach the state of Perfection. What if it does not exist? Perhaps there is no such thing as Self-Realization. Why, then, should I waste my time any longer?" And in that state of frustration and disappointment, they might even fall back into the world of plurality. Holy One, think of such people. Take pity on them. Be compassionate towards them and speak. A look, a word or a touch from a holy person like you, is sufficient for them to attain the goal. That attainment of a single soul is enough for the rest of the world to be benefited.'

"Gradually Buddha's heart filled with compassion. And so, after having experienced the highest Truth, after having been filled within and without, and having attained Oneness with the Supreme Being, he came down.

"The prayers and supplications of the gods in this story represent the inner call and longing of sincere sadhaks and people who believe in the existence of a Supreme Power, who are badly in need of God's grace and guidance. There are always such people who yearn intensely for a tangible experience of God. They see the destructive powers trying to overwhelm the higher values of life, and feel the inner urgency for a positive spiritual change. Their intense call

and prayers will create waves of compassion in the mind of a great soul. That call compels him to descend.”

A brahmacharin said, “Amma, I am feeling confused about what you said. Sometimes you say that once Realization is attained one becomes filled with love and compassion, that there is nothing but love in such a person. But I have also heard you say that in that state of Oneness there is neither love nor lack of love, neither compassion nor any lack of compassion. This sounds contradictory. Amma, please make this clear.”

“Children,” Amma said, “Most of those who attain Realization merge with eternity; very few of them come down. For, who would like to come down after having entered the Ocean of Bliss? In order to come down from that ultimate state, that state from which there is no return, it is necessary to have something to hold on to—a determined thought, a sankalpa. Only a few who can make that resolve to descend will come down. That sankalpa, or mental resolve, is love and compassion, and selfless service to suffering humanity. However, if you do not want to listen and respond to the call of those sincere seekers and the cry of those who are suffering in the world, and if you want to remain in that impersonal state and do not want to be compassionate, it is perfectly all right; you can remain there.

“When you come down, a veil which can be pulled away at any time is put up by Self-will, so that you can function smoothly and uninterruptedly in this world. Consciously, you do not pay any attention to the other side of the curtain. Yet, on and off, you do go over to the other side. But you manage to come back. The very thought or a reminder of

the other side can simply lift you there.

“Once you come down, you play your role well. You live and work hard for the uplifting of all humanity. You will have problems, obstacles and difficult situations. You will also have to face abuses, scandals and calumny. But you do not care because although externally you look like everybody else, internally you are different—totally different. Inside, you are one with the Supreme Truth; therefore, you are untouched, unaffected. Having become one with the very source of energy itself, you work tirelessly. Healing and soothing the deep wounds of those who come to you, you give peace and happiness to everyone. Your way of living life—your renunciation, love, compassion, and selflessness—gives inspiration to others to want to experience what you experience.

“If they do not want to be concerned about the world at all, those compassionate and loving ones who come down can also remain in that non-dual state and merge in Supreme Consciousness. In that state there is neither love nor lack of love, neither compassion nor lack of compassion.

“In order to be loving and compassionate, to perform selfless service, and to inspire others to experience those divine qualities, one must have a body. Once a body is acquired, it has to take its natural course. The Mahatma’s body is different from an ordinary person’s. If he so wills, he can keep the body for as long as he wishes, without being afflicted by disease and suffering. But he consciously makes the body undergo all the experiences that an ordinary human being undergoes. Therein lies his greatness.

“Didn’t Krishna get hurt during the Mahabharata battle? Didn’t He fight eighteen times with Jarasandha, the cruel and powerful king? Finally, He diplomatically left the battle

field. Krishna could have killed Jarasandha if He wanted to, but He didn't. He made Bhima, the second Pandava brother, kill him.

"Remember, it was an arrow shot by an ordinary hunter which put an end to Krishna's life in this world. Jesus was executed on the cross. Both of them could have prevented the events which put an end to their bodies; but they let everything happen in its natural course. They let life carry them. They chose to be as they were and let the events occur. They were willing to surrender. However, this does not mean that the natural course is inevitable or unavoidable for them, as it is for ordinary humans. No, that is not so. If they had wished, they could have averted all bitter experiences. Being all-powerful, they could have effortlessly destroyed those who opposed them. But they wanted to set an example. They wanted to show the world that it is possible to live with the highest values of life, even while undergoing all the problems that ordinary humans have. Yet bear in mind that if a situation arises where it is necessary for them to break a law of nature, they can easily do so. Remember how Sri Rama was about to dry up the entire ocean,¹ and how Sri Krishna lifted up the mountain Govardhana with His little finger."²

Amma paused and asked Br. Rao to sing a song, *Mukaganam pativarum*. . .

*Oh unhappy bees, songs without words,
Won't you come to the Abode of the Divine Mother?*

*The Divine Mother has come to the world.
No more do we have to wander
On the dusty roads of this earth*

*The Goddess has come,
With the flowers of spring,
The days that are gone, are gone forever
Now let us go to the Divine Abode.*

*Let us fill our hearts with new words of wisdom,
filled with the Bliss of the Self,
Let us proclaim that the complex of body and mind
can never be "That."*

After the song, Amma continued: "Children, you may attain the highest Truth, but still you may lack compassion. Without feeling love or any concern for suffering human beings, you may remain in the state of Oneness. You will be like a lotus flower blooming on some hidden peak in the Himalayas. Or you will be like a lake full of pure crystal clear water hidden in a deep, inaccessible forest. Or you will be like a fruit tree, full of ripe fruit, in the middle of a dense forest. Nobody can enjoy the beauty and fragrance of that lotus flower; no bee will gather its pollen to make honey. Nobody will come to bathe in that remote lake or drink from it. Nobody can enjoy the sweet and delicious fruit from the inaccessible tree. And yet, your existence is full, clear and pure; for you have reached the goal.

"On the other hand, the compassionate ones, those whose hearts are filled with love and concern, are like a river flowing down from the highest mountain. They are like the Ganges. Having ascended to the highest peak of bliss, they flow down from the heights, out of their compassion, to let others drink from their waters, and bathe and swim in them. They are like a fruit tree growing by the side of the road, offering its

fruit to everyone. Tired travelers can enjoy the fruit; they can quench their thirst and appease their hunger. They are like a beautiful lotus blossoming in a temple pond. People can gather around to enjoy its beauty and delight in its fragrance, and doing so, they feel contented. Like bees coming to collect pollen for honey, people will gather around the compassionate ones, waiting for pearls of wisdom to fall from their lips. They themselves become an offering to the people. Such souls have wholly surrendered themselves to all of existence, yet out of compassion, they offer themselves back to the world. Still they remain in silence.”

Amma’s explanation was so penetrating and revealing that everyone sat absorbed in Her words. Who else could expound so clearly and convincingly about such truths that are “subtler than the subtlest?” Only one who, by Her mere will, can move effortlessly between these two planes of awareness.

One brahmacharin spoke up: “Amma, you were talking about your own experience. You were telling us that you came down and assumed this human form just because of your love and compassion for us who are groping in darkness. Amma, how can we repay you for all the trouble that you undergo for us? Amma, how are we to develop this love and compassion? Oh, Amma. . . Amma. . . Amma. . .” The brahmacharin started to sob.

Like a mother deeply concerned about her son, Amma consoled him. He slowly stopped crying as She wiped away his tears with Her own hands. It was a truly touching display of Mother’s love and compassion for Her children.

FORGET IN ORDER TO REMEMBER GOD

Another brahmacharin had a question: "Amma, I have heard you say several times that one should 'forget in order to remember God.' What does that mean?"

Amma explained this seeming paradox: "Children, forgetting is necessary, not only for remembering God. To do any work with concentration, one must forget everything else. While you are studying your lessons, if you start thinking about playing football or about scenes from a movie you have seen, you will not be able to learn. You may read mechanically, but since your mind is elsewhere, the lessons will not enter into your head.

"A scientist forgets all about the outside world when he sits in the laboratory doing research. Several other things may be happening in the same laboratory, but the scientist does not see or hear anything as he attends to his own particular work. He may be looking through a microscope to investigate the cells of the human body, but he will not even be aware of the microscope. He sees nothing but the minute cells that he is studying.

"Thus, in everyday life this kind of forgetting and remembering happens all the time. Each moment something is forgotten and something else is remembered. The family is forgotten and the office is remembered; the wife is forgotten, the children are remembered; the children disappear and the wife appears. This happens constantly, from moment to moment, but we are not aware of it. It is clear that in day-to-day life forgetfulness is required in order to remember something; and the same applies to remembering God. In order to remember God, the world should be forgotten,

because, when we see the world, God is forgotten—unless we have the power to see the world as God.

“Constant remembrance of God means a constant forgetting of the world and its objects. A single-pointed remembering increases the gap between two thoughts. We daydream a lot, thinking and brooding about different things, people, places, and so forth. The world exists in us as thoughts and ideas. The world is thought. The biggest impediment to remembering God is thought—our constant thinking and daydreaming, our habit of always trying to figure things out. Our thoughts are always irregular; one thought leads to another. Now we think about our son who lives abroad; we dream about going there and living with him for the rest of our life. Then we dream about that country and the great pleasure and fun we are going to have there. The next moment our thoughts turn to the zoo we visited the other day and the chimpanzees that we saw in one of the cages; the way they jumped from one side to the other; how funny it was when they ate the peanuts we offered, and how they scratched. A moment later we recall our wedding day. . . This is how most people think. They live in their thoughts.

“If you look carefully, if you can see with a subtle eye, you will see that there is a gap between thoughts. This gap is thin—thinner than a hair’s breadth—but it is there. If you can keep the thoughts from flowing uncontrollably, as they do now, this gap will increase. But this is possible only in a mind which is concentrated on a single thought. It must dwell, not on many thoughts, but on just one thought, and that thought is what we call the remembrance of God. That thought can have the name Rama, Krishna, Christ, or Buddha—whatever you call your beloved deity. Through this

kind of remembrance, daydreams are forgotten. All other thoughts are dropped, and in due course this remembrance becomes constant. Through constant remembrance of God, one forgets about the world and what is happening. All thoughts are replaced by a single thought: the thought of God. You may call Him Rama, Krishna, Buddha, or Christ. No matter what name you give Him, this one-pointed thinking results in the constant remembrance of God."

The brahmacharin was doubtful: "What does one gain from this? What is the benefit of this forgetting and remembering?"

Amma answered, "Suppose you build a beautiful house. It has been your lifelong dream to own such a house. You were always thinking about this dream-home, often forgetting everything else. What do you gain when you finally complete the construction of the house and move into it? You feel happy and content, don't you? Similarly, when you constantly remember God, forgetting all about the world, you will attain peace and perfect contentment. The contentment you experience when you move into your house will die soon, because it will be replaced by another desire, whereas the peace and contentment that you attain through constant remembrance of God, forgetting everything else, will give you eternal peace and happiness.

"What is it that man craves? What is it that is most absent in this world? The answer is peace, isn't it? There is no peace anywhere, neither within nor without. To live life fully, one needs peace and love. Peace is not something that is gained when all desires are fulfilled or when all problems are settled. As long as the mind is there, desires will come up and problems

will exist. Peace is something that arises when all the thoughts settle and you transcend the mind. Peace comes when remembrance of God and forgetting the world are experienced simultaneously.

“A person who has inner peace is relaxed. His life is balanced. He is never overexcited or anxious, and he never grieves about his past. He confronts the situations in life calmly and intelligently, because he has great clarity of vision. His mind and vision are not clouded by unnecessary thoughts. Remember, he will have the same problems in life as other people; but a man who knows that inner peace will confront things differently. His attitude will be different. There will be a special charm and beauty in all that he does. He remains unperturbed in all circumstance that arise in life, no matter what they are.

“Children, learn to remember that you are the Self. You are God’s own. Try to forget that you are the body, that you are away from God, or that there is nobody to look after you.”

LOVE AND REASON

When Amma stopped talking, Br. Pai spontaneously sang a song. Everybody, including Amma, joyfully joined him. They sang *Hariyute kalil*. . .

*Without falling at the Feet of God (Hari),
None can extinguish
The fire of sorrow, of transmigration.
Without bowing forever to the Guru
None will gain the bliss of Liberation.*

*None can reach the Lord
Without getting absorbed in chanting His Name.
Without merging in the sweetness of devotion,
None can attain the state of Liberation.*

*He who does not meditate, do japa
Or other practices will not partake
Of the nectar of Bliss.
Without righteousness and compassion
Dharma cannot be performed.
Without renouncing all attachments
The fire of transmigration cannot be extinguished.
Unless jealousy within is removed
God will not come to us.*

After the song, a brahmacharin made the following comment: "To know God or the Self is a question of utter faith, self-surrender and pure love, isn't it? But intellectuals consider these three things irrational and illogical."

Amma had a ready answer, "So-called intellectuals can never enjoy real life. Love is indispensable in real life. Faith requires love, and love needs faith. Self-surrender also requires faith and love. All these qualities are of the heart, and not the intellect.

"Love, surrender, and faith are almost impossible for a rational thinker, for one who is always calculating and analyzing everything. How can such a person love? There is no logic in love. You cannot analyze love. Love is a feeling, a deep feeling. You cannot see love nor can you touch it. But love can be felt, and feelings are in the heart. For love to exist, a heart that can feel and express itself is needed.

“Children, what would happen if a woman fell in love with a rationalist and asked him to marry her? He might say, ‘Wait, I have to think about the whole affair. I must analyze the situation and see whether the marriage would be a success or not. I must be rational and figure it out first.’ He might even write an essay analyzing the success and failure of love and married life. Most probably the conclusion would be, ‘Love is irrational. There is no such thing as love—it is just imagination. Love cannot exist because it cannot be seen, touched, or smelled; it is therefore an illusion. It is impossible.’

“Love just happens. Nobody thinks about how to love, or when and where to love. Nobody is rational about love. Rational thought hinders love. Love is a sudden uprising in the heart. Love is an unavoidable, unobstructable longing for oneness. There is no logic in this. It is beyond logic. So do not try to be rational about love. It is like trying to find a reason to explain why the river flows, or why the breeze is cool and gentle, or why the moon glows and the sky is so expansive, or why the ocean is so vast and deep, and the flower is so fragrant and beautiful. Analyzing kills the beauty and charm of such phenomena. They are to be enjoyed, experienced, and loved. If you rationalize about them, you will miss the beauty and charm and the feelings they evoke. Sit by the seashore. Look at it. Feel its vastness. Feel how the waves swell and subside. Just experience it, and be amazed at creation and at the creator of such magnificence. What good will it do you to rationalize about the ocean?

“Rationalizing destroys beauty. Constant reliance on logic kills poetry, music, painting and singing. It destroys everything that is beautiful in nature. Poetry, music, painting,

sculpture, and singing depend on love. The arts are an expression of the artist. It is his heart which is being expressed in his art. The artist pours himself into his art. He dissolves, and only the poetry exists. Only the music exists. Only love exists.

“Faith and self-surrender belong to the same category as love. Love, faith, self-surrender are all connected and interdependent. They are expressions of the heart. Faith is to believe in something that you feel, something which is not visible or tangible, but is an experience. Like love, faith is also an experience. Faith is something deeply personal and subjective. When one has faith, one knows through one’s own experience, and nothing needs to be proven. If there is clear-cut, external proof, then it is not faith, but fact. When facts are available, there is no need for faith. For example, the sun, the earth, plants, trees, rivers, and mountains exist. These are facts. No faith is needed to know that they exist. Their existence can be demonstrated. Faith operates where reason fails. Faith and love are beyond reason. The heart feels and experiences faith and love.

“Science has greatly expanded its areas of inquiry, but still there are many things that the human intellect cannot understand; many things cannot be explained by scientific facts. Even though science has attained previously unimagined heights of achievement, the universe remains a mystery. Though it has developed tremendously, science has not yet grasped even an infinitesimal part of what the universe really is. Isn’t it true that science has totally failed to make human beings happy and peaceful? Has science with all its great achievements been able to make humanity more humane? All the technological development and scientific advances

that we have achieved are the result of our rational thinking; they are products of the intellect. But the predominance of the intellect has destroyed the quality of life; for it has destroyed love, faith, and surrender to a higher goal in life. It has destroyed beauty. It has only helped to inflate the ego, and the vanity of the ego has become a stumbling block for us."

Not quite convinced, the same brahmacharin commented again: "It sounds as though Amma is against science and intellectual thinking. Shouldn't we also consider the beneficial things that science and intellectual thinking have contributed to the society? "

Mother's answer was benevolent: "Son, Mother is not against science or intellectual thinking. Mother is not saying that science has completely ruined us, nor is She trying to say that intellectual thinking is useless. Science and the intellectual quest have brought about great achievements for the entire human race; there is no doubt about that. But what Amma wants to convey is that we human beings should not give too much importance to science and rational thought to the exclusion of everything else. They have their place. Keep them there, neither in a higher nor a lower place. Remember that life is not a machine. Life is Consciousness itself. Do not make life mechanical. For example, householder shouldn't act like a scientist, a business executive, or an administrator when he is at home. The family is not a machine, and neither are you. Life is not a machine. Love is needed in the home to make it feel alive. Otherwise, home becomes hell.

"If you are a scientist, let your rational side shine forth when you are in the laboratory or among other scientists.

That is fine; you can then make use of that aspect of yourself. But when you go home you should be able to drop that role. When you come home you are returning to your real life, and you should be able to shift from your head to your heart. You should have the strength to stop thinking about your science and experiments.

“In the home you are not a scientist or an engineer; there your work is not the most important thing. Your frowns and serious expression have no place at home. How boring and dry life would be if you went directly to your work room without even glancing or smiling at your wife and children when you came home. Think of the pain and stress this would create in your family life—there wouldn’t be any smiling faces. The head of a family who always sits with his chin resting in his palm, who is constantly thinking about his work, is not living up to his duties as husband and father. If he does not interact with his wife and children, tension, stress, and strain will be created, and everyone will find home life boring and sad.

“How many family relationships collapse because of lack of love and concern? How many wives come to Amma saying, ‘Amma, my husband doesn’t even smile at me. He never speaks lovingly to me. He has no concern for me at all. I find it difficult to live with him. What should I do?’ Sometimes such women go after other men, or they become addicted to drugs, or they even commit suicide. In some cases, it is the husband who is the victim. There are countless cases where children are neglected and ignored.

“Children, what Mother says is that you can become whatever you want, but your professional life must be separated from life with your family. You can use your intellect and

think as much as you like; but at the same time, you should be able to drop the intellect and embrace love and faith whenever you wish. You should be able to change the frown into a beautiful smile at any time.

“Love creates smiling, laughing faces and compassionate hearts, and is expressed in sweet and pleasing words. You can choose both head and heart. There is no problem in this, but there should be a balance, for if you choose logic and rational thinking alone, you are in trouble. Love will not create trouble. Love eliminates all troubles. In love there is no trouble, no fear, no agitation, no tension or anger. But to rely on rational, intellectual thinking solely, you will find yourself burdened with many problems, and you will be in constant trouble. Remember, the choice is yours. Use your discrimination. Remember, Mother isn’t dismissing science and logic. Mother is only trying to point out the dangerous tendency of the modern age to give too much importance to reason and logic, at the expense of love and faith, the qualities that unite the human race.”

It was nearly five-thirty in the afternoon. Amma got up from the coconut grove and walked toward the southern end of the Ashram, where the backwaters divided the Ashram property from the neighbors’ land. These neighbors were devotees of Mother. Two girls, who were older than Amma, were especially devoted to Her. In the years when there was nobody to look after Amma, these two girls helped to take care of Her. They often brought Her to their house, where they bathed Her and gave Her food. Now, as if they had been waiting for Amma, these girls and their whole family came running to the edge of their property. Between Mother

and the family lay the backwaters. Amma was so happy and pleased to see them all together. Calling across the backwaters, She inquired about their welfare. The oldest son told Mother that the fishermen in the area had been having a hard time. Because of the heavy rain and high tide, they had been unable to catch any fish for several days. "What a pity! What will happen to them if this continues?" Amma's sadness was evident as She spoke. "It would be sufficient if they had food for at least one day."

The conversation between Amma and the family continued for a while. At its conclusion the family left and Mother walked back through the coconut grove, Her hands held behind Her back. She stopped when She reached the southwestern corner of the Ashram, and stood there gazing at the sea and the waves, and at a long row of fishing boats perched along the shore.

Mother stood there for some time. Perhaps She was thinking about the misfortunes of the fishermen and their families. Upon hearing of their plight, Amma had immediately displayed deep concern. Having been born and raised in this village, She knew what it meant to go for many days without a good catch. It seemed that the ominous sea serpent of starvation and poverty was raising its hood on the seashore.

During the evening bhajan Mother sang, *Ammayalle entamayalle*. . .

*Are You not my Mother?
Oh, are You not my dear Mother
Who wipes away the tears?
Are You not the Mother of the fourteen worlds,*

*Creator of the world?
How many days have I been calling You,
O You whose nature is Shakti,
Will You not come?*

*O You who love to grant all desires,
Are Creation, Preservation and Destruction
not in You?*

Mother wept as She sang. Were they tears of bliss, or was She crying on behalf of the poor fishermen, praying to the Supreme Self on their behalf?

After the bhajan Amma called Nealu and said, "Son, Mother is sick at heart hearing that the children on the seashore have no food. Mother must do something, otherwise She will not be at peace. Mother will not be able to eat or sleep. Make arrangements to distribute rice and other foodstuffs to them tomorrow."

"As Amma wishes," was Nealu's reply.

The lights in the Ashram were turned off at eleven o'clock, but at twelve the lights in Amma's room were still on. It was raining, but if one listened carefully through the sound of the falling rain, one could hear the melodious sound of the tamboura coming from Amma's room. In harmony with the gentle sound of this string instrument Mother sang *Kalina kanaanen kannukal*. . .

*O dark-colored One,
My eyes are burning pitifully
for the sight of Your Feet.
O lotus-eyed One, come running
with the cows and the music of your flute.*

*Having no butter or milk to offer You,
I offer You a little of my pain.
O Kanna, at Your Feet
I offer the pearl drops of my tears.*

*For how many days have I been calling You?
Have You not even a bit of compassion?
What great error have I committed?
Are You not the Lover of Your devotees?*

Mother might have been praying for the fisherfolk. The dark night wrapped itself around the sounds of the falling rain, around the roar of the ocean waves and Amma's song. The atmosphere of this rainy night was full of pathos. Drawn outside by Mother's song, a few brahmacharins sat in front of their huts listening. Mother's mood seemed to be a reflection of the distress and disappointment of the fishermen. What else could it be? Her mind which is One with the Universe feels and reflects everything that happens around Her.



CHAPTER III

Sunday, 8 July, 1984

Everyone was surprised to see the rising sun this morning. After so many days of heavy rain, it was truly a beautiful sight. The sun's rays danced and sparkled on the wet leaves. Birds chirped gleefully, jumping from one branch to another. The day seemed promising, as if things might now take a better turn for the fishermen. Arrangements were made, according to Amma's instructions, to distribute rice and other foodstuffs to the villagers on the seashore.

The ashramites believed that the change of weather came as the result of Mother's sankalpa to improve the lot of the fishermen and their families. When She had first heard about their distress, She seemed deeply affected, and ceased to eat or drink anything. Her songs were like intense prayers of appeal to save the villagers from starvation. Mother Herself had initially made the statement that they should have food for at least one day. As it was, there was no rain on this sunny day, and most surprisingly, the ocean was not rough as it had been on previous days. The fishermen went out to fish in the afternoon and had a very good catch, which saved many families from starving. Thus Amma's statement

about their having food for at least one day came true, both through the distribution of food from the Ashram and by their having a good catch.

Darshan began at around eleven o'clock. As Amma came into the hut, a little boy was walking beside Her. It was Shakti Prasad, a child born by Mother's blessing to a childless couple. Holding on to Amma's hand, the boy looked like a little yogi. Around his neck hung a mala of big rudraksha beads, and there were long, broad lines of sacred ash applied across his forehead. The devotees stared at the boy's appearance. Seeing their looks of curiosity, Amma told them, "He insisted on wearing the big mala and the sacred ash." Amma sounded very happy and pleased with this boy who had come to spend a few days with Her.

Mother sat down on the cot, and remained in a meditative mood with Her eyes closed for some time, as the brahmacharins chanted the *Guru Paduka Stotram*. . .

Aum

*To You, dear Guru, to Your sandals I bow;
O peerless Guru, to Your sandals I bow.
You are our teacher, the Lord of all powers;
To Your sandals, dear Guru, once again I bow.*

*Endowed with the power of 'aim' and of 'hrim',
Your sandals contain all the glory of 'shrim'.
The deep inner meaning of 'Om' they expound;
To Your sandals, dear Guru, once again do I bow.*

*Fire-ceremonies, oblations by priests,
All rites of religion are hereby complete:*

*The knowledge of Brahman Your sandals bestow;
To Your sandals, dear Guru, I most reverently bow.*

*An eagle to slay all the snakes of desire,
Dispersion and wisdom Your sandals inspire.
Your sandals give knowledge and liberty now;
To Your sandals, dear Guru, once again do I bow.*

*A trustworthy boat to cross over life's sea;
Your sandals awake true devotion to You.
They serve as a fire to the waters of doubt;
To Your sandals, dear Guru, once again do I bow.*

The brahmacharins continued their devotional singing while Mother gave darshan.

SADHANA AND DESTINY

One of the devotees had a bandage on his forehead, and Mother was anxious to know why it was there. With a mischievous smile on his face he replied, "You know why, Amma. Without You I would not have been able to come here today." The devotee then told Amma that he had had a motorbike accident as he was returning home from work. He had been in a hurry to get home to see his son who was bed-ridden with high fever and was vomiting, he ignored the heavy traffic and drove very fast through the rain. As he wove in and out of the traffic, a truck suddenly appeared in his lane and hit him. The impact of the collision was so hard that the bike rebounded off the truck, throwing the devotee onto the road.

"I thought I was going to be crushed to death by the fast moving vehicles," he told Amma. "Gathering all my strength I called out, 'Amma, save me! Protect me!' Suddenly I remembered my son, and again I called, 'Amma, my son!' Closing my eyes tightly, I waited to be crushed to death under the wheels of a heavy truck, but that didn't happen. Instead, I felt someone's hands carrying me. It seemed as if I were floating or flying in the air, and yet I clearly felt I was being cradled in someone's hands. Opening my eyes, I still felt the hands but did not see anyone. Then slowly a face appeared before my eyes. It was You, Amma! It was You. . ." The man sobbed and covered his face with both hands. Through tears he said, "I would never have seen your compassionate face again. I would never have seen my son again. Had I died in that accident, he would have been heartbroken and would have died too." The devotee cried uncontrollably.

Like a loving Mother consoling her favorite child, Amma rubbed his back, patted him and stroked his forehead, telling him not to worry as nothing bad had happened. When the man finally calmed down, he wanted to complete his story. He said that he had lost consciousness after seeing Amma's smiling face. When he opened his eyes, he had found himself lying in the meadow by the side of the road, surrounded by a crowd of people. He had been surprised to learn that all of that had happened just within seconds.

He further related, "From people's remarks about how miraculously I escaped, I guessed that they must have seen how the accident happened and how mysteriously I had landed in the meadow. They were about to take me to the hospital, when all of a sudden I stood up saying that I was all right. Except for this wound on my forehead and one on

my left knee, I was fine. Last night I had a thorough check-up and the doctors said that I was perfectly well. Amma, you have saved my life.” As he said these words, the devotee’s eyes again filled with tears.

Mother gently inquired, “How is your son? Is he feeling well?”

The man replied, “By your grace, by the time I finally got home yesterday, his fever had gone down and now he feels much better.”

Another devotee who had been listening to the story was prompted to ask a question about destiny: “Can his escape from death be considered the fruit of his actions alone? Is it the result of karma? Was he destined to be saved by you, or was he destined to die?”

Mother explained, “This accident was destined to happen and he was destined to die. But Mother warned him months ago that something very serious would happen, and that he should pray and meditate as much as he could. He obeyed and followed all of Mother’s instructions. His obedience, sincerity, and devotion enabled him to receive God’s Grace. It was that Grace that saved him from death. But remember, a serious accident did happen. It was an experience that he had to undergo, but he was saved. This was the result of his own effort. His sincere and dedicated effort made compassion and grace flow, and this saved his life. Children, even destiny can be overcome by sincere and dedicated effort. In such a person’s case, God Himself will alter his destiny.”

The devotee who had met with the accident continued: “Five months ago when I first came to have Amma’s darshan, She told me that I should be very careful, that in a few month’s

I would have to face something very serious and dangerous. When Amma learned that I owned a motorbike, She again gave me a warning. She specifically told me that I should always drive slowly. Amma even forbade me from traveling long distances on the motorbike.”

The man who had asked about destiny brought up another point, “Amma, you said that this devotee followed your instructions perfectly and that is what made grace flow toward him. But in some cases, these kinds of miracles happen even before people meet you. I have heard many tell such stories. They say that Amma helped them or someone in their family, even though they hadn’t met you yet. In cases like these, you did not give them instructions, nor did they perform any sadhana. Can you explain this?

Mother answered: “It is true that some people have experiences similar to this, even before meeting Mother. Son, remember that all those who are associated with Amma in this lifetime were also with Her in their previous lives. You can see only this lifetime and therefore you think they did not know Mother before. But they have all been with Amma before. So you cannot say that those experiences happened before they met Mother. No one remembers or knows his connection to Mother in previous lives. There is a predestined time for each one to come to Mother. Some come earlier, others later. But every one of Mother’s children has always been with Her. They come to Mother at different times, they may hear about Amma or may happen to see Her photograph; they may have listened to a recording of Amma’s bhajans. In some cases people come to Amma after meeting one of Her children; still others realize their relationship to Amma

only through direct contact with Her.

“You talk about ‘before meeting Amma,’ but there is no such thing. All of Amma’s children have already met Amma long ago. Even though no one is aware of it, Amma’s protection has always been there. Having followed the instructions given to them in a previous life, people experience God’s grace. Even if they aren’t following the Guru’s instructions or doing sadhana in this life, they may still receive God’s grace due to the merit they have acquired in a previous life.

“You will not see Amma giving any instructions to those devotees, because they have already been given instructions. You may not see them following any instructions, for they may have already done so in the past. They have accumulated enough merit in a previous life for the Guru’s grace to flow toward them in this life. In such cases the devotee must have done whatever he was supposed to do. Now he is ready for the fruit, because the fruition must come. If the Mahatma decides that the fruit of the devotee’s action is to be given on a particular occasion in this life, it will happen. The Guru is the one who bestows the fruit of one’s actions. He knows when to give it. You see only a very small portion of life. Remember that this life is only an infinitesimal portion of your total life. Don’t evaluate things by looking at this small bit. Furthermore, you see the Mahatma’s actions only from the outside, so how can you judge? The Mahatma is the only one who knows everything about the past, present, and future; therefore, you can’t make any judgments about the Mahatma, or about whether other people deserve the Guru’s grace or not. Once the Guru’s instructions have been followed, the results must come to fruition, because it is a debt that Amma must pay, so to speak.

“Son, do not try to judge things before penetrating them. You do not know how to penetrate because you have always been on the surface. To penetrate you need a subtle mind, a subtle eye, and a still mind. A vacillating mind cannot penetrate. Only a still mind can do so.

“Son, you should approach all the devotees who come here; go to all the residents of the Ashram, and ask them about their relationship with Amma. Try to find out when they met Mother and how long they have been with Her. Ask them about their feelings. All of them without exception will say, ‘I came on such and such a date. I have been here with Mother for the last eight, nine or ten years.’ And they will also add, ‘Yet I strongly feel that my relationship with Amma has existed for many lives. I felt this the moment I met Her. Amma, too, acted with such familiarity toward me; She seemed to have known me before.’

“You feel the same way too, don’t you? Why? Does this feeling of familiarity exist in every relationship? No, it does not. Usually when we meet someone, getting to know him takes time. Usually there is a feeling that the other person is a stranger to you, and that you are a stranger to him. But none of Mother’s children have that feeling with Her. None of Mother’s children say that Amma is a stranger to them or that Amma acts like a stranger. Why? Because She has been with you always. Amma has never left you.

“All of you have the experience within you of having previously been with Amma. It lies dormant within you. When the right time comes it will manifest.

“Children, bestowing a blessing or showering grace on someone is totally in the control of a Mahatma. He can do it anytime he wants, or He can refrain from doing it if he

doesn't want to. Grace is a strange phenomenon. One cannot say when, where, or how grace will come. Human calculations fail when it comes to matters of grace. If he so wishes, in a split second the Guru can bestow the blessing of Self-realization on a stranger who has not performed any sadhana. He can also hold back from giving it to a person who has been doing intense sadhana for a long time. Mother is not saying that a Mahatma will withhold grace from a deserving sadhak. She is simply emphasizing that it is within his power to bestow it or not to bestow grace. A Mahatma can easily bless someone by fulfilling his lifelong desire. We may try to analyze why a person is so blessed since we may not see any merit in him, but such a search to find a reason or cause will remain a total mystery for us mortal human beings who cannot go beyond the intellect. Sometimes there will not be any cause for it. The Guru simply does it. Therefore, in order to attain this grace, cry and pray, hold on to the feet of the Guru, no matter what happens."

The darshan continued as people moved forward to be enveloped by Mother's loving embrace and pour out their hearts to Her. The devotees sang *Samsara dukha samanam...*

*O Mother of the World
Dispeller of the sorrows of transmigration
The shelter of Your Blessed Hand
Is the only refuge for us.*

*You are the refuge of blind and lost souls
The remembrance of Your Lotus Feet
Protects everyone from danger.*

*For the deluded ones
Wallowing in the dense darkness,
Meditation on Your name and form
Is the only solution for their wretched state*

*Cast a glance at my mind
With Your beautiful glowing eyes,
O Mother, Your Grace is the only means
to reach Your Lotus Feet.*

When the song ended there was a brief silence. Then Amma continued talking, “A person’s destiny can be changed through the power of a Mahatma, through the workings of a saint. Here is a story to illustrate this:

“There once lived an ardent devotee of Lord Vishnu. After several years of marriage, he and his wife were not blessed with any children. This devotee did intense tapas for the sake of having a child. But the couple remained childless. One day the devotee met the sage, Narada, who was passing through his village. When he learnt that the sage was going to Vaikunta to receive Lord Vishnu’s darshan, the devotee begged Narada to ask the Lord why he and his wife were not yet blessed with a child. He also wanted to know when he might expect to have such a blessing.

When he reached Vaikunta, Narada faithfully conveyed the devotee’s message to the Lord. Lord Vishnu said that the devotee was not destined to have any children in this lifetime. This was such a disappointing answer that Narada did not want to tell the devotee what the Lord had said. He therefore never communicated this unpleasant news to the man.

“Years passed and Narada once again happened to pass through that same village. He paid a visit to the devotee’s house and was very surprised to find three children playing in the courtyard. Upon being told that they were the devotee’s children, Narada asked the man how it was that these children came to be born to him.

“The devotee related to Narada that not long after the sage had passed through the village the last time, the devotee was fortunate enough to meet a saint and serve him. ‘The saint was pleased with my service,’ the devotee explained, ‘and he told me to ask for a boon. Of course I prayed for a child and the saint said that I would have three children. That is how these children came into my life.’

“Narada went straight to Vaikunta and accused Lord Vishnu of not speaking the truth: ‘A few years ago, when I asked for a child on behalf of a certain devotee, You told me that he was not destined to have any children. Yet, now he has three!’

“Before Narada had a chance to mention anything about the saint, Lord Vishnu laughed and said, “That must be the work of a saint, for only saints can change one’s destiny.

“Children, a Mahatma can bestow a blessing which even God cannot. God is nameless and formless; He cannot be seen. A Mahatma gives reality to the existence of God. In His presence, people can see and experience God. The Mahatma blesses people with a tangible experience of God. He makes a great sacrifice by leaving the Supreme Abode of Bliss to live in the midst of ordinary people, like one among them, yet remaining in eternal union.”

Another question was brought up: “Amma, some people who were nonbelievers before become ardent devotees when they meet You. How does that happen?”

Mother answered, “Children, it is true that they may be nonbelievers for some time. That is their karma. But at some point they will have to come to believe in God. These people—nonbelievers who very suddenly become ardent devotees after meeting Amma—have been atheists only in this lifetime, because of the circumstances and conditions into which they were born. However, deep within they still possess the spiritual *samskara* (qualities) inherited from previous lives, and that will be predominant. Compared to the atheistic qualities they have accumulated during this life or the previous one, the latent spiritual *samskara* of a devotee is stronger. When their atheistic tendencies are exhausted, the long-standing faith within them will emerge. It is only a question of time. This unmanifested devotion manifests when they meet a Perfect Master, or when they are exposed to a deeply spiritual situation. At this point the weaker tendencies give way to the stronger spiritual ones. These people will still have to do *sadhana* under the guidance of a Perfect Master in order to eliminate the accumulated tendencies from this life and previous lives. Remember that they will still have *vasanas* to work on. The only difference is that the spiritual *samskara* will be a little stronger than the *vasanas*. This stronger *samskara* helps them come closer to a Mahatma or God. But a Mahatma, if he wishes, can also create a great transformation in a nonbeliever who doesn’t have any spiritual disposition inherited from the previous life. Nothing is impossible for a Mahatma.

Mother asked the brahmacharins to sing. They sang, *Kerunnen manasam Amma*. . .

O Mother, my mind is crying
O my Mother, have You no ear to hear it?

*With an aching heart, I have wandered
All over the land in search of You.
Why this delay to come before me?
O Mother, what shall I do now?*

*What sin has this helpless weakling committed
For You to show such indifference to me?
O Mother, I shall wash Your Lotus Feet
With my hot tears.*

*O Mother, I am tired of this unbearable burden,
The fruit of past deeds.
O Mother, delay not to give refuge
To this utterly exhausted humble servant of Yours.*

The brahmacharins sang the song with so much intensity and devotion that Amma entered into samadhi. She sat very still; Her eyes were half-closed. Her hands were held in two divine mudras. There was complete silence for a few minutes as the devotees sat gazing at Mother's face with awe and devotion. The silence was broken as the brahmacharins began chanting Hari Om. . . Hari Om. . . Everybody responded. The atmosphere was saturated with divine spiritual energy.

ACT WITH DISCRIMINATION

Monday, 9 July, 1984

This morning Amma was sitting in the dining hall which was located north of the temple. It was breakfast time and She asked Gayatri to pluck a few leaves from a jackfruit

tree. It is customary in the villages of Kerala for people to use these leaves, folded in a certain way, to make a spoon for drinking kanji or any other liquid food. Gayatri went out and came back with ten or fifteen leaves. Seeing so many leaves in Gayatri's hands, Amma exclaimed, "Oh, what a great sin you have committed! I asked you to bring only a few leaves, enough for five people. You have unnecessarily destroyed life. That is a sin. You have done something unrighteous. How could you do this? An action performed without proper discrimination is adharma. What have you learned after being with Mother for so many years? One will commit such a sin only if one does not have any love or compassion. You could not feel life pulsating in those leaves; therefore, you didn't have any compassion towards them. Lack of compassion makes it easy to destroy life. When you have no compassion, you have no concern for others. This indicates that you have no faith either, because compassion is an extension of faith—faith in the existence of all-pervading life. Such lack of faith and shraddha prompts you to act indiscriminately. By picking many more leaves than necessary, you acted without any discrimination."

There was a pause. Amma looked at Gayatri. She wanted to ask Mother something but was afraid to open her mouth. Amma continued, "Gayatri-mol is thinking, 'How can the plucking of a few extra leaves be adharma, if plucking five leaves is not? How come plucking five leaves is not adharma?'"

Gayatri was amazed to hear Amma say this, for that was exactly what she wanted to ask Amma but was afraid to.

Time and time again a Mahatma's omniscience is revealed. Yet, even people who are closely associated with a Mahatma fail to understand him. They may have had a

hundred experiences which fully convinced them of the Mahatma's omniscience and all-pervasiveness, but still occasions arise when they are doubtful. Of course, as Mother puts it, "Complete faith is Self-realization." The power of *Mahamaya* (the Great Illusion) is inexplicable. The thick curtain of vasanas makes it difficult for us to dive deep into the consciousness of the Guru or the Mahatma.

Amma answered Gayatri's thought: "Any action performed without discrimination is *adharma*, an unrighteous act. It is a sin. Whatever is wasted due to our lack of care and attention is a sin. Everything has been created for a purpose. Everything has a use. Without the interdependence of things the world couldn't exist. Plants and trees cannot exist without the earth. Animals depend on plants and other animals for food. Human beings depend on animals and plants. Thus the existence of the entire world is nothing but a story of inter-dependence.

"Things meant for human sustenance can be used. If you need only two potatoes, for instance, take two, and not three. Suppose two potatoes are sufficient to cook a dish; if you then take three instead of two, you are acting indiscriminately. You are committing an *adharmic* act.

"Wastefulness is a form of stealing. Since you are not really using the third potato, you are carelessly wasting it. You could give it to someone else, perhaps to a neighbor who does not have enough to eat. Thus by taking that extra potato, you are denying him food. You are stealing his food, and are committing an unrighteous act.

"Plucking a few leaves, enough for five people, would not have been wrong, but you plucked an extra ten. This changed the whole situation. Your action was *adharmic*: First

of all, you unnecessarily destroyed the life of ten leaves. Secondly, you denied them to someone else. These leaves will be wasted due to your acting without thinking.”

One of the brahmacharins said, “Amma is expressing exactly the same principle that Krishna did in the Srimad Bhagavad Gita. Sri Krishna called people who hoard things and do not give to the needy ‘stenah,’ meaning thieves.”

Amma continued, “Exactly. What else can such people be? Those who keep more than they need without giving anything to others, who are badly in need, are really thieves. Their hoarding causes people to rob and steal. Amma has heard of a Mahatma who was made the magistrate of a country. The way he handled the first case brought before him was very strange. He ordered both the thief and the person who had been robbed to be put in jail. When he was questioned by the king about this odd punishment, the Mahatma said, ‘The rich man hoarded too much wealth. He neither used it properly nor did he distribute it to those who could. There are many people starving and dying for want of food, clothing and shelter. In fact, the rich man should be grateful to the thief that he was not murdered.’

“Then he added, ‘I feel a little guilty because I gave the same punishment to both of them. I should have given a harsher punishment to the rich man, because he is the one who caused the thief to steal. Had he distributed his extra wealth to the poor and needy, this would not have happened.’ “

When Mother had finished the story, She continued to sit in the dining hall for a few more minutes, engaged in light conversation. Then She went back to Her room.

PENETRATE BELOW THE SURFACE

At eleven in the morning Amma was giving darshan in the hut.

As She received the devotees, a brahmacharin who was sitting next to Mother asked a question: “Amma, I heard you say the other day that we do not know how to penetrate, that we are always on the surface. You also said that in order to penetrate, a subtle mind and a subtle eye are needed. What do you mean by penetrating? Can you explain?”

Amma answered, “It is the nature of the human mind to vacillate. Just like the pendulum of a clock, the mind always moves from one thing to another, from one mood or emotion to another. This movement is constant. The mind is always in a state of flux. At one moment the mind loves; the next moment it hates. Now the mind likes something, the next moment it dislikes something else. The pendulum of the mind sometimes moves to anger, then moves to desire. It cannot stop; it cannot be still. Because of this constant movement, the stable, unmoving underlying ground of existence, the real nature of things, is not seen. The movement of the mind creates incessant waves, and these waves, the ripples of thoughts, cloud everything, so that nothing can be seen clearly. This movement is like a fog clouding our vision. You see something, but not clearly. You cannot see properly because of the cloud of thoughts. Thus your perception is defective. You make statements about what you perceive, not knowing that your vision is clouded; thus, you make faulty judgments and give out wrong information.

“Each thought, each emotional outburst, and each desire is like a pebble thrown into the waters of the mental lake.

The incessant thoughts are like the ripples on the surface of a lake. The undulating surface makes it impossible for you to see through the water clearly. What is at the bottom of the lake cannot be seen properly, for it is distorted by the ripples on the surface. You never allow the mind to be still. Either there is a craving to fulfill a desire, or there is anger, jealousy, love, or hatred; and if there is nothing happening in the present, memories of the past will crawl in. The sweet and bitter memories, the joyful moments, the regrets, the desire for revenge—something will arise. Then when the past withdraws, the future comes with beautiful promises and dreams. Thus the mind is fully engaged; it is always occupied and never still.

“Children, you perceive only the waves on the surface; yet because of this movement on the surface, you mistakenly think that the bottom is moving too. But the ground is still. It cannot move. You are superimposing the movement of the surface—the ripples of thoughts and emotions—onto the still bottom, the underlying ground. The movement belongs only to the surface—to the mind. The movement is caused by thought waves. It has nothing to do with the ground. But to see this immovable substratum, the surface should become still and silent. The ripples have to stop; the vacillating pendulum of the mind must be stilled. This quieting of the mind is what is known as penetration.

“Once this stillness is attained, you can see clearly through the surface. You stop seeing distorted forms. You behold the real ground of existence—the Truth. All your doubts end. At this point, you realize that you have been seeing distorted forms, that you have been seeing only shadows and clouds. It is then that you realize your ignorance. Before

reaching this state, you may say that you are ignorant; however, you are never really aware of it. To penetrate is to behold the real nature of everything while constantly abiding in your own Self.

“Look at the eyes of real yogis (saints). They have penetrating eyes. They can see right through you. When they look at you, they are not looking at your illusory, distorted form. On the contrary, they are looking at your infinite being; they are looking at the Self. They don’t see you, the ego: they see beyond the ego. They don’t see the play; they see the immovable stage on which the play is being enacted. This means that they see the play as a play. They don’t give it any reality. The play can stop at anytime, but the stage remains. They watch and enjoy the play but never become identified with it.”

Darshan was still in progress at twelve forty-five. The brahmacharins were singing the song, *Mannayi marayum...*

*Man dies and disappears as dust
But is born again on this earth and grows up.*

*If he does good actions, he may attain
To a higher status, and then return to earth again.*

*In life one must undergo disease and old age
O man, think! Is it worth being born again and again?
What are all these evil tendencies for?*

*A person may have done many evil deeds,
But if he knows Who is behind this world,*

*Then all his negativity will be removed
And he will be immersed in the Ocean of Bliss.*

DO NOT ADD TO YOUR EGO

After the song, another question was asked: “Amma, you have said that at some point, we will realize that we have been seeing only illusory forms; that we will experience the real nature of things only when we attain the state of stillness. That is when we will realize our ignorance. What do you mean by realizing our ignorance?”

Amma said, “Children, at present everyone is in a state of ignorance. Even great scholars admit that they are ignorant. When people pray or when they are in the presence of a Mahatma, they say, ‘O Lord, ignorant as I am, please guide me. I do not know anything. Shower your grace upon me. . .’ These are common expressions used by people who say they are ignorant, but how many really know that they are ignorant? How many are aware of their ignorance? People are not aware. Awareness helps eliminate the ego; but because people are not aware of their ignorance, they cannot remove it. Even if they could understand it intellectually, they would still continue to think that they are great; thus, they are not really aware of their ignorance.

“Ignorance is the ignorance of Reality. The concept most people have of ignorance is different. It is a common belief that an ignorant person is one who has not studied, one who is not learned. Scholars would say that an ignorant person is one who has not studied the Vedas or Upanishads and who has no knowledge of modern science. This is what scholars think ignorance is; therefore, they study. They read whatever

books they can get. Once they have become learned they want to speak, they want to teach others and give discourses. They want listeners. They long to be told by others that they are great scholars with such deep insight and wisdom. They want to be adored, and they want to become Gurus. All this, of course, adds to their ego. Their ego was small before they learned so many things. They had less of a burden then. To unload that lesser burden would not have been such a big job, but now the load has become very heavy. Hard work is needed to make even a small crack in a big solid ego.

“Still people like this will pray. Such egotistical people pray, not out of humility or love, but out of fear. While they are praying they use flowery language. In their prayers they beautifully present their ignorance to God. They ask for God’s grace to remove their ignorance and to kindle the light of knowledge within them. In front of others they make a display of being very humble. Having given a long discourse, this kind of person will repeatedly say how ignorant he is and pretend to be humble when people applaud or praise him. But within he is happy as his ego becomes more and more inflated; he is overflowing with joy because others think he is a great scholar.

“Such people do not realize their ignorance. They may say they are ignorant, but they don’t feel it, for they really believe that they are great. They think their knowledge about the scriptures is real knowledge. For them learning is an ornament, something to acquire and wear as a display. As a result, a person who thinks and acts like this gets an inflated ego. His ego gets puffed up, yet he doesn’t feel its weight. It is important that one should feel the heaviness of one’s

ego. The more one feels that the ego is a burden, the more intense will be the longing to unload it and be rid of it.

"However, most people don't feel that their ego is a burden. They believe it is needed. They see the ego as an embellishment to their personality, that it gives them beauty and charm. Remember, a person may say that he is nobody, that he is nothing; but if you touch his ego, if you point a finger at his ego and expose how identified he is with it, he will erupt like a volcano, and the lava of protests will spill out. He reacts out of his total identification with his ego. How can people like this realize the truth about their ignorance? It is very difficult." Then Mother added playfully, "You need a big sledge hammer to break the ego of a person like this."

Everyone burst into laughter, and Amma laughed too. There was a pause, and then She continued: "This is one of the most important things to understand. One must become aware of how egocentric one is. A person should realize that his ego is a burden; he should be aware of his ignorance. He should know that book knowledge is not real knowledge, that such learning only adds to the strength of the ego, unless one is subtle enough to go beyond the words and see the real truth.

"Even ego-centered people pray, using the same or similar words as real devotees. But their prayers don't come from their hearts. They simply utter the words. Externally they look like great devotees, and they may speak beautifully about spirituality, but they have a strong ego, subtle and hard to break. They may pray and sit in a meditative posture, but within their minds are wandering. Such an attitude is the worst kind of ignorance. Yet, a person who is like this does not realize how ignorant he is."

This brings to mind an incident that happened in 1981. One day Amma was sitting at the edge of the backwaters at the southwestern corner of the Ashram. In those days one could look out beyond the backwaters and get a good view of the ocean. There were a few brahmacharins with Mother, and also some devotees from the neighborhood, and Mother's parents. They were discussing practical matters concerning the Ashram, when a middle-aged, distinguished-looking visitor approached them. After greeting Amma and acknowledging the others present, he sat down and began to tell the purpose of his visit.

"I am on a spiritual journey," he said, "call it a pilgrimage, if you will. I have come to the realization that life is not worth living unless one finds the real meaning of life, the real reason why we are here on this earth. The ancient saints and sages of India all say that we are here to gain the ultimate goal of Self-realization. So now, after having lived a life in which I have been blessed with financial success, I have both the time and the means to satisfy my only passion in life, the spiritual quest."

Thus he continued philosophizing. He spoke eloquently. He sounded as if he wanted to let others know how knowledgeable he was. He seemed to be trying to make others believe how sincere he was in his quest for truth. "As far as I am concerned," he said, "the most important sadhana is meditation. Only in meditation can I establish a real relationship with God, for God knows me more than anyone else, more than I even know myself."

The man continued in this vein for a while as his words were met with slight nods of acknowledgment from those who were present, for he appeared to be well-versed and

erudite in what he was saying. Amma sat, smiling at him as She listened.

Encouraged by the relaxed atmosphere, he slowly glanced around and said, "I feel quite at home in ashrams. I have visited so many. Ah, there is such a feeling of peace here. May I stay here for a few days to meditate?" With those words he sat in the lotus posture, closed his eyes and began to meditate.

Br. Nealu now resumed speaking to Amma about certain Ashram matters. After the brief discussion was concluded, Amma got up. Everyone prostrated to Her. The man seemed to be in deep meditation. As Amma passed by him, She placed Her palm fully on the top of his head and gave it a good shake, saying, "Are you still bargaining in that teakwood purchase?" Then She walked on.

The man was startled. He was obviously shocked. He couldn't meditate anymore. He stood up looking restless and disturbed. As he walked back and forth, he asked one of the brahmacharins several times if he could have a personal audience with Mother. Just before the evening bhajan, Mother granted his request. It was revealed that this man was a timber merchant dealing in teakwood in the northern part of Kerala. For the last two weeks he had been trying to acquire some very high quality teakwood. He had placed his bid but the seller wanted a higher price than the one he had offered. He was honest and told Mother that just when She had placed Her hand on him to shake him, it was exactly as Mother said: in his mind he was actually doing the bargaining with the seller.

This man felt remorseful about his pretense and asked for Mother's forgiveness. "Amma, now I know you are truly

a great saint. You knew all along that I was only speaking from my fantasies about being a spiritual seeker. You have humbled me, Amma. I don't want to be pretentious about spirituality anymore. Oh, Amma, please help me be honest to myself. I know you can help me."

Later, when the man left the Ashram, some of the brahmacharins were discussing this incident, mocking his pretension. When this reached Amma's ears, She scolded them with sharply for being so mean: "Don't feel so great about yourselves. At present you're not very different from him. Who can refrain from brooding when there are so many dreams accumulated within?"

Mother darshan continued as the brahmacharins began another chant of the Divine Name, *Devi maheswariye*. . .

*O Divine Mother, Great Goddess
Whose nature is illusion
O Cause and Creator of the Universe,
I bow to You again and again.*

*O dark-haired Empress of the Universe,
O great Maya of beautiful limbs,
O Supreme Goddess,
You are the Friend of devotees,
Granting them both bondage and liberation.*

*You are that merciful Goddess
In whom everything has arisen,
By whom everything is led
In whom everything will merge. . .*

As the singing continued, Mother slipped into an inwardly absorbed state sitting on the cot in the darshan hut. What an incomprehensible phenomenon! Just a few minutes earlier She had been speaking great words of wisdom. All of sudden, without notice, She was gone! She was no more in this world. Silence fell on the crowd and a deep feeling of peace permeated the hut. Inspired by Amma's blissful state, the devotees easily slipped into meditation.

THE WITNESS

Having soared to the peaks of spiritual awareness, Mother came back down after a few minutes and resumed giving darshan to the assembled devotees. A brahmacharin asked a question: "Amma, you just mentioned that the saint, when he looks at us, is looking at the infinite consciousness, not at the external person. But when the saint speaks to us, he sometimes discloses things about our past and future—things that are related to our physical form. Even you do this, Amma. How can the saint speak like this without seeing our external form?"

Mother responded, "Again Amma says that the saint sees only the infinite Self, not the person. Yes, he may speak to you; so what? When he speaks to you, he is only a witness. He speaks only because it will benefit you. You are inspired by his words, and through his words you are given a glimpse of reality. Otherwise he prefers to be silent. He is silence. When a saint speaks, he doesn't really speak; his body speaks and he witnesses it. When the saint sleeps, he does not sleep; he watches the sleep of his body. When he works, he is not working; he merely observes the body working. He is simply

a presence, a constant presence, a witness to all that happens to his own body and all around.

“If the saint is sick, he comes out of his body and looks at the great pain that it undergoes. If he is insulted or abused by others, again he comes out of his body and watches; he witnesses the trouble the body is undergoing. Then he can laugh at the insults showered on him. He can laugh at the angry looks and words directed toward him. He is no longer the body; he is Pure Consciousness. How can consciousness get angry? How can consciousness be insulted? It’s impossible! The saint is consciousness, thus he is untouched and unaffected by insults or anger.

“When the saint looks at you, he does see your form, your physical appearance; not because your body is in front of him or because his eyes are wide open, but because he wants to see your form. If he does not want to see you, he won’t. He is the master of his mind, not a slave to it. We are the ones who are enslaved by the mind.

“If the saint looks at you and sees your form, it is only because he wishes to see your form, but he can also stop seeing you even if you are sitting in front of him and his eyes are wide open. If he discloses your past, present and future, what of it? Why is that so astounding? If he wishes, he can tell you about the past, present, and future of the entire universe, because he is the universe. The universe is within him. The universe is like a bubble within his existence. To look at the universe and to make a few predictions is not difficult for him. He is the ocean of existence, and the universe is like a bubble or a small wave within him. If he tells you something about yourself, he still remains a detached witness to what he is saying. But usually he doesn’t

bother with disclosures of this sort. He does not engage himself in talk of what happens in the world. He is constantly in meditation.

“Now the word meditation should not be misunderstood. Do not compare your meditation with the saint’s. Your meditation is not meditation. Your meditation is constant effort, a struggle to attain the state of meditation. But the saint is always in this state. Whether he walks, sits, sleeps, eats, or talks, he is always in deep meditation. There is no time when he is not meditating, when he is not abiding in his own Self.

“Thus, because the saint abides in his own infinite Self, he sees the infinite Self in all others. It is not a contradiction to say that he sees another person’s form, for he does so only if he wishes. He can enter his body and join in the play, and he can withdraw at will. He can let the senses see, speak, eat, run, laugh or sleep, but he can withdraw them anytime he wants. Whatever he does, the Mahatma continues to abide within his own Self, beholding everything as his own Self. Never does he become identified with his body—he simply observes. He is constantly watching. As he watches what takes place around him, he can let his body take part in it and withdraw at will. But even when he is taking part in it, he is not involved at all. However, he knows that the only reality is the infinite Self. “

Mother stopped for a while, and the devotees sat in silence, taking in what She had just said. The silence was broken by a devotee, an elderly man, who said: “Amma’s words remind me of a verse in the *Bhagavad Gita*.” Then he quoted the Sanskrit sloka from the fifth chapter, verses 8-9. . .

Naiva kimcit karōmīti
 yuktō manyeta tattva-vit
 paśyan śṛṇvan sprśan jighrann
 aśnan gacchan śvasan svapan
 Pralapan viśṛjan gṛhnann
 unmiṣan nemiṣann api
 indriyānīndriyārtheṣu
 vartante iti dhārayan

The sage, centered in the Self, realizes, "I do nothing at all." Though seeing, hearing, touching, smelling, eating, walking, emptying, sleeping, holding, opening and closing the eyes, he is assured that only the senses are occupied with their objects.

Amma continued, "Let's see now. . . where were we? Yes, the saint can go out and return at any time. If he wants to, he will look and see; if he doesn't want to do so, he will remain within his own Self. With the entire universe revolving within him, is anything impossible for him?"

"Listen to this story. A woodcutter was chopping wood when a man came up to him, 'Excuse me, but a great procession has just passed by. Can you tell me which way it went?' The woodcutter looked at the man and said, 'I did not even see a procession,' and immediately he went back to his work. Such is the state of the Mahatma. His mind is still. He does not see or hear anything. At the same time, if he wants to, he can let the world in. He can see or hear whatever he wants to, and then he can go within again. He is both here in the world and there in the Ultimate. But the world cannot touch him. He cannot be deluded or blemished by the world. Although he does everything, he

remains untouched.”

This raised another question, “How does he do that? How is it possible for him to come and go from the Ultimate at will?”

Mother answered, “When the yogi turns off his mind, the play, or the program, ends. It’s just like turning off a television set. When you want to see the program, you press the ‘on’ button. If you want to watch it, it is there; and when you don’t want to watch anymore, you turn the TV off and the program disappears. The on and off button of the mind is in the yogi’s hand, under his perfect control.

“If you have something and you can let go of it anytime you want, what does that mean? It means you are not attached to it. You do not possess it and it doesn’t bind you. Whether you have it or not, you don’t care. This is detachment. Like this, the yogi is in a supreme state of detachment.

“The yogi himself is like a screen. A screen neither projects the play nor does it enjoy it. It is simply the underlying base on which the action of the play takes place. It simply is.

“You may have heard of the great sage, Veda Vyasa. Once he was sitting in samadhi on the banks of the river Yamuna. The gopis of Vrindavan wanted to cross to the other shore, but they couldn’t because the river was flooded. It was getting dark, and nowhere could they find a way to cross the river. Finally they saw the sage sitting in meditation. With great hope they approached him. Offering some fruits and flowers at his feet, the gopis prayed to him to help them cross the river. Veda Vyasa awoke from his samadhi. He was pleased, for he knew they were great devotees. Accepting their offerings, he ate everything.

“When he had finished eating the fruits, Vyasa, taking

pity on the gopis, raised his hand and said, “If it is true that I have not eaten any of these fruits, let the waters of the Yamuna part and give way to these devout gopis.” Lo and behold! The waters parted and the gopis were able to reach the other shore. This is exactly what Mother was speaking about. Though he ate, the sage Vyasa didn’t eat anything, and the parting of the river attested to that. Though he caused the waters of the Yamuna to part, he did not do anything because he was in the supreme state of detachment.

“Because you see the saint eating, sleeping, and speaking, you may say that he eats, sleeps and speaks. This is your mind projecting such actions onto him because you yourself eat, sleep and speak. You see only the external. You see only his body, and you think you understand him. Furthermore, you see everybody else doing the same as you, so you think that the yogi is not any different from you. Your own thoughts and actions are projected onto him, yet what you perceive has nothing to do with him. His thoughts and actions are not remotely like yours. You are not familiar with detachment; you know only about attachment, anger, hatred, jealousy, and other negative traits. You therefore project the same familiar traits onto the sage as well. You interpret what he is, and what he does, according to your vasanas.

“Children, have you heard this story? There was once a king who had two great painters in his court. Because a great rivalry existed between them, the king decided to hold a competition. He called them saying, ‘We will have a contest to decide who is the better painter. Each of you is to submit a painting using “peace” as the theme.’ The first painter chose to paint a still lake in the mountains, with not even a ripple on the surface. Just looking at the lake made the

mind still.

“The other artist painted a thundering waterfall full of white foam. Right next to the waterfall was a small bush on which was perched a delicate little bird with its eyes closed. The latter is an example of dynamic silence, silence that can exist in the midst of the busy world. This is the great state of the yogi. He can live peacefully even in the midst of chaos and strife. He remains silent and unaffected, for he is absorbed in deep meditation. Even while living in the problematic world of diversity, the sage is in meditation.”

“This state of Oneness is so inexplicable that great souls throughout the ages have found it difficult to describe in words,” remarked one devotee.

“Son, you are right, said Amma. “It is such a difficult task because the experience of the Truth is so full, so overflowing and so perfect that words cannot contain it. The intellect cannot grasp it. Even many ordinary, subjective experiences cannot be explained verbally; therefore, how can one possibly talk about the ultimate experience of Truth? This is one of the reasons why many of the scriptures are written in the form of sutras or aphorisms.

“The rishis did not want to talk much. It seems that they wanted to use very few words to describe their experiences. Even they must have found it difficult to put their experiences into words, and thus they felt that sutras would serve as the best mode of expression. They may have anticipated that in the future scholars would interpret and elaborate on what they had written. They probably knew that each scholar would come up with his own interpretation, that each one would invent many different explanations that the rishis themselves

had never even dreamt of. They may have surmised that even if they did elaborate on their own experiences, people would still not be content and would instead elaborate on the rishis' elaborations, giving yet further interpretations. Perhaps it was for this reason that they decided to say very little.

“As we can see, this is exactly what has happened. So many commentaries and interpretations now exist on the *Bhagavad Gita* and other scriptural texts. People have been writing, writing, and writing about spirituality for centuries. They can't stop. People's heads are so full of stuff that they want to write, talk, interpret, expound and dispute. Eventually they themselves become confused, and in their confusion they make others confused as well.”

Everybody laughed. The last of the visiting devotees were having Mother's darshan. Since there were not many visitors that day, each of the brahmacharins and the other residents of the Ashram also went up to Amma to receive Her blessing. It was a slow and sweet darshan, during which She gave a lot of attention to each devotee.

As the darshan was drawing to an end, the brahmacharins sang one last song, *Mauna ghanamritam*. . .

*The Abode of Dense Silence,
Eternal Peace and Beauty
In which was dissolved the mind of
Gautama Buddha,
The Effulgence destroying bondage
The Shore of Bliss beyond the reach of thought
Knowledge that bestows*

*Perennial equanimity of mind
The Abode having no beginning and no end
Bliss experienced after
The movements of mind are hushed
The Seat of Power, Region of Dense Consciousness*

*The Goal indicated by the statement:
'Thou art That,'
Which grants the sweet eternal Non-dual State
There it is I long to reach
No other ways are there than through Your Grace.*

It was nearly two o'clock and nobody had yet had lunch. Getting up from Her cot, Amma called a few of the brahmacharins and asked them to arrange to serve food to the devotees in the dining hall.

She said, "Children, all of you must have lunch prasad before you leave the Ashram." She then looked around as if searching for something. Not finding what She was looking for, Amma asked Gayatri, who was waiting for Amma outside, "Do you have any plantains upstairs? If there are any, bring them." Gayatri went up and returned with some bananas which Mother divided and fed to each devotee. Making sure that everyone received a piece, Amma asked, "Children, did everyone get prasad?"

There was no immediate reply, but after some time a devotee said in a soft voice, "It appears that everybody has, Amma, but we are always happy to get more prasad from your hands. This is a such a rare opportunity."

Amma went up to him and lovingly pinched his ear as a mother does to a mischievous child. Facing all Her children

as She bowed, Amma left the darshan hut, followed by Gayatri, and went directly to Her room. The devotees, their hearts full of bliss and contentment, moved to the dining hall to have lunch.



CHAPTER IV

At five o'clock Mother again came down from Her upstairs room. It was drizzling, so Gayatri held an umbrella over Mother's head. However, Mother did not remain under the umbrella for long because She was walking very quickly. Gayatri followed Mother, trying again and again, without much luck, to protect Her from the rain. Finally, Mother turned around and said to her, "Amma doesn't want the umbrella. She is not going to get a cold or fever. Amma is used to it, so you can have it."

Then She looked back toward the others, including Gayatri, saying to them as they followed, "Children, don't let the rain fall on your head. You might catch cold."

By now all the residents of the Ashram were with Amma as She walked past the kitchen to the bathrooms and toilets. Amma looked into each bathroom and toilet. Because of the heavy rain nobody had paid much attention to them, so they were not very clean. Without uttering a word, Amma entered one of the bathrooms and started cleaning it with a broom and a bucket of water. Everyone who was nearby started running about, trying to find other brooms and buckets with which to clean the remaining bathrooms and toilets.

Already they knew that this was going to be a difficult time for them. They knew they were being taught a hard lesson.

Buckets and brooms were soon found, but just as someone was about to enter a bathroom, they all heard Mother's voice, "No, no. This is not your job. Your job is to meditate, to pray and to study. You are not supposed to do this kind of dirty work. Mother will do this. She is used to doing dirty work. Children, you all come from good families; you should not do this. This is not like meditating and praying. This is different. You should not do anything that you feel is different from meditation; you have all bathed and are ready for the evening bhajan, so not make your bodies stink. Go and meditate!"

Her words were full of sarcasm. Everybody turned pale and stood motionless as if frozen by the impact of Mother's words. Some held brooms in their hands while others had buckets. Nobody dared to enter the bathrooms. They simply could not because of what Mother had said. The message that was hidden in Mother's words had penetrated deeply into each one's heart. They all stood quietly, buckets and brooms in hand, with their heads hanging in shame. Amma cleaned all the bathrooms and toilets by Herself. It was quite a sight to see the Ashram residents standing, holding buckets and brooms in their hands like immovable statues. Had this been a different occasion, watching them would have been a good joke.

After finishing the work, Amma put the broom and the bucket where they were usually kept and without saying another word, She left. Gayatri sincerely wished to follow Her but was afraid to do so. It was still drizzling as Amma went to the edge of the Ashram compound where She lay

down on the wet sand. Soon the drizzle turned into rain, as if the rain clouds had been waiting for Mother to lie down. Each resident wanted to fall at Her feet to seek forgiveness. Each one wanted to run to Her and beg Her not to punish Herself because of his negligence, but nobody had the courage to do so.

The rain poured heavily as Mother continued lying in the sand. She was completely drenched. The residents stood at a distance until finally one of them could not control himself any longer. He ran over to Her, calling, "Amma!" Each person had been waiting for this, for somebody to take the initiative. Now, the entire group ran to where Mother was lying. The call, "Amma!" rang through the air like the chorus in a great drama. Everyone was crying, seeking Mother's forgiveness for the mistake. But Mother was not there. She was far beyond the realm of sound and speech. A few moments passed before they realized that Mother was in deep samadhi.

Though Mother most often went into samadhi during bhajans or darshan, apparently from the bliss of devotion, there were also times when Her samadhi states were triggered by some sort of trouble or upset, by incidents involving the negligent or inappropriate behavior of Her children. For no apparent reason these samadhi states lasted longer than the other ones. Once in 1979 Mother entered her family temple and did not come out for a whole day. She remained there for many hours in a completely motionless state. She didn't move or blink, there was no sign of breathing. This came about as the result of a quarrel between Mother's two younger brothers. Mother had tried to intervene, but they would not stop. Mother pleaded and begged, but still they continued

to quarrel until their verbal duel became uncontrollable. At this point, Mother rushed into the temple and moving toward one corner became absorbed in deep samadhi.

Because this seemed like a similar type of samadhi, everyone grew worried. Some started crying and praying and some of the brahmacharins began to chant. All the while the rain continued to pour. Umbrellas were brought, but they did not really protect Mother from the fierce pounding of the rain. More than fifteen minutes passed. There was not even a slight movement in Amma's body. Fear and anxiety gripped everyone's heart. Was Mother going to come back from samadhi? Was the pouring rain causing harm to Her body? Everybody was completely drenched by the heavy rain. Finally, it was decided to take Amma to Her room. Assisted by some other women, Gayatri carried Amma up the stairs and into the room while a few brahmacharins continued to chant.

After changing Mother's wet clothes and drying Her, Gayatri, Kunjumol, and some of the women residents massaged Her. A few brahmacharins entered the room and continued chanting. With great emotion, Br. Pai sang a few Sanskrit hymns written by Sankaracharya. . .

*O Mother, You have many worthy sons on earth,
But among them, I am the most insignificant,
Yet, O Consort of Shiva, it does not befit you
to forsake me,
For now and then a bad son may be born,
But there can never be a bad mother. . .*

*There is no sinner like me,
Nor a destroyer of sins like You.
O Mahadevi, knowing all this,
do as You see fit.*

The state of samadhi continued for nearly two hours. A brahmacharin had been instructed by Amma about what to do during Her samadhi states. Every now and then he felt the soles of Amma's feet. He did not disclose exactly what the instructions had been, but he said, "Amma once told me that we must be very careful if Her samadhi should continue for more than half an hour. She strictly said that we should sing the Divine Name or chant mantras continuously until She returns to Her normal state."

Around seven-thirty in the evening, Mother returned to the earthly plane of awareness. She remained on the bed, Her eyes transfixed. Gayatri, Kunjumol, and the other women were still massaging Her body. The sound of evening bhajans emerged from the temple verandah, and Mother opened Her eyes. It did not look as if She had yet fully returned from Her transcendent state. The brahmacharins in the room stopped chanting. With a sign of Her hands, Amma asked everyone to leave the room and everyone, except Kunjumol and Gayatri, went out, closing the door behind them. Still concerned about Amma, a few of the brahmacharins wanted to sit in front of Mother's room, but the others felt that nobody should remain there, that if a need arose, either Gayatri or Kunjumol would fetch someone. So they all went down the stairs.

The rain had stopped just a few minutes after Amma was carried in, and shortly afterward, the sky was clear. The

fact that the storm arrived so suddenly just as Amma lay down in the sand, and left just as abruptly when She was taken to Her room, made the whole drama look like an act of Divine Will. While only Mother can comprehend the vastness of divine power, to the residents who had been there the storm somehow seemed intimately connected to the lesson Mother was teaching them.

THE BEAUTY OF WORK THROUGH LOVE

Tuesday, 10 July, 1984

After breakfast, at about ten o'clock, Amma called all the brahmacharins. One by one they came to Amma's room. The brahmacharinis, Gayatri, Kunjumol and Saumya, were also called. When they had all come in, Amma asked one of them to lock the door. When that was done, Amma closed Her eyes, joined Her palms together and sat in a prayerful mood. The brahmacharins all gazed at Her face. Tears streamed down Mother's cheeks. Opening Her eyes for a moment, Amma wiped the tears with a towel and once again closed Her eyes. Suddenly She began to sing *Vedanta venalilude..*

*Where is the truth of the Gita
which proclaims that You will help
A lonely traveller towards Brahman?*

*Though I am making my way
Through a forestlike path,
for the attainment of You,*

*And for the peace of my soul,
My mind is filled with sorrow.*

*O Friend of the miserable,
My heart forever burns for something,
I know not what.
Do You not intend
To remove my sorrow?*

*O Mother, O Bhagavati Devi,
Do You not know that without merging
Into Your mind-enchanting Being
There is no peace?*

This was not simply a devotional song. Amma's heartfelt expressions overflowed through the song, charging the whole atmosphere with a feeling of intense longing. The brahmacharins' eyes also filled with tears as love and devotion permeated the entire room. Amma's radiant face and the way She poured Herself totally into the song touched everyone deeply, creating an indelible memory in the secret chamber of each one's heart.

After the song, there was a deep, profound silence. Amma remained in a meditative mood, and everybody responded by slipping into spontaneous meditation. The meditation continued until everyone was brought back by Mother's favorite mantra, Om Namah Shivaya.

Unexpectedly Amma asked, "Did Mother make Her children sad?" She was referring to the bathroom incident followed by the samadhi state the previous day.

"We must receive such hard lessons, otherwise there is

no hope for us,” responded a brahmacharin.

“Do not think that Amma wanted to frighten you all. It just happened that way. Sometimes it becomes uncontrollable. What to do about this crazy one!”

“We were all very concerned about your body. Why do you have to torture your body because of our mistakes?” said another brahmacharin.

Mother’s replied, “Those are blissful moments, not torture at all. Amma wanted to be in the rain. Nevertheless, when Her children are very careless, when She sees their lack of shraddha, Amma feels sad. Such sadness sometimes leads Her into a state of absorption. She then feels like withdrawing from the external world. It is when we look on the outside that we see all these faults, lack of alertness and shortcomings. Then She thinks of withdrawing Her mind from this world, this world of events. The very thought of withdrawal is enough, for then She shoots up in no time. The thought that the world and the body are the cause of all those troubles makes Amma close Her eyes to both.

“Children, Amma’s body is maintained only for the sake of Her children, and for the world. You should always be aware of this truth. You should remember that to keep this body in the world is not an easy thing. At any time, Amma can put an end to this body’s mundane existence. It is Her children’s sincerity and steadfast intention on the goal that keeps the body here. It is the call of thousands of sincere seekers and devotees all over the world that draws the body to keep itself down on this plane of existence. Without this, there is no downward pull. This body has no other purpose to be here. Food and sleep are not at all a problem for Amma. She has nothing to do with worldly matters or with wealth.

Amma has trained Herself well enough to overcome any situation, adverse or favorable.

“Children, this Ashram is not Amma’s. This place exists for the world. It belongs to you, and to all the people who come here. Mother, in fact, has no interest in establishing ashrams or other institutions. She would not have done any of these things if it were not for the world. Amma does these things to help the world. The world should not be filled with selfish people. There should be a few places where at least a handful of people can work and serve selflessly. The beauty and charm of selfless love and service should not die away from the face of this earth. The world should know that a life of dedication is possible, that a life inspired by love and service to humanity is possible.

“Children, Amma expects you to be loving, selfless and very alert in performing your duties. When your heart is filled with love and selflessness, it overflows and expresses itself in all your thoughts, words, and actions. Amma knows that you have not yet attained the state of perfection. But isn’t that your goal? You want to live and serve in love, don’t you? So you need practice; you must make a constant effort. Amma is very happy if you at least make an attempt to do this. But Mother is very sad when She sees Her children’s indolence. Children, never become negligent or sink into apathy. Apathy is the worst state of mind for a spiritual seeker. Someone who is inert is not enthusiastic or interested in anything; he has lost all hope and is bored with life. Such a person is too lazy even to try to get out of his dullness and he becomes a burden to others. His burdensome nature causes anger and hatred to rise within him. His anger forces him to hate everything—his own people, society, God and

even his own existence.

“Children, it is necessary to work as we live. Life is precious; therefore, do not waste it by doing things mechanically without love. We should try to put love into everything we do. Machines can do many of the things we do, sometimes even better and more efficiently, but nobody is inspired by a machine. Even though machines can produce greater quantities of work than humans, the quality of love is absent in machine-made products. When love is absent in any action, the action becomes mechanical. People who work mechanically without love become like machines within; they become less human. Humans can love; they can express love and they can live in love—they can even become love.”

Amma stopped abruptly. There was silence for a few moments. The clock struck once. It was ten-thirty in the morning. Time itself was warning each soul: “I cannot wait for you; I cannot come back. Whatever you want to do, do it now; do not postpone. I am carrying you toward death, even without your knowledge.” Amma was in an absorbed mood. She rocked back and forth with Her eyes closed.

Returning to a normal mood, Amma continued to speak: “There are painters who paint hundreds of thousands of pictures. But there is no depth in their paintings. Nobody feels any attraction to them. They do not penetrate anybody’s heart. They do not create any feeling of love or beauty in the viewer’s mind. There are many such painters, and they go on painting until they die, but nobody feels inspired by their work.

“There are other painters, however, who do not paint many pictures, maybe just a few. But those few paintings

become world famous. People crave to possess one of those paintings. By looking at one of them they feel inspired and amazed. If it is a painting of the ocean, one can feel the vastness and the depth of the sea just by sitting in front of the picture. Just by looking at the painting you are able to experience the sea. You see the waves and you even feel the ocean breeze. Why is this possible? Because of the great love the painter pours into his work. Even if the painting is hung in a matchbox-sized room, it appears to create vast space; the mountains, valleys, rivers and trees become alive. You see beyond the canvas and the paint; you see nature in all its magnificence and glory.

“If a person pours his heart and soul into an activity, it will be transformed into a tremendous source of inspiration. The product of an action performed with love will have a discernible presence of life and light in it. That reality of life and love will make people feel immensely attracted towards it. A Mahatma constantly shows the way. Patiently he instructs you, not once or twice but a thousand times. If you don’t listen, if you always disobey, if you still think that you can borrow beauty and love from him instead of working for it yourself, he will withdraw and disappear. A Mahatma has no obligations or duty to the world, other than having created it by their own will, for the good of the world and mankind.

“Children, God has given us the necessary faculties to become like Him. Love, beauty and all divine qualities exist within us. We should make use of our faculties to express these divine qualities in our lives. Don’t be lazy and idle away your time. Life is a precious gift. This human body is a rare gift. Work with love while you are still healthy. Do not be a burden to others. God may not have provided you

with money, but if you are endowed with a healthy body, work and do it with all your heart.

“Once there was a beggar who was poor but very healthy. He would appeal to anyone who passed by, ‘Good people, look at me. God has created me without providing anything. I have nothing, no relatives, nobody to take care of me. Have pity on me.’ One day a wise passerby stopped and said to him, ‘Okay, give up both your hands to me and I will give you a million dollars.’ This caused the beggar to exclaim, ‘How can I live without my hands? They are very precious to me!’ The wise man then said, ‘Okay, don’t worry. What about your legs? I offer the same amount for your two legs.’ Shocked, the beggar replied, ‘Are you crazy? How can I give my legs for a million dollars? My legs are too precious even for that sum.’ The wise man then asked for the beggar’s eyes, but he met with the same response. The beggar said that any part of his body was too precious to be given for a million dollars. The wise man then said to him, ‘Look, brother, day after day you are saying that God created you without providing you with anything. Now you yourself have openly declared that your hands, legs and eyes—each part of your body—is very precious to you. Each is priceless you say. So God has certainly given you a precious and priceless body. Why don’t you work, using your healthy body to earn a livelihood? Don’t just stretch your arms, begging for alms when you are still healthy; that is laziness. God does not like lazy people who want to borrow everything from others. God does not like people who are like parasites; therefore, work, my dear brother, work!’

“Nobody wants to work, to put forth effort to reach the state of perfection. All are eager to know if they can borrow

peace, beauty and love from someone or somewhere. When they see the beauty, and love around a Mahatma, they crave it. They want to become like him. They say, 'How beautiful and wonderful you are! I have never experienced so much love and peace in my life. How can I become like you?' So the Mahatma tells them how, but they will not work hard to attain it. Still they want it, so they ask if they can borrow it.

"A Mahatma is the embodiment of the pure love of God, eternal beauty personified. When people meet him, they are attracted to him. Sometimes they too want to become loving and beautiful like him. But when the Mahatma explains to them the ways to attain those qualities, the great renunciation and surrender that are necessary, they frown and withdraw. They expect to get it free, without doing anything. This body itself is a free gift from God. He gave it simply out of compassion. But human beings are greedy; they always want more. More and more and more—but free! That is their life-long slogan."

"Do your work and perform your duties with all your heart. Try to work selflessly with love. Pour yourself into whatever you do. Then you will experience beauty and love in every field of work. Love and beauty are within you. Try to express them through your actions and you will definitely touch the very source of bliss.

Again there was a pause. Amma moved her right hand in circles while softly chanting, Shiva. . . . Shiva. . . Shiva. . . Shiva. . . Everybody had been keenly listening to the parable Mother had just related and to the explanation which followed. Amma asked the brahmacharins to sing *Maname nara*

jivitamakkum. When they started the song, Amma also joined in. . .

*O mind, this human birth is like a field;
If not cultivated properly
It becomes dry and barren.
You know not how to sow the seeds
Nor how to grow them well,
Neither have you the wish to know.
By removing the weeds and putting fertiliser,
By taking proper care,
You will have a good harvest.*

*The early part of life
Is spent in helpless cries
And youth is spent in lustful attachment.*

*As old age approaches
Your strength is taken away,
You become like a helpless worm
Biding your time, with nothing to do
Looking forward only to the grave.*

After this song a brahmacharin asked, “Amma, your statement that the Mahatma will withdraw and disappear if the disciples don’t listen and obey him sounded like a warning to us all. Are you trying to say that you too will do the same if we act indiscriminately?” There was fear and anxiety in his voice.

Amma consoled him, patting his back as She began to speak, “Son, try not to compare. Amma was not saying that

She too will go away if you don't listen to Her. Amma was indicating that the Mahatma has nothing to lose or gain. You are the losers if you do not follow his words. You will lose the beauty, love, and peace which you see in him and in his actions. In a way, it is his disappearance from your life, isn't it? Mother was simply trying to express that we should perform our actions with love and dedication. Try to follow the footsteps of the Guru with all your heart. Obedience to the Guru's words is the only way to cross over all obstacles which arise in the spiritual path.

"Amma is saying that love alone lends attraction and beauty to our actions. No work is insignificant or meaningless. The amount of love that you pour into your work makes it significant and beautiful.

"You may think that cleaning the bathroom is dirty work. Try to feel that cleaning the bathroom is an opportunity to serve the devotees who visit the Ashram. If you can, clean a dirty public place without anybody's insistence. Do it just out of concern for others. That action becomes a beautiful piece of work. Your pure attitude beautifies the work. An unknown feeling of joy springs forth within you as a result of doing it.

"Behind all great, unforgettable events lies the heart. Love and a selfless attitude underlie all truly great deeds. Behind any good cause, you will find somebody who has renounced everything and dedicated his or her life to it.

"Look at your mother cooking. She does it with love. Look at a farmer working in the field. The farmer can create waves of beauty in his work if he does it with love and sincerity. You can see that his heart is in his work; you can feel his heart flowing toward it. He is happy and enthusiastic while

he tends to his chores. Loudly singing or humming a folk melody, he works tirelessly, without being bothered about food or sleep, or what happens around him. He is patient; he is not worried about the amount of time the work will consume. He enjoys plowing, sowing, irrigating and harvesting by himself. This is the meaning of the word sincerity. Sincerity means the ability to put your whole heart into what you do, the ability to love your work.

“Children, you must do your work with sincerity. Whether you consider it significant or insignificant, whether you like it or not, you should do your work with interest and love. When you work in this way, when love begins to flow into all that you do, your work becomes sadhana. It becomes less and less difficult, until one day all physical and mental exertion are gone. From then on, you will start working with your whole heart. Love blossoms within you and it will be reflected in all that you do.

“Even a saint, after attaining Self-realization, might continue doing the same work he did before, like sweeping the road or working in the fields. But now his attitude is different. After Realization he is totally detached. He is the observer of all that he does. Full of innocence and wonder, the saint never gets bored. He is like a child who never tires of hearing the birds sing, who never gets bored looking at flowers, who is always thrilled by the rising moon. Like a child’s world, the saint’s life is filled with wonder. For him, everything is new and fresh, because he beholds the essential nature of everything with love.”

Amma stopped and said, “There has been a lot of talking. Let us now stop and look within for some time before we

close.” Amma sang a kirtan to which everybody responded, *Chintakalkantyam*. . .

*O Glorious Light of Eternal Bliss
Dawning within me when my thoughts have ended,
Pondering on Your golden feet
I have happily given up everything.*

*When You are there as my own,
I need no other relatives.
Give up quickly the ignorance of selfishness!
This mind will not be gloomy any more
As it sheds the flower of desire.
Let it dissolve in Your light and enjoy great peace.*

*Please dwell within me to help me live like air,
Having contact with everything
Yet having connection with none.
Think, O man! Why are you living?
Do you follow the ways of the animal kingdom?*

After the blissful singing, everybody sat in a meditative mood as instructed by Amma. Then Amma took a portion of the lunch which had been brought for Her, and dividing it up into small balls, She began to feed everyone with Her own hands. Each brahmacharin approached Amma to receive his share of prasad. While feeding Her children, Amma delighted in telling jokes, rejoicing in the moment with the brahmacharins. One of them who always acted like a little child in front of Amma came twice. He was caught red-handed. She said loudly, “Look here, here is a thief. He already came once and got his share.” The brahmacharin innocently

replied, "Give me one more. Then I'll come only one more time." Everybody burst into laughter. Amma too laughed heartily at this childlike reply of the brahmacharin.

Finally Gayatri's turn came. Amma took a ball of rice and was about to feed her. Gayatri sat with her mouth wide open, ready to receive the prasad, but suddenly Amma withdrew Her hand. Once again laughter filled the air. Gayatri flushed with slight embarrassment. Then Amma said, "Here, my darling daughter, take it." Again she opened her mouth as Amma brought the ball of rice closer to her, almost touching her lips. Again at the last moment, Amma pulled back, as another roar of laughter filled the room. When it subsided, Amma looked mischievously at Gayatri, whose face was flushed with embarrassment, then gently but deliberately popped the rice ball into her mouth. Hugging her most affectionately, Amma kissed Gayatri on both cheeks.

It was a very touching scene. An indescribable expression of love and compassion shone on Amma's face. Feeling the qualities of motherhood overflowing, some brahmacharins found it hard to withhold their tears.

Because Gayatri constantly lives with Her, Amma stresses that Gayatri should be perfect in every way. Amma would say, "Gayatri-mol should be like a second mother for everyone, so much so that Amma does not spare her, not even for the smallest mistake." Amma's love and compassion for Gayatri are indescribable. Rare are the occasions when they are expressed, but when they are, it is always a heart-gladdening sight. This was one such occasion.

Being fed by Amma was always a treat for Her children. At one time the affectionate ritual occurred almost daily.

But as the number of residents increased, it became more and more unusual. There was also something else which caused it to stop.

In the early days, before there was a strict Ashram routine, Nealu, Gayatri, Unni and Balu were the only resident disciples. The other brahmacharins, who were still working or studying, used to visit the Ashram frequently, for circumstances were such that they could not be permanent residents. Whenever these brahmacharins came to visit, whether together or alone, Amma used to feed them. She also used to feed all the devotees who were present during lunch. Even after the first group of brahmacharins came to stay permanently, Amma continued the habit of feeding each person.

Later, however, when the brahmacharins started learning the scriptures, they were taught to chant before each meal. They chanted the fifteenth chapter of the Srimad Bhagavad Gita, followed by Brahmarpanam from the fourth chapter, verse 24. . .

Brahmārpanam brahma havir brahmāgnau
 brahmanā hutam
 brahmaiva tena gantavyam brahma-karma-
 samādhinā
*The oblation is Brahman,
 the ghee is Brahman,
 offered by Brahman in the fire of Brahman;
 unto Brahman verily he goes
 who cognizes Brahman alone in his actions.*

Thus, one day Amma announced, “Now that you are chanting this mantra, Amma will not feed you every day

as She used to do. From this day on, do not expect it. The mantra must be practiced. If everything is Brahman, you too are Brahman. How can Brahman be fed?"

From that day on, the daily practice of feeding stopped. Yet, to this day Amma still feeds Her Ashram children, but only once in a while. Still, it is a special experience, one that cannot be put into words. It is not merely rice or some other food that She gives. Rather, into this prasad Amma transmits Her love, purity, compassion, and concern for Her children.



CHAPTER V

Friday, 13 July, 1984

At about four-thirty in the afternoon Amma was playing with some children from the neighboring houses, some of whom were children of devotees. She made a temple for them with wet sticky sand. Using flowers and leaves She decorated the roof. When the temple was completed, a consecration ceremony was performed, and Amma installed a small picture of Krishna inside the temple of sand. Amma was totally lost in this play, and the children were very happy. When the ceremony was over, they all stood up as instructed by Amma and began to circumambulate the temple. Amma led the singing of *Agatanayai* with the children singing the response. . .

Lord Vishnu has come!
Lord Vishnu has come!
Let us always offer worship to the Lord.
The Supreme Lord of the world has come,
Giving comfort to the world.

*The Lord has come to the earth
To rid the men of earth of sorrow.
Has the Lord of Peace, full of compassion,
Descended to show the way to Liberation?*

It did not look as if they were playing at all as Mother and the children sang and rejoiced, clapping their hands. On the contrary, the whole scene had the appearance of a genuine event. After circling the temple for some time, Amma and the children began to dance to the tune of Krishna. . . Krishna, Radha. . . Krishna. Closing their eyes like Amma, they all danced for some time with great enthusiasm and glee. After this song Amma sat down and meditated, and the children followed Her example. Each child sat in perfect posture and meditated until Amma called and gently shook them one by one, telling them to get ready for the distribution of prasad. Amma had already put some toffees in front of the temple which were now distributed as prasad to the children.

It was such a lovely and inspiring sight. The residents of the Ashram who were watching from a distance sincerely wished that they were children so that they too could join Amma. Some of them began to move closer to watch, but others prevented them from doing so. They thought that their presence might spoil the beauty of Mother's time with these little children; therefore, they all watched Amma's play from a distance.

The children did not want to leave Amma, who played with them just like another child of their age. They continued to sit around Her and they were having a lot of fun talking, laughing and cracking jokes. They were really celebrating;

a real festival was taking place. Hearts were overflowing and being expressed as blissful laughter.

After having played with the children for another half an hour, Amma got up and walked toward the temple. The beautiful notes from Br. Sreekumar's flute emerged from one of the huts and filled the atmosphere. Still surrounded by the children, Amma came and stood in front of the temple. One of the girls, who was about six or seven years old, begged: "Ammachi, let's sing and play the game of temple again." She caught hold of Amma's hand and asked again and again.

Turning toward the little girl and affectionately stroking her cheeks, Amma said, "Child, that is enough for today. Amma has many other things to do."

"I liked the play very much," said the little girl. "Can we do it again tomorrow?"

Extremely pleased with the child and her innocence, Amma gave her a big hug and kissed her on both cheeks, repeating, "Darling daughter. . . Amma's darling daughter."

Releasing the girl from Her arms, Amma asked her, "Will you always be devoted like this, even when you grow up?"

The girl nodded her head affirmatively.

While being in the midst of children, Mother also becomes like a child, playing and frolicking with them. Amma makes them feel that She is one of them. Amma always gives a special place to children, and they feel it. Anyone who has watched Her with young children knows this to be true. The children are given so much attention. Amma makes them feel comfortable and happy as She holds them on Her lap. Seating them next to Her, She carefully and attentively listens to their prattles or complaints. They have their own place

and significance in Amma's presence. They feel this so clearly that some children do not want to leave Her, not even when the rest of their family is ready to go. Many children have more love for Amma than for their own fathers and mothers. This attachment children have toward Amma arises from the pure love and genuine concern She shows them. Children are so receptive that Amma's Divine Love penetrates directly into their hearts. With such easy access, Amma touches them deeply and they feel it immediately. Pure, unconditional love is the secret behind all this.

DISCRIMINATION

Amma sat in the front yard of the temple on the sand and was soon surrounded by the residents. Just then, Harshan, Amma's cousin, came to the spot where She and the others were sitting. He was lame and walked with a limp. Harshan had great devotion for Amma. Even when the entire family had stood against Her, Harshan strongly supported Amma and had great sympathy for Her. Just to make Amma laugh, he used to act in funny ways sometimes. He prostrated and sat with the others. Amma was very pleased to see him. He was working on a fishing boat, so Amma inquired about his work. As it was the rainy season, Mother wanted to know about the general well-being of the fishermen. A short chat followed about how the monsoon had badly affected the fisherfolk.

Harshan had a peculiar way of singing devotional songs, gesturing with his hands and making various facial expressions. Amma asked him to sing a kirtan. Without a moment's

hesitation he began to sing; sometimes he stretched his hands out toward Mother, at other times he gestured like a professional musician with one hand on his chest and the other raised high. His facial expressions were sometimes exaggerated and other times he closed his eyes, and with palms joined, bowed reverently to Mother. The song was *Sundarini vayo*. . .

*Please come, O Beautiful One
Consort of Shiva, please come
O Auspicious One, please come
Please come, O Endless One.*

*O Vamakshi, Consort of Lord Shiva
O Kamakshi who radiates brilliance everywhere
To those who look upon You
As their Dear Relation, You are their very own.
O Mother, please remain
As the spring of my inspiration.
Being both of one and of many forms,
You are the Light of the Absolute.
Do You not know my heart well?
Will You not come before me
Even now as I ask?*

Amma looked very happy while listening to the song, but sometimes She laughed like an innocent child seeing his gestures. As he finished the song, he knelt and bowed to Her. Mother lovingly gave him a strong pat on his back, and Harshan playfully fell down to one side. This aroused thunderous laughter. Mother too laughed loudly.

The light playful scene created by Harshan was transformed by a profound teaching of Amma when She answered a question asked by a brahmacharin: “Amma, I have heard you say that a spiritual seeker transcends everything once he attains the state of Perfection. Does that mean that he also goes beyond discrimination, which is considered an important quality that a competent seeker should have?”

Amma’s answer was illuminating, “Children, discrimination is meant for one who is in the process of evolution. You need strict discrimination to understand the difference between what is good for your spiritual progress and what will create obstacles in your path. A seeker must discriminate between what is eternal and what is non-eternal. But once you have attained the state of Perfection, you have renounced everything, even discrimination. You cannot hold onto anything. Transcending all dualities, you become the universe; you become expansiveness itself. You become both day and night. You go beyond purity and impurity.

“In the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother, the Lalita Sahasranama, are the mantras *Sad-asad-rupa dharini*—one who takes the forms of both being and nonbeing, and *Vidyavidya svarupini*—one who is both knowledge and ignorance. These verses mean that Devi, Pure Consciousness, is everything and beyond everything. If consciousness is everywhere and all-pervading, then everything that is is consciousness only.

“But you should always remember that this statement about the Absolute is not suitable for seekers, those who are still striving to reach the goal. This is not applicable to them at all. Amma is talking about the state of Absolute Consciousness. Nothing is without consciousness for one

who is fully established in Reality. Everything is pervaded with consciousness and therefore, there are no differences. When everything is pervaded with consciousness, how can there be any discrimination? A Perfect Soul has no mind, no ego. He has no vasanas, not even in their unmanifested state, for he has completely uprooted them. His mind has become permanently silent and still forever and ever.

“Children, the do’s and don’ts, what is pure or impure, good or bad, are only for ordinary people. A Mahatma, who is beyond body consciousness, is not affected by such rules. He is completely untouched. But if a Mahatma chooses to remain in the world for the uplifting of society, he will observe the rules of society. He will strictly follow them in order to set an example for others. The world needs that. People need morality, good character, and purity to be able to evolve.

“Ordinary people still have body-consciousness; therefore, they cannot act like evolved souls who are beyond all standards of behavior. Without rules of conduct an ordinary person’s life would be a disaster. A sadhak too must have a disciplined life; otherwise, he cannot progress. He cannot imitate a Great Soul who is established in the state of the beyond. The sadhak should sincerely try to follow the Mahatma’s or the Guru’s instructions, but he should not try to imitate the Mahatma or the Guru.

“Children, Amma used to live only on water and tulasi leaves. She even used to forgo food and sleep for several months at a time. There was a time when Amma ate raw fish, used tea leaves, pieces of glass and sometimes dirt. She never felt that any of those things were dirty or impure. At that time, there was neither love nor any lack of love. There was neither compassion nor any lack of compassion. What

there was just like space or the sky—an endless expansiveness. Amma was totally absorbed in that non-dual state and never wanted to return.

“How can there be any concept of purity or impurity, dirty or clean, ugly or beautiful in space? How can there be any thought of discrimination in the state of expansiveness, where there are no thoughts and no mind? That state contains everything; it accommodates everything. In fact, both good and bad exist in that space. It is like the river carrying everything within it and washing everything away. The river doesn’t discriminate. It cannot say, “Only healthy people can bathe in me. I won’t let beggars and lepers wash in my waters.” The river Ganges cannot say that. She caresses everything and carries everything, both good and bad. She accepts even dead and rotting bodies into her flow.

“But then for Amma this state changed. The call from within transformed everything. Once you make a sankalpa to be in the body and to work to save the world, the circumstances become such that you have to follow the traditional ways of society’s rules of conduct. Otherwise, if social norms are ignored, society is disrupted. If you behave in a strange way without following the moral and traditional norms, you will do harm to other people around you; you will be destroying rather than saving the world.

“All names and forms are divisions created by the mind. He who has attained the state of perfection transcends the mind and intellect. For him names and forms drop away. He becomes space; he becomes expansiveness. He may be carrying a body around, and yet, he really doesn’t carry it. He just does what he does, just eats what he eats, just says what he says. He simply is. He exists in an undifferentiated

state. He is not bothered by the world, nor does he bother about the world or its uplift. Amma is talking about that Supreme State where there is no mind or thought. Do not fail to understand that this is about the experience of that Supreme State. It is easy to misunderstand, for you can keep on talking about the highest state, and yet you won't understand anything.

"Remember, there are some enlightened beings who are ready to sacrifice themselves to the world. They are the ones who choose to participate in the world and lead seekers and devotees to God, by setting an example through their words and deeds. Once they decide to remain in the body for the transformation of society, they dwell in the highest state of discrimination. This discrimination is the constant experience that Brahman alone is real and that the world (*jagat*), is unreal. Internally they constantly dwell in that supreme state, but outwardly they tirelessly and selflessly work for the good of the world, observing all the moral norms of society. Again, remember that this is only when you remain in the body after Realization. Otherwise, you are what you are. But for a sadhak who is still striving to reach the state of Perfection, discrimination between good and bad, between the eternal and the non-eternal, is absolutely necessary."

COMPASSION MAKES A MAHATMA TAKE A BODY

Knowing that Mother was speaking from experience, a brahmacharin inquired, "Amma, you said that you too were in a totally absorbed state for some time. What made you come down from that supreme state?"

“Compassion,” came Her reply. “Somehow, a thought arose. No, not somehow; it was simply there. The idea to be compassionate was always there. That was the sankalpa. By holding onto that thought of compassion, Amma could return to this world.

“Compassion is the quality which keeps this body here in the world. If that sankalpa of compassion were not there, the Mahatma would not return to the world but would remain in that state of absorption. His behavior may seem strange, and he may be misunderstood. People have preconceived ideas even about a Self-Realized soul, who dwells in a state where no ideas can reach. They try to fit him in the cage of their limited ideas. A Mahatma cannot be stereotyped; therefore, they will call him crazy.

“You may have heard of the saint named Naranattu Bhrantan, who lived in Kerala a few hundred years ago. He was an *avadhuta*,³ well-known for his strange personality and behavior. Once a seeker wanted to become his disciple and follow him wherever he went. The man approached the saint and expressed his wish, but the Mahatma was not willing to accept anybody as his disciple and immediately denied the man’s request. Nevertheless, the man was very insistent, and finally the saint agreed to his request. “You may follow me,” he said, “but under one condition. Whatever I do, you too must do exactly the same.” “That should be easy,” the man said with enthusiasm, and off he went with the saint.

“Naranattu Bhrantan walked and walked and walked. He never rested. He did not eat or drink for several days. He didn’t sleep or talk. The man soon became exhausted. He tried to keep pace with the Mahatma, but he could not go on much longer. At last he told the saint, ‘I will die if I

do not eat or drink something soon.’ Not long after that they came to a blacksmith’s workshop where lead was being melted. The Mahatma walked up to the pot of boiling lead and started drinking the lead using his bare cupped hands. Turning to his friend, he said, ‘Hey, come here! Drink as much as you want.’ The man stepped back, turned around and ran away as fast as his legs could carry him. The saint in the story was known as a bhrantan which means ‘the crazy one.’ Because they did not understand him, people thought he was mad. He accepted this and never tried to correct them or to teach them. He never tried to make them understand the meaning of his actions. He was never bothered by the world or by what they thought of him.”

“Children, there is another interesting story about him. Naranattu Bhrantan used to cook his food in graveyards, using the funeral pyre as fuel. It is said that one night while he was cooking, a demigoddess who dances around funeral pyres appeared. She and her retinue came to perform their midnight ritual dance. She ordered Bhrantan to leave the graveyard immediately because she could not dance in the presence of humans. The Mahatma was not about to budge so a huge dispute ensued between the two. She let out a roar and said that it was her nightly routine to dance around the funeral pyre and that under no circumstances would She break her regular routine. The Mahatma smiled and said coolly, ‘If you are so strict about your regular routine, so am I. It is my daily routine to cook food over a funeral pyre in a graveyard; therefore, I cannot leave. If you are so insistent upon dancing, why don’t you go find some other graveyard? I will not move.’

“Seeing that this man was very determined and stubborn,

the demigoddess and her retinue tried to frighten him by roaring loudly and making threatening gestures. The Mahatma just smiled. He remained very calm and unperturbed. Watching the whole scene with childlike innocence, he laughed heartily at their fierce display. Finally, the demigoddess gave up. She realized that the man was not an ordinary soul. She changed her tone: 'O great one, I give up. Let your wish be done. I will leave, but before I go, I would like to grant you a boon. Please ask for one.' The Mahatma replied, 'I don't want any boons. There is nothing I need to achieve, and I have no desires to be fulfilled. My only prayer is to be left alone. Let me concentrate on my cooking.'

"Nonetheless, the demigoddess continued to insist that he ask for a boon, so at last the Mahatma gave in: 'Okay, tell me the exact date of my death.' She told him. Again she requested that he ask for another boon, since the first one was no great favor at all. 'All right,' said the saint. 'Now, can you postpone my death by one day or make it come sooner by one day?' The demigoddess replied that such a thing was beyond her control, so please, wouldn't he ask for something else?

"Taking pity on her, the Mahatma pointed to his left foot which was afflicted with elephantiasis saying, 'Since you are so keen on granting me a boon, transfer this disease from the left foot to the right one.' When that was done, he requested her to leave as he did not want any more boons. In obedience, the demigoddess immediately disappeared from the spot, taking with her all her followers.

"Strange are the ways of a Mahatma. Human intellect cannot understand great souls and, therefore, call them crazy. Their apparent craziness has a purpose which is to make

human beings realize their own craziness for name, honor and wealth. Only if humans realize their own craziness can such craziness be removed. A Mahatma has nothing to achieve or gain. He is beyond all achievements. He has attained all that is to be attained and is ever full to the brim. When his heart overflows, that is known as love and compassion. He can remain totally drawn within, and he can also overflow with love if he chooses.

“This story is meant to show the attitude of a completely surrendered soul. The story illustrates how all aspects of divinity are perfectly under a Mahatma’s control. There is no fear in him; there is neither anxiety nor excitement. He is not worried or disturbed about anything. Even though he can change destiny or prarabdha if he wishes, he willingly accepts it. He does not want to change it. Fearless as he is, he wants to pass willingly through all experiences. Fear results when people are tossed about by their own petty desires, always concerned only about themselves. Once you overcome fear, you can smile, looking at all the challenges of life. A Mahatma has transcended vasanas by controlling desires and thought waves. That gives him the power to smile heartily, simply looking at everything.”

But, did you notice that the Mahatma in this story had no compassion? He had neither compassion nor lack of compassion. He was not at all concerned about the world. He always remained in the Absolute State. He was almost like a bodiless person. Compassion is the quality which makes a Mahatma remain in society and work for its uplifting. It is only out of that quality of compassion that he helps sadhaks, devotees, disciples and anyone who approaches him.”

The time for the evening bhajan was approaching. Amma asked everyone to go and get ready. She went and sat in

Her usual place in front of the temple. One by one the residents came and took their seats on the temple verandah. Amma remained on Her seat, leaning against the wall. Fixing Her gaze skywards, She was lost to this world.

Soon the verandah was filled with the residents. The singing started even though Amma did not participate in the beginning. She sat motionless, looking beyond this world. Br. Sreekumar sang *Arikullil*, a song he had composed when he was away from Mother. The song describes his excruciating pain of separation from Amma. Therefore, it was filled with feelings of the heart. The same feelings were expressed as he sang. . .

*Setting in the western ocean, the sun
Has marked the close of day in its sad lament.
It is but the play of the Universal Architect,
So why feel dejected, O closing lotuses?*

*This world so full of misery and deep in sorrow,
Is but the drama of God, the Maker-Creator,
And I am but a marionette, helpless in His hands
No tears have I to shed, as I'm looking on. . .*

*Like a flame I'm burning up, separated from You,
Burning and burning is my mind
In this ocean of grief I'm tossed about
Not finding the shore. . .*

After the first song Amma joined in the singing of *Nilambuja*. Her heart overflowed, creating wave after wave of bliss and ecstasy...

*O Mother with blue lotus eyes,
Will You not listen
To the sobbing of this sorrowing heart?*

*Perhaps due to the deeds of some past birth
I am wandering alone.*

*Through ages and ages have I passed
Before taking birth now.
Will You not take me to You
With a motherly hug and put me on Your lap?*

*Not deserving I may be
But, O Mother, will You forsake this child
for this reason?
Will You not come, take me close
And give me a merciful glance?*



CHAPTER VI

Sunday, 22 July, 1984

At ten-thirty in the morning Amma was already in the hut giving darshan to Her children. Since it was Sunday, a Devi Bhava day, many people had come to receive the blessings of the Holy Mother. Even though it rained nearly every day during the monsoon season, devotees did not allow the weather to prevent them from coming to receive Mother's darshan.

To watch Amma give darshan to Her children is always a unique experience. The people came and moved one by one before Her. Some cried and poured their hearts out to Her, seeking blessings and grace, while others laughed and rejoiced, expressing their happiness and gratitude to Amma for Her infinite grace. There were some who wanted nothing but to be spiritually uplifted. They prayed for Her constant guidance and mercy. Some had desires to be fulfilled and others wanted Amma to solve their problems. It was an endless chain of people and problems. She consoled those who wept, wiped their tears, and assured them that She would be with them always. Amma laughed with those who rejoiced and whole-heartedly participated in their happiness. No wonder

people braved stormy weather to come to seek comfort and solace from Amma. Her protective wings spread out as broad as the universe itself. Reaching far and wide, Amma guarantees loving care for all Her children.

BE COURAGEOUS

During the course of the darshan, a young man approached Mother and complained that he had been having terrible neck pain for the last two years. He said that he had been experiencing the agonizing pain day and night. The young man added that he could never sleep soundly because the pain increased tremendously when night fell. Even as he spoke to Mother, the young man looked as if he were experiencing severe pain.

Amma listened to him with a mischievous smile on Her face. This was quite unusual. Usually when somebody approached Her with such a problem, Amma would clearly become identified with the person and his pain. She would sympathize with him, console him, and lovingly rub the affected area. Thus Amma would share the pain in every possible way. However, to this young man Amma did not show any love or compassion. She continued to smile and kept looking at his face for a while. Slowly the smile disappeared and Her face became very serious. Amma looked straight into the young man's eyes. The look and Her eyes were so penetrating that the young man could not face Her; he hung his head. A few moments passed, but the young man did not dare raise his head.

The look on Amma's face became still more serious and then She spoke, "Look here, is this the place to enact your

drama?” The voice sounded deep and awesome.

The young man raised his head. He was struck with fear and started trembling. Finally he emitted a loud cry and burst into tears. Through the tears he cried, “Forgive me! Forgive me! Don’t curse me. Don’t punish me. I am frightened. I tried to pretend that I was suffering from neck pain. Please forgive me. . . Please forgive me. . . Please forgive me. . .” The young man repeated these words over and over again.

Seeing his helpless condition, Amma could not help but allow Her motherly compassion to overflow. “Son, son,” She said, “no problem. No problem, don’t worry. How can Amma curse you or punish you? She can do neither. How can a mother even dream of doing such a thing? Don’t cry. Be relaxed. Be consoled. Do not feel frightened. You were forgiven as soon as you realized your mistake. Don’t cry.” Amma hugged the young man, wiped his tears, put him on her lap and rubbed his back with great love and compassion.

The young man was an atheist who had no faith at all in Amma. He thought She was just an ordinary village girl to whom people attributed divinity. Armed with an invented story, he had come to expose Her. The young man’s plan was to make Amma believe that he had severe neck pain. He expected that She would comfort and soothe him, and only after that would he secretly reveal the truth to Amma. In his dream of pride and success, he had thought he was going to walk proudly out after accomplishing this, but his plan had crumbled. He had intended to humble Mother, but it was he who was humbled instead.

The young man cried and sought forgiveness from Amma. Then, feeling somewhat consoled, he raised his head from

Amma's lap and sat down near Mother, his head still hanging. Mother resumed giving darshan to the devotees, and the brahmacharins sang *Amma Amma Taye*. . .

*O Mother, Mother, dear Divine Mother
Goddess of the Universe
Giver of food to all creatures
You are the Primal Supreme Power.*

*Everything in the world happens
Because of Your Divine Play.*

*Protect me, Mother, O Mother, protect me
Without conceiving in the womb
You have given birth
to millions and millions of beings.*

*You are my life's goal, O Mother
Do not ignore me, O Goddess of the World.
You are the Goddess Lalita, Ruler of the World.
O Mother, if You throw me into trouble
again and again
Who else is there to protect me?
O Mother with enchanting eyes,
You are the Omnipresent Witness of all.*

After the song, the young man again began to sob like a child. Amma smilingly glanced at him and said, "Son, don't feel ashamed. Forget about the incident. Be courageous. You were courageous enough to come in front of Amma pretending that you had a terrible neck pain. Where is that great courage now? When you set out to do something,

whether it be right or wrong, you should also be daring enough to face whatever consequences it brings you. There are many who have chosen an unrighteous path. They may even be aware that their path is wrong. Still they proceed along their chosen way, determined to confront and overcome whatever results may occur, whether favorable or not.

“But, now look at yourself and the state you’re in. Can’t you be a little more courageous? Son, either you surrender or declare war. Surrendering needs a little more courage. The one who surrenders to the Supreme Being is the most courageous of all. In fact, the one who declares war is afraid. It is fear that motivates him to declare war. He fears he will lose and the other will win. He fears that his ideas will not survive. He fears that he will not be able to overpower his adversary. The thought of the opponent always disturbs him. Day and night he thinks about the enemy. The opposition creates hell in his mind and thus he lives in constant fear. Ravana, abductor of Sita, was in constant fear of Her husband, Rama. Kamsa, the wicked uncle of Sri Krishna, lived always in fear of his nephew. Duryodhana, the eldest son of the blind King Dhritharashtra, was in constant fear of the Pandavas.

“The atheists of today are of that nature; they live in fear. But unlike the heroes of the old days, the people who boast that they are nonbelievers do not have the courage to bear the consequences of their actions. Those ancient heroes were also skeptics and rationalists, but they were far more courageous than today’s skeptics and nonbelievers.

“Yet, in spite of their courage to do unrighteous deeds, they still lived in fear. Ravana was afraid that Rama would destroy him when He came to rescue Sita. The fear that Krishna would come and kill him haunted Kamsa all the

time. And Duryodhana was fearful of the power of the Pandavas, especially since Krishna was with the Pandavas. Fear made the lives of these men a living hell. They constantly devised plots and plans to kill their enemies. Never at peace within themselves, they lived with tension and despair. This is what happens to those who are unwilling to surrender.

“Surrender removes all fear and tension. Surrender leads one to peace and bliss. Where there is surrender there is no fear, and vice versa. Where there is surrender there is love and compassion, whereas fear results in hatred and enmity. But to surrender one needs a lot of courage, the courage to give up oneself. It demands a daring attitude to sacrifice one’s ego. Surrender means welcoming and accepting everything without the least feeling of sorrow or disappointment.

“Therefore, son, if you want to fight, it is all right. Continue all your efforts to expose Amma as a fraud. At least be daring and determined. Look at you, you have lost your strength and confidence. You mustn’t let that happen. Be courageous and don’t lose self-confidence.”

The young man remained silent. He seemed deep in thought. A few devotees who were sitting nearby expressed their anger toward him with some sharp remarks. Amma stopped them, saying, “No, no. You must not do that. Don’t hurt his feelings. By making such rough comments you are setting a bad example. Amma does not want to criticize or abuse him. Amma is telling him these things only for his own point of reference, for his own good. He is free to accept or reject them.

“Besides that, your expression of anger is releasing the negative vasanas within yourselves. Use your discrimination. You must learn how to listen and respond, without reacting.

Therefore, children, Amma will not allow you to be mean to him. She does not want you to condemn him. Why should we do that? What good would it do him or you? Condemnation will only spoil your mind as well as his. That is not the right attitude. Reaction will benefit neither your victim nor you. Therefore, don't react. Learn how to respond."

RESPONSE AS OPPOSED TO REACTION

One of the devotees who had expressed anger toward the young man asked Amma, "Amma, what do you mean by response? Reaction, of course we always react. But how does one respond?"

Amma explained the difference: "Response can be explained in many different ways. It is total acceptance. It is also non-acceptance with a positive attitude. It can also be neither acceptance nor rejection. You simply remain watching the reaction which arises from you. But you remain apart from it. You don't get involved at all. Remember, you see it, and when you see it, you are not part of it. You are watching it. You are not in the scene. In order to respond, one should become like a mirror. One should become a clear reflector of the others' feelings. A mirror just reflects but never gets involved; it is never touched or tainted by the images.

"It is as if you are watching a movie. You are outside of it. You simply look and observe; you enjoy the play. You enjoy the experience of watching the play; you never become involved in the play or the experience. It is beautiful if you can do this. You can stand apart from what is happening

and simply laugh at it. Only a compassionate person can respond.

Out of this explanation, a question arose, "Is it possible for an ordinary person to do this?"

"This kind of doubting will certainly not make it possible," was Amma's reply. "Children, if you want to fulfill a worldly goal, for example, to make a million dollars, you start immediately. You don't waste any time. You can't wait. You strive hard; you work diligently in order to accomplish your goal. You work with enthusiasm. You forget everything else—even food and sleep—in your urgent determination to reach your goal. When you want to become a doctor or an engineer, you study hard to achieve it. But when your goal is something spiritual, something which will really help you to lead a peaceful life, you have a hundred doubts about it, a hundred questions about its possibility. What a pity! By not even trying, you are defeated before you even begin.

"The human intellect has taken man to great heights in the field of science. There was a time when people believed that many of the things which science has attained today were absolutely impossible. They never even dreamed that human beings could go to the moon or that people, while sitting in their homes looking at a small machine called a TV, could see events occurring in another part of the world. Think of the once unimaginable developments of modern science that are now taken for granted. From where do all these things come? What is behind all these wonderful inventions? They are achievements of the human intellect.

"These achievements are the clear-cut proof of the tremendous power inherent in the human mind which is directed toward scientific discovery. And yet, the power of a scientist's intellect is only an infinitesimal portion of the

infinite power inherent in the human mind. The power of the human mind is immeasurable.

“This infinite power is in all human beings. If a person really wants to do something, nothing is impossible for him. Nothing can enslave him, overpower him or control him, if he is courageous enough to dive deep into his own mind, his own consciousness. He can tap into the very source of all power. Amma can guarantee this, provided the efforts are sincere.

“There are many masters around the world who have attained that ultimate state. If they could do it, you too should be able to do it. Why doubt? Try. Doubting is something that you learn to do; you learn to doubt. You never learn to believe. Doubt is your number one enemy. Faith is your best friend. Have faith and make the effort. You will see the outcome.”

A group of devotees who had come from the northern part of Kerala started singing verses from the *Devi Mahatmyam*:

O Devi, You who remove the sufferings of Your supplicants, be gracious. Be propitious, O Mother of the world. Be gracious, O Mother of the universe. Protect the universe. You are, O Devi, the ruler of all that is moving and unmoving.

You are the sole substratum of the world, because You subsist in the form of the earth. By You, who exist in the form of water, all this (universe) is gratified. O Devi of inviolable valor.

You are the power of Vishnu, and have endless valor.

You are the primeval maya, which is the source of the universe; by You all this (universe) has been thrown into an illusion, O Devi. If You become gracious, You become the cause of final emancipation in this world.

All lores are Your aspects, O Devi; so are all women in the world, endowed with various attributes. By You alone, Mother, this world is filled. What praise can there be for You who are of the nature of primary and secondary expression regarding (objects) worthy of praise?

There was so much love and devotion in their melodious chanting of the Sanskrit slokas that some of them became very absorbed. Lost in their own world of ecstasy, they began displaying different gestures—stretching out their arms toward Amma, raising them high, joining the palms of their hands together and saluting Amma. Some shed tears of love as they continued singing the chant with tremendous devotion. The devotees were thrilled at the chance to sing for Amma. As Amma sat looking at them, compassion flowed from Her eyes. Her face shone like the full moon. Amma's mere glance with the bewitching smile She wore on Her lips threw a spell of enchantment over the devotees. Tears streamed down their cheeks as they soared to heights of supreme devotion while they continued to chant the hymn.

Amma sat very still on the cot. She manifested all the signs which She expresses during Devi Bhava—Her hands held in a divine mudra, a blissful smile radiating from Her face—as She gazed at the devotees who were chanting. A tidal wave of supreme devotion arose in them as their singing became more ecstatic and the entire hut vibrated to its fullness.

Mother sat in that mood for some time, then She turned away from them but remained in an indrawn state. The chant slowly subsided. Perfect silence prevailed in the darshan hut. The devotees experienced the bliss of deep meditation. One of them was in a totally intoxicated mood. Filled with devotion and love, he cried and laughed at the same time as he called out 'Amma! Amma!' every now and then. Some of the devotees sat gazing at the Holy Mother's face. Nearly five minutes passed in this way before Amma slowly opened Her eyes chanting Shiva. . . Shiva. . . Shiva. . . Shiva. . . while moving Her right hand in circles, a familiar but incomprehensible gesture to the devotees.

Amma resumed receiving the devotees. The one who had asked the question about 'response' wanted to know more about it.

Amma responded in this manner: "You keep asking what response is and how to do it. Amma can speak to you about response. She might give you a convincing answer. But that won't help much. People are only interested in intellectually satisfying answers. Once they get such an answer, the mind will keep quiet for some time. And then again it will doubt; it will raise another objection or question. Thus, answers are often food for the mind. Every time you appease the hunger of the doubting mind, you only feed it with new ideas. This easily becomes a habit, and therefore, you never cultivate faith in your heart. You don't rely on your heart. And without faith and love, how can you ever learn to respond?

"Children, all great masters of the world, whether in the East or the West, teach us how to respond. They never react. Their whole life stands as a living witness for this great principle

of life—response. Jesus Christ set an unforgettable example of how to respond. He let His body be tortured and crucified, and even when He was dying on the cross, Christ prayed for those who were against Him. He prayed for their own good—that they might be forgiven.

“When Kaikeyi, Sri Rama’s step-mother, sought the boon of having Rama exiled to the forest for fourteen years, the Lord accepted the exile with a smile on His face. He was not at all hostile to Kaikeyi. Smilingly, He touched her feet, His heart overflowing with reverence and love. He simply accepted the exile as a fact; there was not a trace of anger within Him. Lakshmana, on the other hand, wanted to kill Kaikeyi for her cruel deed. When he heard about his elder brother’s ill-fate, Lakshmana became fierce with anger and was determined to seek vengeance. He sought Rama’s permission to imprison his own father, whom he called ‘the unjust and henpecked king.’ Lakshmana’s reaction was terrible, whereas Rama responded beautifully. Rama’s response, in fact, helped Lakshmana to calm down

“Even when engaged in active conflict, you can respond. In the battle between Rama and Ravana, the Lord killed Ravana’s charioteer and his horses, destroyed the chariot and then disarmed Ravana completely. Having lost all hope for his life, Ravana stood waiting for Rama’s sharp arrows to pierce his chest. But instead of the whirl of arrows, he heard Rama’s voice: “Ravana, I see you are completely disarmed.” Rama’s voice was calm, “I could finish you off now if I wanted to. But I won’t. To kill someone who is disarmed and helpless goes against dharma. Therefore, go back to your palace, rest, treat your wounds, and come back tomorrow fresh and fully armed.” What a great enemy Rama

was! Even on the battlefield, even when Ravana had committed the unpardonable crime of kidnapping His divine consort and was standing in front of Him disarmed and totally helpless, Rama bore no malice but could speak such kind and wise words. This is response.

“Here is another example. When the hunter shot the sharp and deadly arrow which put an end to Krishna’s body, the Lord did not react. He did not try to punish the hunter. On the contrary, Sri Krishna blessed the hunter with immortality. He bestowed on the hunter life’s highest goal, mukti. This is response.”

“It sounds like response is forgiveness,” remarked the devotee who had asked the question.

“Forgiveness without having any feeling of anger or revenge is response,” said Amma. “There are people who might forgive, but they still harbor intense hatred; they forgive but with vengeance in their hearts. For different reasons, people may sometimes appear to forgive. For example, one man beats another. The second man may not fight back because the first one is stronger. We cannot call this forgiveness. Though the second man does not retaliate, the fire of revenge may be raging in his mind. Likewise, when a father beats his son, or a teacher punishes a student, neither the son nor the student can return the blows. But they will feel a deep resentment within. This cannot be called forgiveness, for it is suppression of anger. It cannot be called response. Such unexpressed anger will remain deep within, and when the occasion arises, it will be expressed. That would be reaction, not response.

“There was a Mahatma who was a wandering monk. One

day he was sitting under a tree when a hooligan happened to pass by and hit the monk with a cane. The stroke came down so hard on the monk's shoulder that the cane fell out of the hooligan's hand onto the ground. The Mahatma stood up and picked up the cane. Thinking that the monk was going to beat him back, the rascal ran away. The Mahatma ran after him. From at a distance some people had seen the hooligan beating the monk and came running. They stopped and seized the scoundrel. By that time the Mahatma had reached them with the cane in his hands. Handing the cane back to the hooligan, the Mahatma calmly said, 'I wanted to return your cane to you, that's all.' He turned to leave, but the people who had stopped the rogue said, 'What's going on? This blackguard just hit you hard on your shoulder. We saw it. He needs to be punished. You must hit him back—not once, but several times.' The Mahatma smiled and retorted, 'No, I can't. Why should I? He hit me and that's all right. I take it as a fact. But I do not understand why I should return the blow. What if one of the branches of that tree I was sitting under broke and fell on my body? I wouldn't pick up the branch and hit the tree back. Likewise, he hit me and I accept it. He did it out of ignorance. I should feel sympathy for his ignorance, not anger. I must have beaten him some time in a previous birth. And now I am experiencing the fruit of my action. In that sense it is not he who hit me, but it is my past which makes him hit me. Now if I hit him back, I would be creating more karma for myself. I would be adding more to the account I came here to close.' Having said this, the Mahatma walked away without another word.

"Children, response is an attitude. It happens when one is totally detached. This is possible only when one becomes free from the ego. Only egoless people can truly respond.

Response happens when one reaches the state of no-mind. Mind and ego can only react. In fact, it is the mind and the ego that tempt one to react. They are the storehouse of the past. The past is the seat of negativity such as anger, hatred, revenge, attachment, and jealousy. The past is the problem-creator. If the past doesn't exist for one, then no problems arise; only peace and bliss will exist. The past is the account into which we deposit more and more through our reactions. However, a Mahatma destroys the past completely and stops adding to his account. Once the past is gone, the ego is gone; the mind stuff is gone. Such a person cannot react. He can only respond, because all references cease to exist in him. The past is the reference book. There is nothing to refer to once the past is removed."

This last remark raised a question, "The past is the reference book! What do you mean by that, Amma?"

Amma answered, "The past is a dictionary or a thesaurus. Whenever we hear, experience or do something, we automatically refer to these old pages. Through them we find meanings, interpretations or uses that were utilized before. Then we speak or act according to such references. This is reaction.

"For example, someone abuses us. Suddenly the past comes to the foreground. Even without waiting for our permission, even without our knowledge, it gives references. It says, 'You have been abused countless times by different people. Each time you were abused by someone, you retaliated. So do it again, abuse him back. Use stronger words and expressions.'

Thus, the chain of the past reveals itself: When someone offends you, you offend him in return. If someone gets angry at you, you return the anger. This is how it happens. The

habitual reaction stored in the past comes up again and again. And each time you react, it becomes stronger and stronger. You and your victim each have a past. Both of you react to each other. The other person has also been abused a number of times. Each one reacts according to the strength and density of his past reactions. Both of you have volumes and volumes of giant-sized books to which you unknowingly refer. A Mahatma remains a blank sheet of paper, while an ordinary person keeps on writing on the pages, continuing to add to those gigantic books each time he reacts.

“Response comes from the great soul who remains blank. He does not want to disturb the silence with unnecessary sounds or disfigure the blank sheet of paper with unnecessary words. Response arises from a truly loving heart. Love cannot hurt; likewise, response cannot hurt.”

All this time the young man who had feigned the neck pain sat quietly by Amma’s side, listening as She spoke. All of a sudden, he prostrated at Mother’s feet, weeping like a child. Amma lovingly drew him up and put his head on Her lap, once again displaying Her overflowing compassion and motherly love. The young man controlled his tears with great difficulty. Raising his head from Her lap, he said, “Amma, I want to be more courageous. I don’t want to be a skeptic anymore. Sitting in your presence for only this long I have learned many things. I think I understand what I have been missing all my life. It is your love and compassion.” He choked on his words, and once again his eyes filled with tears. He continued, “I don’t want to miss you, Amma. I don’t want to waste my life anymore.” The young man covered his face and wept again.

As the darshan continued, the brahmacharins sang *Ini oru janmam*. . .

*O Krishna, give me not another birth
Lest I fall into the deep quagmire of delusion.
If You give, then bestow the boon
To let me take birth as the servant
Of Your servants forever.*

*O Krishna, fill my mind with Your Holy Name
Reveal Your Lotus Feet bright and clear
Keep my mind ever equipoised
All should be felt as Your manifestation.*

*O Krishna, Treasure of Compassion
Salutations to You
With palms joined, I humbly salute You.*

*If I should get another birth,
Let it be beneficial to the world,
Giving the Imperishable Joy to others. . .
If You allow me that
Then please give me
Any number of births as a human being.*

Amma's response to this young man, Her expression of love and compassion toward him instead of condemning him for his deception, is clearly an example of how response can and does have a good influence on others. It produced such a positive change in his attitude, and this was witnessed by everybody present.

Amma's own life is a perfect example of how to respond rather than react. The early periods of Her life were filled with trials and tribulations. Except for a few people, everyone, including Her own family, turned against Her. A thousand

young men joined together and formed an organization called 'The Committee To Stop Blind Faith.' Supported by some of the villagers and politicians, they tried to scandalize Amma. They tried to have Her imprisoned by accusing Her of crimes She hadn't committed; they used various mean and shabby methods trying to expose Her as a fraud. But Amma remained unperturbed. She never reacted to their torments and threats. She only prayed and cried to God, to Her Beloved Krishna, to the Divine Mother, seeking forgiveness for Her oppressors.

Even when She had to shoulder all the household chores and do all the work for others, Amma did not murmur any complaint. She always prayed, "O Lord, give me work; give me Your work." Amma worked ceaselessly. Even though She had so much to do, She would pray to God for more so that She could constantly dedicate every action to Him. Carrying water for cooking and pots of hot rice gruel on Her head, Amma even became bald in one spot. The hair fell out from the weight and heat of those pots. Nevertheless, She did not complain or stop working.

Amma's own parents and Her older brother were antagonistic toward Her. Her brother always taunted Her, usually for no reason. Amma's mother, Damayanti, was a strict disciplinarian and not at all lenient with Her. Amma lived in the midst of all these adverse circumstances, responding beautifully to all the situations that arose in Her life, constantly focusing Her mind on the Supreme Being.

It would be beneficial to recall another incident when Amma responded to a man who constantly used to abuse Her. He was a notorious rowdy of the village where Amma was born. Ever since Amma manifested Her Divinity to the world, he had an antagonistic attitude toward Her. Whenever

he got a chance, he abused and scandalized Her, but Amma never had any ill feelings towards him. It was Her nature to take everything as the benevolence of Divine Providence.

One day as Amma was on Her way to a devotee's house, She found the rowdy standing at the boat jetty. A contagious type of scabies covered his body. Pus and blood were oozing out of the sores. His body was dirty and smelly. Amma went up to him and lovingly inquired about his disease. Holding both his hands, She compassionately soothed the scabies. Obtaining some sacred ash from Gayatri, Amma rubbed it on his sores. The sympathy and concern She expressed towards this man was so great that one would think that he were a close devotee. Before She left him, Amma held both his hands affectionately and kissed the back of his hands. Now the notorious man could not help crying; he sobbed like a child. Once again Amma expressed Her love for him, wiping his tears, and then went on Her way. After this incident, the man became an ardent devotee of Amma. This is a perfect demonstration of how response, rather than reaction, can create a miraculous change response creates, even in the worst type of people.

Mother says, "We should try to see the nature of things as they are. The nature of anything, whether an object or a being, cannot be other than the way it is. If this is understood, one can only respond. One can only pray for the good of others, and feel sympathy and love. Frogs croak and crickets chirp at night. That is their nature; they cannot do otherwise. They are not going to change even if you get angry at them. Nobody stays awake at night saying, 'I'm not getting proper sleep because of this noise.' People simply ignore them and go to bed because they know that frogs croak and crickets

chirp. They know that it is the nature of those creatures and they cannot be otherwise.

“Likewise, each person has his own nature. Through your anger, you cannot change the nature of other people. Only love can change them. Understand this, and try to feel love and sympathy for all. Be compassionate, even toward those who bother you. Pray for them. Such an attitude will also help your mind to remain calm and peaceful. This is genuine response.”

It was twelve o'clock. There were still many people waiting to have Amma's darshan. Amma continued receiving Her children as the brahmacharins sang *Mano buddhya*. . .

*I am neither the mind, intellect, ego nor memory,
Neither ears nor tongue
Nor the senses of smell and sight;
Nor am I ether, earth, fire, water or air.
I am Pure Awareness-Bliss, I am Shiva! I am Shiva!*

*I am neither the life force nor the five vital airs;
Neither the body's seven elements nor its sheaths;
Nor hands nor feet nor tongue,
Nor the organs of sex and voiding;
I am Pure Awareness-Bliss, I am Shiva! I am Shiva!*

*Neither loathing nor liking have I,
Neither greed nor delusion;
No sense have I of ego or pride,
Neither religious merit nor wealth,
Neither enjoyment nor Liberation have I;
I am Pure Awareness-Bliss, I am Shiva! I am Shiva!*

*Neither right nor wrongdoing am I
Neither pleasure nor pain; nor the mantra,
Nor the sacred place, the Vedas, the sacrifice;
Neither the act of eating, the eater, nor the food;
I am Pure Awareness-Bliss, I am Shiva! I am Shiva!*



CHAPTER VII

Monday, 23 July, 1984

Soon after the morning meditation some of the brahmacharins were discussing Amma's satsang on 'response and reaction.' Since most of them were educated young men, each one was making comments, giving different interpretations of Amma's words, each according to his own understanding and intellectual capacity. A brahmacharin said, "I don't think that a person who lives in society or a person who has a responsible job can always respond. He has to react. For example, how can a business executive or an administrator in the government avoid reacting? If the business executive only responds and never reacts, the company will not function properly and it will have to close down. If a government administrator only responds and never reacts, the government will be a mess. Being in a position of responsibility, he has to discipline others; and to discipline others requires a certain amount of reaction. To make others obey, reaction is necessary; otherwise, one cannot function properly in society. Yesterday Amma gave the examples of Rama, Krishna and Christ, but even they had to react on certain occasions, didn't they?"

Another brahmacharin gave his opinion: “I think that the instructions Amma gave yesterday are meant for serious sadhaks. What She said was intended for those who are inclined to lead a spiritual life, renouncing all worldly desires. The ego is necessary for living in the world. When there is an ego, one cannot respond; one can only react. Amma Herself stressed that point.”

Still another brahmacharin wanted to have his turn. He began, “I think. . .”

He was interrupted by a voice , “Don’t think!”

Startled, they all looked up. Amma was standing on the balcony. “Don’t think!” She shouted down to them. “Children, you just finished meditation and already you’ve started thinking—just the opposite of meditation. You practice meditation to sublimate all thoughts, to cease your thinking. But here you are, brain-storming about something that should be practiced, not discussed.”

Amma continued, “Children, you all think. You all have different views and opinions, but response comes only when you stop thinking, only when all your views and opinions disappear. Here each one of you is ‘thinking’ deeply. Whatever little energy you may have gained through meditation has been dissipated due to this senseless thinking. It is just like wasting hard-earned money on peanuts. What a pity! Go and do something useful.”

The brahmacharins dispersed quickly. Amma retraced Her steps to Her room.

THE ABILITY TO RESPOND WHILE LIVING IN THE WORLD

Two hours after the above incident took place, Amma

was sitting on the bottom step of the staircase leading to Her room. Just behind Amma sat Gayatri and Kunjumol. After being chided earlier in the morning, the brahmacharins who had taken part in the discussion felt a little guilty and were restless. They all stood at a distance from where Amma was sitting, not daring to come any closer. Seeing their hesitation, Amma called them to come. Having offered their prostrations, they all sat on the ground in front of Amma. For some time Amma did not say anything, but Her face had an expression of extraordinary depth. The brahmacharins looked a bit perplexed, not knowing what She was going to say or do. After a short while, Amma spoke: "What was the discussion about this morning?"

Amma's voice was very calm, Her countenance full of love and peace. The brahmacharins relaxed a little, yet out of fear they did not answer Amma's question. She encouraged them saying, "Do not feel frightened. Amma is not angry with you. How can She be angry? Why do you think that Amma would get angry with you? Speak up. What were you discussing?"

Amma's soothing words gave them the courage to speak, and one of them explained to Her the things they had discussed. A big smile lit up Her face as She lovingly glanced at Her children and said, "It is true that a person cannot completely put away his ego when he is living in society. He does have to react. He may have to talk in a rough language, or he may have to take a tough stand at times. But, so what! How can that create a hindrance to responding? What do you mean by saying that response is not at all possible just because someone is a business executive or a government administrator? Response is possible if one tries. It is a positive mental attitude you develop toward others, whether

friend or enemy.

“Response is to stand aside and be untouched, unaffected and detached. But usually, if you get into a disagreement or quarrel with someone, or when you try to discipline someone, you react because you are involved and identified with it. When you get angry, you become identified with your anger and cannot be detached. You cannot see the anger arising in you. Instead, you become the anger. Externally, great souls may sometimes act like ordinary human beings, but internally they always remain apart from the actions they perform. Detachment is the very core of their lives. They cannot react because they are detached. Reactions occur because people are attached to their actions. Attachment to the work and its fruit creates ego, which will destroy the ability to respond. Detachment from the work and its fruit destroys the ego, which will help one to respond. Attachment fills the mind with more thoughts and desires, which will only cause reactions. Detachment empties the mind of all thoughts and desires, which allows response to take place.

“Children, try to perform your work with detachment. In this way, you will learn to respond. You can scold someone and still be detached. You can discipline someone and yet remain detached. That is why Amma said response is a mental attitude, that it is purely subjective. One who watched Rama or Krishna might have thought that they were reacting to their respective opponents. Indeed, Rama killed Ravana for abducting His wife, Sita. He killed many other demons as well. One might also think Krishna reacted when He killed Kamsa or when He sided with the Pandavas to help destroy the Kauravas. But to make this kind of judgment is wrong. Rama was ready to accept Ravana the person, but not his ego. Krishna was ready to accept the Kauravas, but not their

egos. Ravana's ego was dangerous to society. The egos of Duryodhana and of those who sided with him were also dangerous to society; therefore, Krishna had to destroy them. As a king it was Rama's duty to destroy the egos that could harm to the entire world. It was not only because Ravana had kidnapped Sita that Rama had to kill him, but because the latter had become a threat to the whole world. By killing him, Rama was saving the world from demonic hands. Rama was only protecting and preserving dharma.

"The apparent ego that each one of them wore was only a mask—a mask with which they never identified, and which they could remove at any time. They always knew that they were different from the mask, that the mask was not who they really were.

"One should be careful not to mistake the masks for their real nature. One needs a very subtle eye to penetrate and see their real nature. Even Arjuna, Krishna's closest disciple and friend, took Krishna's mask to be real. Only once, when the Lord Himself blessed him with divine sight, did Arjuna see who Krishna really was. Even Lakshmana, the dearest brother of Rama, did not see Him accurately. To be able to discern divinity requires an exceptionally subtle eye. It requires a subtle way of looking to see divine beings. But to see them, in fact, is not seeing—it is experiencing. To experience them one must enter into them, into their real Being. If you have the subtle eye to see them, or if you have the experience of entering into their real Being, then you know that they never react.

"Remember, the same Rama who killed Ravana, and who killed thousands of fully-armed demons in a few seconds, could also remain unmoved and unperturbed like a moun-

tain when Kaikeyi took away the kingdom that was rightfully His, and sent Him into exile. Rama was not impatient. Neither was he a coward. He was as fierce as the fire of dissolution. Recall His fierce form when the ocean would not yield to Him. He was about to dry up the entire ocean. Such was His strength. So if He wanted to, He could have easily regained His kingdom. But He did not do that. Instead, He responded. He accepted. See the beauty of it.

“For some people, apparent response is born not out of love and detachment, but out of cowardice and timidity. There is no beauty in this sort of apparent response. This is how a weakling behaves. He is passive; he is motivated by fear. But when God, the Governor of the entire universe and the most powerful Being responds, there is immense beauty in it, for it is an edifying experience.”

A five-year old boy, who was the son of a devotee, happened to be among those who had gathered around Amma. One of the brahmacharins told Amma that the boy had sung bhajans beautifully the previous day. Amma looked at him and smilingly asked, “Is this true, son?” The boy nodded his head. In a begging tone, Amma asked him to sing a kirtan. Without the least shyness, the boy sang *Vedambike*. . .

*O Mother of the Vedas
O Mother of Sounds, I bow to You.
I bow to Your Feet, adored by the Gods.*

*Bestowing love
Bestowing the radiance of the lotus
O Lover of music
Take me across this ocean of misery.*

*O Goddess of Wisdom
O Parvati Who does good to all the world
Destroyer of pride and rebirth
Be victorious.*

*Mother is the Life of all creatures
Mother is the Cause of all things.
Bowing to You with palms joined
I pray, give me Liberation
O Powerful One
Great Radiance, I bow to You.*

For some time Amma gazed intently at the boy as he was singing. Then She became indrawn and this state lasted until the end of the song. When the boy finished singing, Amma called him to come to Her. She embraced him tightly as She kissed him on both cheeks, telling him, "How beautifully you sang, Amma's darling son!" Amma seated him next to Her. She asked Kunjumol to bring some toffees. When Kunjumol brought a bag of toffees, Amma took a few and gave them to the boy.

Having not yet received an answer on how a person can respond while doing his duties in the world, the resident who asked the question about response now raised the point again.

Amma answered, "Children, even if you live in the world as an executive or an administrator, you can still learn to respond, provided you develop and cultivate detachment. The business executive or the governmental administrator should discharge his duties sincerely. If the need arises he

should be able to take a tough stand. If the workers become lazy or if they try to cheat the company, of course the executive must have the courage and confidence to rise to the situation and take necessary action against them.

“You can be angry with the laziness of a worker but not with the worker himself. The humanity in the worker, the consciousness in the worker, should be respected because it is not different from yours. In that sense you and he are equals. Don’t get angry with the person. Getting angry will shatter your clarity of vision.

“Amma does not understand why you should react and allow your mind to sink into a mire of hellish thoughts. Reaction builds up hatred. Hatred makes the mind a hell. Likewise, anger, jealousy and uncontrollable craving for name and fame make life equal to hell. You lose your peace of mind. You lose the love and beauty within you, and your mind becomes a madhouse. Whether you are a business executive or the supreme sovereign of a country, to react will only create chaos and confusion within you. The very thought of reacting will cloud your vision. You will lose your discrimination. You will not be able to do your work properly. You may do the wrong thing which could destroy the reputation of the company.

“To make an intelligent decision one needs to be even-minded. What you call presence of mind is a state of mind in which one doesn’t become agitated but remains well-balanced, even in the midst of severe problems. A person who reacts thoughtlessly cannot be a good ruler or a good professional in any field of work. He will be a failure in any position of responsibility. His uncontrolled reactions will pull him away from all good fortune or favorable opportunities,

and from all good things that can happen in life.

“Let’s come down closer to our lives. When we come down to the level of ordinary human beings, we can see that knowingly or unknowingly we do respond in our everyday life. But this is not a totally reactionless state. It is controlled reaction—something important is at stake and so you react without being carried away by anger. Internally you may still have negative feelings, but externally you control them to a certain extent, for otherwise, it could create a disaster. A government official can do this for the sake of his country, and an executive can do it for the sake of the company.

“Suppose you are the head of a large firm, and there are demands being made by the workers. The leader of the protesting workers is threatening to call a strike. You personally feel that his demands are unreasonable and that his tactics are unfair, even offensive. In this kind of situation the predominant emotion that bubbles up in your mind will be anger. But you don’t show it, because, if you did, it could worsen the situation. Therefore, you try to control your anger and resentment. You try not to return those negative feelings ‘in the same coin,’ for if you do, it could result in a disaster. You remember when you had a similar experience in the past. You suddenly become aware of the same pattern from the past.

“Previously you could not control your anger toward the agitators. You were rash in your behavior and used extreme measures. The opposition reacted with even greater force. That previous incident affected the entire company. You lost your peace of mind, and your personal family life was disrupted. You now remember what happened that time and how the chain of events resulted in disaster.

“This memory brings you back to your senses. You do

not want to do that again. You do not want to create unnecessary trouble and thereby lose your peace of mind. The last time due to your uncontrollable outburst the company closed down for several months. Many families suffered and you lived in fear and dread of what others might do to you in retaliation. In remembering the adverse consequences which were caused by your uncontrollable reactions, you become discriminative. You control your anger and volatile nature; you calm down and put a big smile on your face. You meet with the leader of the protesters and treat him cordially, inviting him to your office where you offer him a cup of coffee. You express your concern for the welfare of the employees. With deliberate caution you explain the company's situation and assure him that you will do everything in your power to come to an appropriate agreement with the protesters. This way of tackling the problems in your life, whether in your professional life or in your personal family life, can be called a response. In this case, you are reacting too, but it does not hurt the other person, because the anger within you is not expressed. You give him the feeling that you are concerned about him and his problems. You create a positive feeling in the other man's heart.

"However, if you investigate closely, you will see that deep down this is still a reaction because the anger is still within you. You have suppressed it to prevent yourself from expressing it. But you haven't done anything to exhaust it. Many circumstances like this arise in one's life, and each time you do the same thing. The chain of these events becomes longer and longer. Externally, you may look as if you are responding, but internally you are not. It is only the suppression of your reactions followed by giving an external impression of responding.

“Children, it does not matter who or what you are, if you really want to you can master the art of response. An executive or an administrator responds during certain situations in which he is required to act diplomatically without expressing any negative feelings. He could therefore do it also in any other situation, provided he has the determination and sincere interest to practice response. He has the potential to do it. He just has to work on it. He just has to do some practice to digest and assimilate the residue collected within, which has been left behind by such incidents. Once you learn to remove the residue of suppressed anger and desire for revenge, you are transformed into a fountain of tremendous energy with which you can accomplish even so-called impossible tasks. The executive or administrator has the power or mental capacity to do it. Whether he will practice it or not is another question. However, a certain amount of detachment and love is necessary to have the attitude of response.”

Yet another question was asked: “What is the difference between this seeming response of an executive and the sadhak who learns to respond genuinely?”

“Children, a spiritual seeker, who strives hard to attain the state of perfection will also have anger and hatred within him. There will be situations in which he loses control of his mind as well. Like the executive (in the example above) who has learned from his past mistakes of uncontrollable reactions, the sadhak also makes use of the remembrance of past experiences to discriminate and control himself. But unlike the executive, the sadhak constantly works on his anger and strives hard to get rid of such tendencies. Through incessant practice, keeping his mind fixed on the goal of Self-realization, he sublimates his negative emotions, and

in due course, the anger and other negative feelings are uprooted.

“The difference is that while the spiritual seeker feels that eliminating anger is essential to his life, someone like an administrator or an executive, for example, feels it is part of his professional life to keep his anger under control. His aim is to tackle that particular situation, and that is the end of it. He may be able to control his anger when a provocative situation arises, but the anger that has arisen within him filters deep into his mind and gets deposited there, waiting for the opportunity to express itself again.

“Like the executive, the sadhak also may not express anger at the moment he is provoked. Or, under certain circumstances when it becomes uncontrollable, he may express it; but later he will meditate, pray and chant his mantra to remove the anger and its very cause. As far as a sadhak is concerned, removing anger and other negative tendencies is his life’s goal. His entire life is dedicated toward that. Therefore, he works hard to eliminate the ego and all its different aspects. Eventually his constant effort and the Guru’s grace take him to the state of perfection—where there is no ego, no thoughts and no mind. Once he reaches that state he will be able to genuinely respond.”

As the explanation progressed, another question came up, “Amma, from your explanations I get the impression that response is a state where there is neither action nor reaction. Is that correct?”

Amma answered, “Yes, in the ultimate sense there is no action or reaction. There is only the witness-consciousness attitude. You may appear to act or react, but there is neither action or reaction. You simply watch in silence while your

body acts or reacts.

“A genuine response takes place only when you become completely free from the grip of the ego, when you become nothing or nobody. Until then, the ego is hidden behind all your actions, reactions, and seeming responses.

“This is the highest state one can attain. There is no point beyond that. This state is the ‘pointless point.’ To attain this state one must do intense spiritual practices.”

Amma wanted to hear a newly composed song. The brahmacharins sang it, *Katinnu katayai*. . .

*O Mother who shines as the Ear of the ear,
Mind of the mind and Eye of the eye,
You are the Life of life
And Your Being is Life of the Living.*

*As the ocean is to the waves,
You are the Soul of souls
You are the Nectar of the nectar or knowledge,
O Mother! Pearl of the Immortal Self are You
And the Essence of Bliss,
Great Maya You are and the Absolute Itself.*

*Neither can eyes reach You
Nor can the mind grasp You
Words are hushed in Your Presence, O Mother.
Who says they have seen You have really not,
As You, O Great Goddess, are beyond intellect.*

*Sun, moon and stars shine not of themselves
But are illumined by Your Brilliance,*

*Through discrimination the courageous can tread
The path to the Abode of Eternal Peace,
The Supreme Truth.*

It was a sunny day. Mother was sitting on the staircase facing the backwaters which marked the Ashram's southern boundary. A few children from the fishing village were trying to catch fish in these waters. Two of them were standing on the shore holding a clay pot, while another, who seemed a little older, moved silently in the water trying to catch the fish with his bare hands. Now and then he dived deep into the murky backwaters, surfacing after a short while with one or two fish in his hands. Amma was looking intently at the children. She said, "Look at those children. They are the ones who look after their family. Everyday they catch fish like this with their bare hands. They sell the fish to other people or in the market, and with that hard-earned money these small children buy the necessary foodstuffs for their family. At such a young age they are burdened with supporting the family."

There was deep concern in Her voice. Amma called to the two who were holding the pot. They approached and stood in front of Amma. "Did you have a good catch today?" She asked them. "No," replied the children. The older of the two said, "Because of the rain, the water has risen very high, making it hard for our brother to catch enough fish."

Amma looked into the pot. It contained only a few small fish. She looked towards the water and at the other boy. The oldest brother was still diving in the water, feeling about with his hands in search of fish. He had no success. Amma turned around and whispered something to Kunjumol, who got up and left.

A few minutes later, Kunjumol returned with a plastic bag containing a few apples, a bunch of bananas, some sweets and other foodstuffs. In addition to these items Amma gave them a package of rice and fresh vegetables, enough for a family to cook one or two dishes. The children were overwhelmed with joy. They smiled heartily and called out to their brother, "Anna, Anna," (elder brother), Ammachi has given us enough food. Let's stop fishing and go home." "Really?" he asked, coming out of the water. After seeking Amma's permission, the three of them happily returned home.

LOVE AND COMPASSION

Wednesday, 25 July, 1984

It was almost midday. Mother was sitting in Br. Nealu's hut peeling tapioca root. This was the first hut built in the Ashram where Amma, along with Gayatri, had lived for nearly two years. In those days, part of the hut was also used as a storeroom and kitchen to cook food for Amma and the first group of brahmacharins.

Late in the morning, Amma returned from a neighboring devotee's house with some tapioca root in Her hands. Holding it up in front of everyone, She said like an innocent child, "This Amma plucked Herself from their plot. Now She is going to cook it. Once it is cooked, Amma will give it to all Her children."

Amma insisted on peeling and cooking it Herself. While She was peeling and preparing the tapioca root, one of the brahmacharins asked, "Amma, is love and compassion the same thing, or are they different?"

“When love becomes Divine Love, compassion also fills the heart. Love is the inner feeling, and compassion its expression. Compassion is expressing your heartfelt concern for someone—for a suffering human being. Therefore, love and compassion are two sides of the same coin—they co-exist.

“There is love and Love. You love your family, but you do not love your neighbor. You love your son or daughter, but you do not love all children. You love your father and mother, but you do not love everyone the way you love your father and mother. You love your religion, but you do not love all religions. Likewise, you have love for your country, but you do not love all countries. Hence, this is not true Love; it is only limited love. The transformation of this limited love into Divine Love is the goal of spirituality. In the fullness of Love blossoms the beautiful, fragrant flower of compassion.

“Love with a small ‘I’ is limited. It exists in its own small world. It cannot contain more than a few people and a few things. It is narrow and is always changing. It has no peaks. The apparent peaks are not the highest pinnacles. They are only raised a little above ground level, just a little. Soon those little peaks will turn to plain, flat ground. There are ups and downs in love. In due course, all the ‘ups’ will disappear and there will only be ‘downs.’ This changeable love can become permanent love only when the feeling of ‘I’ and ‘mine’ disappears.

“As long as there is the feeling of ‘I,’ there is also the feeling of ‘you;’ thus love always has a personal touch. It occurs between two people. In order to love there must be two. Love becomes impersonal only when the two disappear. In that state of Oneness there is a constant flow of Love.

From then on Love starts flowing from its very source. As it flows, it does not think of the other end. The flow of Love is unobstructed, just like the flow of the river. The river cannot but flow. The river does not think of the other end, the ocean. The merging just happens in the course of its flow. In that merging there are no calculations at all. Likewise, the sun just shines. It does not think about touching the earth with its rays; the contact just happens.

“In the same way, when the obstructions of the ego, fear, and the feeling of otherness disappear, you cannot do anything but Love; and you do not expect anything in return. You don’t care about receiving—you just flow. Whoever comes into the river of Love will be bathed in it, whether the person is healthy or diseased, a man or a woman, wealthy or poor. Anyone can take any number of dips in it. Whether somebody bathes in it or not, the river of Love does not care. If somebody criticizes or abuses the river of Love, it does not care; it simply flows. When that constant flow of Love overflows and is expressed through every word and deed we call it compassion.

“Compassion is Pure Consciousness expressed through your words and actions. Compassion is the art of non-hurting, for compassion cannot hurt. Compassion cannot hurt anyone because compassion is the manifestation of consciousness, and consciousness cannot hurt anyone. Just as open space of the infinite sky cannot hurt anyone, compassion, the manifestation of consciousness cannot hurt anyone. One who has compassion can only be compassionate.

“Compassion does not see the faults of others. It does not see the weaknesses of people. It makes no distinction between good and bad people. Compassion cannot draw a

line between two countries, two faiths or two religions. Compassion has no ego; thus there is no fear, lust or passion. Compassion simply forgives and forgets. Compassion is like a passage. Everything passes through it. Nothing can stay there. Compassion is love expressed in all its fullness.”

A question was interjected, “That is what a real spiritual master has, doesn’t he?”

“Yes,” replied Amma, “a real spiritual master is both Love and compassion in all fullness. Sometimes his love manifests as discipline. Normally a certain amount of pain is experienced when one is being disciplined, but the Guru’s compassion removes it. When you correct someone or when you scold someone, his ego is hurt; his individuality is crushed. That is what people dislike the most. They do not want to be called to question or be corrected even if they are wrong. So there is pain in being disciplined. Whether it is the father disciplining the son, the mother disciplining the daughter, or the teacher disciplining the student, pain is unavoidable. The latter will feel hurt by the former, and in many cases he will react. In some cases even though one feels hurt, he will not express his reaction. He may obey but, at the same time, feel tremendously angry within. There will be great pain inside. He may want to protest, but due to fear he will not do anything. This may continue, and pain, hurt feelings, anger and hatred will accumulate in his mind. At some point this accumulation of negative emotions will explode. It is unfortunate that this happens in the ordinary process of trying to discipline another, even when it comes out of love. Even if the disciplining is born of the father’s or mother’s love, this pain will sometimes remain unhealed.

“On the other hand, in a Guru-sishya relationship, there are no hurt feelings in the disciple’s mind. There is no pain, no deep wounds, no anger or hatred in the disciple’s mind. The reason is that the sishya accepts the Guru’s disciplining and scolding with a positive attitude. He surrenders to the Guru fully. He knows that whatever the Guru does is for his highest good. But the most important factor is the Guru’s compassion which has tremendous healing power. All the pain, anger, hatred and other negativity will be healed by the Guru’s compassion. Sometimes the sishya may feel hurt; he may feel angry toward the Guru when the Guru scolds or disciplines him. But the Guru’s overflowing compassion heals these wounds, helping the disciple to become positive. The Guru’s compassion overlooks the disciple’s anger and hatred; the Guru’s compassion forgives all. That supreme compassion encompasses the disciple completely and soothes all the negative feelings.

“This soothing effect of the Guru’s compassion helps the sishya feel relaxed and at ease. In this way he is able to receive and absorb the Guru’s disciplining with a positive attitude. The compassion makes the disciple feel that he is a part of the Guru, that he is the Guru’s own, that the Guru loves him immensely and that the Guru does everything for his highest good. Feeling the flow of compassion from the Guru and observing his renunciation and selflessness, the disciple knows that the Guru cannot be selfish at all. Thus the sishya will not accumulate any negative feelings, even though he may feel pain or anger from time to time. Thus the Guru can discipline the disciple without letting any trace of the disciple’s reactions remain within. The father or mother cannot remove the traces of reaction from the mind of their son

or daughter because they have no compassion. Because Love has not fully bloomed in them, they are egoistic in their words and actions, and thus they force discipline onto their children; they force their own ideas onto them, most of the time ignoring the children's feelings. However, the Guru cannot force discipline onto his disciples because he is not a person. He is not the body; he is not the ego. He is consciousness.

"After chastising or punishing the son or daughter for his or her mistakes, the father or mother may call and treat their child in a very loving way. But the thought that they have scolded him and forced him to obey remains in the child's mind. Parents really do this; they force their children to do things in a certain way, rather than setting an example for them. They cannot be otherwise because they are limited individuals. They are operating from their egos. When they operate from their egos, they cannot but try to force their own will on another, even though they do it in the name of love. In the name of love, they force their egos on their child. The child feels it, so afterwards, even if they treat him lovingly or affectionately, the hurt feelings in the child remain unchanged. The anger and hatred remain; they are not eliminated.

"In the Guru-sishya relationship, however, this is different. After disciplining the disciple through his pure love, the Guru makes him feel at ease and comfortable by expressing his compassion toward him in great measure. This helps the disciple to be a very good receiver, a very good container; thus, he can continue to be receptive and positive.

"In the Guru-sishya relationship there is no forcing. The disciple's inner thirst to go beyond the limitations of his ego, and the Guru's selfless Love and compassionate guidance

help the sishya refrain from building up anger within him.

“When one lives in Love, when one’s whole being transforms itself into Love, he becomes compassionate. Love fills the heart and overflows as compassion. In that state when the mind and mental thoughts are completely consumed by the fire of Supreme Love, when the seeker’s mind becomes like space, the thing that brings him down is compassion. The quality that makes the soul feel the call of those who are groping in darkness is compassion. That which keeps the body of the Mahatma in this world of plurality is compassion. Love and compassion are basically the same; they are two sides of the same coin.”

Mother stopped for a while and during this time a brahmacharin spontaneously sang a song in praise of Amma, *Kannadachalum turannalum*. As he sang, the brahmacharin shed tears of joy and devotion. . .

*My Mother ever resides
In my eyes, open or closed.*

*With glances pouring forth compassion,
She hugs one and all.
Melting the heart with a shower of love,
My Mother is indeed an Ocean of Joy.*

*A robber or a tyrant, in front of Mother,
Both are Her darling children.
Whether She is despised or adored,
Love streams forth from Mother.
Enjoyed by the tongue, sweetness is not perfect,*

*Perfect sweetness is the love of God
And the sense to enjoy that
Comes only through my Mother.*

At the end of the song, the brahmacharin, with a choking throat said, “Oh, Amma, may your compassion and grace guide us forever on the path of spirituality. Without your grace we cannot reach the other shore.”

Amma was very pleased with his innocence, but She jokingly retorted, “Your Mother is not compassionate. She is a demon. Be careful. She is a tough guy.” Everybody laughed at Amma’s playful threat.

The satsang continued, “Certainly, the greatness of our ancient saints and sages is indescribable. Without their compassion today’s world would be hell. It is their renunciation and compassion which sustain today’s world. All the unrighteous actions performed by selfish and wicked people are balanced by the compassionate and loving actions performed by the spiritual beings who are the world’s only real benefactors. Their compassion surpasses our understanding; it flows even to those who try to destroy them.

“Amma will tell you a story. Once a king brought the prince, his only son, to the hermitage of a great saint. There the young prince was to be imbued with the knowledge of the Vedas and other scriptural texts. That was the kind of education that existed in those days. Whether a prince or a layman, a young person underwent several years of education and discipline under the guidance of a master. During this period students had to stay with the master without having any contact with their own parents or family.

“When the king and son arrived at the hermitage, all was quiet; no one seemed to be there. Looking around, they finally found the saint seated under a tree. He was deep in samadhi—totally absorbed and oblivious to his surroundings. When the saint finally emerged from his meditation, he immediately bowed to the king and offered him a seat.

“The king, however, did not feel that he had been received in the proper manner, especially since he had to go around looking for the saint and then had to wait for him to come out of meditation. His self-image as king was wounded, for he was used to being waited on. He could not tolerate having to wait for others. He felt it was humiliating to have to wait for other people; after all, he was king and they should always be ready to serve him. His ego was hurt and he began to boil with anger. He glared at the saint, trying to contain the rage building within him.

“ ‘Your royal highness,’ the saint spoke very politely, ‘may I know the purpose of your visit?’

At this point, the king’s anger erupted, ‘What?! Are you trying to mock me? Even without receiving me properly, you are asking the purpose of my visit? Where are all the residents of this ashram? Where are your disciples?’ He added sarcastically, ‘Can’t I have their darshan too?’

“The saint apologized for not providing the king with a proper reception. He explained that since this was a school for discipline, the students are taught to adhere strictly to their scheduled routine of study, work, performing religious rites and sadhana. ‘I myself was in meditation,’ the saint said.

“At this remark the king raged with fury. He shouted, ‘Are you also trying to insult me?’

“Seeing that his words only provoked the angry king, the saint did not speak anymore. He just sat calmly and quietly.

“Furious as he was, the king managed to suppress his anger when he recalled the purpose of his visit. He remembered that he had come to have his son educated by this saint. Though he was angry because his ego was wounded, the king brought his temper under control. He did not want to spoil the chance for the prince to have a first-rate education under the guidance of this master who had the highest reputation in the land for his wisdom and knowledge. Therefore, he suddenly put on a show of humility, apologized for his emotional outburst and requested the great master to accept his son as a disciple.

“The saint, who was the embodiment of patience and forgiveness, readily agreed and accepted the prince as a sishya. When the arrangements were completed, the king took leave of the saint with a smiling face but a wounded ego.

“The prince was a brilliant student and a good disciple. His obedience, discipline and devotion to the Guru made him the saint’s favorite. Twelve long years rolled by as the saint taught him everything he knew. The prince not only became a real master in all the scriptures but also in using all weapons. Although he had now become a handsome youth, the prince was very humble and remained an obedient and devoted disciple of the great saint.

“At last the prince’s education was completed, and the day to take leave of his beloved and revered Guru arrived. With a heavy heart and eyes filled with tears, the prince stood in front of the great master. With humility and gratitude he addressed his Guru, ‘O Holy One, my beloved master, I am yours. Whatever I have belongs to you. I am nothing

before your glory. How can I ever repay you for all your love and compassion? This humble servant is waiting to hear from you. What should I offer as Gurudakshina?’

“The great saint affectionately caressed his beloved disciple. Tears of joy rolled down his cheeks as he said, ‘My child, my son, your obedience, humility and the great love that you have had for me are your Gurudakshina. You have already made your offering my son, you have already given it.’

“But the prince lovingly insisted that the saint should accept something from him as dakshina: ‘Let it be anything, O Venerable One, even if it is my own life. I am ready to lay it at your holy feet.’ Embracing his dear student, the saint told him that he did not want anything right at that moment but would definitely ask when the appropriate time came. With the permission and blessing of the saint, the prince returned to the kingdom to live with his parents, the king and the queen.

“The spiteful king had been waiting for the day when his son would return after having finished his studies. The prince had not been back for a day when the king, whose mind was bent on revenge for the humiliation his ego had suffered, sent his soldiers to burn down the saint’s hermitage. The saint and the hermits were severely tortured by the soldiers and abandoned in the forest without any food, clothing or shelter. Hearing his soldiers’ report on how well they had carried out his commands, the cruel, egoistic king felt happy, thinking that he had taught a good lesson to the saint by ‘getting even with him.’

“A few days after this incident, the king announced he would soon retire and his son would be crowned king. Before his coronation, the prince wanted to have the permission and blessing of his beloved master before entering this new

phase of his life. Mounting a steed, he rode to the hermitage, totally unaware of his father's cruel deed. Alighting from the horse, the prince wondered whether he had lost his way and reached another place. The spot where the hermitage had been looked deserted.

"After wandering around for a while, he found his beloved master sitting under a banyan tree deeply absorbed in meditation. Now as he looked around, he could easily see that the hermitage had recently been burned down. The prince waited until the master arose from meditation. When the saint finally opened his eyes, the prince prostrated before him and inquired what had happened to the hermitage. 'Nothing, my son,' replied the great soul, 'some forest fire. Don't bother about it. Tell me what brought you here.'

"The prince sensed that something was wrong. Repeatedly he pleaded with the master to disclose to him what had really happened, but the saint would not speak. Finally the other students of the hermitage relented and revealed the truth to him. Upon hearing the horrible story, the prince went into a state of shock and was even momentarily paralyzed. Coming back to consciousness, the prince gnashed his teeth in anger. His right hand automatically moved to the handle of his sheathed sword, and the next moment the infuriated prince leaped on his horse. 'Coward, you are dead,' he roared and began to charge off.

"With lightning movement, the saint jumped in front of the horse. He tried to stop the prince, but the prince was fierce. All the saint's attempts to calm him down failed. All his advice and warnings fell on deaf ears. The prince was beside himself with anger and determined to avenge the wrong done to his master by his father. Finally the saint said, 'All right, you can go. But before you leave I wish to have the

Gurudakshina that you promised. I want it right now!’

“Hearing these words of his Guru, the prince alighted from the horse and prayed to the Guru to ask whatever he desired. The great saint smilingly replied, ‘I want you to free your father from this punishment that you are about to give him. That is the Gurudakshina I want from you.’ This rendered the prince speechless and all he could do was to gaze at the radiant and compassionate face of his Guru. The next moment he burst into tears and fell prostrate at the great saint’s holy feet.”

Thus, Amma finished the story. The way She had presented it was so alive and powerful that it created an atmosphere saturated with divine love and compassion. Deeply touched, the brahmacharins and the two brahmacharinis, silently shed tears, for they truly felt and experienced the compassion of the saint in the story. A long meditative silence followed. This was so powerful and overpowering that nobody could speak or move for some time. It was as if the experience of compassion had made everything stand still.

A few more minutes passed. Then Gayatri’s voice broke the silence, “The tapioca root is cooked and ready to be served.” Amma distributed a few pieces to each one of Her children. As She was serving them, Amma said, “It is very hot. Careful, don’t burn your mouth.” Thus, after bestowing upon Her children another fond memory to cherish, Amma left the hut.

Friday, 27 July, 1984

Late this afternoon at around five-thirty Amma expressed a desire to go to the seashore with the Ashramites and visiting

devotees. After several days of rain and gray skies, the setting sun's golden rays broke through the clouds as the group led by Amma reached the water's edge. Amma stood looking at the vast ocean and the gigantic waves. As if wanting to touch the Divine Mother's feet, the ocean waves came up to the spot where She was standing. Having washed Her Holy Feet, the waves rolled back to the ocean. As She stood there Amma's bearing reflected Her magnificence. Gently swaying from side to side, Amma kept Her gaze on the horizon. Her eyes were transfixed. The devotees and brahmacharins sat down to meditate, but kept their eyes open and fixed their gaze on the swaying figure of Amma.

Various types of trawlers were lined up on the seashore, as the fishermen had been prevented by the heavy rains from casting their nets out to sea. 'Mother Sea' had not blessed them with a good catch for a long time, except that one day when Amma had helped them. The fishing nets, laid out on the sand to dry, were being gathered up by the men.

Remaining in the same spot, Amma was blissfully enjoying the infinitude. Her dark, curly hair danced in the ocean breeze. Amma's dangling white head scarf looked like a patch of white cloud floating in the sky. The movement of Her body stopped, and She remained motionless, Her eyes wide open. She was totally in an indrawn state.

The sun slowly started its descent into the ocean. With more than half of its fiery orb still visible, it beautified the entire horizon with its golden rays. Eventually the sun disappeared from sight as it dived deep into the ocean waters. As the time approached quarter past six, the translucent veil of dusk spread itself all around. The noisy fisher-children who were somersaulting at the shoreline stopped their play

and retreated to their homes, small huts made of thatched coconut leaves and bamboo poles. The constant roar of the endless ocean evoked a feeling of terrifying yet inspiring awe. As this sunny day came to a close, rain clouds slowly filled the entire sky, adding drama to the twilight.

Amma still stood unmoving. It was now more than forty minutes since She had come to the water's edge. Her white head scarf still floated in the breeze, but other than that there was no movement. Concerned, Gayatri and Br. Rao approached Her to make sure all was well. Sensitive to Mother's states of samadhi, they were a bit uncertain and confused about what to do, for rain was impending. Already someone held an umbrella above Amma. Obviously moved by the beauty and the tension of the scene, Br. Pai began to sing slokas by Sri Sankaracharya. . .

*No desire for Liberation have I,
nor for wealth and knowledge do I crave,
neither do I desire happiness,
O You Moon-faced One;
but this much I beg of You, O Mother,
that my life may be spent chanting Your names.*

*O Mother of the universe,
nothing is there to be wondered
that You should be full of compassion for me,
for a mother does not forsake her son
even if he has numerable faults.*

Transcending the sound of the ocean waves, the song echoed through the twilight. Some fishermen came out of their huts to see what was going on, but as they were familiar

with such happenings around Mother, most of them soon disappeared back into their huts though a few stood around as onlookers.

The song was not sung in vain; it served its purpose. After a while, there was a slight movement in Amma's body. First the fingers of Her right hand moved, then there was the peculiar but familiar sound which Amma sometimes makes when She comes out of samadhi. Hearing that, everyone sighed with relief. After a few more moments, Amma completely regained Her regular consciousness.

It was nearly seven o'clock when Amma and the group returned to the Ashram. A few brahmacharins who had stayed behind in the Ashram had already begun the evening bhajan.



CHAPTER VIII

Monday, 30 July, 1984

It was a quiet afternoon. The Ashram looked almost deserted as all were in their own rooms reading, writing or tending to personal matters. Br. Balu was sitting on the temple verandah talking to a middle-aged man who had come from the eastern part of Kerala. The man, Mr. S., was telling Balu how Amma had cured his cancer.

Mr. S. had been suffering from intestinal cancer for the last four years. From the day it was diagnosed he had undergone different treatments, both allopathic and ayurvedic. In spite of all the treatments and medication, the disease persisted. He had intense, unbearable pain in the stomach which had caused him many sleepless nights. Though Mr. S. belonged to a poor family, he received good medical treatment through the help and financial assistance provided by generous friends and doctors. The doctors did their best, but Mr. S. did not get any better. As time passed, his condition worsened. Finally the doctors gave up all hope and advised him to stop all medication. Counting his last days, Mr. S. still did not give up his faith in God. He prayed

and chanted almost every day.

Finally one day, assisted by his only brother and his wife, Mr. S. came to see Amma for the first time. During *Devi Bhava* when Amma asked about his disease, Mr. S. told Her about his incurable illness and prayed to Her to do as She wished. Amma gave him a drink of sacred water from the *kindi* after She had blessed it by taking a sip Herself. In addition to that Amma gave him some sacred water to take home, instructing him to have a little of it everyday.

“From that day onwards, I started feeling much more relaxed and comfortable. The pain lessened and in a short period of time it was completely gone. I was able to start eating properly and at night I could sleep soundly. Now I am perfectly well. It is almost one year now and still I continue to take Amma’s sacred water everyday. I always have a supply of it in my puja room. Amma has blessed me with a second birth. This life belongs to Her.”

Mr. S. had wanted Amma’s will to be done. He did not ask for a cure. He made no demands. Even when Amma asked him about his illness, the man did not suggest anything to Her. He just prayed, “Let Amma’s will be done.” That was real prayer. Real prayer is when we pray without ego. The ego should be kept away, for only then are real prayers possible. Mr. S. expressed a real prayer and it was answered. Real prayers must be answered.

Amma says, “A real prayer will never contain any suggestions, instructions or demands. The sincere devotee will simply say, ‘O Lord, I do not know what is good or what is bad for me. I am nobody—nothing. You know everything. I know whatever you do must be for the best; therefore, do as you wish.’ In real prayer you bow down, surrender and declare your helplessness to the Lord.”

While Mr. S. sat on the temple verandah, waiting to have Amma's darshan, She happened to pass by. He rushed to Her and prostrated. Amma affectionately lifted him up and inquired about his health and family. The man was overwhelmed with joy. In an excited mood he replied, "Amma, how can there be any problems when You are guiding me both within and without?"

SURRENDERING

After spending a few minutes with Mr. S., Amma stepped into the kitchen. The brahmacharinis and women devotees who worked there did not expect this sudden visit. Of course, Amma's visits always happened like this, and the women were quite sure that, as usual, they would be caught for some negligence or other. They waited in fear as Amma looked around. But much to their surprise, Amma simply sat down on the floor. She picked up a cucumber from the corner where the vegetables were stored and started eating it. After having taken a couple of bites, Amma gave it to one of the women devotees who received it joyfully. Others probably felt a twinge of jealousy.

Amma often does things like this when all the residents are around Her. Then She watches everyone's expression and mental attitude to see if some negative feelings are cropping up in anyone's mind. If there are any people feeling jealous, She immediately catches them.

It seemed as if the women devotees were celebrating, for there were only smiling faces on this day. All of them were happy and thrilled. They usually complain that they always have to work, that they have given up everything to be constantly in Amma's presence, but instead they spend

half their time in the kitchen cooking, sweating and toiling.

All the kitchen workers now sat around Amma. She started singing Radhe Govinda, and everybody sang the response. Amma, surrounded by all the women and girls, reminded one of Krishna surrounded by the gopis of Vrindavan. This was followed by another song, *Ellam ariyunna*. . .

*No need is there to tell anything
to all-knowing Krishna.
Walking beside us, He sees
and understands everything.
The Primordial Being sees all the thoughts
of the Innermost Self.
It is never possible for anyone to do anything,
forgetting Him.
The Primordial Lord abides in all.
All of us should worship with joy
that Embodiment of Truth and Awareness.*

After the songs Amma sat in the middle laughing and cracking jokes. Then the mood changed to a more serious tone.

Amma said, “Mother knows that you sometimes complain about the work load in the kitchen. Children, spirituality is nothing but giving up our happiness whole-heartedly for the sake of others. There shouldn’t be any bad feelings or complaints about that. Usually when people give up something they experience a lot of conflict within. They start having second thoughts about it and feel that perhaps they made a mistake. This is not real renunciation. After having given up something, if you still feel a mental attachment to it, that means you have not given it up.

“In fact, what you should give up is the attachment to the object. You can have the object and enjoy it—if you are not attached. We give up something externally, in order to be internally free from the bondage to that object. **Detachment is what brings peace and happiness.** Real renunciation and detachment come only when we give up all thoughts and feelings about whatever we have renounced.

“Mother has seen many people who still feel very sad and frustrated about something which they gave up long ago. With a voice full of disappointment years later, a person like this says, ‘What a fool was I to give that thing away.’ Though he has not seen it for years, such a person still carries the burden of the object. He is not free from it even though he has not seen it for many years. Internally he is still attached and bound. This kind of person cannot experience the joy of freedom. He can never feel relaxed. When he still had the object, he did not feel any mental agony. He enjoyed having it. The thought that it was his own made him a happy man. But now he experiences terrible agony, ‘I should not have done it. I should never have given it away.’ He repeats this over and over again in his mind a hundred times a day.

“Give up something and feel happy about it. Forget that it was ever yours. To think that you have given up something is also wrong. Don’t feel that. Just feel relaxed; be at ease. Realize that you are free—free from that burden. The object was a burden and now it is gone. Only if you can feel the burden of attachment to objects will you be able to feel the relaxation or bliss that comes with detachment and renunciation.

“Children, it is true that you have given up your belongings and homes to come and spend the rest of your lives with

Amma. But have you really given them up? You still say, 'We have given up everything to be in Amma's physical presence, but just as we did at home, we are still working in the kitchen.' This means you have not given them up because it sounds as if you are disappointed about having done so. You still carry the thought, 'We have given up our house and everything.' This constant thought makes it very clear that you still carry the house and all the household utensils within you.

"Children, try to feel relaxed and at ease about it. Try to feel that you have unburdened yourselves of a heavy load, and now feel happy about doing this work here because you are not doing it for yourselves. You are serving all those who come here. They are devotees of God. You are the ones who cook food for them, food which gives them both physical and mental strength to remember God. This is a great service that you are doing. By serving devotees of God, you are serving God. Consider this work as a sadhana."

A brahmacharini asked, "It is said that a spiritual person should not even expect a word of thanks or gratitude for the service that he or she does. Amma, what does that mean?"

"That is right," replied Amma. "A true seeker should not expect even one word of appreciation. Suppose we do some service for someone. We complete it beautifully. Then the person for whom we have done the work comes along with his friends and relatives to see it. They like it very much; they appreciate it, and praise the quality of the work that we have done. They express their gratitude using flowery words. When all this happens, when they shower you with praises and words of thanks, you remain humble. You may even say, 'Oh for heaven's sake, don't say this. I don't deserve

all these praises. I am just a tool. He, the Supreme Being, does everything through me. Without His grace I am nothing. Please bow down to Him. Shower all these praises on Him. He is the real doer, not I.' But these words are superficial; they don't come from deep within. You are not really humble. You just pretend to be humble. You put up a big show of humility. It is simple psychology. You want others to think that you are a humble devotee devoid of all egoistic feelings. But in reality, all the praises and flowery words they have spoken go to your head and you start feeling proud. 'I am not an ordinary soul,' you think. 'There must be something special about me; otherwise, how could I do this work so well? Look at all these people praising me and my talents. I must really be great.' In this way, thought after thought goes to boost the ego.

"Even a simple word of thanks can work in this way. It enters into your head and makes you feel that you are something special. As sadhaks we are striving hard to feel that we are nothing and that He is everything. But such circumstances work on us very subtly. Without even knowing it, we can become bound by words of thanks and praise. Therefore, if you wish to help someone, fine. Do so, but do not feel that others should thank you or praise you for anything you have done.

"It has become our habit to expect something in return for our help, a single word of gratitude or a sentence of praise like 'You have done wonderful work. We really appreciate it.' And that's enough to make you feel a bit of pride. That's enough for you to get the feeling that you have really done something wonderful. Even the thought, 'I did it,' is food for your ego. When the ego is fed, it feels great.

“When we donate or offer something to a temple, church, or a spiritual institution, we sincerely wish that others could know about it. We wait for some recognition or thanks. We want acknowledgment for our great grand offering. We want someone to say in public that this generous, open-hearted philanthropist has done something great, something wonderful for society. Without praise, we don’t feel satisfied.

“There is a story of a great Mahatma who worked as a priest in a temple. He was a fully surrendered soul. There was not a trace of ego in him. One day a multi-millionaire donated a huge sum of money to the temple. Afterwards, the rich man kept on speaking to the priest about the tremendous amount of money that he had donated. He said that even for a multi-millionaire like him the amount was huge. Over and over he repeated the same thing. The Mahatma kept quiet for some time. But when he found that the rich man was not going to stop, the Mahatma asked, ‘Okay, sir, what do you want? Do you expect something? Something in return? A word of praise or a word of thanks?’ The rich man replied, ‘What is wrong with that? I can expect at least that much.’ The Mahatma smilingly looked at him and said, ‘If so, take this money back. We do not want it here. You should be thankful to the Lord for accepting this amount. You should feel content, thinking that you could return at least a portion of the wealth that the Great Lord has entrusted to you. You should be thankful to God, for He gave you an opportunity to serve Him. If you cannot do that, please take this money back.’

“Children, that should be our attitude. Who are we, the debtors, to demand or expect something from Him? Our giving is nothing but remitting. We cannot give anything

to Him. We can only make a remittance of what we owe God. We call it giving, but that is wrong. To become spiritual, to become egoless, which is our goal in life, we should be able to feel thankful to Him for everything. Never let 'I' come in. Let there be only 'You,' the attitude that everything is 'You.' Never ask for anything, never demand anything. Let Him decide what to give and what not to give."

"Children, this opportunity you have, to work and serve the devotees and sadhaks, should be considered a rare gift bestowed upon you by the Lord to quickly exhaust your prarabdha or accumulated tendencies. Cooking food and serving the devotees of God is no small thing. It is a rare blessing. You are really the blessed ones in the Ashram. When you were in your own homes, you were only preparing food for your husbands and your children, for a small family of five or six. There is nothing great in cooking with love for one's own family. But cooking for others with love and dedication is an act of greatness. This will definitely purify you, uplift you and finally take you to the goal. You should be thankful to God to be given such an opportunity for having been chosen to work in the kitchen. Wherever your work be—in the kitchen, the cow shed or the toilet—let that be your temple. Make your workplace your place of worship, the place where you do your sadhana. Do not curse your work. Feel happy and blessed, and perform your work wholeheartedly."

All of a sudden Amma's mood changed. The Great Teacher who vigorously expounded the highest Truth with unchallengeable authority was gone, and in its place was a playful and innocent two-year-old child. Amma lay down on the bare kitchen floor, placing Her head on a woman's

lap and Her feet on another's. Quite unexpectedly, Amma said, "Where is my cucumber? I want my cucumber." But it was gone! Indeed, who could resist eating Amma's prasad? Someone quickly fetched another one and offered it to Amma. She looked at it but soon pushed it away like a stubborn child saying, "No, I don't want this one. I want mine, the one I was eating."

Falling under the spell of Amma's childlike mood, some older devotees acted exactly like mothers who were really concerned about their child. They tried to coax Amma to accept the new cucumber but failed. Others were thrilled, enjoying the whole scene with great devotion. Amma whimpered like a child and repeatedly asked for the same cucumber from which She had taken a few bites. Finally when Amma did not get it, She pulled the devotee who had eaten it by her hair. In that position, still holding the woman's hair, Amma went into samadhi. After some time Amma got up and left the kitchen. She entered the temple and closed the door. Amma remained inside the temple almost for an hour.

Referring to Herself, Amma once said, "Something—an object, a desire or a thought—is needed to keep the mind down on this physical plane. Otherwise, it is difficult to stop it from shooting up. When the body expresses a desire, that is what it is for." The cucumber business might have been one such play.



CHAPTER IX

Friday, 3 August, 1984

All the residents of the Ashram participated in the large scale cleaning that began at ten o'clock in the morning. Of course, when Amma is there to work along with the group, there is no question of anybody not joining in. On such occasions, everybody's energy is high, for in Amma's presence, it is easy to feel the joy of selfless action. To work alongside Amma is a wonderful experience. Radiating spiritual light and energy, She actively participates in all the Ashram work. Amma never fails to inspire the residents, whatever kind of work they do.

That particular morning all the residents were working hard, blissfully chanting the Divine Names, feeling great enthusiasm and vigor as they worked. Amma sang too and did the work with immense joy. All together they sang *Adbhuta Charite*. . .

*O You to whom the celestials bow
Whose tale is wonderful,*

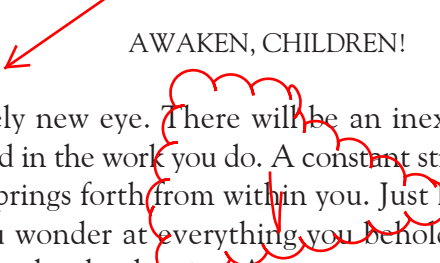
*Grant us the strength to be devoted to Your Feet.
We offer You all our actions
Done in the darkness of ignorance.
O Protector of the distressed,
Forgive us for all impertinent utterances,
O Ruler of the Universe.*

*O Mother, please shine in my heart
Like the rising sun at dawn.
Give me a mind of equal vision
Free of a differentiating intellect.*

*O Great Goddess, Cause of all actions
Both sinful and virtuous,
O Liberator from all bondage,
Give me Your sandals which protect the basic virtues
On the path of Liberation,
The essence of all Principles.*

It seemed as though Amma was everywhere. She was seen at one place sweeping, at another place carrying sand and brick, at still another place chopping wood, or removing dirt in yet another place. . .

Do not think that the world will change after one attains Self-realization. Outwardly everything remains the same. Nothing really changes. The trees, the mountains, the valleys, the rivers and streams, the birds singing on the branches of trees—everything remains unchanged. The world will move on its own. But indescribable change happens within. Your entire being is transformed. You see things differently with



an entirely new eye. There will be an inexplicable quality in you and in the work you do. A constant stream of aesthetic delight springs forth from within you. Just like an innocent child you wonder at everything you behold.

If one closely observes Amma one can clearly see this quality in Her. There is a special beauty in whatever work She does. That beauty can be perceived in all Her actions, in all Her movements. She does the same work as others, but the way Amma does it is so charming and enrapturing to the heart. Amma does it with the delight and wonder of an innocent child, and that childlike innocence encompasses us. That fullness of Love in which She is established can be perceived in everything Amma does.

The work was almost completed. Amma sat down on the sand and asked Gayatri to bring some coffee and some snacks for everyone. Gayatri headed toward the kitchen. Usually after group work like this, Amma likes to serve something hot to drink and to distribute something light, like banana chips, to everyone as prasad.

Amma raised both Her hands and called out, "Hey, Shivane!" Then Amma remarked, "That 'old man' is mindless! He doesn't care about anything." Everybody laughed delightedly.

SPIRITUALITY IS REAL WEALTH

Taking this as a good opportunity to clarify a question he had, one of the residents asked, "Amma, there are different versions of what spirituality is. It is said that stillness of mind is spirituality or that spirituality is a state of silence.

Renunciation of desires and desire-prompted actions is spirituality. Expansiveness of mind is real spirituality. These, and so many more different views exist about spirituality. Amma what do you say about this?"

Amma answered, "Spirituality is everything that you have mentioned. It is stillness of mind, a state of silence. It is also renunciation or an egoless state. Stillness is something to be experienced. Everything you have mentioned has to be experienced. You can write volumes about spirituality. You can compose beautiful poetry about it and sing about it in melodious songs. You can also speak about spirituality for hours in very beautiful and flowery language. But still spirituality will remain unknown to you unless you really experience its beauty and bliss from within.

"Children, spirituality is the real wealth. Spirituality is the inner wealth which helps one to renounce all outer wealth, through an understanding of the meaninglessness of external riches. It is the wealth which helps one to become 'wealthier than the wealthiest.' It is the realization that God alone, the Self alone, is the real wealth. Spirituality is the wealth that helps us have a healthy approach to life."

Amma stopped for a while and continued by telling a story.

"A villager once had a dream. Lord Shiva appeared before him in this dream and said, 'Tomorrow at daybreak go to the outskirts of the village. There you will find a sannyasin. Ask him for the precious stone that will make you a rich man forever.' That night the man couldn't sleep, for he was always thinking of the precious stone he was going to get. Finally, in the morning as instructed by Lord Shiva in the dream, he rushed to the outskirts of the village. There he

was overwhelmed to actually find a sannyasin who just arrived. The latter was about to settle down under a tree when the villager came running up to him saying, 'Where is the stone, the precious stone? Give me the precious stone.' The sannyasin looked up and asked, 'What did you say? A precious stone!' Without uttering another word, he opened a bundle lying next to him and took out a large precious gem. The sannyasin handed it over to the villager without hesitation.

"The villager looked and looked, and again looked at the stone. He was wonder struck because it was a diamond, probably the biggest in the world. With a joyful heart full of hopes and wishes, the man returned home. But that night again he could not sleep. He tossed about in bed. The next morning before dawn the villager once again rushed to the outskirts of the village. He woke **the** sannyasin and said, 'Be kind enough to bestow on me the wealth which made you give this diamond to me so easily.'

"Children, once you know your essential nature, the entire universe becomes your wealth. In that supreme state you have nothing to gain or lose. Having given up all attachment you become ever established in the state of supreme detachment. Just like the sannyasin in the story, you can smilingly give up even so-called precious objects and still feel content and peaceful. Spirituality is inner wealth which makes you feel fully content. You may have nothing to claim as your own, but you can still be full and content. Once you attain that state, you have nothing else to gain or lose. Once you acquire that inner spiritual wealth, you start living in fullness. Externally you may not be wealthy at all, but internally you are rich and full. You realize that you are the master of the entire universe. You become the master of

water, air, earth, and ether, sun, moon, stars and space. Everything in the universe will be under your control. Therefore, children, try to become a master, not a slave.

“A real wealthy man is one who can always smile, even in the face of sorrow. Sorrow cannot make him cry nor does he need happiness to make him rejoice. He does not need the support of objects or favorable external events in order to be happy. By his very nature he is blissful. An externally rich man is a miserable man who does not really know what real happiness is. In this regard he is a loser, even without knowing it. He always loses the priceless wealth—that is, peace and contentment.”

As Mother was talking, Gayatri arrived with the coffee and banana chips. As Amma passed out prasad to Her children, She asked the brahmacharins to sing *Bandhamilla*. .

*No one is ours
There is nothing to call our own,
In our last days only the True Self
Will remain as ours.*

*We take nothing with us on the last journey
Why then this madness for earthly possessions?*

*That which truly exists is within us
To see That, we must go within.*

*There no trace of sorrow exists
There the True Self shines in Its own glory.
We go from untruth to Truth
When we love and serve all living beings.*

CHAPTER X

NECESSITY OF THE GURU'S GRACE

Tuesday, 7 August, 1984

On the southwestern corner of the Ashram just behind the water tank grew some sugarcane. In the afternoon Amma cut a fresh stalk and began eating it. Just like a child who delights in sucking the juice from the sugarcane, Amma relished it with great pleasure. A few brahmacharins and a woman devotee from the neighborhood were sitting next to Her.

Anyone who sees Amma apparently relishing a particular food or drink naturally feels that She has a special liking for it. Always wishing to please Her, later they will prepare this same food or keep a stock of it on hand in case they should have the chance to offer some to Her. But often what Amma seems to like so much on one occasion, She will never ask for again.

Once Amma kept asking adamantly for 'mixture,' a spicy combination of different bits of deep-fried bakery items. Br.

Nealu had a small quantity of it, and he offered that to Amma. She took the tin container from Nealu and spread the mixture all over the cement floor. Then She started to eat the pieces off the floor, crawling around like a little child. As Nealu and Br. Balu happily witnessed this scene, they thought Amma would love to have more of it, and decided it would be a good idea to keep a stock of 'mixture' on hand, so they could readily offer it to Amma whenever She asked. So they purchased some and kept it safely for Her. But they were disappointed because Amma never asked for 'mixture' again. Amma calls this play of Hers "a totally detached attachment to keep the mind down."

Some devotees who were sincere sadhaks were visiting the Ashram from Tamil Nadu. They stood at a respectful distance watching Amma eating the sugarcane. She called them near. Without hesitation they rushed to Amma, prostrated at Her feet and sat down. One of them who was madly in love with Amma wanted to sit as close as he could to Her. Although he was nearly sixty, the man acted like a three-year-old child in Her presence.

Amma gave a piece of sugarcane to everyone, including the brahmacharins. It was always so special to receive prasad from Amma's hands. One could never get too much of it. Whether it was sugarcane or a ball of rice, whatever one received was an indescribable blessing.

"Amma, I have read that no matter how much sadhana one does, the state of Perfection cannot be reached without the grace of a Satguru. Is this true?" asked one of the Tamil devotees.

She answered, "Perfectly correct. In order to remove the

subtler vasanas one needs the Guru's guidance and grace. Again, when the vasanas are removed, the last stage, the point when a sadhak falls or glides into the state of Perfection, cannot happen without his grace.

"Human beings are limited. They cannot do much on their own. Maybe they are able to proceed to a certain stage without anybody's guidance or help, but soon the way becomes complex and help is required. The road to liberation is a maze of intricate paths, a labyrinth. In traveling through the maze, a spiritual aspirant may not be able to figure out where to go or which way to turn.

"Or following a spiritual path without a Guru can be compared to sailing alone in the ocean in a tiny boat that is not equipped with the necessary equipment, not even a compass to indicate the direction.

"Remember that the path which leads to the state of Self-realization is very narrow. Two people cannot walk together hand in hand rubbing each other's shoulders in companionship along this path. One walks this path alone.

"As we walk on the spiritual path there is a light that guides us. That light, showing us the path, is the Guru's grace. The Guru walks in front shedding light on the path as he slowly and carefully leads us. He knows all the intricate paths by heart. The light of his grace helps us to see and remove the obstacles and reach the ultimate goal.

"Children, only out of compassion does the Guru come down to walk with us. As we slowly walk behind him, we follow in the light of his grace. It is his grace which protects us and saves us from falling down. The Guru's grace helps us not to get lost in the darkness of narrow lanes and slip into dangerous pitfalls.

“Sometimes the path becomes very narrow. If it becomes too narrow and you slip off the path, it is necessary to have a Guru pull you back on. Otherwise, left to your own devices, you may retrace your steps and you may find it too difficult, almost impossible, to continue on the right way. In such places too, the Guru encourages you; he instills more faith and confidence in you to try again and again. Without the Guru’s encouraging and inspiring words, without his loving and compassionate glances, and without the faith and courage he instills in you, you might not even try. You cannot cross the final barrier by your own effort alone. Your effort is nothing. From the other side where he dwells, the Guru extends his hand and pulls you through.

“Without the Guru you may turn back and stray from the path. It is quite possible for you to get entangled in the world again. Feeling discouraged and disillusioned, you may even proclaim to the world that spirituality is not a reality, that it is a myth, an illusion. These and other dangerous ideas may take root in your mind.

“In reality, the Guru’s pushing and pulling is not pushing and pulling, that is, you are pushed and pulled without being pushed and pulled. You do not feel it because his compassion and love envelop you totally, so you don’t feel that you are being pushed and pulled. You don’t feel pressure, stress or strain. But if his grace and guidance were not present, the stress and pressure of your own *vasanas* would cause you to stray from the path of spirituality.

“Some places are broad, flooded with light, where the atmosphere is filled with divine fragrance. Your own mind will try to delude you by creating a colorful world. There will be attractive, tempting and alluring sights all around—

divine music on one side, enchanting dances on the other. It may look like the final goal. You may feel this is the final goal and therefore you may stop. Not wanting to proceed further, you won't feel like moving. It is like a 'mini-liberation state,' a kind of imitation. You may even feel that you have reached the goal, that you have attained Realization.

"When you think that you have attained Realization, the very worst will start happening. Slowly and furtively the ego will enter. You won't see him coming in. You won't recognize him, and even if you do recognize him, you won't care because you will be so enamored of the idea that you are truly realized. Thus you will try to overlook his trickery. Or you may feel, 'This is how it is after Realization.' So you start enjoying old habits and indulging in old pleasures, and so you fall back into the world.

"Children, you don't have any idea about how life will be after Realization because you are not realized. As far as you are concerned, the state is totally unknown. You are simply assuming that you are realized, but there is no ground for this assumption. A sadhak who makes this assumption, who feels he is already realized, is wrong. There are no feelings in that state. Even the thought 'I have reached' will not exist. However, if you feel this, then that is another thought which will block your path. You have not yet attained the state of Perfection, for Truth is far beyond. But to convince you of this, to show you the Truth, a Satguru is needed. The Guru's grace is absolutely necessary.

"The Guru knows all there is to know. He knows that what you see and what you hear are just illusions. He makes you understand this so that you do not get trapped thinking that what you perceive is reality. He constantly encourages and inspires you to go further and further beyond the jungles

of illusion until you reach the shore of enlightenment.

“Along the spiritual journey, there will come a time when your growth becomes spontaneous. You may not know that you are growing within, but the Guru will know. To reach this stage of spontaneous growth requires much self-effort. It is like shooting a rocket into space. A lot of human effort and fuel is needed to shoot a rocket beyond the earth’s gravity. Once it is beyond the gravitational force of the earth the upward movement becomes automatic, and then it can go into the orbit of another planet.

“Likewise, the sadhak needs to put forth a great amount of self-effort until he reaches the stage of spontaneous growth. Once he enters that stage, inner transformation will happen effortlessly, even without his own knowledge. But the Guru knows because it is he who has taken the sadhak into that realm. It is the Guru who showered the grace on him to take the final leap.

“The final push into that stage of spontaneous growth cannot happen without the help of the Guru. He is the only one who knows that spontaneous growth is taking place and that the final attainment will be achieved soon. He knows that his grace is already flowing toward the sadhak and that it will bear fruit without much delay. For the sadhak, this period may be like a waiting period because he is not aware of the inner transformation that is taking place. He does not know that the Guru has bestowed his grace upon him. As far as the sadhak is concerned, this is a time when all conscious effort stops. He can do nothing but wait. Then all of a sudden, it happens, the inner awakening. Even without his own knowledge, the grace bestowed by the Guru takes him there. Out of nowhere it happens. Grace comes out of nowhere. It can happen at anytime, at any place.

“The Satguru’s grace is what’s needed the most. Without his loving care, compassionate glances and affectionate touch, one cannot reach the goal. With each compassionate glance and touch, he is sending forth his grace. Therefore, children, pray for his grace.”

It was time for the Tamil devotees to leave. One by one they went up to Amma and prostrated. The devotee who was madly devoted to Amma chanted a Tamil verse glorifying the Divine Mother. It was a poem by a poet named Maanikkavaachakar:

*You bestowed on me a grace undeserved
and enabled this slave’s body and soul
to joyfully thaw and melt with love.
For this I have nothing to give in return,
O Emancipator pervading the past,
the future and every thing!
O Infinite Primal Being. . .*

When he had finished the verse, he prostrated at Her Feet. Amma expressed Her love and concern for each one of the Tamil devotees in a very distinct way. When one of the devotees was about to touch Amma’s feet, She caught hold of both his hands and told him in a voice full of authority, “Tell your teacher that if it is his view that all old concepts of spirituality should die, he should not even study the scriptures because those are all old concepts written by the ancient rishis, aren’t they? Remind him that by asking people not to follow a Guru he himself is becoming a Guru. Also ask him to be humble. Tell him that he is trying to hear

music only by placing the sheet music to his ears. He is like one who is trying to bathe or swim in a picture of a river.”

Hearing Amma’s words, the Tamil devotee was stunned. There was an obvious look of wonder on his face. Amma still held both his hands. All of a sudden, the devotee burst into tears, placing Amma’s hands on his face. Amma sat with a mischievous smile on Her face. The devotee remained in that position for some time and kept crying. At last Amma consoled him saying, “Don’t worry. Amma was simply joking. Don’t take it seriously.”

The devotee now raised his head and said, “No, no. You are not joking. Why do you say that? Now after meeting you and hearing these words directly from you, how can I believe that you are joking? No, you cannot be joking. What you said is the truth. He is very egotistic. But my firm conviction is that he will be humbled when he hears your remarks.” Amma smiled. There was hidden meaning in Her smile.

Before the Tamil devotee left the Ashram, one of the brahmacharins who was curious to know more about that incident, approached the devotee and expressed his wish to him. This is what he told him.

The Tamil devotee had a teacher who taught him the scriptures. This man had a lot of bookish knowledge and thought very highly of himself and of his ability to teach spirituality through the scriptures. His dictum was, “Study of the scriptures is enough. Meditation and devotional singing and other spiritual practices are not of much use. They are all old concepts. It is high time to die to the old and have a new vision of spirituality.” He was also opposed to following a Guru. When this man heard that his student was going

to see a great saint in Kerala, his doubting and argumentative mind started functioning. He summoned his student and said, "I have heard that you were going to have the darshan of a so-called 'great saint' in Kerala. I have also heard that She is all-knowing, that She knows the past, present and future. Of course, I do not believe that. But still, if this is true, let Her prove Her omniscience. Let Her give me a sign, a message or something to prove that She is all-knowing. If She does that, I too will go to see Her."

So when this devotee who was a student of that scholar was about to leave after having sat in Amma's presence, he felt some disappointment. Though his personal experience with Amma was very elevating, She had not said one word or even given a hint about his teacher, who was anxiously waiting for proof. At last, when Amma finally disclosed it at such an unexpected moment, he was stunned and grateful at the same time and could not control his emotions. Tears still welled up in his eyes as he was leaving the Ashram.

Amma's remarks hit the target. After receiving the proof he had asked for, the scholar came to Amma. Even though he himself had a number of admirers and followers, the man became a devotee of Amma.

A GURU'S WARNING

When the Tamil devotee left, Amma called one of the brahmacharins and scolded him for his disobedience. One of the elder brahmacharins had asked him to do a particular job, but he simply refused. When the elder asked why, the younger replied, "I have no time. There is no other explanation for it." The elder brahmacharin reported this matter

to Amma, and now the one at fault was being scolded. In being scolded by Amma, one also gets some good advice. As Amma was talking to him, pointing out his errors, She said, “You are very egotistic.”

This brahmacharin was occasionally very stubborn and argumentative. He retorted, “Then why did you take me as a brahmacharin if you knew that I was very egotistic?”

Amma’s compassionate answer flowed, “Why did Jesus Christ accept Judas as His disciple? Didn’t He know that Judas was going to betray Him, that he was going to lead Him to His death? Yes, Jesus knew that very well. Nevertheless, Jesus accepted Judas as one of His disciples. He loved him just as He loved the others.

“Didn’t the great saints and sages of the past consciously give opportunities to those who cheated them later? Mahatmas are like that. They cannot be otherwise. They don’t think about or care whether somebody will cheat them or love them or whether someone will be egoistic. They don’t expect anything from anyone. They are just there. Anybody who is willing, who is ready to open his or her heart, and who is ready to surrender, can benefit from their presence. Opportunities are open to everyone. Mahatmas don’t differentiate. They cannot do that. Even if someone is a cheat or is very egoistic, if he or she surrenders only for a few days or a few minutes—the time does not matter—their surrender for that much time will have its benefit.

“After that, if the person withdraws himself, what can the Mahatma do? The Mahatma cannot do anything. He simply is. If you want him, he is available—all the time, everywhere. If you do not want him, he is still there available to anyone else. But if you reject him, he cannot force himself on you. That is one thing he cannot do.

“However, if you surrender, he will flow into your heart. When only a small portion of your heart is filled with the Guru, the larger, unfilled portion will still be under the influence of the ego saying, ‘I am something.’ That small filled portion will still remain. It will work. That part of you will have its power. That part will try to save you. You will feel it. But remember now, it is only a little filled while a big portion remains unfilled. That bigger portion is filled with ‘I am something.’

“Children, the danger comes when you totally neglect the small filled portion, not even looking toward that side. If you can throw a glance to that side, the side where the Guru is, you will still have hope. You can still be saved. But the ego, which covers the bigger portion, completely neglects him. The Guru will warn you, not once, but a hundred times he’ll instruct you and give hints to you. But if you completely shut the door, if you bang the door right in his face, what can he do? Then the pressure or the pull of ‘I am something’ becomes stronger in you, and you naturally move to that side. Of course, that is easier. To move to the Guru’s side needs a little more effort, a little more courage.

“The government and the university provide equal opportunities to all students, but the students utilize these opportunities differently. The same analogy can be made about people who desire spirituality. Many are interested in spirituality, but only a few will ‘make the grade,’ so to speak. Merely being interested is not sufficient. Intensity is what is needed. It is not the Guru’s fault. A Satguru cannot be wrong. He can only be right. You are wrong. We are like a musical instrument that is off-key. The Guru wants to repair the keys that are off. But if you protest, if you strongly feel you are all right, if you think there is no problem with you,

that the 'off key' is all right because you don't hear it as being 'off,' then what can the Guru do? In order to make the keys sound more pleasant to the ears, a little scratching, scrubbing, scraping and removing is needed. You should be able to bear the pain caused by this, understanding its purpose is to make your life harmonious, as in a musical concert.

"Amma is crazy, but Her craziness is for Truth and dharma. If somebody moves against Truth, if he is not at all ready to mend his ways, if he is determined to do things his own way, then he is going away from Amma. He is moving away from Truth and dharma. Remember, Amma is not going away from him; She cannot. But he, through his own actions and thoughts, is creating a gulf between Amma and him. Once that happens, the gap becomes wider and wider.

"Amma cannot accept or reject anyone. Acceptance and rejection are possible only when there is ego. The ego can accept and reject. When one becomes egoless, one goes beyond both. Therefore, it is you who accept and reject. Amma cannot. However, there is one thing that you should keep in mind. Your goal is to reach the state of Perfection. Now the question is whether you really want it or not. Sometimes 'yes' and sometimes 'no' is out of the question. If this is your attitude, then this is not your place. There is no such thing as vacillation in spirituality. There is either 'yes' or 'no.' That is it. If you feel spiritual sometimes and non-spiritual at other times, that is not spirituality. What Amma means is that your mind should be fixed on That, i.e., the goal. There ought to be no distractions. It is dangerous if you simply let yourself be carried away by circumstantial distractions. Since your main purpose in life is to realize God, the awareness of the goal and intent to reach it, otherwise known as lakshya bodha, should always be present.

“Suppose you are an executive. When you sit in your chair at the office, your entire thought process should be focused on how to manage the company—how to make more profit, how to solve the employees’ problems and how to create a good market for your products. That is your dharma while you are at the office. You are not supposed to be thinking about your family and its problems at that time. That is your dharma when you are at home. If you think about your home while sitting in the office, then the whole purpose of your job as an executive is not being carried out properly. And vice versa, if you think and act like a executive at home, instead of being a husband and father, you are not fulfilling your duties. Likewise, when you are here in the Ashram as a brahmacharin or one who aspires to become a brahmacharin, you are supposed to act and think in a certain way. If you cannot have the proper attitude, you won’t fit in here. You will start feeling the gulf, the gap which will finally result in a lot of problems in your spiritual life.

“Amma will constantly create circumstances which will help your spiritual growth. She can pardon and forget a hundred times or more. But if you constantly struggle and pull your hands away from Amma’s, you cannot blame Her.”

FORGET THE PAST

Friday, 10 August, 1984

At about eleven o’clock in the morning Amma was sitting on Her cot which was kept outside on the south side of the Ashram. She was surrounded by Western and Indian devotees. A question was raised by one of the Western devotees, “Many

people doubt that they can meditate on God and realize Him because they feel they have committed too many sins that will prevent them from God-realization. They feel that they will not receive God's grace."

Amma's reply was immediate, "There is no basis for such doubts and worries. Once determination and detachment arise, the past becomes ineffective. The past loses its grip on a person who has surrendered everything at the Feet of the Lord. Such a person glides into a forgetful state about his entire past, and he starts living in the beautiful present where he sees only the Lord and His Enchanting Form. The fearful dreams about the past completely die in a surrendered soul, and he will definitely feel God's grace guiding him throughout.

"Amma will tell you a story to illustrate how the Lord's grace is absolutely available for everyone, even for people who have committed serious errors.

"One night a notorious thief was scouting about to find a suitable house to burglarize. As he furtively walked down the road unnoticed by anyone, he saw a gathering by the roadside of people listening intently to one man who was obviously a storyteller. This storyteller was narrating the childhood sports of Lord Krishna as depicted in the Srimad Bhagavatam. The description of Baby Krishna attracted the attention of the thief. The narrator expounded the Child's beauty, 'Thus Yasoda, Krishna's foster mother, after having bathed the endearing Child of Vrindavan, adorned Him, the All-alluring One, with sparkling jewels. Necklaces studded with diamonds, emeralds and rubies graced His neck, and a golden crown embedded with precious gems adorned the Lord's radiant head. Jangling anklets rang like bells on His feet, accompanied by the melodic tinkling of the golden chain

encircling His waist. As Yasoda was further enhancing Krishna's already enchanting Form with ornaments, the Child playfully ran away and hid behind a tree. Yasoda ran after the Boy, calling and calling Him with overflowing love and affection, "Kanna, Kanna".' "

As She said the last sentence, Amma became so identified with the narration that She began gesturing with Her hands. It was as if Krishna were standing right in front of Her. Even Her facial expression bore that love and affection which Yasoda had for Child Krishna. At this point, Amma became intoxicated with pure love and sat still. Tears streamed down Her cheeks as She uttered a laugh every now and then. This state continued for some time; then after a while Amma resumed telling the story.

"As the thief was listening to the story, he was suddenly struck with an idea, 'This Child must be a rich man's son. I must somehow find out where this Baby lives. If I can get hold of this Little One, that would be the end of all my troubles. The precious stones and golden jewelry on this Child are enough for my family and me to live on for the rest of our lives.' So he waited until the narration came to its completion and the storyteller packed up to go. The thief followed him cautiously at some distance until they reached a lonely spot when he suddenly jumped upon the storyteller. Holding him by the neck, the thief threatened, 'Tell me where that Child lives. Where is this place called Vrindavan? Don't try to play any tricks. Tell me the truth. Give me the details of how to get to His house or prepare to die.'

"The storyteller was so shocked he could not speak at all. On the further nudging and threats of the thief, he finally

said, 'That was only a story. The Child isn't real. It is only a fabricated tale. It is not a real story.' But the thief was not going to give up so easily. 'Speak the truth,' he said, 'I know you're lying. How can you describe the child so precisely if he never existed? Open your mouth and speak or you're going to die.'

"The storyteller tried and tried to convince the thief that the description was only from a story, explaining that the elaborate portrayal was only to entertain people's vivid imagination, that it was not reality. But the thief had no doubts about the existence of Baby Krishna and was determined to find this Child. At last, the storyteller thought of a place where there were no human beings or houses but only dense forest. Hoping to get rid of the thief, he told him that Krishna dwelled in this remote place, thinking that the thief would become prey to wild animals in that forest. Taking note of the details of how to get there, the thief released the storyteller, giving him a final warning that if he did not find the Child, he would return and put an end to the storyteller's life.

"Proceeding toward the place indicated by the storyteller, the thief walked rapidly with determination for three days, not stopping to eat or sleep. Along the entire way the thief thought of Krishna and the great fortune that he was going to have. Though with a different intention, in fact, an intention of misdemeanor, his mind was nonetheless totally fixed on the Lord's beautiful form. It took a couple of days for him to reach his destination and by the time he reached the forest, he was totally exhausted. Both feet were bleeding, for they had been punctured by thorns and sharp rocks.

"But the thief was still full of hope because the storyteller

had told him Krishna would come if a person called to Him. He had also been told that Krishna and his playmates would usually come to that forest with their cows, and they would frolic about, while the cattle grazed. When the thief did not see anyone, he called and called, his voice ringing throughout the forest, 'Krishna! Krishna! Where are you?' Wandering in search of the Child, he looked in the bushes and behind huge trees. He even climbed to the tops of trees in order to get a higher vantage point to see if Krishna were anywhere else in the forest. As he continued to roam the forest calling out 'Krishna,' his search reached a climax of intensity and desperation. Finally, from lack of food and sleep, he collapsed into unconsciousness. Yet even in this unconscious state he continued to murmur Krishna's name.

"Upon regaining normal consciousness, the thief found himself on someone's lap. Someone was holding and stroking his head and a voice said, "You are exhausted. Here, I've brought you some food." He looked up and was astonished to see before him none other than the Child for whom he had been searching. It was Krishna! And he was lying on His lap. He rubbed his eyes and blinked several times; he could not believe what he was seeing. Yes, it was Krishna. . . there was the peacock feather. . . the curly hair, the golden crown, the yellow robe adorned with precious jewels. He was captivated by the all-alluring smile and the dark blue complexion of His face. His eyes were transfixed, for he was unable to take them off of Krishna's glorious countenance. As the Child fed him, he automatically opened his mouth and swallowed the food. Oblivious to everything else around him, he languished in bliss.

"Krishna helped him sit up on his own. Next He removed

all His ornaments, wrapped them up and handed them in one bundle to the thief, telling him, 'Here, this is yours. This is what you came for, wasn't it. So now you can go. You can return happy.' Still drinking in the eternal beauty of the Lord, the thief was now totally transformed. He chokingly protested, 'No, no! I do not want that. I want You. I want You.' Krishna continued to urge him, 'You should not return empty-handed. You must not be disappointed after such a long search. Take it.' To this the thief replied, 'My dear Krishna, I do not want anything. I want to embrace You. I want to lie on Your lap. I want to look at Your face. I want to be with You forever and forever. Please, Lord. Please...'“

At this point Amma stood up from the cot where She was sitting. Her entire being was transformed into an incomprehensible bhava of Divinity. There was an extraordinary glow and radiance on Her face. The fingers of Her right hand held the chinmudra.* A bewitching smile further enhanced Her already radiant countenance. Someone exclaimed that Amma looked exactly as She did during Krishna Bhava, yet still there was an inexpressible and indescribable feeling about this present state of Hers. Her body gently swayed from side to side, as a constant and very strong vibration could be detected in Her entire body. The devotees felt very blissful and bathed in supreme devotion.

Seeing the Divine ecstatic mood of Amma, the brahmacharins burst into a song, *Govardhana Giri*. . .

*O You who lifted up Govardhana Hill,
Who play in the hearts of the shepherdesses
Who protect Gokula and indulge in play
Who make the sweet sound on the flute. . .*

*You have danced on the snake Kaliya's head
 In order to dispel fear of him caused by his pride.
 O You who destroy desires and offer desired things
 Please do not delay in coming even for a moment,
 O You with large eyes like lotus petals. . .*

*You are the One who gives the fruits
 Of one's accumulated actions.
 Trying to control the five senses,
 My mind shakes like a peacock feather.
 O Krishna, when will I merge in Your Feet?*

Slowly Amma came back to the physical plane. She still remained standing in the bliss-intoxicated bhava. With faltering steps She moved toward the cot. Drunk with eternal bliss, She looked like one who was completely out of Her body. One of the woman devotees helped Amma sit on the cot. After some time She regained consciousness completely. Reminded by one of the brahmacharins, Amma continued the story. . .

“All right, where were we. . . Oh, yes. Krishna dropped the bundle in front of him and disappeared. Mad with love, the thief ran hither and thither, calling out, ‘O Krishna, where are You? Don’t leave me. Take me with You. My Lord, come back, come back.’ “

It was quite obvious that Amma was struggling hard to keep Herself down on the physical plane. Pausing every now and then, Amma continued to tell the story.

“However, Krishna did not reveal His physical form to

the thief again. Unable to bear the excruciating pain of separation, the thief wandered and wandered in the forest calling for Krishna. Days passed and he dejectedly retraced his steps home, carefully cherishing the bundle containing the jewelry which belonged to His Lord.

“Still tightly embracing the bundle, he reached the storyteller’s house and knocked on the door. Peeping through the window, the storyteller recognized the thief and was frightened. Filled with fear, he was sure the thief had returned to ‘finish him off’ because he had not found Krishna, the Blue Boy of Vrindavan. As the knocking on the door continued, the trembling of the man in the house increased. But had he listened carefully, he could have heard the thief say in a feeble voice, “I have seen the Lord, my Krishna. I have seen my Lord. . .” Knowing the fierce reputation of the thief, he was afraid that if he did not open the door, the thief would break it down and kill him anyway. So he opened the door and stood there frozen with his eyes closed, expecting to feel a sharp razor’s edge slitting his throat.

“Nothing happened. He opened his eyes and saw the notorious thief lying in full prostration at his feet. Perplexed, the storyteller exclaimed, ‘What is this? What in the world is happening?’ The thief raised himself up and placed the bundle at the storyteller’s feet. Through tears the thief said, ‘I have seen the Lord, my Krishna. He gave all His ornaments to me, but I do not want any of them. They belong to you, you who inspired me to long to see my Lord. You are my Guru. Receive this and bless me.’

“Upon hearing this story which sounded utterly crazy to him, the storyteller was taken aback. He suspected that this thief, a great sinner, must have killed an innocent child

and taken all his jewelry. When he exclaimed something to this effect, the thief swore that he had seen the Lord, that the Lord had placed his head on His lap and fed him with His very own hands. He further described how Krishna played such haunting melodies on His divine flute. As the storyteller listened to the thief, he noticed the ecstatic mood, the blissful tears and the excitement in his voice and thus felt something special in the man. His curiosity aroused, he opened the bundle and was absolutely amazed. Blinking several times and rubbing his eyes over and over again, he could not believe what he saw. It did not take him long to realize that these were indeed Krishna's ornaments and the thief really had had a vision of the Lord. Eyes filled with tears and a heart filled with intense longing, the storyteller called out, 'Krishna! Krishna. . . Am I a greater sinner than this thief?' He ran out of the house and disappeared.

"Forgoing food and sleep for several days, the storyteller reached the same spot where he had sent the thief. He fainted and regained consciousness several times over and over again. Each time he came back to normal consciousness, he ran about calling, 'Krishna, am I not worthy to behold your Divine Form? I have been singing Your glories for the last thirty years. What greater merit did the thief have to behold Your Divine Form than killing people and stealing their possessions?' Such were the prayers and supplications of the storyteller. But the Lord did not reveal Himself to the storyteller. Immensely disappointed, the storyteller decided to commit suicide. Without having the vision of the Lord, he found no meaning in life. Now considering how fortunate the thief was to behold the Lord's enchanting form, he lost all ill feeling he had had toward the thief. But his own sincere

wish to see the Lord remained unfulfilled. Greatly pained at heart, the storyteller removed his upper garment and tied one end around the branch of a tree. He climbed the tree and tied the other end around his neck. He was about to jump and hang himself when all of a sudden he heard a voice from the sky.

“It said, ‘You are also very dear to Me. Console yourself. I am pleased with you, but I am not revealing My Form to you right now. Listen to Me. You wanted to know what merit the thief had to be awarded My physical presence? It was nothing but his unconditional faith that I am a reality and not just an imagination. Immediately when he heard you describe My Form, he believed that I was alive in body. He had no doubt I was a reality and was determined to see Me. His determination to see Me was so strong that it had all the qualities of real tapas. Then once he saw Me, he became mad with love. However, for you I was only a fabricated tale and not a reality. Out of fear you were even ready to deny My existence. Where there is fear, I am not. Where there is faith, there is no fear. You had no faith. But the thief had unconditional faith about My existence and about Me as a reality. It was almost mechanical for you to tell My stories and sing My glories. You never felt the longing and the desperation to see Me. At twelve o’clock sharp you wanted to eat your lunch. At eight ‘on the nose’ you wanted your supper and promptly at ten you went to bed—very scheduled. The thief was not like this! He forgot everything else and constantly remembered Me till he saw Me. Now be content with hearing My voice. I will bestow the blessing of appearing before you during this lifetime, but until then, go spread my message with love and devotion. It will help

many other thieves, sinners and nonbelievers change their ways and become benefactors of the world.'

"Therefore, children, do not think about your dark past. Try to be determined and detached. It doesn't matter whether you were a thief or a great sinner. The Lord doesn't care about your past, provided you have determination and detachment in the present."

THE WONDERFUL HEALING TOUCH OF AMMA

Wednesday, 15, August 1984

In the evening at about five o'clock, a family consisting of father, mother and son came to see Amma. Their son, G., a young man about eighteen years old, joyfully ran up to Br. Balu, who was standing near the backwaters. In a few moments, his father and mother came up to join them, and the family was happily talking to Balu. Seeing their pleasant and joyful mood, Balu thought, "What a tremendous transformation that's happened in their lives in the last year and a half. When they first came here, all three of them were so exhausted and drained of life. They were like corpses. Now they are cheerful with smiling faces."

This family had previously had another son besides G. The parents had been delighted in their happy family of four. The two brothers were very loving and attached to each other. G., the elder brother, always cherished and supported his younger brother, J., even though the latter was a little mischievous at times. Their love for each other was

extraordinary, and they never quarreled. G. was fifteen, J. was thirteen, and they were always together. The parents were very pleased and proud of their children's concern for each other. If J. had a problem, G. sincerely tried to sort it out through his loving and affectionate ways. If J. were sick, G. would always sit by his side, tending to his needs and giving him medicine at the appropriate time. If J. did not eat, G. would refuse to eat; and vice versa. It was a strong and unusual bond which existed between the two brothers. But cruel fate did not let this last long.

One day, before the family met Amma, the younger one suddenly fell dead while playing with his brother. Later it was discovered that the cause of death was an embolism in the brain. The death occurred right in front of G.'s eyes. The boy was immediately taken to the hospital, but all was in vain. The entire family was plunged into deep sorrow. The death of his dear brother was such a shock to G. that he lapsed into unconsciousness and remained for several days in a coma. As he lay in the intensive care unit of the hospital, the parents were very worried. They were afraid that they would lose G., too. Finally, one day he opened his eyes and the parents rejoiced. But such happiness was short-lived because G. never came back to his normal self.

Although G. was alive, he was like a vegetable. He slept, but he hardly ate anything. He never talked or smiled. The boy became gaunt like a skeleton. Two years passed like this following the death of his brother. During these two years the parents tried everything—the best medical specialists were consulted; they tried various methods of therapy and different medication was administered to try to bring their boy back to normal. But all their attempts ended in failure. G. would not even blink his eyes. The despairing parents

lost all hope and lived in utter hopelessness and frustration.

While the parents were leading such a life of sorrow and despair, the mother had a dream one night in which she saw a lady in white who was lovingly soothing and rubbing her son's forehead. There was a divine glow around the lady and Her compassionate smile had the power to remove all worries and wounds caused by the past. As She rubbed the boy's forehead, the lady in white called him with overflowing compassion and love, "Son. . . my son. . . Mother's darling son. . . my child. . . Look here, this is your Mother calling you." These words had a wonderful effect on the boy; he looked up at the lady's glowing face and smiled for the first time in two years. His own face was completely changed and he returned to normal. The parent's happiness knew no bounds as the mother cried and laughed out of joy. She was still in this state when her husband awoke her from her dream. Realizing that it was all a dream, the mother sobbed uncontrollably. She related the dream to her husband. Neither of them gave much thought to the dream, but the mother began to have the same dream over and over again the following nights. Since this recurring dream was happening every night, both the husband and wife began to give serious thought to it.

Because Amma was not as well known then as She became later, they were not able to find out who the lady in white was. One day as they were returning home after visiting relatives, they were waiting at a railway station to catch the next train to their town. The mother was sitting next to another woman, and after a while this woman, who was a total stranger, turned to her and spoke, "Something inside tells me that I should speak to you about Mother." The woman was Amma's devotee, and she began speaking to G.'s mother

about Amma. As if she were possessed, the woman told her all about the different experiences she had had with Amma. As the woman continued speaking, the face of G.'s mother blossomed with joy. The latter realized that this woman was talking about none other than the lady in white of her dreams.

She now told the woman about what her family had been undergoing the last two years and further disclosed the recurring dream about the lady in white and that she and her husband had been trying to discover who the lady was and where they could find her, or if she even existed at all. Both the husband and wife were very happy to finally learn who Amma was and they decided to go to Mother's Ashram the very next day. As they boarded the train to their home, they began to wonder how the strange woman was inspired to talk to them about Amma for no particular reason. Had their son been with them, the woman would have seen how he looked and thus might have felt that they should take the boy to see Amma to be healed. But they did not bring the boy on this trip, having left him in the care of his aunt. Anyhow, they concluded, God's ways are incomprehensible to the human intellect.

The three of them—husband, wife and son—came to the Ashram in the morning around ten o'clock. Amma was already in the hut giving darshan. Just as they arrived and were standing in front of the temple, Br. Balu approached them and said, "Amma is calling you. Please come in." They were again surprised. Who had told Her that they were there? The family was led to Amma.

Amma smilingly said to them, "Mother was waiting for you; She knew you would come today." Amma then caught hold of the boy's hand and with a glowing smile on Her face, rubbed and soothed the boy's forehead, saying to him,

“Son. . . my son. . . Look here, this is your Mother calling you. . .” Hearing these words, the boy slowly raised his head and gazed at the glowing, radiant face of Amma and smiled for the first time in two years. His face was completely changed; he looked as if he were coming back to normal.

The mother of the boy, who was intently watching the entire scene, cried uncontrollably and laughed out of joy. The father silently shed tears of joy. What they had just witnessed was the same scene that the boy’s mother had seen in her dreams night after night. Words are inadequate to express their happiness. Later, before leaving the Ashram, the woman and her husband said, “Now we know. We have no doubts that it was all a divine drama conducted by Amma.”

Day by day the boy’s health and mental state improved. In a period of two months, he completely recovered from his sickness and regained his normal state of health.

While the family was still talking to Balu, Amma came down the stairs. Seeing Amma, the family rushed toward Her, calling out, “Amma, Amma!” Mother exclaimed, “Ah, children, when did you come?” She sat down on the bottom step, and after prostrating, the three gathered around Her. Amma’s compassion overflowed toward them through Her loving hugs and caresses. Her soothing words of concern went directly to their hearts, and Her easy, relaxed manner made them so comfortable that they were all laughing and rejoicing together. At last G. began singing a song to Amma, and the parents joined in. Hearts filled with devotion, they all sang together *Arikil undenkilum*. . .

*O Mother, even though You are near
I wander alone unable to know You,*

*Even though I have eyes
I still search, unable to see You.*

*Aren't You the beautiful moon
That blooms forth in the blue winter night?
I am like a wave that beats its head on the shore
Unable to reach the sky.
Upon understanding the Truth
That all worldly comforts are worthless,
I long to know You
As I shed tears day and night.*

*Oh, won't You come and comfort one
Who is so weary of the burden of sorrow?
With the desire that You will come,
I am always waiting.*

At the end of the song all three burst into tears. As Mother wiped their tears with Her own hands, a loving and compassionate smile radiated from Her face. At Her feet sat the father, the mother and their son, each being caressed by the firm gentle strokes of Amma's hands. This touching scene with the family seemed to have a timeless quality about it. There sat the Eternal Mother, majestic yet welcoming all Her children. Though the day was drawing to a close, the small family was blissfully rejoicing at the dawn of Amma, the spiritual sun, in their lives.



G L O S S A R Y

{Certain words are the same or similar in Malayalam and Sanskrit. Thus ashrama and brahmacharin are Sanskrit whereas ashramam and brahmachari are Malayalam}

ADHARMA: Unrighteousness, sin, opposed to Divine Harmony.

AGAMAS: Scriptures.

AMMACHI: Mother. Chi is a word indicating respect.

ANOOORANIYAAN MAHATOMAHYAN: Sanskrit for “Subtler than the subtlest, bigger than the biggest,” a description of Brahman, the Supreme Reality.

ARATI: Waving the burning camphor, which leaves no residue, with ringing of bells at the end of puja (worship) indicating total annihilation of ego.

ARCHANA: A mode of worship by repetition of one hundred, three hundred or a thousand names of the deity.

ARJUNA: The third among the Pandavas and a great archer.

ASHRAMAM: Hermitage or residence of a sage.

ATMA(N): The Self

ATMA BODHA: Self-knowledge or Self-awareness

AVADHUT(A): A Realized Soul who has transcended all social conventions.

BHAGAVAD GITA: The teachings of Lord Krishna to Arjuna at the beginning of the Mahabharata War. It is a practical guide for common man for every day life and is the essence of Vedic wisdom. Bhagavad means ‘that of the Lord’ and Gita means ‘Song’, particularly, an advice.

BHAGAVATA(M): The book about the Incarnations of Lord

Vishnu, especially Krishna and His childhood antics. It upholds the supremacy of devotion.

BHAGAVATI: The Goddess of six virtues, viz, prosperity, valor, auspiciousness, knowledge, dispassion and lordship.

BHAJAN: Devotional singing

BHAKTI: Devotion.

BHAVA: Mood.

BHAVA DARSHAN: The occasion when Amma receives devotees in the exalted state of the Universal Mother.

BHRANTAN: Having the nature of a madman, alluding to the nature or appearance of some Realized Souls.

BRAHMAN(M): The Absolute, Whole.

BRAHMACHARI(N): A celibate student under training of a Guru.

BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy

DAKSHINA: Reverential offering in cash or kind.

DARSHAN: Audience of a Holy Person or deity.

DEVA(TA): Demi-god, celestial being

DEVI: The Goddess.

DEVI BHAVA: Divine Mood of, or identity with, the Goddess

DEVI MAHATMYAM: A sacred hymn in praise of the Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness, in accordance with Divine Harmony.

DHRITHARASTHRA: Blind king and father of the Kauravas.

DURYODHANA: Eldest son of Dhritharasthra, villain of the Mahabharata War.

GITA: Song, See Bhagavad Gita

GOPA(s): Cowherd boy(s), companions of Sri Krishna.

GOPI(s): Cowherd girl(s), known for their supreme devotion to Sri Krishna.

GURU: Spiritual Master / Guide.

GURU PADUKA STOTRAM: Hymn of Five Verses to the Guru's Sandals.

JAGAT: The ever-changing world.
 JAPA: Repetition of a mystical formula (mantra)
 JÑANA: Spiritual or divine wisdom
 KAMSA: Lord Krishna's demonic uncle whom He killed.
 KANJI: Rice porridge.
 KANNA: Name for Krishna.
 KARMA: Action.
 KAURAVA(S): The hundred children of Dhritarashtra, enemies of the Pandavas, who fought in the Mahabharata War.
 KINDI: Fluted metallic water pot usually used in worship.
 KIRTAN(AM): Hymns
 KRISHNA: Principle Incarnation of Lord Vishnu
 LAKSHMANA: Brother of Lord Rama.
 LAKSHMI: Consort of Lord Vishnu and Goddess of wealth.
 LAKSHYA BODHA: Constant awareness of and intent on the goal.
 LALITA SAHASRANAMA: Thousand names of the Universal Mother in the form of Lalitambika
 LEELA: Divine play.
 MAHABHARATA(M): Great epic written by Vyasa.
 MAHATMA: Great Soul
 MANTRA: Sacred formula, the repetition of which can awaken one's spiritual energies and bring the desired results.
 MAYA: Illusion.
 MOL(E): Daughter. Mole is the vocative form.
 MON(E): Son. Mone is the vocative form
 MUDRA: A sign by hand indicating mystic spiritual truths.
 MUKTA: The Liberated One
 MUKTI: Liberation.
 NAMAH SHIVAYA: The Panchakshara Mantra (mantra consisting of five letters) meaning "Salutations to the Auspicious One (Shiva)." 

OM: Mystical syllable representing the Supreme Reality.

PANDAVA(S): The five children of King Pandu and heroes of the epic Mahabharata

PRARABDHA: Responsibilities or burdens. Also, the fruits of past actions manifesting as the present life.

PRASAD(AM): Consecrated offerings distributed after puja.

PREMA: Deep Love.

PUJA: Worship.

RAMA: Hero of the epic Ramayana. An incarnation of Vishnu and the ideal of Righteousness.

RAVANA: The villain of the Ramayana

RISHI: A great sage or seer.

SAD-ASAD-RUPA DHARINI: One who dons the form of existence and non-existence, a name of the Divine Mother.

SADHAK(AN): One dedicated to attaining the spiritual goal, one who practices sadhana (spiritual discipline).

SADHANA: Spiritual practices.

SAHASRANAMA: Hymns consisting of the Thousand Names of God.

SAMADHI: State of absorption in the Self.

SAMSARA: The world of plurality, the cycle of birth and death.

SAMSKARAS: Mental tendencies accumulated from past actions.

SANKALPA: Creative, integral resolve manifesting as thought, feeling and action. The sankalpa of an ordinary person does not always bear corresponding fruit. The sankalpa of a sage, however, always bears the intended result.

SANNYASI(N): Ascetic who has renounced all worldly bondages.

SATGURU: Realized Spiritual Master.

SATSANG: Company of the wise and virtuous. Also, a spiritual discourse by a sage or scholar.

SHAKTI: The dynamic aspect of Brahman as the Universal Mother.

SHIVA: The static aspect of Brahman as the male principle.

SISHYA: Disciple.

SITA: Wife of Rama.

SLOKA: Sanskrit verse.

SRADDHA: Faith. Amma uses it with a special emphasis on alertness coupled with loving care of the work in hand.

SRI RAMA: See Rama. Sree, or Sri, is a mark of respect

SRIMAD BHAGAVATAM: See Bhagavatam. Srimad means 'auspicious'

STENAH: Thief.

SUTRA: Aphorism.

TAPAS: Literally "heat." The practice of spiritual austerities.

TAPASVI: One engaged in penance or spiritual austerities.

TAPOVAN(AM): Hermitage, a place conducive to meditation and tapas.

TATTVA: Principle.

UPANISHADS: The concluding portion of the Vedas dealing with the philosophy of Non-dualism.

VASANA: Latent tendency.

VEDA: Lit. 'Knowledge', the authoritative Scriptures of the Hindus.

VEDA VYASA: See Vyasa. As he divided the one Veda into four, he is also known by the name of Veda Vyasa

VEDANTA(M): The philosophy of the Upanishads which declare the Ultimate Truth as 'One without a Second.'

VEDANTIN: A follower of the Vedanta philosophy.

VEDIC DHARMA: Injunctions on the righteous way of living as prescribed by the Vedas.

VIDYAVIDYA SVARUPINI: Whose nature is knowledge and ignorance, a name of the Divine Mother.

VISHNU: All-pervading. The Lord of sustenance.

VYASA: A sage who divided the one Veda into four and composed 18 Puranas and also the Mahabharata and Bhagavatam.

NOTES

¹ When Sri Rama, an incarnation of Lord Vishnu, reached the ocean and wanted to cross over to Landka to rescue his divine consort, Sita, he prayed to the ocean god to give him passage. Met with indifference, he finally threatened the god who then appeared and gave him passage, and requested that he build a bridge across the water..

² In order to humble the proud king of the gods, Indra, Sri Krishna ordered that the annual worship of Indra by the cowherds be offered instead to the mountain, Govardhana. Enraged by this, Indra created torrents of rain to destroy the villagers and their cows. To protect them, Lord Krishna lifted up the mountain and held it aloft on His little finger for seven days and seven nights, during which everyone stayed protected underneath. This is how he got the name, "Govardhana Giridhari," which means, "He who held the hill, Govardhana, aloft.

³ A Self-realized soul who has transcended all social conventions.

CHAPTER ONE

The Amritapuri Ashram lies on a narrow peninsula off the southwest coast of India. Bordered by the Arabian Sea on one side, and Kerala's famous backwaters on the other, Mother's Ashram has today become popular even among those who pass by on the daily backwaters tours. When it was first registered in 1981, the Ashram consisted of just the small plot of land which was Mother's family's property. Where the colorful temple now towers above the coconut palms, and hundreds of devotees and disciples live permanently, there was only a handful of residents living in a group of huts near the small temple that still stands today. In those days the residents enjoyed very few luxuries or amenities, but no one seemed to mind; the loving presence of the Divine Mother created a safe and solid haven.

A GREAT HEALER OF HEARTS

Monday, 16 July, 1984

A man who was mentally ill came to the Ashram, escorted by his family. He was screaming and shouting as he arrived. He cried and then he laughed. One moment he made strange, contradictory statements, the next

moment he cried aloud, running about erratically. His wife and older brother followed him at all times, watching carefully that he came to no harm. It was obvious that the man was experiencing deep mental agony and pain. His family cried, helpless to ease the pathetic condition of their loved one. Before coming to see Mother, the family had tried several medical treatments, but the young man's condition persisted. Having heard about Mother from a distant relative, they decided to come and see Her with the hope that She could help their son. This was their first visit to the Ashram.

The entire family waited for Mother at the bottom of the staircase leading to Her room. Because She was expected soon, they held on tightly to the sick man to prevent him from running away. He kept on laughing, crying and muttering to himself. At last Mother came down. Bursting into tears, the man's mother and his young wife fell at Mother's feet, and begged Her through their tears to relieve him from his pain. The father explained his son's story to Mother. The young man had lost a great deal of money in a business deal with some unscrupulous people. He had trusted them, and the shock of such a great loss was more than he could bear.

Though his family cried in Mother's presence, the young man was still. At one point he said to Mother quite calmly, "You know, Amma, I lost everything. Can you help me? Can you save me?" Then he began to sob.

As She observed his pitiful state and listened to the man's heart-rending words, Mother's eyes filled with tears. She consoled each member of the family, expressing immense love and compassion for them. Turning towards the mentally ill man, She rubbed his forehead and chest

with the love and care that a mother would show her own child. Placing his head on Her shoulder, Mother said, “Son, don’t worry. Relax. Everything will be all right. Be patient.” For some time Mother continued to rub his back and to soothe him with Her gentle words.

Mother spent a few more minutes with the family before moving towards the *darshan* hut. She had not given them any specific instructions or advice, and as they were left standing at the bottom of the staircase, they felt a bit confused. Their confusion soon vanished however, for, just before entering the hut, Mother turned around. “Children,” She said, “wait till darshan has finished. Amma will see you again then.”

While the darshan was in progress, the family waited outside. During the entire darshan the sick man remained sitting near the hut, in a surprisingly calm mood. His family was very happy to see this change.

As soon as Mother came out of the darshan hut, She went straight to the sick man, took him by the hand, and led him to the northern side of the Ashram. It was a charming sight to see him walking behind Her like a small child dutifully following his mother. At one point he released his grip from Mother’s hand and tried to run away. In no time Mother coaxed him back to Her. When they reached a water tap, Mother sent someone to fetch a bucket and a mug and asked the young man to sit down. Though at first he would not obey, once again, through Her compassionate words and loving caresses, Mother reassured the man, and he finally sat down under the tap. As soon as She turned the tap on, however, the man jumped up and once again tried to run away, but this time Mother held him firmly by the shoulder and said, “No, my son,

no. Sit down. Calm down. Don't run away. This is for your own good. It will make you better. Don't you want to feel better? Don't you want to be healthy again? You want to work and look after your family, don't you? Sit quietly." Mother's words seemed to have a soothing effect on the man, and he again became calm.

By this time someone had arrived with a bucket and a mug. Mother filled the bucket and began pouring the water over the man's head. A beaming smile spread across Her face and, clearly delighted, She continued to pour water over him for a long time. Finally Mother turned off the tap saying, "That is enough." Yet the man remained seated. "Son, you can get up now," Mother said. He immediately got up. Someone handed Her a towel, and Mother wiped his face, chest and back. Turning to his family who had stood by observing the whole scene, Mother said, "Change his dhoti, but don't dry his hair. Let it dry by itself."

The parents of the sick man had not looked away even for a moment while Mother was with their son. They were obviously deeply moved by the way Mother cared for him, by how She had bathed him, all the while showering him with boundless love. Now, as Her attention shifted to them, they started to cry; they had been holding back their tears for a long time. Taking them in Her arms, and placing their heads on Her shoulders, Mother embraced each of them and wiped away their tears.

By now, Mother's clothes were also wet. One of the *brahmacharins* pointed this out to Her. "That's okay," She replied. "There was a time when Mother's clothes were always wet from carrying water and rice gruel for the cows, from wading through the backwaters looking for the ducks,

and from constantly being engaged in household chores. Amma used to remain in the backwaters and in the rain for hours on end. She is used to it. It is not a problem now.”

Mother stayed with the family for a few more minutes and left only after instructing them to stay in the Ashram for a few days. On the second day, Mother again bathed the man; this time he remained quiet and calm. Already there was a big change in him.

While this incident is an outstanding example of Mother’s humility and love, there are countless similar incidents which exemplify Her infinite love, compassion and patience. In the late 1970’s, many mentally ill people came to stay near Her. Mother used to take care of them, bathing them, feeding them, and looking after them as if they were Her own children. Back then, however, Mother’s compassionate ways did not always appeal to Her family members. Their property was very small, occupying only a tenth of an acre of land. Aside from the main house, a cow shed, and a small temple, there was no shelter from the rain and sun. The property was also surrounded by water, making it a hazardous playground for these disturbed people, who were in the habit of screaming, shouting and running about. Sometimes they even tried to attack Mother.

While Mother patiently endured everything and continued to serve these people with patience and love, eventually Her father and older brother summoned their relatives and ordered them to take them back home. Not only was their presence disruptive, but they simply could not be accommodated in a safe and suitable way. Although sorry to see them go, Mother did not object to their leaving,

for She was well aware of the lack of facilities for them and of the hardships they caused Her family.

Though these people were not able to stay permanently with Mother, certainly the contact they had with Her, intimate as it was, had a profound effect. Being fed, bathed and cared for by Mother as if She were their mother, these mentally ill people made great progress under Mother's loving and powerful care.

Countless people have experienced miraculous recoveries through Mother's Grace, but one especially memorable case is that of a leper named Dattan. He used to come for the *Devi Bhava* darshan every Tuesday, Thursday, and Sunday. On these three nights, Mother had a regular routine. Just before entering the temple, She would dance in ecstasy, holding a sword in one hand and a trident in the other. Moving around the temple, She would sometimes stop Her dance in order to bless people with a touch of Her sword. Dattan stood at a certain spot just behind the temple, ready with a few pitchers of water and a towel around his waist. Mother always paused from Her dance to pour each pitcher of water over the leper's head. She bathed him in this way three times a week, until he was cured of his disease.

Mother's life has always been one of sacrifice, with every moment devoted to alleviating the suffering of others. She Herself says, "It is Amma's sincere wish that Her hands will be caressing and consoling a distressed person at the very moment She breathes Her last breath, even when She has little energy left in Her body." Mother's tireless actions and continuous compassion in every moment of Her life show the true meaning of Her words.

The sick man got better. After some months, he and

his entire family returned to the Ashram. They said that all the symptoms of the mental disease had slowly disappeared after they had returned home. During the few days they had stayed at the Ashram, Mother had instructed the man to discontinue all medication.

Convinced that the young man's recovery was the gift of Mother's Grace, the whole family was overwhelmed with gratitude and joy. Once his sickness was cured, he was able to get back all the money he had lost, and with it start a business on his own. Responding to their heartfelt words of thanks, Mother smilingly said, "Children, now that you are happy do not forget God. Remember Him and pray to Him even in times of happiness. Usually people remember God and pray to Him only when they are in pain, as if God were only a pain-destroyer. Don't be like that. Let prayer and remembrance of God become part of your daily life. Amma is always with you."

That night everyone gathered in front of the temple for the evening *bhajan*. Mother sang the lead as everybody sang the response to *Devi saranam*. . .

*Give me refuge, O Goddess,
Give me refuge.
O Mother, whose divine form is being praised
By the celestial beings,
O Primal, Supreme Energy,
Salutations to You!*

*O Giver of auspiciousness,
The Universe exists within You;
Everything is born out of You,
And it is known that everything*

*Eventually dissolves
Into You alone.*

*O Mother,
As I prostrate at Your Feet,
Let me pray with all my devotion,
For just one thing;
I pray that Your pure, effulgent Form
Will shine in me forever
And that my tongue
Will constantly enjoy the taste
Of repeating Your Name.*

*The millions of living beings
Are all parts of the one Whole;
They are like waves of the Ocean.
This Universe has been designed
To help all beings attain their Liberation.*

*When we come to know
That our very life is nothing but You,
We become detached from this world
Like an actor who takes off his costume
At the end of a good performance.*

After the evening bhajan, Mother continued to sit on the front verandah of the temple. The singing had transported everyone to another plane, and all were filled with love and devotion. Some residents meditated, while others sat gazing at Mother, who was leaning against the wall, lost to this world. After some time, Mother moved and lay down on the bare floor. Like iron filings shifting with

the slightest movement of a powerful magnet, everybody gathered closer to Her. As She lay there, Mother raised both hands up and called out, “Shivane!” The next moment everybody heard Mother say to Herself, “He cannot hear you. Such a mindless fellow. He is a mindless fellow.”

The next moment Mother sat up and sang *Shiva Shiva Hara Hara*. . .

*O Auspicious One,
Destroyer of that which is unreal,
Who is clothed in the clouds,
O Beautiful One,
Who is playing the damaru drum. . .*

*Who holds the trident in His hand,
Bestowing fearlessness and boons,
Who has locks of matted hair
And limbs covered with ashes. . .*

*Who is adorned with a garland of cobras
And a necklace of human skulls,
Who supports the crescent moon on His forehead
And whose eyes are full of compassion. . .*

*O Auspicious One,
O Destroyer,
Great God. . .*

The devotees responded with enthusiasm to this lively song. It sounded as if a second session of evening bhajans had begun. The singing went on for some time, and when it ended, Mother returned to Her normal mood.

One of the devotees began to talk about his granddaughter who was barely four years old. Pointing to the child, the man said, "Amma, this girl really loves you. She expresses great devotion for you. Sometimes She covers her head with a piece of white cloth, enters the *puja* room, and sings bhajans, swaying back and forth and sideways just like you. After the bhajan she calls everybody and distributes sacred ash, saying that she is Vallikkavilamma. What a girl she is!"

Mother called the little girl to Her and asked, "Dear child, when you grow up will you have as much *bhakti* as you have now? Will you be as innocent then?"

The child nodded her head. Obviously proud of the girl, her grandfather became excited and said, "Daughter, tell Ammachi who your mother is." Without any hesitation, the little girl answered, "My mother is not Girijamma (her biological mother). Vallikkavilamma is my mother."

"Child, why do you love Amma?" Mother asked.

The little girl's reply was immediate, "Because Amma is God."

Upon hearing this, Mother was delighted. She laughed aloud and embraced the child, rocking her in Her arms. Mother then sat the girl on Her lap and playfully pleaded with her to sing a bhajan. In a hesitant voice, the girl sang the first four lines of *Kamesha vamakshi*. . .

*Salutations to Shakti, the Great Goddess,
Who is accessible through devotion;
Salutations to the Seed, the One Truth,
Infinite and Perfect Awareness. . .*

Mother was so pleased with her that She kissed the child on both cheeks. She rocked the little girl back and forth, and they both smiled and laughed with glee. This playful excitement gradually subsided and soon, the meowing of a cat was heard in the dark. "Here Chakki, here Chakki." Mother called out, looking in the direction of the meowing. Mother continued to call, "Here, Chakki. Where are you? Come here."

Within a few seconds the cat jumped onto the verandah from the side of the temple. It came straight up to Mother and started rubbing its body against Her arm. Next, it jumped right into Mother's lap, trying to find a way to curl up comfortably. Since the little girl was still sitting on Mother's lap, the cat's attempts to settle there made everybody laugh. Mother remarked, "Chakki is very jealous." Again laughter filled the air.

One brahmacharin excitedly said, "Amma, if animals feel jealous, why should it be surprising if we too feel that way? When even animals love to be on Your lap, you shouldn't deny us that pleasure." Again there was laughter.

THE ART OF DYING

The atmosphere grew more serious when one of the brahmacharins asked a question, "Amma, we have heard you say repeatedly that the *Mahatmas* (Great Souls) and the scriptures all state that one should have the urgency to realize the Self, or to break the shackles of worldly bondage. What do you mean by this urgency?"

Removing the girl from Her lap, Mother replied, "It is the urgency to know God, or the Self. Suppose you are diagnosed with a very serious illness. The doctors say you

must immediately start taking such-and-such a medicine and not to delay. What will you do? You will try to get the medicine right away. You may find out that the medicine is very expensive, but that's all right. You don't care about the price. And if it is not available locally, you go to the next town. If it is not available there, you go to the nearest city. You may even have to go to another country to undergo treatment or surgery. So you do what is needed. You do not hesitate to take these steps. Of course, there are people who cannot afford to do this, but most people will do whatever they can to find a cure. Why? Because the disease is a threat to their life and they do not want to die. You do not want to leave this beautiful world and all that is precious to you. You do not want to leave the people and things that you love. The very thought of death makes you tremble.

"Just try to imagine how it will be when you die. The body that your dear ones, your wife, children, and parents have loved so much will be carried to the burial ground. No one wants to keep it. Nobody even wants to look at it. The very sight of it is frightening. Everybody wants to get rid of it as soon as possible. So your body will be taken to the graveyard. Or, someone will light the funeral pyre, and you are finished forever. The thought that after your death the world will continue without you makes you tremble. The world will go on without you, and you are going to miss everything that is beautiful: your house, your friends, your pretty young wife, your children, the flowers in the garden and their fragrance. The thought that you won't see any of them, that you won't see the cute, smiling face of your son again, the thought that you are going to miss all that you love makes you feel miser-

able. Nature and all its beauty, the rivers, the mountains and valleys, the sun and the moon, the stars, the ocean - no more will you see them. Festivals and celebrations, the loving and comforting words of your wife or husband, the affectionate caresses of your loved ones, everything will disappear. You don't know where you will go, but you presume that you will be surrounded by nothing but darkness. You are helpless. Can you imagine this? The very thought of death frightens you. Just imagining the helpless state you will be in when death comes can create an urgent desire to save your life. This urgency, then, is the intense longing to embrace the life-saving principle, the Supreme Truth. It is the longing to realize the immortality of the Self.

“Many people do not want to meditate because the stillness experienced in meditation makes them think that they are going to die. Sugunanandan Acchan (Amma's father) had great fear whenever Amma meditated. Amma was told that he thought She was going to die whenever Her meditation lasted for more than a few hours. In order to save Amma from dying, he would shake Her violently or pour buckets of water over Her head. Poor Acchan, he had no idea about meditation. He did not know that meditation is the saving principle, that it makes you immortal and eternal. Meditation takes you across the cycle of death and rebirth. Meditation is ambrosia. It actually prevents the fear of death. It makes you egoless, and takes you to the state of no-mind. Once you transcend the mind, you cannot die. Meditation and spiritual practices give you the power and courage to smile at death. Meditation helps you to see everything as a delightful play, so that even the moment of death becomes a blissful experience.

“So, children, this urgency comes when all your hopes and dreams collapse. They are bound to collapse because you are searching for happiness in the wrong place, where you cannot get it.

“A man was crawling around on his hands and knees. ‘What are you searching for?’ asked another person. ‘My key.’ Both men got on their knees to search. After a while the neighbor said, ‘Where did you lose it?’ ‘At home.’ ‘Good Lord!’ said the neighbor. ‘Then why are you searching here?’ ‘Because it is brighter here.’

“Likewise, happiness is within you, but you search for it outside. For this reason, frustration is inevitable. You begin to feel that your life is in danger and that you cannot depend on anything but God or a Universal Power. The fear that death is going to take everything away from you makes you search for a way out. The search eventually takes you to the real path, the spiritual path. Your search for a way to conquer death will finally take you to your real Self.

“Man wants to live forever. No one wants to die. ‘Life and love, not death’ is the instinct that reverberates within every living being. Human beings want to live and live and live. They have an urge to cling to everything they possibly can, even the entire universe. They don’t want to lose anything. There are such a variety of ways and techniques suggested by so many people around the world on how to live. They advertise, ‘Gain your heart’s desire in ten easy steps,’ or any such slogan to tempt you to buy their method of gaining happiness and contentment. But what a pity! Nobody hits upon the real path except the true seeker. Nowhere in the world can one learn how to die; how to die to the ego, to attachments,

anger, fear, and all that keeps you from attaining perfect peace. Man does not know that in the process of possessing, mastering and gaining, he is unconsciously losing. He is getting closer and closer to a great loss, a loss which he can never make up again. He will lose the chance of transcending the cycle of death and rebirth, which is the real purpose of this life in human form.

The very thought, 'I am losing, not gaining at all,' can sometimes help you feel the urgency and come to the spiritual path."

Everybody sat in awe of Mother's words. She continued, "Children, you all know the great saint Tulsidas.¹ Of course we know him as a saint now, but before his spiritual quest he was a businessman. He was madly in love with his wife, and his attachment to her, his physical craving for her, was so intense that he did not even want to go to work. Once when she went to her parental home, Tulsidas's craving for her grew so uncontrollable that he walked a long distance in the dark, through wind and rain, just to be with her. So determined was he, that he mistook a dead body for a boat to cross a torrential river. Finally, after midnight, he reached his destination only to discover that all the doors were locked. Since his wife's room was on the upper floor, he had to climb in order to reach her room. Taking a python to be a thick rope, he scaled it and slipped into his wife's room. After all his difficulties, he expected his wife to be happy to see him. But instead, she was so ashamed of his insane attachment to her that she said to him, 'Had you directed this craving you have for me towards God, you would have realized God long ago.'

"Those words came as a shock to Tulsidas, a blow to his ego, and he himself must have felt extremely ashamed

of his unintelligent and foolish attachment to her. He must have felt the burden of his attachment. Thus his whole being, every cell, every atom of his body, every heart-beat, every breath, and every pore of his body turned inward. That very moment he realized the heavy burden of attachment he had been carrying in the name of love. His heart skipped a beat to unload it and then was filled with pure love for God. At that moment he decided to die to his body-consciousness and to live in God-consciousness. He left his wife and home and wandered as an ascetic. Later he became the renowned saint we know as Tulsidas.”

After a few minutes Mother continued, “The moment of revelation that has occurred to many great souls can happen to you as well. Everybody is being prepared to reach this final state of dropping all worldly attachments, all ego. It must happen because that is the final stage of evolution. You cannot avoid it. Consciously or unconsciously, you may try to avoid it today, but sooner or later you are going to lose your grip on everything, possessions, wealth, body, all that you claim as your own. You think there is infinite time for you to live. But the awareness is growing each moment, even without your knowledge. The final destiny for all souls is the dropping away of every obstruction to peace and contentment. When that moment comes, the ego is dropped, and you won’t struggle any more. You will neither protest, nor will you even pause to think whether you should let go or not. You will just bow down and surrender. Deep within, every soul is waiting for this great letting go to happen. Most people do not feel this now because their awareness is so low, but that urgency will come one day.”

A *brahmacharin* asked, “Amma, you said ‘Nowhere in

the world can one learn how to die.' Is death something that can be learned? Can you please explain?"

"Yes, death is an art to learn and practice. It can only be practiced if you drop your ego. It can only be learned by practicing meditation.

"Because death is the greatest threat, the greatest fear, the greatest blow to our ego, each moment human beings try to cover up and forget this fear of death by running after the pleasures of the world. In order to avert the thought of death people want to indulge themselves and enjoy life by creating and fulfilling desires.

"Children, with each birthday we take another step closer to death. It is also a 'deathday'. Birthdays come as a reminder of that fatal day, or the moment of death itself. But we don't want to remember that; therefore, we celebrate it as a day of birth. We arrange a big feast, invite friends and relatives to sing 'Happy birthday to you' or 'Long live so and so. . .'

"We think only of life. We never want to think of death because we feel that death is a complete annihilation, a complete destruction and dissolution of everything we think of as ourselves. We do not want to think about this dissolution. Yet the remembrance of death still keeps coming, and the more we try to forget about death, the more it comes. And the more frequently we think about death and the uncertainty of it, the more fearful we become. This fear robs us of our inner peace. Only when we realize the inevitability of our own death, will we feel an urgency to seek inner peace and true happiness. That is why in order to really live a life of happiness and contentment, one must learn to die. But, unfortunately, we do not know how to die in peace.

“People die all over the world in great pain, with great sorrow and suffering. Death is one of the most unbearable pains. Nobody wants to be in pain; thus, there is fear of death. Everybody wants to cling to this beautiful world, their body, their wealth, their friends and relatives, their home, and so forth. The thought that death will snatch away and annihilate all those things is extremely painful to them. So they die in pain and sorrow, because they do not want to leave these things. They want to cling to life and this creates a great struggle within. This struggle is the cause of severe pain while dying because they are not willing to let go. Many people are unconscious while dying, but within them there is struggle, conflict, and helpless fighting against death as it takes place.

“Children, do not die unconsciously. Learn to die consciously. If you learn to die consciously, you can decide what you should be, where you should be and how you should be in your next life. Or if you do not want to come at all to this world, that too is possible.

“Amma has heard of a Mahatma who was poisoned to death. He accepted the poison smilingly and keenly listened to the jail warden who instructed him on how to drink it. His hands did not tremble. He had no anxiety or fear of death. Coolly and calmly he sipped the poison with a prayer. As he was lying waiting for death, he even described how the poison was working in his body. He died consciously, not unconsciously. This is real dying, real death. Real death happens only when you witness the death of your body. For such a person death is a real experience. Man is consciousness, therefore he must learn to live and die in consciousness.”

Mother’s words on conscious death recall the time in

Devi Bhava when Sugunanandan, Her father, demanded that Devi leave his daughter's body. In those early days he and many of the villagers were totally ignorant of Mother's oneness with the Supreme Absolute. They believed that She was possessed by Krishna and Devi three days a week during the Bhava Darshans and that the rest of the time She was crazy. "I want my daughter back!" he shouted at Mother during Devi Bhava. Mother replied, "If I give you back your daughter, She will be nothing but a corpse and will soon be decomposing and you will have to bury Her!" Sugunanandan continued to demand the return of his daughter, and the Mother said, "If that's the case, here is your daughter. Take her!" Instantly the Holy Mother fell down on the spot. Her body became stiff, her heart stopped beating and there was no breathing. She was dead from every appearance. Full of remorse, Sugunanandan implored the Divine Mother to bring his daughter back to life. The devotees who came for the Bhava Darshan were stricken with grief and prayed fervently. Eight hours passed before there was a slight movement in Her body, and She returned to life."

Here, then, is Mother's own example of dying consciously and re-entering the body consciously. Once you learn how to die you can choose your birth and death. It is perfectly under your control.

"Children, learn to die in bliss. Just as you celebrate your birthday, let death and dying become a moment of great celebration and bliss. Learning to die in bliss is meditation. This can happen only if you learn to cease to cling while living. Through meditation you can exercise ceasing to cling, ceasing to grasp. Your entire life should be a preparation to die happily, for only when you

have learned to be willing to face death happily can you live life happily. Because then you will realize that death, like life, is also a truth. You will realize that death is not complete annihilation, but complete freedom from the grip of ego.

“Children, learn to accept death, welcome death, and say hello to death. Be friendly with death and death will become your friend. Once you learn to receive death, fears of all kinds disappear, and you will begin to live in real peace.

“The next moment is not ours. Only the present belongs to us. Living in the present, dropping the past, and forgetting the future is real life. We do not know whether we will be here in this body in the next moment. We do not know whether we will need the things and objects we use now in the next moment. We may breathe out and may never breathe in again. Who knows whether we will wake up tomorrow? The great saints and sages always lived moment-to-moment. They never planned for the future.

“Only a person who leads a moment-to-moment life can be completely free from fear. He alone can embrace death peacefully. This moment-to-moment living is possible only through meditation and doing spiritual practices. When there is ego, there is fear of death. Once the ego is transcended, one becomes egoless and the fear of death also disappears. In that state, death becomes a great moment of celebration. For those who live moment-to-moment, death is not a fearful experience; on the contrary, it becomes a peaceful and loving experience.

“When death comes, we are helpless. The constant remembrance of the possibility of death is the best way

to learn humility. Humility is surrender; surrender is bowing low to all existence. Then there can be no ego. Once you become egoless, there is no more death. An egoless person cannot die, because he is not a body anymore. He is consciousness. Only people who are identified with the body will die.”

Mother’s profound satsang about moment-to-moment living, how to die and how the moment of death can become a great moment, a blissful experience, makes us recall the great Upanishadic declaration, ‘*Eha atraiva*’, which means, Realization of the Self is here, right now, this very moment.’

A devotee asked another question, “Amma, what is the best way to drop the ego and embrace death lovingly?”

Mother said, “Trust. Simply trust in the Guru’s existence. Trust in a Perfect Master alone will help you drop the ego and all egocentric thoughts and thus enable you to embrace death lovingly. Live life beautifully. The beauty that permeates your life manifests in the beauty of your death. Yet, this beauty in life is possible only when you surrender to a real Master. Surrendering to a real Master is surrendering to the whole of existence.

“A real Master teaches you to accept everything that happens in life. He helps you to be thankful for both good and bad, right and wrong, enemy and friend, those who harm you and those who help you, those who cage you and those who release you from the cage. The Master helps you forget about the dark past and the bright future full of a thousand promises. He helps you live life in the present moment with all its fullness. He lets you know that the whole of Nature—everything, everybody,

even your enemy—is helping you evolve and attain Perfection.

“When a person is thankful for everything, he will give up everything to lovingly embrace death with a beautiful smile on his face. For such a person, death is extraordinarily beautiful. For him, death is not an enemy to be afraid of. On the contrary, death becomes his greatest friend.

“Without knowing life, you cannot know death. For one who has not known life, who has not lived life in all its fullness, death is darkness; it is the end. But for one who has known life, death is the very heart of existence. Life flowers in death. That is why great masters, even though their bodies suffered, could die with big, blissful smiles on their faces. They embraced life with overflowing love. They embraced all of existence, all experiences both good and bad; therefore, they could embrace death also.

“This art of dying can be learned only by surrendering to a true Master. He helps you, your ego, to die in him, and he helps you to live.

“There is no guarantee for the future, for the next moment. Death alone is the guarantee of the future or the next moment. This moment is for you; the next moment may be death, who knows? Therefore, live this moment well. This moment alone is the guarantee. The next moment comes out of this moment.”

It was ten forty-five in the evening. Mother asked everyone to meditate for a few minutes before they got up. Then Mother went to Her room, followed by Gayatri and Kunjumol. The brahmacharins, the householder residents, and the visitors all remained seated and meditated

for about fifteen minutes as bliss permeated the air. Souls were stirred to great inward depths by the Mother's profound words. One by one all dispersed except for a few who remained meditating on the front verandah of the temple.



CHAPTER TWO

DELUDED BY THE EGO

Thursday, 19 July, 1984

As the Holy Mother and Her Ashram became well-known, more and more seekers, including some belonging to well-established spiritual groups, came for Her darshan. Sometimes a lesson was provided by visitors passing through, as if Mother had brought them to the Ashram for that purpose alone. On this day a visitor arrived whose attitude and behavior were unusual for a spiritual seeker. He was a *sannyasin*² from another spiritual institution who had come to inform Mother about a fund-raising campaign the group had undertaken in order to raise money to build an educational complex. His band of spiritual seekers had started their march in Kanya Kumari, the southernmost tip of India, and they were heading north. On the way they wanted to have Mother's darshan and receive Her blessing for the successful completion of their fund-raising campaign. The swami who had come in advance of the group to arrange accommodation and food was not well mannered. There was an air of pride in his demeanor and in the way he spoke; he was neither humble nor polite.

At first the Ashram residents thought that his display of pride wasn't real, that he appeared proud because of a flaw in their own perception. But gradually the visitor's words and manner made it very clear that he was indeed full of self-importance. He made many demands of the Ashram residents and was condescending in his manner towards the brahmacharins who were trying to serve him. As he was planning to stay overnight, the swami asked for a room where he could be alone, but only a few simple huts with minimum facilities were available. Yet the residents made what arrangements they could and offered the best hut to the visitor.

Upon seeing the simple accommodations, he complained loudly, "What! Am I supposed to stay in this damp hut? I cannot stay here!" He stormed out. The residents were shocked. They wondered how a professed spiritual seeker could react in such a way, as they themselves were being taught not to place any importance on such trivial things as where they slept. The ashramites were in a great dilemma. Where were they to put the visitor? There were no 'comfortable rooms' in the Ashram; in fact there were no rooms at all, only huts. The residents and visiting devotees slept on simple straw mats on the ground, and there were many nights when the brahmacharins gave up their huts and even their straw mats to visitors and slept outside in the sand. It was therefore puzzling to them that a spiritual aspirant, especially a sannyasin, could be so demanding.

Finally, with the permission of Mother's father and mother, the residents arranged for a small room with a cot in their house. But the swami was not satisfied with this room either. When he saw it, he made a long face;

he left the room grumbling, and went straight to the hut where Mother was giving darshan.

Inside the hut, Mother was seated on a mat on the floor. Another mat was quickly spread out for the swami so that he might sit facing Her. The swami did not show any respect or reverence towards Mother; he did not prostrate, nor did he offer any salutation as a spiritual seeker normally would to a Master. As usual, Mother's face was lit up by a smile. The Ashram residents who had been trying to arrange a room for the swami were curious how this egotistical person was going to address Mother. They came to the hut and stood at the side and back doors to listen to the conversation.

Exhibiting an air of great self-importance, the swami said, "I represent a group of sannyasins who are on a fund-raising march. I have come ahead of the group in order to inform you that they will arrive here in a few days. The entire group wishes to camp here for a whole day. We will need good food and comfortable accommodations."

"Son," Mother said, "you have expressed the desire of the children in your group to stay and have food in the Ashram when they arrive. That is okay. Amma is only too happy to serve you. But it is not proper for you to demand comforts and good food. One who seeks the Truth should not demand anything. He should not ask for comforts and pleasures. A *sadhak* should feel content with whatever comes to him. A spiritual seeker is one who has surrendered everything to God. He should not expect any special privileges. You should be taking the journey you are on as an opportunity to learn renunciation. Seeking comfort and pleasure should not be its aim."

“I don’t agree with the idea that comforts and pleasures are prohibited to spiritual seekers,” he answered back.

“An undisciplined way of living is most unsuitable if God-Realization is your goal,” Mother responded. “Self-restraint is absolutely necessary for a seeker. It is important for you to study the rules and principles of spiritual life, but what good is study if you cannot practice what you learn? Those words become alive only when you constantly practice them in your life. If you are self-centered, giving importance to your own needs, how can you serve? An attitude of self-surrender and renunciation is necessary in order to serve others selflessly. Only then will everything you do become worship.”

“Are you a person who has renounced everything?” he asked Mother.

This remark infuriated the brahmacharins and devotees who were already feeling annoyed. But because they were in Mother’s presence, they managed to restrain themselves and did not move a muscle or voice any reaction.

Upon hearing the question, Mother laughed heartily and said, “Amma does not claim that she is a sannyasin, nor does She wear special clothes. Amma makes no claims. Whether you accept Her or reject Her, respect Her or show Her no respect, She doesn’t care. But you want others to respect and recognize you. You wear ochre robes and say that you are a sannyasin. That is why Amma spoke to you in that manner. You should be setting an example for others. Asking whether or not Amma has renounced everything does not solve your own problem. What Amma has or has not renounced has nothing to do with you. You will benefit only if you change; and once you change, others will be benefited as well.”

When the swami made no comment, Mother went on to tell a story: "There was once an old man who was looking back on his life. He sat in a tea shop with his friends, telling them his story. 'When I was a young man, I was arrogant and thought I knew it all. I felt I could do anything, and wanted to change everyone. I would pray to God to give me the strength to change the world. When I reached middle age, I awoke one morning and realized that my life was half over. I had done nothing, and I hadn't changed anyone. So I prayed to God to give me the strength to change those who were close to me since they needed it so much. But now I am old and my prayer is very simple: God, please give me the strength to change at least myself.'"

Everyone laughed except the swami. He turned pale and was more agitated than ever. After a brief pause, Mother continued, "Don't try to change the world or other people before you are able to change yourself. If you try to change others without changing your own attitudes, it will not have any effect. Son, the purpose of this colored cloth is not to enhance your personality or make you look beautiful. It should be a constant reminder of the highest goal of human birth. It is not to boost your ego, but to help you become egoless. You feel proud to be a sannyasin. But the very word '*sannyasa*' means to give up, to give up your false sense of pride and self-importance. Try to respect the ochre cloth by humbling yourself. Try to have some more control over your own mind."

The swami was adamant, "I don't agree with any of these ideas. But I don't want to argue with you either. Now, are you going to provide a room for me or not?"

Mother smiled, “Okay, you did not understand the point. Amma does not blame you.”

She then called Br. Sreekumar and instructed him to arrange Mother’s own room for the swami. The residents disapproved of this and began to protest, not wanting Mother’s room defiled by someone they felt to be the very embodiment of arrogance.

Consoling the brahmacharins, Mother said, “Children, what does it matter if he stays in Amma’s room for one night? Or is it that your egos can’t bear his? After all, he is a messenger. He was sent to inform us about a good cause. We must treat him well. Let him behave or speak arrogantly. It shouldn’t matter to us. Whatever happens, we must abide by the rules of conduct that are appropriate for our own spiritual aspirations.”³

Though everyone else was very disturbed by the swami’s blatant display of egotism, Mother was not the least bit bothered. She remained completely unperturbed. Reluctantly some brahmacharins showed the swami to Mother’s room. As soon as he was settled there, he requested that dinner be brought to him. According to Mother’s instructions, the brahmacharins gave him everything he asked for. Having finished his dinner, he requested that his breakfast be ready at seven o’clock sharp. He even specified what he wanted.

Not being able to stand it any longer, one of the brahmacharins protested: “Swami, you should not forget that you represent the tradition of the great saints and sages of India. You should be setting an example for us through your humility and renunciation. But instead, you are making a big display of your ego and pride.”

Momentarily taken aback, the visitor did not answer

right away. But he soon gathered his forces and shot back, "Hey, don't you know who you are talking to? Don't you know how to behave in front of a sannyasin? You require a better understanding about *dharma*. Hasn't your Guru taught you anything? I presume that none of you have studied the scriptures. Tell your Guru that She should make arrangements for you to study them. You need someone like me to instruct you in the scriptural texts."

The brahmacharins could not remain silent any longer. "Swami, if studying the scriptures is going to cause great harm to us as it has obviously done to you, we would rather stay away from such study."

The swami now raised his voice: "Are you mocking me?"

"No, swami, we are not mocking you," answered the same brahmacharin. "It's only that we have a hard time understanding you. You say that we should learn the scriptures to have a better understanding about *dharma*. You say you have studied all the scriptures, and yet we do not see any right conduct in your actions. You are not practicing those *acharas*, and this confuses us."

"I am beyond the scriptures and *acharas*," answered the swami.

Shocked and appalled by such shamelessness, the brahmacharins didn't know how to respond. How could this swami claim that he was beyond the scriptures? After a long pause, one brahmacharin spoke, "Swami, we know that you have a spiritual master. Do you consider him as a great soul and take his words as being as valid as the scriptural statements?"

"Yes, of course," the swami replied. "He is my Guru and a great soul. I must have faith in his words."

Without another word, the brahmacharin who had been speaking with the swami rushed out and returned a few minutes later with a letter. Handing it to the swami, he said, "Be kind enough to go through this letter. It is from your Guru."

The ashramites expected the letter to bring about some change in the swami's attitude, for it had been written to one of the brahmacharins by the swami's Guru, and clearly expressed the Guru's great admiration and reverence for Mother. He had concluded the letter with this sentence: "Everything is Mother's *leela*; I humbly bow down at Her feet." Full of hope, the brahmacharins watched as the swami read the letter. He turned pale, but the next moment, to everyone's surprise, the swami raised his head and said, "I am beyond even the Guru."

What a shock! The brahmacharins were dumbfounded. Stunned by the swami's outrageous statement, they could find nothing to say, and silently left the room. As a group, they walked slowly to the temple where Mother was holding Devi Bhava darshan. The swami remained in his room for the entire evening, and did not come down for Mother's darshan.

Friday, 20 July, 1984

The following morning, when Mother came to the darshan hut, the swami pushed his way in and demanded to speak with Her. Mother smiled and lovingly spread a mat on the floor, inviting him to sit. With a stern expression on his face he took his seat. Mother sat on the other end of the mat facing him. All those present were captivated by Mother's humility and the serene divinity

She radiated. But the swami was a hard nut to crack. As if to challenge Mother's immense presence, he once again revealed his arrogance.

The swami spoke, "As you know, I am from a highly reputed spiritual organization. I have been studying *Vedanta* at the Mission's Headquarters. After the completion of scriptural studies, I was initiated into sannyasa by my Guru. Since then I have been traveling around teaching Vedanta. Countless people have been inspired by my spiritual discourses. Many people tread the path of spirituality drawing inspiration from my teachings. Yet it seems that these boys have not understood me. They are unaware of my spiritually advanced state and have not honored me properly."

Hearing him boast, the ashramites were stunned and at the same time angered. Such a display of pride and arrogance was unheard of, especially in front of the Divine Mother. They all looked at Mother, but Her calm and unperturbed mood reminded them to keep their mouths shut.

As if listening to a misguided child's foolish prattle, Mother smiled at the swami. Very softly and gently She replied, "Son, calm down. Relax. You have studied the scriptures and you know what it means to be spiritual. But the saints and sages through whom the *Vedas* and *Upanishads* have come into being were totally free from ego. To be truly spiritual means to be egoless. These teachers never declared that they were beyond everything. They never said that they were great. They never demanded that others should worship, honor, or even respect them. It is because of their great humility and renunciation that they are still remembered and adored. If you can stop

insisting that others should respect and honor you, honor and respect will come to you unasked. Just try to be humble and patient and you will see how things around you change. Just try to be yourself. When you stop demanding, others will start honoring and worshipping you, even if you don't care, even if you don't want it.

"My son, you talk so childishly. People mock you. They consider you ignorant and immature. They don't pay any attention to you or give any importance to what you say. They think you are a fool. By feeling so proud of yourself and speaking so arrogantly, you bring disgrace and a bad reputation to your Guru and the organization you represent. You are the mirror in which the greatness of your Guru and the organization should be reflected. Let your words and deeds add splendor and glory to your Guru and to the work that he does.

"Try to be like a child. Only then will you be able to learn and grow. The feeling that you are grown-up or great will not help you to learn. Only humility will help you to grow. A child grows emotionally and intellectually because there is no ego to protest and create blocks. Knowledge flows into the child unimpeded. But once your adult ego comes creeping in, the feeling of 'I and mine' appears and any possibility of inner growth is obstructed.

"Now, son, you say that you are from a big spiritual organization. But greatness doesn't lie in size or numbers. A spiritual organization may be large, but its real greatness lies in the humility, patience and renunciation of its representatives. No matter what institution one may belong to, spiritual or otherwise, one should be humble and willing to adapt. Only then can one really grow.

“Nothing is fully grown at birth. Whatever is born must go through a stage of infancy before it reaches maturity. This is healthy growth. Take any object, any plant or animal, institution or country, it has to go through different stages of growth. There is naturally a past, present and future to everything, because everything exists in time. Therefore, it makes no difference whether the spiritual institution you belong to is large in numbers or long-standing in years. What is important is that its representatives learn to abide by its teachings, especially if the representative is a spiritual seeker who has studied the scriptures. Son, didn’t you mention that you have studied all the scriptures? So try to set an example for these boys here. Inspire them through your patience, humility and renunciation. Otherwise, they may develop an aversion towards scriptural studies. They are only beginners. If you are egoless they will accept and admire you; they will be inspired by you, and will try to follow your example.”

The swami answered, “I am beyond all rules and regulations; I am even beyond the scriptures, and I have certainly not come here to set an example for these beginners.” The stern look on his face remained unchanged.

Mother continued, “Son, those who have gone beyond have nothing to say. They know that this great experience is beyond words. Haven’t you studied this great principle? Do you believe that the scriptures are mere words penned long ago by people who had nothing else to do? If you really believe in the Truth that the Great Ones experienced, if you really believe in their words, and wish to do a little bit of justice to this great spiritual tradition and to the ochre colored cloth that you wear, try to practice what they expounded.

“These children whom Amma is trying to bring up should be able to learn lessons of patience, humility and renunciation from people like you. But instead your words and actions have confused them; when you have gone, they will shower Amma with questions and doubts. Just last night they asked, ‘How can a swami be so insistent about good food and comfortable accommodations? How could he sleep in Amma’s room, knowing that it is Hers? We never thought that a spiritual seeker could be like this. We even feel reluctant to study the scriptures, if doing so will create as much ego in us as we have seen in that swami.’

“Somehow Amma managed to console them, saying that they should not find fault with others, for it will hinder their own spiritual progress. Amma also asked the brahmacharins, ‘Why should you want to judge an entire spiritual lineage by looking at one person’s faults? If he acts strangely, it is his own fault. How can you impose blame on the flawless saints and sages? How can you blame the entire medical profession for the wrong prescription administered by one doctor?’”

After a brief pause, the Mother continued speaking to the swami. “My son, you can act as you like, but do you know how much damage you are creating through your words and deeds? You have your own theories and concepts. That is all right. Keep them if you are so attached to them, but why confuse others by spreading such beliefs? That is a grave sin for which you will have to pay at some point. Amma teaches the children *tyaga* not *bhoga*, renunciation not indulgence.”

A hushed silence fell over the entire hut. The swami showed no sign of emotion. Everyone watched and lis-

tened intently. When he finally spoke, the visitor's reply came as a thunderbolt: "You have repeatedly called me 'son'. Perhaps then I should call You 'daughter'!"

The swami's insolence was too much for the residents to take; one of them could not contain himself any longer, and he began to protest. But Mother stopped him with a gesture of Her hand. She turned quickly to the devotee and said, "What is the matter with you? Amma does not want anyone to interfere. Everyone, keep quiet until the conversation is over. Leave the hut if you can't do this."

If only the swami had been sensitive enough to see with his eyes and feel with his heart, he would have realized Mother's greatness by simply observing Her. Her unshakable patience and Her profound humility, devoid of any ego, undeniable signs of an elevated state, shone through all that Mother said and did. But the swami was too closed, too blind. This arrogant attitude of the swami is a demonstration of a famous verse from the *Bhagavad Gita*,

"Fools disregard Me as one clad in human form, not knowing My higher nature as the Great Lord of beings."

(IX-1)

Turning to him, Mother smilingly replied, "Amma has never asked anyone to call Her 'Mother (Amma).' She has never insisted on it. But everyone does call Her 'Mother,' and She, in turn, responds by calling everyone, 'children.' Amma has never cared what people call Her. Devotees and spiritual seekers call Her 'Mother.' Some people call Her by the name given to Her by Her par-

ents. Some atheists and others who are against Her use unflattering or insolent names. This doesn't bother Amma at all. People see things according to their own *vasanas*. The same person who is sister to someone may be daughter to another person and cousin, aunt or friend to others. How many births, how many bodies, how many wombs, and how many names and forms have we passed through before arriving at this present life? How many times and to how many people have we been a father, mother, brother, sister, relative and friend? So, my son, don't worry. It's not important. The body is changing; it's unreal. Call this body by any name you like. *This* (pointing to Herself) does not care."

Mother's mood seemed to change, and She began to speak from a point of oneness with Infinity, "*This* came from the unconditional." She pointed to Herself again. "*This* was bodiless. *This* assumed a form and manifested in this body. Some call it Amma, some Sudhamani, yet there are people who call it Amritanandamayi and many other names. But *this* remains the same, unchanged, unaffected. No one can pierce the mystery of this Being."

Her penetrating words and exalted mood seemed to move the swami. He turned pale and could not speak. The power of Mother's words and Her profound statement coming from the unimaginable spiritual heights in which She dwells made him speechless.

The swami tried hard to hide his astonishment, but within a few moments he was back to his arrogant self, and was trying to cover up his foolish remark about calling Mother "daughter." As he spoke his voice was flat and feeble, "I don't care what you call me. Why should I? I am Brahman."

Upon hearing such a ridiculous statement, everyone

laughed. It reminded them of Mother's words, "Egotistic people sometimes behave like fools."

In reply to his statement, Mother simply said, "A mad dog is also Brahman, but does it have any discrimination?" Then She closed Her eyes and sat deeply absorbed for some time. When She came back to normal consciousness, the swami, said once again, as if nothing had happened, "Well, can you provide food and accommodation for the sannyasins and brahmacharins who will be coming this way on their fund-raising march?"

Laughingly, Mother replied, "Son, that has already been agreed. But it is your duty to convey your message in an appropriate and polite manner. With Amma you can talk in any way you wish; She is willing to forgive and forget. But you cannot act this way towards everyone. People and organizations place a lot of importance on rules and regulations. In a police station you cannot talk and behave as you like. Laws exist and there is a certain way of doing things. You must behave in proper and appropriate ways in front of an officer or before a judge in a court of law. This is also true of how you are to behave in a temple or a church. You should adhere to the rules and policies that have been established in such places. You cannot act according to your own whims and fancies. The institution you come from also has certain rules and regulations, doesn't it? You observe them, don't you?"

"Don't you know that each place has its own dharma? Everything has its own nature. How can you insist that a place or anything should change its nature, that it should stray from its own dharma? Is it right to demand that a place should change from its natural course just because

you or someone else does not like the way it functions? You cannot say that a police station should be like a market place, or a temple like a liquor shop. You cannot expect an ashram to be a five-star hotel. Each place has its own way of functioning, that is its nature, its *samskara*. If it changes its nature, then it becomes something else.

“This is an ashram. It has a way of its own. Amma is very happy to welcome and feed all those who come here. Amma most lovingly invites all the participants in the fund-raising group to stay and eat at the Ashram when they arrive. You have conveyed the message that they are coming, and Amma is grateful to know this in advance. But son, this is an ashram, not a hotel or a palace where you can have the best food and the best accommodations. That is not possible. Simplicity and humility are the goals of an ashram and of a true spiritual seeker. You cannot expect a seven-course meal and a luxurious stay here. If you stay here, everything will be simple. To demand hotel facilities in an ashram is incorrect. That is against the dharma of an ashram. An ashram is a place where spiritual seekers live - people who are trying to lead a life of renunciation. Those who know this will not expect elaborate accommodations. They know that the primary purpose of visiting an Ashram is to feed the soul. To feed the hunger of the body is only a secondary concern at an ashram.”

“I know all these things. Didn’t I tell you that I have undergone Vedanta studies for three years?” remarked the swami.

Gently teasing, Mother repeated what he had said, “I know... I have undergone Vedanta studies...I am great...” Then She admonished him, “Son, you have such a big

'I.' That is your problem. It was 'I' who studied everything. You kept on feeding the ego. In this way, the 'I', the ego, got bigger and bigger, and the real 'you' starved. What a shame! You studied the scriptures and now, like a parrot, you just repeat them without understanding or searching for their real meaning. Son, have you heard this story?

"A rich man had a fine collection of birds and boasted about it to everyone who came to his house. Once when he was showing some friends around the aviary, one friend remarked, 'But you don't have a talking parrot.' Immediately when the guests left, the rich man went to a pet shop and asked, 'Do you have a talking parrot?' 'Yes, of course,' replied the shopkeeper and showed him a parrot in a cage. 'Does this parrot talk?' asked the rich man. The parrot itself made the reply, 'There is no doubt about it.' Ecstatic with happiness, the man purchased the parrot, unaware that the shopkeeper was trying to tell him something.

"Anxious to show his friend who had made the remark about no talking parrot in his collection, he invited the same friends to see the newly-purchased parrot. Seeing the parrot, one of the visitors asked, 'Does this parrot talk?' 'There is no doubt about it,' came the parrot's reply. Amazed by this reply, another friend asked, 'What is your name?' The parrot said, 'There is no doubt about it.' Again and again the parrot replied, 'There is no doubt about it,' to every question it was asked. Realizing that the parrot knew only this one sentence, the visitors began laughing and teasing the rich man. Annoyed and angry, the man opened the cage and let the parrot go, saying, 'What a fool am I!' And as the parrot flew away, it said,

‘There is no doubt about it.’”

Everyone laughed and the swami looked around questioning, “Are you mocking me?” He paused and then looked at Mother and asked, “Are sannyasins prohibited from enjoying the comforts of life?”

Mother laughed aloud, “Son, it is because of the renunciation of sannyasins and their simple way of life that the rest of the world is allowed to enjoy. The very existence of the world depends on the spiritual energy generated by sincere sadhaks through their *tapas*.

“In any field in life, when things are being done the wrong way by some people, there are others who are doing things correctly. This keeps the ball rolling. This is how society functions without everything being completely destroyed. Bad is always balanced by good; evil is always balanced by virtue; insults are balanced by praise; destruction is balanced by creation; indulgence, enjoyment and attachment are balanced by renunciation, abstinence and detachment. While those who live in the world drain all their energies through over-indulgence and pleasure-seeking, spiritual seekers conserve energy by refraining from over-indulgence and inordinate attachment. On one side all the energies are dissipated, and on the other, they are conserved. Saving is a help to spending. Without saving, how can one spend? The tapasvi, the spiritual seeker, who practices austerities and conserves energy, is in due course, through rigorous spiritual practices, transformed into an inexhaustible power source. He becomes an inexhaustible source of energy. On the other hand, people who live in constant indulgence, with never-ending expectations, dreams and hopes, build castles in the air. They drain all their energies and finally break down. Then to

whom can they turn? Who can help energize and revitalize them? Their only source of support is a spiritual person who has conserved a vast amount of energy, who can afford to spend lavishly from his limitless supply. He saves energy for the sake of others, for the sake of the world, and helps those who are in need."

After a short pause, Mother continued, "A sannyasin is one who, having renounced all attachments, is blissful in all circumstances. He is beyond everything. He has great patience, forbearance, perseverance and forgiveness. Dwelling in his own Self, he is not affected by time and place and finds happiness within. He can be in the lowest hell and still be happy. He can live in a dense forest full of ferocious wild animals and continue to feel blissful.

"Haven't you studied the *Ramayana*? Rama renounced his entire kingdom with a smile on His face, without feeling the least hatred or anger towards those who had conspired against him. The night they left Ayodhya, Rama, Sita and Lakshmana had to sleep out in the open without a shelter. Yet Rama found no difficulty in sleeping on the bare ground. In fact, he was the only one who slept soundly. Lakshmana and Sita were so agitated that they did not get one wink of sleep. Rama was a real sannyasin. Remember, He was a prince and had all the luxuries of life at His disposal until the day He left. But He had no difficulty in renouncing the royal pleasures and accepting a very unpleasant situation. Could you do that? You ask, 'Can't a sannyasin enjoy life?' Of course, why not? But do you have the mental maturity and detachment to renounce anything at any time, and to accept and embrace something which happens to you quite unexpectedly? If

so, you can really enjoy life.

“Son, this is not the first time a sannyasin has visited the Ashram. Many sannyasins and spiritual people have come here. The children here always serve them and do whatever is necessary for them. They are happy to serve the guests, and they have great reverence for sannyasins. They respect the ochre cloth. But your ways are strange and unheard of for a sannyasin. You have confused them. They are not perfect souls. They have the expectation that people like you should serve as an example; they need hints and experiences which will help them with their inner growth. But your strange ways and selfish words have shocked them. The ochre cloth that you wear should remind you to cultivate humility and patience in your every word and action. When people do not see such qualities in you, they will simply ignore you, considering you totally unfit for this path.”

Obviously very agitated, the swami was completely silent. Mother closed Her eyes and remained indrawn for some time. The swami was sitting with his head bent in shame, staring at the ground. Yet every now and then he lifted his head slightly and glanced at Mother’s blissful countenance, perhaps attracted by Her ecstatic mood. After a while Mother opened Her eyes. As if She understood what the swami was experiencing, as if witnessing his internal battle with the ego, She smiled benignly at him and continued to speak.

“Son, once a seed becomes a big tree with an abundance of fruit, it doesn’t have to declare to the world, ‘Look everyone, look at me. I am a beautiful tree, laden with fruit. Come, people, come! Rest in the shade of my limbs! Enjoy the cool breeze that filters through my leaves!

Enjoy my delicious fruit!’ Even without any kind of announcement people will flock to the tree to enjoy its fruit, its shade, and the breeze. But first, like the seed coming out of its shell, you must come out of the hard shell of the ego. Just as the seed bows low beneath the soil in order to grow into a tree, so you, if you are to evolve into the Self, must bow low to all of existence in utter humility.

“Take the example of a flower. In the bud stage the beautiful color of the petals and the sweet fragrance of the flower are invisible and unknown to us. But they are there inside the flower in their unmanifested form. They are dormant. When the flower blossoms, the beautiful color of the petals can be seen and the fragrance spreads all around. In the same way, divinity is in you. You are the Divine in unmanifested form. Eternal beauty and divine fragrance are potent within you. But just like an unopened flower, your heart is closed right now from your false sense of pride; because of this, you have not realized your true existence in Consciousness. Through spiritual practice the flower bud of your heart will eventually open up its petals. Only then will you realize your identity with Supreme Consciousness.

“You cannot get milk from the picture of a cow, nor can you quench your thirst with the water in the drawing of a river. In a similar manner, you cannot experience the Atman from the words of the scriptures. Studying the scriptures is like using a map to find the directions to your destination. The question of whether you have understood the directions clearly enough still remains to be seen. The directions can be misunderstood and you may be misled. In fact, as far as Vedanta is concerned,

there is a greater possibility of misunderstanding than of understanding the philosophy properly. More often than not, the study of Vedanta will only help to inflate the ego. Unless the ego is removed, no one can go beyond the *Srutis*, the *Vedas* and the *Upanishads*. Amma's only suggestion is that you should start doing spiritual practices and relinquish your pride about being a great scholar. Otherwise, you are wasting your life. As you progress in your spiritual practices, you will come to realize the truth of Amma's words.

"And one last thing, Amma knows that you have not been initiated into sannyasa. You took this ochre cloth on your own."

Mother's words struck the swami like lightning. He was clearly too shocked to speak, and sat for a long time without moving. Was he contemplating what Mother had said? Did he realize how foolish he had been in front of Mother and the others? Did he feel ashamed at all? Everyone sat in silent anticipation of what would happen next. Without another word the swami got up and left.

Though the Ashram residents did not see him again, they later heard confirmation that the swami had indeed only been initiated into *brahmacharya*, that he was not really a sannyasin. With this news, which did not come as a surprise to anyone, there was a report that he was no longer traveling around giving discourses, but that he had retired to a solitary place to do *sadhana*. So perhaps Mother had made a bigger impact on the swami than they had imagined. Although he had annoyed and even angered everyone with his relentless arrogance, their hearts went out to the swami upon hearing this news.

When the swami was gone, Mother addressed the

brahmacharins, “Children, that son was indeed very arrogant. But there is a lot that you can learn from him. Remembering how you felt towards him, you should strive never to behave in a conceited way. Even when one day you have studied the scriptures and people begin to show you a lot of respect, you should not deviate from the path of renunciation and humility. You should never look upon others as inferior to you, and demand services and respect from them.” After a brief pause Mother continued, “Your minds are agitated, aren’t they? Let us calm down before discussing or doing anything else.” She then asked Br. Pai to sing a bhajan. He sang *Verumoru pulkkodi*. . .

*O Mother, I am just a blade of grass.
I am nothing without Your Grace.
Oh golden-hued One,
Shower Your Compassion on me.*

*I am a form made of ego
And powerful delusion.
O Mother, please remove my sins
And dwell in my heart.*

The song had a deep effect on everyone. They all listened carefully to the words, contemplating their own insignificance and how it was due only to Mother’s Grace that they had been able to accomplish anything in their lives. Mother did not sing. She sat motionless and Her eyes were closed. When the song was over, there was a long and deep silence which no one was inclined to break. A few minutes passed before Mother opened Her eyes and smiled, as She looked around at everyone. Her be-

witching smile reflected Mother's unperturbed and unshakable nature. How can Mother, who is ever-established in Her own Self, be perturbed by anything?

MOTHER'S LOVE

Saturday, 21 July, 1984

Although the swami had left the day before, his visit was still on everyone's mind. His behavior had been so unforgettable that he would be remembered by all the ashramites for months and even years to come. The day's darshan was finished, and Mother was sitting in the coconut grove, surrounded by the ashram residents and a few visiting devotees. One brahmacharin took this opportunity to ask Mother about the swami. "Amma, how could you be so patient and calm before that swami's arrogance? The lack of respect he showed you made me so angry. I think everybody felt the same as I."

Thus came Her motherly reply, "How could Amma get angry with one of Her children simply because he was a little naughty and stubborn? Amma felt only compassion for him. He is also Amma's child, even though he is ignorant of it. A child sometimes kicks and hits his mother, and he sometimes utters a bad word about her, but the mother patiently endures it. She will not hit or kick him back. The mother knows that the child is ignorant and that he has no discrimination. Sometimes while feeding from the mother's breast, a baby may bite. What does the mother do? She doesn't stop feeding the baby. She doesn't get angry and hit the baby for doing that. The mother endures the pain and lovingly continues breast-

feeding her child. Out of her love and compassion for her child, the mother shows patience and understanding.

“When you are a mother, you cannot help but love. You can only be compassionate; you can only forgive and forget. That is why whatever is loving and patient is known as ‘Mother.’

“The earth is Mother Earth for us. Why? Because of her patience. Human beings are cruel to the earth; they have no concern or love for it. They exploit the earth regardless of the wonderful boons and gifts it has bestowed upon us. Still, the earth patiently bears everything and blesses humankind with immense wealth and prosperity. Therefore, the earth is Mother Earth to us and Nature is Mother Nature. All the rivers on the face of the earth, especially the river Ganges, render great benefits for the entire human race. They, too, are our mothers. But we do great harm to the rivers; we misuse and pollute them. Still they are patient and loving to us. Similarly, the ocean with all its resources and immense wealth continues to bless us even though we do it much harm; thus the ocean is mother to us. In India, the cow, too, is considered a mother. Thousands of cows are slaughtered around the world by wicked and greedy humans, but cows still give us milk. And God is the greatest of all mothers because He, who is also She, is the Governor and Governess of the entire universe. Out of His/Her all-consuming love and compassion He/She instructs and inspires all these beings of the earth to be patient and compassionate to us humans, even though humans do not return their love.

“Therefore, children, Amma cannot be angry with anyone because all are Her children. Amma cannot see

any differences. She beholds everything as Her own Self, an extension of Herself in different forms.

“Children, do not feel bad, angry or agitated about how egotistically that son behaved. Anger is very destructive. If you watch an angry man, you can see that he remains angry almost all the time. Sometimes the anger shows more and sometimes less, but it is constantly boiling within him. He cannot see or appreciate the good in others. Even if a person does a good job on something, he cannot congratulate him. Being tight and rigid, he cannot show or express love. He cannot even be friendly. With just the slightest excuse he can go into a rage. Such is the case of a jealous person as well, always ready to find a reason to be jealous, no matter how silly the reason. If nothing is happening to make him react with jealousy or anger, he will search for something to be jealous or angry about.

“An angry husband or a jealous wife can destroy an entire family and the children’s lives too. Whoever comes in contact with them will be poisoned by their anger and jealousy. Fighting and suspicion are the trademarks of such people. Here is a story for you.

“There was a wife who was always so suspicious of her husband that they fought every day. Immediately when the husband came home from work, she would search his pants and shirt pockets, closely investigating and smelling his clothing. Each day she would look straight into his eyes to see if he had any fear or guilty conscience. She would look through each and every page of his diary. Sometimes she found a new phone number in his diary or a long hair on his shirt, and she would get suspicious and demand to know whose phone number it was or where the hair came from. Fighting would ensue with accusa-

tions, shouting and crying. This became a daily routine.

“One day the wife could not find anything, not even a hair. She kept on searching for a long time but still could not find anything. Finally she collapsed and started crying. The husband asked, ‘Now, why are you crying today? There wasn’t even a single hair on my coat.’ Through tears the wife replied, ‘I’ll tell you why I am crying. Now you have started going out with bald women. I knew this would happen!’” Laughter filled the air, and Mother also laughed along with the devotees.

STUDY OF SCRIPTURES

One householder resident asked, “Amma, if studying the scriptures can create so much ego and anger in a person, I don’t want to study them. I do not want to harbor anger and cause harm to society.”

Mother answered, “Study of the scriptures does not necessarily create more ego in you. It is wrong understanding of the scriptures that creates a big ego in a person. Scriptural study is not the mere gathering of information about the Atman, or the Self. You cannot collect information about something beyond words and beyond the mind, about something incomprehensible. You can gather information about people, objects, places in the world and how to do things like computer programming, which are products of human intellect. But you cannot gather information about Consciousness. You can understand Pure Consciousness only if you drop your intellect and reasoning. Study of the scriptures is to help you drop the ego and go beyond all explanations and interpretations. It is to prove the insufficiency of words, to explain that

state fully. Study of the scriptures is to give you only an idea about spirituality. It explains the benefits of spiritual life. They are just explanations and conclusions. But remember, all scriptural statements and declarations have been made by those who have gone beyond the ego. To know the truth of the scriptural declarations one must drop one's ego.

“Information and knowledge block the mind from experiencing Truth. The mind and thought waves interfere with true experiencing. Suppose you want to experience the beauty of a flower. To truly experience you need to stop interfering with mental interpretations. Just look at the flower and you will experience its beauty. In the same way, the real meaning of the scriptures can only be known in silence of the mind, then you will really learn them and experience their fullness. To stop the mind from judging is real understanding. Study the scriptures but do not think they are all there is. Do not think that there is nothing beyond just studying the scriptures. Studying the scriptures must be accompanied by spiritual practices. Truth cannot be explained or interpreted. Truth can only be experienced. There is no harm in studying the scriptures with this attitude. Study the scriptures, yet remain as ignorant as a child. Then you will grow internally.”

After a brief pause, Mother said: “Have you heard this story? There was once a Mahatma who, after accepting a young man as his disciple, told him to write down everything he knew about spiritual life. The Mahatma said, ‘You must try to write down everything you know about religion and spirituality. This will be a very good thing for you to do.’ The obedient disciple left and did as he was instructed. More than a year later, he finally com-

pleted the task and returned to the master with a very thick book under his arm. As he gave the book to the master, he said, 'I have worked very hard on this for a year, trying to put down everything I could think of regarding spirituality and religion. The task you gave me is far from complete, but I felt it would be best to show you what I have done.'

"The master looked through the thick sheaf of papers and said to the disciple, 'You have obviously put much time and effort into this. It is a very persuasive, clear and precise discourse, but it is much too long. See if you can shorten it a little.' The young man went away and worked on this task for five years. When he returned to the Guru this time, he presented a document half the size of the first one. The Guru read it and said encouragingly, 'Very good. You have included the essential ideas and truly approached the heart of the matter. And your manner of presentation has clarity and strength. But it is still too long. Try to condense it a little more in order to reach the real essence.'

"Although he was a bit sad hearing this, the disciple accepted what the Guru told him and continued to work hard and long to reach the essence. This time he labored for ten years and when he returned to the master, he bowed low before him and offered merely five pages with all humility, saying, 'This is the distillation of my spiritual knowledge, the very core of my life. This is what lies at the very center of my reason for existence, what religion is to me. I am most grateful to you for having given me this teaching.' This time the master read it carefully and thoroughly. 'Excellent!' he said. 'You have truly arrived at this through spiritual work, but it is not quite perfect

yet. You still need to present a final clarification.'

"Years passed and one day, as the Guru was preparing to cast off his body, his pupil arrived. Prostrating before the master, the disciple handed him a single blank sheet of paper and then asked for his blessing. The master joyously placed his hands on the head of his faithful disciple and bestowed the greatest boon of Self-Realization, saying, 'Now you truly understand. Now you know.' The disciple silently sat at his Guru's feet while his master gave up his mortal frame to journey to the final abode."

Mother paused for a while, then said, "Children, only the attitude 'I am nothing, I know nothing' will help you reach the final state. That alone will help the Guru's Grace flow towards you. Approach the scriptures with that attitude, and you will really learn the scriptures. And even after studying the scriptures, try to maintain the attitude 'I have not studied anything; I know nothing.' This will take you to the goal. Try to remain like a child throughout your life and you will really learn. Study the scriptures with this attitude."



CHAPTER THREE

THE OMNISCIENT GEM

Monday, 20 August, 1984

The early days of the Ashram were special for all who came to be with the Holy Mother. It was a time filled with precious and intimate experiences for the first group of brahmacharins who treasure many unforgettable memories deep in the caverns of their hearts. Mad with love for Mother, they poured their longing into the songs they composed and sang with fervent devotion. Yet at the same time, many obstacles prevented them from having as much contact with Mother as they wanted. The antagonism of Mother's parents towards the brahmacharins added to the intensity of their pining to be in Her presence. So all the songs were full of meaning, expressing the longings of their hearts.

In the beginning Mother's parents thought that their daughter, Sudhamani (Mother's given name), was temporarily mad. They were concerned about the family's reputation, about what people would think, for they expected that one day they would give Her in marriage. Thus they were very worried about the young men who always wanted to be around Mother. They felt that the devotees and the brahmacharins should come only during the Bhava Darshan days and insisted that they leave

the premises immediately after the darshan was over. The moment Mother's parents saw the brahmacharins around Mother they would get very worried and try their best to drive them away. On several occasions Mother's parents sent the brahmacharins home without even letting them see Her.

While Mother's parents did this out of their concern for the family reputation, some of the older devotees tried to keep them away out of jealousy. They thought that Mother's love for them would diminish if the brahmacharins were always around. Eventually it became so difficult for the brahmacharins to pour out their hearts to Mother in person that they began to compose songs expressing their agony. The following song gives an idea of how deeply they felt their sorrows *Karuna nir kadale*. . .

O Mother,
You are the Ocean of Compassion;
If You are not compassionate towards me,
Who else will give me refuge?

O Mother,
My heart is always waiting for You;
Will this day be lost in vain?
Will this day be lost in vain?

Let this human birth be made complete;
Bathe me in the cool waters of Awakening,
Remove my body-consciousness,
And let me merge in the Light of Your soft smile.
O Compassionate Mother,
If I should eventually perish

*Devoid of Your vision,
The coming generations will conclude
That Your compassion is of no avail.*

In the course of time, as Mother's parents and the devotees began to have a better understanding of Mother's transcendent state, they became more accepting of the brahmacharins. But this did not at all diminish the brahmacharins' desire to express their deepest longing through song.

As more spiritual seekers came to be with Mother, Her parents saw that space was needed to accommodate the visitors, so more property was purchased. Mother's family moved to a house situated on the adjacent plot, and the original home consisting of two small bedrooms, a living room, a kitchen, and a storeroom was transferred to the Ashram's name. The room next to the living room was converted into a library. On this particular morning two brahmacharins, Balu and Sreekumar, were sitting in the library composing a new song. Singing new songs to Mother during Devi Bhava had become a regular event. There was a new song almost every Devi Bhava night.

Sreekumar was concentrating on playing the harmonium while Balu was trying to compose the tune. They had outlined the melody for the refrain and were trying to learn that much by heart when, quite unexpectedly, Mother walked in. She stood still for a while, then seeing what they were doing, She suddenly became like a little child. Full of excitement and innocence, She exclaimed, "Hey, are you composing a new song without calling me?" As She said this, Mother started stomping Her feet on the

floor like a stubborn child. Enjoying Mother's *Bala Bhava* (mood of a child), the brahmacharins looked at each other and smiled. As if placating a little girl, they said, "But, Amma, we just started, we have only set music to the refrain!" Totally identified with the mood of a child, Mother kept repeating, "No, no... I don't believe you! You intentionally didn't call me! I'm not going to speak to you! I'm not going to speak to you!" While repeating this over and over again, She sat down on the floor. She then lay down and remained like that without saying a word.

Even though in their heart of hearts they knew that this was a Divine Play and that Mother was the very embodiment of detachment, the brahmacharins felt concerned and a bit sad. Together they called out, "Amma . . . Amma . . . Amma . . .," but to no avail. They promised Her that they would not do such a thing again, but their pleadings and appeals had no effect, so they simply kept quiet. As soon as they stopped their pleading, Mother shot up from the floor and started pulling and pushing at the brahmacharins. She snatched the song sheet from Balu's hands, pushed him down, and started to sing the song. To their amazement, Mother sang the melody of the refrain exactly as they had composed it. Not only that, She went on to sing the next verse. Verse after verse, She went on to sing the entire song in a most beautiful melody perfectly in harmony with the refrain. What Balu and Sreekumar had been trying to do for such a long time was now being done perfectly by Mother within a few minutes. The song was *Idamilla tala yunna*. . .

*I am a wanderer
I have no hearth or home.*

O Mother, give me refuge
And lead me towards You.
Let me not get tossed about in deep waters.
Extend Your saving hand
And take me to the shore.

Like butter poured in fire,
My mind is being burnt in this world.
If a bird should fall,
The earth beneath is there to catch it.
But for me, there is no ground but You.
You are my only Support.

O Mother,
I long to reach Your Lotus Feet.
Haven't I called Your Name?
I never thought
You would forsake this simple child.
Was I wrong?
O Mother, I do not know.

O Mother,
Bless me with a vision of Your Feet.
I am constantly yearning to reach them.
O Mother of the Universe,
Don't I at least deserve this much?
Tell me, when will Your presence
Light up my mind!

This incident, like countless others around Mother, seemed a clear demonstration of the great Upanishadic declaration, 'That Knowledge by knowing which every-

thing is known.' The Guru is infinite. His knowledge is also infinite. There is a famous verse in praise of the Guru which goes like this, 'One does not have to study every branch of knowledge, for all knowledge and its import will dawn within, of its own accord, if one has the Guru's Grace. To that Guru's Feet I humbly bow down.'

An experience Br. Balu had during this period serves as a good illustration. He had a strong desire to play the harmonium to accompany his own singing, for he felt that if he could play the harmonium while he sang, it would help him to merge more deeply into the mood of love and devotion. He tried again and again to play the instrument but was not able to play anything more than the ascending and descending notes. One morning while sitting inside the temple he was going over his usual scales. Shortly after he had begun, Mother walked over to him and said, "I will teach you." She sat down next to Balu, and just like a teacher helping a child write the alphabet, Mother most affectionately held Balu's fingers and pressed them down on the keys. Having done this only once, Mother got up and left, saying, "That is enough."

Balu thought this was just another one of Mother's plays, another fond moment with Mother; he never dreamt that this one harmonium 'lesson' which lasted only a few minutes was going to make a miracle happen. The following day, Balu was inspired to write a song. As he was writing down the lyrics, the melody came simultaneously to his mind. Shortly after the song was written and set to music, he had a strong urge to play it on the harmonium. It was as if someone had asked him to play it. He brought the harmonium to his room, sat down, and began to play. To his amazement, Balu found that he was spontaneously

pressing the right keys. He couldn't believe that such skill could have developed in such a short time. But he knew that it was Mother's Grace which flowed through his fingers. It was Mother's divine touch which enabled him to play the instrument and thus fulfilled his intense desire. And from that day on he could play the harmonium while he sang.

This is the song, *Nilambuja Nayane*, that Balu wrote while learning to play the harmonium.

*O Mother with blue lotus eyes,
Won't You listen to the cries
Of this sorrowing heart?
Is it due to the deeds of some past life
That I am wandering alone?
I have passed through the ages
Before being born again in this life.*

*Please draw me close to You with a motherly hug.
Let me curl up in Your lap, like a child.
O Mother, I may not deserve You,
But will You forsake this child for that reason?
Come and hold me close to You;
Envelope me in Your merciful glance.*

THE THEORY OF KARMA

Wednesday, 22 August, 1984

One afternoon a group of educated men and women who regularly met for spiritual satsang came to see Mother. They were all sitting with Her in a hut. One of them asked,

“Amma, spiritual science is based on the theory of karma. We all believe that one is bound to reap the fruit of one’s actions, yet the theory of karma is difficult to understand. Amma, can you say something about karma and how it works?”

“Son, first of all, you must keep in mind that the theory of karma is a mystery and not easy to understand. You can keep on explaining it, but it will remain a mystery. The theory of karma is not for intellectual analysis; you cannot prove it in the laboratory using scientific instruments.

“You can go on listening for days on end about the law of karma, and you will still remain ignorant about it. Speaking and listening to intellectually convincing talks is like taking a drug, You can become addicted; it can become a habit. So be careful.

“Children, analyzing the law of karma is not so important. The most important thing is to get out of it, to go beyond the cycle of karma, which is caused by ignorance.

“There is another difficulty in trying to give a proper explanation of the law of karma. Negative actions committed in the past may not bear fruit in the immediate future, and the same is true with good actions. We may see a person lacking in virtue who lives a seemingly pleasant life, and we may see a good person suffering for no apparent reason. This may seem to contradict the law of karma; you may even decide that there is no such thing. To see its significance, the law of karma needs to be examined and evaluated from a higher point of consciousness. Otherwise, you may scoff and just ignore it saying, ‘It’s nonsense.’ To rise up and see karma from a higher

level of consciousness, one needs to do spiritual practices and to have faith. Here the measuring rod is not the intellect; it is the heart.

“You can raise a hundred objections to the theory of karma. You can keep on disputing it. You may even find ways to prove that the law of karma is a fallacy; still, the law of karma is operating in your life. You are in its grip. On the other hand, you may prove that the law of karma exists, quoting several incidents and experiences. But have you really understood it? No, you have not.

“A non-believer doesn’t believe in the theory of karma. He may believe in cause and effect as a scientific theory, but not as religious faith. For example, his parents are the cause and he is the effect; the sun is the cause and light is the effect. His faith in the cause and effect theory is associated only with what he can perceive, only with facts. He believes only in what is manifest. He does not have faith in the Absolute, in the unseen. If you have faith in the theory of karma, you must believe in the invisible hands of God. You must believe that the hidden power of God is the cause of that which is manifest.

“It is like this: What caused this lifetime, this presently manifested state? You say, ‘Vasanas from the previous birth caused this life.’ Neither your previous life, nor the vasanas from that life are visible facts; they are just assumptions or suppositions based on faith. So you have to believe in a past lifetime and in the lifetime before that. Again, after this lifetime there will be another, and after that, yet another and another. Thus, the chain continues. Yet, we do not remember our previous lives, nor can we predict what our future lives will be. So, what is this? Pure faith, isn’t it? Unless you can view it all from

a higher point of consciousness, you cannot accept the theory of karma. That is why Amma said it is purely faith.

“All of life moves in cycles; the whole universe is cyclic. Just as the earth moves around the sun in a regular cycle, all of Nature moves in a cyclic pattern. The seasons move in a circle: spring, summer, autumn, winter, then spring again, and so forth. From the seed comes the tree, the tree again provides seeds, and the seeds grow into trees. It is a circle. Likewise, birth, childhood, youth, old age, death, and again, birth. It is a continuous circle. Time moves in a circle, not in a straight line. Karma and its results must inevitably be experienced by every living being until the mind is stilled and one is content in one’s own Self.

“Cycles happen again and again as action and reaction. Time goes in cycles. It is not that the exact events happen over and over again. Rather, the *jivatman* (individual self) assumes different forms according to its *vasanas*. Reactions are the results of actions performed in the past. It goes on and on. Death is not the end; it is the beginning of another life. As the circle of life turns around, the actions of the past bear fruit. We cannot say when the fruit will come, what the fruit will be or how it will come. It is a mystery known only to the Creator. If you have faith, you believe; otherwise, you deny it. Whether you believe or not, the fruits come, the law of karma operates. But do not try to analyze how or why, because the cycle of karma is as mysterious as God. Karma, too, is beginningless, but it ends when one drops the ego, when one attains the state of Realization.

“Man evolves into God. Every human being is essentially God. Evolution from man to God is a slow process. It

requires a lot of cutting, polishing and remolding. It needs a lot of work and requires immense patience. It cannot be done in a hurry. Revolution is fast, but it kills and destroys. Man is revolutionary; God is evolutionary.

“The circle of life moves slowly because life is evolutionary. Summer comes. It takes its own time. It is never in a hurry. All the other seasons—winter, spring and autumn—they all take their own time. The cycle is slow and steady. But do not try to analyze the cycle of life. It cannot be done. The seasons come and go as a fact in the empirical world. But still they are a mystery, an experience. Behind the mystery lies the invisible power of God. That power cannot be analyzed. Have trust in that power.

“Try to forget about the cycle of karma. There is no meaning in thinking about the past. It is a closed chapter. Whatever is done is done. Prepare yourself to confront the present. Don’t brood over the past or over past actions. What is important is the present, because your future depends on how you confront the present. Only when the constant presence of Divinity fills your entire life are you in the present. Until then you live either in the past or in the future.

“The power of karma veils our real nature, while at the same time it creates the urge to realize the Truth. It helps us to go back to our real existence. The circle of karma is a great transformer if you have the eyes to see it. It lets us know the great message: ‘This life of yours is the effect of the past. Therefore beware, your actions in the present determine your future. If you do good you will be rewarded accordingly, but if you commit mistakes or perform evil actions, such actions will return to you with equal strength.’ And to the true spiritual seeker, the

great message says, 'It is better if you can stop the circle completely. Close the account and be free forever.' All these descriptions, explanations of karma serve to restrain humans from doing harm to themselves and others, and to stop them from moving away from their real nature or God."

At this point, Mother stopped talking. Closing Her eyes, She began to sing softly to Herself. She went on for a short while in this way, while everyone strained to hear Her sweet voice. But soon Mother opened Her eyes and asked the brahmacharins who were seated near Her to continue singing the same song, *Oru Nimisham Engilum...*

*O man,
As you run after the pleasures of the world,
Do you experience one moment
Of true peace?*

*Without understanding Reality
Or the essential principles of life,
Haunted and deluded by the shadows of maya,
You will surely perish in agony,
Like a moth in a flame.*

*Throughout the long process of evolution
You have passed through countless different bodies
Of innumerable insects, worms and reptiles,
Plants and animals,
Until at last
You have emerged
As a human being.*

O man,
Think clearly and use your discrimination!
What is the purpose of this human birth?
Surely it is not to be wasted
In the pursuit of trivial worldly pleasures.
Remember, a human birth is
A precious opportunity
And a great responsibility.

O man,
Without giving up your false pride,
Your desire to acquire and possess,
Your desire to enjoy and indulge,
Without attaining the state of eternal union
With the Supreme Brahman
Peace and bliss can never be yours.

A few moments after the brahmacharins had finished singing, Mother opened Her eyes. One devotee was extremely eager for Mother to continue Her talk on karma. Breaking the silence, he said, “Amma, it seemed that you didn’t finish talking about the law of karma. Please, won’t you say some more.”

“Children, Amma will tell you a story. Once there was an old man who had worked very hard his entire life to build a farm for his children and his grandchildren. He carved this farm out of the wilderness and managed to survive seasons of drought, storms and pestilence. After many years of toiling in the fields and tending the crops, he decided it was time for him to retire and spend his remaining years sitting on the front porch and contem-

plating the universe. His son had a family of his own and was eager to be master of the land. So the old man let him take over, happy to now relax in his favorite chair on the porch after all those years of back-breaking toil.

“At first when the son took over the farm, he was proud that finally he was the master. He too worked hard and spent long days and years fighting the elements and working in the fields. Little by little, he began to resent his father’s laziness as the old man would spend all day looking up at the blue sky or bouncing the grandchildren on his knee. His resentment grew day by day. He looked upon his father as just another mouth to feed, and the more he thought about it, the more he was convinced that his father was a tremendous burden. ‘What does it matter that he worked hard all those years?’ the son thought to himself. ‘Times have changed. I have my own family to feed and take care of now. Why should I take care of him?’ Thus he grew angrier and angrier so that by harvest time he didn’t want to share any food with ‘that useless old fellow on the porch.’ In fact, he decided it was time to get rid of the old man once and for all.

“So, he built a large wooden box out of teak, brought it in a wheelbarrow to his father and demanded that the old man climb in. Without a word, the father bowed his head and did as he was told. The son snapped the brass hinges shut, wheeled the box to a cliff, and just as he was about to dump it over the side, he heard a knocking from within the box.

“‘What do you want?’ the son shouted. His father’s voice from within the box was soft and gentle, ‘You know, I understand your feelings. If you want to get rid of me, I fully understand. You think I’m just a useless old man.

But, before you throw me over the cliff, just let me out of the box and then you can shove my body over the side. I'd save the box if I were you; your children may have use for it someday.”

Everyone laughed at Mother's story and She laughed along with Her children. As the laughter subsided, Mother now spoke in a serious tone, “Children, our actions will return to each one of us, whether one is a non-believer or a believer. Man is a victim of his karma or fate, whatever you want to call it. You may argue or raise objections. You may even convince others that the law of karma is a logical fallacy. But all this verbal jugglery and speculation cannot in any way stop the law of karma from continuing.

“Amma has heard of a weapon called a boomerang, which flies through the air and eventually returns to the person who threw it. Karma is like a boomerang which you fail to catch most of the time, so it hits you. The only difference is the karma boomerang may not return immediately. It may come back only after some time. That is what the old man reminded his son of when he said, ‘I think your children may have use for the box someday.’ He was telling his son, ‘Remember, my son, that your son will settle the debt and close the account with you.’ This settling of accounts may happen now, during this lifetime, or it may not happen until some future life. We cannot say. But no matter what your philosophy or beliefs, it is bound to happen. Keep in mind that this old man was himself reaping the fruits of his own actions. He probably did something similar to his father or to someone else.

“This circle will continue until you stop reacting to

the present, which is the effect of the past. When you can accept present experiences as inevitable, as the consequences of your own actions, and face them without any thought of anger or revenge, then the circle of karma will stop moving.

“You have already created the necessary circumstances for whatever events are happening. And even now, through your actions, you are preparing the ground for your future. When the time is ripe, your actions will bear fruit; you will find yourself helpless in the grip of your own karma.

“Many undesirable events happen in your life. You suffer without knowing why. All your attempts to earn a living end up in vain. Unexpected accidents happen and untimely deaths occur in your family. A certain hereditary disease may afflict your family, newborn babies are physically deformed or mentally retarded. Are such events accidental? No. Each thing that happens in life has a cause. Sometimes the cause is visible, and at other times it is not. Sometimes the cause is to be found in the immediate past, but in some cases it stems from the remote past. For example, a great musician may be born into a family which, if you were to trace several generations back, had no musicians at all. How does this happen? What is the ‘cause’ for a great musician to be born into a non-musical family? If it is not heredity, what could it be?

“Suppose you get up one morning and as you are walking to the bathroom, you find that you are very tired and weak. After climbing just a few stairs, you gasp and struggle for breath. You feel dizzy and faint. Without much delay you are taken to the hospital and you are diagnosed as having a kidney problem. Now, did the kidney trouble

begin just that morning? Did it appear without any particular cause? No, there is a cause. The disease was there, but in a dormant state. The disease manifested its symptoms only that morning. Would you say that this ailment is accidental? There has to be a cause for it, hasn't there?

"Nothing is accidental. Nature is not accidental. Creation is not an accident. The sun, moon, ocean, trees and flowers, mountains and valleys are not accidents. Planets move around the sun without straying even an inch from their predetermined orbits. The oceans cover vast areas of the globe, without swallowing up the entire earth. If this beautiful creation were simply accidental, it would not be so orderly and systematic. The universe would be a mess. But look at the beauty and charm of creation. Can you call this an accident? The vast pattern of beauty and order that pervades all of creation makes very clear that there is a big heart and a great intelligence behind everything.

"Children, our past is not just the past of this lifetime. It is not just a tracing back from now to the birth of this present body. The past is also all the previous lifetimes through which we have traveled in different names and forms. The future cannot be seen either; it is not under our control. We cannot predict what will happen tomorrow. The truth of karma is therefore more a matter of faith than anything else.

"We must be alert and careful about what we do today because we do not know what effect it will produce tomorrow. The present is this moment and we always miss this moment. Moment-to-moment living, in God, in Self alone, will stop the law of karma operating in us.

"Children, once you realize the Self, your true nature,

you come to know all about karma. The mysteries of your previous births will also be revealed to you. You will realize the secret of the entire universe, the entire creation. Until then, you keep on asking questions about karma, trying to arrive at your own interpretations and explanations. Self-realization alone will clear the mystery. But once you attain Perfection, you will know that the real Self was and is ever-present. You will know that the true Self was never born nor will it die, and that it is never subject to the law of karma.

“Of course, the law of karma does exist, but it is more an experience of faith than fact. A fact can be proven, but faith is the strong feeling of the heart which cannot be logically proven.”

After the last statement, Mother repeated, “Shiva... Shiva... Shiva...” circling Her right hand in the air. Then She sat in a totally absorbed mood as one of the scholars chanted a few verses from the *Soundarya Lahari*...

O Mother!
The crest of the Veda
Bears your Feet as its crown.
May You be merciful and place those Feet
On my head also.
The water offered to Your Feet
Forms the river Ganges
In the matted locks of Shiva.
And the lustrous red powder on Your Feet
Lends its glorious light
To the jewels in Vishnu’s diadem.

*By way of praise
 We offer our prostrations at Your Feet
 That are a delight to the eye
 Because of their brilliance
 Which arises from the lacquer-like dye
 Applied to them.
 Your Consort, Pasupati (Shiva)
 Longs to be kicked by those Feet
 And is jealous of the Asoka tree
 In Your pleasure garden;
 As even that tree
 Is a rival aspirant for such kicks.*

When the chanting was over, another devotee asked, "Amma, sometimes a true seeker undergoes a lot of hardship and difficulties. Why does that happen?"

"Children," said Mother, "you may see a person, who really wants to surrender and become a devotee or a real disciple, undergoing a lot of difficulties and problems. This is because such a person is going through a process of purification. All their darkness needs to be removed. It is not only this dirt that you see on the surface, the dirt you are aware of; it is also the dirt that you cannot see and are not aware of. So when you start the process of purification, approaching it with an attitude of self-surrender, naturally all this dirt, both seen and unseen, both ~~the manifest~~ the manifested and unmanifested, will come up.

"The other day one of the western children told Amma that in his country they can purify and convert even drainage water into good drinking water. How do they do that? By removing all the dirt. Drainage water will have all kinds of dirt and impurities in it. Without re-

moving the dirt, how can it be converted into drinking water? Similarly, now we are like drainage water filled with all kinds of impurities and negativity. Just as this dirty water is cleansed through several processes, we too need intense cleansing. When a true seeker or a devotee passes through this sometimes painful process of purification, which is really the exhaustion of his vasanas, a non-believer or a skeptic may use this example as proof that God does not exist. 'If God exists, why does he have to suffer like this?' such a person will say.

"The suffering and problems that you may witness in the life of a person, who is trying to become a true disciple or devotee, is actually speeding up his or her process of purification. Through the exhaustion of both the seen and unseen vasanas, the karmic bondage is being dissolved. What he wants is freedom from all worldly ties and his attitude of self-surrender makes this happen. A real seeker is trying to dissolve his mind and go beyond the intellect and body. Only a person who has been in jail for a long time can enjoy the bliss of freedom. Similarly, only a seeker who has undergone a Guru's disciplining is able to experience the freedom of Realization.

"This quickening may not happen in the case of a devotee who wants to keep his attachments, possessions, name and fame. His evolution will be extremely slow. You will see him living in the lap of luxury, enjoying life. But in this way he is adding more to his existing vasanas, which in turn lengthens the chain of his karmic cycle. Through indulgence and enjoyment, the distance to travel back to the real source of existence also increases; whereas by burning up karma, the true devotee or disciple is returning more quickly to his true nature, the Self."

In a somber tone, Mother added, "Man is bound to go through the cycle. The law of karma is his day-to-day experience, but still he does not believe in it, nor does he try to transcend it."

In great wonderment the devotees and the scholars sat listening to Mother's profound words. There was stillness for a few moments. Many times in the past Mother would not even open Her mouth if a question about karma or life after death were asked. She would just put a full stop to the entire topic saying, "It cannot be explained. It is pure experience. It is too controversial." Or She would say, "You don't need an explanation. Try to escape from the cycle of karma rather than speculate about it." But now Mother was speaking at great length on the subject. Her words, real knowledge from the heights, invisible streams of truth pouring down from the original source, flowed like the rolling waters of the Ganges to the ears of all those present. One could almost touch the teaching, feel it, imbibe it, and carry it in the heart as a precious and unforgettable gift from Mother, a gift to cherish and remember and contemplate during times of hardship.

No one spoke or moved for some time. It was as if everyone had entered into a trance through the power of Mother's sweet words.

"Amma, this is something remarkable," one of the visitors eventually remarked. "Your words have helped to clear many of our doubts. Every Sunday a few of us gather at the house of a devotee. We discuss different topics, read from the scriptures and share our experiences of you. We chant and meditate. The law of karma and its effects has been one of our main topics of discussion. Now, it has been made clear to us. But Amma, I still have

a doubt. You mentioned that man falls victim to the hands of the karmic cycle. Does this mean there is no escape from this law of karma?”

“No, no,” replied Mother, “that is not what it means. For one who does not have faith in a Supreme Power or ideal, there is no escape from the grip of karma. A believer, knowing that he has to reap the fruits of his actions, will perform spiritual practices like *japa*, meditation and prayer. These practices and the good actions which he performs serve as a neutralizer. The good actions in the present nullify the effects of past bad actions. Faith in God or the Guru gives a person immense strength to confront the inevitable karma. Faith in the Guru or God serves as an armor, a protective force. Even though the karmic cycle operates, its effects will be very much lessened due to his faith. Here we are talking about a person who believes in God but is leading an ordinary life in the world. He may not be so intent on stopping the cycle of karma. He may react, get angry and commit bad actions. He may have desires and want to accumulate wealth. But, because he believes in God, he will also perform spiritual practices such as meditation and prayer; and he will do good actions, giving food to the poor, etc. Thus his actions are balanced. This balance helps him to overcome the difficult situations which arise in his life.

“But the way in which a sadhak, a true seeker, faces karma is entirely different from the way of an ordinary believer. A sadhak is not worried about whether the results of his karma will bring good or bad experiences. He is not worried whether fortune or misfortune befalls him. A true seeker puts all his energy into going deeper and

deeper into his own consciousness. He doesn't want to bother about the fruits of his actions. Surrendering himself completely to the Divine, he concentrates fully on doing spiritual practices. He simply allows everything to happen in its own natural way; he does not fight back. He knows that his karma is like an arrow which has already been released from the bow. The arrow must hit the target. The arrow might hurt, injure, or even kill him, but for him it doesn't matter if that should happen. It is like the phonograph needle running in the grooves of a record. The song has to play as long as the needle of life goes through the grooves. The song may be a terrible or a good one. Either way, he has produced it himself; it is his own voice. He knows that he alone has to confront whatever he must, even if it is painful. He will not want to run away from his karma, because he knows that it is a process of purification and that it is cleansing the stains created by him in the past, in some previous life. He wants to speed up the process. He knows fighting back or reacting will lengthen the chain of karma; therefore, he remains calm. Also, in the case of a sadhak, karma cannot operate with the same power or intensity that it would under other circumstances or with other people. The power of his spiritual practices will create a protective force around him. And above all, the true seeker will always have the protection and Grace of the Guru. Therefore, even in the most difficult times, he will receive solace and help.

"Children, a real seeker closes the flow of the mind to the past and the future. He tries to confront the present intelligently and with discrimination. He accepts the present circumstances without reacting to them. Any reaction will lengthen the chain of karma; for this reason, he tries not

to react. His sole aim is to stop the chain of karma and its fruits.

“One can easily overcome one’s karma through the Grace of a *Satguru*. Obey the instructions given by a Perfect Master and you will emerge victorious from all trials and tribulations. Every human being is destined to pass through certain experiences, some good, some bad. But if you follow the instructions of a *Satguru*, you will come out of all such ordeals unscathed. Your faith in the Guru will fill your heart and soul with immense strength and courage. Even death cannot touch you if you have the *Satguru*’s guidance and Grace.”

FAITH

“But Amma, everything depends on faith, doesn’t it? What about a person who has no faith?”

“Yes, of course,” Mother replied. “Love and faith are necessary in order to have strength and courage. Faith alone can cause the *Satguru*’s constant flow of Grace to reach us.

“Children, there are many people whose faith is foolish. They do not have real faith. The question of real faith makes them suspicious and skeptical, and will cause a hundred doubts to crop up in their minds. They are unable to have real faith because they are filled with more fear and doubt than with love and trust. Yet, they have no fear or doubt about their television set or other perishable things. Even supposedly intelligent people place all their trust in things like their cars, televisions and homes. These objects can break down at any moment, yet people have great faith in them. What a pity! They have no faith

in the imperishable Atman, which is their own existence.

“Now, ask one of these people to have faith in a mantra, a prayer or a meditation technique. Or ask him to have faith in a Mahatma or God. He will ask you a hundred questions. He will express his doubts and fears. He cannot trust them. He might say, ‘You know, I have very little time to do such things. Not only that, I consider my work as my sadhana. Also, I do not think that these things really work. Nowadays, spiritual people do more harm to society than anyone else.’ His excuses will go on and on. The fact is, he does not want to believe. For him, his car, house and TV are enough. His faith in those objects makes him feel happy. Now, isn’t this a foolish faith?

“Children, let me tell you a story. There was once a man who was very ill. One day he slipped into a coma and everyone thought he was dead. So the undertakers took his body, washed it and placed it in a coffin. Arrangements were made for the funeral, and a priest was invited to perform the last rites. As the coffin was being carried to the graveyard, the pall bearers heard a knock coming from inside the coffin. They set the coffin down and opened it. Everyone gathered around as the ‘dead’ man spoke, ‘I’m not dead. I haven’t died. Let me out of this box.’ But they said, ‘I am sorry, sir. You can’t be alive. The doctor has certified your death and the priest has also confirmed it.’ Whereupon, they closed the lid and the man was buried as planned.” Laughter filled the air.

After a brief pause, Mother continued, “Our belief in our televisions and cars, even our faith in the body that we carry around, is foolish unless we understand their appropriate place and significance in our lives. If you look around and closely observe people’s lives, you can see that

lack of faith is the cause of all their troubles. Without faith you have no feelings, no heart, no love. This is a universal truth; it applies everywhere to everybody. Without faith you will be full of fear. Fear cripples you; it makes you paralyzed.

“Placing much trust in ‘qualifications,’ in certificates and degrees, people have faith in a doctor’s or a scientist’s words, though the doctor or the scientist is stuck in the intellect, and therefore limited. But, because he has no impressive qualifications, they will doubt the words and authenticity of a Mahatma, one who has delved deep into the deepest mysteries of the universe, and has unlimited wisdom and power.

“A person who has no faith will be unduly sensitive and fragile. Anyone or anything can hurt him—even a word or a look will make him feel dejected and sad. He will tremble in the face of difficulty. He cannot think or act with discrimination. In a moment of weakness, such people may even end their own lives; whereas a person with faith can keep in good spirits all the time. No matter what circumstances you find yourself in, your faith protects you. Amma is of course talking about unshakable faith in God or in a Perfect Master, a Satguru.”

“But, Amma, people who have no faith in the existence of a Supreme Power also live normal lives, don’t they?” one of the visitors asked.

Mother said, “You may find people without faith who lead normal lives without many problems or troubles, and you may wonder, ‘This person has no faith in God or a Higher Principle, but still his life is all right. He looks happy and seems to be satisfied with everything that he has.’ But your observation and judgment are based only

on external appearances. He may seem okay from the outside, but you cannot know what is going on inside. It is quite likely there will be a dryness within him and that he will lack a zest for life. He will feel a constant anxiety about his life, and will rarely be relaxed. Unable to have faith in anything, such a person can be very narrow-minded and loveless. Unable to handle even his own problems, he won't pause to listen to those of his wife and children. Impatient with others, he can easily get angry and hurt people, and no one will want to be his friend.

"People like this continue their way of living for some time until they become aware of their dryness. This realization will help them to finally turn to something that can fill what is missing in their lives. That gap cannot be filled by anything but faith and love. Life becomes full and complete only when the heart is filled with faith in a Supreme Power. Until then, the search for filling the gap will continue. We all hope to fill it with different things. We try to fill it by working hard. We grab onto objects and try to derive enjoyment from them. But this gap remains. Not only that, the gulf may get even bigger.

"Each object we cling to and each petty desire we fulfill is like a shore where we think we can rest and be still. Remember, each leap to a shore, each attempt to find stability in the world outside, actually increases the gap of our dissatisfaction. The time to return to the shore of our real existence is getting longer. Soon we will find all the shores where we hoped to rest are crumbling and sinking. All things we place our faith and hope in will one day prove useless and meaningless. That day will come sooner or later. Yet until then, we remain unfulfilled because

of our lack of faith. We remain skeptical and rigid. But one day we will surely call out, 'O God, I am helpless. Come and save me. Help me! Protect me!' We will call out when we realize that all hopes end in hopelessness.

"The so-called intellectuals or high thinkers who deny the existence of God, and rely on the power of their intellect alone, often consider themselves superior to others, especially to those whose faith in God is strong. But actually, they are the losers; they are the unlucky ones. By not having faith they miss all life's beauty and charm; but they do not understand that. Suppose you see a precious stone lying by the side of the road. What if you simply walk by without picking it up? You lose the opportunity to own it, don't you? You are the one who has missed a great chance. The gem will of course remain precious and priceless, and another person who recognizes its value will be made rich just by picking it up. Instead of admitting your mistake, instead of confessing your blindness, you will defend yourself, saying that the precious stone was a fake, or that you don't care about it at all. Skeptics defend their beliefs in a similar way. But God is not worried if human beings don't believe in Him. Those who are without faith in the Divine are the losers. Without love, such people lack vitality; they are like living corpses. The beauty and charm of life will not shine through people like this. Nobody will be attracted to them; nobody will feel inspired by their actions or words. People will not care about them. Even their own wife and children will find it difficult to put up with them. But the day will come when they will also call out, 'Help! God!'"

SURRENDER TO FACE KARMA

The visitor asked, “Amma, is there a particular period of time in one’s life when this law of karma starts operating? Is it possible to get a hint or sign before it happens?”

With a mischievous smile on Her face, Mother replied, “When the egoistic feelings of ‘I’ and ‘mine’ come up, that is when the law of karma begins to operate on you. When the ego arises, you forget God. You act and talk against the laws of nature. You degenerate in every way. All your virtues and good qualities, like concern for others, love and forgiveness disappear. That is when the law of karma takes effect. When you start brooding about the past, when you start criticizing and insulting others and blame them for the mishaps that happen in your own life, when you plan and dream about a future of promises and forget to live in the present, that is when the law of karma starts operating in you. Both in the case of an individual and in the case of society as a whole, this happens when God is forgotten. When God is forgotten, people enter into the cycle of karma. Certainly this life and the body itself are the results of karma. But there is an intelligent and healthy way to let karma operate in our lives, a way that can allow us to lead a happy and joyful life while confronting each karmic or predestined experience.”

Another visitor asked, “What is this intelligent and healthy way of exhausting the karmic experiences?”

“Never forget your true Self,” answered Mother. “Never forget that your real existence is in God and all that you claim as your own is just passing. If this can become our

slogan and if we can practice it in our everyday life, that is the most intelligent way to exhaust our karmic experiences.

“Never forget God. Never forget your real Source. Never move away from the real center within you. Can you do this? If so, you can overcome the law of karma. If this is practiced, karma and its effects cannot harm you. Karma becomes impotent through God’s or the Guru’s Grace.

“Without Grace one cannot confront destiny. Human effort is, of course, powerful. But human beings lack discrimination. They act out of egotism, and because of this, their actions are ultimately ineffectual in the face of destiny. Surrender to the *Paramatman*. Perform your actions in the world without feeling proud of your power; pray for, and try to feel, God’s presence in all that you do, and be thankful for His Grace. This is what is most important. Human beings think that it is possible to oppose destiny. But they cannot. Try to fight with any amount of power and force, and you will be defeated. You will be completely disarmed. You will be crushed under destiny’s weight.”

A question followed, “Amma, are you saying that man is completely helpless in the face of karma or destiny?”

Mother answered, “No, that is not the point. The point is to face karma, confront it without feeling egoistic about your own power, but by invoking and relying on God. God’s power can be invoked only when you surrender to Him. Surrender is becoming humble, being able to bow down low. Children, humility is the way. Bow low and karma will miss you; it will go over your head because you are the servant of God and thus protected by Him.

“Amma would like to relate to you two incidents which

happened during Lord Krishna's life. Both happened during the great battle of Kurukshethra. Here is the first example. When Drona, the great teacher of weaponry for both the Pandavas and Kauravas, was killed by the Pandavas, Aswathama, his son, flew into a rage. He was so upset by the treacherous killing of his father, that he shot the Narayanastra, the most destructive missile of all. Spitting fire and producing thousands of other destructive weapons from within, the powerful missile created havoc in the Pandava forces. Within seconds, thousands of soldiers were killed. Lord Krishna was the only one who knew how to avoid this great missile. He ran through the battalions of soldiers, instructing everybody to relinquish all their weapons and lie down on the ground. Krishna's command was immediately obeyed, and the entire Pandava force lay down, except for Bhima, the second Pandava brother. He remained on the battle field, shouting and challenging the deadly weapon. He did not want to surrender. He absolutely refused to give up his own weapons and lie down. Wanting to have a face-to-face encounter with the great Narayanastra missile, he boldly kept on challenging the missile and taunting Aswathama. Thus Bhima, one of the strongest men in the world, stood fearlessly in front of the arrow.

"Unfortunately the arrow was extremely powerful and proved too colossal even for him. The fire it emitted slowly began enveloping Bhima. Still, he danced around, shouting and jumping like an enraged fireball. Seeing the inevitable danger that threatened Bhima, the Lord and Arjuna came rushing over, calling out loudly, begging him, 'Bhima, throw your weapons away and lie down!' But all their pleading was in vain. Finally, both Krishna and Arjuna

seized all of Bhima's weapons and threw them away. Together they grabbed him and forced him down. The effect was immediate; the powerful missile withdrew and moved away from Bhima.

"Now, children, the powerful Narayanastra represents karma. Nothing could prevent it from attacking the soldiers; even the strongest and most powerful warriors like Bhima were helpless against its might. Only the Lord's command, 'Lie low, be humble,' could save them. Bhima was egotistic. He thought that through his strength, he could win. But he was attacked and almost defeated. He would have become a handful of ashes in a few moments, had it not been for the intervention of the Lord. Bhima had acted out of his own volition. He had put forth his own effort. He had tried to fight back. That was action, but wrong action in the wrong place and at the wrong time.

"The Lord Himself instructed, 'Lie low, abandoning all your weapons.' But Bhima was too egotistic to do that. He thought, 'I am great. I am powerful. Nothing can defeat me.' Most people are egotistic and think that they can do many things. But destiny is much more potent and will destroy you unless you are adhering to the words of a Perfect Master or God. Even then, the Lord saved him because Bhima was willing to surrender. He had always obeyed Krishna's word. So the Lord was compassionate towards him and saved him.

"Children, in the face of karmic experiences all your weapons of ego and strength are powerless unless you abandon them, following the Guru's instructions and throw yourself down in humble surrender. You cannot escape karma. If God's or the Guru's Grace is with you, the arrow of karma, which has already left the bow of your past

life, cannot hurt you.”

After a short pause, Mother continued, “Now, listen to this second incident from the same battlefield of the *Mahabharata*. In the fight between Arjuna and Karna, Karna was far superior in wielding the bow and arrow. Intending to sever Arjuna’s head, he shot a divine missile. Lord Krishna, Arjuna’s charioteer, foresaw this great karmic danger coming towards Arjuna. Immediately the compassionate Lord, pressing hard with his big toe, made all four horses kneel down. Also, the powerful pressure of the Lord’s big toe pushed the chariot wheels a few inches down into the earth. This made the arrow take away Arjuna’s crown without injuring any part of his body.

“Here also there are a few points to remember. First of all, the Lord himself was Arjuna’s charioteer. This means that Arjuna chose the Lord as the person to hold the reins of his life’s chariot. Before the whole battle had begun, Arjuna and Duryodhana were given two choices. Krishna told them, ‘I can give My entire army to one of you, but I won’t come. Or I can come without any weapons as your charioteer, and the army will help your foe. Which do you choose, Me or My army?’ Without any hesitation whatsoever, Arjuna said, ‘I want you, Lord. You alone are enough. I don’t need the army.’ So Arjuna chose the Lord as his Master. Through his self-surrender, Arjuna could obtain the Lord’s Grace. Arjuna knew how to discriminate. He did not choose human soldiers as his friends and helpers. He chose the Divine Lord alone to help him. That makes a big difference. The Grace of the Lord lets the karmic arrow pass over your head, maybe destroying an insignificant crown or something similar, but saving you from a fatal mishap.

“Arjuna was powerful, but not as powerful as Karna. Arjuna is action, human effort; Karna is the destiny in store for you. Karna was more powerful than Arjuna. But all of Arjuna’s efforts would have failed to save his life from Karna’s fatal arrow had the Almighty Lord’s Grace not been there. You see, Duryodhana had a bigger and better army than the Pandavas. He had many great warriors on his side. His army was stronger in every way. Duryodhana and his army represent human power and strength without the aspect of Grace. The Pandavas had Krishna, the Lord, the very source of Grace and power, on their side. The battle was destined to happen. Nobody could avert it. It was the culmination of all the past actions performed by both the Kauravas and the Pandavas. It was the fruit of their actions. But self-surrender, faith, and devotion helped the Pandavas overcome the situation, whereas arrogance, wickedness, and egotism ruined the Kauravas. They easily fell victim to the powerful force of karma.”

Mother stopped and then said, “Children, enough talking for now.”

One of the visitors in the group was trained in classical Indian music and had composed several songs. He expressed a wish to sing for Mother. Sitting down at the harmonium, he sang *Paravasamannen Hridayam*. . .

O Mother,
My mind is deeply distressed
By many distracting thoughts.
Don’t wait any longer;
Pay attention to this destitute!

Please know that I am helplessly falling

*Into the depths of the sea.
O Mother, whose glorious past is known to all,
Won't You come
And soothe my weeping eyes?*

*My mind is confused
With countless waves of despair
I am floundering in a sea of fire,
Without ever reaching the shore,
Without having caught a glimpse Your Lotus Feet.*

When the devotee began to sing, Mother closed Her eyes and sat in perfect meditative posture. The man sang with much feeling, and all who were present were obviously moved. As the song ascended to its peaks, the scholar singing through tears, Mother raised Her right hand. The ring finger and the middle finger were folded down and the rest of the fingers were held up straight in the gesture of a divine *mudra*. Her left hand rested on Her thigh and a beaming smile lit Her face. Even after the song was over, Mother remained in this state. Her divine mood inspired the scholar to sing another song, *Ehi Murare...*

*O Destroyer of the demons Mura and Madhu,
O Kesava, Ocean of Compassion,
The Friend of those who approach You with humility,
Frequenter of the forest groves,
O Blessed One, with a beautiful face,
Come to me!*

*O Krishna,
Serene Madhusudana,*

*There are hundreds of honey bees
Within the forest groves.
Krishna, my playful Beloved,
O serene Madhusudana,
I beg You for the gift of Your Darshan!*

*O Radha's enchanter,
Slayer of Kamsa,
O Krishna, I prostrate at Your Feet
That remove all sorrow.
O Janardana, clad in a yellow garment,
Come to me in the Mandhara grove!*

Everyone responded to this second song with great love and devotion, some clapping the rhythm as they sang. A few minutes after the song was over, everyone left the hut as instructed by one of the senior brahmacharins. Having been transported to some other realm by the devotee's songs, Mother remained in Her sublime state for some time.



CHAPTER FOUR

Monday, 3 September, 1984

Early in the morning near the temple verandah, Mother was consoling a woman from the neighborhood who was weeping and complaining about her husband. “Ammachi,” she said. “Am I destined to suffer like this for the rest of my life? I have seven children. The eldest girl is still not married and she is already twenty-eight years old. My son, the fifth child, is very brilliant in his studies, and I am trying to send him to school. We need to create a better situation at home so he can concentrate on his studies, but my husband spoils everything. He doesn’t work to support us financially, and he offers no emotional support either.”

Unable to control herself any longer, the woman sat down on the temple verandah and burst into tears. Mother sat next to her and gently lifted the woman’s head. She said, “Daughter, don’t worry,” as She wiped away the woman’s tears. “Amma will try to talk to your husband. Let’s hope that he will listen to Amma. If he continues to be disruptive and does not mend his ways, Amma will think of a way to help you. Don’t cry. Be calm.”

Putting the woman's head on Her shoulder, Mother kissed her cheeks and continued to express her affection and concern. The woman began to relax. "Ammachi," she said, obviously somewhat consoled, "he has a lot of respect for you, and has only good things to say. But he is not very reliable."

Mother replied, "Just let Amma try." She stood up and was about to walk away when the woman called out, "Ammachi!" Mother turned around, "What is it, daughter? Do you need something?" With a bit of hesitation she said, "Ammachi, there is no food in the house. There has been no work for me for the last two days. Until yesterday I could somehow manage with the little savings I had, but today there is not even a single penny in the house. Besides, my son who is good in his studies has a very high fever. I have no means to take him to the hospital or purchase any medicine the doctor might prescribe."

Mother smilingly said, "Why do you hesitate to tell Amma this?" After saying this She asked Kunjumol standing nearby to call Gayatri. Gayatri arrived in a few minutes and Mother whispered something in her ear. Gayatri left and while waiting for her to return, Mother began some light talk with the village woman.

Whenever Mother talks with the village neighbors, She becomes one of them and one with them. They feel so at home with Her that they pour out their hearts fully. They tell Her everything, from the most personal to the most mundane. Mother does not show any impatience. She listens attentively to all that they have to say and makes them feel comfortable and relaxed. Many of them are not devotees, and some don't even believe in God. Yet they are all somehow touched by Mother. After talking

to Mother about their problems, one can hear them say, "Whatever it may be, She gives great relief and confidence."

Gayatri soon returned with a cloth bag filled with rice, fruits, and vegetables. Mother took the bag from her and handed it to the woman. Turning to Gayatri, Mother said, "You give the money." Gayatri handed some money to the woman while Mother explained to her that it was to be used for taking her son to the hospital and for the purchase of any required medication. The village woman left the Ashram with a heart full of gratitude and love.

LIVE IN ANTICIPATION OF THE LORD

Afterwards Mother went to the brahmacharins' huts, where She spent a few minutes in each hut, giving instructions to the brahmacharins about how to hang their clothes, how to keep their altar properly, how to keep their books and personal things in an orderly way, and other such advice. In one hut there was a brahmacharin who was not very neat and did not keep the hut clean. Many of his things were lying around the room and the picture on the altar was full of dust. With a serious look on Her face, Mother turned to the brahmacharin and said, "Son, is this the way to keep your room? Only a person who has no *sraddha* or *bhakti* will do this. Look at your clothes. See how the books are scattered all over the floor. Look how dusty this picture is, your *dhyana rupam* (form of meditation)."

Mother picked up the picture and showing it to everyone, said, "Look at this picture. This is the form he meditates on. Look how careless he is about the dhyana

rupam. Can a person who has love for his Beloved Deity or his Guru do something like this? It is said that one should love one's Beloved Deity as much as one loves oneself." Turning to the careless brahmacharin, She continued, "It is quite obvious that you have not cleaned this picture for a long time. This shows that you have no love for your Beloved Deity.

"Children, a sadhak is supposed to see divinity or the presence of his Guru or God everywhere. When a person tries to see and feel the Divine Presence everywhere, he will value external cleanliness. He thinks that his God, or his *Ishta Devata*, dwells everywhere, walks everywhere, and sits everywhere. With intense love and devotion, the sadhak waits with great expectation for His arrival. The seeker has unquenchable thirst to drink in His beauty, to fill his heart with the Lord's presence, so he anxiously waits. In each footstep he hears, in each movement he feels, in each and everything he looks at, he hopes to behold his Lord, his Beloved God or Goddess. He cannot offer a dirty and dingy place to his Lord. He cannot welcome Him to a place that is messy and not clean. The Lord is his Beloved. But he also knows that the Lord is omnipotent, omnipresent and omniscient, and that He is purer than the purest. This awareness fills him with awe and reverence.

"What do you offer to the person you love most, to the person who is dearest to you? What would you want to give him or her? Only good things. You would never think of offering anything bad to such a person, would you? No. So, the love and affection to the Lord, your Beloved Deity or your Guru, is reflected in your actions, in the beauty of your actions. This does not mean that

God will accept only what is good. It is true that He will accept anything that is offered with love and devotion. But we have not reached that state of supreme love where everything, even your own individuality, is forgotten. In that state of supreme love both purity and impurity are transcended.

“Constant waiting, waiting with intense longing for the Lord’s or the Guru’s arrival is the sign of a true devotee. Such a seeker is always ready to receive Him; therefore, he is always prepared both internally and externally to welcome his Guru or the Lord.”

One brahmacharin asked, “Amma, could you elaborate on what you mean by waiting?”

“Son, waiting eagerly for the Lord should be a sadhak’s constant mental attitude. Each moment you wait you should be prepared to receive and welcome Him. Your altar is not just a place to keep pictures; it is a special place for your Lord to dwell. When you have this feeling, you can never be messy or unclean. Even if your house or your dwelling place is small, even if it is tiny, you should keep it clean. Try to make it serene like a temple. The surroundings should also be kept in the same way. Your room should be rearranged, reorganized, and kept clean in such a way that it should look like you are constantly waiting to welcome your Lord. The remembrance that ‘my Lord’ or ‘my Mother’ can step in at any moment will certainly help you keep the room clean and tidy, for you will want to make it suitable for Him or Her to come in and be seated. Your mental attitude, your purity and cleanliness will be reflected in your actions as well.

“You have heard of Sabari, the great devotee of Lord Rama. That was her attitude. Every moment of her life

she was waiting for her Lord. She thought, 'He might walk in at any time. So I should be well-prepared to welcome Him.' And she was. Sabari always kept her house and its surroundings beautifully clean. Every day she cleaned the room and kept the bed prepared for the Lord to rest. Each day she decorated the house, and not one day passed when she forgot to pave the pathway to her simple home with fresh and fragrant flowers. She plucked the freshest and choicest fruits for the Lord to eat. All the puja articles for the ceremonial washing of the Lord's feet were always kept shining and ready to be used. The seat for her Lord to sit on was beautifully decorated every single day. Sweet fragrance filled the atmosphere. Every morning Sabari made a garland with freshly plucked flowers. The Lord's name was constantly on her lips. With eyes fixed on the pathway, Sabari, the great devotee, waited and waited and waited, for long, long years.

"The Gopis also waited in the same manner after Krishna's departure from Vrindavan. They went mad as Krishna was leaving for Mathura and wanted to stop Him. When king Kamsa's messengers, Akrura and Uddhava, came to take Krishna back to Mathura, the Gopis scolded them severely. So great was their distress that they held these two innocent messengers responsible for Krishna's departure and they cursed them for it. 'Don't worry. I have a mission to fulfill in Mathura,' Krishna said. 'Once that is done, I won't stay there a second longer. I will come rushing back to you, my beloved ones. How can I be away from you who are the very embodiments of love?' But Krishna never returned to Vrindavan.

"For the Gopis, Krishna's departure was the beginning of a long and endless wait full of expectation and

hope. Each day the Gopis kept butter and *ghee* ready in their homes, hoping that Krishna would come. They decorated their houses and drew different auspicious diagrams and symbols in the front yards to welcome their beloved Krishna. Fixing their gaze on the entrance gate, the Gopis waited every day. After Krishna's departure their eyes were always filled with tears. For them, all the aspects of nature—the animals, birds, trees, bushes, plants, creepers, flowers, rivers, mountains and valleys—were all waiting for Krishna. Finally, their longing transformed them into *Krishnamayis*; they were totally permeated with Krishna.

“Children, this is why Amma said you have no love or faith. If you had, you would have been ready and waiting to welcome your Beloved Deity, or Amma, at any time. If that were the case, this room would not have been such a mess. It would have had the serenity and purity of a temple. This shows your lack of *sraddha* and *bhakti* which are the most basic qualities that a *sadhak* should have.”

Mother took the photograph, and using the end of Her sari, wiped off the dust. After placing it back on the altar, She then began to pick up the clothes and books lying on the floor. As She put the books on a small corner shelf, She said, “Look here, he took the books from this shelf but never bothered to put them back.” Next She asked one of the *brahmacharins* for some rope. While waiting for the rope to be brought, Mother all of a sudden turned around and spoke to the *brahmacharin* who had stayed in the room, “Perhaps you’re thinking, ‘Why is Amma creating such of an uproar over such a silly matter?’ You are thinking that it is the heart that needs to be purified and that it is the heart that should become

the shrine of God.” Turning to the other brahmacharins, She said, “He thinks that external cleanliness is not very important. ‘Didn’t Sabari bite into each piece of fruit she offered Lord Rama in order to make sure that it was ripe and sweet? Didn’t Kannappa⁴ offer the Lord meat, and flowers which he had been wearing on his own head? He even bathed an image of the Lord with water he carried in his mouth.’ He is thinking like this.”

The brahmacharin turned pale and hung his head. Even though it was done in a lighthearted way, Mother had said exactly what he was thinking. In a few seconds he raised his head and spoke in a tone full of genuine remorse. “Amma, please forgive me,” he said. “What you have said just now is absolutely correct. You have understood all my thoughts. Amma, please enlighten me.” His eyes were filled with tears.

Although the brahmacharin was a bit upset at being exposed in front of everyone, his confession evoked much laughter. Mother became very animated and began laughing like a child. As She kept on laughing, Mother pushed and pulled those who were standing near Her. At one point She caught hold of Balu’s long hair and pulled hard. “Ouch!” he shouted, which created another round of laughter.

When the laughter subsided, Mother sat down and continued, “Son, your thinking is correct. But is your mind as pure as Sabari’s and Kannappa’s were? It is true that Kannappa’s and Sabari’s behavior was not in keeping with traditional rules; but their hearts were pure. They were as innocent as children. Do you have this kind of purity and innocence? Would you poke out your eyes as Kannappa did? Would you be able to perform such a great sacri-

fice? Or can you be like Sabari, who waited every day for her Lord with a heart filled with intense longing and love? You can do neither; so what is the meaning of such lofty thoughts?

“It was out of pure and innocent love that Kannappa and Sabari made those offerings to their Lord. When your heart is full of innocent love, you are absent, the ego is absent. In that state, only Love is present; in that state, individuality disappears and you become one with the Lord. You become as innocent as a child. When a child offers something, it cannot be rejected because a child’s love is untainted and pure. When you dwell in pure innocent love, there are no dual feelings like pure or impure, good or bad, and so forth. There is only love. Pure love cannot be rejected. When Kannappa and Sabari made their offerings to the Lord, the objects in themselves were not very significant; it was their hearts filled with love that were offered to the Lord. They themselves became the offering. Just like children, so full of love, they transcended even the concept of purity and impurity; they forgot about do’s and don’ts.

“Son, when people cannot do something or when they find a certain thing too hard to accomplish, they try to find justification for their own actions. This is human nature. When they realize they are going to lose, they search for a way out. Even if it does not make much sense, they rationalize. This is a very subtle vasana. This is another trick played by the mind. Be careful and be attentive about this aspect of the mind. A seeker should not fall a prey to such weakmindedness.”

The brahmacharin who had gone in search of rope returned. Mother stood up and took the rope. With the

help of the others in the room, She made a clothesline by tying the ends on two opposing poles of the hut; then She began folding the clothes one by one and putting them on the clothesline. After this Mother walked around and collected all the unnecessary and useless items lying here and there in the room. Some of the things had been inserted in the walls which were made of thatched coconut leaves, and other items were lying in a dark corner of the hut. There were scraps of paper, old clothes, a worn-out toothbrush and an empty toothpaste tube, broken pens, and more. Before throwing each item into an old bucket hastily converted into a trash can, Mother asked the brahmacharin who lived in the hut, "Do you want this?" or "Do you have any use for this?" If he said 'no', Mother threw it in the trash can. If he said 'yes', She gave it back to him. This sorting out of the things went on for some time.

Next Mother inspected the *asana* which was spread in front of the altar. It was a thick cloth on which the brahmacharin sat for meditation. She smelled it and made a funny face indicating that it smelled bad. Handing the *asana* to another brahmacharin, Mother said, "Wash this for him."

Now everything was in order, and Mother Herself did the final sweeping of the room. One brahmacharin lit some incense and Mother sat down on a mat to relax for a while. Gayatri came and offered Mother something to drink. Mother took a single sip and returned the glass to her. Gayatri waited, holding the glass for some time, hoping that Mother would ask for more, but She did not. "Some more, Amma?" Gayatri asked. "No, that is enough," came the reply. Mother asked Gayatri to sit next to Her, then

She lay down with Her head resting on Gayatri's lap and sang *Kannunir toratha ravukal*. . .

*How many nights have I spent
With my eyes flooded with tears?
O Compassionate One,
Won't You come today?
O Sreedhara Krishna,
During each moment of waiting
I am caught for an eon
In a rain of scorching fire.*

*Throughout each night I wait for You
Believing that the dancing swords of lightning
Are a sign of Your pageantry.
I remain where I am,
Imagining each undertone emerging from the dark
To be the sound of Your footsteps.*

*O Kanna,
Who is eternally free from sorrow,
Whose heart is softened by Love,
When may I see Your gentle smile?
When will You come and save this weeping girl
Drowning in her tears?*

*O Madhava Krishna,
Bless me that I may be reborn
As a blade of grass
Or a grain of sand on Your path;
Or else, make me a speck of sandalwood paste
To be used by the servants of Your devotees.*

After the song Mother remained indrawn for a few moments. When She opened Her eyes, the same brahmacharin spoke again, "Amma, by cleaning this room you were actually punishing me." He then corrected himself, "Forgive me, Amma, I shouldn't use the word punish. I know you do not punish anyone. You only correct us in order to teach us to be better. The lessons we receive through your words and deeds are for our own good. You 'punish' us only out of love and compassion. But we are so ignorant that most of the time we forget this. When Mother exposed my thoughts, and while You cleaned my room, and especially when You took my dirty asana and handed it to another brahmacharin asking him to wash it for me, I felt terribly ashamed and hurt. I thought Mother was deliberately trying to humiliate me in front of all the others. I know this is not the attitude that a sadhak should have. But, Amma, I feel helpless; these negative tendencies and feelings are so strong." His eyes were filled with tears and his throat was so choked he could not continue.

Mother stroked the brahmacharin's forehead and caressed his head with great tenderness and love. "These tears are the impurities within you," She told him. "These tears should be transformed into 'those' tears. These tears come from the pain and anguish caused by the world. But 'those' tears are the tears of bliss which are shed out of pure love and devotion." Mother smiled as She spoke. It seemed that Her smile and eyes held enough power to remove any amount of pain or sorrow. The divine touch of Mother's hand soothed the brahmacharin, and the heaviness born out of a guilty conscience continued to stream out in the form of tears. After having wept for some time, he managed to control his tears and soon began

to look relaxed and free of mental pain.

Mother's darshan is a healing process, a wonderful divine healing process. Her touch heals the wounds caused by a painful past. Her presence purifies, uplifts, and carries us towards our true Self. Mother is purity embodied. Thus all those who come in contact with Her are transformed and cleansed. In some cases this purification can be seen, while at other times, it is subtle. How many of Mother's devotees are familiar with the seemingly innocent hug that transforms lives, and with the look that causes hearts to melt. Whether you are aware of it or not, whether or not you feel worthy, this purification happens. Just as an iron piece is magnetized when it is rubbed constantly by a powerful magnet, an ordinary soul is transformed into a spiritual being through the constant contact and companionship of a Mahatma like Mother.

HOW TO HANDLE INSULTS

Now that the brahmacharin was feeling better, Mother continued to speak, "Son, there is nothing to worry about. Negative feelings will arise. It is just the past showing up. At least you have confessed your feelings. That means you are not a hypocrite. There are very few people who can remain calm and unhurt when their faults and weaknesses are exposed. These hurt feelings have come up now, in Mother's presence, and the negative feelings will disappear in your love for Her. But in other cases, negativity will remain and can create another deep wound. Be careful about that.

"Negativity after negativity will form a long, long chain attached within you. You have been insulted and scolded

numerous times in the countless births you have taken. When somebody insults you, he is insulting you from his past, and when you react, you, too, are reacting from the past. Both of you have been victims of insults and have made others your victims in your previous lifetimes as well as in this lifetime. So all your actions and all your words, whether positive or negative, reflect your past. The storing up of the past exists within you. The storage within you is full, overloaded even. To empty the ego which is the sum total of all these negative feelings, one should first of all feel the heaviness of it. Still, it is a wonder that you do not feel the heaviness of the load. If you start feeling the heaviness that is a good sign. From that point on you will start unloading it.

“Amma has heard the story of a disciple who was instructed by his master in this way: for three years he was to give money to everyone who insulted him, and was not to utter a word back to them. When his period of trial was over, the master said to him, ‘Now you can go to the world of true knowledge and learn wisdom.’ When the disciple was about to enter the world of true knowledge, he met a wise man who sat at the gate insulting everybody who came and went. This wise man also insulted the disciple, who immediately burst out laughing. ‘Why do you laugh when I insult you?’ asked the wise man. ‘Because,’ answered the disciple, ‘for three years I have been paying for this kind of thing, and now you give it to me for nothing.’ The wise man said to him, ‘Enter the kingdom of knowledge; it is all yours.’

“Laugh heartily at those who insult you, seeing their past coming through the words. Reward those who insult you. Try not to utter anything bad to them and slowly,

in due course, try not to have any bad feelings against them at all. Act, but do not react. By doing so, you will enter into the deeper realms of your own consciousness.

“Now, when you thought that Amma was insulting you, you could keep quiet and did not react. Furthermore, you confessed that you felt hurt when Amma said those words. This is a good sign. Try the same with others. When others insult you or get angry with you, try to keep your mouth shut, imagining that you are in Amma’s presence and that it would be disrespectful to react. Try to feel respect for the other person, because, in truth, he is doing something good for you. He is teaching you to be silent, to be patient. Start feeling pity for him, for his wounded past, feel deep concern and compassion for him. ‘Poor man, he is suffering all those deep wounds from the past. He is sick. I should really help him as much as I can.’

“You may still have all the reactions within. You may be boiling within. Yet through proper understanding, penetration, and awareness, try to see that your accuser is suffering from his past wounds. You do not want to hurt a wounded and suffering person. That is cruelty. You do not want to be cruel. You are a sadhak, a seeker; you want to be kind and compassionate.

“It is possible that you may feel respect, but not compassion and concern. Once compassion arises, you forgive the other person. You forget his abusive words. A compassionate person cannot react, for he can only be compassionate. This is difficult to attain in your present mental state, but that is okay. To let go is not so easy. You may fail to feel love. Just as in this situation with Amma, first your silence was out of respect and reverence, or call it fear, for Amma. But still you had a little

bit of reaction within. After some time, you contemplated and thought well enough to confess your mental reaction to Amma. Thus if you feel respect for the other person, consider him as a teacher who teaches you patience; or if you can imagine that Amma is talking through him, you will be able to keep silent. It is just like your school teacher scolding you for misbehaving in the classroom or for not studying the lesson properly. You do not shout back at him. You keep quiet out of respect, don't you? Keep silent and move away from the person who insults you. If you remain physically in the presence of a person who is abusing you, you may eventually react even though you had succeeded in keeping your mouth shut in the beginning. Therefore, physically move away from that kind of atmosphere.

“Or, if you must stay, try to recall some fond memories, such as the most unforgettable events you had with your spiritual master, the day you met him, how he showered his love and compassion upon you. Recalling uplifting ideas and cherishing sweet memories can help you keep silent.

“Yet, even though you are able to remain silent while he utters words or retorts, you may still have thoughts of hatred and revenge towards him for his mean and abusive behavior. But you must also be careful not to have any revengeful feelings towards the person. Do not carry the wound of anger and hatred in your mind. Remember that he wanted to teach you something; he had a message for you. You should have an ear and a heart to hear the message and absorb it. You will have to work on acceptance of this later. Meditate, pray, chant, repeat your mantra, and contemplate deeply to remove those and other emotional disturbances.”

CHAPTER FIVE

AN UNFORGETTABLE BOAT JOURNEY

Friday, 7 September, 1984

In the evening Mother went to visit the house of a devotee in a nearby village. As his house was situated several kilometers away from the Ashram, Mother decided to travel there by boat. Soon after the evening bhajans ended, Unni, who lived just in front of the Ashram, was ready with the boat. The group traveling to the devotee's house consisted of Mother, Gayatri, Damayanti (Amma's mother), Harshan (Amma's cousin), Satheesh (Amma's brother), Balu, Rao and Sreekumar. By eight-thirty in the evening the party set off on the journey with Unni as the boatman.

As they sailed on the backwaters, the reflection of the moon on the water created a play of light and shade. All of nature was bathed in moonlight. The vastness and expansiveness of the sky above had a very soothing effect on the mind. A gentle breeze added to the feeling of calmness. Mother's gaze was fixed on the peaceful sky. Sitting in the boat, She looked extraordinarily beautiful in the moonlight.

A few moments later, as if She were talking to the moon, to the sky, to the infinitude or to something of which no one could know, Mother pointed Her index finger

up towards something indefinite. Remaining in this position for some time, Mother began singing. All the passengers responded with vigor, enthusiasm and joy, *Adiyil parameswariye*. . .

*O Supreme Goddess,
Mother of the Universe,
You are my only goal in this world.*

*O Mother, with beautiful eyes
Like the petals of a blue lotus,
You are the Sustainer of the three worlds,
The One who dwells
within the flower of Maya.
O Beautiful One, the Source of everything,
Rid me of all sorrows.*

*O Gracious One,
Destroyer of greed,
Who leads us through the land of transmigration,
Protect me.
O Mother, giver of devotion and liberation,
O Katyayani, far-famed One,
I bow to You.*

*O Goddess of the earth,
Who is Wisdom and Knowledge,
You are the only delight and the only nourishment;
You are all of Creation.
O fulfiller of all desires,
Please rid me of my pride
Dwell within my mind and remove my distress.*

Throughout the song, Mother was looking up at the cloudless sky. She sang another song and in the middle of it went into samadhi. With both Her arms outstretched as if supplicating the Supreme Being, Mother remained motionless for some time. Her eyes were open, but they were transfixed. The unearthly glow on Mother's countenance was made even more radiantly beautiful by a beaming smile which adorned Her face. She shone like another moon.

Mother's divine mood continued for several minutes. Later when She was Her normal self again, Mother noticed two of the brahmacharins talking to each other. Mother said to them, "Children, talking unnecessarily is one of the greatest enemies of a sadhak. This opportunity to travel so intimately with Mother is rare. You may not get another chance to spend time with Amma like this. Look how beautiful the night is. Look at the vast, expansive sky and the beautiful moon shining among the glimmering stars. Feel the calmness and silence. Feel the gentle breeze that blows so sweetly and see the trees and bushes on either side of the backwaters. Listen to the *pranava mantra* reverberating from the ocean. Look at the dark blue waters and enjoy the beauty of Nature with the awareness that these are all expressions of the Divine.

"Amma never used to sleep at night. In the early days She would stay awake and call out to the Lord. She cried, prayed, meditated, and danced in bliss. Moonlit nights were Amma's favorite times. On those silent and peaceful nights Amma would become totally oblivious of everything around Her. Her longing for the Divine would reach its peak. She would spend the entire night seeing everything as an expression of the Supreme Absolute, crying

and praying and dancing in bliss.

“Sadhaks love the night. That’s when they can dive deep into their own consciousness. In the beginning stages it is good for one’s spiritual progress to meditate and pray during the night, especially after midnight when the entire world goes to sleep. It’s the best time for a sadhak to stay awake and do his spiritual practices. In more advanced stages he will be able to meditate and pray anytime he wants, regardless of time or place. When he is able to meditate with such focus, both day and night will come under his control. But that is possible only when his mind becomes so completely fixed on the object of meditation that he doesn’t care when or where he meditates. Wherever it may be, he simply gets absorbed in a meditative mood. But before a sadhak reaches this state of spontaneous meditation, he should select ideal conditions for meditation.

“Therefore, children, do not waste these opportunities by talking about silly things. Utilize the time for meditation, silent prayer, and repeating your mantra. Look at the sky and try to visualize the form of your beloved deity there. Try to imagine that He or She is moving with you. Try to see your Ishta Devata’s face in the moon or imagine that the moon is the face of the Divine Mother or of Krishna or Rama. As the wind blows try to feel that it is the gentle caress of your beloved deity. Look into the water and visualize the smiling face of your Ishta Devata there. You can imagine that your beloved deity is calling you near, hugging you, kissing you, caressing you, blessing you, and then hiding in the clouds and coming out again a little later. By this kind of imagination you go deeper and deeper into your own consciousness. You

enshrine His or Her form within your heart. You open up more and more, and you get closer and closer to your own Self.”

Mother stopped and asked everyone to meditate, repeat their mantra, or to imagine that they were merging with infinity as they looked up at the sky. Mother sat silently looking at the sky. The boat kept on moving slowly. The only sound was the rippling of the waters as the boat gracefully glided upstream. This period of meditation and silent prayer continued for half an hour. Even afterwards there was not much talking. Mother sang, *Mara yadukula hridayeswara. . .*

*O most charming One,
Lord of the Yadavas’ hearts,
Who is the color of a rain cloud,
Who bears the Goddess Lakshmi on Your breast;
O lotus-eyed One,
Where are Your gentle fingers
That caress the lullabies to sleep?*

*O You who lived in Vrindavan as Nanda’s son,
Who danced and played in the heart of Lord Chaitanya,
And in the hearts of others;
You are bound to Your devotees;
You are the beginning and the end of everything.
We join our palms in adoration to You.*

Mother’s blissful singing deepened the silence. The hallowed mood went straight into everyone’s heart. Mother’s presence in the boat remained the very source, the heart and soul of these inspiring moments. In that peaceful and

serene atmosphere Mother chanted Her favorite mantra, 'Shiva... Shiva... Shiva... Shiva...' Every now and then Her soft and gentle utterance of the mantra helped everyone remain at the center of his consciousness, even though the natural tendency was to let the mind drift.

After an hour and fifteen minutes, the party reached the devotee's house. Even when the boat stopped in front of the house, which was situated on the banks of the backwaters, nobody felt like getting out or even saying a word. The bliss and peace which Mother radiated permeated the air to such an extent that no one wanted to spoil this precious moment by engaging in any unnecessary conversation. Seeing everyone still sitting in the boat, Mother said, "Hey children, what happened? Are you all in samadhi?" Mother's words awoke them from their in-drawn state, and everyone quickly got out of the boat.

Rejoicing at the sight of Mother and Her brahmacharins, the family ushered them to the front entrance where together the husband, wife and children ceremonially washed Mother's feet. Their youngest daughter garlanded Mother, and the father and mother together waved the camphor flame in front of Her, performing the *arati*. The family members then sipped the sacred water from the *pada puja* and sprinkled it on themselves and everywhere in the house. They all offered their prostrations to Mother, who expressed Her love and compassion to each one of them in Her natural, innocent way.

The evening began with the *Lalita Sahasranama*, the chanting of the Thousand Names of the Divine Mother, and continued with devotional singing. Mother Herself performed the *arati*, the concluding ceremony of waving the camphor flame in front of the images on the al-

tar. This closing worship and chanting of prayers created a serene atmosphere in the house, but above all, Mother's divine presence made the entire event perfect and heavenly.

Midnight came quickly and everyone had a late supper. Mother ate only a few spoonfuls of one of the side dishes and had a few sips of plain water. The family members wanted Mother to eat more, but Mother refused in a loving way. The woman of the house complained sadly, "Maybe it is because of our lack of devotion that Amma is not eating anything from our house." Mother most affectionately but emphatically said, "No, daughter, not at all. You know Amma's nature; She is unpredictable. Amma does not feel hungry, and it is very late. You have already fed Amma with your love; Amma is full with that."

Nevertheless, Mother let the wife feed Her with a piece of *dosa*, a pancake made with rice flour. As she fed Mother with the attitude of a mother feeding Her child, the woman seemed full of affection and joy. Perhaps it was because of the woman's innocent love that Mother spontaneously opened Her mouth again until finally the third time Mother closed Her mouth and said, "Enough, daughter." The woman was ecstatic. She kissed Mother's cheeks and distributed the remaining portion of the *dosa* as prasad to everyone.

After supper Mother came out of the rather small house which was no more than a hut thatched with coconut leaves. The family had remarked about the small size of their house to which Mother replied, "Children, your hearts are big enough." The front yard was spread with milky white sand, and from the front yard one could step right into the backwaters where the boat was moored. As Mother sat in the sand near the backwaters, she was surrounded

by the family members, the brahmacharins, Damayanti, Unni, and Satheesh.

The youngest daughter came and sat on her mother's lap. The girl's mother said to the brahmacharins, "It is this child who was saved by Mother. And for that we have become eternally grateful and devoted to Mother. We all thought that our daughter would not live very long. This little one had chronic asthma. We tried all kinds of medicines but they were of no use. We were utterly helpless, so as a last resort we went to Ammachi. She gave the girl some sacred water. After blessing some more water, Mother told us to give her a sip or two everyday. Mother also instructed us to rub the sacred ash on her chest. That was all we did and the asthma never returned. Now the girl is perfectly healthy."

Mother did not pay much attention to the woman's narration. Mother asked the child, "Don't you feel sleepy?" The girl shook her head and said, "How can I when Ammachi is here!" "You clever, mischievous little girl," Mother remarked with a big smile. Then She asked one of the brahmacharins to sing a *kirtan*, *Mauna ghanamritam*...

*In the abode of impenetrable Silence
Of eternal Beauty and Peace,
Where the mind of Gautama Buddha was dissolved,
In the Effulgence that destroys all bonds,
On the Shore of Bliss
Which lies beyond the reach of thought. . .*

*In the Knowledge that bestows eternal harmony,
The Abode without beginning or end,
The Bliss known only when*

*The movements of the mind subside,
At the Seat of Power,
The Region of perfect Consciousness. . .*

*At the Goal that bestows the sweet state
Of eternal non-duality
Described as 'Thou art That,'
That is the place where I long to reach;
But I can only do so
Through Your Grace.*

When the song ended, Mother asked them to sing another one. It seemed that Mother wished to avoid conversation for a while. When the second song was over, Mother said, "One more." After the third song, Mother sat silently looking at the dark blue sky. Ten or fifteen minutes passed in silence. Suddenly there came the sound of an engine as the daily passenger ferry boat with its puttering engine passed by the house. Pointing to the big motorboat, Mother said, "Amma used to travel in such a boat when She was sent to work in relatives' houses. While traveling in the boat, Amma used to hum 'Omkara' (the sacred syllable OM), or She would chant kirtans to the rhythm of the engine. Traveling in a boat was a highly spiritual experience for Amma. Constantly remembering the form of Her beloved deity, Amma used to sing, pray, repeat the mantra, and meditate on such occasions. She would not waste even a single moment."

One of the brahmacharins commented, "Amma, it was so effortless and spontaneous for you to get into that divine mood, because that is your nature. But how can we, who are still in the physical and mental bodies and in the grip

of vasanas and thoughts, get into that mood? How can we even think of attaining that without your Grace?”

Mother replied, “Children, if a person really wishes to do something, he can do it. This feeling, ‘I am weak; it’s too difficult; it’s impossible for a person like me to reach there,’ is not fit for a spiritual seeker. He should believe that he has this power within him and that he can reach it. Each one of you has the beauty and power of a saint or a sage. Each one of you is an infinite source of power. Yet when you see a saint or a sage, or a powerful person, you recoil, saying, ‘No, this is for those special people. I can’t do it. I have my own tiny little world to bother about, and that’s enough for me. Divinity is none of my business, so I’m not going to poke my nose into it.’ This kind of an attitude will never help you to come out of the small, hard shell of your little ego. This weakness makes man helpless and inactive. That is why Vedanta tells us to contemplate the Vedic dictum, ‘I am Brahman. I am God. I am the Universe. I am Absolute Power, the totality of consciousness which makes everything beautiful and shiny, full of life and light.’

“Self-deprecating thoughts are not good for a sadhak. Such thoughts are not good even for a person living in the world. God has blessed us all with this precious gift of human birth. We have a well-developed body, mind, and intellect. We can learn or do whatever we want. It is only a question of utilizing the instruments or faculties given by God for whatever we choose to pursue. If one chooses the path of spirituality, one is not supposed to remain idle waiting for Grace to come. Realization does not just come automatically; there is great work involved. Realization cannot be purchased. It is not like going to

the ice cream parlor and buying an ice cream cone. Even that involves work. How was the ice cream made? It doesn't just materialize out of thin air. Where did you get the money to buy it? It is hard-earned money, isn't it? Suppose there is ice cream at the shop and you have the money, but you don't buy it. It's simple, you won't eat ice cream, will you? Yet you have an intense desire to eat ice cream. So you lie in bed and think of eating chocolate ice cream. You daydream about the different flavors, and you dream about eating and enjoying ice cream, but still you haven't actually eaten any. It is not that there was no ice cream; there are all sorts of flavors available. You have the money and you can obtain as much as you want, but you don't feel like getting up and going to the ice cream parlor. You only think about it and dream about it.

"In a similar manner God is there, the Guru is there, and Grace is always there. You have all the faculties to know and experience this. You have a map and have been given the directions in the form of the Guru's words. The wind of his Grace is always blowing. The river of his divine being is always flowing, and the sun of his knowledge is always shining. He has done his part. His work was over long, long ago.

"Yet, you think the Guru has not done anything. You think that he is not letting his Grace flow. You think that you do not have his blessing or Grace, so you are still waiting for him to bestow it upon you without doing anything yourself. You wait for the day, for the moment, when he will touch your heart. It is all right to wait, but are you really waiting with faith and one-pointedness like the Gopis of Vrindavan, or Sabari, Sri Rama's great devotee? No, you aren't. You might be waiting, but your whole being

is not waiting. You are not burning with love and devotion. While waiting you are engaged elsewhere. Your mind is chasing a thousand other things. You are not waiting solely for His Grace. Instead, you are waiting for numerous other 'important things' to happen in your life, and along with those, you also want Grace to happen. And you want Grace to happen for free.

"You may be waiting for God or God's Grace, but the thought of God occurs in you only once in a blue moon, or on Sundays, or at best two or three times a day. Furthermore, those few occasions on which you may think of God are very dull and lacking in intensity, because you are preoccupied with so many other supposedly important things. It is all right if you faithfully wait for Him to come, but be sure you are attentive in your waiting. If you are preoccupied with other things, how can God come? How can His Grace flow? The Guru is there. His ever-flowing Grace is there; it is always present. But you want Him to come uninvited, without any effort on your part. In the name of waiting you idle away your time. You do not consider it an intrinsic part of your life to wait faithfully. You do not take this period of waiting seriously and sincerely. You say, 'I am waiting for God, for His Grace to come. He is all-compassionate, so He will come. Until then, let me engage in other important matters.' This is foolishness. You will neither receive Grace nor will you have the power to overcome difficult situations with this kind of faith.

"It is possible to become the master of the entire universe. You have that potential within you, but you must work. Actually, you are already the Lord of the universe. You are the emperor of the entire world, but you are dream-

ing that you are a beggar who has to beg for food. The moment you stop dreaming, the moment you realize that the present so-called waking state is, in fact, a dream, you will realize that you are the Lord of the universe, and you will awaken to God-consciousness.

“The whole world, each object in this universe—the sun, the moon, the stars, the galaxies, the milky way, the earth, the mountains, the valleys, the rivers, the ocean, the trees, the animals, the birds, the plants, the flowers, and the entire human mind, all minds—are under your control. You are the master of everything. The entire universe is waiting to welcome and accept you as Lord. But you are still begging with a bowl in your hand. Open your eyes and try to see clearly. You are a king disguised as a beggar. Throw away the beggar’s clothes. The universe is waiting for you to don an emperor’s robes. Come out of this dream, this illusion of weakness.

“Amma has heard a story about a student who was taking an examination. The question had to do with writing an essay on the religious and spiritual significance of the miracle of Christ’s turning water into wine. The students in the examination hall were writing furiously for two hours, filling their exam booklet with their ideas of what the miracle meant. Towards the end of the allotted time, the proctor discovered that one student had not written anything, not a single word. The proctor insisted that he write something before turning in his exam booklet. The student picked up his pen in his hand and wrote, ‘The water met its master, and blushed.’

“Children, everything is within you. You are the master of all the five elements. By your mere look, or touch, they will become what you wish. Therefore, do not think, ‘O

Amma, it happened to you and to you alone. It could not happen to me with all my vasanas and weaknesses. It cannot happen to me. So I will wait till you shower your Grace for this to happen.'

"Do not think that God will enter uninvited. He is already an uninvited guest everywhere, in every nook and cranny of the world, in every inch of space. There is not even a gap between atoms where He isn't. Everywhere in this world He is an uninvited guest. But you will have to recognize Him."

GOD THE UNINVITED GUEST

The brahmacharin asked, "I don't understand. You said God will not come uninvited, but you also say that He is an uninvited guest everywhere in this universe. This seems to be a contradiction."

Mother responded, "Children, God is compassion. He is waiting at the door of every heart. He is an uninvited guest everywhere because whether you call Him or not He is there. Whether you are a believer or a non-believer, He is within you uninvited. Behind every form, behind everything, God is hiding. He beautifies things and makes them what they are. He is the hidden formula of life. But He won't reveal Himself to you. You won't feel Him unless you call Him. Prayer is the invitation. You must invoke Him through prayer and meditation. Chanting, singing and repeating the mantra are invitations, asking God to reveal Himself.

"You should have the ability and power to recognize God, the God in everything and in every being. This is not possible unless you see the God within yourself. Once you know godliness, which is your real nature, you will

know godliness in others. Then you will see God seated everywhere, uninvited.

“Children, God cannot break in. He is not aggressive, because He is love. God is not a person; He is Consciousness. He cannot break in, because Consciousness cannot be aggressive. Invite Him and He will step in. But even uninvited He is waiting there at the door, waiting to be called in. The uninvited God remains hidden outside your heart. He is ever-present, waiting with love and compassion. His glory and splendor are ever-present yet hidden, because you have not invoked the power of His presence through prayer and meditation. Through your invitation, through your prayers and meditation, God will step into your heart and reveal His presence. Then you will know that He was always there waiting for you to call Him.”

Everybody listened attentively to Mother’s inspiring words. The time was now two o’clock in the morning. No one was at all sleepy, not even the youngest child of the family, who was still sitting on her mother’s lap, gazing at Mother’s face. The girl’s mother said, “Look at this girl. She usually can’t stay awake past nine, but today She’s wide awake even after two o’clock in the morning.” Mother looked at the girl and asked, “Daughter, don’t you want to go to bed? Aren’t you tired?” The girl shook her head.

Everyone continued to sit in silence, watching Mother as She sat gazing beyond the night sky. Then She raised Her hand up towards the sky and began to sing, *En manasin oru maunam...*

*I am dejected because Sri Krishna hasn’t come;
I have not yet seen Him,*

*And the longing of my heart
Brings forth a flood of tears.*

*Is it because He has not yet returned
From grazing the cattle?
Or has He not yet woken up?
Has the dark-colored One forgotten
That my heart is weeping with longing for Him?*

*Perhaps he has not yet had his milk and butter?
Perhaps His tender feet have slipped somewhere
And He has fallen?
Or are His devotees swarming around Him like bees,
Drinking the honey from His Feet?*

*O Kannan, why have You not come today?
O You, who are the color of a rain cloud,
Have You forgotten me?
O, please appear before these tear-filled eyes!*

After the song Mother sat in a meditative mood. Ten or fifteen minutes passed before She got up. As everyone else arose, Mother said, "Where is Harshan? He is not here." Everybody looked around, but Harshan was not to be seen. In fact, no one remembered having seen him since they reached the house. Usually he would not miss an occasion like this. He would be present throughout, gesturing and cracking jokes. But today he had been very silent during the entire journey. As everyone began to disperse, Mother wandered away from the rest of the group.

Suddenly the quiet night was interrupted by shouting and the sound of coughing and spitting. Everybody ran to the southwest corner of the house, and there they

found Mother with Harshan. Earlier in the evening, as everybody had gotten out of the boat, Harshan fallen gone to sleep lying on the bare sand. That was why he did not appear at the puja, the bhajan or the meal. Mother probably surmised that he had gone off somewhere to sleep, so when She got up from the banks of the backwaters, She went looking for him and found him sleeping around the corner of the house with his mouth wide-open. Mischievously, Mother had stuffed his mouth full of sand. Now, as Harshan was coughing and spitting, She was laughing excitedly and enjoying the scene like a child.

Mother's was in a playful mood. She laughed and laughed, and through Her mirth She teased Harshan, "You were sleeping comfortably while everybody prayed and meditated. Happiness must be followed by sorrow. You enjoyed and now you must pay for it!" Harshan had no complaints since he was quite familiar with Mother's different moods. He always enjoyed Her practical jokes, even those played at his expense. Once all the laughter had subsided and Harshan had stopped cleaning out his mouth, the return journey began. It was three-thirty in the morning.

An hour later Mother and Her party had traveled only halfway home to the Ashram. Unni continued to row the boat. Damayanti and Harshan were fast asleep on a mat spread on the floor of the boat. The moon shone richly in the sky as if overflowing with the bliss of Mother's divine presence. The clouds floating up in the sky seemed to dance ecstatically. The trees and plants on both sides of the backwaters waved their leaves and branches in yet another dance as if celebrating a great occasion. Silence and a meditative mood prevailed. Mother seemed to be reveling in Her own solitary world; She remained still,

fixing Her gaze at the sky above. The brahmacharins and Gayatri sat looking at Mother's face, drinking in the eternal beauty that She radiated.

The silent, meditative atmosphere lasted for some time. Mother saw Harshan and Damayanti sleeping and said, "It is cool. (Turning to Gayatri) Do you have something to cover them?" Gayatri searched in the bag and took out a shawl. Mother covered Damayanti with the shawl and took the upper cloth of one of the brahmacharins to cover Harshan. Then She returned to Her seat.

The early light of dawn slowly started creeping over the backwaters. Perching on the branches of the trees and flying around in delight, the birds seemed to be chanting their morning mantras. The beautiful sound created a joyous atmosphere. Facing east, Mother sat enjoying the pristine beauty of the dawn. Every now and then Mother burst into ecstatic laughter. Sometimes it was just the sound, "Ho, ho, ho," as if She were greatly excited. In that exalted mood of spiritual union, Mother sat with Her arms stretched upwards. Her face glowed with ecstasy and bliss. Her sudden bursts of laughter created a heavenly rhythm in the silence of the dawn's golden rays. Captivated by the beauty of Mother's mood, Unni stopped rowing and let the boat drift for some time. A large motorboat passed by creating waves on the surface of the backwaters. The little boat with the passengers from the Ashram bobbed up and down, but Unni immediately awoke from his reverie and controlled it with great skill.

Mother spontaneously burst into song... *Bhramaram...*

*O hummingbird of my mind,
You are wandering about exhausted
In your search of pure Nectar.*

*There is a grove of flowering trees
Where there is no sorrow;
It is blissfully nestled
On the bank of the river of devotion.
O mind, do not despair,
For one day Mother will come
To the one who is pure at heart.*

*O Shakti,
For those who are wise,
You are the Spring of intelligence;
And through the art of Knowledge
You remove all sorrow.
I offer all of my suffering to You
In Whom everything exists.*

*O Mother, when will You come?
O Mother, don't wait
Until all my energy is dissipated!
Won't You shower Your Grace upon me?
Who else is there but You?
You are my only support.*

The song created waves of spiritual bliss and supreme love in the atmosphere of dawn. Like a beautifully carved marble statue, Mother remained still and silent until the boat reached the Ashram shortly after five-thirty in the morning.

CHAPTER SIX

CONTENTMENT

Saturday, 8 September, 1984

The weather was clear and the air was crisp and bright. It was around nine-thirty in the morning as the residents and some visiting devotees gathered around Mother in front of the temple. The morning puja had been completed and people were sitting, just enjoying Mother's presence. One devotee took this opportunity to ask a question. "Amma, why does Amma place so much importance on the path of devotion?"

"Children," She began, "there are many reasons why we should consider the path of devotion the most suitable path for most people. First of all, it gives much contentment to the practitioner. A contented person will have enthusiasm and vigor. He will be very optimistic and endowed with an adventurous mind. His attitude is that life and everything that happens in life is a gift, and this gives him immense patience and strength. Unlike those who pursue other paths, he does not believe that happiness is a right to which he is entitled. As far as he is concerned, there are no rights, there are only gifts. This attitude helps him to accept everything as a gift, both good and bad, and also instills him with courage and faith. Such a person will have a loving and compassionate heart,

a child-like innocence, and a pleasing nature. Not wanting to injure anyone or hurt anybody's feelings, he cannot harm anyone. He will also have the power to renounce his comforts and pleasures for the happiness and peace of others. He will experience the same problems in life as everyone else, but he will have the mental ability and balance to remain calm and quiet when adversity arises. He practices acceptance, for his attitude is that life and everything that happens in life is a gift, not a right.

"Such a person derives his power to be content and relaxed from his unshakable faith in, and love towards, the Supreme Power. And he will have a name and form for this Supreme Power. He may call it Krishna, or he may call it Christ or Buddha. The power of the name that he chants, and the mental image of the form he cherishes, as well as his faith that his Lord is always with him and protects him from all dangers, helps him to be content, relaxed, optimistic and cheerful at all times and in all circumstances.

"Take, for example, the Gopas and Gopis of Vrindavan. They were always blissful and happy, full of vigor and cheer. All the work they did carried a special charm and beauty of its own. They were always in a festive mood, and one could see only happy and contented faces all around, for their lives were sparkling with joy. Life was a festival for them, and idleness was non-existent as they sang and danced with great joy while performing any work. Even their customary chores of taking the cows to the meadows, milking them, and selling the milk and butter became blissful work. They had extraordinary strength and courage, and if they had problems, they confronted them most courageously. Always adventurous and lov-

ing in nature, they lived life to its fullest.

“What was the source of their contentment and joy? Their faith in their beloved Lord Krishna. It was their faith in His omnipotence and their adoration of Him that helped them celebrate all of life. They became fearless and courageous in His presence. So, children, love and devotion for God is the way to contentment. That alone is the way to peace, happiness, courage and fearlessness. Such qualities that help bring us the fullness of life are not easily available to people who practice other paths.

“Look at Hanuman, the great devotee of Lord Sri Rama. He stands as a magnificent example of tireless work, inexhaustible energy and a being of great achievements. There was not a single incident when Hanuman said ‘no’ to anything he was asked to do. Obstacles were nothing to him. Whenever Rama was struck with a tragic incident, Hanuman was by His side to carry out His commands. Even the seemingly impossible became possible through Hanuman’s constant effort, determination and unshakable faith. He was the embodiment of strength, courage, vigor, fearlessness, determination, optimism, discrimination and contentment. Yet he remained Sri Rama’s simple and humble devotee, completely surrendered at the Feet of his Lord.

“Contentment ensues from egolessness. And egolessness comes from devotion, love, and utter surrender to the Supreme Lord. Egoistic people cannot be content or happy. They are tense because they have fear, and this fear makes them almost crazy. Most of the time such people are hungry for power, and that craving makes them blind. They want to grab and possess everything, not caring if they use mean and wicked ways, not caring if they ruin other people.

The constant fear that they will be deprived of their power and possessions haunts them, and increases their fear and discontent. Look at all the dictators of the world. They are the most egotistic people. Craving power and position, they are war-mongers with no concern for the peace and happiness of society. They don't even care about their own wives and children. They are concerned only about themselves and what will happen to them tomorrow and in the future. They have no qualms about what evil means they may use to gain power. Tense with their own discontentment, they carry negativity around with them and spread it to others. Thus everyone, every single soul around them, is made unhappy and discontent.

"Hiranyakasipu, Prahlada's father, was a typical example of someone who abused power. Children, by looking at his life, you will get a very good picture of how an extremely egotistic person is totally lacking in compassion. Such a person is full of discontent, anger, fear and cruelty. Hiranyakasipu even tried to kill Prahlada,⁵ his son, just to protect his own power, name and fame. But look at Prahlada. In all adversities, he was calm and unmoved like a mountain. He was fearless, courageous, and always content. Why? Because he was a true devotee of God. His joy didn't leave him even when he was thrown into the ocean or was condemned to death by being trampled by a mad elephant or burned alive. Through all of this he remained calm and unperturbed. He was content with whatever happened, good or bad, because he considered life and everything that happened in life as a gift from God. All true devotees have this attitude.

"Contentment comes only when you are surrendered, only when you have the attitude of complete acceptance.

It arises only when you can welcome impartially every experience in life. You can be fully content when you can smile at and even welcome death. And even if surrender does not happen immediately, one must at least have the willingness to surrender to the Supreme Will. Only then will one be able to enter into that state of everlasting contentment. If one develops this attitude of acceptance, the moment will eventually come when one becomes eternally content. Do not idle away your time in waiting for contentment. Nothing will happen. Discontent will prevail in a person who waits without doing anything. Prepare your mind and try to develop the willingness to accept and surrender. Try to welcome and receive both the good and bad. Try to build up an attitude that allows you to smile even at death. This is the way to contentment.”

HUMILITY AND RENUNCIATION

A listener commented, “Amma, your explanation is so enlightening. Yet contrary to your statement, Ravana, who was a devotee of Lord Shiva, remained discontent and tense almost all his life. There are also believers who lead discontented lives.”

To this Mother said, “Children, it is true that Ravana was a devotee of Lord Shiva, but his devotion was only a means to increase his material power. The spiritual aspect was totally missing in him. In other words, he had no renunciation. He was intensely desirous of accumulating, possessing and enjoying as much as he could. Although he was strong and courageous, he had no love or compassion. Just like any other dictator, he was a power-monger,

a person who cared only about himself and his own security. His power, which he derived from the Lord, made him so egotistic and blind that he even tried to lift Mount Kailas, Lord Shiva's abode. Ravana had no humility, no renunciation.

"Without renunciation and humility one cannot be content. A true devotee has both of these qualities. A person who lacks renunciation and humility can never be content because he still craves material prosperity. His desires are countless and unsatiable. He is never satisfied with what he has. Instead he thinks about accumulating more wealth, more money, a bigger house, a better car, more and more comfort."

"The slogan of an extremely egotistic person is 'more... more... more...' He will always want to replace an object of lower quality with something of higher quality for his own comfort and satisfaction. But he will never replace his lower thoughts with noble ones. The quality of his words and deeds is of no concern to him. Always fixing his gaze on the future, always trying to figure out how to do this or that, he will spend his whole life planning, calculating, and dreaming. Not able to be in the present and enjoy what is right in front of him, he cannot even relish his food, because while he is eating lunch he is planning his supper. How can such a person be happy and content? He cannot. Living the way he does, he is almost dead; he is like a moving corpse without the beauty and charm of life.

"The past and future are unreal. They are illusions. The past is dead and gone. It is not going to come back, and the future is yet to come. We do not even know whether we will be alive from one moment to the next.

Anything can happen at any time. Therefore, do not lead an illusory life. Do not fabricate a world of dreams to live in. You simply cannot live in the future. You can only live in the present. The present alone is real. Almost all dictators and skeptics, and those who run crazily after the world and its pleasures, are living in the future. They never live in the present, so they cannot be content.

“Ravana was a devotee, but he used God as an agent. His devotion was only a means to fulfill his monstrous desires. If he’d had the opportunity, he would even have devoured God. While Rama’s devotion for God saved society, Ravana’s devotion destroyed it.

“Children, you say that there are also believers who lead discontented lives. But true believers, those endowed with real faith, cannot be discontented. A person whose faith is very shaky will not be content. His faith is divided; he will have doubts. A man who has an intense desire for material prosperity cannot feel content. For such people, devotion to God exists in name only. Their devotion is superficial. It is only skin deep. There is no love in their devotion. For them God is an agent who takes care of their wishes and desires. Their God sits on a golden throne somewhere up in the skies. He is a judgmental and punishing God, a God who loves only those who love Him. They believe that God dislikes those who worship and pray to other deities, to other aspects of the Divine. Ganesh will be angry with them if they worship Krishna, they think. Lord Shiva will punish them if they worship Vishnu instead of Him. They have so many strange beliefs. The God they believe in is inaccessible, inhuman, and unapproachable. He is not pleased with people who do not please Him. He may even curse or punish them.

Can you call this devotion? This relationship with God cannot be called devotion. It is a divorce from God, a divorce from your own Self. How can such people ever find peace? They don't see the whole. They see only parts. Their prayers are always filled with petty complaints; they lack any feeling of devotion or love. Their prayers are expressions of their selfishness, greed and hatred."

"Listen to this story. Once a sannyasin was invited by a widower to pray for the peace of his wife's soul. The sannyasin began to pray, 'Let everyone be happy; let there be no sorrow; let auspiciousness fill the entire universe; let everyone reach Perfection.'" The husband who was listening to the prayer became upset. He said to the sannyasin, 'Swami, I thought you were going to pray for my wife's soul, but I haven't heard you utter her name even once.' The swami replied, 'I am sorry, but I can't pray like that. My faith and my Guru have taught me to pray for everyone, for the entire universe. In truth, only by praying for the good of the whole world will the individual be benefited. Only if I pray for everyone, will your wife receive her blessing, only then will her soul find peace. I cannot pray in any other way.' The swami was so adamant about this that the husband had no choice but to yield to his wishes. The husband said, 'All right, you can pray as you like. But can't you at least exclude my neighbor from your prayers?'

"Children, if you water the branches of a tree, the water will be wasted. It is only when the roots are watered that the nourishment will reach the branches and leaves of the tree. Likewise, only when we pray for the uplifting of the entire society will we also be benefited fully. Unfortunately our hearts are closed. We have lost our ability

and willingness to share. This is the prevalent attitude among people today. We are only interested in our own gain, in what we can acquire and possess for ourselves."

Another question was raised, "It sounds as if Amma is speaking against the accumulation of wealth. But how can people be expected to give up everything they have worked so hard for during their whole life? How can they live without any expectations? How can people simply give up their egos? It sounds impossible for a normal person living in the world."

"Impossible, impossible!" exclaimed Mother. "Children, all you can say is 'impossible.' You make everything 'impossible,' but there is no such thing as 'impossible.' Remember that you are living in the space age. Man has gone to the moon. The other day one of the western children was telling Amma that in the West people rarely use their hands to do any kind of work. They have machines for almost everything. This Westerner was surprised to see how we spend hours carrying sacks of cement on our heads. It takes us a whole night to move what he said a machine could do in less than an hour.

"In the future people may even have electronic spoons to feed themselves; they won't have to use their hands at all; and yet you keep on saying, 'impossible.' It has become a habit to say that everything is 'impossible'. It is easy to say 'impossible' to anything asked of you. It takes no effort, just a few movements of the tongue. Is anything possible as far as you are concerned? This word 'impossible' is a curse on mankind. Try to remove the curse; work hard, and you will see that nothing is impossible.

"It is true that man cannot live without expectations

and without his ego. Amma knows that it is not easy to give up all that one has earned through years of hard work and determination. Amma is simply trying to say that a person should not live in a dream world, but should concentrate more on the present than on the future or the past. **You can keep your ego if you want; that's no problem. But don't let it eat you up.** A person can make use of his ego to put forth effort in his work, to acquire possessions and to engage in pleasurable activities. That's fine. But he must not be blinded by his ego. He must not go against his own conscience, his own human nature. Let him try to live as a human being and not as an animal.

“Blindness of the eyes is bearable and can be managed to a certain extent. You can still live as a human being. You can still have a loving and compassionate heart. But when you are blinded by the ego, you are completely blind. Even if you lose your eyesight, if your heart is full of light and love, it will reflect on your deeds and on your entire being. You can still be a human being radiating the light and love of life. Whereas the blindness carried by the ego pushes you into complete darkness. You can't see or hear anything correctly. What you perceive through your eyes and ears is perverted and you react accordingly. You suffer and you also make others suffer.

“You must have heard of the great devotee, Surdas. He was blind, but his blindness was not a problem, for he was full of love and compassion. Singing the glories of his Beloved Krishna, Surdas led a happy and blissful life. Once Lord Krishna and His consort Radha both appeared before Surdas and restored his eyesight. But after beholding the enchanting beauty of his Lord, Surdas told

Sri Krishna, ‘My Lord, now make me blind again, for I do not want to see the world with the same eyes that have beheld Your Divine Form.’

All of a sudden, Mother’s mood changed. Lifting both hands skyward, She began calling out, “Krishna... Krishna... Krishna...” Her supplication was so powerful that it created waves of supreme love in the still air of the morning. All were filled with longing as they sat gazing intently at Her. Mother’s call had culminated in silence. As She sat perfectly still, a glowing smile on Her lips, Mother seemed to be in Krishna Bhava. The presence of divinity danced and sparkled in the morning light. A slight breeze stirred the air and Mother began to sing *Anjana sridhara*. . .

*O beautiful, sapphire-blue Sridhara,
I salute You with joined palms.
Victory to Krishna, salutations to Him!*

*O You who are like a beautiful jewel,
O Son of Vasudeva,
Remove all my sorrows.*

*O Krishna,
Who was born as a Divine Child,
Protect me in every way.*

*O Cowherd Boy,
Please come running
And play your flute.*

Some time passed before one of the brahmacharins reminded Mother about the Surdas story. Mother continued, “You may find it difficult to imbibe the essential

message of the story of Surdas, but it remains a truth that people like him existed, who could be fully content even without external eyes. It requires rigorous spiritual practice for the inner eye to be opened. Once that is open, the external eyes are secondary. You may say 'impossible' to this as well, however let's come back to the point in question.

"You don't have to give up everything you've gained through endless work. Keep your possessions and have great fun in life. But while you are in society, while you are enjoying being with your family and friends, or while you are at work dealing with business associates, don't let your power and position blind you. Allow yourself to express at least some love and concern when it is necessary.

"Don't let your power and position, your name and reputation, your wealth and possessions make you look down on others. If someone who is badly in need of help approaches you, you should have the capacity to smile warmly at him, to have a compassionate word for him and to listen. Even if you do not give him anything, smile at him and console him with a few loving words. You should be able to tell him, 'Brother, I understand your problems. It is quite obvious that you are having a hard time. I wish I could help you by sharing your sorrow, but unfortunately I am not in a position to do so. Please forgive me.' These words will have a soothing effect on him. They will work like a balm for his aching heart. He will be consoled and think, 'Oh, at least he gave me some comfort with his kind words. It is a great relief to know that good-hearted people like him still exist in the world.' He will have new hope and new enthusiasm. He will not be desperate and

depressed. He will not think of committing suicide.

“Suppose you behave harshly to someone in need, speaking in a rude way and not showing any concern or compassion to the suffering man. You threaten him and chase him away. Several others before you may have treated him in the same harsh and loveless way, and now, because of your rude and thoughtless behavior, he might lose heart completely. The accumulation of all these rejections might fill him with disappointment and frustration; he might feel desperate and lose all hope to live. In that state of hopelessness he might even end his life. Who is responsible for his death? Who pushed him to death? You contributed, you and the others who ill-treated him. Your ego, power and position made you blind. They made you a heartless person. Your words and deeds reflected the inner blindness caused by your ego.

“Do not give up your wealth. Do not give up your expectations in life. Have them, but try to be a real human being. Try to feel the suffering of others. You are not a machine or an animal or a demon. You are a human being. You represent the human race. Therefore, try to be loving and compassionate, because those are the signs of an evolved life. Remember, only a human being can develop compassion and only a human being can empathize with others. You might think, ‘If he is suffering, it is his karma.’ It is none of your business to think about his karma. If it is his karma to suffer, consider it your karma to help him. Only helping others will help you evolve. No other species receives this precious gift from God: the ability to understand and be compassionate. Utilize it. Do not misuse it.

“The ability to grow in love and compassion has al-

most been forgotten. By not making use of this rare gift, you are rejecting God, going against God and denying His gift. This is the worst thing that can happen to you. If something goes wrong in your work, that can be corrected. Material loss is not irreversible. If, for instance, you lose a huge sum of money, it can be replaced. But if you reject God's gift, that is irreparable. He wants you to use it properly. If you reject it, you are obstructing the flow of His Grace. You are building a dam between Him and you. Your ego is the dam.

"Children, Amma knows that, except for a few who can be counted on our finger tips, human beings are ambitious and filled with desires. For almost everyone who lives in the world, it is impossible to live a life without action and the expectation of the fruit of that action. Still, while living in the world, one can lead a happy and contented life. Man has the power to be content if his energies and capacities are directed through the proper channels."

"How is it possible to close off the past and future and let all the energies flow in the present?" one of the brahmacharins asked.

"Listen carefully," Mother said. "Suppose the only child of a couple is suffering from a fatal illness. The doctor says that unless a miracle happens, there is little hope. The medicine which he gives the child may or may not work. The doctor says, 'Pray to the Almighty. He is the only one who can make this medicine work. He is the only one who can save the child.' The father and mother normally have little faith in God; but now, out of desperation, they do as the doctor tells them. With great intensity they both begin to pray. Why? Because there

is a serious threat and an urgent need. They are now living in the moment. They look at their son. They watch his face and feel his breath. They caress his tiny limbs, and anxiously wait for him to open his eyes. When they see that there is no sign of improvement, they call out to God and they pray. In order to please God, they read one of the scriptures. They express great love and compassion for everyone who comes to see the child. At that moment, even if their worst enemy should come, they would offer him a chair and they would talk kindly to him. They would do this because now they have no feeling of hatred towards anyone. They don't speak ill of anyone. They have suddenly become very humble and loving. It is as if by really living in the present they have become saintly or enlightened for a short period of time, until the child is saved or dies. But, in either case, the old tendencies will soon return.

"But for now why do they behave like this? How is it possible to forget the past and the future at this particular time? They're not concerned about the argument they had the day before. They have forgotten all about it. Their child's life is in danger, and so they have a common aim which is for him to get well. Thus they are now working together with great love. Maybe for the first time in their lives they can really love each other. They don't feel enmity towards anyone. Confronted with the crisis at hand, they do not think about the future. Tomorrow, or even the next moment, does not exist for them. It is impossible for them to think about the future as they sit, full of hope, looking at their son's face.

"All their thoughts are in the now. Will he open his eyes now? Each movement of the child's body fills them

with hope. They are in the moment, present to what is at hand, not wanting to think of the possibility of their son's death. They want only to think of life. Because of their common concern for their son, they are in accord with each other, grateful for each other's company and for those who come to visit.

"Where do they get this power to be humble, friendly and loving even to people they don't usually like? How do they get this power to live in the present, to forget the past and the future? Where do they get this great power of concentration? They get it from living in the present, living from moment-to-moment with their son's life hanging on the edge of death. An ever-present need and urge helps them live in the present. The threat to their son's life helps them to pray, to be compassionate and friendly towards all who come. They feel that the child needs not only God's Grace but also everyone's blessing and prayer, so they ask the people who come to see him, 'Please pray for him. Please pray for our son.'

"This is just an example to show you that you have the mental power and strength to channel all your energies into the present, forgetting all regrets about the past and anxieties about the future.

"Remember, at each and every moment, this great threat of death is present. When we realize that, it is a blow to our ego. If we can feel the immanence of death, it will help us to live in the present. It will help us to be concerned about others. Your energies can be channeled properly only when you realize the need to do so. You must become conscious that you are wasting your abundant energies, and that they ought to be used for greater achievements in life. Once you are aware of the tremendous

loss, you know that your energies must be conserved and put to proper use in order to bring about a wonderful gain. You can remain in the same field of work but can become a tremendously inspiring source of power if your energies are properly channeled.”

BE CONTENT WITH WHAT YOU HAVE

Except for the sound of the wind rustling through the coconut trees and the gentle roar of distant waves, all was quiet. Turning Her gaze away from those gathered around Her, Mother began to sing. Looking towards the sky, Mother poured Her heart out as She sang, *Hridaya nivasini Amme*. . .

*O Mother, who dwells in my heart,
Embodiment of affection,
I can utter nothing but Your sacred Names.
O Mother of the world,
Bestow your Grace
That I may tell Your story.
I do not care for worldly pleasures;
I want only to adore You
With pure devotion.*

*I have carried many burdens,
Lived life after life without knowing You;
But since I have come to You,
I have surrendered all my burdens.
O Mother, apart from You
I cannot see that anything is lasting;
Let me forget myself
And dissolve in the stream of Your Consciousness.*

*Mother has told me
That Mother and I are not two
We are One;
But I do not yet perceive this.
I just want to stay with Her
And be Her child.
Mother looks after Her children with love and care
And by the mere touch of Her hand
She washes away my sins.*

*Oh Mother, am I not your child?
Then why is it taking so long?
I feel I am your child
And am counting each moment. . .
O Mother, what can I do to get closer to You?
Please show me the way.
O Mother, I am nothing
You are all there is
You are everything.*

When She had finished singing, Mother again began to speak. Gazing at the coconut palms silhouetted against the sky and the distant backwaters, She said, "Look at the beauty of Nature. Living harmoniously with Nature will in itself bring happiness and contentment."

Br. Rao said, "It is a pity that human beings, supposedly the most evolved creatures on earth, don't understand this truth. It seems that it has become their nature to complain and be dissatisfied."

Mother said, "There was a time when many, many people in the world were so unhappy that they all wailed and lamented to God for relief. Every person who was dissatisfied with his own lot in life complained and said

he would gladly change places with someone else. God responded to their cries and appeared before them. All the people with grievances assembled before Him in a large valley. God said to them, 'Peace be with you. Having heard your sorrowful wailing, I have come in response to your prayers. Lay down all your troubles and sorrows in front of Me. Any sickness, disability or woe that causes you discomfort or misery, give it up now.'

"Eagerly the people all threw down their burdens, their sorrows and fears on the valley floor. There was such a large heap of woes that the whole valley was filled and a mountain was formed. God then declared, 'In exchange for what you have given up, you may now select from this mountain of woes any burden you prefer.'

"There was a mad scramble as each person snatched a burden of woe that had belonged to someone else, hoping it would be much better than the one he'd had before. The beggar's burden was exchanged for the rich man's, and the childless woman took the burden that had belonged to a woman with many children. This went on for some time until the mountain of woes disappeared. For the moment, everyone felt happy and relieved. God left them and the people returned to their homes.

"But what do you think happened the very next day? The complaints began again, but a hundred times louder and a hundred times worse than they had been before. So again, God came down and stood before the people. Now they all cried out, begging to be given back all their old problems, as they could not bear the new pain and grief they had chosen. God granted their prayer and they all returned to their old lives, satisfied for the moment, but soon to become dissatisfied again." Everyone laughed

at this, recognizing themselves in the people of the story.

Mother continued, “Children, learn to be content with what you have. Don’t desire what you don’t have or covet what others have. Don’t think that someone else’s pain is nothing compared to your own, or that you would feel much better if only you were in someone else’s shoes. This is not true. Each individual has his own set of problems and worries. You cannot exchange your troubles for someone else’s because you would not be able to bear anyone else’s pain. The same is true of happiness. You find that your neighbor is happier than you, and pray to God to be like him. Yet once you experience his happiness you realize that you actually prayed for the wrong thing. Your neighbor’s happiness and sorrows belong to him. By the same token, your joys and sorrows are yours alone. Realize this truth and be content with what you have. You cannot have more or less than what is intended for you. What you have is what is meant for you.”

Another brahmacharin commented, “That is why the scriptures also say, ‘The next moment does not belong to us. It is not under our control. Therefore, whatever good you want to do, do it now right now. Do not postpone it.’ Isn’t that right, Amma?”

“The threat of death is the greatest threat to our ego. It is always there; yet, we don’t see it,” replied Mother. “We don’t hear death’s soft steps, and that’s why we persist in our tendencies and do not want to change our ways. Ignoring the great challenge of death, we do not exercise love and compassion, and we do not feel like sharing the sorrows and sufferings of other people. That is why we are not humble. The most humbling experience, death, is just one step behind us; therefore, do not say ‘tomorrow.’ Now is the right time to do what needs to

be done. Now we should take an oath for a change to happen in our approach to life.

“Children, here is a story. Once a *brahmin* came to the great king Yudhishtira, seeking help to finance his daughter’s marriage. Yudhishtira said, ‘Revered brahmin, come tomorrow morning; I will give you the necessary funds then.’ The poor brahmin left the palace disappointed. He had many things to arrange and had hoped to get the money immediately.

“A few moments later, cymbals began sounding, trumpets blew, and war drums echoed throughout the citadel. This was quite unusual. Normally this kind of jubilation would take place only when the king returned from a victorious battle. Upon hearing all the commotion, Yudhishtira was annoyed since there was no war going on. He sent a messenger to inquire about the noise, and the latter returned saying that the band party was playing at Bhima’s⁶ command. Bhima was immediately summoned and asked to explain. Bhima replied in a very polite way, ‘Your majesty, I was only celebrating your victory.’ ‘My victory?’ exclaimed Yudhishtira. ‘But there has been no victory!’ Bhima said, ‘Oh yes, my Lord, there has. You sent that brahmin away, telling him to return tomorrow. This can only mean that you have gained a victory over death, for who can know anything about the next moment, not to mention tomorrow, but one who has conquered death.’ The wise Yudhishtira understood the message hidden in Bhima’s action. He realized his mistake, confessed it, and felt thankful to Bhima for helping him to open his eyes to the truth. He then summoned the brahmin and gave him more than enough wealth to perform his daughter’s marriage ceremony.

“Children, understanding that death can happen at

any moment will help us to have real faith and to move towards God. Death will snatch away all that we have. This body which we love and care about so much will not come with us. We cannot take even a needle with us when we die. Understanding this great truth, take refuge at the Supreme Lord's Feet and be content and happy with whatever comes to you."

The last words Mother spoke resounded within each person's heart, "...take refuge at the Supreme Lord's Feet and be content and happy with whatever you are given..." Mother began to sing, *Parinamam iyalatta*. . .

*O Supreme Goddess,
Unchangeable One,
Bless me and remove my suffering.
Lord Shiva Himself, who burned down Tripura,
Is not He Your husband?
O please, remove the darkness!
Will the full moon visit me this night?
Are You aware of the darkness in my heart?
The days drop by, like petals falling from a flower,
And still, You do not come.*

*O Mother,
You are what any small child would long for.
Doesn't a huge tree support a tiny creeper?
O Mother, I don't know what to do;
Help this sad and lonely one;
Let me merge in You.*

*O Mother,
Exhausted in this desert, I drag myself along;*

*I cannot even crawl to You.
O Goddess of all,
Take pity on my fate and turn towards me
Grant me refuge at your Feet.*

The song ended and everybody sat without talking. One of the brahmacharins took this as an opportunity to clarify another doubt. "Amma, it is said that if you try to pursue happiness, you will miss it.' Why?"

"Because the search for happiness will cause discontent," Mother replied. "Searching is bound to create turbulence within. A turbulent mind is an unhappy mind. Your search for happiness is always in the future. It is never in the present. The present is within. The future is outside. In your anxiety to gain happiness you create hell in your mind. After all, what is the mind? It is the accumulation of all your unhappiness, negativity and discontent. The mind is the ego, and the ego cannot be happy. How can you seek happiness with such a mind? More seeking will only bring more unhappiness. Happiness ensues only when the mind and all its egocentric thoughts disappear. To be happy, you must forget about happiness. To be content, you must forget about contentment. Stop living in the past and future. Stop seeking happiness and you will find that you are no longer unhappy. Stop seeking contentment and you will suddenly become content."

"Pray for a contented mind in all circumstances. Prayer becomes genuine only when you pray for a peaceful and contented mind, no matter what you get."

"Lord Vishnu once said to his devotee, 'I am tired of your constant petitioning. I will grant you three wishes."

After that, I shall not give you anything more.’ The devotee was excited to hear this and did not hesitate to make his first wish. He asked for the death of his wife so he could marry a better woman. This was immediately granted.

“But when friends and relatives gathered for the funeral and began to recall all the good qualities of his wife, the devotee realized he had been too hasty. He realized he had been blind to all her virtues. He began to doubt if he would ever find another woman as good as she had been. So when the time came to make his second wish, he asked the Lord to bring her back to life. Now only one wish remained. He was determined not to make a mistake this time, for he would have no chance to correct it. He consulted many sources, and different people suggested that he ask for different things like health and wealth. Some of his friends told him to ask for immortality. But what good was immortality, said others, if he did not have good health? And what’s the use of health if he had no money? And how could he enjoy having money if he had no friends?

“Years passed and he still couldn’t make up his mind what to ask for: health or wealth, power or love. Finally, he said to the Lord, ‘Please tell me what I should ask for.’ The Lord chuckled at the man’s predicament and said, ‘Ask to be content no matter what you are given.’

“Renounce and enjoy. The real fruit, the real happiness, lies within. Learn to be content with that inner experience of happiness. When you eat a banana, you eat only the fruit. You don’t eat the peel because it will give you a stomach ache. Similarly, don’t allow your wealth, status and reputation to be the very core of your existence. They may seem to provide happiness, but such happiness is transient and riddled with pain. But remember,

your real existence lies within.”

Another brahmacharin asked, “Amma, while talking about contentment, You said that real contentment can arise only when one understands the spiritual aspect of devotion, and only when one has renunciation. What do you mean by that?”

Mother replied, “The word renunciation scares some people. Their attitude is that if contentment can come only through giving up, then it is better not to be content. They wonder how they can lead a contented life without wealth, without a beautiful house, a nice car, a wife or husband, without all the conveniences and comforts of life? Without all these, life would be impossible, it would be hell, they think.

“But do you know anyone whose possessions make them really happy and content? People who look for happiness in life’s many conveniences and comforts are the most miserable ones. The more wealth and comforts one has, the more worries and problems one will have. The more one desires, the more one will feel discontent, because desires are endless. The chain of greed and selfishness continues to lengthen. It is an endless chain. A person who is always thinking about accumulating more and more and more cannot be content. This does not mean that in order to be content one should never want to fulfill any desire. That is not the point. The point is that one should learn to be content with what one has. To merely acquire more wealth and to seek honor and status should not be life’s sole aim. Plow the field, sow the seeds, take good care of the seedlings, remove the weeds, give water and manure, and then wait patiently. If all this is done well and with an attitude of self-surrender and love, there

will be a bountiful harvest. All actions bear fruit. The future is the fruit. But don't worry about the future. Wait patiently, dwelling in the present, performing your actions with concentration and love. Action is the present. Love each action; find bliss in all that you do. That is the most important thing. When you can live in each moment of action, good results must come.

"Only by living in the present can one fully enjoy what one has. This means that you must stop getting anxious about the results of your actions, and stop worrying about things that have been done in the past. **Real renunciation is the renunciation of the past and the future.** The past is the garbage can where you have dumped all the actions you have performed. It is a storehouse of everything good and bad. The past is a wound. Don't touch it or scratch it. Don't make it bigger. If you scratch the wound - that is, if you delve into your memories - the wound will get infected. Don't do that. Try instead to let it heal. Healing is possible only through faith and love of God. This is possible only in the present. Remember God, chant His name, meditate on His form, and repeat your mantra. That is the best medicine to heal the wound of the past. Take that medicine to forget the past and do not be anxious about the future.

"Real devotion requires renunciation. This is what most so-called devotees lack. Such a devotee constantly broods over the past, or he dreams about the future, building castles in the air. Even while chanting God's name, he is lost in past memories or creating some future dream. Thus, he misses the beauty of chanting God's name. He does not appreciate the divine beauty of his beloved deity or his Guru's compassionate and loving form, and thus

misses the Grace as well. His prayers are empty; he never looks into his own heart. He never enjoys the ecstasy of love and devotion. Lacking absorption, his meditations are dry. Because he can renounce neither the past nor the future, he misses the beauty of the present. His actions are not beautiful. His words cannot inspire.

“Living in the present is the spiritual aspect of devotion. The so-called devotee is more concerned about the material aspect of his faith. For him faith in God is a part-time business. His prayers and meditations are not real. He cannot let go. He is so attached that he sometimes even calls out, ‘Oh, I cannot forget my memories! They are grabbing me, binding me.’ What a pity! Memories cannot bind him. They are inert and lifeless. They have no power of their own. It is he who gives power to them; it is he who grabs at them. If he would just release his grip, he would be free. He philosophizes a lot about renunciation and selflessness, but he is not sincere.

“Amma has heard this story:

One man flatly said to another, ‘I love the path of renunciation and selfless service.’

The second man said, ‘Hey, do you even know what renunciation and selflessness mean?’

The first man replied, ‘Yes, I do.’

‘Then,’ retorted the second, ‘if you have two TV’s, you should give one to someone who doesn’t have any.’

‘Oh, yes I can do that,’ said the first.

‘Okay,’ said the second, ‘now if you have two cars, one should go to a person who doesn’t have any.’

The first replied, ‘No problem. Consider it done.’

Amazed at the first man’s big-heartedness, the second man continued, ‘So, if you had two cows, you would

give one away. Right?"

'No! That's not possible!' the first man exclaimed. 'I can't do that!'

The second man was puzzled, 'Why not? It's the same logic, isn't it? If you're willing to give up a TV and a car, why do you hesitate to give away a silly cow?'

The first man explained, 'No, it's not the same logic at all. I don't have two TV's or two cars, but I do have two cows!'"

Everybody laughed at this wonderful illustration of Mother's teaching. Then She went on, "Children, this is the kind of renunciation we have. We make all sorts of excuses, 'If only I had this I would have helped you. If only I had that, I would have given you what you needed.' But when we do have the means to help, we forget all about our promises. We make promises regarding what we do not have, but are never willing to part with what we have."

CHAPTER SEVEN

*Sahasra-seersha purushaha
Sahasra-aksha-h sahasra-paath
Sa-bhoomim viswatho vrittwa
Atya-tishtah-dhasangulam*

“He, the cosmic Lord, the Purusha, with a thousand heads, a thousand eyes, and a thousand legs, pervades the whole universe, and beyond.”

—PURUSHA SUKTAM

Whether big or small, significant or insignificant, nothing escapes Mother’s sight. She sees everything. It is said in the scriptures that the cosmic Lord, the Purusha, has a thousand heads, a thousand eyes, and a thousand legs. He is said to pervade the entire universe and beyond.

In this context, the word ‘thousand’ denotes the infinite. One who has realized God or the Infinite, sees as if through an infinite number of eyes, hears through an infinite number of ears, and tastes through an infinite number of mouths. One who is one with Brahman, feels through everything in creation. Such a person experiences the world through every mind dwelling in all the three worlds because all are parts of that infinity. Such a person cannot miss anything that is happening in the world. His or Her look penetrates into everything. So, Mother’s eye is the cosmic eye. Her mind is the cos-

mic mind, for Mother is one with the universe. She is Infinity. In the Bhagavad Gita, referring to the Supreme Purusha, Lord Krishna says, "All heads are His, all eyes are His, all legs are His." The same is true of Mother. Nothing can escape Her sight.

Soon after coming to stay at the Ashram, one of the brahmacharins had an experience which convinced him that Mother knew everything he did. This happened in the beginning of 1982 when one evening a devotee presented the brahmacharin with a big packet of biscuits and told him that they were for all the Ashram residents. There were no more than twelve permanent residents at the time, and at first the brahmacharin had every intention of sharing the biscuits with his spiritual brothers. But later, while sitting alone in his little hut, he thought, "Nobody knows that the devotee gave these biscuits to me, and now he has gone. I don't have to worry about his telling the others about them. Let me keep them for myself and enjoy them over the next few days." And so, the brahmacharin hid the packet of biscuits behind Mother's picture on his altar and covered it with the altar cloth. He thought that this was a good hiding place. His altar was located in a dark corner of the hut and, in any event, why would anyone look around on his altar? The brahmacharin then left his hut and continued with his day. Who can predict what will happen in Mother's presence? After the regular evening bhajan, the unpredictable happened.

When the bhajan ended, Mother walked over to the coconut grove. She wandered among the trees for a few minutes and then, for no apparent reason, went straight into the "biscuit thief's" hut. He was sitting outside at

the time, but when he saw Mother entering his hut, the brahmacharin rushed to his room behind Her. Mother stood in the middle of the room for a few seconds, then suddenly put Her hands behind the picture and pulled out the biscuits. The brahmacharin turned pale and stood with his head hung in shame. Soon he fell at Mother's feet and began to weep. With a mischievous smile on Her face, Mother stood there with the biscuits in Her hands. After some time Mother asked the brahmacharin to get up. He stood, but without raising his head. From that position, he begged forgiveness through his tears.

Still glowing with a bewitching and mischievous smile, Mother coolly held the biscuit packet in Her outstretched hand. She didn't show even a wrinkle of consternation as She said, "Son, take these. They are for you. You can eat them all alone. Don't feel bad." Hearing Mother's softly put but sharp words, the brahmacharin cried aloud saying, "Amma, please don't torture me anymore!" Now Mother could not hide Her compassionate and loving qualities any longer. She put the brahmacharin's head on Her shoulder and consoled him saying, "Son, it was just a joke. Amma knows that you did this out of your childlike innocence. Don't worry. After all, it is Amma who caught you. Don't feel ashamed or hurt. But son, try not to be selfish. If you can't share even a small little thing with your own spiritual brothers, how can you ever share your heart with the entire world? How will you renounce your selfishness, and begin to love and serve the world? This is the place where you have to begin, so try to be more open and sharing."

This incident is just one of countless illustrations of the power of Mother's 'thousands of eyes.' Through it one can see the great beauty and charm in the way Mother

points out Her children's mistakes and corrects them. The way She does it cannot hurt, or create a wound. Yet, even if it does create a small wound, Mother knows how to heal it as well. Even though She allows sadhaks to experience a certain amount of pain or tension in order to help them realize their mistakes, the unconditional love and compassion She expresses is so great that it soothes them and heals their pain.

RESPECT FOR ALL LIFE

Friday, 14 September, 1984

A few days ago, one of the residents transplanted a half-grown mango tree from one spot to another on a plot of land which the Ashram had recently bought. He didn't like the way the mango tree looked where it was, and so, with the help of some other residents, he moved the sapling to a corner of the plot. However, none of them had thought to ask Mother's permission before transplanting the tree.

A day or two after the mango tree had been moved, Mother made an unannounced inspection of the premises. When the brahmacharins saw that Mother was walking in the direction of the new land they looked at each other and started to whisper. They were all afraid because the mango tree had withered away soon after it was moved to a new spot. As soon as Mother reached the new plot, She said, "Something is missing. What is it?" Everyone turned pale; no one spoke. "Shiva! Where is the mango tree!" Mother exclaimed. All remained silent. No one dared to say a word. Mother once again inquired, "What happened to the mango tree? Has someone cut it down?" Finally

Br. Pai stepped forward and in a very feeble voice said, “Amma, Nedumudi moved the tree from here to the other side and we all helped him transplant it.”

“Where? Where did you plant it?” Mother said in a very worried tone.”

With Pai leading the way, Mother and the group walked to the place where the mango tree had been transplanted. Seeing its withered limbs, Mother called-out in a heart-broken tone, “Shivane! What did you do to this tree? How could you do this? What a great sin you have committed. Why didn’t you ask me before you moved it? I wouldn’t have allowed you to do such a thing. I can’t bear the sight of this poor wilted tree.”

There was much pain and concern in Mother’s words; Her agony was even expressed on Her face. She displayed the feelings and concern of a mother for her hurt child. Mother squatted down on the bare ground with her head down and her hands on her forehead. Those who stood near Mother noticed that She was wiping away tears. While some wondered why Mother would cry over such a silly matter, others were overwhelmed with admiration for the divine love and compassion that She could show towards all of nature, even towards plants. Moved by Mother’s emotion, some could not control their own tears.

Moments passed. After a long interval, Mother spoke. “Children, please do not destroy life like this ever again. Such acts are not fitting for those on the spiritual path. Our goal is to feel life everywhere. We should avoid destruction. We have no right to destroy. We cannot create; therefore, we should not destroy. Only God can create, sustain, and destroy. All three are beyond our capacity. Such great feats fall only under His jurisdiction. Therefore, do not repeat such an act. If you cannot judge things

and situations properly on your own, seek the advice of someone knowledgeable or wise. And if they cannot give you proper advice, remain still. It is wiser to do nothing than to act foolishly.

“We must remember that everything is sentient, that everything is full of consciousness and life. Everything exists in God. There is no such thing as mere matter; consciousness alone exists. If we approach all situations with this attitude, destruction becomes impossible for us; the very idea of destruction disappears. Only then can you help and serve others for their benefit and for the betterment of the world.

“When Amma talks about the ‘world,’ She is not talking only about human beings. The ‘world’ includes everything—humans and animals, plants and trees—the whole of nature. It is true that human beings are the most visibly evolved creatures, but that doesn’t mean that other forms of life are without feelings. The *Vedas* and the *Upanishads* say that everything is pervaded with consciousness.

“God dwells in everything. Nowhere is it mentioned that God dwells only in human beings and not in animals or other species of life. He is in the mountains, the rivers, the valleys, the trees. He is in the birds, the clouds, in the stars, the sun and moon, everywhere. God dwells in *sarva charaachara*, in both the moving and the unmoving. How can a person, who has understood this, kill and destroy?

“You may think that humans can speak, walk, act, think and feel, whereas plants cannot; you may think that they are lifeless, and that you therefore have the right to cut them down, destroy them, and use them for your own selfish purposes. However, everything in Nature has

a purpose to fulfill. There are no mistakes in creation. Everything in Nature is well calculated and accurately measured. The proportions are perfect.

“Every creature, every thing that has been created by God, is special. Think of the miracles of Nature. Camels are blessed with a special bag to store water; the kangaroo has a cradle to carry its baby wherever it goes; even the most insignificant and seemingly harmful creatures or plants have a specific use. They have a part of their own to play. Amma has heard that spiders keep the insect population in balance; snakes keep the rodent population under control, and even the tiny, one-celled plankton in the ocean serve as food for whales. We cannot know the purpose of everything. Nature is a mystery to us. Therefore, we act foolishly and destroy trees, plants, and animals. Many ayurvedic herbs and plants look to us like useless weeds. Out of ignorance we destroy them. But a knowledgeable ayurvedic physician knows how useful and significant they are.

“Man is dependent on Nature for his very existence. Nature is an indispensable part of life on earth. Without Nature no creature, not man or anything else, can live. Therefore, it is one of our foremost duties to lovingly care for all living things. You may feel that destroying a tree or a plant is a lesser wrong than killing a human being. This concept is wrong. Plants and trees also have emotions and can feel fear. When somebody approaches a tree or plant with an ax or a hacking knife, the plant is afraid; it trembles with fear. You need to have a subtle ear to hear its cries, a subtle eye to see its helplessness, and you need a subtle mind to feel its fear. You do not see its suffering, but you can feel it if you have a com-

passionate heart. In order to see the suffering of a plant, your mind's eye must be open. Unfortunately, you do not see subtle things with your external eyes. Because of this, you destroy a helpless tree or plant.

"It has been scientifically proven that not only humans and animals, but plants and trees also have feelings and emotions. They can even express themselves to a certain extent; and if we have the right attitude, we can learn to understand. Ages ago, the saints and sages of India, having delved deep into the laboratory of their own consciousness, proclaimed that plants and trees also have feelings and that they could express their feelings if one had a loving and compassionate attitude towards them.

"The story of Shakuntala is a very good illustration of this point. Shakuntala was the adopted child of a sage named Kanwa. From a very young age, Shakuntala had a spontaneous love for Nature, for animals, plants, and trees. She loved them and cared for them like her own life. Every day Shakuntala watered the plants and bushes around the hermitage and spent much time in the garden expressing her love for them. She would even caress and kiss the plants. She expressed the same love for animals and birds, too. There was one jasmine plant in particular that she had a special attachment to and loved the most. She spent hours each day bathing its leaves and sniffing its lovely blossoms.

"Once a king came hunting in the forest. He happened to see Shakuntala and fell in love with her. The king and Shakuntala were married. It is said that on the day that Shakuntala left the hermitage, the plants and trees all bent low as if hanging their heads in sorrow. Shakuntala

went up to each and every plant, tree, and animal and bade them good-bye with tear-filled eyes. The deer and the peacocks shed tears of great sorrow as Shakuntala took leave of them. And the jasmine plant, which she loved the most, even caught hold of Shakuntala's feet, wrapping its tendrils around them as if to prevent her from going."

Interrupting the profound flow of Her words, Mother looked at the mango tree. For some time Mother remained silent, Her gaze fixed on the tree. A few moments passed and She slipped into an indrawn mood. While Mother sat with Her eyes shut, tears ran down Her cheeks. Perhaps She was feeling compassion for the mango tree. Perhaps her tears were for something else which we can never know.

DON'T BE SELF CENTERED

"Amma, we're sorry we were so careless," murmured one of the brahmacharins, his voice full of genuine regret. "We didn't mean to destroy the tree."

Opening Her eyes, Mother said, "What a pity it is that destruction has become the slogan of modern man. Nobody sincerely wishes for the good of another person. People have become very self-centered and selfish. They want to destroy each other. They want to destroy everything. The thought of destruction comes when greed and selfishness overpower man. Love and compassion are a uniting force. They alone can create a sense of oneness and cooperation. When man thinks only of himself and of his own desires, he becomes narrow. He becomes almost blind and sees nothing but himself and his utterly selfish little

ego.

“Amma has heard a story about some young men who wanted to become the disciple of a certain spiritual master. The master took the would-be disciples to a well and asked each one to look inside and say what he saw. All but one of them said that they could see only their own reflection in the water. ‘You don’t see anything else?’, the master asked once again. ‘All replied ‘No,’ except for one young man who said, ‘Yes, I, too, see my reflection in the water below, but along with it I see the reflection of the trees and plants that grow around the well.’ The master accepted this young man as his disciple and told the others, ‘You saw only your own image. That shows that you are self-centered. But this young man saw other things. He saw plants and trees as well. This shows that he is not self-centered. His vision is clearer than yours. It is him I will accept as my disciple.’

“Children, a self-centered person does not feel compassion or love. Such a person can become harmful to society. Such a person can easily and needlessly destroy. Wanton destruction is evil. Some countries have senselessly attacked other countries only out of the selfish desire to further their own interests. Selfishness, greed and self-centeredness are all evil. Evil can easily control human minds. Children, do not let evil overpower your mind. Willful destruction is sinful. Do not let sin overpower you. Absolutely lacking in feelings, a person with a destructive mind is obsessed with cruelty. Totally self-centered, he cannot see the oneness in everything, for he is unable to see or feel life in all things. Whatever he sees is ‘other’ than himself. Devoid of love and compassion, he cannot perceive the life in all things; he sees only inanimate

matter. This attitude makes him destructive.

“A destructive person is filled with hatred and anger. Anger and hatred make humans blind, causing people to destroy each other. Everywhere in the world people are killing each other. That is what happens when the destructive force of anger and hatred takes over human minds. But the real nature of man is consciousness. Man is God, but he has forgotten this. What a pity! What a downfall! What degeneration!

“Once God was worried about three countries that were constantly at war. Each country wanted to destroy the other two countries and their people. Not only the leaders but even the people of the three countries hated one another. Eventually God called a meeting of the representatives of the three countries. God asked them, ‘My dear children, why do you fight and quarrel like this? There is no peace anywhere, and people live in constant fear. Tell me, what do you want? Why do you fight, when I am here to fulfill all your desires? Come, if you have any problems, tell me. I will solve them, but no more destruction.’ Then turning to the representative of the first country, God said, ‘Tell me, what do you want?’

“The representative of the first country looked arrogantly at God and said, ‘Look here, first of all we do not believe in Your existence. We have our own leaders that we believe in. If You want us to believe in You, You will have to give us proof of Your power.’

“‘What proof do you want?’ asked God. Pointing his finger at the ambassador of the second country, the representative of the first country said, ‘Destroy him and his country. Destroy them totally. If You can do that, we will believe in You. We will build temples, churches and

mosques for You, and we will encourage our people to worship You.'

"God was so taken aback to hear the desire of the first country, He was speechless. This silence of God persuaded the first representative to speak again. 'Okay,' he continued, 'it does not matter. Your silence means that You can't do it. That's okay. Since You can't do it, we will do it anyway. It might take us a little longer, but that's no problem.'

"Now God turned to the representative of the second country. The people of the second country were believers, so God thought he would respond in a more decent and agreeable manner. However, when God asked him what his country wanted, the ambassador said, 'My Lord, our desire is very small. We simply don't want to see any place for our friend, the first country, on the map. Just take their country out. Remove it, and leave only a blank space there. We don't want the name of our friend on the map. However, my Lord, if you do not do it with Your Grace and blessings, we will definitely do it with our armies in Your name.'

"This time God was really shocked. If even those who had faith in Him talked in this way, what would be the attitude of those who didn't? For some time He was struck dumb. Finally, with great hope, He turned to the representative of the third country, who looked very polite and gentlemanly. The representative of the third country smiled at God and greeted Him with joined palms. This gesture filled God's heart with optimism. He sighed and thought, 'At least he understands Me. Now I will be able to feel happy and content thinking that I can at least save one country from the path of destruction.' Returning the smile,

God asked, 'Yes, my son, what is your wish?'

"The representative of the third country once again bowed down to God and coolly said, 'Divine Lord, we have no desire of our own. Be compassionate and fulfill the desires of both these countries; then our desire will also be fulfilled!'

"Such is the attitude of every country, every human being. Destruction, destruction, destruction. Children, stop destroying! This is not your path. Yours is the path of love and compassion. Yours is the path of empathy, of feeling the pain and happiness of others as your very own."

Gayatri brought a drink for Mother, but She refused it, saying, "Amma does not feel like drinking or eating after seeing what Her children have done. Their thoughtless and indiscriminate act has created great pain in Her heart." Turning to the brahmacharins, she continued, "Due to your wrong judgment, you have destroyed a life. You should repent. You must not commit another mistake like this. But since you don't feel any concern for the life you have unnecessarily destroyed, Amma does not feel like eating or drinking today."

The thought that Mother was not going to eat or drink because of them made the brahmacharins feel remorseful and extremely sad. They never thought the course of events would take such a sharp turn. When Mother had begun to tell stories, the brahmacharins all thought the mango tree incident was over, that there would be no more fuss. But Mother's declaration upset them all over again.

Mother once again went up to the tree. This time She embraced it and kissed its trunk. As if addressing the very life of the tree or some deity which presided over it, She

spoke, "My children acted indiscriminately. They are ignorant children. I consider it my own fault. How can it be otherwise? I have not taught them well enough for them to understand and feel that there is life in all of creation. I seek your forgiveness on my children's behalf. Forgive them for their ignorant act." Mother once again embraced the tree and kissed it before walking directly back to the Ashram.

Mother's strange but magnificent act provided everyone present with a great example of humility and love. The brahmacharins and the residents all felt very ashamed. They never would have imagined that someone would apologize to and seek forgiveness from a tree. Who but a person who beholds life everywhere could do such a thing? Who can set such an example of humility and compassion but one who is filled with love and compassion, a person who is constantly established in that supreme state? How could one who sincerely wants to follow the path of spirituality ever forget this event? Special lessons or experiences with Mother, the unusual things that She does, are never forgotten. The memory of such events and incidents are treasured forever in a sadhak's heart, in the innermost recesses of his very being.

Desperate with remorse, the brahmacharins followed Mother, saying, "Amma don't fast! We won't make this mistake again. Amma, please don't fast. We will not do such a thing again. Amma..."

Mother seemed deaf to their pleas. She was about to climb the stairs to Her room when suddenly Nedumudi, the brahmacharin whose idea it had been to move the tree, burst into tears. He cried and called to Mother, "Forgive me! I will never make a mistake like this again.

From now on I will not do anything without seeking your advice. It was all my fault, Amma. You have taught me a good lesson. Please don't fast, Amma! I will fast on my own for as many days as you say. But please, Amma, please, you must not torture your body. I should suffer! I should be the one to suffer! Even when You shed tears, and sought the tree's forgiveness, I was unmoved. What an ego I have! What a sinner I am!" He started beating his head with his hands.

At the sight of the brahmacharin's anguish, Mother's heart melted. She turned towards him and caught hold of both his hands. "Son... son... Amma's darling son. Don't worry. Amma will not fast. Do not beat yourself. You have repented enough. Now calm down. Amma will eat."

The above event is a very good illustration of the way Mother punishes Her children for their mistakes. In fact, one cannot call it punishment, for the word punishment is too negative to use in this context. Mother does not penalize Her children. Her way is simply to make them aware of their mistakes. Once the realization "I have committed this mistake, I should not have done it, I must repent" comes, then one is on the right track. In order to repair or make up for a mistake, one must first become aware of it. Without realizing that one has made a mistake or that one has a particular weakness that will become a stumbling block on one's path, how can one overcome or remove it?

Mother shows us our weaknesses and mistakes. She does not always wait for us to realize on our own the areas where we need work, but creates the circumstances necessary to make us realize our weaknesses on our own. And that She does by setting an example. One who witnesses

and absorbs such an example cannot easily make the same mistake again. The examples and profound advice that Mother gives help a seeker to be more alert and careful; they inspire him to use his discrimination before performing any task or making any decision. Thus Mother's so-called punishments serve as precious experiences which guide Her children along the right path. Mother's lessons cannot really be called "punishments." They are actually blessings. Mother's scoldings or punishments are Her flowing to the sadhak in that form.

Mother sat down on the last step of the staircase. Covering his face with his hands, Nedumudi continued to weep. Compassion filled Mother's eyes as She affectionately rubbed his head. Gayatri was still holding the drink she had brought for Mother. Mother now took the drink from Gayatri and had a sip. Raising the crying brahmacharin's face, Mother poured some of the water into his mouth. She then did the same with all the others and soon everyone was smiling. All were happy to have Mother's blessing and to know that She was not going to fast. Mother smiled at everyone again and said, "Children, everyone's mind is turbulent now, let us calm ourselves." Mother then began to sing, *Purnami ravil*. . .

O Mother,
You are the splendor of moonlight
Shining forth in the sky on a full moon night;
You are a spring evening,
Arriving in a beautiful, fragrant palanquin
Covered with flowers.

O Mother,
You are the exquisite sound
Awakening in the gentle strings of a tambura;
You are a lyrical poem
Within the bursting imagination of a poet.

You are the One in whom the seven primary colors
And seven notes have merged;
You are the fragrance of a flower,
The beauty of a rainbow,
And the coolness of a breeze.

The atmosphere once again grew calm and peaceful
and everyone was left with the memory of yet one more
wonderful experience worthy of contemplation.

A MAHATMA CANNOT DESTROY

Saturday, 15 September 1984

The morning meditation was going on. Mother was sitting among the coconut trees, surrounded by the Ashram residents. Mother kept a close watch on everyone to see if they were meditating with proper sraddha. Even when, at nine-thirty, the time for meditation ended, no one stirred. No one spoke for a while. Moments passed, then one of the brahmacharins raised a question, "Amma, you said that one cannot destroy life if one has love and compassion. But Krishna and Rama killed many people. Jesus lashed the merchants who did business in the temple. These Masters are known as the embodiments of love and compassion, yet they did harm to life. Isn't this a contradiction?"

“First of all,” Mother began, “you should remember that Rama and Krishna were not only Perfect Beings; they were kings too. Rama was a king and Krishna a maker of kings. As the rulers of their countries, it was their first and foremost duty to protect their countries and people from danger. Whenever and wherever there was a threat to righteousness, they had to fight to destroy the unrighteous and evil forces. But they fought only against cruel kings and evil forces.

“Rama and Krishna were embodiments of Universal Power. They were God’s power in human form and thus had the power to create, sustain, and destroy. You say that they destroyed life. But don’t you know that they also created and sustained life? Many such incidents are narrated in the great epics. We have neither the power to create nor to sustain, yet we go on destroying, always seeking excuses for our actions. Seeing that other people are doing the same as we are, we think we can justify even our worst actions. We feel that what we do is justifiable, if we can accuse a superior person of doing the same thing. We know we do wrong, but we have to find someone else to blame. It is ridiculous to blame God for our mistakes. God is the Creator, the Creator of the entire universe, while man is His creation. God is all-powerful, all-pervading, and all-knowing, whereas man is limited, confined as he is by his body, mind, and intellect. While God or the Guru acts out of complete and pure knowledge, man acts out of ignorance.

“Rama, Krishna, and Jesus were all-powerful, all-pervading, and all-knowing. When you say that Krishna killed, you are forgetting that He also gave life. Do you recall how He brought Arjuna’s grandson back to life? The child

was born dead, but Krishna gave the child life. It was the same Krishna who bestowed the ultimate fulfillment of human birth, emancipation, on the hunter whose arrow killed Krishna's body. It is said that the people who were killed by Him were all freed eternally from the cycle of birth and death.

“When you kill or destroy someone or something, you only lengthen the chain of your own karma. It is your destructive mind—your anger, hatred, selfishness or greed—that causes you to do such things. The anger or greed or selfishness in you persuades you to do evil, and that action adds more to your existing anger, greed and selfishness. It blows more air into the balloon of your ego, and you become more puffed up. Each time you act selfishly or angrily or greedily you are taking one more holiday, one more day of leave, from the state of perfection, from your eternal freedom.

“If you do not care how many births you take or how much you will have to suffer, that it is your choice. But you are harming other people. Not only by injuring or killing someone, but just by feeling angry, just by acting greedily or selfishly towards others, you are triggering the same negative feelings in them. Your negative feelings will invoke their negativity as well. They too will suffer, thereby adding to the storehouse of their karma, and will be born again with the additional vasanas that have been accumulated. Thus through your anger or selfishness, you have lengthened the chain of someone else's karma. You are responsible, since it happens due to your anger and greed. This is the kind of destruction you do.

“The same thing happens in the case of trees, plants, and other forms of life. When you destroy them, you are

not doing it out of love and compassion. Mostly, it is out of anger, hatred, selfishness, or greed. Each time you destroy a plant or an animal, you are releasing one of these negative feelings in the form of vibrations. These negative vibrations cause that particular life form to suffer. What you give them will be returned. If you love them and feel compassion towards them, the same sentiment will be returned. But if love and compassion are absent, can feelings exist other than negative ones? Some animals or snakes can strike back in revenge when man behaves cruelly. Some plants also have a certain degree of protection, but in general, plants and trees cannot defend themselves or strike back. They cannot express their anger, fear, or love, at least not in a way that most people can understand or perceive. Saints say that plants can express their feelings, but ordinary people cannot perceive them. Today, modern science has created instruments that can detect and register the feelings of plants, and in some cases even measure the intensity of such feelings. Thus, they have observed that through loveless actions and lack of compassion, plants also suffer. By harming them, you are lengthening their karma. Your selfishness blocks their evolution into a higher species of life and prevents them from attaining eternal freedom. Children, what do you think? Aren't you harming them?"

Mother paused as a devotee named Sarasamma came and prostrated before Her. Sarasamma began complaining about her son who she felt was very disobedient. As she spoke, the woman cried and placed her head on Mother's shoulder. "Daughter, don't worry," Mother said. He will be all right. It is just because of his age that he acts in this way. He is entering his teens, isn't he? Then

this is how he should be now. This is the period when the immature ego is at its peak. At this time of life young people begin to feel that they can stand on their own two feet. They feel they do not need anyone's advice or guidance. They start feeling that their parents and society have been controlling them for all these years and now they want to be free. The boy just wants to be independent. He does not want to listen to or obey anyone. No advice can enter his mind. He becomes so arrogant that he closes his heart and is not open to anything. He thinks he already knows everything. He now feels that life until this point was filled with darkness, that he was locked in a prison by his parents and now he is free. Now he is like a newly-blossomed flower with its head held high. The flower doesn't know that it will soon wither away and its head will droop. Like this the arrogant teenager walks around with an air of pride, disobeying everybody and rejecting everything. But when he enters real life, his ego will be crushed. He will be forced to lower his head. Life will teach him lessons. After a while his ego will be mature, and he will have a better understanding of life. He will be humbled then; he will learn to obey.

"When a newly-recruited police officer reports for his initial duty on the streets, he will be terribly puffed-up. His arrogance may lead him to commit blunders such as catching the wrong person, or beating someone without good reason. He puts on a big show of his power. It goes to his head and makes him blind. This is quite natural. But he will soon learn his lesson from experience. If you meet the same policeman a few years later, he will be different; you may not even recognize him. His ego will have gained greater maturity, and thus, his whole per-

sonality and appearance will have changed. Life will beat you up until you learn your lessons.

“Daughter, the same is the case with your boy. Don’t feel over-agitated and frightened about him. He is like a newly recruited policeman.” Everybody laughed, even Sarasamma.

“He will be all right soon,” Mother continued. Just wait. Have a little more patience. And be sure to send him here. Tell him that Amma would like to see him.”

“He will definitely come when he hears that Amma has called him.” Sarasamma looked happy; it was clear that she felt consoled.

When Sarasamma stopped talking, Mother suddenly left the normal plane of consciousness for another world. With arms out-stretched She began to sing, *Chintakalkkantyam*. . .

*O Glorious Light of Eternal Bliss
That dawns within when all thoughts subside,
I have happily surrendered everything
And am contemplating Your Golden Feet.*

*When You are there with me as my very own,
I have no need of other relatives;
I will quickly eliminate the ignorance of selfishness;
This mind will not be sad any more,
For it has shed the flower of desire.
Let the mind dissolve in brilliant luster
And enjoy eternal Peace.*

*Please come and dwell within me;
Help me live like the air,*

*In contact with everything
But bound to nothing.
O man, think!
Are you not living like an animal?
What is the real purpose of your life?*

When the song was over and she had regained her normal consciousness, one of the brahmacharins spoke. “Amma, I don’t think you finished answering the question about Rama and Krishna destroying life.

“Yes, that is right,” Mother continued, “You say that like others, Mahatmas destroy life. But they cannot destroy life. The Mahatmas are great saviors of mankind and of the entire creation. Even when they kill or destroy, what they are really doing is purifying and saving. Any destruction they do is only on the surface. They cannot kill or destroy because they have no egos. They are consciousness. Consciousness cannot kill or destroy. Only a person with an ego can kill and destroy.

“When Rama or Krishna killed someone, they did not feel any anger or hatred. As always, they were totally selfless and detached. Even then they were full of love and compassion. Though one may have seen a fierce form outside, hidden behind that was infinite love and compassion. A Mahatma is not attached to his body. The body may get angry but the Self does not. He is just a witness. The anger and fierce external form that you see is a facade. Mahatmas are filled with divine energy and vibrations, and only that can be released. They do not even have to release this divine energy because that is simply what they are. Even while breathing his last, the Lord’s victim feels this divine energy. He becomes peaceful and

calm. He merges with the Lord or attains a superior birth, a noble birth endowed with noble qualities.

“If the victim were to feel anger or hatred towards the Lord, even that would not create another circle of karma for them because the Lord is consciousness. Their negative feelings are released without creating an impact on the other end; and so, no chain of negativity is formed. The feelings just merge in space, in consciousness. Thus, even when releasing the energy of anger and hatred, the victims’ egos melt and disappear and their souls are purified and transformed. At that time, their vasanas are exhausted and they either transcend the cycle of karma or gain a higher birth. Once the vasanas are exhausted the soul is free from all worldly bondage.

“So, there is no comparison between the killing or destruction done by a Mahatma and that done by an ordinary mortal. Mahatmas bless their victims, either with a new and higher birth, or sometimes even with liberation. And so their so-called killing or destruction can only be considered as a blessing. The Mahatma is the real savior and human beings are the real destroyers. Even if a Mahatma cuts down a tree or a plant, even if he or she injures or harms someone, it is uplifting; the victim is actually being helped, he is being carried to a higher plane of consciousness. Because we are looking at it from the outside, we see only the harm that is done. Only when through spiritual practices we develop a subtle eye and a subtle mind can we see the great service that a Mahatma does through his so-called killing. What they kill is the ego only, freeing the individual self from the clutches of negativity. Because the transformation or purification that occurs in their presence and through their actions is so subtle, to see and understand a Mahatma’s actions

requires a subtle eye and a subtle mind. Blinded as we are by our egos, we cannot really behold what they do. The external eye is the eye of ego. The real eye is the inner eye, the eye of the mind of minds. That eye alone will help us to see through.”

Mother got up and climbed the stairs to Her room. Gayatri followed while the brahmacharins stood below, their eyes fixed on Mother as She moved up the stairs. Even after She disappeared from sight, they remained motionless, basking in the lingering radiance of Her being.



CHAPTER EIGHT

MOTHER REMEMBERS EVERYONE

Thursday, 20 September, 1984

As if to demonstrate that, as Mother had said, Mahatmas are the saviors of life in all its forms, the transplanted mango tree sprouted new leaves. Everyone had thought that the tree was dead. It had shed all its leaves and its young trunk had gone limp. Then suddenly after receiving Mother's attention, the tree slowly began to show signs of life. And now, to everyone's great relief, it was again looking healthy and well. Only now did the residents realize the significance of Mother's embracing and kissing the tree. In doing so, She must have transmitted new life into it. Who can understand the meaning of a Mahatma's actions unless they themselves reveal it to us?

On this day a devotee who was not able to come to the Ashram very often arrived and said to Mother, "I am physically away from you most of the time. I rarely see you more than once a month. When I am not here, Amma, do you ever remember me?"

"Amma remembers everyone!" She laughingly replied. "How can Amma forget anyone, when the whole universe is within Her? You are all parts of Amma. How can the

whole forget the part? The part exists in the whole. The part may think it is different from the whole, but the whole, which is the soul of everything, knows that the part is not different from it. That Supreme Soul is pure and transcendent love; it cannot see the part as different from Itself, so there can be no question of forgetting. Amma always remembers you, but your remembrance of Amma is equally important. When you remember that you are Amma's child, Amma's son or daughter, Amma's disciple or devotee, when you remember that She is always with you, that She sees all your actions and is your sole protector and guide, you are remembering the whole—you are recalling your real nature and true abode.

"Spiritual practices like meditation and prayer are also remembrance of the Whole; they too are the remembrance of God in whom you exist. Spiritual practice reminds you, 'I am not just a part, but the part of the Whole—indeed, I am one with the whole.' All prayers and remembrance of God or Guru remind you of the great truth that you are not a separate entity, that you are not just a limited individual, but that you are His, that you are He.' When this loving remembrance arises within, you can never be away from Amma, nor can Amma ever be away from you.

"A person who is blinded by ego will forget others, because he is selfish. Having no concern or compassion for others, he lives in a small world of his own and sees everything as different from himself. He and everyone else are separate entities as far as he is concerned. He sees the many and thus cannot see life as a whole. But a Mahatma's vision is entirely different. Having emptied his mind completely and filled it with love and compassion, he is egoless. He is wide awake and His all-pervading

consciousness sees and hears everything. Everything happens within him. Within him, the entire universe exists. He is the universe. This is the meaning of the *Viswarupa Darshana* of Lord Krishna.⁷ Nothing is different from him. Realizing his oneness with the entire creation, he beholds everything as his own, as his own Self.

“Mahatmas live in love and compassion. Forgetting their individual existence and sacrificing all bodily comforts, they not only love and constantly remember others, but they also selflessly serve the world. As they are dead to the ego, they cannot think of their own happiness or comfort. Therefore, son, questions such as yours have no significance. Your wife, children, parents and friends can forget you. Go away for some time and they will forget you. When a husband dies, the wife may cry, remembering the sweet times she spent with her husband. But she will soon learn to forget him and may even marry someone else. And when a wife dies, the husband will act in this same way.

Because people are limited, egoistic and selfish, this is bound to happen in all worldly relationships. Ordinary people, who are under the great pressure of their *vasanas*, are bound to forget. After the death of a wife or husband, any remembrance will probably be observed on an annual Memorial Day. Or the large, elaborately framed photograph on the mantle of the fireplace might invoke some memories once in a blue moon. With a sigh you might murmur, ‘Ah, he (she) was a good person, but what can I do? I’m helpless. I must live, so I’ve found another partner. There was pressure from all sides.’ Finished. Remembrance is over! Between each remembrance is a long interval of forgetfulness.

“But a Mahatma is beyond all such weakness. His heart is as big as the universe. He is infinite space which can contain everything and everybody. He is not sleeping. He is fully awake and therefore, he cannot forget.

“Son, Amma remembers you, not only you but everyone. How can Amma forget anyone when She is within them? Stop doubting and try to go beyond your limited vision. Don’t ask, ‘Do you ever remember me?’ Don’t think that you are physically away from Amma, or that you see Amma only once a month. These are only questions and doubts asked by your mind. Stop listening to your mind and you will feel Amma right there in your heart. Then you will know that Amma has never ever forgotten you, that you have always existed in Her and always will.

“Listen to this story: A lover came and knocked at the door of his beloved. ‘Who’s there?’ asked the beloved from within. ‘It is I,’ said the lover. ‘Go away. This home cannot hold both you and me.’ Feeling terribly dejected, the rejected lover went away. For months on end he lived alone, pondering over and contemplating the words of his beloved. At last, one day he returned and knocked again at his beloved’s door. ‘Who knocks?’ came a voice from within. ‘It is you,’ was the reply: And the door immediately opened.

“Love cannot contain two. It can contain only one. Love is *purnam* (fullness). In Love’s constant and devoted remembrance, ‘you’ and ‘I’ dissolve and disappear. Love alone remains. The entire universe is contained in that pure, undivided Love. Love is endless; nothing can be excluded from it. Love is all-pervasive.”

This statement shows Mother’s real nature which is as big as the universe. “I see the entire universe as a small

bubble within Me,” says Mother. Infinity is Mother’s nature. In the song, *Ananda Vidhi*, Mother describes the state of realization, “...From that moment onwards, I could not see anything as different from my own Self. Merging in that bliss of eternal union with the Supreme Shakti, I renounced the world with all its objects.” The state of supreme renunciation is the state of the highest detachment. In that state one goes beyond all form, one loses all individual consciousness and becomes one with Infinity.

“If you always remember Amma and you love Her, that is sufficient. It is enough if you can remember Her sincerely and intensely just once a day,” Mother continued. “Son, where there is love there is no distance or separation. It is your love for Amma that keeps you close to Her. Whether or not you love Her, whether or not you’re able to feel Her love, Amma loves you and She is with you. But you will feel Her closeness or presence only when you love Her. Lord Krishna used to dance ecstatically on the banks of the river Yamuna with the Gopis of Vrindavan. One day Krishna suddenly disappeared and did not return for a long time. The Gopis were plunged into great sorrow. Some cried aloud, some fainted, and still others called out “Krishna, Krishna, Krishna!” as if they’d gone mad. At last, late in the night, the Lord returned. Forgetting themselves, the Gopis ran towards Him and pleaded, ‘O Krishna, You who are so affectionate to Your devotees, why did You punish us like this? Why did You disappear, leaving us all alone? Isn’t our love for You pure enough? O Krishna, You are our beloved Lord and God. Please do not forsake these Gopis who have no refuge other than Your Lotus Feet.’

“Krishna smiled and replied, ‘Beloved ones, how can I be away from you, you who are so filled with love for

Me? Even the air you breath is filled with My name and form. Even your heartbeats sing My praise. Dear gopis, where there is pure and innocent love, there is no difference, there is no distance. Though the sun shines way up in the sky, the lotuses in the ponds on earth still bloom. Like this, the lotuses of your hearts have blossomed fully in the sunshine of your love for Me. We are forever one.' Likewise, children, how can there be any feeling of difference or distance when you constantly remember Amma with love and devotion? Mother is within you and you are within Mother."

Hearing Mother's soothing words, the devotee felt very happy and gazed at Mother with a smile of joy on his face. He then expressed a wish to sing to Mother. The song he sang was *Orunalil varumo*. . .

*O Mother of unearthly Bliss,
Will You come, one day, soon,
To the shrine of my heart
With Your eternally shining lamp?
It is for this reason alone
That this supplicant is wandering about.*

*O Devi, won't You bless me
With a melting heart?
I have searched for the Divine Mother everywhere.
O Mother, bestow Your Grace upon me
Caress me with Your soft hands
O Mother, give me shelter.
I am falling with exhaustion.
I know the truth that You dwell within me,
But when will the day of Realization come?*

SELFLESSNESS AND INTELLECT

Saturday, 22 September, 1984

Late in the afternoon Mother was sitting in the coconut grove with some of the brahmacharins, Gayatri, Kunjumol and a few devotees. One of the brahmacharins asked a question, "Amma, does a person who is doing selfless action need to do any sadhana?"

"Children," Mother began, "complete selflessness is possible only after the attainment of Self-Realization. All actions that we call 'selfless' before the attainment of that state are merely attempts to reach the ultimate state of selflessness. Selfless action is possible only when the ego is completely uprooted. Until then, all actions will be tainted with selfishness. You may think that what you have done is 'selfless,' but if you look a little deeper you will find that there is always a hidden motivation of self-interest.

"Children, selflessness is the goal to be attained. Action coupled with meditation, japa, chanting, and other spiritual practices are the means to attain the state of selflessness. There should always be a balance between meditation and action. Action alone cannot take you to the goal. Action performed with an attitude of self-surrender and love is the right path. Action should be well-rooted in the essential principles of spirituality, otherwise it will not take you to the goal. Only action performed with the right attitude can take you to the state of selflessness.

"We see people working. Work alone cannot make people selfless. They work to earn their livelihood. They work in order to gain honor, status and position, thus their work will only strengthen their egos. Such work

becomes food for the ego. They have desires to fulfill, for they still have a heap of vasanas within. Their outlook on action is totally different from a sadhak's. It has nothing to do with spirituality and its essential principles. Such desire-prompted action cannot lead you to selflessness. It cannot help you dive deep into meditation because selfish action creates more mental waves, more vasanas, and more desires. Only action performed with an attitude of selflessness can help you to go deeper into meditation. And real meditation will happen only when you have become truly selfless, because it is selflessness that removes thoughts and takes you deep into the silence.

“Action performed with a spirit of selflessness is far superior to action performed with selfish motives. A person who is inspired by the ideal of selflessness is less attached to the action and more dedicated to the ideal of selflessness. This attitude of selflessness has a beauty of its own. As you feel the bliss and joy of selfless action more and more, you enter deeper and deeper into a state of selflessness and meditation. So in the beginning, just feel inspired by that very ideal. Love the ideal; be inspired by it. In the beginning it is a conscious and deliberate attempt. As you feel more and more inspired by the ideal of selflessness, you start working from your heart. By the very performance of the work, a joy will spring forth from deep within you. Eventually it will become spontaneous. Along with doing selfless action, one should also find enough time to contemplate, meditate and pray. As you try to perform selfless actions, friction and conflicts are bound to occur. It is inevitable for these things to come up, especially when you work in a group. Friction and conflict will sometimes cause your mind to be agitated. This, in

turn, might cause your enthusiasm and vigor to diminish, and you may feel less inspired by the ideal of selflessness. Anger, hatred and thoughts of vengeance are bound to arise. In order to remove all such negative feelings and in order to keep yourself always in the right spirit, you must meditate, pray and contemplate. You should not let any thoughts block your spiritual growth. You should not have any ill feelings towards anyone.

“Children, because in our present state of mind, our so-called ‘selfless’ actions are not always completely selfless, we must try to keep a perfect balance between action and meditation. Introspection, contemplation, prayer, and chanting are necessary in the beginning stages of spiritual life. As we grow in our attitude of selflessness, our meditation will become deeper and deeper.

Another brahmacharin asked, “Amma, can proper intellectual understanding take one to the state of Self-Realization? Or is it just a question of undivided faith and pure, innocent love?”

Mother smiled, “Children, a person endowed with proper intellectual understanding can no more be called ‘an intellectual,’ because proper intellectual understanding means proper discrimination, or *viveka*. Viveka helps you see clearly and to penetrate into the things and events which surround you.

“A person who only uses his intellect, who takes pride in his intellect, is a person with an obsessed personality. Whether he is right or wrong, he strongly believes that his point of view is correct, that what he sees is right. Such a person cannot listen to or hear what others feel about something. Even when someone else is speaking, he will continue to speak within. He is filled with ideas and information; and he is always waiting for the other

person to stop speaking so that he can start. He does not listen; he absorbs nothing. Such people cannot surrender. Being restless and confused, they cannot pray or meditate. One will find it very difficult to be with them, for they can easily anger people and make enemies. It is difficult for them to believe in God or a Guru because they cannot accept someone else as their superior. Such a person will say, 'I am my own boss.' He is stuck in his intellect and cannot see or go beyond it. To go beyond one needs faith. Most intellectual people are coiled up in a shell of their own creation. They cannot come out of it, for they feel secure there. Outside the shell, they feel very insecure. They have their own concepts and theories, and are keen on expounding them. A person who relies solely on his intellect cannot surrender in complete acceptance unless a serious danger, a threat to his life or a near-death experience, confronts him. Only in the face of a serious threat is there a chance that he might call out for God. Unless one surrenders, how can one open up? How can one see the reality behind things?"

Mother continued, "A few months ago Amma visited a house in which the wife was a good devotee who still comes to the Ashram today. When she first came to see Amma, this woman was undergoing many difficulties because of her husband, a professor of philosophy. As a non-believer and a skeptic, he would not let his wife and children pray or meditate. He had issued strict orders not to have any pictures of gods and goddesses in the house. He had also forbidden his family to read religious texts. His wife and their two daughters suffered greatly under his restrictions.

"It was while the husband was away on a lecture tour that this woman and her two children first came to see

Amma. The woman and her children wept as they told Amma all about the difficulties they had been having at home. During the period of his absence they made several more visits to the Ashram and grew more and more devoted to Amma.

“When the husband returned, he learned that his wife and children had visited the Ashram. He was furious, and from that point on he became even more controlling about where they went and what they did. The family suffered terribly, and found it difficult to openly express their love and devotion to Amma. They lived under his tyranny until suddenly he was diagnosed with lung cancer. He soon became completely bedridden, and was not able to eat or sleep because of intense pain.

“Unable to bear the sight of her husband’s agony, the wife came to the Ashram and told Amma that her husband had lung cancer and was suffering from unbearable pain. With great hesitation, she told Amma that her husband had expressed a desire to see Her. She hesitated because she thought Amma would never think of coming to see anyone who was so critical about religion and God. So, she was very surprised when Amma readily agreed to visit her husband. Amma never had any bad feelings about this son. She sympathized with his nature and had only love and compassion for him. Even when his wife had only complaints about him, Amma never advised her to go against her husband’s wishes. Amma would tell her, ‘Daughter, have patience and love. Only your love and patience can change him.’ Amma believes the wife understood and followed this advice.

“Amma was only too happy to go and see this suffering son. When the man saw Her, he was completely humbled and full of remorse. Keeping Amma’s hands on

his chest and sometimes on his face, he cried like a small child. He must have apologized to Amma a hundred times for his faults. After Amma's visit he became very peaceful and relaxed, and always kept a picture of Amma on his chest. His wife said to Amma that after Amma's visit he never suffered again from pain. He could eat and sleep comfortably, and was very much at peace. Every day he used to apply Amma's sacred ash all over his body. His eyes full of tears, he would often pray to Amma seeking Her forgiveness. He had been extremely afraid of death before he met Amma. But after seeing Her, he was relaxed and calm; the prospect of his own death no longer filled him with fear. He is still alive, and is today a transformed and devoted person."

Everybody sat in silence after Mother concluded this story. They felt fortunate to be in the compassionate presence of a Mahatma. Mahatmas are compassionate even to those who oppose them and are disagreeable towards them. Their compassion is beyond all differences. That is why Krishna bestowed the final state of emancipation even on the hunter whose arrows put an end to His body. That is why Rama could smilingly renounce his royal position and kingly pleasures without a shred of anger or hatred towards Kaikeyi, who issued the order that Rama should go and live in the forest for fourteen years. That is why Jesus could pray for those who crucified Him. It is for this same reason that Mother visited the professor who always abused Her.

Love is Mother's nature. She cannot be otherwise. Just as egotism is our present nature, egolessness is the nature of a Mahatma. A person's ego cannot affect a Mahatma, as there is nothing for it to hold on to.

Egolessness is nothingness filled with love and compassion; it is nothingness filled with the presence of divinity. For this reason, Mother cannot return our anger, hatred or abuse. Mother can only bestow boundless love and compassion. Our anger, hatred and abuse dissolve and disappear in the ocean of Her of compassion. When we attack a Mahatma with the weapons of our anger and hatred, he or she fights back with the weapons of love and compassion. Eventually we will be disarmed, and the Mahatma will be victorious over us.

Mother continued, "In the professor's case, he feared that death was going to take his life. He thought he was going to die. He clearly understood that his intellect was useless. From that realization, real intelligence and discrimination arose. At one time he had considered his intellect as something great and invincible. However, this invincible intellect turned out to be utterly useless as the realization of death dawned in him. At this point he felt that he had been defeated. A defeated man has no claims to make. He is at the mercy of his conqueror; he can do nothing but surrender. Before he found out that he was ill, he was full of ego, drunk with himself, intoxicated by his power and position. He must have thought that he was great. 'Why should I bow down to anyone? How can I, a great professor of philosophy, accept the existence of God!' 'I' and 'mine' were his greatest friends. After realizing the inevitability of death, he was thrown down and completely humbled. There he lay, utterly defeated, saying, 'You, You alone can save me from this helpless state.'

"Once you realize that you are utterly helpless, you sincerely wish that someone will save you from this state.

This wish to escape death is extremely intense. This is the greatest crisis of your life, and the wish to avoid death is the strongest desire you have ever had.

“In some people, intellect gives way to intelligence or discrimination at this point. The professor realized his helplessness and deeply regretted how he had been. He sincerely wished to see Amma, and that is why Amma had to go to him.

“When you become aware of your helplessness, your heart will be very open and receptive. You become very thirsty; your thirst is unquenchable. All your sense organs, all the pores of your body, are fully open to receive peace and love. The experience is akin to being trapped in a forest fire. Imagine such an experience. Think how you would act. You would want to get out of the fire. You would not have many thoughts. You do not pause to recollect sweet memories such as the day you met your wife, and at that fatal moment the future also disappears. You cannot stop to think of the arrangements that are to be made for your daughter’s marriage or your son’s birthday the following month. You live solely in the present because your life is at stake. You cannot think of anything but the safety of your own life. And at that moment, for the first time ever, you are wide awake. Up until then you were asleep. You were sleeping either in past memories or in future promises and dreams. You were never awake to the present. But now, when there is the urgency of a great threat, you must be awake for at least some time, otherwise you will die.

“When two warriors fight, both are wide awake. Having developed a subtle eye, they are aware of every movement. This awareness comes suddenly. A bat of his opponent’s eye and the warrior will lunge forward with

his sword. They are fully awake and alert. In the moment of danger they die to their past and future and live entirely in the present. When faced with a great threat, we become like these warriors. We too surrender to the present in the face of death.

“Children, surrender comes through the realization of your own helplessness. The realization that all that you claim as yours—your intellect, beauty and charm, your health and wealth—are nothing before the great and imminent threat of death. Death will snatch everything away. This realization wakes you up. You become alert. You realize that you are laying claim on things which are not really yours. Therefore, surrender. You can enjoy life’s many pleasures, but you should do so with the awareness that it may all be taken away at any time. If you live life with this awareness, surrender will follow.

“There was once a great emperor who set out to conquer the world. He waged one war after another, amassing a vast amount of wealth by looting every country and then making the people pay high taxes. He was a powerful ruler, but selfish and cruel. Greedy for acquisitions, he was considered the richest man on earth. But death calls even the powerful and wealthy. When this great emperor was dying, he reflected, ‘To gain this empire I have committed so many evil deeds, all for the sake of power and wealth. Now death is approaching and I can take nothing with me. I, the great warrior who set out to conquer the whole world, can take nothing with me when I die. When death calls, I have to leave everything—all the riches, the splendor of the court, the glory of the battlefield. I must go alone; I cannot take even a single coin.’ He told his courtiers and attendants, ‘When you prepare my body for burial, be sure that my two hands are stretched out and that my

palms are open and fully exposed. Like this my subjects will see that I, a great emperor—the richest and most powerful man in the world—went completely empty-handed on my final journey.’ This is a great truth. Whoever you are, whatever your position may be, in a moment’s time death will grab everything, even your body. Therefore, surrender.”

An extraordinary silence followed and lasted for some-time. Gradually, the mood drifted into a poignant song led by Br. Sreekumar, *Kannadachalum*. . .

*Whether my eyes are open or closed,
I constantly see my Mother;
Mother embraces one and all
Her every glance pours forth compassion
And by the flood of Her Love
Each heart is melted.*

*My Mother is an ocean of joy;
To Mother, both a robber and a tyrant
Are Her own darling children;
Whether She is despised or adored,
Love constantly streams from Mother.*

*Mother’s life,
Befitting a descendant of the great sage Vyasa,
Illustrates that the Power of the universe
Can manifest
In a place as simple as a humble hut.*

*The tongue may enjoy the taste of sweetness,
But the senses are not perfect;*

*The Love of God is the perfect sweetness,
And that sweetness can be enjoyed through Mother.*

Mother sat with Her eyes closed during the song. When it ended, everyone was silent for some time, waiting for some indication from Mother as to what would take place next. Mother opened Her eyes and flashed an endearing smile to all. When Mother smiles, it is so engaging, so all-encompassing that every single person present feels that She has looked deep into his or her very own heart. A child may feel that the sun is shining on him alone, following him wherever he goes, for every time he looks up, the sun is there, shining down on him. Mother's smile is like the sun that shines on all. And each person, like a child, feels that She is smiling at him or her alone.

The same brahmacharin who had raised the doubt about intellect spoke again, "Amma, what is the conclusion? Is proper intellectual understanding helpful or not?"

Mother answered, "Proper understanding will help you realize that unless you drop the intellect you cannot reach the state of eternal freedom. Proper understanding will dawn only when you feel the burden of your ego, only when you feel the heaviness of the intellect. Only when you feel weighed down by the ego can you begin to unburden it. The ego makes you feel that you are great. Only when you are thrown into a helpless situation will you come to know that you are nothing. Death is the most helpless state of all. All big egotists and stubborn intellectuals have realized their helplessness while dying. Only a real blow to the ego or a serious threat can bestow this understanding. But once this understanding dawns, the intellectual obsession is removed and you are no longer

a prisoner of the intellect and its reasoning. Viveka arises. Viveka gives you more clarity of vision. This clarity, in turn, helps you to realize the impermanent and transitory nature of the world. All the wealth and possessions you have accumulated are with you now and at your disposal. But within a flash they can all become someone else's. Later they will go to another person, and then to another one and then to yet another. Therefore, do not be full of ego, thinking that you are the owner of all this wealth. Life is a mystery. You cannot understand it unless you surrender, for your intellect cannot grasp its expansive and infinite nature, its real meaning and fullness. Bow down low and be humble; then you will know life's meaning.

"Once the transitory nature of the world is understood, once this helplessness of the ego is realized, faith arises. Because you know then that you are nobody and a nothing in life, you realize that you want help from a supremely powerful being. This clinging to the Supreme Power leads you to faith and surrender. Proper discrimination, which springs from proper understanding, will help you to develop faith and love. Through faith, self-surrender happens, and through self-surrender one can definitely attain the state of Self-Realization.

"Only the knowledge or realization that you know nothing can really help you to grow internally. Only a person with this knowledge is truly wise. Greatness lies in humility, not in claiming to be great.

"Once the oracle of a city declared that a certain Mahatma was the wisest man in that city. When this news was reported to the Mahatma, he laughed and said, 'It must be a mistake. I do not know anything. In fact, the

only thing I know is that I do not know anything, that I am ignorant.' The puzzled messenger returned to the oracle and told him what the Mahatma had said. 'That is why he is considered the wisest man in this city,' the oracle explained. 'Those who claim to be wise and knowledgeable are fools.'"

Without any warning, Mother's mood suddenly changed into that of a playful and innocent child. She stood up and picked an orange from a big bag of fruit that had been offered by one of the devotees. Putting the orange on Her head, and humming a tune, Mother started to dance just like a little child. Next Mother put the orange on Her forehead and held it there as She continued to dance. Soon Mother's humming turned into a song, and everyone joined in, *Chilanka Ketti*. . .

*O my lotus-eyed One,
Tie on Your anklets and come running!
Come dancing!*

*We have come
In search of Your tender Feet,
And we are singing Your divine Name.*

*O Devaki's Son,
Radha's own Life,
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava,
O Slayer of Pootana,
Destroyer of sins,
Child of Gokula, come running!
O Cowherd Boy, come dancing!*

*O Slayer of Kamsa,
Who danced on the serpent Kaliya,
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava,
Who is affectionate to those
taking refuge in You;
Protector of those in danger,
O Embodiment of OM,
Come running!
O Melody of Bliss,
Come dancing!*

To the delight of everyone, Mother's enchanting dance went on for some time. Her innocent smile and sparkling eyes made Her look like a divine child, the embodiment of purity. To watch Her made the others long to become innocent like children; they also wanted to dance and play. Mother's innocence was so powerful and captivating that everyone was overwhelmed with love.

Eventually Mother stopped dancing. Still in the mood of a child, She took a handful of sand and made it into a ball. Soon She was walking around with the ball of wet sand balanced on Her forehead. Her head bent a little backwards, Mother tried not to let the ball of sand drop. This play went on for a while until finally the ball fell to the ground. Like a helpless child, Mother exclaimed, "Oh no, it broke!" and a disappointed expression crossed Her face.

The mishap with the ball of sand and Mother's funny, childlike look triggered a little laughter among the brahmacharins. Seeing that they were laughing, Mother's face changed. Now She looked a little angry. But even the anger of a child has a certain beauty. The next mo-

ment, with a lightning-quick movement of Her hands, Mother took some sand from the ground and threw it at the brahmacharins, and then She walked away.

Since She seems like an ordinary village girl, one may wonder at first how Mother could so suddenly and so completely transform Herself into a child. But if one looks a little deeper it is not hard to see the truth. How can various moods and roles be unnatural for one who is One with Infinity. Changing masks is a wonderful play for a great being like Mother. But it is a divine game, and can be played only by one who can discard or change the mask after it has served its purpose. There is never any sort of attachment to the mask.

There is an infinite number of masks that Mother may wear. Sometimes She wears the mask of a Great Master who talks about the profound truths of life. At other times She is the most loving and compassionate Mother of all. And at still other times, She is a great disciplinarian. Sometimes one can see Her playing the role of a great administrator who oversees even the most minute detail of the spiritual institution run by Her. And there are also occasions, like the one just described, when one can see Mother in the mood of an innocent child. But still, the truth remains that Mother is far beyond all this. And all these moods and leelas are possible only because She is the Beyond.



CHAPTER NINE

A TRANSCENDENT MOOD

Sunday, 30 June, 1984

Preparations for the celebration of Mother's thirty-second birthday were underway. Constant activity was going on everywhere in the Ashram. Devotees and the residents worked hand in hand cleaning the premises, filling in certain areas with sand, moving construction materials out of the way, and giving the buildings and the temple a fresh coat of paint.

Brahmachari Balu had prepared a special presentation to be given during the celebration. He wanted to narrate the life of a Mahatma with appropriate songs interwoven with the story. This kind of storytelling, famous in the temples of Kerala, is known as *Harikatha*. The word *Harikatha* means the story of the Lord. Balu's original plan had been to narrate Mother's life in this way, but Mother disagreed. "No, not when Amma is alive," She said. So the life of another Mahatma was chosen. But before performing it in front of an audience, Balu wished to have Mother approve and bless the project.

The opportunity soon arose. Mother, Balu, Rao, Sreekumar, Venu and Pai, were all sitting in Mother's room above the meditation hall. Mother was seated on Her cot, and the others were gathered around Her on

the floor. Mother said She wanted to listen to the story. Sreekumar was soon ready with the harmonium and Venu quickly set up his *tablas*. Balu began, and Mother listened keenly to the story and the songs. At times She suggested a few changes here and there. Sometimes Mother felt that the dialogue was not very effective, and asked Balu to change a sentence or a few words. In other places Mother instructed Balu to replace one song with another one. And sometimes Mother even sang along.

At one point Balu was describing the Mahatma's intense longing to realize God. He was depicting the excruciating pain of separation from his beloved deity through the following song, *Kera vrikshannale*. . .

*O trees and creepers,
Have you seen my Mother?
O glittering stars,
Where has my Mother gone?
O birds of the night singing in the trees,
Did my Mother pass this way?
O Lady Night,
Where can I find my Mother?*

*I am wandering along every shore,
crying and seeking my Mother.
O my Beloved Mother,
I will ask every particle of sand
To tell me where You are.*

Hearing these verses and their description of the intense yearning and agony of separation, Mother entered into a deep state of samadhi. At first She silently shed tears of bliss and then, suddenly, Mother burst into blissful

laughter. After this had gone on for some time, in Her ecstasy, Mother began to roll very fast on the ground like a spinning wheel. As She rolled around, Mother continued to laugh. For some time, the brahmacharins watched in wonder and awe. But when after a few minutes Mother showed no sign of coming out of Her ecstatic mood, they began to worry. It was not the first time that they had seen Mother like this, and in the past, She Herself had instructed them to sing bhajans in order to coax Her back to the normal plane of consciousness should She remain in samadhi for more than a short while. And so, gathering in a corner of Mother's small room, the five brahmacharis began quietly to sing *Nirvanashatkam* (*Manobuddhya*). . .

*I am not the mind, intellect, ego or memory;
I am not the taste of the tongue,
Or the sense of hearing, smell and sight;
I am not earth, fire, water, air or ether;
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva.*

*I am not right or wrong actions,
Nor am I pleasure or pain;
I am not the mantra or any sacred places,
The Vedas or the sacrifice;
I am not the act of eating, the eater or the food;
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva.
I have no birth or death,
Nor have I any fear;*

*I don't hold any caste distinction;
I have no father or mother,
Associates or friends;
I have no Guru
And I have no disciple;
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva.*

*I have no form,
Or movements of the mind;
I am the All-Pervasive;
I exist everywhere;
Yet I am beyond the senses;
I am not salvation,
Or anything that may be known;
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva.*

In Her God-intoxicated state, Mother continued to roll and laugh for ten or fifteen minutes. Finally She got up from the floor and began moving around the room as if drunk. Mother stumbled about with faltering steps, laughing blissfully all the while. Her fingers were held in identical divine mudras, and Her face glowed, emitting a penetrating radiance. Several times Mother's head or body came close to hitting the walls or banging against the floor, but the brahmacharins were very watchful and protected Her from any possible harm. For some time, Mother remained in one spot and gently swayed from side to side, reveling in Her own world, a world to which no

one else had access. Eventually Mother lay down on the floor and remained still. The brahmacharins continued to sing until Mother had finally descended from Her exalted state.

SATYA AND DHARMA Truth And Righteousness

In the evening, Mother was sitting in front of Nealu's hut talking to a few devotees who had just arrived. One of them asked, "Amma, is it possible in this modern age to follow the examples set by great devotees and saints in the great epics of old? The incidents in those stories must have occurred thousands of years ago when *satya* (truth) and *dharma* and love for God were commonly observed. As people no longer place so much importance on truth and righteousness, are those examples applicable in today's world?

Mother replied, "Son, a doubting mind is a great hindrance to the observance of spiritual truths. We never learn to believe. We only learn to doubt. This is the greatest curse that humanity is confronting today. It is true that long ago *satya* and *dharma* were more predominant than they are now, and that prevalence made the atmosphere more conducive for devotion and spiritual practices. But *satya* and *dharma* are imperishable; they are indestructible and therefore they still exist. The difference is that in ages past people practiced those ideals, but now we do not. Yet, today it is still the observance of *satya* and *dharma* by at least a few souls that helps sustain the entire world.

"Son, you ask if this is applicable in modern society. There are still many people who observe the principles

of satya and dharma. Even though they are a minority, you cannot deny the fact that they exist.

“Look at these children here in the Ashram. They are all very young and well-educated. Most of them are from well-to-do families. They had the courage and strength to renounce their old way of living and to embrace an entirely different lifestyle. They were leading normal lives in the world like all modern youths, but once they realized that spirituality is the highest truth, they fearlessly renounced their home. Their intense love for Amma and their longing to realize God enabled them to do this. Their love for the path of spirituality gave them courage and made them fearless. Their families, neighbors, and friends, and sometimes their entire village, criticized and abused them. Seeing their unusual behavior, people believed that they were crazy. People insulted and taunted them in public, but they could easily dismiss this ill-treatment and were never affected by insults or mean words. Because of their love and devotion they became so fearless that they could calmly stand before their parents and explain that they were going to embrace the path of spirituality, no matter what happened.

“Their families tried to tempt them back to worldly life, to the life of enjoyment and indulgence, which most people consider normal. But an indulgent person has no mental balance; he is actually abnormal, while a spiritual seeker, on the other hand, is well-balanced and therefore ‘normal’. Thinking that their children had been hypnotized or that they were under an evil spell cast by this crazy girl, some of their families performed rituals to eliminate what they thought to be an evil power. They gave their children food laced with an antidote which these boys accepted and ate without fear. Some families

even took them to psychiatrists to have them treated for mental illness. These boys willingly surrendered to everything with the strong faith that nothing bad would happen to them and that Amma would protect them from any harm. That faith saved them. They were fearless, not even afraid of death. They were mad with love for Amma and God and wanted to practice the principles of spirituality in their lives.

“One night, a group of hostile young men surrounded Balu when he walked out of the Ashram after the Krishna Bhava. It was dark, and the young men, who had been hiding somewhere, suddenly surrounded him. These village rowdies were adamantly opposed to Amma and the children who were devoted to Her. First they told Balu that he should stop singing bhajans in the Ashram. Then they said that he should stop coming to the Ashram at all. Some of them even wanted to beat him up. They egged each other on saying, ‘Why do we waste time speaking to this rascal? You think he deserves special treatment? Let’s beat him up!’ They kept on abusing him, using harsh and crude words. But Balu remained silent; he felt no fear. He could have run away or shouted for help since this happened just outside the Ashram and devotees would surely have come to his aid. But he stood his ground and remained silent and calm.

“All their threats and efforts to provoke and scare him failed. In the end, one of the ruffians said that they would let him go, but that they would kill Balu and throw his body in the backwaters if they ever saw him in the village again. Balu was fearless and unmoved even by such a threat. He coolly and smilingly replied by telling them that he was not afraid. ‘Mother has taught me that the Atman is imperishable,’ he said. ‘I have faith in Her. I

have surrendered to Her. Nobody can stop me from coming here or from singing to Mother. If you want to beat me up or kill me, do it now. I will not raise even my little finger against you.’ Having spoken, Balu closed his eyes and folded his arms across his chest. He expected that all of them together would jump on him like a pack of wild dogs. But nothing happened. In a few moments he opened his eyes to find that all the rascals had left. Where did Balu get his courage? How could he be so fearless and calm? It was because of his love and devotion. Wasn’t he following the path of the great devotees and saints of old?

“Rao also underwent great difficulties. His family was dead set against his spiritual life and created many problems for him. They even took him to a mental hospital where he underwent ten days of shock treatment. Think of the great danger in giving shock treatment to a person who is not suffering from any sort of mental illness! It could have done serious damage to his brain. But Rao was fearless and let them do what they wanted, for he had strong faith that Amma would protect him. As it turned out, the treatment didn’t do him any harm.

“Even today, many such incidents are taking place in peoples’ lives. But you still doubt whether the observance of spiritual principles is possible in the modern age. Why shouldn’t it be possible? Stop doubting and learn to believe, then you will see the possibility.

“Children, practice of spirituality is possible only through the knowledge that the Atman, the Self, cannot be harmed or killed. Only knowledge of the Self will lead one to the state of complete fearlessness. The body must die because whatever is born must die. But the Atman was never born. It was always there; it is and always will

be. There is nothing but the Atman, the Self, therefore it cannot be destroyed. This knowledge can completely free one from the grip of death and all the fear that goes along with it. A Mahatma is consciousness embodied. Having faith in a Mahatma, then, is equal to having faith in the infinite power of the Self.

“These boys were not Self-Realized souls, but their faith and love made them fearless. Only a fearless person, full of trust in God, can renounce everything, as they have done. All our attachments arise from fear. When you begin to penetrate through appearances, you will see that human beings live in constant fear. Fear prompts us to cling. Fear for our security bothers us constantly; if we have no money, fear grips us; if our wife leaves us, we feel fear; if we do not get a job, fear creeps in. Similarly, if we lose something—money, our home or our job—we experience fear. We feel safe and secure when we are attached to something, or if we have something in our hands. Attachment helps us temporarily to forget our fear; but deep down the fear remains.

“The people and objects that we are attached to must leave us one day. They cannot be with us forever. In due course they will disappear from our life. Our wife and children, our home and car, and everything that we are attached to will change or disappear. And when each thing or person disappears we are again overcome by agony and fear. This will continue until we surrender to God and develop faith in the eternal nature of our real Self.

“Children, devotion to God and faith in the Atman are possible even today. All the calamities and problems that exist in the world come only from lack of faith and devotion, from a lack of love. Once we lose faith in a Supreme Controller, or God, there cannot be any har-

mony or peace in society. People will act and live as they like. Morality and ethics will disappear from the face of the earth. People will be tempted to live like animals. Absence of faith, love, patience and forgiveness make life hellish. 'More comfort... more comfort...' will be the aim of life. Selfishness and greed will overpower many, destroying their humanity.

"Children, the present world is almost like this already. There is an urgent need for people to observe and practice spiritual principles. That is the only way to save the world and the human race from destruction. Doubt will destroy all of our good tendencies. Put aside your doubts and call out for help to the Supreme Lord. Pray, meditate, and perform other spiritual practices. Everyone has a responsibility to save humanity. You, too, have a part to play. By doing your duty with the utmost sincerity and love, you are helping your own Self. You are saving your own life, which in turn will help society as well."

Everyone listened keenly to Mother's soul-stirring satsang. When Mother stopped speaking, Her audience sat in rapt silence, and it seemed that all of Nature was standing still. The silence between Mother's talks always created an inspiring atmosphere. Sometimes Mother withdrew from Her surroundings and sat deeply absorbed in Her own Self. This intensified the power of these deeply quiet moments, enhancing the presence of Divinity that already filled the air. As if to heighten the meditative mood, Mother asked the brahmacharins to sing *Kodanukodi...*

*O eternal Truth,
For millions of years*

Mankind has been searching for You.

*The ancient sages renounced everything,
And for the purpose of making the Self flow,
Through meditation,
Into Your Divine Stream,
They performed endless years of austerities.*

*Your infinitesimal Flame,
Inaccessible to all,
Shines like the blaze of the sun;
It stands perfectly still, without a flutter
In the fierce wind of a cyclone.*

*The flowers and creepers,
The shrine rooms and temples,
With their newly installed sacred pillars,
Have been waiting for You for eons
And still You remain unreachable.*

FEAR OF GOD

Soon after the song ended, another devotee asked, “Amma, when you explained that fearlessness is the sign of a true devotee, were you talking only about one who has dedicated his whole life to the search for God? What about an ordinary devotee? Do you think that a certain amount of fear, like the fear of God, is necessary for some devotees?”

“Children,” Mother began, “fear is completely absent only when love is present in all its fullness. This kind of love is found only in a devotee who has surrendered

completely to God. Such a devotee lives in love; he has drowned in the ocean of love. Fully consumed by Divine Love, his individual existence is lost, for he has merged with the totality of love. He becomes love. He becomes an offering to his Lord. Like a drop of water which falls into the sea and merges with its vast expanse, the devotee dives into the ocean of bliss as he offers himself to existence. In that state, all fear, all worries, all attachments and sorrows disappear.

“Sometimes fear arises from the understanding of the Lord’s all-powerful, all-pervasive, and all-knowing nature. He is the Emperor of the Universe. He is the one who decides and bestows the fruit of all actions. When we think and believe that the Lord is all this, fear and reverence naturally arise. That fear and awe helps us to refrain from committing mistakes.

“Arjuna always considered Lord Krishna as his close friend, brother-in-law, and expert advisor, and therefore used to address him casually as ‘Madhava,’ ‘Kesava,’ and ‘Yadava,’ which were some of Krishna’s different names. But when Arjuna beheld the Lord’s universal form, the *Viswarupa*, he was frightened and amazed. In that *Viswarupa*, Arjuna beheld the entire universe, its beginning, middle and final dissolution. He saw all the gods and goddesses in the Lord’s wondrous form. He even saw the Pandava and Kaurava armies existing within the Lord. Arjuna beheld great warriors like Bhishma, Drona, and Karna struggling with death, caught in the Lord’s powerful jaws. Now Arjuna saw God as the Supreme Controller and authority, and thus called Him Visweswara, Lord of the Universe.

“Most people want to protect their possessions and their wealth. They believe in God, but they do not want

to lose what they have accumulated. They want honor, status and position. In other words, they do not want to give up their egos. Such devotees believe that God can help them to prosper materially. And when they are prosperous, they believe that God will protect their wealth. They have the faith that if God gets angry, He can destroy their wealth and possessions, or that He can snatch everything away. They believe that if God gets angry, He will invoke natural forces like storms, floods, draughts and earthquakes to destroy everything they have. Therefore, they worship God out of fear. They think that they can appease Him through prayer and offerings; and they abstain from things which they think will displease Him. They will perform righteous actions and help others in different ways. They may even build a temple or a church or an orphanage. All this is done to please God, so that they themselves will profit. Nevertheless, this kind of reverence and fear of God is good. At least, it helps people to be good and righteous. Though they do not want to surrender fully to God, and though they don't want to surrender their egos or their attachments, such people are far better than people who don't do any spiritual practices at all.

“A true devotee completely surrenders to God. He longs for God to kill his ego. That he will not be able to surrender to God or that God won't destroy his ego is a true seeker's greatest fear. Look at the fierce form of Kali. Kali is the destroyer of the ego. Because a true seeker wants to be free from the ego, he will love this aspect of the Divine Mother. Surrendering to Kali or to what she represents, a true devotee will happily offer his head to Her in order to add one more bead to Kali's garland of skulls.

“On the other hand, a devotee who is still attached

to possessions and wealth, and to honor and position, will greatly fear this aspect of the Divine. He will never keep a picture of Her in his house or in his puja room. He's afraid that Kali will destroy everything that is dear to him. He thinks that She will kill his ego and that without his ego he cannot exist. An ordinary devotee wants to keep his ego, whereas a true devotee wants to die to his ego so that he can live in consciousness or in pure, innocent love. A true devotee stops feeding the ego; he stops listening to the intellect. He only listens to the heart. Dying to the ego is real death. That death makes you immortal. **Death of the ego leads you to deathlessness.** When the ego dies, you live eternally in bliss.

"Amma has heard a story. Once a devotee was about to go to see his spiritual master. Before leaving the house he thought, 'I must offer something to my Guru. Let me take some flowers.' But just as he was about to go, it occurred to him that maybe the flowers were not a good enough offering. So, just in case, he took some diamonds, thinking that if necessary, he could offer these to the Guru as well. The devotee arrived at the place where his master was giving darshan to the public. He went to the master and was about to offer the flowers at his master's feet, when he heard his Guru's voice saying, 'Drop it.' So the devotee dropped the flowers. 'He must want the diamonds,' the devotee thought. But when he tried to offer these, the master again said, "Drop it." Confused, the devotee bent his head and was about to bow to the Guru before getting up to go. But again the master said, 'Drop it.' The puzzled devotee looked up at his master's face. Smiling, the Guru replied, 'Yes, unless you drop your head, the ego, you cannot realize the Self.'"

"Is that what is meant by prostration?" asked a

brahmacharin.

“Yes,” said Mother, “prostration is a symbol of self-surrender. The physical prostration becomes meaningful only when you surrender your ego at the feet of the Guru or God. When you prostrate, you are inviting the Guru or God to trample your ego. The Guru or God will not do that to an ordinary devotee, but they will ruthlessly do it to a true seeker. If you still fear for your security and comfort, if you are still after honor, status and position, the Guru or God will wait. But the day will come when you will renounce all fear for your worldly security and turn fully towards the Satguru or God. Until you realize that you are helpless, that your ego cannot save you, and that all you have acquired is nothing, God or the Guru will keep on creating the circumstances necessary to make you realize this truth. When that happens, you surrender. That is when you cast off all your fear and let the Guru or God dance on your ego while you lie low at His Feet. That is when you become a true devotee. This is the real meaning of prostration.

“The physical prostration that we do now is to lead us to that mental state. Having attained that state, your whole life is a constant prostration to your Guru or Lord. The entire human race, all living beings, the whole of creation is moving towards that state. It does not matter whether or not you resist. It must happen one day, now or later, in this lifetime or the next, your turn will come. Until then you can wait; you can live as you like.

“While God may not be visible to you now, He is always there, guiding and controlling you, holding the reins of your life. To begin with, God allows you long reins, and you don’t notice that He is actually in charge. But remember, everything is in God’s hands. You are not aware

of it, but as you proceed through life, God is gradually shortening the reins. Finally, one day you realize that you cannot move another inch. At that point, when you are utterly helpless, you will feel God tugging at the reins as he begins to pull you back towards Him. You may at first put up a struggle, but you will soon find that the pull is of an unworldly power, and you have no choice but to surrender to His pull. It is at this point that you begin your journey back to God, the Source of your existence. This journey has to happen. You will inevitably find that you can't do anything other than move towards God.

"If God wants to, He can draw in the reins at any time. God thinks, 'This child isn't ready yet. Let him play a little longer. He will tire of it one day. Then he will return.' So be vigilant. Be alert, for you are always under His close watch. You cannot run away from God. Wherever you may go, whatever you may do, He is always there, watching over you, His child. Whatever you do is done only with His consent. He allows you to do it. He lets you play. But you have a limited area to play in. Do not think that you can play anywhere you like.

"At times you may step out of bounds; you may venture where you are not meant to go. It may seem as if God has not noticed, but He is just pretending. God sees and hears everything. At this point He thinks to Himself, 'My child can certainly be mischievous,' and He continues to let you play. But He reminds you that you cannot go on playing forever, by putting you into difficult situations and subjecting you to painful experiences. After a difficult experience you are well-behaved. For a while you remain obedient and calm. But your good behavior is short-lived, and you soon return to your mischievous ways. Now God will think, 'He needs a more

painful experience, an even stronger lesson than before.’ So God again lets you play a little longer, but He will soon send yet another difficult situation for you to face.

“The lessons learned from this experience have a strong impact on your awareness and cause a great change in you. Each time you are given a painful experience, the effect of the lesson lasts for a longer period of time. But each time, you again wander back into a forbidden playground, and you revert to your old ways. At last God thinks, ‘This is too much, I have warned him several times. What he needs now is a real shock.’ So God sends a terrible thunderbolt. Once and for all, it puts an end to your play. You crash down helplessly. The thunderbolt hits your ego and breaks it into a hundred pieces.

“For some people, this is a time of revelation. But for others, this becomes a point of total disappointment and frustration. They may lose all interest in life. Their mental agony may be so great that they may commit suicide unless a person endowed with wisdom helps them to see the divine message that is hidden in this excruciating experience. Unless they get proper guidance from a real Master, they are likely to break down completely. Yet, if with the blessings of a Satguru, they are able to open their eyes, they will clearly see the futility of the ego and how it has deluded them. At this point they feel God’s pull. They hear His call. They wake up, and for the first time ever they find that they are truly alive. This crashing down of the ego can happen at any time, in this life or the next. It happens sooner for some, while others, because of their lack of maturity, will, with His permission, be allowed to play a little more. At all times, each one of us is being watched over by God. He cannot miss us.

“A spiritual master once gave a hen to each of his

two disciples and said, 'Take them to a spot where you can kill them without anyone seeing you.' The first disciple walked out and hiding behind a bush, he looked around and made sure that no one was watching. He then killed the hen and brought it right back to his master. The second disciple didn't return until sunset. He was tired and weary, and in his arms he carried the hen, which was still alive. With his head hung low he handed the hen to his master. 'Revered Master,' he said, 'Though I tried and tried, I could not find a single spot where no one would see me; for wherever I went, the hen was always looking at me.' Likewise, children, wherever you go and whatever you do, you are under the watchful eyes of your Guru or God."

At this point Mother asked the brahmacharins to sing a song, *Ellam ariyunna* (The One who knows everything)...

*There is no need to tell anything
To the all-knowing Krishna;
He sees and understands everything
As He walks beside us.
The Primordial Being
Sees every thought in the innermost Self;
It is not possible for anyone
To do anything without Him.
The Primordial Lord abides within everyone
We should all worship with joy
That Embodiment of Truth and Awareness.*



CHAPTER TEN

DO NOT COMPARE YOURSELF WITH OTHERS

Tuesday, 1 October, 1984

A devotee who had just arrived at the Ashram began explaining to all present how he'd had the darshan of Mother as Krishna. He was very excited as he told the following story: "A week ago I was sleeping in my room when all of a sudden I was awakened by a strong light and an extraordinary fragrance which filled the room. I got up and sat on my bed. The light that permeated the room was as bright as sunlight, yet it was as beautiful and cooling like moonlight. Bathed in this effulgence, my body became so light that I felt I was losing body-consciousness. Suddenly the atmosphere changed. Like water gushing from a dam, peace and supreme bliss filled the air. It was so tangible and penetrating; it engulfed my entire being. The next moment, the divine light that had filled the room seemed to gather together and become concentrated in one particular spot. As I gazed at this concentrated effulgence, the beautiful and enchanting form of Lord Krishna emerged."

The devotee could hardly control his excitement. With tears streaming from his eyes, he said, "It was my Lord! But at the same time, it was my Mother also—His face was Mother's face. It was just like Mother in Krishna Bhava—the same smile, the same look, the same eyes—

everything was the same. The Lord walked up to me. He had a bowl in His hands. Krishna fed me with butter and *panchamritam*, and He also put some in each of my hands. The Lord gave me a *tulasi* leaf, and then looked into my eyes and placed His right hand on my head. As I looked at His divine form and enchanting smile, the Lord vanished.

“The next morning when I awoke I found myself lying on the floor. I was in what I can only call a semi-conscious mood. Still in bliss, I cried and cried, and found that I was calling out to the Lord and to Mother. It must have taken over two hours before I could function. When I came back to normal consciousness, I tried to recollect everything. But I still couldn’t believe this had happened, that the Lord had actually visited me! In order to convince myself, I smelled my hands. And sure enough, they had the smell of butter and the sweet fragrance of *panchamritam*. It was such a beautiful smell; it remained on my hands for three days. And the taste was in my mouth as well. To my wonderment, I also found a *tulasi* leaf on my bed. I was in bliss for more than a week, and my heart was full of divine love.”

The devotee once again shed tears of love and devotion. Later he went and sat in the darshan hut, where he remained until Mother arrived at eleven o’clock. As She entered the hut, Mother saw the devotee sitting in a corner, deeply absorbed in meditation. As if to let him know that She was aware of all that had happened, Mother exclaimed, “My son!” as She walked up to him and placed Her right hand on his head. The devotee opened his eyes and looked up at Mother, who stood there, gazing at him. There was an extraordinary glow on Her face. With his

palms joined, and shedding silent tears of bliss, the devotee gazed back at Her. For a few seconds, no one spoke. But the silence was soon broken when the devotee burst into tears and fell at Mother's feet. After expressing Her love towards him in the form of an affectionate hug, Mother walked over to the cot where She receives Her devotees, and the day's darshan began.

That evening, Mother was sitting in the coconut grove talking with the Ashram residents. One of the householder devotees, who was a good sadhak, mentioned the devotee who'd had the darshan of Krishna and Mother, and said that he was feeling dejected at not having had such a vision.

Mother responded by saying, "Son, don't compare yourself with others. This is not good for a sadhak. A sadhak should look into himself; he should detect his own mistakes and correct them. You have enough problems of your own to worry about and to work on. Don't make yourself unhappy thinking, 'I will never have an experience like his.' Try to feel happy for him. You should have the attitude that he needed that vision, and that is why Mother or the Lord graciously appeared to him. Think that it was due to his spiritual practices and his strong faith. Don't feel discouraged. Don't think that you are less fortunate than he. What happens with him is meant only for him. And what happens in your life is meant only for you, and has nothing to do with anyone else. Comparison will spoil everything. Whatever happens in your life is the outcome of your own samskaras. Your experiences are your own. They cannot be repeated in his or in anybody else's life because each person's samskara is different. What you picked up is different from what he

has picked up. And the experiences will differ accordingly. So, there is no sense in comparing and worrying. It will only help to dampen your enthusiasm.

“If you have not been given such an experience, feeling sad about it and calling yourself a sinner or unfit will not help things at all. It will only cause you to close down. It will only destroy any possibility of having such an experience. So give up self-degrading thoughts and strive hard, with determination, for your own vision of the Lord. It must happen if you have the determination and the love.

“Comparison will kill all your talents. Comparison will make you more self-conscious and less efficient. A self-conscious person cannot express himself well. He or she will lose all power of creativity. A person who constantly compares himself with others will constantly think about other people. ‘Oh God, why am I not able to sing like him? How I wish I could paint like she does! I should also do tapas like him.’ Brooding over what others have, he loses his own power of expression. His talents lie dormant and eventually die. What a fate! A person such as this can never be himself. He will not correct his own mistakes and drawbacks and thus, he can never improve. He is always worried and disgusted with himself. This self-contempt may even make him mentally ill. Never content or happy, he cannot experience the real joy of life.

“Amma remembers a young man who came here once. He had been a good singer with a beautiful, rich voice, and had won the first prize in a university music festival. On the same day that he was awarded the prize, one of his friends had teased him, saying that however much he strove or whatever recognition he got, he could never be as good as the famous film singer, Jesudas. These words

wounded him deeply. They hurt him so much that from that day onward he stopped singing and never sang again.

“Upon hearing his friend’s words, he thought, ‘What he said is true. I can’t sing like him. And if I can’t sing like Jesudas, then why should I sing at all? It’s better not to sing.’ This thought, this comparison, struck his mind like lightning. At that moment he must have felt himself to be worthless, and as result, suddenly lost all interest in his singing. He was such a talented singer; he could have become one of the best. But one moment’s thought, one fateful comparison, destroyed all possibility for growth.

“So you see, comparison can be very destructive. It will hinder your spiritual progress. It can obstruct all possibilities of mental and intellectual growth. It can cause depression or a serious mental disease. Children, it can affect all aspects of life. Keep in mind that you cannot be someone else and that no one else can be you. You can only be you. Comparison destroys your personality. It will make you look like a fool in front of others. A spiritual seeker should never compare himself or his experiences with someone else’s. That is why a sadhak should not disclose his experiences to anyone. Before the attainment of Self-Realization, spiritual experiences can differ. You may never receive a darshan like that son did. And even if you do, it will be different. Some people may feel peace and bliss within, but may never behold the form of a god or goddess. Some may only see an effulgence or a pinpoint of light. It is always different. Different people’s experiences cannot be the same. They can only happen according to each individual’s unique mental constitution, the path he follows, the amount of effort he puts

forth, and the samskaras he has inherited from previous lives. What you experience now is not a beginning; it is a continuation of the past. Also, you must remember that the Guru gives only what is needed, and that whatever he gives is for your own good. The Guru cannot be partial. If you feel upset, thinking that the Guru is partial, that he gives more to others than to you, the problem is within you. We are so judgmental that we cannot see this truth with impartial and discriminating eyes.

“Children, above all else, your innocence and love play a very important role in building up your spiritual life. Receptivity is fundamental to spiritual life. A devotee or disciple should always be receptive.”

THE CHILD WITHIN

“Amma, what do you mean by receptivity? How can one be receptive?” asked a devotee.

“Receptivity comes where there is love within,” Mother answered. Love helps you to be open, open like a child. Love makes you innocent like a child. A child is the most receptive person. Receptivity is the power to believe, the power to have faith, the ability to accept love. It is the power to prevent doubt from entering your mind. Receptivity is the ability to accept all experiences of life without reacting to them.

“Receptivity makes you simple. A receptive person is like an innocent child. If you want to be closer to God, try to be like a child. A child’s world is full of wonder and imagination and play. As you get older this look of wonder disappears from your eyes. You cannot play anymore. You cannot believe anymore; like so many grown-

ups, you can only doubt.

“Have you watched children play? They can imagine that a small sand heap is a big castle. At one moment white sand is sugar for them, and the next moment it is salt. A rope with its ends tied together becomes a car or a bus. For them a rock can be a throne, and a leaf becomes a big fan. Sometimes they imagine that a long coconut frond is a serpent. They can believe in anything. If you tell a child that rain is the water that falls down when the celestial beings who live in the sky wash their dishes, he will believe you; a child won’t express any doubt. This openness, the power to accept, is receptivity. Don’t think that Amma is asking you to believe in everything people tell you. She is only asking you to have faith in the Satguru’s words, and in the words of the great saints and sages who have realized and experienced the ultimate goal of life.

“As we get older, we lose all enthusiasm and joy. We become dry and unhappy. Why? Because we lose our faith and innocence. It is good for you to spend some time with children. They will teach you to believe, to love and to play. Children will help you smile from your heart and to have that look of wonderment in your eyes.

“There is a child within everyone. The innocence and the playfulness of a child exists in all human beings. People of all ages like children’s stories and while hearing or reading them the child within is invoked. Who does not like to play with children now and then? Watch a ninety year-old man, look at a politician or a government administrator, a business executive or a scientist; all will become playful and free when they are around a child. When he is with his grandchildren or his youngest child, even an

old man becomes a child. Crawling on all fours, he pretends he is an elephant. He makes a castle out of playing cards for them. Using sticks and leaves, he builds a play house for the little ones. Bouncing the children on his knee, he tells them that he is a horse.

“Why does he do all this? Is it simply to please the child, to make him or her happy? No. That is not the only reason. It is because in each of us a child is hidden. Somewhere in each one of us, a child’s joy, innocence, and faith lie dormant. We delight in searching for the child within. When we were children, we had no worries or problems; recalling these days with love, we want to return to them. This desire is felt by all living beings.

“Children, the wonder and the love that you felt as a child will never return unless you can again play like a child. Innocence is within you, hidden deep inside. You have to rediscover it. And for this to happen, you must go deeper and deeper into your spiritual practices. When you can dive deep into your own consciousness, you will realize this innocence one day. At that moment you will discover the child within you. You will experience the innocence, the joy and the wonder that were hidden inside of you, and you will realize they were always there. You merely forgot your innocence for some time. It is as if you suddenly remember something after having forgotten about it for a very long time. That childlike innocence deep within you is God.

“Children, have you heard this story? God decided to create the world. His purpose was to give Himself a place to live. So as soon as He had created this beautiful earth full of trees and plants, animals and birds, mountains and valleys, God began to dwell here. Everything was perfect,

and God was leading a happy and blissful life. Years rolled by until one day God made a mistake: He created human beings. From that day on, there was trouble. Night and day, the human beings complained to God. No matter what God was doing, whether He was eating or sleeping, they would come knocking on His door.

“The never-ending complaints drove Him crazy. God lost his peace of mind. No sooner was one problem solved than another one arose. The first man’s solution became the second man’s problem. One person wanted rain, yet when God granted that, another person complained: ‘God, how can you do this to me? My whole house is leaking; my crops are all ruined.’ Everything became a problem. No matter what God did, people complained.

“Eventually God asked His advisors to suggest a way out. One suggestion was that He go to the Himalayas, but God said, ‘No, no. People would soon come there.’ ‘What about the moon, then?’ another of God’s advisors asked. ‘Soon man would also make his way there.’

‘You, my good friends, cannot see the future,’ continued God. ‘But I can. No matter where I go, man will come to know about it. He will follow Me, and I will again be in trouble.’

“This statement was met with silence. After some time an aged advisor stepped forward and whispered something into God’s ear. God’s face brightened. ‘Wonderful!’ He exclaimed.

“The old man had suggested a perfect hiding place for God. ‘Go and hide deep within him,’ the wise man had advised.

‘Yes, it’s perfect.’ was God’s reply. ‘Man would never think to look for me inside of him. There is no chance

that he will find me there.'

"Children," Mother continued, "God is deep within us. He dwells there as innocence, as pure and innocent love. Now this innocence is veiled by the mind and its egotistic feelings. But it is always there; it has only been forgotten. You have to go deep within; you have to re-discover and remember.

"Amma, how does this remembering happen?" asked the same devotee.

"Sometimes when you are trying to remember something, a certain word or a name, you have the feeling that it's on the tip of your tongue. You know that it's there, but still, you can't quite remember it. Pacing back and forth, you think about it. While sitting in your living room, you try to recall the word; and it is still on your mind when you get up to go to your room. But nothing happens and you begin to grow restless. You pull at your hair, you scratch your head, you try and try to remember, but your effort is in vain. After struggling like this for a long time, you finally stop; you give up and soon forget all about the word that you had wanted so much to remember. You even forget all about the effort that you made. Later, having gone outside to relax and to enjoy some solitude, it happens. Suddenly you remember the word. It dawns within you. Only when your efforts ceased, were you able to recall the word. When you work hard during the day, you sleep well at night. Similarly, when you stopped trying to remember, the mind became quiet and still. And in that state of relaxation and stillness the memory could effortlessly emerge.

"Similarly, after doing all your sadhana, you have to wait for everything to settle down and to sink in. You

have to reach a state of complete forgetfulness. When you are lying in bed, you will not make a conscious effort to fall asleep; you will just lie there and wait for sleep to come. You don't think about the past or the future. You just throw yourself in the hands of sleep. You relinquish all control and effortlessly glide into sleep. Likewise, you have to forget about the goal and all the effort you have made to reach it. You must forget about Self-Realization and the spiritual practices you have done to reach that supreme goal. Don't think, 'Oh, what a pity! Even after doing so much sadhana I have not progressed at all.' Such thoughts can also obstruct your way to the final goal. You should neither complain nor think. Thinking will only get in your way; therefore, keep quiet; relax both inside and out. You cannot predict when Grace will happen; you can only wait. It can happen at anytime, at any place. It is up to the Guru or God. It is the Satguru who decides when he should let Grace flow to the disciple. Then, when the time is ripe, all of a sudden it happens: you become a fully conscious, innocent child."

THE CONSCIOUSLY INNOCENT CHILD

At this time Sreekumar's sister's seven year-old daughter, Takkali, came with her grandparents to see Mother. Though her given name was Sheeja, Mother called her 'Takkali', which means tomato, and so everyone began to call her by that name. Upon seeing the girl, Mother exclaimed, "Oh, you are a grown up girl now. Come here, sit by Amma's side." The girl walked up to Mother and sat down at Her side. Mother lovingly held her hand and kissed the girl on her forehead. Turning to Balu, Mother

asked, "Do you know her." Balu said, "Yes, of course I know her, Amma." Holding Takkali tightly, and pointing at Balu, Mother asked, "Do you know him?" "Yes," the girl replied, "that is Baluannan (elder brother Balu)."

Mother then asked her to sing. Closing her eyes, Takkali sang, *Orunalil nyan en. . .*

*Some day I will see Krishna;
I will hear His melodious song
My darling Krishna will come
And stand before me,
With the flute gently pressed
Against His beautiful lips.*

*On that day, the purpose of my life
Will be fulfilled;
I will be immersed in Bliss,
And on the highest summit of ecstatic devotion,
I will dance in Divine Bliss.*

*O Sustainer of the Universe,
Are You not the Lord, the Source of all Beings?
O God, let me see You
Without a moment's delay!*

When Takkali finished the song, Mother affectionately kissed and hugged her all over again. Obviously delighted, Mother smiled fondly at all who were gathered, praising the little girl's singing and her sweet innocence. As he watched Mother play with young Takkali, one of the brahmacharins was inspired to ask a question,

“Amma, you said earlier that one day we will all become conscious, innocent children. How is that possible? What did Amma mean?”

“Children,” Mother said, “a small child is not aware of its innocence. His or her innocent nature is completely unconscious. A small child is absolutely pure; he dwells in the state of purity before impurities are manifested. But soon, the child’s purity and innocence will begin to disappear. Impurity and ignorance will take their place. The qualities of wonder and joy, imagination and faith, that we see in a child are short-lived. As long as a child remains a child, his innocence is there. But a child changes. Even a child’s mind is bound by time and space, therefore time brings about changes even in a child. Thus, the innocent child gradually slips into the clutches of the ego. The unmanifested ego and the accumulated tendencies of past lives gradually manifest, and the child’s innocence slowly slips back into an unmanifested state.

“In a grown-up, innocence is dormant, whereas his ego is in full bloom. As the karmic cycle revolves, the time will come for an individual soul to take another birth. When the *jiva* emerges from the womb as a child, the dormant or unmanifested innocence once again manifests, but it will recede again as the ego manifests. This alternating cycle in which the ego manifests and innocence recedes, and vice versa, continues until we turn to God and the ego is eliminated by its root. When the ego is completely eliminated, we become a consciously innocent being; we become eternally innocent. Until that uprooting of the ego takes place, we will have to experience the state of being an unconsciously innocent child through countless lives; that is, we will be born again and

again as a child who is not aware or conscious of its innocence.

“While a child’s innocence lasts only for a short period of time, a Mahatma is eternally innocent. The child has not realized this innocence, whereas the Mahatma has full realization of his innocent and pure nature. One can get a glimpse of God in a child, but the child is not God. A Mahatma is God. A Mahatma lives in Supreme Consciousness. He is beyond the cycle of birth and death. He has the strength and support of his realization. He is wide awake, fully aware and conscious of his realized state. A child is not wakeful to consciousness and has no realization of its pure nature. It is still fast asleep to that state. This is a vast difference, isn’t it? The Self-Realized state of the Mahatma is what Amma meant by conscious innocence.”

Mother’s words having penetrated deep into their hearts and minds, everyone sat quietly for some time after She had finished speaking. Glancing briefly at each person, Mother’s gaze finally rested on Br. Pai and She asked him to sing, *Kattutta Sokamam*. . .

*Let me not fall into this dark pit of sorrow
I am neither a scholar,
Nor was I born under a lucky star.
O Mother, though You know all this,
Don’t simply smile at me and walk away
When my thoughts are intensely fixed on You.*

*O Embodiment of Compassion,
Remove my ignorance,*

*And bestow pure intelligence on me.
Though in the midst of worldly pleasures,
I am never happy;
I am always gazing at You.
O Ruler of all the worlds,
Giver of true greatness,
Light the lamp of equal vision
Within my innermost Self.*

*O Mother,
The hummingbird of my mind
Has flown to Your Lotus Feet;
To prevent it from flying away,
Please close Your petals and enfold it.
O greater than the greatest,
Let me dive deep within
And enjoy Your nectar of Bliss.
O Quintessence of the four Vedas,
I bow to You.*

*Your stream of Love flows towards me
In the form of anger;
Your terrifying laughter
Is like a gentle smile to me.
Understanding the unreal nature
Of this dream-like world,
I have taken leave of it
I will never be separated from You,
Who have showered Your nectarine Grace upon me.*

FORGIVING AND FORGETTING

Wednesday, 2 October, 1984

During this morning's darshan a devotee began complaining to Mother about her husband. She described at great length how uncooperative and loveless he was. She said that she felt like leaving him because of the unbearable situation.

Wiping away the woman's tears, Mother replied, "Daughter, problematic situations are difficult to avoid. You are not the only one with such problems. Everywhere in the world, people are suffering like you. If you try to run away from this situation, another difficult situation will await you; no matter where you go or what you choose to do with your life, problems will arise. It could be worse than this, you know. You'll never feel peaceful or happy if you don't have patience and humility. Family life will be miserable as long as the family members lack these virtues. Nowadays it is difficult to find a family where both the husband and the wife are patient; but one of them, either the husband or the wife, should exercise patience. In most cases both are 'patients without patience', but unless there is a balance, unless a certain amount of patience is exercised on both sides, a harmonious family life will be impossible.

"There is a tendency in human beings to run away from difficult situations. You think that running away will save you or help rid you of your sorrows. You might even change to another situation which you hope will be more comfortable. Initially you may feel wonderful and peaceful after making such a change. You don't realize that you are only running towards yet another problem. If you go to live with your parents, relatives or friends, when you

first arrive, you might be given a warm welcome. They will express great sympathy and love for you in all that they say and do. They will all embrace you and cry; you will exchange promises, and wet each other's shoulders with tears.

"But within a few days, or in a week or two at the most, the situation will change. This will happen because when you ran away from the previous situation you did not leave your ego. It followed you. You carried it with you, and along with it, all your impatience and lack of humility. So after a short while in this new place, negativity starts to manifest. You begin to find fault with someone in the family, or the situation you are in. You grow impatient with your mother or your father, your brother or sister, or your friend, and they begin to react, because they, too, have their own *vasanas*. They cannot bear your impatience or disobedience. Soon you will realize that you have run from one problem right into another, and that this new situation might even be worse than the one you left. When you were together with your husband, he at least didn't kick you out of the house. After an argument, he used to repent and there was always a reconciliation. But now your friends or relatives may ask you to leave. And the only thing gained from all this is more resentment, more frustration, and more negative feelings.

"Daughter, whether you are living all alone or with a family, your life will not be happy and successful unless you have the mental capacity to adapt to any situation. This is one of life's most basic principles. You may think that living alone is the way to be happy, but you will have problems even then. As long as you are gripped by prejudices and preconceived ideas, you cannot be free

from the difficulties of life.

“However, getting rid of the ego is not an easy thing to do. Daughter, you think that your husband is uncooperative and that he doesn’t love you. But there must have been times when he was loving and cooperative. Amma can’t believe that he is always so bad. If he’s as bad as you say he is, he must be a monster.”

Mother stopped for a while and looked at the woman’s face. She replied, “No, of course he’s not. Sometimes he is very loving and sweet.”

Smiling, Mother once again questioned the woman, “How did you feel when he was loving and sweet?” The woman blushed and said, “I felt comfortable and happy. I was also loving to him.” “And when he was unfeeling and difficult?” Mother inquired. “I felt terribly angry and closed,” responded the woman.

Smiling mischievously, Mother continued, “Daughter, these reactions and feelings are common. Human beings naturally have such feelings towards each other. Still, you should try to respect and admire your husband’s good qualities. When he shows you no love or when he is not cooperative, you react, don’t you? And haven’t there been times when it was you who started the fight with him?” The woman hung her head. She had nothing to say.

Mother continued, “So, you do react to him. Don’t worry, it’s all right. But, at that moment, instead of reacting, try to listen patiently, try to remain calm. Later, when he is in a good mood, when you get an opportunity, you can talk to him in a very loving way. Then he will listen and understand because his mind is calm. Don’t throw your ideas at him when he is angry. He won’t listen then. Learn to keep quiet at that time; don’t listen

to your ego then. When he has left the house, you should go and sit either in your family shrine room or in a solitary place where you can contemplate and think deeply.

“While sitting there, try to recall the whole incident. Try to remember how the scene began. If it started when you insisted that he do something, and he refused; now you should try to remember a time when he bought something for you or did you a favor as soon as you asked. Remember how nice he was at that time. Think of another occasion when he was patient and forgiving, even when you yourself were impatient and rude. Try to recall the sleepless nights he spent sitting beside you when you were hospitalized. Try to appreciate the loving care and consoling words which helped you so much at the time. He had to work the whole day, yet he took a lot of time and trouble to make you feel happy and comfortable. Think of a few occasions when he tried to make up with you after you’d quarreled over a silly matter. Also, you should try to remember how angry and impatient you were throughout the incident, and how impolitely you spoke to him.

“Contemplating these memories will surely help you to feel better about the situation. These moments of solitude will enable you to see the incident with more clarity and understanding. You may even begin to feel remorse for your own harsh and impatient behavior. By the time your husband comes home in the evening, you will have prepared yourself to face him, and will be able to receive him with a big smile. You offer him a good cup of coffee. While he sips the coffee, you first of all apologize for your behavior in the morning, then you ask him whether the headache he had in the morning was still there or

gone. Suppose he says, 'No, it is still there.' You take some balm and rub it on his forehead, then you lovingly inquire about the day's happenings at the office. You try to console him about his boss being rude to him on that day.

"Your husband will look at you in wonder, 'Is this the same wife whom I fought with this morning?' Even if he has harbored some anger or resentment, it will melt. His attitude will change. Filled with remorse, he spontaneously apologizes for his rude behavior. Now is your opportunity to explain to him whatever you want. You tell him everything and he listens with great interest. He then tells you whatever he wants to say and you pay great attention to that. Thus, what began as an argument evolves into a great event. It becomes an opportunity for reconciliation and sharing. You are full of love for one another. Both of you feel happy and relaxed.

"Married life is not a joke. It is something that should be taken seriously. Relationships can become a path to God, a path to eternal freedom and peace, provided you have the right attitude. Don't automatically consider separation each time you feel uncomfortable. Strive to be adaptable. Try to be patient, not once or twice, but many times.

"Man is extremely impatient, but God is immensely patient and careful about His creation. Impatience destroys. Think of the warning you see on road signs, 'Speed kills.' Speeding is impatience. Human beings are impatient; they are always in a hurry. Hurrying is necessary sometimes. But mostly, hurrying kills. When you give medicine to someone who is critically ill, don't hurry. Even if the medicine must be given immediately, even if it is

an emergency case, still you should not hurry. If you hurry, in your excitement, your hands might tremble while pouring water into the patient's mouth while giving him pills to swallow. You may miss and water might go into the nose. That can cause trouble. In your hurry, you may give too much or even the wrong medicine to the patient, and this could kill him. Be patient. Real life is love. When you love, you cannot hurry. You must be patient.

"Look at the care and patience God showers on His creation. A tiny flower may not last for more than a day. But still, God is very careful and patient with it, providing it with water and sun until it finally blossoms. The hatching of an egg and the birth of a child require great care and patience. It takes nine long months of nurturing before a child is born. God is not at all in a hurry.

"Think of the suffering your mother endured when you were in her womb for nine long months. She carried you with no complaints, and happily endured all discomfort and pain. She could do this because she knew that all pain would disappear when she saw you, when she saw her baby's beautiful face. Daughter, in this way, you should bear with your pain by thinking of the peaceful and harmonious life which you will have if you are able to endure. It doesn't matter who is at fault. Sometimes it will be your husband, and at other times, it will be you. But whoever is to blame, just try to do what Amma has said, and see what happens."

"Practice forgiveness. If there are still difficulties in a relationship even after you put forth a lot of effort, you can consider it your karma, your destiny. At this point you can either endure it, accepting the difficulties as your *prarabdha*; or, if you find the situation too difficult to

withstand anymore, maybe you can think of separation or divorce. But before that, you must play your part well. You must put forth effort at least to see whether the relationship can work or not. To simply let it fall apart is an unpardonable mistake. It is a sin and you will have to suffer for it.”

Full of compassion, Mother looked at the woman’s face. She was again crying, but this time they were tears of repentance. She had realized her mistake. Through her tears, the woman asked Mother to forgive her for her faults. Her voice was full of remorse as she continued to speak. “Now I understand that I am also to blame, and not just today but always. I, too, am responsible for our conflicts. I was the one who triggered them. Had I kept quiet and acted as you advised, this situation would not have happened. However, Amma you have opened my eyes. From now on I will try my best to control myself and to keep quiet on such occasions. I will try to act just as Amma has instructed.”

Daughter,” Mother said, “whenever such a situation arises, if you can pause and be patient, your problems can easily be solved. But it is our habit to react. When anger arises, we cannot pause and see clearly; we cannot wait. When you are in the midst of an upsetting situation, can you simply observe what is happening? Can you stop thinking that someone is insulting and abusing you? Can you forget that you are being treated unfairly and let go of the wish to do something about it? Don’t be abusive. Don’t react. Try to realize that the real problem is not what is happening, but how you are reacting to it. When you see that you are going to react negatively, at this point, pause. Stop talking. Say to your mind, ‘No, don’t say anything now. You will get a better op-

portunity to present the whole matter in a more effective way. But now you keep quiet for the time being.’

“During this pause, try to think of something positive, something elevating, something sweet, something that you consider unforgettable. Try to recall a pleasant event or memory. Focus all your energies, all your thoughts on that. If you can do this, you won’t be bothered or angered by the ridiculous words and unbearable face of the other person.

“If you can, try to make this pause last longer and longer. Whenever you find that you are feeling even a little bit angry or annoyed, you can experiment. To begin with, you can choose some silly matter to which you are used to reacting. For example, say your husband has a habit of tapping his fingers on the table whenever he is lost in thought, and you find the sound irritating. Instead of saying anything, think of the sound as coming from raindrops falling on the roof. You might then remember a time when you and your husband got caught in the rain and together you ran for shelter under a tin awning. Rather than getting angry or annoyed, let your imagination and associations put you in a positive, even a loving mood.

“In due course, when you have learned to overcome these mildly provoking situations, you can slowly begin to test your experiment in more trying and serious situations. As you continue to practice, you will see that you are changing. And eventually, you will see that you cannot react anymore, that you can only respond. You will experience much more peace and joy in your marriage and in your family life in general. The change in your attitude and the patience that you show will also create a positive change in others.

“When your husband sees that you are not reacting anymore, when he realizes that his anger and insults are no longer being accepted, that they are no longer affecting you, he will feel embarrassed. What happens when a warrior finds that his weapons are not powerful or effective anymore? He throws them away. Similarly, when your husband finds that his weapons, the words that he uses against you, are not hurting you anymore, he will give up and keep quiet. In addition, you will now be treating him with more love and care. This is a great gift. Your smiling face and loving inquiries, your care and comforting words will serve as a balm, as a great relief and consolation to him. He will forget everything, all his anger, failures and any resentment that he has harbored. If he was working hard the whole day, if he was scolded by his boss and comes home with his head full of troubles, and you can give that gift to him, or to her (it does not matter whether it is the husband or the wife who shows this attitude), he or she will become your best friend and admirer. Great love and concern will develop in the relationship. Therefore daughter, before getting upset, pause, wait and be patient.

“Amma will tell you a story. There was a professor who had been invited to deliver a speech. He did not prepare the speech well and, as a result, his talk was not very good. A few days later, he received a letter from one of the listeners. The content of the letter was as follows, ‘Dear sir, if you are not very knowledgeable, you would be wise not to speak, rather than give false ideas and create a bad impression on your audience.’ The signature on the letter was a woman’s.

“Upon reading the letter, the professor was furious. He immediately sat down at his typewriter and pounded out a fiery and burning response to his critic, full of the

choicest harsh words. As soon as he was finished, he went to post it, but he realized then that the day's mail had already gone. So he put the letter aside. The next morning when he saw the letter on his desk, he thought, 'Maybe I wasn't polite enough to this person. Let me go through the letter once again before I mail it.' So he opened the letter and read it, and was shocked to see how rudely he had reacted. He said to himself, 'This is certainly not a very polite letter. I should definitely not mail it in its present form.' So he sat down and drafted another letter which, though milder in its expressions and images, was still abusive.

"He was about to mail this second letter when he thought, 'Wait a minute, let me read it one more time. Maybe the tone is still not right. If my attitude could change so much in just a few hours, maybe it can still change.' So he read the letter again and finding the tone still too harsh, he rewrote it. But still he did not feel good about the letter, so he changed and rewrote it a few more times until finally, it became a love letter. In it, the professor confessed his mistakes and agreed with the woman; he even mentioned how gracious it was of her to point out his drawbacks. 'People like you are really helpful. I am very grateful to you,' he wrote. 'If you are not married, I would like to ask you to be my wife. Eagerly awaiting your positive reply, I am yours truly...'

"The poison that the professor was at first emitting was transformed into nectar. Sometimes you may make a bad decision, or judge someone wrongly, or you may act in an indiscriminate way. But, if you can pause, wait patiently, and contemplate the matter, you will not run into trouble. This is what you gain from patience and proper contemplation. Therefore, daughter, be patient and con-

template matters well before you act. Amma is with you. Don't worry."

At this point the woman fell into Mother's lap. "Amma, forgive me for my mistakes!" she cried. "Forgive me! I will try not to repeat them again. Forgive me." Expressing Her love and compassion to the woman, Mother consoled her and helped her to relax. Before she left the Ashram a short while later, the woman seemed to be fully at peace. She wore a big smile on her face, a clear sign that her sorrows had been unburdened.

In the *Lalita Sahasranama*, Devi is praised as *Tapa-trayagni-samtapta-samah-ladana-chandrika*, which means 'the moonlight that gladdens the hearts of those who are tormented by the fire of misery.' This misery, it is explained, is caused by the sense organs, both internal and external, by the objective world which they mediate, and by supernatural powers beyond the visible world. This mantra is equally applicable to a Great Soul like Mother, who is Devi or the Divine Mother incarnate. Through Her compassionate and soothing looks, Her profound words and divine touch, or by Her presence alone, Mother bestows this blessing of healing human hearts. Only a Realized Master, one who has attained the state Perfection can save human beings from this triple misery. Such a being alone can give repose and solace to people afflicted by the sufferings incidental to birth, old age and dying.



FOOTNOTES

¹Tulsidas wrote Ramacharita Manas, another version of the Ramayana epic originally written by Valmiki.

²A brahmachari is one who has taken vows of celibacy and leads a life of spiritual study, austerity and practice coupled with service to the Guru. Through these means he builds the foundation for his spiritual life. He may remain as a lifelong brahmachari, get married, or become a total renunciate or sannyasi when he has attained the requisite detachment. The brahmachari wears yellow cloth to remind him of the perishable nature of the body which becomes yellow on the life force leaving it. A sannyasi takes lifelong vows of renunciation and celibacy and cultivates the attitude of oneness with Brahman, the Absolute Reality underlying the phenomenal existence of time and space. He wears ochre cloth signifying the burning away of all attachments which might bind him to identification with the body.

³At this time, Mother's room was being constructed. Until then, She had been living out in the open under the trees or in a thatched hut. With increased crowds, the devotees felt that She needed some privacy and constructed a double-story brick house, the lower floor of which was used as a meditation hall by the brahmacharis, and the upper floor consisting of one room, a porch and a bathroom, was used by Mother. For a number of years it was the only living space made of brick, all the rest being thatched huts. Even after completion of the room, Mother did not move into it. She only occasionally used it until a year or so after completion when She moved in permanently.

⁴Kannappa was a hunter who came upon a Shiva temple while hunting in the forest. He spontaneously felt loving devotion for the image of Lord Shiva installed there. Though knowing nothing of ritualistic worship, he felt the reality of the Lord's existence in the image and began to worship in his own way. He offered freshly killed boar meat to the Lord, carried water from the river in his own mouth and spit it on the Lord to bathe Him, and carrying flowers in his hair, adorned the Lord with the same. From the orthodox viewpoint, all

these actions were a sacrilege trespassing the rules of ritual purity. The priest who was regularly worshipping there would find the meat before the Lord every morning and was infuriated. He finally had a dream wherein the Lord told him that Kannappa was His greatest devotee and that He would prove it the next day. The priest hid in the temple when Kannappa was expected. The next day when Kannappa came for worship, he noticed that one of the Lord's eyes was bleeding. He tried various remedies which all failed to stop the flow of blood. At last he resolved to give his own eye in exchange for the Lord's ailing one. He poked out his eye and placed it over the bleeding one. Then the Lord's other eye began to bleed. He then started to poke out his other eye. Seeing his devotion, the Lord restored his sight and spread his fame.

⁵Prahlada was the son of Hiranyakashipu, king of the demons. Though born in the demon race, he was by nature devoted to God and an abode of all saintly qualities. Hiranyakashipu looked upon Lord Vishnu as his greatest enemy. When he saw that his son was devoted to the Lord, he began to persecute him and finally tried to kill him. All his efforts were unsuccessful, for Prahlada was completely surrendered to Lord Vishnu and was protected by Him. At last, the Lord killed Hiranyakashipu and making Prahlada the king, blessed him with Self-Realization.

⁶Bhima is the second eldest of the five Pandava brothers, relatives of Lord Sri Krishna. The Pandavas, fighting on the side of righteousness, defeated their cousins, the Kauravas, who were ever engaged in wicked deeds. Bhima was renowned for his strength.

⁷The *Vishwarupa Darshana* took place during Lord Sri Krishna's discourse to Arjuna in the *Bhagavad Gita* which is part of the epic *Mahabharata*. The Lord revealed to Arjuna in a mystic vision that He was the entire universe; the sun was His eye, the moon was His mind and so on. Arjuna saw that every form was a form of God.

GLOSSARY

{Certain words are the same or similar in Malayalam and Sanskrit. Thus *Ashrama* and *Brahmacharin* are Sanskrit whereas *Ashramam* and *Brahmachari* are Malayalam}

ADHARMA: Unrighteousness, sin, opposed to Divine Harmony

AGAMAS: Scriptures

AMMACHI: The Mother. *Chi* is a word indicating respect.

ANOOORANIYAAN MAHATOMAHIYAN: Sanskrit for “Subtler than the subtlest, bigger than the biggest,” a description of Brahman, the Supreme Reality.

ARATI: Waving the burning camphor, which leaves no residue, with ringing of bells at the end of *puja* (worship) indicating total annihilation of ego.

ARCHANA: A mode of worship by repetition of one hundred, three hundred or a thousand names of the deity.

ARJUNA: The third among the Pandavas and a great archer.

ASHRAMAM: Hermitage or residence of a sage.

ATMA(N): The Self

ATMA BODHA: Self-knowledge or Self-awareness

AVADHUT(A): A Realized Soul who has transcended all social conventions.

BHAGAVAD GITA: The teachings of Lord Krishna to Arjuna at the beginning of the Mahabharata War. It is a practical guide for common man for every day life and is the essence of Vedic wisdom. *Bhagavad* means ‘that of the Lord’ and *Gita* means ‘Song’, particularly, an advice.

BHAGAVATA(M): The book about the Incarnations of Lord Vishnu, especially Krishna and His childhood antics. It upholds the supremacy of devotion.

BHAGAVATI: The Goddess of six virtues, viz, prosperity, valor, auspiciousness, knowledge, dispassion and lordship.

BHAJAN: Devotional singing

BHAKTI: Devotion.

BHAVA: Mood.

BHAVA DARSHAN: The occasion when Amma receives devotees in the exalted state of the Universal Mother.

BHOGA: Enjoyment

BHRANTAN: Having the nature of a madman, alluding to the nature or appearance of some Realized Souls.

BRAHMAN(M): The Absolute, Whole.

BRAHMACHARI(N): A celibate student under training of a Guru.

BRAHMACHARYA: Celibacy

DAKSHINA: Reverential offering in cash or kind.

DARSHAN: Audience of a Holy Person or deity.

DEVA(TA): Demi-god, celestial being

DEVI: The Goddess.

DEVI BHAVA: Divine Mood of, or identity with, the Goddess

DEVI MAHATMYAM: A sacred hymn in praise of the Goddess.

DHARMA: Righteousness, in accordance with Divine Harmony.

DHRITHARASTHRA: Blind king and father of the Kauravas.

DURYODHANA: Eldest son of Dhritharasthra, villain of the Mahabharata War.

GITA: Song, See *Bhagavad Gita*

GOPA(S): Cowherd boy(s), companions of Sri Krishna.

GOPI(S): Cowherd girl(s), known for their supreme devotion to Sri Krishna.

GURU: Spiritual Master / Guide.

GURU PADUKA STOTRAM: Hymn of Five Verses to the Guru's Sandals.

JAGAT: The ever-changing world.

JAPA: Repetition of a mystical formula (*mantra*)

JÑANA: Spiritual or divine wisdom

- KAMSA: Lord Krishna's demonic uncle whom He killed.
- KANJI: Rice porridge.
- KANNA: Name for Krishna.
- KARMA: Action.
- KAURAVA(S): The hundred children of Dhritarashtra, enemies of the Pandavas, who fought in the Mahabharata War.
- KINDI: Fluted metallic water pot usually used in worship.
- KIRTAN(AM): Hymns
- KRISHNA: Principle Incarnation of Lord Vishnu
- LAKSHMANA: Brother of Lord Rama.
- LAKSHMI: Consort of Lord Vishnu and Goddess of wealth.
- LAKSHYA BODHA: Constant awareness of and intent on the goal.
- LALITA SAHASRANAMA: Thousand names of the Universal Mother in the form of *Lalitambika*
- LEELA: Divine play.
- MAHABHARATA(M): Great epic written by Vyasa.
- MAHATMA: Great Soul
- MANTRA: Sacred formula, the repetition of which can awaken one's spiritual energies and bring the desired results.
- MAYA: Illusion.
- MOL(E): Daughter. *Mole* is the vocative form.
- MON(E): Son. *Mone* is the vocative form
- MUDRA: A sign by hand indicating mystic spiritual truths.
- MUKTA: The Liberated One
- MUKTI: Liberation.
- NAMAH SHIVAYA: The Panchakshara Mantra (mantra consisting of five letters) meaning "Salutations to the Auspicious One (Shiva)."
- OM: Mystical syllable representing the Supreme Reality.
- PADA PUJA: Worship of the Guru's feet or sandals.
- PANDAVA(S): The five children of King Pandu and heroes of the epic *Mahabharata*
- PRARABDHA: Responsibilities or burdens. Also, the fruits of

past actions manifesting as the present life.

PRASAD(AM): Consecrated offerings distributed after *puja*.

PREMA: Deep Love.

PUJA: Worship.

RAMA: Hero of the epic *Ramayana*. An incarnation of Vishnu and the ideal of Righteousness.

RAVANA: The villain of the *Ramayana*

RISHI: A great sage or seer.

SAD-ASAD-RUPA DHARINI: One who dons the form of existence and non-existence, a name of the Divine Mother.

SADHAK(AN): One dedicated to attaining the spiritual goal, one who practices *sadhana* (spiritual discipline).

SADHANA: Spiritual practices.

SAHASRANAMA: Hymns consisting of the Thousand Names of God.

SAMADHI: State of absorption in the Self.

SAMSARA: The world of plurality, the cycle of birth and death.

SAMSKARAS: Mental tendencies accumulated from past actions.

SANKALPA: Creative, integral resolve manifesting as thought, feeling and action. The sankalpa of an ordinary person does not always bear corresponding fruit. The sankalpa of a sage, however, always bears the intended result.

SANNYASI(N): Ascetic who has renounced all worldly bondages.

SATGURU: Realized Spiritual Master.

SATSANG: Company of the wise and virtuous. Also, a spiritual discourse by a sage or scholar.

SHAKTI: The dynamic aspect of *Brahman* as the Universal Mother.

SHIVA: The static aspect of *Brahman* as the male principle.

SISHYA: Disciple.

SITA: Wife of Rama.

SLOKA: Sanskrit verse.

SRADDHA: Faith. Amma uses it with a special emphasis on

alertness coupled with loving care of the work in hand.

SRI RAMA: See *Rama*. *Sree*, or *Sri*, is a mark of respect

SRIMAD BHAGAVATAM: See *Bhagavatam*. *Srimad* means
'auspicious'

STENAH: Thief.

SUTRA: Aphorism.

TABLAS: A type of Indian drum.

TAMPURA: Stringed instrument which gives a droning sound,
the underlying "sruti" of Indian music.

TAPAS: Literally "heat." The practice of spiritual austerities.

TAPASVI: One engaged in penance or spiritual austerities.

TAPOVAN(AM): Hermitage, a place conducive to meditation
and tapas.

TATTVA: Principle.

TULASI: The sacred basil plant worshipped as a goddess.

UPANISHADS: The concluding portion of the Vedas dealing
with the philosophy of Non-dualism.

VASANA: Latent tendency.

VEDA: Lit. 'Knowledge', the authoritative Scriptures of the
Hindus.

VEDA VYASA: See *Vyasa*. As he divided the one *Veda* into
four, he is also known by the name of *Veda Vyasa*

VEDANTA(M): The philosophy of the Upanishads which
declare the Ultimate Truth as 'One without a Second.'

VEDANTIN: A follower of the Vedanta philosophy.

VEDIC DHARMA: Injunctions on the righteous way of living
as prescribed by the Vedas.

VIDYAVIDYA SVARUPINI: Whose nature is knowledge and
ignorance, a name of the Divine Mother.

VISHNU: All-pervading. The Lord of sustenance.

VISHWARUPA: The Universal Form of God.

VISHWESHWARA: Lord of the Universe.

VIVEKA: Discrimination.

VYASA: A sage who divided the one *Veda* into four and
composed 18 *Puranas* and also the *Mahabharata* and
Bhagavatam.

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CHAPTER ONE

NOT THE LIMITED SELF BUT THE INFINITE ATMAN

*H*ow is it possible for Mother to transform the lives of so many people, especially young people who have not yet enjoyed the pleasures of life? This is a question asked by many, both believers and nonbelievers. The answer is simple: When we are in Mother's presence and when we look into Her eyes, we are given a glimpse of our real Self. Mother's eyes reflect infinity. Her whole being gives us a glimpse of the state of being beyond the mind, the state of total egolessness. In Mother we behold our own purity, the purity of taintless love, the purity of the Self (Atman).

Suppose we have been eating junk food all our lives. Then one day we happen to eat a very nutritious meal for the first time, and it's delicious. Having tasted this delicious, wholesome meal, and if such food is readily available, will we still crave junk food? No, we will begin to crave good, nutritious food. Likewise, in Mother's presence, through Her every glance, touch, word and deed, we experience the ambrosia of immortality. We get a taste of it, and we sense that therein lies our real nature, the Atman. We also discover that what we have experienced up till now, in the name of enjoyment, is

absolutely nothing compared to this blissful experience. It is our first exposure to the knowledge that we are not just the body, or small, limited self, but the all-powerful, infinite Self, or Atman (God). As Mother puts it, “We come to realize that we are not a meek lamb, but a mighty lion.” Mother tells a story to illustrate this point.

“A hen once lay brooding on an eagle’s egg which happened to be lying among its own eggs. After a period of time, the eggs hatched and the chicks came out. The eaglet grew up with the chickens, scratching and searching for worms in the soil. He was completely unaware of his true nature - that he was a mighty eagle. As the days and months went by, all the chickens developed into fully grown birds. But still, the eagle continued to live with the hens, believing himself to be one of them. He was completely deluded, identified with his existence as an ordinary farmyard cock. One day, another eagle who was soaring up in the sky happened to see our ‘cock-eagle,’ who was busy scratching and pecking worms with the group of hens. The eagle in the sky was amazed at what he saw. He decided to save Cock-Eagle by bringing him out of his delusion, and he waited for an opportunity to meet him. One day when Cock-Eagle happened to be alone, Sky-Eagle flew down and approached him. When Cock-Eagle saw the great eagle descend from the sky, he became very frightened and began to crow like a chicken. In no time, all the hens came running to Cock-Eagle to protect him. Thus, without

succeeding in his mission that day, Sky-Eagle had to fly away. But soon thereafter, Cock-Eagle happened to stray quite far from his friends and Sky-Eagle found another opportunity to meet him. Slowly and cautiously Sky-Eagle once again approached Cock-Eagle. This time he managed to tell Cock-Eagle from a distance that he was a friend and not a foe, and that he had something very important to say to him. Cock-Eagle was suspicious and tried to run away, but Sky-Eagle succeeded in coaxing him back. He explained that Cock-Eagle was not just an ordinary farmyard chicken, but a mighty eagle like himself, who had the ability to soar up in the sky. Sky-Eagle said, “You don’t belong to the earth. You belong to the vast, infinite sky. Come with me, and experience the bliss of soaring through the air. You can do it, because you are just like me - you have the same powers that I have. Come on, try it!” In this way, Sky-Eagle tried to persuade Cock-Eagle. At first Cock-Eagle was full of disbelief. He even thought that it might be a trap of some sort. But Sky-Eagle was determined not to give up. Through his patience and tactful manners he gradually managed to gain Cock-Eagle’s confidence, and then he asked Cock-Eagle to follow him to a nearby lake. As Cock-Eagle had begun to trust Sky-Eagle, he was feeling a bit more confident, and he went with Sky-Eagle to the lake. They stood at the edge of the water and Sky-Eagle said to Cock-Eagle, “Now, look into the water. Look at your reflection and

see the close resemblance between the two of us.” Cock-Eagle looked into the clear, still water. He looked and looked and he couldn’t believe his eyes. It was the first time in his life that he had seen his own reflection, his real image. And now he knew that he didn’t look like a chicken at all, but that he looked exactly like Sky-Eagle. After this experience his trust in Sky-Eagle increased tremendously. He gained a great deal of self-confidence and he unconditionally obeyed all the instructions given to him by Sky-Eagle. At first, Cock-Eagle had some difficulty in rising from the ground. But, not long after, the two eagles could be seen flying together, soaring through the sky with graceful majesty.”

Mother says, “Most people are like Cock-Eagle, living their lives in ignorance without realizing their real abode.” Mother reminds us, “Children, you are the all-powerful Self. The entire universe is yours. You are the Master of the universe - in fact, you are the universe. Don’t think of yourselves as being meek, powerless or limited.”

In Mother’s presence we get a glimpse of our true nature. In Her we discover our real identity. We become silent and we gaze at Her with great wonder, for this is the first time in our lives that we have been given a real inkling of our true existence. When Mother says that we are not just our body, or the small self, the ego, but that we are the Supreme Self; Her words go straight to the heart because the words come directly from the

highest Truth, the Supreme Atman Itself. She wins us over completely, and then slowly helps us to soar to the highest peaks of spirituality. We have been living like Cock-Eagle, not knowing who we truly are. And in the glory of Mother's presence, we come to know in a lightning flash that we are not of this world, but that we are the highest Self.

When we identify with the body, mind and intellect, we are living, like Cock-Eagle, in a state of delusion. We are mighty golden eagles who could soar up to the heights of the vast spiritual sky, and yet we live and die like chickens, without knowing our real nature.

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CHAPTER TWO

THE MIND IS MAD

*M*other was chatting with the brahmacharins and a few householder devotees. A question was asked by one of the brahmacharins.

“Amma, if we truly are the Atman, why is it so difficult to experience the truth?”

Mother replied, “Truth is always the most difficult thing, and at the same time, the easiest. For ignorant and egoistic people, it is the most difficult thing to know, and for those who are inquisitive and have a burning desire to know, it is the easiest.

“People are intent on only feeding the ego. They never think of knowing the Self. To know the Self, one should starve the ego. But unfortunately, most people cannot starve the ego. Instead, they cling to it more and more. The predominant tendency in human beings is to attract as much attention as possible. They want to be praised and recognized, believing that it is their birth right. This is all food for the ego which thrives on attention. How are you going to know the Self if your ego is constantly craving attention?”

“In order to realize the Atman, the mind has to dissolve. As long as there is a mind, you will be domi-

nated by the ego.

“People point their finger at insane people and call them ‘crazy.’ But they don’t know that they themselves are actually crazy, as well. **Whoever has a mind is mad, because the mind is madness.** In the case of a person who is insane, it is clearly manifested and therefore you can see it. Whereas, in your case, it is not so clearly manifested and therefore not as obvious. But the madness is there, because the mind is there.

“Look at people whenever they get excited, anxious or angry. They actually go mad. **Anger is nothing but temporary madness, and it is the same with excitement and anxiety.** When you are extremely angry you are crazy; you speak and act in a crazy way. It is a temporary state, in which you lose your mental balance. When such a state becomes permanent, it is called insanity. If you give in to your mind too much, and it is not kept under proper control, you lose your stability and go crazy. “The mind is the ego, which makes you very self-centered. But, instead of being self-centered, you should become centered in the Self (Atman), the real Center of your existence. For this to happen, the mind should be extinguished. The ego should die. Only then can you become established in the state of *sakshi bhava* (witness consciousness).

“The ego is the greatest obstacle on your path towards the Truth. The ego has no real existence of its

own, for the mind and the ego are false.¹ At present we are under the impression that the mind and ego are our friends, but they are only misleading us, taking us away from our true nature. The mind and the ego have no power of their own; the source of their power is derived from the Atman, our real existence. The Atman is our true Master. But we are presently being controlled and misguided by false masters, namely, the mind and the ego. Not only do they delude us, they also cover the face of our real nature. Know this and try to come out of the limited shell of your mind and ego. The seedling cannot emerge and grow into a large tree unless the outer shell breaks and dies. Likewise, the inner Truth cannot be realized, unless the ego dies.”

THE EGO LIVES ON ATTENTION

Question: “Amma, You said that the ego lives on attention. What do You mean by this?”

Mother: “Children, this is something we do every day, every moment. To crave attention is part of human nature. Whether we are conscious of it or not, all of us demand it. Human beings have an innate tendency to find ways through which to attract the attention of others. Even

¹ The mind has four different functions, or aspects. They are: The mind = the doubting faculty; *chitta* = The store house of memories; *buddhi* = the determining faculty; *ahamkara* = the ego - the feeling of ‘I’ and ‘mine’. It is the same mind, but named differently according to its function.

a child wants attention. The mind and the ego cannot exist without getting it.

“A husband wants his wife’s attention, and she wants his. Children crave the attention of their parents. Men seek the attention of women and women want to be noticed by men. People will do anything to get attention. The whole world is craving attention. This tendency also exists in animals. The only difference is that they have different ways of seeking it. Whoever has a mind and an ego is in need of attention and cannot exist without it.

“The things people do to get the attention of others are the same in almost all countries. It appears in a much grosser form in the teenagers of all nations. The things they will do to attract the attention of others, especially that of the opposite sex, are sometimes very foolish. But they do it, because at that age they are completely under the grip of their mind and ego. The mind is mad. What else but madness can emerge when you are completely under its sway? The product of a mad mind can only be madness.

“As you grow up, your mind and ego also grow, but they become more subtle and your ways of attracting attention will therefore also become more subtle. Your methods may not be as gross as before, but the craving is still there.

“Mother once heard this story.

“A journalist was writing an article about the mayor

of a certain town. The journalist wanted to know what people's opinions were about the mayor, so he interviewed a cross section of the town's population and asked them what they thought about the man. Everyone had something bad to say about the mayor. He was said to be heartless and corrupt; he was being blamed for everything that was wrong with their town, and there were many who said that they regretted that they had ever voted for him. He was a very unpopular mayor. Finally, the reporter met the mayor. The reporter asked him what kind of remuneration he received for his work. The mayor explained that he wasn't getting any salary at all. "Then why are you so keen on retaining your position as the mayor of this town, when you do not earn anything and when you are so intensely disliked by the people?" asked the journalist. "I will tell you why - but off the record," said the mayor. "I might be unpopular, but I enjoy all the honor and the attention that I'm given."

"Many murders are committed just for the sake of getting attention. The ego reaches such a climax that a person may even think of getting recognition through acts of extreme cruelty. This is happening all over the world.

"A few weeks ago a young man came to visit Amma. He shamelessly disclosed to Amma that his greatest wish was to become famous. He told Amma that he had an intense desire to see his name and picture appear in a

major newspaper. Amma talked to him for some time and tried to make him understand the folly of his attitude. In the end he changed his mind and regretted what he had said. He had simply been honest, and this is why he openly told Amma about his desire. But isn't this what most people long for? It's just that people are seldom sincere; they never say what they feel. There is a big wall between people, between the individual and society. People have lost their openness because of the predominance of their egos. They care only about pleasing their own minds and fulfilling their desires.

“When a child cries, it is asking for attention. All your ambitions and desires are based on the ego's strong yet subtle demand for attention. When you want to become a successful professional you are seeking attention. You don't want to be an ordinary human being, you want to be extraordinary, better than others. You cannot simply be content with what you are. You feel a need to be recognized and honored. This happens because people tend to dwell more in the mind than in the heart. Amma is not saying that you shouldn't have any such ambitions. It is all right to have them, but they shouldn't make you feel too proud and egoistic. You shouldn't get carried away by the mind and its desires.

“A scientist can be a better scientist if he learns to be less egoistic. A politician can set a better example and be an inspiration to people, if he learns to work more from his heart than from his mind. And a sportsman

will achieve more if he is able to control his ego.

“The more egocentric you are, the more attention you demand, and you become too sensitive about everything. You expect people to speak and behave in a certain way towards you, and you demand respect from others, even though you may not deserve it.

“Amma knows a musician who demands to be treated with great respect. He is a talented musician, but his pride has made him an unattractive personality. One day, one of his admirers, who himself was highly musical, made a comment about the musician’s way of singing a certain classical Indian song. The comment was made in front of a small group of the musician’s admirers. Unfortunately, the musician couldn’t take the criticism, even though it was put in a very mild, respectful way. He took it as an insult and slapped the man right in front of the others.

“Egoistic people, whoever they may be, are deeply afraid of not being respected. They are afraid of losing their importance. They cannot even dream of such a thing, because it is the whole foundation of their existence. Their ego feeds on the admiration and respect that they are shown by others, and if they don’t get it they go to pieces. If people don’t praise them, or show them the respect or the attention they demand, they become irritated and their tempers will flair. Because of their ego and their sense of self-importance, they cannot take any criticism, even if it happens to be construc-

tive. They feel deeply hurt if anyone questions anything about them. They always want to be the center of any discussion, especially when they themselves are present. Their whole lives revolve around whatever attention they can get from others. When such people eventually retire, their only source of entertainment will be in recalling the past. They live in the past, because that was the time when they were given the maximum amount of attention. Their retirement will be a miserable experience, because now they have nothing to feed their egos with, except their memories. They either dwell on the past, or else, they keep some of their ardent admirers very close to them, so that they will still be given some attention and be told about their glorious past.

“Listen to this interesting story.

“The period of final dissolution had come to an end and the next creation was about to begin. Brahma, the Creator, conceived a multitude of species. It was now time to allocate to each species its respective life span. He began with man. To man He gave a life span of thirty years. But man was not content with that and demanded a longer life. Brahma replied that a life span cannot be arbitrarily increased, as the total number of years given to all living creatures had already been established. But man insisted that he be given a longer life. He prayed and pleaded with Brahma, until the Lord finally said, ‘Okay, let me see if I can help you. Stand

here beside me and wait. I am going to call the other creatures now. If any species do not want all of their apportioned life, I will let them decide how long they wish to live, and then I will give you the remaining years of their allotment.' Man gladly agreed and stood beside the Creator as He called each species.

"Brahma next called the ox and gave it a life span of forty years. The ox said, "O Lord, I couldn't bear to live such a long life. Have mercy upon me and cut it short by half." Brahma did so, and transferred the remaining twenty years of the ox's life to man. Man was happy to have a life that would last for fifty years.

"Next, Lord Brahma called the donkey to whom he allotted a life of fifty years. In a mournful tone the donkey said, 'O my Lord, don't be so cruel! It would be better not to have created me at all. My Lord, I don't want to live that long. Twenty-five years is more than enough for me. Please be so kind and give me no more than that.' Twenty-five more years were thus bestowed upon man. Thus man's life span had become seventy-five. But still he continued to wait expectantly.

"Following the donkey, Brahma called the dog and was about to bless him with thirty years of life, when the dog started howling in protest. The dog said to the Lord, 'No, no my Lord! I don't want to be on earth for more than fifteen years.' Thus man received another bonus of fifteen years.

"Brahma turned around to see if man was satisfied.

But lo! Still, only discontent was written on his face.

“The fifth species to be summoned was the worm. Brahma proposed for it a life of ten years. Hearing this, the worm almost fainted. It pleaded with the Creator, “O Lord, I shudder to think of such a long miserable life. Kindly reduce it to just a few days!” Again man was very happy to receive another ten years, which made his life span a full hundred years. Having been given the longevity of one hundred years, man rejoiced and danced gleefully in celebration, and he began to live his life on earth.

“Children, until the age of thirty, life is a period of education for man - a time when he is free from all worries and responsibilities of life, when he leads a carefree, easygoing life. Then he gets married. From then on, his life is verily like that of an ox. Just as the ox laboriously pulls a cart, man strains himself pulling the heavy cart of his family. In this way he reaches the age of fifty. Still he is carrying the heavy burden of the responsibilities of life and of his family. He no longer has the health and vigor that he enjoyed in his earlier days and he is also becoming lazy. His life, at this stage, can be likened to that of a donkey, for he is now living the life span of the donkey.

“When the years of the donkey have come to an end, man is totally exhausted and has lost his strength. For the next fifteen years, he is left to guard the house, like a dog, and look after the grandchildren. Most of

his time is spent sitting by himself, or lying down, completely ignored by both his children and grandchildren. He is now constantly thinking about the past, about old memories.

“The last ten years, which were borrowed from the worm, man spends crawling. Man is helpless, due to old age and sickness. His body and senses have become powerless. All he can do is lie down, brooding about the past which is all he has left. Finally, he passes out of this life, verily like a worm. The awful face of such a life is marked by despair, regret and misery.

As they were listening to this beautiful story, the devotees laughed softly as they recognized how true to life this is. Mother smiled at them and said, “Children, learn to live as if you have never existed. Only then will you live in Truth.”

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CHAPTER THREE

SAKSHI BHAVA

(THE STATE OF WITNESSING)

*T*he brahmacharins and a few Western devotees were sitting around Mother, at the edge of the Ashram grounds. One of the Westerners put forth a question about *sakshi bhava*, the experience of being a witness to everything.

Question: “Amma, the other day You were mentioning the state of *sakshi bhava*, or witness consciousness. I wonder if witnessing is a function of the mind, or is it an experience beyond the mind?”

Mother: “No, it is not a function of the mind. *Sakshi bhava* is a state in which you remain constantly detached and untouched, simply watching everything that happens, without the interference of the mind and its thoughts. You cannot be a witness to everything if there is a constant interference of the mind. The mind consists of thoughts. It can only think and doubt. In that supreme state of witnessing you constantly abide in your true nature.

“In *sakshi bhava* you become a witness to everything. You simply watch everything. There is no attachment

or involvement. There is only watching. You will even witness your own thoughts. As you consciously observe your own thought process, you are not thinking - you are not doing anything. You are still. You are simply watching and enjoying, without being moved or affected by anything. How can the mind be in a state such as this? The mind can only think, doubt and cling. It cannot witness.

“The thinking process belongs to the mind; whereas, witnessing belongs to the higher Self. Witnessing is a state of abiding in Pure Consciousness. The mind and its thoughts are not real. They are the fiction of our own creation. Consciousness alone is real. Thinking may seem natural to you, but it is not natural. It is not part of your real existence. Your thoughts and your ego create nothing but restlessness and agitation. They don’t belong to you, and you will continue to be restless until they are eliminated.

“Witnessing is the state of simply watching with perfect awareness. In the state of *sakshi bhava*, you are absolutely conscious. On the other hand, when you are identified with your mind and your thoughts, you are not conscious - you are far away from Pure Consciousness. You are in darkness and you cannot really see. The mind sees only the external world, the outer shape of things. It can never see something as it is, because you never see, you only think. And when you think, you miss the thing as it is.

“More and more accumulation and indulgence will only create more thoughts, and more thoughts will drive you away from your real center. In order to witness, one needs to be established in a supreme state of detachment. A clinging mind cannot witness; it can only be attached to thoughts and objects. It cares only about ‘I’ and ‘mine.’ In witnessing, there is no experience of ‘I’ or ‘mine.’ You go beyond all such limited, narrow thoughts.

THE REAL CENTER IS WITHIN

“When you become the witness of everything, you no longer have any claims. Everything, whether it be ‘you’ or ‘I,’ is the Supreme Lord, or Supreme Consciousness. Once you are established in that state, nothing can hurt or affect you. You move away from the mind and you are no longer identified with the body. The body is there, but it is as if it were dead. You don’t give any importance to the outer world or to what people say. You know that you, in truth, cannot please or displease anyone. Sometimes you act as if you are crazy, at other times you appear to be an ordinary person. At one moment you may seem attached, and the next you are beyond all sense of attachment - completely carefree and detached. You may be extremely loving and compassionate, and then all of a sudden, you seem to lack any trace of love. Altogether there is something very unpredictable about

you.

“Once you have attained the state of *sakshi bhava*, you can be in any mood you like, go to any level of consciousness - from the highest to the lowest and vice versa. But at the same time you are just a witness. Everything becomes a beautiful, delightful game - a wonderful play. Externally, people will still see you moving from one mood to another, from one place to another, and from one emotion to another; but internally you are motionless. You never move from that one center of Reality. The real center is within. It is not to be found in the external world.

“When you are established in that real center, you do not move. You are established there forever. And at the same time you can move without limit, in infinite ways, without ever leaving the center. You become God and God can move infinitely. There are no limits.

“Once you are established in the center of existence, you can ignore everything if you wish; or, if you want to smile at everything you are free to do so. If you don't want to sleep or eat at all, there is no need for it. On the other hand, you can eat what you like, and if you prefer to sleep for a whole year, that is also possible. But you will be awake within - wide awake. Though you may appear to be sleeping, you are not sleeping at all, and though you may appear to be eating, you are not eating anything. If you want to remain in your body, that is possible. Or, if you wish to leave your body, that,

too, can be done. And, having left your body, whenever you wish to reenter the body, you can do so. Or, if you do not want to return to the body, you can remain where you are. You can choose the womb that you will enter and what type of body you will have. Anything is possible.

“People may say that you are doing something, but you know that you are not doing anything. You are just watching, just witnessing.

“So, witnessing happens only when you become totally detached from the mind and the thought process. You then become fully conscious of everything, even your own thought process. For the aspirant on the spiritual path this can also be practiced as an attitude towards everything.”

BE FULLY CONSCIOUS

Question: “Amma, what do You mean by being conscious of your thought process?”

Mother: “Can you see a thought rising in your mind? Can you see how the thought works and how it dies? Once you are able to see a thought clearly, that very thought becomes impotent. Identification with a thought gives it power and the thought will then culminate into action. When you are not identified with a thought, it has no power. It becomes weak and inactive. When you see a thought and you are not identified with it, you are witnessing it. When you witness, you are fully

conscious. In witnessing there is no thinking, which means that you do not identify with any thoughts. In witnessing there is only consciousness.

“You may see two people fighting with each other. As you witness their fight, you are not part of it, you have nothing to do with it. You are simply aware of it, consciously watching. When you witness, you are aware. You are wide awake. Your consciousness is unclouded, clear and untouched by what you see.

“But what about the people who are fighting? They are part of the fight. They cannot see because they are fast asleep. Negative energy and negative feelings such as anger, hatred and the need for revenge, cloud their minds and makes them blind. When negative energy is predominant, you are not really conscious, and therefore, you cannot witness.

“The mind consists of negative energy. Your thoughts are negative energy and your past is negative energy. To become a witness is to really wake up and become conscious of everything that happens, both within and without. But in reality, there is no within or without. In that state of supreme witnessing, you become the center of everything, just watching all the changes that occur. The changes never affect you because now you have become the center, the very life force of everything. In the state of witnessing you become one with the supreme, cosmic Energy.”

Question: “Amma, You said that when we become the

witness, nothing will affect us. But, contrary to this statement, it is reported that even *Mahatmas* seem to suffer from physical ailments.”

Mother: “Son, you are right. It is true that they seem to suffer, that is perfectly correct. They never suffer but they *seem* to suffer. Once you become the witness, you will witness even the death of your body, you will simply watch the suffering of your body.

“Listen to this story: There was once a saint who lived on the shores of the river Ganges. He was totally absorbed in the state of God-consciousness, and in that state he constantly uttered the mantra, ‘Shivoham, Shivoham’ (I am God, I am God). The constant chanting of the saint could be heard by the *sannyasins* who lived on the opposite shore. One day, as he was sitting on the banks of the river uttering the usual ‘Shivoham, Shivoham,’ a lion came down from the forests of the Himalayas and moved towards the saint. The *sannyasins* on the other side of the Ganges watched in horror as the wild animal approached the saint and was about to jump on him. They shouted across the river, ‘Beware of the lion! Run for your life or jump into the water!’ When the saint saw the lion coming towards him, he was not at all afraid. He accepted what was about to happen, for it was time for his life on earth to come to an end. And, as he was abiding in a state of oneness with all creation, he could not experience any difference or separation between the lion and him-

self. He and the lion were one, and it was he himself who was roaring through the lion. He sat where he was and continued to chant calmly, 'Shivoham, Shivoham.' The *sannyasins* watched as the lion sprung upon the old saint. As the lion caught hold of him, he continued without any fear to chant, 'Shivoham, Shivoham.' The beast began to tear at his body. But what a wonder! The saint continued chanting, 'Shivoham, Shivoham', as if he himself, in the form of a lion, was simply having his hunger satisfied. Throughout the scene of his death, the saint behaved as if nothing were happening to him.

"There are biscuits available in different animal forms. There are, for example, tiger and rabbit shaped biscuits. Do you believe that a tiger shaped biscuit is a tiger just because it has that particular shape? And when you see a rabbit biscuit and a tiger biscuit together, do you think that the rabbit has anything to fear from the tiger? Will the rabbit shaped biscuit feel frightened, thinking that it will be killed and eaten up by the tiger shaped biscuit? No, of course not, because, basically, there is no difference between them. The different shapes are made from exactly the same ingredients. It is the same when you know that your true nature is the Atman. You become a detached, impersonal witness, who watches everything in complete awareness, knowing that the different shapes of all phenomena, both living beings and every circumstance in life, are all made out of the same underlying ingredient - the Supreme Self.

“The mind is your past. Die to your past and you will suddenly become fully conscious. The past is nothing but dead debris. Get rid of it and you will learn how to witness. When you die to your past, to your thoughts and your memories, then you will be fully in the present. When you truly exist in the present, you are simply witnessing. The past can only exist as long as there are thoughts. When the thoughts are eliminated, the past disappears and you abide in your own Self. The Self does nothing but witness. The Self is not a person - it is Pure Awareness. It is completely detached from all phenomena. It is the state of being the one subject, the core of your existence.

“Children, at this time you are leading an unconscious life. You may wonder, ‘How can I possibly be unconscious? I am walking, eating, and breathing, and yet Mother says that I am leading an unconscious life. Of course I am conscious! How else could all these things be happening within and around me?’ You may have a hundred arguments to prove that you are conscious, but the truth remains that you are not.

“Son, you may say that you are wide awake, because you are walking, eating, breathing and seeing. Yes, you may be doing all these things, but, son, how many times a day are you really aware of your hands and legs, your tongue, your mouth or your breathing? Even when you eat, you are not aware of your hand that is feeding you, or the tongue in your mouth; when you walk, you are

not at all conscious of your own legs - and are you breathing consciously? As you look around and observe, with your eyes, all the beauty and ugliness before you, are you aware of your own eyes? Even when your eyes are wide open, are you conscious of them? No, not at all. You are doing everything, but you are doing it unconsciously. You are leading an unconscious life. And yet you are eager to claim that you are conscious, that you are leading a conscious life. Therefore, wake up and be conscious."

Mother stopped talking and sat in meditation. After a little while She opened Her eyes and asked Br. Balu to sing a *kirtan*. He sang *Nirṅkumilapol Nimishamatram...*

*The entire creation rises and dissolves
within a moment like a bubble.
You cannot understand this phenomenon
unless the mind disappears.*

*The mind will vanish only when you realize
that the mind is an illusion.
You cannot comprehend your own mind;
it is enveloped by darkness.*

*The mind cannot understand the mind
for it conceals its own nature
But the mind will proclaim
that it knows.*

*You will come to understand
that the mind does not know anything
You will know
by keeping your mind calm and steady
and by doing tapas.*

*If you have really understood
then you will know
that the mind does not exist
that the mind is a no-mind
and once the mind is not,
everything shines forth as the Atman,
the Pure Self.*

THE POWER TO WITNESS EXISTS WITHIN

When the song had come to an end, Mother continued to talk about witnessing.

“The experience of witnessing actually does occur in our day-to-day lives. It is just a question of being aware of it. And once that awareness comes, when you taste its flavor, its joy and bliss, you are on the right track.

“Say that a husband and wife are quarrelling. They are abusing and insulting each other, using the choicest of harsh words. Now, the couple from the house next door arrive on the scene. They could hear all the shouting and they have come to see what is going on. They do all they can to calm and console the quarrelling couple. But the couple continue to rage at each other. The

neighbors talk to them and try to give them whatever advice they can. The neighbors are very calm and controlled as they try to handle this complex situation. They are able to see the problem and can therefore work on it. Finally, they manage to settle the dispute.

“How were they able to remain so calm and peaceful? Because they were only witnessing the scene, they were not part of it. Their minds were not as clouded or as turbulent as the minds of the quarrelling couple. They were much calmer and thus they were able to be good counsellors.

“On the other hand, the fighting couple were carried away by their turbulent minds and the dark, negative energy which they released. They were agitated and completely immersed in that darkness, both within and without. They couldn’t see at all. They could not witness the situation because they were so completely identified with their negative minds. Whereas, the other couple were presently at peace with themselves, and were therefore able to gain a better view of the situation. Because there was some light in them, that is, they were not immersed in the situation, they could, to a much greater extent, stand back and just witness the event. They were not completely blind. The veil of agitated thoughts were far less present in them than in the other couple. But just the reverse would happen if they were to have an argument. Their neighbors who were now fighting, would, at that time, be able to stand back and witness, and it

would then be their turn to act as counsellors.

“This example shows that the power to witness exists within everyone. It also makes it clear that witnessing is possible only if the mind is calm and quiet, only if you are detached.

“If this ability to witness can happen during certain moments of our lives, we should be able to experience it constantly, in any situation. This can be achieved because it is, in fact, our real nature.

“In the example given above, the mind still exists. It has slowed down at that particular moment, but the agitation will return. It is very difficult to be in a state of witnessing when difficult circumstances arise in our own lives.

“There are psychotherapists, counsellors and healers all over the world, who try to cure people’s mental and physical problems. They may be experts in their fields, but they are professionals who are doing a job, and they are attached to it and to many other things. Witnessing cannot happen when you are attached. A person with many attachments cannot really help others. Only a person who knows the art of witnessing, who is established in the Self, in the real Center, can truly help others. The experts analyze the problems of their patients, which stem from the past, and they then try to suggest certain methods by which the patient’s depression or anxiety can be overcome. As long as it is somebody else who needs the therapist’s help, it is fine. He can help oth-

ers to a limited extent. But what if something happens in his own personal life? Then everything collapses. The therapist is not able to apply the same methods to himself that he has tried on all his patients. Once something goes wrong in his own life, he cannot effectively counsel people anymore. He becomes useless. Why? Because as long as it is someone else who needs his help, the therapist can, to a certain extent, stand aside and observe the problem. His mind is comparatively unclouded and he just watches the other person's problem. The therapist is not involved in it, and therefore he is able to suggest some helpful methods. But when the problem happens in his own life, the mind exposes all of its negative tendencies. He can no longer be a witness, because he is himself entangled in the problem, completely identified with it.

“What is the use of all our methods if they cannot be applied to our own lives? And if they are not practiced in our own lives, how can they be expected to work effectively for others?

“Children, getting established in *sakshi bhava* is the real purpose of life. That supreme state of witnessing is the pivot around which all of life and the whole universe revolves. You may work, use your mind and your intellect; you may live in a house and have a family; you may have a lot of family responsibilities and you may have a lot of official duties to perform, but once you are established in *sakshi bhava*, in the real Center,

you can do anything without moving even an inch out of that center.

“Being in the state of *sakshi bhava* does not mean that you will remain idle without taking care of your duties. You may be concerned about your children’s studies, the health of your parents and your wife and so on, yet in the midst of all these external problems you remain a *sakshi*, a witness, to all that happens and to all that you do. Within, you are perfectly still and unperturbed.

“While enacting the role of a villain in a movie, the actor may be seen to be shooting his enemy, getting angry, being cruel and treacherous. But within himself, does the actor really become angry or cruel? Is he really committing those acts? No, he is not. He is just a witness to all that he does. He stands aside and watches without becoming involved or touched by it. He is not identified with the external expressions of his body. Likewise, one who is established in *sakshi bhava* remains untouched and unperturbed within, under all circumstances.”

Question: “Amma, You say that a person who is established in the supreme state of *sakshi bhava* will be calm and unperturbed in all circumstances, whether positive or negative. But You also say that outwardly he may behave like an ordinary person. This sounds like a contradiction!”

Mother: A *sakshi* can choose. He can express emotions if he wants to, or he can remain unaffected. But such

people, even though they may outwardly express ordinary human feelings, will also possess an incomparable charm and beauty. There will be a natural charisma about them. Even though they may express different feelings, they can also switch off a feeling at any time they want. If they choose to remain calm, quiet and detached, they can easily do so. If they want to express any feelings such as love and compassion in the extreme sense, with their whole being, that, too, is possible.”

Mother further elaborated, “Once you are realized, if you outwardly wish to give the impression of being affected by somebody, or an experience or situation, you let it happen. Remember that you yourself allow something either to happen or not to happen, because your mind, which is perfectly under your control, will not receive, reject, or react to anything without your permission. If you want to remain still and detached as a *sakshi*, it is possible for you to do so. But if you want to set an example of renunciation, sacrifice and selfless love, you simply live out those ideals. You may have to undergo extreme sorrow and suffering, much more so than any ordinary human being. But even then, you remain unaffected internally.

“Suppose you want to express deep sympathy and sorrow in front of someone. You know that if you do this, it will create a great transformation in the person’s life. So you express that sadness. But you are just a witness to the expression. As you are showing this feel-

ing of sorrow, the person in front of you feels grateful to you for sharing such feelings. Your deep love and concern has a great effect on him, because when you express a feeling you do it full justice, you express it perfectly and fully. You never express anything partially; your whole being is involved in it. Similarly, you can express any mood, at any time, whether it is positive or negative. Other people will feel it deeply and their hearts will be touched by it. It will invariably have the intended impact on the person. But the *Mahatma* is only a witness to the mood which is being expressed through his form.

“If the *Mahatma* wishes, he can express anger, anxiety, fear or excitement. But this will be only an outer appearance, because his mind will always remain calm and quiet. For him, it is just like wearing a mask. The *Mahatma* will wear different masks of anger, happiness, sorrow and fear, but he will do so for a certain purpose. And once that purpose has been served, he will remove the mask. He never becomes identified with it, because he knows that he is not the mask.

“Our problem is that we identify with all the moods of the mind. When we are angry we *become* anger. It is the same with fear, excitement, anxiety, sorrow and happiness. We become one with that emotion, whether it is positive or negative. We identify with the mask.

“When you are in a negative mood you may feel angry, and when you are in a relaxed mood you may feel

peaceful and loving towards others. In reality, none of these moods are really you. For example: you have a house and a family, and a beautiful dog and cat. Suppose somebody asks you, 'Whose house is this?' What will you answer? You will say, 'It is my house.' And you will say the same about your car, family, cat and dog. They are all yours. But, whatever is yours is not really you. It is different from you. The house is yours but it's not you. Your body is yours but it's not you. It is the same with your mind, thoughts, feelings and intellect. They are yours but they are not you. You are the seer who sees through the eyes, you are the perceiver who feels the emotions, you are the thinker behind the thoughts; you are the one who feels, thinks, sees, hears and tastes. You are the experiencer, the subject. Once you become the very subject behind everything, all differences drop away and you go beyond.

"Not knowing that you are the power behind the entire universe, not realizing that you are its very life force, the totality of all existing energy, you identify with your mind, with its different thoughts and feelings, and you say, 'I am so and so - I am angry, thirsty, hungry, etc.' You identify with the outside, not with the inside. Once you are identified with the inside, then there is no longer any inside or outside, because you have transcended both.

"Throughout His life, from birth to the end of His incarnation on earth, Lord Krishna remained a pure

witness to everything that happened in and around His life. The smile on His face never left Him, whether it was in the battle field or in the midst of dealing with any other of life's challenges. He remained perfectly calm with that alluring smile on His face. Even when Dwaraka, His abode, was swallowed by the sea, and when the hunter shot the fatal arrow which put an end to His mortal frame, Sri Krishna bore that same benign smile on His countenance, because He never wavered from that state of *sakshi bhava*. He was a constant witness to all that happened in His life. He never identified with the outside. He always remained as the Supreme Self."

Mother stopped talking and was suddenly in another world. Every now and then She would burst into a wave of blissful laughter. After a while She started making circles in the air with Her right hand. She opened Her eyes and requested that the brahmacharins sing a song. They sang *Parisuddha Snehattin...*

*Your Name
is the name of Pure Love
You are the reflection of Eternal Truth
You are the cool stream of peace
that offers comfort to my heart.*

*Your generosity is bounteous
in fulfilling the desires*

*of those who come to You
seeking worldly pleasures.*

*You pour out
the nectar of Knowledge
to those who surrender
at Your Feet.
You are the abode of peace and love
beckoning the soul.*

*You are spreading the message
of brotherhood
throughout the world
and You sing the song
of eternal freedom.*

*You are our inspiration
leading us to the land
of everlasting freedom.
You have lit the lamp of Love
and are constantly guiding us
toward the knowledge
of Eternal Truth.*

*At Your Lotus Feet
I place a flower
from the inner recesses of my heart,
with the prayer
that You will bestow upon me
the gift of undivided devotion
and steadfast yoga*

*so that I may attain
the bliss of the Self.*

MOTHER, THE SARVASAKSHI

Mother is a living example of the supreme state of *sakshi bhava*. One only needs to observe Her life closely, to see that She constantly remains in that state. Her whole life serves as an example of this. Throughout Her childhood She had to undergo severe trials and tribulations from all directions. As She was living in the midst of people who were completely ignorant, She had to be immensely patient and detached to be able to accomplish all that She did. She stood firm and unshakable, like the Himalayas, before the tremendous difficulties that She had to face.

The *Bhagavad Gita* says,

Brahman, or the Atman, is uncleavable, incombustible, and neither wetted nor dried. It is eternal, all-pervading, stable, immovable and everlasting.

CHAPTER 2, VERSE 24

Mother could not be affected by anyone or anything. She never looked back and grieved, nor was She ever worried about the future. Calm and courageous, She managed to confront all the difficult situations in life with a smile, always ready to accept whatever happened. In the face of the never-ending suffering She

went through, an ordinary person would have broken down, having lost all self-confidence and courage.

In spite of such adverse circumstances, of having no support from any direction, not even from Her own family, Mother managed to raise a great spiritual organization completely by Herself.

She was born as a village girl in a poor fishing community. She received no education whatsoever and had no money at Her disposal. And yet what unimaginable heights She has reached! How could this possibly be explained?

Somebody asked Mother recently, “What do You think about the enormous transformation that has happened to Your Ashram and the organization? There was a time when people tried to disgrace You and create all kinds of obstacles in Your life. But now You are recognized and worshipped all over the world. How do You feel about this?”

Mother smilingly replied, “Amma feels no difference of any kind. Amma is always the same. At the time, when the so-called difficulties existed, I lived within my Self, and now when so-called name and fame have come, I continue to live within my Self.”

Yes, Mother is always the same, and Her love and compassion never waver. There is never any difference at all, and yet She can be playful and childlike when She wants. She can switch off from this world and dwell in Her own plane of consciousness whenever She feels

like it. She can remain completely detached and can forego food and sleep for as long as She wishes. The world doesn't affect Her at all.

The ignorant villagers threatened Her life several times. They insulted Her and spread false rumors about Her. On one occasion, Her own elder brother, Subhagan, together with one of Her cousins, wanted to kill Her and even tried to stab Her. But even then, She could smile at them and say, "I am not afraid of death. You may kill this body, but the Self is immortal - indestructible. You cannot kill the Self." She then sat down calmly and quietly. But they were powerless. They couldn't do anything to Her. This is the power of the Self (Atman). And it is possible only for a person who is established in *sakshi bhava*, watching everything while dwelling in the supreme state of witness consciousness.

THE INFINITE POWER OF THE SELF

Mother once said, "Once you are established in the state of no-mind, no one can do anything to you, unless you consciously let them do it. You can allow something to happen or not to happen. Whether it happens or not, you remain a witness - completely untouched and unperturbed, ever established in the state of supreme detachment. Suppose someone wants to harm you or even kill you. They cannot lift a finger against

you if you do not permit it. As long as your *sankalpa* (resolve) is not there, nothing they do can affect you. They will in some mysterious way always fail. Finally they might reach the conclusion that something, some divine power, is protecting you. But that power is the infinite power of the Self; it is not some power that comes from outside. The source of this power is within you. You become that infinite power. When you are egoless you are everything. The entire universe is with an enlightened being. Even the animals, trees, mountains and rivers, and the sun and the moon and the stars are on the side of a Self-Realized soul - because in that state you are egoless. When you bow down before all of existence, in utter humility, the universe (existence) bows down to you and serves you. But, remember that you can also command them to turn against you, because, either way, you are not affected.

“When there is no mind or ego, then you are one with the whole of existence, and the universe with all its beings are your friends. No creature will perceive you as an enemy. And even an enemy would be your friend, would be one with you, because your enemy is your own Self, though he or she would not be aware of this truth. If, internally, you are one with the enemy, strictly speaking, how then can he be your enemy? How can anyone or anything, sentient or insentient, that actually exists within you as a part of your Self, harm you in any way? It is impossible. Nothing can happen to you once

you drop your ego, unless you want it to happen.

“The Rana of Mewar wanted to kill Mira Bai. He sent a cup of poison to her saying that it was a special drink that had been prepared for her, along with a beautiful and sweetly worded letter of apology for all the cruelty that he had shown her.

“Even though Mira knew that it was poison she nevertheless accepted the cup and drank from it. But nothing happened. The Rana tried to kill her by several other means, but all his attempts were in vain. As for Mira, she remained blissful and unperturbed throughout. How was this possible? Because she was egoless. She was beyond the mind.

“As far as Mira Bai was concerned, everything was her ‘Giridhar,’ her beloved Lord Krishna. She had no desires, because she did not want anything for herself. It didn’t even matter to her whether Krishna loved her or not. All she wanted was to be able to love Him, claiming nothing for herself. For Mira Bai, everything was Krishna. ‘Oh Lord! You, and You alone!’ There was no ‘I’ at all, or any sense of doership. Her Lord, Krishna, did everything for her, whether it was good or bad. Whatever happened, she had no complaints. She simply accepted everything, seeing everything that came to her as His *prasad*. By surrendering to Krishna, Mira Bai surrendered to all of existence. For Mira Bai, Krishna was not just a limited person who she perceived only in that one particular form. For her, the entire universe was Krishna.

She had become one with all of creation. She had become one with the energy of Krishna. She was not aware of her own body. And when you do not have a body, how can you be killed? The whole of creation is on your side, protecting you. How, then, can any poison affect you? How can any part of creation harm you in any way? It can touch you only if it has your permission to do so. Only if you say yes will it affect you. If you say no, it turns around and moves away. Once you reach that highest state, nothing happens, even if the body is tortured or destroyed, because you are not the body - you are the Self.

“The entire universe is your body. Each part of creation is part of your universal body. When all is one, how can the part possibly harm the whole? How can the hand consciously hurt the eye? They may look different and their functions may be different, but they are one with the whole body.

“When you realize your oneness with the Self, the entire creation becomes your faithful servant. You are the master and everything in Nature is awaiting your orders. When all of Nature fully supports you, how can anything turn against you unless you really want it to? Nature will do whatever you command. If you say, ‘No, don’t do it,’ nothing can happen. When you are in the right state of mind, nothing can harm you. Self-realization is the perfect state of existence.”

This reminds us of an incident which happened in

Mother's own life. Mother once put Her hands into the mouth of a rabid dog. The dog had been one of Mother's early companions, at the time when She was living out in the open. Mother loved the dog very much, and when She saw that he had been chained to a tree, She went up to him and expressed Her love by embracing him and kissing his face. She tried to feed the dog and as She did so, She put Her hand into his mouth. Those who happened to be there and saw what was happening, were extremely shocked because Mother's hand was covered with the dog's saliva, which was highly infectious. They were all extremely worried and suggested that Mother take injections against rabies as a precaution. But Mother just smiled and replied, "Nothing will happen. Don't worry." And, of course, nothing happened.

Mother says, "Once you are realized, you become the cosmic Mind. All minds are yours. You become the sole controller of all minds, not only of human minds but of the entire cosmic Mind. This means that you hold the reins of every single mind in your hand. You have become everybody. Their bodies may be different, but you are abiding within each body. **Your antagonist is nothing but you, yourself, in another wrapper.** It is just like candies of the same flavor enclosed in different wrappers. The wrappers are of many different colors. They may be blue, green, red or yellow. The candies may think, 'I am blue, I am green,' and so forth. But

what is inside? The same sweets with the same flavor, made of the same ingredients.”

Mother once said, “All your thoughts and actions pass through Amma.”

Infinite are the ways of a *Mahatma*. We are able to see only what we perceive on the outside. The *Mahatma* remains a total mystery to us - an unknown phenomena - that can be understood only when we come to know our own Self. We realize our limitations when we are in the presence of a *Mahatma*, whose infinite dimensions and unlimited love and compassion help us to feel humble. Only then will we become aware of our own nothingness. Only the feeling of nothingness and humility will help us reach the state of perfect fullness, the experience that ‘I am everything.’

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CHAPTER FOUR

A few new huts were being built for the brahmacharins in the Ashram. In the evening, after the *bhajan* singing, Mother wanted everyone to go to the seashore and carry sand, to fill the foundations of the new huts. As soon as this was announced, everybody went to the seashore with baskets and shovels. Mother led the way and soon the group arrived at the beach.

The night was dark and cool. The sea was rough. With a deep, vibrant sound that permeated the night, gigantic waves arose from the dark expanse of water and crashed against the shore. The sight of the vast ocean in the darkness of the night was awe inspiring and created a feeling of great inner peace. It also created a sense of openness and a deep awareness within the mind of all those present.

The sand *seva* (work) began. Everybody worked with great enthusiasm. Mother was also actively participating. Sometimes She used a shovel to fill the sacks with sand. At other times She carried a sack of sand on Her shoulders all the way to the Ashram. Even though the residents tried to stop Her from working, Mother wouldn't yield to their pleading. The sand *seva* went on for nearly

two hours. It was now eleven o'clock. Mother sat down beside the ocean, surrounded by the residents and a few householder devotees.

Mother distributed salty banana chips and hot black coffee to all those who had been working. One by one, the brahmacharins and brahmacharinis went up to Mother to receive their share. As Mother distributed the chips and the coffee, She said to one brahmacharin who was standing in line, "No, you haven't worked, so you won't get any *prasad*. It is only for those who have been toiling hard for the last two hours."

When the brahmacharin left the line without a word, Amma's motherly affection overflowed and She called him back and said, "It's all right, son. Don't feel sad. Just carry one bag of sand to the Ashram and Amma will give you some *prasad* when you come back."

The brahmacharin did as Mother told him. While he was carrying a sack to the Ashram, Mother said, "He has to carry one sack, because Mother doesn't want to be unfair to those who have been working selflessly. Relaxation comes only after effort."

THE MIND IS A BIG LIE

While everybody was enjoying Mother's *prasad*, one of the brahmacharins asked, "Amma, yesterday when You were explaining about *sakshi bhava*, You said that the mind is unreal. I have also read that the world is

unreal. Which statement is correct?”

Mother: “Son, both statements are correct. The mind is a big lie, and the world is a projection of that lie. Both are unreal. The world exists only because the mind exists. The mind is responsible for all your problems. It creates doubts and makes you suffer; it causes all your anger, hatred and jealousy; it prompts you to act indiscriminately and even to commit evil. It inevitably pushes you into a state of misery. The mind is hell. It is *maya* (illusion) and untruth. As long as you have a mind, your existence is unreal. Elimination of the mind alone can bring you back to the truth and to reality.

“The ego is a product of the mind. Therefore the ego is also a lie. It is unreal. Your existence will become full and perfect, only when you get rid of the mind and the ego.”

Question: “Amma, You say that the mind and the ego are unreal, that the world of phenomena is only a projection of the mind, that our real nature is the Supreme Atman, or the Self. This is very difficult to understand, unless you can explain it in a much clearer way.”

Mother: “Son, first of all, you must know that this cannot be explained in words. No matter how much proof and how many examples Mother may give, you will continue to have the same questions until you, yourself, experience the truth. The fact that the mind and the world are unreal is something which you, yourself, have

to realize. Perform *tapas* (austerities) and you will come to know this.

“Children, know that the mind is the greatest mystery there is. But Pure Consciousness, or the Self, is not a mystery. Once you know the Self, you will realize that it is not a mystery at all - it is you - your own real nature. It is closer than the closest. The mind makes it a mystery. The mind is a complication which makes everything very complicated.

“You are not the mind. You are the Self (Atman). You are born within that consciousness. You grow within it. You live in it. And you die within that consciousness. But you are never conscious of this great truth. Why? Because of the mind and the world which is created by the mind. The mind makes it impossible to know the Self. The mind kills you; it dissipates all your energy and all your vitality. The mind is a thing of great weakness. Therefore, try to escape from that unreality. Get out of that great liar, the mind, the ego.

“Children, you always ask for proof and explanations. This is something that cannot be proven. Proof can be given of a scientific solution, and one can prove something which can be perceived by the senses. But the Atman is beyond science or any perception of the senses. You cannot prove it empirically. You experience it within you. But consider that it is the mind that is demanding the evidence. The mind which is unreal is demanding that reality be proven! The very source of

your doubts and questions is itself unreal. All your doubts and your fears stem from that great liar, the mind.

“Here is an example. There was once a famous wrestler. No one could defeat him. He was unconquerable. He had been the champion of his country for several years. Being the strongest man in the country he naturally became proud and arrogant. It happened one day that a wrestler from another town came to challenge the champion. He accepted the challenge and a date was fixed for the match. Wide publicity was given about the great wrestling match which was about to take place. The fateful day arrived and the wrestlers appeared in the stadium. Our proud wrestler, the champion of the country, was very confident of his own victory. Compared to his opponent, he was stronger, extremely well built and had long years of experience. The fight began. The audience shouted and cheered for both of them, whistling and waving their hands. Some hailed the champion while others took the side of his opponent. The fight continued for quite some time. It was difficult to judge who would win. But finally, the visiting wrestler overwhelmingly defeated the champion, and the challenger was declared to be the champion of the year. The audience shouted, ‘Victory to the new champion!’, and they jeered at the defeated wrestler. They insulted him and laughed at him derisively. Somehow he managed to get up from the wrestling

mat and he walked away with his head bent in shame. Long after he had left the stadium, he could still hear the echo of the scornful jeers ringing in his ears. His heart was full of hatred and his mind was very agitated. At this point he suddenly woke up.

“Yes, it had only been a dream! But our champion was extremely restless. He had lost his peace of mind and was walking to and fro in his room, like a caged lion. His mind was filled with thoughts of revenge. He was totally identified with the dream, and tried with great intensity to figure out what method he would use to defeat the opponent in his dream. He thought, ‘Oh my God! I have lost everything! I have lost my reputation. How can I show my face in public? From now on, no one will respect me. How will I bear all their insults? I’d rather die than live like this. I’m going to seek revenge against that idiot.’ Such thoughts gushed into his mind. Brooding and pulling at his hair, the proud wrestler paced back and forth like one gone mad. But the more agitated he became, the more he longed to get out of his mental state. So, he eventually sat down and tried to relax. And it worked. As his mind began to calm down, his thoughts gradually subsided, and he soon realized how stupid he had been. He thought, ‘Oh my God! What has happened to me? What a fool I am. It was just a dream! It was not real at all, everything was the creation of my own mind. I have been getting scared and agitated about something that never happened.’

“Children, see how the champion was completely deluded by his own mind. He was totally identified with the dream and thought that everything that happened in the dream was real. Where did the other wrestler and the people, with their loud cheering and their insults, come from? Who created the different techniques that the two wrestlers tried on each other? Who created the stadium, the defeat of our champion, his shame, anger and desire for revenge? It was all created by the mind. Of course, it wasn’t real, but still, the wrestler believed that it was real and reacted accordingly. As long as he was identified with the dream world created by his own mind, he had to suffer. But as soon as he realized that the dream wasn’t real, he was released from its grip and found peace.

“In a similar manner, all of us are identified with a dream. The wrestler was identified with only a short dream. As soon as he woke up, the dream world disappeared, and as he relaxed, his identification with the dream also disappeared. Whereas, we are identified with a much longer dream. It is a dream that is projected by the mind, based on our thoughts and past experiences. At our present stage, we believe that the dream is real. We live in a dream created by the mind and we are identified with it. The awakening is yet to happen.

“You were asking for a clearer explanation. How can this be clarified as long as you are dreaming? The dream will disappear when you wake up. Only then

will everything become clear. Children, you are all dreaming and you believe that the dream is real. No amount of explanations can make it clear to you. Until you wake up, and for as long as you identify with the dream, it will remain unclear. Wake up and you will realize that you were only dreaming, and then everything will become clearer than the clearest.

THE TWO POWERS OF THE MIND

“The mind has two powers: the veiling power and the power of projection. First, the mind veils the true nature of a phenomenon, and then it misinterprets it. That is why Amma says that the mind is a liar. It covers the truth and makes us mistake the truth for something else.

“A man was walking alone along a village path. It was getting dark, and he was struggling to find his way in the dim light. Suddenly, something bit him in the foot. He felt the area with his hand and discovered a small wound. He could also feel that it was bleeding. He suddenly froze when he saw a snake lying coiled in a bush next to him. He must have been bitten by the snake. The panic stricken man screamed at the top of his lungs, ‘Help! I have been bitten by a poisonous snake! I’m going to die! Please, someone come and take me to a doctor!’ The man was hysterical. He called and he called. He was now beginning to feel terribly tired and his head was

spinning as if he were about to faint. He sat on the ground and continued to call for help. Within a few minutes, a man appeared out of the dark. He was carrying a torch. ‘What is the matter? What happened?’ he asked. ‘I was bitten by a poisonous snake. I am dying. Can you take me to a doctor?’ ‘Don’t worry. Of course I will help you. But where exactly did it happen?’ asked the stranger. ‘Right here, on this very spot,’ replied the man. ‘Look at that bush. There’s a snake there!’ The stranger turned his torch towards the bush, and what did he see? A thorn bush with a piece of rope entangled in it. The stranger said, ‘Take a good look! It’s a thorn bush. A thorn must have pricked your foot. The unfortunate thing was that you simultaneously saw the rope in the dim light and mistook it for a snake. Thus you were convinced that you had been bitten by a snake. But now that you know the truth, you can calm down.’ Once the man realized the truth, all symptoms of tiredness and dizziness disappeared, and he began to relax.

“This is how the mind plays its tricks on us. In the above example, the mind first veiled the reality of the rope and then projected the snake onto it. The snake is your past. This is what the mind does constantly. The Atman, the one Reality, is veiled and, in its stead, the world of plurality is projected. The Atman (the Self) is veiled and our thoughts are projected onto it. This deceit of the mind goes on without end. The illusion can be

removed only when a true Master brings you the light of true knowledge. Then you will realize the Truth and be at peace. That is when the real awakening takes place. Until then, the Truth will remain unclear.”

WAKE UP AND YOU WILL KNOW

There was a short pause, after which another question was asked by Br. Venu.

Question: “Amma, the waking up that you just mentioned, and the state of *sakshi bhava*, are they one and the same thing, or are they different?”

Mother: “Son, both awakening and the state of *sakshi bhava* require being conscious. Real spirituality means to be fully conscious - they are one and the same. Most people are not conscious. They live in a world of non-awareness, for they are taught to live in this way.

“A child is born with pure consciousness, but society teaches him to be unconscious. The people who surround the child, his parents, siblings, friends and society, teach the child to pick up different habits. They raise him in a certain way, in a certain religion, with a certain culture, language, food, education, and habits. Everything around him conditions him. He becomes completely clouded and is made to forget his real nature. He is taught everything except how to simply abide in his real nature. Thus the child becomes unconscious as he grows up, clouded by all the conditioning which

is forced upon him. He loses his purity and innocence, and he is never taught to be calm.

“In order to be conscious, one needs to be calm. Relaxation cannot take place unless you learn to break the shackles of the mind. The ancient saints and seers have, through the example of their own lives, shown us the technique through which to dissolve the mind, the thoughts and all the bondage that they create.”

Venu interrupted and remarked excitedly, “Amma, why go so far back? You, Yourself, are showing us the right path.”

Without paying any attention to the comment, Mother continued:

“Learn to be whatever you want in life, and at the same time learn this technique of being fully conscious under all circumstances. Once you have learned this art, you will always be aware and be a witness to whatever happens around you, without being involved in it.

“Suppose anger arises within you. Know that it is there. Know that the thought of anger has come up within you. When you are aware of it and can see it clearly, how can you become involved in a mood of that kind? Anger is a disaster. Nobody would consciously enter into such a state. It pollutes and poisons everyone and everything. Anger and all other negative moods of the mind are disastrous. They arise unconsciously. If you are conscious, fully awake and constantly watching, they cannot have any effect on you. Similarly, when an emotion leaves your

mind, again, watch it consciously. At present, everything happens without our knowledge; we get carried away by all our thoughts and emotions, as if we are fast asleep within.

“*Sakshi bhava* can be both a practice and a permanent state. When you are permanently established in that state, then it will become spontaneous and completely natural to you. **Witnessing will not happen unless you are ever wakeful.** The dream world created by the past has no place in that state. The past must die. The mind has to dissolve, so that *sakshi bhava* can take place.

“Children, your true nature is like the sky, not the clouds. Your nature is like the ocean, not the waves. The sky is Pure Consciousness, and the ocean is Pure Consciousness. The sky simply witnesses the clouds. The ocean simply witnesses the waves. The clouds are not the sky. The waves are not the ocean. Clouds and waves come and go. The sky and the ocean remain as the substratum of the clouds’ and the waves’ existence. They have no existence of their own, they are unreal and constantly changing. Like the sky and the ocean, the Witness is the substratum. Everything happens within that supreme state of witnessing, but the Witness remains uninvolved. The Witness simply is - pure and untouched.

“In a similar way, the mind and its thoughts come and go. They are unreal and impermanent. They are like the ephemeral clouds of the sky and the waves of the ocean. They cannot touch your consciousness. Beyond the surface, your consciousness remains pure and

untouched. That Pure Consciousness, which is eternally aware of all that happens, is the Witness, the *Sakshi*, of everything.

“To become established in *sakshi bhava* means to be ever conscious. Unless you are wide awake with perfect awareness, *sakshi bhava* cannot take place.”

One of the visiting devotees said: “The *Lalita Asthottara* (108 names of the Divine Mother) says that Devi is the Witness of all three states of mind, namely: *jagrat* (the waking state), *swapna* (the dream state) and *sushupti* (deep sleep). *Jagrat swapna sushuptinam - sakshi bhuttyai namah.*” The devotee joined his palms together and said, “O Amma, we believe that You are Lalita Parameswari, the Supreme *Sakshi*, who is the witness of all the three states of mind.”

Mother began to sing a song, *Uyirayi Oliyayi...*

*O Goddess Uma,
Life, Light and Strength
of the earth,
where are You?
O Wise One
who is the wind, the sea and the fire,
have You no mercy on me?*

*You are the true, hidden Knowledge
and in Your absence
all the wisdom of the world
has fled into the distance,
rebirths are being endlessly repeated,
unreality has become reality,*

*and unrighteousness is increasing.
The monkey of the mind
wanders ceaselessly
holding the fruit of conceit in its hand.
Not reflecting on its real nature
it becomes food
for the God of Death.*

After the song Mother was deeply absorbed in meditation. She was sitting completely still, immersed in Her own natural state of the Beyond. She seemed completely detached. The explanation She had just given about the highest state of consciousness had evidently removed the thin veil between Mother's real nature and the external world. Mother has said: "A thin veil has been created just for the purpose of being here in this world with all of you. However, this thin curtain can be removed any time that Amma wants to remove it."

Sitting in Mother's presence and observing Her, one sometimes experiences Her impersonal aspect, as well. At this particular moment, one could get a glimpse of this supreme state in Mother. Against the background of the immense ocean with its waves breaking against the moonlit shore, and the endless sky above filled with countless twinkling stars, Mother, in Her exalted spiritual mood, seemed an impregnable mystery. The entire atmosphere was permeated with a tangible spiritual energy, a unique sense of depth which in turn created an extraordinary feeling of peace within everyone. It

was a moment of pure bliss. Almost fifteen minutes passed in this way. And even though a chill wind was blowing in from the ocean, no one even thought of moving an inch.

It was nearly twelve o'clock. There was a slight movement in Mother's body, and a few seconds later She returned to Her normal external consciousness. Everyone soon noticed that Mother had moved.

Some fishermen came out of their huts to see what was happening at this odd hour of the night, and a few of them even joined the group.

ATTACHMENT IS A DISEASE

Soon Mother could be heard speaking again. Mother said, "Human beings have two major problems. One of them arises when you do not get what you desire. The other problem is strange because it arises when you get what you desire.

Question: "Amma, that sounds strange! How can a problem develop when you get what you want?"

Mother: "Son, it is simple. Whenever your desires are fulfilled, that in itself will create a chain of problems, because of your attachment to what you have attained. And having attained the object of your desire, your next move will be to protect it, and your sense of possessiveness will only continue to increase. The mind becomes very turbulent, whether you get what you want or not.

In your struggle to safeguard whatever you have gained, you will lose your peace of mind. The real problem, then, is attachment, which is caused by the problematic mind. Attachment is a disease. If a person is too attached, it can even make him go insane.

“You cannot be attached to anything in the world and at the same time be at peace, because too much attachment to anything builds up a lot of tension in the mind, and this is bound to create pain. When you are too attached to anything, the excitement and anxiety born out of that attachment accelerates the thought process and intensifies the chaos of the mind. The pressure that builds up is such that your mind becomes uncontrollable. You don’t know in which direction to turn, and you lose all sense of clarity. Your mind becomes like a forest after a cyclone. Until now, you could, to some degree, watch things from a distance as they occurred in your life. But now, the pressure of attachment has reached its peak, the burden has become too heavy, and you don’t know what to do or how to face it.

“You lose your grip on life, and feeling utterly lonely and disappointed, you become an easy victim of your mind. You will drown in your thoughts; they will overwhelm you and swallow you up, as you become identified with the mind and all its negative emotions. An emotional breakdown takes place and you are forced into the darkest realms of the mind. You may even go

mad. This is what our attachments can do to us.

“Mother will tell you a story that She has heard. A man was visiting a mental hospital where the doctor was a close friend of his. The doctor took him around and showed him the patients. In one cell a man was sitting on a chair, rocking back and forth while he happily repeated the name, ‘Pumpum, Pumpum, Pumpum...,’ over and over again. The visitor said to the doctor, ‘Poor fellow. What is his problem? Who is this Pumpum?’ The doctor replied, ‘Pumpum was his beloved. She jilted him and ran away with another man, which is why he went insane.’ The visitor sighed and went on to visit other patients. As they approached one cell, the visitor was surprised to see another man sitting in his cell hitting his head against the wall, as he uttered the same name, ‘Pumpum, Pumpum, Pumpum...’ The visitor asked the doctor, ‘What is this? Has Pumpum something to do with this man, too?’ The doctor replied, ‘Yes, this is the man who Pumpum finally married.’”

There was uproarious laughter as Mother finished the story. In the stillness of the night, it sounded like an explosion. The laughter slowly subsided and merged with the sound of the ocean. At about twelve-thirty a.m. Mother got up and, followed by Her children, She returned to the Ashram.

It had been a wonderful night. These are unforgettable events which create a deep impression in the heart of the disciple - invaluable events upon which there is

so much to contemplate. Living with a true, living Master is a rare blessing, the rarest and most precious blessing a human being can receive. These moments will later create endless waves of intense love and longing in the disciple, which will finally cause him to dive deep into his own consciousness and thereby soar to the heights of spiritual bliss. Blessed indeed are the ones who associate with a great Master like Mother.

WHEN AMMA SAYS, “DON’T WORRY...”

One devotee was saying, “When Amma says, ‘Don’t worry,’ there is no point in worrying, because somehow or other the problem will be sorted out.”

This is the experience of many devotees. The devotee who made the comment had come this evening with his whole family to see Mother and to receive Her blessings. He had a special reason for saying this.

A year and a half ago, his daughter had been given away in marriage to a pious young man, and the couple had begun a very happy married life together. A few months after the wedding, to the family’s great shock, the young woman was diagnosed with cancer of the womb. She was five months pregnant at the time. The doctors were of the opinion that it was a serious, extremely complicated case. There was a tumor in the womb which was thought to be malignant and it had to be removed through surgery. The doctors were pes-

simistic about the outcome of the operation. They didn't believe that the baby would survive, and the mother's chances of survival were also very slim. The doctors actually told the parents of the young woman that God alone could save their daughter and the baby. The worried parents went to Mother, their only source of hope. They told Her about their daughter's life-threatening illness and prayed for Her Grace. The whole family had been very devoted to Mother, ever since they first met Her in 1981. Whenever they had a problem they always turned to Mother for Her Grace and guidance.

Mother listened to their problem, and, having expressed Her deep concern for their daughter, She said to them, "Don't worry. Mother will take care of both your daughter and the baby." They had complete faith in Mother, and after She said this they didn't worry anymore, even though, four months later, the girl still had to undergo the operation. Their faith in Mother's words proved to be one hundred percent correct. The operation was performed, the baby was removed from the womb, and to the wonderment of the doctors, both mother and child survived. The doctors removed a tumor weighing four pounds from her womb. And even though the doctors still expected complications to set in, there were no complications at all; everything went smoothly. Both mother and baby were perfectly healthy.

When Mother came down from Her room, the family, who were anxiously waiting to receive Her *darshan*,

came rushing up to Her. They prostrated before Her and placed the newborn babe at Her feet. Through tears of gratitude, the mother of the baby said to Mother, “Amma, he was born only because of Your Grace.” Mother picked up the infant, and as She held him in Her arms and was fondling him, She said, “See how much trouble you have caused your mother, just for her to give birth to you!”

Mother sat down at the bottom of Her staircase. Soon She was surrounded by the Ashram residents. The baby kept looking at Mother, gazing intently at Her face. He had a dark complexion and because of this, Mother called him ‘Karumba’ (The black one). Mother continued, “Son, you are black just like Amma. Don’t you want to be fair like your mother?” The baby suddenly began to cry. Mother said, “It seems that he didn’t like it that Amma called him Karumba.”

The baby’s grandfather was bursting with excitement and couldn’t contain himself anymore. “No! No!” he retorted, “He was very happy when you called him ‘The black one.’ He rejoiced to hear that he is as dark as You, Amma. But he didn’t like it when You asked if he wanted to be fair like his mother. He is protesting! That is why he’s crying!”

Everyone was delighted by this sweet remark and laughed in appreciation. Mother also joined in the laughter, as She returned the baby to its mother.

THE NECESSITY OF TAPAS

Mother turned to the residents who were sitting next to Her and said: “Immense *tapas* (austerities) is needed for any new birth to take place. Take, for example, the birth of a child. A mother is literally doing *tapas* during her pregnancy. She has to be very careful with everything she does, the way she moves and acts, and even in the way in which she’s lying down. She cannot eat certain foods, and she must not strain herself by doing too much physical work. She may have to avoid certain kinds of situations where she could get nervous or upset, and it wouldn’t be good for her to brood over things or be anxious. Only if the mother follows all the instructions given by her doctor will she give birth to a healthy, intelligent child. If she makes a mistake it could harm the baby. The pregnant woman will constantly be thinking about the child she is carrying in her womb. She will never forget the baby for a moment and her awareness will be tremendous. Similarly, we ourselves should have the same commitment to the spiritual birth that is about to take place in us. This commitment is known as *tapas*. “For anything to be born, whether it be, for example, the birth of a nation, an institution or a business, it requires a lot of *tapas*. Only through *tapas* can one attain the heights of any chosen field; it doesn’t matter which. Whether you are a spiritual person or a person whose aims are predominately material, if you want to

become a real master in your field, it is absolutely necessary to do *tapas*.

“To seek spiritual attainment is to die and to be born again. The ego needs to die. Only then can the real you be born. And just like any birth process, you will have to undergo *tapas*, intense *tapas*. *Tapas* is, in a way, unavoidable; it is the pain which you have to undergo in the process of gaining anything. In order to reach the spiritual goal, a maximum amount of *tapas* is needed. The difference between the spiritual goal and other aspirations lies only in degree. Spiritual realization is the highest type of happiness that can be attained, and therefore, the price that you have to pay for it is also very high.

“It’s just common sense. The happiness that we gain from the outer world is fleeting; it never stays with you for long. It is there for one moment and the next moment it is gone. But, spiritual bliss is not like that. Once the final breakthrough happens, that is, once you transcend the limitations of body, mind and intellect, once you reach that state, there is no return. The bliss is forever. And it is infinite. But for this to happen you need to pay accordingly. It is not sufficient to pay with only a part of yourself, you have to pay with everything. Your entire life is what has to be given.

“You have to sacrifice a great deal just to gain a few material objects, or to attain a higher position, or to become famous. You need to study and train yourself to

gain a fitting education and whatever qualifications you may need. Many people sacrifice the pleasures of family life to attain a higher position in society, or to acquire a more profitable business. A lot of time and energy have to be concentrated towards that end. The more happiness you want to enjoy, the more effort is necessary, and the more you have to pay.

However much you grow materially, the pain and tension will remain with you. It doesn't end. Whereas, in spirituality, once you attain the highest peak, all pain and tension disappear. You will become completely independent and fully relaxed.

"If, on the other hand, you wish to remain in your own village, content with your modest work and enjoy the pleasure of being with your family, that is fine. It will be less strenuous and will consume much less of your time and energy. The *tapas* or pain that you have to undergo will be relatively small. But if you are very ambitious and wish to earn more money, believing that this will make you happier, then you will have to do much more *tapas*. However, if you desire to become a doctor or a scientist in a foreign country, such as the United States of America, then the intensity of the *tapas* (commitment) or pain required will be very great.

"So, if a person wants to become the happiest person in the world, the only way to gain the highest type of happiness is to lead a spiritual life, performing intense *tapas*. This is simple logic. Just to become the owner of

a few things - a house, a car, or a plot of land - you have to pay a great deal and a lot of sacrifice is involved. But spirituality is like becoming the owner of the entire universe. The universe becomes yours; it becomes your servant and you become the master. You can imagine the amount of *tapas* you will have to do to own the universe, to become that wealthy, to become the Lord of the Universe, to be the happiest of all, for all times to come.

“Yes, children, it is a new birth. To become truly spiritual, you need to be born again. And only if you die will the real You be born.

“As the outer shell of the seed dies, the seedling emerges. Gradually it grows into a shady tree with an abundance of fruits and flowers. Likewise, the outer shell, the body and the ego, should die so that we may grow into the Atman (the Self).

“Just as a mother is willing to endure the pain of giving birth to a child, a true *sadhak* (spiritual aspirant) should be willing to undergo the pain of *tapas* with great perseverance and immense awareness, so that he can blossom into a divine, beautiful and fragrant flower. The bud opens for the flower to unfold, and as the bud breaks open, some pain is involved. At this stage, your heart is like a bud, and in order for your heart to open, the pain and the heat of *tapas* are unavoidable. *Tapas* literally means heat. Only the heat produced by *tapas*, the pain and the longing that it creates, can burn up the mind

along with all its thoughts, its *vasanas* (tendencies) and the ego. The process of opening is painful, but once it opens up, the beauty and charm of the divine flower of the heart is indescribable and eternal.”

BE AN INNOCENT BEGINNER

Question: “What is the best way for this opening to happen?”

Mother: “Son, can you remain a beginner forever? If you can remain an innocent beginner, that is the best way for this opening up to happen.”

One brahmacharin exclaimed, “Beginner! What do you mean by that, Amma?”

Mother: “Yes, son, only when you are aware of your ignorance can you remain with the attitude of a beginner. A beginner is always ignorant and he knows that he is ignorant. Therefore, he listens intently. He is open and receptive. Once you think that you know, then you do not listen anymore; you only speak. Your mind and intellect become full. You are not a beginner anymore, you have turned into a knowledgeable person. But in reality, a knowledgeable person is more ignorant than others, because he is completely closed. He has lost his ability to be open and receptive. He may be knowledgeable, but he does not really know. To really know is different from being knowledgeable. You need to be open in order to know. You need to be an innocent beginner.

“The beginner is able to bow down in humility, and because of this, true knowledge flows into him. But a knowledgeable person is merely full of information and tends to be egoistic. He therefore cannot bow down and be humble. True knowledge cannot enter into him. There is no room for it and so it spills out.

“Amma has a story to tell you. A *Mahatma* once lived in a deep forest. One day, a very scholarly person came to the forest to visit him. The scholar was in a great hurry and said to the *Mahatma*, ‘Revered Sir, can you tell me something about meditation?’ The *Mahatma* smiled at him and said, ‘Why are you in such a hurry? Sit down, relax and have a cup of tea. Then we will discuss the matter, there is time enough.’ But the scholar was very restless and impatient. He said, ‘Why can’t we do it right now? Tell me something about meditation!’ However, the *Mahatma* insisted that the scholar should sit down, relax and have a cup of tea before he would talk to him. Finally, the scholar had to yield to the *Mahatma* and he sat down. But, as is the nature of a scholar, he couldn’t possibly relax. He was constantly talking within. The *Mahatma* took his own time. He made the tea and came back to the scholar who was waiting for him impatiently. The *Mahatma* handed a cup and a saucer to the scholar and then he began to pour the tea into the cup. The cup became full, it started to overflow, but the *Mahatma* did not stop pouring. The scholar shouted, ‘What are you doing? The cup is full!’

Stop pouring!’ But the *Mahatma* kept on pouring. The tea overflowed into the saucer and from the saucer it slowly began to drip onto the floor. The scholar shouted at the top of his voice, ‘Hey, are you blind! Can’t you see that the cup is full and that it cannot contain another drop?’ The *Mahatma* smiled and stopped pouring the tea. ‘That is right,’ he said. ‘The cup is full and it cannot contain another drop. So, you know that when a cup is full it cannot contain any more. How then can you, who are brimful with information, listen to me when I talk about meditation? It’s impossible. So, first empty your mind and then I will talk to you. However, meditation is an experience; it cannot be explained verbally. Meditation happens only when you get rid of your mind and your thoughts.’ ”

Mother continued, “Knowledgeable people or intellectuals only know how to talk. They cannot listen. Listening is possible only when you are empty within. Only one who has the attitude, ‘I am a beginner, I am ignorant,’ can listen with faith and love. Others cannot listen.

“If you observe two scholars talking to each other, you will see that neither of them is listening to what the other is saying. But you will also see that one is keeping quiet while the other is talking and vice versa. You may think that they are listening to each other, but, in fact, they are not. They cannot listen. When one speaks, the other one may not be speaking externally, but he is

speaking within, forming his own ideas and interpretations. Each one is waiting for the other to stop so that he can start, and there will be no connection between what they are saying to each other. One will be talking about A and the other will be talking about Z. Neither of them is a good listener; they each know only how to speak.

HOW TO LISTEN

“If you want to be a good disciple, you must become a good listener, a listener endowed with faith and love. You must always have the attitude of being a beginner, so that you can listen properly. Such a beginner will be completely open and innocent, like a child.”

Question: “Amma, I feel that I do listen when You talk. I don’t think that I am talking to myself when You are speaking. Or am I?”

Mother: “Son, Amma is not saying that you aren’t listening. You are listening, but only partially. You listen with your mind. Your listening is divided, not undivided.”

“If you, for example, look at the people who are watching a cricket match or a football match, you will see that they sometimes forget themselves. When their favorite player bowls or kicks the ball, they will also make funny movements with their hands or legs, and sometimes you will see some odd expressions on their

faces. They are participating with their bodies. But they do not forget themselves completely; they are still there, engrossed in the play, but only partially.

“When a great musician is performing, the listeners will participate, shaking their heads and clapping their hands. But this is only partial participation, only emotional participation. Your whole being is not involved.

“When you listen to a song, you are present; whereas, in actual participation, you are completely absent. You forget yourself. Your whole being, every cell of your body, opens up and you receive wholly, without missing a single drop. As you drink in the object of your thoughts or meditation, you become one with it. In that kind of participation you yourself are totally absent. It is as if the player is absent - only the play exists. The singer is absent - only the song exists.

“When Mira Bai sang and danced, her whole being participated. When the *gopis* of Vrindavan longed to see Krishna, their whole being participated. They forgot themselves. They became identified with Krishna.

“Your listening becomes complete only when your whole being participates. Only then will true knowledge flow into you. When you learn to listen to the Master with your whole being, then you yourself are absent. You cannot be present; your mind or ego cannot remain present in that kind of listening or participation. You identify with your Master, with his infinite consciousness, and you become everything.

“Once, Lord Krishna and Arjuna went for a stroll. They had a long, pleasant talk. At one point Krishna said to Arjuna, ‘You say that you believe that I am an incarnation of God. Then, come with Me, for today there is something that I want to show you.’ They walked together along the countryside. After a while, Krishna stopped and pointed at a large vine bush growing in a field, and He said, ‘What do you see there?’ Arjuna replied, ‘I see a huge vine, bearing clusters of ripe grapes.’ The Lord said, ‘You are mistaken, Arjuna. That is not a vine and those are not grapes. Take a closer look.’ Arjuna looked again at the vine and was amazed to find that before him there was no vine at all. There was only the Lord. And there were no bunches of grapes, only countless forms of Krishna hanging from the form of Krishna.

“When you participate wholly, you become everything, you identify with the entire universe. A new world opens up before you, and you become permanently established in that state.

THE THREE TYPES OF STUDENTS

“The scriptures talk about three types of students. The best, most competent student listens to the Master’s words with his whole being. If the Master tells him, ‘You are Brahman,’ He immediately realizes Brahman, the Absolute Reality. How does this happen? Because

he listens totally - his whole being participates in that listening. He listens with undivided faith and unconditional love. Such a student must have an unquenchable thirst to know. He drinks in his Master's words - nay, he drinks in the Master, Himself, with his whole being. The saying, 'You are Brahman,' goes straight into his heart and he realizes.

"Such a disciple maintains the attitude of a beginner, an innocent beginner. He may have learned all the scriptures but he still remains a beginner, innocent as a child. He is extremely humble and therefore, true knowledge flows into him. The deepest knowledge is available only when you learn how to participate with your whole being, only when you learn the art of bowing down before all of creation in utter humility.

"The second type of disciple listens, but only partially. It will take much more time for him to realize the truth. He does listen, but only emotionally - he does not listen totally. His listening is divided; his faith and love are divided. The Master, therefore, has to be very patient with him, so that he may learn how to listen fully. He doesn't yet know the art of forgetting everything and participating with his whole being. True knowledge can enter into him only when he listens to the Master with such intensity that he forgets himself. The ever vacillating and doubtful mind will not allow him to be an innocent beginner, so that the knowledge may flow into him. He sometimes manages to do it, but

before long the mind comes back. The receptivity comes and goes. The mind does not allow him to remain firmly in that state. The mind shouldn't interfere at all. It shouldn't ask any questions. Only then does the mind cease to interfere and total listening becomes possible. Until then the disciple will listen only partially. But a true Master, who is patience and compassion embodied, will help him to reach the final goal.

"The third type is the disciple who is intellectually inclined. He is very talkative within, and his mind contains so much information that he cannot listen at all. Such a disciple will be very egocentric, and the attitude of 'I' and 'mine' will be very predominant in him. The Master has to wait with endless patience to bring him to the light. The disciple's ability to listen is extremely poor, because he does not know how to be an innocent beginner at all. He cannot bow down and be humble, and therefore, true knowledge will not flow into him. Even if the Master constantly repeats to him, 'You are God. You are God... You are Brahman, the Absolute,' the disciple will constantly be asking within, 'How?' 'Why?' 'What?' 'When?' *ad infinitum*, because his intellect is crammed with his own ideas and those of the scriptures. The Master must have tremendous patience to bring this kind of disciple to the right track. The divine discus alone can open up a crack in such a disciple. The true Master will finally use the divine discus of true knowledge to break open the ego of the

disciple. He will empty his intellect by making him feel the heavy burden of his storehouse of limited knowledge, and he will then fill the disciple's heart with true knowledge and with the light and love of God. This is a tremendous job which can only be done by a true Master."

Mother is a living example of someone who does everything with Her whole being. Her entire being participates during *darshan*, when She speaks and sings *bhajans*, and when She works with everyone in the Ashram. Mother participates fully and completely in whatever She is doing at the moment. While receiving Her children during *darshan*, Mother offers Herself to them and forgets Herself. Mother doesn't care about Her own body or any physical comforts. She is completely available to Her devotees, offering them Her whole being as She participates in their happiness and sorrow, their success and failures. She is fully present without the least presence of an ego or any judgement.

In whatever Mother does, Her whole being participates. She is totally in the present. We see only Her outer form, but She is not there. Pure Being alone exists. Her presence and participation is total, and it is deeply inspiring. Mother cannot do anything halfheartedly. She can only participate in Her fullness. It is this fullness that makes Mother's presence such a wonderful and unforgettable experience in one's life. And it is this fullness that adds a special charm and beauty to all

that She does. It becomes a meditation. Mother's smile, the way She walks, Her voice, Her glance and Her touch, every detail of what Mother does is so perfect, because She is *Purnam*. She is the Whole.

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CHAPTER FIVE

*M*other was in Calicut for a few days. It was Her first visit to that part of the state. She was staying in the home of a devotee. The morning *darshans* were also held at the house. There was a constant flow of devotees who came each day to receive Mother's *darshan*.

Mother was sitting on a cot in Her room, which was quite big, and She was receiving the devotees, one by one. Mother's room was on the first floor of the building, and there was a long line of people standing outside the room, patiently waiting their turn. The line of people went all the way down the stairs and continued out beyond the main entrance of the house and onto the road. Inside Mother's room, some people were sitting in deep meditation, while others simply gazed at Mother in wonderment. The brahmacharins were singing *bhajans*. A professional musician expressed a wish to sing a song about Mother which he himself had set the tune to, *Paravasamannen Hridayam...*

*My mind is deeply troubled
by countless distracting thoughts.*

*O Mother, don't delay anymore!
Take care of this destitute one.*

*Know that I am helplessly falling
into the depths of the sea.*

*O Mother
who has been known to us
throughout the ages,
won't You come
and soothe my weeping eyes?*

*My mind is confused
with all its unfortunate waves.
I am struggling in this ocean of fire
without reaching the shore,
without having beheld
Your Lotus Feet.*

A VISION OF MOTHER AS PARASHAKTI

When the song had come to an end, a woman who was in the middle of receiving Mother's *darshan*, suddenly got up and began to dance and sing while she chanted the mantra, "Aum Parashaktyai Namah." The woman raised her arms above her head and joined her palms together. Her eyes were closed and tears were streaming down her cheeks. She looked very blissful. She had the serenity and joy of one who is totally absorbed in meditation.

In her state of bliss the woman exclaimed, “Blessed indeed am I today! By touching Your holy feet I have become blessed and purified. Today, I have seen *Parashakti*.² O Mother, please don’t leave me!”

Some devotees tried to carry her out of the room. But Mother interrupted and said, “No, no, it’s all right! She’s in bliss. Don’t touch her. Let her dance and sing.” Having received Mother’s instructions, the devotees gave up the idea of carrying the woman away, and she continued to dance and sing for some time, in the same blissful mood.

Later, the woman talked about her experience:

“As I was waiting in front of Mother, She looked at me and smiled so lovingly. That smile was like a blissful, electric shock to me and all my hairs stood on end. I felt as if I was losing all my body consciousness, and I fell in full prostration in front of Mother. I called out and prayed, ‘O Mother, great Enchantress, protect me! O Mother, protect me! O Parvati, Lord Shiva’s holy consort, give me refuge!’ With infinite love and affection, Mother took hold of me, drew me towards Her and placed my head on Her lap. She then lifted my head from Her lap and applied sandal paste between my eye brows. This divine touch was another supremely blissful experience. My eyes were opened wide. It was like an outer space experience. I was completely im-

² The Supreme Power, or the Divine Mother

mersed in a divine feeling, its presence so full and tangible, I felt as if I were floating in the air, floating in a feeling of perfect fullness. But what I beheld in front of my eyes was something unbelievable. It was not a dream or an illusion - it was as real and as clear as I am seeing you now.”

The woman was very excited. She couldn’t speak any more, as her words choked in her throat. Her eyes filled with tears and she seemed ecstatic. The listener who was anxious to hear the last part of her narration said to her, “Kindly tell me about the vision you had. What did you see?”

The lady somehow managed to control her emotions and said, “I saw the beautiful and enchanting form of Devi right in front of my eyes, in all Her splendor and glory, sitting in a lotus posture with all Her weapons. Words cannot begin to describe the wonderful experience I had. My heart was intoxicated with bliss. There was only bliss, bliss, bliss - I was drowning in supreme bliss.” Even as she was talking about the experience the lady sounded very blissful.

The four day visit to Calicut was unforgettable. An endless flow of devotees came to seek Mother’s blessings. The morning *darshan*, which started at nine-thirty, ended at four or four-thirty each afternoon. Most of the evening programs took place at different public places. People from all walks of life came to meet Mother. There were children, elderly people, *sannyasins*, intel-

lectuals, students, lawyers, doctors, laborers, politicians and journalists. During the morning *darshans*, there was not an inch of space to spare. The way Mother gives *darshan* to the devotees is indescribable. Just as one sees one's own image in a mirror, people see their own true nature, their own Self, in Mother. They feel that the purpose of their lives has been fulfilled. And Mother fulfills their desires; She knows what each one of them wants and it is available in abundance from the inexhaustible source of Her infinite Self.

IS RELIGION RESPONSIBLE FOR THE CONFLICTS OF THE PRESENT DAY?

One journalist who came to see Mother during Her visit to Calicut had the following conversation with Her:

Question: “Amma, religion and spirituality are supposed to guide people on the right path and give them peace of mind. Religious and spiritual people are the ones who have to act as catalysts in bringing harmony and integrity to society and among people, aren't they? But it seems that they are the ones who create a lot of confusion, conflict and a lack of integrity in society. Do you have any explanation for this?”

Mother: “Son, the problem does not lie in religion or spirituality. It lies within the human mind. The essential principles of all religions teach love, peace and harmony. The spiritual masters have never preached

selfishness, nor have they ever encouraged people to fight each other.

“The conflicts and problems of the present day, which exist in the name of religion, are due to the lack of proper understanding about religious principles.

“In this modern age, people live more from their minds than from their hearts. The mind is confusing. It is the dwelling place of selfishness and wickedness. The mind is the seat of all our doubts, and the intellect is the seat of the ego. When you dwell more in the mind and ego, you are concerned only about money, fame and power. You are not concerned about others; you are thinking only about yourself and your status. There are no feelings in your heart. The intellect makes you think, ‘I, and I alone.’ The mind will keep you busy with all kinds of doubts, suspicions and attachments. Without any faith, love or compassion, hell is created within you.

“The intellectuals interpret; the people believe in those distorted interpretations, and then they fight. This is what is happening in our society. In each religion there are intellectuals and there are minds who listen to them. The intellectuals interpret the teachings of the scriptures and the masters of their religions, and the unsuspecting people fall easy prey to their definitions of the truth, and end up fighting. The intellectuals become leaders and revered advisors. Their followers idealize them and worship them as God. In fact, God has been completely forgotten. The truth and the essential prin-

ciples of religion have been totally forgotten. The very purpose of religion and religious practices are being ignored.

“Unfortunately most religions are led by intellectuals. The heart alone can guide a person, but the heart has been forgotten. Only a true Master who dwells within the heart can throw light on the path of religion. Such a person alone can unite the people; he alone can make people understand the true import of religion and religious principles.

“No one who has any real understanding of true religion can blame religion and the true religious masters for the present day calamities that are happening in the name of religion. It is the fault of the intellectual interpreters and not their innocent followers. The entire responsibility goes to the pseudo religious teachers, the so-called torch bearers of religion, because they are misguiding people. They want to force their own ideas and evil visions onto others. They are full of their own ideas and interpretations and they want people to listen to them. Their egos crave attention, and because of their greed for recognition, these extremely selfish individuals have made innocent believers pray to them - to their egos.

Their innocent followers have full faith in their words, in their false interpretations. Of course, the ego is much more powerful than the mind. The mind is intrinsically weak. The ego has determination, whereas the mind is always doubting, vacillating and unsteady. The intellectual interpreters of almost all religions have the deter-

mination to convince people. Their enormous egos and their determination can easily overpower the weak minded followers of any religion. And thus they win their victory over innocent believers, who end up fighting for them.

“Such intellectuals have no faith, or love and compassion. Their mantra is money, power and prestige. Therefore, do not blame religion, spirituality or the true masters for the present day problems. There is nothing wrong with spirituality or religion. The problem lies in the human mind”

The journalist seemed stunned. He was silent for a while before he began to ask another question.

RELIGION AND SPIRITUALITY

Question: “Amma, are spirituality and religion two separate things, or are they one?”

Mother: “Spirituality is the real name of religion. Religion is the outside and spirituality is the inside. Religion can be compared to the outer skin of a fruit and spirituality then, is the real fruit - its essence. Spirituality is the true essence of religion; in fact, they are one and the same. You cannot differentiate between religion and spirituality, but it needs proper discrimination and understanding to penetrate the outer skin and dive deep into the true essence.

“People mistakenly believe that religion and spiritu-

ality are two separate entities. But religion and spirituality are as interdependent as body and soul. If viewed and evaluated with the mind and the intellect (ego), you will see it as two. Go a little deeper and you will find that they are one.

“If true religion and religious texts can be compared to the surface of the ocean, spirituality is like the pearls and priceless treasures that lie hidden deep beneath the waters. The real treasure lies deep within.

“The outside of religion, the religious texts and the scriptures, satisfies the intellect, whereas spirituality, which is the inside of religion, gives true happiness and peace of mind because it calms the mind. The search always begins on the outside, but it is bound to culminate on the inside of religion. Through the study of the *Vedas*, the *Upanishads* and other scriptures one may gain a certain amount of intellectual satisfaction. The ego is fed thereby and the mind continues to be turbulent and agitated. But this may cause us to slowly turn from outer religion towards internal religion. When the search on the outside of religion stops, we turn within, and that is spirituality. The outside can never give us complete happiness. One day or another, one has to turn within to the real source. Intellectual happiness can never make us truly happy. You may feel convinced for a moment, but again doubts, questions and reasoning will begin.

“Suppose you get a coconut. But, you have never seen one before. You have heard that it is a very healthy

food and that its milk is a wonderful thirst quencher. As you are holding the coconut you see that the outside looks so good and green. You take the outside for the real kernel and you start biting on it. But nothing happens. It's so hard that your gums start bleeding and your teeth ache. You are about to throw the coconut away, when a passerby notices your dilemma. Just when you are about to get rid of it he comes and tells you, 'No, no, don't throw it away! The kernel and the milk are inside. Open it and you will see it.' The man then walks away. Somehow you manage to open the outer shell of the coconut. Now you come upon a cluster of brown fibres and a hard shell. Mistaking the fibre for the kernel you try to chew on it. It is softer than the outside shell, but it tastes funny. The layer underneath is much harder; there is no sense in trying to bite into it. You spit out all the fibre and are about to throw away the coconut in utter desperation. At that moment another person comes up to you. This man has also been watching your struggle. He takes the coconut and opens it for you. You drink the sweet, refreshing water; you eat the kernel and feel fully satisfied. At last your thirst is quenched and your hunger is appeased.

"This is what has happened with spirituality and religion. You mistake the outside for the inside. But the outside is a part of the inside. They are inseparable. The outside is religion and the inside is spirituality. This can also be explained

in a different way. Just like the shining outside of a coconut, the human body looks beautiful. People mistake the body for the soul, the Atman, and being strongly attached to the body they focus all their attention on it. One has to go beyond the body to know the Self, one's true essence. But beyond the body exists the far more subtle and complicated mind. Due to their lack of proper understanding, people also believe that the mind is the Atman. To go beyond the mind and its confusing thoughts is much more difficult. Within the mind there exists an even harder shell, made up of the intellect and ego with its sense of 'I' and 'mine.' Only when that is transcended does one reach the kernel, the real Essence. Only a true Master can guide you to that innermost secret of life. Most people are either stuck in the body or in the mind and intellect (ego). Only when one penetrates and goes beyond these three layers can one reach the real abode of happiness, the essence of true religion that is spirituality.

"Just like the outside of a coconut, the outside of religion with all its visual splendor, can be very attractive and alluring. But you won't really get anything out of it, you may even be deluded by it. If you get too attached to the outside, it will only create more pain and more problems.

"Unfortunately, human beings do not have the proper eyes with which to see reality. They are far more attracted to the unreal than to the real, to the outside than to the inside. People are very attached to their own ideas

and do not relate to anything else. They live with their own understanding of what religion is, which is very far from true religion.

“Children, here is a story that Amma has heard:

“A group of tourists were travelling through the countryside, when their bus broke down. They were given some food to eat by the natives of the area. But the foreign dishes looked strange to them; they even suspected that the food might be spoiled, and although they were very hungry, they hesitated to eat. Just then, a dog came walking by. The tourists threw a portion of the food to the dog who quickly swallowed it. They studied the dog to see how it would react. But the dog seemed to enjoy the food and suffered no ill effects. The next morning they learned that the dog had died, which meant that the food must have been bad after all. The tourists were shocked. Within a short time many of them were taken seriously ill and suffered from symptoms of food poisoning. A doctor was found. When he was informed about the situation he began to make some inquiries about the whereabouts of the dead dog, intending to take a look at it to verify the cause of death. A person who lived in the area knew what had happened to the dog. He said to the doctor, ‘I threw the dog into a ditch, because it had been run over by a car.’

“The reality of religion is something far beyond people’s concept about it. The so-called intellectuals of

all religions have taught people about a religion that they themselves have created; a religion corresponding to their own ideas, which has little to do with true religion and its essential principles. They fool the people by making them follow only the external aspect of religion, and never the internal. If the internal oneness of religions were to be revealed, their own importance would be greatly diminished and they wouldn't be given any more attention. This is the reason why they highlight only the external differences. Otherwise their egos will starve, which would be unbearable to them. Also, since they, themselves, are stuck in their own intellects, they cannot assimilate the real principles of spirituality; and if they have not imbibed those principles, how can they teach anyone about spirituality?

“Once people come to understand the inner significance of religion, they will leave the false religious leaders. They will no longer seek their guidance, for they will know that only a person who has gone beyond the ego can truly guide them to the real goal of life.

“The essence of all religions of the world is spirituality. A religion without spiritual principles as its base is like an artificial fruit made of wax. Such a religion will be like an artificial limb, lacking any life or vitality. It is like the hollow skin of a fruit, containing no meat.

“Spirituality is the substratum on which all true religions exist. No religion can exist for long if it has no spiritual principles as its foundation. Such a religion would soon die.

“It is like Brahman, the Absolute, and the world of phenomena. The world cannot exist without Brahman, for Brahman is the substratum on which the world exists. But Brahman exists without the world. In a similar manner, religion cannot exist without spirituality. But spirituality exists without religion. It can also be compared to the body and soul (Atman). The soul is needed for the body to exist, but the soul exists without the body. Religion and spirituality are essentially one. If viewed from the right perspective and with the right understanding - they are not two.”

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CHAPTER SIX

MOTHER STOPS MANIFESTING KRISHNA BHAVA

 On October 18, 1983, Mother announced that She was going to stop giving Krishna Bhava. This decision created a lot of pain in the hearts of many Krishna devotees. Mother, of course, had Her own reasons for stopping. Mother said, “Amma is in a completely detached mood during Krishna Bhava. In that state Amma doesn’t feel any compassion, nor does She feel any lack of compassion. Everything is just a play of consciousness. Amma does not feel touched or affected by anything. But during Devi Bhava it is not like that at all. At that time, She is the Mother who cares deeply for all Her children. Amma feels nothing but love and compassion during Devi Bhava.”

Mother Herself has revealed several times that She is both the external and the internal Mother. The external Mother appears as the most compassionate and loving Mother, who cares deeply for Her children. But the inner Mother is beyond all such feelings - like infinite space. Mother says, “If Amma wants, She can remain in the state beyond, completely unaffected and unconcerned, but that wouldn’t help much to uplift

the suffering and society. This is why Amma chooses the aspect of being a loving and compassionate Mother.”

Mother’s decision to stop Krishna Bhava soon spread among the residents and devotees. It was shocking news to many of the devotees. Even though they experienced Her divinity both during the divine moods and at all other times, the devotees were very much attached to Amma’s Krishna and Devi Bhavas.

In the early days, Mother was very playful and mischievous during Krishna Bhava. She behaved just like Krishna, to the great delight of the devotees.

As far as a *Mahatma* is concerned the world is a delightful play. He is totally detached and unaffected by the diverse and contradictory nature of the world.

Why should there be such a play at all? Since the Lord is the sole ruler of all creation, one may wonder what, is the purpose of this play (*leela*) which He enacts?

Mother once said: “The play of the Supreme Lord has been created only for the sake of enjoying the play. He is the Supreme Ruler and omniscient Reality, but the play can only be a play when it is done without that authority, when the authority is forgotten. The moment you exercise your authority, you step out of the play, and it ceases to be a play.

“Another way to interpret this is that the world seems real only because of our attachment to it. Attachment to the world makes it seem real, while detachment makes

it a wondrous play. In the state of detachment there is no feeling of authority. Once you give up your attachment, you realize that everything is only a play and you can then join in.

Mother tells a story to explain this point.

“A little prince was playing with some children on the castle grounds. They were playing hide and seek. The prince was busy searching for his friends and was completely involved in the game, enjoying himself immensely. He couldn’t find anyone and he was running here and there, eagerly trying to find the others. A grown up caught hold of the prince and remarked, ‘Why are you going through so much trouble to find your friends? They would come to you immediately if you simply were to exercise your royal command and call them?’ The prince looked sympathetically at the grown up, as if the poor man were ill, and said, ‘But then there would be no game to play and it wouldn’t be fun anymore!’

“During Krishna Bhava, Amma is totally detached. In that state of detachment everything is a play. No authority is exercised during Krishna Bhava; whereas, in Devi Bhava, Amma does use Her authority and Her omnipotence to protect Her children.”

This playful mood of Amma’s during Krishna Bhava created an intense attachment to Amma as Krishna, even though She was surprisingly detached in that state.

One of the most fulfilling moments of Krishna Bhava was when Mother gave the devotees *prasad*, by letting

them drink *panchamritam*³ directly from the palm of Her hand, which She brought right up to their lips. Sometimes, when a devotee opened his or her mouth to receive the *prasad*, Mother would playfully withdraw Her hand. She would do this several times to certain people, especially if they were devotees of Krishna.

Sometimes one could see Mother, as Krishna, playfully tying a devotee's hands together, because he or she had committed some mistake which Mother knew everything about, without having been told a word about it. The person had perhaps been fighting with his wife, or disobeyed some of Mother's words or instructions. The devotee might have kept quiet about it, but Mother would catch him when he came for *darshan*.

Once, a young man stopped smoking as a result of having met Mother. But one day while in the company of his friends who were smokers, the devotee became tempted; the pull became so strong that he took just one puff. But he was so pricked by his conscience that he refrained from doing it again. During the next Krishna Bhava when he came up for *darshan*, Mother smiled at him with a look of mischief in Her eyes. She held Her middle and index fingers in such a way that it looked as if She were holding a cigarette, and She brought the imaginary cigarette right up to Her lips. The young man was embarrassed and took an oath in front of Mother,

³ A sweet dish, which is offered during worship, made of milk, bananas, clarified butter, brown sugar, sugar candy and honey.

promising that he would never smoke another cigarette.

On another occasion, Mother covered the mouth of Her paternal grandmother, Acchamma, with a piece of cloth because Acchamma was talking too much. Another time, Mother blind-folded a devotee and ordered him to walk round the temple three times, because he had been watching too many movies.

There was an old man who was very innocent, with whom Amma, as Krishna, used to sport mischievously. He was an ardent devotee of Sri Krishna and his faith in Mother was unshakable. Mother always enjoyed playing Her tricks on this childlike old man. He was in his seventies and his eyesight was so poor that without his glasses he couldn't see anything. Whenever he came up for *darshan*, Mother would remove his glasses, and when She did this he used to laugh and laugh until She gave them back to him. Having fixed his glasses on properly, he would move towards Mother to receive Her blessing. But, all of a sudden, Mother would again remove his glasses. Sometimes She did this several times, and the innocent old man just kept on laughing. At some point he would say, "O Krishna, what is this? How can I see You without my glasses?" Then he'd say, "Okay, You can have them. You can take these external glasses and cloud my vision as much as You like, but You can never escape from my mind's eye, or from my heart. You are imprisoned there forever."

Sometimes, during Krishna Bhava, when Mother would feed the old man with *panchamritam*, She continued to feed him without stopping. He would never say that he had had enough; he just kept on gulping it all down. Mother sometimes used to feed him very quickly without even giving him enough time to swallow. When Amma as Krishna saw that he was struggling and getting tired, She laughed sweetly. But it had to stop some time, and when Mother finally stopped feeding him, he protested innocently, “Why did You stop? I like it very much. I want more! Give it all to me!” And sometimes he would say, “Oh Krishna, do You know what? I love the sweetness of Your hand more than the sweetness of any *panchamritam*. That is why I can’t say no when You feed me. Sweet are Your hands, oh Lord.”

There is a Sanskrit song, *Adharam Madhuram* (*Madhurashtakam*), glorifying Krishna which the old man used to sing when he came up to Mother for *darshan*.

*Your lips are so sweet
 Your face is sweet
 Your eyes are sweet
 and Your smile is sweet
 Your heart is sweet
 and sweet is the way that You walk;
 O Lord of Mathura
 Your whole being is utterly sweet.*

*Your words are sweet
and Your stories are sweet
also sweet are the clothes that You wear
Your every movement is sweet;
O Lord of Vrindavan
Your whole being is utterly sweet.*

*Your flute is so sweet
and Your hands are sweet
and sweet is the dust of Your feet
Your legs are sweet
The way You dance is sweet
Your friendship is sweet;
O Lord of Mathura
Your whole being is utterly sweet.*

At the end of each Krishna Bhava, when Mother was dancing blissfully, the brahmacharins and the devotees used to sing the following *bhajans*: *Krishna Krishna Radhe Krishna, Govinda Gopala Venukrishna, Mohana Krishna Manamohana Krishna, Murare Krishna Mukunda Krishna, Radhe Govinda Gopi, and Shyama Sundara.*

Mother's divine mood as Krishna was utterly sweet and enchanting. At the end of Krishna Bhava, She would come to the entrance of the temple, where She stood for a long time, looking at the devotees and smiling at them. And as She stood there, the brahmacharins sang Krishna *bhajans* at a high, fervent tempo. Mother then slowly came out of the temple to the veranda. She raised both Her arms up high, and with Her hands held in divine *mudras* (gestures), She began to dance.

This blissful, ecstatic dance, which was always performed in a gentle, meditative way, invoked a great amount of love and devotion in those who witnessed it. It transported the devotees back to Vrindavan, where Lord Krishna used to sport with the *gopis* and *gopas*. Exactly the same atmosphere and the same vibrations were created by Mother, here, in this small fishing village, for the benefit of the devotees.

The devotees were very attached to Mother's Krishna Bhava, because it was the first Divine Mood that She ever manifested. There were so many memories of Krishna Bhava and the devotees found it difficult to let go. They were in great pain and their agony could clearly be seen reflected in their eyes and movements.

Wherever one went within the Ashram one could hear people talking about their experiences during Krishna Bhava. The innocent old man, who was mentioned earlier, had many wonderful stories to tell. He was constantly recalling how Krishna Bhava began and about the days when Mother used to give Bhava *darshan* on the seashore. He talked about all the great hardships that they had to undergo during that first period.

The devotees were so upset that on Bhava *darshan* days, most of them would burst into tears, first on Krishna's shoulder during Krishna Bhava⁴ and then later

⁴ Mother would always stand during Krishna Bhava, with one foot on a small *peetham* (sacred stool).

on Devi's lap. They prayed to Mother, pleading with Her not to stop the Krishna Bhava. This is why She finally agreed to appear as Krishna once a month. Because of Her infinite compassion towards Her devotees, She could not deny their prayers so easily. But finally, Mother stopped manifesting Krishna Bhava altogether. However, this happened only when Her devotees had gained a much greater spiritual understanding, which allowed them to see that Mother is always the same, whether She is in Krishna Bhava or Devi Bhava. The greater dimension of Her infinite nature was slowly being revealed to Her devotees.

One devotee who was very attached to Mother's Krishna Bhava was telling Br. Balu about one of his experiences. "You know, every evening I place a glass of warm milk in front of a picture of Mother in Krishna Bhava. One day, my wife and I were in such a hurry to leave for the Bhava *darshan* that we didn't have time to cool the milk after it had boiled. It was time for the bus to leave for Vallickavu, so I placed the boiling hot milk in front of the picture in the family shrine room and rushed to the bus stop. The Krishna Bhava had begun when we arrived at the Ashram. My wife and I went up to Mother, who was in the divine mood of Krishna. Like a small, mischievous child, Krishna looked at us and smilingly exclaimed, 'Look! My lips were burnt from drinking the hot milk!' Believe me, a burn mark could actually be seen on Mother's lips!" As the devotee recalled this, tears were streaming

down his cheeks. His voice became choked and he couldn't speak anymore due to the uncontrollable emotion that came over him.

A situation similar to that of Krishna leaving Vrindavan was now being created in Mother's Ashram. But, as Mother puts it, "Sometimes this is Krishna and at other times this is Devi. But both Krishna and Devi are always here within this crazy girl." There is a profound teaching hidden in this statement. Since Mother, who in reality is both Krishna and Devi, is living here among us, why should there be any reason to worry? Mother's different aspects, or forms, are not different isolated entities; they are all manifestations of the same Universal Reality. And that one Supreme Reality that is Mother, from whom all forms emerge, is here to protect and to guide us. Therefore there is no point in worrying.

But the despair and the deep sense of loss experienced by the devotees, didn't last for long, because their attachment to Mother was far more deeply rooted than any other consideration.

Over and above all, Mother Herself revealed to everyone that She is one with all these different aspects of the Divine, and that She can manifest any one of them, by Her mere will, at any time She wishes. For instance one day, a few months after Mother had started giving Krishna Bhava only once a month, Mother, Nealu, Balu, Venu and Gayatri were sitting in Nealu's hut. Mother

and Nealu were having a conversation, when Nealu suddenly said, “Amma, You are everything to me. You are Krishna, Devi and all the other aspects of the Divine. I know that You are Krishna, and also Radha and Devi. You are verily the embodiment of Brahman. But I still sometimes have an intense thirst to see you in Krishna Bhava.”

Mother gave Nealu a mischievous smile and asked, “Nealumon (Nealu my son), do you really want to see Mother in Krishna Bhava?”

“Yes, very much!” replied Nealu. Without another word, Mother took hold of Nealu’s cotton shawl and tied it around Her head. Turning around to Nealu, She said, “Look!” Those present were amazed to see Mother sitting there, looking exactly as She would during Krishna Bhava. The way She held Her hands in sacred *mudras* and all Her facial expressions - the sparkling eyes and the way She smiled⁵ - all were exactly the same. The brahmacharins and Gayatri spontaneously prostrated before Her. But the divine revelation lasted for only a few seconds, and Mother resumed her conversation with Nealu.

Once, Br. Pai wanted a certain image of Mother that he had a special love for. He had a few photographs of Mother, including ones of Her as Devi and Krishna, and of course he liked them all, but this spe-

⁵ During Krishna Bhava, Mother used to smile with a peculiar downward bent of Her lips, which was very attractive.

cial image, which had yet to be photographed, was a picture of Mother sitting in a certain posture. It was the image of Her on which he meditated. He had an intense wish to have a photo of Mother, sitting in exactly that posture on the Devi Bhava *peetham*, but in Her ordinary white clothes and with Her hair tied up, without the crown. He also wanted Mother to display the classical *abhaya mudra* of protection and blessing.⁶ But how could he ask Mother to sit in a particular pose in order to take a snap shot? He did not open his heart to anyone about this.

One day, Pai couldn't bear it anymore. He felt very sad about this matter and wept for a long time. Suddenly Mother came walking towards him. She smiled at him and said, "Son, Amma knows your desire. Don't worry, Amma will fulfill it." She told Pai to follow Her and went into the temple. Mother seated Herself on the Devi Bhava *peetham* exactly in the same posture that Pai had visualized. But the moment Mother sat down on the *peetham*, Her mood changed. She became exactly like Devi, expressing all the divine signs that She would normally manifest during Devi Bhava. Br. Srikumar took the photograph and Pai's long cherished dream was fulfilled. The most important point to remember here is Mother's power to manifest both

⁶ In this *mudra* both palms are open, facing outward with the fingers held together. The right hand is held at the shoulder and the left hand is pointing downward towards the hip.

Krishna and Devi, or any divine mood, at any time She wills. It is not something that is limited to a certain time or place. Whenever and wherever She chooses to be in that mood, that is the right time and place for it.

In the early days, the few brahmacharins who were staying at the Ashram used to chant the *Sri Lalita Sahasranama*, the thousand names of Devi, with Mother seated on a special *peetham* for that purpose. But sometimes Mother preferred to sit on the Devi Bhava *peetham*. There were many occasions when Mother fulfilled the brahmacharins' wishes and even wore the Devi Bhava costume, including the crown, during this special chanting of the thousand names. The brahmacharins would sit in a semicircle in front of Mother and perform the worship, which took one and a half to two hours to complete. Throughout this time Mother would be deeply absorbed in *samadhi*. Her appearance was then exactly the same as in Devi Bhava. There were occasions when Mother remained in *samadhi* even after the chanting and worship were over.

There were countless occasions when Mother clearly revealed Her oneness with the Divine, or when She spoke openly about it. These revelations, coupled with some profound experiences which gave the brahmacharins and devotees a deeper insight into Mother's real nature, helped them to gain more spiritual maturity and understanding.

The last regular Krishna Bhava *darshan* was an un-

forgettable night. The devotees, one after the other, burst into tears on Krishna's shoulder. Only Krishna *bhajans* were sung that night, and finally when the brahma-charins ran out of Krishna *bhajans*, they chose songs about Devi, songs that were poignant with longing, and converted them into Krishna *bhajans*. Br. Venu was in tears throughout the entire Krishna Bhava. Finding himself unable to sing, he got up and went inside the temple. Mother let him sit close by Her side.

One of the songs they chose to sing that night will give the reader an idea about the mental agony that the devotees were going through. It was *Povukayayo Kanna...*

*O Kanna, are You leaving?
I have been abandoned
by everyone in this world
Are You also forsaking me?*

*O Kanna
I want to keep You
as a blue jewel
in the chamber of my heart
and worship You there
each day.*

*O Kanna
let me gather the pearls of Love
from the depths of the blue ocean
that is Your form.*

*And when You come to me
in the guise of a blissful bird
the mournful bird of my life
will long to merge with You
O Kanna.*

The regular manifestation of Mother's Krishna Bhava ended that night. However, as has already been mentioned, for the sake of Her devotees, Mother continued to appear as Krishna once a month, until November 1985 when the last Krishna Bhava took place.

Let us close this chapter by recalling a few of Mother's words:

"Devotees call this 'Krishna,' 'Devi,' 'Shiva,' 'Mother,' or 'Guru,' according to their faith. Amma is none of these, and at the same time She is everything. But She is also beyond. The entire universe exists as a small bubble within Her."

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CHAPTER SEVEN

A devotee, who lived four kilometers south of the Ashram, had invited Mother to his home, and Mother had promised him that She would come.

This evening, at about ten o'clock, after the evening *bhajans*, Mother, along with a few brahmacharins (Balu, Srikumar, Pai, Venu and Rao), Damayanti-amma, Harshan, Satheesh and two other ladies from the neighborhood, set out walking along the ocean, towards the devotee's house. It was a beautiful night. The full moon shone in the sky, and in the moonlight the Arabian Sea glittered, its waves reverberating with the sacred sound, "Aum". Now and then the clouds would cover the moon for a few seconds and it would suddenly become dark. But soon again, the face of the earth would be lit up by the moon's milky light.

The party moved slowly southwards with the sea to their right. At the beginning of the journey no one spoke as they walked. When they had gone about half a kilometer, Mother suddenly went up to the edge of the water where the waves washed the shore. She stood there gazing towards the western horizon, while the waves washed Her sacred feet, over and over again, as

if they wanted to do it as many times as they could before She continued on Her way.

AS VAST AND DEEP AS THE OCEAN

As Mother was standing there, a few words slipped from Her lips. She said, “The ocean is vast and expansive, but it is also deep. You can see and experience the vastness to some extent, whereas its depth is invisible and beyond your normal vision. To know it you have to dive in. But to take that deep plunge you need self-surrender, courage and an adventurous mind.”

Mother was silent after this, and they continued walking towards the South. Along the way one of the brahmacharins asked Mother a question. “Amma,” he said, “what did You mean by what You said when You were standing at the edge of the water?”

Mother answered and said, “Children, you can experience a *Mahatma*’s love, compassion, self-sacrifice and other godly qualities. You can experience these qualities on a large scale in the presence of a Great Soul. It can be compared to seeing the vastness of the ocean. You can see the vastness to a certain extent, but you cannot see all of it. You may get a glimpse of it, an infinitesimal portion of it, but it is nothing. Viewing the ocean from the shore is nothing. But although you are actually seeing just a tiny bit of it, it allows you to grasp the fact that the ocean is immeasurably vast.

“The ocean is deep and vast. The depth is within and the vastness without. The love and compassion of a *Mahatma* that we experience can be compared to the vastness of the ocean. The *Mahatma's* love and compassion is an external manifestation which gives us a tangible experience of that which lies within. But, we do not know how to be completely open like children, and because of this, the experience of infinite love and compassion showered upon us by a *Mahatma* is only partially felt by us. We are only able to experience a fraction of his or her divine qualities. But that which lies within, that immeasurable depth, is like the depth of the ocean. It is not visible to us. To experience that depth one has to penetrate the surface and go beyond. One should see beyond the love which is manifested outwardly.

BOW DOWN AND KNOW THE DEPTH

“The outer form (of a *Mahatma*) is certainly beautiful and spectacular, and outer association is relatively easy, whereas inner contact is not that easy. It can be compared to swimming and diving. Swimming on the surface of the ocean is a pleasant and joyful experience. But diving can be a far greater experience. It is an adventure. As you dive in, you are entering an entirely different world of experience. You are going to explore the unknown and mysterious realms of the ocean. But it needs

a greater effort than just swimming on the surface. You have to hold your breath and bow down before the ocean as you go beneath the waters. The swimmer thus surrenders to the ocean. And when you surrender, the ocean reveals its hidden treasures to you. Until now you have only seen the beautiful surface; you never thought that there could be far more beautiful areas yet to be explored. As you dive deeper and deeper, you find that you want to see more and more, you want to experience more of its depths. You will feel an unquenchable thirst for knowledge. And so, you dive deeper and deeper until you reach the very ground of the ocean.

“In a similar manner, a *Mahatma*’s external expressions of love and compassion are extraordinarily beautiful. It is incomparable. There is nothing like it on the face of the earth. But even more so, the beauty of his inner Self is utterly beyond words. In order to experience that hidden beauty, the beauty of unfathomable depths, one has to go beyond the body of the *Mahatma*. One has to go beyond the surface expressions of love and compassion. To reach that which is inexpressible, one has to go beyond all forms of expression. To be able to penetrate the surface and go beyond the external form of the *Mahatma*, one needs to bow down and surrender to him with complete humility. It is like taking a deep plunge into the ocean. Once you completely surrender, the *Mahatma* will reveal his inner nature to you.

“The love of a *Mahatma* is beyond words. The love that you see and experience outwardly is of course deep and intense, but that depth and intensity is only an infinitesimal fraction of what he or she really is. And that is infinite. When something is infinite, you can speak or write about it endlessly without ever coming to a satisfactory explanation, because it has no limit. It is vaster than the universe.

“Being an embodiment of love and compassion, the *Mahatma* is as patient as the earth. But it can also be said that the anger of a *Mahatma* has exactly the same depth as the love, compassion and patience that he or she expresses.”

Mother stopped talking. The time was almost eleven p.m. Some fishermen were still wandering on the seashore, others were lying here and there, sleeping on the sand. In the moonlight one could see a group of fishermen sitting on the beach, talking and gossiping. During the moments when the clouds covered the moon, it was possible to discern only the burning ends of their beedies.⁷ Some of those who were roaming about came nearer to take a closer look at the small group of people walking along the ocean at this late hour. When they recognized familiar faces, they left without saying anything.

One person who came to look at them happened to be a devotee. When he discovered that it was Mother and the

⁷ Inexpensive Indian cigarettes rolled in a leaf, commonly used by the poor.

brahmacharins, he became very excited. “Oh! Is it you, Ammachi?” He exclaimed. “Where are you going at this time of the night?” The man called out to his wife and children, “Come here! Come and see who it is!” His wife and their three daughters appeared in no time. They were all very excited to see Mother and the others. They invited Mother to their hut. Politely and lovingly Mother declined the invitation, saying, “Children, Amma is already late. We were walking too slowly since we were talking about spiritual matters, and in between, we spent some time just standing on the beach. Amma is sorry. She will come another time.” The man gave his wife a mild scolding for inviting Mother in such an odd manner. He said, “What is this? Is this the way to invite Ammachi to our home? Even though Ammachi is very unassuming in Her manners, we should invite Her in the traditional way, and not as if we were inviting a friend or a neighbor.”

The woman was embarrassed and said in a defensive tone, “I am uneducated and illiterate. I don’t know any traditions. Ammachi knows this and She will surely forgive me if I have committed a mistake.”

Mother turned to the husband and said, “Son, it’s okay. Where there is true love, there is no need of *acharas* (customary observances). Her invitation was innocent. **There is no greater *achara* than love.**”

Mother turned to the woman and gave her a hug, saying, “Daughter, don’t worry. Take it easy. Amma

will visit your home when She has time. But today, Amma won't be able to come."

Mother did not forget to also express Her love towards their daughters. She was about to leave when the man called out, "Ammachi, may I come with you?"

Mother said to him, "Yes, son, of course you may come." Without even changing into a clean dhoti, he began to follow Mother.

Mother and the group continued on their way, accompanied by the surging drone of the ocean and a cool wind blowing from the West. Mother was gazing at the ocean as She walked. The sea was glowing dark and blue in the moonlight.

LIKE THE PRALAYAGNI (THE FIRE OF DISSOLUTION)

As they were walking, another question was asked:

"Amma, you stated that the *Mahatma's* anger has the same depth as his patience, and his love and compassion. What do you mean by that?"

Mother continued to gaze towards the ocean for some time before She answered.

"Children, *Pralayagni*, the fire of dissolution - that is what the anger of a *Mahatma* is like. It is as fierce as the final dissolution. A *Mahatma* is one with infinity, so even his anger is of an infinite dimension. You cannot imagine its intensity. It has the power to destroy the

whole world. It is like dropping countless nuclear bombs simultaneously. Its flames can consume the entire world.

“When the Mother of the Universe, the embodiment of love and compassion, who loves and cares for the entire creation, got angry, She became Kali, and Her anger was as fierce as *Pralayagni*, the fire of dissolution. The entire universe would have been burned into a handful of ashes, if the celestial beings had not intervened.

“When the Universal Mother becomes angry, it is a dazzling sight - like billions of suns ablaze at the same time. Who could bear such a thing? Only one who is egoless and who has completely surrendered can bear it. The infinite power of Kali’s anger can only be born by one who has gone beyond body-consciousness. In other words, only consciousness in its pure, motionless form can bear it. The anger of the Universal Mother is a violent tempest of consciousness, so to speak. It can only be counterbalanced by an energy that is perfectly motionless; and that is Shiva lying prostrate, while Kali dances out all Her fury on top of Him.

“Kali’s rage is *rajas* in its extreme state. It is the explosion of the cosmic energy with all its power and glory. It is like the explosion of a hundred thousand atom bombs. But even this analogy is insufficient. The explosion of this energy can only be counter balanced by pure *sattvic* energy, and that is Shiva.

“Recall how fierce Sri Rama became when the ocean

would not yield to His prayers. In order to please the ocean, so that He could build a bridge across it, Sri Rama sat down on the seashore and performed severe austerities continuously for three days. He wanted to cross the ocean and reach Lanka, the abode of Ravana who had kidnapped Sita, Rama's holy consort. His intention was to rescue Sita with the help of the monkey army, led by Hanuman and Sugreeva. But the ocean would not yield. It continued raising gigantic waves and became more turbulent than ever.

"Sri Rama was the Supreme Lord Himself, the Master of all creation. He did not have to be humble towards any one of His creatures, and there was no need for Him to be so humble towards the ocean. But He acted with humility because He wanted to set an example. However, the great epic, the *Ramayana*, says that when He did this the ocean became proud, and this made Sri Rama terribly angry, that is, he commanded anger to come. Taking His great bow and stringing an arrow to it, the Lord in His fierce form stood up and said, 'I have tried to be humble and patient, obeying the set laws of Nature. But do not consider it to be a weakness on my part. With this single arrow I can dry up your entire waters and destroy every living creature within you. Should I do this, or are you going to yield?' And the ocean yielded by subsiding its waves.

"Sri Rama was the personification of supreme patience and forgiveness. He had even forgiven Kaikeyi,

His stepmother, who had been extremely cruel towards Him. But when He now became angry, His anger was as deep as His patience. The *Ramayana* says that when Rama stood with the bow and arrow in His hands, ready to charge at the ocean, He looked like the God of Death, the fire of final dissolution.”

THE HIGHEST PEAK OF HUMAN EXISTENCE

Mother continued, “Self-Realization is the highest peak of human existence. It is the final point of concentration (one-pointedness). There is no point beyond that. The depth and energy of such concentration is indescribably piercing. The Self-Realized soul has used that power of concentration to penetrate into the deepest mystery of the universe, the mystery of Brahman. In that supreme state of Self-Realization he has become an adept in concentration, and with his absolute one-pointedness he can concentrate and direct his energies wherever and whenever he wishes. A true Master will never use his power for any destructive purpose. He always uses it for the good of the world and for the uplift of society. But remember that he can also use it to teach the entire human race a lesson. A Self-Realized Master is one with the Cosmic Energy, and that energy is infinite. He can release it or hold it or do whatever he wishes with it. He can choose to release

either positive or negative energy. But even if he should release it in a seemingly negative way, it is only for the good of the world; it is done only for the sake of teaching someone a lesson.

“So, whether that energy is released positively or negatively, it will have its intended effect. Either way, its power will be infinite, beyond words. Just as the divine love and compassion of a *Mahatma* is beyond words, his anger is also beyond words. There is no way to measure the depths of a *Mahatma*.”

Mother’s words remind one of a song, *Ananta Srishti Vahini*, written by one of Her devotees about Mother’s infinite moods.

*Salutations to You
O Great Divine Goddess
the Support of all creation
who has infinite states of Being
and is eternally dancing
the Supreme Dance.*

*Salutations to You
O Ever-Effulgent One
Mother of Immortal Bliss
who unceasingly breaks the silence
of the dead of night.*

*Prostrations to You,
O Bhadrakali,
the fierce form of Devi,*

*the cause of all that is auspicious,
who permeates all consciousness,
who is full of compassion.*

*You are the One who dissolves
the individual.*

Prostrations to You

whose form is like a triangle⁸

who had three eyes,

who carries the trident

and wears a garland of skulls.

O Bhairavi,

You bestow good fortune

and live in the cremation grounds.

Prostrations to You

O Chandika

ever-increasing

fierce and effulgent

infinitely strong

who swings Her sword,

making the sound "Jhana, Jhana."

Prostrations to You

O Goddess Chandika

who is full of radiance.

You are Shankari

and Your Power is infinite.

You are the giver of all yogas

and of immortality.

⁸ Referring to the triangles in the Sri Chakra *yantra*.

Mother and the group reached the house at eleven-fifteen. The whole family was eagerly awaiting Mother's arrival, and they were overjoyed when She arrived. The head of the family, along with his wife, received Mother with the traditional *pada puja* (washing of the sacred feet) and *arati* (the offering of light), after which they all prostrated at Mother's feet. Mother expressed Her love and affection to everyone in the family in Her usual manner, and there was real joy among them. The youngest child, a boy who was barely four years old, was dancing gleefully saying loudly, "Amma has come! Oh, Amma has come to our house!" Mother called the boy to come to Her and She showered him with kisses. Having received Her kisses he looked even more joyful.

The worship started at midnight and was completed by two in the morning. After the *puja*, Mother went outside and sat in the backyard looking out across the ocean. There was deep silence everywhere except for the sound of the ocean, chanting its eternal hymn. Mother, in Her white sari, sat swaying gently back and forth in the moonlight.

As Mother was sitting there, the whole family and the group from the Ashram came out and sat at a slight distance, from where they could see Mother. No one wanted to sit very close to Her, for they all knew that Mother was revelling in Her own world of Aloneness.

THE COMPASSIONATE MOTHER

The return journey started at two-thirty in the morning. There wasn't much talk during the walk back, but Mother sang a few *bhajans*.

When they reached the home of the devotee who had accompanied them from the beach, he stepped forward to take leave of Mother. To his great surprise Mother turned towards his house and said, "Amma is coming with you." The man was dumbfounded for a second and stood frozen like a statue. He almost shouted in excitement as he said, "What! Are You coming to my house!" Soon he could be seen running at full speed towards his house. He pounded on the door, calling out his wife's and children's names. He was all in a flurry and did not know what to do. He ran hither and thither in front of his home calling his wife and children, again and again. Within a few seconds the whole family were wide awake. They were completely startled. They could not understand why he was making so much noise at this odd hour of the night. The wife shot several questions at her husband, all in one breath. "What has happened to you! Why are you shouting like this? Didn't you go with Ammachi?" A neighbor had also been awakened by all the commotion. He called out from the veranda of his house, "My friends, what is going on? Do you want me to come over?"

By this time Mother had reached the front yard.

The devotee's wife stood staring with her mouth wide open when she noticed Mother standing, smiling in front of her. The children were also stunned. At first, the woman could not speak. A moment later she burst into tears and fell on Mother's shoulder. The man was already lying prostrate at Her feet, weeping like a child. Mother raised the man and lay his head on Her other shoulder. His wife managed to say through her tears, "Am I dreaming, Ammachi? O God, what *leela* (play) is this! You should have told me that You were going to visit us on your way back. I would have prepared everything and waited for You! Now, there is nothing in the house. The oil lamp hasn't even been lit! O Amma, why are You playing this *leela* with us?"

The woman cried uncontrollably. Mother tried to console her saying, "Daughter, Amma is not a guest. She is your Mother. There is no need of any elaborate preparations to receive Her. Your love for Her is more than enough, there is nothing to worry about. Whatever you offer with your own hands is like ambrosia to Amma. Don't cry!" But the innocent woman couldn't stop crying. Finally, Mother took the initiative and walked into the house with Her arms around the woman.

It was a hut with two small rooms and a tiny kitchen. Mother went straight into the kitchen followed by the woman, her husband and their three daughters, while the others waited outside. Mother searched through the kitchen; She looked inside the pots and pans, but every-

thing was empty. And as Mother was searching, the woman kept saying, “What a pity! There is nothing to eat in the house!” At last Mother found a tapioca root lying in a corner. “Ah, this will be more than enough!” She said and picked it up. Mother bit into the root as She walked out of the kitchen.

It so happened that Harshan had been carrying a bag with fried edibles from the other house which they had visited. Mother took some of that food and began to feed the family with Her own hands. Their joy and gratitude knew no bounds. With tears in her eyes, the woman began to sing a few lines from a *bhajan*, *Ammayalle Entammayalle*, and soon the whole family joined in.

*Aren't You my Mother?
O, aren't You my dear Mother
who wipes away my tears?*

*O Mother of the fourteen worlds
the Creatrix of the world
I have been calling You endlessly!
O Shakti!
Won't You come?*

*O You, who loves to give us
all that we desire
who contains within Yourself
creation, preservation and destruction,
I have been calling You endlessly!*

*O Father and Mother,
the five different elements
and all the Earth,
I have been calling You endlessly!*

*The Vedas and the scriptures
true Knowledge and Vedanta
the beginning, the middle and the end
all exist within You.
I have been calling You endlessly!*

After spending a few more minutes with the family,
Mother returned to the Ashram.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

LEARN TO CONQUER BOREDOM

A visiting devotee, known for his questioning nature, asked Mother, “Amma, the majority of people usually get bored when they do the same work, the same thing, day in and day out. That is why people want to change their lives; they want to try a new job, buy different things, etc. But Amma, You are doing the same thing every single day, receiving people and giving them *darshan*. Don’t You ever feel bored with the same routine, over and over again?”

Mother: “Son, boredom happens only to human beings, not to God. God never gets bored. A *Mahatma* is God Himself, in a human form, who is ever established in the Absolute Brahman. He constantly experiences a sense of wonder and freshness in his outlook and in all his actions. He is the Immanent Consciousness which shines in and through everything. Therefore he cannot be bored.

“Boredom and dryness come only when you have a feeling of duality, the attitude of ‘I’ and ‘you,’ when you believe that you are a separate entity. If you are everything, how can you be bored? Oneness with the entire universe eliminates any such feelings. When you

are content within your own Self, boredom automatically disappears.

“A *Mahatma* is like a lake filled with pure, crystal clear water, with a bottom made of solid rock, from which a never ending spring gushes forth. The substratum is firm and immovable, and at the same time it is constantly producing pure, clean water. The spring of water is unending, it will never dry up. It is eternally full, and it allows everyone to drink from it.

“A *Mahatma* knows that he is the changeless and indestructible Atman, or Brahman, the Substratum of the entire universe, and this knowledge makes him firm and immovable within. He is also a never-ending source of love and compassion.

“When your existence is rooted in pure love, how can you ever be bored? Boredom comes only when you do not love. There is no sense of separation in true love. Love just flows. Whoever is willing to take the plunge and dive in, will be accepted as they are. There are no terms or conditions. If you are willing to take the dip you will be accepted. If you are not willing, what can it do? The stream remains where it is. It never says no. It is constantly saying yes, yes, yes...

SAY ‘YES’ TO LIFE

“To accept is to say yes to everything. Everything may go wrong in your life, but still, you find yourself

saying, 'Yes, I accept.' The river says yes to everyone. All of Nature say yes, except human beings. A human being can say both yes and no. Sometimes he says yes, but mostly he says no. He doesn't see life as a gift; he sees it as a right, and he also considers happiness to be a right. When you see life, and all that life brings you, as a precious gift, you will be able to say yes to everything. If, on the other hand, you insist on seeing it as a right, then you cannot say yes - you can only say no. That is where everything goes wrong. If you always say no to life, to all the experiences that life brings you, you will be miserable and you will get bored. But if you learn to always say yes, if you can see life and each experience as a gift, and not as a right, you will never be conquered by boredom.

"When you are full of love and compassion, you cannot say no to anything, you can only say yes. Amma can only say yes. She never says no, and therefore, She doesn't get bored. 'Yes' is acceptance. Only when there is acceptance is there no boredom.

"The word 'no' exists only where duality exists. When you say no to life you feel unhappy and discontented. You will protest about everything and you cannot be happy with yourself. You always feel insignificant and unsatisfied. Why is this? Because you are always wanting. You want money, fame, a new house, a new car, the list goes on and on. Thus you become unhappy, you get bored and life becomes dry. You become a constant

complainer who isn't satisfied with anything. Why? Because you insist on constantly saying no. Due to your lack of acceptance, you are unable to say yes to whatever life provides you with.

"People are always chasing after things. That is why, in spite of all their education and intellectual knowledge, people are still unhappy and they still feel inadequate. Even the wealthiest people are unhappy. They still get easily bored and are plagued by numerous desires, because they are dissatisfied and feel that they have yet to become complete.

"Life is a precious gift. But we don't use our discrimination to choose what is right. We choose the wrong things and then we end up feeling unhappy. So the problem lies within ourselves. It is our wrong attitude that brings us discontentment and boredom. We give too much importance to that which is only secondary, while the most important, primary things are completely ignored."

Mother then proceeded to tell a story to clarify this point.

"A person was suffering from two different ailments. His eyes were troubling him and he also had digestive problems. He went to a doctor, who gave him some eye drops and some medicine for his stomach. He was to put a few drops of the eye medicine in his eyes and to take several spoons of the stomach medicine for his indigestion. But unfortunately, in his excitement the patient confused the doctor's instructions. He went home and

drank a dose of the eye drops and poured stomach medicine into his eyes, with the result that both his problems became more aggravated.

“Likewise, there is great confusion with regard to our own lives. We need to give far more importance to the soul, to the realization of the Self, so that we can lead truly contented, blissful lives. And we ought to give far less importance to the body. But we are doing it the other way around; we are mixing up the two containers, taking the wrong medicine for the wrong ailment. All the energy, care and attention that we are meant to direct towards the soul, are being given to the body instead, as we concentrate on making the body as beautiful and comfortable as possible. But the soul is barely given a drop of our attention and is left to its own fate. In our state of confusion we have lost our sense of perspective, with the result that we think and act in a negative way, and we feel bored and very discontented.

“When you are established in the Self you are in an incessantly giving mood. You cannot feel bored when you constantly want to give, when you do not want anything from anyone. Amma just wants to give. She doesn’t need anything from anyone, and She doesn’t expect anything. Amma simply accepts everything that happens in her life. It is because of this that Amma never gets bored.

“Only when the feeling of being separate disappears can you become a person who gives incessantly.

All sense of duality should go, which means that the mind should go. Only then can you become a true giver who doesn't need to take or receive anything. Boredom comes only from being selfish and self-centered. When you are centered in the Atman, when your center shifts from the self to the Self, and you have no other center, that is when you are completely free from getting bored.

“Radha's love for Sri Krishna never died, and Mira's love for her beloved Giridhar never died either. Neither one of them ever expected anything in return for their love. They were both great givers, and they were never bored - only blissful and content. Whatever they received, whether good or bad, was appreciated and accepted wholeheartedly. This is why they are still living in the hearts of people. And they became immortal because they gave up everything. You only truly begin to live when you die to your ego - to your mind. Radha and Mira were dead to their egos. Mira said, 'O, my Giridhar, it is okay if you do not love me. But my Lord, don't ever take away my right to love You.' This was her attitude. Radha and Mira were completely selfless. Their love was pure, untainted by the ego and selfish thoughts.

“When you live as an ego, obeying your mind, acting according to its whims and fancies, you are not yourself - you are the mind. It is a form of insanity. It is as if you were dead, because you are living as a mere body and mind, without being aware of your real existence

as the Self. If you believe that you are the body, you are leading a life of illusion. Isn't it madness to consider the unreal to be real, to superimpose upon reality that which does not belong to it? As long as you live in the mind, you will continue to be bored.

“The burden and constant noise of your mind is a heavy load to carry. It has become an enormous load, enough to overwhelm you. The pitiful thing about this is that you who are carrying this load are not aware of its terrible weight.

“Thinking that your boredom is caused by external situations and by other people, you run from one place to another, you try out as many things as possible, until you finally collapse. Don't you want to unload the burden of your mind, to feel free and at peace? ‘Yes, I would like to,’ is the answer of most people. But they do not want to release their grip on that to which they are holding. They think that if they let go, they will become vulnerable and insecure.

“Even a small child has this feeling. If a child is not with its mother or father, it will feel very insecure. Children always walk around holding onto one end of their mother's sari or their father's shirt. This makes them feel secure and protected. But, it won't last for long, because the source of security will shift. As the child grows, the feeling of insecurity will also grow, and he discovers that being with his parents is not real security. He will even begin to feel that his parents are an obstacle to his freedom. He will soon begin to feel that

there is something or somebody else that can provide him with more contentment than his parents or his home or the city where he lives. Discontentment and boredom go hand in hand. You become bored with your parents, so you want to be away from them. You feel bored in your home and in your city, so you want to live somewhere else. You are bored with your old car, so you want a new one, you are bored with your old girlfriend, so you want a different one. In your search for security and contentment, you constantly embrace insecurity. But you never find that contentment. You just continue to come face to face with your insecurity and discontentment.

“It is your mind that is insecure. It is your mind that creates your boredom and your fears, and is the cause of all your problems. Get rid of the mind rather than trying to replace one object or place with another. Rid yourself of the mind, and you will become a new person with a fresh, ever new outlook on life. As long as you carry the mind with you, you will remain the same old person endowed with the same fears, insecurity, boredom and discontentment.

“Real security in life can be found only in the Self (Atman), or God. And the only way to get rid of your boredom is to surrender to your own Self, to God, or to a perfect Master. Be a witness to everything that happens in life. You are the eternal *Purusha*. You are *Purnam* (Perfection). You are the Whole, and not a limited

individual. Remove all your feelings of sorrow, boredom, and discontentment. Be blissful and content.”

When the conversation ended, no one felt like saying anything. The explanation which Mother had just given was so beautiful and revealing, that if anyone had earlier wanted to ask a question, it was now forgotten. Mother was sitting with Her eyes closed. Everyone spontaneously did the same, and sitting with closed eyes, in a contemplative mood, they drank in and relished the spiritual feeling that was tangibly present in the atmosphere.

Later, when everyone began to come out of their meditative mood, Mother asked the brahmacharins to sing a song, *Sukhamenni Tirayunna*.

*You, who are searching
for happiness everywhere,
how will you find it
without shedding your vanity?
Until the compassionate One,
the Mother of the Universe,
shines within your heart
How can you be happy?*

*The mind
in which devotion towards Shakti,
the Supreme Power,
is not alive
is like a flower without fragrance.*

*Such a mind will be forced
to toss about in misery
like a leaf
tossed by the waves
of the restless ocean.*

*Do not get caught in the talons
of the vulture known as fate
Worship the Self in seclusion
Stop expecting the fruits
of your actions
Worship the form of the Universal Self
in the blossom of your heart.*

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CHAPTER NINE

THE INCOMPREHENSIBLE MOTHER

Even people who are very close to Mother have always felt that She is incomprehensible. After several years of close association with Mother, the author personally feels that there is something impenetrable about Mother, that She is somebody who is far beyond his understanding.

The first group of brahmacharins who came to Mother have always wondered, “How is it possible to understand Mother? How are we to know Her wishes so that we can act and serve Her accordingly?” Sometimes they have run into trouble because of their difficulties in understanding Mother.

They have on countless occasions experienced Mother’s impregnable nature. It is easy to understand the nature of a person, if we move in close proximity with him or her for some time, a few weeks or maybe even months. But after nearly two decades Mother remains a completely unknown personality to the first brahmacharins and to everyone who has come close to Her. Bri. Gayatri, who today is known as Swamini Amritaprana, and who has been serving Mother for two decades, once stated about Mother, “What phenomenon is this? Even in-

finity can be understood, but not Mother!”

Once, Br. Balu was with Mother in Her room. Bri. Gayatri was also present. Mother was being very loving and affectionate towards Balu. She talked to him for a long time, put all his doubts at rest and answered all his questions. She even fed him with Her own hands. He was feeling filled with Mother’s love, and with joy and bliss. But all of a sudden, Mother turned around and asked him to get out of the room. No trace of love could be seen on Her face. She was completely detached. Balu was shocked to see this sudden change in Mother, and felt utterly confused. At first he thought that Mother was playing a game with him, but he soon realized that She was being serious. He wanted to ask why, because he didn’t understand what was happening. He wanted to ask but he couldn’t, because Mother’s words and the forbidding look on Her face were of such depth and power that he didn’t dare. This sudden change in Mother’s mood was like throwing a big rock in the still, calm waters of a lake; it was as if a beautiful castle was crumbling to pieces at the very moment when its beauty was being admired and appreciated.

Balu remained silent and stood like a statue in the room. He could barely move when he heard Mother’s voice repeat, “Get out! I want to be alone! Why should it take you so long to leave?” With a heavy, broken heart Balu slowly walked out of the room, and just as

he crossed the threshold, Mother shut the door with a bang. The sound of the door was like an unbearably hard blow which had been aimed at Balu's heart.

Even though he had left Mother's room, Balu couldn't bring himself to move away from the door. His attachment to Mother was so intense that he sat down in front of the closed door to Her room and cried like an abandoned child.

Balu thought, "This must be a real test of my faith and patience. Of course, one gets a little puffed up when Mother allows one to be close to Her for some time. The ego thinks, 'I must be very special, otherwise, why would Mother let me be this close to Her for such a long time?' It is then that Mother's thunderbolt falls upon you. The problem is that the mind never thinks, 'How fortunate and blessed I am to spend so much time in Mother's presence.' The mind and ego can only think negatively in terms of selfishness and pride. When Mother's unexpected attack comes, one's pride is shattered. If there is no pride, if there is only a good and positive feeling of how blessed I am and how gracious Mother is, then there can be no question of feeling sad and upset. Pain and sadness come when the role of the ego is questioned. If I don't feel proud and think that I am special, because I spend so much time with Mother, and that I have a right to be in Mother's presence, then there cannot be any sadness. How can I feel sad or upset when there is only humility?"

A few minutes later he heard somebody open the door. He raised his head and was surprised to see Mother standing there with a big smile on Her face. Her mood was the same as it had been before She had told Balu to get out. As if nothing had happened She now said to him, "Come in, son. But what happened to you! Why are you crying?" Balu could hardly believe it. It took a few moments for him to comprehend what was happening. As he stood there, wondering about the strangeness of it all, Balu once again heard Mother's voice, "Son, come in. What happened? Why are you crying?" Those words were like a burst of rain to the chataka bird of Balu's heart.⁹ All the pain of his heart melted away, like ice in the scorching heat of the sun. He was so overwhelmed by Mother's compassion that he burst into tears all over again. But he couldn't help wondering to himself about the apparent contradiction in Mother's nature. At first She had been so loving and affectionate, and then suddenly, for no apparent reason, She had become completely detached. What had happened? He simply couldn't understand. A few minutes later he asked, "Mother, I am unable to understand You and act accordingly. This is my greatest sorrow. How am I to understand You?"

⁹ It is said that the chataka bird (the hornbill bird) will drink only raindrops that fall during the rains. It does not relish any other water. In the absence of rain, the chataka bird is thirsty and miserable.

Mother smiled and replied, “To understand Me, you have to become Me.”

It was the same as if Balu had asked how he was to understand infinity. “Unless you become infinity, you cannot understand infinity,” was the answer.

This is just one small incident. There have been countless incidents of this kind.

MOTHER’S ILLNESS

One morning Mother was found to be very ill. She was so weak that She couldn’t even get up from Her bed. It happened to be a Sunday, and hundreds of people were waiting for Mother’s morning *darshan*. She complained that She was having trouble breathing and that Her whole body was in terrible pain (Sometimes this happens when Mother takes upon Herself the diseases of devotees). She was in so much agony that She was rolling on the bed. But the single bed was not wide enough, so Mother decided that She wanted to lie on the bare floor. Gayatri and the brahmacharins were afraid that the cold floor would only aggravate her pain, so they spread a thick blanket over it. But Mother didn’t want the blanket, so Gayatri removed it and she then helped Mother down onto the floor. As Mother lay on the bare floor, She began to roll back and forth groaning with pain. Her suffering was obvious. The brahmacharins decided that there should be no morning *darshan* or

Devi Bhava that day. They mentioned this to Mother, but Mother didn't say anything. Taking Her silence as consent, a sign was placed in front of the Ashram announcing the cancellation of both the morning *darshan* and Devi Bhava. One of the brahmacharins went downstairs and broke the news to the devotees who were waiting for Mother in the *darshan* hut. They were all greatly disappointed.

It was just after nine-thirty. Mother was still lying on the floor. Her physical condition had not improved even slightly. Everybody was feeling worried. Gayatri and Damayantamma were massaging Mother's legs while a brahmacharini was holding a hot water bottle against Her chest. All eyes were fixed on Mother. All of a sudden Mother sprang up from the floor and asked, "What time is it?" Everyone was astonished and they all asked, "Why, Amma? Why do you want to know the time?" It sounded like a chorus.

"Why do you ask?" said Mother, as if nothing had happened, as if there had never been anything wrong with Her. "Why, don't you know that today is Sunday? The devotees must be waiting downstairs for *darshan*. What time is it?" She again inquired. She turned to look at the clock, and when She discovered what time it was She exclaimed, "Oh Shivane! It's nearly nine forty-five!" By now She was on Her feet. Br. Nealu protested and said, "But Amma, we have already announced that there will be no *darshan* today, and the devotees already know

about it. They are slowly getting ready to go. Amma, you are very sick. You need to rest for at least one day.” Mother gave Nealu a stern look and said, “What did you say? Did you say to them that there is no *darshan* today? Did you make such an announcement? And who told you that Amma is sick? Amma is not sick! She has never done any such thing before! Amma is surprised to see that you, who have been with Her for such a long time, are still so utterly lacking in compassion. How could you even think of sending all those devotees away?” She immediately sent Br. Pai downstairs to inform everyone that Mother would be giving *darshan* as usual. The devotees were elated and they all rushed back into the hut.

By now Mother looked completely normal. There was no sign of any pain or illness to be seen in Her at all. She said to the brahmacharins, “You do not understand the feelings of the devotees. Some of them have been waiting eagerly for a long time to see Amma. Many of them have had to borrow money, or sell their earrings or nose rings, to be able to come and see Amma. There are many who scrape together ten paise a day, from their meagre earnings, to save enough money for the bus fare to visit the Ashram once a month. It’s easy for you to send them away, saying that there is no *darshan* today. But think of the mental agony that they will go through if they cannot see Amma. Think of all the trouble they have had to undergo to come here.

Think of their disappointment. Most of the devotees won't make any major decisions in their lives without first asking Amma. Those who are here now may need an answer today. There are certain things which cannot be postponed. How easy it was for you to suddenly decide that there would be no *darshan* today. Children, try to understand the problems of others and try to feel their sorrow."

Br. Nealu was concerned and remarked, "What will people think about us? They are going to think that we brahmacharins cancelled the *darshan* on our own initiative."

Mother again looked sternly at Nealu and said, "Nealu, are you still concerned about what people think about you? Very good! So you are afraid of others and their ill feelings. Whatever happened was Amma's wish - can't you take it in that way? Is this how a disciple should feel about his Master? The thought of what others may think about you comes from the ego. The ego wants a good image. You don't want anyone to dislike you or to criticize you. You are far more worried about that than feeling any concern about Amma's health. A surrendered person would never think like this. Once you have surrendered, you do not think about yourself or what others may think about you. You should learn to surrender your ego."

As soon as Mother had finished speaking, Gayatri requested everyone to leave the room, so that Mother could get ready for *darshan*.

A STRANGER TO FIX THE MIND

Twenty minutes later Mother came down to the *darshan* hut and began receiving the devotees. She looked enthusiastic and cheerful, and She was also looking perfectly healthy.

The brahmacharins once asked Mother how they were to understand these perplexing moods of Hers, and why She sometimes acted in such seemingly strange ways.

Mother answered, “It is only according to your strange and noisy mind that Amma is acting strangely. You feel that it is strange because you have certain preconceived ideas about behavior. You have picked up certain concepts and habits from your own life and from the way in which you have been brought up. You believe that certain ways of behavior are strange and that other ways are normal. Strangeness and normality are nothing but your own concepts, your own personal belief. You want Amma to speak and behave according to the way in which your mind has been trained.

“You may have certain ideas about life which you think are right, but they are bound to be different from everyone else’s. Everyone has his own ideas, his own thoughts and feelings, and each one thinks that he is right and that everyone else is wrong. Everyone functions like this. Each mind has created its own concepts, and each mind expects Amma to fit within that framework.

“It is true that Amma is trying to please all Her devotees who come to Her to unburden their sorrows, their suffering and their fear. You must have seen how Amma behaves towards them to make them feel at ease, so that they will open up in Her presence. The more they open up, the more Amma can work on them. Amma would gladly sacrifice Her entire life for the sake of making others happy. But, Amma doesn’t believe that She should treat you, who wish to devote your entire life to know God, in the same way. Your mind needs to be churned and churned, so that it will become clearer than the clearest - so transparent that you will be able to perceive your real existence, the Atman. In other words, you have to become mindless. But this is not easy. The mind cannot simply be removed. It is dissolved by the heat produced by *tapas*, and this heat is created by the Master’s disciplining, coupled with your love and attachment towards him.

“Your mind and intellect cannot comprehend the Master, which is why you call him strange and contradictory. But understand that it is only your mind that judges him like that.

“In the heat produced by *tapas*, the mind, along with all its judgements and preoccupations, will melt away, and you begin to function from your heart. For this to happen the disciple must have a tremendous amount of patience.

“A true Master sacrifices his entire life for the uplift of his disciples, devotees and the entire society. But there

also has to be a certain amount of commitment from the other end. Be patient and you will receive everything from the true Master.

“Don’t try to judge the Master with your intellect. Your understanding of him is bound to be completely wrong. Because you dwell in the mind, and your habits and tendencies are very strong, you will insist on trying to solve the mystery of the Master’s ‘strange moods’ through logic and reasoning. But you will fail to understand until, at last, it will be revealed to you that the Master cannot be understood through the mind or intellect. You will realize that faith alone is the way. It is only through surrender and a childlike openness that one can come to know him.

“In the process of trying to comprehend the Master through your intellect, your mind will become exhausted. You will realize that you are helpless in your efforts to understand the infinite nature of the Master with your intellect, and you finally open up. You suddenly become receptive. This process involves *tapas*, and it is your love and attachment to the Master’s external form that extracts the heat.

“You may call the Master strange, but it is only according to your mind that he is strange. The mind creates a sense of strangeness in you because you identify with it. The more you surrender to the disciplining of the Master, with an intense feeling of love in your heart, the more you will come to know that it is your

own mind that is strange, and not the Master.

“The mind is an outsider. He is a stranger in your real abode - the Self. The mind, being a foreign element, creates an irritation which itches. The itching is the desires of the mind. It is just like the sensation you sometimes get to scratch an itching wound. As you scratch the area, you find it soothing, and so you scratch it repeatedly until the wound and the surrounding area become red and infected. And with that, the pain of the wound increases.

“The mind creates such an itch when it is full of desires and emotions. So you keep on scratching, until finally, your whole life becomes a big pus infected wound. “All that pus needs to be squeezed out of your wound; only then will the wound be healed. It is Amma’s duty to treat the wound and squeeze out the pus. That is how Amma shows Her compassion towards you, but when She does, you call it strange. But Amma isn’t bothered by your reaction, for it is only due to your lack of understanding. You would call Amma normal if She just kept on soothing the wound and allowed you to continue to scratch it. The choice is yours. If you want the wound only to be soothed and not healed, it is all right with Mother, but you will suffer later.

“Suppose you go to see a doctor to have a wound treated. The doctor might give you an injection, after which you may feel even more pain than before. The wound might become filled with pus and the pain may

be excruciating. You ask the doctor, ‘How can I be in so much pain when you have given me the medication?’ The doctor smilingly replies, ‘Don’t worry. The injection was meant to bring out all the pus. It has to come out.’ The doctor looks pleased about your condition, because he knows it means that the treatment is working. But you think it is strange that the doctor is pleased. You cannot blame the doctor for your limited understanding. He knows what he is doing, and it is his duty to do what is best for you. Don’t judge the doctor. You are likely to misjudge him, because you do not know anything. He is healing the wound, but before the wound is healed, pain is unavoidable. **The present pain you are experiencing is meant to remove all pain.** If you yourself are not a doctor and you do not know anything about medical treatment, your ideas about how a disease should be treated belong to you and your mind alone.

“The same is the case with a true Master. Your sense of confusion and the pain that you have are due to the spiritual medication which he has given you, to bring out the pus from the wounds of your past.

“External cuts and wounds are not a big problem. They will soon heal, provided that they are treated properly. But the inner wounds are far more serious. They can destroy your entire life because you are ignorant and do not know anything about them. An ordinary doctor cannot treat such wounds. They are deep, age old wounds, for which you need an all-knowing,

divine doctor. A real Master is absolutely necessary, someone who can see into all your past lives, who knows how to treat and cure your inner wounds.”

Question: “Amma, You compared the mind to a foreign element. Why is it foreign? Could You please elaborate on this point?”

Mother: “Whenever a foreign element enters into our lives we ruthlessly try to reject it. For example, if there is a dust particle in our eye we want to remove it. Why? Because it is not part of the eye. It doesn’t belong to us. What about an illness? Even if it is a headache or stomach ache we will want to get rid of it, because it is foreign to us. The body wants to reject it, for it is not part of our nature. Similarly, the mind is a foreign element, a complete stranger, that we need to get rid of.

“Everybody wants to be happy and peaceful. There are no arguments about that. But, to attain real peace and happiness one has to go beyond the mind and its desires. It is the mind that causes the sorrow and the itching. The mind is like a wound. Every time a desire crops up you feel an ‘itching’ sensation of the wound of the mind. Fulfilling the desire is like scratching the wound, and your itch is relieved for the moment. But you are completely unaware of the truth that by yielding to your desires, you are making the wound of the mind deeper. It becomes more and more infected. But the mind will constantly continue to demand and desire, and you will continue to fulfill those desires. It is like

a continuous scratching of the wound of the mind, which only makes the wound increasingly larger.

“If you vigorously keep rubbing the dust in your eyes instead of removing it, your pain and irritation will only increase. Remove the dust and you will be all right. Similarly, the mind is like dust in the eye, a foreign element. Learn to get rid of the mind. Only then will you achieve perfection and happiness.

“To be happy and peaceful is the goal of all human beings. But they choose the wrong ways to attain it. Almost everyone knows that they are not experiencing real peace and happiness. They are lacking something in their lives and they try to fill that gap by acquiring and possessing. But the real problem exists within your mind. The mind is a stranger that needs to be eliminated. But who can do this? Only a complete stranger to your mind can eliminate it. The Master is that Stranger. The *Mahatma*, the Perfect Master, is perhaps incomprehensible to your mind, but he knows your strange mind and its strange ways perfectly well. He is the Master of all minds, but to your mind he is a very strange phenomenon indeed.

“As long as your mind exists, you will judge the *Mahatma*’s ways as strange, but when you slowly start to control the mind and thoughts, you will realize that there was nothing strange at all about the *Mahatma*, it was only your mind that was strange.

“As Amma has mentioned before, your mind needs

to be churned. Only a certain stranger with strange moods knows how to churn your mind. You are used to ordinary people and their moods, and your mind sometimes gets churned by them. But this churning is only superficial and is not sufficient. The effect of real churning should reach the bottom most part of your mind; only then does purification take place. No ordinary individual can do this, because no ordinary person knows the strangeness of your mind as well as the true Master. A true Master is beyond the senses and the mind. That is why you call him strange. But only such a strange person who is beyond the mind and the senses can do the churning effectively, and help you to eliminate your strange mind and its strange feelings. That strange person is the Master - the Satguru. The Satguru brings the disciple close to him through his love and compassion, and then slowly, by his seemingly strange ways and moods, the churning begins.

“Children, there is a Malayalam proverb which says, **‘Catch the fish after stirring up the water.’** If you create turbulence in a pond, all the fish living in different parts of the pond will come out from beneath the mud and from other hiding places. They will hear the frightening noise and come scurrying out. It is like a total churning of the pond. Once all the fish have come out of their hiding places, the fisherman will cast his net and capture them. In a similar way, the Master will create turbulence in our minds, through his strange,

incomprehensible ways. But this turbulence will bring out all the vasanas (tendencies) lying dormant deep within. Only if these vasanas manifest can we become aware of them and remove them. The Master's strange ways have been deliberately created only to catch your mind. The turbulence that the Master makes you experience is only to show you the amount of negativity that you have within. Once you realize the tremendous weight of the burden of negativity that you are carrying, you will have a sincere desire to get rid of it. This will enable you to cooperate with the Master, because now you know the root-cause of the itching; you know how deep the wound is. You don't want to carry the burden anymore. You want to unburden yourself and be completely happy and relaxed. Once you become aware of the negativity, it will be easy to eliminate it. You come to know that your mind is the real cause of all your sorrow and suffering, and you will be able to renounce it, by the Grace of the Master."

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CHAPTER TEN

A GOOD REMINDER

One brahmacharin wanted to leave the Ashram for a few months and spend some time in solitude. He had been asking Mother about this for some time. But Mother said to him, “Why do you want to go? Is it going to do you any good? Amma doesn’t think that you would gain anything by being away from this atmosphere. If your goal is Self-Realization, this is the best place to be. But, if you want to act according to your *vasanas*, then it’s fine, go ahead. It is your mind that is the problem. As long as you carry the mind along with you wherever you go, you are not going to gain anything. You can keep on changing places and situations, but you will remain the same old person with the same old habits and tendencies, unless you stop your noisy mind. Self-Realization will remain out of reach for you until you silence your mind. What you need is not another place or situation, but a person who has completely silenced his own mind. Only such a person can help you become aware of your real problem and bring you out of it; only such a person can help your mind become still and silent.”

The brahmacharin nevertheless decided to go. He left the Ashram early one morning, leaving a letter for

Mother, saying, “Amma, forgive me for disobeying You. The desire to be alone is so strong that I cannot resist it. I simply have to leave. Oh Compassionate One, please accept me as Your son and disciple when I return.”

But the brahmacharin, who had wanted to be in solitude for at least three months, returned to the Ashram that same day. He later described a very interesting incident which forced him to give up the idea of leaving the Ashram.

Hoping to catch the early morning bus to Kayamkulam, he had taken a boat across the backwaters and was about to proceed to the bus stop, when all of a sudden, half a dozen dogs ran up right in front of him and stood blocking his way. The brahmacharin thought that the dogs were harmless, so he decided to ignore them and tried to move forward. But as soon as he moved, the dogs began to bark at him and they looked fierce. The brahmacharin grabbed a stick which was lying nearby, intending to use it to frighten the dogs away. But this move enraged the dogs and their barking became ferocious. Some of the dogs moved threateningly close to the brahmacharin. He had wanted to frighten the dogs away, but finally he himself became so frightened that he let go of the stick. As soon as he dropped the stick, the dogs stopped barking and stood still, but they were not yet willing to give up. They continued to block his way and wouldn't move an inch.

The brahmacharin made a second and third attempt to proceed to the bus stop, but whenever he tried to take a step forward, the dogs began to bark again, as they continued to block his way.

At one point the brahmacharin got so angry with the dogs that he took a few threatening steps toward them. But as he did so, one of the dogs jumped at him, and with a lightning move, bit him on the calf of his right leg. It wasn't a deep wound but his leg was bleeding. The brahmacharin was shocked at what had just happened. It was, in fact, an eye opener for him. He thought, "This must be Mother's *leela*, because She doesn't want me to go. I am being disobedient, but not even my disobedience will succeed if it isn't Mother's will. Why else would these dogs act in such a strange way?" Thinking in this way and feeling somewhat consoled, the brahmacharin returned to the Ashram.

The brahmacharin wanted to keep this incident a secret. He decided to tell Mother about it at a later time, when he got an opportunity. But, to his wonderment, the next morning Mother asked him, "The dogs taught you a lesson, didn't they?" Mother laughed and continued, "Son, let this serve as a fitting punishment for your disobedience." Everybody soon found out about the incident. During the next two days, as the brahmacharin was walking around the Ashram with a bandage on his leg, he aroused a lot of laughter wherever he went, and was teased mercilessly by the other resi-

dents. Looking at his bandage, Mother laughed and said, “Let this serve as a good reminder.” The brahmacharin was full of remorse. He shed copious tears asking Mother to forgive him.

Later he wanted to know how this could have happened. He asked Mother, “Why did the dogs behave in such a strange way? It was Your will that was being expressed through them, wasn’t it? But is such a thing possible?”

THE ALL-PERVASIVE NATURE OF A TRUE MASTER

Mother replied, “Son, haven’t you heard the story about how all of Nature answered when the great sage Vedavyasa called his son, Suka, urging him to come back? Even as a boy, Suka was detached from the world. Vedavyasa wanted his son to get married and lead the normal life of a householder. But Suka, who was born divine, was strongly inclined to live the life of a renunciate. So, one day he gave up everything and left to become a *sannyasin*. While Suka was walking away, Vedavyasa called out his son’s name. It was Nature that responded to his call - the trees, the plants, the mountains, valleys, animals and birds - they all answered him. But what exactly does this mean?

“A person who has become one with the Supreme Consciousness is also one with all of creation. He is no

longer just the body. He is the life force which shines in and through everything in creation. He is that Consciousness which lends its beauty and vitality to everything. He is the Self, which is immanent in everything. This is the meaning of the story.

“When Vedavyasa called his son, Suka, Nature answered, because Suka was that Pure Consciousness which is immanent in all of Nature. Vedavyasa called Suka, but Suka was not the body and therefore had no name or form. He was beyond name and form. He existed within everyone, and the bodies of all creatures were his. He was in every body, and therefore everything responded.

“You saw only the bodies of the dogs. But what was within those bodies? Within each body dwells the Atman. You may call what you see a dog because it has a dog’s body. But once you realize the truth, you will experience that the dog and everything that exists in creation is pervaded by the Supreme Atman. A true *Mahatma* can make anything obey him, whether it be sentient or insentient. Everything is his, everything can be controlled by him. Nothing is impossible for a *Mahatma*. Even a wooden plank will do anything he wishes it to do. What then can't he ask a dog to do, who is far more intelligent! The *Mahatma* can act through the sun, the moon, the ocean, mountains, trees and animals. He can express himself through the entire universe. He just has to give the command. A word, a glance, a thought or a touch is enough to make anything obey.

“Do you know the story of how Sri Krishna turned the entire herd of cows against a powerful demon who came to steal the herd? He turned the cows against the demon by simply playing the flute. The demon was a servant of Kamsa, Krishna’s evil uncle. Kamsa had tried many different methods to kill Krishna, using his faithful demons, one after the other, to do the job. But all his attempts had failed. His frequent failures made Kamsa very revengeful. One day, he called another demon and ordered him to kill all the cows belonging to Krishna and his friends.

“Every morning Krishna and the cowherd boys used to take the cows to the meadows to graze. The meadows were far away from Gokul, where Krishna and His friends lived. One day, when the cows were grazing happily in a forest, the demon appeared. He first of all wanted to take all the cows to a more suitable place where he could use his demonic powers to kill them. The hideous appearance of the demon was enough to frighten the cows, and they ran hither and thither in a frenzy. The demon managed to gather the whole herd and make them run in a particular direction. Krishna’s friends, the cowherd boys, were terrified and they rushed to the place where Sri Krishna was sitting. When they told Him what had happened, Sri Krishna smiled, whereupon He took out His flute and began to play a beautiful, melodious tune. That was all that was needed. As soon as they heard that melodious tune, the cows,

who were running in the direction towards which the demon was chasing them, turned around and began to chase the demon. There were hundreds of cows, and now the demon's magical powers had no effect on them at all. So finally, it was the demon who was forced to flee from the cows.

"The Saint, Jnaneswar, could make a wall move and a bullock chant the *Vedas*.

"Mastery over the mind means mastery over all of creation. It does not mean only the mastery over your own individual mind. You become the master of all minds, all minds are under your command. You are the whole, and not the part. Once you realize this, there can be no separation from anything."

TAKE REFUGE AT THE FEET OF A PERFECT MASTER

In connection with the incident of the brahmacharin who tried to leave, Mother later elaborated, "People all over the world run here and there, in search of spirituality and Self-Realization. They want to find a peaceful, solitary place, perhaps a cave, or a forest, or a mountainous area, with a river running nearby, and so on. What they should do first of all is learn how to become patient and settle down somewhere - but not just anywhere they like; it should be at the feet of a person who can help them to see that their problems do not stem

from somewhere outside themselves, but that they exist within. It should be someone who can take the seeker by the hand and lead him to the goal; it should be someone who will make the aspirant feel that he is not alone - that he will always have the help and loving guidance of his Master, who is endowed with infinite spiritual power.

“This is not an easy path, and there is pain involved. But, the aspirant should not feel too much pain, for then he may fall from the path or he may want to run away. Competent students are hard to find nowadays. They existed a long time ago, when truth and faith were prevalent in society. Their intent on the goal was so strong that they could easily withstand the strict disciplining of the Master. Those seekers had complete faith and self-surrender. But things have changed. Faith and self-surrender have become limited to words. More speaking and less doing is the policy of the modern age, and the tendencies of the mind are stronger than before. No one wants to be disciplined. Everyone wants to keep their ego, it is so precious to them. People think that the ego is an embellishment; it is not considered to be a burden anymore. People do not feel the heaviness of their ego. They feel comfortable inside its small, hard shell. They feel afraid and insecure to come out of it. They think that they are well protected where they are. For them, what lies beyond the shell of their ego is frightening, it is unknown and therefore unsafe.

They believe that what lies beyond their ego is not for them, it is meant only for those who are 'not capable of doing anything else.'

IT TAKES COURAGE TO SURRENDER

"Surrendering to a Master is not easy. It needs courage. It is like jumping into a flowing river. The Master is the flowing river. Once you jump in, the current will inexorably take you to the sea. There is no escape. You may struggle and try to swim against the current, but the river is so strong that it is bound to take you to the ocean - to God, or the Self - your real dwelling place. To jump in is to surrender. It needs a courageous mind because it can be compared to the death of your body and mind.

"You may not take the plunge now, because you are not yet ready to jump into the deep waters of the river. For the time being, you may want to remain standing on the river bank enjoying the beauty of the river. You may want to enjoy the cool gentle breeze, the constant chatter of the running water, the power and charm of the river. That is fine. The river is not going to force you to jump in, and you can stand there for as long as you like because it won't send you away. It is not going to say, 'Enough is enough! Go away! There is a long waiting list.' Nor is it going to say, 'Okay, the time has come. You either jump into me right now, or I will force you.' No, nothing of the sort. It is all up to you.

You can either jump in or stay on the shore. The river is simply there. It is always willing to accept you and to cleanse you.

“The river of the Master does not have an ego. It does not think, ‘I am flowing, I am powerful and beautiful. I have the power to take you to the ocean. In fact, I am the ocean. See how many people bathe and swim in me, and how they find delight in me!’ No, the river of the Master has no such feelings. It just flows because its nature is to do so.

“But once you dive in, the current is such that you will become almost like a corpse. You will find yourself so powerless, that you have no other choice but to simply be still and let the river carry you wherever it wants. You have the freedom to choose. You can either remain on the shore or dive in. But once you take the leap, you do not have a choice anymore; you will lose your individuality, you will have to give up your ego. At that point you disappear and you find that you are floating in Pure Consciousness.

“So, you are free to stay on the shore. But for how long? Sooner or later, you will either have to turn and go back to the world, or you will have to jump. Even if you return to the world, the beauty and charm of the river is so enchanting and so tempting that you will keep on coming back. The day will come when you will be tempted to take that final leap. And finally you will dive in - it has to happen.

“While standing on the shore you may have many things to say about the river. You will sing its praises, you will describe its beauty, you will have many opinions about it, and you have unending stories to tell about the river and its history. But you are describing the river and telling stories about it without having taken a dip in it even once. And whatever you may say about the greatness of the river without having gone into it, is simply meaningless. Once you finally dive in, once you surrender to the River of Existence - the Perfect Master - you will be silent. You will have nothing to say.

“Surrender makes you silent. Surrender destroys the ego and helps you to experience your nothingness and God’s omniscience. Once you know that you are nothing, that you are totally ignorant, then you have nothing to say. You have only unconditional and undivided faith; you can only bow down in utmost humility. In order to really know, one should be humble. The ego and real knowledge are not compatible. Humility is the sign of true knowledge.

“There are people who are good speakers. They tend to have big egos. There are exceptions, but the general tendency is to speak more and do less. Why? Because they haven’t surrendered to a higher reality, to the higher values of life. They have not really accepted God’s all-powerful nature and become aware of their own nothingness, even though they may speak about it. Such

people may do a lot of good for the world, but they also do a lot of harm.

“Amma is not trying to generalize. Everyone is not like that. There are people among them who have surrendered, but they are only a few who can be counted on one’s finger tips. The general tendency is to be as egoistic as possible.

THE EGO KILLS THE REAL YOU

“The greatest problem with the world of politics and business is the tough competition, the tug of war which goes on between party members or rival business groups, as each one tries to establish its supremacy over the others. In situations like that you have to show some aggression towards your rivals; you want to gain power over them, and you therefore need to show them that you count for something. To achieve your goal, you are willing to use any method. You do not even care if it is inhuman. And in the struggle to survive you lose your qualities as a human being. You become almost like an animal. You lose your heart and a hard rock takes its place. Your concern for your fellow beings will be lost. The real you will be sacrificed. Amma has heard a story.

“A man was involved in a lawsuit. He thought he might lose the case and desperately told his lawyer that he was about to send the judge an entire set of golf

clubs, as a bribe. The lawyer was shocked and said to his client, 'The judge takes great pride in his honesty. He cannot be bribed. If you do that, it will only serve to turn him against you and then you can just imagine the result.'

The man won the case, and when it was all over he invited his lawyer for dinner. He expressed his gratitude towards the lawyer for his advice concerning the golf clubs. 'I did, in fact, send them to the judge,' he said, 'but I sent them on behalf of our opponent.'

"The ego makes life very similar to a battle field, and in a battlefield there are only enemies, there are no friends, no near or dear ones. In a battlefield there is no love or concern for others. You are always thinking about how to destroy the other. You never even consider forgetting and forgiving. Even those who seem to be on your side are trying to pull you down. In fact, they are thinking the same way that you are. They have similar suspicions. And so it is, that to begin with, you destroy the people on the opposite side, and then you end up destroying the people on your own side. Power and money make you blind. Why should there be all this trouble? Because there is no surrender or humility. Everybody feels that they are something special, that they are great. So, they keep trying to show others how great they are, and this is what always ends in destruction.

"The other day, a film actor visited Amma and talked

about his struggle for survival in the film business. He said to Amma, 'People are of the impression that the film business is one of the best fields of work, and that film stars live happy and contented lives.' With great pain he told Amma that the film business is one of the worst professions you can be involved in, because of all the jealousy and competitiveness which exists between actors. Those who are at the top never encourage the other actors to succeed. Even though there are many talented actors and actresses, they are at the mercy of producers, directors and the leading actors and actresses. There is a shameless hostility among them, as each one tries to pull the others down.

"Sometimes people hide their egos to achieve something. Suppose a person wants to find a job. He has been wandering around for a long time, unable to find any work. As he approaches a factory owner asking for a job, he carefully hides his ego and pretends to be very humble. He readily agrees to all the conditions that the owner puts forth, and he signs the contract. He even repeats a pledge several times, saying that he will never participate in any kind of strike or protest which might be instigated against the management, and that he will discharge his duties promptly, without fail. But once the job is his, he begins to think that he is something and he wants to show it. He begins to break all his promises and he forgets about the pledge that he repeated. He brings his ego out from hiding.

“When you surrender to a higher consciousness, you give up all your claims; you release your grip from everything that you’ve been holding on to. Whether you gain or lose, it doesn’t matter now. You don’t want to be something any longer. You long to be nothing, absolutely nothing. So you dive into the River of Existence.

“The ego, or the mind, is that which makes you feel that you are something. Unless it is eliminated, you cannot dive deep into your own consciousness. You have to become nothing. Not even a trace of, ‘I am something’ should remain. If you are something, there is no entry into the realm of Pure Consciousness.

BEAUTY LIES IN EGOLESSNESS

“The ego can only destroy. It destroys everything - even life itself. It destroys everything that is good and beautiful. When the ego is predominant, ugliness is also predominant, because the ego is inherently ugly and repulsive. An egoistic person may be considered handsome and highly capable, but there will nevertheless be an unpleasant feeling about him.

“Ravana, the demon king, was handsome, majestic and very talented. He was a great singer and musician. He could play several instruments beautifully at the same time. He was a great scholar, a great composer and writer. But there was always something abhorrent

about him. Even though he had all these great qualities, he also had a disagreeable nature. This was because he was extremely egotistic. He thought he was greater than everybody else. The thought that, 'I am something great,' creates a certain ugliness in people.

"Vedavyasa, on the other hand was not at all handsome. But his presence was divine and exceptionally beautiful because he was the very embodiment of humility and simplicity. He had no ego. He was genuinely great, but he never claimed that he was great in any way. He thought of himself as being nothing, and because of this, he was everything.

"Vedavyasa was a completely surrendered soul; whereas Ravana had not surrendered at all. Ravana had a grossly inflated ego; whereas Vedavyasa had no individual ego at all. He was Pure Consciousness personified. The difference is enormous."

Everybody sat spellbound as they listened to Mother's words. They kept gazing at Mother - the incomprehensible One.

Br. Pai sang a song called, *Ammayennullora Ten Mori*.

*Is there one other name
among the countless names in existence
that equals the honey-like name of Amma?
Is there any realm
other than the one of Your Love*

*that is worthy of being the resting place
for all my thoughts?*

*O Mother, if you forsake this helpless one
who is wandering
along the shores of lonely nights,
then the garden of my mind
will be haunted by endless sorrows.*

*Oh Mother, is there anyone, except You
my only support
who knows my innermost sorrows?
If we who adore You
should become a despicable lot
what purpose would there be
in meditating on Your Lotus Feet?*

*O blessed, infinite Light
Please caress me with the slightest touch
of Your glance.
If You do, my mind will flow
along the sacred River
of Nectarous Bliss.*

O

CHAPTER ELEVEN

During the Devi Bhava one evening, Br. Balu couldn't sing because he had a sore throat. So, he sat inside the temple, meditating and repeating his mantra, and often simply gazing at Mother's radiant face.

Saumya was sitting at Mother's other side, serving Her as she did during every Bhava *darshan*. In the beginning Gayatri and Saumya were the only brahmacharinis who were staying permanently at the Ashram. Before that, in the early days, when the Krishna and Devi Bhavas first began, it was the local women devotees who served Mother during each Bhava *darshan*. When Gayatri came to stay permanently, in the beginning of 1980, she began taking care of Mother's personal needs, and she also started serving Mother during the Divine Moods. The task of serving Mother during Bhava *darshan* was later passed on to Saumya, when she became a permanent resident at the end of 1982.

It was a common practice in those days for Mother to let one of the brahmacharins sit right next to Her, on Her left side, during Devi Bhava. Those were very precious moments.

Having invited a brahmacharin to sit close to Her, Mother would usually apply some sandal paste between his eyebrows. This touch had a wonderful effect on the recipient; it created a feeling of such tremendous peace that he would spontaneously become absorbed in deep meditation. She therefore deliberately bestowed this blessing upon them. The first group of brahmacharins were very fortunate to receive this experience. There were times when one of them would be called to come and sit next to Mother and She would let him lay his head on Her lap. While lying with his head on Mother's lap he would have wonderful visions and other spiritual experiences. It was, of course, considered to be a great privilege and blessing to be allowed to sit next to Mother during Devi Bhava. Occasions were not few when Mother bestowed this blessing upon a householder devotee.

As being allowed to sit next to Mother during Devi Bhava was considered an expression of Her special love, each brahmacharin always waited anxiously for Mother to call him. But among the six or seven brahmacharins who were then living at the Ashram, Mother would invite only one of them to sit next to Her during each Devi Bhava. On some days She completely ignored the brahmacharins and asked a householder devotee to come and sit next to Her. When the others realized that they had lost their chance for this time, they would become extremely jealous of the chosen one. But, in due course, Mother completely stopped this practice of calling one of them.

The memories of those days still remain fresh and vivid among the brahmacharins. The deep, spontaneous meditations that they used to experience on those occasions were extraordinary. Sometimes Mother would also take the time to answer the questions of the person who sat next to Her.

This was one such blessed night for Br. Balu.

On the front veranda of the temple, *bhajans* were being sung with great intensity. Br. Pai was singing *Oru Pidi Sneham*.

*I have wandered after shadows
yearning for a morsel of Love
But, when almost within grasp
Love slipped from my hand.
Oh Mother, here I am
wandering again
O Mother.*

*My heart is broken
struck by the lashing waves
of grief.
O Mother
Where is this shattered soul
to search for You?
Do You not care?
O Mother, do You not care?*

*As I continuously drink
the tears of sorrow,*

*I shall sleep no more.
O Mother, have mercy on me
so that I may reawaken
and discover myself
at Your Lotus Feet.*

Balu was sitting next to the wall, at a slight distance from Mother. He was gazing at Mother's beautiful countenance, and he was thinking to himself, "How wonderful it would be if Mother were to call me now and let me sit close to Her." Suddenly Mother looked at him and smilingly invited him to come and sit beside Her. Balu's happiness knew no bounds. The thought that Mother had responded to his prayer so quickly, made him feel completely open and receptive.

Without wasting a moment, Balu moved closer to Mother and sat on the floor next to Her *peetham*. Mother looked at him with a beaming smile and said, "Amma knew that you had an intense desire to sit next to Her." Balu fixed his gaze on Mother's face and shed silent tears. When Mother saw this, Her compassion towards Her child overflowed, and She expressed this by gently putting Balu's head on Her lap. And as She kept his head cradled in Her lap, She continued to give *darshan* to the devotees.

From the temple veranda, Pai could be heard reciting the following *Amritanandamayi Stavamanjari* sloka as an introduction to a song:

*I prostrate before You, O Mother
Who is the Essence of Aum
the Infinite, the Eternal
Existence-Knowledge-Bliss, Absolute
that shines in the temple of the hearts of Sages...*

*Who brings joy
to upright and steadfast disciples
immersed in meditation...*

*Who instills in them
the fervent devotion
that arises from soulful devotional singing...*

*the Mother, who is adored
by those who are virtuous.*

Balu lifted his head from Mother's lap and once again looked at Mother's radiant face. As She threw a compassionate glance at him, Balu asked Her, "Amma, have I been with You in all Your previous incarnations?"

Mother smiled and replied, "Son, you have always been with Amma. Son, know that all those who are with Amma now were with Her in all Her previous incarnations. Otherwise, how could you feel this strong and spontaneous bond with Her?"

Question: "Amma, some say that it is the Guru who chooses the disciple; others say that the disciple chooses the Guru. Which is correct? Did You choose me or did I choose You? Did I find You or did You find me? Could You please clarify this?"

Mother: “Son, if Amma were to tell you that She chose you, would you believe it completely and blindly, without any doubts? No, Amma doesn’t think so. In your present state you may believe it for a little while, but it won’t take long before the mind starts raising its objections. It will apply the theory of cause and effect, and once that line of thinking is adopted, you will begin to analyze, thinking, ‘Okay, so Amma said that it was She who found me. But, if She found me, it must have been the effect of something. What, then, is the cause? The cause must be my *punya* (merit) or the *tapas* that I have performed.’ If you think in that way, the ego will slowly come crawling in.

“This may all seem very logical, but the best attitude for your spiritual growth would sound like this: ‘God chose me. My Master chose me. I was lost and I was found by my Master, my All-in-all.’”

Question: “Will I attain Self-Realization in this lifetime or will I have to be born again for that?”

Mother: “Son, will you be able to put forth enough effort to destroy your mind and all your desires in this lifetime? Amma will always be by your side, to guide you and to hold your hand. But will you be able to do your *sadhana* regularly without fail, as Amma tells you to do? If you can do this, it is Amma’s assumption that you will not be born again.

“Son, if you do your spiritual practices exactly as Amma instructs, you will definitely attain the state of

Self-Realization in three years. Amma can guarantee this. Then there will be no coming back. But the mind should disappear; the ego should die. If even a trace of the mind is left without being eliminated, you will have to come back.”

Question: “Amma, I am not afraid of coming back. I just want to be with You, even if I have to take many more births!”

Mother: “Son, if you really are with Amma during this lifetime, you will definitely be with Her in all Her future incarnations. There is no doubt about it.”

Question: “Amma, what do You mean by ‘if you really are with Amma’? Aren't I with You now?”

Mother: “Unconditional obedience to Amma is what it means to ‘really be with Her.’ Being in Amma’s physical presence, without being aware of the spiritual principles which She stands for, is not really being with Her - it is forgetting Her. Real remembrance of Amma is to obey Her words and to understand the spiritual import of those words, and to practice them. However, being in a *Mahatma’s* presence will cause purification to take place of its own accord.”

Balu looked up at Mother and said, “Amma, one last prayer. Bless me so that I may always be in Your Divine Presence.”

Mother dipped Her index finger into a small bowl of sandal paste. She then placed the tip of Her finger between Balu’s eyebrows and Balu felt immensely bliss-

ful. He closed his eyes, and as Mother continued to press Her finger against his third eye, he became absorbed in a state of deep meditation.

The brahmacharins were singing a song called *Brahmanda Pakshikal*.

*O Mother
You are the glorious Tree of Knowledge
The galaxies fly to You
like flocks of birds
Until I reach You
through the knowledge of my Self
let me grow in Your shade.*

*O Mother of Supreme Power
I worship You
knowing that the blue sky
is Your head
the earth is Your Feet
and the whole atmosphere
is Your body.*

*O Mother
who is glorified in all religions
who is the Essence of the four Vedas
and the Abode
into which all names and forms
finally dissolve
I prostrate before You
with all humility.*

At the end of the Devi Bhava, Mother called Dattan, the leper, to come up to Her for *darshan*. It was very touching and at the same time awe inspiring to see how Mother took care of him. He was given far more time and attention than any of the others.

Dattan went up to Mother and lay prostrate at Her feet. Mother raised him up and put his head on Her lap. After some time She gently lifted his head and held him against Her shoulder. She then began to lick his festering wounds with Her tongue. Such an extreme act of compassion can hardly be imagined. For those who witnessed what was taking place, it was both horrifying and deeply moving at the same time. One devotee who was standing in the temple fainted at the sight and had to be carried out of there. Mother then asked the rest of the devotees to leave the temple. What She did next was astounding. She made Dattan bend his head down, and holding his head between Her hands, She bit into a deeply infected wound on his forehead, and after having sucked out the blood and pus from it, She spat it out into a basin which Bri. Saumya held out next to Her. After repeating this scene a few more times, She took some sacred ash and rubbed it over the leper's body. Mother hugged him one more time with great affection, and finally walked over to the open doors of the temple and began to shower the devotees with flower petals, which marked the end of the Devi Bhava. It should also be mentioned here, that

Dattan was completely cured. His only medicine was Mother's saliva. All his wounds disappeared and only the scars remained on his body.

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CHAPTER TWELVE

NOT MY RIGHT BUT HIS GRACE

*I*t was the day after Devi Bhava, and the Ashram was therefore less crowded. Balu, Venu, Ramakrishnan, Rao, Srikumar and Pai¹⁰ were sitting next to Mother, who had just come down from Her room, and was sitting in front of the meditation hall. Balu took the opportunity to ask, “Amma, last night during Devi Bhava, when I asked You whether it is the disciple who chooses the Master or the Master who chooses the disciple, You said that it is always good for the spiritual growth of the disciple to have the attitude that, ‘God has chosen me,’ or ‘My Master has chosen me.’ Can you tell us a little more about this attitude?”

Mother: “Son, if you think that you were the one who chose your Master, it will make you feel egoistic. You cannot choose your Master unless he wants you to. It would be conceited to think, ‘I have chosen my Mas-

¹⁰Balu is today known as Swami Amritaswarupananda,
Venu=Swami Pranavamritananda,
Ramakrishnan=Swami Ramakrishnananda,
Rao=Swami Amritatmananda, Srikumar=Swami Purnamritananda,
Pai = Swami Amritamayananda.

ter.' Then you could also abandon him whenever you wish. But how could you possibly choose your Master who is completely beyond your understanding? Before you choose or reject anything, you try to understand if it is good or bad for you. If it is good you choose it, otherwise you don't. You can also use it for some time and then get rid of it whenever you wish. There is a lot of thinking involved in that kind of choosing. But, whenever a disciple falls helplessly in love with the Master, at first sight, there is no thinking process involved. The Master's spiritual attraction is so great that the disciple becomes his. Thinking is an obstruction to real love and self-surrender.

"The Master, however, is not a thing, nor is he a limited person. The true Master is your very own Self, the Self of everything. He is infinity.

"How can the river choose the ocean? It flows helplessly towards the ocean. All rivers are like that: they are carried away towards the ocean and they merge with it. The pull of the ocean is so infinitely powerful that the rivers just have to flow in that direction.

"Similarly, you are helplessly being pulled towards the Supreme Master. His infinite power attracts you and so you flow towards him. The power of the Master precludes any choice on your part. The power is his alone. It is his Grace for which you cannot take any credit, whatsoever.

"You are just a tiny bit of iron filing which is help-

lessly being attracted towards the all-powerful magnet of the Master's spiritual glory. An iron filing has no choice. Once it is within the magnetic force of the magnet, it cannot choose whether to come or go. As the magnet draws it, it simply has to move in that direction. Similarly, you are being helplessly drawn towards the Supreme Master, and you have no choice. It just happens.

"The Master picks you out of the dirt and uplifts you to the same state in which he himself is constantly dwelling. Therefore, the right attitude is to think, 'I didn't choose him. He chose me.' But there is also a danger in thinking that you have been chosen by your Master, because then you will slowly start to feel, 'I am the chosen one. So, I must be special in some way.' This too is dangerous, because with that sort of attitude you easily forget about the part that the Master's Grace plays in all of this. You may think that because your Master wanted you, it is your absolute right to be his disciple, and this can easily inflate your ego. The ego of a spiritual person is far more subtle than the ego of a person who is leading a worldly life.

"It is much better if you think, 'It is only because of my Master's Grace that I am here with him. It is not my right. It is his gift. It was the Master who found me. I was useless, I was completely lost and without hope, but due to his Grace and compassion I am here now. I don't deserve anything, but he is showering me

with his divine Grace anyway.” This attitude will make you humble, and is very helpful in eradicating the ego. The most important thing is to constantly retain this awareness. As the mind and the pull of the *vasanas* are very powerful, it is easy to fall prey to them and forget about the Master’s Grace. To become humble is the very goal of spiritual life. Humility alone is the way to God. On the other hand, if you feel that you were chosen by your Master, you may soon start thinking, ‘There are so many people in the world, and yet my Master chose *me*. I must have acquired a lot of merit or spiritual power in my previous life. That must be why he chose me and no one else. No one, except me, is capable of doing the work that I am doing in this world. He wanted me and that is why I am here.’

“Such thoughts can overwhelm you and soon you become worse than anybody else. You will have a huge ego, and this is dangerous. Such an attitude will make you feel very self-important. Your personality will be disfigured by your ego. A true devotee or disciple will have great humility and because of this he will also possess a certain spiritual beauty. The beauty of spirituality lies in humility.

“The Master chooses you in order to save you. The fact that he has chosen you should be considered as a gift, which you don’t actually deserve. It is not your right - it is his grace and his blessing. If you do not have this attitude, the ego will crawl in, without you

even knowing it.

“One should have the humility to think, ‘I am nothing. You are everything.’ Only when you feel that you are nothing will you become everything. If you feel that you are something you will be nothing.

BEWARE OF THE SUBTLE EGO

Question: “Amma, You said that the ego of a spiritual person is very subtle and that it may even push us back into the world. Could You please explain this?”

Mother: “Children, just the thought, ‘I am spiritual, I am spiritually advanced,’ or ‘I am a renunciate,’ can be a big stumbling block to your spiritual progress. Such thoughts are also part of the ego, but a more subtle form of ego. You may think, ‘I am great because I have renounced everything. Look at all those worldly people out there who are still immersed in the quagmire of materialism. They are so ignorant!’ You may feel that those who live in the world are far beneath you. If you cherish such thoughts, it only shows that you are mentally immature. It means that you are ignorant. Those who live in the world may be ignorant, but they are not on the spiritual path; whereas, you are supposed to be on the spiritual path and yet you are still spiritually ignorant. Such thoughts are of the ego and need to be uprooted. If you are under the guidance of a real Master, you cannot feel this sort of pride. The Master will

immediately notice your pride and uproot it. A subtle ego is much more powerful and harder to destroy.

“A worldly person is proud of his achievements in life and likes to show them off. His ego is born out of his attachment to the objects of the external world. He has a big, beautiful house which he is attached to and feels very proud of. The house is excellent food for his ego. He is also proud of his power, wealth and reputation, and he sometimes expresses this on a large scale. You can experience it in his presence, even the way he walks and talks will have a certain air of pride about it. The more wealth and power you have, the more ego you will have. Whether you are wealthy or poor, the difference in ego lies only in degree.

“Also, the more thoughts you have, the more ego you will have. This is why scholars, thinkers and speakers are often more egotistic than others. People who enjoy a high position in society are often very egotistical, unless they have an attitude of self-surrender. They are used to being praised by the public, for the exceptional work that they are doing. Usually, the more famous you are, the more egotistic you are, because the ego grows with all the recognition. This is what happens to many people who are successful in the world. In such people, the ego is quite obvious; you will recognize it by their speech and by their actions. They cannot hide it; they are so full of ego that there is nowhere for their egos to hide. However, there are also people

who have achieved fame and recognition, and yet they have remained humble. These are rare exceptions.

“It is quite natural for people who lead a materialistic life to be egoistic. It is pardonable, because they don’t have the proper spiritual understanding. This is not the case with spiritual people who have dedicated their lives solely for that purpose. It has to be their way of life. They are supposed to be humble and devoid of any ego.

“Unfortunately, it may happen that a spiritual person learns how to hide his ego and pretends to be very humble. He tries not to show that he has an ego, because he knows that expressing it outwardly is wrong so far as a spiritual seeker is concerned. He knows that people won’t appreciate it. It is also like this in the world, but there is a difference. In the world, once you are recognized as an expert in some field, the country needs you and you can afford to be egoistic. You can speak and act selfishly, but you are safe because of your expertise. Your employers, or those who have appointed you, cannot simply throw you out, unless they have a very good substitute. But in spiritual life it is not this way. Your spiritual advancement is recognized by the humility, egolessness and wisdom that you express.

“If a so-called spiritual person behaves in a very egoistic way, he will not be respected by people. He will only acquire a bad reputation within the spiritual

community. Knowing this, you will learn to suppress your anger and all other negative tendencies, and you act and behave like a spiritually mature person. This becomes far too mental and subtle. As long as you express it outwardly, it exists on a gross level. But when you consciously keep it hidden within and act differently on the outside, it becomes subtle and very dangerous.

“You can express your ego outwardly. That, too, can be harmful, but it is less so, because at least people will not be deluded. They will realize that you are egoistic and be warned that you may harbor a lot of anger, hatred, and other negative feelings within you. They can then be careful of you and keep their distance, if need be. But what if you skillfully learn how to hide your ego and pretend to be a yogi? People will then be seriously deluded, and that would amount to real cheating. But such hypocrisy cannot last. It cannot be hidden for long because soon, your ego will begin to expose itself. What is hidden within must become manifest sooner or later, no matter how much one may try to do otherwise. It is just a question of time.

“It is like a mother-in-law with her newly arrived daughter-in-law.¹¹ She will give her son’s wife a lot of love and attention in the beginning. She will not allow her daughter-in-law to work in the kitchen, or to clean the house or do any work outside, as if she were a

¹¹ In India it is customary for a newly wed couple to go and live with the husband’s family.

precious stone which would wear away if it is used too much. The mother-in-law can be heard telling her, 'My daughter, don't even think of such things! There are many others in the house who can do the work. Just sit down and relax.' When the oldest son's wife hears her mother-in-law say such things to the newcomer, she smiles to herself, for she knows from experience that it is just a big show; she knows that her mother-in-law will soon start showing her real nature. And this is exactly what happens. Within a week or two, the same mother-in-law, who until now has been so loving and concerned about her new daughter-in-law, can be heard shouting at her, 'You lazy girl! Do you think you are the master of this house? We are not your servants! Go and clean the kitchen!' This sort of thing is not unusual in Indian families, though sometimes it is the other way around, and the family will become the victim of the daughter-in-law. During the first few weeks, she will be very gentle and loving, but it will not take long for her real nature to emerge.

"This is what happens with people who hide their ego, just to win people over and gain control over them. They may succeed in hiding their ego for some time, but it will soon become manifest. Their real nature will be expressed of its own accord.

"A person who wears the false mask of a spiritually advanced person does not know what terrible harm he is doing. He is misleading others, and also paving the

way for his own destruction. A number of sincere people may get trapped in his deception. And once they realize that they have been misled, they will lose their faith. From then on, they will be suspicious of everything that has anything to do with spirituality. They will even be suspicious of genuine masters. Think of the enormous harm that these so-called spiritual leaders are doing to society and the human race. The ego of such a person is very subtle and is difficult to get rid of. He believes that he is great. This happens naturally because he feels proud of the big crowds who attend his speeches and the praise people shower upon him. People say to him, 'Oh, you are so great and knowledgeable! What an eloquent speaker you are! You have such a presence!' With all this praise and adoration, he himself will begin to think that he is great. This thought becomes more and more ingrained in him, and as it gets deeper it also becomes subtler. He learns how to hide it and he pretends that he is great. But it won't take long for that which lies hidden within to reveal itself externally. Such people are easily fooled by others, and at times they even act foolishly."

THE BLISS-INTOXICATED MOTHER

There were clouds in the sky. It looked as if it were about to rain. The sound of the ocean waves grew louder and a strong, cool wind came blowing through the air.

Mother looked up at the sky and at once became deeply absorbed in a spiritual mood. By now the sun was completely covered by dark rain clouds. Though it was only eleven-thirty in the morning, it looked as if night were approaching. Soon it began to drizzle. Bri. Gayatri came down from Mother's room with an umbrella and held it over Mother's head. The residents didn't move but continued to sit in the rain next to Mother. Within a few seconds the rain was pouring down. But Mother continued to sit in the same spot with Her gaze still directed towards the sky.

A few minutes later Mother got up and walked into the rain, and She began to play like a child. She jumped about and danced in circles, now and then pausing in the pouring rain to look up at the sky. She would stand with Her arms outstretched, Her open palms facing up towards the sky as if She were trying to catch the rain drops in Her hands. All the residents were standing a few yards away, watching this beautiful scene.

Mother was by now completely drenched. Gayatri stood helplessly by Her side with the folded umbrella in her hands. Suddenly, Mother joined Her palms together above Her head, and began to turn around in a circle. And as She did so, She recited the following verse.

Anandam Saccitanandam
Anandam Paramanandam

Anandam Saccitanandam
Anandam Brahmanandam

The Bliss of Pure Existence/Consciousness
The Bliss of Supreme Bliss
The Bliss of Pure Existence/Consciousness
The Bliss of Absolute and Undivided Bliss

Long after the song had come to an end, Mother continued to circle round and round. Her palms were still joined above Her head and Her eyes were closed. There was no sign of Her having any body consciousness at all. She was transported to another world. Her face was radiant and enchanting. There was a beautiful, divine smile on Her lips, and as She continued Her dance, rain water dripped through Her black, cascading hair and streamed down Her cheeks.

Nobody knew what to do. Somebody suggested that they carry Her inside. But Br. Nealu thought that they shouldn't touch Mother as long as She was in that state of bliss. While they were discussing among themselves what to do, Mother slowly stopped Her dance and lay down on the ground, which by now had become a pool of muddy water. And as She lay in the rain without moving, the spiritual glow continued to radiate from Her face.

The rain continued to pour as heavily as before and the residents grew increasingly anxious. Bri. Gayatri who was sitting next to Mother on the soaking wet ground, trying to shield Her with the umbrella, in-

sisted that they should carry Mother inside. Finally everyone agreed and did as she directed.

As soon as Mother had been brought into Her room, Gayatri requested everyone to leave so that she could remove Mother's wet clothes. Everybody left immediately and the door was closed. Mother remained in the state of *samadhi* for a long time.

What can one say about such a mysterious personality, who at one moment is the great Master and the next an innocent child, and who then again, a few seconds later, slips into the highest state of *samadhi*?

On account of constant absorption in Brahman, freed from the sense of reality of external objects, only seemingly enjoying them when offered by others, like one sleepy or like a baby, perceiving the world as something seen in a dream and recognizing it only now and then, such a man is indeed rare. He is the enjoyer of the fruits of untold merit and is truly held blessed and revered on earth.

- VIVEKACHOODAMANI

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CHAPTER THIRTEEN

DIVINITY CANNOT BE BORROWED

The story of Paundra Vasudeva

Today, Mother was sitting in the little room that served as a library. The question about the subtlety of the spiritual ego was raised again. One of the brahmacharins asked, “Amma, yesterday, while You were talking about the subtlety of the ego of a spiritual person, You said that sometimes such people even act like fools. How can they go to that extreme?”

Mother: “Children, why not? When people get carried away by their desire to become famous and to be admired by others they sometimes act foolishly, because when the mind becomes obsessed with something, you lose your power of discrimination. The mind loses its sense of clarity and you become an easy tool in the hands of other people. In your desire to be recognized for your greatness and for people to admire you and sing your praises, you lose your power to express yourself spontaneously and your behavior becomes unnatural. You may begin to believe that what others say about you is true, and that unless you act in a certain way,

you will not be considered to be great. And so, you end up acting foolishly. When you are that mesmerized by the admiration accorded to you by others, even if somebody should happen to give you some excellent advice, it won't serve any purpose, because you will not be able to look at the truth.

“Children, do you know the story about Paundra Vasudeva, who pretended that he was Krishna? Paundra Vasudeva was the king of a country called Karurusha, at the time when Krishna reigned over Dwaraka. Paundra was too attached to his role as a king and he had an intense desire to be worshipped by his subjects. Both he and the king of Kashi were against Sri Krishna; they were jealous of Krishna's fame and the way people adored and worshipped Him. In his intense craving for fame and recognition, Paundra, with the help of the king of Kashi, finally conspired a plot against the Lord. They made a public announcement saying that the Krishna who lived in Dwaraka was a fake, and that he was not the real incarnation of Lord Vishnu. They further declared that the real Krishna, the real incarnation of Vishnu, was none other than Paundra himself.

“When people heard this they said that if their king Paundra was the real incarnation of Lord Vishnu, he should be holding the divine signs, namely the conch, discus, mace and lotus flower, in his four sacred hands. In response to this, Paundra, who by this time had

begun to believe that he really was Lord Vishnu, would on certain occasions fix two wooden arms to his shoulders, so that he appeared to have four arms, just like the Lord. He also made sure that he was carrying replicas of the four sacred signs. Paundra got so carried away that he even had a Garuda made out of wood.¹² Unfortunately, the wooden eagle couldn't fly; instead, it was placed on top of the royal chariot. Paundra commanded his wife to dress up like the Goddess Lakshmi and the two of them travelled around the city, blessing people from their perch on top of the wooden Garuda. Paundra became the laughing stock of the country. Many people obviously thought he had gone mad.

“Those of Paundra's subjects who happened to admire Lord Krishna were angered at this shameless, self-aggrandizing declaration of their king, but they didn't dare say anything against him, directly. Instead, they mocked him by making loud comments whenever they saw him on the streets, on top of his peculiar chariot. They would say, ‘Oh, our King really does look like Krishna! He should wear a crown with a peacock feather tucked in it, and he ought to be holding a flute in his beautiful hands. And think how enchanting it would be if his body were of a dark blue color! In fact, he should ask for all the divine weapons that the fake Krishna in Dwaraka is carrying. That Krishna has no

¹² The divine eagle, Garuda, is the *vahana* (vehicle) ridden by Lord Vishnu.

right to those weapons. After all, they don't belong to Him. The real owner is our own king, the great Paundra Vasudeva.'

"Whenever Paundra went out, he would be met by such comments. Even the people who were close to him - the royal family and all his courtiers - began making such comments. The king got so carried away by what he heard that he painted his body blue and started dressing like Sri Krishna. He walked around in an exact replica of Krishna's costume, holding a flute in his hands, even though he had no idea how to play the flute. And he gradually came to believe that he really was Vishnu, or Krishna. Sometimes he was Vishnu and at other times he was Krishna.

"But the drama was not yet over. Considering the comments of his subjects to be a truism, he also wanted to acquire all the divine weapons of Sri Krishna. He consequently sent a messenger to Dwaraka saying, 'Cowherd, You are nothing but a fake. Hand over all the divine weapons, including the divine discus, which rightfully belong to me - the real Krishna, the true incarnation of Lord Vishnu - or be prepared to die in the battlefield.'

"When Krishna received the message He said, 'Very well. But I would like to hand the weapons over in person. Ask Paundra to come and receive them.' Sri Krishna wanted to teach the foolhardy king a good lesson.

“Paundra arrived at the prearranged meeting place, along with his entire army, prepared to fight if necessary. He was dressed in the costume of Lord Vishnu. When Paundra and his army arrived, Sri Krishna was already waiting for him. As soon as Paundra saw Krishna, he shouted at the top of his voice, ‘You fake! Don’t try to play Your tricks on me! Surrender the divine weapons and the discus, or be prepared to die!’ In the battle which followed, Sri Krishna destroyed Paundra’s entire army. When it was all over, Sri Krishna stood holding the divine discus with His index finger. With a mischievous smile on His face, He said, ‘Paundra, I have come for no other reason than to give you this weapon. Here it comes! Take it, it’s yours!’ With these words, Krishna released the divine discus from His finger. You can imagine what happened. The discus sliced through Paundra’s neck and he fell dead to the ground. Thus the king’s foolish attachment to fame and self-glorification was destroyed by Lord Krishna, the Perfect Master, and he was released from the self-created ego.”

Question: “Does this mean that only a Perfect Master, who is beyond the mind and the ego, can save a person from the grip of the subtle ego?”

Mother: “That is right. An extremely powerful weapon like the divine discus is needed to pierce the subtle ego. But this weapon is under the sole control of the Perfect Master. It is the weapon of true knowledge, the weapon

of the Master's omniscience, omnipotence and all-pervasiveness.

“A person who has a mad craving for fame, and for power and prestige, will want to grab everything in the world. He will become so foolish that he might even declare, ‘I am the greatest and therefore I have a right to everything.’ He will lose all his power of discrimination and will be completely clouded by his thoughts of power and self-glorification.

“People who have been blinded in this way are likely to forget God. In their mad pursuit to gain the respect and admiration of others, they sometimes challenge God. But when they do this, it also means that they are about to be exposed.

“Divinity cannot be borrowed or imitated. Divine love and other divine qualities cannot be imitated.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

This night was a great festive occasion. It was *Tiruvatira*, a special festival which is celebrated all over Kerala. In India, Lord Shiva and the Goddess Parvati are considered to be the Universal Father and Mother. On the day of Tiruvatira, the married women of Kerala take a vow of fasting during which they pray for the well being of their husbands. It is also part of the tradition that they should stay awake that night, praying and singing to the glory of Shiva and Parvati.

A group of elderly women from the village and some women who were staying at the Ashram were standing in a circle, in the front yard of the temple. They were about to begin the celebration with the *Tiruvatirakali*, an ancient, traditional folk dance performed by the women of Kerala.

All the ashramites were sitting in front of the temple. Mother was sitting under the mailanchy tree, surrounded by a dozen children. Some of them were from the neighborhood, others were the children of devotees. Mother was in a playful mood; one could hear the sound of laughter and loud conversation coming from Her direction. Everyone was more interested in what Mother was doing, than in watching the dance. But even though all eyes were fixed on Her, everyone stayed

instinctively at a distance, not wanting to go near and so disturb the beautiful picture of Mother and the children.

The older women now began the traditional singing and dancing. They sang *Thirukathakal Padam...*

*O Goddess Durga
O Kali
remove my bad fate
Each day I beg to receive a vision
of Your form.*

*Let me sing in praise of Your sacred acts
Please give me a boon
and when I sing of Your glories
please come into my heart.*

*O Essence of the Vedas
I do not know the methods of meditation,
and my music lacks a melody.
Have mercy on me
Let me immerse myself in bliss.*

*.
You are Gayatri,
You are fame and Liberation,
Kartyayani, Haimavati, and Kakshayani¹³
You are the very soul of Realization
my sole refuge.*

¹³ Names of Devi

O Devi

*give me the power to speak
on the essential ideas.*

*I understand that without You,
the embodiment of the Universe,
Shiva, the Causative Principle,
would exist no more.*

THIS IS 'THAT'

The song reached a very high tempo. At this point Mother got up from the place where She had been sitting with the children and went over to the women who were dancing. She looked very excited and at the same time divinely intoxicated as She joined in the dance. There was an innocent expression on Her face which made Her look like a divine child among the dancing women. The women were overjoyed to have Mother dancing in their midst.

At one stage of the dance, two ladies facing each other made a pair and clapped their open palms together. Mother who was transported to another world was still dancing but in Her own blissful way. Her eyes were closed and both hands were held in divine *mudras*. After dancing in circles with the ladies for some time, Mother moved towards the center of the dance where She continued to dance blissfully, while the devotees were singing a song, glorifying the Goddess Parvati.

After some time Mother stopped dancing and came

to a standstill. Her external form and Her countenance were radiating with a divine glow. She looked exactly as She did during Devi Bhava. It was evident that She was still absorbed in Her divine mood. The devotees continued to dance and to sing, one song after another, until Mother finally sat down on the ground, still in that indrawn state.

The devotees had a strong feeling that Mother was in the bhava of the Goddess Parvati. Who knows? Perhaps She was revealing that mood for the benefit of the devotees. Nothing is impossible for a soul who is one with the Supreme Brahman. Such a person can manifest any aspect of the Divine at any time he wants.

When Mother finally returned to Her normal self, one of the devotees asked Her, “Amma, we strongly felt that You were in the divine mood of Goddess Parvati?” Mother pointed first at Herself and then upward, as She replied, “This is That.” After a pause She continued, “Whether or not it is manifested, this is That. Don’t mistake this for the body. The body is only a cover. There is infinity beyond the cover.”

The incomprehensible expression on Mother’s face and the words that She uttered seemed to be coming directly from the highest plane of consciousness. If one penetrated a little, it was not difficult to discern that Mother, though not directly, was saying that She was in the divine mood of the Goddess Parvati. The depth of such a declaration was so profound and piercing

that everyone was deeply touched in the innermost recesses of their hearts.

THE IMPORTANCE OF FEMININE QUALITIES IN A SEEKER

A few minutes passed in silence until one visiting devotee was unable to resist the temptation to ask a question. “Amma, I have heard of two kinds of disciples: those who are predominantly intellectual and those who are more feminine in nature. I don’t think that I have understood this properly. Could you kindly enlighten me on this point?”

Mother: Spiritual realization cannot be attained without love, devotion and an openness which allows one to receive true knowledge from a real Master. A seeker who is predominantly intellectual in nature must therefore try to create a balance between the intellect and the heart. He must have immense love for his Master and at the same time he should have a proper knowledge about his Master’s omniscient nature.

If you are too intellectual, it could create an imbalance and you will become too egoistic. Intellect is reasoning. It can only dissect and cut asunder. It cannot unite. It won’t help faith and love to develop, which is an essential factor for a spiritual seeker’s inner growth. Too much intellect is not good for a seeker, because he will lack love and devotion towards his Master. Without

love and an attitude of self-surrender and humility, the Master cannot impart true knowledge to you.

“It would be difficult to discipline a seeker who is predominantly intellectual, unless an all-powerful Master takes charge of him. Only a perfect Master can break his ego and bring out the real essence that is his true nature. He may then outwardly retain his intellectual qualities, but within he will be deeply devotional; there will be a perfect balance between the two qualities.

“When the Master has worked on the ego, the ego becomes useful to the world. His characteristics will be refined and well moulded, and by the Master’s Grace, his ego will be well under control.

“When the ego, through the Master’s Grace, is perfectly under control, the disciple does everything in the Master’s name. The Master does everything through him, and he himself has no place in what he does. His attitude will be, ‘I am only an instrument. My all-powerful Master does everything through me.’ He attributes everything to the Master and will take no credit for anything. But at the same time, he will have an adventurous mind, tremendous courage and the power to undertake seemingly impossible tasks and drive them to the goal.

“But this chiselling, moulding and rebuilding of the disciple’s ego can only be done by a Satguru. If such a seeker is on his own or if he is being trained by an imperfect guru, it will only create a further

imbalance in his nature, in some way or other. This in turn will do a lot of harm to others and to society as a whole. He will soon try to become a guru himself. You may see him trying to form his own group of disciples and building his own ashram.

“In Hanuman, the great devotee of Lord Rama, one can find a beautiful blending of both masculine and feminine qualities. He did everything in the name of Rama, his beloved Lord, and he took no credit for anything. Even though Hanuman succeeded in doing very difficult tasks, he was never proud of any of his feats. On the contrary, he remained the humble and obedient servant of his Master, Lord Rama. ‘Not by my power and strength, but by Lord Rama’s Grace,’ was always Hanuman’s attitude.

Disciples with feminine qualities are entirely different. They do not want to go out and preach, nor do they want any attention or respect. They do not even worry about attaining Self-Realization. Their only wish is to stay in the Master’s physical presence and to serve him. That is their *tapas*. They know of no spirituality higher than that. For them, there is no higher Truth than their Master. ‘My Master, my World, my All in all,’ is their attitude. Such a disciple’s heart is full of love and attachment towards his Master. This relationship cannot be explained through logic or reasoning. It can only be compared to the love of the *gopis* towards Krishna: Love, love, love and love. Overflow-

ing love. That's it. They don't care about anything else."

Mother then shared a story about one of Buddha's disciples.

"One day a certain disciple suddenly disappeared. Nobody could find him anywhere. Seven days passed, but still nobody knew where he was. Then one day, Buddha found him lying on the roof of the ashram. Buddha knew that he was there and knew that the disciple had attained enlightenment. Buddha held his hand and said, 'I know that you have attained the state of *nirvana*.'

"The disciple said, 'My beloved Master, I know that it has happened, I don't need any confirmation from You. In fact, I am afraid of Your confirmation, because the next thing You say to me will be, 'Now that you have attained *nirvana*, you must go out and preach, you must spread the message of Truth throughout the world.' I am afraid, my Lord, because I would much rather have to stay in Your presence remaining in a state of ignorance, than have to leave You and go out into the world fully realized.' "

"This is the attitude of a disciple who is endowed with feminine qualities. He will always remain deeply in love with his Master. The heart of a feminine disciple is so full of love for the Master that he always wants to remain in the Master's physical presence. That is the fulfillment of his life. That is his highest realization."

A TRUE MASTER IS
THE UNIVERSE AND BEYOND

Question: “Amma, I have heard you say that bowing down in utter humility to the Master is equal to bowing down to all of existence. Please tell us what You mean by that?”

Mother: “Children, only when you become completely egoless can you bow down to all of creation. When there is no ego, you go beyond the limitations of the mind and become the all-pervasive Self. Once you behold everything as your own Self, you can only bow down and accept. When you go beyond the ego, it means that you become nothing. But, like space you become everything, you become all of creation.

“Once, when Krishna was a child, He was playing with His friends. They were playing with all sorts of imaginary things, just as small children will do, and they were having great fun. Krishna was going to eat with His friends. One of the children served a meal of sand to everyone, imagining that it was rice. They were supposed to only pretend that they were eating, but Krishna actually ate the sand. Krishna’s older brother, Balaram, and the others immediately ran and told Yashoda, the Lord’s foster mother, what had happened. Yashoda seized Krishna and asked Him to open His mouth. Lo and behold! She saw the entire universe inside His mouth. She saw the sun, the moon and the

stars, the Milky Way and all the galaxies. She saw mountains, valleys, forests, trees and animals. Yashoda beheld the entire universe within Krishna.

“In a similar manner, during the battle at Kurukshetra, while Krishna was giving Arjuna the great sermon of the Bhagavad Gita, the Lord showed His universal form to Arjuna, when he expressed a desire to see it. Arjuna then also saw the whole universe within the Lord’s form. He even saw the Pandava and Kaurava forces on the Lord’s body.

“What does this mean? It means that the entire universe is contained within the true Master. Krishna was a true Master, and a true Master is God. His consciousness is one with the Universal Consciousness. That Consciousness is one and the same Consciousness that shines in and through all of creation. Such a great Master has an infinite number of bodies, an infinite number of eyes. He sees, hears, smells, eats, and breathes through every body. He is infinity itself. Surrendering to such a Master with complete humility is the same thing as surrendering to all of existence, and bowing down to the whole of creation.

“In that state you realize that nothing is different or separate from you. Bowing down to all of existence is also a state of total acceptance. You stop fighting with the situations that arise in your life. You fight and struggle only when you have an ego, only when you are identified with the body. When you shake off the

shackles of the ego, no more fighting is possible. You can only accept.

“While an egotistic person considers everyone except himself to be an ignorant fool, a true *Mahatma* beholds everyone as an extension of his own Self. In the state of Self-Realization one cannot reject anything - one can only accept. Space accepts everything, whether good or bad. A river accepts everything, and the ocean accepts everything. You can accommodate anything and everything when you become as vast as the universe. When your mind and ego disappear, you become infinity.

“Space and Nature accept the polluted air from factories as well as the sweet fragrance of flowers. They embrace everything. Likewise, a true *Mahatma* welcomes everything, both negative and positive. He accepts everyone, and out of his unconditional love and infinite compassion he gives only grace and blessings in return.

“Children, have you heard this story? An unmarried village girl once gave birth to a child. At first she refused to tell anyone who the father was, but after repeated questioning she finally named a highly respected spiritual Master, who lived at the outskirts of the village. The girl’s parents, followed by the villagers, stormed into the Master’s house. They insulted him, they beat him up and accused him of being a hypocrite. They brought the baby to him and ordered him to take care of it. The Master took the baby in his arms, looked at it lovingly

and said, 'Very well. So be it.' From then on, the *Mahatma* looked after the baby with great care. He treated it with as much love and tenderness as a mother towards her own child. The Master's reputation was ruined. He was shunned by all the villagers and by his own disciples. Yet, even after everyone had abandoned him, the Master said calmly, 'Very well. So be it.' A year passed by. The girl who had given birth to the child was being troubled by a guilty conscience, and finally confessed that the father of the child was the young man next door and not the innocent saint. Her parents, the villagers and the disciples were filled with remorse. They all went to see the *Mahatma* and fell at his feet, asking him to forgive them. And they asked him to return the child. The unperturbed *Mahatma* smiled as he handed them the child. He blessed everyone and once again said calmly, 'Very well. So be it.'

"This is the attitude of a true *Mahatma*. He bows down to existence. It is not his nature to reject anything. He does not say no to life or any of life's experiences. He simply says yes to everything that life brings him. He does not curse or take revenge; he only forgives and blesses.

"With the exception of human beings, all of creation stands as an example of thankfulness to the Creator for the infinite blessings He showers upon it. Even birds and animals live their lives in gratitude. Nothing errs from its own nature, whether it be of the plant or

animal kingdom. Everything lives according to the laws of nature. But so-called intelligent human beings are breaking the laws and disturbing the harmony of nature. They disturb the life of other living beings and other aspects of creation.

“God has blessed man with an abundance of gifts, but man turns everything into a curse. This life is a wonderful blessing. Our mind and every limb of our body, our health and our riches - all are blessings bestowed on us by God. But what are we doing with these blessings? We use our hands to do wrong actions, our legs carry us to prohibited places, we use our eyes to look at ugly things, with our minds we make unrighteous plans and think ill of others, we use our intellect to invent destructive things, and whatever wealth we have, we use it only for our own selfish purposes. We have made life a curse for ourselves and for others.

“All creatures once approached Lord Brahma, the Creator. They all had an intense desire to escape from the sorrow and suffering of life. The pig stepped forward first. With tears rolling down his cheeks he pleaded with the Lord, “Oh Lord of all creation, is there any escape from this suffering? Is there any hope for my species?” The creator nodded positively and said, “Yes, my child. Of course.” Next came the bullock, the dog and the elephant. They all cried and asked the same question. And to all of them, the Creator said, ‘There is hope for every one of you.’ Then, man stepped for-

ward with the same request. Lord Brahma looked at man, and suddenly the Creator Himself burst into tears.”

An uproarious laughter followed. When it had quietened down, Mother said, “Today is Tiruvatira. We are supposed to sing in praise of Shiva and Parvati. So, let us now sing and dance. Mother then spontaneously started to sing a song in the exalted mood of supreme devotion. Everybody responded to Mother’s singing with great love and enthusiasm. The song, *Indukaladhara*, glorifies Lord Shiva and the Goddess Parvati. Mother sang the refrain repeatedly in a very high tempo.

*Shambho Shankara Shambho Shankara
Shambho Shankara Shiva Shambho*

*O Lord Shiva
who carries the crescent moon
on His head
who keeps the Holy Ganges
in His matted hair locks
whose body is adorned with serpents
and whose fragrance is Divine
I prostrate
at the Holy Feet
of that Supreme Lord.*

*O Lord
who is the Primordial Cause
who is extremely compassionate
towards His devotees
The great God*

*who bestows auspicious boons
 who holds the trident
 and whose Feet are being worshipped
 also by celestial beings
 O Destroyer of all afflictions
 Shambho Shankara.....*

*O Lord of the Universe
 I take refuge at Your feet
 O Lord, Beloved of Parvati
 O compassionate One
 Remove my endless sorrows
 and give me refuge
 at Your Feet.*

Everyone seemed to be in ecstasy. At one point Mother got up and began to dance, and everybody else also got up.

The devotees clapped their hands and sang loudly, forming a perfect circle around Mother. As they sang the words, *Shambho Shankara Shambho Shankara...*, they moved slowly and rhythmically around Mother. Mother remained in the middle of the circle dancing in supreme bliss.

Living with a great Master is an indescribable experience. It is like a constant festival, and each moment is a celebration. The word festival in Sanskrit is *utsavam*. The original word is *utsravam*, which means to rise up and flow, or to overflow. All festivals are symbolic of the overflowing of pure bliss and consciousness; especially the festivals that are celebrated in temples symbolize the overflow of spiritual energy and bliss.

The spiritual energy that is created in the temple through prayer, meditation, worship and chanting, fills the temple compound. It then rises above the four walls of the temple and overflows into the entire village or city where it is situated, purifying the whole environment. This is the idea behind the festivals that are celebrated in the temples every year.

In Mother's presence it happens unceasingly, for Her presence is a never-ending stream of divine energy, which overflows from Her being into the hearts of Her devotees. They experience that divine energy as they drink it in. This is what was happening now and what is happening always.

The dancing and singing continued, until Mother suddenly broke out of the circle and walked away toward the southern end of the Ashram, to the edge of the backwaters. The women immediately stopped dancing as if an electric switch had been turned off. Everybody turned to see what Mother was about to do, but nobody followed Her, because She gave the impression of wanting to be alone. One of the senior brahmacharins asked everyone to go and meditate. Within a few minutes they all dispersed and the whole night was spent in meditation and prayer.

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CHAPTER FIFTEEN

IS ATTACHMENT TO THE SATGURU'S FORM IMPORTANT?

*M*other was answering a question asked by one of the Western devotees.

Question: “Amma, some people are very attached to Your external form. They have so much love for You that they have an intense craving to be in Your physical presence. Whereas, there are others who do not have that kind of attachment, although they truly long to realize God. They love You, but they are of the opinion that being attached to Your form will cause pain, and because of this, they stay away. Amma, I am wondering if it's absolutely necessary to be attached to the Master's physical form, or is it sufficient to have the longing to realize God, without being attached to the external form?”

Mother: “The most important trait that a true *sadhak* should have is the attitude of complete self-surrender and acceptance. In the beginning stages of spirituality, it is hard to surrender and accept everything, especially if there is no one there to guide you, someone who you can look upon as an example. One should have at

least the willingness to surrender. But confusion can always arise as to whom or what one is supposed to surrender. How is it done? Until you have attained Self-Realization, you can only have a vague idea about all the aspects of spirituality. Your unsteady, suspicious mind will always raise doubts. If there is no one there to guide you, you will be confused and easily misled, and you don't know who to turn to. So to begin with, the need for a true Master arises; someone you can relate to and learn true surrender and acceptance from. Surrender and acceptance is not something that you are simply taught. You can not learn it by studying books, or from a school or university. It will develop within you from the tremendous inspiration you receive through the Master's physical presence, for the Master is the embodiment of all divine qualities. In the Master, you observe true surrender and acceptance, and thus you are given a real example that you can relate to, something tangible to commit yourself to. The immensely inspiring and transforming presence of the Master creates a deep love within you towards the Master, and a strong bond develops between you. Surrender and acceptance are usually born when pure love arises within.

JUST LIKE A CARING MOTHER

“In the primary stages of spiritual love there is the

attitude that, 'I am Your devotee, disciple, servant, or lover, and You are my Lord, Master, or Beloved.' In this initial period, you have fallen in love with the Master and thus cannot go beyond the form. You are so attached to the external form of the Master, that you don't want to go beyond it. Since this is the primary stage, you are slowly learning surrender and acceptance, but it is not yet complete. Spiritually, you are just a newborn baby, for you know nothing about the world of spirituality. Just as a baby drinks nothing but its mother's breast milk and knows of nothing but the warmth of her bosom, the spiritual baby in you knows only about the form and the physical closeness of your Master. As far as you are concerned, the Master's external form is the whole world of spirituality, and you become extremely attached to it. You need the physical presence and the warmth of your Master, and you will always crave it.

"Just as crying is the only manner of expression a child uses to let its wishes be known - be it hunger, thirst or pain - in the beginning stages of spirituality you have only one way of expressing your heart, and that is through shedding tears of intense longing. The Master will bind you with his love and he will become the absolute center of your life. In that experience of divine, unconditional love you have nothing to say. You will just silently shed tears of love and longing.

"As a spiritual baby, you are born into a totally

strange and unknown world. A baby needs warmth and its mother's milk. The mother knows the heart of her child and will do everything for him. Her breasts spontaneously fill with milk for the baby, whenever he is hungry. The mother intuitively knows if her baby is in any pain or discomfort. If the baby is lying in urine or excreta, the mother will come and bathe the child and change his clothes. The baby falls asleep listening to the sound of its mother's voice as she sings it a beautiful lullaby. Thus, the baby cannot live without its mother. A mother or a motherly person is absolutely necessary for a child's healthy growth. A real mother nourishes not only the child's body but also its mind. The child's world revolves around its mother. He is completely dependent on her. To him his mother is the most beautiful being in the whole world. Because he is so attached to her, all his dreams and fantasies are woven around her.

"In a similar way, the spiritual Master is everything to the *sadhak* at the beginning of his spiritual life. It can never be an exaggeration then to state that the Master is everything to a true disciple, even more than God.

"As a mother is the whole world to her baby, a true Master is everything to the disciple who is just a beginner, a baby on the spiritual path. And the Master has even more concern for his spiritual baby than a mother for her newborn babe.

"In the beginning stages of spirituality the disciple

assumes the role of a child towards the Master. For the disciple the whole of spirituality can be put in a nutshell: 'My Master, my All in all.' All his imagination and all his dreams about spirituality are woven around the Master. The disciple is extremely attached to his Master, always wanting his love and affection, his attention and his warmth, wanting always to remain in his physical presence. He cannot dream of a world or a life without his Master. This is a very spontaneous and natural feeling on the part of the devotee or disciple.

"But the baby never remains a baby, for he grows under the loving care of his mother. Likewise, the spiritual baby grows under the guidance of the Master, but his growth is internal. As the spiritual child grows, the mother in the Master slowly changes into the father, and the disciplinarian in the Master is invoked. This disciplining is meant to teach the disciple detachment, self-surrender and acceptance, not only to the external form of the Master, but towards all of creation. The Master is not just the body - he is the power that shines in and through everything, and therefore he teaches the disciple to bow down in humility before all of creation. This training serves to lift the disciple from narrow-mindedness to a higher level, allowing him to experience everything in a broader way. He will then realize that everything in existence is nothing but his own Master. Through the Master's training it will be impressed upon

the disciple that the Master is not just the physical human form, but the one Consciousness that pervades all of creation. As the disciple grows internally and matures, the Master lets him become more and more independent, that is, dependent on his own Self.

“In the final stage of love, the lover and the Beloved become one. Even beyond this, there comes a state where there is no love, lover or Beloved. That state is beyond expression. That is where the Master finally takes you.

“The way of a true Master is far beyond words. Unlike the mother in the world, a true Master never binds the disciple to him. On the contrary, he takes the disciple beyond all limitations and attachments of the body and makes him completely independent and free. Attachment to the Master’s body will eventually take you to complete detachment and freedom. Even though the disciple will feel a strong attachment towards the Master’s external form in the early stages of his development, you cannot call it bondage. Two people who dwell on the physical plane can bind each other, but a true Master cannot bind anyone, for the Master is not the body. He is not personal in the way we think of our personal friends or other people. The Master is both impersonal and personal. Bondage exists if you are attached only to the person’s body. When you love the Master’s external form you are not loving a limited individual, you are loving Pure Consciousness, and the Master will slowly reveal this to you. As your

awareness grows internally, that is, as your awareness of the Master's true nature deepens, you will gradually experience the Master's all-pervasive nature. You will come to know that the Master is not limited to the body, that he is the *Atma Shakti* immanent in everything. The Master himself will take you through this experience. His Grace will finally help you go beyond all bondage. That is why Amma says that your attachment to the Master's external form can never bind you."

A TRUE MASTER DESTROYS ALL PAIN

Question: "Is Amma saying that attachment to the Master's external form is necessary? But what about all the pain that some people are talking about - the pain connected to one's attachment to the Master?"

Mother: "Amma doesn't understand the strange concepts people have. You are saying that because there is some pain involved if one is attached to the Master's form, one does not want to be attached to it. Children, can you point somebody out to Amma who is not in pain in this world? People are constantly in pain, either physically or mentally. Ask anyone in the world and they will tell you, 'My body is suffering so much,' or 'My feelings are hurt,' or 'So and so didn't treat me with respect and I feel insulted.' Tell Amma who is not in pain! People are undergoing pain either internally or externally. What do you know about pain? Pain does not involve just

physical pain. The inner wounds are much more painful. There is no logic in you saying that attachment to the Master's external form will create pain. You are carrying deep wounds within you that have been caused by the past. All those wounds and the pain that comes from them are the result of your over attachment to the pleasures of the world. You are not bothered about your pus infected wounds and the pain they cause. All those wounds remain unhealed. Nobody can heal them, because you are carrying the wounds and tendencies from your previous lives. They are not just from this lifetime. No doctor or psychotherapist can heal those wounds. They cannot penetrate that deep into your mind and remove your wounds. Your wounds and tendencies lie deep within you; they are very old and have slowly started gnawing you from inside.

“People turn to experts to lessen their inner pain, but all the experts in the world, the doctors, scientists, psychologists etc., are people who dwell in their own minds, within the small world created by their egos. As long as they themselves have not penetrated into their own minds, how can they penetrate into others? As long as they themselves are in the grip of their mind and ego, how can they help others to go beyond the mind and ego? They too have deep wounds and strong tendencies, just like you. Such experts cannot help you to heal your wounds and remove the pain. Only a true Master, who is completely free from such limitations

and who is beyond the mind, can penetrate into your mind and treat all those unhealed wounds and remove all your strong tendencies and old habits.

“It is very strange to hear you say that there are those who do not want to be attached to the Master’s form because there is pain involved. You are already experiencing a tremendous amount of pain. In fact, you are the very embodiment of deep, agonizing pain. Attachment to the Master’s form cannot create any pain whatsoever, because he is not an object, nor is he a body or an ego. He is beyond. He cannot possibly hurt you, or enforce anything upon you. He is like space, like the boundless sky, and space cannot hurt you. So, do not project your preconceived ideas onto the Master, or try to judge him. The mind is inherently wrong; it is incapable of making any sound judgement. All your concepts and your judgement belong to your mind and have nothing to do with the perfect Master who is beyond the mind. A mind can perhaps judge another mind, but the mind cannot judge that which is beyond itself. A mind or ego can hurt another mind or ego, but someone who is beyond the mind cannot hurt anybody, because such a soul has no ego or judgement to direct towards anybody. Your pain lies within yourself, it does not come from the Master.

“When you are in the physical presence of a great Master, a *Satguru*, you are made to look at all your pain. It has been lying hidden within you and it now

becomes manifest, because a true Master is like the sun, a spiritual sun. There is no night in his presence. There is constant daylight. When the sun of the Master shines, it penetrates deep into your mind, and in its light you see everything within you. You see the hidden hell that lies within you, and now that you have seen it, you know that it is there. It has always been there, but you never knew it. How can you remove your hidden pain if you are not aware of its presence? It is important to know that the pain is coming from within you, and not from somewhere outside. Until now you have thought that the pain came from external factors; from broken relationships, from unfulfilled desires, from someone's death, or from the anger of others, their insults and abuse. But the real source of that pain is to be found within you. And now, in the light of the Master's infinite spiritual glory, you are made to see everything clearly. You realize that all the pain exists within you.

“Remember that the Master is not simply going to leave you there all alone. He will help you by using his infinite spiritual energy. He will heal your wounds.

“So, the pain does not stem from your attachment to the Master's external form, it is your mind and your negative tendencies that create the pain. When you come to understand the nature of your pain, you need to cooperate with the Master. He is the divine doctor, whose capacity and energy is inexhaustible.

“Remember that you are a patient in need of major surgery. But don’t worry, you can trust this doctor completely. Have undivided faith in him. You are in his operation room. Let him work on you; cooperate with him and don’t struggle; be still and do not move. Of course, he will give you anesthesia. His anesthesia is the unconditional love and compassion that he expresses through his entire being, and with that anesthesia you will be made ready for the operation.

“Once the Master begins to operate he is not going to let you go, because no doctor will let his patient run away when the operation is only half over. In one way or another, the Master will see that you remain on the operation table, because it would be dangerous if you were to run away in the middle of the procedure. The Satguru won’t let you run away. But the surgery performed by the Satguru is not very painful, compared to the worst condition of your disease, and in relation to the highest bliss and the other benefits that you will gain. The Master’s overflowing love and compassion will greatly lessen the pain. The true Master is one with God, and therefore, you will be basking in God’s love and compassion.

“The Master is not a pain giver, he is a pain killer. His intention is not to give you temporary relief, but permanent relief - forever. But for some reason people want to keep their pain. Even though supreme bliss is our

nature, it seems that in their present mental state, people enjoy their pain, as if it has become a natural part of them.

“A palm reader was reading someone’s hand and he predicted, ‘Until the age of fifty you will experience a lot of sorrow and suffering in your life. You will be in constant mental pain and agony.’ ‘And after the age of fifty?’ asked the customer. The palm reader said coolly, ‘After the age of fifty it will become your nature.’

There was tremendous laughter and even Mother joined in. She continued, “It seems that human nature has almost become like this. People are in pain, and they have almost become identified with it. So much so, that they are not even aware of it, nor do they really want to get out of it.”

The brahmacharin who had asked the question said, “Amma, I still have one more question.” He looked at Mother to see Her reaction, because sometimes Mother remains quiet without responding to any questions. Mother’s ways are always puzzling and unpredictable. Nobody knows when She will choose to speak or not. Even in the midst of a brainstorming discussion Mother will suddenly slip into Her own infinite consciousness. Her endless moods are beyond human understanding. It can happen anywhere and at any time.

NONE OTHER THAN THE SUPREME GODDESS

Once, some devotees wanted to take Mother to a famous Devi temple in Tamil Nadu. This incident happened in the middle of 1977. During this period Mother would frequently become completely oblivious to all outer circumstances. At such times She didn't have the least awareness of Her body.

The family who wished to take Mother to the temple were very devoted to Her. In those days it wasn't as crowded around Mother as it is today. The devotees would come only during the Bhava *darshan*, and the following morning, when it was over, they often invited Mother to their homes. Mother would sometimes go and spend a day or two with them. The devotees hoped that if She came to their home, they could look after Her for a day or two and She would be able to get some rest. In those days, Mother never ate or slept unless somebody was there to remind Her, and, if need be, pester Mother and insist that She should rest and eat something, at least now and then. But even so, it was very difficult. She never bothered about Her bodily needs. Most of the time, Mother remained in a totally absorbed mood.

The Krishna and Devi Bhavas were manifested three nights a week (Tuesdays, Thursdays and Sundays). On all these days Mother would spend twelve to thir-

teen hours receiving people. On Bhava *darshan* days, the evening *bhajan* started at three-thirty or four p.m. and lasted until six p.m. During the first half of the night there was Krishna Bhava, which usually began at six-thirty, and during the second half there was Devi Bhava. Suppose there were two thousand people there - all of the two thousand would go up to Her twice - first to Krishna and then to Devi. The Devi Bhava sometimes ended at seven or eight in the morning.

In those days only a few families were really close to Mother; that is, only a few families had the good fortune to understand that Mother was abiding in the highest state of spiritual realization. This particular family who invited Mother to the famous Devi temple was one such family. At first Mother didn't show any interest in going, but as always, She finally yielded to their innocent prayers.

On the subject of temples, Mother once said, "The outer temple is for those who have not realized the constant presence of God within their own heart. Once that realization takes place, God's presence pervades everything, both within and without. For such a person, every place, every inch of this universe becomes a temple."

The following is a story which Mother tells to illustrate this point.

"Namdev was a highly evolved devotee of Lord Krishna. He was instructed by the Lord Himself to go and surrender to a certain enlightened soul (Vishobukechara)

who was staying in a Shiva temple at the outskirts of a village. Having reached the temple, the devotee saw an old man lying down in the inner sanctum, with his feet resting on the *Shiva Lingam*. Infuriated at the sight of such sacrilege Namdev clapped his hands loudly to wake up the old man. The old man heard the noise and opened his eyes. He looked at the newcomer and said, ‘Oh yes! You are Namdev who Vittal¹⁴ sent, aren’t you?’ The devotee was wonderstruck and knew that he was standing before a great soul. But still, there was one thing he couldn’t understand, and he said to the old man, ‘You are undoubtedly a great being, but I don’t understand how you can rest your feet on the Lingam?’ ‘Oh, are they on the Lingam? I didn’t know that. Kindly remove them for me. I am too tired,’ said the saint. Namdev lifted the old man’s legs away from the Lingam and placed them on the floor, but amazingly, wherever he put them, a Shiva Lingam appeared. Namdev moved the saint’s feet to different places, but always a Shiva Lingam would appear at the exact spot where the feet would touch. Finally, Namdev placed them on his own lap, and as he did so, he himself attained the state of Shiva.

“A true *Mahatma* is God, Himself. He doesn’t need to go to any temple or place of worship, because the place where he dwells is a temple in itself. But sometimes he visits sacred places just to set an example.”

¹⁴ An aspect of Lord Krishna

However, Mother visited the temple to make the devotees happy. When they arrived at the temple, they walked up and stood in front of the entrance, from where one could clearly see the image of Devi, the Divine Mother, through the open doorway which led into the inner sanctum. When Mother saw the image of Devi She immediately went into a state of *samadhi*, and She remained standing absolutely still for more than one and a half hours. The members of the family were very frightened by this. Mother remained where She was, immovable as a mountain. What greatly surprised them was the posture in which She stood. Mother was standing in exactly the same pose as the Divine Mother inside the sanctum.

The family was wondering how to bring Mother back to Her normal, external consciousness, when a middle aged woman suddenly approached them. There was a dignified look on her face, but she also seemed deeply devoted and sincere. In a commanding tone she addressed the head of the family, “Can’t you see that that one (pointing at Devi inside the inner sanctum) and this one (pointing at Mother who was in deep *samadhi*) are one and the same? Chant the *Meenakshi Stotram*!” The authenticity of the lady’s words were such that the head of the family, like an obedient child, spontaneously began chanting the ancient Sanskrit hymn to the Divine Mother.

*O Sri Vidya
 who adorns the left side of Shiva,¹⁵
 the One who is worshipped by the King of kings,
 who is the embodiment of all gurus
 beginning with Lord Vishnu,
 Treasure Chest of Chintamani,
 wish-bestowing Divine Gem,
 the One, whose Feet are worshipped by the Goddess
 Saraswati
 and the Goddess Girija,
 Consort of Shambho, the Sweet Heart of Shiva,
 who is dazzling like the midday sun,
 the daughter of King Malayadwaja,
 Save me, O Mother Meenakshi.*

While he chanted the Stotram, the woman herself remained in a deeply prayerful mood, with her eyes closed and palms joined together.

After a few minutes Mother returned to Her normal mood, but She continued standing in the same spot, swaying slightly sideways. Her gaze was still fixed on the statue of Devi, or somewhere; it was impossible to say where exactly. The family then finally stopped chanting.

The unknown woman who had told the family to sing the *Meenakshi Stotram*, fell at Mother's feet and remained there for a long time, until Mother bent down and lovingly pulled her up towards Her. There was an extraordinary expression of love on Mother's countenance as

¹⁵ i.e., who is the Consort of Shiva

She looked at the woman's face. The woman seemed to be in a state of bliss. Mother continued to look at her for a long time. Finally, She gently drew the woman's head onto Her shoulder. The woman was shedding tears of bliss as she rested on Mother's shoulder. Nobody knew who the woman was or where she had come from.

This is just one among countless such incidents which have happened around Mother. The woman who had come to the temple at that moment was like a divine messenger who wanted to remind everyone, especially the family, that Mother is the Supreme Goddess Herself.

This is why the brahmacharin who wanted to ask another question suddenly stopped and looked at Mother. He wanted to make sure that Mother was in Her normal mood. When he saw that Mother was willing to answer his question he continued.

ATTACHMENT TO A SATGURU IS ATTACHMENT TO GOD

Question: "Amma, I am still wondering whether this attachment to the Master's external form is necessary, or if mere longing to realize God is sufficient to reach the ultimate goal?"

Mother: "Children, first of all remember that an attachment to the Master is an attachment to God. Your prob-

lem is that you try to differentiate between God and the true Master. Attachment to a true Master's physical form intensifies your longing to realize the Supreme. It is like living with God. He makes your spiritual journey much easier. Such a Master is both the means and the end. But at the same time there must be a conscious effort to see the Master in all of creation. One must also try one's best to obey the Master's words and adhere to his instructions.

"Do you have any idea about God or the supreme state of realization? You have heard about it and read about it, that's all. Whatever you have heard and read were only words. But the experience is something far beyond. It is an incomprehensible mystery.

"You cannot experience the state of God-consciousness through your mere senses or through the scriptures that you have learned. To experience it, you need to develop a new eye, the inner, or third eye. The two eyes that you have now should become one, only then can you see God. This means that even while you are seeing everything with both your eyes, you should not see the dual world. All duality disappears and you behold the oneness of creation, the whole universe. The inner eye, or the eye of true knowledge, can only be opened by a real Master."

This statement of Mother's reminds one of a famous saying of Sri Krishna, the Perfect Master, to his disciple, Arjuna:

“You cannot have an experience of Me merely with your physical eye. I therefore give you the power of divine vision. Behold My power as the Lord of all.”

-BHAGAVAD GITA, CHAPTER 11, VERSE 8

Mother continued, “You may have a longing to realize God, but it may not last long, because the intensity will weaken, unless you are a very competent student. Your longing will come and go, it will be very unstable. Even if you are able to sustain your longing, you may still have an intense craving to enjoy the pleasures of the world. You don’t know how to create a balance between the inner and the outer worlds. If the Master is not there to guide you from time to time, you may stray away from the path, you may journey in the wrong direction, or, you may stop in the middle of your journey and fall back into the world. You will then lose all your faith and think that there is no such state as God- or Self-Realization.

“Attachment to the Master’s external form is like the *gopis*’ attachment to Krishna’s form, or Hanuman’s attachment to Rama’s form, or the attachment that the disciples of Buddha and Jesus had towards them. Those disciples lived with God. To live in the physical presence of a true Master, and to be attached to his external form, is like living with and being attached to Pure Consciousness, or the Supreme. It inspires you and creates an intense longing within you, and you will

then be able to sustain that intensity. When you are under the watchful eye of the Master, you cannot stray away from the path, provided that you live in faith, surrender and obedience to the Master's words.

"Being attached to the external form of a Satguru is like having direct contact with the Supreme Truth. The presence of such a Great Being is so filled with Divinity that you feel it in your heart, you see it with your eyes and you sense it everywhere. It is a tangible sensation that you experience through the Master's entire being - when you look into his eyes, when you feel his touch, observe his actions and listen to his words.

"Everyone wants someone to be attached to; a boyfriend or a girlfriend, a husband or a wife. Children cling to their parents or their toys, or they demand the company of their brothers and sisters, and people want friends. There are countless things in the world to keep the human mind busy. Companies and businessmen are constantly producing new products for this purpose. In their search for happiness (that is, in their need to quiet their minds) people run from one object to another. But they soon find the object boring and are then compelled to run after a new one. The search is never-ending.

"When there is something new on the market, when, for example, a new movie is released, your mind becomes excited and you want to see it. The more you hear about the movie, the more you want to see it. And

when your desire has been fulfilled, the nagging mind quiets down for a while until you hear about another movie, or something else. This is the nature of the mind. It cannot be silent, it cannot be alone by itself and be happy. If it has nothing to attach itself to, you become extremely restless. The mind creates a long chain of attachments. People live in a fantasy world and are building castles in the air. If they cannot dream, or if they have nothing to think about, they may go crazy or commit suicide.

“You are bound to become bored with all the objects and experiences that you get in the world. You can never remain with anything for any length of time. You have to move on, because the mind is constantly moving from one thing to another; it forces you to jump from one thing to another. Boredom is bound to occur in every single worldly situation, because of the incessant demands of the mind. This is why people in the West try different boyfriends and girlfriends, or husbands and wives, or a new house in a different city. They want to try new things, new relationships, because they easily get tired of the old and familiar. The mind is attached to a thousand different things and it is pulling you in all directions.

“As the mind is always vacillating and is full of negativity, even the spiritual longing that you are experiencing now may disappear, because your present longing for realization stems from the mind. One day you may

suddenly get bored, because it is the nature of the mind to be bored with everything, and because it is always wanting something new. If you have nothing to hold on to or relate to, it is bound to get bored with spiritual life as well.

“In order to steady your mind and make it still, you need to be attached to something higher than the mind. The mind is the noisiest place in the world. Unless there is something on which it can really contemplate or meditate, the mind will not be quiet. But the object of one’s meditation or contemplation should not be anything familiar, for then the mind will soon get bored.

“The longing that you have now for God-Realization may be just one attachment among many. You cannot withstand strong temptations for any length of time. In your present mental state, your other attachments are much stronger than your attachment to God-Realization. The longing that you feel could stem from some excitement and attraction which you might have felt during a particularly inspiring moment. It could die away soon, because boredom is bound to occur if you don’t feel a much more powerful and tempting pull. That pull is your attachment to the Master’s external form. It is that attachment which balances out all other attachments. By being attracted and attached to the Master’s form you develop a special power to withstand all other attractions. The Master’s physical presence is pervaded with Divinity, so there is no chance

for boredom, because boredom happens only when the mind is concerned with the objects, experiences and ideas of the world. The mind gets easily bored with external things, because true happiness is not the nature of anything which belongs to the world. A Satguru, however, is the very source of eternal bliss and happiness. His very being is immortal, and if one is inquisitive enough, one can, in his presence, behold infinity unfolding in infinite ways. Boredom is therefore very rare in the Master's presence. He is the embodiment of the Divine; and boredom cannot happen if one is receptive to his presence which is Divine. Attachment to the Master's physical form fills the disciple's heart with love, enthusiasm, contentment and a feeling of freshness. The Master himself will instill these qualities in the disciple. Whenever the disciple feels depressed and discouraged, the Master, through his unconditional love and compassion, or by giving the disciple an inspiring experience, lifts him out of his negative condition and encourages him to march forward with new determination and enthusiasm. This helps to steady the disciple's noisy mind and make it still, because the presence of a true Master is the only place where the restless mind can rest forever without getting bored.

“Spirituality is not an observable fact, like the sun and the moon, the mountains and rivers. Spirituality is faith. Only complete, undivided faith can help one reach the goal.”

“Every human being in the world is either intellectual or emotional. It is difficult for intellectuals to believe, because they only believe in visible things. Since God is invisible, to believe in His existence one has to depend solely on faith, and faith is not an intellectual process. Even though emotionally centered people may believe more easily, it is not easy for them to believe completely either, because their faith is not undivided; their faith is only partial because of their doubting minds. And soon, when they begin to get bored, they will look for another object to pin their faith upon.

“Both intellectual and emotional people need evidence of something solid and visible in order to believe and to strengthen their faith. Otherwise, they may develop a little bit of interest, a little longing to realize God, and then after a short time, if they don’t get any real experience or feel a tangible presence of the Divine, they may turn back and say, ‘This is just nonsense. There is no such thing as God or God-Realization.’ Of course, the problem lies within their own mind and in their lack of patience, but still, if they have something which they can relate to, they will feel assured and inspired. That will help them remain in spiritual life and to live according to its principles. But this is possible only in the presence of a true Master, by developing a personal relationship with him, and by creating an attachment to his external form. By doing this you are establishing a relation-

ship with God, the Supreme Consciousness, your own inner Self. This is not like developing attachment to an ordinary individual; it is a relationship which will help you to be detached in all circumstances. It prepares your mind to take the final leap into God-Consciousness.”

Silence fell upon the listeners. Mother’s powerful words seemed to be resounding everywhere, within the hearts of those who were listening and outside in the physical environment as well. An inspiring meditative atmosphere prevailed, as if to give a tangible experience of what Mother was talking about - the significance of a great *Mahatma’s* physical presence, the importance of feeling attached to Her external form, and the necessity of having a relationship with the physical embodiment of the Divine.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

MOTHER, LIBERATOR OF THE SOUL

Mother was sitting with some of the residents and a few devotees in the coconut grove in front of the temple. Mother was talking about different subjects with the householder devotees. Suddenly Mother turned towards Balu and said, “Ottoormon (My son, Ottoor) wishes to see Amma. Bring him here.” Balu got up and went to fetch Ottoor. Ottoor was staying in a room especially built for him, above the underground meditation cells, situated just behind the old temple.

Ottoor Unni Nambootiripadu was a well-known poet and Sanskrit scholar in Kerala. He was an authority on the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, which mainly depicts the *Avatars* of Vishnu, especially that of Lord Krishna and His childhood sports. Ottoor’s beautiful poems glorifying Krishna are famous throughout India, and Krishna devotees love them very much. As an exponent of the *Srimad Bhagavatam* and also as a gifted poet and author, Ottoor had won many titles and awards, both from the central and state governments. He was a great devotee of Lord Krishna and was closely associated

with the famous Guruvayoor temple of Kerala. The following song, *Kannante Punya*, will help the reader get an idea about the blessed poet's wonderful compositions and his devotion.

*When will I hear
the auspicious names of Kanna
sounding in my ears?
And upon hearing them
when will my hair stand on end
and when will I be totally
immersed in tears?*

*Being immersed in tears
when will I become pure?
And in that state of absolute purity
when will I sing His Names
spontaneously?*

*And as I sing in ecstasy
when will I forget the earth and the sky?
And forgetting everything
when will I dance
in utter devotion?
And as I dance, will my steps
sweep the stains
from the stage of the world?*

*In that playful dance
in which I sweep all stains away
I will cry out loud*

*And through that cry,
will my purity be sent
in the eight directions?*

*And when the play has been enacted
when will I fall at last
into my Mother's lap?
And lying on my Mother's lap
when will I sleep blissfully?*

*As I sleep
when will I dream
of the beautiful form of Sri Krishna
who dwells within my heart?
And as I wake up
when will I see Sri Krishna
the Enchanter of the world?*

This song was written by the great poet twenty-five years before the Holy Mother's incarnation on earth. There is a most touching and wonderful story behind this song. It shows how an incarnation of God fulfills the sincere and wholehearted prayers of a true devotee. In this poem he says, "And when the play has been enacted, when will I fall at last, into my Mother's lap? And lying on my Mother's lap, when will I sleep blissfully?"

Ottoor first met Mother in 1983. He had been invited to Mother's 30th birthday celebration. Ottoor had heard about Mother from one of Her devotees while he was visiting Trivandrum. He immediately felt an intense,

spontaneous desire to meet Her. Ottoor strongly felt that Mother was the divine incarnation of the Supreme Goddess and also of Lord Krishna, his beloved deity. Thus, he came to meet Mother on Her birthday, on September 27, 1983. And once he had met Mother, Ottoor, the eighty-five year old devotee, poet and scholar, became like a two year old child who constantly craved the care and attention of his Mother. He realized that he had at long last reached his destiny and decided to spend the rest of his life in Mother's presence. From then on, he also began to compose poems to Mother. The relationship between Mother and the eighty-five year old poet was unique - something very special and extraordinarily beautiful. Mother greatly appreciated his childlike nature, and She gave him the pet name, 'Unni Kanna' (baby Krishna).

Just like a child, he used to ask Mother before he did anything. If he wanted to take a special medicine, he would get Mother's permission before taking it. Even before he would use a different bath soap or change his diet, he would first ask for Mother's permission. Only if Mother said yes would he do it. Otherwise, he never did anything different. Sometimes he wanted Mother to feed him. At other times he wished to lie on Her lap. The occasions were not rare, when one could hear him calling loudly from his room, "Amma! Amma!" at the top of his voice. He did this whenever he had a strong urge to see Her. At such times, if Mother happened to

be in the vicinity, She would go to see him in his room. If Mother was in Her room and not nearby, She would send him some *prasad* through Gayatri or another messenger. Being aware of his childlike nature, Mother sometimes sent somebody to bring him to the hut when She was giving *darshan* to the devotees. She then showered him with great love and affection and let him sit very close to Her. During those moments, Ottoor, who was always complaining about the state of his body, forgot about his suffering. He always loved to sit close to Mother. Ottoor often used to say, “I get so much energy when I sit next to Mother.”

This rare Mother-child relationship is beyond the human intellect. The eighty-five year old renowned poet calling Mother, who was only thirty years old at the time, “Amma”, is perhaps difficult for the human mind to understand. How can the intellect comprehend such a mystery? For Ottoor Unni Nambootiripadu, Mother was both his Guru and God. In Mother he saw both Lord Krishna, his beloved deity, and the Mother of the Universe. This was clearly depicted in all his compositions to Mother, including the one hundred eight Names of Mother which were written by him. The following is a song about Mother, written by Ottoor.

*O Mother
You are the embodiment of both Krishna and Kali.
O Mother*

*You sanctify the worlds with Your smile
and Your song,
with Your glance, Your touch and Your dance,
with Your delightful talk,
by the touch of Your Holy Feet,
and by the nectar of Your Love.*

*O Mother
Who is the celestial creeper
joyously and bounteously
bestowing all the purusharthas
from dharma to moksha,
to all sentient and insentient beings
from Lord Brahma down to a blade of grass.*

*O Mother
Who astonishes the three worlds,
inundating all human beings
and the bees and the birds,
the worms and the trees
by the turbulent waves of Your love.*

Ottoor had only one wish. Whenever he received Mother's *darshan*, his only prayer to Her was, "Amma, when I breathe my last, let my head rest on Your lap. This is my only wish, my only prayer. O my Mother, please let me die with my head on Your lap." This prayer was repeated fervently to Mother whenever he met Her. The poet chanted his prayer so much that his wish became known to practically all of Mother's devotees and to his own admirers.

Soon after Ottoor met Mother he became a permanent resident at the Ashram. He had a very blissful, contented stay at the Ashram. He always used to say, “Now I know that God has not abandoned me, because I am living in His presence and I am basking in His divine love. I used to feel greatly disappointed when I thought of the fact that I couldn’t be with Krishna or Chaitanya Mahaprabhu,¹⁶ or any of the *Mahatmas*. But I don’t feel that anymore, because I believe that Mother is all of them.”

Just before Mother’s third world tour in 1989, Ottoor’s health took a very bad turn. His body was falling apart, and even though Mother made all the necessary arrangements for his treatment, Ottoor was unable to regain his health. He became very weak and his eyesight was failing rapidly. Unable to see properly, he could not write poems the way he used to, instead he dictated them to his nephew, Narayanan, who also took care of Ottoor’s personal needs.

Though Ottoor’s physical condition grew worse, his childlike innocence and his attitude towards Mother did not change at all. In fact, it became even more intense. His well-known prayer to be allowed to die in Mother’s lap became constant. When his eye sight became very poor, Ottoor said to Mother, “It’s okay if Amma wants to take away my external sight. But, O

¹⁶ 1485-1535

Divine Mother of the heavens, kindly bless Your servant by removing the inner darkness and open the inner eye. Please don't refuse the prayer of this child."

To this Mother lovingly replied, "Unni Kanna, don't worry! It will definitely happen. How can Amma refuse Your innocent prayer?"

Just a week before Mother left for Her third world tour, Ottoor's health suddenly deteriorated. His condition became very serious and he was completely bedridden. Everybody thought he was going to die. Ottoor was not afraid of death. His only fear was that he would die when Mother was abroad. He expressed this fear to Mother and said, "Amma, I know that You are everywhere and that Your lap is as big as the universe. Still, I pray for You to be physically present when I leave my body. If I die while You are away, my wish to die in Your lap will not be fulfilled." Mother caressed him affectionately and replied with great authority, "No, my son, Unni Kanna, that will not happen! You can be sure that you will leave your body only after Amma's return." This was a great consolation to Ottoor. As this assurance came directly from Mother's own lips, Ottoor firmly believed that death couldn't touch him before Mother came back.

After three months of touring around the world, Mother returned to the Ashram in August. During Her absence, Ottoor had been undergoing treatment in the home of an ayurvedic doctor, who was also an ardent

devotee of Mother. He took very good care of the poet, and Ottoor's health improved a little, but after a short time he again became worse. Mother then told Ottoor to return to the Ashram, as the time for him to leave his body was getting close.

During Krishna's birthday, Ottoor sat near Mother and participated in all the celebrations which took place. The day after Krishna's birthday was a Devi Bhava day. The Bhava *darshan* ended at two-thirty in the morning, after which Mother went to Ottoor's room. He was very weak but was extremely happy to see Mother. The great poet wept like a child and prayed to Mother, "O Amma, Mother of the Universe, please call me back! Please call me back, quickly!" Just like a mother caring for her child, Mother rubbed and soothed the poet's chest and forehead, and She caressed his head with overflowing love and compassion.

A devotee had offered Mother a new silk mattress that day. She now asked Bri. Gayatri to bring the mattress to Ottoor's room. Gayatri left and soon returned carrying the mattress. Mother picked up Ottoor's thin, frail body from the bed, and like a mother carrying a baby in her arms, Mother held Ottoor in Her arms, while Gayatri, Balu and Narayanan spread the new mattress on the cot. As Ottoor was experiencing this demonstration of Mother's infinite compassion, he cried out, "O Amma, Mother of the Universe, why are You showering so much love and compassion upon this unworthy child?"

Oh Amma, Amma, Amma...”

Mother lay him gently down on the cot and said, “Unni Kanna, my son, sleep well. Mother will come in the morning.”

“O Amma, put me to eternal sleep,” replied Ottoor.

Mother once again glanced lovingly at Ottoor before She left the room.

That night, the poet dictated one last song.

*Treating me and hoping for a cure
the physicians admitted their defeat.
All my relatives have turned despondent.
O Mother, lay me on Your lap with tender love
Save me and never forsake me.*

*O Saradhamani, O Sudhamani, O Holy Mother
Lay me fondly in Your tender lap
Reveal the moon of Ambadi on Your face
Tarry not to bless me with immortality.*

*Reveal Uncle Moon, Nanda's son
on Your sweet face
and lay this little Kanna on Your lap.
O Mother, lull him to sleep.*

At seven the next morning, Friday the 25th of August 1989, Mother sent for Narayanan. When he arrived, She told him that Ottoor was going to leave his body in a few hours. Mother further told Narayanan to find out from his uncle whether he wanted his mortal

frame to be buried at the Ashram or at his birth place. Narayanan went back to the room and conveyed to his uncle what Mother had said. Though his voice was very feeble, Ottoor clearly replied as he gestured emphatically with his hand, “I will be buried here, in this sacred land. There is nowhere else.”

At about ten o’clock Ottoor asked Bri. Leela,¹⁷ who was standing by his side, to call Mother. But Leela didn’t pay much attention to Ottoor’s request; she was holding some medicine in her hands and was explaining the dosage to Narayanan. Finally, Ottoor gave Leela a hard push and gestured, “No more medicine! Go and get Mother!” Leela then left the room, and for the next few minutes one could clearly see Ottoor’s lips moving as he constantly chanted, “Amma, Amma, Amma...” During this chanting Ottoor went into a *samadhi* like state.

At this time Mother was in Her room. As Leela came in through the door, Mother said to both Gayatri and Leela, “In a few minutes, Ottoormon is going to leave his body. But it is not yet time for Amma to be there. Now, his mind is completely focused on Amma. This intense thought will culminate in a state of *layana* (merging). When this happens, Amma will go to him. The intensity would be reduced if Amma had gone to him earlier.” A few seconds later, Mother left Her room and

¹⁷ Bri. Leela is today known as Swamini Atmaprana. She was previously a practising medical doctor.

went over to Ottoor's room, followed by Leela. Mother entered Ottoor's room with a beaming smile and sat down on the bed close to Ottoor. With an extraordinary glow on Her face, She kept gazing at Her Unni Kanna's face, as if telling him, "Come, my son! My darling Unni Kanna, come and merge in Me, your eternal Mother." As Mother had predicted earlier, in Her room, Ottoor was lying in a state of *layana*. Mother caressed him, rubbing his head and chest with overflowing love and compassion. Even though Ottoor was in a state of *samadhi*, his eyes remained half open. There was no sign of any pain or struggle on his face. One could easily see how absorbed and blissful he was. Mother slowly moved closer to his head. She gently lifted his head up and placed it on Her lap. And as Mother held Her darling son's head in Her lap, She held Her right hand on His chest, and She continued to gaze at his face.

As the great poet devotee, Mother's Unni Kanna, lay on Her lap, Mother gently caressed his eyelids, and they were closed forever. Ottoor left his body and his soul merged with Mother for all eternity. Mother bent down and placed a loving, affectionate kiss on his forehead.

Thus, the last line of his own composition, *Kannante Punya*, which he had written twenty-five years before Mother's incarnation, was fulfilled by the all-compassionate Mother of the Universe: *And when the play has*

been enacted, when will I fall at last into my Mother's lap? And lying on my Mother's lap, when will I sleep blissfully? As I sleep, when will I dream of the beautiful form of Sri Krishna who dwells within my heart? And as I wake up, when will I see Sri Krishna, the Enchanter of the world?

This incident stands as a great example of how the *Satguru*, who is none other than God Himself, fulfills the desires of a sincere devotee.

Another significant point in this incident is Mother's response when Ottoor expressed his fear that he might leave his body while Mother was away on the world tour. To this She had responded, as has already been mentioned, "No, my son, Unni Kanna, that will not happen! You can be sure that you will leave your body only after Amma's return."

Who can give such an assurance, guaranteeing that a person will not die before a certain period of time? Mother's reply sounds so categorical. It is as if death is perfectly under Her control as She says, "Unless I permit it, you cannot touch my darling child." And death obeyed Her! Who else can command death like this but Amma, who according to Ottoor is "the Divine Mother of the Universe, who is the complete manifestation of the Absolute Truth (Brahman); who is existence, knowledge and bliss embodied; who verily is the Supreme Goddess in human form..."¹⁸ Who, but God

¹⁸ From the one hundred eight Names.

alone, can issue such an order? It is only the One who has gone beyond Death who can say, “Stop, and wait until I tell you when.” Isn't this what happened here?

After Ottoor's death, N.V. Krishna Warriar, a famous writer, linguist and scholar of Kerala, wrote an editorial about Ottoor in a major newspaper. “Ottor saw the Universal Mother in the young Mata Amritanandamayi. She endearingly loved the aged Ottoor like her own son. It was indeed a unique Mother-son relationship.”

Let us now go back to that afternoon, a few years before Ottoor left his body. Balu returned to the coconut grove with Ottoor, holding the old poet by his hand. With great devotion and humility Ottoor fell at Mother's feet. As he lay prostrate in front of Mother he said, “Amma, You knew that this servant wanted to see You. I was longing to be with You. O Amma, You sent for me because You knew the wish of my heart. Amma, kindly place Your holy feet on my head.” Mother laughed and said, “Unni Kanna, no, no! They are all full of dirt.” Ottoor, in a very powerful and august voice said, “What are you saying? Dirty! Your feet? O Amma, do not say that! I know that the dust of Your feet is sufficient to kill the darkness of ignorance in the whole world. Please place Your feet on my head, otherwise I won't get up.”

Finally, Mother had to yield to Ottoor's wish and She placed Her feet on his head. Ottoor, the great devotee,

was thrilled. He repeated loudly, “*Anandoham, Dhanyoham, Anandoham*” (Blissful am I, blessed am I, blissful am I). And as he was chanting, he took the dust of Mother’s feet and rubbed it all over his body.

Ottoor knelt in front of Mother and She embraced him affectionately. The great poet looked up at Her like an innocent child, and with eyes filled with tears he said, “O Amma, never abandon this child. Let me always be in Your divine presence.”

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GLOSSARY

ABHAYA MUDRA: Hand pose indicating bestowal of fearlessness.

ACHARA: Customary observances.

ARATI: Vespers, waving the burning camphor, which leaves no residue, with ringing of bells at the end of worship, representing the complete offering of the ego to God.

ATMA SHAKTI: Energy of the Self or Soul.

AVATAR: Incarnation of God.

BHAJAN: Devotional singing.

DARSHAN: Audience of a holy person or deity.

DHARMA: Righteousness, in accordance with Divine Harmony.

JAGRAT: Waking state.

KIRTAN: Singing.

LALITA ASHTHOTTARA: One hundred and eight Names of the Divine Mother Sri Lalita.

LAYANA: Merger into God-Consciousness.

LEELA: A divine play or show, appearance.

MAHATMA: Great Soul or Sage.

MAYA: Illusion.

MOKSHA: Release from the cycle of birth and death.

MUDRA: Hand pose indicative of mystic truths.

NIRVANA: Liberation from the cycle of birth and death.

PADA PUJA: Worship of the feet of God or a saint.

PANCHAMRITAM: A sweet jam-like substance offering to God in Hindu temples.

PARASHAKTI: The Supreme Energy or Goddess.

PEETHAM: The holy seat on which Mother sits during Devi Bhava.

PRALAYAGNI: The fire of Universal Dissolution at the end of creation.

PRASAD: Consecrated offerings distributed at the end of worship.

PUJA: Ritualistic worship.

PUNYA: Merit, opposite of sin.

PURNAM: Full or perfect.

PURUSHA: Male being, the Spirit or God.

PURUSHARTHAS: The four goals or ends of human existence, i.e. wealth, enjoyment, righteousness, and Liberation.

RAJAS: One of the three gunas or qualities of Nature, the principle of activity.

SADHAK: A spiritual aspirant.

SADHANA: Spiritual practice.

SAKSHI BHAVA: The attitude of being a witness.

SAMADHI: Absorption of the mind into Reality or Truth.

SANKALPA: A resolve.

SANNYASIN: One who has taken formal vows of renunciation.

SARVASAKSHI: All-witness.

SATTVIC: One of the three gunas of Nature, the principle of purity and serenity.

SHIVA LINGAM: The emblem of Lord Shiva, oval in shape.

SUSHUPTHI: The state of deep, dreamless sleep.

SWAPNA: Dream.

TAPAS: Austerity, hardship undergone for the sake of self-purification.

UPANISHADS: The concluding portion of the Vedas or scriptures of the Hindus, dealing with the nature of the Absolute Brahman, the Transcendent Reality, the True Self.

UTSAVAM: Festival.

VAHANA: Vehicle or mount.

VASANAS: Residual impressions of objects and actions experienced, habits.

VEDAS: The authoritative scriptures of the Hindus, lit. "Knowledge."

YANTRA: Mystic diagram.

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CHAPTER ONE

THE PLAYFUL MOTHER

Mother looked like a beautiful dark-blue statue. She was sitting in a deeply absorbed state of samadhi in front of the new Ashram building that was under construction. Mother was surrounded by most of the Ashram residents and a visiting family who were all looking intently at Her. The sun shone bright and warm; it seemed to be gazing down to get a glimpse of Mother and to caress Her body with its beautiful golden rays. As everyone sat contemplating Mother's enchanting countenance, She opened Her eyes and smiled at them. When Mother smiles, the heart of everyone opens up, and one cannot help but smile as well. Her sweet smile has a wonderful healing effect. Without saying a word, Mother can express Her Divinity through Her look, smile or touch. Sitting in Her presence is like experiencing direct communion with God. This holy place, Amritapuri, which is constantly illumined by Mother's presence, where one can experience a never ending stream of supreme love and the depth of true knowledge, reminds one of the *gurukulas*¹ of the ancient *rishis*.

Mother began to play with a little girl who was barely two

¹ Hermitages where children of ancient times used to be sent for twelve years to study with a master.

years old, and who belonged to the visiting family. The little girl had a piece of a sweet in her hands. Mother stretched out Her right palm and said to her, "Give some to Amma." The child gazed at Mother for a long time with a wondrous look in her eyes. All of a sudden she turned around and ran towards her parents with a giggle. Mother followed her, picked her up and forcibly carried her back to the place where She had been sitting. The child sat calmly on Mother's lap. Now Mother opened Her mouth and wanted the child to feed Her with some of the sweet. This time the child smiled beautifully at Mother and brought the sweet very close to Mother's mouth. Mother was about to take a bite when the child suddenly withdrew the sweet, scrambled down from Mother's lap and again ran away. This evoked much laughter. Mother was very amused by this and She burst into peals of laughter. One of the devotees remarked, "She is like you, Amma." The devotee was referring to Krishna Bhava, when Mother used to feed *prasad* to the devotees in a playful mood that reminded one of Krishna's childhood sportings.

The Holy Mother was not willing to give up that easily. She adamantly followed the child, caught hold of her and brought her back to the same spot. It looked as if Mother Herself had become an innocent child. The little girl who

was again sitting on Mother's lap was also enjoying the play. Mother again opened Her mouth wanting the child to feed Her. The parents encouraged the child saying, "Kunji (little one), give some to Amma! You love Amma so much, don't you?"

Gazing at Mother's beautiful face, the child once again brought the sweet close to Mother's mouth. She was about to withdraw her hand and run away again, but this time Mother took hold of her little hand and took a tiny bite from the sweet. This was too much for the little girl. She began to cry, expressing her anger and protest by throwing the sweet onto Mother's lap. Seeing the child's innocent behavior, Mother again burst into laughter, followed by much laughter from all those present. Even the child's parents joined in. This made the little girl cry even louder. She protested more strongly by throwing herself down and rolling on the ground. Mother looked at her and said, "She feels that she is being teased." But soon Mother picked her up from the ground and consoled her. She asked Bri. Gayatri² to bring another sweet for her. The child was happy to receive a fresh piece of sweet from Mother, but she also wanted the old one. She now had two pieces in her hands. The child stopped crying as she sat on Mother's lap. Somebody commented and said, "The little

² Swamini Amrita Prana

girl doesn't want to discard the old piece because it's Amma's prasad." When the atmosphere calmed down, the child again looked up at Mother's face. All of a sudden she brought both the pieces of sweet up to Mother's mouth and wholeheartedly offered them to Mother. She kept her little hands in the same position until Mother opened Her mouth and took a small bite from each of the sweets. The child again wanted to feed Mother. But Mother said lovingly, "No, no, my darling! This is for you! Mother has had enough." Mother affectionately hugged and kissed the little one, and holding the child on Her lap, Mother began to sing *Chilanka Ketti*, as if She were singing a lullaby. . .

*O my lotus-eyed One
Tie on Your anklets and come running!
Come dancing!
We are singing Your divine Name
As we go in search of Your tender feet.*

*O Devaki's Son
Radha's own Life
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava³
O Slayer of Pootana
Destroyer of sins
Child of Gokula, come running!
O Cowherd Boy, come dancing!*

³ Names of Krishna.

*O Slayer of Kamsa
Who danced on the serpent Kaliya
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava
Affectionate to those
Who take refuge in You
O Embodiment of Aum
Protector of those in danger
Come running!
O Melody of Bliss
Come dancing!*

*O Protector of the Pandavas
Destroyer of sins
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava
Protector of Arjuna
Destroyer of ignorance
O Kesava, Hare, Madhava
O Nectar of the Gita
Come running!
O Bliss of the heart
Come dancing!*

The little girl sat quietly on Mother's lap for a while, and then Mother let her go to her parents. Mother lay down on the ground with Her head resting in Gayatri's lap. One of the brahmacharis asked Mother a question.

"Almost all children cry when they are born. But Amma, You smiled when You came into this world. Is there any significance to this?"

Mother: “A newborn baby usually cries because, to the baby, this world is a strange place. Having spent nine long months in the mother’s womb, the child suddenly finds itself in a new world. While in the womb, the baby has been in great discomfort caused by the intestinal filth, the heat of the mother’s digestive system and the constant movements of the processes of her body. The child suffers like this for nine months and nine days before it comes out into the world in a painful crush and suffocating discomfort. And now, the newborn child again feels discomfort, caused by the unfamiliar atmospheric pressure and the strange surroundings. For the baby, this is a strange, unknown world. It therefore cries out of sheer despair.

“But Amma had no feelings of strangeness when She came into this world. Everything was so utterly familiar to Her; and when one knows everything about the world one can only smile. When one beholds the entire universe as a play of consciousness, what else can one do but smile? When you have the power, the penetrating eyes, with which to see the Reality behind all outer appearances, you can only smile. You then perceive only the changeless within the ever-changing exterior. You don’t see the outer shell of the seed—you see the whole potential tree within the seed. In short, you behold Reality, the true nature of everything. Once you are able to see the Truth, nothing is unknown or strange to you; you are

familiar with the entire universe, and you smile, not occasionally, but continuously. Your life becomes a big smile. You constantly smile at everything—not only during happy moments, but also during unhappy moments. You even smile at death. This is spirituality. Spirituality is a deep and genuine smile at all the situations in life.

“When do people feel sad and desperate? When they find themselves in strange situations, not knowing what to do or where to go; when they feel helpless and there is nobody to turn to; and in the face of failure, loss, disease and death. At such times, they are pushed into a strange, helpless state. They are overcome by despair and they cry because they don’t know anything; they don’t know any methods by which to overcome their situations.

“But as far as a perfect soul is concerned, he knows the secret mystery of life. He knows that everything that happens around him is just a play of consciousness. His eyes can penetrate beyond the three periods of time and behold Reality. He knows the Truth out of which the whole world has emerged. He knows the true existence, the Ground, of the world; he knows what everything is moving towards, and what it finally merges into. This knowledge allows him to smile heartily at everything. The Perfect Soul can smile at everything because of his omniscience.

SMILING EYES

“When you are all-knowing, when your eyes can penetrate beyond the past, the present and the future, then your eyes will also smile, and not just your lips. Look at the picture of Kali dancing on Shiva’s chest. Even though She looks fierce, there is a smile in Her eyes. That smile is the smile of omniscience. Krishna had smiling eyes. All great masters have uniquely smiling eyes. When your eyes have the power to penetrate beyond the surface of existence, then your eyes will radiate with joy. You see the truth—that which lies within—and therefore you smile. The outer surface is a lie. But now the false surface cannot deceive you any longer, because you have learned the art of penetrating and seeing right through everything. Your mere look exposes the outer thief and liar, which then disappears and the Truth comes to light. The meaning of the smile is: ‘I know the Truth.’ It is a sign of perfect omniscience.”

At the end of the conversation Mother suddenly rolled over onto the bare ground. The residents who were sitting there were familiar with Mother’s strange moods and they quickly moved out of the way. They knew that during such occasions, Mother didn’t want anyone to touch Her and that She preferred to lie on the bare ground. Mother was lying with Her eyes focused towards the sky. She raised Her right

hand and held it in a divine mudra, and She was repeatedly making strange sounds as if She were conversing with someone in an unknown language. Mother was lying absolutely still. After a few minutes She closed Her eyes and Her face lit up with a wonderful smile, which made Her entire face shine with an extraordinary brilliance. Mother lay in this position for about ten minutes. She then uttered Her usual mantra, “Shiva, Shiva.” She got up and walked towards the old temple. Having entered the temple, She closed the doors behind Her and remained there for half an hour.

A PINCH AND A CARESS

The description Mother had just given about Herself and Her omniscience gives us a glimpse of the tremendous awareness Mother had of Her godly nature even at birth. Hearing that great truth from Her own lips is a thrilling experience.

Mother’s statement that a Mahatma is able to penetrate the three periods of time, is reminiscent of an incident which happened to a devotee who came to meet Mother for the first time. The man, who lived in Bangalore, had come to see Mother, together with his wife. The long line of devotees moved slowly towards Mother, who, as usual, was receiving Her children one by one. When his turn came, Mother gave him a hard pinch without uttering a word. He got very angry at this, to

the point where he was boiling with rage. There was a reason for his anger. As a young boy, he had had a strong aversion to being pinched and he had protested vehemently whenever he was pinched by his parents or teachers. He even quarreled with his teachers who sometimes pinched him as a minor punishment for not studying his lessons. He would tell them, “You can beat me with a stick if you want or send me out of the classroom, but don’t ever pinch me!” So on this day, when he came up to Mother and She pinched him, it made him extremely angry. But before he had a chance to protest, Mother pulled his head onto Her lap; and as he lay on Her lap, Mother caressed his hair and combed it softly with Her fingers. This experience touched him so deeply that all his anger vanished, and he was in blissful tears. There was a specific reason for this feeling as well. He was in the habit of sometimes asking small children to stroke his hair exactly the way Mother was now doing with Her fingers. He loved it so much that when he was lying in bed, he used to ask the children to gently comb his hair with their fingers, so that he would sleep well. Because he knew that he liked it more than anything, it didn’t take much time for him to realize that Mother is omniscient. When Mother first pinched him, and then, a moment later, combed his hair with Her fingers, he had a sudden revelation that, “Here is somebody who knows everything about me,

my likes and my dislikes, and to whom my life is an open book.” This experience was all that was needed for him to surrender everything at Her feet.

The devotee said, “When Mother lifted my head up from Her lap, I looked at Her face in utter wonderment. She was smiling at me and She said, ‘Being pinched is what you hate the most, and having your hair stroked is what you like the most, isn’t it?’ By pinching me and stroking my hair like that, I strongly felt that Mother was saying, ‘Son, Amma knows everything about you.’ I was tongue-tied and completely taken aback. Thereafter, I never doubted Mother’s omniscience.”



CHAPTER TWO

RELATIONSHIPS

Today, before the evening bhajans, Mother came down and sat at the western side of the temple. She was soon surrounded by the residents and a few householder devotees. One of the householders, a bank manager, asked Mother a question about relationships.

Mother: “A true relationship can be developed only if there is proper understanding between a husband and wife, between friends, or whoever is involved in a relationship of any kind. There are different passages in life. Marriage is one such passage, and it is one of the most important ones there is. For a person who lives in the world (i.e. a householder), to be able to live a full, productive life, he or she must pass through the passage of marriage with as much love, intimacy, caring and commitment as possible. Married life, if it is lived with the proper love and understanding, will help awaken the feminine within a man, and the masculine within a woman. This balance can eventually help both of them reach the final goal of eternal freedom.

“If the couple takes the necessary steps, making the effort

to understand and respect each other's feelings, they will be able to live their lives fully. They should be willing to forgive and forget each other's faults and weaknesses. Married life can be a rich field of learning that teaches the couple to develop such qualities as patience and humility.

"In Indian society this is easier as Indian women tend to be more yielding in nature and less aggressive. The ego of a man is kept in check by the humility and patience of a woman. Although modern society is changing at a rapid pace, the basic culture of Indian society remains the same. But if there is to be a proper balance and sense of harmony in married life, men should try not to be aggressive, arrogant, or self-important in front of women, and they shouldn't try to dominate them. In India men often think they have the right to control women, and that a woman should never be ahead of a man in any way. This is clearly the wrong attitude, which is due to the lack of proper understanding of the culture that was founded by the ancient saints and seers.

MOTHERHOOD

GOD'S WONDERFUL GIFT TO WOMEN

"A woman should be respected and her feelings should be given proper consideration. Her maternal qualities should be

recognized and she should be given a higher, well deserved position in society, along with men. At the same time, she should know that the greatest gift God has bestowed on her is the gift of motherhood, the right to give birth and to raise a child with the proper care, love and affection. It is a unique gift, and it is hers alone. To give birth to the greatest people born on this earth, the divine incarnations, the great leaders, philosophers and scientists—to give birth to all the eminent souls and to all of mankind—this is one of the greatest blessings of all. Why has God given women this wonderful gift? Because they alone have the capacity to express such qualities as love, compassion, caring and patience, in all its fullness and beauty. Every woman should know this and try to comprehend the significance of this blessing. But it would seem that women are slowly forgetting this truth; and if they ignore this fundamental and indispensable quality within themselves, our society will be turned upside down. It is therefore vitally important that women recognize these qualities within themselves.

“It is mostly in western society that women are forgetting their feminine qualities. In the name of equality, many women are disregarding this most priceless blessing they have been given. In the West, as opposed to Indian society, women are

more aggressive and less yielding. As western women try to catch up with men in all areas of life, they do not realize that they are sacrificing an essential part of their nature. The result of this is total chaos and confusion, both in the outer and inner life. Amma is not saying that a woman shouldn't do the same things that men do—she can and she should, and women have an immense inner power—but it should never be done at the cost of sacrificing her essential being. Going against nature is destructive; it is dangerous for the person in question as well as for society as a whole.

“In the West both men and women tend to be aggressive. Aggression, however, is negative energy. Sometimes it may be needed in life, but not in relationships, not in married life. When two poles are negative, only negative energy is produced, resulting in complete disharmony and disruption.

“In western society both husband and wife try to control each other; they believe it is their right to do so. In the constant clash and tug-of-war that follows, the love and the beauty of the relationship is destroyed.

“Love is not aggressive, and neither is life. They cannot be forced. Life is love. Without the feeling of love, through which we experience true life, our existence becomes dry and empty, like a robot. Life and love are interdependent; if there is no love, you are ignoring life itself.”

MARRIED LIFE

Question: “Amma, why is there no real love in married life? What causes the conflicts and the friction?”

Mother: “There is a serious lack of understanding between the husband and wife. In most cases the couple won’t even make an attempt to understand each other. For the development of a true relationship to take place, a basic understanding of human nature, the nature of men and women, is essential. A man should know what a woman is really like and vice versa. But, instead, they dwell in two isolated worlds with no connection between them. They are like two separate islands with no link between them, not even a ferry service.

“Men are mostly intellectually centered, while women tend to be more emotional. They dwell in two different centers, along two parallel lines. No real meeting takes place within them. How, then, can there be any love between the two? If the one says yes, the other will undoubtedly say no. You will never hear the harmonious blending of yes and yes or no and no in unison. Their different natures should be understood and accepted, and each one, both husband and wife, should make a conscious effort to reach out to the other’s feelings, to the heart, and then try to work out their problems with this understanding as their foundation. They shouldn’t try to control each other. They shouldn’t say to each other, ‘I say

yes, and therefore you should also say yes.'

"Any such attitude should be dropped, for it will only lead to anger and even hatred. The love in such a relationship will be very superficial. If the gulf between these two centers, the intellect and emotions (mind), can be bridged, the sweet music of love will spring forth from the depths within them. This unifying factor is spirituality. If you look at our ancestors, you will see that their marriages were generally more loving than such relationships are today. There was much more love and harmony in their lives, because they had a better understanding of the spiritual principles and their implications in day-to-day life.

"Amma has heard the following story. A married woman decided that she wanted a pet. But her husband was against it. One day when he was away, she went to a pet shop and bought a monkey. Needless to say, her husband was angry when he came home and found the monkey in the house. He asked her, 'What is that creature going to eat?'

'What else but the same food that we eat,' she replied.

'And where is it going to sleep?'

'Where else but in the same bed where we sleep,' came the reply.

'But are you not worried about the smell!'

'No! Don't worry, if I could bear it for the last twenty years,

I'm sure this poor animal can bear it as well!"

Everyone burst into laughter as Mother finished the story. Mother continued, "It is very rare to find a truly loving relationship. The love between a married couple is usually only skin deep. If one of them says 'yes,' the other will make it a point to say 'no.' Children, learn to respect each other's feelings. Learn to listen to each other's problems with love and concern. When you listen to your partner, he or she should be able to feel that you are genuinely interested and that you would sincerely like to help. Your partner should feel your care and concern, your respect and admiration. An open acceptance of the other is needed, and there should be no reservations. Still, conflicts are bound to occur; misunderstandings and disagreements may arise. But later, one should be able to say, 'I'm sorry, please forgive me. I didn't mean it.' Or you could say, 'I love you and I'm deeply concerned about you—don't ever think otherwise. I'm sorry, I shouldn't have said what I said; in my anger I lost my temper and my power of discrimination.' Such soothing words will help to heal any hurt feelings; it will also contribute to a deep feeling of love between you, even after a big quarrel."

Mother stopped and said, "Balumon (Balu,⁴ my son), sing a song." Br. Srikumar⁵ was asked to bring the harmonium.

⁴ Swami Amritaswarupananda. ⁵ Swami Purnamritananda.

They started chanting, *Mauna Ghanamrita*. Mother leaned Her head against Bri. Gayatri's shoulder and listened to the bhajan with Her eyes half closed. The blissful, radiant smile on Mother's face made it clear that She was in an indrawn state.

*In the abode of impenetrable Silence
Of eternal Beauty and Peace
Where the mind of Gautama Buddha
Was dissolved,
In the Effulgence that destroys all bonds,
On the Shore of Bliss
Which lies beyond the reach of thought. . .*

*In the Knowledge that bestows eternal
harmony,
The Abode without beginning or end,
The Bliss known only when
The movements of the mind subside,
At the Seat of Power,
The Region of Perfect Consciousness. . .*

*At the Goal which bestows the sweet state
Of eternal non-duality
Described as 'Thou art That,'
That is the place where I long to reach;
But I can only do so
Through Your Grace.*

After the singing had stopped, Mother continued to lean against Gayatri's shoulder. When She eventually stirred and sat up, one of the devotees said to Her, "Amma, you were talking about relationships."

Mother then continued to speak.

RECOGNIZE AND ADMIRE THE GOOD QUALITIES IN EACH OTHER

"Children, as ordinary human beings, everyone has both good and bad qualities. Always try to recognize and admire the good qualities in each other. Whenever you are talking to others about your partner, try to highlight his or her good qualities; don't ever mention the weaknesses in front of others. Whatever your weaknesses may be, they should remain a secret between the two of you. You should work out your problems together with a positive attitude, without provoking or hurting each other with accusations. First of all, we should become aware of our own weaknesses, because this is the best way to remove them. Never use your partner's faults as a weapon against him or her. When you are pointing out a weakness, do so lovingly and with every intention of eradicating it in a positive way from your lives. These weaknesses are blocks that prevent you from expressing yourselves fully. See these blocks as obstructions and learn to remove them.

“Recently, a devotee, who is a hospital administrator working in Bombay, was talking about a problem they had in the hospital, concerning cleanliness. Most people in the North are in the habit of chewing pan, a concoction made of betel leaves, arcanut and other ingredients. It is their practice to chew the pan and then, without a second thought, spit out the bright red substance wherever they happen to be standing. The four corners of the hospital elevators were splattered all over with the crimson spittle of visitors. The hospital administration had a meeting, in which they tried to come up with a solution to this problem. Finally, they decided to install mirrors in all four corners of the elevators. As soon as this step had been taken, people stopped spitting in the elevators. What made them stop? Undoubtedly it was the sight of their own image as they were spitting, being reflected in the mirrors. Once they saw how ugly it was, they couldn’t bring themselves to do it again, and so they stopped.

“Similarly, try to look at your own faults and you will automatically eradicate them. By seeing your own weaknesses and bad habits you become aware of how ugly they are. Your weaknesses lie hidden in the dark, but as you look at them they are brought out into the light.

“Our great ancestors have given us wonderful examples on how to recognize and respect others for their good qualities.

“One of the *Ramayanas* describes a beautiful incident in which Lord Rama set an unforgettable example of humility, by recognizing the great sacrifice of Urmila, Lakshmana’s chaste wife. When Lakshmana, Rama’s brother, followed him to the forest during the period of Rama’s exile, Urmila was forced to spend fourteen years in Ayodhya, experiencing the terrible pain of separation from her husband whom she adored. Rama had brought His holy consort, Sita, along with Him. But Lakshmana had to leave his wife behind in Ayodhya. Urmila lived a life of great self-sacrifice, spending her days and nights constantly thinking about her husband. One day, when Rama finally returned to Ayodhya, he was seen walking towards Urmila’s private chamber. Out of curiosity, Lakshmana followed him and secretly watched what the Lord was doing. What Lakshmana witnessed literally made him burst into tears. Urmila was lying fast asleep on her bed. The Lord joined his palms together in a gesture of reverence and walked round the bed thrice, after which he prostrated on the floor in front of her feet, just as people do in temples.

“Later when Lakshmana asked Sri Rama to explain the meaning of this act, the Lord replied, ‘Urmila is worthy of the greatest respect and appreciation. The great sacrifice she has made deserves our admiration. I simply wanted to acknowledge her but without her knowing it, because if she had been

awake, she wouldn't have let me do it. That is why I went to her when she was asleep.'

"Such great examples shown to us by the mahatmas should be remembered and followed. This will bring love, peace and harmony both to our inner and outer lives. It will remove any discordant notes that may exist in a relationship and in married life. Men should never be arrogant or reluctant to recognize a woman's good qualities. Their attitude is very wrong if they think, 'After all, she is only a woman.'

"Look at how meaningless modern relationships are. There is rarely any true love between a married couple. There is too much judgment, fear and suspicion to make a loving relationship possible. Due to the lack of love and proper understanding, relationships have become no more than skin deep.

"Amma recently heard a funny story that comes to mind. Two young men met on the street. One of them said to the other, 'You lucky man! You have won yourself a pretty girlfriend. Tell me, what does she think of you?'

'She thinks I have a great personality, that I am a gifted singer and a talented painter,' came the reply.

'And what about you? What attracts you to her?'

'That she thinks I have a great personality, that I am a gifted singer and a talented painter.'"

When the laughter had quieted down, Mother asked for

a song. One of the householder devotees sang the song,
Amritamayi Anandamayi. . .

*O Goddess of Nectar
Goddess of Immortal Bliss
O Mother Amritanandamayi
O Goddess of Nectar
Goddess of Eternal Bliss. . .*

*O Mother
As you watch Your children shed tears
Your heart melts with concern.*

*O compassionate Mother
Lovingly You caress Your children
As You feed them
The milk of tenderness.*

*O Mother, with the hue of an emerald
Come and dwell in my heart!
Your Lotus Feet are the sole refuge
Of this poor one.*

*You shine forth from within
As the inner eye of the external eye;
You are the Mother of Kanna
You are the Mother of the whole Universe
The Goddess of the Universe.*

THE SIGN OF A TRUE RELATIONSHIP

After the song, Mother continued to enlighten Her children on the same subject.

Question: “What are the signs of a true relationship?”

Mother: “When two people identify with each other, it is the sign of a true relationship. The intensity of love depends on the amount of identification there is between people. Suppose someone were to ask you, ‘Which one of your friends do you love the most, a or b or c?’ Perhaps you’d have to think about it for a while, or perhaps you’d spontaneously say, ‘I like a the most. He is my best friend.’ What does it mean when you say that you like a the most? It means that you are more identified with a than with b or c, doesn’t it? A true relationship, or true love, is based on the amount of identification one has with someone. However, it isn’t something that can be measured, for it is a deep feeling, something that happens within. As the identification intensifies, that sense of oneness becomes manifest externally as well. Your heart overflows with love and expresses itself through your words and actions. At its peak, even your bodies will bear a close resemblance. This rarely happens in worldly relationships. In a spiritual relationship, however, it happens in a clear, profound way. It happens, for example, to a disciple who has

completely surrendered to his spiritual master, and whose heart is filled with love and devotion towards his master.

“This is exactly what happened to the gopis of Vrindavan. By constantly thinking of Sri Krishna, the gopis became like Him. At one stage the gopis used to say to each other, ‘Friend, look at me. I am Krishna. I walk like Him, don’t I? Can’t you see the divine flute in my hands and the peacock feather in my crown?’

“Amma knows a married couple who have developed this sense of identification with each other. They look like twins—even their voices and movements are similar. Amma has known them for a long time. They are the ideal couple. The mutual love, respect, understanding, patience and forgiveness they have towards each other is extraordinary. So it can happen even in a worldly relationship, even in married life, provided you have the right attitude.

“In such deep love, even your thought patterns will be the same. For example, a husband may think of something without saying a word about it. Yet somehow his wife is aware of it. He thinks of something and his wife says the same thing, or he wishes to do something and his wife suddenly expresses the same wish. It is Sunday. He is sitting in his work room trying to get some urgent work done. He happens to feel very tired, but he can’t go and take a nap because the work has

to be finished and lying on his boss's desk by the very next day. As he struggles to keep his eyes open, he thinks to himself, 'I need a cup of strong coffee.' But he doesn't want to go and ask his wife to make it because he knows that she is busy preparing the Sunday lunch. It is not his habit to drink coffee at that time of day; and yet, to his surprise, a moment later his wife enters the room and hands him a cup of coffee. He asks, 'How on earth did you know that I needed a cup of coffee?' She smiles and replies, 'I just felt that you'd like a cup, that's all.' This sort of thing happens during certain moments in a relationship, and it can be developed, provided the couple have the right feeling and understanding between them. It will then grow and eventually manifest through all their thoughts and actions.

"If this can happen in a normal relationship, the identification or sense of oneness that happens in the Guru-sishya relationship is incomparably greater.

"Gayatri had an experience that is worth mentioning. Once, Amma was working outside with the ashramites. When Amma later returned to Her room, Her hands were dirty. Amma wanted to wash Her hands, so She asked Gayatri to bring Her some soap and water. But instead of bringing Her the soap and water, Gayatri started washing her own hands under the bathroom tap. Lakshmi saw her standing in the bathroom

washing her own hands while Amma was waiting for the soap and water. Lakshmi had to remind her that Amma was waiting for Her hands to be washed. When Gayatri heard Lakshmi's words, she came back to her senses. Realizing that she was washing her own hands instead of Amma's, she exclaimed, 'O my God, I thought I was washing Mother's hands!' She felt perplexed and glanced at Amma with a guilty expression. But Amma understood what had happened. This happened to Gayatri at a particular moment when she was able to forget herself. But the power to experience that oneness, that total identification, is always there within us.

"A true relationship is possible only when one is able to let go of all one's preconceived ideas and prejudices, and when one stops being possessed by the past. Your mind is the past. Stop clinging to the past and you will be free and peaceful. To cling to the past is like living in the dark. We all want to be in the light. Stop fighting the past, stop reacting to it, and you will be in the light. You will then clearly be able to see everything that is happening within you. With such a clear vision it is possible to form a true relationship."

As Mother spoke, the sun was slowly descending on the western horizon for its usual dip in the deep-blue ocean. Just as the sun works tirelessly and selflessly to sustain life on earth,

Mother, the “spiritual Sun,” is constantly working hard to inspire Her children through Her profound words, Her divine presence, Her compassionate embrace, and Her elevating bhajans. She touches the heart of everyone by expressing Her incomparable love and compassion with Her whole being, helping everyone to open up fully and to, in their turn, spread a sweet, divine fragrance and beauty all around.

When Mother had finished talking She got up from Her seat and stood with Her arms outstretched towards the sky. She called out, “Shivane!” For some time, She remained standing in that position with Her eyes closed, and then She walked over to the temple. It was time for bhajans. Mother was about to carry Her children on the wings of Her ecstatic, melodious song. Blissfully Mother began to sing the song, *Anjana Sridhara*. . .

*O Sridhara,
Collyrium-hued and beautiful
I salute You with joined palms.
Victory to Krishna,
Salutations to Him!*

*O Krishna
Who was born on earth*

*As a Divine Child,
Protect me in every way.*

*O darling Krishna,
Please destroy the grief in my heart.
O Cowherd Boy
Lotus-eyed Krishna
Come and shine in my heart!*

*O Krishna!
I am filled with the desire
To see the beauty
Of Your dear, auspicious form.*

*O Cowherd Boy,
Please come running
And play Your flute!*



CHAPTER THREE

THE SECRET OF A CHILD'S BEAUTY

Because the new temple was being constructed, the Ashram premises looked rather messy. Mother, however, insisted that all the bricks, sand, and other construction materials be kept in an organized way. Whenever She came down from Her room, Mother Herself took the initiative and started cleaning the grounds. As far as Mother was concerned, no work was too menial for Her. She could be seen carrying the bricks and baskets of sand on Her head. A moment later, Mother would grab a shovel and begin to fill the baskets with sand. This morning when Mother came down, She asked the residents to bring baskets and tools, and She began to clean the grounds. Within a few minutes the entire Ashram population were on their feet ready to work. As Mother worked along with the residents, She sang the song, *Entu Chevo Yedu Chevo*. . .

Alas! What am I to do?

The Son of Nanda is not to be found anywhere.

*Did He get up early this morning
And go to the forest to graze the cows?
Or—O God!—did He break His legs
In a fight with the other children?*

*Or, perhaps, he has been running here
and there
And fallen into a ditch. . . .*

Everyone responded and sang the chorus of the song. Mother was setting a perfect example of doing work as a form of worship. The work continued for more than an hour. As Mother's presence adds beauty and charm to any given situation, there was now an atmosphere of great joy amongst the participants. When the cleaning was over, Mother sat down, surrounded by the Ashram residents and householder devotees. While everyone was relaxing, one of the residents raised a question. "Spiritual masters all over the world use the small child as an example of the ultimate state of perfection. What is so special about a child in connection with spirituality?" **Mother:** "Look at a child. The child is not at all concerned about the past or the future. Whatever the child does, is done with total participation. The child is fully present in whatever he does, he cannot do anything partially. Children live in the present moment; this is why people feel so drawn to

them. You cannot really dislike a child, because the ugliness of the ego is not present in the child.

“A child can attract anyone’s attention; even the most cold-hearted person will have some feelings towards a child, unless the person is a demonic monster. This attraction is due to the innocence of the child. When you are free from the grip of the ego, you, yourself, will become as innocent and playful as a child.

“Most human beings live with one foot planted in the dead past, and the other in the future which is not real. The future is an unreal dream which has yet to happen. You cannot be sure that it will actually happen in your case. The future is uncertain; it may or may not occur, and yet, the most intelligent human beings constantly worry and dream about the future, or they brood and cry recollecting the dead fossils of the past. Both the past and the future should disappear. Only then will you be able to live in this moment, for it is in this moment that you experience reality. This moment alone is real. The past and the future are unreal.

“Just as a child lives fully in the present, when you love, let your whole being be present in that love, without any divisions or reservations. Don’t do anything partially, do it fully by being in the present moment. Don’t brood on the past, and don’t cling to it. Forget the past and stop dreaming

about the future. Express yourself by being fully present, right now. Nothing, neither the regrets of the past nor the anxiety about the future, should interfere with the flow as you express your inner feelings. Let go of everything, and let your whole being flow through your mood. This is exactly what a child does.

“A child doesn’t have any attachments to the past, nor does he worry about the future. When a child says, ‘Mummy, I like you so much!’ he really means it. Through his kisses, looks and loving ways he expresses himself with his whole being. The child doesn’t recall the scolding or thrashing he was given yesterday, nor is he upset because the toy he so badly wanted wasn’t bought for him; and he has no worries about tomorrow. He doesn’t hold onto anything. The child simply loves and forgets. A child can never do anything partially. Whenever he does anything, he is fully present. Doing something partially is possible only when there is an ego.

“Whatever a child does is not related to any memories. The child experiences the present moment, and whether he is feeling love or anger, it is being fully expressed. But he will soon forget it and pass on to the next moment. A child’s expressions, whether it be anger or love, are never caused by attachment. That is why even the anger of a child has a cer-

tain beauty. It is purely natural and spontaneous, and whatever is expressed spontaneously, without any interference of the ego, has a beauty and charm of its own. But you have to be innocent to be that spontaneous. This is why even the anger of a Mahatma is beautiful, because the Mahatma is absolutely pure and innocent. His expressions are spontaneous, direct and utterly natural. He is not reacting out of the past. He just is, right here, in this moment.

“A grownup’s anger is ugly. Nobody likes a person when he is angry. But the anger of a child is different. When a child is angry, the father, mother or someone else will lift the child into their arms and embrace him. They will kiss the child and do all they can to calm him down. Whereas the anger of a grownup is repulsive and will arouse the anger in others, a child’s anger invokes our love and sympathy. It is the presence of the ego in the grownup, and its absence in the child, that makes the difference.

“You can only be attached if you have an ego. The ego makes you attached to the past, and as long as the ego’s attachment to the past exists, you cannot express anything fully. Your every word and action will be tainted by the ego. The past creeps up before you and creates a fence between yourself and whatever you do or say. Whatever you wish to express is first filtered through the fence of the past; thus the

child, or the innocence within, is completely blocked.

“A child has no ego, no past or future. The child has no attachments, and because of this, he is able to express himself fully, without any prejudices or preconceived ideas.

REAL GROWTH AND MATURITY

“Grownups believe they have grown up, that they should no longer be like children, and that childlike qualities are something to be ashamed of. But what really has grown up in the grownup is the ego. The body, intellect and ego may have grown, but the heart, i.e., such essential qualities as love and compassion, is on its death bed. People think they have become mature adults. But are they really grown up and mature? The body has changed from a child’s body into a grownup body, but the inner personality is still undeveloped.

“If you continue to cling to the past, you cannot call it maturity. Of course, you can find people with a so-called mature ego, but among them you will not find a truly mature human being. A person with a mature ego may behave in a decent and refined way, but he still acts and speaks in the light of his past. His words and actions in the present are rooted in his past experiences. He has made many mistakes in the past. He has learned a lot from all those experiences; and now, when-

ever he says or does anything, he is careful not to repeat the same mistakes and not to say something foolish, because he knows from experience that this could create problems. So he chooses his words carefully and acts with deliberation. This shows that the past is still working within him, in a subtle, refined and powerful way. We may call this maturity, intellectual maturity or maturity of the ego—but it is not real maturity.

“Real, genuine maturity develops when you drop the ego and you stop dwelling in the past. When the inner Self is allowed to express itself, without being tainted or interrupted by the ego, a spontaneous and genuine maturity unfolds.”

Question: “Is Amma saying that the growth and maturity of people, which is considered to be so real, is not real at all?”

Mother: “Children, it has a reality of its own. But it is relative. Amma feels that everything should be evaluated from two levels: from a worldly and a spiritual level, from the individual’s viewpoint and from a higher perspective, a universal perspective. What seems true from a worldly level may not be real from a spiritual level. The growth and maturity that people generally consider to be real, is not necessarily real from a higher level of consciousness. This doesn’t mean that material growth is useless or unimportant. The point is

that ordinary human beings consider only proven facts to be real and valid. But the unknown, that which can be known only through faith and constant spiritual practice, coupled with strong determination, is the ultimate Truth and Reality. From that ultimate viewpoint, this world, and what happens in the world, is only relative. Take, for example, the death of a person. As far as his family is concerned, it is certainly a big loss which creates deep sorrow in their lives. But if you look at it from a different angle, there are hundreds of thousands of people dying everyday. Hundreds of thousands of wives are losing their husbands, mothers are losing their children, and children are losing their fathers and mothers. Death must happen to everything that is born—it is inevitable and unavoidable. From a universal level, the death of one person is only relatively real. It is a major and very sad event for the family of the individual, but it is not so from a higher, universal level.

“Similar is the case with growth and maturity. It should be evaluated from both these levels. From the individual’s point of view, growth of the body and intellect is real and necessary for his existence in the world. But from a universal point of view, real growth happens only when you realize that you are *purnam* (the Whole), and not an isolated entity, not a part.

“External growth, that is, the growth of the body, mind and intellect, certainly has a place of its own. However, when you are only growing externally you are not growing fully. As long as the infinite potential of your inner Self remains untapped, your growth is only relative. From the level of the ultimate reality, only when Self-unfolding takes place can we call it real growth.

“Maturity of the ego is necessary for the growth of an individual; this, in turn, will benefit society to a certain extent. But real inner growth and maturity happens only when one transcends the ego, and when the personality grows as a whole. For real, integral growth to take place, the inner Self must unfold. Only then will your vision of life be transformed.

“Humility is the best soil from which the inner Self can unfold. Develop intellectually but always remain humble, then your intellect and maturity will be perfected.

“To be truly humble is to bow down, not just with your body, but with your entire being. You should feel with your whole being that you are nothing, not just before the Master or a few selected souls, but before all of creation. **Recognize the Master’s supreme consciousness shining in and through everything.**

“Grow without allowing your innocence to be destroyed; and as you grow, remain humble in all circumstances. Your

physical growth should not affect the child within. Let your intellect become sharper, let your mind gain more clarity and vigor, but along with the development of your faculties, the feelings of the heart should also be allowed to grow. Such growth is perfect growth in perfect proportion. It will help you maintain a healthy and intelligent attitude towards life, in every possible situation. This verily is the fundamental foundation of life that allows you to experience a loving and intelligent relationship with everyone and everything.”

After Mother had finished speaking, one of the devotees began to sing a song, *Maha Kali Jagado Dharini*, in praise of Goddess Kali, which he himself had set the tune to. . .

*O Mahakali
You sustain the whole universe
And You destroy it
O Giver of solace
You captivate my mind
Please awaken
And cast Your glance on this soul.*

*O Bearer of salvation
With a necklace of skulls
Giver of boons
O Protector of the three worlds
Destroyer of evil*

*O Kali!
You captivate my mind
Please awaken
And cast Your glance on this soul.*

*Brahma, Vishnu and Narada
Are forever worshipping You
Shankara resides forever at Your feet
You are eternally victorious
And untouched by vasanas
You captivate my mind
Please awaken
And cast Your glance on this soul.*

At five-thirty in the evening Mother called all the residents to the seashore. By the time everyone arrived at the beach Mother was in deep samadhi. Bri. Gayatri was sitting a few yards away from Her. The residents sat down quietly around Mother. Soon everyone was meditating, except that many of them meditated with open eyes, gazing at Mother. The dark-blue ocean raised its gigantic waves as if to embrace and welcome Mother. The waves seemed to be dancing in bliss at the sight of Mother sitting so close to them on the shore.

An hour later Mother stood up and walked slowly along the beach. It was getting dark and a strong breeze was blow-

ing in from the sea. Mother's white sari and Her curly black hair danced in the wind. The waves seemed to be competing with each other to catch hold of Mother's sacred feet and to prostrate at those feet. As Mother walked with slow steps along the edge of the ocean, a few waves were fortunate enough to embrace and kiss Her feet. They then peacefully withdrew and merged back into the sea. The other waves chanted loudly the sacred sound, "Aum," and they rushed towards the shore, as if they, too, were hoping to embrace Mother's holy feet.

In a deeply absorbed spiritual mood Mother sang *Omkara Mengum*, as She continued to walk along the shore followed by Her children.

*The sound 'Om' resonates everywhere
Echoing in every atom.
With a peaceful mind,
Let us chant, 'Om Shakti.'*

*The tears of sadness are overflowing
And now, Mother is my only support.
Bless me with Your beautiful hands
For I have given up all worldly enjoyments
Sorrowful and worthless as they are.*

*The fear of death has disappeared
The desire for physical beauty is gone.
I must incessantly remember Your form
That shines with the Light of Shiva.*

*When I am filled with an inner light
That overflows and shines before me
And I am drunk with devotion,
I will merge in the beauty of Your form.*

*Your form is what I long to see the most
All existing loveliness has crystallized
And come as this unequaled Beauty
Oh, now my tears are overflowing. . .*

When the song ended, Mother stopped walking and stood gazing at the western horizon for a few more seconds before She turned around and walked back towards the Ashram followed by the others.



CHAPTER FOUR

“YES, I AM KALI”

A few more people and the darshan would be over. Mother ended the darshan and was soon to be found in the dining hall, where She Herself was serving food to all the devotees. Like the most loving and affectionate mother, She waited until everyone had been given their food before She left the dining hall. Just as Mother was leaving, She suddenly turned and approached a visitor. She took a ball of rice, which he had kept aside on his plate, and She ate it without saying a word. As if struck by a thunderbolt the man froze and stared at Mother’s face. Tears welled up in his eyes and ran down his cheeks. Soon he was sobbing uncontrollably, calling out, “Kali! Kali!” as he fell at Mother’s feet. Stroking his head and back with a radiant, compassionate smile, Mother spent a few more minutes in the dining hall before She returned to Her room.

Later, the devotee, who came from Bengal, explained the mystery of Mother’s seemingly strange behavior and his emotional reaction. He had been in Cochin the previous day, when a friend told him about Mother. Being an ardent devo-

tee of Kali, he felt strongly attracted towards Her. His friend had some urgent work to attend to, so he came to the Ashram alone to meet Mother for the first time. He went up to Mother in the hut and had Her darshan. Then later, while sitting in the dining hall in front of the food which had just been served by Mother, he made a ball of rice and put it aside on his plate with the resolve that, "If Mother is Kali, my Beloved Deity, whom I have worshipped for so long, She will come and eat this rice." So that is what happened. When he saw Mother stepping out of the dining hall, he felt tremendously disappointed. But a moment later Mother was standing in front of him, and before he knew what was happening, Mother took the ball of rice which he had kept aside for Kali and She ate it. The man said, "When Mother ate the rice ball, She was clearly telling me, "Yes, I am Kali." After this incident he was in a divinely intoxicated mood during the entire time he spent in the Ashram, until he left for Calcutta the next morning.

KNOW THE INNER SELF TO BE SELFLESS

This evening, a group of householder devotees came to receive Mother's darshan. Mother was sitting with them behind the old temple.

Whenever Mother is in the midst of Her children, She is more than willing to clear any doubts they may have. When the devotees and brahmacharis are around Mother, their unquenchable thirst for true knowledge takes the form of spontaneous questions. This time a question was asked by a woman who was a college professor, and who had been deeply devoted to Mother for a long time.

Question: “Amma, selfless love and selfless action are considered to be a path to God. But how can one possibly love and act selflessly when one is full of judgment and preconceived ideas? Selflessness sounds more like a goal to be attained, and not something that can be practiced. Amma, could you throw some light on this?”

Mother: “Selfless action is the outward expression of selfless love. When the heart is filled with love, it expresses itself as unselfish action. One is a deep inner feeling and the other its outward manifestation. Without deep, unconditional love, selfless actions cannot be performed.

“In the initial stages, the actions we perform in the name of selflessness are not selfless, because the love that we feel for ourselves is present in everything we do and say; in fact, in the beginning, our self-love is the driving force behind every one of our actions, even though we may call them selfless. Love for the ego, or oneself, is the most predominant feeling

in every human being. Unless this feeling dies, real selflessness cannot emerge.

“Alertness is necessary to stop the ego from interfering. It is much easier to be in love with the ego than to feel truly inspired by the ideal of selflessness. Most of the time the selflessness we talk about is really selfish, because everything we do stems from the ego. It is the ego, and not our inner Self, that is the source of our so-called love and our actions. Nothing can be selfless unless it springs directly from the heart, from our true Self. This is the reason why the great saints and sages have said that you should know your own Self before you can love and serve others selflessly. Otherwise, who knows? It could all amount to the fact that you are in love with your own ego, and nothing else.

“Selflessness is the final state to be attained. A person cannot be one hundred percent selfless without getting rid of his preconceived ideas and judgmental attitude. You can, however, have selflessness as your goal, as an ideal, and then try to reach it through the proper methods recommended by the masters.

“There is a story about an old man who was planting mango trees. When his neighbor saw what he was doing, he came to him and said, ‘Do you think you will live long enough to taste the mangoes from those trees?’

‘No, I doubt it,’ replied the old man.

‘Then why are you wasting your time?’ asked the neighbor.

The old man smiled and said, ‘All my life I have enjoyed eating mangoes from trees that have been planted by others. This is my way of expressing my thankfulness to the people who planted those trees.’

“Selflessness can be the driving force behind all your actions. Learn to be thankful to everyone, to the entire creation, even to your enemy, and to those who insult you and get angry with you, because they all help you to grow. They are mirrors, images of your own mind. If you know how to read and interpret the images properly, you can get rid of your mind and its weaknesses.

“If you choose love and selflessness as your goal, you need to be watchful. Watch your mind constantly, because the mind won’t let you do anything selflessly. The mind doesn’t want you to be selfless—its one and only aim is to drive you along the path of selfishness, because the mind is selfish. As long as you dwell in the mind you can only be selfish. You have to be free of the mind to be selfless.”

WATCH THE MIND

Question: “How, then, does one break out of the mind?”

Mother: “By being watchful and constantly aware. There was a man who used to come to the Ashram. He would criticize everyone and complain about them for hours on end; he never had a good word to say about anyone. Finally, Amma said to him, ‘Son, you shouldn’t slander people like that. Everyone has weaknesses, but they also have good qualities. Try to see the goodness in everyone. That is the best way to become good in word and deed.’ After this he was quiet for a while. But one day when Amma was talking to him, he said, ‘Amma, do You know what? Mr. D. says that Mr. S. is a very selfish and unkind man.’

“In one way or another, the mind will keep on playing its tricks. When Amma told this man that he shouldn’t criticize others, he couldn’t say no to Amma because of his reverence for Her. So he agreed to it outwardly. But deep within he rejected it. His mind just couldn’t accept that he should change, because it was such a deep-rooted tendency in him. You see, the mind is a very tricky, wicked thing. His mind didn’t want to accept Amma’s advice, but at the same time, it wanted to put on a big show, just to impress others. With slight variations and modifications, the mind continued to play its nasty

game: 'This man is saying that that man is no good.' See how the mind works!

"So be watchful. Don't let the mind deceive you. It has been playing its tricks and making a fool of you for ages, life after life. To begin with, you need to understand that the mind is a trickster, a clever liar, that stops you from being aware of your true nature, the Self. Constant watchfulness will prevent that liar from lying. You should be so watchful that even if the mind tries to tiptoe through the backdoor, you are immediately aware of it. Nothing should happen without your knowledge; not a single thought or breath should escape without you being aware of it. Once you are able to remain wakeful, keep a close watch on the mind. The mind will then disappear along with the deceptive traps of the past.

SELFLESSNESS IS SPONTANEOUS

"Selflessness is a state of utter spontaneity, which arises once you are established in the Self.

"In the great epic, the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, there is a story about Saint Samika. This story will give you an idea of how spontaneous selflessness can be. King Parikshit, Arjuna's grandson, once went out on a hunting expedition. It was a long and tiring hunt, and the King was eventually overcome by

thirst. He went off by himself to find a place where he could get some water. He finally came across the hermitage of Saint Samika. The thirsty and exhausted King entered the hermitage calling out loudly for water. But the Saint was in deep samadhi, oblivious of his surroundings. When Samika didn't respond to the King's repeated request for water, the King became furious. He felt deeply insulted, and losing his discrimination, he picked up a dead snake with the end of his bow and wrapped it around Samika's neck. The King then left the place. But a few young friends of Samika's eight-year-old son, Sringi, witnessed the King's act. They reported the matter to Sringi, who was playing in a nearby field. When the boy was told what had happened, he flew into a rage and he uttered a curse: 'Whoever the person may be who dared to do such a vicious thing to my pure and saintly father, will be bitten by the terrible snake, Takshaka, seven days from now, and will thereby meet his death.'

"Remember that this boy was only eight years old when he uttered the curse. This shows the tremendous willpower the children, who were brought up in the ancient gurukulas, had in those days. That power was the power of *dharma*.

"When the Sage came out of his samadhi, he was stunned to learn about the curse that had been uttered against the

King. He immediately fell to his knees and prayed, ‘O Lord! My little son, in his ignorance, has committed the unpardonable mistake of cursing a great and just monarch. Please make the curse ineffective and save the King from death.’ He summoned his son and sent him to the King’s palace to inform him about the curse and to request that the King take the necessary precautions to prevent the curse from being fulfilled.

“The curse, however, could not be reversed. But King Parikshit only benefited from the curse, because it allowed him to meet the great sage, Suka, who told him the stories of the *Bhagavatam*, and thus King Parikshit attained *Moksha* (Liberation).

“The story shows how selfless and forgiving Samika was. He was not at all bothered about the King’s lack of discrimination; he didn’t feel insulted or abused in any way. When he came to know how the King had wrapped the dead snake around his neck, the Sage said to his son, ‘You cursed the King without knowing the truth. The King was thirsty and exhausted. In his desperation, all he could think about was water; and when he couldn’t get any, he lost his temper and put the snake around my neck. But, above all, he is the Monarch. Though we live out here in this remote forest, we, too, are his subjects. He protects us; it is thanks to him that

we live here safely and undisturbed. Also, the King is a great devotee of the Lord. By cursing him, you will lose the Lord's Grace.'

"Such a beautiful and spontaneous expression of forgiveness can only come from the heart of a selfless soul. Once you are established in the Self, you are egoless, and your selflessness will be spontaneous."

Mother suddenly went into a state of *bhava samadhi*. There was a radiant smile on Her face. She was sitting with Her right hand held in a mudra; her index finger and the little finger were outstretched while the other three fingers were folded together. Inspired by Her divine, intoxicated mood the brahmacharis sang, *Kurirul Pole*. . .

*Who can that be
With such a terrible form
Dark as the darkest night?*

*Who is that One
Dancing wildly
In this battlefield splashed with blood
Like a bouquet of blue flowers
Twirling in a crimson lake?*

*Who is that One
With three eyes
Flashing like fireballs?*

*Who is that One
With thick, black, unfettered locks
Flowing like dark rain clouds?*

*Why do the three worlds tremble
As Her dancing steps strike the earth?*

*Oh, that resplendent damsel
Is the sweetheart of Shiva
The Bearer of the trident!*

After the song, Mother returned to Her normal mood. The college professor, who was inquisitive and wanted to know more about the attitude of selflessness, asked Mother for further clarification.

Mother: “Before you have attained Realization, whatever actions you do in the name of selfless service, are bound to be tainted by selfishness, because everything is filtered through your mind. Only such actions that come straight from the Self and from the heart can be selfless. But don’t worry; if you have the determination and the proper attitude, you will eventually become selfless.

“Continue to perform your actions in the world with the attitude of selflessness. In the beginning you have to make a conscious effort to remain intent on the goal. Your conscious effort will in due course become unconscious effort, and this

will take you to the state of perfect selflessness. Your selflessness will then be spontaneous. But, for now, you need to be constantly on the watch. The moment the mind interferes, you should be aware of it. Recognize the mind for what it is: an obstacle, the greatest enemy on your path. Know that it is a liar. Ignore the noisy mind and its chattering.

“A medical student is not a doctor. It takes years of concentrated study and preparations to become a good doctor. But during the period when he is still an intern, we might call him a doctor even though he hasn’t yet received his degree. Why? Because it is the goal he will reach at the end of his studies. Whatever he does is done as a preparation towards that goal. His aim is to be a doctor; he constantly remembers this and makes every effort to attain that final goal. He refrains from any action or situation that could create an obstacle on his path. Likewise, our final goal is selflessness, but we haven’t reached there yet. We do our duty and perform our actions with that state as our goal. Even though our actions at present are not selfless, we call them selfless, in the same way as we might call a medical intern a doctor. But this is still our period of training, and we have a long way to go before getting there. We should be fully intent on the goal; we should avoid any unnecessary thoughts, and whenever we perform an action, we should try to desist from being attached to the

action or its fruit. The action is being done now, in this moment—it is the present, and the fruit is the future. Live in the present moment. Learn to do your actions without any attachment and ignore the fruit of the future. This attitude will cleanse the mind of all its negativity and impurity, and will slowly uplift you to the state of selfless love and devotion. It will eventually take you even beyond that, to the ultimate state of Supreme Knowledge.

“You may ask, do we human beings have the capacity to attain the state of love and selflessness? Children, the truth is that human beings alone have the capacity to reach that ultimate state. It depends, however, on how we think and act. This world belongs to us. It is up to us whether we make it heaven or hell. Everything in nature remains exactly as it is. Only man has the power to choose; and if he chooses the wrong way, everything will go wrong. He can prepare for himself a bed of poisonous thorns or a bed of divinely scented flowers. Unfortunately, what can be seen around the world is man’s hasty preparation of his own deathbed. Consciously or unconsciously, people are moving farther away from true life and closer to death. Even though immortality is readily available, it is being ignored.

“The truth is that death is unnatural to us. Death is natu-

ral only to the body, not to the Self, which is our true being. It is life, the life principle, that is natural. Sorrow is also unnatural, whereas joy is our natural state. But man seems to be far more eager to embrace both death and sorrow. He has forgotten how to smile. Only when you tap into the joy of the Atman will you truly be able to smile. At the present stage, however, there is little happiness within, for our hearts are filled with sorrow; and this is being reflected in every word, thought and deed. How, then, did this downfall from immortality take place? Children, it is doubt and fear that has torn us away from true joy and immortality. However, that lost, forgotten joy can be regained if we just make the effort to be selfless. Immortality, which is our true state, can be rediscovered through the attitude of selfless love and selfless action.

“One doesn’t need any special training to behave selfishly, because it happens to be the predominant tendency in humans. While all of nature—the birds and the animals, the mountains, rivers and trees, the sun, the moon and the stars—stands as a typical example of selfless service, man is the only one who acts out of utter selfishness and greed. He dwells in his ego and has made his entire life into a cheap business venture. For man, there is no longer any sanctity of life; there is only selfish bargaining. All of life, the entire universe, is a

play of divine consciousness. But man has turned it into a play of the ego.

THE NEGATIVE MIND

“If man wants to be selfish, he doesn’t have to be taught, because he is already selfish, except when he is in deep sleep. Even his dreams are selfish, for they are the projections of his selfish mind. Because the mind is inherently negative, so too are most of his dreams. The dream state is a projection of the past. Unless the past disappears, spiritual progress cannot be attained.

“There is a beautiful incident in the *Mahabharata* in which Karna describes the negative and fickle nature of the mind. Karna was revered by everyone for his kindness and his great generosity. One day, he was rubbing oil on his hair as he was preparing for his bath. At that moment, Lord Krishna arrived and asked for the jeweled oil cup as a gift. Krishna was testing Karna, for it was reputed that Karna would, without exception, immediately give away whatever was asked of him. He never postponed a chance to give. When Krishna now asked for the jeweled cup that Karna was using, Karna was a bit surprised. He said, ‘Ah my Lord, how strange that you should want such a paltry thing. Yet who am I to judge? Here, take it.’—and because Karna’s right hand was full of oil, he placed

the cup in Krishna's hand with his left hand. But the Lord scolded Karna for offering the gift with his left hand. (In India one would never offer anything with the left hand, as it is considered to be improper.)

'Forgive me, Lord!' said Karna. 'As You can see, my right hand is covered with oil and I was afraid that during the time it would take to wash my hand, my untrustworthy mind might change its course and no longer want to give you the cup. My fickle mind would then deprive me of the good fortune obtained by Providence to offer You something. This was why I acted that very moment. Please forgive me.'

"Children, this is a good description of the mind."

"Amma isn't saying that you should abandon all action, or stop showing any love until you attain the state of perfection. Your sincere effort to love and to act selflessly must be continued. But Amma wants you to be aware of how subtle the ego is. If you are not constantly watchful and aware, it will trick you by sneaking in through the back door.

"Children, you cannot help anyone without benefiting yourself, nor can you harm anyone without injuring yourself. Listen to this story that Amma heard the other day.

"A man bumped into a friend in the street. When he noticed that his friend was grumbling to himself, he asked, 'What happened? Why are you so upset?'"

His friend said, 'That stupid taxi driver at the junction, whenever I meet him, he slaps me on my back. Well, I have decided to show him a piece of my mind!'

His friend cautioned him and said, 'Don't get into trouble.'

But the grumbler insisted, 'This is too much! I have to teach him a lesson!'

'Okay,' said his friend, 'what is your plan?'

'Listen,' said the grumbler, 'today I'm going to hide a stick of dynamite inside my coat; after that he will no longer have an arm to slap me with.'"

Everyone was laughing as Mother finished the story.

Mother continued, "Children, having a selfless attitude will uplift us. By helping others we are, in fact, helping ourselves. On the other hand, every time we do a selfish action, we are harming ourselves. Learn to bless everyone. Don't ever curse anyone, because a human being is not just a bundle of flesh and blood. There is a consciousness at work within everyone. That consciousness is not a separate, isolated entity; it is part of the whole, a Supreme Unity. Whatever we do is reflected in the Whole, in the one universal Mind—and it returns to you with the same intensity. Whenever you do a good or a bad action, it is reflected in the Universal Consciousness. Therefore, learn to be selfless and learn how to send blessings to everyone. Pray for everyone, because we

need the support and blessings of all of creation for our uplift.

When we pray for others the entire universe prays for us; and when we bless others the whole universe blesses us, because man is one with the cosmic energy.

“Why did Krishna ask the entire population of Vraja to worship mount Govardhana?⁶ He turned that day of worship into a big festival, even though He didn’t need anyone’s blessings. He did it only to teach humanity the way of seeking, and tapping into, the blessings of all of creation.”

Our beloved Mother Herself sets an example along this line. Before Mother installs the idol during the consecration ceremony of a Brahmasthanam temple, Mother appears, in turn, at each of the four doors of the temple, and with joined palms She seeks everyone’s permission saying, “The consecration is about to take place. Children, all your blessings are needed.” When Mother, who is the infinite power of God in human form, and who can bless the whole of creation with a single glance, seeks the permission and blessings of Her children, it is a unique example of humility. This is a great lesson for us all on how to seek our blessings from everyone and everything, even the most insignificant creature.

⁶ A sacred mountain near Lord Krishna’s birthplace. It is told in the *Srimad Bhagavatam* that He held up the hill on His upraised hand for one week and asked the villagers to take shelter under it from a severe rainstorm.

CHAPTER FIVE

After holding a program in Kodungallor, Mother and the residents were driving back to the Ashram in the ashram van. When the party reached Alleppy, the van suddenly broke down. Br. Ramakrishnan, who was driving, looked helplessly at Mother. He got out of the vehicle and examined the engine, but there was no obvious problem to be found. He once again tried to start the van but nothing happened. He asked Mother if he should call a mechanic or if they should rent another van. But Mother didn't say anything. She simply smiled, got out of the van and walked away. Ramakrishnan was in a fix. As everyone was walking away with Mother, he followed as well, hoping that She would give him some directions. But Mother ignored his questions. After a few minutes they arrived at the home of Mr. Sekhar whose house was not far from the spot where the van had broken down. Mr. Sekhar and his family were deeply devoted to Mother, and when they saw Mother, they were overjoyed. They laughed and cried at the same time, trying in a panic to quickly get everything organized, so that they could receive Mother in the traditional way. With tears in their eyes they did *pada puja* to Mother, as they chanted a few verses from the *Devi Mahatmyam*.

O Queen of the Universe, You protect the universe. As the Self of the universe, You support the universe. You are the (Goddess) worthy to be adored by the Lord of the universe. Those who bow in devotion to You themselves become the refuge of the universe.

O Devi, be pleased and protect us always from the fear of foes, as You have done just now by the slaughter of asuras. And destroy quickly the sins of all worlds and the great calamities which have sprung from the maturing of evil portents.

O Devi, You who remove the afflictions of the universe, be gracious to us who have bowed down to You. O You, worthy of adoration by the dwellers of the three worlds, be a boon-giver to the worlds.

The family had been wanting Mother to visit their home for a long time. They had heard that Mother would return to the Ashram via Alleppy after the Kodungallor program, and they sincerely hoped that Mother should visit their house. Since that morning they had been talking only about Mother, and just a few moments before Mother stepped into their house, Mr. Sekhar and his father were saying to each other that they doubted Mother would visit their house uninvited. A mo-

ment later Mother was standing at the door. They couldn't believe their eyes. It was like a dream.

After the pada puja, Mother went into the family shrine room where She performed *arati*. When the *arati* was over, Mother called each family member and talked to them individually. She listened to the stories of their aching hearts and affectionately comforted them with Her compassionate touch and with Her soothing words. Mother spent forty-five minutes with the Sekhars.

When Mother left the house, a sad and confused Ramakrishnan was waiting outside. Mother walked back to the ashram van without saying a word. When they reached the vehicle, Ramakrishnan said, "Amma, the van has not been repaired."

Mother got into the van and said, "Try to start it again." Ramakrishnan did as Mother told him and turned the ignition key. The vehicle started immediately and began moving smoothly along the road. With a big grin on his face, Ramakrishnan turned around, looked at Mother and said, "So it was just another one of Your *leelas*!" Mother had a mischievous expression on Her face, as if She were saying, "Son, you have only seen a tiny bit of this infinite leela."

Living with Mother is like being an airplane as it moves on its way to the take-off point. First the airplane moves slowly

out of the airdrome towards the runway; it then moves faster and faster along the runway until it finally takes off. If one learns to live in Mother's presence with an attitude of love and self-surrender, it will certainly bring one to the take-off point. In Mother's presence you do not remain the same—you are constantly changing internally. The old patterns disappear as you move deeper and deeper into the new realms of your true existence.

On the way back to the Ashram, Mother visited the homes of two more devotees in Harippad. It was 7:30 p.m. when Mother and the group reached the Ashram. A brahmachari named Anish⁷ was waiting for Mother to arrive at the Ashram. He was taking a Vedanta course at another spiritual organization in Bombay. This was his first visit to Mother's Ashram. Mother sat down next to the old temple and talked to Anish while the residents sang the evening bhajans. Those who had been traveling with Mother went and joined the bhajans. They all sang *Akalatta Kovilil*. . .

*In a distant temple a wick was constantly
burning
Guiding those who are groping in the dark.
In this way Mother was showing Her
compassion.*

⁷ Swami Amritagitananda.

*One day when I was wandering along that path
The Radiant One beckoned me with Her hand;
She opened the sacred door
Took some holy ash
And rubbed it on my forehead.*

*She sang the songs of God
And made a place for me to sleep
With Her own soft hands.
A novel kind of dream then came to me
Declaring the truth:
Why do you weep?
Don't you know that you have reached
The sacred feet of the Lord?*

*I awoke with a sigh
And I clearly saw that Lotus Face
I saw it so clearly.*

LOVE AND FREEDOM

After the bhajan everyone quietly watched Mother, who was sitting at the southern side of the temple. One of the brahmacharis spontaneously asked a question.

“Eternal freedom from all bondage is the goal of a true spiritual seeker. But, somehow, there is a misunderstanding concerning this, that the attainment of eternal freedom and

the path of love and devotion are two separate things. Amma, kindly throw some light on this.”

Mother: “Love and freedom are not two; they are one. They are interdependent. Without love there can be no freedom; and without freedom there can be no love. Eternal freedom can happen only when all your negativity has been uprooted. Only in the state of love will the beautiful, fragrant flower of freedom and supreme bliss unfold its petals and bloom.

“There is an old story about a group of monks, who lived in a monastery with their master. The monks led a very devoted and disciplined life. The place had such a wonderful, spiritual atmosphere that people flocked there from far and wide. But one day the master left his body. To begin with, the disciples continued in the same way as they always had; but little by little they began to slacken, their devotion and discipline gradually disappeared, and the monastery fell into a state of neglect. People stopped visiting and no new monks wanted to join the place. All the monks felt deeply discouraged. They often argued with one another, their hearts were dry, and they no longer felt any love or devotion.

“One day, a senior monk decided that something had to be done. He had heard of a spiritual master who lived as a hermit in a nearby forest. So he left the monastery and went to look for him to seek his advice. When he found the mas-

ter, he told him about the neglected state of the monastery and its desperate condition. The master smiled and said, 'There is one among you who is a great saint, a true incarnation of God Himself. The residents are not showing him any love or respect, and that is the cause of all your problems. But the incarnation of God is living with you in disguise. He will not reveal his identity.' Having said this, the master closed his eyes and went into samadhi. The monk could get no more information out of him.

"On his way back to the monastery, the monk kept wondering which one among his brothers the Incarnation could be. 'Could it be the monk who washes our clothes?' he thought to himself. 'No, it can't be him, for he has too much of a bad temper. Could it be the cook?' he wondered. 'No, it can't be the cook because he is far too sloppy in his work and he doesn't know how to cook good food.' Thus, he went down the list of all the monks, dismissing each one of them with some bad quality that he had seen in that monk. But suddenly he thought to himself, 'It has to be one of the monks, because the master said so. But I cannot see who it is, because I am only seeing the faults of each one of them; and what if the Holy One is deliberately showing some fault in order to better disguise himself?'

"As soon as he reached the monastery, he told his broth-

ers the great news that the master had made known to him. They were all astonished and looked intently at each other, trying to discover who the divine incarnation might be (each one knowing it was not himself). But as they looked around they could only see their brothers who they knew so well, with all their faults and blemishes. There was a big discussion among them about who the Mahatma might be. They finally decided to make an effort to respect each other, and to be kind and humble towards each other, because they had no idea who the disguised Mahatma could be, and they didn't want to be disrespectful and arrogant towards a Master. All the monks agreed that this was an excellent idea. From then on they started treating each other very differently, with great respect and kindness; for they never knew if the monk who stood before them was the Mahatma; and making every effort to see only the goodness in everyone, they began to love each other dearly. Not knowing which one of the monks the Holy One might be, they could not help but imagine they could see Him in every one of their brothers. Through the love that filled their hearts the bondage of negativity which had bound them for so long dropped away from them. They gradually began to perceive the Holy One clearly, not only in each other, but everywhere—even within themselves, and they attained the state of eternal freedom. The atmosphere

of the monastery changed completely, and people began to return there to drink in the love and the divinity that permeated the place.

“So, children, love and freedom are interdependent.

“Complete freedom from the bondage of mind and ego will create a flow of love within. People are bound by the past and the future; that is why it is so difficult to find true love in the world. In order to really be able to love, both the past and the future must dissolve and disappear. You will then experience the present moment as it is; and living this moment in a state of total openness, you then pass on to the next moment, remaining in that same state. When you live in the moment, you are completely here—the next moment doesn’t matter to you at all, it never enters your mind. You do not worry about anything, you have no fears or preconceived ideas. Similarly, as you continue on to the next moment, you let go of the previous one. The past doesn’t matter to you anymore; you forget it. Nothing can bind you—you are ever-free. To truly be able to love, you need to be free of everything. But at the same time, if you are to be completely free, you must have love within. If you are filled with anger, fear, or jealousy, you will be a slave to those emotions. Whatever you think, do, or say will be colored by the negativity within you. How can you be free when you are

bound by past regrets and by worries about the future? If you, in the name of freedom, try to run away from the world, to a Himalayan cave or to some solitary place, it will only cause you trouble. Your mind will soon feel lonely—and what happens when you are in the grip of loneliness? You languish and begin to dream and brood. Only when we learn to love everyone and everything can we truly be free. Only then will the night of ignorance come to an end and the day of Supreme Realization begin.

“Amma has heard a story. Once a spiritual master questioned his disciples, ‘How do you know when the night has ended and the day begun?’ A disciple replied, ‘When you can see a person at a distance and can tell if it’s a man or a woman.’ But the master shook his head at the reply. Another aspirant said, ‘When you can see a tree standing at a distance and can tell if it’s a mango tree or an apple tree.’ But this answer was also incorrect. The disciples were curious and requested that he enlighten them by giving the correct answer. The master smiled and said, ‘When you behold your brother in every man, and your sister in every woman, then the night has ended and the day begun. Until that time, even when the sun illumines the earth at the height of noon, it is still night and you are in the dark.’

“Children, this is a good story to remember. Only when

you learn to love everyone equally will true freedom emerge. Until then, you are bound; you are the slave of your mind and ego.

“So, in order to be free you have to love. But also, to be able to love selflessly you should be free of everything that binds you, both physically and mentally.”

LIVE ACCORDING TO YOUR OWN DHARMA

A householder devotee raised a question.

“Amma, we are family people who have to work in the world to earn our livelihood and to protect our families. Do we have to choose any particular field of action to experience this love and freedom?”

Mother: “Children, stay where you are and do your duty with love and dedication. If you are married and settled in the world, don’t run away, abandoning your job and your responsibilities as a husband or wife, and parent. Don’t think that God will accept you only if you renounce all your duties and wear ochre-colored clothes. No, that is not how it is. Continue to wear the same clothes, perform your duties, stay at home, and do your work. But at the same time, learn to live within your true Self. This is the most important art that we should learn. We learn everything else but never this: the art of dwelling in our own Self.

“We should try to live according to our own dharma. We should never try to adopt someone else’s dharma, for that would be as dangerous as it would be if a dentist were to act as a cardiologist and treat someone afflicted with heart disease. It would be dangerous for both him and his patients if he tried to do something that he is not qualified to do. Needless to say, the dentist should stick to his own job. He has enough to do in his own field. By diligently performing each action with an attitude of love, dedication and self-surrender, he can attain perfection.”

A devotee remarked, “In the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita* it is written: ‘Better to die at one’s own duty; the duty of another is fraught with danger.’” (Ch. 3, v. 35)

Mother smiled and continued, “One cannot live without being active in some way, whether physically, mentally, or intellectually. Everyone is constantly engaged in some form of action; this is an unchangeable law of nature. No one becomes pure and selfless overnight; it involves time and concentrated effort coupled with tremendous patience and love. Do your actions in the world, without forgetting that your final goal in life is to break out of all bondage and limitations. Always remember that you have a higher goal to attain. Simply do what needs to be done; but at the same time, don’t miss the

opportunities you come across to perform unselfish actions. You will then gradually gain mental purity and devotion. As you proceed with diligence, you will attain more clarity of mind and a deeper understanding. This will finally lead you to the state of perfection, the state of Self-Realization.

“Any action done with the right attitude, understanding and discrimination will take you closer to liberation. If, however, the same action is done without the right attitude, it will bind you. An action can either serve as a purifier, which will finally help you realize your godly nature, or it may add more and more to the already existing amount of negativity, which will eventually cause you tremendous suffering.

“Whenever you are doing something, try to be aware. If you are constantly watchful, you will slowly begin to take notice of the unnecessary burden of negative thoughts you are carrying. Watchfulness helps you to drop all your burdens and be free.

“Nothing should happen without your knowledge. Not even a single thought should go by without you being aware of it. Closely observe the mind and its different moods. As you consciously observe, you can clearly see what is happening within you. If you are watchful when anger arises, it cannot escape without your knowledge. But observation alone

is not sufficient. Try to find the root cause of a particular mood such as anger.”

HOW TO TRACE AND UPROOT ANGER

Question: “Amma, how does one trace the cause of anger and uproot it?”

Mother: “Something has caused that anger; there must be a root cause that triggers it off. That cause is invisible. You have to search for that invisible root within. The anger is at the surface, which is why you can see it through close introspection. But now you have to look for the root cause which lies hidden in your subconscious, deep beneath the surface of the mind. Only by uprooting that cause can you destroy the anger that is creating all the turbulence on the surface.

“The anger at the surface of the mind can be compared to a tree. The cause of the anger is like the unseen root of the tree lying hidden beneath the soil. All the strength of the tree is derived from the root. If you want to destroy the tree, you just have to uproot it. Once the root is destroyed, the tree will automatically die. In a similar way, once you become aware of the negativity within you, you should practice introspection and search for the root of that negativity. Just as the tree exists because of the root, the negativity within

you, whatever it may be, exists because of its powerful cause lying deep within the mind. Investigate and find that root. As you discover the cause behind the negativity, it disappears, never to come back again. This is possible only by being watchful.

“When you are watchful, you cannot move in the wrong direction, nor can you do anything unrighteous. Constant watchfulness makes you so pure that, at last, you yourself become the very embodiment of Purity—and that is your true being. Once you reach this highest state, your every intention, word and action, becomes pure. The burden of impurity is no longer there. The light of purity is all that exists. You then behold everything as Pure Consciousness. This means that you see everything as equal. External appearances are no longer significant, for you have developed the ability to penetrate deeply and to see through everything. Matter, which is ever-changing, loses its importance. Within everything you see only the immutable Atman (Self).”

Mother closed Her eyes and began to sing *Santamayi Orukatte*. . .

*Let the River of Life glide along gaily
To join at last
The Infinite Ocean of Silence,
To merge into the
Ocean of Sat, Chit, Ananda.*

*The seawater evaporates
Massing into swollen clouds,
Which again rain down
To become flowing rivers,
Rushing, hurrying to empty into the ocean.*

*Our experiences, though varied,
Have a purpose in the Divine Play,
Our life, running in windy ways,
Is goaded by an urge
To lose and fulfill itself
In the Great Beyond, the Divine.*

*The River of Life thus flows on and on,
Deepening in experience and wisdom;
Let it glide on smoothly, without a hitch,
For the final tryst with its Lord.*

Mother is the embodiment of Supreme Purity and Love. In Her presence purification happens effortlessly. In that Purity, the entire universe is reflected and the cosmic energy experienced. To this Supreme Light, Purity and Love we can offer ourselves, and we will be made pure in return. Mother will happily accept our impurity in exchange for the purity and love She bestows upon us. Approach Her with the prayer, "O Mother, here is Your child! I am incapable of offering You anything but my impurity. O great Giver of everything,

receive my life. Purify me, and let me be a pure instrument of Yours, forever.”

ASK YOURSELF,
WHY CAN'T I JUST SMILE AND BE HAPPY?

An American devotee said to Mother, “Amma, my past is bothering me terribly. Is there no way to escape? You tell me to smile but I cannot smile. I feel so tense and frightened. What can I do to overcome this and begin to smile, as you are telling me to do?”

Mother: “Daughter, as long as you are carrying the burden of your past, you cannot genuinely smile. You have to ask yourself, ‘Why am I sad? Why can’t I just smile and be happy?’

“Look at the beauty and perfection of nature. Everything in nature is so joyful, even though it doesn’t have the intelligence of a human being. All of creation is rejoicing. The most beautiful flowers are picked by people—torn by their stems. Some are made into garlands while others are trampled heedlessly. A flower has such a short life span, and yet it offers itself wholeheartedly to others; it even offers its own nectar to the bees—and yet it is happy. The stars are twinkling in the sky, the rivers are flowing blissfully, the branches of the trees are dancing in the wind, and the birds are burst-

ing into song. You should ask yourself, ‘Why, then, do I feel so miserable living in the midst of all this joyful celebration?’

“Ask the question, ‘why,’ repeatedly, and you will find the answer. The answer is that the flowers, stars, rivers, trees and birds do not have an ego; and, being egoless, nothing can hurt them. When you are egoless, you can only rejoice. Even occasions that would normally be painful are transformed into moments of joy.

“But unfortunately, you have an ego, and you have been wounded by people many times. There is a mountain of hurt feelings within you. Your individuality, your ego, has been hurt. All those wounds are in bad shape: pus and blood is oozing out. It is amazing that you choose to live in that state without finding an effective cure.

“As mentioned earlier, the best cure is to closely observe the mind. This will bring the hidden cause of your suffering into light. The ego is the cause, the invisible root. The invisible but powerful ego needs to be exposed. Just by being exposed the ego disappears, saying, “I have nothing to do here, so good-bye—I will never see you again.’ It won’t say, ‘See you later.’ Exposing the ego is the same as destroying it; it is like exposing a thief in his hideout.

“Drop all your regrets of the past and relax. Relaxation

will help you acquire more strength and vitality. Relaxation is a technique through which you can catch a glimpse of your real nature, the infinite power source of your existence. Learn to be relaxed during times of stress and strain. Learn to stand aside and just watch the negative thoughts, the hurt feelings and the mental agony you are going through. As this happens, withdraw your cooperation and your involvement with the stress and the agony. Once you learn this technique, you will realize that the tension, burdens and negativity you are carrying belong to the mind; they don't belong to the inner Self, your true being.

“You may not experience total relaxation in the beginning, you may get only a hint of it at first; but once you get a taste, you become interested. It is a wonderful experience which you relish; you want to experience it again and again, in ever increasing amounts. As you learn the technique of entering into that mood, you become immensely desirous of remaining in that state, because for a moment you are able to forget everything; for a few seconds you have experienced real peace and joy, and you cannot let go of those precious moments. Also, the vibrant wakefulness you experience after that moment of relaxation is indescribable. You feel an unquenchable thirst to return to that state.

“Remember: relaxation gives you the strength and en-

ergy to confront the challenges awaiting you in the future.
Just be at ease and, at the same time, be watchful.”

Mother asked the brahmacharis to sing a bhajan. They sang together, *Anantamayi Patarunnor...*

*The vast, expanding sky
The inner Being
Vibrant with enthusiasm
Awakens!
O Mother!
Goddess Ambika, Eternal Virgin
Infinite, Blissful and Immaculate. . .*

*Never—O, never again allow this suppliant
To succumb to temptation!
As the days go by
The pain of my heart increases;
O Goddess of my heart,
Aren't You aware of it?*

*Is there no Mother for me?
Oh, don't I have a Mother?
Tell me, O Blissful One
Tell me. . .
I do not seek bliss or anything else
Give me only pure love and devotion.*

WATCHFULNESS AND SHRADDHA

When the song came to an end, everyone sat in silence for some time until another question was asked.

“Amma, is watchfulness the same as *shraddha*?”

Mother: “Children, the whole of spirituality can be put into one word, and that is ‘shraddha.’ Shraddha is the unconditional faith the disciple has in the words of the Master or in the scriptural dictums. The Master’s words are in full accord with the words of the scriptures. In fact, a true Master’s words are verily the scriptures. A disciple who is endowed with such faith will be constantly watchful of his mind and thoughts. So in that sense shraddha is also watchfulness. The meaning of shraddha is to be constantly aware. But this is only possible when you are relaxed. A tense, agitated person, who is constantly thinking about his failures in life, cannot be watchful, nor can he be fully aware of the present moment. It is the same with a person who keeps dreaming about the future. Both of these moods will make you inert; you lose your creativity and cannot be productive. Relaxation, however, will enhance your awareness and bring out your real being. Only a relaxed person can be ever watchful and aware.

“Children, failures are bound to happen in life. Suppose we have stumbled over something and fallen. We don’t say

to ourselves, 'Okay! Now that I've fallen, let me remain lying here on the ground forever. I'm not going to get up and proceed to my destination.' It would be ridiculous to think like that.

"A toddling child will fall countless times before he can walk properly. Similarly, failures are a natural part of life. Keep in mind that each failure comes with the message of success. Just as a toddler will fall before he or she learns to walk with firm steps, our own failures are the beginning of our ascent towards ultimate victory. So there is no need to feel disappointed or frustrated. Don't remain in the dark. Come out into the light.

YOU ARE THE LIGHT OF GOD

"You don't belong to the dark. The darkness is a prison created by your own mind and ego; it is self-imposed and self-created. It is not your real abode, for you belong to the light. You are the light of God. So let go of the dark. Realize that you are in prison; recognize the prison for what it is, and understand that it is not your real home. We have created our own prison and our own imprisonment. Nobody else is responsible or involved. Observe that the darkness is dark, and not light. We are in the dark but unfortunately we think

we are in the light. Thinking is the problem. We are totally identified with the thought process.

“In our present mental state, although we are in the dark and are bound by the self-created ego, we believe that we are free and in the light. We are mistaking darkness for light, and bondage for freedom. It is a question of recognizing the bondage for what it is. We don’t understand that we are chained, for we have been in chains, in the dark, for a long time. The chains that bind us are like ornaments to us, and the prison has become almost like a home. What we consider to be embellishments—fame, power, wealth—are, in fact, the chains that bind us. Because of this mistaken concept, misery and sadness have become part of our lives, and this is why we cannot smile wholeheartedly. But the truth is the opposite. We are the light of the Divine, and bliss is our birthright. We are the eternally free, infinite Atman.

“There is a vague memory of our true nature within us. Sometimes this memory becomes a little clearer. But most of the time we are unaware of it, which is why we continue to remain in bondage. Whenever the memory stirs, we struggle to free ourselves. This chain, however, is such that the more you struggle, the tighter it becomes. **Stop struggling, quiet down and relax, and you will discover that you are free.** Being aware of the bondage is enough to free you from its clutches.

You are holding on to all the illusory objects created by the mind. You unwisely identify with your thoughts, thus creating your own prison and being imprisoned therein. How do you free yourself? It is very simple. Just release the grip and withdraw your cooperation—just let go.

“Do you know how monkeys are caught in some parts of India? A narrow-necked pot, filled with nuts and other eatables that monkeys like, is placed on the ground. Then a monkey comes to take the nuts. He puts his hand into the pot and grabs hold of the nuts. Now, because his hand is full he cannot take it out of the narrow-necked pot. The foolish monkey doesn’t open his hand and let go of the nuts, which would be an easy way to escape. He won’t let go of the nuts he has grabbed, and so he is trapped. By holding on to a few nuts, the poor monkey loses the entire forest with all its beautiful trees—the vast area where he could roam freely, play and enjoy life to his heart’s content. Just for the sake of a few nuts he loses the abundance of fresh and delicious nuts and fruits available throughout the forest. He loses his entire world.

“Human beings are much the same. A person calls out, ‘Free me! I want freedom!’ But who has chained him? What is binding him? No one—nothing. He just has to stop creating all this unnecessary noise, stop struggling, calm down

and relax; then he will see that it is he, and he alone, who is responsible for his own bondage. He just has to let go of the few nuts he is holding onto, and he can then easily take his hand out of the narrow-necked pot of body, mind and intellect. He can be ever-free. The entire universe belongs to him.”

CONSOLING A DISTRESSED SOUL

A woman devotee from the West was sitting next to Mother looking very sad. Mother turned to her and lovingly asked her what was troubling her. The woman looked at Mother with tears in her eyes. She seemed to want to have a private conversation with Mother. With a sign of Her hand Mother asked everyone to leave, except Bri. Gayatri who was needed as a translator. The woman then opened Her heart to Mother. She had had two abortions in the past, and she was constantly in deep agony thinking about it. The woman told Mother, “The more I try to forget, the stronger it becomes. I cannot forgive myself. Mother, forgive me for what I have done! Help me to forget and to be at peace.”

Mother looked at her with great compassion and gently rubbed her chest. She consoled her saying, “Daughter, don’t think that what you have done is a great sin. It was the karma of both you and the two children to go through that expe-

rience. The fetuses were destined to live only for that long. Now that you have met Amma you should forget about it. Don't react to the past. There is force and aggression implied in reaction. Reaction creates more turbulence in the mind and the very thought you are trying to forget will come up with much more strength. To react is to fight. Fighting the wounds of the past will only deepen those wounds. Relaxation is the method that heals the wounds of the mind, not reaction.

"The mere realization of your wrongdoing has freed you from it. You have already been forgiven. The pain you have suffered is more than enough to wash away the sin. Any sin will be washed away by the tears of repentance. Daughter, Amma knows that you have suffered a lot. From now on you shouldn't carry this burden in your mind. You have Amma to take care of you. Forget it and be at peace."

Those nectarous words of Mother's made the woman break down in tears. Mother gently put Her arms around the woman and drew her onto Her lap. The woman lay with her head on Mother's lap and continued to weep. As Mother caressed the woman's hair, She said to Gayatri, "Poor woman! She committed those acts out of ignorance. At the time She must have found herself in very difficult circumstances, which was why she destroyed the child. Her guilty conscience has haunted her during all these years."

A few brahmacharis had been lingering at a distance, unable to completely pull themselves away from Mother's presence. Mother called them back, and they all came and sat down in front of Her. The woman continued to rest her head on Mother's lap as Mother spoke and Gayatri continued to translate.

NO ONE SHOULD BE PUNISHED ETERNALLY

"Whatever may be the gravity of the mistake you have committed, once you realize your mistake and feel remorseful, you need to be forgiven. This does not mean that anyone can consciously commit a mistake and think they will be free from punishment, as long as they repent later. No, that is not the case. As far as possible, we should refrain from making any mistakes. As mortal human beings, we are bound to make mistakes, sometimes out of ignorance, at other times due to the pressures of our circumstances. As a lesson, a certain amount of punishment may be necessary, depending on the seriousness of the mistake. Punishment is definitely necessary if a person consciously keeps committing the same mistakes, again and again. However, nobody should have to suffer forever; no soul should be punished eternally because of a few mistakes he has committed or has intended to commit.

There are some people who sincerely regret their sins. They realize what they have done and wish to change. They should be given every opportunity to start afresh with a new outlook on life. They should be forgiven; a conducive and loving environment should be created around them, so that they can forget and let go of the past, and live fully productive lives. They need your love and compassion. Smile at them from your heart and speak to them lovingly. Let your encouraging words and your smile touch their hearts and heal their wounds. If you can touch them with your love and compassion, they will be able to let go of the darkness of their past. Because of your compassion they will feel that they are loved; they will begin to relax and be at peace with themselves. Don't ever reject them or call them sinners; for, in that case, not only they, but all of us are sinners, for we have all committed the great mistake of forgetting our true nature, our existence in God. No mistake can be greater than this, for which we could all be punished. But God is all-compassionate and all-forgiving. God has forgiven us. Amma doesn't believe that God will let any soul suffer forever. If He did, He wouldn't be God."

With the woman still resting on Her lap, Mother began to sing, *Amme Yi Jivende*. . .

*O Mother of the Universe
There is no one but You
Who can wipe the tears from this face
And liberate my soul.
Upon reaching Your feet,
This soul realizes itself.*

*Alas!
Even now, this mind is steeped in sorrow
For it has lost its way in Maya
Before reaching the goal.
Please bless me
That I may hold You forever
With pure devotion
In a tight embrace.*

*In this fearsome ocean of birth and death
The only refuge is Your Lotus Feet.
Won't You come
And sprinkle a little nectar of Love
On this smoldering one?*

*This little infant spends every moment
Meditating on Your form;
Please don't let me wait any longer
Draw me close to You
Bestow inner peace
On this tortured soul.*

At the end of the song, Mother gently made the woman sit up. The woman looked as if a heavy load had been lifted away from her. Her face was brighter and she smiled happily at Mother. Letting out a deep sigh she said, “Ah, Mother, I feel so peaceful now. You have brought light into the dark chamber of my heart. Thank You so much!”

Mother stood up, gave the woman another hug, and walked away towards the edge of the backwaters.



CHAPTER SIX

RESPECT WITHOUT LOVE CREATES FEAR

Mother was sitting outside the old kitchen in the midst of the brahmacharinis and householders, cutting vegetables. Sensing that Mother was there, a few more brahmacharinis arrived within a few minutes. As the vegetable chopping progressed, Mother noticed that one of the girls was peeling too much skin from a cucumber. Mother said, “Daughter, why do you remove that much? Don’t waste anything unnecessarily. Only a person who has no shraddha will waste things. Whatever actions a spiritual seeker performs must be well thought out. We should be able to transmit the inner silence and stillness that we gain through our meditation into our actions. In fact, meditation helps one to gain a deeper insight into all the aspects of one’s actions. Once this depth is attained, you won’t waste anything unnecessarily. By peeling away too much of the skin, you are removing some of the edible part as well. This means that you are denying the benefit of it to everybody in the Ashram, as well as to others, including those who are starving and who would really benefit from it. A person who has gained

a certain amount of inner silence and stillness through meditation and other spiritual practices will never do such things.”

Mother paused and a question was asked.

“Amma, I heard you say once that a disciple should feel both love and respect towards the Master. You also said that if there is only respect, there is bound to be fear. Could you please explain this?”

Mother: “When there is only respect and no love, fear is bound to occur. There is an aspect of fear in respect. The school teacher asks the student to learn a poem by heart before he comes to class the next day. The poor student isn’t interested in poetry. He’d rather play sports and watch TV. The student respects his teacher, but he doesn’t love him. He feels that the teacher is forcing something on him that he doesn’t like. He dare not say no to his teacher, because he is afraid of him and also of his parents, and of the punishment he may get if he doesn’t obey. So he repeats the poem several times and learns it. This is not real learning. No real learning is possible as long as there is fear. This form of learning will never help the student to attain any true knowledge, because it isn’t done with the heart. Out of respect and fear of his teacher, the student learns like a parrot without imbibing the meaning. But the student’s heart is closed. Fear

closes the heart and there is then every probability that the student will forget what he has learned. Only if the heart is open, can he really learn. Otherwise, the process of learning and all his actions will be mechanical.

“You feed information into a computer and you store the information there. Whenever you want to use this information, you simply press a few keys and it appears before you. But, if you happen to press the wrong button by mistake, that’s it!—all the data you have saved is gone. The screen goes blank.

“The computer can only obey whatever command it is given. The computer is not intelligent and it cannot feel anything, because it’s only a machine invented by the human intellect.

“A human being can become almost like a breathing, moving computer, if he doesn’t have a loving and compassionate heart. Respect that is devoid of love and based on fear will close your heart and turn you into a human machine. If you obey your teacher or your parents only out of fear and respect, it is no more than feeding information into a computer. It can go blank at any time, because there is no love to hold and support it.

“The other day a family came to see Amma. They had a seven-year-old son. He was sitting on Amma’s lap, and just

to make him happy and to make him talk, Amma asked him several questions: his name, what grade he was in, about his friends, the games he liked, etc. Each time he was about to answer a question, the boy would first look at his father, as if asking permission to speak. The boy would answer each question only after being given his father's consent. When Amma asked what his name was, he immediately looked at his father. Only when his father said, 'Tell Amma your name,' did the boy dare say his name. The boy was afraid to speak. You cannot even call this respect—it is plain fear. If you threaten a child saying, 'Obey, or I will punish you,' you don't know how much harm you are doing. The child closes up and cannot express himself. He will carry this fear within him throughout his life. He may become a wealthy man, highly educated, holding a top position in society, but the fear will still be there, deep within him, and it will make his personal life a living hell.

“Creating fear and respect in order to teach obedience cannot be called disciplining, which is what we like to call it. True, constructive disciplining takes place when love is allowed to blossom. If love is absent, any reverence or respect will be based on fear. A loving relationship, however, will open up your heart and enable you to express yourself fully in whichever way you choose. Love brings you closer together,

and in that closeness there is no lack of discipline at all. Out of that love, which comes from proper understanding, a natural and genuine respect will be born. In other words, once a strong bond of love is established between the teacher and student, or parent and child, disciplining can be done easily, without causing any hurt feelings in the one who is being disciplined. This loving closeness, this meeting of hearts, is vitally important in the relationship between teacher and student, or parent and child. But for this closeness to happen, one must be patient and forgiving.

“Children, you might have heard about the Guru-disciple relationship that existed long ago. Students from all different casts and backgrounds used to come and stay at the gurukula. The period of education would last for at least twelve years. The system was entirely different in those days. It was not at all like modern schools and colleges. Nowadays, the students cannot study without writing notes and staring at their textbooks. During class the students barely ever look at the face of their teacher; they are either writing notes, sitting hunched over their textbooks, or daydreaming through the window. They don’t look at their teacher’s face, because they don’t like his face. The students feel resentful towards their teacher. Outwardly, they may be respectful towards him, but deep within they resent him. Respect without love is

usually born out of fear, which, in turn, may culminate in anger and even hatred.

“Most children feel some resentment towards their fathers and teachers, because they are being controlled by them. They feel that the adults are trying impose their own ideas upon them. As long as a youngster is still dependent on his father and teachers, he isn’t in a position to express his anger. Some children, of course, erupt and cause problems, but the majority lie low during their period of dependency. They are instinctively concerned about their own security. However, once they are free of their dependency, they often explode and begin to vent their feelings. The child or student keeps his anger suppressed in his subconscious. During his period of dependency he may mask his anger in an outward show of love and respect, because he needs his father and teacher; he needs their material support and education. But once that period is over, he cannot suppress his anger any longer, and it comes out. Thoughts such as, ‘He controlled me, he didn’t do what I wanted, he punished me and insulted me in front of everyone,’ may manifest as anger and even hatred. He then wants to take revenge. All his respect disappears, because the respect was never real; it wasn’t rooted in love. He now reveals the real face hidden behind the mask of respect: the face of anger. This happens in all such relationships if the

proper love and understanding is absent. It is only a question of time. The anger keeps smoldering within until a situation arises which causes it to flare up. Until then, if the individual, who is involved in any type of relationship, doesn't cultivate the right attitude with the proper love and understanding, he will be carrying a hidden volcano within. This is the experience of hundreds of thousands of people. Because of Her personal contact with the millions of people She has met from all walks of life around the world, Amma can assure you that this is true. Of course, there are exceptions; there are people who lead happy and well balanced lives, but the majority fall under the above said category."

Mother stopped for a while and asked the brahmacharinis to sing a song. They sang *Amritanandamayi Janani*. . .

*Mother Amritanandamayi
You are the embodiment of mercy,
compassion, wisdom and bliss.*

*You are the remover of all obstacles
The Mother of Vinayaka Ganesha
O Mother
You are the embodiment of holiness
And of knowledge
You are the bestower of intellect
The Vedas are Your form
You are Consciousness and the Pure Self*

O Mother Amritanandamayi.

*Amritanandamayi,
You are Saraswati,
The Goddess of Knowledge
With the book and the veena
In Your hands;
You are Brahman
You are Mahalakshmi, the Goddess of Wealth
Parvati, the Goddess of Power
Sankari, the Auspicious One
And Adi Parashakti, the Primordial Power.*

*You are Vishnumayi
The dynamic Power of the Sustainer,
And Shiva-Shakti
The Active and the Passive;
Mother of the universe
Please protect us!
Appear to us in Krishna- and Devi Bhava
O Amritanandamayi. . .*

Mother's eyes were closed. The brahmacharinis sat in silence around Mother, gazing at Her and trying to absorb the profound meaning of the song they had just sung. After a few minutes Mother opened Her eyes and smiled at Her children. One of the brahmacharinis said, "Amma, kindly enlighten us by saying something more about the Guru-sishya relationship which existed in the ancient gurukulas."

THE GURU-SISHYA RELATIONSHIP IN THE ANCIENT GURUKULA

Mother: “In the gurukulas of the ancient rishis, where the disciples lived with a Master, serving him and studying their lessons, there was no such thing as students writing notes or sitting in class with their heads plunged into textbooks. The disciples simply sat gazing at the Master as he spoke. That was all. There were no notes or textbooks. Whatever the Master said went straight to their hearts. This was possible because of the deep bond that had been forged between the Master and his disciples. The Master’s way of disciplining his disciples was not done unwisely in a forcing or controlling way; on the contrary, it was a relationship born out of true love and understanding. The Master truly cared for his disciples and they in turn showed their love and respect by caring deeply for him. It was not respect born out of fear, but out of deep love.

“The Master opened the door of his heart to his disciples. He welcomed and accepted them wholeheartedly without any reservations. The Master’s openness and selflessness made the disciples receptive and humble in his presence. Even though the Master was a treasure chest of knowledge, he was also very humble. He didn’t have the attitude that, ‘I am the master

and you are my disciples, so you'd better do whatever I say, or I'll punish you.' The disciples were free to ask the Master any questions if they needed to clear their doubts. Because the Master was the embodiment of knowledge he could dispel their doubts both through theory and practice. In the modern classroom even if the students have doubts and questions they hesitate to ask anything, because of the lack of love and closeness between them and their teacher. Neither teacher nor students are open enough or thirsting to give or receive any real knowledge. Both teacher and students tend to be arrogant. The teachers find it difficult to clear all the doubts of their students, because they themselves never imbibed any real knowledge when they were students. Their relationships with their teachers were similarly lacking.

"In the ancient gurukula, the Master prayed together with his disciples: 'May Brahman protect us, may He nourish both you and I, may both you and I be given the energy we need, may this study make us both illumined, and may we never hate each other. Om shanti, shanti, shanti.' The prayer was dedicated to both teacher and student, blessing each one's uplift and understanding—not that the master needed anything from the disciple—it was only a magnificent example of his humility.

“The Master was always in a prayerful mood. You know, children, a person who is constantly in a state of prayer cannot be egotistic. He is humble in all circumstances. In those days, humility, love and patience were the factors that made people’s lives so beautiful and complete. Even though the Master was fully enlightened and all-knowing, he was still humble in front of his disciples.

“No one can feel egotistic in front of a genuinely humble soul. So the disciples who came to study with such a Master, even though they weren’t free from the ego, turned out to be humble and obedient in his presence. In those days, royal princes, the children of noblemen, and students who belonged to all the different classes of society, came to the Master’s gurukula. But to the Master they were all the same. They lived together, ate and slept together, and were all taught the same lessons. They had to do physical work, including looking after the Master’s cows, fetching firewood from the forest, taking care of the crops and so on. But still, there was tremendous love between the Master and his disciples. There was not a trace of anger or resentment.

“When there is that much love, your heart is wide open, as open as that of a child. It was this openness, born out of love, that helped the disciples to learn by simply listening to the Master and gazing at his face. They never needed to write

notes or to use a textbook, nor did they have to repeat a poem or an essay a hundred times to learn it. They listened once to the Master, and that was enough: they remembered it till the end of their lives. They never forgot what they had learned while gazing at the face of their beloved Master. Real listening happens only where there is love.

“When the Master spoke it was Love that spoke; and at the receiving end it was absorbed by nothing but Love. Because of their love for their Master, the disciples’ hearts were like a fertile field, ready to receive the knowledge imparted by the Master. Love gave and love received. Love made them open to each other. True giving and receiving takes place where love is present. Real listening and shraddha is possible only where there is love, otherwise the listener will be closed. If you are closed, you will be easily dominated by anger (your past) and resentment, and nothing can enter into you.”

THE MODERN EDUCATIONAL SYSTEM AND THE ANCIENT WAY OF A TRUE MASTER

Question: “What is the problem with the modern educational system?”

Mother: “In the modern educational system this openness is absent. Both teacher and student are closed to each other.

There is no sharing and no love; there is only resentment. The teachers are not humble, and many are arrogant. They want to control the students and to force their own ideas upon them. If the students don't listen, the teachers get angry and want to punish them. Due to their unintelligent way of approaching the students, the teachers in modern schools and colleges shut off any possibility of establishing a loving relationship with the students, and to thereby help them dive into the depths of true knowledge. One of the most important reasons for the degeneration of the educational system is this absence of a loving bond, of a positive relationship which could bring the teacher and student closer to each other. Only a flow of genuine love and acceptance from both sides could make them understand each other, which in turn would open up the gates between them for true sharing to happen.

“But they are poles apart, and this inner distance makes learning impossible. Their egos have created a big gulf between them. The teacher is speaking, not with love, but with the proud feeling that, ‘I am the teacher and you are my student. I know everything and you know nothing, so you'd better listen to me, or else. . .’ The student feels this pride. He, too, is proud, and when he senses the pride in his teacher he thinks, ‘Why should I listen to that fellow? I'm not going to!’ His heart is closed and now there is a big wall between

them. The teacher continues to speak but nothing reaches the student. Physically the student is present in the classroom and the teacher is standing just a few yards away, but in reality, they are very far away from each other. Both of them are closed. When a closed heart speaks, nothing comes out; the knowledge only echoes within the speaker; it cannot create any impact at the other end—a closed heart speaks and a closed heart listens. In other words, no real imparting of knowledge takes place.

“Everybody craves attention in the modern age, because attention is food for the ego. The ego lives on attention. Both the teacher and student strongly crave attention, and if it isn’t forthcoming, their minds become filled with anger and revenge. There are even instances when students and teachers seriously hurt each other.

“The kind of teacher-student relationship that we have today cannot transform a person or help anyone grow. No real knowledge will dawn within the student in this way. It will only create negative feelings in both teacher and student. As you carry around the burden of unhealed wounds that have been caused by such incidents, your whole life becomes a wound, infected with the pus of your intense negative feelings.

“There was a time when a Master would transform his disciples by his mere presence; or, it would be more appropriate to say that the transformation just happened to the disciples. Such was the power of the Master’s presence.

“The power that created this transformation was the love and compassion the disciples experienced in their Master’s presence. When someone’s heart is filled with love and compassion, your own heart will spontaneously open up like a blossoming flower. The closed bud of your heart unfolds in the presence of love. The Master doesn’t necessarily give you any instructions as such, he may not teach you verbally—the opening up simply happens, as naturally as a flower opens up its petals. This is bound to happen in the presence of a true Master.

“A flower doesn’t need instructions on how to bloom. No music teacher taught the nightingale to sing. It is spontaneous. There is no force involved, it happens naturally. Similarly, in the presence of a great Master, the closed bud of your heart opens up. You become as receptive and innocent as a child, a humble and obedient child of the Master. He doesn’t teach you anything. You learn everything without being taught. His presence, his very life, is the greatest teaching of all. There is no control or force involved; everything happens naturally and effortlessly. Only love can create this miracle.

“In the modern educational system the students are being drained of their energy, by having to repeat the lessons countless times in order to memorize them. Education has become an energy dissipating process. The students are constantly under great pressure; and the stress and strain caused by their parents, especially during examination time, is often noticeable.

“Amma is saying that whether one’s goal is spiritual or material, nothing can be achieved if there is too much pressure coming from all directions.

“The modern educational system lies like a heavy, overloaded sack on the student’s shoulders, and the parents often make it worse. The parents have only one mantra which they incessantly repeat to their children: ‘You should study your lessons, do your homework and do nothing but study.’ During examination time the students are under great pressure. They are not relaxed at all.

“Teach them the art of relaxation, how to be at ease. If they don’t feel relaxed, how can they learn? Without relaxation, no real learning is possible. This is the first lesson that clearly needs to be understood. It’s very important that parents should understand this before they ask their children to do something. Amma suggests that they practice it in their own lives. For, unless they, themselves, experience the im-

portance of relaxation, they won't know how important it is for their children. Spiritual practices such as meditation, repetition of a mantra, and singing bhajans are different methods which are meant to relax the mind so that you can always be open like a freshly blossomed flower.

"Parents do not know the great harm they are doing their children by their constant whipping: 'Study, study, study!' When they arrange private tuition on every subject during holidays and weekends, the poor boys and girls have to literally rush from one teacher to another, exhausting all their energy and feeling very stressful. By the time the youngster gets back home in the evening, he is pale and exhausted; he cannot even eat his food with composure. The result is that the child cannot think about anything but his studies. He reads and reads, repeats endlessly and memorizes everything, as if he were feeding information into a computer. The child keeps on feeding and feeding, overloading and stuffing himself with more facts than he can possibly absorb.

"He or she may get record high marks and pass with distinction, but by the time the youngster finishes his education, he will be almost like a machine. He will no longer be able to experience the vibrancy, or the beauty and love of life, and he will lack any real wisdom. There will be no playfulness or laughter in his life. He is closed. As an adult he

cannot even smile at his wife or be playful with his own children. He may be well-known and eminent in his field, but he will not be a successful human being. The luster of life will be absent in such a person. At home he will always be tight and serious. To always be extremely serious, whether it seems called for or not, is like a disease.

“When such people grow old, their faculties also wear out, because of the unintelligent methods by which they have gathered their knowledge. They have gathered information through their intense studies, during which they were never at ease, never relaxed. In this process they have used their inner faculties unwisely. They never allowed their mind to rest. It consequently got overused and overheated. They kept on feeding it non-stop; they never turned it off and let it be still for a time, so that it could relax and cool down. They never took care of their equipment, and now they are burned out.”

As Mother’s vibrant words carried the fragrance of Her divine presence into the hearts of the listeners, She began singing *Devi Jaganmata*. . .

*Hail to the Goddess, the Mother of the world
The Goddess of Supreme Energy!*

*O Eternal Virgin
Doing penance on the shore
Of the blue sea at Kanyakumari,
Come and give me a boon!*

*O Mother, whose true nature is Light
And whose exquisite form
Is made of wisdom, truth, energy and bliss!*

*Aum
Hail to the Mother of the Universe!*

THE ART OF RELAXATION

The conversation continued.

Question: “Amma, You were talking about relaxation. Could You kindly elaborate a little more on this point?”

Mother: “Only through relaxed study can knowledge be retained. A study undertaken with stress and strain, without any relaxed, restful moments for the body, mind, or intellect, cannot be successful. In fact, it is relaxation that provides the clarity of vision and the energy necessary to learn and retain any real knowledge. The knowledge gathered in this way remains fresh forever, irrespective of your age. Whatever learning one does mechanically, under stressful and strenuous circumstances without any relaxation, will not help in the overall development of a person. Only someone who has

gathered knowledge with a peaceful mind can really put that knowledge into practice and become a master in his field. Others will simply carry around the weight of their knowledge in their heads. They are carrying around a load of information, which they think is an embellishment to their personality, when, in fact, it has the opposite effect, for it disfigures their personality to a certain extent.

“There are hundreds of thousands of people all over the world who study the different sciences and other subjects. You can see Ph.D. holders springing up like mushrooms everywhere. There are also millions of engineers and medical doctors around the globe. But how many of them really benefit the world with their knowledge and their studies? How many among them become truly great in their fields? Only a few. Countless people also learn painting and music, but how many become soul-capturing artists or musicians? Only a handful. There are people who may have studied in the same college and with the same teacher; their circumstances may have been identical. Why, then, is it that only a few become true, renowned masters?

“It is because only a few of them have ever learned the art of relaxation. Only a few were at ease during their studies. The rest were just stuffed with information. They wanted to score high marks, get a decent job with a good salary, a

nice house, a wife and children—and that was the end of it, the end of their studies. They put a full stop right there and began to worry about other things. Such people cannot stop worrying and are never at ease. They will always be under a lot of pressure and feel stressful, because they have never learned the art of relaxation.

“But a person who knows how to relax continues to learn new things. Throughout his life, his thirst for knowledge will remain ever fresh. He feels no tension; he is relaxed, and he therefore keeps on gathering knowledge, which he actually puts into practice. He not only studies about space, he invents new methods, new techniques and equipment with which to explore the subject. He not only learns about the under-sea world, he dives deep into the water to discover what is there. His curiosity is inexhaustible. Even though he has an unquenchable thirst to learn and to know, he is always relaxed, and this relaxed mood gives him the strength and vitality to absorb more knowledge and to put it into practice through his experiments. Such people can dive deep into their own Self, the Source of all knowledge, if they have the faith and determination. This will eventually help them to realize their true existence in the Self.

“There are poets, painters, musicians and scientists who

spend a lot of time in solitude, contemplating and relaxing. They withdraw from the noisy world and go into seclusion. While sitting there in a fully relaxed mood, they withdraw from the mind and its thoughts. They will sometimes slip into a deep, trancelike state; and as they come out of that state they are able to create a great masterpiece. There have been many such incidents—but how does it happen? It is the outcome of the deep silence they feel within during such experiences. When the mind is devoid of thoughts, when there are no disturbances, no agitation whatsoever, an awakening takes place and the dormant talents, the infinite capacities of the mind, are manifested. Revelations occur as you tap into the unknown realms of pure, divine knowledge. This is the greatness of inner relaxation.

“So children, if you want to learn your lessons well, relaxation is the best method. It will keep your intellect clear, your memory power will increase tremendously, and you will not exhaust your energy by repeating a lesson a hundred times in order to memorize it. When you are deeply relaxed, you need only read the lesson once and you will know it forever.

“Have you ever seen the old grandparents chanting the entire text of a scripture, or a long Sanskrit hymn, without glancing at a text even once? They must have learned it when they were young. They were either taught by their parents or

they must have listened to it being recited. They chant it so clearly and precisely without making any mistakes. Even when they are in their nineties, they chant it perfectly. What memory they have!

“A few years ago when Amma visited the house of some devotees, She met the grandmother of that family. She was ninety years old, gaunt like a skeleton and completely bed-ridden. Her life was ebbing away but she could still speak. As Amma sat down next to her on the bed, the old woman’s daughter said, ‘Mother, open your eyes. Look who is sitting next to you! It’s Amma!’ The old lady slowly opened her eyes. With a beaming smile she looked up at Amma. As the old woman lay gazing at Amma’s face her daughter said, ‘Mother, chant the *Narayaneeyam* for Amma.’ Before the daughter had finished the sentence the old lady began to chant the Sanskrit *slokas* fluently, with absolute clarity. She continued to chant for a long time without showing any sign of tiredness until, finally, her daughter had to tell her to stop.

“Children, look at Acchamma.⁸ She is nearly eighty, but she still gets up at four in the morning, takes a bath in cold water, repeats her regular chants; and every day, without fail, she makes a garland for Amma to wear during Devi Bhava.

“In the olden days people were much more relaxed than

⁸ Mother’s paternal grandmother

they are now. There was no hurry. They always managed to find some free time to read the scriptures, chant the verses from the epics, and to sing the glories of the Lord in a peaceful and relaxed atmosphere.

“Every morning and evening, the whole family gathered in the family shrine room to pray together and to sing the names of the Supreme Lord. Those moments of relaxation, which they found in the midst of their active day to day lives, helped them perform their work in the world in a well balanced frame of mind.

“Look at the above example of the old woman reciting the Sanskrit *slokas* from the *Narayaneeyam*, even on her death bed. How could she do this? Because it hadn’t been fed into her as if she were a computer. She absorbed it like an intelligent human being with a relaxed, tension-free mind, and she loved it. Whatever you study, if you do so in a relaxed mood, it will remain fresh with you until the day you die; whereas, whatever you learn in a tense and stressful mood will soon be forgotten. In reality, you cannot learn anything without relaxation—it doesn’t enter into you. It will remain only at the surface, and whatever is at the surface of the mind is bound to be forgotten. It is like the ephemeral waves of the sea that come and go. Whatever knowledge is gathered by a mind that isn’t relaxed, that knowledge will not take root but

will be subject to change and distortions. The mind can subsequently only provide you with unclear pictures.

“Children, learn to be relaxed in all circumstances. Whatever you do and wherever you are, relax and you will see how powerful it is. The art of relaxation brings out the power that exists within you. Through relaxation you can experience your infinite capacities. It is the art of making your mind still, and of focusing all your energy on the work you are doing, whatever it may be. Thus you will be able to bring out all your potential. Once you learn this art, everything happens spontaneously and effortlessly. For example, you want to memorize a speech or a poem; so you sit down and relax, dropping everything else from your mind, and you go through the subject just once—not a hundred times while forgoing food and sleep—and you get it, once and for all. It stays with you forever. Within the human mind infinite capacities lie hidden. It can accommodate the entire universe and all the knowledge in it. But we haven’t learned the art of tapping into the infinite power of the mind.”

Mother stopped talking while one of the women devotees was inspired to sing a few verses from the *Uddhava Gita*.⁹ She sang it melodiously in the classical way.

⁹ A chapter from the Srimad Bhagavatam. It is a conversation between Lord Krishna and His great devotee, Uddhava.

Lord, to Thy Lotus Feet, that those seeking liberation from the strong meshes of work, fervently meditate upon within the heart, we bow with our buddhi, organs, vital powers, manas and speech.

O Thou Invincible One, through Thy Maya consisting of the three gunas, and resting in them, Thou dost create, maintain and destroy in Thyself this unthinkable universe; but these activities do not touch Thee, for Thou art unimpeachable, being immersed in the unobstructed bliss of the Self.

O Adorable One! O Supreme! Mental worship, scriptural study, charity, austerities and work do not confer such purity on men of unsatisfied desires as the men of balanced minds obtain through a heightened true regard for Thy glories, developed by means of hearing (of them).

When she finished the last verse, Mother looked at her affectionately and said, "Daughter, you chanted beautifully." The woman was pleased and happy. She said, "It is Your Grace, Amma."

The stream of Mother's nectarous words continued to flow. "Children, have you heard this story? A long time ago there

was an emperor who conquered India. The Emperor also had another intention: he wanted to take all the four *Vedas* in their pure, original form back to his country. The Emperor sent his messengers to several parts of India to find out where he could get a genuine copy of the *Vedas*. Eventually he received the information that one such copy was preserved by a Brahmin family in northern India. He immediately set off to that part of the country with a whole battalion of soldiers.

“The Brahmin, who was the head of the family, was a poor man who lived with his wife and four sons in a small hut on the banks of the river Ganges. The Emperor commanded his forces to surround the hut, whereupon he entered the dwelling and ordered the Brahmin to surrender the *Vedas* to him. The Brahmin was very calm. He replied, ‘Your Highness, surely there is no need to make such a fuss. I will happily hand them over to you! But give me one day—just one day. I have a special ceremony to perform before I can give them to you.’ When he saw the suspicious look on the Emperor’s face the Brahmin continued, ‘Do not worry, let your army remain here if you wish. Let them keep an eye on me. I’m not going to run away. Be kind enough to come back tomorrow morning, for I must do this ritual before I can hand the *Vedas* over to you.’

“The Emperor left, having given his troops the necessary instructions. But what did he see when he returned the next morning and entered the hut! He saw the Brahmin offering the last page of the fourth Veda into a sacrificial fire, as he loudly chanted the mantras of that page. His four sons were seated on either side of the fire, with the Brahmin at its head. The Emperor was furious. He shouted at the Brahmin, ‘You have betrayed me! I will have you beheaded for this!’ The Brahmin remained very calm and replied, ‘Your Highness, there is no need to be angry. Please look at my four sons. They have been sitting by my side the whole night, listening as I chanted all the Vedas, one by one. As you saw, I have just finished the fourth and last Veda. Do not think that I have cheated you by destroying the Vedas, or that I have broken my promise. Believe me or not, my sons have memorized all the four Vedas, word for word. They have listened to me. They can repeat the entire scripture without missing a single word. Take my sons with you to your country. They are capable of imparting the knowledge in all its original purity.’

“The Emperor couldn’t believe it. He said, ‘This is unthinkable! I don’t trust you.’ The Brahmin then asked his sons to chant the Vedas, and to the astonishment of the Emperor, they chanted all four of them beautifully, without making a

single mistake. Remember, they had studied it all in a single night. They simply listened intently and with great love to their father as he chanted, and it went straight to their hearts. Thus they could memorize everything so spontaneously.

“But see how it is today. The students learn something by repeating it countless times; and yet, they may still forget it when they later have to stand up and recite it in front of everyone in the classroom. The problem here is fear.

“Magicians, mathematicians, scientist, musicians, painters and others develop only an infinitesimal portion of the power that is inherent within them. Only a true master, who is established in the Atman, has tapped into that infinite power source which exists within us all.”

Mother stopped talking and in a sudden change of mood, Her face took on the expression of an innocent child. Mother turned around and in a begging tone asked one of the brahmacharinis, who was classically trained, to sing the song, *Nilambuja Nayane*.

*O Mother, with blue lotus eyes
Don't You hear the cries
Of this sorrowing heart?
Is it due to the deeds of some past life*

*That I am wandering alone?
I have passed through the ages
Before being born again in this life.*

*Please draw me close to You
With a motherly hug;
Let me curl up in Your lap
Like a child.
O Mother, I may not deserve You
But will You forsake this child for that reason?
Come and hold me close to You
Envelope me in Your merciful glance.*

THE TECHNIQUE

After a short silence another question was put forth.

“How does the technique of relaxation work?”

Mother: “Children, when you relax you forget everything. A space is created and your mind becomes empty. Suppose you are sitting in a park with your beloved by your side. Many different things are happening in the park. People are gossiping or talking about the recent political changes, children are playing, youngsters are shouting, screaming and merry-making; but you and your lover, sitting in a corner gazing into each other’s eyes, are unaware of what is happening around you. When all thoughts are put aside and forgotten, you are

filled with the sweet fragrance of love, and the heart is allowed to blossom. At that moment, everything stops—even you and your beloved cease to exist. There is only love. At that moment, yesterday and tomorrow can no longer interfere. When the past and the future dissolve, love will arise, and only out of that love can real relaxation be experienced.

“In the same way, when you are relaxed you forget everything else; and in that forgetful mood, if you focus all your energy on something of your choice, the whole subject just enters into you. At that moment your whole being is wide open—every atom, every cell of your body is so receptive that you can just swallow the whole subject and digest it.

“This is the method that the rishis used in the education of their disciples. They made their disciples forget everything and relax. In that atmosphere of love and openness all their previous conditioning was forgotten.

“The disciples who studied at the gurukulas belonged to all classes of society. From the royal prince to the son of the poorest man, they all studied in the same hermitage, under the same master. Normally, in such a situation, there would be plenty of opportunities for all kinds of divisions and conflicts to occur. Can you imagine how all those children, coming from entirely different backgrounds, and with different mental dispositions, could stay in the same hermitage, where the

conditions and facilities were usually very spartan? They led a hard life. Most hermitages in those days were situated in the forests, far away from any town or village. The Master never treated the disciples differently; he never provided a prince with a separate, beautifully furnished bedroom, along with a bunch of servants to take care of his needs; nor did he put the son of a poor man in a musty, dusty, matchbox-sized hut. There was no such discrimination with food, accommodation or clothing. They ate the same food, slept on the same floor, and they all wore simple clothes. Whether it was a prince, the child of a minister or a nobleman, or the son of a poor man, they all had to adjust to the same simple way of living, and they worked hard. There was absolutely no division or partiality. On the other hand, there was much sharing, deep love and a feeling of oneness among them.

“It was the quality of the Master that was the source of all the beauty and charm in their lives. It was his presence that helped the disciples forget all divisions and live in oneness, and to drink in the knowledge imparted by the Master.

“So, My children, remember: only through love and relaxation is it possible to grow. But unfortunately, our concept about what growth really is has changed. We believe that growth is something external: become rich, buy as many cars, houses, as much property and as many stocks as you

can; then people will say, 'He has grown tremendously!' This is the sort of comment we would make about such a person. We think he has developed, but is it real growth? As long as one is divided within, one cannot grow. The majority of human beings are divided, both within and without. How can any real development take place in a person, or in society, as long as there is no love or sense of unity?

"Real growth takes place in the unity that is born out of love. The milk that flows out of the mother's breast nourishes the baby and provides its body with strength and vitality, allowing all the organs to grow healthily and in proportion. But it is not just milk that flows out of the mother's breast—it is the warmth, the love and affection of the mother in the form of milk. In a similar way, love is the 'breast milk' that helps society to grow as a whole. Love provides the necessary strength and vitality which enables society to grow without division."



CHAPTER SEVEN

THE MOTHER OF THE UNIVERSE

It was five o'clock in the afternoon. Mother was standing in front of the cow shed with a group of brahmacharis, brahmacharinis and visiting householder devotees. The cows were tied up outside and were being led into the cow shed by a brahmachari. As the brahmachari was about to untie the last cow, Mother said to him, "Son, wait a minute." Mother smiled and approached the cow. She suddenly got down on Her hands and knees like a small child and began drinking milk directly from the udders of the cow. The cow stood very still with a look of tremendous bliss on her face. As Mother drank from each udder, the udders were filled with more and more milk. Mother looked so utterly sweet and innocent with the milk trickling down Her cheeks.

Those who watched this unique scene were deeply moved, because it reminded them of the stories of Sri Krishna's childhood. The cow must have accumulated a great deal of merit to be given the opportunity to feed the Universal Mother directly from its udders.

Finally, Mother stood up. She wiped Her face with a towel

and kissed the cow affectionately. She said, “Children, this cow has been waiting for Amma to drink from her for a long time. Her desire for this was very strong.”

One of the devotees said with great feeling, “Amma, You are truly the Mother of the Universe. You can understand the thoughts and feelings of all of creation and act accordingly.

Mother walked towards the back of the cow shed. The brahmachari untied the cow and as the cow was being led into the cow shed, she turned her head towards Mother and kept gazing at Her.

Mother said, “Children, there was a time when everybody, even Amma’s parents, were against Her because of Her unusual ways, and they abandoned Her. When that happened, it was the birds and the animals who took care of Her needs. A dog used to bring food packets for Amma from somewhere. Sometimes Amma would sit in deep samadhi for several days at a stretch. When She came out of that state, a cow would come and stand in front of Her in such a position that Amma could drink as much as She wanted directly from its udders. There was an eagle who was in the habit of bringing fish for Amma, which She ate raw. Children, when you are one with creation, when your heart is filled with nothing but love, all of nature will be your friend and will serve you. It is your

selfishness and narrow-mindedness that is keeping the creatures away.

Mother was now standing behind the cow shed. When She noticed that the tank that collected the cow urine was full to overflowing, She said, “Children, Amma is surprised to see that none of you have taken the initiative to empty this tank.” Mother then summoned the brahmachari who was in charge of the cows and asked, “Didn’t you see this? Isn’t it your duty to make sure that the cow shed and its surroundings are kept clean? Children, it doesn’t matter what you do. The important thing is how you do it. If you don’t perform your actions with love and dedication, how can you progress spiritually? Amma doesn’t want to say much. You children should learn to do things willingly and spontaneously without having to be asked.” Having said this, Mother Herself began emptying the tank with a bucket. When they saw this, the whole group came forward. At first they were afraid to approach Mother in case She was angry and wouldn’t let them help. But Mother didn’t say anything. Taking this as a sign, they fetched more buckets and began to help, and within a few minutes the tank was clean. By the time the work was done, Mother’s dress was covered with dirt. But Mother didn’t care. She grabbed a broom that was lying in a corner and began sweeping the whole area around the cow shed. Though

everyone begged Mother to let them do it, She continued to sweep until the place looked clean.

It was time for the evening bhajans. Mother went to Her room and returned a few minutes later to let everyone drink in the bliss of Her soulful song.

FEAR BLOCKS SPONTANEITY

When the bhajans were over Mother again graciously answered some questions. The devotees were delighted at the opportunity to tap into the knowledge of this infinite source of wisdom.

Question: “Amma, the other day, you said that one cannot be relaxed if one is gripped by fear, and thus one fails to express oneself spontaneously. What causes this fear?”

Mother: “It is the thought of what others may think of us that causes this fear. It is the fear of judgment. The problem lies in the feeling of otherness. As long as this fear remains, your heart will be closed, and a closed heart cannot express itself.

“Take the example of the student who is asked to recite a poem in front of the class. He learns the poem by repeating it in the solitude of his home; but when the student later tries to recite the poem in front of the others he is overcome by fear—the fear of judgment. He is overwhelmed by the thought

of what his friends and the teacher will think of him if he makes a mistake, and so he suddenly forgets all that he has learned.

“When the student is alone behind the closed doors of his room, he is relaxed and unafraid. In the midst of others, however, he cannot relax. The thought that they are watching him and that they may judge and criticize, creates a block within him and he loses his ability to express himself. A feeling of otherness creates this fear and blocks the flow of inspiration and expression. The feeling of otherness should disappear if we are to express ourselves fully. We should learn to always feel as relaxed as we do in the solitude of our own room.

“A beautiful song will only come from a singer who forgets both the audience and himself. A heart-capturing painting will emerge only when the artist forgets himself and everything else, even the world. All sense of otherness must disappear if your talents are to be expressed in all their fullness and beauty. The feeling of otherness obstructs the flow of your heart.

“Amma knows a boy who is a very talented singer. He has a wonderful voice, but whenever he tries to sing in front of others, he utterly fails to express his gift. He trembles, breaks out in a sweat and sings off key. Poor boy! In his fear

of judgment, he is overwhelmed by thoughts such as, ‘How am I going to sing in front of all these people? Will my singing please them? Will I be able to sing properly? If I don’t, what will they think of me?’ It then becomes impossible for him to sing in front of an audience.

“Look at a Mahatma. Whenever he wants, he can express his whole being with all its charm and beauty. He is not conditioned by anything. The feeling of otherness is absent in him, and he is fearless. He can move and mingle freely with anyone at any time, no matter where he is. How is this possible? It is possible because he beholds everyone as his own Self. For him, there is only the Self.”

It sounded as if Mother was speaking about Herself. A person who observes Mother will soon notice how freely Mother mingles with people and spontaneously adjusts to different situations without the least feeling of unfamiliarity. No one is a stranger to Her, nor do people perceive Her as a stranger in any way. This helps people to open up and share all their feelings with Mother. They feel that Mother is very close to them, that She is their very own. And this is true—no one can be closer to us than Mother—for She is our own innermost Self. The feeling of otherness is totally absent in Her. Being beyond all fears, Mother can express Her whole being in any situation.

ALONENESS AND LONELINESS

Question: “What is the difference between being lonely and inner solitude?”

Mother: “Aloneness (inner solitude) helps you to relax. Aloneness has nothing to do with loneliness. You can feel lonely when you are overwhelmed by thoughts and emotions. Imagine that you are living a happy family life, your workplace is close to your home, you love to spend time with your family, and then your office suddenly sends you abroad for two years. You are asked to go immediately and you can’t take your family with you. So you leave your home to settle down in a new place. When you get there you feel intensely sad. You seem to lose all your strength and enthusiasm. You cannot stop thinking about your wife and children. The separation from your family makes you lonely, and the more you miss your family the more vulnerable you feel. When you are lonely you become emotionally upset, and when you are upset you become vulnerable. You become the slave of your mind. In that state you are an easy victim of any situation, and as a result you lose your peace of mind. A lonely person is agitated and cannot feel peaceful or happy. This is what loneliness does to you.

“Aloneness, on the other hand, is something that hap-

pens deep within; it makes you feel contented and at peace in any situation. Whether you are physically alone, or in the midst of a big crowd of strange people in a foreign country with a different culture and language, you will be immensely happy and you will be spontaneous in the way you express yourself. A person who has developed this inner aloneness cannot be overpowered by emotions. He will never feel sad or empty. Nothing can upset the spontaneous flow of his heart when he is in this state.

“Whereas you feel lonely when you are enslaved by the mind, aloneness is a state you enter when you become the master of your mind, when you go beyond the mind. Loneliness is external, it is of the mind and body. Aloneness is internal, it belongs to the Atman. Loneliness is the outcome of attachment. Aloneness is the outcome of detachment. Loneliness plunges you into a state of darkness and sorrow. Aloneness brings light and love into your life.

“Aloneness is not the same as seclusion. When we are in a beautiful picturesque place, away from the crowd, we are in seclusion. But in that sort of solitude, one can still be agitated, if aloneness, or *inner* solitude, has not been attained.

“You feel lonely when you are tense and agitated. Aloneness, on the other hand, is experienced when you are relaxed and free of all tension. Loneliness closes your heart

and blocks off every possibility of self-expression. Aloneness helps you to open up fully and to express yourself naturally and spontaneously. Loneliness is the sign of a person who is bound by the world and its objects, and by desires. Aloneness is the sign of a soul who is free from all desires and the objects and pleasures of the world.”

Question: “How can we attain this state of aloneness? How can we let go of all our fears and our feelings of otherness?”

Mother: “This is possible only through meditation. In order to feel completely relaxed and to finally reach the state of perfect aloneness, the interference of the past and the future should stop. Only this moment exists and should be experienced. Meditation is the technique of knowing how to be in the present moment.

“By concentrating on, for example, a form, sound, or light, we learn to constantly be in that state of inner aloneness, and to be joyful in any situation. To be content in one’s own Self, by the Self, and for the Self, is what is known as inner aloneness. All spiritual practices are done in order to experience this aloneness or one-pointedness of mind. In reality, we don’t have to depend on anything external for our happiness. We should become independent—depending only on our own Self, the very Source of all joy. A true Master’s presence is the best place for this aloneness to be experienced.

“Don’t confuse this state of aloneness with being physically alone in a quiet place. Unless you have silenced your mind, you will not find that inner aloneness even if you sit in a quiet spot, in a beautiful cave in the Himalayas, or in a pleasant, secluded forest. If the mind is noisy you won’t experience real aloneness, but will continue to remain in the grip of the mind and its negativity.

“Once, three seekers went to the mountains to do serious *sadhana*. Before starting they decided to take a vow of silence for three years. All three of them then began doing severe austerities. One day a horse happened to pass by. Almost a year went by when one fine morning one of them said, ‘That was a beautiful white horse.’ That was all he said. There was no more speaking after that. Thus another year went by, when one day the second man suddenly remarked. ‘No, that wasn’t a white horse. It was a black horse.’ That was it. Again silence prevailed for a whole year. When finally the three years had come to an end, the third person opened his mouth and said, ‘Enough is enough! I am leaving this place right now! You two have no discipline and you are disturbing others with your talk as well.’”

Everyone laughed at Mother’s story.

“Children, that inner aloneness can be experienced only when the mind is still and silent. From that stillness the beau-

tiful flower of peace and bliss will emerge. Once that aloneness is experienced, you can be anywhere on this planet or in any other world, even in the netherworld, but you will always be immersed in bliss and peace. It doesn't matter if you are physically alone or in the noisiest place in the world—you are always joyful and contented.

“A Satguru will create situations through which this aloneness can be found within you. The Master doesn't teach anything, but in his presence helpful situations spontaneously arise. This can happen because the Master is the embodiment of 'That.' He is the creator of each situation that will allow you to grow spiritually. The Master helps you to close the doors and windows of your senses. Your senses are the doors and windows through which you stray away from your inner Self. You cannot see the Self through the doors and windows of the senses. In reality, you don't need them to see your Self.

“Suppose you are living in the most wonderful, picturesque surroundings. You are in your house and you suddenly wish to take a look at the beautiful landscape outside. You open the door and walk out into that landscape, or you may stay inside and look out through the window. But if you want to take a look at yourself, there is no need to go outside. You can close the door and turn away from it, because you know

that you are not to be found somewhere out there; you are here within. You need the outlets of the senses to perceive the external world, but through those senses you cannot experience the inner Self; for that Self is not to be found somewhere out there in the world. The Self cannot be seen through the eyes or experienced through any of the senses, which are all focused outwardly, in the opposite direction of your Self. If you wish to see the Self, you have to become blind; you have to close the doors and stop directing your focus outwardly, because the Self is within. However, once you realize your true, indwelling Self, you can go out through the doors of your senses as much as you wish, for then you no longer see a world of diversity—everything is transformed into one totality. But for this to happen you have to become blind to this world of plurality. When you become blind to the outer world, even when your eyes are open, that is when you develop the divine, inner eye, a new vision—the third eye of infinite knowledge and wisdom. That is what you see in a Mahatma’s eyes.

“Meditation is the technique that allows you to shut the doors and windows of the senses, so that you can look within and see your Self. Real meditation, however, can only be experienced in the presence of a Satguru. A true Master is

constantly in meditation, even though you may see him being physically active. His presence is the most conducive place for your Self-unfolding to take place. In his presence you can attain that inner aloneness and thereby get rid of all your fears and feelings of otherness.”

Mother paused, and in the silence of the night She began to sing, *Nilameghangale* . . .

*O blue clouds!
How did you get that azure tone today
The charming dark-blue complexion
Of the Child of Nanda in Vrindavan?*

*Did you meet the Child, Kannan Krishna?
Did you talk to each other
And exchange a smile?
Did the glance of His eyes
Blue as the lotus
Caress you from head to toe?*

*Did Kannan tell you
When He will appear before me?
Did He say that He would welcome me also?
Did He send a few consoling words
For the peace of my mind?*

SELF-EFFORT IN THE SATGURU'S PRESENCE

As they heard the sound of Mother singing, more residents came out of their huts and gathered around Her. When the song came to an end, Mother sat quietly looking up at the beautiful sky that was lit by the moon and numerous twinkling stars. After a few minutes, another question was asked.

“Amma, it sounds as if everything simply happens in the presence of a true Master, without any self-effort on our part. But isn't self-effort necessary for the inner eye to open?”

Mother: “Children, even self-effort happens spontaneously in the presence of a Master, provided you have the right attitude, faith and understanding. The intensity of the situations created by the Master is such that self-effort happens without your knowledge. Just as a bud opens up into a beautiful, fragrant flower, you will also experience yourself opening up naturally and spontaneously in the presence of a Satguru.

“Of course, there is such a thing as self-effort; but for that effort to bear the right fruit we must first know what is to be done and how. Only a perfect Master can bestow this knowledge upon us. Through our constant companionship with the Master, it becomes known to us, and from there on it is easy. You think that something has to be done to attain libera-

tion; but the point of the Guru-sishya relationship is to let the disciple know that there is nothing to be done, because *Moksha* (Liberation) is not something that comes to you or enters into you from outside; on the contrary, it is something that is intrinsically part of you, something that you already are.

“The mind, or the past, is not the problem; the problem lies in your *identification* with the mind, with your past. The unintelligent attachment, the feeling of ‘I and mine,’ is the problem. Once you learn the art of withdrawing your attachment and being a witness, then something changes in the way you see everything.

“Amma has heard a story that She will use as an example. A factory is on fire. The owner of the factory is in a terrible state, sobbing and screaming like one gone mad. ‘Everything is being destroyed!’ he cries. ‘All my wealth, everything that I have earned through hard work is gone. I’m ruined!’ Then suddenly, a friend comes up to him and says, ‘Why are you crying so desperately? Don’t you know that your son sold the factory yesterday? It is no longer yours!’ The factory is still burning, the situation hasn’t changed, but the man immediately stops crying. The burning within him has stopped. He wipes his tears and smiles relieved. Just then, his son comes and tells him, ‘Dad, why are you just standing

there? Don't you see that the factory is in flames? Why don't you do something!' The father says, 'What is there to do? You have sold the factory.' But the son tells him, 'No, father, we almost sold the factory yesterday but something went wrong; the sale didn't go through.' As soon as he learns the news, the father is again thrown into a state of despair, and his sobbing is resumed.

"The burning building is not the cause of his suffering. His attachment to the building is the real reason for his suffering. The thought that the factory is his, and then later that it is no longer his, creates entirely different moods in him. His initial terror and despair changes into happiness and relief, and then again back to despair. The outer situation hasn't changed as the factory continues to burn—the changes happen within him. When he hears that the factory has been sold, he withdraws his attachment and just witnesses the building being burned. But as soon as he receives the news that the building hasn't been sold after all, an attachment is created which plunges him back into sorrow. If you can renounce your feelings of attachment, then you will always be calm. Stop identifying with the world created by your mind, and a new world will open up before you. You may still own a big house, a beautiful car and other comforts, but you don't really possess anything. By not letting any insentient objects

affect your life, you become their master.

“Don’t think that all your memories of the past will disappear when you attain the state of perfection. No, the memories are still there, but you will never again identify with them. Once your identification with the past is withdrawn, the past becomes no more than a storage place for your memories. Think of the past as a storage place and not as the place where you live. If you need to use something from the past, you go there and fetch it, and as soon as you have found what you need, you leave the place. You do not live there. This is what needs to be understood. Don’t spend your life in the storage place of your past, for that is not your home. Come away from there and live in the light, the love and the freedom where you belong. This is the message of a true Master. You will learn it by just being in his presence. Nowhere else in the world can this be learned.”



CHAPTER EIGHT

WORK AS WORSHIP

The concrete work of the new prayer hall had started early today. Almost all the Ashram residents were working hard, carrying the concrete in big metal pans which they passed on to each other. Soon after they had begun, Mother arrived at the site and was about to participate in the work. Br. Balu pleaded with Her and said, “Amma, this is concrete work. Please don’t do this! Why do You worry when there are so many people here to do the work? Amma, the material will burn your skin if it happens to spill on You.”

Mother replied, “It will burn your skin as well, not only Amma’s.”

But Balu persisted, “Amma, please don’t do this! We will do the work.”

Mother smiled at him and said, “Son, Amma is happy to do any kind of work. From a very young age, Amma had to work hard. Her body never knew what rest was. Don’t worry.”

Several others also tried to dissuade Mother from join-

ing in the work. But their pleas fell on deaf ears. With a radiant smile, Mother tied a cloth around Her head and began working beside Her children. She lifted a metal pan filled with concrete onto Her head, and carried it away.

Everyone was engrossed in work when one concrete-filled container suddenly slipped and fell from a brahmachari's hands heavily onto the ground. He managed to step back the moment before it fell, so that he didn't hurt his feet. But the cement splashed and made a few marks on Mother's face. The brahmachari said, "Amma, please forgive me for my lack of shraddha." Mother smiled at him and said, "No problem! This is just part of the play." Mother wiped Her face with a towel handed to Her by one of the brahmacharis and continued to work. As they worked Mother chanted, "Om Namah Shivaya," and everyone responded in a chorus. This was followed by another song, *Adiyil Parameswariye*. . .

*O Primal, Supreme Goddess
O Mother of all the worlds
I have no goal in this world
Except Mother.*

*O Mother, with beautiful eyes
Like the petals of a blue lotus,
You are the Sustainer of the three worlds.*

*O Dweller in the lotus flower, Maya
O Beautiful One
The Source of everything
Rid me of all sorrows.*

*O Gracious One
Destroyer of greed
Who leads us
Through the land of transmigration
Protect me.
O Mother, Giver of devotion and liberation
O Katyayani, far-famed One
I bow to You.*

*O Goddess of the earth
Who is wisdom and knowledge
The only delight and the only nourishment
You are all of Creation.
O Fulfiller of all desires
Please rid me of my pride
Dwell within my mind and remove my desires.*

Mother was standing in the blazing sun. A devotee tried to hold an umbrella over Her head, but Mother lovingly refused and moved away saying, “No, no! How can Amma use an umbrella when all Her children are working in the sun?”

It was getting hotter. Beads of sweat glittered on Mother’s beautiful face. Mother had been working continuously for

the last two hours, but Her smile never faded for a moment. She wiped Her face with a towel and said, “Children, as you work, try to feel God’s presence everywhere. Just imagine that all those who are working with you are sparks of Divinity. God is carrying sand; God is passing the concrete to God; the masonry, the people who are mixing the cement, the metal pans—everything is pervaded with God-consciousness. Try to do the work with this feeling. Then your time will not be wasted.”

Mother continued to work. At one point She put the metal pan down. Now there was only the cloth wrapped like a turban around Her head. She looked so cute and attractive, that some of the residents paused in their work just to look at Mother, and their faces lit up with a smile.

Just then, a group of young men, who were long time devotees of Mother, came to see Her. They had brought a few new people with them. Mother removed the turban and walked with them towards the front of the meditation hall. Br. Balu and two other brahmacharis joined the group, knowing that Mother was bound to talk about spiritual subjects with the young men, who were inquisitive and sincere.

After offering their prostrations to Mother, one of the young men said, “Amma, it looks as if You have been working for a long time. You must be tired.”

“Son,” Mother replied, “You will feel tired only if there is no love in your actions. You cannot be overcome by tiredness and boredom if your actions are done with love.”

After some light conversation, one of the newcomers asked Mother a question.

WHETHER OR NOT YOU BELIEVE,
YOUR DIVINITY REMAINS UNCHANGED

Question: “Amma, spirituality recommends that we eliminate our ego. But what is the use of dropping the ego? I believe that the ego is useful—it’s not a useless thing. It’s only because of the ego that this beautiful world exists. If this world is going to disappear when the ego is destroyed, I would rather cling to my ego. If I have a choice, I’ll keep my ego. I won’t let it go.”

Mother: “Son, you cannot force anyone to drop his ego. Nobody likes to let go of the ego—it’s so precious to everyone. However, once you have attained the state of egolessness, the world won’t disappear, as you may think it will. The world will continue, but a change takes place within you. Something is uncovered. You start seeing everything with the wonder and innocence of a child.

“When you realize the Self, the entire universe attains

realization, as it were; because, in that state, you realize the all-pervasive nature of the Atman. You behold and experience the Atman everywhere. As the realization that everything is pervaded with Divine Consciousness dawns within you, you also see that every human being, everything in creation, is already Divine. The only difference is that you know that you and they are one with the Supreme Divinity, but they do not. It is only a question of uncovering the truth.

“Son, whether you drop your ego or not, divinity is your true nature. Nothing can change that. If you insist on saying, ‘I am the ego, body, mind and intellect,’ it won’t make any difference. Your true nature isn’t in the least affected by your lack of understanding. It is like saying that the earth is flat and not round. If you keep preaching that the earth is flat, believing it to be true, is it going to change the shape of the earth in any way? No, of course not. Similarly, you are free to believe that you are the ego and that the ego is real, but you will nevertheless continue to remain what you are: the Self (Atman). Your divine nature will not change or be diminished, even if you don’t believe in it.

“If someone believes that fire is cold and ice is hot, will it make the fire cold and the ice hot? No, that would be impossible. It is the same with you and your true nature.

“You may say that the round shape of the earth and the hot and cold temperatures of fire and ice are proven facts; whereas the Self, our true nature, is only a question of faith. Son, before it was proven that the earth is round, it was only a belief based on faith, wasn’t it? There was a difference of opinion among scientists concerning the shape of the earth; people even thought that the earth was flat. Later, it was proven that the earth is round; but until then, the shape of the earth remained a mystery, a matter of faith. Before scientists are able to prove anything, they simply believe. They work on the basis of a certain hypothesis, and when it has been proven through their experiments, they declare it to be true. So everything is a question of faith until it is experienced directly or proven scientifically.

“Just as scientists have proven their different theories through the work they do in their laboratories, the saints and sages, having worked in their inner laboratories, have experienced the Self, the Ultimate Reality, directly. This is not the experience of one or two persons at a particular place in history; it is the experience of all those around the globe who have explored their inner Self. So you cannot deny its authenticity by saying that it is only a belief and not something that is based on fact.

ONLY A BUD CAN BLOOM

“Keep your ego if you wish and don’t let go of it. Nobody is not going to force you to drop it, because force won’t work here. It is like opening the petals of a flower. The bud has to open up naturally without any external force. Only the natural process of blossoming will bring out all the beauty and fragrance of a flower. However, if you become impatient and forcibly try to pull the petals open, the flower will die. Force will only destroy the inner process of opening up.

“When a bud has been closed for a long time, it feels an intense longing to open up, to come out and to dance joyfully in the fresh breeze of open space. The bud stage is like a prison. Being imprisoned creates a longing for freedom; it creates an intense thirst to break the bondage and come out. You could say it is an inevitable law that to really know the joy of freedom one must first be bound and imprisoned. For only a bud can bloom. Before the flower blossoms, it has to go through the stage of being a closed bud. The urge to open up arises out of the bud stage.

“In a similar way, your heart in its closed stage is known as the ego. At some point before it opens up, the bud may think, ‘I am a bud and I like it this way. This world is so beautiful! If I had a choice I’d rather stay right here. They say there’s a much higher state known as being a flower, a

state full of beauty and fragrance. They talk about the colorful petals and the exquisite perfume that I have. But I myself know nothing of this; I am quite comfortable and secure as I am. Actually, I am afraid to change. . . .’

“You can remain where you are and argue as much as you like, but it won’t last for long. The bud will soon begin to feel uncomfortable—a bit restless, a feeling of suffocation—and these feelings will intensify. As the suffocating feeling increases, an unquenchable thirst to come out and free yourself will also develop; and this will slowly culminate in your full unfolding and blossoming.

“The bud stage of the heart is the ego. You are experiencing the same trepidation as the bud: ‘This world is beautiful as it is. I am afraid it might all disappear. If I have a choice, I’d rather cling to my ego.’ You can rationalize like that, it’s all right; but no matter how much you argue, the fact remains that you are a potential flower. Every single bud is a potential flower; it may be a bud now, but that doesn’t mean that the latent flower isn’t there. It is an unchangeable fact that there is a flower waiting to unfold within each unopened bud. You may be skeptical and deny it, but none of your thoughts can change the truth. Your thoughts and your doubts belong to the mind. No, the Truth cannot be changed. The Truth remains the Truth—indisputable and

unchangeable.

“In a way, it is good to remain for as long as possible as a bud, in the closed stage of the ego, because the longer you stay in that condition, the more you will long to break out of it. The longer you are in jail, the more intense will be your longing to enjoy the bliss of freedom. Likewise, the more time you spend inside the closed shell of your ego, the more momentum you will gain for the final breakthrough to happen. So, it’s good. Don’t be in a hurry; stay in the shell and continue to rationalize and argue for as long as you like. It’s a good sign, for it means that you are getting closer.

“But remember: nobody is going to force you to open up; you cannot be forced to drop your ego. If your choice is to cling to your ego, that’s fine. You prefer the dark world of the bud; you feel comfortable there. Your mind has become so accustomed to the darkness within the closed bud that in your ignorance you believe that the darkness contains all the light you need. You don’t know that the faint light you perceive is only the few pitiful rays of light that manage to enter through the minute cracks of the bud. It is like the dim light of a dungeon.

“It is as if you have spent such a long time in a dungeon that you have forgotten what true light is. ‘This dungeon is enough for me,’ you say to yourself. ‘There is no brighter

light than this. I don't want anything else.' Even if someone were to tell you about the brilliant sunlight that is available outside the dungeon, you would say, 'No, it can't be true.' But the sun exists and its light is the truth. How could it cease to exist, just because you happen to deny it? The problem lies within yourself, and has nothing to do with the sun or its light. You have to come out and experience the light. But you feel secure inside your dungeon and are afraid to come out. You are concerned about what would happen if you were to leave. Your concern is quite understandable, because you don't know anything about what lies beyond the dungeon. In your situation, you have no other source of information, except the words of the person who says to you, 'Look, my friend, there is a wonderful, radiant world out there! It is full of sunlight, beautiful mountains and valleys, sparkling rivers, blossoming trees; there is a moon and countless twinkling stars to be seen. Come with me. I know everything about it because I live there. Come, my friend, I will help you to be free.' You just have to trust him and believe in his words. Surrender to him and take a few courageous steps, so that you may know what he is talking about. He says to you, 'My friend, you are not free at all; you are in jail, bound in chains. Follow me, and I will show you the path to freedom. Take my hand and I will lead you there.'

“Nothing will happen if you resist saying, ‘No, it isn’t true! This dungeon is the most beautiful world there is. I prefer to be here. This light is the only light, and, as far as I’m concerned, there is no such thing as the sun, the moon or the stars.’

“However, sooner or later the jail itself is bound to create an instinctive urge within you, a longing to experience the bliss of freedom. Every human being, consciously or unconsciously, has a desire to be free and to be at peace in all circumstances. A breakthrough is therefore bound to happen at some point.

“The self-created shell of the ego should break open so that the heart can express itself fully.

“But the ego can only be broken through the pain of love. Just as the seedling emerges when the outer shell of the seed breaks open, so the Self unfolds when the ego breaks and disappears. When a conducive atmosphere is created, the potential tree within the seed will begin to feel the discomfort of being imprisoned in the shell. It longs to come out into the light and to be free. It is the intense urge of the dormant tree within that breaks the shell open. There is pain involved in this breaking of the outer shell. But that pain is nothing in relation to the glory of the manifested tree. Once the seedling emerges, the shell becomes insignificant. Simi-

larly, once Self-Realization is attained, the ego loses all its significance.

“Son, if you believe that the ego is so precious, you may keep it. But your turn will come. Your closed heart, your ego, cannot remain closed forever—it must open up. However, no force can be used for this opening to take place.

“Don’t think that the world will disappear once you become egoless, once the bud of the ego has been transformed into the flower of Self-Realization. The world will remain as it is. But you will see it differently. A new world opens up before you—a world of wonders and heavenly beauty will be uncovered within you.

“Within the bud of the ego it is dark and narrow. When the bud gives way and the flower emerges, everything becomes beautiful and pervaded by the most glorious light. You come out of the dark into the radiant light, from imprisonment to freedom, from ignorance to true knowledge. This world of diversity is transformed into perfect oneness. It happens within you, not externally.”

IT JUST HAPPENS IN THE TRUE MASTER’S PRESENCE

Question: “Amma, you said that this opening up cannot be

forced. What, then, does the Master do for this opening up to happen?”

Mother: “A true Master is a *presence*, the presence of Divine Consciousness. He does nothing. In his presence everything just happens, without any effort on his part. There can only be effort where there is an ego. A true Master is egoless. There is therefore no effort involved from his side. Even the situations that allow the seeker to dive into his own consciousness arise in the presence of the Master. That is simply how it is—it cannot be otherwise. The sun doesn’t make any effort to create its light; yet the sun cannot do anything but shine. A flower doesn’t make any effort to be fragrant; being fragrant is just part of its nature. A river doesn’t make any effort to flow; it simply flows. It is all so natural. Human beings create unnatural things, but nature can only be natural. Likewise, the perfect Master doesn’t do anything in particular to create a suitable situation for your progress. His very presence makes what is needed happen spontaneously. There is no effort involved on his part. His presence is the most conducive atmosphere for the opening of your heart to take place. That is how it is.

“The sun doesn’t do anything in particular to make a lotus flower bloom. The sun simply shines in the sky, and by its mere existence, all the lotuses in the ponds and lakes on earth

open up. The sun is not doing anything—it just shines. There is no effort involved. Similarly, the presence of a perfect Master is like the radiant sun that makes the lotus of our heart blossom. There is no question of force. His infinitely loving and compassionate presence has the power to melt the rock of the ego. The ego melts and a flow of supreme love is created. The Master is not doing anything.

“Huge ice blocks melt in the heat of the sun. The masses of ice on the Himalayan peaks melt and run down into the valleys. They become rivers and streams where people can drink and bathe. The Satguru’s presence can easily melt our rocklike egos and create a wonderful flow of universal love and compassion.

“There is no effort involved in the Master’s presence. He is simply there. In his divine presence everything happens spontaneously. The earth doesn’t force anything upon us, nor does the sun, the moon or the stars, or anything in nature. Everything simply is. Only selfish, egotistic human beings try to force things on each other.

“As long as you are identified with your body, you will try to force things; but once you go beyond the body you cannot force anything. Once you go beyond the body, once you become bodiless, it means that you are egoless. Using force then becomes impossible.

“Because of the presence of the sun in the sky, countless things happen on earth. The sun is the source of the energy necessary for creation to exist. Without the sun and its rays, humans, animals and plants could not exist. But the sun is not forcing anything on anyone. The sun is—and by its mere existence everything just happens.

“It is the same with a perfect Master. The sun that we see in the sky is just a small manifestation of the infinite Consciousness. The power of the sun is a minuscule fraction of the entire cosmic energy. The Master, however, is *Purnam* (the Whole). He is that infinite Consciousness itself. Whatever is needed for human evolution happens automatically in his presence. He doesn’t need to use any force.

“A perfect Master is the totality of all life, manifested in a human form. In his presence you experience life in all its intensity and vibrancy.”

Everyone was deeply absorbed and attentive as Mother spoke. It was as if the Fountain of Knowledge was flowing from its very source, like the holy Ganges flowing down from the Himalayan peaks to the valleys below, letting everyone bathe in its sweet, sacred waters. Sitting still and gazing at Mother’s radiant face, everyone gradually went into deep meditation. Only later, when Mother began singing a kirtan did they become aware of their surroundings. Mother sang

the song, Kodanukoti, creating blissful waves of supreme love.

*O Eternal Truth,
For millions of years
Mankind has been searching for You.*

*The ancient sages renounced everything,
And for the purpose of making the Self flow,
Through meditation,
Into Your Divine Stream,
They performed endless years of austerities.*

*Your infinitesimal Flame,
Inaccessible to all,
Shines like the blaze of the sun;
It stands perfectly still, without a flutter
In the fierce wind of a cyclone.*

*The flowers and creepers,
The shrine rooms and temples,
With their newly installed sacred pillars,
Have been waiting for You for eons
And yet You remain unreachable.*

Mother sat in silence for some time looking up at the sky, and then She continued her sweet, profound conversation.

LOVE CAN ONLY EXIST
WHERE THERE IS NO FORCE

“True life—real, meaningful living, has almost disappeared from the face of the earth. Human beings and the entire society have become mechanical and unfeeling. Bargaining and competition is prevalent everywhere. It can be found even in the family, where there ought to be an atmosphere of deep love and concern, and where life is meant to be experienced in all its fullness. Man, in his selfishness and greed, and his lack of love and compassion, has turned into a heartless machine, familiar only with forcing and imposing.

“The mechanical mind of man likes to use force. We have grown accustomed to selfishness, competition, anger, hatred, jealousy and war. Our familiarity with love is only superficial. We are more familiar with the negative tendencies and know only how to force and impose. Force, however, will destroy all possibilities for love to grow.

“Only anger and hatred can force. Take war for example. War is an extreme way of using force. War is the sum total of the anger, hatred, revenge and all the negative feelings of a population. When the collective mind of a country erupts like a volcano, we call it war. Countries at war try to force each others ideas and conditions on each other.

“Love cannot force, for love is the presence of Pure Consciousness. And that presence cannot force—it simply is.

“Real love is experienced when there are no conditions. To have conditions is to force. But where love is present, nothing can be forced. Conditions exist only where there is division. Force is used where there is duality, a sense of ‘you and I.’ You use force because you perceive the other to be different from you. But force cannot take place when there is only One. The very idea of force disappears in that state. Then you simply are. The universal life force flows through you; you become an open passage. You let the Supreme Consciousness take charge of you. You remove whatever has been obstructing the flow; you remove the self-created bund allowing the river of all-embracing Love to run its course.

LIKE THE SHINING SUN AND THE EVER-BLOWING WIND

“It is as if you have locked yourself in a room for a long time; and now, at last, you open all the doors and windows. You have been complaining, saying, ‘Why is there no sunshine in this room? And why is there no breeze in here?’ But now you realize what it was that obstructed the light and the breeze. The sun was always shining and the wind was always blowing. They never stopped. As you sat inside the

room with all the doors and windows closed, you kept complaining and you blamed the sun and the wind for staying away from you. Now you realize that the fault lay entirely with yourself and not with the sun or the wind. So you open up the doors and windows allowing the wind and the light to stream in.

“When you open up, you will find that the sun was always shining and the wind was always blowing, carrying the sweet fragrance of Divinity. There are no conditions and no force is being used. You just allow the door of your heart to open up, the door that was never locked. It has always been open, but in your ignorance you thought it was locked.

“The common expression is, ‘I love you.’ But, instead of ‘I love you,’ it would be better to say, ‘I am love—I am the embodiment of Pure Love.’ Remove the I and you, and you will find that there is only Love. It is as if Love is imprisoned between the I and you. Remove the I and you, for they are unreal; they are self-imposed walls that don’t exist. The gulf between I and you is the ego. When the ego is removed the distance disappears and the I and you also disappear. They merge to become one—and that is Love. You lend the I and you their reality. Withdraw your support and they will disappear. Then you will realize, not that ‘I love you,’ but that ‘I *am* that all-embracing love.’

“Children, whenever you go through a difficult time in life, think to yourselves: ‘I don’t expect any love from others, because I am not someone who needs to be loved by others. I am Love itself. I am an inexhaustible source of love, who will always give love, and nothing but love, to everyone who comes to me.’

“A perfect Master’s presence is the presence of Divine Love. Divine Love cannot force—it is simply there, for our benefit. Not even worldly love can be forced; what, then, can be said about Divine Love, which is beyond all limitations?

“When two lovers meet and fall in love, they don’t talk about terms or conditions before they begin to love each other. If any such exchange were to take place, love couldn’t happen. When the lovers see each other their hearts spontaneously overflow; they are irresistibly drawn to each other. There is no force or effort involved, no words or conditions. Love happens when you don’t force anything, when you are fully present without any sense of ‘I and mine’ blocking the flow. The slightest use of force will destroy the beauty of love, so that love cannot happen.”



CHAPTER NINE

FEEL THE PAIN OF THOSE WHO SUFFER

This morning during darshan, a woman devotee, who looked as if she was very poor, prayed to Mother with tears in Her eyes, “Amma, there is a terrible poultry disease spreading throughout my village, and my own hens have caught the disease. Amma, please save them!”

A brahmachari who was sitting next to Mother didn’t like this. He thought, “What a silly complaint! It is such a crowded day; instead of leaving the hut as soon as they have offered their prostrations to Mother, why do people have to trouble Mother by talking about such trivial things?” As the thought flashed through his mind, Mother who had been busy consoling the woman, gave the brahmachari a stern look and said, “Learn to understand the sorrows and the feelings of others.” The brahmachari turned pale. He was stunned when he realized how instantaneously Mother could catch him by reading his thoughts.

Mother in Her spontaneous and affectionate way consoled the woman. She gave her sacred ash to put on her sick hens. The woman smiled relieved and, having received Mother’s darshan, she happily left the hut.

When the woman was gone, Mother turned towards the brahmachari and said, “Son, you cannot understand the suffering of that daughter. Do you know anything about the difficulties and the affliction people go through in this world? If you did, you wouldn’t have considered her complaint to be silly or insignificant. You have never known the sorrows of life. Only if you yourself have experienced suffering, will you be able to understand that daughter’s concern about her hens. Her only way of earning a livelihood is by selling the eggs of those hens. If they die, her family will starve. Those hens are everything to her—they are her entire wealth. When Amma thinks about the hard life that woman leads, She cannot think of that woman’s concerns as being insignificant in any way. With the little money she manages to save from the sale of her eggs, she visits Amma once or twice a month. Because Amma is aware of her difficulties, the Ashram sometimes provides her with the bus fare. She has a difficult life, but look at her self-surrender and her love for Amma. Try to see and learn from her simplicity and innocence. When Amma thinks of such people, Amma’s heart melts and She finds it difficult to control Her tears. Those who have always had plenty of food to appease their hunger cannot comprehend the hunger of a starving person.

“You know, son, there are three types of people in this

world. There are those who have nothing; then there are those who are just scraping by; and the third type are those who have far more than they need. Now, if those who belong to the third category don't do anything to help those of the first two categories, then Amma would say that those who belong to the third category, who are supposed to be rich, are, in fact, the poorest of the poor. Those who have far more than they need should have eyes with which to see the suffering of others; they should have ears to hear the distressed calls for help; they should have a loving heart with which to feel compassion towards those who suffer, and they should have willing hands with which to lend their assistance to those in need. Children, listen to the desperate calls for help! No one's pain is insignificant. In order to really hear their sorrow-stricken words you need to have a compassionate heart, a heart that enables you to see and to feel the suffering of others as if it were your own. Try to come down to their level and feel the vibrations of their aching hearts. If you cannot do this, then all the spiritual practices you do are a useless waste."

On hearing Mother's powerful words the brahmachari was full of remorse. With tears in his eyes he sought forgiveness for the mistake he had committed.

Since the beginning of darshan, a young man had been

looking intently at Mother. He was a college lecturer from Nagpur. The day he had arrived at the Ashram he had been in a hurry and had said, “I’m just going to have Mother’s darshan and then I’m leaving. I have some urgent things to do as soon as I get back to Nagpur.” But several days had now gone by, and he was still at the Ashram. Mother said to the other devotees, “Everyday he comes and tells Amma, ‘I am leaving today,’ and everyday Amma gives him permission to go. Amma says to him, “Okay, son, you go and come back.’ But he never leaves.”

The college lecturer, who didn’t speak Malayalam, didn’t understand what Mother was talking about. But because everyone was looking at him, he guessed that Mother was talking about him. A devotee came to his aid and translated what Mother had just said. He responded, “I am not going at all. Then what to say about going and coming back?”

Mother smilingly replied, “But Amma also knows the trick of chasing you away.”

Everybody laughed.

As the darshan continued, the brahmacharis sang *Prema Prabho Lasini*. . .

O Goddess
Enjoyer of immortal bliss

*Who revels in the brilliance of Love
And from whose flowerlike smile
The light of bliss pours forth. . .*

*You are the One
Who, with the waves of the River
Of Immortal Bliss
Caresses those who are searching for the path
Of a life untouched by the fear of sin.*

*Your Lotus Feet
Richly enveloped by the light
Of the Supreme Self
Are granting auspiciousness
By destroying the bondage of Becoming.*

*May You cast that indestructible Light on me
Whose heart bows down to You
That I may merge in the Universal Soul.*

THE FEELING OF BONDAGE

A brahmachari asked a question. “Amma, the scriptures say that the sense of ‘I and you’ is unreal, that it is a self-imposed wall that doesn’t exist, and that we ourselves lend it its reality. If it is unreal, and if everything is one, why, then, am I feeling the difference?”

Mother: “It is your ignorance about your oneness with the

Whole that causes the difference. In reality, there is no bondage, there is no wall separating you from your divine nature. The wall, or bondage, is an illusion created by the mind. Remove the illusion, and your mind will simultaneously be removed.

“There was a cowherd boy who took the cows to the meadows every morning and brought them back to the cow shed in the evening. Before he left for the night, he made sure that all the cows were properly tied to their posts. One evening, he found that one of the cows was missing its rope. The boy was in a fix. He couldn’t leave the cow untied as she would probably run away and get lost, and as it was already dark, it was too late to go and buy a new rope. The boy went to the monk who was in charge of the place, and sought his advice. The monk said to him, “It is nothing to worry about. Just go back to the cow, stand next to her and pretend that you are tying her. Make sure that the cow sees you doing it, and that will be enough. The cow will stay where she is.’

“The boy went back to the cow shed and did as the monk had told him. He pretended that he was tying the cow to the post. When the boy returned the next morning, he found to his amazement that the cow had remained absolutely still throughout the night. The boy untied all the cows as usual and was about to go to the meadows, when he noticed that

the cow with the missing rope was still lying down next to the post. He tried to coax her back to the herd, but she wouldn't budge. The boy was perplexed. He once again went to seek the monk's advice. The monk listened to the boy and smiled. 'Look, my child,' he said, 'the cow still thinks that she is bound to the post. Yesterday when the rope was missing, you pretended that you were tying her. This morning you untied all the cows except this particular one. You thought it wasn't necessary as she wasn't actually tied up. But because of your little act last night, the cow still believes that she is tied to the post. So now you have to go back and pretend that you are setting her free.' The boy returned to the cow and pretended to untie her. The cow immediately got up and ran off to join the herd.

"We are in a similar situation. The bondage, or the wall of separation, is self-created. The wall has been created by the ego, but the ego is also unreal—it is an illusion that has no existence of its own. It appears to be real because of the power it derives from the Atman. It is animated by the Atman. The ego can be compared to dead matter, for without the Self it is insentient. Stop giving any importance to the ego. Learn to ignore it. It will then withdraw and disappear. We give the unreal ego its reality. Expose it and that will be the end of it.

“Due to our ignorance, we believe that we are bound just like the cow, when, in fact, we are completely free. We need to be convinced of this, however. When our ignorance about our true nature, our freedom, is removed, the bondage also disappears.

“Amma knows a man who was in chains for a long time. He was totally insane and had to stay in a mental hospital. Finally, he was brought home. But they had to lock him in a room, with his hands tied behind his back. His hands were tied like that because he often became violent and would attack people. After many years of treatment he finally recovered. But even today one can see that he always keeps his hands behind his back as if they were tied there. When Amma met him, he told Her that after all this time he continues to feel as if his hands were tied behind his back. Whenever someone offers him a cup of tea, or when he is about to eat, his mind finds it difficult to move his hands. It takes a few seconds for him to realize that his hands are no longer tied behind his back. Occasionally, others have to remind him that his hands are free. His hands are free, but he needs to be reminded of it. There is no real bondage; there is only a self-imposed bondage.

“It is the same with us. As long as there is a feeling of bondage, we need the help of a perfect Master who can show

us the way and say to us, 'Look, you are not bound at all. You are the all-powerful Atman, the Self. Come out of the illusion and soar up through the skies of Supreme Consciousness.' The Master pretends that he is untying the rope that binds you to the post of worldly objects and pleasures. Once the illusion is removed, you realize that you were always in that Consciousness, that you have never, ever strayed from it.

"A perfect Master's guidance and his presence is the light that illumines your path. His presence helps you to see the self-created wall of the ego. By understanding the illusory nature of your bondage, it can easily be removed. Your wrong understanding about your relationship with people, with the world, and the objects of the world, creates the bondage."

A UNITY - NOT A RELATIONSHIP

Question: "Amma, are you saying that relationships cause that bondage?"

Mother: "Yes, a relationship does create bondage, if one doesn't have the proper understanding and discrimination. But the truth is that a relationship can only exist as long as there is a perception of there being two. Once the realization of the Self arises, there can be no question of a relationship, be-

cause the two disappear. From that point onwards, there is only oneness, and total detachment.

“When all feelings of duality disappear, all relationships also disappear. Two individuals, families, or nations can have a relationship; but when everything is One, there can no longer be a relationship. Then, there is only One, an all-encompassing awareness. Relationships bind, whereas perfect awareness of the Self frees you from all bondage. In a relationship you are like a caged bird. Realization of the Self lets you out of the cage of the ego and sets you free.

“The body and its different parts, though seemingly different, are one, a unity. The hands, legs, eyes, nose, ears and all the internal organs, are part of the whole. It is a unity, one body—not a relationship. Similarly, the branches, leaves, flowers and fruits of a tree are all parts of the one whole tree. You cannot call it a relationship.

“When the self-created wall of the ego is lifted, you will realize that the dualistic nature of the world is only an external appearance, and that, in essence, everything is a whole, a single unity.

“The outer world is given far too much importance, while the inner world is ignored. This will only serve to increase the density of our ignorance. If we lay too much emphasis on our relationship with the outer world, while we ignore the

inner world, it will increase the gap between us and our true Self.”

Mother stopped talking and asked the brahmacharis to sing. They sang *Sukhamenni Tirayunna...*

*You, who are searching
For happiness everywhere,
How will you find it
Without shedding your vanity?
Until the compassionate One,
The Mother of the Universe,
Shines within your heart
How can you be happy?*

*The mind
In which devotion towards Shakti,
The Supreme Power,
Is not alive
Is like a flower without fragrance.*

*Such a mind will be forced
To toss about in misery
Like a leaf
Tossed by the waves
Of the restless ocean.*

*Do not get caught in the talons
Of the vulture known as fate
Worship the Self in seclusion*

*Stop expecting the fruits
Of your actions
Worship the form of the Universal Self
In the blossom of your heart.*

DON'T BLAME THE CIRCUMSTANCES

When the song had come to an end, Mother continued to talk.

“The natural tendency in human beings is to find fault with the situations in life. We always complain about the circumstances, blaming the world for our sorrows, suffering and fear. This habit of ours to complain and find fault with the outside world, and the circumstances it creates, is due to our ignorance of our true nature, that we are the Self (Atman). The Atman is beyond all limitations, untouched by anything that happens to us, whether good or bad.

“A man was strolling in a mango grove. Suddenly a rotten mango fell with a splash on his bald head. His head was covered with the juice of rotten mango; it even trickled down his cheeks. The man was furious and began cursing the mango and the mango tree, and also the bird who had pecked it down; above all, he showered curses on the law of gravity itself! Wouldn't it be foolish to do such a thing? We would make a laughing stock of ourselves. But seen from a higher level of consciousness, this is exactly what we are doing.

“If we take the above example and think for a moment, we will find that the situation, in itself, clearly can’t be blamed. Wouldn’t it be absurd to curse the law of gravity? Or the tree and the bird? How is the law of gravity supposed to change? Whether rotten or not, a mango cannot fall upwards. It has to fall down because that is the law of nature. When mangoes are ripe they either fall from the tree of their own accord, or they are sometimes pecked down by a bird. No one, with even a little intelligence, would lay any blame for this. To view the situation in that way would clearly be wrong. Once we perceive this in a deeper, more subtle way, and learn to accept the situations in life, rather than fight against them, we will discover that life is extremely beautiful.

“Do not blame the circumstances and do not blame others. Remove your own weaknesses. Your failures and your hurt feelings, your fears and your troubles, are all due to some weakness within yourself, and this weakness is known as ignorance. You identify with your thoughts which are based on a total misconception.

“The following story will be helpful in understanding the illusory nature of the world. After having performed the *rajasuya yajna* (the royal festival of charity), the Pandavas invited their cousin, Duryodhana, and his brothers to stay at Indraprastha, the royal abode of the Pandavas, for a few more days, to which Duryodhana agreed. One day they were looking at the beau-

tiful palace, which had been very skillfully designed. In one of the halls the floor was so polished and transparent, it was made to look like a small lake with gleaming ripples on the surface. Duryodhana and his brothers were so deluded by this that they got undressed intending to swim across the lake. When Draupadi and Bhima saw this they laughed, because there was no lake or any water there.

“In another palace they thought the floor looked like any ordinary floor and began to walk on it without a moment’s hesitation. But that spot was, in fact, a lake, though it didn’t look like one. The brothers just walked out onto it and fell with a splash into the water. They were completely drenched. The whole place was so cleverly designed that Duryodhana and his brothers were totally deluded.

“This can be compared to the world. The entire world has been so fantastically designed and decorated by the Creator that, if we don’t move cautiously, we are easily deluded. Each step should be taken with alertness.

“Some places, situations and experiences may look normal, harmless and wonderful. But look carefully, be watchful, because what you see on the surface may be just a cover. The beauty and charm may be only skin deep; just behind that beautifully decorated cover great danger may be lurking.

“Another place, situation, or experience may seem dangerous. You may create a hue and a cry and take all sorts of precautions if you are forced to face it. But it could turn out to be something very normal, and even constructive. Such things happen in life. We are fooled and deceived more than a thousand times, and yet, we don’t learn our lesson. Even after countless deceptions, people continue to run after all sorts of things. This is the extraordinary power of *Maya*.

“The world is not the problem. The problem lies within ourselves. So be watchful, and you will see things with greater clarity. Watchfulness provides you with a penetrating eye and mind, so that you cannot be deceived. It will slowly take you closer to your true being, the bliss of the Atman.

“Bliss is our true nature, not sorrow. But something has happened to us. Everything has been turned upside down. Happiness has become a ‘strange’ mood while sorrow is considered to be natural.

“There is an old musician who frequently visits the Ashram. He is a very happy man, always laughing, telling jokes and moving freely with people. He is always joyful. When people see how happy he is, they accuse him of being mentally abnormal. Amma knows this son well. He is perfectly all right, a good-hearted soul. But his joy is strange to others. If somebody is happy, people immediately become suspicious. They

want to know why the person looks so happy, as if it were something unnatural. Only when we are sad are we believed to be 'normal.' That is why Amma says that everything has been turned upside down. What a pity! People, who are essentially joyful and harmonious, believe that happiness is unnatural, and that the only natural state is pain and sorrow."

As the darshan was coming to a close, the brahmacharis sang another song, *Asa Nasi Katora*. . .

*O mind,
You are a busy harbor of desires
Constantly buffeted by their flow.
Beware, do not drown
In the deep ocean of sorrow;
Do arati to the Atman instead;
Keep your attention focused on the Self.*

*Beware,
If you continue in this way
Without any real support,
You will fall in the end
And be full of remorse.*

*If you cherish Eternal Bliss,
If you covet Liberation,
Then meditate,
O mind, meditate on your Source.*

*Meditate on the inner Ocean of Bliss
Give up your demonic qualities
And follow the teachings of the Divine chants.*



CHAPTER TEN

A HEALING TOUCH

A young man was sitting on the verandah of the old temple, with his head resting between his knees. Mother happened to walk by, and when She saw him sitting there She went up to him. The young man, lost in thought, was not aware of Mother's presence. Mother lovingly tapped him on his shoulder saying, "Son." The man looked up and was startled to see the Holy Mother standing in front of him. There was a look of deep agony in his eyes. Mother smiled at him, gently tapped his chest and said, "Anger. . . anger is poison. You should control it." There was obvious shock on his face. He covered his face with his hands and started weeping. Mother looked at him and Her motherly affection overflowed. She gently put his head on Her shoulder and caressed him saying, "Son, don't worry! Everything will be all right. Amma will take care of everything."

The man had a very bad temper, and on that particular day he had had a big fight with his wife. Finally his parents interfered. They supported his wife knowing that she was an innocent victim of his frequent attacks. The interference of

his parents accelerated his anger. He shouted at them and behaved disrespectfully. This was not an isolated incident. Due to his uncontrollable anger such scenes were quite common in the house. He always regretted his mistake afterwards and ended up apologizing to his wife and parents. But again and again he found himself helplessly plunged into his terrible moods. Finally, after the incident on this particular day, his neighbors, who were devotees of Mother, advised him to go and meet Her. That is how he came to see Mother. Now he is a completely changed person. The same man who, because of his uncontrollable anger, was a terror to his family, is now a loving and caring husband, son and father. The whole family visits Amma to seek Amma's blessings at least once a week.

He said, "After that first touch of Mother's on my chest, I felt that something very heavy had been lifted away from my heart. That touch removed the poison of anger within me. Before this, my family life had been a nightmare. Now, by Mother's Grace, my home has been transformed into an abode of peace and happiness. My whole family has become Mother's devotees."

Countless similar incidents have happened around Mother. Millions of lives have been transformed by Her Grace. But though She is a great transformer of lives and a healer of hearts, Mother remains a wonderful example of utter humility and simplicity.

HOW TO OVERCOME FEAR

At about four o'clock in the evening, while everyone was sitting in front of the old temple, a young lawyer asked Mother a question. "Amma, fear seems to be taken for granted as being part of human existence. People are afraid of everything: their job, the security of the family, fear of others and of society. Man has created a whole world of fear around him. How could this happen? What causes it, and how can we overcome these fears, which gnaw away at all the beauty of life from within?"

Mother: "We again come back to ignorance. Ignorance about our true existence in God, or the Atman, is the cause of all sorts of fear. The outer life of a human being—whatever he does for the sake of his bodily existence—should be lived in concordance with his inner existence. There should be a perfect balance. If man gives more importance to his body, as he is doing now, and neglects his soul, he becomes worried and anxious, fervently clinging to false securities.

"There was a great Master who was worshipped by hundreds of thousands of people from all over the world. People were amazed at his purity, his innocence and the depth of his wisdom. He transformed many lives through the beauty of his teachings and the love and compassion he manifested. Out of curiosity his disciples and devotees used to ask him to

reveal the source of his knowledge and his purity. But the Master would only say to them, 'It's all contained in the book you will inherit when I leave this body.'

"One day the Master left his body. A few days later his disciples began to search for the book he had mentioned, and they found it. But there was only one page between the covers of the book and only a single sentence written on it. This is what it said: 'Dear ones, know the difference between the container and the content, and true knowledge will dawn within you, dispelling all fear and darkness.'

"Children, the secret lies in knowing that the body is the container, and that the content, the soul, is different from the container. The milk is different from the vessel in which it is contained. The vessel is not the milk, and the milk is not the vessel. Self-knowledge will eliminate all the unnecessary fears that grip our lives.

"As human beings we want food, clothing and shelter. This is understandable. These three things are the main concerns of our body, and we are anxious to make the body comfortable. But what is this body? Where does it come from? What is the power that manifests through this body, making you love it so much? Few consider this, and are concerned about it. People believe that the body is everything, that there is nothing beyond their bodily existence. This attitude makes

them extremely attached to the body and its security.

“Your attachment to the body causes fear concerning everything in your life. As your attachment to the body increases, the ego also increases, with the simultaneous increase of your fear. Attachment to the body makes you attached to the ego, because you believe that your body is the most precious thing you have. You want to protect it from anything that could harm it in any way. You think your bodily security is the only safety in existence. What a pity that is! We do not understand that the existence of the body depends on the soul.

“The nature of both body and soul needs to be properly understood. The body is constantly subject to change, whereas the soul is immutable. Without the immutable soul as its substratum, the mutable body could not exist. The ever changing body is perishing, whereas the changeless soul is imperishable. The imperishable soul is the life force; it is the taproot supporting the tree of the body.

“Our problem is that we give too much importance to the external, manifested body and completely ignore the unmanifested Self, the source of our existence. We may try to reason with ourselves saying, ‘I see only the body and not the soul, which is why I give so much importance to the body.

How can I believe in a soul that is invisible?" But this is like saying, 'I can only see the tree, so how am I to believe in the root which is invisible to my naked eye?' No person with even a little bit of intelligence would make such a statement.

"Say that you are looking out across an immense ocean. You are thrilled by what you see and you think, 'How wonderful that infinite ocean is! It is so inconceivably deep and vast.' But you can only see the surface—you cannot see the world that exists beneath the surface, nor can you see the underlying ground. Wouldn't it be unwise if you were to say that the world beneath the surface and the bottom of the ocean do not exist, just because they happen to be invisible from where you are standing? The very existence of the surface of the ocean is enough to prove the existence of the underlying ground. Without the substratum to support it, the sea could not exist. Even without the water, the ground exists.

"In order to see and experience the world beneath the ocean and its underlying ground, you have to go beneath the surface. You have to dive deep into the ocean. In a similar way, to realize the soul one has to go beyond the body and penetrate deep into one's own Self.

"Just as we feel a sense of amazement when we look at the vastness of the ocean in this way, if we could only feel the

same sense of awe and wonder when we look at all of nature and her infinite manifestations, we would never be skeptical about the inner life force existing as the one Substratum of the manifested world.

“Man’s fear is due to his ignorance about his own soul, the life force and substratum of his existence. He believes that he should worry only about his physical existence, that life is all about the body, and nothing else. This is his concept about life—indeed, his whole life is built around this misunderstanding. Once he gives all his attention to the body and the ego, the next step is his security. He builds a fortress of false securities around him. He clings to his house because that is a form of security; his job or business is another; his status in society is yet another; then comes his family and his countless possessions. He thinks that life consists of clinging to these external ‘securities,’ that without them, and without his body and ego, there is no existence. For him the whole of life can be put into two words: ‘body’ and ‘attachments.’ But it is not his fault; for, to him, existence is the same as the existence of the body, and for the sake of his body he needs all those false securities. Poor man, he has completely forgotten the inner life.

“Real life is developed from within. Real living means

that the soul expresses itself through all one's thoughts, words and actions. **A person becomes fearless once he understands the nature of the imperishable soul.**

"At this stage, however, he is only familiar with the perishable body, which makes him increasingly afraid and pushes him more and more towards death, which is his greatest fear.

"Death will grab everything, all that he has and that he claims as his own. Death is the greatest threat to a human being. Nobody wants to die. The very mention of death causes tremendous fear. But death is an experience like any other."

When Mother speaks, Her words take wing as if they were about to soar up, carrying the listener along with them. Her words and expressions never sound as if they are coming from a person, from an individual. They resonate as if emerging out of a deep cave, from an ancient, unknown source. Mother's words act as a vehicle that carries the listener to the deeper realms of the spiritual world.

Mother began to sing the song, *Marikkatta Manushyarundo...*

*Is there anyone who will not die?
Is there a moment when desire ends?
We are born on this earth
We are scorched by sorrow*

*And then we die
To be reborn again.*

*Though man learns to laugh
What greatness has he
If he is afraid of death?*

*Though born as a human being
What glory is there to a human life
If the fear of death doesn't leave?*

*Everything happens as decided by destiny
But who creates that destiny?
This world can never lead to happiness,
Once we realize this truth
We will renounce everything.*



CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE ALL-KNOWING MOTHER

It was almost midnight. Mother was strolling in the coconut grove in front of the Ashram. At times She stopped and stood facing east as if She was waiting for someone to arrive. Bri. Gayatri and the senior brahmacharis suggested several times that Mother go to bed. But Mother politely refused and stayed in the coconut grove. A few minutes past twelve a large family arrived at the Ashram. The entire family were overjoyed when they saw Mother standing in the coconut grove. Mother called them, and having expressed Her love and affection towards them in Her unique motherly way, she began talking to them. The Ashram residents now understood why Mother had remained in the coconut grove and hadn't wanted to go to Her room.

The family had left Quilon at eight o'clock in the evening, hoping they would see Mother if they reached the Ashram by nine, but their car had broken down on the way. By the time a mechanic was found and the car had been repaired, it was very late. They decided to return to Quilon and to visit Mother another day.

But their five year old son was extremely disappointed and repeatedly told them he wanted to see Mother that night. He was so insistent that, finally, the family yielded to his wish and continued driving to the Ashram. They never thought they would be able to see Mother at such a late hour of the night. Their only desire was to spend a few minutes in the Ashram atmosphere and then return to Quilon. But to their great surprise, as they arrived they saw Mother standing in front of the Ashram as if She were expecting them.

The family had some serious problems. Their aching hearts found much relief by just seeing Mother. The most compassionate Mother talked to them for more than two hours.

At four-thirty in the morning Mother had just taken a bath and was again walking outside. She looked fresh and radiant. One of the brahmacharis approached Mother and begged Her, “Amma, why don’t You go and rest for some time? Today is a Devi Bhava day, so You won’t get any rest tonight either.”

“Son,” Mother replied, “one shouldn’t sleep while the *Archana* is being performed. That would be setting a bad example. During the morning *Archana* the whole Ashram should be awake and vibrant with the spiritual energy that is created by the chanting. There shouldn’t be any tamasic energy present at that time.”

The brahmachari said, “But Amma, You are beyond everything. You are Devi Herself. You are completely detached and untouched by everything.”

Mother replied, “Son, if Amma is not up at this time, you won’t be either. It would cause discipline problems in the Ashram, and everyone would do whatever they felt like doing. Unless Amma sets an example by practicing what is being preached, nobody will feel inspired to follow the rules.”

“But, Amma, if Your body doesn’t get any rest, won’t Your health suffer?” asked the brahmachari. “You are sacrificing everything for the sake of others. Amma, what can we, Your children, do for You?” The brahmachari was almost in tears as he spoke.

Mother patted him affectionately on the back and said, “Don’t worry about Amma.” Pointing at Her own body, She said, “This will take care of itself. Amma has not come to the world to protect Her body. Amma doesn’t care what happens to the body—let it take its natural course. Amma wants to sacrifice everything for the uplift of Her children, and for the benefit of the world. You should strictly follow your daily routine and try to be free from the grip of the ego. That is enough. Son, everything about this body and its existence in the world is decided by Amma. There is a purpose to fulfill. Only when that has been achieved will this body go.”

Mother uttered the last three sentences as if She were talking from another world. For some time, the brahmachari just stood there and gazed at the indescribable phenomenon that is Mother; and then he proceeded to the meditation hall where the morning Archana was about to begin.



CHAPTER TWELVE

DEATH IS ONLY A CHANGE

Mother was sitting with a few brahmacharis beside the moonlit backwaters. The moon and the stars were strewn like jewels across the blue-black sky.

A brahmachari asked Mother a question. “Amma, what causes the pain and the fear of death?”

Mother: “The pain of death is caused by the thought that death is going to destroy everything you have, all that you are attached to and all that you cling to. That clinging causes the pain. If only you can let go of all your attachments, then the pain of death will turn into an experience of bliss. In death you lose everything that you claim to be yours. All that is dear and wonderful to you, your family, the love and the laughter of your near and dear ones, this beautiful world with all its precious treasures—everything is going to dissolve and disappear. Just the thought of it shakes your entire being. You want to forget about death because you are afraid that you will enter oblivion and won’t exist anymore. It kills your enthusiasm and makes you numb with dread, so you don’t want to think about it at all.”

Question: “Amma, I have heard You say that death is an experience, like any other. What do you mean by this?”

Mother: “Birth and death are two inevitable experiences. Once you go beyond death you also go beyond birth. A person who can see birth and death as being perfectly natural, just like any other experience in life, will be able to lead a happy and blissful life. He sees the whole of life with all its experiences, both good and bad, as being a play. He won’t complain about anything; he cannot find fault with anyone or any situation. Such people will always have a genuine smile on their face, even while confronting the worst situations in life. The words and deeds of others cannot hurt them or make them angry. Being established in a relaxed and composed mood, they enjoy life with the wonder and innocence of a child.

“Just like other joyful moments of life, death can also be a joyful experience. People normally rejoice when a child is born, but they weep when death occurs. Both birth and death are two normal transitions. But this can be known only when one goes beyond the ego and realizes the Self.

“When a child is born a transition takes place. It doesn’t stop there. The child grows; he or she passes through several stages, or passages, of life. The body is transformed from that of a child to a teenager, to a young adult, and then comes

middle age and finally old age. The process of transformation continues. Death occurs which is another transformation. This is normal; there is nothing wrong with it. You should learn to see death as a normal transformation just like other changes of the body. Birth is not the beginning of life, nor is death the end. The beginning and end are only relative.

“When a child is born, we think it is the very beginning of life. But life, itself, is neither first nor last, new or old; it never began, nor does it ever end. Life is another name for God. Life, when conditioned by the body, is known as the *jivatman*, and when that same life is devoid of all conditions it is the *Paramatman*. So life is another name for the Atman, or Brahman. Life is without beginning and without end.

“A new birth is therefore not the beginning of existence. You could call it a fresh start, or yet another chance to continue the onward journey towards the real Source of existence. Being born is like the return of the same contents in a different package.

“Death is not complete annihilation. It is a pause. It is like pressing the pause button on a tape recorder in the middle of a song. Sooner or later, when pressed again, the pause button is released and the song continues. Death is only a period of preparation before the start of another life. You unpack your

content only to re-pack it in a fresh new package, in which the ingredients will be the same.

“Life and death are the two major events in life, two intense experiences. Once you realize that birth and death are neither the beginning nor the end, life becomes infinitely beautiful and blissful.

“Experiences keep on changing, but the inner ‘Experiencer’—the Self, God, or Life, is immutable. This is the truth which needs to be realized. The Experiencer, that is, the Substratum of all experiences, even that of birth and death, is always the same—it is imperishable and immutable. The Experiencer takes you through all your experiences. This is the truth which cannot be altered by time or space.

“Birth and death are only relative. They are not real from the ultimate viewpoint. Like any experience in life, they are two events that a person is bound to go through. But they are by far the most intense experiences we go through. Because of their intensity, nature had devised a method by which man completely forgets these two major moments of his life. Because of the intensity of these experiences, it is difficult for an ordinary person to remain aware during his own birth and death. Birth and death are two stages of life in which one is utterly helpless. While in the womb and while emerging out of the womb, the child is helpless. It is the same with a dying

person. During both these experiences the ego has receded so far into the background, that it is powerless. Children, you are not aware of what is happening to you during or after death. You have to be fearless and fully aware to be open to the experience. If you are afraid you will be closed to the experience. Only those who have enough depth, who are fearless, and who are constantly in a state of awareness, a state of absolute wakefulness, are able to consciously experience the bliss of death.

“Suppose you have an intense stomach ache. You are then aware of the pain. If water is hot or cold, the body immediately feels it. The sorrow caused by your father’s death, or the joy felt when a child is born, is experienced directly by the mind. Also, your intellect immediately reacts to the praise or insults showered upon you by others. Such a direct experience of the mind is not available during birth and death. This is the reason why we don’t consider birth and death to be ordinary experiences.

“Of course, if you have the capacity to remain conscious and alert while passing through the experience of death, it becomes an ordinary experience like other experiences. Then birth and death do not bother you; you simply smile during both occasions. Death is then no longer a strange experience to you. However, this is possible only if you are at one with your true Self.”

Question: “Amma, what is the reason for this absence of direct experience during birth and death?”

Mother: “Lack of awareness is the reason. Our level of awareness is very low. Due to our unwise attachments to the world, which is due to our wrong understanding, we are leading an almost unconscious life, even though we are moving and breathing.

“Once all these attachments are dropped, death will turn out to be a blissful experience. As a result of the realization that you are not the body, but the Supreme Consciousness, the whole center of your existence will be shifted to the Self. You will wake up and realize that you were sleeping, and that the dream that is this world, and all the experiences associated with it, is only a play. You will laugh as you look at this exquisite play of consciousness. You will laugh at all the colors. Just as a child, who is looking at the different colors of a rainbow, laughs and enjoys it with wonder in his eyes, so you will find yourself laughing with joy, and you will continue to laugh, even at the face of death, because death is just another play of colors, a different nuance in the rainbow of life.

“Once you attain this state, all experiences such as happiness and sorrow, insult and praise, heat and cold, birth and death, pass right through you. You remain beyond it all, as

the ‘Experiencer,’ the very substratum of all experience, witnessing everything like a playful child.

“Children, learn to do everything consciously. Not even a single breath should escape without you being aware of it. Be conscious of your every movement. This will slowly make you fully aware, even of death.

“To attain the state of complete oneness with the Supreme, one has to lose oneself. This, however, is our greatest fear: that we will lose ourselves. For to lose oneself would be a form of dying, and who wants to die? Everyone wants to live. But in order to live life fully, we must learn to love life at its very essence, and to let go of everything else. Learn to embrace life with open arms as you let go of your attachments. Let go of all that you cling to, all your regrets, all your fears and anxieties. But this letting go is not a loss at all, it is the biggest gain there is. It brings the entire universe to you, and you become God.”



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

GIVING INSIGHT TO THE BLIND

A young man who had been blind since birth was staying at the Ashram. Ever since he came, the brahmacharis had been looking after him, taking care of all his needs. They served him food and even assisted him when he had to do his nature calls.

Today, more people than expected came for Mother's darshan. Because of this, the rice and curry that had been cooked for lunch finished very soon, before everyone had eaten. A second round of cooking was underway. Due to the workload, the brahmacharis forgot to fetch the blind man from his room for lunch. As soon as they realized their mistake, one of the brahmacharis rushed to the man's room to fetch him. But the blind man was already coming down the steps with the help of a devotee. The brahmachari apologized and explained what had happened saying, "Kindly forgive me. I was so busy serving in the dining hall that I forgot to come and fetch you."

But the blind man was not appeased. He was feeling hurt and unhappy. "I have money with me," he said. "I can al-

ways get food from somewhere outside the Ashram if I pay for it.” With these words he returned to his room with the help of the devotee.

Even though the man was upset, the brahmachari ignored it, thinking that he had only reacted because he was hungry. The brahmachari soon returned with some fruits which he placed in front of the young man. He said to him, “Lunch will be ready in a few minutes. I will bring your food. In the mean time, please eat these fruits.” But the man was still angry and bluntly rejected the fruits that were offered to him.

Somehow the news reached Mother, and shortly thereafter, she entered the blind man’s room. Looking sternly at the brahmachari, Mother said, “What sort of shraddha do you have? Why didn’t you serve him his lunch at the right time? Don’t you know that this son is blind and that he cannot come down by himself? If you thought it would take too much time to fetch him, you should have brought a plate to his room. If you don’t feel compassion towards those who are helpless, like this son, what is the point of doing spiritual practices?

“Children, don’t miss a single opportunity you get to serve others. Nobody should have to wait patiently to receive our help according to our own convenience. In offices and other work places, people do their duty according to the schedule.

They get remuneration for the work they do, which is why they work. But a *sadhak*'s (spiritual aspirant's) whole life is dedicated to serving others. The reward is not received in terms of a monthly salary. You receive your reward in the form of mental purity and God's Grace. Because you are not getting any immediate remuneration, you shouldn't feel that it is any less important or that your work can be postponed a little. Every opportunity to serve others must be utilized to the maximum, and the work should be done with utmost love and diligence. Only then does it become real worship. True service is to assist those who are helpless, and to make the effort to understand their needs and their feelings."

Mother stroked the blind man's back and asked him, "Son, were you sad? The brahmacharis were very busy in the dining hall; that is why they couldn't fetch you at the right time. Also, the brahmachari who usually helps you is not here today. He entrusted the job to another brahmachari, who is in charge of serving the food in the dining hall. Don't think it was done on purpose. Son, you should learn to be more flexible and adapt to the circumstances wherever you are. Patience is needed in an ashram. As long as you are here, you should be prepared to make a little sacrifice now and then. In that way you will receive God's Grace.

"Son, your blindness is not really a problem. Remember

that you are closer to God, to your true Self, than most people with external eyes. It is true that you cannot see the world, but you can feel God more than a person with normal eyesight, provided you have the right understanding and shraddha. A person with external eyes moves far away from God, from his true nature, the Atman, because he travels too much through the world of objects. So, don't think you are unlucky. Learn to adjust to life. Have more forbearance and patience. That will certainly help you experience God's presence, both within and without. Son, there are millions of people who are plunged into utter sorrow and despair, even though they have eyes with which to see the world. But there are also people who are happy and contented, even though they cannot see. Surdas, the great devotee of Lord Krishna, had no eyesight; but he led a totally contented life, because he was wise enough to understand the essential principle of life. Through his love and devotion to the Lord, he developed the inner eye, which made him completely blissful, even without his external eyes."

The young man shed tears as he listened to Mother's words. He sobbed like a small child. The brahmacharis and some of the devotees present couldn't control their tears either. Such was the intense love animating Mother's words.

Affectionately rubbing the young man's back and wip-

ing away his tears with her hands, Mother inquired, “Son, did you eat anything?” He shook his head and said with a choked voice, “But I am satisfied just by Your presence and by listening to Your words. I don’t feel hungry at all anymore. My heart is so full with the joy of Your nectarous words.”

Mother asked the brahmachari to bring him a plate of food. When he came back with a plate filled with rice and curry, Mother made the blind man sit down next to Her, and She began feeding him with her own hands. Mother fed him with balls of rice, just like a mother would feed her small child, patiently waiting for him as he slowly swallowed the food. In this way, She fed him the entire plate of rice. Those who witnessed this scene were deeply moved as they beheld the pure, divine love that was flowing out of Mother. Softly, everyone began to sing *Kannilengillum*. . .

*Today I have seen my darling Krishna,
The Beloved of Radha,
Not with these eyes
But with the inner eye.*

*I have seen the Stealer of the mind,
Beauty personified,
The Divine Musician;
I have seen my Lord of Oneness.*

*Was He as blue as the ocean?
Did He have a peacock feather
Adorning His curly locks?
I cannot say
But I have seen His gracious form
Through the sound of His Flute.*



GLOSSARY

ARATI: The ritual in which a light is offered, in the form of burning camphor, and a bell is rung, before a holy person or the deity in a temple, at the conclusion of puja (worship). The camphor does not leave behind any residue, which symbolises the total annihilation of the ego.

ARCHANA: A form of worship in which the 108 or 1000 names of a deity is chanted.

ARJUNA: The third of the five Pandava brothers. A great archer who is one of the heroes of the Mahabharata. He was Krishna's friend and disciple. It is Arjuna whom Krishna is addressing in the Bhagavad Gita.

ATMAN: The true Self. One of the fundamental tenets of the Sanatana Dharma (Hinduism) is that we are not the physical body, feelings, mind, intellect, or personality. We are the eternal, pure, unblemishable Self.

AUM: Sacred syllable. The primordial sound or vibration which represents Brahman and the entire creation. Aum is the primary mantra and is often found at the beginning of other mantras.

BHAJAN: Devotional song or hymn.

BHAVA SAMADHI: Complete absorption of the mind into God through devotion.

BRAHMA: The aspect of God associated with the creation of the universe.

BRAHMACHARI(NI): A celibate disciple, who practices spiritual disciplines and is being trained by a Guru.

BRAHMAN: The Absolute Reality; the Whole; the Supreme Being beyond all names and forms, which encompasses and pervades everything, which is One and indivisible.

DARSHAN: An audience with, or a vision of, a deity or a holy person.

DEVI: The Goddess.

DEVI MAHATMYAM: An ancient hymn in praise of the Divine Mother.

DHARMA: "That which upholds the universe." Dharma has many meanings, including, the Divine Law, the law of existence, in accordance with divine harmony, righteousness, religion, duty, responsibility, virtue, justice, goodness and truth. Dharma signifies the inner principles of religion. The dharma of man is to realize his innate Divinity.

GURUKULA: A Guru's ashram cum school where students gain a foundation in spiritual and worldly knowledge through study and service.

JIVATMAN: The individual soul.

KALI: An aspect of the Divine Mother. From the viewpoint of the ego, she may seem frightening because she destroys the ego; but she destroys the ego and transforms us only out of her immeasurable compassion. A devotee knows that behind her fierce facade, the loving Mother is to be found, who protects Her children and bestows the Grace of Liberation.

KAMSA: Lord Krishna's demonic uncle whom he killed.

KANNA: "He who has beautiful eyes." A nickname for the baby Krishna. Krishna is sometimes worshipped as the Divine Child.

KESAVA: "He who has long, beautiful hair." One of Krishna's names.

KIRTAN: Hymn.

KRISHNA: The principal incarnation of Vishnu. He was born into a royal family, but grew up with foster parents and lived as a young cowherd in Vrindavan, where he was loved and worshipped by his devoted companions, the gopis and gopas. He was a cousin and adviser of the Pandavas, especially Arjuna, to whom he revealed his teachings in the Bhagavad Gita.

LEELA: "Play." The movements and activities of the Divine, which by nature are free and not subject to any law.

MADHAVA: "He who is sweet as honey." One of Krishna's names.

MAHABHARATA: An epic of ancient India, written by the sage Vyasa, about the family feud between the Pandavas and the Kauravas, both cousins of Lord Krishna, which culminated in a catastrophic war.

MAHATMA: Great Soul or Sage.

MANTRA: Sacred formula or prayer which is constantly repeated. This awakens one's dormant spiritual powers, purifies the mind and helps one to reach the goal. It is most effective if received from a Master during initiation.

MAYA: "Illusion." The divine "veil" with which God, in his play of creation, conceals himself and gives the impression of the many, thereby creating the illusion of separation. As Maya veils Reality she deludes us, making us believe that perfection and contentment is to be found outside ourselves.

MOKSHA: Liberation. Release from the cycle of birth and death.

MUDRA: Sacred hand sign or gesture which represents mystic truths.

NARAYANEYAM: The story of Lord Krishna's life written by the great devotee, Narayana Bhattatiri of Kerala.

PADA PUJA: The worship of God's, the Guru's or a saint's feet. As the feet support the body, the Guru Principle supports the Supreme Truth. The Guru's feet thus represent the Supreme Truth.

PANDAVAS: The five sons of King Pandu and heroes of the epic Mahabharata.

PARAMATMAN: The Supreme Soul or God.

POOTANA: A female demon who tried to kill the baby Krishna by feeding him at her poisonous breast. But it was she who died instead, as the Divine Infant sucked the life force out of her.

PRASAD(AM): Consecrated offerings distributed at the end of worship.

PURNAM: Complete or perfect.

RAJASUYA YAGNA: A Vedic sacrifice performed by kings.

RAMA: The Divine hero in the epic, Ramayana. An incarnation of Vishnu, he is considered to be the ideal of righteousness.

RAMAYANA: "The life of Rama." One of India's greatest epic poems, depicting the life of Rama, written by the sage, Valmiki. Rama was an incarnation of Vishnu.

RISHIS: (Rsi = to know) Self-Realised Seer. Usually refers to the seven Rishis of ancient India, i.e. Self-Realised souls who could "see" the Supreme Truth and expressed this insight through the composition of the Vedas.

SADHAK: A spiritual aspirant.

SADHANA: Spiritual practice.

SAMADHI: (Sam = with; adhi = the Lord. Oneness with God) A state of deep, one-pointed concentration, in

which all thoughts subside, the mind enters into a complete stillness where only Pure Consciousness remains as one abides in the Atman (Self).

SANKALPA: A creative, integral resolve. The sankalpa of a Perfect Being inevitably manifests its aimed result.

SANNYASI(NI): One who has taken formal vows of renunciation. A sannyasi traditionally wears an ochre coloured cloth representing the burning away of all attachment.

SATGURU: A God-Realised spiritual Master.

SHAKTI: The Universal Mother; the dynamic aspect of Brahman.

SHANTI: Peace

SHIVA: "The Auspicious One; the Gracious One; the Good One." A form of the Supreme Being. The masculine Principle; the static aspect of Brahman. Shiva is also the aspect of the Trinity associated with the destruction of the universe, the destruction of that which is not Real.

SHRADDHA: Care, attentiveness, faith.

SISHYA: Disciple

SITA: Rama's consort. In India she is considered to be the ideal woman.

SLOKA: Verse

SRIMAD BHAGAVATAM: One of 18 scriptures known as the Puranas, dealing with the Avatars of Vishnu; especially, and in great detail, the life of Krishna, including his childhood. It emphasises the position of devotion.

TAPAS: "Heat." Self-discipline, penance and self-sacrifice; spiritual practices which burn up the impurities of the mind.

UDDHAVA GITA: A discourse between Lord Krishna and His great devotee, Uddhava. This occurs in the Srimad Bhagavatam.

VASANAS: (From “vas” = living, remaining) Vasanas are the latent tendencies or subtle desires within the mind, which have a tendency to manifest into action and habits. Vasanas are the collected results of the impressions of experiences (samskaras) which exist in the subconscious.

VEDANTA: “Veda-end.” The philosophy of the Upanishads, the concluding part of the Vedas. Holds the ultimate Truth to be “One and indivisible.”

VEDAS: “Knowledge, Wisdom.” The ancient, sacred scriptures of Hinduism. A collection of holy texts which are classified into four parts: Rig, Yajur, Sama and Atharva. Altogether the Vedas consist of 100 000 verses, as well as additional prose. The oldest part was composed about 6000 BC, and was written down in Sanskrit between 2000 and 500 BC. They are among the world’s oldest scriptures. The Vedas are considered to be the direct revelation of the Supreme Truth which God bestowed upon the Rishis.

VISHNU: “The All-Pervading.” A name of God. He descends upon the earth as a divine incarnation when the world is in most need of his Grace. He is usually worshipped in the form of two of his incarnations, Krishna and Rama. Vishnu also represents the aspect of the Trinity associated with the preservation of the universe.

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Though Mother's 1987 world tour lasted for three months, I have omitted mentioning many of the details of the tour in this book. I have instead chosen to focus mainly on Mother's dialogues and a few events that I thought would be of most interest to the reader. A more comprehensive version of Mother's tour, including the devotees' and my own experiences, will be published at a later date.

Swami Amritaswarupananda

ॐ श्री मात्रे नमः

AWAKEN, CHILDREN!

Volume 9

INTRODUCTION

The year 1987 marked a turning point in Mother's mission of spreading Her message of love, compassion, and peace to mankind. The time had come for Mother to go out and gather all Her children, who were waiting for Her all over the world, into Her fold. A few of Mother's American devotees, led by Brahmachari Nealu's brother, Earl Rosner, invited Her to the United States. They had cherished this desire for a long time, and were thrilled with joy when Mother finally accepted. It was decided that She would spend a few days in Singapore, two months in America, and one month in Europe.

One may wonder why Mother travels when She has the power to bless anyone anywhere on the planet, without going anywhere. She simply does it for the benefit of humanity. Just as spring arrives, bringing new life, freshness, and color to the world; and a cool rain brings life to the parched plants and trees after a drought, a true master like Mother arrives in different places, bringing love, hope, and renewal to all of humanity.

Mother sent two of Her children, Br. Nealu and Br. Amritatma Chaitanya,¹ to America, three months in advance, to help prepare the ground for Her tour. An American woman, Gretchen MacGregor, was also going to help with the organization.

Having arrived in the United States, the little group traveled all over the country in an old battered Volkswagen van which had been lent to them by a devotee, and which was clearly on its last leg. They were eager to let people know about Mother, but, at the same time, it was

¹ A few years later when they received sannyas initiation, Brahmachari Amritatma Chaitanya was given the name, Swami Amritaswarupananda, and Brahmachari Nealu was given the name, Swami Paramatmananda. All of Mother's brahmacharis and brahmacharinis who have received sannyas initiation have the name Puri added at the end of their names (for example, Swami Amritaswarupananda Puri), indicating which of the ten branches of the Order they belong to. Other names of disciples which have changed since 1987 are indicated within parenthesis.

difficult for them to be without Her for so long. Especially Br. Amritatma suffered greatly from the separation.

Day in and day out they drove across the country, stopping in different cities along the way to give *satsang* (speeches) and to organize Mother's tour. For weeks the old van was their home, in which they slept, cooked, and did their daily spiritual practices. It was a powerful experience, which taught them that Mother is always present, and it helped them to constantly remember Her.

Miraculously, the old van ran smoothly all the way from California to Wisconsin, without the slightest mishap. But on the very day they arrived in Madison, which they had originally decided was to be the van's final destination, it finally broke down, right outside the house where they were going to stay! What else but Mother's grace had brought Her children all the way there?

As they continued to travel throughout the States, they constantly experienced Mother's love and protection, sometimes in the most remarkable ways. They felt Her guiding Hand at every step that She was taking care of everything behind the scenes. Everything they needed for the tour—volunteers to help with the work, financial assistance, suitable halls where Mother could give darshan, etc.—somehow appeared at the last moment.

It should be mentioned here that the brahmacharis were amazed at and deeply touched by the tremendous enthusiasm and kindness of a few individuals, most of whom had not yet met Mother, but were longing to see Her—people like Steve and Kathy Schmidt, Earl and Judy Rosner, David and Barbara Lawrence, Michael and Mary Price, Steve and Marilyn Fleisher, Dennis and Bhakti Guest, Phyllis Castle, George Brunswig, Susan Cappadocia (Rajita), and Ron Gottsegen. Their generosity helped to make the tour possible.

As they traveled, they met hundreds of people along the way, many of whom were so deeply moved by just hearing about Mother, seeing a picture of Her, or listening to recordings of Her singing bhajans, that they knew they belonged to Mother without even having met Her. Some people even had dreams and visions of Mother before they ever heard of Her.

Mother had begun calling Her flock of Western children....

On May 15, 1987, Mother left Vallickavu. The whole ashram was plunged into a state of despair. The scene was reminiscent of when Krishna left Vrindavan 5000 years ago. Mother's brahmacharis and brahmacharinis were so deeply attached to Her that at the airport, where

they had come to see Her off, some of them collapsed as She walked into the building.² Br. Pai (Swami Amritamayanda), who had to stay behind and look after the ashram, burst into tears. His grief was so unbearable that he fainted.

Just before Mother walked into the building, She touched Her folded hands to Her forehead and bowed to Her children. As everyone responded by bowing back to Her, She said: “My children, Amma needs all your blessings and prayers for the success of this tour. It is for the benefit of all the crying souls out there that Amma is traveling like this. Those who live in other countries are also Amma’s children. Amma can hear their prayers and their yearning. It is to soothe their pain, to alleviate their sorrow, and to show them the eternal light that Amma goes abroad. How can Amma not respond when Her children are calling Her from deep within their hearts? Amma will come back to you soon. But in reality, She is not going anywhere. Children, remember that Amma is always with you. Love one another, serve others selflessly, and don’t ever forget to do your spiritual practices.”

Mother sought their prayers and blessings only because She wanted to set an example of humility. The *Bhagavad Gita* says, “Whatever is adhered to by great people will be followed by the common masses.” Why, otherwise, would Mother ask for such a thing when She Herself has the power to bless all of creation?

When Mother had finished speaking, She stood quietly for a moment. With infinite tenderness, She let Her gaze wander, resting briefly on each of Her children, and then She turned and walked away. As Mother disappeared through the glass doors, everyone called out, “Amma! Amma!” Some of the brahmacharis and brahmacharinis rushed madly towards the doors crying out Her name.

When Br. Amritatma was later told about this, he said: “This proves that Krishna and the gopis really existed. The love of the gopis for Krishna is not a fairy tale, but a true story. Mother is Krishna who has stolen our hearts and made us all mad with love for Her.”

On May 18, 1987, Mother arrived in the United States, where She visited the following places: the Bay Area, Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz (May 18-26), Carmel (May 27), Seattle (May 28-June 1), Berkeley (June 2), Garberville (June 3), Mt. Shasta (June 4-7), Santa Fe and Taos (June 8-14), Boulder (June 15-18), Taos (June 19-21), Chicago and Madison (June 22-29),

² At the airports in Kerala, only passengers are allowed to enter the airport building.

Charleston (July 1), Pittsburgh (July 2), Cambridge and Boston (July 4-9), New York City and Stamford (July 10-14).

On July 15, Mother arrived in Paris and Her European tour began. In Europe Mother visited the following places: Dourdon and Paris, France (July 16-18), Zurich, Switzerland (July 19-21), Schweibenalp, Switzerland (July 21-31), Graz and St. Polten, Austria (August 1-12).



Through this book, the ninth volume of *Awaken, Children!*, Mother's call to Her children continues. And it will continue until we respond from deep within. The response must come because Mother's words are not mere words, but the expression of Supreme Love, the call of the absolute Truth. That call will therefore sooner or later touch and awaken the innocent, slumbering child within us. Mother, the Supreme Master, will then slowly lead us to *moksha*, the ultimate goal of life—a state of liberation from all bondage; from all pain and suffering—a state of infinite joy, bliss, and fulfillment.

Swami Amritaswarupananda

Amritapuri

April, 1998

MOTHER ARRIVES IN THE UNITED STATES

San Francisco

Mother was about to arrive. A group of about fifty people had come to receive Her at the San Francisco International Airport. Most of them had never met Mother before. As they waited, eager for their first glimpse of Her, the TV monitors announced that the flight from Singapore had just arrived. It was 3:40 in the afternoon. Everyone's gaze was fixed on the exit doors where the arriving passengers were coming out. In their excitement, those who were waiting were getting increasingly restless as they tried to catch sight of Her through the doors that kept opening and closing. Finally, as the doors opened, they caught a glimpse of Mother standing next to Brahmacharini Gayatri. "There She is!" everyone shouted at the same time. Br. Amritatma also saw Mother. His eyes were filled with tears. He tried his best to control himself, but the more he tried, the more he failed.

At last, after a long wait, Mother came out into the welcoming lobby with a beaming smile on Her face, and with Her palms joined together in greeting. A devotee garlanded Mother and, as Mother approached, everyone prostrated spontaneously before Her. At the mere sight of Her, many people broke into tears; but at the same time, their faces were lit up with joyous smiles. They could sense Mother's infinite compassion by just looking at Her.

As Mother walked past Amritatma, She smiled at him, giving him a look so loving and so intense that it penetrated his soul, filling him with joy and peace.

Amritatma was extremely glad to see his spiritual brothers. With great warmth, they embraced each other, exchanging a few words of love and concern. He also greeted his spiritual sisters, Gayatri (Swamini Amritaprana) and Saumya (Swamini Krishnamritaprana), and inquired about their well-being.

Apart from Gayatri, Saumya, and the brahmacharis, there were three other devotees traveling with Mother: Mr. Gangadharan Vaidyar, an ayurvedic doctor, his wife, and Mr. Chandradas who hailed from northern Kerala. They felt very fortunate to be able to accompany Mother on Her first world tour.

After a short reunion and some light conversation with everyone, Amritatma joined Mother, who was being led by the devotees to a van which was waiting outside. But before Mother reached the door, She suddenly turned right, went up to a chair, and sat down.

AIRPORT DARSHAN

As Mother sat down, She looked at all the people who had come to meet Her and were now gathering around Her. She smiled at them with great affection, stretched out Her arms towards them, and said in English, “Come, my children!”

Amritatma thought, “O my God! Is She going to give darshan to everyone?” He bent down and whispered to Mother, “Amma, we’re still at the airport! Isn’t it enough if you give darshan tomorrow at the house?”

Seeing the worried look on his face, Mother smiled reassuringly and said, “No. What’s the problem with here and now?”

“But Amma,” he protested, “this is an airport! The airport officials are watching us. They may wonder what strange things we are doing.” But there was already someone kneeling in front of Mother, being enfolded by Her warm, motherly embrace. Mother had started giving darshan. That is simply what Mother is like. How could She, who is the Mother of all, do otherwise?

One after the other, they all went up to Mother and were embraced by Her, and then they sat down on the floor around Her, gazing at this phenomenal wonder before them. They seemed filled with the peace and love that Mother so clearly radiated.

Seeing this unusual event taking place in the middle of the airport, a few policemen and some others came up and watched the scene for a few minutes.

Nowadays, such scenes occur at every airport in the cities where Mother gives darshan. In 1987, when Mother first arrived in America, there was only a small group of people waiting to receive Her. But now, when this book is being written, whenever Mother arrives and departs at any airport in the world, a large crowd is there to see Her.

Many interesting incidents take place at the airports when Mother is traveling. While boarding and getting off the plane, or while waiting in the passenger lounge, Mother receives Her children with open arms, expressing Her love by hugging and kissing them.

About Her hugs and kisses, Mother says: “Amma’s hugs and kisses should not be considered ordinary. When Amma embraces or kisses someone, a process of purification and inner healing takes place. Amma is transmitting a part of Her pure vital energy into Her children. It also allows them to experience true, unconditional love. When Amma holds someone it can help to awaken the dormant spiritual energy within them, which will eventually take them to the ultimate goal of Self-realization.”

It has happened many times that Mother has grabbed hold of a pilot, air-hostess, air-steward, or passenger who happened to pass by, and has expressed Her all-embracing love by giving them a hug and a kiss. Surprising as it may seem, when this happens the person never protests or shows any negative reaction. On the contrary, without exception, they spontaneously open up to Mother's love. Usually, Mother has taken hold of them and embraced them before they even know what has happened. The receptivity of the strangers, who unexpectedly receive Mother's darshan in this way, reminds one of Her saying, "True love cannot be rejected. You can only receive it with an open heart. When a child smiles, whether it is the child of your friend or foe, you cannot help but smile back because the child's love is so pure and innocent. Pure love is like a beautiful flower with an irresistible fragrance."

In July 1995, when Mother was proceeding to Europe after the American leg of Her tour, an amusing incident occurred. Before going through the passport control, Mother, as usual, sat down on a chair ready to receive the hundreds of devotees who had come to see Her off. Mother was completely surrounded by Her children, who all sat down on the floor around Her, wanting to be as close to Her as possible. Some of the passengers moved away from their seats when they saw the crowd gathering around Mother. An elderly gentleman, who was sitting on a chair, absorbed in a newspaper, wasn't fast enough to move. Before he realized what was happening, Mother was sitting on the chair next to him, and the devotees were swarming around Her, not leaving an inch of space for him to stand up and move.

The poor man looked alarmed and bewildered. What was he to do? He had no choice but to stay where he was and continue to read his newspaper. He buried his face in the paper and tried to cover his head as much as he could with the large open sheets. But for how long could he keep this up? Mother was now giving darshan to everyone. With heavy hearts, and with their eyes filled with the tears of impending separation, the devotees began to sing:

*Take me away
 Won't You carry me
 Let me rest in Your arms for a while
 Take me away
 Won't You carry me
 Let me bathe in the sweetness of Your smile*

Mother, take me away

Take me away

Now, the poor old man grew even more restless. Despite people's tears, there was intermittent laughter as Mother joked with someone or played with a child. The man sat as if imprisoned. But, try as he may, he simply couldn't continue to ignore the great celebration of love that was taking place next to him. Every now and then his curiosity gave way, and he would discretely peep out from behind his newspaper. Mother's irresistible attraction had begun to work on him.

To begin with, he glanced at Mother every thirty seconds or so. But gradually, the intervals were reduced to just a few seconds. Finally, he was so captured by the sight that he threw his paper aside and stared at Mother. A few moments later, to everyone's amusement, he asked Mother, "Can I also have a hug? It looks so wonderful and soothing!" Before Mother had time to respond, he fell on Mother's shoulder and was seen in the fold of Her affectionate embrace. Everyone laughed so much at this that all the passengers who were waiting nearby turned around and stared at them.

For a few moments during this incident, Mother's children managed to forget that She was about to leave, and that they would have to wait a whole year for Her return.

A MEMORABLE FIRST EVENING

From the airport, Mother was driven to the Rosners' house. Nealu, Amritatma, and Gayatri traveled with Her in the van.

Mother gave them a brief description of the events that had taken place at the ashram in Vallickavu after their departure. She told them how terribly sad the ashramites and devotees felt about Her leaving for such a long time.

Mother turned to Amritatma and said, "Did you go crazy thinking about Amma? Son, Amma knows your heart so well! When you left India, Amma told Gayatri how hard it would be for you to be physically away from Amma."

Amritatma looked at Mother's face, which showed deep concern and compassion, and said, "Amma, that madness is only occasional. Only if you give that madness fully will I feel truly blessed."

“Son, that is what you asked for when you first met Amma.” (Mother was reminding him of the first time he met Her, in July 1979. She had told him then that She was just a crazy girl, to which he had replied, “Amma, I, too, want a little of that craziness.”)

Mother now turned to Nealu and said. “How is everything, old man? How is your health?” (Mother sometimes calls responsible people, “old man.”)

Nealu smiled and said, “Everything is going well by Amma’s grace.” He then gave a short account of their visit to different cities and the programs they had held there.

It took them an hour to reach Earl’s home. When they arrived, Mother was given a warm welcome. The house was filled with devotees who were all very excited. As Mother stepped out of the van and walked towards the door, everyone was chanting the mantra, “Om Amriteswaryai Namah.” Earl and Judy did *pada puja* to Mother’s sacred feet, and their two-year-old son, Gabriel, managed to garland Mother. He had been talking with great excitement about garlanding Mother ever since Earl had entrusted him with that task. Whenever he met someone, he would say, “Do you know what? I am going to garland Ammachi!”

After the reception, Br. Nealu insisted that Mother should get some rest after Her long, tiresome flight from Singapore. Without even responding to his request, Mother sat down on a chair which had been lovingly prepared for Her with a beautiful silk cloth.

Before leaving for the airport, Nealu had removed the chair from the living room, because he feared that if She saw it, Mother would immediately sit down and call everyone for darshan. But someone had put the chair back before Mother arrived. Nealu was upset about this because, to him, there was nothing more important than Mother’s health, and he desperately wanted Her to get some rest. But it was not to be, for Mother’s infinite compassion never stops flowing towards Her children.

Mother now began calling one person at a time for darshan. As each person came up to Her and knelt before Her, She made them rest their head on Her lap, and then on Her shoulder, as She held them close to Her. As they got up and returned to their seats, they looked calm and blissful. Having gone up to Mother for darshan, Steve Fleisher staggered away from Her as if he were drunk. He came up to Amritatma and tried to express what he felt, but he couldn’t say anything because, as was obvious by his glowing face, his heart was full to overflowing. Amritatma suggested that he sit down and meditate for a while. Steve went and sat in a corner of the room with a serene expression on his face.

As Mother continued to embrace Her children, She sang two songs called *Durge* and *Radhe Govinda Bhajo*.

Victory to Mother Durga!
O Mother
Ocean of Compassion
Mother Kali
Adorned with a garland of human skulls³
Upholder of the world
Victory to the Divine Mother of the Universe!



O Radha
Beloved of Krishna
Radha, who worships the Lord of the cows
O Radha, Beautiful One
Who relieves our distress
Beloved of Krishna, the Lord of the cows

O Radha
Beloved of Krishna, the Lord of the cows

When everyone had received Mother's darshan, Mother asked for some fruit. She cut the fruit into small pieces and fed everyone a piece of the prasada with Her own hands. Mother then sat down on the floor and played with Gabriel. After a while She called a devotee who had just arrived. As She embraced him and his head was resting on Her shoulder, Gabriel, who was standing behind the man, started pulling at his shirt saying, "No! She's my Mother!" When Amritatma translated this to Mother, She turned to Gabriel and asked, "Is Amma only yours?"

Gabriel nodded his head firmly and said, "Yes!" Everyone laughed at his innocent remark.

Earl and Judy had two sons, Arlo and Gabriel. Both of them were very excited about meeting Mother, especially Gabriel, who was the youngest. Though he was only two, Gabriel

was like a twenty-five-year old within a two-year-old boy. He was a very sweet and clever child.

Gabriel had been born to Earl and Judy through Mother's grace. After the birth of their first son, the couple had longed for another child, but Judy wasn't able to conceive again. Earl wrote to his brother Nealu about their wish to have another child. Nealu wrote back saying, "I told Mother that you would like to have another child. Mother said She doesn't think it's in the cards, but She will nevertheless make a sankalpa (resolve) that you will have another baby." Shortly thereafter, Judy became pregnant with Gabriel.

Mother went into the kitchen. She called everyone and then She Herself began serving them their dinner. It was now 11:30 in the evening. Those who had traveled with Mother were exhausted. But even after a sixteen hour plane journey, Mother was still fresh and full of energy. She was spending time with everyone, giving of Herself, offering them Her whole being.

Nealu was walking around feeling restless because he was so worried about Mother. He kept grumbling, "Can't someone make Her go and rest?" But his words had no effect.

A man came up to Amritatma and asked, "Is Mother always like this, or only on special occasions?"

Amritatma replied, "My brother, Her whole life is like this! She simply cannot be otherwise. Day and night, She makes Herself available to everyone who comes to Her. Mother's life is an offering to the world. Wherever She is, there is a celebration—a celebration of pure, innocent love."

The man turned towards Mother, who was still serving food, and looked at Her with an expression of awe and wonder.

At 12:30 a.m., Mother finally retired to Her room.

THE FIRST FORMAL DARSHAN IN AMERICA

Everyone got up early the next morning. Mother's darshan was scheduled to begin at 9:30. During the first world tour, most of the morning programs were held in the homes of Mother's devotees, while almost all the evening programs took place in different halls and churches, except the Devi Bhavas which took place in the living rooms of devotees.

³ The skulls worn by Kali symbolize the death of the ego

The brahmacharis and a few of the others were now hastily making all the last minute preparations for the morning darshan. People began arriving at 8:30, and by 9, the Rosners' living room was almost full. Mother entered the room at exactly 9:30. As She entered, everyone stood up as a sign of respect. Mother got down on Her knees, bowed down in front of everyone, touching Her forehead to the ground, and then She sat on a small carpet which had been specially laid out for Her. She closed Her eyes and began to meditate, diving deep into Her own world of transcendent aloneness.

The people followed Mother's example and also began to meditate. Mother's presence helped everyone to experience a state of spontaneous absorption. A little while later, Mother got up, seated Herself on the darshan chair, and began giving darshan.

There was no darshan queue in those days. People sat around Mother and waited as She called everyone individually. Mother spent a long time with each person, asking many questions about their lives. Though Mother already knew everything about them, She asked these questions to help them open up. The personal attention people received from Mother, and Her unique way of giving darshan to every individual, no matter how long She had to sit, was an entirely new experience for everyone. It was an experience that filled them with profound spiritual bliss. The healing that happened in Mother's presence was also remarkable.

In those days, when someone asked a question, if the question wasn't too personal, Mother would ask Amritatma to translate aloud so that everyone could hear, and then She would answer the question in such a way that it applied to everyone.

During the course of the day, Mother also sang several bhajans. Now and then, She would enter into a state of samadhi in the middle of a song. When this happened, Br. Amritatma took over and continued the song.

People were so moved by Mother's presence that some of them sang and danced out of pure joy. Throughout the darshan, people sang spiritual songs in English, Malayalam, and Sanskrit, creating an interesting blend of East and West. A man named David played the harp and sang traditional English hymns. The songs, which were sung in the form of prayers, were pregnant with meaning.

Listen, listen, listen

To my heart song

I will never forsake You

I will never forget You

Many people wept as they came up to Mother and were enfolded in Her arms. Radiant with love, Mother's expression often shifted from joy to one of empathy and deep concern as She wiped the tears of those who were crying, consoled and counseled them, and healed their deep inner wounds which had been caused by the past.

A woman from Taos sang:

*What wondrous love is this
For my soul, for my soul?
What wondrous love is this
For my soul?
What wondrous love is this
To cause the Mother of Bliss
To be born upon this earth
For my soul, for my soul
To be born upon this earth for my soul?*

*I will bow before Thy feet
Before Thy feet I will bow
I will bow before Thy feet, Thy feet
I will bow before Thy feet
You who've made my love complete
You who've made my life complete with Your love
With Your love
You've made my life complete with Your love*

*To the beloved form of Thee, I will sing
I will sing
To the beloved form of Thee, I will sing
To the beloved form of Thee, Amritanandamayi
To Mata Amritanandamayi, I will sing
I will sing*

To Mata Amritanandamayi, I will sing

And when from death I'm free

I'll sing on, I'll sing on

And when from death I'm free, I'll sing on

And when from death I'm free

I'll sing and joyful be

Throughout eternity I will sing

I will sing

To Mata Amritanandamayi, I will sing

Someone asked a question: “Amma, how does it feel for you to be here in the West, compared to being in India? There's a big difference, isn't there?”

Mother smiled and replied: “The barrier created by the body and mind is the cause of all diversity. When you transcend that barrier, all differences disappear. Amma doesn't feel there is any difference. All beings are Her children, and all the three worlds are Her dwelling place. That is Amma's experience. Whether it be here or in India, Amma alone is—seeing everyone as Her own Self. If you are one with the Supreme Consciousness, how can there be any sense of difference? For Amma, there is no here or there; wherever She goes, Amma is simultaneously here and there. There is no question of east or west. Though a flower is composed of many petals, it is one flower. The human body consists of many parts, and yet it is one body. In the same way, the world consists of many different countries, cultures, languages, races, and people; but for Amma there is just the whole—there is only One.

“As long as you are identified with the body, there will be division. Body-consciousness makes you aware of time and space; and with time and space, differences arise, such as religion, caste, race, and nationality. That division makes everything appear to be different and separate from you.

“The one Consciousness, which holds everything in creation together, has been forgotten. Because of this, people experience themselves as outsiders. An ordinary person is aware of nothing but differences everywhere. But for the soul who has realized the Self, and has transcended the body, there are no differences whatsoever. For such a soul, everything is part of the one universal Consciousness. He clearly perceives that everything is interconnected; that there are no separate entities, but that everything forms a part of the Whole. In that state

you experience yourself everywhere and in everything—here and there, above and below, in all directions, and in the ugly as well as the beautiful. Wherever such a soul goes, he finds his own Self already there. He is always present, never absent; always conscious, never unaware; functioning spontaneously from deep within. He is not a stranger to anyone, because he is the all-pervading Consciousness. In that state, there is not a moment when you are not perfectly aware.”

Amritatma, who was sitting next to Mother translating Her words, found himself remembering a day in 1982 when he was preparing for his exams towards a master’s degree in philosophy. He was sitting in a room with his professor, who had agreed to come to the ashram to teach him. They were having a discussion about one of the aphorisms of Patanjali’s *Yoga Sutra*. The professor didn’t believe in Mother. He said to Amritatma, “Look here! I don’t believe for a moment that your Mother has reached that state. Of course, I do believe that a state of all-knowing can be achieved through *tapas* (austerities), but I am not in the least convinced that your Mother is omniscient.”

Amritatma felt hurt by the professor’s remark. At the same time, he took it as a challenge to his own faith. He found himself impulsively saying to the professor: “All right, if that’s what you think of Mother, I’ll prove to you that She’s omniscient. I’ll show you how She responds to my prayers. Just give me a moment and see what happens!” Amritatma turned towards the little altar in the room, on which there was a small picture of Mother. He closed his eyes and prayed with great feeling, “Amma, my God and Guru, please don’t think I’m being arrogant or self-serving. I myself have no doubts about you, but let the professor understand that you know everything. It would be a blessing for him. But Amma, you know what is best. Let your will be done.” Amritatma then prostrated in front of the picture. As he offered his prayer at Mother’s feet, he found himself weeping with emotion. Suddenly, he heard someone say, “Mother is calling you!” Amritatma got up on his knees and glanced towards the door. A brahmachari was standing in the doorway repeating, “Mother is calling you!”

Amritatma’s happiness knew no bounds. Filled with gratitude, he again bowed down in front of Mother’s picture, saying quietly: “Amma, did you respond so quickly to the prayer of this child?” With tears in his eyes, he looked at the professor and asked: “Sir, what do you think now?” The professor didn’t say anything as Amritatma excused himself and quickly left the room.

The darshan hut was about fifty yards away. As Amritatma reached the hut, he looked in through the open doorway. The hut was crowded with people seeking Mother's darshan. Mother glanced towards the door, and when She saw Amritatma, She broke into a smile. "Child, did you call Amma?" She asked. At the sound of Mother's sweet, heart-soothing words, an inexpressible joy welled up in Amritatma's heart. He stood there in the doorway shedding tears of bliss. Mother gazed at him intently, and again She said, "Son, did you call Amma?"

Amritatma was so moved that he couldn't answer. Of course Mother knew everything that had happened, so there was no need to tell Her anything. He sat down and sobbed like a child, covering his face with his hands. When Amritatma returned to his room a little later, he told the professor what had happened. In a deeply regretful tone, the professor said, "Who am I to judge Mother? But let me say this—I confess, I do agree with you that Mother must be omniscient."

After this incident the professor became devoted to Mother.

This experience is told here to illustrate the fact that Mother is present everywhere, at all times, because She is one with the Supreme Consciousness. There is never a moment when She isn't everywhere. There is no place where She is absent.

Amritatma also remembered how Bri. Lakshmi once told him about one of her experiences with Mother. This happened before she began serving Mother personally. Lakshmi was working somewhere on the ashram grounds. Due to the heat she felt very thirsty and had an intense craving for ice water. But as the only refrigerator in the whole ashram was in Mother's room, she knew there was no chance of getting any cold water. A few minutes later, a girl approached Lakshmi and handed her a glass of ice water, saying, "Mother gave me this and told me to give it to you."

Lakshmi was astonished and asked the girl to explain what had happened. The girl told her that as usual someone had offered Mother something to drink during darshan. But instead of accepting the water, Mother immediately said, "Give it to Lakshmi. She is very thirsty and wants ice water." Thus the girl brought the glass to Lakshmi.

There are countless such striking examples of Mother's omniscience, which clearly help us to understand that She is not limited by the body or mind, and that Her compassionate heart and helping hands are always there for Her children, wherever they are.

A BLISSFUL CELEBRATION

A couple, John and Linda, who were sitting next to Mother, said to Amritatma, “The way Mother receives people is beyond comparison. This is unheard of! Her intimacy and the motherly love She gives us in its purest form is exactly what we need. The Western world has never experienced anything like it.”

“Neither has the East,” Amritatma replied.

John continued, “Look at these people! They’re in another world. It is divine healing. Meeting Mother for the first time—Her touch and the way She looked at us—had a tremendous effect on both of us. Mother has taken away so much pain....” Tears welled up in John’s eyes as he spoke. His wife, Linda, who was suffering from severe respiratory problems and wasn’t healthy enough to travel or even to sit up, nevertheless came to every morning and evening program, just because of the extraordinary peace she experienced in Mother’s presence.

As they were talking, an elderly Afro-American man, who had come with his young wife and three-year-old son, suddenly got up and spontaneously started singing and dancing, “We have seen Christ! In Mother, and in Her divine love and compassion, we have seen Christ, the Lord! In Mother, and in Her self-sacrifice, we have seen Jesus Christ, the Savior!” He looked divinely intoxicated, and his joy was so contagious that the rest of the devotees joined in by clapping their hands and responding to the song. The man’s little boy was dancing happily next to his father. Within a few minutes, all the devotees got up and were dancing in the Rosners’ living room, responding to the lines of the song. The refrain, “In Mother, we have seen Christ, our Lord,” echoed throughout the room. The dancing and singing continued for some time until, finally, one by one, everyone sat down and the atmosphere became calm and serene. As they sat down, they spontaneously began to meditate.

That same divine presence of Mother which, a moment ago, had inspired people to sing and dance with joy, now inspired them to dive deep into meditation. Many of the participants had tears of bliss streaming down their faces.

During the first and second world tours, people had the opportunity to spend a lot of time in Mother’s physical presence. Sometimes, a person could spend up to ten minutes in Mother’s lap, especially when Mother spontaneously burst into song during darshan. Mother would then slip into a state of rapture, and the person who at that moment was receiving darshan could stay in Her lap until the song came to an end. When Mother sang in that state,

She rocked from side to side, as if Her lap were a cradle and the song a sacred lullaby being sung to the child in Her lap. This happened only during the first and second world tours. As the number of people increased, Mother stopped singing in this way during darshan.

Because the time allotted to each individual was so long, darshan often lasted from 9:30 in the morning till late in the afternoon—six or seven hours, without Mother moving from Her chair.

Soon after the morning darshan had finished, the evening program would begin at 7 p.m., lasting until the early hours of the morning. Mother consequently had very little time to rest. She simply ignored Her body and its needs for the sake of helping others. One devotee said, “Mother reminds me of the crucified Jesus, who sacrificed His life for the whole world.”

JNANA YOGA AND KARMA YOGA

During a darshan, the following question was asked by a devotee: “Amma, why do the *jnani*s, those who adhere to *jnana yoga* (the path of knowledge), usually extol the path of knowledge, while they condemn *karma yoga* (the path of action)? Even in the *Bhagavad Gita*, Lord Krishna criticizes the section in the *Vedas* that deals with *karma yoga*. He states that *jnana* is the highest. The Lord says:

*Thus various sacrifices are prescribed by the Vedas. Know all these to be born of action: knowing this you will be free. There is nothing as purifying as knowledge.*⁴

“Amma, doesn’t this mean that even Lord Krishna, who was a perfect *jnani*, was advocating the path of knowledge rather than the path of action?”

Mother: “Son, Amma doesn’t believe that the *jnani*s have claimed any of the differences between the path of action and the path of knowledge that you are implying. Why would Lord Krishna, who set a perfect example of how to live and act in the world, though he was, in fact, *purnam* (complete), and a perfect *jnani*, condemn the path of action? There is nothing wrong with the words of the *jnani*s—it is people’s interpretations of those words that are mistaken.

⁴ *Srimad Bhagavad Gita*, Chapter 4, verses 32 & 38

“Life can be divided into two aspects: performing actions and enjoying the fruit of one’s actions. The body and mind are active during the waking state. In the dream state, the body is inactive but the mind is active, which is why we dream. The impressions that have been created in the subconscious, which is the unfulfilled part of us, are projected as dreams. Also, even if no actions are being done externally, the blood is still circulating and the heart continues to beat; and that, too, is action. In other words, as long as we have a body, mind, and intellect, we cannot refrain from some form of action.

“Although actions tend to be binding because of our attachment to their fruits, an action can also serve as a stepping stone to freedom from action.

VEDIC RITUALS

“There are many rituals prescribed in the *Vedas*. People have a tendency to become too attached to those rituals, rather than understanding their inner significance and thereby transcending them. The Vedic rituals, and the mantras which form a part of them, purify the atmosphere and benefit mankind. Of course they do much good, but they can’t be compared to the immeasurable benefit humanity receives from a person who has attained realization. No matter how important and valuable the rituals are, the practitioner should strive to go beyond them and to experience the ultimate Truth within himself. That is the very purpose of religion: to realize that there is no God or Goddess existing separately from our own innermost Self. This supreme experience of oneness with the Truth is the foundation of all religious teachings. What, then, is the point of practicing spirituality or Vedic rituals if it doesn’t lead to that oneness? The mere presence, breath, touch, look, and word of a Self-realized soul has the power to purify and uplift those who come into contact with him. Even the wind that caresses his body, and his saliva, has this power.

“It’s inadvisable to give too much importance to rituals, and to become too attached to them, forgetting their real purpose, which is to lead the aspirant to the inner experience of the Truth. This is probably what Sri Krishna meant. Amma doesn’t claim to know anything about the *Bhagavad Gita*, but She believes this is the reason for the Lord’s criticism of the section on the *Karma Kanda* in the *Vedas*. In those days people were probably too attached to the ritualistic aspect of the *Vedas*, while the section on jnana was ignored.

“If Krishna were to be born in this age, He would undoubtedly criticize the so-called jnanis who simply talk about *Vedanta* without experiencing or practicing even a bit of it. He

would, however, praise the Vedic rituals. Do you know why? Because we have forgotten those rituals that could be of such great benefit to the world.

“Not only Vedic rituals, but any karma (action) that we do, is meant to help us attain a certain amount of mental purification. But this is only possible if we have the right attitude. Once the mind and the senses have been purified, we are meant to renounce all action and turn inward in search of the Truth. Having attained that purity, the quest to know the truth of existence will intensify and we will automatically turn within. That longing will eventually help us to experience the Supreme Truth. In the state of oneness there are no *Vedas*, and no gods or goddesses other than our own Self. Everything is experienced as one and the same Self.

“The scriptures say that for a person who has attained Supreme Knowledge—the state of *Jivanmukti*, the realization that everything is the Atman—the *Vedas* cease to be the *Vedas*, and the gods cease to be gods.

“The experience of oneness with the inner Truth is the goal of all religions. Why would there be any religions at all if that realization couldn’t be attained? Everybody—the people of all nations, from rich to poor, from the illiterate to the highly educated—are of the impression that God is different and separate from them. What is the use of religion or spiritual principles if the so-called teachers and practitioners remain ignorant of the Truth? It is not incorrect to criticize such people as long as they continue to ignore the inner reality. That must have been what Krishna meant by what he said in the *Gita*, for he came to the world with the purpose of awakening people to true knowledge.

“Today the situation is different. People boast of being jnanis without knowing, that is, without directly experiencing, jnana itself. They are of the opinion that a jnani is someone who carries a lot of intellectual concepts in his head. They don’t realize that they are simply carrying around a big burden without getting anywhere.

“Karma and jnana are interdependent. You cannot say you are a jnani without first having acquired the necessary mental purification, through the performance of certain actions mentioned in the scriptures (*Vedas*). It isn’t possible to simply take a big leap to the state of jnana; it is a question of slow and steady evolution. It is like the development of a child. You can’t expect a child to grow up in just a day or two. The child has to go through several stages in order to grow up; it doesn’t happen in a moment.

IMPATIENCE DESTROYS

“In the same way, spiritual growth is evolutionary, not revolutionary. In their impatience, people tend to be revolutionary. But revolution is always destructive. Unfortunately, in the modern age people demand spiritual upliftment as fast as possible. Instant enlightenment is what they’re asking for. Can you imagine a mother saying to her baby, ‘I want you to grow up right now! Why do you keep being a child for so long? Hurry up, I don’t have time to wait!’ What would you say about such a mother, except that she is either extremely foolish or deranged? People expect a miracle to happen. They have no patience to wait or to make any effort. They don’t understand that the real miracle consists of the opening up of one’s heart into the one Supreme Truth. That inner blossoming, however, is always slow and steady. Everything in nature is evolutionary. God takes great care and is extremely patient, even with the opening of a flower—and the opening of a flower is a miracle. It takes nine months before a child is ready to be born—and that birth is a miracle. God is never in a hurry. He is evolutionary. Real growth will happen only if you’re evolutionary.

“Amma isn’t saying that supreme realization cannot happen just like that. It could happen at any time, through the grace of the master. But are you prepared for that to happen? There are people who say, ‘Why should I prepare for it when I already am that?’ Yes, you are that; but what about the burden of negativity you are still carrying? What about your ego? As long as there is any trace of bondage, you have to work on removing that bondage. The feeling that you are the body and mind is a form of bondage; so is anger, hatred, lust, and jealousy. When you’re in the grip of such feelings, the Truth that exists within you, which is your real nature, cannot be realized. This is why the process of sadhana (spiritual practices) is needed.

“People have countless wants and demands, which they want to fulfill as soon as possible. They want results but they don’t have the patience to work for those results. To become a great artist or scientist, or to make a fortune, people are willing to undergo long-term training, but when the subject is God-realization they demand it instantly. Impatience, however, can only bring negative results.

“Everybody knows the story of the Pandavas and the Kauravas. The Pandavas were born out of *mantra shakti* (the power of certain sacred formulas). When Yudhisthira, the oldest of the five Pandava brothers, was born through the invocation of a deity, Gandhari, who was pregnant at the time, became extremely impatient. She beat her own stomach so hard that she miscarried and gave birth to a lump of flesh. At that moment, a great sage took pity on her and came to her aid. He divided the lump of flesh into a hundred pieces and placed them in a

hundred sealed pots. He filled the pots with his life energy and instructed Gandhari not to open them before a certain period of time. But again, Gandhari was so impatient that she couldn't wait, and she opened the pots before she was supposed to. As a result, the Kauravas were born imperfect and evil-minded. They were instrumental in the destruction of the entire clan.

“Because of her impatience, Gandhari couldn't wait for the sankalpa behind the sage's power to take effect. Had she been patient enough, she would have had brilliant, virtuous sons like the Pandavas. But her impatience destroyed the potential goodness and beauty of that part of creation that was the Kauravas. As a result of her impatience, the evil prince, Duryodhana, was born as the eldest of her children. Thus her impatience was the cause of terrible destruction.”

Mother stopped talking and sang a bhajan called *Oru Nimisha Menkilum*.

*O Man,
While seeking happiness in this world,
Do you experience peace of mind
For even one second?*

*Without grasping the Truth,
You run after the shadow of Maya.
You will face the same fate as the moth,
Deluded by the sight of a glowing fire.*

*Having gradually evolved through different incarnations
As insects, birds, and animals,
You have finally been born as a human being.
What could be the purpose of human life
Other than Self-realization?*

*Cast away your pride and greed,
Leave the life of delusion,
Spend your human life
Glorifying the supreme Brahman.*

*God-realization is your birthright;
Don't waste this precious life.*

When the song came to an end, a devotee asked Mother to elaborate on the story of Gandhari.

Mother: “The human race is heading towards destruction. People don’t have the patience to let God’s sankalpa work in their lives, or in society as a whole. People are blinded by their impatience and their demands for instant gratification. The ego always wants to take up challenges and fulfill its desires within the shortest possible time. In their hurry, people lose their patience and discrimination, which, in turn, destroys their clarity of vision. If this is allowed to continue, it will end in a disaster. When everyone in society has become blinded in this way, they will clash with each other: individuals will clash with individuals, communities with communities, and nations with nations. Impatience causes disharmony and imperfection. The evils of today’s world, which have been caused by people’s impatience, are paving the way for terrible destruction. Unless we wake up, it cannot be averted. This is the moral of the story.

“God’s divine sankalpa is behind everything in creation. The Divinity is always present, but our impatience closes the doors, preventing God’s sankalpa from taking effect in our lives. Duryodhana, the son of impatience, closed all the doors to his heart, so that Lord Krishna’s grace and light couldn’t enter into his life. Even though he was surrounded by many wise men in his court, none of them were able to open his eyes. Because of his wickedness and extreme impatience, he was quick to jump to conclusions, displeasing everyone around him.

“Only a deep, gradual, steadfast development can have any real effect. God’s motto is evolution. Growing into the state of God-consciousness is almost always an evolutionary process. We have to acquire the necessary prerequisite of purity and mental maturity before we can enter into the realm of the Supreme Truth; and that is what we gain through rituals. Once that maturity and purity is attained, we are ready to dive into the ocean of Sat-Chit-Ananda (Being-Consciousness-Bliss), and then there is no more need for action or rituals. While engaged in any action, or while performing rituals, we should keep in mind that Self-knowledge is the ultimate goal. During Krishna’s time, people had forgotten the purpose of the rituals they were doing. They were attached to them and didn’t make any effort to transcend the ritualistic aspect of religion. They had forgotten that the rituals were meant to

lead them to the supreme goal. That is why Krishna criticized them. So, children, don't think that Krishna had anything against the Vedic rituals per se. If you read the *Bhagavad Gita* properly, you will understand what He really meant.

“If you observe a tree, you will notice that the fruit will not appear unless the flowers first blossom and fall from the tree. On the spiritual path, the ultimate fruit is Self-knowledge. To attain that fruit, the flowers of karma (action) first have to blossom and drop away.”

In the background, the fingers of David the musician danced gracefully over the strings of his harp as he sang softly:

*Soham, soham,
You and I are one;
Ammma, Ammma, soham,
You and I are one;
Shiva, Shiva, soham,
You and I are one;
Krishna, Krishna, soham,
You and I are one;
Jesus, Jesus, soham,
You and I are one...*

THE DIVINE TOUCH

The evening program was held at the Quaker Friends meeting hall. A large crowd was waiting for Mother when She arrived. It is remarkable how Mother is able to communicate with people, even though there is no direct conversation.

At the door, Mother was greeted in the traditional way: Her sacred feet were washed, She was garlanded, and burning camphor was waved in front of Her. As Mother walked through the hall, She often touched people as She passed them. She rubbed someone's chest, affectionately ruffled another person's hair, threw a loving glance at someone, patted a cheek, or smiled at someone. All these small gestures had a great impact on those who received them. Having received a touch, glance, or smile from Mother, people often laughed joyfully, while others were so moved that they wept. Mother's glance, for example, was so radiant

with love, and Her mere touch could fill a person's whole being with so much joy and peace of mind, that some of those who experienced it went and sat by themselves in a corner and became absorbed in meditation. The faces of others, who looked tense and troubled by the stress and suffering in their lives, were markedly transformed by that moment of contact with Mother.

The program began at 7 p.m. The last song of the bhajans was *Omkara Divya Porule*.

*Come quickly, My darling children!
You are the essence of Aum;
Remove all sorrows,
Grow to be adorable and merge in Aum.*

*You may stumble My children,
But Mother is walking beside you,
Creating within you
The awareness of Eternity.*

*Darling children,
Always remember in your hearts
That God is Love;
And by meditating on the embodiment of Love,
You yourselves will become that Love...*

Mother replaced the refrain with "Aum."

The song ended with the melodious chanting of "Aum," and the whole audience joined in. The chanting lasted for more than five minutes. It sounded as if Mother was leading the audience into the world of the Supreme Truth, the realm of "Aum," the primordial Sound.

AN ACT OF INNOCENT LOVE

At three in the morning, when the darshan was finally over, Mother got up from Her chair and walked slowly out of the hall, lovingly touching everyone who had lined up on

either side of Her path. It was cold outside. Amritatma was waiting for Mother beside the car. As he stood there, he witnessed something very moving.

The ground in front of the hall had been excavated for repair work. A broad wooden plank served as a bridge across the hole. The plank was strong, but looked rough and dirty. Though it was cold outside, a devotee called Ken Goldman removed his coat and lovingly spread it over one end of the plank for Mother to walk on. Seeing that it wasn't enough to cover the whole plank, his wife, Judy, immediately removed her coat and placed it next to Ken's. But there was still some space left where the dirty plank showed through. Inspired by their parents, the couple's two sons took off their little coats and carefully placed them over the remaining area.

When Mother came out and saw the four coats lying across the bridge, She said, "Children, what is this? Why are you damaging your good clothes? It's very cold, please take your coats and put them back on. This body was brought up in very difficult, austere circumstances, so Amma can easily adjust to any situation. Amma doesn't need any special treatment." Mother bent down and tried to pick up their coats, but Ken and Judy knelt down in front of Her and said, "No Amma! Please purify our clothes by the touch of your feet, so that when we put our coats back on we will also be purified." As Ken and Judy looked up at Mother, their two children stood close to Mother, leaning against Her. Mother smiled, and with great affection She gathered the whole family in Her arms. And, then, responding to their prayer, She walked over their clothes across the bridge and stepped into the car. The family happily picked up their coats and put them back on.

In the car Mother said, "What those children (The Goldmans) did reminds Amma of what a *grihasthasrami*'s⁵ family should be like. When my son took off his coat and spread it over the plank, he was prepared to sacrifice his coat and stand freezing in the cold, because he considered it his *dharma* (duty) to protect Amma's feet. When his wife noticed that his coat wasn't large enough to cover the whole plank, she took off her coat as well, feeling that it was her *dharma* to fulfill what her husband couldn't complete. But her coat wasn't big enough either, so now both the children came forward to complete the work which their parents had begun. Thus the whole family, inspired by an ideal, sincerely supported each other to fulfill a task which they believed to be their *dharma*. Though a seemingly small incident, each of them sacrificed something for someone else's happiness. It doesn't mean

⁵ A *grihasthasrami* is someone who is dedicated to a spiritual life, while leading the life of a householder.

that Amma needed those coats to be placed on the plank, but their example melted Her heart. She felt so much love for those children!

“This attitude should develop, not only towards Amma, but towards everyone. We should lovingly cooperate and support each other for the common good of all, for the upliftment of the entire society. That is our true dharma; and it can take us to the ultimate goal of life, Self-realization. However, it should always begin with the family.”



AMAZING GRACE

It was 4 a.m., the following day, and Mother had just finished giving darshan. People had been sitting for hours around Mother, gazing endlessly at Her radiant face, which at every moment seemed absolutely fresh and new to them, and yet so utterly familiar. For hours they had been drinking from the inexhaustible cup of Her divine love, never moving from their seats, except to go up to Her for darshan. Mother finally got up from Her chair, and was about to walk towards the door, when She suddenly paused and stood looking at someone at the back of the hall. She called out, “Mol (My daughter)!” Everyone turned around to see who Mother was calling. Again, Mother called, “Mol, come!” A moment later, a young woman came rushing up to Mother. With a loud cry she fell at Mother’s feet. The woman was sobbing uncontrollably, calling out, “Mother! Mother!” A few people were about to pull her away from Mother, but Mother stopped them saying, “No, it’s all right! She’s in terrible pain. Let her pour out her grief.” So they stood by and quietly watched the scene. A few minutes went by. The woman was still lying prostrate at Mother’s feet, weeping profusely. Br. Amritatma and a few others became impatient and stepped forward, asking her to get up. This time Mother didn’t say anything, but She stopped them with a stern look. A few more minutes went by, and then the woman slowly raised herself and knelt in front of Mother. She joined her palms together in a gesture of reverence and looked up at Mother’s face. She tried to speak through her tears, but couldn’t due to her intense emotions. Mother smiled at her with a look of great compassion and drew the woman close to Her. Again the woman burst into tears. Mother closed Her eyes and seemed to slip into a different world. She caressed the woman, stroking her hair and murmuring softly, “Mol... mol...”

Then, gently, Mother said to her, “Darling daughter. Child, don’t cry. Amma knows your heart so well!” At one point those who were present noticed that Mother was wiping the tears from Her own eyes. When they saw this, many of them were unable to hold back their tears.

This reminds one of Mother’s saying: “When you are in Amma’s presence, She becomes you. Amma is like a mirror. She simply reflects the inner feelings of Her children.”

Eventually, the woman managed to calm down. Mother gave her one more hug, kissed her gently on both cheeks, and then walked slowly out of the hall.

As Mother left the hall, She affectionately touched everyone She passed. Her love permeated the atmosphere. A woman spontaneously began to sing *Amazing Grace*, and everyone joined in. Then, Mother, the very source of all grace, got into the car and was driven away.

The next day, the woman who had wept so profusely at Mother’s feet, told Br. Amritatma what had happened to her. She had come to the hall just before the program started, and had sat at the back of the room during the entire program, watching Mother giving darshan. She herself had no intention of going up to Mother, and there was a reason for her resistance. She had made a few serious mistakes in the past, which she thought were unforgivable, and was feeling extremely guilty about it. As she watched Mother, and the limitless love that Mother showered upon everyone, the woman thought that a sinner like herself didn’t deserve to receive such love. Having decided not to go for darshan, she sat there crying throughout the program. But Mother saw her and called her at the end, knowing all about her mental agony.

A few days later, on the way to an evening program, Br. Amritatma asked Mother why She had waited that night until the very end to call the woman.

Mother: “By sitting in Amma’s presence and watching Amma for such a long time, that daughter suddenly became conscious of the terrible burden of guilt she was carrying, and this awareness created the urge to empty it all out and be free. The deep feeling of Amma’s love, which she experienced while sitting there at the back of the hall, helped to relieve her inner pain. All those tears washed away her guilt, and finally, when Amma called her, she was ready to unburden herself and find the peace she longed for. This couldn’t have happened if Amma had called her at the beginning of the darshan, because a certain amount of time was needed for her to open up. Everything is meant to happen in a certain way, only then will it have a lasting effect.

“A sinner—but, in fact, there are no sinners; for the state of enlightenment lies hidden in all human beings, even in the worst ‘sinner’, just waiting for the right moment to emerge. So,

no one is really a sinner. There is only the Atman. Amma is using the word 'sinner' only to explain something.

"A sinner can find peace only in the presence of a great master. For in the master's presence the mind is able to flow freely. In that atmosphere of unconditional love, all sins melt away. The closed dam of the mind opens up, allowing the hardened mind and its emotions to soften and flow unhindered.

"That daughter had become trapped in her pain. She had never had the opportunity to rid herself of the guilt and grief which had stagnated in her mind, because there had never been any favorable conditions for this to happen. So the pain had stayed hidden deep within her.

"You try to cover up your pain with different thoughts, objects, and pleasures. For example, you buy a new car or a new house, find a new boy- or girlfriend, and as you continue to cover up your pain with layer upon layer of distractions, the pain hardens with age; it becomes stronger and its hold more subtle. You go to a psychotherapist, but what can he do? He is trapped in his own mind. All he can do is help you to cover up your pain even further, and the pain remains within you, without any possibility of being removed. Whoever tries to help someone remove such pain will find that, unless his own consciousness is at a higher level than that of the person he is trying to help, no real healing or change can take place. What really matters is your level of awareness. A realized soul is at the highest level of consciousness; he has reached the highest peak. In his presence all sorrows are removed and the wounds of the psyche are healed spontaneously.

"Only a satguru (Self-realized master) can bestow the necessary grace and create the right conditions that will uncover your pain. That is exactly what happened here. The woman's pain was unmasked. Amma's presence helped her to unburden herself of the guilt she had been carrying around for so long.

"The best way to get rid of the great burden of guilt, which is like an infected wound gnawing at you from within, is to become fully conscious of it. This can happen only in the presence of a true master. The master shows you the deep wounds that are festering within you. He helps you to become aware of the serious damage those wounds could cause you, how they could destroy your whole life; and eventually, through his infinite love and compassion, those wounds are healed.

"Amma has heard a story that will perhaps help you to understand.

"There was a rich man who was suffering from overwork and severe stress. Because of this he completely lost his peace of mind. He went to different doctors and healers seeking a

cure for his dilemma. Everyone, including his friends, urged him to retire from his work and rest, to stay at home and enjoy a peaceful life. But neither their advice nor the medicines he was given seemed to help him. One day he heard about a great saint who lived in a remote cave. He was so desperate that he decided to visit the master. After a long, arduous journey he finally reached the place. Although it was freezing cold, the saint was sitting naked in the cave. He gestured quietly to the visitor to sit down next to him, and then he closed his eyes and went into a state of samadhi. The saint remained in that state for three days, while the visitor continued to sit there patiently in the ice-cold cave, without any food or sleep—so great was his desire to free himself from the pain. On the third day the saint opened his eyes and said to him, ‘Retire from your work and rest. Stay at home and enjoy a peaceful life.’ The man listened to what the saint had to say and went home.

“A few days later his friends came to see him. They were surprised to see how peaceful and contented he seemed. They wondered how such a transformation could have happened to him in such a short time. When he told them about his visit to the saint, and what he had said to him, they exclaimed, ‘But that’s exactly what we have been telling you all along!’ The man smiled and said, ‘Perhaps those were the words you used. But when I heard those same words from a true master, I suddenly saw their real, inner meaning. For when the Master uttered those words, I had a revelation. It dawned on me that to “retire from work and rest,” means to withdraw the senses from the world of diversity, and to “stay at home and enjoy a peaceful life,” means to dwell within the Self, seeing everything as a manifestation of God. The Master’s presence and the power behind his words removed all my fear and tension. At last, I am experiencing real peace of mind.’

“Children, only in the presence of a Self-realized master can any real transformation take place. However, both in that daughter’s case and in the case of the man in the story, peace of mind was experienced only after they had made the necessary effort. But, actually, there is no effort to be made as such, because there is no force or strain involved. The effort is effortless and spontaneous—it simply happens: the gates of the heart open up, letting the master’s grace flow in, bringing new light and energy into your life.”

What Mother said about the woman proved to be true because one day, soon thereafter, she came back to see Mother and told Her that she felt like a different person, that for the first time in years, she was relaxed and at peace with herself.

Amritatma asked Mother another question: “Amma, you could have removed her pain by your mere sankalpa, without her having to cry for such a long time. Why didn’t you do this?”

Mother: “Son, that is exactly what happened. Amma’s sankalpa was at work—it’s always there. What do you think inspired the woman to come and see Amma in the first place? And if she had come of her own accord, she might simply have left, instead of sitting at the back of the hall, crying throughout the entire darshan. What made her sit there for so long? And finally, what was it that made her open up to the extent that she did? Do you think all this could have happened without Amma’s sankalpa? Her own effort would not have been enough. There is grace and a divine sankalpa behind everything.

“Situations that cause you to open up and develop inwardly can only happen through God’s or the guru’s sankalpa. Nothing is accidental. We should be able to see this.”

THE FIRST DEVI BHAVA

The first Devi Bhava was held in the living room of Earl’s house, in a small temple shrine which had been specially made for the occasion. In the early evening, before the Devi Bhava, Br. Amritatma presented Mother’s life story in the traditional *katha* form, illustrated with songs that were woven into the narration. Everyone was deeply moved by it; especially since most of them had just met Mother and didn’t know anything about Her remarkable life.

The house was cram-packed; there were people everywhere in the house, and outside in the garden. After the story telling, people sat in the living room in front of the closed temple waiting for the Devi Bhava to begin. They didn’t know what to expect. They had been told that Mother was about to reveal Her oneness with the Divine Mother in a more tangible way.

Mother once said to a few of Her disciples, “If you were to really see Amma as She is, it would overwhelm you—you couldn’t possibly bear it. Because of this, Amma always covers Herself with a thick layer of Maya (illusion). But during Devi Bhava, Mother removes one or two of Her veils, revealing a little more of what She really is.”

On this night—Mother’s first Devi Bhava in the West—it seemed to the brahmacharis that Mother removed even more of Her veils than usual. It turned out to be an unforgettable night for all those who were present.

Suddenly the curtains, which were made of different colored silk saris, opened and the brahmacharis started chanting the *Durga Suktham*,⁶ as they always did at the beginning of each Devi Bhava.

Mother was sitting on a chair, wearing a beautiful deep green silk sari and the traditional crown of Devi, the Divine Mother. People were entranced by what they saw. During the daytime darshan one could clearly see and feel Mother's divinity in a way that no words could describe. But now it was revealed to them in an even more powerful way. Her face was utterly radiant with the power, beauty, and compassion of the Divine Mother. And that radiance spread throughout the room, permeating the atmosphere like a glorious fragrance. Mother was so filled with divine energy that Her whole body visibly vibrated with power, and this continued throughout the Devi Bhava which lasted until the early hours of the morning.

One by one people went up to Mother and were embraced by Her. When Mother touched them they were given a direct experience of a supernatural power which was very subtle, and yet, immensely powerful. Some people compared it to being charged with a powerful current, which was extremely soothing and uplifting. Some people had the experience of being purified, and their negativity was removed. Others were transported to a transcendental state of awareness beyond time and space. Throughout the night, many people sang and danced with joy. The brahmacharis sat in front of the temple, singing bhajans. At the beginning of the Bhava darshan they sang, *Jaya jaya devi dayamayi ambe*.

Victory to Mother, who is full of kindness!

O Mother, please give me the bliss

Of Your ocean-like compassion;

Utter the Vedas to Your servants

O my Goddess, Amritanandamayi.

By remembering Your Lotus Face,

Our sins and our fears of becoming are destroyed.

O my Goddess, Amritanandamayi,

Who is attached to Pure Dharma;

Giver of auspiciousness.

⁶ Mahanarayana Upanishad

*O Mother,
 Who urges us to give up
 The comforts of the mortal world;
 Creatress of the Universe,
 Whose nature is purity itself
 O my Goddess Amritanandamayi.*

*O Great Holy One,
 Worshipped by the devotees;
 With a pure enchanting smile on Your face,
 You dwell in the supreme state,
 untouched by desire
 O Amritanandamayi.*

*You have been born as the Goddess of Wisdom
 To rid us of this sorrowful world.
 O Amritanandamayi,
 May Your holy feet transmit their brilliance
 Into our hearts, forever.*

*You have been born for the sake of the miserable;
 Your sacred aim is the well-being of others.
 O my Goddess Amritanandamayi,
 Who has a human form,
 Yet whose real nature is Being-Awareness.*

*You teach us to discriminate between the Self
 and the non-Self,
 So that our minds will be purified.
 Being immersed in the Atman
 Your soft words flow out in a nectarous stream
 O Amritanandamayi.*

Later that night, at the end of the Devi Bhava, Mother stood up and walked to the front of the shrine, and standing before the people, she showered handfuls of flower petals on everyone, worshipping the Supreme within each person. And then, as She stood before them, turning Her body slightly from side to side, Mother underwent a visible transformation. It seemed to Br. Amritatma that Mother had suddenly grown larger and that Her face was quite different. Though Her boundless compassion still shone in Her eyes, he no longer saw the sweet, gentle Mother before him, but the immensely powerful, awe-inspiring form of Devi, the Mother of the Universe, in Her more impersonal form. And as Mother revealed this one aspect of the infinite aspects of Her Being, he and the other brahmacharis sang *Om Bhadrakali*.

*Aum Bhadrakali,
O Goddess, who gives us refuge,
Enchantress and Mother,
Bless me!
O Goddess, who killed the demon Chamunda,
Please lovingly protect Your people
and make them happy!*

*We bow to Your Lotus Feet,
Which are adorned with golden anklets.
O Chandika,
Beautiful One,
Great Dancer,
Bless us with Your glance of Grace!*

*O valiant Bhairavi,
Who has severed the head of the demon Darika;
Seeking refuge at Your feet,
We sing your praises!
Ocean of Grace,
We bow down to You.*

THE ALL-KNOWING MOTHER

Carmel

In Carmel, Mother held an evening program in the hall of the Women's Club. Mother stayed with Nealu's and Earl's cousin, Ron Gottsegen. Ron, who was in his early fifties, and who owned a highly successful electronics company, felt deeply attracted to Mother from the first moment he saw Her. In the afternoon before the evening program, Mother was sitting by Herself on the vast lawn in Ron's garden, when Amritatma came out and joined Her. As he sat down next to Her, She said, "Ron has the qualities of a true seeker. He will renounce everything one day. He is my son." (This is exactly what happened. Ron was later to buy some land in San Ramon and give it to Mother as an offering of love; and that land was to become Mother's ashram in California. Ron would also later be in charge of organizing the development of Mother's super-specialty hospital in Ernakulam, and go and stay with Mother permanently in India.)

Seattle

In Seattle, Mother stayed with Mr. and Mrs. Hoffman. The first evening program was held at their house.

Ever since Mother had arrived in America, She had been writing short letters to each resident at the ashram in Vallickavu, because She knew how much they were suffering from being separated from Her. During whatever little free time She could find between the morning and evening darshans, Mother was writing letters.

One evening Mother said, "The morning meditation has just come to an end at the ashram in India. Amma can see all Her children sitting together in front of the meditation hall. They are thinking about Amma, and they are very sad. Some of them are crying because they miss Her so much!" Mother mentioned the names of those who were crying, and then She closed Her eyes and sat quietly with tears trickling down Her face.

When the darshan was over that evening, Mother expressed a wish to talk to all the ashramites in India. So they telephoned Mahadevan, one of Mother's devotees who lived in Alleppey, a town near the ashram, and arranged that all the ashram residents would be waiting there at the same time the next day.

The following night after the evening program, Mother telephoned Alleppey and spoke to Her children, who had been brought there from the ashram. They were eagerly waiting to hear Her voice over the phone. Mother asked them if they were sad. They told Her that they had been especially sad the day before. They had been sitting outside the meditation hall after the morning meditation, thinking about Mother and crying—and now She was calling them! With words laden with compassion, Mother tried to console them over the phone. She told them that She was always with them and had seen them the day before. When She finally put down the receiver, She told those who were present how sad Her ashram children were; and how it broke Her heart when She heard them calling, “Amma!” over the phone.

It was clear that the intense longing of Her children in India had made Mother respond by telephoning them.

THE MEANING OF HER TEARS

You may wonder how a great master like Mother could cry. Once, when Br. Srikumar (Swami Purnamritananda) had to be away from Mother, and Mother was reading a letter he had sent Her, Br. Amritatma noticed that She was weeping. The letter contained a song that Srikumar had written called *Arikilumenkilum*.

*The sun has set in the western ocean;
The day has begun its lament.
It is only the play of the Universal Architect,
So why should you, O closing lotuses, feel dejected?*

*This world, full of misery and sorrow,
Is but the drama of God, the Creator;
And I, the onlooker, am a puppet in His hands
I watch, but have no tears to shed.*

*Separated from You,
I am burning like a flame;
My mind is burning and burning.*

*I am being tossed about
In this ocean of grief,
Unable to find the shore.*

When Amritatma saw Mother's tears, he thought, "How can Mother, who is beyond all feelings, cry like this?" Later when he asked Mother this question, She replied, "Son, in that letter and in the song that Srimon (my son, Sri) had written, Amma felt his innocent longing very strongly. Amma simply mirrors everything, and the reflection of his innocence made Her cry. When you cry or laugh, the image in the mirror does the same. Likewise, in the state of realization, you easily become the other; but you are not attached because your identification is merely a reflection. You don't become attached to or identified with anything. A real master responds to the calls of his devotees and disciples. But the response depends on the intensity of the disciple's call, it depends on his faith and his love for the master.

"Everyone is part of the universal Consciousness. So when you call out to God from the innermost depth of your heart, the waves of that call will reflect in a great soul who is one with that Consciousness—and there is a response. You may see tears in Amma's eyes, but don't mistake them for tears of sadness. They are simply a response to the innocent call from the other end.

"Sri Rama wept when Sita was carried away by the demon, Ravana. He even asked the birds, animals, trees, and plants if they had seen his beloved Sita. Rama's tears were reflecting the pain Sita felt at being separated from her beloved Lord. Similarly, tears welled up in Sri Krishna's eyes when He met his great devotee Sudama. The tears in Krishna's eyes were mirroring Sudama's devotion towards Him. Even in worldly love we can find such examples—provided the love is genuine. The intense feelings of one lover is reflected in the other.

"The lover calls and the beloved responds; the disciple calls and the master responds; the devotee calls and God responds. But the nature of the response depends on the call.

DISTANCING YOURSELF FROM SITUATIONS

"However, the response is just a reflection, because God is beyond everything. He is the Witness Consciousness, completely untouched and detached. In that ultimate state, when you

just witness everything that happens—all the experiences you go through, both good and bad—there is a distance between you and each situation.

“Suppose someone dies, not in your family but in the family of a friend. You go to your friend, you sit with him and try to console him. You say to him, ‘Don’t be sad, my friend. This is part of life; we all have to die some day. But remember that the soul is eternal—only the body perishes.’ You are able to say this because there is a distance between you and the situation.

“But if a death occurs in your own family, your attitude will be quite different. You will then suffer because you are too close to the problem.

“A famous surgeon who has done thousands of operations wouldn’t want to operate on his own wife or child, because he is too attached to them. If someone in his immediate family needs an operation, no matter how experienced or great a surgeon he may be, he will let another surgeon perform the operation. Likewise, a psychologist is too identified with his own problems to really be able to analyze or counsel himself; so he goes to another psychologist for help. A *jivan mukta*, on the other hand, simply witnesses everything that happens in and around him. He may express different feelings, but he is not attached to them. He is there—totally present—and yet not there.”



FARTHER THAN THE FARTHEST,
NEARER THAN THE NEAREST

During the last morning program in Seattle, the following question was asked by an American devotee who was studying the Indian scriptures:

“The *Upanishads* say that the Paramatman (the Supreme Being) is far away, and at the same time, very near.⁷ I’m confused about this statement. How can something be far away and near at the same time? Amma, could you explain this?”

Mother: “Son, that which is everywhere is always near and far away at the same time. The Paramatman is everywhere. We are born within the Supreme Self; we live in it, die in it, and are again reborn within it. It is not a distant entity. The Paramatman is truly ‘nearer than the

⁷ Tat dūre tadvantikē (That which is far away is very near.)—*Ishavasyopanishad* (verse 5)

nearest.’ The apparent distance is due to our ignorance. As long as there is ignorance, the Self (Atman) will appear to be far away, to be ‘farther than the farthest.’⁸ Once the misconception that we are the body is removed, that which is ‘farther than the farthest’ becomes ‘nearer than the nearest.’ We realize that we have never been away from the Paramatman, that we have always existed within it—it was always *here*.

“Imagine that you are standing on the seashore watching the horizon. At a particular point in the distance, the horizon appears to be melting into the ocean. It looks as if the sky is meeting the earth. If there is an island out there, it may look as if the trees on the island are touching the sky. We may think that if we go there, we will arrive at the meeting point of earth and sky. But instead of reaching the horizon, we would find that the horizon appears to be still further away. As we move towards the horizon, it continues to recede from us, so that we can never catch up with it. When we were standing on the shore, the horizon seemed to be touching the island and the trees, but as we approached the island, the horizon moved away. Where, then, *is* the horizon? It is right here, where you are. You and the horizon are at exactly the same point. In the same way, the Paramatman is not somewhere far away—it is within you. In truth, you yourself are the Paramatman.

“People often say, ‘I am sad.’ They are saying that they *are* the sadness. Whenever they feel sad, they become immersed in it. They begin to identify with their sorrow until they feel they are that sorrow.

“The Paramatman, the Supreme Consciousness, is very close. But because of our wrong identification with pain, pleasure, sorrow, anger, and other emotions, which are caused by our wrong understanding that we are the body, rather than consciousness, we experience a distance. This identification is ignorance. Once you transcend that ignorance and are no longer identified with the body, you will not experience that you are in pain, or that you are the pain—but only that you are aware of the pain. You become a witness, simply watching the pain or whatever sensation it may be. Your consciousness stays detached from what is happening to the body. When this realization takes place, the Paramatman will be nearer than the nearest. But until then, it appears to be farther than the farthest. This explains why that which is far away is also very near.

“There is a story about a woman who had an intense desire to get married. For years she had been trying to find a suitable husband, but she hadn’t met the right person. Finally, she gave up. She decided to console herself by traveling around the world. She traveled from

⁸ Dōrāt Sudōre tadihāntikē cha (Farther than the farthest, nearer than the nearest.)—*Mundakopanishad* (3:1:7)

country to country, from continent to continent; and then one day when she was staying in a hotel at the other side of the world, she met a wonderful man, and the two of them fell in love. He turned out to be her perfect soul mate. What astonished them both was not only the fact that they came from the same city, but that they actually lived in the same apartment building and that their apartments were right next to each other. They had been next door neighbors for years, without even noticing each other!

“Children, you may search for God everywhere, but you won’t find Him because He is closer to you than you could ever imagine. He appears to be far away, only for as long as you remain ignorant. Remove your ignorance, shake off your identification with the body and transcend it, wake up and be aware; then you will realize that God is ‘nearer than the nearest.’”

After the program in Seattle, Mother flew back to San Francisco.

GANESHA

In the morning, Mother, the brahmacharis, Gayatri, and Saumya left the Bay Area in a small recreational van, lovingly offered to Mother for Her trip to Mt. Shasta by Dennis and Bhakti Guest. The van wasn’t big enough for everyone, but because they had such a strong wish to be with Mother, they all somehow managed to squeeze in. On the way, Mother stopped in Garberville, a small town on the way to Mt. Shasta, where She held a retreat program at a lodge, surrounded by redwoods and immense sequoia trees. Responding to their invitation, Mother also visited Ken and Judy Goldman, who lived in a mobile home not far from Garberville.

The Goldman’s two small sons were very drawn to Mother. During Her visit, they followed Her around everywhere. Mother taught them to sing a song. Repeating each line after Mother with great enthusiasm, they sang, *Devi Devi Devi Jagan Mohini*.

*O Goddess,
Enchantress of the world,
Chandika,
Destroyer of the demons, Chanda and Munda;
O Chamundesvari,*

Divine Mother,

Show us the right path across the ocean of transmigration.

The two boys asked Mother to play with them. Mother couldn't reject their innocent request, and so She spent some time playing with the two children. Later, while sitting with the family, Mother asked the boys, "Will you be as innocent and have the same devotion when you grow up?" The boys immediately shook their heads in affirmation.

Judy Goldman was so deeply moved by Mother's presence that she burst into tears and couldn't stop crying. Ken was very excited, and was eager to show Mother his collection of Ganesha icons. Mother looked at the Ganeshas with great interest. She reached out and lovingly caressed the big belly of one of the statues, and remarked with a laugh, "What a hungry man! He has the whole universe in this belly!"

Mother pointed at the elephant god's round stomach and said, "The big stomach symbolizes the true seeker's unappeasable hunger to know the Truth. Ganesha's big ears represent *shraddha*, the capacity of a *sadhak* (aspirant) to 'hear', that is, to imbibe, the subtle spiritual principles. An elephant can uproot a huge tree with its trunk, and it can also pick up a small needle. So Ganesha's trunk signifies the *sadhak*'s ability to grasp both the gross and the subtle principles.

"Ganesha's mouse represents desire. Just as one small mouse can destroy an entire crop, a single desire can destroy all our virtues. But a Self-realized soul (Ganesha) has complete mastery over his mind and his desires. That is why He rides on a mouse. At other times, the mouse sits at the feet of Ganesha, gazing intently at the Lord's face, without touching the sweets that are kept in front of the god. This means that a Self-realized soul is the Lord of his own mind; his mind will only move at his command." Mother suddenly looked at Ken and called him "Ganesha." Ken joyfully accepted his new name.

On the morning of their departure, Mother meditated with the brahmacharis and the others beside the swimming pool at the lodge. At ten o'clock Mother left for Mt. Shasta. This trip turned out to be one of the most memorable events of the whole tour.

FAITH IS MORE IMPORTANT THAN REASONING

On the way, Nealu thought it was a good opportunity to talk to Mother, so he asked Her a question:

“Amma, spiritual science always stresses the importance of functioning more from the heart than from the intellect. In fact, I sometimes feel that intellectual reasoning and knowledge is being put down by some of the spiritual masters. Why do they do this?”

Mother: “Son, spirituality is more a question of faith than a subject for intellectual analysis. True faith will develop when the intellect is put aside. This doesn’t mean that intellectual knowledge is irrelevant. The intellect does have its place, but it shouldn’t be overestimated. Don’t think that spirituality is nothing but scriptural knowledge and intellectual analysis. This is often where the problems arise. It is important to create a balance between the intellect and complete trust in the spiritual principles. Your knowledge and reasoning power may, for example, help convince others about the science of spirituality; it may help satisfy their intellectual thirst. However, for your own spiritual development, faith is much more important than reasoning.

“In your spiritual practices, faith is of far more help to you than the intellect. To be able to meditate, you must have complete faith in what you are doing. While engaged in any type of sadhana, you should put aside all doubts, questions, and pondering and focus completely on your spiritual practices; otherwise, you cannot progress spiritually. If you don’t have faith, you should try to develop it by seeking the guidance of a satguru. Intellectual knowledge has its own place; when used in the right way it gives you a certain amount of mental strength and determination. But to become grounded in what you have learned, you need to do rigorous practices. When it comes to actual practice, unconditional faith is what you need. So it’s a question of creating a harmonious balance of faith and knowledge.

“To remember God, you have to forget. To be really focused on God is to be fully and absolutely in the present moment, forgetting the past and the future. That alone is real prayer. This sort of forgetfulness will help you to slow down the mind, and will enable you to experience the bliss of meditation. Genuine meditation is the end of all misery. All suffering is caused by the mind, and the past is of the mind. Only by letting go of the past, which can be achieved through meditation, is it possible to become established in the Self or God.

“In fact, we already have this capacity to forget and remember. It is done quite often. For example, when a doctor is at the hospital, he forgets about his home and his family. And when he goes home to his wife and children, he has to forget about the hospital and his persona as a doctor, if he wishes to be a good husband and father. In the same way as the

doctor forgets his role as a doctor when he is at home, if we want to remember God and focus on the object of our meditation, we have to forget the past, and we even have to forget ourselves. We all know how to do this, to a limited extent, but we haven't yet learned how to tap into the realm of Supreme Consciousness. To be able to drop one aspect of life and embrace another is an art. Letting go of your intellectual side and embracing the attitude of innocent faith is not difficult, as long as you really desire it.

“Sri Shankara⁹ was a Self-realized master. He was also a great scholar with a superb intellect. Through his knowledge and reasoning, he removed many misconceptions about spirituality, and brought to light the right interpretations of the scriptures. At the same time, he had immense faith in what he taught. It was not just because of his intellectual ability to penetrate into the meaning of the scriptures that Shankara was so widely admired and respected, but because he himself was an embodiment of everything he preached. The realization, ‘I am That,’ is possible only through absolute trust. Without that faith you cannot put the spiritual principles into practice. Intellectual certainty is one aspect of spirituality, while faith is another. Both are important. However, the state of Self-realization can be attained through faith alone, whereas intellectual knowledge and reasoning, without faith, cannot take you to the ultimate state.”

IN A STATE OF RAPTURE

As they were driving, they came to a beautiful, clear blue river beside the road. The river was glistening in the sun, and from the car they could hear the sound of the flowing water. Mother was gazing intently at the river, through the car window. Suddenly She went into a state of rapture shouting, “Hoo... hoo... hoo!” (a sound Mother often produces when in a state of ecstasy). She bounced up and down on the seat like a child, while Her hands formed several *mudras*, one after the other. Seeing Mother's divine, intoxicated mood, the driver slowed down the van. Within a few seconds, Mother went into a deep state of samadhi. Inspired by Mother's spiritual mood, the brahmacharis sang a song called *Prapancha Mengum*, as the van continued to move slowly along the river.

O illusory Appearance

⁹ Sri Shankaracharya, who lived in the 8th century, was a great philosopher and exponent of the Advaita philosophy.

*Permeating the entire Universe,
O Radiance, won't You dawn in my mind,
And stay there, shining Your light forever?*

*I will drink in Your love and motherly affection,
And be utterly content;
Coming close to You,
Melting into Your divine light,
All my suffering will vanish.*

*For how many days have I been wandering
In search of You, the Essence of everything?
O my Mother, won't You come to me,
And grant me the bliss of the Self?
O, won't You come?*

When the song came to an end, Mother was again in a state of rapture; and in that state She sang the song, *Radhe Govinda Bhajo*. She was laughing loudly as She sang and Her whole body was moving back and forth, as if dancing in tune with the cosmic rhythm; and as She sang Her hands continued to spontaneously manifest divine mudras. Gradually, Mother returned to ordinary consciousness. For a long time they drove in silence, until Mother again began to speak. She told them a story.

SILENCE IS THE ANSWER

“Amma has heard this story somewhere. Once, there lived a great master who was renowned for his wisdom and spiritual attainment. He used to give beautiful, deeply inspiring sermons. The people of a certain village cherished a desire to hear the master speak, and invited him to their village. The master accepted their invitation. When he arrived, there where hundreds of people waiting for him. After a grand reception, the master stood on a podium to deliver his speech. The crowd was eagerly waiting for him to speak. He said to them, ‘My dear brothers and sisters! I feel happy and privileged to be here with you today. But let me ask you something. Do any of you know the subject I am going to talk about?’ As

a response to his question, the whole audience shouted, 'Yes, we know!' The master paused, looked out at the crowd, smiled, and said, 'Well, then, if you already know everything about it, there is no need for me to say anything, is there?' Without another word he got down from the podium and left the village.

"The villagers were very disappointed. They decided to invite the master again; and again he agreed to come.

"The day arrived and the master was received in the traditional manner. He was about to deliver his speech, when he asked the audience the same question he had asked the previous time. But this time the villagers were prepared. So when he asked, 'Do any of you know the subject I'm going to talk about today?' all the villagers shouted in unison, 'No, we don't know anything!'

"The master paused, and there was a slightly mischievous smile on his face. He said, 'My dear ones, if you don't know anything at all about the subject, then it would be useless for me to speak, wouldn't it?' Before anyone could protest, the master had left. The audience was stunned. They had been so sure that 'no' was the answer the master expected. You can imagine how disappointed they must have felt. However, they refused to give up. They asked themselves, 'If the answer to the Master's question is neither yes nor no, what, then, could it be?' What were they to say to finally benefit from his wisdom? The villagers had a meeting to discuss the matter, and they decided what they would do next time the master asked them the question. They were certain that this time it would work. Once again they invited the master. He arrived on the appointed day. The villagers were both nervous and excited. The master stood up before them, and as usual he asked the same question: 'Brothers and sisters, do you know anything about the subject I wish to talk about?' Without a moment's hesitation, half the crowd shouted, 'Yes!' and the other half shouted, 'No!'

"The villagers then waited expectantly for the master's response. But the master said, 'Well, then, let those of you who know teach those who do not know!'

"This was an unexpected blow to everyone. Before they had time to recover from the shock, the master quietly left the place.

"What were they to do now? The villagers were determined to hear him speak. They decided to give it one more try. They had another meeting. People suggested all sorts of things, but nothing seemed to be the answer. Finally, an old man stood up and said, 'Whatever we answer seems to be wrong, so the next time the Master asks that question, wouldn't it be best if we were absolutely quiet and said nothing?' The villagers agreed.

“The next time the master arrived, he asked the same question as usual. But this time no one spoke. It was so quiet you could hear a pin drop. In the depth of that silence, the master finally began to speak, and the words of his wisdom flowed out towards the villagers.”

When Mother had finished the story, Br. Amritatma thought, “The story is beautiful, but what does it mean? It must have a deeper meaning. If Mother would only explain....” Before he had finished formulating the question in his mind, Mother turned to him and said, “The meaning of the story is that only in the depth of pure silence can we hear God’s voice. During his first visit, when the master asked if they knew what he was going to speak about, the villagers said, ‘Yes, we know.’ That is the ego. The thought, ‘I know’, is the ego speaking. When the intellect (the seat of the ego) is full of information, nothing else can enter into it. The mind that is brimful with intellectual knowledge cannot receive even a drop of true spiritual knowledge. This is the reason why the master did not speak during his first visit.

“During his second visit, the villagers replied to the same question saying, ‘No, we don’t know anything!’ That is a negative statement. A closed, negative mind cannot receive the highest wisdom either. To receive pure knowledge, one has to be wide-open and receptive like an innocent child.

“The third time, they said both yes and no. This exemplifies the doubtful, vacillating nature of the mind. An unsteady, doubting mind is incapable of being open to any real knowledge.

“Finally, when the people kept quiet, the master spoke. Only when the mind stops all its interpretations can we hear the inner voice of God.

“These four responses can be compared to a tumbler that we want to fill with water. The first answer, ‘Yes, we know,’ is like a tumbler that is already filled to overflowing. There isn’t room for another drop. The second response, ‘No, we don’t know anything,’ is like a tumbler turned upside-down. It would be useless trying to pour anything into it. The third response, when the two opposite answers, ‘yes’ and ‘no,’ were given, can be compared to a water-filled tumbler mixed with dirt. The water has been contaminated and has lost its purity. Any additional water poured into it would also be spoiled. Only the fourth answer, silence, is like an upright, empty tumbler that is capable of being filled with, and retaining, the water of knowledge.

“To be able to listen to, assimilate, and digest the words of a true master, we need to develop our inner ear. The physical ears are not capable of listening to God. They usually

work like two ventilators: the sound comes in through one ear and goes out through the other. We need to have a special ‘inner’ ear.

“To be able to imbibe the teachings of the master, we have to be open within. We need to develop a special ‘womb’ to contain the master’s teachings. A noisy mind that is full of words should be taught to be silent and to listen intently. Not just a part of you should listen, not just your mind and ears—you should listen with your whole being.

THE WAY TO SURRENDER

“Only when Arjuna stopped speaking on the battlefield, did Krishna begin to speak to him. In the beginning Arjuna had countless misconceived ideas. He talked and philosophized endlessly. Finally, he was exhausted and felt utterly helpless. He dropped his weapons to the ground and stood quietly next to Krishna. His bow and arrows symbolize his ego—the intellect, the feeling of ‘I’ and ‘mine’, the attitude that ‘I’ can fight and win. He dropped the ego and stood quietly in a state of utter despair. His worldly knowledge, his royalty, his strength and skills as a great warrior couldn’t help him now. He had no choice but to accept his total failure; and, having done so, he exposed his sense of helplessness to Krishna. Only then did the Lord speak, because now Arjuna was open enough to listen. That silent stillness is the state of surrender. Only in the silence of surrender can you truly listen. In that inward silence, when your whole being is still and quiet, surrender takes place. That is why it is impossible to teach anyone how to surrender. It is something that simply happens in the presence of a satguru. The master slowly leads the disciple to this state, by creating the necessary conditions for it to happen.

“When Arjuna demanded to take a look at his enemies, who were eagerly waiting to fight with Krishna and the Pandavas¹⁰—Krishna, the Universal Being, deliberately placed the chariot in such a way that Arjuna could see Bhishma, Drona, and the other warriors whom he deeply loved and respected. The Lord had slowly created different situations leading up to this finale: Arjuna’s self-surrender. This was only one among a chain of circumstances which had been created for this purpose. Krishna knew that what was happening now would bring the whole process to a climax; and this is precisely what happened. Seeing there before him on the battlefield the people with whom he was about to fight: his beloved kith and kin and his teachers whom he worshipped, Arjuna was overcome with attachment and fear. He began

to speak like someone deeply disturbed, emptying out all that was in his mind, all the knowledge and values he had gathered from the outer world. The Lord allowed him to let it all out, and Arjuna was soon exhausted. He became aware of the state of delusion he was in. He realized that he couldn't find a solution to the extraordinary situation he now had to face. In his state of utter hopelessness and helplessness, he finally surrendered to the Lord. However, it happened only after all his talking had come to an end. From the world of words he slipped into a new world of inner silence, and he was able to listen to Krishna's words of wisdom with his whole being.

"Everyone hopes to succeed in life. A successful person hopes to continue doing well, or even better; there are people who have not yet made it to the top, but they are trying; and there are those who have failed, and yet they continue to hope they will succeed. But all those people are very tense. They experience a great deal of stress and strain. Whether they have failed or succeeded in the past, they have a lot of hopes about the future, and they're always dreaming about it. In the case of such people, surrender will not come easily, for they will be strongly inclined to continue their struggle. On the other hand, a person who finds himself in the same mental state as Arjuna has no choice but to surrender. Such a person feels utterly defeated. In that state there is no longer any question of hope or hopelessness, past and future. You just surrender.

"Only a satguru can lead you to this state. Only in his presence can this happen. Put aside all your logic, interpretations, and explanations, as Arjuna did, because it won't help you in the critical stage when you realize you have failed. That failure is the failure of the ego, the failure of your intellect. Accept your failure and allow yourself to move into a state of inner silence. Then, in that silence you can easily surrender.

"It is when you have tried and failed that you are truly able to surrender. Though you fail time and again, you continue to try until, finally, there comes a point when you accept your failure; you fully experience and understand your incapacity to move forward. It is at that point that you surrender. So keep trying. That ultimate sense of failure must come to everyone, either today or tomorrow.

"All effort comes from the ego. Because the ego is limited, its capacity is also limited. Utter defeat and failure is therefore bound to happen, sooner or later. When that happens, your mind becomes silent and you surrender. Your whole being turns towards God. It is your efforts that lead you to the state of utter failure, which in turn helps you to surrender.

¹⁰ Arjuna and his brothers

“Unfortunately, we have a strong tendency to find an explanation for everything. Never accepting our failures, we find some reason or other to justify everything we do. Amma has heard a story.

“A man went into a restaurant and ordered a meal. He was so hungry that as soon as the food was placed on the table before him, he began to eat ravenously, using both his hands. The waiter was puzzled by his strange behavior and asked, ‘What are you doing? Why are you eating like that with both hands?’ The man replied, ‘Because I don’t have three hands!’”

Mother continued, “Most people are like that. They are not honest enough to tell the truth or to admit their failures. No matter what happens, they always try to justify their actions.”

Mother stopped talking and sat looking out through the car window. It had been a long drive. They had left Garberville at ten in the morning and it was now five o’clock. They were nearing Mt. Shasta. For some time, Mother sat gazing up at the sky. Then the mountain came into view. Mother kept looking intently at some fixed point, either in the sky or on the mountain—no one could tell.

Mt. Shasta

When they finally arrived at six o’clock, Mother received a warm welcome by a group of local devotees. Two hours later She was driven to the town where She was to give an evening program of bhajans and darshan. Many people had traveled up from San Francisco to be with Mother. There was a big crowd waiting for Her at the hall. It was located near the source of the huge Sacramento river, which is just a spring of crystal-clear, ice-cold water that pops out of the ground, carrying down the melted snow from the mountains.

After the bhajans, Mother gave darshan to Her children. By the time everyone had gone up to Mother, it was 3 a.m. Despite Her long journey and so many hours of giving darshan, Mother still looked as fresh as a newly blossomed flower.

The lifestyle at Mt. Shasta was simple. There were only small, rustic houses with no electricity. But it was quiet and peaceful. People in this area liked to be away from all the noise and bustle of city life. They preferred to be with nature, even though they had relatively few material comforts.

The morning darshan was held on a hill out in the open, against the backdrop of the sacred mountain, which loomed majestically above the scene, silently witnessing the beauty and grace of the Universal Mother blessing its foothills with Her presence. People were sitting

around Mother in the chilly morning air, which was permeated with the power of Mother's presence. The day began with meditation, and then Mother gave darshan. Spending the day with Mother in this beautiful landscape was an unforgettable experience for everyone.

A few months earlier, the local devotees had built a small temple for Mother. They now expressed a wish that Mother would hold the next day's darshan inside the temple. When Mother agreed, the excited devotees spent the whole afternoon cleaning and widening the area in front of the little building to enable more people to sit inside.

As Mother walked into the temple the next morning, people were clapping their hands and singing, *Amma Amma Taye*. The joy they felt could clearly be seen on their faces.

*O Mother,
Dearest Divine Mother,
Goddess of the Universe,
Who nourishes all creatures,
You are the Primal Supreme Power.*

*Everything in this world takes place
Because of Your divine play;
Protect me, O Mother.
Without conceiving in the womb,
You have given birth of millions upon millions of beings.*

*O Sister of Lord Vishnu who rides the bird Garuda,
O Beautiful One,
From the moment of my birth
I have sung Your praises.
You are the Perfect One,
The Primordial Cause,
The Destroyer.*

*O Mother, You are the goal of my life
O Goddess of the world, don't ignore me!
You are the Goddess Lalita, the Ruler of the world*

*O Mother, if you cast me into trouble again and again,
 Who else will be there to protect me?
 O Mother with the enchanting eye,
 You are the omnipresent Witness of everything.*

*Oh Mother,
 Dearest Divine Mother...*

After the usual ceremonial washing of Mother's holy feet, followed by arati and meditation, Mother began calling people to come for darshan. A little girl pushed her way through the crowd and came up to Mother. She handed Mother a drawing. It was an attempted portrait of Mother. Just below the drawing she had written in a big childish scrawl, "I love you, Amma." Mother looked very moved. She took the picture and brought it up to Her face, touching it to Her forehead as a sign of love and reverence. Mother hugged the little girl and lifted her into Her arms. Holding her close, Mother rocked her back and forth with great affection.

Finally, when Mother wanted to put her down, the little girl refused to let go. Claspings her arms around Mother's waist she said loudly, "No! I want to stay in Amma's lap!" This innocent statement evoked much laughter. Someone shouted, "Yes, that's what all of us would like to do!" Again everyone laughed. Mother also burst out laughing, while the little girl snuggled in Mother's lap with her eyes closed. Eventually, her mother came and managed to coax her away..

THE ATMAN ALONE IS

A devotee asked Mother: "Amma, I have seen you touching your forehead when you receive an offering or a letter from your devotees, as if you were bowing down to it. You did this just now when that little girl gave you her drawing. What is the significance of this?"

Mother: "Children, Amma beholds God in everything. To Amma, there is nothing but God, the Paramatman. The Atman alone is. Amma sees everything as part of the whole, as an extension of Her own Self. Once we experience everything as part of ourselves, how is it possible to ignore anything? How can we consider any living being, or even a non-living

object, to be insignificant? In that state there is no sense of otherness: everything is permeated with consciousness.

“Only if we perceive ourselves as separate entities can we ignore others or think of them as insignificant, because then we are identified with the ego—with our anger, hatred, jealousy, judgment, and all the other negative qualities. But when we are one with the Self, we do not place any importance on petty feelings. The ego is not given any importance. We constantly remain within the Self, the very center of existence. It is because we have forgotten our true Self, and because the ego interferes, that a sense of otherness is experienced. At present we are only aware of our small self—we are self-centered. We have to grow out of our self-centeredness and become centered in our true Self, in Brahman, the Absolute Consciousness.

“A person who is poor will strive to get rich; an obese person will try to lose weight; and a person who is sick will do everything he can to find a cure. So there is no question of people not being aware of their limited selves. People are very conscious of their bodies and their physical existence. That is not the problem. The problem is that, at the same time, they don’t know anything about the divine inner Self. Once you become aware of the boundless Self, you stop identifying with the small, limited self.

“People have forgotten who they are; that they are the very center of everything, the center of the entire creation. Instead, they identify with something that they are not.

YOU ARE THE CENTER OF THE WHOLE SHOW

“Amma will tell you a story. A great party was in progress. It was a wonderful party; everything was perfect, and all the guests were happily enjoying themselves. Around midnight a crazy gatecrasher sneaked into the house and joined the celebration. He approached the host and said, ‘What a boring party! What a suffocating atmosphere!’ He went on and on about what a terrible party it was in such a convincing way that, finally, the host began to be persuaded. He forgot how much he had been enjoying himself until now and became convinced that it really was a terrible party. He even forgot that he himself was the host! So he said to the gatecrasher, ‘You’re absolutely right. It’s awful! Let’s go somewhere else.’ ‘Yes,’ said the gatecrasher. ‘I will organize a fantastic party—it will be my party, and you will be my guest.’ The gatecrasher began to promise him all sorts of wonderful, enticing things. They left the party together and went to the gatecrasher’s house. It was a dreary

place—ugly, dirty, and lifeless, and no one else was there. But the crazy gatecrasher, believing his own illusions of grandeur, kept trying to persuade his guest that the gloomy house was a beautiful mansion and that they were about to enjoy themselves at any moment. ‘The fun will soon begin,’ he kept saying. But nothing happened. In the beginning the man believed him, but then he suddenly returned to his senses. ‘Wait a moment!’ he exclaimed. ‘What is it?’ said the gatecrasher, looking worried. ‘Oh no!’ exclaimed the man. ‘What am I doing here in this horrible place? I have forgotten that I am the host of that other wonderful party—that is my home! I have forgotten how much I was enjoying myself there.’ Ignoring the gatecrasher’s protests, the man walked out through the door and hurried back to his own house. All his friends were still there having a great time; they hadn’t even noticed he was gone. He smiled at them and happily rejoined the celebration.

“The entire human race is in a similar position. People have forgotten who they are. We are supposed to be living in our own wonderful home, where we belong, enjoying the splendid celebration of life and creation. Like the host in the story, we are, in fact, the center of it all, but we do not know it. Something has gone terribly wrong. The ego has sneaked in and has lured us into a state of utter forgetfulness, a state of unconsciousness. We have forgotten that we are the host of a glorious celebration. Instead, as if sleepwalking, we have left to join the ego, the ‘crazy gatecrasher’, at his non-existing party.

“The ego is an outsider. But we, the host, the real center of the wonderful ‘party’, around whom the whole play of creation is taking place, have forgotten the truth about our real Self. We have mistakenly attached ourselves to the ego, the impostor, identifying with the ego and its distorted views.

“We need to wake up from our stupor and remember that we are the ‘host’, the very center of creation. Then, we, too, will exclaim, ‘Oh no, what am I doing here? I have forgotten that I am the host of that party! That is my home! I have completely forgotten how much I was enjoying myself over there!’ Then you will not waste another moment. You will rush back to your real home, and remain within your blissful, joyful Self.

“From your real dwelling place within the Self, you witness everything. Everything revolves around the Self. Everything is great fun. While remaining forever within the Self, you enjoy the whole play.

“Others are also part of the game, but for them it’s a play of the ego. Being ignorant, they play the game from within the tight clasp of their egos. Instead of simply witnessing the play, they become entangled in it, identifying with it. The awakened soul, on the other hand, never

identifies with the play, though he enjoys taking part in it. For him it is a play of infinite Consciousness. While all the others are playing the game in a state of forgetfulness, as if they were sleepwalking, the one who is centered in the Atman is always fully awake and aware.

“In that infinite play of consciousness, where God is the very center, nothing is insignificant. Everything is permeated with Divinity. Every blade of grass and every sand particle is filled with divine energy. The awakened one thus has an attitude of deep reverence and humility towards all of creation; because once you go beyond the ego, you are nothing—you are infinite nothingness filled with Divine Consciousness. When you have the attitude of constantly bowing down with a feeling of humility towards all existence, that existence flows into you. You experience that everything is part of you, nothing is separate.

“Think of how much you care about yourself. You want to eat good food, live in a wonderful home, sleep in a comfortable bed, travel in a beautiful car, and you don’t want anyone to hurt or insult you in any way. You always want to be happy. This is because you love and care about yourself more than anything. Now imagine what will happen when you become one with everything and everyone. You will love, honor, and care about everyone and everything equally, but with infinitely greater depth and power than you have ever loved yourself.”

Mother began singing a song called *Devi Jaganmata*.

*Hail to the Goddess, the Mother of the world,
The Goddess of Supreme Energy!*

*O Eternal Virgin,
Doing penance on the shores
Of the blue sea at Kanyakumari,
Come and give me a boon!*

*O Mother, whose true nature is Light,
And whose exquisite form
Is made of wisdom, truth, energy and bliss!
Aum
Hail to the Mother of the Universe!*

A BONUS DARSHAN AT MT. SHASTA

There was no darshan scheduled for the next day. In the morning, Mother was supposed to leave for San Francisco, from where She was to fly to New Mexico the following morning. But Mother decided not to waste the day, and announced that She would be giving darshan one more time at Mt. Shasta. Everyone was overjoyed. They had been feeling sad because Mother was leaving.

Once again the devotees prepared the small temple for Mother's darshan.

Mother came at 10 a.m. It was a rainy day, so everyone squeezed into the temple. Before long the little building was completely full.

Even though the Devi Bhava the night before had been very long, Mother looked fresh and radiant as usual. She spent the whole day with the people. Amritatma, who was sitting next to Her, was amazed to see how much Mother gave of Herself, lavishing Her love on each person. Her whole being was present in what She was doing. Through Her every word, look, touch, and smile, Mother poured Herself into the people. Nothing was done in a partial way. Whatever She did at each moment was complete and perfect.

People were glued to Mother's every movement, word, and glance, and to every smile on Her face. No one could bring themselves to leave.

Throughout the day, parents also brought their children up to Mother. The children clearly adored Mother, their faces shining with joy as She loved them, played with them, and joked with them.

To each person who came up to Her, Mother gave a great deal of time and attention. Some people asked questions to clear their spiritual doubts, others asked Her to bless their families or to help them in their careers, while others hoped that Mother could cure their diseases. Many people burst into tears in Mother's lap.

As usual, bhajans were being sung throughout the darshan. Sometimes Mother sang a whole song while a devotee rested in Her lap. Now and then, She went into a deep state of rapture. The temple was filled with an extraordinary feeling of joy and peacefulness. At one point, Mother sang *Mano Buddhya*.

I am not the mind, intellect, ego, or memory

I am not the taste of the tongue
Or the senses of hearing, smell, and sight
I am not earth, fire, water, air, or ether
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva

I am not right or wrong actions
Nor am I pleasure or pain
I am not the mantra or any sacred places
The Vedas, or the sacrifice
I am not the act of eating, the eater, or the food
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva

I have no birth or death
Nor have I any fear
I don't hold any caste distinction
I have no father or mother
Friends or companions
I have no Guru
I have no disciple
I am Pure Bliss Consciousness
I am Shiva
I am Shiva

I have no form
Or movements of the mind
I am the all-pervasive
I exist everywhere
Yet I am beyond the senses
I am not salvation

Or anything that may be known

I am Pure Bliss Consciousness

I am Shiva

I am Shiva

A devotee came up to Mother and asked for a mantra. Mother gave him a mantra, and then, at his request, She spoke about mantras.

THE MANTRA

Mother: “Children, when Amma gives you a mantra, She sows a seed of spirituality within you. She transmits a part of Herself into your heart. But you have to work on it. You have to nurture that seed by meditating, praying, and chanting your mantra regularly, without fail. You have to be totally committed.

“The natural way to get yogurt is by adding a spoonful of yogurt to warm milk. Having added the culture, you let it stand for some time, and thus, all the milk is transformed into yogurt. In the same way, Amma has transmitted part of Herself into you. Now you have to ‘let the milk stand’—you have to attain a state of inward stillness by constantly repeating your mantra and doing other spiritual practices. Your entire being will thus be transformed and you will then realize your divine nature.”

A young man interrupted:

“Amma, long ago, a spiritual master would put a potential disciple through rigorous tests before he gave him a mantra. Amma, you don’t do that. Why do you give us mantras without first testing our competency?”

Mother smiled and replied: “Simply because Amma loves you! How can a mother not want to help her children! However incompetent her children may be, a mother can only be compassionate towards them. Children, you are Amma’s own, and Amma wants all Her children to reach the ultimate goal. This is why She gives you a mantra. You don’t need to analyze the reason; just make use of the mantra by constantly chanting it, and it will take you to the state of realization.

“The vital force of a perfect master has been sublimated and is completely pure. There is no lust in such a being. He or she is like a vast transformer which can transmit an unlimited amount of power to others. By receiving mantra initiation, you imbibe some of the master’s

spiritual power. By doing sadhana you can become that pure 'Essence' itself. In other words, you become like the master, or you become one with the master.

"The mantra given by a satguru will take you to the state of the supreme swan, the *Paramahansa*."¹¹

As Amritatma was translating, he mispronounced the word "swan", and it sounded as if he was saying "swine." Everyone was wondering what Mother could possibly mean by this. When Amritatma saw the confusion on their faces, he repeated the word several times. The people said, "Swine? What do you mean by swine?" Someone said, "You don't mean a pig, do you?" Amritatma said, "No! No!" Finally, someone figured it out and said, "Oh, you mean swan!" When the misunderstanding was translated to Mother, She laughed so much, Her whole body was shaking.

By this time, almost everyone in the tent knew they wanted a mantra, and Mother was ready to fulfill their wish. When each person had gone up to Her and had received a mantra, Mother continued to speak on the subject.

"To begin with, chant the mantra quietly, while moving your lips. Then chant it mentally. Then with each inhalation and exhalation, chant the mantra until it becomes spontaneous and continuous. You will eventually reach a state of meditation in which the mind becomes still, and the *japa* (repetition of the mantra) will stop of its own accord."

Question: "But Amma, where can we find sufficient time to chant the mantra in the midst of our busy lives?"

Mother: "Children, if you have the determination and sincerely long for it, you will somehow find more than enough time. Just be patient. Amma will tell you a story.

"There was once a very busy businessman who was experiencing a lot of tension and worries in his life. None of the methods he used to try to calm his mind seemed to work. One day he saw a holy man sitting under a tree and decided to approach him for advice.

"Bowling down humbly before the master he said: 'Oh Revered One, my mind is filled with tension. I have no peace of mind. Please tell me what I can do to find happiness.'

"The sage replied, 'Try to do some spiritual practices every morning and evening.'

"'But where would I find the time for such things?' exclaimed the businessman. Saying thus, he brought out a bundle of keys from his pocket and dangled them in front of the

¹¹ The ultimate state is symbolically represented by a swan. It is said that the swan can extract milk from a mixture of milk and water. This represents the supreme state of being able to discriminate between the Atman and *anatman*, the eternal Self and the ever-changing body and outer world.

master. 'Just look at how many keys I have!' he said. 'Each key represents a multitude of responsibilities I have to attend to! So please suggest a much easier path.'

"The master replied, 'All right then, I will initiate you into a mantra. Try to repeat it a few times each day, that's all.'

"But I don't have enough free time to do even that! Isn't there an easier method?"

"How far is it from your bed to your bathroom?" asked the mahatma.

"Puzzled by the strange question, the businessman replied, 'About fifteen yards.'

"In that case, I'm sure you don't have any other work to do when you are walking the short distance to your bathroom. So try to repeat the mantra at least during those few seconds every morning.' And having said this, the mahatma gave the man a mantra.

"The next morning when the man woke up, he remembered to chant his mantra on his way to the bathroom. Then, as he was brushing his teeth, he thought, 'I can chant the mantra a few times now as well.' The same thing happened while he was taking a bath, when he was putting on his clothes, and while driving to work. In fact, many times during the day, he realized that he was free to chant his mantra at least a few times. And as the days went by, he managed to find more and more time to chant his mantra, until it became his habit to repeat it wherever he was, no matter what he was doing. This had a great effect on him. By chanting his mantra he became a changed man. He found the inner peace he needed, and his business also greatly improved.

"Some people want to know the meaning of the mantras. But when you are traveling in an airplane it isn't necessary to know what type of metal the plane is made of, how the instruments work, or who the pilot is. You don't have to know those details. The only important thing is that you reach your destination. By simply repeating the mantra, you will reach the goal.

"The ultimate goal of life is Self-realization. Knowing this, we should try to understand the transitory nature of the world. Then, with strong faith, determination, and full concentration, we should chant our mantra during every possible moment.

"You are trying to cross the ocean of transmigration, the cycle of birth and death. The mantra is the oar of the boat; it is the instrument you use to cross the *samsara* of your restless mind, with its unending thought waves.

"The mantra can also be compared to a ladder that you climb to reach the heights of God-realization.

“The mantra can be chanted anywhere and at any time. You should chant it always—even when you’re in the bathroom. If you constantly repeat the mantra, while visualizing the deity that the mantra represents, you yourselves will gradually take on the characteristics of that deity.”

Question: “Amma, is it all right to visualize your form?”

Mother: “You can do so if you wish. Amma would be happy if hundreds of people became like Her, because then Amma could serve many more people in the world.”

“ALL YOUR THOUGHTS PASS THROUGH ME”

It was now late in the afternoon. Br. Amritatma was exhausted and was beginning to feel restless. He had been busy the whole day, without a moment’s break, translating Mother’s answers to all the questions She was asked, and he was also busy giving instructions to those who had received a mantra. But Mother showed no sign of fatigue. She was smiling happily, glowing with Her inexhaustible love and energy. Amritatma wanted to say to Her, “Amma, it’s enough! It’s 4 o’clock. Why can’t you stop?” As he was thinking this, Mother turned to him and said, “How can Amma stop when Her children are crying for help? Son, you should surrender and accept, because that’s how real joy is found.”

Mother gazed at Amritatma for a moment and said, “Son, every thought of my children passes through me.”

At five in the afternoon, Mother finally finished giving darshan and got up. But, before She left, She stayed in the temple a few more minutes and chatted with everyone. They were overwhelmed with gratitude towards Mother for Her compassion.

Finally, at a quarter past five, Mother left. As She walked towards the van, She sang, Shiva, Shiva, Hara, Hara.

O Auspicious One

Destroyer of the unreal

Who is clothed in the clouds

O Beautiful One

Who is playing the damaru drum

Who holds the trident in His hand

Bestowing fearlessness and boons

Who has matted hair locks

And limbs covered with ashes

Who is adorned with a garland of cobras

And a necklace of human skulls

Who supports the crescent moon on His forehead

And whose eyes are filled with compassion

O Auspicious One

O Destroyer

Great God

When Mother stepped into the van, everyone crowded around it, wanting to catch a last glimpse of Mother before She left. When the van sped away it was still raining, as it had done all day—not a gray, dreary rain, but a cheerful shower dancing on the ground. It was as if nature was reflecting the atmosphere of joy and celebration around Mother, playfully mimicking the outpouring of Her grace with a continuous shower of shining raindrops.

Santa Fe

On June 4 Mother arrived in New Mexico, where She was going to spend almost two weeks giving darshan in Santa Fe and nearby Taos. In Santa Fe Mother stayed with Steve and Kathy Schmidt who lived in the countryside just outside the town.

Mother received people in the Schmidt's living room. Though the crowd was small, Mother spent many hours giving darshan.

HOW TO HEAL THE WOUNDS CAUSED BY THE PAST

A young man came up to Mother and asked a question: "Amma, many Westerners have been hurt and disillusioned by some of the gurus that have come to the West. In the name of spirituality and the importance of self-surrender, they have exploited the men and women who have sincerely approached them for guidance. They have exploited them financially, sexually, and emotionally. Many have lost their faith in gurus and spirituality because of

these incidents. Amma, how can these people overcome their loss of faith, and their fear and suspicion? How can their faith in a guru ever be rekindled?”

Mother: “Only in a *satguru*’s (Self-realized master’s) presence can the deep wounds of the heart, which have been caused by a false guru, be healed. You may have been with a so-called guru who has hurt you in many ways, but don’t ever lose your faith or give up hope. Amma can assure you that the time and energy you have dedicated to your sadhana have not been wasted. The power you have acquired through your spiritual practices is still there, because, unlike material gain, what you have gained through your sadhana cannot be lost.

“When the hurt feelings you harbor deep within are manifested outwardly, they are expressed as anger, hatred, anxiety, and guilt. If your inner wounds are not healed, those negative tendencies will accumulate and grow worse.

“Unfortunately, there are many sincere aspirants who have been deeply hurt by so-called gurus. Amma understands how difficult it must be for a seeker who has been hurt and misled to trust anyone. But complete distrust is not a solution; it will only make you far too negative, which will be the cause of further fear and anxiety. If the wounded seeker should happen to come across a *satguru*, a truly realized being, the *satguru*’s mere presence, touch, look, and words can heal the inner wounds, no matter how deep they are.

“Children, many of you have deep inner wounds. There is so much pain. Those wounds and that pain give others the power to hurt you, again and again. Words cannot heal you, nor can intellectual knowledge; but the unconditional love and compassion you experience in the presence of a perfect master can heal your wounds, and you will receive the necessary strength to prevent you from being hurt again by anyone. You will no longer be vulnerable because of any psychological wounds, and therefore, no person or situation will have the power to harm you.

“However, before you can remain unaffected by situations, you have to work on removing the existing pain and hurt feelings. But you cannot do it alone. You are a sick patient, so to speak, and you do not know enough about your disease or its treatment. You need a competent healer who is able to penetrate deep within your mind, who can clearly see your problems and remove them. A person with only ordinary eyes cannot help you. Only someone whose inner eye is opened can heal you, and that person is the *satguru*.

“If you feel you can no longer trust anyone because of your past experiences with a false guru, who will lose by this? Not the true master who is willing to help you. It makes no difference to him whether you surrender to him or not. Being perfectly complete as he is, the

satguru has nothing to gain or lose by anything. He doesn't need anyone's praise or adoration. He has no desire for fame, nor does he need any disciples. The master is the wealthiest of all beings, the entire universe is contained within him. He is the master of the universe. His very presence creates a constant wave of circumstances in the disciple's life, which leads to the disciple's transformation. There is no force involved, nor does the master make any claims. If you trust him, you will be greatly benefited; if you don't trust him, you will simply remain as you are.

"Suppose you happen to walk past a garden full of exquisitely beautiful flowers. As you glance at them, a hint of their beauty and scent reaches you. But instead of pausing to enjoy the garden, you ignore it and walk on. Who loses by this? The flowers have nothing to gain or lose. It is you who lose what could have been a precious experience. Whether you care to enjoy them or not, the flowers will continue to manifest their beauty. They are simply offering themselves to the world, without the slightest wish to be praised or adored.

FAITH AS A WHOLE CANNOT BE LOST

"You are asking how to rekindle the faith of those who have lost their faith due to the bitter experiences they have had with other gurus. Children, your faith cannot be totally lost. Faith in someone or something can be lost, but your faith as a *whole* cannot be lost.

"Most people, even after such bitter experiences, decide to get on with their lives. They may have lost faith in spirituality and all spiritual masters, but they haven't lost faith in life itself. After all, one can observe that they are living normal lives; they are working, and many of them are raising families. So, they still believe in many things.

"Very few people believe that spirituality is an important part of life. Even fewer consider it a way of life, the very essence of life itself. The traumatic experiences mentioned in your question would be a terrible blow to anyone. However, there are seekers who have the mental strength, courage, and spiritual understanding to overcome their initial shock and disappointment. They realize that the so-called guru is not a real master, and that they have made an unfortunate mistake in trusting him. After such a deeply distressing experience, the genuine seeker will have the spiritual insight to see what has really happened. He will immediately leave the false guru and search for a perfect master, who can lead him to the goal of God-realization.

“Such a seeker will certainly find a real master, or it would be better to say that the master will find him: the master will appear in his life, without him having to wander about looking for a teacher. This will happen because of the disciple’s sincerity and intense longing. It has to happen.

“For the sincere seeker, spirituality is not a minor aspect of life—it is as much a part of him as his own breath. His faith is unshakable. Nothing can destroy his faith in the possibility of experiencing God, or his faith in the great masters who are established in that state.

“Even in the case of people who have been deceived by a false guru and react by turning away from the spiritual path, their faith has not been totally destroyed. Their thirst to know God and to be with a true master still exists deep within them. It may stay hidden for awhile, but it is bound to resurface when the time is ripe. Sometimes this happens when they hear about or see a picture of a great satguru, or if they happen to meet a Self-realized soul. They must have tasted the bliss of God somewhere, either in this or a previous life, and the memory of that experience remains within them, ready to express itself when the proper time comes.

“If you no longer believe in the spiritual masters, it is because you don’t believe that spirituality is really necessary, that it’s an indispensable part of life. You may think you can live without it—and of course you can to a certain extent—but your life will lack any real charm, richness, joy, or meaning.

“Suppose you were to suffer a great loss in your business. Would you give up hope and stay idle for the rest of your life? No, you’d somehow try to make up for the loss by adopting more effective methods in your business. You may feel disappointed to begin with, but then you’ll pick yourself up and start again. You have to, because it’s a question of survival, a very real need. So you regain your faith and resume your work. One may ask why people don’t have the same attitude towards spirituality and the spiritual masters. If they happen to experience a disappointment on the spiritual path, why don’t they feel the urge to continue their pursuit? The answer is that they don’t really believe spirituality is an existential problem. The general feeling is that if we lose faith in the spiritual principles, we can live without them, because it won’t raise any serious challenge to our lives.

“You may once have believed in spirituality and trusted someone whom you believed to be a real master. Unfortunately, owing to some bad experiences, you lost your faith, and that part of your life was apparently closed forever. But it did not die. A small part of it remains alive. Sooner or later, from that ‘green’, living area, the shoot of spirituality will again come

forth. But only if you meet a satguru can this happen. The satguru will rekindle your faith and heal the wounds and the pain of your past experiences.

“Children, if your faith in God and spirituality was sincere and innocent to begin with, it will eventually return, no matter what you have been through.

“Amma knows many people who have had some bitter experiences with false gurus, which shook them at the very foundation of their faith, and yet they have regained their faith and are again inspired to continue their sadhana. Amma knows that there are many such people present here today. Children, faith in God or in a satguru is the only way to make you truly happy and contented, to make your life a festive celebration.

“If you think about it, it is a form of prejudice to believe that all spiritual masters are false because of the bad experience you may have had with one particular person. Suppose you go to a library. As you enter the place you pick up a book from a shelf, and it happens to be a third-rate novel. You react by walking out of the library saying to yourself, ‘Oh no! All the books in this library are worthless!’ There may be many good books in there, but your hasty judgment prevents you from discovering and enjoying them.

“Or suppose you enter a shop at the market place. You want to buy some milk, but unfortunately you have mistakenly entered a liquor shop. You immediately get back into your car and drive away saying to yourself, ‘How awful! All the shops in this area are liquor shops!’ Wouldn’t that be foolish? Don’t be too quick to judge or to jump to conclusions. Be calm and patient; use your power of discrimination, and be open. Otherwise you are bound to miss many great opportunities in life, many precious experiences.”

A SATGURU IS BEYOND ALL VASANAS

After a short, meditative silence, another question was asked.

“Amma, how can a spiritual master, who is supposed to be beyond all *vasanas* (desires and tendencies), have sexual desires?”

Mother: “A true spiritual master is beyond the mind and the ego. In such a master all sexual energy has been converted into pure *ojas* (vital energy), which he uses for the ultimate good of the world. A satguru is someone who has moved out of the sex center, which is the lowest center of existence, to Sat-Chit-Ananda, which is the highest center of existence.

“All desires exist in the mind. Once the mind is dissolved, there can be no question of having any desires. In that state no trace of desire remains. The so-called gurus who exploit

their disciples, sexually or otherwise, or who try to force their ideas on people, are not true masters—far from it. They are still strongly identified with their minds and their desires. A true master will help his disciples to overcome their *vasanas*. His intention is to make them detached from the grip of the fleeting pleasures and objects of the world. The master teaches the disciple, who until now has been dependent on external objects for his happiness, to become *independent*, finding happiness and contentment in his own Self. However, to be able to lead the disciple from bondage to freedom, the master must himself be completely free from the grip of any *vasanas*. He must be free from all identification with the mind and its desires. How can he uplift his disciples if he himself is still enslaved by the mind with all its whims and fancies?

“A satguru lives in the world with the selfless intention of leading others out of the dark. Through his words and deeds, he constantly sets an example for his disciples and devotees to follow. He is a living witness to all the sacred scriptures of the world. Such a master is the embodiment of all the divine qualities, such as love, purity, self-sacrifice, patience, and forgiveness. The great masters of the past have given us clear instructions on what a true master is like and what his qualities are. So there is no need to be confused or deluded.”

ONCE ACQUIRED, YOUR SPIRITUAL POWER CANNOT BE LOST

Question: “Amma, you have mentioned that the spiritual power we gain through spiritual practices cannot be lost, that it will always remain within us. But what about a sadhak who falls from the path? If he, for example, suddenly ceases to be celibate, or if he explodes with anger, doesn’t he lose his accumulated energy?”

Mother: “Children, when something like that happens, don’t think you will lose all the spiritual power you have gained through hard work. Rather, you are creating another powerful obstacle which will prevent you from progressing spiritually. It will also add to your existing *vasanas*.

“The purpose of sadhana is to reduce the existing *vasanas*, and not to add anything to them. When you get angry, it doesn’t destroy the power you have accumulated through your sadhana. It does, however, add to your negative tendencies. By creating more negativity, you prolong the journey towards Self-realization, because now additional effort is needed.

“Children, there is no need to lose faith or to feel disappointed. The spiritual energy you have acquired through your sadhana remains within you. Neither your efforts nor the fruit of your actions can be destroyed. If you have done only one second of sadhana, that merit will always be there—and now, you need only do the rest of it. So don’t ever give up hope. Don’t lose your faith or enthusiasm.

“In worldly life things may go wrong in two ways: There may be complete destruction, or things may turn out the opposite of what you expected. In the first example, suppose you have cultivated a field of rice paddy. You have worked hard and done everything necessary to get a good crop. The plants are growing healthily and you are expecting a rich harvest. But the night before the harvest, there is a terrible storm and the entire crop is destroyed. In this case, you have to start the process of sowing and cultivating all over again.

“In the second example, you have enrolled your son at college. You are expecting him to study hard, to get high marks, and to pass with honors; but all your expectations come to naught when he falls into bad company. He doesn’t even bother to appear for his exams and is finally expelled. He ends up ruining his life. So things can turn out very differently from what you expect. However, this is not the case with spirituality. If you have done even one minute’s worth of sadhana, the power you have thereby gained will stay within you; it can never be destroyed; that minute will be stored deep within you and can never be lost or dissipated, not even after several lifetimes. Unlike the effort you put forth to accomplish worldly or material goals, spiritual sadhana can never be done in vain. Your actions have to bear fruit.

“If you remember God or if you do your sadhana for just one second, it can never be wasted. The merit you gain will stay within you, and will inevitably come forth, like an ungerminated seed that is still fresh and alive. If you have called God with genuine faith and surrender even for a second, it must be rewarded. Those moments when you remembered God will remain within you and will manifest at the right time.

“Children, stay in the bus until you reach your destination. You may see beautiful, tempting scenes along the way. Enjoy them if you wish, but do so without getting off the bus. Always remember your goal. Once the destination has been reached, you can alight from the bus, because then the means (faith or religion) by which you have traveled is no longer needed—you have gone beyond that. As you dwell in the beyond, you can return if you wish, staying in the world to uplift others. On the other hand, you don’t have to come back at all; you can simply dissolve into the infinite.”

In Taos Mother stayed with a woman who had a black Labrador and two parrots. Mother enjoyed playing with the dog. Like all creatures, the dog was very drawn to Mother and approached Her as soon as it saw Her. Mother would throw a stick across the garden, and the dog would dash off and retrieve it, wildly wagging its tail as it brought the stick back to Mother, to be rewarded with Mother's delighted laughter and an affectionate pat.

The two parrots lived in a cage outside, at the entrance of the house. Whenever Mother came back from darshan, She would stop at the cage and talk to the birds, while She fed them a handful of nuts. Mother looked at the parrots with great pity and said, "I know how painful it must be for you to be in that cage; how you long to be free and fly through the sky where you belong."

Mother couldn't bear to see birds being kept in cages. Once, when Mother was visiting Her ashram in Reunion, Swami Premananda, a native of Reunion, who was in charge of the ashram, proudly showed Mother a small aviary filled with lovebirds which someone had donated. But instead of being pleased with the gift, Mother was heartbroken when She saw the little creatures trapped in the aviary, flying from one end to the other. She told Swami Premananda that no one in any of Amma's ashrams should ever have birds in cages. She said, "Look, my son, a sannyasi is supposed to feel great empathy towards all creatures. He should feel the pain and the sorrows, not only of human beings, but of animals, birds, plants, and everything throughout creation. These little birds are suffering. They belong to their own world. We have taken away their freedom which is so valuable to them."

Understanding his mistake, Swami Premananda apologized to Mother, and a few days later, he gave the birds away.

DEAL WITH THE PRESENT, NOT WITH THE PAST

Boulder

A man came up to Mother and asked a question: "Mother, can you tell me about my past life?"

Mother lovingly patted his back and said, "It is the present that needs to be solved, and not the past. What is happening now is far more important than what has happened before. Only by taking care of the present moment will all your questions and problems come to an end. It is meaningless to look back and try to find out about your previous lives—that is not

important. Everything in your present life is the result of the past. Deal with the present; make the very best of each moment, and everything will be all right.

“You are already carrying a heavy burden. You have a tremendous amount to unload. By learning about your previous lives, you will only add more to your existing burden. Amma could tell you who you were, but She will not do so because it would only harm you. It wouldn’t serve any purpose. Amma would never do or say anything that could harm Her children. Her purpose is to help you to grow and to open up, not to close down.

“Suppose Amma were to tell you about your past life: who you were, what you were doing, etc. What if you were to discover that some of the people who are with you now, or someone who is very close to you, have harmed you in a previous life? It would cause unnecessary turbulence in your mind.

“A person may discover that their husband or wife has hurt them deeply in the past, or they may have hated someone who they are very fond of now. Why would you want to recall such things? It would only be destructive.

“Even though Amma knows everything about your previous lives, She prefers not to disclose it. You have come to Amma so that the wounds of the past can be healed, and not to create more wounds. The sole aim of a satguru is to pull you out of the quagmire of the past, and not to make you return to it. Your past is the cause of your suffering. The master will see to it that you do not have to suffer again. He wants to take you beyond all suffering.

“Amma knows a woman who was told by a psychic that she had been the cause of her husband’s death in a previous life. The psychic told her that she had accidentally given her husband the wrong medicine which had suddenly killed him. Having been told this, she suffered terribly and ended up having a nervous breakdown. So, if this is what the past can do to us, why should we know about it? Of course, there have also been many happy events in the past, but people have a tendency to brood on the painful and depressing incidents, rather than the pleasant ones.

“For a human being to be transformed and to transcend all imperfections and limitations, the past has to die. Everyone has the capacity to do this, provided they have the right determination. Forget who you were or what you may have done in the past. Focus on what you would like to *be*; and then, while you are doing whatever is necessary to attain the goal, let go of the future as well. Who or what you may have been until now is of little importance. The past can be compared to a graveyard; and it wouldn’t be wise to live in such a place,

would it? Forget your past. Remember it only when you really need to do so, but don't settle down in it.

“The story of Valmiki, the first poet, who wrote the great epic, *Srimad Ramayana*, is a great example of how it is possible to completely die to the past, no matter how negative one's actions may have been.

“Ratnakaran was a robber. He supported his wife and three children by robbing travelers who passed through the forest where he lived. He was a ruthless man, who never thought about God, morality, or ethics.

“One day, the seven *rishis* (great saints) happened to pass through the forest. As usual, Ratnakaran jumped out in front of the travelers, brandishing his knife, and threatened to kill them if they didn't surrender their belongings. The rishis, who had realized the imperishable Atman, and were ever established in the Supreme Truth, were unperturbed by the robber's threats and remained perfectly serene. They said to him, ‘We are not afraid of death. We will give you whatever we have; but before we surrender everything, we would like you to answer just one question.’ Ratnakaran agreed to their request. The saints asked him to tell them for whom he was doing all those terrible deeds. ‘For my wife and children,’ he replied. The saints asked him, ‘Are your wife and children also willing to take upon themselves a share of your sins?’ Ratnakaran was perplexed by this. He wanted to go and ask his wife and children. The rishis gave him their word that they wouldn't move from the spot until he returned. Quickly, the robber ran to his house and asked his wife if she was prepared to share the consequences of the evil actions he was committing to support her. She answered, ‘No! You alone will have to suffer the fruits of your actions!’ Ratnakaran turned to his children, hoping that at least they would be sympathetic towards him. But they all refused to take upon themselves a share of his sins. Ratnakaran was deeply shocked. He ran back to the rishis, who were patiently waiting for him, and fell at their feet seeking their forgiveness. He completely surrendered to them. With great compassion, they counseled him, initiated him into a mantra, and advised him to do tapas (penance) until he realized God. Ratnakaran sat down right there and then in the forest, and sitting absolutely still, like a rock, he immersed himself in meditation. For years, he stayed there and did severe austerities, until one day, the rishis passed by again; and they remembered their encounter with Ratnakaran. They felt a wonderful serenity in the atmosphere. They found him in deep meditation, completely covered by a termite nest. He had been doing intense tapas and had attained the ultimate state of realization.

“Having aroused him from his state of absorption, the rishis instructed him to go out into the world and sanctify it with his presence, words, and deeds. Because he was sitting in a termite nest, which is known as *valmikam* in Sanskrit, the rishis named him Valmiki.

“This story tells us that it’s possible to let go of the past, to leave it behind and move on to an entirely different realm of consciousness. The past is of the mind; it belongs to the world of thoughts and actions. From the mental plane it is possible to ascend to the highest plane, the plane of Truth, provided you have the necessary determination and detachment. From the world of thoughts, you reach a state of no-thought; and from action you move to freedom from action. You transcend to a state of no-mind. Out of compassion, you may then choose to continue to live in the world, blessing and benefiting all beings.

“That one negative response from his wife and children was enough to transform the life of Ratnakaran, the robber. But more than anything, it was the grace and the blessings of the rishis that helped him to realize the error and futility of the life he had been leading, and which raised him to a different level of understanding. It was through their grace that the perfect situation was created which enabled him to surrender.

“Within that short period of time, his whole outlook on life underwent a transformation. He came to see how meaningless human relationships can be, and the shallowness of worldly so-called love. Though it goes without saying that it was unrighteous to live as a robber, he had nevertheless worked hard, day and night, risking his life for his family. When he then heard them so mercilessly reject him, thinking only about themselves, without the slightest sympathy for him, he had a sudden revelation and another world opened up before him. When this happened, he could simply lay aside his great burden of fear, worries, and attachments. Until then, he had believed that his family loved him, that they would support him under all circumstances; and then he suddenly heard them say no, that they would turn their backs on him when the time came. That ‘no’ was a form of shock treatment that opened a new gate of awareness, through which he suddenly saw life from an entirely different angle. His new understanding helped him to surrender to God, to simply let go of his mind, of his past, and to be at peace. His terrible past disappeared, and a new man was born. The cruel, limited man was dead, and a new, deeply compassionate soul was born.

“Everyone can be transformed like this. The path of spirituality is not just meant for a select few—it is for everyone. However, grace and the willingness to surrender are the most important factors; and when these two factors are combined, a transformation takes place:

both the past and the future disappear, and you are fully present in your heart, abiding in the Self.”

Mother sang the song, *Krishna, Krishna, Radha, Krishna.*

Krishna Krishna Radha Krishna

Govinda Gopala Venu Krishna

Mohana Krishna Madhusudana Krishna

Mana Mohana Krishna Madhusudana Krishna

Murare Krishna Mukunda Krishna



HOW TO RECOGNIZE A TRUE MASTER

Mother was giving darshan in the round dome at the Lama Foundation in the mountains above Taos. While holding someone in Her arms, She was blissfully singing, *Hey Giridhara Gopala*. Everyone participated with great feeling, responding to each line as Mother sang:

O Giridhara

Protector of the cowherds

Beloved of Lakshmi

Destroyer of the demon Mura

O Sweet One

Enchanter of the mind

O Son of Nanda

Beautiful form

Who sports in Vrindavan

Who plays the flute

O Protector of the sages

O Giridhara

*Who wears the Kaustubha gem
And a pearl necklace
Who plays in Radha's heart
Who uplifts the devotees
O Baby Krishna*

*O Protector of the cowherd boys
Playmate of the gopis
Who lifts the Govardhana Hill
O Son of Nanda
Butter stealer*

Someone began talking to Mother about how deluded people are in the world today. Mother listened to him patiently, and then She said, “Yes, son, you are right. In our modern society people are almost blind. Seeing everything only from an external viewpoint, they have lost their clarity of vision. Their way of seeing and evaluating everything is very superficial. They don't perceive things as they really are. We live in a society that is so unaware, it is half asleep.

“Amma has heard a story. One day a man walked into a gift shop looking for a unique present to buy for someone. As he browsed through the shop he was surprised to see a human skull in a glass case. He was even more surprised to see that the price of the skull was 25,000 dollars. He couldn't believe it when he saw another skull in an adjoining glass case, with a price tag that said 50,000 dollars. With great curiosity, he asked the shopkeeper why the skulls were so expensive. The shopkeeper said, ‘Sir, the larger skull is the skull of the first ruler of our country. Being such a unique and precious item, surely you can understand why the price is so high.’

‘Yes, I understand,’ said the customer. ‘But could you please tell me why the smaller one is twice as expensive?’ Coolly, the salesman replied, ‘Oh, the smaller one! Well, that is also the first ruler's. It was his skull when he was young.’

“The man said, ‘O really? How wonderful! I'll take that one!’”

When the laughter had subsided, another question was asked.

“Amma, what is a true spiritual master, and how does one recognize such a master?”

Mother: “A certain intellectual understanding of spirituality is necessary for a seeker to be able to recognize a true master. Of course, one of the criteria is the spontaneous love and attraction one feels towards the master. A satguru is irresistible; people are drawn to him like iron filings to a powerful magnet. The relationship between a real master and disciple is incomparable—there is nothing like it. It has a permanent effect on the disciple. In that relationship the disciple can never come to any harm.

“However, when you feel drawn to someone whom you believe to be a true master, it is very important that you use your power of discrimination. You may feel spontaneously drawn to that person, but as you are not yet established in the state of real wisdom, your feelings are not necessarily to be trusted. You may simply be mesmerized by that person’s powers, believing that he can fulfill your needs and desires. As long as your intuition is not a real, integral part of your nature, your feelings are not always to be trusted.

“Think of how many painful psychological blows you have received in your life. Eventually, you become a big walking wound. Why? Because of your wrong judgment. You have failed to use your power of discrimination. An aspect of *karma* is certainly involved here, but remember that however powerful your past may be, how you deal with the present moment is much more important because that is what determines your future.

“If a person boasts of being a guru, without being established in God-consciousness, he will only hurt people through his thoughts and actions. He may talk, walk, and look like a realized master—but see if he loves everything in creation equally and unconditionally and is truly compassionate. If not, be alert, for he is undoubtedly still identified with the ego. Just to catch disciples he may conceal his ego and act innocently. But once he has caught you, he will begin to exploit you and hurt you, creating deep wounds within you.

“Don’t get excited if you meet somebody who claims to be a Self-realized master, because people who make such claims can be dangerous. First of all, when one attains the state of supreme realization, one loses oneself in the ocean of Sat-Chit-Ananda. You lose your limited, individual self, and there is no one to claim or declare anything. You simply merge into the infinite ocean of bliss and, instead of speaking about it, you prefer to be silent. However, a realized soul sometimes does speak out of love and compassion for the people. But he would never announce, ‘I am Self-realized! I’ll take you to God, on the condition that you surrender to me!’

“An authentic master won’t do anything in particular to attract anyone’s attention, but people will nevertheless be drawn to him. His love, compassion, and serenity spontaneously

flow from him, just as rain pours out of a cloud, or water flows forth in a gushing river.

Those who are thirsting will be drawn to the water.

“If you are sincere, dedicated, and have enough yearning, you will find the perfect master and he will heal your wounds. Your genuine longing to realize God will lead you to a satguru; or rather, the satguru will appear in your life.

“However, be careful when you enter spiritual life. There are people out there who are good at using flowery, persuasive words, who won’t hesitate to make all sorts of claims. Examine such a person and see if he radiates divine love and peace.

“This doesn’t mean that you shouldn’t listen to any spiritual talks given by scholars. It’s all right to do so, but always remember to be cautious and alert. Watch your mind and emotions. Don’t allow yourself to be deluded by false claims and promises. That is why Amma says you should have a basic understanding about spirituality, what it really is, and what to look for in a true master.

If you see someone who constantly radiates divine love and compassion, and deep immeasurable peace; someone with an attitude of humility and profound reverence towards every aspect of creation—that is where you need to go. Divine love cannot be imitated. A person who hasn’t yet reached the goal may talk like one who is realized, but he cannot possibly love or be as compassionate as a Self-realized being.

“Only a lighted oil-lamp can light another lamp. An unlit lamp cannot light anything. The lighted lamp can continue to light any number of lamps, and yet its flame will remain as full and as bright as ever, without losing the slightest fraction of its power. In the same way, only a jivan mukta, a Self-realized master, can awaken the Divinity within you. He is the blazing lamp that can kindle as many unlit lamps as he wants, and yet he remains ever perfect and complete.¹²

“Once you have attained the state of God-consciousness, peace and compassion will inevitably follow; because peace and compassion are as inseparable from God-consciousness as the light from a lamp, or the fragrance from a flower. Once the lamp is lit, it has to shine; and once the flower opens up, it will inevitably spread its fragrance. Likewise, when your heart blossoms into Divinity, peace and compassion become part of you like a shadow, and you cannot avoid your own shadow. So look for a master who constantly radiates divine love,

¹² “Just as one lamp lights another lamp, the guru imparts the knowledge that everything is Brahman—the Brahman that is imperceptible, eternal, the highest, without form or attributes.”—*Guru Gita*

compassion, and peace towards everyone equally—towards all of creation. For that is what a true master is like.”

THE EMBODIMENT OF OUR NOBLEST VALUES

Question: “Amma, some say that a master must abide by certain moral and ethical values in his own life. Others disagree about this. What is your opinion?”

Mother: “A true master will always set an example for his disciples to follow. He is the embodiment of our noblest values. Amma would say that a satguru, even though he is beyond all laws and limitations, must strictly adhere to moral and ethical values. As long as a master remains in his body, serving society, he has to abide by certain fundamental moral and ethical values; for only then can he be an example to others. If the guru says, ‘Look, I am beyond everything, and therefore I can do whatever I please! Just obey me and do as I tell you,’ it can only harm the disciple. It could even cause the disintegration of society. An authentic master would never make such declarations, because it would be a sign of arrogance. Such a statement in itself implies that the sense of ‘I’, the ego, is still very much present. A true master is exceptionally humble. He has the attitude of bowing down before everything, allowing pure existence to flow into him and take complete possession of him. The great masters have no sense of ego at all.

“A genuine master is the embodiment of humility. In him you can observe true surrender and acceptance, and thus you are given a real example that you can relate to. Only in the presence of a fully surrendered soul can the disciple spontaneously and effortlessly surrender, without the slightest feeling of there being any force involved.

“To force the disciple in any way would be harmful and would, if anything, impede the disciple’s development. Real surrender is something that happens naturally within the disciple. A change takes place inwardly. There is a change in his perception and understanding, and in the attitude behind his actions. The whole focus of his life changes.

“Also, a master wouldn’t be setting a good example if he were to proudly declare, ‘I am Self-realized,’ or, ‘I am beyond everything.’ If there is any sense of ‘I’ present, the person is not realized. Self-realization is the total absence of ‘I’ and ‘mine.’ It can be compared to being the boundless sky or open space. Does space have any sense of ‘I’? No, it just is. It is simply *present*. Does a rain cloud or a flower have any sense of ‘I’? No, not at all. Each exists as an offering to the world. Similarly, a true master, who is established in the Self,

offers himself to the world. All the great masters of the past, the ancient saints and sages, were perfect living examples of our highest and noblest values.

“There are people who say, ‘Why quote or follow the ancients?—after all, they lived eons ago.’ They say, ‘Spirituality and the spiritual masters have to change and become more flexible, because the world we are living in today is completely different.’ Those who say this should understand that there is only one Truth. People may talk about the Truth in different ways, but the experience is one and the same. The Truth has already been explained. There is no new Truth. Asking for a new truth would be childish; it could be compared to a child at school saying to his teacher, ‘All the teachers keep telling us that three plus three is six. I’m bored hearing the same old answer again and again. Why can’t you give us a new answer, and make three plus three equal something else for a change?’

“No, that isn’t possible. Someone may present it in a different way, but you can’t invent a new Truth for your convenience. Even if the guru is beyond the body and devoid of all human weaknesses, the disciples are not. They are still identified with the body and the ego. So they need a living example, an embodiment of all the divine qualities, as a reference to hold on to. The disciples draw their inspiration from the master. A true master, therefore, places great importance on morality and ethics; and he himself strictly adheres to those values, to set an example and to inspire his disciples.

“Of course, the customs, ethics, and morality of different nations may differ. There are, however, certain principles that are universal, that have been shared by people throughout the centuries. For example, the principle of truthfulness has always been applicable to every individual, society, and nation. Truth, peace, love, selflessness, self-sacrifice, and humility are all universally applicable values.”

AMBROSIAL RICE WATER

The first Devi Bhava in Santa Fe was about to take place in Steve and Kathy Schmidt’s living room. Gayatri came up to the Schmidts and offered them a cup containing plain *kanji* (rice) water that Mother had drunk from. Both Steve and Kathy took a sip. They immediately felt the effect of the *prasad*. Steve, as he later told Br. Amritatma, was suddenly intoxicated with bliss and felt completely detached from the busy scene around him. Kathy reacted by sitting down in a corner and closing her eyes. She sat like that for several hours, experiencing a profound feeling of peace and joy, while oblivious to the divine play happening around her.

For many hours the couple remained in that state. The house was filled with devotees who had come for the Devi Bhava. But as the two hosts were absent from this world due to having tasted the ambrosial kanji water, there was a lot of confusion to begin with, since no one was available to take care of things. This was Steve and Kathy's first experience of Mother's divine power.

THE TRUE JNANI

Chicago

Mother was giving darshan at the Hindu temple of greater Chicago. She was singing a song called *Rama Nama Tarakam*, while a devotee rested in Her lap.

*The name Rama takes us across the Ocean of Transmigration
It gives us both material prosperity and Liberation*

*That Name was enchanting to Sita
It is the Support of the whole world
And is being worshipped and sung by Shiva and other gods*

*Rama Hare, Krishna Hare!
I constantly worship Your Name
To cross the ocean of worldly existence
We know no other means than the Names of the Lord*

When the song came to an end Mother raised the devotee from Her lap. He lifted his head like someone emerging from another world. There was an expression of deep bliss on his face. As the darshan continued an Indian Brahmin scholar asked Mother a question: "There are certain jnanis (perfect knowers of the Self) who don't perform any actions. They just seem to be blessing people without doing anything. Amma, could you please explain this?"

Mother: "What makes you think *anugraha* (blessing) is so insignificant? The entire universe with all its beauty is a blessing. To be given a human birth is a rare blessing. A jnani blesses people by giving them peace, happiness, and prosperity. Who else could do this but a true jnani? No one in the world, except a person who is one with God, can give such

blessings. The grace of a true saint is all-encompassing, it touches the person's life as a whole, making all the different aspects of his life blossom.

“You say that a jnani doesn't do anything. By this, do you mean a well read, scholarly sort of person who calls himself a jnani? Such a one will perhaps do nothing but say, ‘I am Brahman’—but a true jnani will always be active in some way, benefiting the world with his presence, words, and actions. Even if the jnani doesn't do any physical work and, from an ordinary person's viewpoint, seems to be doing nothing, he is, in fact, blessing people by his presence. He doesn't have to do any *yagas* or *yagnas* (ritual sacrifices) to bring about a blessing, because his life itself is a sacrifice. Through him flows the grace, glory, and infinite power of God. Indeed, the true jnani is God. That's why people inevitably flock to him, even if he tries to stay away from them. So one cannot judge and say that the jnani isn't doing anything, just because one may see him being physically inactive.

“However, a jnani usually sets an example by being physically active. As for the exceptions to this rule, the jnanis who seem to be doing nothing—an ordinary person cannot even begin to comprehend what such beings are giving to the world.

“Lord Krishna was a perfect knower of the Self. He was exceptionally dynamic, constantly engaged in different actions. He was perfect in every field of action. But although unequalled, Krishna is just one example. There are many great souls who have set a perfect example and have benefited the world immensely by their actions.

“Jivan mukti, liberation from bondage to the cycle of birth and death, is not something to be attained after death, nor is it to be experienced or bestowed upon you in another world. It is a state of perfect awareness and equanimity, which can be experienced here and now in this world, while living in the body. However, the great masters sometimes impart knowledge of the Self to some of their disciples at the time when the disciples leave their body (*videha mukti*). Having come to experience the highest truth of oneness with the Atman, such blessed souls do not have to be born again. They merge with the infinite Consciousness.

“Once jivan mukti is attained, you do not feel as if you are being separated from your body at the time of death, or that you are losing your sense of identity, because, even before the death of the body, your identification with the body has ceased to exist. In other words, you are dead to the body while still living in this world. This supreme state is called moksha,

liberation from all attachments to the body.¹³ This ultimate goal is to be reached in this life itself.

“The Atman alone is the subject, the One who sees—the Seer. Everything else—that which is seen—is the object. The meaning of *Atma jnana* (knowing the Self) is that the Atman knows the Atman, the Self experiences the Self. The Self cannot be known or experienced by anything other than the Self, dwelling within the Self. If the Atman could be known in any other way, the Atman would only be the object, like any other object. There would then have to be something separate from the Atman with which to perceive the Atman. No, the Atman cannot be seen or known by anything separate from itself; for only the Self is the true ‘I’, the One who sees everything—the ‘Experiencer.’ Experiences change, but the Experiencer—the Substratum of all experience—remains one and the same. There is nothing that can know the Atman except the Atman itself—the subject knowing the subject. This is what it means to know the Self. So, if someone thinks he has known the Self, understand that he has not known it, because the Self is not an object that can be known; it is the Self knowing or experiencing the Self.

“The ultimate state of knowledge of the Self isn’t really an experience; rather, it is a state of *experiencing*—unbroken and everlasting.”

Madison

In Madison, Mother stayed with David and Barbara Lawrence, who were old friends of Nealu’s. They were both very devoted to Mother. Their daughter, Rasya, later became deeply attached to Mother and moved to Her San Ramon center.

SHRADDHA

One evening, when Mother got into the car to go to a program, Gayatri, who was putting Mother’s things in a basket to bring to the car, was delayed, so that Mother had to wait for her. When she came running to the car, Mother scolded her for her lack of shraddha.

On the way to the program, Mother said, “Amma doesn’t want anyone to serve Her, nor does it matter to Her how you behave; but a spiritual aspirant should be alert and vigilant in all her actions. Shraddha entails both love and faith. When you have love and faith, alertness in all your actions will automatically follow.

¹³ When Amma refers to the body here, the mind is also implied.

“Life brings unexpected experiences. Unless we are alert and vigilant at every moment, we cannot overcome those experiences and face them boldly. An individual’s situation in life is like that of a soldier in a battlefield. You can imagine how alert and watchful a soldier has to be in the midst of a battle. An attack could come from any direction. If he isn’t extremely alert and constantly on the watch, he could be killed. In the same way, life can bring you any kind of experience at any given time. You need a great deal of shraddha to be able to welcome those experiences and to stay unperturbed in all circumstances. This is what spirituality teaches us. To a spiritual seeker, nothing is more important than shraddha. Don’t think that Amma is fussy about small things. Amma is simply trying to help you develop that all-important quality. Even while performing the smallest and seemingly most insignificant action, you need to have shraddha.”

Later that night, Mother talked to the brahmacharis about Gayatri. She talked about her with great tenderness. She said, “Amma knows that Gayatri is feeling sad. She may think that Amma is angry with her; it may appear that way, but Amma isn’t angry at all. Amma’s heart melts when She thinks of Gayatri’s selflessness and sincerity, and how extremely hard she works.” There was intense love and compassion in Mother’s voice as She spoke.

In Madison Mother visited a home for handicapped children. Mother spent a lot of time with the children, giving each child a great deal of attention, inquiring about their condition, holding them in Her arms, caressing them, joking, and playing with them. The children were enchanted by Mother. Like all children, they immediately took to Her, feeling instinctively that She was their own. As Mother was about to leave, a little girl, who was sitting in a wheelchair, clutched hold of Mother’s sari and wouldn’t let Her go. Mother held the girl close to Her, stroked her hair, and said, “My child, Amma isn’t going anywhere. Amma will always be with you. Amma is with you every single moment.” The little girl seemed comforted by this. She grinned happily and let go of Mother’s sari.

PEACE COMES AFTER PAIN

On the way to a program, Mother asked Br. Rao (Swami Amritatmananda) to get into the car. He had been feeling sad because he wasn’t able to spend much time with Mother due to the busy schedule. On the way, Mother spoke to him about pain and joy.

Mother: “Inner peace always follows in the wake of pain. To reach the state of joy, you first have to experience pain. Pain in the beginning and lasting happiness at the end is far superior to happiness in the beginning and long-lasting pain at the end. Pain is an unavoidable part of life. Without having suffered in some way, you cannot experience any lasting peace or happiness.

“This is also applicable to worldly life. Suppose you wish to become a great singer. If this is your goal in life, how can you expect to achieve it without first undergoing the necessary voice training? You should be able to master the most intricate and subtle tones, vibrations, and variations with your voice, traveling smoothly from the lowest to the highest keys. How would this be possible without training the voice properly under the strict guidance of an expert singing teacher? This training is the pain you have to undergo at the beginning before you can become a great maestro. Pain at the beginning is the tapas you have to do, the price you have to pay, for the happiness you enjoy in life. The intensity of the pain varies according to the measure of happiness you seek. Because spiritual bliss is, by far, the greatest joy of all, the intensity of the tapas that is required, or the price you have to pay for that bliss, is also the greatest. You have to dedicate your whole life towards that end.

“In some parts of India, especially in Tamil Nadu, people eat the extremely bitter neem (margosa) flower on New Year’s Eve. There is another celebration at the end of the year called Pongal, on the day the sun touches the tropic of Capricorn. On this day, people traditionally chew sugarcane. There is a great deal of symbolism in all the Hindu celebrations. In these two particular examples, chewing the bitter neem flower symbolizes the acceptance of life’s bitter experiences from the very first day of life. Life involves many hardships and misfortunes. We should learn to accept and even welcome them wholeheartedly; to be patient, enthusiastic, and optimistic, never allowing ourselves to be mentally weak or disappointed. Only then can we progress towards the real goal of life—the sweet bliss and joy of immortality. This is symbolized by eating sugarcane at the end of the year.

“Some form of pain awaits you in every area of life and in every field of action. Without accepting the pain and going beyond it, you cannot experience the joy and peace that is available as the end result of the pain you go through. By learning to accept the pain of life, you can truly enter into the joy of life.

“Only love can make you open up into God-consciousness. The whole of life is a lesson of acceptance.

“The presence, love, and touch of a divine soul has a great effect on people; it makes them so receptive that they open up.

“There is an incident in the *Ramayana*, which describes how the presence and the mere touch of a great soul can create this receptivity. This incident also explains how inner peace comes after painful experience.

“The date had been set for Sri Rama’s coronation. But unfortunately, it didn’t take place due to the intervention of Kaikeyi, Rama’s stepmother, who at this point demanded the two boons that had once been promised her by her husband, King Dasharatha, who was Rama’s father. She demanded that her own son, Bharatha, be crowned as king instead of Rama, and that Rama be sent into exile in the forest for fourteen years. King Dasharatha, who was deeply attached to Rama, was so shocked by his wife’s demand that he collapsed. He pleaded with her to change her mind, but the queen was adamant and told him it was his duty as king and the father of Rama, who was the very embodiment of dharma (righteousness), to keep his promise and to implement it immediately. Dasharatha was in a hopeless situation. But Rama, who was the Lord Himself, calmly accepted it. He willingly agreed to leave Ayodhya and go to the forest, allowing his brother Bharatha to accede to the throne. Rama, who was beyond all attachments, showed no sign of anger or disappointment. He was the same calm, balanced Rama as ever.

“But Lakshmana, Rama’s brother and faithful servant, who loved the Lord more than anything in the world, became enraged at the news of Rama’s impending exile. When Lakshmana found out that Kaikeyi was behind it, his anger knew no bounds. He accused his father of being ‘henpecked and unjust.’ He wanted Rama’s consent to have Kaikeyi and their father imprisoned. He wanted to capture the kingdom for Rama and have Him crowned as the rightful king. Lakshmana was fuming with anger. No one could console him. Rama kept quiet and simply watched as His brother screamed and shouted with rage, challenging their father, until he was finally exhausted. At this point, Rama, who until now hadn’t said a word, went up to his brother. He gently touched him and said: ‘My child.’ That was all that was needed. Those two, simple words and that caress had an immediate effect on Lakshmana. It awakened the child within him. He became absolutely calm and composed, and all his anger vanished. Such is the power of the word and touch of a Self-realized master. It made Lakshmana as peaceful and open as a child before Rama. Rama then began to counsel him, giving him some profound spiritual instructions that went straight to his heart. Before that point, Rama didn’t go near Lakshmana or say a word to him. He waited patiently for

Lakshmana to go through all that pain and anger, and then He created the perfect opportunity to teach him. Had Rama spoken to his brother before then, when Lakshmana was still raging with anger, his spiritual teachings would have gone straight over Lakshmana's head. So the whole situation, from beginning to end, was created by Lord Rama. If Rama had protested against His father's decision, this opportunity could not have come to pass.

"There are, of course, many reasons on many different levels for everything that happened in the *Ramayana*.

"Rama was the Universal Power in human form. Had he so wished, He could have defeated his opponents in less than a moment and recaptured the kingdom. It was his acceptance of the situation that caused Lakshmana to explode in a fit of rage. But that explosion helped Lakshmana to exhaust all the stagnant negative energy which had been lying dormant within him. Above all, the grace behind Rama's words and divine touch healed Lakshmana and transformed him into a vessel fit enough to receive Rama's spiritual instructions. But before Lakshmana opened up, he had to pass through the painful experience of rage and despair. So, peace and relaxation always follow in the wake of pain and effort. Rama, the perfect master, created the situation by his divine sankalpa for the sake of his beloved brother and disciple.

"It should be mentioned, however, that this situation was specifically suited for Lakshmana in the controlled conditions of his master's presence; otherwise you may think there is no need to control your anger or to be aware of its largely negative aspect. To just explode in a fit of rage whenever you get angry is not a good idea, it's obviously destructive. This particular situation happened in Rama's presence for a special purpose.

"There is always a divine message hidden in the seemingly negative experiences we go through. We just have to penetrate beneath the surface of a situation, and the message will be revealed. But we usually remain on the outer surface of our experiences."

The car stopped at the entrance of the hall and Mother stepped out into the waiting crowd. As the people caught sight of Mother, spontaneous smiles lit up their faces. They were like lotus flowers blossoming at the mere appearance of the sun in the sky. A baby girl straddling her mother's hip was staring at Mother. Mother walked over to the baby and kissed her, calling, "Baby, baby!" The child broke into a smile and reached out for Mother, wanting to come to Her. Mother lifted the little girl into Her arms and walked towards the entrance of

the hall, where She stopped for the traditional pada puja, garlanding, and arati. With the baby still in Her arms, Mother then proceeded to the stage.

JIVAN MUKTI

Charleston

In Charleston, Virginia, Mother gave darshan in a non-sectarian church. She had been invited there by a monk, who ran the place. He treated Mother with great reverence. Before the bhajans he told the gathering, “This may be the first time Mother comes to America—the first time She comes here in the body, that is....” Pausing for a moment he continued, “But I know that Mother has been here before. She has been with me. For She came to me in a vision, before I had ever heard of Her; and in that vision She told me that She was coming to America. Later I found out about Mother and that She was about to visit this country.”

During the bhajans that followed Mother led everyone in the song, *Jay jay jay Durga Maharani*.

*Victory, victory, victory to Durga,
The Great Queen!
O Durga, Great Queen,
Grant me Your vision!*

*O Enchantress of the universe,
O Mother who dwells in all the three worlds,
You are the One who gave birth to all of creation;
You are the Bestower of all boons;
O Durga, Great Queen,
Grant me Your vision!*

*O Mother Durga,
You are the One who destroys all ignorance,
You are the One who removes all fears and sorrows;
O Mother, who is seated on a lion,*

You are the embodiment of all that is auspicious.

O Durga, Great Queen,

Grant me Your vision!

O Mother,

You are the embodiment of faith,

Compassion, and love;

You alone are the Great Illusion,

The Supreme Power;

O Mother Bhavani,

You dwell in all hearts.

O Durga, Great Queen,

Grant me Your vision!

Victory, victory, victory

To Durga, the Great Queen!

When the darshan began, a woman who had been traveling with Mother, came up to Her for darshan and then sat down next to Her. She had heard Mother talk about jivan mukti, and wanted to know more about the subject. She said, “Amma, the other day you were talking about the ultimate state of liberation, a state of freedom from all bondage to body and mind, which can be experienced while still living in this world. You said that in that state, the body and mind cease to exist. Does that mean that the world will disappear before our eyes? Because without the body and mind, how can one experience the world?”

Mother: “The state of jivan mukti doesn’t mean that the world disappears. The world will continue to exist. But your wrong notions about the world will disappear. It is your wrong understanding that causes all differences and diversity. This will dissolve and you will behold only the oneness of everything, everywhere. But God’s creation will still be there; for you can only destroy what you yourself have created. In other words, you can destroy the ego, for that is your own creation. This universe is not your creation, so you can’t do anything about it.

“Your thoughts are your own creation. You make them real by cooperating with them. Withdraw your support and they will dissolve. Observe your thoughts. Don’t love or hate

them, don't judge them as good or bad. Just be an onlooker and they will disappear. The external world will not disappear just because you observe it. But if you can be a detached witness, the inner world of thoughts will disappear. Just imagine that the world of thoughts is a flowing river, and you are an observer standing on the bank of the river, without jumping into it.

"The clouds in the sky have different shapes. A cloud may take the form of a monster, a chariot, a prancing horse, or the beautiful face of a god—and as the cloud drifts by, it continues to change. Small children enjoy this. As they watch the passing clouds, they may believe the shapes are real. But a grownup knows that the shapes are illusions, that they are only clouds continuously changing their forms. The grownups don't judge; they just look at the sky without any attitude, without commenting on the shapes they see up there. They don't say: 'O, what a beautiful horse!' because they know it's only a cloud. In the same way, thoughts are the ever-changing 'clouds' that appear in the inner space of the mind. They may assume different shapes but they are always unreal. Because you haven't created the clouds in the external sky, they won't disappear as a result of your observing them. However, the clouds of thought in the inner sky will dissolve if you can simply witness them as they go by.

"A lion made of sandalwood is real to a child, but to a grownup it's a piece of sandalwood. For the child, the wood is concealed, revealing only the lion. The grownup may also enjoy the lion, but he knows it is not real. For him, the wood is real, and not the lion.

"In the same way, to a jivan mukta, the entire universe is nothing but the essence, the 'wood', that everything is made of, the Absolute Brahman or Consciousness.

"The world doesn't disappear before the jivan mukta's eyes. Everything continues as it is. Nothing changes. The sun doesn't stop rising on the western horizon when someone attains realization. However, a change happens inwardly. You perceive the world from a different level of consciousness. For the jivan mukta, everything is permeated with God, with pure, undivided Consciousness. Just as the wooden lion is still a piece of wood to a grownup, the jivan mukta beholds everything as the Paramatman, the Supreme Self. The world of names and forms still exists, but he perceives the inner essence of everything. Being in the state of jivan mukti doesn't mean that you lose your body. You can stay in your body and continue to function in the world, but your identification with the body has ceased. You become an observer, a witness. You stop experiencing the world from the outside. You observe everything from within, from the true center of existence.

“The kernel of a dry coconut automatically separates from the hard outer shell. The kernel remains inside the shell without being attached to it. It is the same with a jivan mukta, because, in that state, the soul and the body are seen to be separate. The delusion that the body is the soul, or that the soul is the body, is removed. All attachments to the body vanish. When the vasanas (latent tendencies) have ‘dried up’, the realization dawns on you that the body is not the Self, but that the Self is totally free and independent. To the jivan mukta, the Self is everything, everywhere—the Paramatman has become the entire creation.

“There is a beautiful story about Lord Brahma, the Creator of the universe. It is said that after creating each living being, the Lord fell in love with it to such an extent that He entered into His creation and became one with it. He created a tree, He fell in love with the tree and became the tree. He created a pig, He fell in love with the pig and became the pig. He created a human being, fell in love with the person and became that person. Thus he entered into everything.

“God has fallen in love with His creation. He permeates everything, as the one life-giving Power. Jivan mukti is the state in which you behold the glory of God, His infinite power, within everything—not only in what is good and beautiful, but also in all that is bad and ugly. You see the inner essence of the world, not the outer surface. The surface of things remains the same, but your inner eye has opened, allowing you to penetrate the exterior and to clearly perceive ‘That’ which lies within.

“In the *Srimad Bhagavatam*, Prahlada, a boy who worshipped Lord Vishnu, told his father, the demon king Hiranyakashipu, that the Lord is everywhere, whether it be in a blade of grass, an inert pillar, a dry leaf, a simple hut, or a palace. Hiranyakashipu, who was enraged at his son’s faith in the Lord, pointed at a large pillar inside the palace and shouted at the boy, ‘Is your Hari in that pillar too?’ Without a moment’s hesitation, the boy replied, ‘Yes, He is there too.’ The demon was infuriated by this and struck the pillar with his sword. The force of the blow split the pillar in two and out came the fierce form of Narasimha (the divine man-lion) in an explosion of Cosmic Power.

“Without the Supreme Energy nothing could exist. Without the integrating force of the Cosmic Power, which holds everything together, the world would dissolve in an instant. The Supreme Energy is the ultimate building force.

“The story symbolizes the all-pervasive, omnipresent nature of the Supreme Energy. Jivan mukti is the highest point of human existence, a state in which one constantly

experiences eternal bliss while still in the body. In that state, the body is no more than a cage for the soul to dwell in, for you are always aware of the Self being different from the body.

“Have you heard of King Janaka, the father of Sita Devi who was the holy consort of Lord Rama? King Janaka was a jivan mukta. He was one with the Self; and yet he never turned his back on his responsibilities as a king. He ruled the land and did his duty with perfect equanimity. He remained completely untouched and detached from the events that took place in his life, whether they happened to be good or bad.

“In the state of jivan mukti, the world still exists, but one’s whole perspective changes. Having attained oneness with the Supreme Being, the jivan mukta performs the duties entrusted to him for as long as he continues to live in the world. He doesn’t sit idle saying, ‘Everything is an illusion, so there’s no reason for me to do any work?’”

THE AVATAR

Boston

This morning, a young man expressed a wish to ask Mother a question. Mother smiled at him and said, “Of course you can. But do not ask anything about God, karma (the theory of action), or moksha.”

The man was bewildered; for how could he ask a spiritual question without touching on any of those subjects? Seeing his puzzled expression, Mother and the devotees laughed. Mother hugged him and said, “Son, don’t worry. You can ask your question.”

Although, Mother had been joking when She said he wasn’t to mention anything about those three subjects, it was a deeply significant statement; because any question about God, karma, or moksha remains unanswerable. Nothing can be said about these subjects because, unless they are experienced directly, they cannot be understood. Any explanations or interpretations will only create more questions. Mother says, “Words will delude you. Go beyond words, and you will know.” However, when a great master like Mother speaks to us, their words spring forth from their immediate experience of the highest Truth. So the words of a God-realized soul are the only reliable source we have on these subjects.

Having received permission to proceed with his question, the man asked, “Amma, are you an *avatar*? Are you the Divine Mother? Are you Adi Parashakti (the Supreme Power)?”

Mother: “You may call this body by any name you like. Some call it Amma (Mother), some Devi or Krishna, yet others consider it to be a Buddha or a Christ. There are many who call this body Amritanandamayi and other names. There are also those who criticize this

body. It doesn't matter to Amma what you call Her. The Truth, the inner Self, remains eternally the same—immutable and unaffected. No one can pierce the mystery of this pure being.

“The word ‘avatar’ means to descend. The infinite Consciousness descends into the world, assuming a human form for the sake of uplifting and saving humanity. However, this is only from the standpoint of the devotee, because there is no space for the infinite Consciousness to come and go. Where could that which is infinite and all-pervasive possibly descend or ascend to? There's not an extra inch of space in which to move. Ascending and descending exist only for those who do not experience their oneness with the Supreme Reality. When you are one with the ocean of Sat-Chit-Ananda, there is no question of coming or going.

“One could say that when a soul attains realization, the clay pot in the ocean breaks, and the water inside the pot merges with the water that surrounds it, so that there is nothing but water everywhere. Here the ocean represents the infinite Consciousness or the Paramatman, and the clay pot is the individual Self. In the ultimate state of realization, your individuality or body-consciousness disappears. You merge with the Infinite and go beyond all limitations. For an avatar, however, there was never a clay pot to break, for he or she has always been one with the Supreme.

“The avatars live among human beings, undergoing all the hardships of life; but they are constantly setting an example of divine love, compassion, self-sacrifice, etc. Such beings become a great source of inspiration for millions of people all over the globe. They are like great ships that can carry hundreds of thousands of people across the ocean of transmigration. The avatars are born with perfect awareness of the Supreme Truth. They may perform severe austerities, but they do so only to set an example for the world. It is like a loving mother whose child is suffering from jaundice and has to follow a strict diet. To make it easier for her child, she will follow the same diet. For if she eats any other food in front of her child, he may feel tempted to do the same.

“If you wish to communicate with someone who is deaf and dumb, you cannot speak to them in your own language. To get the message across, you have to communicate in sign language. You have to go to their level. But though you are using sign language, it doesn't mean that you yourself are deaf. Likewise, the avatars may undergo severe austerities, or you may see them meditating, but that doesn't mean that they really need to do so. Whatever spiritual practices they do are done to set an example to others and thereby inspire and uplift them.

“Everything in nature moves in an endless circle: there is birth, death, and again, birth. The seasons move in a circle: spring, summer, autumn, winter, and spring again. The earth moves on its axis around the sun. A seed germinates and becomes a tree; the tree blossoms, and new seeds are born. The ages (yugas) also move in a circle: there is the *Satya yuga*, *Treta yuga*, *Dwapara yuga*, *Kali yuga*, and again the *Satya yuga*. Before this creation there was another creation. This universe will eventually cease to exist, and another universe will manifest. When Rama descended to the world, he said to Hanuman: ‘There have been countless Rama avatars, not just this one.’ And Krishna said to Arjuna, ‘You and I have been born together a number of times. I know all about it, but you do not.’”

Amritatma exclaimed, “O Amma, I remember you said once that all those who are with you now have been with you before.”

Mother: “Yes, all of Amma’s children who are with Amma now have been with Her before.”

A CLEAR SIGN

The question about Mother being Adi Parashakti, the Supreme Power, brings an incident to mind.

A young man, Madhavan, who was a student of *Tantra* and worshipped the Divine Mother in the form of Sri Lalita Parameshvari, came to see Mother for the first time. He was standing at the bottom of Mother’s staircase, waiting for Her to come down from Her room. As he was waiting, he thought, “If Mother really is Sri Lalitambika (an aspect of the Divine Mother as Sri Lalita), who is *Karpūra vīṭikāmoda samākarṣi digantarā*¹⁴ (She who enjoys camphor-laden betel rolls, the fragrance of which attracts the entire creation),¹⁵ She has to give me a sign so that I will know.”

A few minutes later Mother came down the stairs. He noticed that She was chewing something. (Mother doesn’t normally walk around chewing anything.)

When She reached the bottom of the stairs where Madhavan was standing, She opened Her mouth and, pointing at it, said, “Look, son! This is *karpūra vitikā*. A devotee gave it to Amma.”

¹⁴ One of the names of the Divine Mother in the *Sri Lalitasahasranama*.

¹⁵ *Karpura Vitika* is a combination of cardamom, coconut, black pepper, ginger, and lime.

Madhavan was speechless. He couldn't have asked for a clearer sign. It turned out that one of Mother's devotees from a nearby town called Kottayam, who was always chanting the *Sri Lalitā Sahasranāma*, and who strongly believed that Mother was none other than Adi Parashakti, had given Mother the karpūra vitikā as an offering a few days earlier. But Mother hadn't touched it because She normally doesn't chew such things. However, that particular day, before She left Her room, Mother took a pinch of the substance which had been kept on a table, and put it in Her mouth. It became clear to Madhavan that Mother knew his every thought, and that She was none other than Devi Herself.

As the darshan continued, another question was asked: "Amma, you mentioned that there have been countless Rama and Krishna avatars. But we have heard of only one Rama and one Krishna. What, then, do you mean by this?"

Mother: "Even today, Rama, Krishna, and Buddha could come back, and it is happening—but people don't have eyes to see. Don't look for Rama or Krishna in the same forms as before. If you look for Rama with a bow and arrow, or Krishna with a flute and a peacock feather, you are bound to be disappointed. God is not a miser; He spends lavishly. His extravagance appears before humanity in many forms. Rama, Krishna, and Buddha are appearing in different forms. No, you won't find them in this world if you expect them to have exactly the same bodies as before, or to dress in the same way as they once did, or if you expect their play on earth to be the same as it once was. No, they will not be exactly the same. However, if you really long to see them, it is possible to find them. Search for them where there is divine love, where everyone is loved equally and unconditionally and there is boundless compassion; where there is great humility and self-sacrifice. Wherever you come across those qualities, that is where Rama and Krishna dwell.

"God is infinite. He once appeared as Rama and Krishna. That all-pervasive, limitless Consciousness, with its inexhaustible energy, is now assuming another form.

(Jokingly) "People get bored with everything, don't they? They may even get bored with God if He were to come again as Rama or Krishna. Because God knows how easily humans get bored, He wishes to amuse everyone with His infinite wisdom, and so He appears in different forms!"

"Children, the container changes but the content remains the same—that doesn't change. This is what happens with an avatar. Also, each divine incarnation appears according to the needs of society at the time. The problems of the world today, the solutions to those

problems, and the ways to implement those solutions are different from what they were during Rama's and Krishna's time."

Br. Amritatma, who was translating Mother's words, was reminded of how a few months earlier, at the ashram in India, Mother had incidentally referred to Herself in the middle of a conversation, saying: "The saints and sages performed years of severe tapas to realize God. Here you have God right in your midst—but how many people care?"

"I AM YOUR MOTHER"

New York

During the first morning program in New York, when Mother had just begun giving darshan, She pointed at a little blond boy, who was sitting with his father at the other side of the room, and said to Amritatma, "That child has no mother. Amma feels great love and compassion for him." The boy had not been up to Mother yet, and no one had told Her anything about him.

After a while, Mother playfully tossed a chocolate kiss across the room to where the little boy was sitting. He smiled and ate the chocolate. Soon after, Mother threw another chocolate halfway across the room. He walked a little closer to Mother and got his second treat. Mother repeated this a few more times and when he was close enough, Mother reached out and grabbed him. They both laughed. The little boy immediately felt a strong bond with Mother.

His father, Larry Richmond (Arun), came up to Mother and explained that his son, Jason, who was six years old, had lost his mother when he was only eight months old; that he often woke up crying at night, asking why he didn't have a mother. Mother held Jason in Her arms and said to him, "Jason, I am your Mother!" Jason gazed at Mother in wonder. He thought Mother meant that She was his biological mother. His face shone with joy. For the first time in his life he was experiencing the unconditional love of a mother.

Larry also told Mother that Jason suffered from epilepsy; that he had frequent seizures and the medication didn't help at all. Mother told Larry to continue giving him the medication. She gave him a piece of sandalwood and instructed him on how to use it.

Mother's instructions were followed to the letter, and from then on, Jason never had another seizure.

THE HUMILITY OF A SATGURU

During an evening program at the Cathedral of St. John the Divine in New York, Mother was asked a question.

“Amma, in California I heard you talk about the humility of a true master; that a satguru doesn’t have any sense of ego and that he bows down to all of creation. My question is whether humility is an integral part of a Self-realized master.”

Mother: “A Self-realized master is beyond everything. But humility will be one of the basic qualities that he or she expresses. The master is humble because he perceives everything as God and worships the entire creation as the Supreme. So you could say that a satguru is always in a worshipful, prayerful mood. He bows down to everything, and all of existence, in turn, bows down to him.

“No inner change is possible around an egoistic person. The sadhak (aspirant) cannot be transformed if the feeling of ‘I’ and ‘mine’ are predominant in the master. Such so-called teachers can only create fear and anxiety around them, which closes all possibilities of transformation.

“There have been many cruel kings and dictators all over the world, who have cared only about their own interests and nothing else. During their reign, terror prevailed and people’s hearts were consequently closed. But there have also been many examples of great souls who have changed the lives of countless people for the better, with nothing more than their humble presence. Every trace of fear disappears in the proximity of such beings. A genuine master is beyond all egoism. True humility creates a vibration of love and compassion which, in turn, produces the necessary conditions for a spiritual unfoldment to take place. This is why the presence of a satguru provides the most suitable atmosphere in which your heart can blossom.

“A Self-realized master dwells eternally in the Self, unperturbed by the different experiences of life. You may observe that the master is humbler than the humblest, simpler than the simplest, inconceivably loving, compassionate, and patient—and yet, he is none of these, for he is beyond all qualities. His mastery over the mind and the senses gives him the unlimited capacity to focus on any divine quality, and to manifest that quality, fully and perfectly, expressing it in any way he chooses. But the next moment he can withdraw from it, totally untouched and detached.

“Though a master may be humble for the sake of setting an example, it is impossible to judge him as being this or that. Of course he is humble but, at the same time, he is beyond that.

“A disciple should learn to be humble, for it is through humility that true discipleship is born. Unless this quality is awakened, the master cannot really enter into your life.

“It is this awakening of the disciple within you that brings the master to you. Your intense thirst to know the Truth gives birth to the disciple within. The lover within you awakens, and once the lover is awakened, the beloved appears. Without the lover, there is no beloved; without the disciple, there is no master—the master will still exist, but not in your life.

“The disciple’s humility—his attitude of being an absolute beginner, and his acceptance and awareness of his own ignorance—makes him open and receptive to true knowledge, which the master then pours into him. Humility is the gateway to real discipleship, and the master will himself set a perfect example of humility.

“Without the slightest hesitation, Sri Rama touched the feet of his stepmother, Kaikeyi, and sought her blessing before he left to spend fourteen years of exile in the forest—even though it was Kaikeyi who was responsible for his exile. Rama was humble enough to lovingly and respectfully bow down to her, without a thought of anger or revenge.

“Look at the example of Sri Krishna’s life. He was perfectly aware of His divinity, of who He was. Yet He humbly washed the feet of all the saints and sages who came to participate in the *rajasuya*, which was being performed by Yudhishthira, the eldest of the Pandava brothers. Also, think of how, just before Lord Krishna left his mortal frame, He bestowed the state of moksha (liberation) on the hunter who was instrumental in putting an end to His life on earth. Amma has also heard that the night before his crucifixion, Christ washed and kissed the feet of all his apostles, including Judas, who betrayed him for thirty silver coins.”

THERE IS AN AMMA HIDDEN WITHIN EVERYONE

Question: “Amma, by their selflessness and the example of their lives, those great souls have inspired and uplifted humanity. But is there any ‘inner’ significance to their great deeds?”

Mother: “Every human being, even if he or she happens to be cruel and selfish, has the capacity to become enlightened. This capacity lies dormant in everyone. Amma sees an Amma hidden in each one of you. There is a Krishna, Rama, Buddha, or Christ within you. God’s divine light could dawn within you at any moment; it’s just waiting for the right opportunity to arise. The great masters are able to see that hidden light which is waiting to emerge, waiting to break through the walls of the ego. They behold a future Krishna, Rama,

Buddha, or Christ within everyone. Seeing the Divine Mother within you, Amma bows down to Her own Self—to God. This is what the great masters have always done. The masters can clearly see the Divinity within you, but you yourself cannot perceive it because of your lack of awareness. The masters can see the Divine Light within you, which is why they bow down to it. You cannot be truly humble unless you are able to perceive this light in everyone. It is the experience of the Self that makes you naturally humble in all situations. When you behold everything as God, you are always in a worshipful mood. When there are no feelings of otherness, your whole life becomes an act of worship, a form of prayer, a song of praise. The ‘other’ disappears, and in its place you behold the dormant state of enlightenment, the innermost Self, in the person standing before you. You then feel a deep sense of reverence towards that person. In that state, nothing is insignificant for you; everything has its special place. You behold the Supreme Light shining even in a blade of grass.”

Mother Herself is the living embodiment of every word She preaches. Mother prostrates before everyone when She is about to give darshan, and again when the darshan is over. She accepts any offering a devotee may give Her, bowing down to it with reverence and gratitude, whether it is something very significant, or a fruit or just a simple leaf.

Who has not seen Mother worship Her children at the end of Devi Bhava, showering flower petals on them? Who hasn’t heard about the incident when Mother visited the man who had tried to kill Her, when he lay dying in the hospital, and how She lovingly fed him with Her own hands?

Thousands of people have witnessed Mother treating Dattan the leper with Her healing saliva; and in the early days, at the end of each Devi Bhava, the devotees would line up around the little temple, and then Mother would dance around the temple three times, touching and blessing the people as She passed them. Dattan would be waiting for Mother behind the temple with two pitchers of water. When Mother came around the temple the third time, She would pause in front of Dattan and pour the water over him, giving him a bath.

One year, when Mother was staying in Seattle, She returned to the house at about 3:30 one morning, after having given darshan for many hours. As Mother walked along the garden path towards the door, She suddenly jumped back saying that She had trodden on something. She bent down and found a snail that She had touched with Her foot, and which was slightly injured. “Oh no!” She exclaimed. “Poor thing!” She picked it up and held it in Her cupped hands. Looking sadly at the little snail, She said, “This poor creature’s mate will be looking for him soon. She will be very worried, wondering what has happened to him.” Mother

continued to gaze at the snail in Her hands for several minutes. She then closed Her eyes, held the snail to Her forehead, and then gently put it down beneath a plant before She went into the house.

Though Mother is one with God, She worships every being in creation as a manifestation of God. What greater examples could one possibly need to be inspired?



Stamford, Connecticut

The last program in the US was held in a small house near Stamford in Connecticut. Mother gave darshan sitting on an upside-down milk cart with an asana spread on top of it.

In the late afternoon Mother meditated with the devotees beside a lake. Everyone was disturbed and was having trouble sitting still because the air was thick with swarms of biting mosquitoes. Only Mother was unaffected. Surrounded by a cloud of mosquitoes, She sat perfectly still, in a completely absorbed mood, Her face glowing with serenity.

AMMA IS ALWAYS WITH YOU

Mother's first American tour was drawing to a close. The evening before Mother left the States, She turned to a young woman at the house where She was staying and asked, "Why are you so sad?"

"Because Amma is going," said the women.

"Where!" was Mother's immediate response.

From Connecticut, Mother was driven to JFK airport in New York, where a group of devotees were waiting to bid Her a tearful farewell. Before going through the passport control, Mother tenderly took each one of them in Her arms.

She said to them: "Children, Amma is always with you. Each time you think of Her, Amma can clearly see your faces. And do you know," She continued, "at the ashram in India, every night when Amma lies down to rest, Amma goes out to all Her children all over the world. Amma's children are Her swans, and like a shepherd Amma checks on them and brings any straying swan back into Her fold. You are all baby birds, and Amma is keeping you under Her wing."

As Mother was about to leave through the passport control, several in the group shouted, “Mother, please come back to us!” Mother looked at them with great affection and said, “Don’t worry, children. Amma will come back.” She saluted them with Her folded hands above Her head, and said softly in English: “My children....”

Thus, having sown the seeds of true spirituality in the soil of the United States of America, and in the hearts of those who had come to see Her, Mother left for Europe on July 14. But Her subtle presence was to remain with Her children.

Within a short period of time, Mother had brought about a great transformation in people; their whole outlook on life had changed. Without giving scholarly lectures, or talks delivered with flowery words; but rather, by Her simple, innocent approach—reaching out to everyone through Her all-embracing love, Her mere presence, touch and look—Mother became permanently established in people’s hearts. Though She spoke in Her mother-tongue, Malayalam, language or nationality was not a barrier in any way. Enfolded in Her loving arms, people spontaneously poured out their hearts to Her. They simply opened up. And they realized that a divine message was being imparted to them through Mother’s every movement. Her eyes and Her smile spoke to them. Her every breath seemed to convey something divine. Her whole being silently communicated with them.

EUROPE

Mother arrived in Paris in the early morning of July 15, 1987. Sarvatma (Jacques Albohair) and a few other devotees welcomed Mother at the airport. When the devotees saw Mother coming towards them, they just stood there stared at Her in wonderment. They knew nothing about the Indian custom of garlanding the guru; they just gazed innocently at Mother, not knowing what to do. Mother greeted them with great warmth, like long lost children. While She waited for the luggage to pass through customs, She sat down on the floor in a corner of the airport and hugged everyone. She asked each person simple questions about their health, where they lived, and so on. She came down to their level and talked to them in this way just to break the ice and to make them feel more familiar with Her.

When the luggage had been organized, the devotees drove everyone to Kathy and Daniel Demilly’s house in Dourdan outside Paris. There were a few people waiting for Mother at the

house. Mother embraced them, talked to them for a while, and then retired to Her room to rest.

The first darshan took place in the living room later that afternoon. About forty people attended. Mother sat on the floor and called the devotees one by one. She spent five to ten minutes with each person, holding them, caressing them, putting sacred ash on their foreheads, giving each person a sweet, speaking to them and asking questions. Many of the people, both men and women, young and old, shed tears in Mother's presence. They were deeply moved; for it was clear to them that Mother knew everything about them, every detail of their lives, their past and their future, and every thought in their minds; and yet, in Her there was not a trace of judgment, only a boundless, unconditional love that was unmistakable—a love greater than any love they had ever encountered. Each person was made to feel that he or she was Mother's most precious child.

In the late afternoon, Mother went to Her room, and there She continued to see the people who had come up to Her earlier and had expressed a wish to talk to Her in private.

As in the U.S., almost all the morning programs in Europe took place in people's homes, while the evening programs were held in different halls.

FACING PROBLEMS

Paris

In Paris a devotee told Mother about his strong desire to leave his job because of the stressful situations he was experiencing there. He said, "Amma, I feel helpless and confused whenever I have to deal with so much stress. What do you suggest that I should do?"

Mother: "Whenever you are confronted with a difficult situation, your first instinct is to escape, to somehow avoid it and run away. People think that by doing so, they can get rid of their problems. But this is not so. They may be able to escape for a while, but sooner or later the same difficulties will reappear with even greater force than before.

"It should be understood that external situations don't have the power to hurt you. It is only when the mind interprets those situations that the pain bubbles up from within. A situation becomes a problem when you interpret it in the wrong way. The aim is to not let the mind interpret or comment on external situations. This is possible only when you learn the art of witnessing.

“Children, your problems do not lie in the outer circumstances. You cannot avoid external situations. They are part of life. For example, one fine morning, an elderly woman walks into the home of a married couple. The husband sees her and rejoices. ‘O Mother, how wonderful to see you!’ he exclaims. But his wife doesn’t have a pleasant look on her face at all when she sees her mother-in-law. How do you explain this? How can the same person create such widely different reactions in two people? She didn’t do anything except walk through the door! It was simply a situation. But for one person it became a joyous moment, while for the other it was a cause for great unhappiness. For one person it was a problem, while for the other it was the opposite. So the aim is to not let the mind interpret or comment on external situations. But our minds are so weak and judgmental that we naturally fall victim to situations and become deluded. The problem arises when you react negatively to those situations. In other words, the root of your troubles exist within yourself. Straighten out the creases of the mind, where the problems really exist, and the external creases will automatically disappear.

“Some students come and say, ‘Amma, my exam paper was a terrible problem.’ Amma asks them, ‘Where is the problem? Is it to be found in the question paper? No, because there are others who have succeeded very well in the same exam. The real difficulty is you yourself, because you didn’t study hard enough. So it may have been a problem for you, but it wasn’t a problem for those who really applied themselves and studied the subject.’

“Many people tell Amma that they have difficulties with their husband or wife. But the same husband or wife is often a good friend to someone else, a brother or sister to someone, and a loving parent to their children. To the Pandavas, Krishna was a good friend, whereas the Kauravas thought of him as their enemy. Similarly, the believers looked upon Jesus as their beloved friend and savior, whereas others saw him as a threat. Would you say that the problem lay with Krishna or Jesus? No, the problem lay with the Kauravas and with those who doubted Jesus.

“In the West people date for a long time, and then, if they like each other they get married and have children. They are happy for some time, but soon difficulties arise. Conflicts based on fear and anger begin to manifest. They both want to escape the situation and run away, and so they end up separating. After their divorce, they may live on sweet and painful memories for a while; but it won’t be long before they begin dating someone else, and they’ll again go through the same cycle of experiences. Think of how often this happens. People

keep abusing each other, and criticizing each other's faults and weaknesses. They are not aware of the fact that the problems exist within themselves.

“You may run away from that person now; you may run from one marriage to another, hoping that your troubles have been put behind you at last—but it won't be long before you find the same person, that is, someone with the same weaknesses and the same level of consciousness, in another ‘wrapper’ and in a different situation. You may find it even worse than before. The outer appearance of the person has changed, but the content—the level of consciousness within that ‘wrapper’—remains the same. This is because you haven't changed. So the level of consciousness of the partners you choose is the same as before. Only the outer appearances differ.

“Unless there is a considerable shift in your consciousness, and thus in your attitude, your problems won't go away. They will continue to appear everywhere, constantly disturbing you. Your mind will continue to persuade you to escape from the situations of life, deluding you with false promises about the future.

“By changing a very common misconception—the idea that your problems are to be found in the outer situations of life—you can remove your problems once and for all. Understand that the difficulties are to be found within your own mind. Once you become aware of this, you can begin the process of removing your inner weaknesses. Meditation is the method that is used to achieve this. Only the inner silence, stillness, and relaxation which you gain through meditation will help.”

At Mother's request, the brahmacharis then sang a song called *Shakti Mahadevi*.

Salutations to Shakti, the Great Goddess

Who can be reached through devotion

Salutations to the Seed

The One Truth

Infinite and Perfect Awareness

O my Divine Lotus

Left eye of Shiva

Fulfiller of all desires

Ruler of all

Who shines through everything

Protect me

You are the Goddess of the celestials

Protecting them from all sorrows

You are the Pure One

Who protects even the Lord of the Ocean of Milk

The Creator does his work

Only because of Your glance

Salutations to You who came forth out of Brahma

As Saraswati

The Seed of the entire Universe

Creation, sustenance, and destruction

Take place at Your command

O Destroyer of the eight-faceted ego

Who is fond of the sound of the veena

When angered

You are also fond of blood

You are the Veda

The Absolute

You are in all living beings

You are the ultimate liberation



OPTIMISM

During darshan one evening, a woman came up to Mother and told Her that almost all her hopes about life had vanished. Mother said, “My daughter, as long as you are able to trust in God, there is no need to give up. Sometimes you may feel that all the doors are closed to you, that there is no way out; but if you look carefully, you will see that there are still many doors

that are wide open. You are focusing only on the closed doors and thus you miss the ones that are open to you.

“Life and God are one and the same. You are God’s child. God would never close all the doors around you. His unlimited love and compassion wouldn’t allow Him to be that cruel. God always keeps more than one door open. They may look as if they are closed, but they have, in fact, been left slightly ajar. Just a mild knock is enough and they’ll give way. But our eyes are blinded by our ignorance. We fail to see the open doors through which the light of God’s grace is pouring in.

“My child, never lose courage. Never lose your trust in God or in life. Always be optimistic, no matter what situations you find yourself in. It’s very important to be optimistic. Pessimism is a form of darkness, a form of ignorance that prevents God’s light from entering into your life. Pessimism is like a curse, an illusory curse created by the illusory mind. Life is filled with God’s light, but only by being optimistic will you experience that light.

“Look at the optimism of nature. Nothing can stop it. Every aspect of nature tirelessly contributes its share to life. The participation of a little bird, an animal, a tree, or a flower is always complete. No matter what the hardships, they continue to try, wholeheartedly. Only humans are pessimistic, and this causes suffering.

“Amma has heard a story. A shoe company sent two sales representatives to a distant island, where only primitives lived. Their mission was to explore the sales opportunities on the island. Some time later, one of the salesmen sent a message to the company, ‘The people here don’t even know what shoes are! They don’t wear shoes! The situation is hopeless. I’m coming back.’ This was followed by a message from his partner: ‘These primitives don’t wear shoes. They don’t know anything about them. Plenty of opportunity—100% chance! Send me the first shipment.’

“Amma knows it isn’t easy to always be optimistic. You may ask, how is it possible to be optimistic in the face of the many hardships and sorrows in life? It is true that it’s difficult—but by being pessimistic you move towards even greater despair and darkness. All your strength and clarity of mind gets dissipated; and in the darkness of pessimism you feel abandoned and isolated. Optimism is the light of God. It is a form of grace which allows you to be much more perceptive and to look at life with greater clarity.”

PATIENCE AND ENTHUSIASM

A woman who had been on the spiritual path for a long time said to Mother, “Amma, I have practiced meditation since 1973, but even so, I haven’t experienced any progress. At times I feel so disappointed that I stop doing my sadhana. Could you please advise me?”

Mother smiled and asked, “No progress at all?”

The woman replied, “Well...actually, there has been some progress.”

“How much progress? Can you say something about it?” Mother asked.

“I’ll try.” The woman thought for a moment. “I used to be very sensitive and felt extremely vulnerable. But since I began meditating and doing other spiritual practices, I think I’ve gained more courage and self-confidence.”

“You *think*. Daughter, that means you’re not very sure.”

The woman was perplexed. She said, “Amma, you’re like an investigating officer!”

Mother laughed and retorted, “Yes, Amma explores and investigates your inner self. She tries to pull out the old in order to create the new.”

Mother gazed lovingly at the woman. She put Her arms around her and hugged her affectionately.

“My daughter, a spiritual seeker must have a lot of patience and enthusiasm. There are some who are patient but not enthusiastic; others are enthusiastic but lack patience. Only a perfect balance between the two will help a seeker to deepen his experience.

“Look at the youngsters. They are very enthusiastic about doing things but they don’t have the patience to think things through. It is patience that opens up the gateway to discriminative thinking. The youngsters, however, in their one-sided enthusiasm, tend to jump into things, without giving anything the necessary thought. Their senses are strong and healthy, and their egoistic minds are drawn to thrills and adventure; but their lack of patience and discrimination often land them in trouble.

“On the other hand, elderly people in their sixties or seventies are usually very patient, but they lack enthusiasm. Experience has taught them to be patient, to do things with more discrimination. They are therefore far more thoughtful. But they don’t have the necessary enthusiasm to do things. They cannot be as enthusiastic as teenagers because their senses have weakened, their strength has deteriorated, and they have lost the thrill of life.

“Look at a toddler who is trying to stand up and walk. The child will fall countless times, failing in his every attempt. He may bruise his knee, hit his head on the floor, and cry; but, again and again, he will stubbornly try to get up and walk, until he finally succeeds. Though

the child fails, not once but countless times, he is both patient and enthusiastic. These qualities finally help the child to succeed in his attempts.

“Another notable point is the constant encouragement the child receives from its mother. Fortunately for the child, the mother is always there with supportive words, providing the child with faith and courage. Whenever the toddler falls, the mother’s loving hands are there to pick him up. She kisses and caresses him saying, ‘Don’t cry. It’s all right. Mother is here.’ She puts the child down and persuades him to try again. This happens innumerable times before the infant is finally able to stand on his own feet and walk with steady steps.

“The mother’s encouraging words and soothing touch helps the child to develop. Her love gives the child the inner strength it needs. In the same way, a sadhak needs the patience and enthusiasm of a child—but most importantly, he needs the loving presence and encouragement of a satguru to guide him to the goal. It is the master’s presence that encourages the sadhak to be patient, enthusiastic, and optimistic during times of frustration and lack of hope, when he feels like giving up his sadhana.

“Children, your vasanas are extremely strong and deep-rooted. They will try to pull you down, again and again. But don’t ever give up hope. Be determined and proceed.

“Suppose a person has been sitting in a dark room for a long time. Then one day he comes out into the sunlight. To begin with, he will find it difficult to get used to the light. It will take time for his eyes to adjust. Similarly, we have been living in this world believing that we are the body. We have become so identified with it that, now, as we try to withdraw that identification, we find it very difficult. We have become so accustomed to the darkness of our ignorance that we find it hard to come out into the light of God.

“The strength of our vasanas and age-old habits are such that we cannot easily free ourselves from their grip. As soon as the situation arises, the vasanas automatically manifest. Amma will tell you a story.

“There were two children, a brother and a sister. One day they dressed up in robes and put paper crowns on their heads. They pretended they were the king and queen of the land. They walked over to the neighbor’s house and knocked on the door. ‘Who is it?’ she asked. ‘It is the king and the queen,’ said the children. The neighbor decided to play along with them. She opened the door wide and said, ‘Your Majesties! What a great honor! Had I known you were coming, I would have laid out the red carpet and called the trumpeters.’ ‘It doesn’t matter,’ said the children. ‘Just let us in and give us something to eat.’ The woman led them inside and pulled out two chairs for them. ‘Please sit on your thrones, your Majesties,’ she said. The

‘king’ and ‘queen’ sat down with great dignity. The woman brought them homemade cookies and milk. ‘Here are some delicacies fit for royalty,’ she said. The king and queen nodded their approval. The cookies were beautiful, shaped like different animals. There was a large variety of bears, cats, fish, ducks, and lambs, but there was only one elephant cookie. And because there was only one elephant cookie, both the king and the queen wanted it. They both reached for it, but the queen got hold of it first. This made the king so angry that he threw his milk all over the queen. The queen grabbed a handful of cookies and threw them on the king. Soon they were bombarding each other with cookies, and then they jumped up from their thrones and began fighting in earnest. Their crowns flew off and their robes were torn. No more were they the king and queen of the land, but only two children fighting over a cookie.

“Only constant practice done with great patience and enthusiasm will enable you to overcome your latent tendencies and old habits. But above all, you need the grace and loving guidance of a satguru. Don’t ever give up your spiritual practices just because of a moment’s frustration or disappointment. Whatever type of sadhana you do, the result cannot be lost. Whatever you have gained remains within you and will bear fruit at the right time.”

Mother closed Her eyes and became absorbed in a state of meditation. After some time, She opened Her eyes again and began to sing the song, *Karunalaye Devi*.

O Goddess

Abode of Compassion

Giver of all that we desire

*O Katyayani, Gauri, Sambhavi, Sankari!*¹⁶

Dearest Mother,

Essence of Aum,

You adore the Sound Aum

O Mother, when You hear the mantra, “Om Shakti”

You will come running!

O Great Power of universal illusion.

¹⁶ Names of the Divine Mother

*You are the Cause of the creation,
 Preservation and destruction of the universe
 O Mother, everything is You
 You are everything
 There is none other than You
 O Mother, this suppliant has no support
 Other than You, the Self of all Bliss
 O Blissful Self, grant me a wonderful boon*

HERE AND NOW

Zurich

In Zurich Mother stayed with Heidi Furer. The first evening program was held in her house. Heidi had visited Mother at the ashram in India in 1984.

Although it was summer, the weather was cold in Zurich. The brahmacharis and the Indian householder devotees who were traveling with the group were not used to the cold. They wore sweaters and caps, but that didn't help them much. They froze so much that they had a difficult time getting out of their sleeping bags in the mornings.

During the first evening program a young man asked Mother a question.

“Most spiritual masters tell their disciples to forget about the past and future, and to live in the present moment. They teach many different techniques to help people attain this moment-by-moment living. Unfortunately, most of us are glued to the past and are worrying endlessly about the future. How is it possible for ordinary people, who are worried about how to pay their bills, their insurance, rent or house-payments, and their children's education, to stop being concerned about all the basic needs of life and, at the same time, to feel completely at peace? Isn't it the anxiety about the future that drives a person to work, earn money, and take proper care of his needs and obligations? Isn't it his past experiences that prompt him to be careful in the future, and to make sure that his mistakes are not repeated? Under these circumstances, how would it be possible for someone to live in the present moment, completely forgetting the past and the future?”

Mother: “What you have said about the concerns of most people is correct. No one can deny the reality of an ordinary individual’s day-to-day worries. Past experiences certainly help a person to mold his future. It is also true that his dreams about the future inspire him to work and to fulfill those dreams. The real question, however, is whether there is any benefit to be had in regretting the past or being anxious about the future. You can plan your future on the basis of the experiences you have had and the lessons you have learnt from the past, but you don’t have to dwell in the past or the future.

“You can plan your dinner, but not while preparing your lunch. Don’t think about how much salt you will use in tonight’s meal while adding salt to the soup you are cooking now. And don’t regret that the soup you made yesterday wasn’t a success. Just concentrate on the soup that is boiling on the stove at this moment. You want it to be healthy and delicious, don’t you? So be alert and conscious of this moment.

“This teaching of living in the present moment can be viewed from two different angles: from that of the ordinary person who has professional, social, and family responsibilities; and from the standpoint of the sadhak who wants nothing but God-realization.

“For an ordinary person, who has worldly responsibilities to take care of, to completely forget the past and the future isn’t possible, and he doesn’t have to do that. Yet even for such a person, too much interference from the past and the future will prevent him from carrying out his duties properly in the present. An action always takes place in the present moment. To be able to carry it out properly, using all your talents and capabilities, you have to concentrate one hundred percent on the work at hand. Brooding or dreaming about something else will interfere with the work. Before you begin the work, you should think about any past related mistakes or failures, and prepare the mind for the job you are about to do. All calculations should be done beforehand. However, once the work has begun, all your attention should be on what you are doing now. In between, if you need to remember something, pause, go to the repository of the past, and find what you need to know. Then come out of there and continue with what you were doing, putting all your heart and soul into it. But do not stay with your memories, with your past. To be able to express yourself fully, you have to be present in the moment. Take, for example, a painter who is trying to capture the beauty of a landscape. If he thinks about his girlfriend while painting, he will do a mediocre job because his heart isn’t in it. His focus is divided.

“A woman was on her way to the market carrying a basket of eggs on her head. As she walked along the road she began to daydream: ‘I’ll get a good price for these eggs. With the

money I can buy a few more hens. Those hens will lay so many eggs that I'll soon be able to buy a cow. That cow will produce so much milk that before long I can afford to buy several cows. From the money I get from all that milk I shall buy a farm. The farm will make me so rich that I'll be able to buy a beautiful mansion. By then I'll be so rich that many young men will be after me. When I meet them on the street, I'll wiggle my hips and walk like this...' And as the woman wiggled her hips, the basket fell from her head and all the eggs lay broken on the ground.

"Human beings have a deep tendency to dream about the future, to sail away on the wings of the imagination. Dreams belong to the future. Dreaming can make you inactive and incompetent. Dreaming needs no effort; if you have nothing else to do, you can simply sit down and dream about going to the moon, marrying a beautiful princess, or beating your opponent. It is the nature of the mind to brood over the past and to dream about tomorrow. Even a normally successful, active person can easily be caught in the clutches of the past and the future. People don't know how much energy they are wasting by immersing themselves in such thoughts. It is a great mistake if you keep thinking about the past or the future while engaged in some activity. You may be very talented and successful at what you do, but when you engage in such reverie you are killing half your talents, instead of utilizing your full capacity. In order to function fully, to be complete and perfect in your actions, you have to learn to live in the present moment. Then your total capacity will be channeled into whatever you do.

"Those who desire nothing but God-realization do not bother about the past or the future. Their wish is to be in the present moment, for that is where God is; that is where perfect peace and bliss is to be found. It is by being in this moment that you attain perfect stillness and quietude within. The past and the future are movements of the mind. The mind moves from the past to the future and back again, like the movement of a pendulum from one end to the other. The real center of existence is experienced when the pendulum of the mind reaches a point of stillness. The mind attains a state of stillness when it rests in the present moment. That stillness, or center, is what a true seeker yearns for, and this is why he doesn't bother about the past or the future. His focus is on the here and now. That is what is known as remembrance of God. Remembrance of God can only take place when you let go of the past and stop dreaming about the future. Then the pendulum of the mind stops swinging back and forth; it reaches a point of stillness, and you dwell in the stillness of the present moment."

Schweibenalp

Mother spent nine days in Schweibenalp in the Swiss Alps. People had come there from all over Europe to see Mother. A lot of families came and there were many children present. The small hall that had been prepared for Mother's darshan was jam-packed with people. They were joyful and enthusiastic, many of them dancing and singing in Mother's presence as if they were in seventh heaven. Because people had come from all over Europe, Mother's satsangs were translated into English, German, and French.

It was even colder in the Alps than it had been in Zurich. The brahmacharis and Indian devotees were walking around with clattering teeth, wearing woolen caps and several layers of thick clothes.

MIRACLES

During the first morning darshan a few questions were asked.

"Amma, could you say something about miracles? What exactly is a miracle?"

Mother: "Miracles are usually attributed to godmen. There is a widespread belief that only a divine being can perform a miracle, and that miracles are part and parcel of such a soul. People even believe that if a person doesn't perform any miracles, he cannot be a great soul, even though he may, in fact, be Self-realized. But our idea of what constitutes a miracle may or may not occur in the presence of the truly great ones, because they don't really care that much about such things. They have nothing to gain or lose by performing miracles. They don't care about name or fame, nor do they wish to please or displease anyone. If it happens, that's fine, and if it doesn't happen, that is also fine. Today, however, people's faith in God has come to depend on the miracles of a Self-realized master or a godman. Unfortunately, there are also so-called gurus whose only intention is to exploit and control people, and who like to draw attention to themselves by performing all sorts of miracles in public.

"To have absolute mastery over the mind is the same as having mastery over the universe. Everything in creation is made of the five elements: fire, water, earth, air, and ether. Once you attain God-realization, all the elements are under your control. They become your obedient servants. If you want something to turn into a mountain, it will do so; or if you wish to create another world, that is also possible. But for this to happen, you don't actually have to reach the final point of realization. You could gain this ability even before that.

“When you are able to concentrate with absolute one-pointedness on certain aspects of the five elements, and are able to retain that one-pointedness, separating the object of your concentration from its inner essence, you will know the essence of everything and be able to control it. You will develop *siddhis* (supernatural powers), by which you can, for example, read people’s minds, see and hear things that are happening at a distance, materialize physical objects, know everything about the past and the future, understand any language—including the language of animals, make yourself as light as a feather or as heavy as a mountain, and move through space at any speed or distance.

“In the Indian epics there is a saint called Viswamithra. Before becoming a sage, Viswamithra was a king. He once went on a hunting expedition with a large group of his soldiers. When the hunt was over they were all exhausted and needed to rest. The king remembered that the great sage, Vasistha, had a hermitage in the area, and he led his soldiers there. Vasistha had a divine cow called Nandini, who could fulfill any of the sage’s wishes. So when King Viswamithra arrived at the hermitage with his army, Vasistha managed, in no time, to serve them all a grand feast, with the help of the wish-fulfilling cow. Viswamithra was wonderstruck at the power of the cow. He thought to himself that such a precious creature ought to belong to the king of the country, i.e. to himself, and not to a sage who had renounced the world and therefore had no needs. He conveyed his thoughts to the sage, who immediately permitted the king to take the cow. But when the king tried to lead the cow away, the animal protested. She wouldn’t move an inch. All the efforts of the king to take her to the palace failed. The king became furious and tried to drag the cow by force with the help of his soldiers. But Nandini responded by creating thousands of fully armed soldiers out of her own body. In the battle that followed, Nandini’s soldiers defeated the king’s army. Understanding that the cow derived her power from the great sage, the king was enraged and turned to fight the sage, himself. He began showering arrows and other powerful missiles at Vasistha. But the sage was unmoved. With a beaming smile on his face, the sage stood rooted on the ground, holding up his *yogadanda* (the stick of a yogi) in his hand. No thought of enmity, anger, or hatred existed in Vasistha’s mind, because he was a true saint, who was beyond the ego and all its negative feelings. All the powerful weapons which the king hurled at him proved to be ineffective before his simple wooden stick. The king was soon disarmed and defeated. He felt deeply humiliated. He was struck by the fact that though he was the most powerful king of his time, his mighty military force and all his weapons were nothing before a great sage like Vasistha, who had immense spiritual powers which he had gained

through severe tapas (austerities). The king returned to the palace, boiling with rage. He abdicated from the throne and retired to the forest to do intense tapas. The sole purpose of his tapas was to take revenge on the sage.

“According to the story, Viswamithra did severe tapas and then returned to the world to pour out his vengeance on Vasistha. But each time he tried, his efforts ended in failure. Again and again, he did more tapas, constantly intensifying his practices. He was never discouraged by his failures; he simply continued to do more austerities. Through this he developed such siddhis (yogic powers) that at one point he even managed to create another heaven, a world full of fleeting pleasures, for the sake of challenging Vasistha. Viswamithra performed numerous miracles, but his obsessive anger towards the sage, and his constant miracle making, created countless blocks on his path.

“Eventually, though, his attitude changed, and he finally attained Self-realization. But this could happen only after he had succeeded in eliminating all sense of ego and anger, and had gone beyond the petty feelings of ‘I’ and ‘mine’; when he had given up his vengeful thoughts against the sage, and had learned to love everyone equally; when he stopped using his powers to harm others, and was instead using his powers for the good of everyone, benefiting the entire world.

“There are two aspects to this story. The first shows how genuine the sage Vasistha was. He was a Self-realized master. He had all the divine powers at his disposal, and yet he had no ego. He had no ill feelings towards Viswamithra, who was constantly trying to attack him and insult him. In fact, the epics say that Vasistha, in spite of all the humiliations showered upon him by Viswamithra, praised the latter’s greatness and determination on several occasions.

“To begin with, there was a great difference between the two men. While Vasistha maintained a perfect state of mental equilibrium in all circumstances, Viswamithra’s hatred was raging within him despite all his achievements. Viswamithra underwent rigorous austerities and attained tremendous spiritual powers. He could perform fantastic miracles; but by doing so, he lost all the powers he had gained through his tapas. He was also constantly in a state of agitation, due to his vengeful thoughts about Vasistha. Because of this, it took a long time for him to reach the state of final emancipation, relative to the intensity of his tapas. Vasistha, on the other hand, was always blissful and serene, and though he also used his divine powers—doing so when and where the need arose—he didn’t lose anything by it. Vasistha was purnam (complete). He was one with the Cosmic Power. His spiritual power was inexhaustible, and at the same time he was egoless.

“Nandini, the divine cow, who could fulfill any wish, represents material prosperity (*ashtaiswaryas*). This means that once you have attained the ultimate state of Self-realization, the whole world with all its wealth will serve you. But because you are beyond all desires, you use that wealth for the benefit and upliftment of society as a whole.

“A person may possess miraculous powers, but as long as he is in the grip of the ego and the feeling of ‘I’ and ‘mine’, those powers are useless, because his basic nature remains unchanged, and he himself cannot change or transform anyone. Such a person cannot lead anyone on the path to divinity. A person who misuses his powers can only be destructive and harm society. By using his powers against the laws of nature, he is inevitably paving the way for his own destruction.

“In fact, by performing miracles one upsets the laws of nature. Of course, a Self-realized soul is free to do so, because he is one with the Cosmic Power; but he does so only if it is absolutely necessary, preferring to refrain from it as far as possible.

“While in the highest state of meditation, when their minds were totally attuned to the Universal Energy, the rishis (the ancient seers) saw the mantras, the pure divine vibrations that are the essential principles of the universe. The rishis are the ones who brought these laws into light, for the uplift of society and the benefit of humanity.

“The government, with the help of administrative experts, sets the constitution of a country; and they themselves have to abide by the rules and regulations they have created.

Similarly, in order to set an example, the rishis have to abide by the essential principles which they themselves have revealed, without going beyond and disrupting them.

“The Hindu epics like the *Ramayana*, the *Mahabharata*, and the *Srimad Bhagavatam* contain stories about many kings, demons, demi-gods, and pseudo-masters who have had great powers but could only harm others. Although they were not Self-realized, but were stuck in their egos, they had certain powers. Because of their occult powers they became totally carried away by their egos. They were a curse to humanity. But in the end, they themselves came to grief and perished. So a person may have some supernatural powers without necessarily being Self-realized.

“Spirituality is not meant to feed the ego. On the contrary, spirituality gets rid of the ego; it teaches you to go beyond it. Anyone can develop occult powers by performing certain practices as prescribed by the scriptures. But true spiritual realization is something far beyond such matters. It is a state in which you are completely free from all bondage to the body, mind, and intellect. It is the inner experience of the Supreme Truth. Once that final point has

been reached, one cannot harbor any negative feelings, such as anger, hatred, or vengeance. In that state you dwell in divine love and peace, irrespective of the outer circumstances; and wherever you are, you radiate that same love and peace towards everyone. Your love, compassion, and serenity will transform people. An enlightened being can make the ignorant wise, change mortals into immortals, and man into God. That is the real miracle that happens in the presence of a great soul.

“To go beyond the ego is to become one with the universe. You become as expansive as the universe. You dive deep into its secret mysteries, realizing the ultimate Reality. You become the master of the universe.

“In a Self-realized master’s presence, miracles may happen spontaneously; it’s simply a natural expression of their being. When a realized soul makes a sankalpa (resolve), it has to manifest. Whatever he thinks inexorably comes into being. If he so wishes, he can transform anything into whatever he wants.”

Question: “Amma, you said that the rishis had seen the mantras. What does this mean? Didn’t they create the mantras?”

Mother: “No, the mantras have always existed. They are the eternal principles. They are beginningless and without end. They are not created, nor will they ever be destroyed. That is why the *Vedas* are said to be without beginning or end. No one created them. The printed text didn’t always exist, but the divine vibrations or mantras which form the *Vedas* have always existed. They were simply revealed to us by the rishis. When it is said that they ‘saw’, it means that they experienced the *Vedas* in their hearts, when their whole being was at one with the highest point of existence. They experienced what was already there. So they did not create the *Vedas* (*mantra kartha*);¹⁷ rather, they saw or experienced them (*mantra drishta*).¹⁸

“When the astronauts landed on the moon, they didn’t discover a new moon. They revealed to us what was already there. They saw and experienced the moon, and then, through pictures and words, they transferred what they saw to us. It is the same with the mantras.”

The brahmacharis began singing *Radhe Govinda Gopi Gopala*, and Amma took the lead.

¹⁷ Mantra kartha = creator or author of a mantra. The Sanskrit word ‘kartha’ means ‘the doer’ or ‘the author.’ The rishis are not mantra kartha.

¹⁸ Mantra drishta = perceiver of a mantra. The word ‘drishta’ means ‘seer’ or ‘perceiver.’ It is derived from the root, ‘drish,’ meaning ‘to see.’ It implies that the mantras have always existed on the subtle plane; and the rishis discovered them, that is, they perceived them. So the rishis are mantra drishta.

O Radha

Lord of the Cows

Milkmaid

Cowherd Boy

Lord of the Cows

Cowherd Boy

Salutations to the Son of Nanda

O Radha

Lord of the Cows

Milkmaid

Cowherd Boy

Mira Bai's Lord

Flute playing Cowherd Boy

Who lifted up the Govardhana Hill

Boy Gopala

O Radha

Lord of the Cows

Milkmaid

Cowherd Boy

ARE MIRACLES RELEVANT?

Question: “Amma, should miracles be encouraged, or are they obstacles on the spiritual path?”

Mother: “For an ordinary person miracles can be of some help to instill faith in a supreme power. But any faith that is rooted only in miracles can also easily be lost when the miracles are not forthcoming. What if God, or a great soul who is one with God, who is omnipresent, omnipotent, and omniscient, decides not to perform an expected miracle? It can happen because such a soul doesn't owe anything to anyone, and has nothing to gain or lose by performing miracles. It makes no difference to God or to a great saint whether or not people

believe in Him. He doesn't need our faith or our service. It is we who need His grace. But His grace can only be obtained through faith.

"A perfect master doesn't need anything from us, for he is complete as he is. It is we who need his grace to purify and uplift us. Our faith shouldn't depend merely on miracles. Faith for its own sake, and love for love's own sake, is the healthiest and wisest approach.

"Our faith should be rooted in both the heart and the intellect. For a true sadhak, both devotion and intellectual knowledge are necessary—unless, of course, we possess the same intense love, total faith and self-surrender that the gopis of Vrindavan had. Though their love was a type of blind love in the beginning, it gradually evolved into *tatwattile bhakti* (devotion rooted in the essential principles of spirituality), which is bhakti grounded in jnana.

"We should feel both love and respect for God or a perfect spiritual master—love of the heart and the respect that arises from an understanding of the master's all-pervasive, omnipotent, and omniscient nature. Only then will we receive the full benefit of his presence. It is the blend of love and knowledge that helps us to fully experience the grace of God or a true master in our lives. But that inner experience of God's blissful presence cannot be experienced if one is too obsessed with miracles.

"Miracles do have a place, but we shouldn't give them too much importance. People have a tendency to get too attached to such things. When this happens, people lose their perspective, and the miracles themselves become the sole point of focus.

"People who have too many desires tend to give too much importance to miracles. Their faith is shallow. Too many miracles will only serve to create even more desires in the minds of such people, and their desires will only lead to sorrow and suffering.

"True spirituality is to go beyond all desires, to go beyond the mind and its thoughts. This is what a true aspirant longs for. A genuine seeker is not satisfied with anything less than the state beyond the mind, and miracles cannot help you reach that state. If anything, they will only be a hindrance, because a person who is attached to miracles is stuck at the level of the mind and its demands to be stimulated—and that, of course, is not the ultimate state.

"In the spiritual pursuit, while the aspirant is advancing in his sadhana, he may develop the power to perform miracles. Whereas a less sincere seeker may get trapped in the power of such abilities, the true seeker, who genuinely wishes to realize the ultimate Truth, will ignore such things and transcend them.

"People consider materializing objects and curing diseases to be the only kinds of miracles. Such things are, of course, miracles of a sort; but the greatest miracle is the inner

transformation that happens to a person. People don't consider that the real miracle consists of the opening of one's heart into the one Supreme Truth. If they were to just open up their hearts, they would experience the real miracle—they would realize that God's grace is always present—nay, that they themselves are God—and that miracles are happening at every moment.

“Everything in nature is a wonderful miracle. Isn't a little bird flying through the vast sky a miracle? Isn't a tiny fish swimming in the depths of the ocean a miracle? Unfortunately, people think that only if a fish flies through the sky can it be called a miracle!

“True spirituality and true religion has little to do with performing miracles, nor is the amount of miracles a person performs a criterion by which to measure his divinity. True spirituality is to be found in the immeasurable love and inner peace that the master transmits to others. True spirituality is expressed as pure love and perfect equanimity. Only through love can a real transformation be brought about. A harmonious blend of selfless love and pure knowledge will remove all misconceptions about spirituality.”

IN MOTHER'S LAP

One by one, the people were called by Mother and came up to Her. A man came up and, as he lay his head in Mother's lap, Mother began to sing *Sri Krishna Sharanam Mama*.

Sri Krishna is my Refuge

Sri Hari is my Refuge

Prostrations to Sri Krishna

Whose nature is Being-Awareness-Bliss

Who is the Cause of

The creation, preservation, and dissolution

Of the universe

Destroyer of the three types of suffering

I know no Reality other than Sri Krishna

Who holds the flute in His hands

Who is beautiful like a fresh rain cloud

*Who wears yellow robes
Whose lips are red like an aruna bimba fruit
Whose face is charming like the full moon
And whose eyes are slanted like lotus petals*

*Sri Krishna, how sweet is Your Name!
O Son of Nanda, how sweet is Your Name!
O Moon of Vrindavan
Sri Krishna is the Name that is dear to You
All these Names are dear to You*

*Victory to Radha Govinda!
Victory to Radha Gopal
Govinda, Govinda, Goparipal (Protector of the cows)!*

*Some say You are the son of Vasudeva
Others call you the son of Nanda*

*On the banks of the Yamuna river
The Child Krishna plays the flute so sweetly
Sri Krishna is a Name that is dear to You
The One Who Loves to Dance is a name that is dear to You
Protector of the Sages is a name that is dear to You*

Mother suddenly went into a state of rapture, and in that state She continued to sing for at least ten minutes. She kept repeating the refrain of the song: “Sri Krishna Sharanam Mama, Sri Hari Sharanam Mama....” At the end of the song, She was in a deeply absorbed mood, which lasted for another ten minutes. When Mother finally opened Her eyes, the man who had been receiving darshan all this time was still kneeling in front of Her, resting in Her lap. Mother gently tapped him on the shoulder as a sign for him to get up. He didn’t move. Again Mother tapped his shoulder, but there was no response. Mother said to him, “Son, get up.” But nothing happened. Mother used a little more force by lifting his head slightly and calling louder, “Son!” This time he jumped up with a start. He looked as if he had just emerged from

another world. He rubbed his eyes and looked around confused. Everyone thought they understood what had happened to him, that he had fallen fast asleep in Mother's lap, and they laughed heartily. Mother also burst out laughing; but a moment later, when She saw the innocent, helpless expression on his face, She took his hand and made him sit down on the floor next to Her chair, and She affectionately put his head back on Her lap. As the laughter slowly subsided, the man sat up and Mother continued giving darshan.

While the next person was receiving Mother's darshan, She turned to Amritatma and said, "He was in bliss!"

Only a few people came to know what had really happened. As the man was resting in Her lap, Mother had begun singing. After a minute or two, he suddenly had the experience that Mother's lap was growing; and as Her lap continued to expand, the depth and intensity of the bliss he was experiencing also increased. At last he felt that he was swimming in an ocean of bliss. He remained in a state of merging until Mother finally brought him out of it.

PUT OTHERS BEFORE YOURSELF

From Switzerland Mother took a train to Austria, where two programs had been arranged by a woman called Christine Essen—one program in Graz and the other, a residential program, in St. Polten, a small town between Vienna and Linz. Austria was to be the last stop on the tour.

While traveling on the train the brahmacharis had an opportunity to spend some time alone with Mother. At one point, Mother said to them: "People ask why they are being put through such severe tests in life; why they, of all people, have to suffer. 'Why me?' is the question. They don't seem to care if it happens to anyone else. Their attitude is, 'Let someone else suffer, as long as it isn't me.' Let us change that attitude and, instead, sincerely wish that no one in the world should have to suffer. Let us not think, 'Why me?' but rather, 'Why should anyone have to suffer?' Let us learn to put others before ourselves. Amma has heard the following story:

"A little boy was staring in wonder at a beautiful, newly-built mansion. As he stood in front of the house, a young man came out of the gate. The boy asked him, 'Who does that beautiful house belong to?' 'It's mine,' said the man. 'I have a brother who happens to be very rich. He built it for me.' Hearing this the boy exclaimed, 'Oh, if only...' and he sighed deeply. The man could easily guess what the boy was about to say next—that if only he had a

brother like that.... But when the boy continued to speak, the man was surprised by what he said. ‘Oh,’ said the boy, ‘if only I was a brother like that!’

“Children, it is this sort of attitude that brings joy to our lives. Why should anyone have to suffer in this world? If you are goodhearted enough to put others before yourself, you will experience peace and happiness. But for this to happen, you have to move away from selfishness and journey along the path to selflessness.

“People have a tendency to want more and more and more. They are never satisfied with what they have. Instead, we should learn to give and to share. We should never be mere takers.

“We should share whatever we have with others; and we should try to contribute to the welfare of society in some way. It is through giving that we progress on the spiritual path. If we hoard our wealth, our spiritual development will be stunted, and slowly our lives will wither away. The blood that is pumped by the heart is circulated and distributed evenly throughout the whole body. What would happen if our circulation were to stop? We would collapse and die. Likewise, whatever we have should be circulated and shared. We shouldn’t hoard our wealth because then society becomes stagnant, and cannot grow as a whole.

“It is through selfless sharing that the flower of life becomes beautiful and fragrant.”

In Mother’s own life there are countless examples that clearly show Her selfless love and compassion.

In the early days, the financial position of the ashram was very poor. Sometimes the residents didn’t have enough to eat. They had only one set of clothes each, and whenever they had to attend Mother’s programs outside the ashram, they would share the few good clothes that were available. Also, Mother was very particular that the visitors who came to the ashram should be given food. Only after all the guests had been served were the residents allowed to eat. Because they never knew how many people would arrive on any given day, and because there was hardly any money available, there was often no food left for the residents. On those occasions, Mother would go to the neighboring houses and beg for food.

One day a woman from the neighborhood came to Mother and told Her that the marriage of her daughter had been arranged. Because the woman was very poor, she asked Mother to help her. Even though the ashram was struggling financially, Mother assured her that She would help. She called one of the brahmacharis and asked him to fetch a box from Her room.

When the box was brought to Mother, She opened it and took out a brand new, gold necklace, which someone had recently given Her.

Br. Ramakrishnan (Swami Ramakrishnananda), who was sitting next to Mother, was wondering what Mother was about to do. Without the slightest hesitation, Mother handed the necklace to the destitute woman. Ramakrishnan was shocked at this because the ashramites themselves were so poor. At the time, he was working in a bank, and he knew the value of that necklace.

By the time the woman had left, he was so agitated that he could no longer control himself. He blurted out, “Amma, how could you do such a thing! Do you know how valuable that necklace is? I could have taken it to the bank for you and received a lot of money for it. You shouldn’t have done that!”

Mother replied, “Is that so? Why didn’t you tell me earlier? Hurry up! Go and call her back immediately!”

Ramakrishnan was very pleased with Mother’s response. He felt proud of himself for having been able to correct Mother’s mistake. He ran to the woman and brought her back to Mother. The woman looked bewildered. Mother pointed at Ramakrishnan and said to her, “This brahmachari says that the necklace Amma gave you is worth a great deal of money.”

Ramakrishnan was so impatient, he was about to interrupt and tell the woman to give it back, when Mother turned to him and told him to keep quiet. She continued, “Because the necklace is so valuable, whatever you do, don’t pawn it or sell it for a cheaper price than it is worth. Make sure you get a good price for it.”

Ramakrishnan suddenly felt deeply ashamed of himself, for not having understood the extent of Mother’s compassion.

The train moved along, making the sound, “chuck, chuck, chuck....” Outside the train window the sun was beginning to set. Mother asked the brahmacharis to sing the usual evening bhajans. Mother was very particular that the brahmacharis should stick to their daily spiritual practices, no matter where they were. She often told them that a sadhak should not be enslaved by circumstances, but should be the master of all situations.

Br. Srikumar took the harmonium out of its carrying case and began to play. During the next hour and a half they sang several songs. One of them was called *Orunalil Varumo*.

O Mother of unearthly bliss,

*Won't You come one day to the shrine of my heart
 With Your eternally shining lamp?
 It is for this reason alone
 That this suppliant is wandering about.*

*O Devi,
 Won't You bless me?
 With a melting heart
 I have searched for the Divine Mother everywhere.
 O Mother, bestow Your Grace upon me;
 Caress me with Your soft hands.
 O Mother, give me shelter;
 I am collapsing with exhaustion.
 I know it is true that You dwell in me
 But when will the day of realization come?*

During the bhajans, Mother intermittently joined in the singing, but most of the time She sat quietly looking out through the window.

One evening in Vienna there was no program. Mother, along with the group who was traveling with Her, went out for a stroll. They walked along a country road for about half an hour, until Mother sat down beside a beautiful wooded area, with Her face towards the setting sun. It was only seven degrees Celsius. The few people who passed them on the road were wearing several layers of warm clothes. Mother was just wearing Her white sari. Someone covered Her with a woolen shawl. The brahmacharis were wearing nothing but their dhotis and cotton shirts, and they were freezing. Seeing the brahmacharis huddled together, shivering with cold, Mother removed Her shawl and lovingly wrapped it around them. But as Mother would then have nothing to protect Her from the cold, the brahmacharis politely refused, saying, "No Amma, you should wear it." But Mother refused to put it on again. "No problem!" She said, insisting that they use it. The shawl which Mother so lovingly insisted that they wear was so precious to them that they all wanted to be covered by it; so they all huddled close together.

BRAHMASHAKTI

Still sitting huddled under the shawl, Br. Ramakrishna asked Mother a question:

“Amma, it is said that the divine sankalpa of the Paramatman (the Supreme Self) is everywhere. What does this mean? Could you please explain?”

Mother: “The Paramatman’s sankalpa or *Brahmashakti* (the power of Brahman) underlies everything in the universe. Look at this amazing cosmos and the harmonious way in which our planet and all other planets function. Without a cosmic intelligence, a universal power that controls everything, how could such perfect order and beauty exist? Can we call it accidental? No, because nothing is accidental. Whenever there is something the human intellect cannot explain, we dismiss it and call it accidental. But that is the language of intellectual reasoning. A person who functions more from the heart doesn’t think of anything as mere chance. He calls it God’s power, God’s *leela* (play), or sankalpa.

“Amma is not trying to deny the value of science and its contributions. Science has a certain dharma (duty) to fulfill. Let science follow its dharma; but let us remember that, as human beings who are trying to live our lives attuned to God, we have a dharma of our own which we should adhere to. We should live our lives accordingly, listening to the call of our inner conscience.

“The ego or the intellect cannot comprehend or even begin to perceive the great sankalpa that is the power behind the universe. Science is still searching for that cosmic intelligence. But unless the scientists create a balance between science and spirituality, they will not find the life-giving Principle which is beyond the intellect. The inner world, which is normally given no importance, needs to be explored if they wish to understand what lies behind the outer world.

“A beautiful melody emerging from a flute is neither to be found in the flute nor in the player’s fingertips. You could say it comes from the composer’s heart. But if you were to open up his heart and take a look, you wouldn’t find it there either. What, then, is the original source of the music? The source is beyond; it emerges out of Brahmashakti, the Paramatman. But the ego cannot recognize this power. Only if you learn to function from the heart can you really see and feel this divine power in your life.

“God’s sankalpa is behind everything—behind the blossoming of a flower, the chirping of a bird, the movement of the wind, and the flames of a fire. It is the power by which everything grows; it is the power that sustains everything. That divine sankalpa is the

underlying cause of the birth, growth, and death of all living beings. It is the cause of the entire creation. It is the Paramatman's shakti that sustains the world. Without it, the world would cease to exist."

Mother turned to Amritatma and asked him to sing *Kodanukodi*.

*O Eternal Truth,
For millions of years
Mankind has been searching for You.*

*The ancient sages renounced everything,
And for the purpose of making the Self flow,
Through meditation,
Into Your Divine Stream,
They performed endless years of austerities.*

*Your infinitesimal Flame,
Inaccessible to all,
Shines like the blaze of the sun;
It stands perfectly still, without a flutter
In the fierce wind of the cyclone.*

*The flowers and creepers,
The shrine rooms and temples,
With their newly installed sacred pillars,
Have been waiting for You for eons
And yet You remain unreachable...*

After the song Mother continued speaking:

"Do you know the story of when Brahman appeared among the *devas* (celestial beings)? Brahmashakti (the power of the Absolute Reality) won a victory for the *devas*. But the *devas* gave all the credit to themselves. They chose to believe they had won solely because of their own greatness. Drunk with their egos, the *devas* forgot about Brahman, as they rejoiced and celebrated their victory on a grand scale. When Brahman came to know of this, He appeared

before them in the form of a *yaksha*, an adorable spirit. Being totally carried away by their egos, the devas failed to recognize Him, who was the very cause and power behind the victory they were celebrating. When the yaksha appeared, Indra, the chief of the devas, sent the god of fire,¹⁹ to find out who the spirit was. When the fire god approached the yaksha, the spirit asked him who he was and what his powers were.

“With great pride, the god replied, ‘I am the deity presiding over fire. There is nothing in the world I cannot burn.’

“Brahman, in the form of the yaksha, placed a single straw in front of the god and asked him to burn it.

“The god tried with all his might, but no matter how hard he tried, he wasn’t able to leave the slightest mark on the straw. He withdrew and reported to Indra that he didn’t know who the yaksha was. He didn’t mention a word about his own defeat, because the ego never accepts defeat.

“While the ego places great importance on its own achievements, it refuses to admit any of its failures. This is human nature. People say, ‘I have achieved this and that,’ but they rarely say, ‘I was defeated,’ or, ‘I have failed in such and such an area of my life.’ Because of their lack of humility, they get carried away by their egos, and become drunk with the idea of power and wealth. They fail to see the Universal Power, God’s *sankalpa*, in their day-to-day achievements, and also in their failures. If everything is pervaded with God’s *sankalpa*, our failures are also His *sankalpa*. But people do not see His *sankalpa* anywhere. They believe that whenever they succeed, it is due to their own power and greatness. On the other hand, when they fail, they refuse to admit they had anything to do with it. Instead they blame their failures on others or on different situations.

“When Brahman appeared, the fire god wasn’t able to recognize him. This is a typical example of how the ego works. The ego is proud of its own apparent power and cleverness, while it ignores the Universal Power. Even when that Supreme Power appears in front of us in manifold forms, we fail to recognize it. How could fire burn if the Paramatman’s *Shakti*, the Supreme *Shakti*—the power behind all fire—was not present? This is why the god of fire became powerless and was defeated.

“Indra then commanded Vayu, the god of air, to approach the spirit. Vayu went up to the spirit, introduced himself, and boasted that there was nothing on earth that he couldn’t blow

¹⁹ The Hindus consider all the natural forces to be deities, and worship them as different aspects of the Supreme.

away. The yaksha placed the straw in front of Vayu and said, ‘You claim to be so powerful. Then blow this away!’ Vayu huffed and puffed at the straw with all his might, but the straw wouldn’t budge.

“The ego likes to make a great huff about its own importance. But how could the ego function without the life force behind it? Agni (fire) and Vayu (air) are just minuscule points of the Universal Energy. If that energy is withdrawn, they lose all their power. In other words, it is the Cosmic Energy that functions through fire and air, without which they wouldn’t exist.

“Vayu also refused to admit his defeat. All he said to Indra was that he didn’t know who the yaksha was either.

“People think that their sense organs (devas) are very important and give them great credit, but when they find themselves in situations in which they are helpless or defeated, they turn to the mind or the intellect for help, which is higher and subtler than the senses.

“Now all the devas (gods) came together and asked Indra (the mind and intellect, that is, the chief of the senses)²⁰ to find out who the yaksha was. But when Indra, who by now was a bit humbled, approached the yaksha, the spirit disappeared and in its place he beheld the great, effulgent Goddess Uma. Indra asked Her, ‘Who was that adorable spirit (yaksha)?’

“Uma, the Universal Mother, said to Indra, ‘That was Brahmashakti, who won your victory for you. What you believed to be your victory, was actually *His* victory. It was only through Him that any of your glory was achieved.’

“So, whatever you achieve in life, it is not your but Brahman’s achievement. The Paramatman’s sankalpa lies behind each one of your victories and failures. Learn to recognize it; for in that understanding lies true success in life.

“In your quest to understand the Cosmic Energy, the Supreme Consciousness, with your mind, senses, and intellect, you will always be confronted with defeat, though you may not accept it as such; because the Atman or Brahman is beyond the intellect; it is subtler than the senses, mind, and intellect—subtler than the subtlest. Out of your utter inability to understand, a strong urge will be created within you to know what that great power is. In your state of helplessness, you finally give up, and this leads to the surrender of your mind. It is this surrender that brings your ‘beloved’, the master, to you. The master will help you and guide you to the real source of existence. In reality, the master himself is Brahmashakti. The

²⁰ Indra symbolizes the chief of the senses, i.e., the mind. The word ‘Indra’ is related to the word ‘indriya,’ which means the senses.

form exists as long as you are identified with the body and mind. Once you have transcended the body and mind, you will experience the infinite, formless aspect of the master.

“The *Vedas* say that the universe emerged out of the Paramatman’s breath. The meaning of this is that it is the Supreme Life Principle or Vital Energy that functions throughout creation. When that Principle withdraws by itself, everything stops. The very purpose of life is to recognize the Divine Principle (*sankalpa*) in all our thoughts and actions, and in every aspect of life.”

Mother turned to Br. Srikumar and said, “Bring the harmonium.” The harmonium was back at the house where they were staying, but, as he had anticipated that something like this might happen, he was carrying a small keyboard. He showed this to Mother, and She accepted it. Then, to Srikumar’s accompaniment, Mother sang a bhajan called *Sokamitentinu Sandhye*.

*O twilight, why are you so sad?
Are you also wandering
On the shores of your memories?
O dusk, bathed in shades of red,
Does the fire of sorrow burn within you?*

*O twilight, do you have a Mother like mine?
Have you seen my Mother?
She radiates beauty and cool purity
Like the full moon.*

*O dusk, if you should see Her,
Please convey the message of this helpless child,
Who cannot speak.
I am weighted down with infinite sorrow,
Caused by the pain of separation.*

*O twilight, please offer these flower petals at Her feet
And convey my words.
When you return, I shall tell you*

My sweet stories of a bygone spring.

Mother continued to sing two more songs. While everyone was shivering in the cold, Mother seemed totally unaffected. It was as if the cold air was too timid to come close to Her. A little later Mother stood up and they all walked back along the road.

It has happened many times that Mother has asked for a cardigan or a pair of woolen socks, or even a heater, when it is very hot. But when it's cold, it doesn't seem to affect Her at all. It is impossible to understand Mother. Her ways are often incomprehensible. Even Her body is subject to entirely different laws than those of any ordinary person.

Mother's first world tour was coming to an end.

She had blessed the land of many countries with the touch of Her sacred feet; and who knows what effect that was to have on those countries in years to come? Mother works on different levels, most of them so subtle that we cannot even begin to perceive them. We can only see the tip of the iceberg of what Mother is doing on this planet.

The 1987 world tour was the beginning of a spiritual conquest by that great Conqueror of hearts. In the years to come, Mother was to return to the West, again and again, bringing countless people to the spiritual path, and gathering those already on the path under Her wing of Grace.

Mother had spent just a few days in each place, passing through like a sweet whirlwind of Supreme Love, leaving in Her wake countless hearts awakened with a new, strange longing for a spiritual life, a yearning to know God, which could not be extinguished. No one who had met Mother would ever be able to forget Her; and those whose hearts She had captured in Her divine net found that they were beginning to change; that their hard edges were softening, and that, as a result of the immeasurable love that Mother had given them, they themselves were beginning to feel a compassion towards others that they had never known.

In countless people, Mother had transformed pain into joy, despair into hope, sickness into health, fear into peace, lack of meaning into renewed faith, and indifference into love and compassion. People's hearts had been touched by Her Grace.

On their way back to India, Mother and the group had a stopover in the Maldives. Near the airport they got into a small motor boat and were driven out to one of the islands where they were to stay overnight.

When they arrived on the island, the group enjoyed a very special day, an opportunity to be alone with Mother. Mother spent most of the day outside. They all sat together on the beach, meditating and singing bhajans. Nealu put on a diving mask and dived into the shallows. When he came back up to the surface, he excitedly told Mother that he had seen a variety of multicolored fish. Mother got up, saying, “That old man always wants to amuse Amma and make Her happy! He finds all sorts of different methods to accomplish this.” Mother looked down into the clear water. She spotted several fish and started shouting and jumping up and down like an excited child. Suddenly, Mother stopped, and like a persistent child demanded to be given something to feed the fish. Nealu happened to have some nuts and Indian mixture with him, which he gave Mother. With Her face bathing in bliss, She fed the fish. As She stood gazing down at the brightly colored creatures, She went into a state of rapture. She sat down at the edge of the water and became immersed in samadhi. Everyone sat down close to Her. When Mother finally emerged from that state, She softly sang the Sanskrit hymn, *Vidamsam vibhum*.

Again and again, I salute Parabrahman, the Absolute Reality, which is one without a second, permeates everything in the universe, and is pure and totally auspicious; yet, which, at the same time, is beyond all attributes—the Unmanifest, the fourth and highest point of consciousness.

It started to drizzle. Mother didn’t move, but continued to sit at the edge of the water.

THE AWAKENING OF THE INNER CHILD

Br. Nealu took the opportunity to ask Mother a question.

“Is it the duty of a Self-realized being to lead others towards the goal? Isn’t that the obligation of such a soul?”

Mother: “Obligations exist only on the mental and physical plane. Once you transcend the mind and realize you are not an isolated entity, not just a part, but the whole—the Cosmic Energy itself—then there is nobody, or no body, to feel obliged. A satguru, who is one with existence, doesn’t owe anything to anyone, he has no obligations whatsoever. His life is perfect and complete as it is. He simply exists, as a great, divine Presence. Does infinite space owe anything to anyone? Does the sun, the wind, or the oceans owe anything to

anyone? They simply exist; and we benefit by their existence. What do the great masters need from us? It is we who owe everything to them.

“We have nothing to offer those who are willing to sacrifice their lives for the sake of the world. It is only because of their grace that we may receive the unique gift of God-realization. Isn’t such an immeasurable gift far more than anyone could ask for? We can only bow down to them with great humility, and be immensely grateful to them for coming down to us and helping us evolve to the plane of supreme bliss, where they themselves dwell eternally.

“Guiding a disciple to the supreme goal of God-realization is like giving birth to a baby and carefully raising it; that is the only way to describe it. Staying in the presence of a satguru is like being born again; it’s like a second birth.

“Until this point, you have developed only externally, only the body and intellect have grown. But once you come to a satguru, an inner development takes place and you grow into the experience of the soul (Atman). Externally, you may be grown-up; but internally, the master teaches you to go back to the state of a child, to the state of childlike innocence. The master’s whole purpose is to awaken the slumbering child within you.

“When a mother breast-feeds her baby and gives it other nourishing food, and when she provides the child with all the love and warmth it needs, she is creating the necessary conditions that will enable the child to grow and develop properly. Just as a mother creates the most favorable conditions for the healthy development of her child, a true master creates a conducive atmosphere for the innate innocence to awaken and develop in the disciple. The satguru’s presence, look, and touch is the food that is needed for the sleeping inner child of the disciple to awaken and to develop.

“Think of the tremendous amount of love and care your mother bestowed on you, the patience she had in helping you to grow up and become a young man or woman. Most of us owe much to our mothers for our mental and physical development. She took care of us without expecting anything in return. She did it simply out of the immeasurable love she felt for her child.

“If you can imagine this picture of a mother, selflessly nourishing and nurturing her children, you will get an idea of how a spiritual master brings up his disciples; how the master helps the disciples to grow out of their ego and become as expansive as the universe. This simile of a mother raising her child is only an example to help you understand the great task of the master in transforming the disciple, of turning the disciple into a pure vessel of

supreme power. A true master must be as patient as the earth to do this. You could say that by performing this miracle, he is more loving and compassionate than God Himself. By this, Amma means that we do not know anything about God, except the extremely vague concepts we have received through stories and the scriptures. It is only through the immense compassion of a satguru that we are able to experience God in a tangible way. It is in the satguru's presence that we come to know that God really exists.

“When the disciple approaches the master, he is raw, rusty, and primitive. The master, the infinitely loving, divine alchemist, transforms the disciple into pure ‘gold.’ The master doesn’t have to do this. He has a choice and could simply dissolve into the Totality without ever uttering a word. But, instead, he chooses to become an offering to the world. He sacrifices himself out of sheer compassion for those who are groping in the dark.”

Bri. Gayatri was trying to hold an umbrella over Mother. But Mother refused to accept it. “No,” She said, “as long as Amma’s children are in the rain, She doesn’t want an umbrella.” But soon it began to rain so heavily that Mother and the others went back to their rooms.

A WONDERFUL COSMIC PLAY

That night, when the rain had stopped, Mother and the entire group walked out to the end of a pier and sat down together in a thatched gazebo. Mother sang several hymns and the group responded in the traditional way.

A full moon illumined the earth and sea. The waves reverberated with their eternal chanting of “Aum.” Mother’s pure voice and the power and beauty of Her presence uplifted the souls of Her children, and lent the atmosphere a unique spiritual glow.

She sang, *Samsara Dukha Samanam...*

*O Mother of the world,
Dispeller of the sorrows of transmigration,
The shelter of Your blessed Hand
Is our only refuge.*

*You are the refuge of lost and blind souls;
By remembering Your Lotus Feet*

We are protected from danger.

*For the deluded ones,
Who are immersed in impenetrable darkness,
Meditation on Your name and form
Is the only escape from their wretched state.*

*Let Your beautiful, radiant eyes
Cast a glance at my mind;
O Mother, Your Grace is the only way
To reach Your Lotus Feet.*

The following day they took the little motor boat back to the main island. It was a windy day. As the boat headed out towards the sea, a storm suddenly blew up and the sea became extremely rough. The little boat was being tossed up and down like a toy among the waves. At times the waves were so gigantic it seemed they would crash into the boat. The brahmacharis, Gayatri, Saumya, and the others were terrified. They were cowering in the boat, trembling with fear. Several waves came very close to breaking into the boat. They were sure the little vessel would fill with water at any moment and they would sink. Suddenly, through the wind and the roar of the waves they heard someone laughing. They looked up and realized it was Mother. Mother was thoroughly enjoying Herself. She kept laughing and Her face had the expression of a delighted child. At that moment, they understood that Mother is completely fearless, and that for Her, every situation in life is just part of a wonderful cosmic play.

Listening to Mother's blissful laughter they calmed down and were no longer afraid. For what need is there to fear when the Mother of the Universe Herself is sitting by your side, as you cross the ocean of life?

OM NAMAH SHIVAYA